

心霊探偵

八

Psychic Detective

YAKUMO

Horror Kaitoko

霊

4

守るべき想い

神永学



角川文庫

Information

Table of Contents URL: <https://www.lightnovelworld.co/novel/shinrei-tantei-yakumo-12040103>

Shinrei Tantei Yakumo

Psychic Detective Yakumo

Author: [Kaminaga Manabu](#)
RANK 1251

5.0

42

Chapters

10K

Views

325

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Completed

Status

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Shinrei Tantei Yakumo novel is a popular light novel covering Adventure, Drama, and Horror genres. Written by the Author Kaminaga Manabu. 42 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

Haruka, consulted by a friend who ran into a ghost at school, goes to the Movie Research Circle to see a man with mysterious powers. However, the person who meets her there is an affected young man with terrible bed hair and sleepy eyes. What does Haruka consult him about? A confinement and murder case at a women's university, a false suicide case... The great detective who can see the spirits of the dead, Saitou Yakumo, takes these cases on in this astoundingly high-speed spiritual mystery!

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Why this (wn) is discontinued. Anybody knows the reason.

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I thought it said 'Psychedelic' Detective Yakumo.. was thinking..
"That's pretty interesting.." lol..

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smiling_shadow
Reader
1y

This was one of the first animes I followed when I started watching
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Reals
Reader
1y

I am... third? why... is... there... no... one... here...

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I was here...

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FINALLY... THE FIRST COMMENT BELONGS TO ME(took me way too long)

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8 0

Volume 1 Chapter 0: Prologue

VOLUME 1 – THE RED EYE KNOWS prologue

That day, the thick layers of clouds that had been there since morning blocked out the sun.

Nevertheless, the delivery room was enveloped with a coiling heat.

‘You’ll be fine.’

The nurse, Iida Youko, repeated those words to the pregnant woman like they were a spell.

Her forehead was covered in sweat and her pale blue veins stuck out from her skin. She was clenching her teeth as she contorted her body.

She was desperately withstanding a bone-jarring pain.

Youko wanted to relieve her pain, even if it was only by a little. While rubbing the pregnant woman’s back, they performed the Lamaze breathing technique together.

‘Haa, haa, haa.’

It had already been some time since she had come to the delivery room. It was a considerably difficult birth.

The pregnant woman’s eyes were already vacant.

Wasn’t it better in some situations to switch to obstetric analgesia?

Youko looked at the doctor, Kinoshita Eiichi.

'The head's out. Just a bit more,' said Kinoshita, quelling Youko's thought.

'Now, just a bit more – do your best.'

Youko spoke while patting the pregnant woman's shoulders. Though her face was slack from the pain, she nodded.

'Don't push. Relax.'

'Please relax.'

Youko repeated Kinoshita's words.

The pregnant woman was breathing painfully with tears in her eyes.

'OK! The baby's out!'

Just as Kinoshita said that, the cry of a healthy baby echoed through the delivery room.

'Aah!'

The pregnant woman's breathing still sounded painful, but she let out a cry of relief and joy.

'Congratulations. From today on, you're a mother.'

Youko smiled at the woman and wiped the sweat off her forehead.

The woman might not have heard, since she didn't reply and just regulated her rough breathing with a relaxed expression on her face.

It had been a difficult birth, but this was a relief. Just when Youko thought that, Kinoshita spoke up.

'Bring a penlight.'

Though Kinoshita's tone was definitely not wild, there was a tinge of impatience and nervousness.

Youko immediately handed the penlight on the operation table to Kinoshita.

'Ha – '

The moment she saw the baby's face, Youko unconsciously swallowed her breath.

She couldn't believe what she saw in front of her.

'Don't react. The mother's here,' muttered Kinoshita.

At those words, Youko regained her calm.

However, that moment of panic reached the mother.

'My baby,' she gasped.

Her expression was exuding anxiety.

'Please wait a bit longer.'

'How is my baby?'

Youko approached the mother and spoke while patting her body.

However, she couldn't stop her anxiety.

'Where? Where is my baby?'

The mother gripped Youko's arms with her fingernails.

'It's fine. Everything's fine.'

Youko tried to calm down the mother while bearing with the pain, but there was no effect.

Youko could feel the mother's growing anxiety through her skin.

'My baby. Is my baby safe?'

The mother looked like a demon.

Youko ended up looking away without thinking under that pressure. She shouldn't have done that.

'My baby!' shrieked the mother, thrusting Youko away.

'He's fine. He's a healthy baby.'

The one who replied was Kinoshita.

Kinoshita took off his mask and slowly walked towards the mother with the baby in his arms.

The mother's franticness disappeared and her expression changed into a gentle smile for her child, whom she had just seen for the first time.

Youko immediately walked towards Kinoshita and whispered in his ear.

'Is this really OK?'

'It can't be hidden forever.'

Kinoshita's expression stiffened.

It was just as he said. It couldn't be hidden forever. She would find out eventually. It was just a matter of when.

'Go ahead.'

Kinoshita brought the baby to the mother's chest.

'Ah, my baby.'

The mother took her baby and hugged him tightly, looking blissful as tears rolled down her cheeks.

Then –

With a smile, she peered at her child's face.

The mother's expression went cold in an instant.

'Nooooo!'

That bitter cry echoed through the delivery room.

Youko bit her lip and put her hands together in front of her chest, struggling with pessimism as she thought about the new-born baby's future.

The baby had been born with his left eye open.

That eye glowed red like a blazing flame —

Volume 1 Chapter 1: VOLUME 1 – THE RED EYE KNOWS

Chapter 1

VOLUME 1 – THE RED EYE KNOWS

file 01: the locked room (TRANSLATION NOTES)

At the edge of the university campus, there was a forest .

Since the campus had been built on a hill, it wasn't strange .

Deep in that forest, there was a one-storey concrete building .

Nobody knew what it had been built for .

Now, it was just a deserted building .

Since it was deep in the forest, many students wouldn't notice it was there at all if they lived normal student lives .

There had long been rumours that ghosts appeared in that deserted building .

Someone claimed to have spotted a figure near that deserted building, but the figure had suddenly disappeared when chased . Another person said that they'd heard a pitiful cry of 'Save me, save me' when they passed the deserted building . Somebody else said that it wasn't 'Save me' but a curse: 'I'll kill you . '

There was more to the rumours of this deserted building .

In the very back of the building, there was a locked room behind an iron door .

Nobody knew what was inside . The reason was that nobody who had seen it ever returned –

1

Because of the strong, dry wind, the clouds had all floated away by noon .

The pale moon could easily be seen .

It was a full moon –

Somebody had once said that moonlight absorbed noise . The night was so quiet that that nonsense seemed believable .

Miki, Kazuhiko and Yuuichi had been drinking at a bar when they missed the last train . Now, they were thinking of a way to spend the time before the first train .

Then, the topic of the rumour spreading across campus came up .

The three of them knew about the rumour, but none of them had ever checked it out .

'Let's go see if that rumour's true,' said Miki .

Kazuhiko and Yuuchi agreed to Miki's suggestion . They ended up sneaking into the university at night .

They climbed over the mesh fence, passed the back of the school building and went into the forest .

They pushed their way through the branches on a trackless path .

It felt like a little adventure .

The path was much harder to walk than Miki had imagined .

When they reached the deserted building, she was covered in sweat and she had sobered up . Miki had lost her initial energy and was starting to regret her decision .

The building had one storey with a flat roof and was built out of concrete . It felt cold – rather than a building, it was more like a clump of concrete had just been left there .

'Since we've come all this way, let's take a photo to commemorate this,' said Yuuichi .

Kazuhiko took the camera first and took a photo with the deserted building as a backdrop . The pale light of the flash made Yuuichi's shadow appear on the dark wall of the deserted building .

Next, Yuuichi took the camera . Kazuhiko and Miki stood next to each other and turned towards him with a smile .

The flash lit up again .

Clunk!

There was the sound of metal hitting metal .

Miki's shoulders jolted in her surprise .

'Did you hear something just now?'

Miki looked around . Kazuhiko and Yuuichi held their breath as they looked around and listened .

Rustle .

All they heard was the sound of branches shaking in the wind .

'Can't hear anything . '

Yuuichi put his hand to his ear .

'What? You're the one who suggested this, but you're scared now?' said Kazuhiko coolly .

Miki glared at Kazuhiko sulkily .

'I'm not scared . '

Miki walked to the entrance and tried the knob on the rusty iron door .

Next, Kazuhiko tried the knob, but it still wouldn't open .

'For times like this, tada!'

Yuichi took a thin metal hook out of his trouser pocket .

'What's that?' asked Kazuhiko .

'Well, just look . Ah, Kazu, give me some light with your lighter . '

Kazuhiko lit up his lighter as asked and put it near the doorknob . Yuuichi stood in front of the door, knelt down and put the metal tool he had taken out earlier into the keyhole .

'What are you doing?'

'Now, now . '

A few minutes after Yuuichi started grappling with the doorknob, he stood up and turned it .

Creak .

There was the sound of metal scraping against metal as the door opened .

'You're amazing!' said Kazuhiko, sounding impressed .

'Anybody could do this with the right tools . '

Yuuichi rubbed at his nose, seeming proud .

'Where'd you get something like that?'

'Online . I'll give you the URL later so you can take a look . '

Kazuhiko and Yuuichi went inside with no hesitation .

Since Miki didn't want to be left by herself, she hurriedly followed them .

The cold wind from outside blew inside, lifting the dust that had gathered on the floor . The building was warm in comparison to how it felt outside, but it was so dark it was difficult to see her fingers .

Kazuhiko lit his lighter, but the small, flickering flame wasn't of much use so they couldn't see the inside of the building .

For a moment, a pale light flashed and lit up the room .

Miki jumped in surprise at that light . Yuuichi smirked when he saw how frightened Miki was . Yuuichi had used the flash on the camera .

'I'm going home,' said Miki .

'What? You scared?' said Kazuhiko and Yuuichi at the same time .

'B-but I feel like somebody's watching me . '

Miki clung to Kazuhiko's arm, as if trying to hide .

For a while, the three of them looked around in the dark . Nothing was there but the complete darkness that covered the room .

'It's fine . Nothing to worry about . '

After Kazuhiko said that to Miki, he started walking slowly by the walls .

'Hey, protect me . '

Miki tugged at Kazuhiko's arm .

'Yeah, leave it to me . '

Kazuhiko casually patted Miki on the shoulder and then started walking again .

They passed through the room right at the entrance and went down the corridor .

The corridor was narrow enough for people to bump shoulders . On both sides, there were evenly spaced doors with windows . Behind those doors were rooms of about four tatami in size .

In each room, there was one bed, and nothing else .

The three of them walked along the walls to the locked room in question .

The room was at the end of the corridor .

It was an incredibly eerie room . The metal door looked heavy, clearly different from the other rooms . There was an observation window with iron bars . Besides the normal lock, the doorknob was bound to the pipe that went up the wall with chains and had a combination padlock .

'Can't open this,' grumbled Yuuichi .

'What's inside?' Kazuhiko peered into the room through the window .

'See anything?'

'Nothing . Can't make anything out in the dark . '

The moment Kazuhiko gave up –

Rustle .

Something moved in the dark . In the very corner of the room, where the shadows were darkest .

What was there? Kazuhiko stared at it .

Eyes!

Kazuhiko's eyes met with the eyes of whatever was in the dark .

The eyes in the dark were unusually vivid . White, cloudy eyes . The blood vessels were showing . Eyes that were filled with hatred that felt like it would swallow everything up –

Kazuhiko screamed and jumped back, falling on his behind .

'What's wrong? Is something there?'

When Miki called out to him, Kazuhiko opened and shut his mouth in his fright, but his breathing was erratic and he couldn't speak .

There was just the sound of his raspy throat .

Kazuhiko managed to get up with Yuuichi's help .

'Did you see something? Yuuichi asked .

Kazuhiko looked to the door .

Yuuichi looked also .

The next moment, Kazuhiko and Yuuichi lost their words .

From the gap between the bars of the window, a hand so pale it didn't look like that of a living person reached out and suddenly gripped the shoulder of Miki, who had her back to the door .

Miki gasped .

Kazuhiko and Yuuichi were in front of her .

Then who was the person grabbing her shoulder?

She didn't have the courage to turn around and check . The blood drained from Miki's face .

She lost all her strength – she couldn't even scream .

Miki reached out with a trembling hand to ask Kazuhiko and Yuuichi for help . However, Kazuhiko and Yuuichi couldn't move from fear .

'... Please... save me...'

Miki spoke in a rasping voice . Yuuichi put his hand out towards Miki to try to pull Miki away from the door .

That moment .

Those eyes peered out again from the gap between the bars .

'Aaahhh!'

Kazuhiko and Yuuichi's heads both went blank . They screamed and ran away without looking behind them .

'Wait – don't leave me by myself!'

Miki's bitter cry didn't leave her mouth .

This was only the beginning of the case –

2

After the morning lecture, Ozawa Haruka refused an invitation from a friend and left the classroom .

The wind was cold .

In just a rough outfit of skinny jeans and a grey parka, it was chilly, as was to be expected .

She regretted not wearing something warmer .

Since she had short hair, her neck felt especially cold .

Haruka was headed for the prefabricated two-storey building behind Building B in order to visit somebody introduced to her by Aizawa, an upperclassman from the orchestra circle .

There were a number of small four-and-a-half tatami rooms on the first and second floor which the university leant out to students for club and circle activities .

The room she was headed for was at the very end of the first floor .

Movie Research Circle .

Haruka checked the plate on the door and then knocked .

There was no response . She said, 'Hello,' but the result was the same . She thought it was a bit rude, but she opened the door and peeked inside .

When she opened the door, her eyes immediately met those of the man sitting in front of her .

His skin was as white as porcelain .

He looked at her with half-closed eyes, as if he would fall asleep at any moment, and she found herself lost for words .

'E-er...'

'Could you close the door once you come in?' said the man, interrupting Haruka .

She hurriedly went in and closed the door .

The man wore a white shirt with the first two buttons unfastened, so his chest showed through .

It was unclear whether he was showing it on purpose or he was just sloppy .

Judging by the hair as messy as a bird's nest, it was probably just sloppiness .

Recently, the so-called bedhead hairstyle had been getting popular, but this man's hair was clearly just bedhead .

Besides the man at the front, there were two other men in the room .

Those two men were looking at a playing card while hiding it from the man facing her .

It was the five of spades .

'Sorry, but could you sit down? I can't concentrate . '

'Ah, yes . '

Haruka stepped away from the door and sat on the folding chair by the wall that the man gestured at .

Inside the room, other than the table, there was a fridge in the corner and a shelf next to it that had been covered with a cloth .

Rather than a clubroom, it felt more like somebody's flat .

The man who had spoken earlier closed his eyes and pinched his brow with his fingers, like he was thinking . Finally, he opened his eyes and his red lips parted .

'The five of spades . '

He was right . Amazing!

The card that the men had been looking at earlier had definitely been the five of spades . Haruka couldn't hide her surprise, while the men let out cries of dismay and threw the card on the table .

'Damn . You got us again . '

The men took thousand yen bills out of their pocket in a displeased manner, hit the table and left the clubroom .

'Please sit down . You have a request, don't you?'

The man put the thousand yen bills in his shirt pocket and yawned as he spoke .

Haruka sat on the chair that the men had sat on earlier .

'Er, might you be Saitou Yakumo-san?'

'There's no might about it – I am,' the man responded .

This person is Saitou Yakumo –

Aizawa had told Haruka to consult Saitou Yakumo of the Movie Research Circle if she ever had to talk about something related to ghosts .

According to rumour, he could sense the supernatural and might be able to help with things of that nature .

To be honest, she had been dubious before coming here and hadn't known what sort of ability he had .

However, there was the card from earlier .

Maybe he had read their minds or was clairvoyant, but he definitely appeared to have some sort of ability .

'So?'

Yakumo urged her to continue .

'The truth is, an upperclassman from my circle introduced me . '

'Who?'

'Aizawa-san . '

'Don't recognise the name . Who is that?'

'Eh?'

That didn't make sense . Since Aizawa had introduced Yakumo, she'd been sure that they knew each other .

'Well, it doesn't matter who introduced you . Explain in a summary what you've come here for . '

'Um, er, my friend is in trouble . Saitou-san, I've heard that you were an expert on that sort of thing, so, er, I want you to help her...'

'You've summarised too much . I don't understand at all . What is "that sort of thing"?''

'Ah, sorry . I'll explain properly . '

'By the way, who are you?'

What an unpleasant guy –

This person's expression hadn't changed at all the whole time . He still looked sleepy . It was like he enjoyed seeing people all flustered .

'Ah, my name is Ozawa Haruka . I'm a second-year student at this university in the education department in the faculty of literature...'

'Just your name is fine . '

Yakumo waved his hand like he found her bothersome and stopped her words .

Her anger towards this unpleasant person was escalating .

'So what do you want?'

'The truth is, a few days ago, my friend Miki went to a deserted building on campus, since there was a rumour that ghosts appeared there . Then, it seems like she actually saw a ghost . '

'What sort of ghost?'

'I don't know the details either . I didn't go with her . She went with her boyfriend Kazuhiko and a friend called Yuuichi-kun . '

'So you came all this way to tell me a ghost story?'

'That's not it . Ever since then, Miki's been acting strange . She has a high fever and she's been sleeping the whole time . '

'The cold going around recently is a frightful thing . '

'Like I said! Please listen until I'm finished!'

Unable to restrain her irritation, she spoke in a loud voice that even surprised herself .

However, Yakumo leant back on his chair, and his eyes still looked sleepy .

'So? What happened next?'

Yakumo urged her to continue, running a hand through his messy hair .

'... She isn't just sleeping . She keeps on muttering things like "Save me" and "Let me out of here" . '

'And the doctor?'

'Of course a doctor's been to see her, but besides the fever, apparently there's nothing in particular wrong with her body... The doctor said it was probably something psychological . '

'Something psychological...'

Yakumo crossed his arms and leant on the back of the chair .

'She lives alone, so I contacted her parents, but the call didn't go through... I don't know what to do...'

She wanted to do something for her friend, but she didn't know what to do in a situation like this .

Meanwhile, Miki was wasting away .

'So you want me to look into the matter since her condition might be related to the ghost she saw in that room?'

'Yes . I've heard that Saitou-san was an expert on that sort of thing . '

Yakumo took in a deep breath and looked up at the ceiling, like he was thinking about something .

'No good? Is that a no?'

Haruka looked at Yakumo's expression with wide eyes .

'Twenty-five thousand yen . Tax included . '

'Eh? You're asking for money?'

'Are we friends?'

'No, we aren't . '

'Are we lovers?'

'Of course not . '

'So, money . '

'Why?'

'Wouldn't it be strange for me to do something for you for free when we're not friends or lovers?'

What he said was logical in a sense, but somehow, she couldn't honestly accept it .

That said, she couldn't just leave things like this .

'I understand . I'll pay . I'll pay, but please let me defer the payment . '

'Ten thousand yen up front . The remaining fifteen thousand yen after this is finished . '

Haruka took a thousand yen bill from her wallet and put it on the table .

Yakumo shook his head . Haruka took out another two thousand yen, but Yakumo shook his head again .

'You're missing a digit . '

'That's all I have on me right now . '

Haruka waved her empty wallet in front of Yakumo's eyes .

'I understand . I'll look into it,' said Yakumo with a yawn, like there was nothing else he could do .

From the flow of the conversation up until now, she was dubious about whether he would actually look into it for her, but she had nobody else to rely on .

'Please contact me if you find something out . '

Haruka put a memo with her contact information on it on the table, stood up and put her hand on the doorknob .

This is –

She noticed something unbelievable .

Movie posters and photographs were stuck on the door .

In a gap between them, a pair of eyes and her own not very tall nose were reflected back at her .

It was a small mirror .

She'd been fooled .

'That playing card from earlier...' said Haruka, turning around .

'I was almost tricked . When you guessed the number of the playing card earlier, you were cheating . The mirror on the door – from your position, you could've seen the number on the card... I see – that's why you told me to move away from the door . '

Haruka said that all at once with a face red from anger .

How could he! She was angry at how stupid she was for believing in this person for even a moment . This was why her friends made fun of her for being naive .

'Correct . You're the first person who's seen through it . '

Yakumo said that nonchalantly, not ashamed at all as he clapped his hands .

'You're the worst . Please give me back my money . '

'Why?'

'Don't say "Why" . You tried to trick me out of my money . Please give it back . '

She couldn't believe him . Taking advantage of a person's weakness . She really felt that way .

'Don't say something so rude . '

'What was rude about it?'

'I don't plan on tricking you . I'll give you back the full amount if I can't save your friend . '

'How can I believe that?'

This man called Saitou – there was a limit to shamelessness .

'What can you do anyway? I came because I heard you had some sort of psychic ability, but aren't you just cheating?'

'Who said I had some sort of psychic ability? I definitely didn't . Just as you said, the thing with the playing card earlier was fraud . '

There was no reason for him to sound so proud as he said that .

'If you don't have a psychic ability, how are you going to save Miki?'

'You're free to choose whether to believe what I am about to say next or not . If you'll believe me, then you can leave it to me . If you won't, the exit is over there . '

Yakumo gestured at the door .

'I'll give back your money too . '

Yakumo put three thousand yen bills on the table .

'I can see things that other people can't . '

'Is this a riddle?'

'You can interpret it as you will . What's the answer?'

'I don't know . '

'The spirits of the dead . '

'Spirits?'

'To put it simply, ghosts . '

'That's idiotic . '

'You're the idiot . '

Yakumo pointed at Haruka .

Calling somebody he'd just met an idiot –

'But you said earlier you didn't have any psychic ability...'

'I did . I don't have a psychic ability . I can just see the spirits of the dead . '

'That's the same thing . '

'It isn't . It isn't a psychic ability but a physical one . '

'Physical?'

He had been quibbling for a while – it felt like he was just trying to make the conversation confusing .

'For example, you wouldn't call perfect pitch a psychic ability, right? You'd call it an ability they were born with or a talent... Anyway, I'm not clairvoyant and I can't use telekinesis . I was just born with the ability to see the spirits of the dead . '

'If you're going to say that much, can you prove it?'

'I don't know whether this will count as proof, but there is a ghost in this room right now . '

Yakumo put his index finger between his well-shaped eyebrows .

She didn't have to check – only the two of them were in here .

'You can't trick me with that . '

'The ghost in here right now is your older sister . Your twin...'

'You're lying . '

She shook her head . Her fingers were trembling .

'Yes, your sister . Her name is Ayaka . She died in a traffic accident at the age of seven . '

'How do you know...'

Her throat felt tight .

'I said so, didn't I? I can see her . '

Even her childhood friends didn't know that she had an older sister .

Then why did this person who she'd just met know? Rather than nonsensical, it was mysterious .

'You still think that your sister's accident was your fault . '

That one sentence from Yakumo pierced deep into Haruka's heart .

The blood left her face . Her head went blank – she felt like she might faint .

The ball that fell to the asphalt .

The sound of the car horn .

The deep red blood kept pouring out .

'Your sister ran into the road to catch the ball you threw . Then...'

'Stop... I... That isn't... I didn't think it would end up like that...'

Haruka shut her eyes tightly and covered her eyes .

– No matter how I yelled, my sister Ayaka didn't move at all .

It was so sudden that I couldn't cry or scream .

My palms were dyed red with the blood from my sister's head .

Blood –

She could remember the wet feeling clearly . She had frantically tried to stop the blood, but it was no good .

She'd felt her sister Ayaka's life disappearing from her hands .

'I see... So you threw the ball far away on purpose . '

'You're wrong!'

Haruka lifted her head at Yakumo's words and clenched her teeth .

Yakumo continued speaking regardless .

'You always missed the ball, but your older sister always caught it skilfully . So you threw the ball far away on purpose so your sister wouldn't be able to catch it . '

'Stop it!'

Her hands were shaking . Her breathing was ragged .

Why? She had never talked about this to anyone . Nobody should have known about it . Her eyes were filled with tears even though she didn't want to cry .

'Why are you doing this...' asked Haruka in a hoarse voice, wiping her tears away with her fingers .

'...'

Yakumo didn't reply to Haruka's question .

After Haruka glanced at Yakumo, she picked up her bag and stood . She opened the door and tried to leave .

'If you don't believe me, there's more . Your sister says there's something she regrets . '

'Regrets...'

'She was the one who hid your mother's ring . Your mother got angry at you then . The ring was stuck to the top of a shoe cupboard with gum . She was going to confess, but she couldn't say it...'

Haruka couldn't breathe . The corners of her eyes felt hot .

'I...'

'Also, your sister said she doesn't blame you,' said Yakumo, interrupting Haruka's words .

Doesn't blame me? That's ridiculous . I mean, it's my fault that my sister –
She felt the urge to run away and fled from the room .

* * *

When Haruka reached the courtyard, she collapsed onto a bench .

The dry autumn wind made her short hair flutter .

The noise from the students passing by hurt her ears .

She looked down, covering her face with her hands .

The memories from her past – she had never talked to anybody about them before .

A man she had just met guessed everything right in such a cold manner .

She thought that she would be assaulted by unstoppable anger and humiliation, but that wasn't actually the case .

It would be a lie if she said she didn't feel that way at all .

However, her heart felt a bit lighter –

It was a mystery even to her why she felt that way .

Haruka took her mobile phone out of her bag and, after thinking for a while, punched in her parents' phone number . After a number of rings, her mother Keiko answered .

'What is it?'

Her mother said that first thing .

'Nothing really . I just...'

'You've always been bad at lying . Something happened, right?'

Her mother saw right through her after just that .

Haruka felt like she'd cry if she talked at length .

'Hey, Mum . You lost your ring a while back, right? Back when Sis was still alive . '

'What is this all of a sudden?'

'Could you look at the top of the shoe cupboard?'

'Why are you talking about that now?'

'Just go and look . '

'Fine, fine . '

Her mother sounded exasperated . Then, the hold tone started playing .

It was Chopin's Farewell[1] . Her sister Ayaka had been good at piano . Her slender fingers appeared to dance as they played this song that even adults had difficulty with .

While I wasn't good at music, not just piano . My rhythm was always off . I was always compared to my sister .

Not just for piano . Even for school and sports, I couldn't beat my older sister .

When we were together, we were often mistaken for an older sister and her younger brother .

Part of it was because of my short hair, but we were completely different even though we were twins .

I had even thought that having my sister there was unpleasant .

And then that accident –

Just as Saitou had said, Haruka had thrown the ball far away on purpose .

She hadn't thought it would end up like that .

When she saw her grieving parents, how could she live in a carefree manner?

She had lived with the fear that somebody would someday find out how her sister died .

'It was there . It really was there . '

Her mother's voice from the phone brought Haruka back to reality .

'Haruka, so it really was you?'

'No, it was Sis . '

'Eh? What?'

Haruka hung up without answering her mother's question .

I didn't know where the ring was hidden .

So my sister really was –

Haruka knocked once more on the Movie Research Circle clubroom door .

When she opened the door and went inside, a paper aeroplane was circling about .

'What are you doing?'

'Throwing a paper aeroplane . '

The paper aeroplane made a wobbly landing at Haruka' feet .

'I can tell just by looking . I'm asking why you're doing it . '

Haruka picked up the landed plane . It was made out of a thousand yen bill .

'I was killing time until you came back . '

'...'

'Go ahead . '

Yakumo urged Haruka to sit .

Haruka put the plane she picked up on the table and then sat down .

'Could I ask you one thing?

Yakumo nodded as he stretched his arms behind him .

'This is the clubroom for the Movie Research Circle, right? Is there nobody in the club besides you, Saitou-san?'

'There isn't . Since this is my room . '

'What do you mean?' asked Haruka, raising a shapely eyebrow .

The conversation was advancing naturally, but she didn't understand it .

'In the first place, the Movie Research Circle doesn't exist . '

'But this is...'

'It's simple . I went to the student affairs office, borrowed some student's name and applied for a clubroom to make a circle . That's all . It's like a secret hiding place . '

'Aren't you just using this room as your own?'

'Exactly . '

'You really are the worst – you're even deceiving the university . '

'Ah, I'll give you back your three thousand yen . '

Yakumo ignored Haruka's objections and gestured at the thousand yen bills on the table .

'Because your trick was exposed?'

'You came back because you didn't think it was a trick . Isn't that right?'

She didn't deny it, but his know-it-all tone irritated her .

'That's...'

'It was there, right? Your mother's ring . '

Yakumo crossed his arms behind his head and leant back on his chair .

'How do you know that?' asked Haruka, her eyes wide in surprise .

Yakumo didn't reply .

The way he stuck out his chin was like he was saying 'I've already explained it, right?' . But she couldn't accept that .

'Please tell me . '

'Your sister told me . '

'Stop lying . A fraud like you is just saying you can see ghosts so you can trick people out of their money, right?'

Haruka leant forward as she said that, putting herself closer to Yakumo .

Yakumo tapped the table rhythmically with a long, white finger, as if he were considering something .

Finally, his finger stopped and his almond eyes looked right at Haruka .

'Then let's do this . Let's go to that deserted building together . '

'By together, do you mean me and you?'

'Who else would it be?'

'That's true, but...'

This person keeps on –

'If you go with me, then you can tell whether I'm a fraud or not . Like with the mirror on the door . '

'...'

She couldn't reply right away .

It was just a coincidence that she saw through the trick with the mirror on the door . There was no guarantee that she'd see through the next thing .

Haruka looked at Yakumo's expression with her own black eyes .

She thought she'd be able to see through him if he was lying, but that was naive .

His eyes were still sleepy and he had his chin in his hand .

'Well, it doesn't matter to me either way . To be honest, I don't care at all what happens to your friend . '

Just from that one comment by Yakumo, Haruka made up her mind .

4

Yakumo wanted to meet up with Miki before they went to the deserted building .

At his request, Haruka brought Yakumo to the hospital Miki was in .

It was a twenty-minute walk from the university . After passing through the station and exiting from the north, the hospital was about two hundred metres down the main road .

While walking on the sidewalk, Haruka glanced at Yakumo's profile .

He had a pencil-straight nose and sharp chin – he would probably be popular if he kept his mouth shut, but he had an unapproachable atmosphere to him .

'What?'

Yakumo looked at her coldly, like he had noticed her gaze .

'Can I ask you one thing?'

'Only one thing . '

'Can you exorcise spirits?'

'I can't do something as handy as that . '

'Eh?'

Haruka was taken aback .

He was full of coincidence, but how did he plan to save Miki?

'I'll say this again, but all I can do is see the spirits of the dead . '

'But you said you'd save my friend...'

'I might be able to save her . It's an "if" situation,' said Yakumo, as if it were completely obvious .

'That's irresponsible . There's no point to what we're doing now then, right?'

'That isn't true . '

'Why?'

'By seeing something, it means I understand that something is there . If I understand what is there, I can understand why . If I understand why, I might be able to remove the cause for it . '

She understood his logic .

However, she didn't know what he meant specifically . She couldn't imagine it at all .

While she was doing that, they arrived at the hospital .

She didn't completely understand, but it seemed as if there was nothing to do but go with him .

The hospital was a four-storey building with white walls .

They passed the asphalt parking lot and wrote down their names in the visitors log as instructed by the nurse . Then, they took the elevator at the back of the waiting room .

'Could I ask you one thing too?'

Yakumo spoke just as the elevator doors closed .

'If it isn't a rude question,' replied Haruka guardedly .

'Three people went to that deserted building . How are the other two?'

'Kazuhiko and Yuuichi-kun were both so scared they ran away, but Yuuichi-kun realised at the campus exit that he'd separated from everyone and went back even though he was scared . '

'I see . '

'After getting back to the forest, he found Miki collapsed there... and then he carried Miki back . '

'Was she conscious then?'

Haruka shook her head .

'Miki wouldn't wake up so he brought her right to the hospital . The next morning, Yuuichi-kun contacted me, and then I...'

'And how about Kazuhiko?'

'I don't care about a guy like that . Even though he's Miki's boyfriend, he left her behind . '

'It's not like I deserted her . '

As Yakumo said that, the elevator doors opened .

At Haruka's instruction, they went down the corridor and stopped in front of the third hospital room . After knocking, they went inside .

It was a large room with four beds, but besides the bed in the front that Miki was sleeping in, the room was completely empty .

An IV catheter went along Miki's arms .

It was probably for nutrients or something like that . Her eyes were open, but they were empty – they didn't appear to be looking at anything .

There was sweat on her forehead and her face was pale . If Haruka didn't hear the faint breathing – like air being let out of a balloon – there'd be no difference between Miki and a corpse .

'Even though she's in this state, the doctor said there's nothing in particular wrong with her body and that she was probably overworked from stress... Do you think somebody who was talking so cheerfully yesterday could end up like this?'

Haruka was agitated, but Yakumo didn't seem to be listening .

He stood by the bed and gazed at Miki . There was a wrinkle between his well-defined eyebrows, and Yakumo's eyes, which had been sleepy until now, were grim .

'Do you see something?'

Haruka spoke up, bewildered by Yakumo, who seemed like a completely different person .

'Who are you?' murmured Yakumo .

'... ve me... Save me... Ple... a... se...'

Miki's mouth opened, and out came a voice that sounded like the groan of a beast .

Yakumo leant over Miki and put his ear near her mouth .

'... Let me out... of here...'

Miki's mouth moved again and spoke .

'Where are you now?'

Yakumo took Miki's face in his hands and stared into her eyes . When Yakumo looked at Miki, her eyes seemed to move slightly .

'... I can't see... Where am I... Let me out...'

'Where are you now? Tell me . '

Miki made no response . Her faint breathing turned ragged .

'No!'

Miki suddenly shrieked, threw her hands up towards the ceiling and arched her back .

What? What was happening?

While Haruka was confused, Miki dropped her arms, as if tired, and was as still as the dead .

Yakumo didn't say anything . He just sighed and left the hospital room .

'Wait . '

Haruka hurriedly followed Yakumo out of the room .

Yakumo was leaning on the wall right outside of the hospital room and had a hand on the left side of his forehead and eye .

His breathing was ragged . His shoulders shook as if he were in pain .

'Are you all right?'

Haruka approached Yakumo and tried to look at his face, but Yakumo quickly fixed his posture and started walking, as if to avoid her .

His left hand was still against his forehead and eye .

'Does it hurt?'

Haruka chased after him .

'No . '

'I think it'd be better if you get that checked . '

'Shut up!' Yakumo said sharply as he turned around .

A cold sweat was running down his forehead . His wide eyes were glaring at Haruka .

'W-what is it...' said Haruka, accepting Yakumo's pained gaze directly .

'There'd be no point in telling you . '

'You can't know that until you tell me . '

'You ask too many questions . '

Yakumo started walking away quickly to get away from Haruka .

'Honestly! Just explain a bit,' complained Haruka as she ran a bit to catch up to Yakumo .

'Hey, what'd you see in the hospital room?' asked Haruka as they got into the elevator .

However, Yakumo didn't reply .

He had his back against the elevator wall and crossed his arms, looking displeased .

Honestly –

'Why don't you just tell me? You're the one who told me to go with you, Saitou-san . '

'I regret it . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair and finally started an explanation .

'Your friend's possessed by the ghost of a woman probably around the same age as us . However, that would be when she died... Her hair went to her shoulders and there was a mole underneath her eyes . '

'And?'

'Dark . A completely dark room... Narrow... The sound of water...
Hunger... A heavy atmosphere... Pain... Terror... Terror... Terror...'

'What do you mean?'

'If I could understand it so easily, I wouldn't be suffering . Think about me a little . '

'Please don't talk to me like I'm an idiot . '

'Am I wrong?'

When the elevator reached the first floor, Yakumo started walking briskly again .

Haruka had to run to catch up again .

* * *

The autumn sunset showed its unique colours .

The sky looked like a brilliant stained glass window .

When Haruka and Yakumo arrived at the station after leaving the hospital, there was a crowd .

It was rush hour, but it was clearly different from that .

The station was teeming with people who couldn't get onto the platform .

There were ambulances parked nearby and emergency personnel were still stepping out .

The words <Outward and inbound lines have been suspended because of an accident> were scrolling on the electric signboard that displayed train times .

'Because an accident occurred at this station, train operation has currently been suspended! As accident procedure is in place, please step outside the gates . We sincerely apologise for the inconvenience . '

A train attendant was saying that message loudly . There were people trying to rush out and curious onlookers, so everyone was crowded together .

'Seems like there was an accident . '

'You can tell just from looking,' said Yakumo with his arms crossed .

This person really just goes on and –

'Ah, Professor Takaoka . '

Haruka spotted a face she knew in the crowd and called out .

'Professor Takaoka?'

'A lecturer for one of my seminars . Please wait . '

Haruka made her way through the crowd towards Takaoka .

'Professor Takaoka . '

She bumped into countless people but finally reached the one she was looking for .

Takaoka acknowledged Haruka with a flat 'Ah' .

He had round glasses and looked at first glance to be a man of delicate features, but his shoulders were wide and solid in his suit .

He gave an immaculate and refreshing impression .

With his gentle manner and friendly personality, he was rather popular with female students .

'Professor, did something happen?'

Takaoka looked around, seeming troubled by Haruka's question, but he finally spoke .

'Ichihashi-kun jumped in front of a train...'

'Ichihashi – do you mean Yuuichi-kun?'

Takaoka nodded .

'When you say jumped, do you mean...'

Her heart was beating loudly . Her throat dried up .

I can't believe it –

'It was a suicide . '

'That's...'

More of her friends were meeting with misfortune . And they were the two who had tested their courage by going to the deserted building .

'I can't believe it either . I didn't notice at all . '

Takaoka looked pained as he spoke .

'It isn't your fault, Professor . '

'Haruka-kun, did you hear anything from Ichihashi-kun?'

Haruka shook her head . Takaoka wouldn't believe her even if she told him .

The atmosphere was suffocating .

In the middle of that, somebody who looked like a station attendant called out to Takaoka and he walked away towards the stationmaster's office .

'What was it?'

Yakumo had walked up to her at some point in time .

'Yuuichi-kun committed suicide...'

When she said it aloud, she felt how terrible it was .

I didn't think he'd do something like kill himself when I was talking to him on the phone yesterday –

'Is Yuuichi one of the three who went on that test of courage?'

Haruka nodded .

Her legs were shaking – she could barely stand .

'It seems like it'd be better to look for the one who's missing,' said Yakumo as he ran a hand through his hair .

'He was normal yesterday, but...'

Her words got caught in her throat . She couldn't speak .

'I have no hard evidence, but I can say this . It isn't a suicide – '

Yakumo said that as he looked straight towards the station gate .

It was so unexpected that Haruka's eyes went wide .

It isn't a suicide –

'What do you mean?'

'I said I didn't have any hard evidence, didn't I?'

Yakumo had his hands in his pockets as he started walking with his gaze on his feet .

'Miki was possessed by a ghost – '

Haruka started speaking as she followed him .

'That's impossible . '

'Impossible . '

'The ghost possessing your friend is afraid of something . She has no ill will . '

'Afraid... Ill will...?'

'Why don't you try thinking with your own head a bit?'

This person keeps on –

'I'm asking because I don't understand even after thinking about it . '

Yakumo suddenly stopped walking .

'I believe the incident this time involves somebody living,' said Yakumo as he looked up at the sky with its lines of clouds .

Involves somebody living, he says –

'What do you mean?'

'I'm going to investigate that . '

'Huh . '

'That's all for today . Until tomorrow...'

After Yakumo declared that, he gave the duty of looking into Kazuhiko's disappearance to Haruka, and they split up there for the day .

5

Haruka's morning lecture ended, and she went to Yakumo's secret hiding place after noon, as promised .

Even though it was after noon, Yakumo looked as sleepy as always .

'Good morning,' said Haruka, sitting in the chair opposite Yakumo .

'And?'

Yakumo brought up the topic at hand in a displeased tone .

Haruka explained to Yakumo that she had called Kazuhiko's mobile multiple times, but it looked like the battery had been off, and she hadn't been able to contact him .

She had asked the acquaintances of Kazuhiko that she knew, but nobody knew where he was .

He had been missing since the incident –

'Let's put things in order,' said Yakumo, letting out a large yawn . 'Tell me once more in detail about the test of courage . '

'Put things in order?'

Haruka searched her memories, as Yakumo suggested, and started explaining how the three of them had gone on a test of courage .

There were a number of points when he asked questions, but Haruka couldn't respond .

She was just telling the story she had heard from Yuuichi as accurately as she could . She hadn't been at the scene herself .

Even if she wanted to confirm, Yuuichi was already dead .

When Haruka finished speaking, Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair and then crossed his arms .

'What are you going to do now then?' Haruka asked, knowing that he would get angry at her .

'Right . First, who is the spirit possessing your friend? I'm going to look into that . '

'Do you have any idea?'

'If you ask whether I do, I guess I do?'

'You're always so vague . '

'The world is full of vague things . '

Yakumo stood up .

* * *

Haruka was brought by Yakumo to the reference room in Building A .

She had come to this room a number of times before .

It was a white-walled room of about fifty tsubo in size, lined with moving cabinets that went up to the ceiling .

The student registry and class materials were kept here .

'What are you going to look into here?'

'I believe that the spirit possessing your friend was a student at this school .
,

'You're not going to look at everything here, are you?'

'I plan on it,' said Yakumo matter-of-factly .

Searching from the very beginning would –

'How many students do you think have enrolled in this school? You'll stay here until you're an old man . '

Haruka sat in front of the rack of three computers at the back of the room and clicked the mouse .

That turned off the screensaver and showed a screen asking for a password .

'Searching with the computer is great, but what will you do about the password?'

Yakumo crossed his arms and snorted .

'They organised the data here last year . Since they didn't have enough hands, a few students did part-time . '

'And you were one of them . '

'Yes . '

'Do you think the password hasn't been changed since then?'

That made sense .

But it was better than not trying . The password then had been the date of the school's founding in numbers .

She input the numbers with the number pad and clicked the enter key .

The monitor displayed the next screen . She felt somewhat triumphant .

'What dreadful security,' said Yakumo with a sigh .

'Though looking into all of these documents would have been dreadful too,' said Haruka with all the spite she had garnered until now .

For once, Yakumo didn't say anything back . Though he was acting calm, he must not have been inside .

Haruka clicked the file with the student registry . A screen listing name, address, birthdate, contact information and school department showed up .

'Are there photos too?' said Yakumo, expressing his wonder as he looked at the screen .

'Just the past ten years . '

'That's enough . '

'So who are you looking for?'

'The name Yuri . I don't know the kanji . '

Haruka typed Yuri into the furigana table and searched . There were almost two hundred results .

'This would be tough . Don't you have any other information?'

'They're female . '

'I know that . '

'She has a mole under her eye . '

'I can't search for that . '

There, the conversation stopped .

They had suddenly become stuck . Haruka thought over it, but she couldn't come up with anything .

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair in his irritation, but he suddenly looked up .

'Absences . Or withdrawals . Can you search with those parameters?'

That was right . That would lower the number drastically .

'I can probably do it . '

Haruka searched again and found three people .

'It's her!' exclaimed Yakumo upon seeing the second woman's photo .

Shinohara Yuri . In the Arts and Humanities faculty, department of English .
Absent .

She had long hair that was tied in the back with glasses that looked strong .
Just as Yakumo had said, there was a mole underneath her eye .

Overall, she looked sensitive .

I –

'I know this person,' said Haruka, looking up at Yakumo who was standing beside her .

'A friend?'

'We were in the same seminar in first year . I haven't spoken to her directly, but I've seen her a number of times before . At the end of last month, she suddenly stopped coming to school . '

'What is the reason for her absence?'

'I don't know... But it seems like she's disappeared . Her parents asked the police to search – there was a bit of a fuss . '

'Disappeared, eh?' said Yakumo, rubbing his sharp nose .

It was too much for this to just be a coincidence .

'That's right! Professor Takaoka might know something!' Haruka said quickly, unable to hide her excitement .

However, Yakumo was the picture of calm . He put his index finger in his ear like he thought her noisy .

'Talk more calmly . And who's Professor Takaoka?'

'Did you forget? You met him at the station yesterday, right? That's Professor Takaoka . He was in charge of our seminar . '

'That isn't much help,' said Yakumo with a yawn .

'You're negative about everyone . '

'Do you believe in anyone?'

'Anyone besides you . '

'That's an honour . '

Yakumo didn't seem to care about Haruka's unpleasantness . He took a mobile phone out of his pocket and started making a call .

'Ah, Gotou-san? There's something I'd like to request...'

Yakumo started speaking – it seemed like the call had connected .

Though Haruka couldn't hear the voice of the person on the other side of the line, she could get the gist of the conversation . Yakumo wanted the other person to look into everything about Shinohara Yuri .

Yakumo just gave his request and then hung up .

'Who was that just now?' Haruka asked, unable to think of somebody who could respond to a search request .

'An acquaintance . '

'Would that person know about news regarding missing people?'

'I wouldn't call him if there wasn't the possibility . '

That made sense, but what sort of acquaintance could it be if just one call was enough to look into a missing person?

While Haruka was thinking about it, Yakumo opened the door and left .

'Again?'

He really did just do whatever he wanted . Though Haruka was fed up, she went after Yakumo and left the room .

'Haruka-kun . '

Just as she left the reference room, somebody called out to her .

When she turned around, she saw Takaoka walking towards her – the person they had just been talking about .

'Professor – '

For a moment, Haruka wasn't sure if she should chase Yakumo, but in the end, she stood there and waited for Takaoka to reach her .

'Yesterday must have been tough for you . '

'No, no – it must have been more so for you, Professor . '

Takaoka had clearly been worn out yesterday . It made sense – his own student had died .

On the contrary, Haruka wouldn't know what to do if he smiled at her .

'That's not true . Though of course I'm not well . '

Takaoka's expression softened, but that hurt even more .

'Anyway, you can't overdo yourself at a time like this . '

'It goes for you too, Professor – '

'That's right,' said Takaoka with a wry smile, and then he walked away from Haruka .

'E-excuse me, Professor . '

Haruka called out to Takaoka, who was about to leave .

Takaoka stopped walking and turned around .

'What is it?'

'No, er...'

Haruka was lost for words .

She had called out to Takaoka because she felt like she had to ask him about Yuri, but she didn't know how to bring up the topic .

'What's wrong? Don't worry about it and just tell me,' urged Takaoka, who seemed to sense that Haruka was troubled .

She let herself talk as he said .

'Professor, do you remember Shinohara Yuri-san?'

'I do . She's on leave right now, yes?'

'Yes . She's gone missing . '

'Is that so... But why are you suddenly talking about Shinohara-kun?'

Takaoka looked suspicious .

It made sense .

'I can't talk about it in detail now, but it might be related to the matter with Yuuichi-kun . '

'Ichihashi-kun?'

'Yes . Do you remember anything?'

'Anything I remember, eh...'

Takaoka scratched his chin – it looked like he was thinking .

'Anything is fine . Like how she was before she went missing, students she was friends with, or her boyfriend...'

Haruka listed a number of topics to help Takaoka remember .

'Her boyfriend – '

Takaoka seemed to have remembered something, as his mouth suddenly opened .

'Did you recall something?'

'Ah, Shinohara-kun did have a boyfriend . Aizawa-kun, in the year above her . '

'By Aizawa, do you mean the one in the orchestra circle?'

'Yes, yes, that Aizawa-kun . '

Haruka was so surprised she couldn't say anything else . The name that Takaoka had just said now was one Haruka knew .

'I just remembered something I have to do . Please excuse me . '

She had to tell Yakumo as soon as she could .

Urged on by that impulse, Haruka made a bow at Takaoka and ran down the corridor .

After turning the first corner, she suddenly spotted Yakumo .

'Where are you going in such a hurry?' said Yakumo with a yawn .

'Ah!'

People can't stop suddenly . Haruka almost fell as she screeched to a halt and had to take a few steps back .

'I heard most of the story . '

What kind of monster ears did he have? But if he had heard, that was easier .

'The boyfriend of the person named Yuri was Aizawa-san . '

'I said that I heard . '

Then be more surprised! Haruka bit down the urge to yell .

'Aizawa Tetsurou-san is the one who introduced me to you . Isn't that too suspicious to be just a coincidence?'

'You're a hundred times more suspicious . '

Yakumo started walking briskly, seeming completely uninterested .

Really, what a man!

6

Yakumo led Haruka to a prefabricated building in behind the main school building .

It was used as the janitors' room .

Why had they come here? No matter how Haruka asked, Yakumo didn't answer .

'Hello . '

Yakumo spoke up at the entrance .

When there was no response, Yakumo opened the door and went inside the room .

'Hey . Is it OK just to go in?'

Haruka couldn't bring herself to go in and peered into the room from behind Yakumo .

Right past the entrance, there was a long table and folding chairs . In the back, there was a refrigerator and a sink . There were tools like shovels and sickles against the wall .

'Hey, isn't this bad?'

Haruka called out to Yakumo's back, but she was ignored .

Haruka had just let out a sigh when a person appeared from the door in the back of the room .

'Eek!'

Haruka leapt instinctively .

'W-w-what are you d-d-doing?'

A middle-aged man in a grey uniform came in .

He had a thin face with deep wrinkles . The tip of his nose and his cheeks were red . His skin was dark . He looked like a stereotypical alcoholic .

Though Haruka didn't know his name, she'd seen him around campus a number of times before .

This man, who was a caretaker for this university, always dragged his left leg as he walked .

Haruka didn't know if it was true, but there was a rumour that a female student had almost been molested by him .

It put Haruka a bit on guard .

'I'm sorry for coming so suddenly . Actually, I was wondering if I could borrow the key to the deserted building in the back . '

Even though they had been found trespassing, Yakumo spoke calmly .

'W-w-what do you want to g-g-go to that place for?'

The man's voice was piercing, like a cicada's .

'Actually, my friends went to that building earlier for a test of courage . '

'Test of courage?'

'Yes . It seems like they dropped something important to them then, so I want to go look for it . '

Yakumo kept speaking at random, like he had thought this up in advance .

The caretaker didn't seem to doubt Yakumo's lie, but there was a wrinkle between his thick eyebrows – he looked obviously exasperated .

'Please, Yamane-san . '

Yakumo bowed his head .

The caretaker was called Yamane? It was the first Haruka had heard of it .

Yamane slowly dragged his foot over to the key box on the wall and took a key out, throwing it at Yakumo .

'Y-y-you don't have to return the key today . I'm going home . '

'Thank you very much . '

'D-d-don't do something as s-stupid as a test of courage again . '

'So they do appear?'

Yakumo pretended to be a ghost .

'T-that isn't it... The b-building is old . It'll be taken down n-next month...'

'I see . I understand . '

Yakumo was about to leave when he stopped and turned to look at Yamane .

'Excuse me, but is there a dial-type padlock there?'

'I-I-I don't know . I've never had anything to do at t-that place, so I've n-never gone in . '

Yakumo bowed once more and left .

'Hey, why did you know that caretaker's name?' asked Haruka .

'His name was sewn on his uniform . What on earth were you looking at?'

I see –

* * *

When Haruka stood in front of the deserted building, the sun had already set .

There was just a faint blue at the line of mountains in the distance –

It was quiet . The sound of the wind rustling the tree branches sounded unnecessarily loud .

With the creepiness of the building, the fact that Yuuichi was died felt heavier in Haruka's chest .

If she didn't focus, her legs would collapse underneath her .

Even though this was for a friend, she had stuck her neck into something unbelievable . She was regretting her decision .

She glanced at Yakumo beside her .

He didn't look disturbed . He yawned and wiped away the tears that appeared in his eyes with his arm .

'Come save me if I need help . '

Though he was a slippery man, there was nobody else she could depend on .

'I'll try, but I can't guarantee it . '

It was like a politician's reply .

'I was an idiot for asking . '

The biggest mistake was involving herself with this man named Saitou Yakumo . She felt that way .

'Are you afraid?'

'Not really . I'm fine . '

Haruka tried to act strong when Yakumo said that, but if she didn't focus on her throat, her voice would tremble .

'Then, shall we go?'

Yakumo stood in front of the door and stuck the key he'd borrowed into the keyhole .

However, there was no point . The door opened before he turned the key .

The two silently pushed open the door and stepped inside .

They lit up the room with a torch .

Leaves from outside were scattered on the floor .

Every time they stepped on them, there was a crunching sound .

They went down the corridor to the back of the room .

The air was thick and cloudy . It made it hard to breathe .

Yakumo used the torch to light the rooms on the left and right while looking around .

Each room appeared to be fashioned in the same way . Square rooms with one bed, one window . Perhaps this had been used as a student dormitory .

Haruka gripped Yakumo's shirt sleeve so that she wouldn't be separated from him in the dark . She walked carefully .

– When Yakumo suddenly stopped .

'Your friend saw a ghost in the locked room at the end of this corridor, right?'

'Yes . '

'There was a dial-type padlock so they couldn't get in . '

'This was something that was told to me, so I'm not sure, but...'

'This . '

Yakumo stooped over and took something in his hand .

There was the sound like change being rubbed together .

'What's that?'

Yakumo lit it with the torch so that Haruka would also be able to understand .

Haruka saw chains that hung to the ground and a dial-type lock .

'It doesn't look like it's been cut . The numbers <7483> match...
Somebody's opened it .

Haruka looked at Yakumo's face, unable to understand .

'The locked room has been unlocked – '

Yakumo put the chains at his feet and put a hand on the door in front of him .

A chill ran down Haruka's spine . Yuuichi had said that something was in this room .

'Please wait . '

She spoke without thinking .

Before Haruka's inhibitions reached Yakumo's ear, there was a rusty metal sound and the door opened –

Haruka went stiff from fear, but nothing happened .

There was a deep darkness that made her wonder if her eyes were closed .

Yakumo used the torch to light up the room .

The room looked the same as the others . There was just one bed, nothing else .

However, something felt different .

A smell like something had gone bad pierced her nose .

'It's a bit creepy,' said Haruka, looking into the room from behind Yakumo's back .

'It's the window . '

'Window?'

With the light of the torch, Haruka looked around the room .

It was just as Yakumo said . Though the other rooms had had windows, though small, there wasn't one in this room .

Yakumo slowly walked into the room .

Haruka followed him, as if led in .

That moment, the air suddenly felt heavier, like she was underwater .

Yakumo silently looked around .

It didn't look like there was anything in particular in the room to Haruka .

'Is there something here?' asked Haruka, gripping Yakumo's sleeve tightly .

'Nothing . But there should be . '

'If you find out what that is, will you be able to save Miki?'

'I don't know, but it's possible . The spirit that has possessed your friend is afraid of something in this room . '

Yakumo knelt on the concrete and looked around diligently .

Haruka crouched too, but she couldn't find anything .

'Is it this...'

Yakumo suddenly murmured that .

'Eh? What?'

'Look here . '

Yakumo lit up the foot of the bed with the torch .

Haruka stared, but she couldn't understand .

'What is it?'

'Here . '

Yakumo pointed at a part of the floor .

It looked like something had been dragged . The bed had probably been moved .

But –

'What about it?'

'Why was only this bed moved?' murmured Yakumo, as he tried to peer underneath the bed .

And then...

<Watch out! Behind you!>

Suddenly, Haruka heard a girl's scream .

Haruka turned around in shock .

A person was standing there . She couldn't tell what gender they were in the dark, let alone what their face looked like .

She could just tell that they had something like a rod in their hand .

They were waving it around . It was a shovel . It came down towards Haruka's head .

Frozen by fear, Haruka couldn't move .

Thunk!

Haruka heard something that sounded like a large rock hitting the ground .

The strength in her body escaped her . She fell . It didn't hurt .

'Ugh...'

Haruka heard a groan and opened her eyes .

'!'

Yakumo was collapsed in front of her .

He was bracing his legs as he tried to get up . It looked like his body wouldn't move the way he wanted it to, as he stayed on his arms and legs .

Did he protect me? That was all Haruka could think in her confusion .

'A-are you OK...'

'Ru... Run...'

Yakumo said that in a hoarse voice while pressing a hand against his forehead . Even if he told her to run, she couldn't just leave him here .

'... It's fine! Just run!' yelled Yakumo .

Haruka stood up instinctively .

'But...'

'It's fine – just go!'

Pressured by Yakumo's insistence, Haruka ran towards the door .

However, a dark shadow was waiting there .

Something hit her shoulder with a thump, thrusting her to the back of the room .

The dark shadow slowly approached her .

Even if she wanted to run, her back was pressed against the wall . She couldn't go back any farther .

The shadow picked up the shovel again .

All Haruka could do was grip her fists in front of her chest .

It's too late –

Then, something suddenly hit that shadow .

The two shadows seemed to be fighting, and then they collapsed .

There was the sound of something hitting something else multiple times .

All Haruka could do was watch .

Suddenly, one of the shadows stood up .

'We're running!'

She heard a voice . It was Yakumo .

He was OK .

<Down . >

There was a girl's voice again . In contrast to Haruka, who didn't understand, Yakumo quickly responded .

Yakumo took Haruka's head and forced them both to the ground .

There was a whizzing sound as the shovel went straight over her head .

It hit the wall and let off sparks .

Haruka was still bewildered as Yakumo grabbed her arm and ran out of the room .

'Aahhh!'

There was a howl as the shadow came after them, waving a shovel .
Yakumo slammed the door shut with his body . There was a dull thump .

Yakumo took the chains on the floor and wrapped them around the door right away .

Rattle, rattle .

Thump, thump .

It appeared that the shadow was trying to get out from the other side, turning the doorknob and hitting the door .

Suddenly, the sound stopped . Did they give up? Haruka had just thought that when –

Bang!

There was an incredible noise .

It seemed like they were smashing their body against the door from inside .

Haruka's body shook in shock . There was a slight gap between the door in the wall . Then, a gloved hand wormed its way out .

Yakumo grabbed Haruka's arm again and pulled her along .

Haruka couldn't even scream .

'We're going!'

Dragged along by Yakumo, Haruka started running .

Tree branches hit Haruka's cheeks and arms .

Strangely, it didn't hurt . She just ran deliriously, with Yakumo pulling her arm –

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She couldn't remember where or why she was running .

When she noticed, Haruka was at Yakumo's secret hideaway, the Movie Research Circle room .

Sitting on the floor, it hurt just to breathe .

Sweat fell from her forehead .

Her heart was breathing quickly and furiously within her chest .

'It hurts...' said Yakumo, pressing his forehead .

'You OK?'

Haruka remembered that Yakumo had been hit with a shovel earlier and hurriedly spoke to him .

'Yeah . '

Though Yakumo nodded, he was gritting his teeth with a frown on his face .

'Please show it to me . '

Haruka went around to Yakumo's front and looked at his face .

Yakumo lifted the hand he was using to press his forehead .

A bit above his right eyebrow, there was a cut three centimetres long .

The flesh looked like it had been turned inside out . Though the bleeding had stopped, it wasn't a shallow cut .

Haruka took out her handkerchief and put it to Yakumo's injury .

'It's fine . I'll do it myself . '

Yakumo took the handkerchief from Haruka and pressed it against the wound himself .

Then, a large teardrop rolled down Haruka's cheek .

Eh? Why is there a tear —

When she realised it, it made it harder to stop .

Why? Why am I crying?

'Was it frightening?'

Yakumo's palm gently touched Haruka's shoulder .

It was very warm –

The tension within her lessened at once .

That's right . I was frightened .

I'd really thought I would die when that shadow stood in front of me with the shovel .

I've never been so afraid before . But Yakumo saved me and I'm still alive
–

Haruka nodded . Led by her impulses, she gripped Yakumo's shirt sleeve and started to cry loudly .

Yakumo just waited silently for Haruka to stop crying .

Haruka had never cried like this in front of somebody before .

Ever since her sister died, she had decided not to cry . However, this was the second time she'd cried in front of Yakumo .

In front of this unfriendly and contrary person, for some reason, her heart weakened . That was baffling to Haruka .

'Sorry...'

After crying for a while, Haruka said that and wiped her tears with her palm .

Yakumo didn't say anything . That just made her more embarrassed .

'Show me your injury again . '

Haruka forcefully took the handkerchief from Yakumo when he refused and looked at the cut on his forehead .

The bleeding had stopped completely .

'You should have it properly checked at a hospital . '

'It's fine,' said Yakumo in his usual curt tone .

'What do you mean, it's fine? Think of the place – what will you do if some strange symptom occurs?'

'You're so meddlesome...'

He always said one thing too many . That one sentence of his ruined everything .

'You know, you're...'

Haruka started speaking, but when she saw Yakumo's left eye, she was lost for words .

Illuminated by the fluorescent light, Yakumo's left eye glowed red like a blazing flame .

It was a deep red, more vivid than any she'd seen before .

'I was born with it...' said Yakumo in an annoyed tone, perhaps noticing Haruka's gaze .

'It's beautiful...'

'Hah?'

'The eye is beautiful . '

For a while, Yakumo looked puzzled, but he finally started laughing quietly .

That laughter became louder, until he was finally laughing while clutching his stomach .

What was so funny –

'Hey, why are you laughing?'

Haruka hit Yakumo's shoulder .

'I mean... That's amazing . Beautiful? There's something wrong with your senses . '

'What?'

Yakumo took deep breaths to calm his laughter before continuing .

'I thought you'd scream . Or look like you saw something disgusting, or with pity...'

'Why would I scream? Nobody would scream after seeing something beautiful, right?'

'That's why I said there's something wrong with your senses . All the people who have seen my eye up until now have first screamed or acted like it was disgusting . Sometimes, there are people who'll look at it with pity . You're the first who's done something as ridiculous as call it beautiful . '

Ridiculous – what an awful way of saying it .

After a few more breaths, Yakumo continued .

'I dropped my contact lens when I was hit earlier . '

'Contact lens?'

'Normally, I hide it with a contact lens . There are the ones you can change your eye colour with . '

'You said you were born with it earlier...'

'That's right . It's been red since I was born . And it seems like I was born with just my left eye open . I heard that even my mother screamed when she saw my red eye . Funny, right?'

It wasn't funny at all . Being thought of as disgusting by his mother – how deep an injury must that have left on his heart?

Haruka couldn't even imagine .

'Though I don't know if it's because of that eye, my left eye can see things other people can't . '

'Things other people can't?'

'That's right . I said it before, but I can see the spirits of the dead . It took some time for me to realise only I could see them . I was treated differently for it . Nobody believes me when I say I really can see them . '

That made sense . Haruka hadn't believed it either .

She slightly understood why Yakumo took such a contrary attitude .

Nobody had faced him properly before .

Fright, fascination, pity – the people that connected with Yakumo had had that as a pretext . Even his mother –

She wanted at least to face Yakumo properly herself, without sympathy .

That feeling bloomed within Haruka .

'It hurts . '

Yakumo spoke up again .

It looked like the pain came in spurts .

He got that injury because of me . I haven't thanked Yakumo yet for saving me .

'Thank you for saving me earlier . '

'Thank your sister . '

'My sister?'

Haruka cocked her head, unable to understand what Yakumo meant .

'At the time, your sister told me there was danger . If she hadn't, your brains would currently be spilt out on that room's floor . '

Haruka had heard a girl call out <Watch out> then too .

'That voice was my sister?'

'It was . She's always behind you . She's watching over you . '

'Really?'

Haruka looked around, but she couldn't see anything .

'It's your choice whether to believe me or not . '

'Sis...'

She might not have believed Yakumo's words up until yesterday .

However, it was different now .

What feelings does my sister have while watching over me? How does she feel, and what does she think?

'If only I could see her too . I'm jealous...'

Haruka's eyes were teary again .

The next day, Haruka went to Yakumo's secret hiding place in the afternoon .

It wasn't locked .

It was incredibly careless what with what had happened last night .

Haruka opened the door and Yakumo was right in front of her, curled up in a sleeping bag . Just like a caterpillar . Haruka poked him lightly with her toe, and he opened his eyes, seeming annoyed .

'It's past noon already . '

Yakumo slowly got up, rubbing his eyes .

'It amazes me that you can live in a place like this . '

Haruka sat on a folding chair and waited for Yakumo to dress himself .

'I go back sometimes . '

'You have a home?'

Without answering, Yakumo took a toothbrush out of the refrigerator and started brushing his teeth .

Why the fridge?

'If you have a home, why not just go back? Your parents must be worried . '

'Worried? They're not . '

Yakumo mumbled a reply while brushing his teeth .

He was talking just like a rebellious teenager .

'How can you say something so selfish? Why not think a bit about your parents' feelings?'

Yakumo nonchalantly gargled like he wasn't interested in what Haruka had to say .

'Hey, are you listening?'

'Things I don't want to hear don't enter my ears . '

Yakumo wiped his forehead with a towel as he sat down on the chair opposite Haruka .

'Respond if you can hear me . '

'If they were worried, they wouldn't try to kill me, right?'

'Eh?'

'I'm talking about my parents . '

'?'

That was just more confusing .

'My red left eye . It can see things people can't . Maybe she was frightened? Or she hated it? I don't know, but one day, my mother took me out for a car ride . '

Yakumo continued to speak in a disinterested tone .

'She kept saying "Sorry" as she put her hands on my neck . She kept putting more force into it, so I became faint...'

Yakumo was talking about a tragedy that was beyond Haruka's imagination as if it were something that happened to somebody else .

'A police officer who just happened to be passing by saved me . My mother ran away . She's been missing since . I have no memories of my father . '

'That's...'

Haruka tried to say something, but she couldn't speak .

Haruka often heard stories like Yakumo's on the news or in dramas, but she had thought of them as something from a world completely different from hers...

'I'm saying that in this world, there are parents that don't love their children and children who don't love their parents . '

When Yakumo finished speaking, he let out a yawn, raking his fingers through his hair .

Behind that attitude of his that wouldn't let anybody in, there was an immeasurably large wound –

'I'm staying at my uncle's now . '

'Oh?'

'Though my uncle tells me not to hold back, I can't cause him that much trouble, and there are circumstances . '

Yakumo had already put the contact lens in his left eye, so it was black .

'I...'

Haruka lowered her long eyelashes and bit her lip .

I said something without knowing the whole situation . I feel so ashamed .

'Don't worry about it,' said Yakumo, as if he'd sensed how Haruka was feeling .

'I'm sorry . '

Haruka bowed her head .

'Why are you apologising?'

'Because...'

'You didn't run even after seeing my eye . That's enough . '

Though Yakumo said that himself, he seemed to find the words that came out of his mouth unexpected as his face scrunched up like he had eaten something strange .

Haruka laughed a bit upon seeing that .

Yakumo glared at her . Haruka hurriedly covered her mouth and stopped laughing .

'I've found out one thing from yesterday . '

Yakumo quickly changed the topic . Perhaps he'd felt very awkward .

'What?'

'That shadow that assaulted me . It was definitely a living human being . '

'How can you be sure?'

'My eyes are convenient . My right eye can only see the physical . My left eye can only see the spirits of the dead,' aid Yakumo, his index finger on his brow .

'So you could see the shadow that attacked you yesterday with your right eye but not your left?'

'Exactly . I'm also concerned about how the locked room was unlocked yesterday . '

'But who could've done it?'

'Who knows? There are many candidates . '

'The caretaker, Yamane-san . '

That face came up in her head first thing .

'It's possible . He knew we were going to that abandoned building, and with the key, he could go in and out all he wanted . '

'Aizawa-san might be related too . '

'Aizawa?'

Yakumo cocked his head .

'Remember? Professor Takaoka said this yesterday . He was Yuri-san's boyfriend . He introduced me to you, Saitou-san . '

'It's not impossible,' said Yakumo, crossing his arms and looking up at the ceiling .

'That's quite negative . '

'That isn't it, but something feels off . '

'Then let's go ask him directly . And I think it'd be good to talk to Professor Takaoka once more...'

'If you want to investigate, go,' said Yakumo, interrupting Haruka .

'Do you mean I should go myself?'

'Call it splitting up the work . There are a number of other things I'm concerned about, so I'll be investigating those . '

That would be more effective .

In the end, Yakumo and Haruka agreed to meet again in the evening and went separate ways .

Haruka had to make three promises to Yakumo for acting alone .

Don't go to places with few people .

Ask in a roundabout way when questioning people .

Contact him immediately once she found something out .

He also instructed her to be very careful, since there was what happened yesterday, though she probably wouldn't be attacked in the middle of the day .

* * *

After walking around for a while, Haruka found Aizawa in the cafeteria .

It seemed like he'd skipped out in the middle of class . He was reading an employment magazine while drinking a can of coffee .

There were a lot of people here, so it was probably OK .

'Aizawa-san . '

Haruka called out to him and sat in the opposite seat . Aizawa looked up and gave her a friendly smile .

He was short and plump – cute, like a stuffed animal .

Haruka put Yuri and Aizawa together in her mind, but she felt like they didn't quite fit .

'How is it? Found out something?'

Haruka shook her head .

Rather than finding anything out, she felt even more confused .

'But it must be tough for you, Ozawa . That Saitou Yakumo's quite odd, right?'

'Yes, definitely . That reminds me, he said that he didn't know you, Aizawa-san . '

Aizawa laughed aloud .

'Of course . I must have been just like scenery to him . I just went with a friend once to see him guess the number on cards . '

That was a trick . Haruka wanted to say that, but she stopped herself .

But still .

'Please tell me that from the beginning . '

'But you looked troubled, and I didn't say I was his friend, right?'

It was true that she'd consulted her friend from the circle and Aizawa had just happened to be there and told her to talk to Saitou Yakumo .

Come to think about it, he'd never said that they were acquainted .

'Well, that's so...'

'Seems tough, but hang in there . '

Aizawa made a move to stand up .

'Ah, please wait . '

Haruka hurriedly called out to stop Aizawa .

'What is it?'

Aizawa sat down again .

Ask in a roundabout way –

Haruka recalled Yakumo's warning, but she didn't know how to bring up the topic and ended up asking the question straight .

'Aizawa-san, do you know someone called Shinohara Yuri?'

'Shinohara Yuri – '

The moment Aizawa heard that name, his cheek twitched – he looked clearly displeased .

There was something in that response . Haruka continued without any hesitation .

'I heard that you dated Shinohara-san, Aizawa-san . '

'We didn't date . '

'Eh? But...'

Aizawa clicked her tongue .

'I don't know who you heard it from, but we didn't date . '

'Is that so?'

'I just confessed to Shinohara and was rejected . And does that have something to do with this?'

Aizawa was tapping his foot underneath the table .

'Is that really true?'

'There's no way I'd lie about getting rejected . '

That was true .

The conversation stopped there .

'I'm going . '

Haruka couldn't say anything . She just watched Aizawa leave .

Yakumo was in the reference room .

He moved the sliding bookcases and looked at the neatly lined up files .

He found what he was looking for immediately . As-built plans for the student dormitories .

Yakumo took the document on the very top of the bookcase out . It was considerably old . It was yellowed and smelt of mildew .

It said it was built in Showa 30[2]

Yakumo moved to the table and flipped through the pages .

The information was detailed, with a line map of the area and a rendering .

After about ten pages, Yakumo found building floor plans .

There were two floor plans . One was the first floor of the abandoned building . The other was for the basement –

Yakumo looked at the floor plan carefully, following it with his finger .

He found it . The locked room had a door that went to the basement .

Yakumo took the key he had borrowed from Yamane yesterday out of his pocket .

There were three keys on the key holder .

One was the entrance door key . One was the room master key .

The last was the basement key .

The reason only the bed of the locked room had been in a different place was probably to hide the door to the basement . There had to be something there .

Taking care not to stand out, Yakumo left the campus and went into the forest .

It took more time than he expected to walk through the pathless forest .

Fallen leaves filled his shoes .

He might have been a bit naive . His regret grew the more his forehead sweated .

He silently walked along, brushing aside the tree branches .

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Haruka looked at the clock – it was just past three .

There was about an hour before she had to meet up with Yakumo .

She couldn't question Aizawa more . Haruka didn't have anything in particular to do, so she just whiled away time in the cafeteria .

She laid her head on the table and sighed .

Did Yakumo find something out?

It would annoy her if she were the only one who had found out nothing .

'Haruka-kun . '

Haruka lifted her head when somebody called her .

It was Takaoka . His eyes were bloodshot – he looked more exhausted than yesterday .

'Professor, there's something I want to ask . '

This was a good chance . She could ask about Yuri again .

'Something you want to ask?'

Though Takaoka cocked his head, he sat opposite her at the table .

'Er, about Shinohara Yuri-san, who you talked about yesterday...'

She didn't know if he would believe all the strange things that had happened to her, like Miki's state after the test of courage and the attack at the abandoned building . She just wanted more information, even if it was just a little .

Just, if he thought of something upon hearing her story –

Takaoka covered his face with both hands and shook his head .

'I'm sorry for saying something strange . '

'No, don't worry about it . But I remembered something important upon hearing what you said,' said Takaoka, lifting his head .

'Eh? Really?'

'But talking here might not be a good idea . Let's go somewhere else . '

Takaoka spoke in a lowered tone .

Haruka agreed to his suggestion and stood up from her seat .

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Yakumo reached the abandoned building and put his hand on the doorknob .

It was locked .

Somebody had locked it after what happened yesterday .

Probably the person who had attacked them –

Yakumo unlocked the door and stepped inside .

The light from the window made it easier to see than yesterday .

He headed down the corridor to the locked room at the end .

Here too –

The chains were wrapped around and the dial-type lock was on . Yakumo put the numbers <7483> on the dial .

The numbers that had been there yesterday .

There was a click and the lock came off .

He took the chains from the handle, unlocked the door and carefully stepped inside .

Partially because there was no window, this room alone was impossible to see clearly in without the light of his torch, even though it was day .

He dragged the bed in the corner of the room with all his force .

Just as he expected, underneath the door, there was a one-metre square of metal floor .

To be more accurate, it was a door . There was a handle .

It was shut with a padlock with a keyhole .

Yakumo put the third key in – it fit perfectly . He gripped the handle and pulled it up with all his strength .

There was the sound of creaking metal as dust flew up .

A square hole appeared, completely black .

He used his torch to peer inside, but he could see virtually nothing .

Yakumo decided to climb down the wooden ladder .

The wood creaked underneath his foot .

It was too late when he realised .

His foot slipped and he fell to the basement all at once .

His face twisted from pain after he hit the floor, but he forgot that immediately when a strong rotten smell assaulted him . He bent back and hurriedly covered his nose and mouth .

To look for the source of the smell, Yakumo picked up the torch he had dropped and illuminated different areas of the room .

He saw something like a black line on the wall .

He slowly approached the wall and focussed –

'What is this...'

Yakumo spoke aloud without thinking .

It was a scratch in the wall .

Not just in one or two places . The whole wall was covered in scratches .

And these scratches weren't natural or from a machine .

Yakumo put his hand up to it .

From the size, it was probably human .

Somebody had clawed the wall with their fingernails .

Some of the scratches had dark red stains on them .

Somebody had probably scratched the walls again and again to try to escape, even though they knew it was useless .

He found a detached fingernail stuck to the wall .

There was blood and even part of the flesh of the finger, but still the scratches continued .

Yakumo touched the scratch lightly with his finger .

'This is a real locked room...'

Yakumo suddenly felt something cold on his neck .

Yakumo looked up with his torch and saw two pipes on the ceiling .

Probably water pipes . Water was dripping from the place where they connected .

The woman who had been in here had probably lived here for a number of days with that water .

If she hadn't had those pipes, the time she suffered might have been slightly shorter .

This water had given her hope and pain .

She hadn't been frightened of something in this room – she had been trying to escape from the room itself .

The question was who had kept her in here, and for what reason –

12

After Yakumo crawled out of the basement, he quickly went down the corridor out of the abandoned building .

The cold wind made him feel revived .

He knew that Yuri had been stuck in that place, but he had no decisive evidence .

A corpse –

The person who had locked Yuri in there had probably moved it .

'W-w-what are you doing here?'

Somebody called out from behind him . For a moment, Yakumo stopped thinking . He knew that husky voice .

It was the caretaker, Yamane, who had a key and could go in and out of the abandoned building whenever he wanted .

Yamane's face was red from alcohol as usual, and he had a towel around his neck . He was holding a rusty shovel .

'Y-y-you're looking for this, right?'

Yamane took a digital camera from the pocket of his work pants and handed it to Yakumo .

'I-i-it was on the ground there . '

Yamane pointed at the forest about ten metres away .

Yakumo thanked him and took it .

This was probably the camera Yuuichi had used to take photos .

There was still battery left .

Yakumo turned on the camera and looked at the pictures on the camera monitor .

It was probably from some bar . There were a number of people drinking in a lively manner .

After about ten photos, a photo of the abandoned building came up .

First, there was Yuuichi . Then, there was Kazuhiko and Miki . Next was a close-up of Miki's frightened profile .

Then, in the back, there was a man in the back, hiding behind the corner of the room . He was dragging something .

It was too dark to see properly, but it was probably Yuri's corpse –

'What is this...'

Yakumo's expression froze over . Then, he ran as quickly as he could .

Yamane yelled something from behind him, but Yakumo didn't have the time to pay attention to that .

As Yakumo ran, he called Haruka's mobile .

However, the call tone just kept going –

'Where'd she go?' muttered Yakumo as he kicked the ground .

<This way . >

A girl's voice came from somewhere –

13

Haruka was led to the rooftop of Building B by Takaoka .

They stood in front of the water tower right by the roof entrance .

The concrete roof had no fence – just a ledge about thirty centimetres tall .

The view was good, but when she looked down, her legs shook .

Why did he bring me here?

Haruka had that question as she looked at Takaoka .

'Where should I start – ' said Takaoka, looking at the reddish purple clouds, which were lit up by the setting sun .

'Wherever is fine,' Haruka replied .

'I lied to you about one thing . '

'Lied?'

Haruka brushed her hair behind her ear .

For some reason, she couldn't calm down .

'About how Aizawa-kun was dating Yuri . That was a lie,' said Takaoka with a blank expression .

Haruka had a really bad feeling .

Her heart was beating more quickly .

'Why would you make that up...'

At Haruka's question, Takaoka's thin lips twisted into a smile that showed his white teeth .

However, his eyes weren't smiling . They were cold eyes .

'That was a failure . I didn't think I'd hear Yuri's name from your mouth . It was so sudden that I tried to turn the conversation around, but that was no good...'

Takaoka's voice sounded faraway .

It was difficult to breathe .

Her ears were ringing . Run . Her instincts were telling her that, but her feet didn't move .

'Professor . Could it be that you and Yuri-san...'

'That's right . I committed adultery with Yuri .

'Professor... did you kill her?'

Haruka was hoping for a denial rather than affirmation from Takaoka .

'That's not quite it...'

Takaoka grabbed Haruka's arm .

Haruka's body froze in resistance, but she couldn't win in strength .

When Haruka tried to bite Takaoka's arm, Takaoka's fist hit the back of her head .

Haruka's head shook, and she fell to her knees .

'Sorry, but you're going to have to die . You're going to jump off the roof – a suicide . Like with Ichihashi-kun . '

Takaoka grabbed Haruka's hair and dragged her to the edge of the roof .

No –

Haruka frantically tried to resist, but she couldn't move properly from the pain .

'That was an accident . On that day, she said that she was pregnant . That she was going to tell my wife everything . That was against the rules . You have to obey the rules . Don't you think so too?'

Takaoka's words just sounded like an excuse to justify what he'd done .

'But killing her for that...'

Even while bearing with the pain, Haruka glared at Takaoka in her anger .

'I didn't plan on killing her . We had a fight, and I hit her . Then, she stopped moving...'

'She wasn't dead . '

Haruka suddenly heard a voice . A voice she recognised .

When she turned around to look, Yakumo was there .

There was sweat on his forehead . His shoulders were shaking .

'What are you talking about?'

Takaoka's face muscles twitched at Yakumo's sudden appearance, but he played dumb .

Yakumo sighed and ran a hand through his messy hair before starting his explanation, though he seemed to find it troublesome .

'You must have noticed . In that basement, there are signs that she tried to escape . '

Takaoka made no response . He just looked away, his cheek twitching .

Yakumo took one step closer to approach Takaoka and continue speaking .

'You probably thought that you had killed her when you saw that she had stopped moving, and you abandoned her in that basement . However, she had just fainted...'

There, Yakumo took a breath and looked at Takaoka with a piercing gaze .

'You shut a living person in that room . '

'What proof do you have for your lie...'

'Don't play dumb . '

Yakumo's voice was full of anger .

'You saw them, didn't you? The basement's walls . '

'I don't know what you're talking about . '

'The countless scratches . She made them in her frantic attempt to escape . A dead person wouldn't be able to do that . '

Takaoka's shoulders heaved as he spoke . His eyes were darting about .

'You were also the person who killed the student named Ichihashi Yuuichi .
,

Yakumo continued to pursue the wounded Takaoka .

'What proof do you...'

'I have proof . I should have noticed earlier . At the station, you said that a student called Ichihashi had jumped – correct?'

'What's strange about that?'

'How could you be sure he jumped? The police said there was no note and called it an accident . '

'That's – '

'Unless you witnessed his death, there was no way for you to declare that at that stage . You wanted to make it seem like he jumped in front of the train and committed suicide, right?'

'There's no reason I would kill him,' said Takaoka in a shaking voice .

Haruka didn't know that reason either .

Though she could understand the reason Professor Takaoka might kill Yuri-san, Yuuichi-kun was unrelated .

Yakumo's thin lips turned up in a faint smile as he continued to speak .

'After you shut Yuri-san in that basement, you had peace of mind . However, when you heard that that abandoned building was going to be torn down, you panicked . If her corpse was found, everything would be exposed . So you went back to move the corpse . Then...'

'He met Miki and the others,' finished Haruka .

Everything was connected .

Yakumo nodded before continuing .

'You coincidentally ran into the group of three that had come for a test of courage, and you tried to hide . However, they took photos at that building . Without knowing that you were there – '

Yakumo's eyes narrowed as he looked at Takaoka .

Takaoka's body turned stiff, as if frozen by that gaze .

'I don't know what you're talking about . '

'I have proof . '

'Proof?'

Yakumo took a digital camera out of his pocket .

'You want this, right?'

After Yakumo said that, he threw the digital camera towards Takaoka .

Takaoka grabbed it with both hands . At the same time, the hand that had been holding Haruka let go .

Haruka used that chance to run up to Yakumo .

Takaoka looked at Yakumo angrily .

'Finding out that much is admirable, but if I destroy the proof, how will you prove it?'

Takaoka was acting tough, but he was standing on a cliff .

'I forgot to say one thing . '

After saying that, Yakumo took a digital camera memory card out of his pocket and showed it to Takaoka .

'The image data is here . '

Laughter escaped Takaoka's lips .

It might have been pointed towards his foolish self, for trying to hide his own crime .

'This is the end . The police have been called already . '

Takaoka turned pale – everything he had built up collapsed at once .

His laughter finally turned into tears –

'That's right... It's the end...' said Takaoka in a hoarse voice, sitting on the concrete like his soul had left him .

Haruka heard the sound of sirens in the distance .

It echoed in her ears like a cry –

14

Yakumo and Haruka were questioned by the police as witnesses .

Yakumo spoke for most of the time, with Haruka just nodding .

They gave the summary of the events . Neither Yakumo nor Haruka mentioned the spirit possessing Miki . Nobody would believe them if they did .

Haruka heard about this after, but Yuri's corpse was found buried at the root of a tree only ten metres from the abandoned building .

Everything seemed so ill-prepared .

Another thing was that she wasn't pregnant . Her strategy for love had caused a misunderstanding, and in the end, two people had lost their lives . It was awful –

'Hey . Well done . '

After the questioning, Haruka was about to leave with Yakumo when a man in a suit called out to them .

He had a huge frame, like a bear, and wore a loose tie with a wrinkled shirt . The man had stubble on his face and a sleepy expression like Yakumo's .

'What, if it isn't Gotou-san,' said Yakumo, sounding displeased as he ran a hand through his hair .

'Don't just say "What"! You should be grateful to me . '

The man called Gotou suddenly let out a loud voice .

Yakumo frowned and stuck his fingers in his ears .

'You've put me through a lot of trouble . Please don't complain so much just because I made one request . It's childish . '

'You...'

Gotou started speaking, but his eyes suddenly went wide when he spotted Haruka .

W-what?'

Haruka's shoulders hunched up unconsciously under that pressure .

'Hmm,' murmured Gotou, rubbing his chin like he'd understood something .

Haruka didn't know how to respond, so she quickly put a smile on her face and nodded .

'She's pretty cute, isn't she?' said Gotou with a smirk .

'What are you talking about?'

Yakumo looked displeased, the complete opposite of Gotou .

'So you're that age too, eh, Yakumo? And she's cute . '

'That isn't it . '

'If you say cold things like that, she'll get away . '

'Like your wife, Gotou-san?'

'Shut up! I don't need to hear that from you!' said Gotou with a click of his tongue .

'If you have the time to worry about other people, please do your work for once . If the police had looked into this properly in the first place, I wouldn't have been involved in this . '

Yakumo's opinion made sense .

'Don't say that . The police haven't got enough hands either . Girls of that age often disappear . If we had to look into all those cases, there wouldn't ever be enough people . '

'I'm glad you seem busy . '

'Well, anyway, it was tough . I'll make the story fit with the paperwork . '

Gotou hit Yakumo's shoulder lightly and walked with a bowlegged gait .

'Hey, who was that just now?' asked Haruka after she couldn't see Gotou any longer .

'Even though he's like that, he's a detective,' said Yakumo, pointing at the direction Gotou had gone with his chin .

'Oh, you know a detective?'

'Rather than know, it's more that I can't avoid him . '

'Can't avoid?'

'He's the one who saved me right before my mother almost killed me . A number of things have happened since . '

'A number? Does he look out for you?'

'That isn't it . To me, there are two types of people in this world . People who see my red left eye as a monstrosity, and those who try to use it . Gotou-san is one of the latter . '

Haruka couldn't understand what Yakumo said .

Could you divide everyone into just two types? The relationships between people should have been more complicated and meaningful than that .

However, Haruka didn't know how to explain that, so she kept her mouth shut –

'Now that I've said that though, there's one strange person who's an exception . '

Yakumo said just that and walked away briskly .

'Hey, by strange person, you don't mean me, right?'

Haruka hurriedly ran after Yakumo .

15

A few days afterwards, Haruka went to Yakumo's secret hideaway again .

Miki became much better after that .

She appeared to have forgotten everything that happened after losing consciousness at the abandoned building .

Kazuhiko, who had gone missing, returned to the university like nothing had happened . When Haruka asked him about it, it turned out he'd returned to his parents' home in fear .

Haruka was so exasperated she couldn't even be angry .

At the university, the media came because of the incident – there was quite some fuss .

The news announcers commented that the entrance rates for the next year would probably be the lowest ever, and some students had transferred to other universities, thinking that the incident could have an effect on their job searching .

However, the clamour would probably fade away with time .

Even though it was past noon, Yakumo had his usual bedhead and sleepy eyes .

He was like a cat lazing in the sun .

'No matter when I see you, you always look like you've just woken up . '

'Because you only come when I'm just waking up . '

Yakumo replied bluntly, as usual .

Yakumo's slightly sulky expression was so funny to Haruka that she laughed .

'What do you need today?'

He was clearly telling her to go home if she didn't need anything .

Haruka covered her mouth to stop her laughter and took an envelope out of her bag, placing it on the table .

'What's this?'

'The money, as promised . A lot of things happened, but Miki is better . '

Yakumo pushed the envelope back .

'I don't want it . '

'Why not?'

'I owe your older sister a favour . We're even . '

'A favour?'

Haruka cocked her head, unable to understand .

'Your sister's the one who told me that you were on the roof . '

'Sis...'

She tried to save me –

Thinking that was enough to make her chest feel warm .

'Sorry . '

'?'

'When I first met you, I called you a fraud, Saitou-san...'

'Don't worry about it . '

'But...'

'And stop calling me Saitou-san,' said Yakumo, pointing at Haruka .

'Then what should I call you?'

'I don't mind if you just call me by my name normally . '

Haruka felt like she'd taken a step into his heart .

'I accept that your mysterious power isn't fraud, Yakumo-kun . '

'I'm very grateful . '

Yakumo yawned, like he didn't care .

His actions were just like a cat's .

'I'm jealous of you, Yakumo-kun . '

'Jealous?'

'You can meet my sister, right? I can't meet her even if I want to . I've always wanted to apologise and I have so many things I want to tell her, but I can't see her . . '

Haruka's voice was shaking slightly .

My sister died because of me .

She had carried that burden for thirteen years .

She couldn't put it down even if she wanted to . When she thought about how she would continue carrying it for the rest of her life, she couldn't help but curse her own sin .

'Don't blame yourself like that . I said this before, but your sister doesn't blame you . '

'That's a lie . My sister died because of me...'

'Then just ask her yourself . '

Yakumo took off the contact lens in his left eye and turned towards Haruka with his red eye .

No matter how many times she saw it, it was a beautiful red colour .

It was like it was letting off a light of its own .

'Close your eyes . '

Haruka closed her eyes like Yakumo said .

Her vision went dark –

'Sis . '

Suddenly, her sister was standing in front of her .

She looked just like she had then .

From the accident when she was seven –

'Sis, sorry . At that time... because I threw the ball far away...'

Haruka bit her lip . She forced the words out of her throat .

Ayaka didn't say anything . She just smiled .

That was enough .

Tears fell from Haruka's eyes . She was helpless to stop them .

Ayaka's incredibly warm and gentle smile .

It felt like all her pains were being washed away .

Haruka kept wiping her endless tears and opened her eyes again .

Ayaka had disappeared . Instead, Yakumo was standing there with sleepy eyes .

'Thank you...'

Yakumo looked up at the ceiling, like he hadn't heard anything .

'I've cried in front of you twice now, Yakumo-kun . '

'Three times . '

Yakumo corrected her, putting up his fingers .

'Don't keep track . I'm not crying because I want to . '

Haruka used her handkerchief to wipe her tears and stood up .

'I'm really thankful for all you've done . This is farewell then . '

Yakumo didn't respond to Haruka's words .

He just yawned .

He's not honest at all –

Haruka smiled and put her hand on the doorknob .

Would this really be farewell for her and Yakumo? That thought suddenly came to her head .

'Hey, what should I do if I want to meet my sister again?'

Haruka asked that question, her back still facing Yakumo .

Yakumo didn't respond .

What did I expect? Haruka tried to cover up the words that had unexpectedly come out of her mouth with a laugh .

'Just open that door and come here . '

Haruka hurriedly turned around .

Yakumo was leaning back on his chair with his usual sleepy eyes .

'Eh?'

'I'm saying you can come whenever you want . But I'm taking money next time . '

'I'll be negotiating the price next time though . '

Haruka said just that and opened the door, leaving the room with a smile .

Even though the sky was the same colour as usual, it looked refreshing to her –

NOTES:

[1] Since it was named Wakare no Kyoku (別れの曲) in the original text, I used the name Farewell, but Chopin never called it by that name himself even though it is known as that (or L'Adieu) . It's Étude Op . 10, No . 3 and it is absolutely beautiful . HERE is Lang Lang playing it .

[2] Showa 30 is 1955 in the Gregorian calendar .

Volume 1 Chapter 2: VOLUME 1 – THE RED EYE KNOWS

Chapter 2

VOLUME 1 – THE RED EYE KNOWS

file 02: the dark tunnel

That tunnel was the shortest path from the residential area to the shopping district, but nearly no locals used it .

It was a famous tunnel for having a high accident rate .

There was a death every year .

Inside the tunnel, there were no lights, and it was dim and hard to see even during the day .

There was a sharp curve right outside the tunnel, and unlucky cars got into accidents there so often it was almost guaranteed .

However, the reason for the accidents appeared to be more than just bad visibility .

There had long been endless rumours about how something mysterious appeared in the tunnel –

Some drivers said they'd seen human heads fly by their window .

When they tried to escape in their fear, then their brakes stopped working – they would barely avoid hitting the guard rail .

Others said they'd seen countless human faces in the tunnel walls .

Some cab drivers said they'd taken on a drenched woman in front of the tunnel, but when they looked in the rear-view mirror after exiting, she would suddenly be gone –

Nobody knew the truth .

All that was certain was that many people had died at that tunnel's exit –

1

It was a quiet night –

'It's cold . '

Haruka tried her best not to be hit by the wind, putting up the collar of her beige coat and hunching over as she walked .

It was late at night on Sunday, so even though she was in front of the station, there was practically nobody there .

She just heard the echo of her boots hitting the ground .

She had gone to a party because Miki had forced her to, but when she went in, it had turned out to be a mixer .

Perhaps she was outdated, but she didn't really like parties of that sort .

Miki would die from loneliness without a boyfriend . She was like a rabbit . But Haruka wasn't desperate to find someone .

'Haruka, you've never really fallen in love . '

Miki often said that to her .

It was true .

Even when she thought back, she felt like she'd never had a romance that felt like a romance .

'So just go date someone . '

Miki said that too .

However, Haruka didn't feel like trying desperately to meet somebody to find love .

She thought that love would come about naturally – that it wasn't something to be decided, like with shopping when deciding on goods and checking a wallet's contents .

'I really am old-fashioned...' murmured Haruka, letting out a sigh that came out white .

After reaching the roundabout in front of the station, she heard a car horn .

A white car slowed down and rolled up to her, stopping in front of her .

It was a bit suspicious . Haruka was on guard as she stepped back .

Then, the passenger seat window opened and the car's lights turned on .

'Haruka-chan, I'll give you a ride . '

Why do they know my name? She felt even more suspicious .

'You can't have forgotten already, right? We were just together earlier . '

Haruka recalled upon hearing the man's quick speech .

'Ah!'

It was one of the people from the party earlier . If she remembered correctly, his name was something like Nakahara Tatsuya .

He had a medium build and a rather plain face, but his hair was like a famous soccer player's . That said, it seemed like he didn't actually like soccer that much .

'Get on already . '

Tatsuya smiled as he hit the passenger seat .

'It's fine – the trains are still running . '

Haruka refused with a bow of her head and started walking again .

'Hey, wait a sec . '

Tatsuya quickly got off the car and ran up to stand in front of Haruka, grinning as he pointed at his left wrist .

'What time is it now?'

What's this all of a sudden?

Haruka didn't understand, but she checked the time on the wristwatch .

'11:50 . '

'Sorry, but the last train's already left . '

'Eh? The last train is at 12:06 . '

'Ah, that's on weekdays . This is Sunday – a holiday . Trains stop earlier . The last train on holidays is 11:48 . You just missed it . Though for me, I just made it . '

Haruka hadn't known . She was really out of it today .

'That's why I said I'd drive you . You live in the same direction as I do, Haruka-chan . '

As Tatsuya said that, he opened the door on the passenger side .

“But...”

'Please . I'm frightened of going home alone . '

Tatsuya put his hands together as if praying and bowed his head .

Frightened, he says –

She didn't mind getting in the car, but...

'Nakahara-san, you weren't drinking?'

'Ah, I'm no good with alcohol, so I drank oolong tea the whole time . '

After this exchange, Haruka lost and sat in the car .

Tatsuya started talking about the car they were riding in the moment he started the car .

He spoke energetically about how it was a famous sports car that he'd got cheap from an acquaintance who was a car mechanic, but since Haruka had no interest in cars, she didn't really understand .

Though she didn't know what sort of car this was, Tatsuya had turned the heat on higher than necessary, and the air freshener made her want to lean away .

Not just that – the rap music in four-four time sung by a Japanese group was so loud it echoed in her belly .

Being shut in this place would make her feel uncomfortable in just five minutes .

She felt bad and kept quiet since he had offered her a ride, but she was at her limits –

'Sorry, could you turn down the volume a bit?'

Haruka spoke to Tatsuya in the driver seat .

'Right? This song is the best . '

What was the best? He wasn't listening to her at all .

Hair mimicking a soccer player and Japanese rap . And he was wearing a rather seedy suit . What on earth were his interests?

It felt like a comedy – a mix of everything that was popular .

Haruka used the panel to turn down the volume .

Tatsuy looked at her dubiously .

Haruka ignored Tatsuya's gaze and opened the window slightly, breathing the outside air, unpolluted by the air freshener .

'Ah, it's a left at the next road,' Haruka told Tatsuya when they reached the corner with the police precinct .

'Left . Got it . '

Though Tatsuya said that, he turned the wheel right without even putting on the turn signal .

Haruka lost her balance at the sharp curve .

What dangerous driving –

'It isn't right . It's left . Please turn around . '

'There's a place with a beautiful night view ahead . Did you know?'

'I didn't . '

'Let's go take a look . '

'It's fine . '

'It's really beautiful . You'll definitely like it . Just at the top of that hill . '

It was no use . He wasn't listening at all .

It was like he thought everybody in the world had the same perspective as he did .

It was useless no matter what she said .

If she went with him to see the night view, hopefully that'd satisfy him and he'd go back . Haruka gave up and looked out the window .

Come to think of it, she knew another man who did whatever he wanted, no matter what anybody else said .

He was stubborn and contrary . Even though he hated things that were crooked, he was slightly crooked himself . A man full of contradictions .

But even though he also did whatever he wanted, Haruka felt like there was something fundamentally different when comparing him to Tatsuya .

It had been a month since then .

How was he doing? Haruka thought about that sleepy-looking face and ended up smiling slightly .

'Just ahead of this tunnel . '

Tatsuya's voice brought Haruka back to reality . She looked forward .

Just as he said, there was a tunnel in front of them .

By the entrance, she saw a sign that read 'High Accident Area . Watch Your Speed!'

It looked like there were no lights in the tunnel – an ink-black darkness opened up in front of them .

The moment the car went into the tunnel, the air suddenly felt heavier .

The sound of the engine echoed against the tunnel walls .

Ooooooooooh .

It sounded just like a person moaning .

The tunnel was really eerie .

Just as they were approaching the exit, Haruka suddenly felt like something had passed them .

'Ack!' yelled Tatsuya, suddenly slamming the brakes .

The tires screeched .

Haruka was forced forward and hit her head against the window .

Tears welled up in her eyes from the pain .

They had stopped sideways right outside the tunnel .

They'd almost hit the guard rail .

The car was filled with the smell of the burnt tires .

Haruka looked at Tatsuya in the driver's seat .

Tatsuya was clinging to the wheel, looking down while shivering .

Sweat was rushing down his forehead and his jaw was chattering .

'Hey, what's wrong?'

Tatsuya didn't look normal .

Tatsuya tried to respond, but his mouth just moved – no words came out .

'Say it clearly . What happened?'

Haruka shook Tatsuya's shoulders .

Then, Tatsuya lifted his head for the first time . His face was completely white . Even a mannequin would have more colour in its face .

'...A k-kid...'

'Eh? What about a kid?'

'...Again... I might have hit... Suddenly... a kid...'

Tatsuya's shaking finger pointed out the front window .

'Hit... You can't mean...'

A kid? Haruka didn't think there was any impact after the sudden brakes .

However, she couldn't be optimistic . Anyway, she could go check .

Haruka opened the door and tried to leave, but Tatsuya grabbed her arm .

'Don't go . '

'Why? I need to check . '

'It wasn't my fault . the kid – the kid... suddenly jumped out...'

Tatsuya was frantic as he grabbed Haruka's arm .

There were tears in his eyes .

'It's not a problem of who was at fault . We need to call an ambulance . '

'You can't... If you hit... a person, you can't drive any more, and university and finding a job... And your parents won't keep quiet... My life is a mess... Please, Haruka-chan, if you keep quiet...'

'I can't believe you . '

What a man . The moment he might have taken somebody's life, all he could think about was how to protect himself .

Arguing with somebody like this was itself pointless .

'Let go of me!' Haruka yelled, forcing Tatsuya's arm off her and getting off the car .

The intense difference in temperature shocked her .

Though it was dark outside, with the car's lights, she could see .

Haruka timidly walked to the front of the car .

She felt like they were driving pretty quickly .

If somebody were hit at that speed, it'd be no use .

Haruka's legs shook when she imagined a child, collapsed and covered in blood .

However, there was nothing there .

She just saw black lines on the asphalt from the burnt tires . She checked the car's bumper, but there wasn't even a dent .

Haruka checked the side and rear as well .

However, she couldn't find anything . Was Tatsuya just seeing things? That would be fine . They could laugh it off –

Step step step .

There was the sound of someone running .

She thought it might be Tatsuya, but he was still in the car with his head down .

Step step step .

Again .

She heard it from the opposite side, beneath the car .

Haruka crouched and peered under the car . She saw a foot that could be a child's .

It can't be! Haruka hurriedly stood up and went around .

However, nobody was there . She might have just imagined it since Tatsuya had said he'd hit a child .

If that was all, it'd be OK .

Haruka was about to go back in the car, when she felt a piercing gaze on her back and stopped .

When she turned around, she saw the large half-circle hole into the dark tunnel .

There was a woman standing there with her back facing her .

Even though nobody had been there earlier –

Haruka couldn't be sure from her back, but the woman was probably in her late twenties .

She thought that because the woman was wearing a grey suit, but she could actually be younger .

She wasn't doing anything – just standing there .

Her brown hair shook in the wind .

What was she doing here at a time like this?

'Excuse me...'

When Haruka spoke up to her, the woman slowly turned around .

Haruka thought that her heart might stop from surprise .

There was a large injury on the woman's forehead, and blood was pouring out, almost pulsing .

The chest portion of her white shirt was dyed completely red .

That wasn't all – her right arm was bent in such an unnatural way it might have been broken .

It was mysterious how she could stand at all .

'This is terrible...'

Tatsuya hadn't hit a child . He'd hit this woman .

'Are you all right?'

The woman didn't respond at all to Haruka's question . That wasn't all – her expression was blank, like she didn't feel the pain at all .

She was probably numb .

'I'll call an ambulance right away . Please sit down for now . '

The moment Haruka tried to touch the woman –

The woman shook .

Her body convulsed violently .

She was coughing when she vomited blood from her mouth .

'Aaahh!'

Haruka screamed without thinking and leapt back .

Then, as if she had been absorbed by the scenery, the woman disappeared .

Why –

Haruka was disoriented . All she could hear was the wind going through the tunnel –

2

The next day, Haruka went with Tatsuya to Yakumo's secret hideaway, the Movie Research Circle clubroom .

Yesterday's experience had to have been a spiritual phenomenon .

If that were the case, it would be best to consult him .

However, while Haruka explained what had happened yesterday to Yakumo, he just played shogi by himself, as if to say he was bored .

'So it's come to this...'

Yakumo seemed to be admiring something as he moved the pieces on both sides by himself .

What was interesting about playing shogi alone? Haruka couldn't understand at all .

'Are you listening?' asked Haruka, displeased .

'Yeah, at any rate . '

'What do you mean, at any rate? Can't you listen more seriously?'

'You should be more humble . You just barged in here without thinking about how I'd feel about that and suddenly started telling a ghost story . '

Haruka couldn't think of a comeback .

It was just as he said . She had become agitated and hadn't thought about him at all .

'Sorry . '

'Well, I get the gist of it . Business is business, so shall I take it up?' said Yakumo, stretching his arms .

'Really?'

'I just have to save your boyfriend, right?'

'I'll say this again, but he's not my boyfriend . '

'You're so cold to him even though he's right there . '

Haruka let out an exasperated sigh and looked down .

Then, Tatsuya started smirking, though Haruka didn't know what was so funny .

When she caught his eye, he brought his face close to her ear and whispered .

'We look like a couple . '

'No, you don't . '

The one who denied that was Yakumo .

'We don't, you say... Weren't you the one who said we did earlier?'

'I don't recall that . '

Did too, did not – it was just like a kid's fight .

Haruka didn't feel like talking . For a while, Tatsuya looked at Yakumo's expression, but then he suddenly seemed to remember something and then started laughing .

'Oh, I see . You like Haruka-chan too . That's why you don't like me getting friendly with her . That's it, right?' said Tatsuya boastfully .

'Hey, what are you saying?' objected Haruka .

Tatsuya ignored her and continued .

'Unfortunately, an oaf like you doesn't match Haruka-chan at all . '

'That's true . I don't like stubborn women who get emotionally easily anyway . I couldn't care less if you simmered her or boiled her,' said Yakumo, his expression not changing even in the least .

'Is it really OK for you to say that? I'll really eat Haruka-chan up . '

'Do what you want . If you plan on eating her, you should watch out for food poisoning . '

'Hey, what do you mean by that?'

That was just saying too much . Haruka objected while hitting the table .

'I mean exactly what I said,' replied Yakumo in a flat tone without bowing his head .

Haruka's face flushed in anger and she bit her lip .

Really – this man's words always riled her up . He had to be a genius at making people angry .

'Then I'll do what I want . '

Tatsuya was still smiling triumphantly as he took a piece from the corner of the shogi board and moved it to another square .

'Checkmate . '

Yakumo had been expressionless, but now there was a deep wrinkle between his brows .

His thin lips were a straight line, and his almond eyes were narrowed .

'I'll give you just one warning . '

Yakumo put the piece Tatsuya moved back in its original spot and pointed at Tatsuya .

'Warning?'

'Yes . A warning . '

'Oh? What is it?'

'You should use contraception and properly hold memorial services for aborted fetuses . '

'W-what are you suddenly saying?'

Tatsuya pushed Yakumo's finger away and stood up .

He looked terribly shaken . He was showing his true cowardly nature, that had been hidden behind his exaggerated confidence .

He was disturbed because it had hit home . Haruka looked at Tatsuya coldly .

'Haruka-chan, don't get the wrong idea . This guy's nuts . Oi, don't just say whatever you want . If you don't stop fooling around, I won't keep quiet . '

'I'm not fooling around . Would it be easier to understand if I said her name?'

'Who'd you hear it from?' said Tatsuya, his expression stiffening .

He fell right into the trap . What he'd said just now proved everything . Tatsuya's head was sweaty as Yakumo continued to pursue him .

'Not just one person either . Two . You didn't learn your lesson, it seems . '

'You're wrong . They just selfishly got pregnant . It's not my fault . '

Tatsuya was so shaken he was digging his own grave . And it was pretty deep .

There was no doubt about it now .

Tatsuya's careless words made Yakumo even angrier .

'They just selfishly got pregnant? What are you talking about? That might have been an acceptable excuse if it were a false pregnancy, but aren't pregnancies only possible with a partner?'

'That's...'

'Though small, it was a new life born into this world . Did you say that they just selfishly got pregnant, like some awful joke, and cruelly kill that life? I rue the fact that Japan's laws don't consider people like you murderers . '

Tatsuya's mouth opened and shut as he frantically tried to think of something to say, but in the end, he said nothing .

Tatsuya had been foolish for getting ahead of himself and challenging Yakumo in an argument .

Tatsuya's self-respect was probably in shreds .

Tatsuya stood up in a rage, slammed the door open and left . That was probably all he could do to protest .

'Is it all right for you not to go with him?' said Yakumo, looking at the shogi board again .

'That person is the worst, but you don't lose to him either . '

'Thank you for the praise . '

That sounded pointed .

'Are you angry?' asked Haruka .

Yakumo sighed .

'Think a bit . You might like him, but I hate that sort of person . He thinks he's the most important person in the world and doesn't care about anything else . '

'So that's why you lied?'

'Lied?'

'About whether there was an aborted baby or not . '

'Decide that on your own . It's completely irrelevant to me . '

'That's right . It was irrelevant . I apologise for causing you trouble,' said Haruka, standing up . She tried to leave the room .

'There's more to that story, right?'

Yakumo finally lifted his head .

In the end, she decided that her eyes must have been playing tricks on her and went home .

However, the situation changed the day after . Tatsuya's front bumper had a bright red handprint the size of a child's .

Like a bloody hand had touched it .

Tatsuya had been frightened of it and tried to wash it off, but even after using cleansing liquid and a brush, it wouldn't come off .

He had been too frightened to drive it since .

Haruka gave a short explanation . Yakumo silently crossed his arms and looked up at the ceiling . Haruka couldn't tell if he was listening or not .

'Hey, are you listening?'

'I am . It's just that the story seems a bit convoluted . '

'Convolutated?'

'Yes, convolutated . For example...'

Yakumo started speaking, but then he ran a hand through his hair in irritation, like something was bothering him .

'What's wrong?'

'No, it's nothing . Speculation will start nothing . At times like this, the scene...'

'Let's go . '

Haruka finished Yakumo's sentence .

'Exactly . '

'Don't leave me behind this time . '

'Leave you behind? If you're talking about the last incident, you were the one who wanted to move separately . Try not to get the wrong idea . '

One sentence too many .

Haruka glared at Yakumo, but Yakumo didn't care at all .

'It's not walking distance, right?'

Even though Haruka kept glaring, Yakumo asked a question, as if he didn't care at all .

'Eh?'

'The tunnel where the incident occurred . '

'Ah . I know where it is, but it'd be difficult to walk there . '

'Do you have a car?'

'I don't even have a licence . '

'Don't act proud of it . '

'I'm not...'

'DO you have the address?'

'Should I ask Tatsuya-kun?'

'I'd rather walk . '

Yakumo tapped his temple with his finger . It looked like he was thinking, but in the end, he slowly stood up and put on a black hooded coat that was in the corner of the room and started getting dressed .

'Do you have the address?'

'I have an idea . '

Yakumo opened the refrigerator and took a key out . Why was there a key in the refrigerator?

'Promise me one thing before we go . '

As he said that, Yakumo pointed his index finger at Haruka's nose .

'What?'

'For the next little while, don't ask any questions . '

'What do you mean?'

'To put it simply, shut that chatty mouth . '

'Chatty...'

That was an awful way of putting it .

Haruka wanted to object, but Yakumo had already left the room .

'Hey, wait a second . '

Haruka ran after Yakumo .

Yakumo suddenly turned around and threw something at Haruka . It was so sudden that Haruka almost lost her balance as she caught it with both hands .

'It's cold – '

It was the key from the refrigerator .

'Shut the door properly . '

'Wait...'

'Don't forget to shut your mouth too . '

What a guy . Talking to a girl like this –

He was really insensitive, selfish and unpleasant .

'Idiot!'

Haruka couldn't stop herself from yelling .

However, Yakumo seemed to have mistaken what she said, as he just raised his hand and continued walking away briskly .

Haruka locked the door and ended up having to run after Yakumo again .

3

Haruka walked behind Yakumo .

She couldn't say anything after he'd told her to shut his mouth . She had been silent for fifteen minutes .

They soon reached a steep slope .

On both sides of the road, there were ginkgo trees with yellow leaves .

It was a beautiful little road that made you want to stop and enjoy it .

However, Yakumo didn't seem to want to enjoy it, as he briskly climbed the slope .

At the top of the slope, there were the gates to a temple . Yakumo stopped in front of them .

It looked like a fairly old temple, but it was well kept and didn't seem wild .

Why did they come to a temple?

'Hey...'

'Did you forget? No questions . '

The moment Haruka tried to ask why, Yakumo glared at her coldly .

Am I that chatty? Though she couldn't be called quiet in comparison to her friends, she didn't think she was particularly chatty .

Of course she would have questions without any explanations, and it was human to want to ask about that .

I'm not chatty – Yakumo's just strange .

'Don't move from the gates . '

'I don't have to go?'

'No questions . '

Yakumo refused her flat with an expressionless face .

Even a wooden Buddha statue would have more emotion .

It looked like he really didn't plan on saying anything . Haruka gave up and went to the pillar by the gates and put her hands behind her back .

Yakumo seemed to be satisfied by that, as he started walking briskly .

He went on the path to the temple, surrounded by gravel on both sides, and went inside a separate building that was probably the priests' quarters .

He hadn't pressed the intercom button or greeted anybody .

Did Yakumo have some sort of connection to this temple? Perhaps that was why he didn't want to talk about it .

It's cold though –

She hadn't noticed while walking, but the wind was biting when she stood here alone like this .

Why did she have to wait here by herself?

Anger rose within her as she waited .

'Hurry back!'

Unable to keep in her anger, Haruka picked up a rock at her feet and threw it towards the direction Yakumo had walked .

'Ouch!'

She was surprised by the sudden voice .

Somebody slowly walked out from behind the gates .

'I-I-I'm sorry . '

Haruka hurriedly bowed her head .

Even though there shouldn't have been anybody in the direction she threw the rock, she'd actually hit someone –

'You might get cursed for throwing a rock at a temple . '

'I'm really sorry . '

Haruka shrunk further .

'No, no, don't look so worried . It didn't actually hit . Now, lift your head . '

Urged by the low and gentle voice, Haruka timidly lifted her head .

There was a middle-aged monk standing there in navy working robes and straw sandals .

He had an egg-shaped face and eyes thin like string . He had a warm impression to him, like Maitreya .

'Ah . '

Haruka let out a voice of surprise upon seeing the monk's face .

'What is it?'

'No, it's nothing . '

She recalled that Yakumo had asked her not to ask anything . Perhaps this was why .

The monk standing in front of Haruka had a left eye that glowed red like Yakumo's .

'What are you doing here?'

'E-er, I'm waiting for Yakumo-kun – no, a friend...'

Even though it wasn't like she was doing anything suspicious or like she was lying, she was fumbling for words .

'I see . Are you Yakumo's girlfriend? Quite the curio . '

'C-curio?'

'Ah, sorry . It's the first time Yakumo's brought a girlfriend over, so I got excited . '

Could this person be Yakumo's father?

'U-um, do you know Yakumo-kun?'

Yakumo had said not to ask him questions, but he hadn't said not to ask anybody else questions .

Haruka changed the interpretation the way she liked and tried asking .

'I'm Yakumo's father . '

'Eh?'

Yakumo had said his father was missing –

'Ah, no, to be correct, I plan on being his father . Since he definitely won't accept it . I'm his mother's little brother . His uncle . '

Yakumo's uncle smiled wryly as he scratched his shaved head .

'Well, let's not just talk while standing . Come in . '

'Eh, but...'

'It's fine, it's fine . Just ignore what Yakumo says . No matter what you do, he'll complain . '

Haruka was troubled, but she went through the gates, as urged by Yakumo's uncle .

After she went into the priests' quarters, she got under the kotatsu in the living room and waited for Yakumo .

His uncle brought tea on a tray and sat across from Haruka .

When she looked at him properly, he did look like Yakumo .

She wouldn't know how to explain if asked what was similar, but if she had to say, it was probably the shape of the face .

However, the atmosphere around him was completely different from Yakumo's .

'Sorry . I invited you in, but this is all I can offer . I should have bought some youkan . '

'No, please don't fuss over me . '

'It must have been cold standing there by yourself . '

'Yes, very . '

Normally, she would have said something like 'Not at all', but she ended up saying the truth .

'How honest . '

Yakumo's uncle smiled .

When he smiled, his eyes closed . It was a gentle expression .

'I'm often told I'm too honest . I think I need to fix that myself . '

'No, honesty is best . There are probably people who have been helped by your words . '

'Do you think so? I always just hurt people . '

It was strange . This person found his way into people's hearts with incredible ease .

However, it didn't feel unpleasant at all .

'Not at all . I know at least one person who's been helped by your words . '

'Eh?'

She didn't think somebody she'd just met would say that .

Even though he has no way of knowing who I've met –

'It's you, isn't it? The one who said Yakumo's eye was beautiful . '

It was true that Haruka had said that the first time she saw Yakumo's red eye .

Yakumo had laughed at her, saying she was the first person who'd said that .

'How do you know that?'

At Haruka's question, Yakumo's uncle leant forward before saying, 'This is just between us...'

'Uncle, you don't have to say anything else unnecessary . '

Suddenly, Yakumo interrupted .

Yakumo stood in the living room entrance, looking disapprovingly at Haruka . Even though Haruka noticed, she just slowly sipped her tea .

'What are you wasting your time for? We're going . '

Yakumo's order irritated her . She decided to pretend that she hadn't heard it .

I'm not a dog . Even if I were, like I'd listen to the words of such an oppressive owner .

'What, it's you, Yakumo? Don't interrupt . I want to talk with your girlfriend a bit more . '

'She's not my girlfriend . She's a troublemaker . Don't get the wrong idea . '

'Oh, so you already have such a strong bond? Well done . '

'Uncle, listen properly to what other people have to say . '

'Saying things like that . If you dawdle too much, some other man will snatch her up . There must be a lot of takers since she's so cute . '

What on earth were they talking about with her right there? Haruka felt somewhat astonished, or rather –

'If there are people who want to take her, they can do whatever they want . '

'I'll do what I want even without you saying so . '

Haruka had planned on saying that so that Yakumo wouldn't be able to hear, but it looked like the words hadn't escaped Yakumo's ears .

His cold gaze came her way .

'Yakumo, can't you be a bit nicer?'

'I wouldn't mind thinking about it depending on the amount of money . '

His uncle shook his head in exasperation .

'Uncle, sorry, but I'm borrowing the car . '

'A drive with your girlfriend?'

'You're obstinate . '

Yakumo said just that and left the room .

Haruka thought for a while, but just as Yakumo said, this was trouble that she had brought to him . She couldn't just let Yakumo deal with it . After politely thanking Yakumo's uncle, she stood up .

'That's the sort of kid he is,' Yakumo's uncle said quietly as Haruka was about to leave the room .

It sounded somewhat lonely .

'Though Yakumo can see more than most, he's shut his heart . '

'Are you talking about ghosts?'

After nodding, Yakumo's uncle continued .

'Because he's afraid of connecting too deeply with other people, he runs away . His emotions are a little twisted . Even though he's like that, he's really a nice kid... Hm... . That isn't very convincing...'

His uncle cocked his head, looking troubled .

'I know . '

Haruka replied with a smile and left the room .

She wasn't just saying that to make Yakumo's uncle feel better . At that time, she honestly thought that, for some reason .

4

'Hey, about your uncle's eye . '

When Haruka got in the white sedan, she timidly asked Yakumo in the driver seat this question .

There was no reply .

Haruka gave up and looked out the window .

Neither the car audio or radio was playing .

All she could hear was the engine and the sound of cold air blowing through the car .

In this car where there wasn't even conversation, Haruka strangely didn't feel uncomfortable .

'My uncle's eye wasn't like that from birth . He's wearing a red contact lens . '

Yakumo suddenly started speaking once they approached the slope leading to the hill .

Haruka looked at Yakumo's profile .

'Eh?'

'What? Isn't that what you wanted to ask?' said Yakumo, looking to his side .

For a moment, their eyes met . Haruka looked away in surprise . Her whole face felt hot .

'Why would he go out of his way to do that?'

'By going out of his way to make his eye red, he's trying to get the world to look at him oddly and feel the same suffering and solitariness that I do . '

'To the point of sacrificing himself?'

'That's the sort of person he is . '

Though Yakumo said that simply, what his uncle was doing wasn't something that could be done simply .

'Even though there's somebody who cares so much for you, why are you living at the university, Yakumo-kun? You should think a little about how your uncle feels . '

She was speaking unusually strongly .

'Your faults are blabbering without thinking properly and deciding everything with your own perspective . '

'Your faults, Yakumo-kun, are your unfriendliness and your tendency to say insensitive things without thinking about other people's feelings . '

Haruka bit back, not losing to Yakumo .

Yakumo shook his head, as if he were talking to an unreasonable child .

'Do you know what sort of place that was?'

'A temple . '

'Correct . A temple . '

'What about it? Isn't that unrelated?'

'Have you forgotten? My left eye can see the spirits of the dead . Regardless of whether I want to or not . '

'Ah...'

Haruka finally understood what Yakumo was trying to say .

That was right . If a person who could see the spirits of the dead were at the temple, he would have to see dozens – no, hundreds of ghosts every day .

He would have to live with all the negative emotions from the spirits of the dead – their hatred, their anger, their sadness .

It would be impossible to stay sane .

For Haruka, it was just a temple, but it wasn't the case for Yakumo .

'Uncle knows that . It's too noisy there for me . '

Haruka felt like she had peered into Yakumo's heart for the first time .

Just as Yakumo says, I might just decide things based on my own perspective .

Haruka opened the window and stuck her head out slightly .

The wind hit her forehead . The wind which was too cool felt pleasant now

—

5

When they got close to the tunnel in question, Yakumo stopped the car by the road .

At the tunnel entrance, there were chrysanthemum flowers in an empty can .

They had probably been a fresh white colour before, but now they were withered and brown .

Even in the day, the tunnel felt eerie .

'This is the right place, right?'

Haruka responded with a silent nod .

It made her think of how frightening it had been then . Yakumo leant back on the seat and looked into the tunnel with a serious gaze .

Though it wasn't that long a tunnel, perhaps because it was curved or because it sloped, she couldn't see the tunnel's end .

It was just a pitch-black hole, like an entrance to another world .

The wind coming through the tunnel made a low moan, like a beast's howl .

The fallen leaves on the road danced up, rustling as they did so .

'Did you see something?'

Haruka asked Yakumo's profile .

'It's certain that there's something, but I can't clearly tell what it is from here . '

'So we have to go?'

'We do . '

After saying that, Yakumo slowly put down the side brake .

The car moved forward, as if being sucked in by the tunnel .

The car went inside the tunnel .

It suddenly grew darker . The air became heavier, and Haruka's ears were ringing . Just like then .

Ooooooooo .

For a moment, she felt like the wind's moan grew louder .

After going through about half of the tunnel, the sound of the engine clearly changed . It was the sound an engine made when failing to climb a steep slope .

'This is bad...'

Yakumo said just that and bit his lower lip .

His usual sleepy expression was gone from his face . They were the eyes of a wolf on his prey . There was sweat on his forehead .

'I was too careless . '

'Eh?'

'Cover your face until I say it's OK . Don't look outside the window . '

'Why not?'

'Just cover your face!' yelled Yakumo . He probably saw something .

Something incredibly frightening . Haruka did as she was told and covered her face with both hands, hunching over .

At the same time, Yakumo slammed the accelerator, making the engine roar . However, it felt like the speed didn't go up that much .

Haruka was bent over with her eyes closed, but she felt something outside the car .

Oooooo .

She heard something like a moan that was clearly not the sound of the engine . There was also a sticking sound of something gluing itself to the window .

What could it be? Haruka tried to lift her head .

'Don't look! Cover your face!'

Haruka's shoulders jolted and she returned to her previous posture . Suddenly, something brushed Haruka's neck .

What?

What just passed? She didn't know .

Stick .

Something touched her cheek .

Cold . Very cold .

Ooooo .

She heard the moan again . What was happening?

She didn't know .

No . I can't stand this any longer –

Haruka lifted her head .

She saw the tunnel exit . There was a sharp curve there .

Yakumo was in a daze, as if he wasn't looking forward at all .

'Watch out!'

She yelled immediately .

Gripping the wheel, Yakumo came back to his senses .

'Hold on!' shouted Yakumo .

Hold on to what?

Before Haruka could ask, Yakumo slammed the brakes . The tires locked and let out white smoke as the car started to veer .

In the end, Haruka couldn't find anywhere to hold on to and was swung about by the centrifugal force . Her cheek hit the side window hard .

This was the second time . Her vision went white .

She came back to reality with the smell of burning tires .

Yakumo was bent back on the driver's seat, breathing deeply with his eyes closed .

The car had stopped after turning around so that it was facing the tunnel again .

It was just a few centimetres from the guard rail . It was a cliff ahead of that, with ten metres to the bottom .

They had narrowly escaped death .

'If you're going to slam the brakes, tell me earlier,' said Haruka, rubbing the cheek she had hit .

'Ask me earlier . '

'Why can't you apologise honestly? There's going to be a lump here . '

'I want you to be grateful that it's just going to be a lump . '

Really, whatever this man said, it was always acerbic .

'Hey, was there something there?'

'Yeah . '

When Yakumo finished saying that, he made a U-turn and put the car by the side of the road . He got off the car .

Haruka followed him .

Yakumo went to the front of the car and pointed at the front glass .

'!'

Haruka was lost for words . Shudders crawled up from her toes to her head .

There were handprints on the car's front glass, like somebody had touched it with their bare hand .

It wasn't just one or two . There were handprints everywhere, with almost no cracks .

She had felt like something was there, but for there to be this many –

'At first, there was one person . A man in his thirties was on the car's bonnet . '

Yakumo put his index finger to his brow and started talking .

'After that, more and more stuck to the car . It was like there were trying to stop me in the tunnel . '

'They made the handprints?'

The strength left Haruka's body and she sank to the floor .

It made her think of zombies she'd seen in a late-night movie before . They had surrounded the protagonist's car – an endless number of the dead .

'An amazing number of people have died in this tunnel . '

'Why – '

'At first, they were probably just accidents . Then, the spirits that died but couldn't rest in peace wandered here and caused the next accidents . Then the spirits that couldn't rest in peace grew in number . A cycle of that . The dead call the dead, causing the same thing to happen endlessly . '

Hearing it was enough to make Haruka's spine feel a chill . A chain of death .

'Hey, what are you going to do?'

At Haruka's question, Yakumo slowly walked towards the tunnel .

'There's nothing I can do . '

Yakumo said just that .

'Can't you get them exorcised?'

'It's pointless . That wouldn't solve anything . '

'You said that before, but what do you mean?'

Yakumo smiled bitterly at Haruka's question and ran a hand through his messy hair .

'I don't believe in curses or exorcisms . It's heresy . Chanting to get ghosts to leave and exorcising them – it's really hard for me to believe in that . '

'To me, it's just as hard to believe in your eye that can see ghosts, Yakumokun . '

'You're mistaking spirits of the dead for something like demons . '

'What do you mean?'

'What do you think ghosts come from?'

It was a sudden question .

However, it wasn't like she couldn't answer . Naturally –

'Living people . '

'Correct . It's not like they're born from eggs or like they come from space . They were originally people with emotions . However, what do you think ghosts are?'

That was –

'I don't know . '

'This is just my theory, but I think that they might be a cluster of the dead person's wills and emotions . '

'Cluster?'

It didn't really make sense to her .

'Human memory and emotion are said to be electric signals . Some people even say that the whirlpool of information flowing in the internet resembles the construction of the brain . '

'Really?'

She kind of understood, but she kind of didn't –

'If you think that way, the moment human emotions lose their container, they don't just all return to nothing, right? Electricity flows without a container, and the information on the net moves to another container once it loses its original . It wouldn't be strange for the dead's thoughts and feelings to wander . '

'That's true . '

'It's a theory I've made from my experience, so I wouldn't be able to explain it scientifically if asked . '

'So they don't have a physical body and exist just as emotions?'

'Well, something like that . If ghosts are just emotions, returning to exorcism, what effect would mediums chanting curses and performing exorcisms have on people's emotions? I'll say this again, but ghosts aren't demons . '

Haruka kind of understood . Perhaps it was as Yakumo said .

Whether they were alive or dead, ghosts weren't new living things . People didn't become different life forms after dying .

They were still human .

'Let's say mediums have amazing powers and can exorcise ghosts and send them to the underworld . But that ignores the people's emotions – they would just be forcing them . '

'That's true . '

'That's the same as beating up people who don't listen to make them submit . To put it clearly, it's savage . '

It felt like he was a bit prejudiced, but Haruka could understand what he was saying .

Still, it was a bit unexpected that Yakumo saw ghosts as people .

The words Yakumo's uncle had said came up in her mind . ' His emotions are a little twisted' –

It suddenly seemed funny to Haruka, making her laugh .

'What's so funny?'

Yakumo's brows furrowed in displeasure as he glared at her .

Ooh, scary .

Haruka hurriedly swallowed her laughter and decided to ask another question .

'Then how about with Miki?'

'I just restricted the spirit, found out the reason it was suffering and explained that to the spirit . In short, it was only persuasion . '

Haruka nodded a number of time in understanding .

Now that she thought about it, it was true .

Yakumo hadn't done anything to Miki directly . By finding out the reason the female spirit that possessed her had died, she had taken away her fear .

As a result, he saved Miki .

'You said you saw a woman in front of the tunnel,' Yakumo said suddenly .

With a sharp gaze, like a beast, he looked at the tunnel . There was a tension she'd never seen in his back .

'I did, but...'

'In her late twenties . A woman with long hair and a grey suit?'

Haruka recalled the scene in her head .

With blood flowing from her brow, a woman with long hair, standing there emotionlessly –

'That's right, that's the person . Do you see her?'

'She's standing right in front of you . '

'Eh?'

Haruka looked around frantically, but she couldn't see anything .

At the time, the woman was trying to express something, but I didn't understand .

But if it's Yakumo –

Yakumo slowly walked up to the guard rail and leant over it, looking down .

Was something down there? Haruka did the same, looking down .

On the sharp cliff, weeds and pine trees were growing wildly like a forest .

When she looked carefully, there was oversized rubbish there in the back of the forest, like refrigerators, televisions and bicycles .

It looked like people had used it as a dump because it was difficult to see from the road .

'Here...' murmured Yakumo, jumping over the guard rail, gripping tree branches skilfully as he climbed down the cliff .

It was starting to grow dark .

The large entrance to the tunnel felt eerie .

It even felt like she might be sucked in .

It was getting harder to see Yakumo .

She didn't want to be left behind here . Haruka climbed over the guard rail too and went after Yakumo .

She was naive .

It had been a much steeper cliff than it had seemed from above .

Haruka tried futilely to advance and lost her balance, practically rolling down the cliff .

Countless tree branches hit her arms and legs . It hurt, but she couldn't stop . It was better than waiting alone . It was too late to regret now .

After getting down the cliff, she fell forward from the force .

It was like being hit hard in the knee . There was a jolt of pain .

She felt pathetic and wanted to cry .

When she held back her tears and looked up, she saw Yakumo holding out a hand in front of her .

She gripped the cold white hand and was pulled up .

'I told you to wait, didn't I?'

'You didn't say that!'

Haruka's tone was rough because of the pain .

Haruka sat on a nearby rock and looked at the knee she had hit . Her jeans were ripped and she could see her knee clearly . The skin was broken and it was bloody .

'It hurts...'

The words slipped out of her mouth .

Yakumo went to stand in front of Haruka, knelt on one knee and pressed a handkerchief against Haruka's knee .

'Hold it until the blood stops . '

She couldn't say thank you .

'Explain why we came here so suddenly . '

Instead of gratitude, dissatisfaction came out of Haruka's mouth .

Yakumo shook his head in exasperation and stood up . Then, he pointed at the ground a few metres ahead .

Haruka looked where Yakumo was pointing .

Her breath caught .

There was a woman in a grey suit lying face-up there .

Perhaps that woman –

Haruka didn't have to check to know that the woman was dead .

The blood from her forehead was dark, sticking to her lifeless skin . What could her cloudy eyes see as they looked up at the sky?

'There was probably an accident on that road,' said Yakumo .

How many days had she been here?

The woman must have shown up there wanting somebody to find her .

If I could see clearly like Yakumo, I could have found her sooner .

I'm sorry .

Haruka murmured that in her head and closed her eyes –

When Haruka went to Yakumo's secret hiding place, there was the man she'd seen at the police precinct during the last case .

If she remembered correctly, he was a detective named Gotou .

He had a large frame with sharp eyes . It made Haruka think he could be a professional wrestler .

Yakumo had told her to come if she was interested because there was something he'd found out about the woman they found yesterday .

Haruka closed the door, thinking she could come again if he already had a guest .

'Great timing . Come in – I'll explain . '

Yakumo urged her to sit, and Gotou pulled out the chair .

Now she couldn't not go in .

Haruka sat next to Gotou . When she thought about how a detective was next to her, it made her a bit nervous .

'You've met Gotou-san before, right?'

Haruka nodded .

'Oi, Yakumo . Introduce me properly? I don't know her name . '

Yakumo scratched his back, looking annoyed .

'She's Ozawa-san . '

'Oi, oi, that's all? There's gotta be more, right?'

'Please ask her yourself afterwards . '

'Ah, what a cold guy, really . So what's your given name?'

Gotou suddenly turned towards Haruka .

Though he had a full-faced smile, with the shadows under his eyes and his stubble, it was weird .

'Ah, it's Haruka . '

'Oh? You're too cute for Yakumo . So how'd you get to know each other?'

'Er...'

'I said afterwards, didn't I?'

Yakumo cut the conversation down . Gotou muttered 'Stingy' under his breath .

Haruka couldn't tell how these two knew each other .

Gotou was a detective and was older than them .

Though Yakumo used polite language, his attitude made it clear he was making fun of Gotou . Gotou seemed to be talking to Yakumo as a friend .

'Now, introductions are done . Please start explaining . '

Yakumo urged Gotou to continue . So that's how it was, thought Haruka .

Yakumo had set the time to make Gotou explain everything .

'Ah, that's right . I almost forgot . '

Gotou completely ignored Yakumo's acerbity and took a notebook out of his wrinkled shirt . He cleared his throat and started speaking .

'For the corpse of that woman, the cause of death was probably a brain contusion . '

'Was it murder?' asked Yakumo .

'No . According to the coroner, the body had car paint and a light fragment on it – it's clear that she was hit by a car . '

Gotou rubbed the stubble on his chin with his palm .

Haruka was bewildered . Gotou was talking about police information .

'E-excuse me . Is it OK to talk about this?'

Haruka interrupted without thinking .

Yakumo and Gotou looked at Haruka at the same time .

She hadn't thought she'd said something strange, but that made her feel anxious . After a silence, Gotou continued like nothing had happened .

'So about the female victim, her bag and wallet – all the things we could get her identity from – were taken off of her . '

'Somebody hid her identity on purpose . '

Yakumo put a finger on his brow .

'Exactly . We found out her identity immediately from her dental records . The victim lived in a nearby residential area . Let's call her A-ko-san . She was spotted leaving her office a couple days ago and went missing after that . '

'The search request?'

'Parents put it out . We got the parents to identify the corpse . A-ko-san's parents were confused, but they said they wanted to thank the person who found their daughter . '

Gotou glanced at Yakumo, but he didn't respond .

'And the culprit?'

'Ah, because of the fragments of the car, we figured out the type of car . It didn't take that long . '

'So everything's settled?'

'Man, it's an awful story . The culprits were two middle school students who live on the same street as the victim, A-ko-san . '

'So they didn't have a licence . '

'They were full of themselves, took the car for a spin, and hit her . They say they were driving like mad out of the tunnel 'cause they were being chased by ghosts, and they couldn't turn the curve and hit the woman . '

'That story's true . '

Haruka interrupted without thinking .

'I believe it too, but unfortunately, Japanese law doesn't acknowledge the existence of ghosts . '

'Somebody's dead . The existence of ghosts isn't an excuse,' said Yakumo, bringing the off-track conversation back on topic .

'How harsh . '

Gotou smiled wryly . He loosened the already loose tie around his neck and took out a cigarette from his inner pocket .

'I think you know . '

'I know . No smoking, right? I won't light it . just gonna hold it in my mouth,' said Gotou in irritation at Yakumo's retort .

Gotou cleared his throat and started talking again .

'Well, putting aside those kids, their parents are the problem . After the two kids caused this incident, they got afraid and called their parents . And the parents...'

'Hid the incident,' said Yakumo, biting his lip .

'Correct . They stole the wallet and bag and then tossed the corpse off the cliff...'

Haruka's shoulders shuddered upon hearing Gotou's words . She felt uncomfortable, like she would vomit .

They didn't treat her like a human .

Throwing away a corpse . How cold could people be to protect themselves

'Well, that's the gist of it . Pretty much as you expected, Yakumo . '

Gotou concluded the story and clapped his notebook shut .

As expected? So Yakumo had seen through the whole case?

Haruka had just been confused, unable to see the truth ahead at all .

It even made her want to suspect that Yakumo's eye couldn't see just the spirits of the dead but the future as well .

'Ah, I forgot to say one thing . The car that caused the accident's already been repaired . Seems like they requested some car shop somewhere, but there must've been a lot of blood . '

'They fixed it knowing it had hit a car . '

Yakumo finished Gotou's words .

'Well, that's it . We're asking the parents now where that car shop was...'

It really was an unpleasant case .

However, there was something Haruka didn't understand .

'So what will happen with Tatsuya-kun's case?'

'Can't go near that tunnel again if he doesn't want to die,' said Yakumo with a yawn .

Well, that was probably how it would be, but the uneasy feeling didn't leave her chest...

7

Tatsuya was driving the car for the first time in a while, when he spotted the back of somebody unexpected on the hill leading to the university .

When he honked the horn, the person turned to look at him with sleepy eyes .

Saitou Yakumo . He'd embarrassed Tatsuya in front of Haruka earlier .

If he loitered around any more, to say it clearly, it'd be a hassle .

It'd be better to warn him here .

Tatsuya opened the car window and drove up to Yakumo .

'Thanks for earlier . I heard from Haruka-chan . I won't go to that tunnel any more . '

Yakumo was clearly displeased as he continued to walk silently .

'Wait a second . I'm trying to thank you here . '

Tatsuya matched Yakumo's pace and slowly drove the car as he spoke .

'You have no reason to thank me,' said Yakumo, giving Tatsuya a glance .

He really didn't like this guy . That thought came to Tatsuya again .

When those eyes looked at him, like they could see to the bottom of his heart, he just couldn't relax .

'Don't say that . I'm counting on you the next time something happens . '

'There's no next time . Do something about it yourself . '

Tatsuya clicked his tongue .

'Don't want to help your rival in love?'

'Are you talking to me?'

'Is there anybody besides you?'

'If you're talking to me, you've missed the mark . I couldn't care less about what the two of you do . I won't get in your way or interfere, so do whatever you want . The reason I'm cold to you is because of a physiological dislike . Don't read that much into it . '

Tatsuya somehow managed to restrain his growing anger .

'Got it . I'm going on a make-up date with Haruka-chan now . No complains, right?'

'Do what you...'

Yakumo started speaking, but he didn't finished . His brows were furrowed as he looked at the back seat .

'Oi... Who's the kid in the back?'

'What?'

Tatsuya didn't understand what Yakumo was saying at all .

He moved his eyes to the back of the car . He didn't have to check . There was nobody there .

This guy –

'You talking about aborted babies again?'

Tatsuya didn't know who the hell this guy had heard it from, but his rumour mongering pissed Tatsuya off .

'No, not an aborted baby . That kid... maybe...'

'Man, like I can deal with you! Go die!'

Tatsuya spat that out and slammed the accelerator .

Yakumo's figure grew smaller . That guy . He was still looking this way .

What a creepy guy –

8

Haruka was waiting at the train station's traffic circle, which was where Miki had called her out to .

Miki was going to introduce her new boyfriend or something . To be honest, Haruka didn't care .

It was probably just the guy from the mixer last time .

It wasn't a judging fair, so what was she supposed to do upon seeing her friend's boyfriend? Normally, this wasn't the case, but when it was romance, Haruka didn't get along with Miki at all .

Haruka looked up at the sound of a horn .

A car was stopped in front of Haruka . If she remembered correctly, this car – but the colour was different . It had been white before, but now it was a garish red .

'Hey . '

Haruka had hoped she was wrong, but the face that popped out was Tatsuya's smirking one .

Tatsuya had kept sending her texts since . All he wrote about was himself .

Haruka had been making sure not to respond .

'What are you doing?'

'I'm waiting for a friend . '

'Ah, I see . Great timing . I was ordered to pick up a princess who was waiting for a friend . '

Oh no .

Haruka should have refused Miki's invitation today .

Now that she thought about it, she understood . If Miki's new boyfriend was somebody she knew from the mixer, naturally, Tatsuya would be a friend of Miki's boyfriend .

'Let's go . Everyone's waiting . '

Haruka felt uncomfortable just thinking about riding this car again .

She couldn't cancel at the last minute now .

Haruka reluctantly got into the car .

9

Gotou was in front of the car shop in the suburbs .

It had a garage that could hold three cars with a small building that was probably the workshop .

There were a number of police cars surrounding the area with officers running about .

Gotou had went to the road to avoid the noise so that he could make a call on his mobile .

After three rings, Yakumo answered .

That was miraculously quick for him .

<What do you want?>

That was the first thing he said .

'Continuation of that case . We found the mechanic who we think repaired the car...'

<And?>

Yakumo urged Gotou to continue . Another rare thing .

Gotou started explaining while Yakumo was still in a cooperative mood .

The mechanic used to be in a biker gang in the city and was working at the car shop after his dead father .

The people around him thought he was bumbling .

When you brought your car in for repair, it always came back with something broken in another place . He was famous for it .

With testimony, the police searched his place, and a kid's corpse was found in the backyard .

After questioning him, the story was that the kid had been hit when he was in a car with an acquaintance . Then, they'd buried the corpse in the backyard to hide the evidence –

Everyone was rotten to the core . They were looking into the kid's identity now .

It would take time to settle things, since they didn't know the identity of the kid the mechanic hit, and the body was too damaged for easy identification .

Their own perverted coroner would probably be happy .

<So what are you telling me to do?>

When Gotou finished explaining, Yakumo said that, sounding displeased .

'I won't tell you find out who that kid is, but I thought that maybe you could at least find out any special facial characteristics,' said Gotou, though he thought it wouldn't work .

If Yakumo could see the spirit of the dead boy, the investigation would go a bit more smoothly .

Well, he'd probably just refuse, saying he wasn't interested .

<Gotou-san . Could I see a photo of the corpse?>

Yakumo's reply was unexpected .

'Really!?' exclaimed Gotou happily .

It had been worth trying .

He quickly arranged to meet up with Yakumo and hung up .

10

Haruka gloomily sat in the car's passenger seat .

The four-beat hip hop music played as usual .

'What do you think of the car colour?'

Haruka didn't really car . She gave a vague 'Hm' as a reply .

'Well, it had been a red handprint, so I changed the colour with that . Pretty cool, right?'

More importantly –

'Where are we going?' she asked Tatsuya in the driver seat .

The plan had been to go to Miki's house, but the direction was clearly different .

They had left the town and were climbing a mountain road .

'I was thinking we could take a look at the night view we didn't get a chance to last time . '

'Miki's waiting, and I don't really want to see the night view . '

It was like she watching a replay of a tape of last time .

'It's fine . Miki-chan knows about this . '

'Eh?'

Haruka spoke without thinking in her confusion .

'She's being considerate of us,' said Tatsuya with a smirk .

She knew about the both of them and was being considerate .

This was just harassment .

Haruka would complain to Miki at length afterwards .

But –

'The place with a nice night view is through that tunnel, right?'

'It's fine, it's fine . There's another road . '

Why do only self-centred people surround me?

Haruka felt miserable . Her shoulders slumped .

* * *

Gotou parked a ten-year-old white sedan in front of the university gates .

His beloved car, which had never been washed even once .

When Gotou stopped, Yakumo ran out from the gates and got into the car .

Had he been waiting for Gotou in this cold? Yakumo had never done something like this before .

'Please show me the photo,' said Yakumo after catching his breath .

Gotou turned on the lights and took an envelope out from the dashboard, handing it to Yakumo .

Yakumo took the photos out and looked at each one assiduously .

They were photos that you'd want to look away from, but Yakumo's eyes were serious . His power had probably taken away the fear of death from him .

Yakumo saw blood, flesh and bone – and their decay – on a daily basis –

Yakumo put his head in his hands and sighed .

'Do you have an idea?'

'Unfortunately, I do . '

Though Yakumo smiled, his eyes weren't smiling at all .

'Tell me . What do you mean?'

'I'll explain later . More importantly, we have to confirm it . '

After saying that, Yakumo took his mobile phone out of his coat pocket and made a call .

* * *

In the passenger seat, Haruka noticed her mobile phone vibrating in her bag .

'Hello?'

<Where are you now?>

She heard Yakumo's restless voice .

'In a car . '

<When you say car, is it the car of that guy named Tatsuya?>

'Yes, but...'

<Get off that car right now . >

There was no arguing with Yakumo's tone .

'Get off? What do you mean?'

<Just get off the car if you don't want to die . >

Eh? If you don't want to die –

It was true that she didn't feel good about being together with Tatsuya, but she wouldn't die from that .

While Haruka was thinking, her mobile was taken away from her .

It was Tatsuya . What was he doing all of a sudden? While Haruka was flustered, Tatsuya started talking into the phone .

'This isn't what you promised . It's got nothing to do with you, right?'

That was a considerably pointed tone .

He'd regret talking to Yakumo like that .

'Shut up! It's got nothing to do with you!'

As expected . Tatsuya was furious – it seemed like Yakumo had said something .

He deserved it from doing something as thoughtless as taking somebody else's phone .

'Anyway, let me do what I want!' yelled Tatsuya, hanging up and putting the mobile on the dashboard, as if he didn't even want to give it back to Haruka .

HE had no manners at all .

To be honest, she was sick of this .

'I'm getting off,' she said, while putting her mobile phone in her bag .

11

'Oi, Yakumo . What was that? Explain . '

Gotou asked that question to Yakumo, who was gripping the mobile phone with a disappointed expression .

'I've seen the child in the photo,' said Yakumo, handing the photos back to Gotou .

'You know the kid? The face was wrecked, so...'

'Though it isn't certain, you should be able to figure it out part of it from gender, height and shape, right?'

Made sense . Gotou accepted that .

Rather than looking for an identity, Yakumo was just putting faces together .

Still –

'Where?'

'He was sitting in a car's backseat today . That was probably the car that hit him . '

'I see . '

Gotou opened the window and lit his cigarette .

'If you're going to smoke, please go outside . '

'Oi, oi – this is my car . You've got no right to complain . So does it seem like that kid's ghost is going to do something?'

'Perhaps... Though I didn't notice when I was in the tunnel, now that I think about it, I should have known . I regarded something completely different in the same light...'

Yakumo bit his lip in his frustration .

It meant that an accident could occur somewhere .

Gotou wanted to do something, but to be honest, it'd be difficult . If he used his wireless to follow the car, he might be able to avoid the accident .

However, there was no reason to do so . Police couldn't move because a ghost might cause an accident .

Even if he tried to explain that it was a car that had hit a kid, all he had to prove it now was Yakumo's testimony .

'Is the car owner your friend?'

Gotou asked the question that suddenly came to his head .

'No . I wouldn't be the friend of somebody like that even for a request . '

'I see . '

'Just...'

'Just... what?'

Even while asking that, Gotou had an idea .

He could tell from Yakumo's restlessness .

'My acquaintance is in the car . '

'That girl?'

The face of the female student called Haruka appeared in Gotou's head .

She was so cute and amiable that she didn't match with Yakumo .

'Yes,' said Yakumo .

'Damn . '

Gotou threw the documents into the backseat and leant back on his seat .

'Anyway, it was helpful . '

Yakumo ended the conversation and opened the car door .

'What are you going to do?'

'It's not like she's my friend, but I can't leave this alone . '

'You got any ideas?'

'I'll come up with them now . '

Acting tough as always .

Even though he didn't have any ideas . He could just honestly ask for help .
How troublesome .

'Oi, Yakumo . '

'What?'

'You owe me one . '

Yakumo looked surprised .

It was the first time Gotou had seen him look like that . Gotou could get used to this .

'Just get on . I'll take you . You're in a hurry, right? Don't dawdle . '

'Thank you very much . '

It was probably the first time Yakumo had thanked Gotou .

'Forget about the thanks . It's as unpleasant as being told "I love you" by my wife . '

'Have you ever been told that?'

'Shut up . '

Damn, even at a time like this?

'Hold on tight . '

Gotou slammed the pedal and sped up, spinning the wheel to make a U-turn .

Yakumo lost his balance and hit his head against the side window .

'If you're going to make a U-turn, please tell me . '

'You didn't ask . '

Gotou laughed aloud in triumph .

Yakumo put a hand against his injured head and looked like he wanted to say something, but in the end, he didn't say anything .

Gotou felt like he'd won .

'Do you always drive like this?'

'I always need to hurry for work . '

Gotou turned on the siren and drove even more quickly, caught up in the moment .

There were honks from behind him, but he didn't care .

'That was a red light . '

'I've got the siren on . The other cars will avoid us . '

'What an astonishing officer you are . '

'If you complain any more, I'll drive at the speed limit,' said Gotou as he drove even more quickly .

The mountain of documents on the dashboard fell down, scattering through the car .

'I don't want to ever sit in a car you drive again, Gotou-san . '

Though Yakumo said that, he was smirking .

'That's my line . I won't give you a ride ever again . '

'Please turn left at the next intersection . '

Gotou spun the wheel as Yakumo instructed .

The tires squealed .

'Oi, Yakumo . If we're going on this road, are we...'

'Yes, we are . '

A heavy atmosphere .

He'd been the one who said he'd drive him, but it made him want to back out .

'The ghost tunnel, eh...'

'Yes . That child is probably also heading for that tunnel . '

'How can you tell?'

'There's a call . From the amazing number of spirits that died there in similar accidents...'

It was true that the number of accidents there was abnormal . There were a quite a few of them in the photos taken by forensics after the accidents .

It wasn't just one or two .

Heads all over the tunnel . And all of them looking right at you .

Honestly, if people were seeing that, an accident or two would be a matter of course .

But –

'Yakumo . Can I ask one thing?'

'If it isn't a stupid question, yes . '

Yakumo frowned, troubled by the smell of the cigarette, and opened the window as he replied .

'I've always thought it strange, but you can see dead people all the time . Putting that aside, though normal people can't see them, that isn't always the case . There are some people who can see them sometimes . '

'Yes . '

'Even for spirit photography, the people in the photo don't notice, right?'

Yakumo seemed to think as he ran a hand through his hair .

Gotou forgot to tap the cigarette against the ashtray as he waited for an answer .

'Probably...'

Yakumo started to speak, like he was thinking to himself .

'I think that it changes depending on a number of conditions . '

'Conditions?'

'Yes . For example, there might be a change if the spirit of the dead has a strong will . Perhaps the will of the person who is looking has an influence . It's often said that telling ghost stories calls out ghosts . '

'Yeah . '

Gotou had heard that a lot .

There was an urban legend that if you turned off the lights and told ghost stories, another person would show up .

'There is also the possibility that neither of those matters, and that it changes depending on natural phenomena . Temperature or humidity or light...'

'Like mirages?'

'There are many possibilities, but to be honest, I don't know . If I could explain the cause, I would be able to heal my eye...'

'Right . That was a stupid question . '

Gotou smiled wryly and apologised honestly .

'Please don't be concerned about that . Though I wish you would be more concerned about the cigarette smoke . '

'How many times do I have to say this? This is my car . '

Gotou pressed his cigarette into the ashtray and lit a new cigarette .

12

Yakumo didn't call again .

What on earth did he mean, saying something like 'if you don't want to die'?

Though Haruka had said she was getting off? the call earlier, Tatsuya ignored her .

She didn't have the courage to jump off a moving car .

As Haruka looked out the window, she noticed something strange .

This scenery . She'd seen it before .

Tatsuya had said he'd take a different road to avoid the tunnel .

However, the scenery was the same as last time .

'Hey, Tatsuya-kun . This road...'

No response . She looked at the driver's seat .

His face was completely pale . His lips were trembling .

'Hey, Tatsuya-kun . Won't we get to the tunnel if we go this way?'

'...I-I know...'

Though Tatsuya said he knew, it didn't look like he was turning around .

Rather, he was speeding up .

There was a curve in front of them, but he still didn't slow down . It was dangerous .

The tires screeched as they just managed to make the turn .

If she was in a car like this, she could actually die, just as Yakumo said .

'Hey, Tatsuya-kun!' said Haruka frantically as she glared at Tatsuya .

A cold sweat ran down Tatsuya's forehead . His eyes were bloodshot, and it looked like he was stuck to the wheel .

'Hey, wait . '

Tatsuya didn't reply to Haruka's repeated questions, but he kept looking at the rear-view window pleadingly .

Haruka looked at the rear-view window as well .

There was a boy there .

With narrow eyes and plump red cheeks, the boy was looking at them with a smile .

Haruka hurriedly turned to look at the backseat .

There was no boy there . She looked at the rear-view mirror again .

She saw the boy smiling in the backseat .

However, when she turned around, there was nobody there .

A boy that only existed in the rear-view mirror –

'What is this?'

'... The brakes... The brakes aren't working...'

Tatsuya sounded like he was going to cry .

'Aren't working? What do you mean?'

'It wasn't me . It's not my fault . Help . Please help . '

Tatsuya started yelling as tears rolled down his cheeks .

He couldn't drive properly in this condition .

What on earth should she do? Haruka was confused when she heard a police car's siren .

When she looked to the side, she saw a white car with a siren on .

The man in the passenger seat was leaning out and yelling something .

A face she'd seen before —

It was Yakumo .

* * *

'It's great that we found them, but what are we going to do now? If a car comes this way, we're wrecked,' said Gotou in his irritation towards Yakumo as he drove .

There were two cars going in the same direction on a road with one lane for each direction .

They couldn't keep doing this .

'First, I'll confirm the situation . '

'How? By yelling from here? They won't hear . '

Yakumo took his mobile from his pocket, opened the window, leant out and gestured .

'Turn on the power! The power!'

Yakumo yelled as loudly as he could .

Shit! Another car!

'Yakumo, come back in!' yelled Gotou, slamming the brakes and grabbing the belt of Yakumo's jeans so that he wouldn't fall out .

Then, he swung the wheel to the right and followed the car Haruka was in .

Next to them, the truck let out a honk as it passed .

That was dangerous .

Yakumo leant back on the seat and took deep breaths .

The wind was strong . With the sound of the engine, Gotou didn't know whether Yakumo's voice had reached .

All he could do was hope it did .

Suddenly, Gotou noticed that there was a kid in the back of the car in front of them .

He was looking back at them, with his face stuck to the window . He had a cute smile .

That's the kid's ghost –

* * *

Haruka couldn't hear what Yakumo was saying .

At first, she was confused about what Yakumo was doing here, but she didn't have the time to think about that .

Yakumo had been trying to expression something .

He had been yelling with his mobile phone in his hand .

Ah . Mobile .

Haruka took her mobile out of his bag .

She couldn't believe it – the phone was off . Did Tatsuya turn it off earlier?

Haruka hurriedly turned it on .

That moment, her mobile started vibrating .

'Hello?'

<Are you OK? Though I'll head back if I'm getting in the way of your date . >

It was Yakumo's voice . He was speaking spitefully even at a time like this . Really, what a hateful guy .

However, Yakumo's spiteful voice was her only hope now .

'It's not a date . What should I do?'

<First, stop talking and explain the situation . >

If Haruka got back alive, she'd definitely poke him in the forehead .

'He says the brakes – the car's brakes suddenly stopped working . '

<Can you turn the wheel?>

'Tatsuya-kun, can you turn the wheel?'

Haruka covered the mobile phone's receiver and spoke to Tatsuya .

Perhaps Tatsuya couldn't speak, as he just nodded a number of times while sniffing .

'It seems the wheel's OK . '

<And the hand brake?>

'Tatsuya-kun, how about the hand brake?'

Haruka asked Tatsuya another question in the same way .

Tatsuya's mouth just moved – she couldn't tell what he was saying .

'Talk properly! What about the hand brake?'

I'm frightened too . Haruka yelled at Tatsuya .

'I don't know . I didn't try...'

Tatsuya finally spoke .

* * *

'It looks like the brakes are completely dead . The wheel is working . He hasn't tried the hand brake . '

Gotou drove as he listened to Yakumo's quick explanation .

'That's bad...'

A hand brake on this downward slope .

The car wouldn't be able to stop completely .

What to do?

'Isn't there any method? They'll reach the tunnel soon . '

'Wait . I'm thinking now . '

Gotou took out his cigarette case, but he saw that it was empty and threw it out .

'It's dangerous, but there's no helping it . '

After saying that, Gotou took the mobile from Yakumo .

'Sorry, but could you hand the phone to the driver?'

Soon, he heard the trembling voice of a man half in tears say <Hello> .

'OK, listen carefully to what I'm going to say . '

Gotou spoke as slowly as he could so that he wouldn't startle the guy .

'When I give the signal, put the car in low gear . Then, use the hand brake and turn the wheel slightly to the left . '

<I-if I do that, the car'll hit the guard rail...>

'It will! Don't move the wheel after it does . Stick to the rail . Got it?'

After a while, Gotou heard Tatsuya's weak reply .

Is this guy really OK?

Gotou was anxious, but all he could do was try . He took in a deep breath and waited for the right time .

'Got it? I'm going... Now!'

The car slowed slightly . Looked like Tatsuya was going along with the instructions . Then, the car slowly approached the guard rail .

Crunch .

The front of the car hit the guard rail and let out sparks .

However, the car continued moving .

They'd be out if they hit the curve .

'Any other methods?' yelled Yakumo .

'Damn it!'

Gotou threw the mobile in his bad mood .

It hit the front glass and broke into parts .

'Yakumo . You'll really owe me . '

As Gotou said that, he stepped on the accelerator and drove parallel to the other car again .

'Hold on tight . '

After saying that, Gotou used his own car to hit the one beside them .

There was the sound of metal hitting metal as Gotou's car hit and drove erratically, but he forced it back again .

They hit once more, and this time, Gotou's car didn't move away and instead pushed the other one into the guard rail .

There was an unpleasant high-pitched screech as metal hit metal, letting off yellow sparks .

Finally, the sparks stopped, and the unpleasant sound of metal stopped too .

The two cars stopped just in front of the curve before the tunnel, letting out white smoke .

'If you're going to ram into the car, please say so,' grumbled Yakumo as he held a hand against his left shoulder .

'You didn't ask . '

13

Her head was dizzy .

Haruka's feet were shaking, but she somehow managed to get out of the car on her own .

'Oi . You OK?'

Somebody hit her shoulder . Haruka's blurry vision became clearer .

She saw Yakumo's red left eye .

Unusual for him, he looked worried .

'Somehow...' said Haruka, rubbing her forehead, which had been hit .

It didn't hurt that much, but her consciousness was fuzzy .

'It's good that you're safe . '

'Couldn't you have saved me in a better way?' complained Haruka, pushing Yakumo's chest .

'Do you have a complaint?' Gotou interrupted immediately .

'Sorry, that wasn't...'

Haruka hurriedly bowed her head towards Gotou .

Yakumo smirked upon seeing it .

'What's so funny? This is your fault anyway, Yakumo-kun . '

'Stop shifting the blame . It's just deserts, right? I even lost my contact lens – I'm really suffering here . '

'Can't you be a bit nicer?'

Thank you – why can't I say that simple phrase honestly in front of Yakumo?

Haruka tried to make sense of her inexplicable feelings, but she didn't come up with a reason .

Oooooo .

The moan of the wind interrupted the conversation .

Yakumo suddenly looked towards the tunnel .

It looked like he saw something there .

Haruka looked as well, but all she could see was the pitch-black tunnel .

Yakumo staggered towards the tunnel .

'Hey, what is it?'

It looked like Yakumo hadn't heard Haruka's words .

'Stop! You can't go there!'

Yakumo suddenly yelled out and started running towards the tunnel .

'Don't go! You won't be able to come back if you do!'

Yakumo continued to run . Like he was chasing something –

However, it looked like he couldn't catch it .

He stopped in the middle and fell to the asphalt, as if exhausted .

Then, he didn't move for a while .

Only the cold wind proved that time hadn't stopped .

How long was he there –

'Why... Why didn't you understand...'

Yakumo finally murmured that and stood up, swaying as he did so .

'Yakumo . '

Gotou called out to him .

In response, Yakumo very slowly turned around .

Haruka's spine jolted .

Yakumo was as expressionless as a dead man . But –

His red eye was trembling with anger .

'You... That child was still alive . '

With a slow but steady gait, Yakumo walked towards Tatsuya .

Yakumo's red left eye glowed in the darkness, focussed on Tatsuya .
Tatsuya let out a shriek .

He backed away in fear .

'Oi, Yakumo, what's wrong?'

'Yakumo-kun?'

Yakumo didn't respond to Gotou's or Haruka's voices .

He just continued to walk straight towards Tatsuya .

'You hit that boy with this car . '

'Y-you're wrong . '

Yakumo continued, ignoring Tatsuya's excuse .

'But that boy was still alive . You killed him . Thinking it'd be better for him to die, since he wouldn't be able to be saved anyway – '

'W-what are you saying?'

'You hit his head again and again with a hammer and killed him . '

Tatsuya's fear had reached its limit .

Under the intimidating pressure emitting from Yakumo, Tatsuya started crying as he continued to back away .

However, Yakumo didn't let him get away .

'Who the hell decided that it would be better for him to die?'

'That isn't it . There wasn't anything we could do . '

'You killed that child to hide the accident! Do you understand what you did!?'

Yakumo grabbed Tatsuya's collar and rammed his head into Tatsuya's nose .

Tatsuya's nose and upper lip seemed to have been cut, as they were bleeding as he collapsed to the ground right there .

'Oi, Yakumo . You're not saying that these guys – '

'They did! They killed a child who was still alive and buried him to hide their accident . He was still breathing – he was still conscious!'

Yakumo's words stabbed Haruka deeply in her chest .

What Tatsuya had done was completely unforgiveable .

'That isn't just illegal disposal of a body – that's murder . '

Gotou approached Tatsuya with a sharp gaze .

'S-shut up . Shut your mouth! You have no proof . Where's there proof? This guy's nuts . Nobody'll believe this story,' yelled Tatsuya, waving his hands wildly .

'I believe it,' said Gotou, looking down at Tatsuya .

'You don't have any proof . No proof . '

Tatsuya's shoulders heaved as he screamed frantically .

'Got this? That child has been wandering here this whole time . Do you understand? This whole time . Should I kill you here and have you experience the same thing?'

Yakumo grabbed Tatsuya's hair and forced him to stand up .

Tatsuya had been bluffing as well as he could, but his mind was at its limit .

Yakumo raised a tight fist .

'Stop it . '

Gotou grabbed Yakumo's arm to keep him in check .

'Why?'

'You don't need to do that . I'll take responsibility for this guy and send him to prison . So bear with it for now . There are other things you can do, right?'

Yakumo and Gotou glared at each other, unmoving .

A tension that felt like it would explode at any moment –

'Yakumo-kun! Stop!' shouted Haruka, unable to bear it .

Yakumo slowly lowered his raised fist .

'Gotou-san . Please find the evidence afterwards . You must . '

'You don't even have to ask . '

After saying that, Gotou pushed the resisting Tatsuya into the car's backseat .

'Oi, I'm going back . '

Gotou called out to him, but Yakumo didn't move .

He was looking into the dark of the tunnel, which looked like the entrance to another world .

Haruka looked at Yakumo's back, which seemed sad .

'I'll come to pick you up after . '

After saying that, Gotou made a U-turn with the car Tatsuya was in and drove away, climbing the slope .

'You found out the truth . That child must...'

Haruka spoke towards Yakumo's profile .

How on earth must Yakumo feel? Is he angry? Sad? Haruka didn't know .

'It's frustrating sometimes . '

'Frustrating?'

'I told you this before, right? I can't exorcise ghosts or anything . '

'Yeah . '

'I said that exorcism was like heresy, but the truth is, it's frustrating that I can't do it . '

'Yakumo-kun – '

'I can't do anything but see them . '

Haruka slowly walked up to Yakumo and stood next to him .

I don't have a red eye, but if I thought that I might be able to see the same things if I were in the same place .

'Just because I can see them, everyone treats me like a monster . Despite that, all I can do is see them . I can't do anything . '

That isn't true . Haruka tried to say that, but her voice wouldn't come out properly .

'Why can I see with this eye, when I can't do anything...'

Yakumo said just that .

At least I was saved by Yakumo-kun .

Because of that eye, I was released from my older sister's accident, which I had been suffering from for thirteen years .

And he's saved my life three times .

Haruka whispered that in her heart as she looked into the dark tunnel as Yakumo was doing –

14

Haruka pedalled the bicycle frantically as she climbed the slope to the tunnel .

In the bicycle's basket, she had put white chrysanthemums that she had bought at the flower shop in front of the station .

The crime Tatsuya had committed had been proved as murder through Gotou's investigation .

If he hadn't thought about trying to get away with it, it would have just been an accident, but this incident had caused many people misfortune .

With more investigation, they found out that the boy's parents had had an accident at that tunnel and had already passed away .

When he was hit by a car, that boy might have gone to his parents .

Thinking that made Haruka feel a bit better, but it didn't change the fact that a life that didn't have to be lost had been –

Though it was winter, it was intense exercise .

Haruka was completely sweaty when she reached the tunnel .

She took off her brown jacket . She was just about to take the flowers from the basket when somebody called out to her .

'You came all the way here by bike?'

Haruka lifted her head and saw Yakumo's uncle, the priest, standing in front of the tunnel .

Unlike the last time they'd met, he was wearing black robes with a monk's stole .

Haruka greeted the priest and walked up to him .

On the path beside the tunnel, there were beautiful white chrysanthemums in a vase along with incense, which let off white smoke .

'Did you do this, sir?'

The priest shook his head .

'It was Yakumo . '

Haruka sat down and looked at the white chrysanthemums .

It was unexpected that Yakumo would do something like this .

'Yakumo called me out here . After talking about this tunnel, he told me to do something about all the spirits wandering here,' continued the priest, smiling wryly .

'Even if he tells me to do something, I can't see the spirits of the dead like Yakumo can . I really can't do anything...'

'Yakumo-kun said it was frustrating,' said Haruka, recalling the incident from before .

'Frustrating?'

The priest cocked his head .

'Yes . He said it was frustrating for him, since he can see them but can't do anything . '

Suddenly, the priest laughed, nodding a number of times .

'Is something funny?'

The priest stopped laughing and cleared his throat before speaking .

'Before, Yakumo just hated being able to see them . Wondering why he was the only one who could see them . When he was a student, he even tried to stab his own eye with a knife . '

'That's...'

'If he couldn't see them, nobody would be afraid of him, and he wouldn't have to be afraid . '

If Haruka had been in the same position, she might have thought the same things as Yakumo .

'Is that so?'

She felt like her impression of Yakumo had changed a bit .

'It's quite an improvement for that Yakumo to say that it's frustrating to just be able to see them without being able to do anything . '

'An improvement? It doesn't seem like that at all to me thought . '

The priest started laughing again .

What is so funny? Haruka didn't understand at all .

'I'm the one who gave Yakumo his name . '

The priest sat next to Haruka and started talking .

'When there are many layers of clouds, it's called "yakumo" . '

'Is that so?'

'When that child was born, and I saw that red left eye, I thought that he would definitely have to undergo many trials . Like thick layers of clouds that block the sun's lights . '

'So you called him Yakumo . '

'I didn't want him to lose to those trials . The path ahead is long, but I think that Yakumo has broken through one of those clouds . '

'Yakumo...'

Haruka said that name once more .

She heard the sound of a bird from far away .

No matter what changed, time continued to flow .

'Ah, that's right . '

Haruka took out the flowers that she had brought from the basket and placed it beside the vase Yakumo had placed . She put her hands together and closed her eyes .

Did Yakumo come here and talk to that boy?

She suddenly wondered that .

'I think it'll be tough, but take care of Yakumo for me . '

'Yes . '

Haruka replied to the priest's words with a smile . Then, she stood up, thanks the priest and left .

When Haruka looked up, a cloudless blue winter sky spread above her .

Will a day like this come for Yakumo too?

That thought suddenly came to her –

Volume 1 Chapter 3: VOLUME 1 – THE RED EYE KNOWS

Chapter 3

VOLUME 1 – THE RED EYE KNOWS

file 03: message from the dead (TRANSLATION NOTES)

There is something called premonition .

It comes when somebody you are close to is about to die . You feel it in an omen .

The omen appears differently to everyone .

Some might feel it vaguely, while it isn't rare for people to say they see something like a single firefly in the winter or someone's death in a dream .

There are people who have experienced seeing somebody who should have been very far away suddenly appearing before sleep, saying 'Thank you' or 'Goodbye' in the end and suddenly disappearing .

This premonition comes as a final farewell to those left behind from those who are going to their deaths –

That is what is usually thought, but there are cases where it is different .

Premonitions are sometimes imbued with important meanings .

The words of those who are going to their deaths, wrung out with the last of their strength –

A message that must not be overlooked –

1

Haruka couldn't sleep that night .

She had her part-time job after her lecture, and she had to do her report due tomorrow when she returned home .

It was two in the morning when she got into bed .

Though she felt like she should have fallen asleep immediately, she couldn't sleep at all .

She opened her eyes slightly and looked at the clock . It was already past three . She had been in bed for over an hour .

These sleepless nights came to her frequently .

It was always when she remembered her sister's death and felt guilty about it .

However, she had been able to sleep well ever since meeting Yakumo and coming to feel her sister's presence close to her .

It had been a while since she hadn't been able to sleep like this .

Suddenly, Haruka felt a presence and opened her eyes .

She could see her dim room . She looked around as much as she could by turning her neck, but she couldn't see anything .

She had just been mistaken . There was no way that somebody would be in her room .

The moment she was about to close her eyes, she saw a shadow wriggle in the corner of her eye . She sat up reflexively .

Her heart beat wildly . She was sweating . She timidly turned her eyes towards the corner of the room that she had spotted the shadow in .

'... Shiori?'

The shadow was Shiori, one of her high school friends .

'What are you doing at this time? You could have called if you were coming . '

Shiori didn't reply .

She just looked at Haruka with a blank expression .

But how had Shiori got in?

'Did I forget to lock the door?'

As Haruka said that, she reached up to turn on the lights .

'... Ru... n...'

Shiori said that in a weak voice .

There was clearly something strange about her –

'Hey, what's wrong?'

'... Please... ru... n...'

'Run from what?'

'Hurry... Run . '

Haruka didn't understand what Shiori was saying .

Haruka got off the bed and tried to approach Shiori .

Then, a line of dark red liquid flowed down Shiori's forehead .

Drip, drip, drip .

The blood burst out, like water from a broken dam .

Shiori's face and white sweater were dyed red, and the carpet at her feet were dyed dark red as well .

Haruka froze in shock – she couldn't even scream .

Shiori said 'Run' once more and collapsed .

'Shiori!'

Haruka finally managed to scream and tried to run up to the collapsed Shiori .

However, the moment she tried to touch her, a fire burst up and enveloped Shiori's body .

Haruka instinctively leant away and fell backwards .

Why fire all of a sudden? No, she didn't have the time to think .

Haruka stood up, but the fire and Shiori had disappeared .

Haruka frantically turned on the lights .

The sudden light made her vision go white . After blinking a number of times, her eyes finally grew accustomed to the lighting .

She looked around, but she couldn't see Shiori –

Did she see an illusion? No, it was too real for that .

Thinking about it wouldn't start anything . Haruka picked up her mobile from the table and called Shiori's number .

<The number you have called is not currently in use . >

There was a message .

Did she call the wrong number by accident? Haruka checked her call log .

It had been Shiori's number . Maybe the reception wasn't good . Haruka tried calling again . The result was the same .

Shiori hadn't mentioned changing her number . Something was strange .

Haruka's heart felt uneasy .

Shiori's apartment was about a five-minute walk from here .

There was no point just thinking . She'd go take a look .

Haruka picked up her beige coat from the coatrack and wore it over her pyjamas . Then, she put on sandals and ran out of the room .

When she took the elevator and left the apartment building, she cursed her rashness .

The cold air bit at her through her coat .

She was also wearing open-toe sandals . Her toes had already lost feeling .

She thought about going back to her room to change, but she had slipped up . The apartment entrance had an automatic lock .

Her key was in her room .

There was nothing she could do .

Haruka felt disappointed, but now that she thought about it, Shiori's apartment was just nearby .

If she held on for a bit and went to Shiori's to explain, Shiori would probably giggle in her usual way and make some warm cocoa for her .

Shiori's cocoa was a bit different from the instant kind you could buy at the super market . The aroma was exceptionally good .

It seemed like she used a secret ingredient, but she wouldn't tell Haruka even after she asked .

Haruka would get Shiori to tell her this time .

Haruka walked quickly on the road to Shiori's apartment .

She had gone to the same high school as Shiori and were going to the same university .

They lived near each other, so they often made visits .

Rather than going places together, they would go to one of their places and read or watch television together, just doing what they wanted .

However, they hadn't had many chances to meet as of late .

Shiori's parents had died in a fire at the end of last year, and she had quit the university .

Haruka had thought that Shiori would return home, but she started working at a department store and was still living in the same apartment .

Haruka had been happy, thinking they'd be able to keep in touch, but the rhythm of a university student's life and a working person's was different . They weren't able to meet up as frequently as they had .

She had last seen Shiori about two months ago .

She remembered telling her about meeting Yakumo and the gist of the case surrounding that .

After walking about five minutes, Haruka reached Shiori's apartment .

Shiori's room was at the very end of the second floor .

Haruka looked up – the room lights were off .

Of course . While thinking that, Haruka took the steel stairs up to the door at the very end for room 204 .

She rang the doorbell . No response .

She tried once more and placed her ear to the door . Still no response .

She couldn't continue ringing the doorbell at a time like this . She couldn't yell or knock loudly either .

'Shiori . '

Haruka put her face to the door and quietly knocked the door with her finger .

Please . Wake up . Haruka prayed that, but the door didn't open .

Haruka leant against the door and looked up . The sky was starting to brighten .

It felt somewhat like she was in water .

'The person in that room moved out . '

Haruka came back to her senses when somebody suddenly called out to her .

A young man was looking at her curiously . It made sense .

'E-excuse me . When you say moved out...'

Haruka couldn't believe his words and asked him that .

'Yeah, about a week ago? There was a call, saying to cancel the newspaper subscription since she was moving . '

'Is that true?'

'There's no reason for me to lie, right?'

That was true .

'Do you know where she moved to?'

'I don't know . I asked, thinking she might subscribe to our newspaper after moving, but she didn't say . '

Was Shiori really gone?

'More importantly, you'll catch a cold . '

The young man said just that and returned to delivering newspapers .

Haruka was stunned –

2

Gotou Kazutoshi's eyes narrowed as he looked up at the sun, which was starting to set . He lit his cigarette .

There was a burnt house in front of him .

The walls and roof were mostly gone . The pillars were pitch-black, and a number of them had collapsed .

Though the firefighters were using hoses to clean up, they looked fatigued .

It made sense . Surrounded by cars parked on the road, when they arrived, it had already been too late .

Corpses covered in black sheets were carried out .

'Damn it . '

Gotou spat that out with a glob of saliva .

Police had been too late with everything this time .

It made sense . The culprit's movements had been beyond their imagination . They'd even sent a will to the police and used gasoline to set everything on fire .

It was an unpleasant case .

Gotou threw away his cigarette .

'Do you feel like starting another fire?'

There was a shrill voice .

A small-framed old man in a medical gown walked up beside Gotou .

His facial features were in the centre of his square face . He was wrinkled all over like a dried persimmon .

It was Hata Hideyoshi, the coroner .

'What, it's you, old man?' said Gotou, bored .

'But they really got us good . '

Hata's shoulders shook as he laughed .

This old man was as creepy as usual . Even Rat Man[1] would be cuter .

'Yeah, they really did . '

'Well, that's the end of it, anyway . '

'What do you mean, end of it? Is it OK for you to be loitering around here, old man? You have to autopsy the corpse, right?'

'I'm not autopsying it . With it all black like that, the autopsy won't show anything . '

'You're not going to do it?'

'I'm not . I'll leave it to somebody else . They have the blood type and belongings like rings . They just have to look into the cause of death . '

This old man really was quite a pervert .

His attitude towards work changed completely depending on the state of the corpse .

The more destroyed the corpse was, the more excited he became, but he didn't do burnt corpses . The family of the corpse would probably faint if they knew the body was being autopsied by a man like this .

'Isn't that skipping work?'

'Do you know how many corpses I get to autopsy in a year?'

Hata suddenly turned serious .

'Who knows? Probably a hundred?'

'One hundred thousand in the whole country . I don't have the time to do all that personally . '

Gotou couldn't say anything to that .

'Corpses really should be fresh . '

After saying something awful, Hata laughed again . Why did strange people like this surround Gotou –

He was fed up .

'By the way, Gotou-kun . That boy who can see ghosts . Could you let me meet him next time?'

Why did Hata know Yakumo? For a moment, Gotou was surprised, but then he remembered .

Come to think of it, he had carelessly talked to Hata about Yakumo during the last case .

'Why do you want to meet Yakumo?'

'Scientific interest . '

'I refuse!'

Gotou cut Hata down immediately .

Scientific interest? It was just his perverted desires .

If he thoughtlessly let Hata meet Yakumo, he might autopsy him alive .

'Don't say stupid things and get back to work . '

Gotou waved his hand like he was shooing away a wild dog . Then, he took out another cigarette and lit it .

'Gotou-san, do you have some time?'

Who was it now? It was a rookie who'd just been placed .

Gotou had forgotten his name . No, he hadn't known it in the first place .

'What?'

'There is something I would like you to look at . '

The rookie held a photo out towards Gotou . This was –

Gotou couldn't hide his surprise .

3

Haruka woke up to the sound of rustling fabric .

She had fallen asleep on the table at some time .

Her blurry vision slowly became clearer . She saw a man sitting in front of her looking displeased .

'What on earth are you doing here?'

A pointed way of talking . Ah, so it was Yakumof .

Haruka rubbed her eyes and lifted her head .

Yakumo had his usual bedhead . He was wearing a black jersey .

'Morning . '

As Haruka greeted him, she looked at the clock in the corner of the room .

It was still before six . It looked like she'd slept for about fifteen minutes .

'Explain what you're doing,' said Yakumo, running a hand through his messy hair . He sounded irritated .

It made sense . Anybody would be angry if somebody broke into their room .

'Actually – '

Haruka explained the strange thing she had experienced .

Something must have happened to Shiori .

When Haruka was sure of that, she went to see Yakumo, even though she knew it was an unusual time .

He didn't answer when she knocked or called .

Haruka had been troubled and finally tried the doorknob – it had opened without any resistance .

Yakumo had been sleeping in the corner of the room, curled up in a sleeping bag . He had looked like he was in a bad mood even while sleeping, so

Haruka had decided to wait until he woke up and sat down on the chair .

Then –

'So you'll go into people's room without permission if the door is unlocked?'

Once Haruka finished her explanation, that was the first thing Yakumo said .

'You're at fault for being careless . Locks are there to be locked . Did you know that?'

'I don't want to hear that from a blockhead who left her auto-locked apartment without her key . '

Haruka had no way of winning against Yakumo in an argument .

Yakumo yawned and stood up . Then, he turned his back to Haruka and suddenly started taking off his shirt .

'Wait – what are you doing?' said Haruka, covering her eyes with her hands .

'I'm obviously changing . '

Haruka was astonished .

How insensitive was he?

'Starting to change in front of a girl – what kind of sense do you have?'

'I'm just going to say this, but this is my room . I can do what I want . Don't speak so loftily when you sneaked into a guy's room without permission . '

Now that he said that, it was true .

So many things had happened that Haruka was less wary of Yakumo, but now that she thought about it, this was the same as sneaking into the house

of a man who lived alone at dawn .

Her face went red like it had been lit on fire .

And, now that she thought about it more, she had no makeup on .

'Yakumo, you here?'

After hearing a familiar thick voice, the door suddenly opened .

Gotou was the one who showed up .

When Gotou saw Haruka in Yakumo's room, his eyes went wide .

It was like he had seen the end of the world .

The cigarette in his mouth fell to the ground .

'Ah, sorry . '

'E-er, this is – that's – that's not it...'

Haruka frantically made excuses, but she couldn't find an appropriate explanation and was flustered .

The misunderstanding just grew bigger .

'No, it's fine . I'll come after . '

Gotou closed one eye clumsily . He had probably meant it to be a wink .

Then, he closed the door and left .

What terrible timing . He had completely misunderstood . Haruka would have misunderstood too if she had been in the situation .

'Everyone's noisy this morning,' mumbled Yakumo, sounding annoyed .

When Haruka looked, Yakumo had already finished changing and was scratching his bedhead .

He was pretty carefree .

'Hey, what should we do? He misunderstood and left . '

'Is that inconvenient?'

'Inconvenience isn't the problem here, right?'

'It's nothing to be concerned about . People will wonder about other people's actions even if they don't do anything . People will suspect you no matter what you do . '

'That's...'

Was it true –

'Well, you don't have to fuss so much – that old man always follows the same pattern in his actions . '

After saying that, Yakumo walked up to the frosted glass window opposite the door and forced it open .

Standing there, stooped over and peering into the room, was Gotou .

'You found out?'

'What do you mean, you found out? Please don't act like a child at your age . If you keep doing things like that, your wife will run away again . '

'Again? What do you mean, again? Got this, Yakumo? Women who run away once won't come back a second time . It's too late to regret afterwards . '

'Oh, so your wife isn't back yet . And it looks like you're reflecting on your actions a bit . '

Gotou gritted his teeth .

'I don't want to hear that from a gutless guy who won't do anything even with such a cute girl in front of him . '

Gotou snorted .

'The reason I won't do anything with her isn't a matter of will . '

'What?'

'It's this person's tastes . That is, it's a matter of my preferences . '

Saying that right in front of me –

Haruka didn't even feel like objecting .

'If you've got the time to say boring things, please get in already . You have some business, don't you?'

'Ah, that's right, that's right . I almost forgot . '

Gotou nodded, ending their joking conversation, and went to the front, coming in through the door .

Haruka felt awkward facing Gotou like this . She had to change too, and she was concerned about her room, which she had left unlocked .

Haruka told Yakumo that she would come back later and left his secret hideaway .

4

'Even though she came all the way here . I feel like I did something bad . '

Gotou scratched his stomach as he sat in the chair Haruka had been in .

However, it was also true that he didn't want Haruka to hear what he was about to say .

Though last time it had all been facts that he knew, this time it was just Gotou's theory, and it was also a personal privacy issue .

Forget about his boss – he hadn't even talked to his colleagues about this .

'Though I'm grateful that there's one fewer noisy person here,' Yakumo said in his usual acerbic tone as he yawned .

Gotou smiled wryly .

Though this guy was saying this, Gotou thought that he actually felt differently on the inside .

Maybe it wasn't romantic, but Yakumo definitely trusted Haruka . They had some problems, but Yakumo definitely thought her more important than others .

But if Gotou pointed that out, Yakumo definitely wouldn't acknowledge it .

Yakumo might not have noticed himself .

'What are you smirking about? It's creepy . '

Gotou came back to his senses .

He was annoyed, but he had no way of beating Yakumo in an argument .

'So what does the busy detective need from me so early in the morning?'

When Yakumo spoke politely, it just sounded like superficial courtesy .

'It might be morning for you, but it's still night for me – I haven't slept a wink . '

'I don't really care about your lack of a sense of time . '

'Ah, yeah, you don't care . '

Yakumo's words really irritated him, but if Gotou retorted to each one, it'd burn a hole through his stomach lining .

Gotou decided to continue talking .

'There's something I want you to look at . '

'It's spirit photography, isn't it . '

'Correct . How'd you know?'

'There isn't anything else you'd show me, Gotou-san,' said Yakumo .

'I don't remember showing you anything else either . '

As Gotou said that, he placed the brown envelope in his hand on the table, took a number of photos out and spread them out .

A burnt house was in the first photo .

The photos were probably from right after the fire .

Some of the pillars that were left were still smoking .

Gotou placed the second photo down . There was a person burnt completely black in it . The person was face-up, reaching up with a hand and looking pained .

'Taken this morning . And...'

Gotou placed another photo down .

There was a woman probably in her early thirties .

The photo was probably taken at a wedding reception . She wore a gaudy purple dress and was laughing with her mouth wide open .

'Is this woman the burnt corpse from earlier?'

'Yeah . '

Gotou placed one more photo down .

It was the same burnt house in the earlier photo, but there was somebody standing in the house in this one . A woman in white .

'This is...' said Yakumo .

Gotou smirked at that .

'So you can tell? It's probably just what you think . There wasn't anybody there when the photo was taken...'

'Thinking normally, it would probably be the spirit of the woman who burnt to death, but since you went out of your way to bring it here, is there something that makes you think otherwise?'

'You really are sharp . I'd like to have you as a subordinate . '

'I'd rather die first . '

'Do you dislike the police so much?'

'Please don't misunderstand me . The one I dislike is you, Gotou-san . '

That was quite a firm tone .

Gotou ignored Yakumo and took out another photo to put on the table .

There was a dark-skinned man in his late thirties . He had a sharp profile that didn't look Japanese .

Though he was handsome, he looked sickly and swollen .

'This person has a disease in his internal organs, doesn't he . '

'Correct again – congrats . You win a trip to Hawaii . '

'Says someone who's never left the Kantou region,' muttered Yakumo loudly so that Gotou would be able to hear .

Shut up! No, just ignore it . Ignore it .

Gotou continued his explanation .

'The man's name is Katou Kenichi . Died of a heart failure last month, but there was something suspicious about his death . After investigating, it turns out he'd been taking small doses of poison for a long time . '

'How'd you find that out?'

'There's a perverted old man who loves looking into that sort of stuff, see . '

'How excellent . You should learn from him, Gotou-san . '

Gotou felt unpleasant just recalling that perverted old man's face .

Is he kidding? Who'd learn from that?

'Since the culprit's got to be somebody who can give him doses of poison continuously, that naturally narrows down the suspects . '

'A relative then . '

'Right . Katou Kenichi was pretty wealthy . Well, he himself only had a small realtor's office, but his dad had a lot of land . '

'For the inheritance then?'

'Right . He had one younger brother, but he was quite the player . His dad ended up leaving all the inheritance to his brother Kenichi . '

'So you suspected the younger brother?'

'The younger brother came up in the investigation, but he lives in the next city and doesn't really come here, so he was left out . Remaining is...'

'He had a wife . And that burnt corpse is that wife . '

Gotou clapped his hands together without thinking .

'Exactly . It's easy explaining to you . '

'Please forget about the boring interjections and finish your explanation already . '

What an impatient guy .

'The police marked his wife, Fumiko . After getting the evidence, the police were on the verge of arresting her when a letter came . It was from Fumiko, saying she couldn't deal with her guilty conscience and would take her own life...'

'And that fire in the photo was a result of her suicide . '

'Right . When we got there, the house was already burning . '

'Is it definitely from her?'

'Yeah, the handwriting analysis is done . '

'Isn't that nice? That's the end of it then . '

Yakumo yawned, seeming bored .

The end of it? To hell with that .

'Do you think I'd come all the way here if it was?'

'You have a lot of free time . '

Gotou would punch this guy .

'This is just my gut – I have no evidence . '

'Will that be of any use?'

And he never shut up!

'I don't think that woman had the balls to kill herself . Looking at the way she killed her husband, Kenichi, she's careful and cunning . '

'Well, that's true . '

'Without that perverted coroner, we probably wouldn't have found out the truth behind the murder . She'd been intent on killing her husband for years and years and acted like she didn't know it . It's not your average brand of boldness . '

Gotou said that all at once and hit the table in his agitation .

Yakumo pinched his brow with his fingers – it looked like he was thinking .

'So what do you think actually happened, Gotou-san?'

'I suspect the brother, Junichi . Kenichi was killed by his wife, Eriko, and Eriko was killed by his younger brother, Junichi . Since then the inheritance would go to Junichi . '

'Then, can't you just go get the person named Junichi-san?'

Gotou groaned and scratched his head .

'Tried that already, but the guy's got an alibi . Got a parking ticket and went to the precinct . And it was because of Junichi's car that the firefighters arrived late . The story's too neat . '

A steel alibi .

Gotou was at the end of his rope .

'So what are you telling me to do?'

Asking that even though he knew .

Though Gotou thought that, he explained anyway .

'I think this ghost photo might be a lead . '

'I see . I understand, but there is too little information and the story is too abstract – I don't know where to start at all . '

'So it's really no use...'

'I can't guarantee it, but I'll look into what I can . '

'Really?'

The conversation ended quickly for one with Yakumo – Gotou stood up in his surprise .

'But please allow this to clear the favour from last time,' said Yakumo, pointing at Gotou .

Gotou understood now .

So Yakumo had anticipated it .

If Yakumo refused, Gotou had been thinking about threatening him with the favour form last time .

This guy really is cunning –

5

Haruka asked the apartment administration to unlock the entrance and somehow managed to enter the room .

Since the entrance did have an auto-lock, her room was fortunately intact .

After letting out a sigh of relief, her phone rang .

It wasn't her mobile, but the home phone she rarely used .

'Hello?'

When Haruka picked up the review, there was a long silence . Then, the phone call ended .

A prank call?

Haruka took a shower and changed .

She wanted to go straight to Yakumo's, but she didn't want to meet Gotou again . She sat down on the bed and looked out the glass door .

She tried to understand what had happened last night, but it wouldn't be so easy .

She couldn't even tell what was reality and what was illusion .

The curtains waved in the wind .

That was strange . The glass door should not have been open .

Haruka stood up and walked to the glass door .

Between the lace curtains, on the other side of the glass door, there stood Shiori .

'... Shiori?'

Haruka hurriedly pushed the windows aside, opened the glass door and went out on to the veranda .

However, no matter how she looked, she didn't see Shiori .

Where did she go?

Haruka leant over the veranda to look, but there was no way she'd be there . This was the fourth floor of the apartment .

There was no way for somebody to be on her veranda .

It must have been an illusion –

Haruka went to Yakumo's secret hiding place after noon .

She had put on makeup properly this time and was wearing a turtleneck sweater with a denim skirt, instead of pyjamas .

'Honestly, I'm not a detective . Why does everyone do this...'

That was what Yakumo said right after Haruka came to visit again .

As Yakumo spoke without even hiding his displeasure, he boiled water with an alcohol lamp and beaker .

Gotou had probably brought him some sort of trouble too .

Though Yakumo was complaining, to be honest, Haruka thought it'd be better for everyone if he became a spiritual detective or something .

While Haruka was thinking that, a teacup was placed in front of Haruka .

It was green tea .

'Eh? Could you have been boiling this in the beaker earlier?'

'There's no "could" about it – I was . I borrowed it from the lab . It'll be happy being used by me than for some incomprehensible scientific experiments . '

Ack . What kind of nerves did he have?

'I don't think that's the problem... If I drink this, it'll hurt my stomach . '

'Stop complaining and just drink it . The secret ingredient is hydrochloric acid . '

Like she'd drink this!

'So what did you want to talk about?' urged Yakumo .

How should she explain? Haruka couldn't think of an effective way, so she just told Yakumo what had happened in order .

Yakumo crossed his arms and leant back on his chair, listening silently as he looked up at the ceiling .

If somebody who didn't know him were looking, his attitude might have made them feel indignant, but Yakumo was still listening properly even if he acted like this .

'A better explanation than Gotou-san's . ' Yakumo smiled as he put his hands together and placed his elbows on the table . 'That old man tries to make his stories dramatic and throws the order out the window – it makes it hard for the listener . '

Haruka hadn't experienced herself, so she couldn't say .

'So what can you understand?'

'That's different . An easy-to-understand story is different from understanding what's behind a story . '

That was true .

However, Haruka didn't have anything to say back to that .

Her shoulders drooped in disappointment .

'However, I understand to a point the possibilities of what might have happened around you . '

Yakumo started to speak, bringing the conversation together .

'Possibilities?'

'Yes . There are two possibilities I can think of . Even you should have come to this conclusion if you heard the story objectively, but you've been very subjective about it . '

'Subjective?'

'Because of that, you rejected both of the possibilities you could naturally have reached before noticing either of them . '

'Huh...'

Haruka didn't understand what Yakumo was talking about .

'Let's verify that . First, one possibility is that all you saw was an illusion . '

'That's not it . I saw it with these eyes,' Haruka said firmly .

'See, you just rejected a possibility, right?'

Haruka understood now what he'd meant .

Just as Yakumo said, if she had been listening as a third party, she would have definitely suggested that possibility first .

So that was what he was talking about .

'What you saw was all an illusion, and your friend moved away without telling you because of some circumstances...'

'Shiori definitely wouldn't...'

'Listen to me until the end,' reprimanded Yakumo .

'But...'

'It's because you erase possibilities like this that your reasoning fails . '

'But...'

'It is entirely possible that she had to move in a hurry and will contact you afterwards . Maybe you'll be able to laugh it off as something silly once you hear the circumstances . '

That was true, now that Yakumo said it .

Haruka felt her shoulders relax slightly . Though Yakumo didn't seem to like it, she really was glad that she'd talked to Yakumo .

'And the other possibility?'

When Haruka asked that, Yakumo's expression clearly changed .

'I didn't want to talk about it until I knew more about the situation if possible, but...'

'It's one of the possibilities, right?'

'Yes . I want you to listen to this just as a possibility . '

Haruka nodded .

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair and started to speak .

'Supposing what you saw wasn't an illusion...'

I don't want to hear it .

Somebody in her head said that . Probably herself . Another self .

But that voice didn't reach Yakumo . Yakumo's words continued mercilessly .

'Perhaps your friend is already dead . If she appeared in front of you as a ghost...'

Haruka felt like she had fallen from a high place .

Her ears were ringing . She couldn't hear the rest of Yakumo's words .

Dead because she's a ghost? Shiori was dead? No . That can't be . I don't want to acknowledge it . Aren't there living ghosts?

Living ghosts –

'Hey, there are things like living ghosts, right? Aren't those the spirits of living people?'

Haruka gripped the table and leant forward .

Though Yakumo looked dubious at Haruka's sudden action, he still responded to Haruka's question .

'It isn't entirely impossible . Just as I said before, if ghosts are the clusters of people's emotions, I can't deny the possibility that they'd leave the body even without dying . The living ghosts you're talking about are often referred to as out-of-body experiences . A third possibility...'

Yakumo kept talking as he rubbed his furrowed brows .

Haruka waited for Yakumo to gather his thoughts .

'Though it's a hopeful perspective, it isn't as if that wouldn't work . Shall we bet on that possibility?'

A flame of hope lit up in Haruka's chest just from hearing Yakumo's words .

She'd be able to meet Shiori . Definitely .

7

Yakumo and Haruka first headed for the management company of the apartment Shiori lived in .

Haruka remembered that they had looked for rooms together when they first came to Tokyo .

It was a mall shop by the shopping street in front of the station .

On the way, Yakumo bought an assortment of cookies from the bakery . It was wrapped nicely and even had origami on it .

Of course Haruka paid .

Yakumo didn't explain what it was for and just said it was a necessary expense .

There was a table for guests and a counter, with a desk in the back .

That was all there was in this constrained space .

Even though there were customers, nobody greeted them with a 'Welcome' . But it wasn't like the employees were working so hard that they wouldn't notice .

'Excuse me . '

When Yakumo leant over the counter and called out, a bald man appeared .

'Excuse me . I'm the older brother of Itou Shiori, who lived at 204 Heights Hinoki . It seems like my sister forgot something... I'm sorry, but could I borrow the key?'

Yakumo politely said a number of lies .

The bald man didn't check anything . He just took a key from the key rack on the wall in the back and handed it to Yakumo . He didn't say anything .

'Ah, by the way, did my sister come to greet you properly?'

The bald man shook his head, still silent .

'As I thought . That girl... I told her she had to properly greet the management company she was under the care of . She really is irresponsible that way . '

Yakumo kept going .

However, it was a natural performance .

'Ah, I'm sorry about being late, but please eat this with everyone . '

Yakumo handed the box of baked goods they bought to the bald man .

The bald man's expression went soft immediately . How easy to understand .

'The truth is, we're troubled too . She suddenly called, saying she would cancel the contract, and came the day after to return her key . We were at fault too, but we haven't even heard her address for returning the deposit . '

'I'm really sorry . '

Yakumo looked completely like an apologetic older brother as he continued .

'Ah, if there are any necessary documents, I'll write them right now, so would you show me the contract?'

'Ah, wait a sec . '

The bald man went back to his desk and took one contract from the pile of documents there .

Yakumo looked at it fastidiously .

Haruka peered at it from behind .

The cancellation form was stapled to the last page of the contract, and the new address was in Nagano . Shiori's home address was written there .

Shiori's home in Nagano was burnt there . It wasn't there any more . But –

Haruka had a bad feeling .

'I'll make Shiori come again and properly fill in what's necessary for the deposit repayment too . '

'I'm sorry about that . '

The bald man wiped his forehead with a handkerchief .

'Did my sister cause any other trouble?'

After thinking for a bit, the bald man brought his face close to Yakumo's and started speaking .

'Ah, I don't know if it's all right for me to tell this to her big brother, but a man would go in and out . Well, it's nothing strange for a woman that age, so I didn't say anything, but...'

Shiori's boyfriend? Haruka hadn't heard about that .

Haruka knew the boyfriend Shiori had had until two years ago, but Shiori hadn't shown any signs of dating someone afterwards .

Up until now, Shiori would always tell Haruka in detail even if she didn't ask .

'And then, at some point it became a warzone . Another girl was there and there was a scuffle in front of the apartment . There were complaints from the neighbours too... I think that might have been the reason she moved...'

'That's a lie!'

Haruka spoke up without thinking . The bald man stared at her .

'Ah, thank you . I'll return the key tomorrow . '

Yakumo said that quickly, grabbed Haruka's arm and left the shop .

The story just now was completely different from Haruka's image of Shiori .

Shiori wasn't the type to fight over a man .

Haruka had been with Shiori all this time . When they fought, Shiori always apologised first .

That had irritated her . It had felt like Shiori was treating her like a child . That had made them fight more .

For that Shiori to get into a scuffle –

* * *

Haruka and Yakumo stood in front of the apartment that Shiori had lived in .

It was an old two-storey apartment .

There was rust on the railings and the walls were dirty too . When Haruka thought about how Shiori wasn't here any more, it felt even dirtier .

'Probably nothing is left,' murmured Yakumo as he took the stairs up .

Haruka didn't mind . If she didn't look at it herself, she felt like she wouldn't be able to acknowledge that Shiori had gone .

Haruka followed Yakumo's back and went up to the door to Room 204 .

Yakumo opened the door, letting out a sweet smell .

It was the smell of Shiori's room . She didn't really move . She was still here .

Haruka pushed past Yakumo and went inside .

'Shiori...'

However, it was just an empty space .

There weren't even cardboard boxes, let alone furniture . It was cleaned up well – somebody could move in right now and it wouldn't be a problem .

All that was left was the smell –

'How clean,' said Yakumo, who had come in .

Yakumo walked to the centre of the room and looked around .

A six-tatami room with a kitchen and bathroom . A regular one-person apartment .

'Hey, did that girl called Shiori smoke?'

Haruka shook her head .

She hadn't ever seen Shiori do that .

'Why?'

'Look at the walls . '

Haruka looked at the wall as she was told .

There was the yellow of tobacco resin on the walls .

Though Haruka didn't realise upon first look, only the places where furniture and photos had been remained their original white colour .

Parts of Shiori that Haruka didn't know kept appearing .

She felt weak . Haruka sat down right there .

The wooden floor was cold . Yakumo went to the bathroom .

'Could you come here?'

After a while, she heard Yakumo's voice .

Haruka stood up and looked inside the bathroom .

Yakumo took out a photo . Shiori was in it . She had a really gentle smile .

It was a completely different from the smile she had when looking at Haruka .

Next to her was a man with finely chiselled features . He was probably in his late thirties .

'Is this Shiori?'

'Yes... Where'd you find this?'

'The mirror... It's unnatural . '

'Why? Didn't she just forget it?'

'No . This place is so keen – she wouldn't have left behind one photo . And if the photo had always been there, it would be wet from the humidity . '

This photo wasn't wet at all and didn't look like it had been . Come to think of it, it was true .

Shiori was always meticulous . She even kept a diary .

'She probably left it on purpose . '

'Why?'

'She probably wanted somebody to see it,' said Yakumo, scratching the back of his ear .

'Who?'

'You, maybe . '

Me?

Haruka looked at the photo in her hand, but why did Shiori leave this photo? Haruka didn't understand .

'Does she not have a pinkie finger on her right hand?' said Yakumo, pointing at the photo .

'She doesn't . She was in an accident when she was young... She said she doesn't mind at all, but I think she really did . '

'She's strong . '

'Shiori never talks to anybody even when anything tough or sad happens to her . She takes everything on herself and always tells people about it afterwards...'

Shiori was always like that . She never showed what she was thinking on her face .

'Hey, why do you think Shiori didn't tell me about her lover?'

'Probably because it was adultery . '

'Eh? How can you tell?'

'Look at the man in the photo . He has a wedding ring . '

'Eh?'

Haruka looked at the photo again .

It was just as Yakumo said . The man's left hand had a silver ring on his ring finger .

'I suspect the sensitivity of a man who would keep his wedding ring on when taking a photo with another woman . '

Yakumo didn't have the right to talk about other people's insensitivity either .

But –

'Why wouldn't she tell me it was adultery?'

'If you knew, wouldn't you object to it?'

'That...'

Haruka thought of something then .

When Haruka had heard that the man Shiori was dating had been two-timing, she had gone out of her way to go to find that man and complain .

'Probably nobody wants their lover to be rejected . '

That was true .

There was nothing sadder than having something important to you be rejected . Especially by a friend .

Haruka was angry at herself .

'What is that? Are you saying it's my fault? Because I'm stiff and stubborn, Shiori didn't tell me – that's what you're saying, right?'

'What, so you know . '

Yakumo was as acerbic as always even now .

'That's awful . '

'You don't have the time to start sobbing here . '

When Yakumo told her that, Haruka bit her lip .

That's right . I have to look for Shiori .

8

Gotou woke up to the sound of his mobile phone .

He remembered up to leaving Yakumo's secret hideaway and returning to the precinct by car .

It looks like he'd fallen asleep at the wheel . Natural, since he hadn't slept properly .

'Who is it?'

Gotou answered the phone in an unpleasant mood after waking up, without checking the ID .

<What sort of telephone manner is that?>

'What, it's you, Yakumo...'

Gotou rubbed his eyes, yawned and put a cigarette in his mouth, lighting it .

<Don't just say "what" . Honestly . >

He heard Yakumo's usual voice .

Gotou didn't want to hear that from a voice that was even sleepier than he was .

'What do you want?'

<I acquired some useful information regarding your request, Gotou-san, but since you don't seem that interested, I'll hang up . >

Gotou woke up immediately . He leapt up from the seat .

'What did you find out?' said Gotou with vigour .

However, it looked like those words hadn't reached Yakumo .

There was just a beeping noise .

'That guy . He really hung up...'

Who the hell does he think I am?

Gotou immediately called Yakumo back, but Yakumo wouldn't answer even after multiple calls . He was enjoying Gotou's frantic response .

An even worse personality than Gotou's wife, who had left the house .

It took a full five minutes before Yakumo answered .

'Ah, Yakumo-kun, I'm sorry about earlier . I'm reflecting on it . Really . '

<Do you always apologise to your wife like this?>

'Ack . '

If Yakumo had been in front of him, Gotou would have wanted to punch him .

Well, Gotou was the one who'd made the request, so even if Yakumo were in front of him, Gotou couldn't do that .

All Gotou could do was force a laugh out . He just wanted to get to the topic .

'So what did you find out?'

<Before that, there is somebody I would like you to find out the whereabouts of . >

'What?'

<It's her friend . >

'By her, do you mean Haruka-chan?'

<Yes . Her friend's name is Itou Shiori...>

'Oi, oi . Wait a sec . Even if it's your request, I can't look for her friend . You should know that much, right?'

What on earth was he thinking?

That was too much as an exchange .

<Well, please don't make such a fuss . If you listen to what I'm about to say, you'll want to look for her, Gotou-san . >

Was this some sort of hypnotism?

'Is she some amazing beauty?' joked Gotou, but Yakumo completely ignored him .

<The woman named Shiori cancelled her contract at her apartment a few days ago and suddenly disappeared . >

'That's common among young woman . '

<I went to the apartment she used to live in today and found something interesting in her room . '

Acting all mysterious .

'What was it?'

<A photo with her lover . >

'That's not strange or anything . '

Gotou felt a bit disappointed after Yakumo had said something meaningful like 'you'll want to look for her' .

<And if the person beside her were Katou Kenichi-san? Wouldn't that pique your interest?>

'What? She was Katou Kenichi's lover!?'

Gotou was so agitated that he hit the wheel .

The horn honked loudly, even surprising himself .

<I can't say anything for certain yet, but you can't say it's completely unrelated to your case, right, Gotou-san?>

It was just as Yakumo said .

The lover of a man who had been killed had gone missing with this timing . It couldn't be a coincidence .

'I'll go there in two hours,' shouted Gotou . Then, he hung up, got off the car and ran .

9

After parting with Yakumo, Haruka trudged back to her room at the apartment .

Yakumo instructed her to talk to her and Shiori's mutual friends about the situation .

Haruka took out her high school graduation album and flipped through the pages while looking for people that would fit, when her intercom rang .

What was it? She saw a mailman through the intercom monitor .

'Excuse me, could you stamp this?'

He held out an envelope that required proof of delivery .

There was no sender, but Haruka could tell it was from Shiori immediately from the handwriting . Haruka was so agitated that she snatched the envelope .

'Er, excuse me . The stamp . A signature would be fine too . '

The mailman's urging brought Haruka back to her senses .

She borrowed a pen from him and signed . Then, she shut the door .

With shaking hands, she opened the envelope . Five sheets of paper came out .

<To Haruka – >

They were sharp letters for a woman .

Haruka had made fun of Shiori because her writing was like a man's . It really was Shiori . Haruka was glad . Her chest felt warm .

She recalled one of the possibilities that Yakumo had mentioned .

He'd said that Shiori might have moved away silently and that when Haruka heard the reason, she would think it was silly .

Haruka went into her room, sat on the bed and started to read the letter .

That letter began with <Sorry> .

10

Gotou went to Yakumo's secret hideaway exactly two hours afterwards .

'For Gotou-san to be on time, it's rarer than a horse race ticket that pays out one hundred times its value . '

Acerbic right as he opened the door .

Gotou suspected that if Yakumo couldn't say sarcastic things, he probably wouldn't open his mouth for the whole day .

Even objecting would be troublesome, so Gotou sat down silently .

'Did you find anything out?' asked Yakumo as he stretched in a bored manner .

'You make it sound so simple . There's a limit to what you can do in just two hours . Police investigation power isn't bottomless . '

'Though you were the one who said two hours later, Gotou-san . '

'Ah, yeah, I was at fault . '

Gotou threw the envelope he'd brought on the table .

'The results of two hours of investigation . '

Yakumo took the contents out of the envelope and started looking at the documents .

'Anyway, at the current stage, I know the name and address . And workplace . '

'She's a department salesperson?'

'Yeah . She suddenly quit there a few days ago too . Seems like a request was sent in . Don't know if it was the department manager or section manager, but they were really angry . '

Gotou recalled the situation .

Even though it wasn't like Gotou was at fault, the manager had turned all that anger towards him .

Gotou was irritated just thinking about it .

'What the hell do they think the police are?'

'Thank you for your hard work protecting the safety of citizens . I'll listen to your complaints afterwards, so please continue . '

Right .

Gotou cleared his throat and continued .

'Her parents died a year ago in a fire . Her only relative is her grandmother, but she's got dementia . She's in a facility . Seems like she'll be taken care of until her death with the girl's parents' insurance . '

'Not a single relative then?'

'Yeah . Her grandmother can't even recognise her grandkid's face . The land where the burnt house was has already been sold...'

After saying that much, the feeling of discomfort Gotou had had during the investigation came up again .

'What's wrong?' said Yakumo, who had already noticed Gotou's unease .

'No, I was just wondering why she didn't return home when her parents died . '

'Maybe she didn't have anywhere to return to?'

'Maybe . Places for people to return to come about when there's somebody there for them . '

'It seems you've grown to understand other people's feelings slightly . '

Yakumo smirked .

'You're the last person I want to hear that from!'

Gotou bared his teeth as he said that threatening .

'But if she had no place to return to, then where did she go?'

'There's only one place people go when they've lost the place they return to...' Yakumo said with sad eyes .

Actually, where did Yakumo return to? That thought suddenly came to Gotou .

Maybe he was one of those people with nowhere to return too .

'I thought about asking some movers I know, but it was no use . '

'No use?'

'She sold all her furniture . The stuff she couldn't sell, she got rid of . And she cancelled her mobile contract that day too . Seems like she wasn't planning on going anywhere . Just like you said...'

She wanted death .

A lonely woman killed the man she loved .

She probably had no more reason to live . Her reason to live –

Did you need a reason to live? Gotou's mind was wandering again because he was tired .

'Anyway, let's give up on finding her for now... Ah, I almost forgot . This is the only clue that I got . '

'What is it?'

'I talked to the apartment's management company . Apparently, a man who called himself her brother came today and borrowed the apartment key . She should be an only child . It's shady, right? I sent the fingerprints in – they're being analysed now . '

Yakumo thrust his thumb out between Gotou's eyes .

'Hm? What?'

'It's this . '

'What is?'

'The fingerprint on the key . It's this . '

'What?'

'I'm saying that I was the one who called himself her brother and borrowed the key . So my fingerprint will show up . '

'You idiot! Say that earlier! I was looking into it . '

'You didn't ask . Anyway, please just cover it up appropriately . '

Gotou's strength left him in his disappointment and he hung his head .

On top of the only clue disappearing, he had even more work now . This pest!

'But you've done well investigating this much in just two hours . '

'Much better than being praised by the chief, but I still don't want to hear that from you!' yelled Gotou, pointing at Yakumo . His temper had reached its limit .

'You're noisy . '

Yakumo stuck his fingers in his ears and frowned .

'Well anyway, my gut feeling is that the girl named Shiori is suspicious . No, I feel bad about Haruka-chan, but Shiori's black . She killed Fumiko and disappeared . Revenge for killing her lover . It matches up . '

'It doesn't,' said Yakumo, crossing his arms .

'Why not?'

This guy always complained about what other people thought .

'Isn't there a will?'

'You know, it's that thing . Forced the wife to write it with a knife or something,' said Gotou, mimicking holding out a knife .

'Does the handwriting seem like it was written under threat? And being told to write a will makes it certain that you'll be killed . If the wife had been forced to write it, she would have written something for help . Anyway, it's unnatural . '

Now that Yakumo said that, it was true .

'What you thought first is the most likely, Gotou-san,' said Yakumo, ending the conversation .

What the hell had those two hours been for?

Gotou suddenly felt exhausted .

'This is depressing...'

'Well, in any case, leaving this as it is would be unpleasant . We have nothing to lose, so let's...'

'Go to the scene of the crime!'

Gotou regained his energy and finished Yakumo's sentence .

11

When Haruka finished reading the letter from Shiori, her head went blank .

She couldn't believe any of it .

Even though the writing on the letter was Shiori's, it felt like the contents were from someone else .

The letter that started with 'Sorry' first wrote about the man that Shiori was dating .

Just as Yakumo thought, they had had an adulterous relationship .

They met at a bar and started talking suddenly .

He had a problem with the relationship with his wife and said that he didn't have anywhere to return to .

Shiori had felt that she didn't have a place to return to either .

They made a place they could both return to .

Soon, Shiori became pregnant . He decided to leave his wife too .

And then, he died –

It was a heart failure . Shiori had miscarried in shock .

However, Shiori didn't accept that .

Shiori remembered what he had said to her .

I'll be killed by my wife –

Could it be? Shiori was thinking that and about to investigate when the wife came to Shiori's home .

Then, the wife gave her one million yen, telling Shiori not to spread any dumb rumours .

At that time, Shiori realised . She had killed him –

Then, she had a fight with her in front of the apartment .

Ever since then, Shiori felt hate towards her and a killing intent .

She had killed the person Shiori loved and even given money to Shiori to keep her quiet . Shiori couldn't forgive her nerve . Shiori didn't have anything else to love .

Shiori killed her and decided to die herself .

Then, at the end of the letter, she wrote 'Sorry' again .

All she had kept quiet until now . Troubling Haruka, since her friend was a murderer .

Deciding to die on her own –

It was selfish . It really was . Shouldering everything herself like that . Haruka wouldn't forgive Shiori if she died .

But how can I save her if I don't know where she is –

There's one person! Just one person who might be able to save Shiori .

Haruka picked up her mobile .

12

Gotou looked out from the driver's seat .

The layers of clouds moved slowly, covering the sky which had started to grow dark .

'Looks like rain,' he said to Yakumo in the passenger seat .

However, Yakumo didn't respond, like he hadn't heard anything .

He had been thinking seriously about something since earlier .

Gotou had no way of knowing what Yakumo was thinking . All he could do was ask .

'Hey, what are you thinking about?'

'I'm not thinking about anything . '

Yakumo frowned, looking annoyed .

So he doesn't want to talk? Gotou clicked his tongue .

Then, a mobile phone rang .

It wasn't Gotou's . Yakumo took his mobile out of his pocket and answered .

'Hello...'

Yakumo looked suspicious .

Though Gotou couldn't hear the conversation clearly, he could hear a frantic woman's voice . Was it Haruka-chan?

'Please just calm down . I can't tell what you're saying,' Yakumo said like he couldn't stop himself .

'... So you got a letter... I see... And then...'

Gotou almost missed a red light because he was paying attention to Yakumo's conversation .

Gotou slammed the brakes .

He thought that Yakumo would complain about it, but he seemed to be concentrating and didn't say anything .

'I see... I understand... So that's how it was...'

Though it sounded like a slow conversation, Yakumo was somehow able to get something out of Haruka, who seemed disturbed .

'I'll call you after, so wait until then . '

After saying that, Yakumo hung up .

'What was it?'

'It turns out that your gut is sometimes right, Gotou-san . '

This, after talking so seriously?

'Don't say stupid things . Get on with it . '

'She got something . '

'Haruka-chan?'

'Yes . It seems like she received a letter from the girl named Shiori, saying that she killed Fumiko and that she would die too...'

'What? That's bad! We need to stop that Shiori right away!' shouted Gotou, led on by his rising emotions .

'Stop her? How will you find her?'

'Well, somehow...'

Now that Yakumo said that, Gotou realised he was right .

A woman who had disappeared without even telling her best friend wouldn't be easy to find .

'And if she is truly intending to commit suicide, if we think about the timing, she must already be dead . '

'Why do you think that?'

'With Fumiko's death . she achieved her goal . It would be different if she had another . On the other hand, if she doesn't die now, she probably doesn't have any intention of dying afterwards, right?'

'You say that, but people's emotions aren't set results from chemical responses . '

'A difference in opinion . '

Yakumo crossed his arms and looked out the window .

'But that's the end of that . No need to go to the scene now . '

When Gotou tried to make a U-turn, Yakumo stopped him .

'No, let's go . There is something that I can't get off my mind . '

'Something you can't get off your mind? What?'

'...'

Yakumo shut his mouth .

He had probably drawn out the blueprints to the case using his train of thought .

It hurt to admit it, but this guy had never made a wrong guess before .

Gotou decided to go along with Yakumo's theory .

* * *

When Gotou and Yakumo reached the scene of the fire, it had started to drizzle .

Rain in December was so cold that it hurt .

'Hope it doesn't start to snow...' muttered Gotou, looking up at the sky .

Yakumo slowly went to the middle of the building that had burnt down .

'Wait . '

Gotou ran after Yakumo .

Yakumo had gone to the middle of the building, but the ceiling and walls were mostly burnt down – there wasn't much left that could be called a home .

On the floor, there was misshapen glass and plastic .

Puddles from the firefighting efforts were still there .

'There is one thing that concerns me . '

Yakumo's breath came out white as he stood up .

'What?'

'If the girl named Shiori killed Fumiko, why would she make Fumiko send a will to the police?'

'To fool the police, obviously . '

'Is that really the case?'

When Yakumo turned around, his eyes seemed to know something .

It made Gotou feel dread .

'What do you mean?'

'If it were to hide her crime, wouldn't that suggest she wanted to continue living?'

'Well, yeah . '

'Then why did Shiori send her a letter? And saying that she intended to commit suicide at that...'

It was just as Yakumo said .

Gotou's heart was restless .

People who intended to suicide from the beginning wouldn't need to make a murder look like a suicide .

Gotou had thought he'd seen the reality of the case, but it wasn't true .

They were still missing something important .

At his feet, there was water that had been dirtied with ash .

His breath was so white that it cut through his vision .

Yakumo knelt where the white line had been drawn in the shape of a person's body and looked at something .

'What are you looking at?'

Yakumo didn't respond to Gotou's question .

Did he not hear? Or did he not feel like answering? Gotou had no way of knowing .

Either way, all he could do was wait .

Gotou put a cigarette in his mouth and tried to light it, it wouldn't light up properly, perhaps because it was wet .

'Why are you here...' murmured Yakumo .

The sound of the rain hitting the ground continued .

Gotou couldn't see anything .

'I see...You were here from the start . Which means... she...'

When Yakumo said that, there was the sound of thunder from faraway .

'What on earth... Then...'

Yakumo stood up, his expression suddenly changing .

'Oi, Yakumo . What's wrong?'

'Gotou-san, there is something I want you to ask the coroner to confirm immediately . '

'Coroner? What are you saying?'

'Just hurry!' shouted Yakumo with an angry look .

Gotou had never seen Yakumo so agitated . It was urgent . Gotou immediately called Hata's mobile .

<What do you need?>

He heard Hata's relaxed voice after one ring .

'There's something I want you to check . '

<Something you want me to check?>

'Oi, Yakumo! What should he check?'

Yakumo took the mobile from Gotou .

'The burnt corpse from before . Was the pinkie finger on the right hand missing?'

Yakumo held the phone silently .

That response . Looked like Yakumo's hunch had been right, but Gotou didn't know at all what it meant .

When Yakumo hung up, he used Gotou's mobile to make another call .

13

After Haruka finished talking on the phone with Yakumo, she put the letter in her coat pocket and ran out of her flat .

Yakumo had said he'd call afterwards, but afterwards would be too late .

Shiori was trying to end her life now .

She had lost her parents . She had lost the person she loved . She had lost the child of the person she loved . She might have lost the very reason for living .

But did you need a reason to live?

Shiori was probably sad beyond Haruka's imagination .

I might not have the right to say this when I suffered hesitatingly for so many years after my sister's death .

But I still want Shiori to live .

Even if she will have to walk with suffering in the future –

Haruka left the apartment, but she didn't know where to start looking, so she wandered the streets like an abandoned cat .

Soon, rain started to fall .

She walked alone on the road to the park when she heard her mobile phone ring with the sound of the rain .

There was a number Haruka didn't recognise . Could it be? Haruka answered .

<Are you all right? Where are you now?>

It was Yakumo's voice . What did he mean by all right?

<Where are you now?>

Yakumo repeated himself once more while Haruka was confused .

The reserved Yakumo had lost his composure .

'I'm looking for... Shiori...'

<Got this? Return to your home right now . Don't take one step out of it until I get there . >

'What are you talking about? I'm looking for...'

<She's already dead!>

Yakumo's shout pierced Haruka's ears . Her head shook .

Shiori's dead . So she really is...

Unexpectedly, that was the thought that came to her head .

I knew before Yakumo said it . But I just didn't want to acknowledge it –

The corners of her eyes felt warm .

Haruka didn't know if the drops on her cheeks were rain or tears .

<Choose a path with as many people as possible when you head back . >

Yakumo emphasised that .

Many people –

Haruka looked around . She was the only one there .

She heard the sound of a car . A van .

It slowly passed by Haruka . Then, the car door suddenly opened . Hands reached out and pinned Haruka's arms behind her back .

'Ah – '

Something was clamped over her mouth, stopping her yell halfway –

14

'Oi! Give me a reply! Oi! Damn it!' yelled Yakumo, throwing the mobile against the ground .

The flip phone broke in half, and the parts flew about .

'... Oi . That's mine...'

Gotou's voice didn't reach Yakumo .

Gotou picked up his mobile, which was in a sad state .

'Ahh, this is beyond repair . '

'Damn it! What should I do...'

Yakumo kicked the ground in irritation .

'Calm down . What happened?'

Gotou grabbed Yakumo's arm .

'We completely misunderstood!' sad Yakumo, shaking off Gotou's hand .

'Misunderstood?'

'The one who burned to death wasn't Katou Fumiko . It was Shiori-san!'

'W-w-what did you say!?'

Gotou was so shocked that his voice jumped an octave .

'Fumiko's alive! Shiori is probably similar in body shape to Shiori-san .
Same blood type too . That's why she used her as a substitute . '

'You're lying, right?'

'It's the truth . I checked with the coroner just now . Shiori-san lost her right
pinkie finger in an accident when she was young . '

'So the burnt corpse was missing the right pinkie finger too?'

What the hell .

It's because they didn't have enough people working that they ended up
here –

'She sent a will to the police on purpose, killed Shiori-san, lit the place with
gasoline and burnt her house . The younger brother, Junichi, made the
firefighters arrive late by parking on the road . In order to burn the body to
the point that it wouldn't be able to be identified!'

'So showing up at the police for the parking ticket would become his alibi .
,

And they could split the inheritance .

There'd be no search for somebody who was supposed to be dead .

So they would have had an easy life waiting for them .

A cold chill ran down Gotou's spine . It was disgusting . He wanted to
throw up . They were worse than cockroaches .

And they'd totally got them good .

No matter how much forensic science had advanced, they didn't have the money or time to analyse the DNA for every case .

If they had enough evidence, that was the end of it . They'd used that blind spot . That was why they went out of their way to send a will –

'Anyway, let's look for Fumiko right now . '

'It's too late for that!'

Yakumo yelled from the bottom of his stomach .

'Late?'

'Shiori-san sent a letter to her before she died . '

'What you were talking about earlier?'

'Yes . And Fumiko has noticed . '

'Why?'

'The diary . Shiori-san kept one . Shiori-san probably wrote about writing a letter to her in that diary . Katou Fumiko should have her . '

'What did you say!?'

Gotou understood why Yakumo was having a fit .

The only mistake in this plan . That was the letter that Shiori-san left behind .

'So where's Haruka-chan now? I'll send someone . '

'She suddenly ended the call earlier with a scream...' Yakumo replied lifelessly .

So even this cold-hearted person could worry about others like a normal person now .

That was quite the change . Gotou wouldn't let those emotions be stolen from Yakumo . He'd save her no matter what . Gotou was hit by that strong impulse .

'Don't dawdle! We're going!'

Gotou ran towards the car . It was still too early to give up .

15

Haruka was forced into the backseat of the car .

The knife felt cold against her neck . If she moved even a bit, she would be cut .

The man holding the knife to her neck had a face that looked like Shiori's lover .

However, the air about him was completely different .

Though Haruka couldn't see her face clearly, it looked like the driver was a woman .

Her hair was permed into very large curls and the smell of perfume filled the car .

'Where are you going?' asked Haruka, focussing on her trembling throat, but the two of them didn't answer .

'What do you want with me? Who on earth are you?'

A cold sweat ran down her body .

The car stopped at a light .

The woman at the driver's seat leant towards the back and smirked, showing her teeth, yellowed from cigarettes .

'Right . I didn't introduce myself yet, Haruka-chan . '

'Why do you know my name?'

'I asked your friend . Her name was Shiori-chan, right?'

'Do you know Shiori?'

Haruka leant forward, but the man next to her immediately grabbed her and pushed her back down to the seat .

'What a noisy brat,' said the man, his cheek twitching like a mouse's . It was a spiteful and slimy voice .

'My name's Katou Fumiko . That's Katou Junichi,' said the woman driving .

Haruka felt the blood leave her face all at once . This woman was Katou Fumiko .

The woman Shiori was supposed to have killed –

But she was in front of her now . Which meant –

'From that face, you do know the situation . '

Fumiko looked at her coldly .

'...'

'Yes . I made it look like I'm dead . '

Made it look like she was dead?

Could it be –

Haruka glared at Fumiko .

'Don't look like that . I'm not going to do anything to you . '

Fumiko petted Haruka's hair .

A chill ran down Haruka's spine . There was no truth in her words .

If she really wasn't going to do anything, she wouldn't have called herself Fumiko .

'We're looking for a letter . It got to you, right? A letter . '

Ah, so that was their goal .

'I don't know anything about a letter . '

'Don't lie!' said Fumiko . Her palm came flying .

Haruka had no time to avoid it – it hit her . A flash of heat spread through her face .

'There's no point hiding it . It was written in this diary . Saying that she sent a letter to tell only you the truth!'

Fumiko threw a diary at Haruka .

Without saying anything, Haruka embraced that diary .

Oh, so Shiori was killed by this person . As a substitute...

Tremendous sadness and anger boiled up within Haruka at the same time .

'So where's that letter?'

'...'

'I thought it was rude, but I've already searched your room . You're so careless, leaving your room without locking it . '

'...'

Like I'd respond . I've never forgive these people .

'Tell me already! Where is it!?'

The woman slapped Haruka again .

Haruka slammed into the seat . She did it on purpose . She would pretend to be collapsed in pain .

She heard a honk from behind them . The light was already green . Fumiko clicked her tongue and started the car .

Haruka took the letter out of her coat pocket in a way that they wouldn't notice and pushed it into the back of the car seat . She would probably be able to buy some time this way .

However, what was she buying time for?

Despair spread through her chest .

16

They'd got on the car, but where to now?

Driving at random wouldn't solve anything . Where did they have to look to find Haruka-chan?

Damn it . What were they supposed to do? Gotou clicked his tongue .

'Gotou-san, you said that Katou Kenichi had land left to him by his parents, right?'

'Yeah, what about it?'

'What has happened to that land now?'

What the hell was he thinking about at a time like this?

Gotou looked at Yakumo's profile . His expression was the definition of seriousness .

'One plot's that burnt-down house . I think there're some in Shizuoka and Nagano too . And one more should be within the city . I think one of them

was an apartment building that's in construction?'

'There,' Yakumo said with confidence .

'Really?'

Gotou was doubtful, but he didn't have any idea about where else to go .

Yakumo was probably saying it as a possibility too . Thinking about it was a waste of time . They had to bet on that possibility .

Gotou stepped on the pedal .

Gravel flew out behind the wheels as the car sped up .

'They are desperate to get that letter . They need to talk somewhere there aren't many people,' Yakumo said quickly .

'I see...'

If they made the wrong guess, they would be out of luck .

Even if they managed to catch Fumiko in the end, there would definitely be one more corpse .

'I'm gonna fly . Hold on tight . '

Gotou turned on the siren and pressed down on the pedal more .

* * *

The van Katou Fumiko was driving went onto the premises of an apartment building that was under construction .

The building itself was mostly finished .

All that was left was the interior .

They went around the two-storey building to the back, which had an entrance to the basement . They went down the slope .

After reaching the bottom, they turned left . The car stopped at the end of the road . It looked like an underground parking lot .

The only lights were the car's headlights .

Junichi grabbed Haruka's arm and pulled her out of the car .

Haruka fell forward, still holding the diary, and hit her face .

It felt like her lips were cut . Her face twisted in pain, but she didn't even have time to gasp before Junichi grabbed her hair and pulled her up .

'Let go of me – I'll stand up on my own!' yelled Haruka, shaking Junichi's hand away .

Fumiko flicked a switch on the wall .

There was the sound of an electric motor and screeching metal . It was probably to close the garage door . Haruka went pale .

She felt like her light of hope had flickered out .

Now, the parking lot was completely closed off .

Nobody would come save her even if she screamed .

She shut her eyes, knowing that it was too late for her .

I can't stand it . Even though the people who killed Shiori are right in front of me, I can't do anything –

But even if I die, at least Yakumo will find out the truth .

That was the only good thing to come out of this .

Will Yakumo be angry for me?

If I die, will that insensitive and unfriendly contrary man be a little bit sad?

Those thoughts suddenly came to Haruka's head –

* * *

'I hope we make it in time,' murmured Gotou to nobody in particular .

His palms were sweaty because of his agitation, so they didn't have a good grip on the wheel .

'Please make it in time,' Yakumo said immediately .

'You say that so easily . '

'Is it difficult even for you, Gotou-san?'

This guy said really hateful things even at times like this .

'It's no problem . '

Gotou hadn't touched the brakes even once .

Horns kept honking as he kept passing cars .

Though Gotou could hear people screaming, honking and slamming their brakes to avoid Gotou's wild driving, he didn't have the time to worry about that .

If they were a minute – even a second – late, it would be too late .

They had to hurry .

If Haruka-chan didn't immediately hand over the letter under threat, they might be able to save her .

Don't give up . I'm bringing Yakumo now . Do your best .

Gotou thought that, though there was no way for that thought to reach her .

'Gotou-san! Look in front!' shouted Yakumo, just as Gotou was about to cut through an intersection .

The car driving in the opposite direction made a sharp right turn .

'Damn it!'

Gotou turned the wheel, but it was too late .

Thunk!

There was a terrible noise as the car shook .

The car went onto the kerb, mowing down three parked bicycles and slamming into a telephone pole .

The front glass cracked like a spider web, while white smoke came up from the bumper .

Damn it . At a time like this .

Gotou clicked his tongue . He felt something wet on his cheek . After touching it with his hand, he found out it was blood .

He looked at Yakumo in the passenger seat .

'You OK?'

'Somehow...' replied Yakumo, holding his shoulder .

Gotou looked to the back . A black car was stopped by the kerb .

Though the front bumper was damaged, it was just a scratch . Looked like Gotou and Yakumo were the only ones injured .

Gotou tried to turn on the car engine again .

It wouldn't light up . Gotou tried once more .

No luck . Damn it .

'I'm begging you! Work!'

* * *

Junichi took off Haruka's coat and checked everything that could be a pocket .

Fumiko checked Haruka's pants pockets and even stuck her hands up her shirt .

All Haruka could do was stand there and bear with the humiliation .

'Nothing here,' said Junichi, throwing the coat aside .

Fumiko seemed to have given up too, as she went to stand in front of Haruka and held up a knife .

'Why not start talking already? Where's the letter?'

Haruka would be lying if she said she wasn't afraid .

However, that didn't mean she would yield .

She was going to be killed anyway . This was all she could do . Haruka glared straight at Fumiko .

'Do you think you'll be all right? I'm just going to say this, but in the real world, protagonists die . '

'I know that . To speak honestly, you don't plan on letting me go anyway, right?'

After a moment, Fumiko's fist came flying .

It was different than her slaps from earlier . Haruka saw stars as she staggered backwards, hitting the car and falling down .

She could taste blood in her mouth .

'Talk already! We don't have the time for this either!' yelled Fumiko, her hair a mess .

This was good . No matter how tough they acted, these people were worried .

As long as they didn't know where Shiori's letter was, they would have to continue being frightened as they imagined their downfall .

Right . If I use their anxiety or –

But no matter how shaken they were, Haruka couldn't do anything against two people .

'You'll really let me go if I tell you where the letter is?' Haruka said as she stood up slowly .

Fumiko looked surprised, but then that changed right away into a high-pitched laugh .

'Of course, girl . '

Liar! Haruka shouted that in her heart .

'I put the letter in my room . '

'Don't lie . We searched the room . '

'Did you look properly? In the refrigerator, too . '

It was the first lie that came to her head .

She wasn't Yakumo – she wouldn't put everything in a refrigerator .

Junichi looked up, as if thinking .

'Tsk . '

Junichi clicked his tongue and ran towards the car .

Fumiko threw the car key at Junichi . Success .

The garage door opened and the car drove out, tires screeching . Now, Haruka was one-on-one with Fumiko .

'That had better not be a lie or you'll really get it . '

How would she get it? Haruka looked at Fumiko and smiled .

Fumiko's cheek twitched .

'Why did you kill Shiori? Because she stole your husband?'

'You're seriously misunderstanding something . '

'Misunderstanding?'

'Yes . Misunderstanding . '

Fumiko looked down at Haruka triumphantly . There was a faint smile on her lips as she put a cigarette in her mouth and lit it . She blew the smoke out at Haruka .

'Everything went according to plan . Of course that includes making it look like my husband was sick and killing him, but the police seeing through that and finding out it was a murder and your friend noticing that I was the one who killed him – that was part of the plan too...'

'So you planned to kill Shiori from the start . '

'Yup . This plan wouldn't have succeeded without your friend . No, I thought up this plan because of your friend . Our physique and blood type were the same . And her parents were dead too, with no relatives . Don't you think she was asking to be killed as my substitute?'

This person –

'Of course I don't! Shiori wasn't born to be your substitute! Shiori had her own life! You ruined all of that!' yelled Haruka with all her power .

I can't forgive her . I definitely can't forgive her!

For the first time in Haruka's life, she truly hated somebody .

'Don't act so tough!'

Fumiko's fist came at her again . This time, Haruka managed to take it standing .

'You're the one acting tough . '

'Girl . Your friend wouldn't have been wrapped up in this if she didn't commit adultery . She deserved it . Her forbidden love got too hot for her, so she really ended up burning . '

Fumiko laughed aloud .

'You're just angry she stole your husband from you . '

'You just don't shut up . I'm done with you . Die . '

Fumiko put the knife to Haruka's neck .

It felt cold .

It was too late for Haruka now .

Life was too short .

If I die, I'll go meet Yakumo .

Yakumo will definitely find me .

He'll say something sarcastic with his sleepy face as usual, like 'What are you here for?' –

'Don't give up...'

Haruka heard a voice in her ear .

Shiori's voice –

Haruka's eyes snapped open . There was a light of hope .

She couldn't give up yet .

Haruka rushed at Fumiko with all her strength .

Fumiko staggered back and fell down . For a moment, she looked stunned, but then she stood right up and tried to run at Haruka .

'You've misunderstood something too,' said Haruka, pointing at Fumiko .

Fumiko stopped in her tracks .

'Misunderstood?'

'Yup, misunderstood . There are people besides you who know about the letter . And they've noticed the truth behind this case . '

'Stop making up stupid lies!' yelled Fumiko angrily, but her eyes were anxious .

She probably felt something from Haruka's sudden change in attitude .

However, it was too late even if she felt something .

'If you think it's a lie, look behind you . '

At Haruka's words, Fumiko turned slowly, like a rusty mechanical puppet .

Then, her eyes went wide in surprise .

Yakumo and Gotou were standing there .

'Katou Fumiko . I've got quite a few questions for you,' said Gotou, holding out his police ID . For some reason, his face was covered in blood .

Fumiko's mouth flapped open and shut as she tried to say something, but nothing come out .

'Ah, and we ran into Junichi at the entrance . He's handcuffed right now,' Gotou said lightly, spreading his arms .

Fumiko looked dumbfounded . It made sense . There was nowhere for her to run now .

Her plan was completely ruined .

She was just an empty shell now . Gotou placed a hand on Fumiko's shoulder .

Then, Fumiko suddenly turned to face Haruka and rushed at her with the knife .

Gotou tried to stop Fumiko, but he was a moment too late .

Fumiko avoided Gotou's arm and ran at Haruka .

Everything seemed to be in slow motion to Haruka .

She was too shocked and afraid to move .

'Aaahhh!'

She yelled as loud as she could .

Yakumo said something .

Haruka was going to be stabbed .

The moment she thought that, somebody moved to stand in front of Haruka .

Fumiko didn't reach Haruka . She tripped on something, fell forward, and dropped the knife .

Gotou didn't let the chance slip away .

He climbed on Fumiko's back, pulled her arms behind her and restrained her .

'Are you all right?'

Yakumo went up to Haruka .

'Shiori... Shiori saved me,' said Haruka as she collapsed right there .

Her body shook from fear and the relief she felt from being released from that .

'Oh, her,' said Yakumo, looking beside Fumiko .

So she really was there .

'Thank you,' said Haruka, looking in the same direction as Yakumo .

'Can you see her?'

Haruka shook her head at Yakumo's question .

'I can't see her . But I can feel her . I can tell Shiori's here right now...'

Haruka gripped Shiori's diary tightly in front of her chest .

There was the faint smell of cinnamon from the diary .

'Oh, I see now...'

Haruka started laughing quietly .

She knew the secret to Shiori's cocoa . The secret ingredient was a cinnamon stick .

'You've been saved by many people... There must be something that makes them do that,' said Yakumo, like he was thinking about something .

My sister saved me . Shiori saved me . I really have been saved by a lot of people .

Haruka looked at Yakumo's face, and all the feelings she had been restraining came up at once .

She bit her lips, but she couldn't hold them in any longer .

They came out from her eyes as tears .

Haruka clung to Yakumo and started sobbing .

17

Two days after the incident, Gotou visited Yakumo's secret hideaway .

During questioning, Fumiko admitted everything .

The results of the DNA test proved that the burnt corpse was Shiori .

Fumiko and Junichi were charged with two premeditated murders and assaulting Haruka . It would take a few years before the results of the trial, but if the premeditated murder charges stuck, they'd be severely punished .

The death penalty . Even if they were lucky, they'd probably get life terms .

Even though Gotou had gone all the way here to explain the aftermath of the case, Yakumo didn't seem to care .

He leant back on his chair and yawned .

'What – you're not interested even though I went out of my way to explain?' said Gotou, his irritation evident .

'There's no point showing interest now, is there? All we can do is already done . I know the truth even without hearing the police report . '

'Well, that's true...'

'Furthermore, Shiori's spirit, which was the key to solving the case, wasn't mentioned in the police report, right? Isn't that a bit different from the truth?'

'Yeah, yeah, I got it . '

Gotou waved a hand limply .

I was an idiot for thinking about explaining to him .

'What I want to know is how you've been punished . '

Gotou didn't want to talk about that .

Even though he'd solved the case, of course that wasn't publicly acknowledged .

Though it was while he was chasing the culprit, he had hit a civilian's car and run off .

'Anyway, it's house arrest until that's decided . I might get fired . '

'It never rains but it pours . '

Saying it like it had nothing to do with him .

Gotou wanted to say that Yakumo was partly at fault, but he stopped himself .

They'd saved Haruka-chan – that was good enough .

'But it's not all bad, right?'

'What?'

'It seems your wife's returned,' Yakumo said nonchalantly .

'H-how do you know that!?'

Gotou stood up in shock .

'I heard it from somebody named Hata-san . '

'Why are you and Hata-san...'

Gotou started speaking, but then he stopped .

He could guess . It was that old man . He'd probably do anything to satisfy his urges .

'But your wife will just run off again if your lose your job . '

'I don't need your concern . And it's not like I don't have an idea,' said Gotou, sitting on the folding chair again .

'It must be a worthless idea anyway . '

'Don't decide that for yourself . I was actually thinking of opening a detective agency . '

'Do your best on your own . '

Yakumo yawned .

'About that . When I open my detective agency, I was thinking of recruiting an excellent assistant . '

Gotou stared at Yakumo .

He'd probably figure it out without Gotou saying the rest .

'Please stop looking at me . It's creepy . '

'Will you think about it?'

'I would rather die . '

As expected .

Gotou snorted .

'That's not all you're here to say, right?'

Yakumo crossed his arms and looked up .

This guy really had terrifying perception . He saw through everything .

To be honest, Gotou wasn't sure he should talk to Yakumo about it . He didn't know how Yakumo would react .

His desire not to talk about it if possible was stronger, but if he hid it now, Yakumo would have to walk that path eventually anyway .

Gotou opened his mouth, determined .

'Actually, during Katou Fumiko's questioning, it seems like she said something strange . '

'Something strange?'

'Yeah . She said that she wasn't the one who made the plan . '

'Was it Junichi?'

Gotou shook his head .

'Seems like a man visited Fumiko one day . He'd seen through her desire to kill her husband and offered up this plan . '

'...'

'She says she can't remember his name, let alone his address or his job, even though she thinks she heard them . It's too weak a story to have been made up . But even if we do believe it, if she doesn't remember him, there's nothing we can do . '

'So you're concerned, Gotou-san...'

'Yeah . I think her memory was erased with hypnotism or something . Plus, they remembered something about that man . I can't help but be concerned about this one thing . '

'What is it? Please stop putting on airs . '

'Seems like both of that man's eyes were red...'

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair and shut his eyes .

'... So he's still doing that...'

Yakumo said just that after a silence .

So that really was it . Yakumo had confirmed Gotou's fear .

He had wanted it just to be a coincidence .

* * *

Haruka visited Yakumo's room two days afterwards .

She was going to head home afterwards to attend Shiori's funeral . She wanted to visit Yakumo before then .

'Have you calmed down a bit?' said Yakumo, after he sat down opposite her .

Haruka nodded silently .

To be honest, her heart was still unsteady .

'It's like that . '

Yakumo scratched his cheek awkwardly .

'What?'

'... No, it's nothing . '

After crossing his arms and thinking for a bit, Yakumo said, 'You're always so chatty, so when you suddenly shut up like this, it's strange . '

'What? Don't make it sound like I'm a walking ball of noise . '

'Am I wrong?'

Haruka was too exasperated by Yakumo's usual attitude to say anything .

She didn't have the energy to retort right now .

Not just now . Ever since the incident, she hadn't been eating properly . She stayed inside her flat and kept crying as she read Shiori's diary .

'Shiori-san's saying "Thank you" to you,' said Yakumo .

'You can see her?' asked Haruka, leaning forward .

Yakumo nodded silently .

'I'm thankful too . And sorry,' Haruka said quietly, looking around the quiet room slowly .

There was no response .

'I wonder if she heard me . '

'She did . '

'I see...'

'Shiori-san has a message for you . '

'Message?'

'I don't know what she's talking about, but she says the guy's better than she imagined . She also says that you're obstinate about the important

things, so you should be more honest...’

That was just like Shiori .

For the first time since the incident, Haruka laughed aloud .

Yakumo cocked his head, looking confused .

‘Tell her I don’t need her concern . ’

‘What on earth are you talking about?’

‘It’s fine . It’s nothing . ’

Yakumo didn’t press any further .

It looked like he thought it was a pointless conversation anyway .

‘I was thinking about this the whole time . If I understood more perspectives and wasn’t prejudiced about things like adultery, Shiori would have talked to me sooner... It hurt . I felt really pathetic . ’

‘I’m not sure about that,’ said Yakumo, running a hand through his messy hair .

‘Eh?’

‘If you were a more perceptive adult, wouldn’t Shiori-san not have been your friend?’

Haruka thought about what Yakumo meant, but she still didn’t understand .

‘I’m saying that the relationships between people are difficult . ’

Yakumo shrugged as he looked at Haruka, whose brow was furrowed .

‘I don’t understand . ’

‘I’m saying being incomplete has more meaning for people . ’

'I don't understand at all . '

'... In short, I'm saying you can just stay the way you are,' said Yakumo, shaking his head in exasperation .

'Hey, stop calling me "you" already . '

'What should I call you?'

'You can just call me by my name normally . '

'I refuse!' Yakumo said bluntly . Then, he sipped his tea .

Haruka checked the time on her wristwatch and stood up .

'I have to go soon . '

Yakumo didn't say anything, as usual .

He yawned like a cat . Was he incapable of saying 'Bye' or 'See you later'?

Though it'd just feel creepy if he said it .

'Hey . Can I come by next time when nothing's up?'

Yakumo didn't respond, as expected . Haruka gave up and put her hand on the doorknob .

'Please . Don't bring trouble with you next time . '

Haruka turned around and saw Yakumo drinking tea with his usual sleepy expression .

'I will then . I know how to make amazingly yummy cocoa . I'll make it for you next time . '

Haruka opened the door and left the room .

Haruka didn't even think that she'd end up breaking the promise she made with Yakumo –

NOTES:

[1] Rat Man (Nezumi Otoko / ねずみ男) is a character from GeGeGe no Kitarou . He is a youkai and human halfbreed who looks like a rodent . He is characteristically stinky and filthy .

Volume 2 Chapter 0: Prologue

VOLUME 2 - THAT WHICH CONNECTS SOULS prologue

I'm picking up psychic detective yakumo translations as a bit of an end-of-summer project. I'm starting from volume 2 since volume 1 has already been translated, but I'll go back to do that later if I decide to continue this since it appears that it was translated from a different version than mine (e.g., missing/added sentences) and I'd like a uniform translation.

I know the prologue and the first bit of chapter 1 for this volume has already been translated, but again, I'd like to do it uniformly so I'll be starting from the beginning! if there are any translation notes, they'll be at the end of the post, but so far yakumo doesn't seem to need many of those. as a note for this translation and all future ones, if you spot any errors, please send me a message so that I can fix it!

anyhow, I hope you enjoy this as much as I did (o · ω · o)┐

PROLOGUE

The rain was beating down that night.

Entering March, the days were becoming warmer, but it was still cold once the sun went down, especially in rain like this.

Gotou Kazutoshi was writing his work log at the police station.

He hated doing it. It had already been two years since he entered the police force, but this was the one thing he could not grow accustomed to. He would rather some sort of incident occurred.

Gotou reclined on his chair as he mulled over these indiscreet thoughts in his head.

The sound of pouring rain rang in his ears.

Suddenly, he noticed that somebody was standing in front of the police station.

He was a man in his mid-thirties. Even though it was raining so heavily, he was not carrying an umbrella, and his black coat was completely soaked.

That wasn't all. It was a rainy night. Even though visibility was already not that great under the circumstances, the man was looking down and had on dark sunglasses, as if to hide his face.

There was a strange atmosphere.

Gotou stood up and headed towards the man at the entrance while keeping a hand on the police baton in the holder at his hip.

'What are you doing there?'

When he spoke up, the man slowly raised his face.

'A child...'

'What?'

Gotou could only hear the beginning of his sentence, the rest of which had been drowned out by the rain.

'A child is about to be murdered.'

The man spoke in an emotionless voice. Almost like the synthetic speech of a machine.

'What did you say?'

'A child is about to be murdered, officer.'

The man's expression was serious, and it did not feel like he was lying or joking. However, something was missing.

Urgency.

A child might die. Even though he came to inform Gotou about such a dangerous situation, this man was not panicking at all.

'If you don't hurry, the child will die.'

The man spoke while water dripped from the tip of his chin.

He was right. There was no time to think about that sort of thing. If what the man said was true, it could be too late.

'Where's the kid?'

'I'll show you the way.'

The man said that quietly, turned around and started walking.

Gotou rushed out into the rain after him.

The rain was incredible. His uniform was soon completely soaked through. He couldn't see anything. The man was doing very well walking perfectly in a situation like this while wearing sunglasses.

Still –

'A kid's going to be killed, right?'

Gotou yelled at the man's back.

'Yes.'

The man stopped and looked up at the rainy sky.

'Then we have to hurry.'

'Yes.'

After the man replied, he started walking again, but he was not walking any faster.

What was up with him? Why was he so walking so leisurely?

'Where's the kid?'

Gotou spoke up, unable to bear it any longer.

The man stopped again. He slowly took his right hand out of his pocket and pointed down the completely dark street.

'Just down the road.'

'The kid's ahead?'

'There is a building under construction.'

'The kid's in there?'

'Yes.'

'Got it.'

At the same time as he replied, Gotou dashed down the asphalt.

He knew the building the man was talking about. It was a bit over a hundred metres ahead. If he ran, it wouldn't even take twenty seconds.

Soon, he could see the building he was looking for. There were five floors, but the concrete only went up to the second floor, while the floors above it still showed steel scaffolding.

He should have just asked in the first place. When he turned around, the man from before had been swallowed by the darkness and could not be seen.

Gotou stepped onto the premises. There was a red car parked in front of the buildings with its engine still on.

He approached and took a peek inside a window, but there was nobody inside.

'That's strange,' Gotou mumbled. Then, he went inside the building.

He was able to hide from the rain, but it was pitch-black and he couldn't see anything.

Gotou took the torch from his hip holster out and switched it on, waving it left and right.

Clunk.

There was the sound of something falling.

Gotou switched the torch to his left hand and took out the baton with his right. He slowly headed towards the direction the sound had come from.

Something moved in the shadow of a pillar.

Gotou pointed the light towards it.

Someone's there –

He could see the back of somebody crouching.

'I'm a police officer. What are you doing?'

A woman in her late twenties turned around, surprised by Gotou's voice.

She had refined features and skin that was so white it seemed almost transparent. The glossy black hair that fell to her shoulders was covered in droplets of water.

Though she was so beautiful it would make someone hold their breath, Gotou could only see that beauty as something manufactured.

The woman said nothing. Her almond eyes stared as her thin red lips trembled.

'I asked you what you were doing.'

'Ki... ll...'

Finally, the woman opened her mouth.

Unlike her appearance, her voice sounded like an old woman's. He couldn't hear what she said clearly.

'What did you say?'

'I'll kill him.'

The woman spoke again.

This time, the words properly reached Gotou's ears.

'Kill? Who are you...'

Gotou started speaking, but he stopped without thinking. In front of the woman, there was a boy of elementary-school age who had fainted face-up, and the woman had her two hands around that boy's neck.

'Stop! Take those hands off!'

Gotou shouted and pulled the woman towards him, but she clung on and put more strength into her hands around the child's neck.

'Let go!'

'No! I have to kill this child!'

'Don't be ridiculous!'

'Don't get in my way!'

The woman violently shook her body to resist.

'I'll listen to what you have to say after, so take your hands off that kid!'

'I have to kill this child now! If I don't, the child will definitely kill many people! Just like him!'

The woman's cry reverberated against the concrete.

'What are you saying!?'

'Let go! Kill that child, and me too..'

Damn! She wants to commit double suicide –

If she wouldn't listen to him, he would have to use force.

Gotou hit the woman's arm with his baton. Just as she was bent over in pain, he thrust her away with a tackle.

The woman rolled a few times on the concrete floor and collapsed with her face to the ground.

Gotou immediately checked the carotid artery of the boy, who had collapsed facing up.

It's fine. There's still a pulse. Breathing too. That's great.

'Hey. You OK?'

When Gotou shook the boy's shoulders, he opened his eyes soon after.

He abruptly got up, still expressionless.

Even though the kid must have had some scary experiences, he didn't cry or scream. Maybe he didn't understand the situation he was in, or –

That was right. The woman.

Gotou looked towards the location where the woman had fallen, but she was already nowhere to be seen.

For a moment, he thought of chasing her, but he couldn't leave the boy by himself. He gave up and turned back to face the boy.

'Everything's OK now.'

There was no reply.

'What's your name?'

'Yakumo.'

'Oh, so you're Yakumo-kun.'

Gotou patted the boy's head. He had pale skin and almond eyes. The boy's face looked a lot like the woman's.

Was the woman from before this kid's mother?

Gotou picked up the torch that had fallen to the ground in the confusion earlier and shone it on the boy's face.

For a moment, he thought his eyes were tricking him. However, he was wrong.

The child's left eye glowed red like a blazing flame.

Notes:

(Though these aren't translation notes this time, they will be here in the future!)

Each chapter of Yakumo is separated into many mini chapters, some of which are under a thousand words in length. However, if I were to put the full chapter in one post, that would be tens of thousands of words (and it would take me much longer to translate (´; ω; `)ﾌﾟﾌﾟ). There isn't really a good way to group the mini chapters either because of all the shifts in

perspective, so I'll either be posting further translations a chapter at a time or a mini chapter at a time. (For reference, the first chapter is fifteen mini chapters long.)

If you could drop a message telling me which would be preferable, I'd greatly appreciate it. (o · ω · o)┐ Messages about the translation would also be really nice (◦ · ◦ · ◦)

Volume 2 Chapter 1: VOLUME 2 - THAT WHICH CONNECTS SOULS

Chapter 1

VOLUME 2 - THAT WHICH CONNECTS SOULS

file 01: vessel (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

The rain that had started at dawn did not seem as if would stop even after noon; rather, it was just raining more heavily.

The endless pitter-patter of the raindrops created a hazy mist.

It had become warmer with the arrival of March, but with the weather like this, even spring would hesitate to visit.

She really shouldn't have gone out in this weather. Mayuko regretted her decision as she walked along the riverside promenade.

The rain had made its way into her sneakers, making her feel uncomfortable.

In the first place, it was Miki's fault for calling her out on a day like this. She had said that she was lonely because of her broken heart, but when Mayuko thought about it, it was already Miki's fourth broken heart this year.

At the end of the season, her heart was broken, and at the beginning of the season, she fell in love. She was a calculating person. In any case, she was just going to start a love once spring called.

The more Mayuko thought about it, the stupider she felt.

Mayuko stopped in front of the water gate and held her umbrella between her shoulder and her neck so that she could breathe on her hands.

It was cold. Her breath was white. Her red fingertips were trembling slightly.

Dummm.

What sounded like subterranean rumbling reached her ears.

Mayuko examined her surroundings, moving only her eyes.

She found the source of the sound immediately. It was the river, swelling as it swallowed up earth and sand.

The water level had risen, and the current of the now brown river was just like a drove of violent oxen.

Dumbfounded, Mayuko took in the sheer intensity of the current.

The wind suddenly whooshed by.

‘Ah!’

It was already too late when Mayuko cried out. Her umbrella had been carried away by the wind that had blown from below.

Her white plastic umbrella spun as it tumbled down the embankment.

‘Oh, come on.’

Mayuko grumbled her displeasure to nobody in particular and chased after her umbrella. She tried to head down to the lawn of the embankment, but

her feet were caught by the soggy turf and she fell on her bum, so she ended up sliding down the embankment like that.

'Argh! This is the worst!'

Resisting the urge to cry at how miserable she was, she stood using both of her hands to prop herself up. Her back and elbows were pulsing with pain. She might have grazed them.

The umbrella was being blown about by the wind on the riverbank.

Water dripped from Mayuko's fringe. While thinking that it might have already been too late to pick it up now, she started walking towards the umbrella.

'... o... p..'

Just as she was about to take the umbrella in her hands, she heard somebody's voice.

'Who's there?'

She tried asking, but nobody answered. She might have mistaken the sound of the wind for something else. Mayuko sniffled and stooped over to pick up the umbrella.

Whoosh.

There was another gust of wind.

'Ah.'

The umbrella escaped her fingers and fell into the river, where it was finally swallowed by the muddy waters.

Mayuko couldn't do anything but stare, completely dumbfounded.

I've really got no luck –

She'd go to a nearby convenience store and buy a new umbrella. She'd give up on going to Miki's house for today. She would just hurry home and take a warm bath.

'...St... op.'

Just as she turned away from the river and took one step, she heard that voice.

She hadn't misheard. It was somebody's voice.

'Who's there?'

Mayuko asked as she turned around. There was no reply.

'Pl... e... se.'

She heard the voice like it was coiling around her ear.

Who was it? Where were they? Mayuko looked around for the source of the voice. Her heart was beating quickly. She had a unbelievably bad feeling about this.

Finally, Mayuko's eyes saw something incredible.

She couldn't let out the breath she had been holding. In the middle of the river. In the middle of those violent muddy waters, there was a person. A girl who looked to be in middle school.

She was up to her shoulders in water and swaying in the waves.

Her hands were reaching up towards the sky like she was struggling. There were fifty metres between the riverbank and where the girl was. The distance was much too large for Mayuko, who had no confidence in her swimming ability.

Even if she was confident, it would just make for two disasters if she jumped into save her in this current.

Mayuko yelled as loudly as she could. As if ridiculing her efforts, the river's muddy waters roared.

'I'll call for help, so hang on a little longer!'

Mayuko shouted out to the girl in the river.

The girl bobbed up, like she was replying to her. At first, Mayuko thought her eyes were playing tricks on her, but she was wrong.

The girl's shoulders, chest and waist were slowly but surely coming out of the water.

Finally, the girl was standing on top of the raging river.

'Eek!'

The unbelievable sight of the girl's figure was vividly burnt into Mayuko's mind.

She couldn't see the girl's face clearly. She could tell that the girl had long black hair tied into a ponytail and was wearing a school uniform with a blazer.

That girl slowly started walking on top of the river towards Mayuko.

How can she walk? People can't walk on top of water –

Mayuko was bewildered by this act that defied comprehension, and her body was stiff – she couldn't move even one step from that spot.

The girl approached.

'No! Don't come here!'

Mayuko screamed so loudly it felt like her throat would split. At the same time, the girl's figure disappeared.

There was only the raging river, as if that girl hadn't even been there in the first place.

Were her eyes playing tricks on her? Was it a dream?

Mayuko pressed a hand against her chest and breathed deeply to try to organise her disordered thoughts.

Gurgle.

A sound came from near her foot.

Gurgle gurgle.

Air bubbles were coming up from the river bank and popping. What? What was it?

Splash.

Something touched Mayuko's foot.

It was cold. It felt slimy. It couldn't be –

Mayuko timidly looked at her foot.

From the river, a purplish red rotten human hand had thrust out and grabbed Mayuko's foot.

'Agh!'

Mayuko's horrified scream was drowned out by the sound of rain.

2

Though the rain had lightened to a drizzle, it showed no signs of stopping.

Hijikata Makoto looked up at the sky from under an umbrella while waiting for the light at the intersection to change.

The sky was a solid grey, making for a depressing mood.

The rain wasn't the only reason Makoto felt that way. She couldn't get any information today at all. When she returned to the office, her boss would definitely complain.

Her boss's mouth was so spiteful it wouldn't lose even to this weather.

Since she was a new employee who had only been working at the company for two years, there was nothing she could do about the complaints.

However, she hated it when her father came up in conversation. 'I hired you because you were the police chief's daughter, but you're telling me you can't even bring back one piece of news?' That phrase rubbed Makoto the wrong way.

She hadn't mentioned that she was the police chief's daughter even once during the interview. She couldn't remember ever claiming that she could use her father as a source of information.

It might sound like she was just evading responsibility, but the company had just went and thought that on their own.

Even though she was his daughter, there was no way that the police chief could just chat about incidents with her. In the first place, Makoto didn't even have one memory of her father talking about work at home.

Looking at it from the police's point of view, there was nothing more troublesome than having the chief's daughter work as a newspaper reporter. They couldn't just spill the information, but they couldn't handle the situation coolly either.

The chief detective Ideuchi, for example, would openly run just from seeing her face.

Only one detective would ignore her position as the daughter of the chief. He was an extremely detective-like and uncouth man named Gotou.

Even though he would ignore her position, it wasn't like he would give her information. 'You're annoying!' 'I don't know!' 'Get lost!' Those were the only three phrases he would say. Still, it was better than being treated like a fragile article.

On that topic, she hadn't seen Detective Gotou around lately.

According to a rumour, he had had an accident while chasing a criminal, so he had been transferred to a do-nothing job.

Screech!

There was the sound of metal scraping against metal, bringing Makoto's thoughts back to reality.

Without a pause, there was the sound of a collision with something falling –

When she looked towards the direction of the sound, she saw the bloody figure of a person collapsed in the middle of the intersection.

Makoto immediately dropped the umbrella she was holding and rushed towards the person who had fallen face-up.

He was a man in his early twenties. He had refined features, but he was so thin he seemed sickly, and his sunken eyes had lost their light.

The back of his head was caved in, and a cut ran from his left cheek to his nose like a crack, with blood flowing out.

Makoto knelt on the asphalt and asked, 'Are you OK?' At the same time, she took out a handkerchief and pressed it against the wound on the man's cheek.

'Please hang in there.'

She shook his shoulders, but there was no response. She put her ear to his chest. She couldn't hear the sound of breathing or a heart at all.

It's too late to save him –

Makoto thought that as she took her mobile phone out from her bag and pressed 119[1] to call an ambulance.

Suddenly, she noticed that there was somebody standing behind her.

Maybe it was the driver who hit him. Makoto turned with the mobile phone still in her hand.

A man was standing there. He was slim and had blood flowing from his cheek.

'Eh?'

He was the same man as the one collapsed in front of her.

Why were there two of the same man?

Makoto was bewildered when she remembered a story she had heard from a senior at work.

When her senior had gone to a traffic accident to gather data, he had seen the person who was supposed to be dead loitering around nearby.

The person's soul hadn't realised he was dead and had been wandering.

A boring story made up to surprise a junior. That's what she had thought at the time. But –

The man's lips warped into a crooked smile to reveal sharp canine teeth.

It was full of ill will. A cold smile.

Blood dripped from the tip of the man's chin onto Makoto's cheek.

Drip. Drip.

She had to run. Fast. She had to get away from here. No matter what she thought, her body wouldn't move, as if it had been chained down.

Something was flowing into Makoto.

Something else. Something that wasn't her.

– I won't.

There was a voice. A man's voice. It sounded just like it was speaking directly to her mind.

– I won't die.

Her body was tingling like insects were crawling on her.

<Yes, 119.>

She heard the voice of the operator from her mobile phone.

Even though she tried to reply, her mouth wouldn't move the way she wanted it to.

– I don't want to die.

She lost her strength, and her mobile phone fell from her hand.

<Hello? What's wrong? Hello...>

The operator's voice sounded far away.

Makoto was being dragged into the darkness.

3

Ozawa Haruka sat on a park bench.

It was a small park that ran along the national highway. There was nothing except for the bench. When she looked up, she saw the towering Togakushi mountain range.

A familiar place. A children's park near her home in Nagano Prefecture.

The sunlight was warm.

Pale pink petals were fluttering down from the cherry blossom tree that stood in the corner of the park.

Two girls were playing with a soccer ball.

They were twins.

One of them was me. The other was my older sister, Ayaka.

This is a dream –

This is a memory from my past –

She knew what would happen afterwards.

She wouldn't be able to catch the ball her sister Ayaka threw, and she would run hurriedly to get it. Her sister would smile.

– You have to keep an eye on the ball.

That was what her sister said.

Her younger self stared at her sister silently after picking up the ball.

She had been mortified. Her sister could catch the ball so well, but it never went well for her.

– Haruka, hurry.

She held the ball up, as if to throw it.

'You can't! Stop! You can't throw that ball!'

Haruka stood to call out to her younger self.

However, that voice didn't reach her.

Her younger self threw the ball.

'No!'

Haruka yelled while running.

Time flowed leisurely, just as if it were in slow motion.

The ball flew higher than normal.

Her older sister jumped to catch the ball, but she couldn't reach it. The ball went out the park and rolled onto the road.

Her sister went to chase that ball.

'You can't chase that ball!'

Haruka's shout didn't reach her sister.

– Even my big sister can't catch the ball.

My younger self said that.

I didn't have any bad intentions. I just thought I'd bother her a bit.

That was all –

Her sister picked up the ball that had rolled onto the road.

A white minivan travelled towards her.

Haruka closed her eyes subconsciously.

There was the squeal of brakes and the sound of a crash that shook the ground.

My temple hurt. The strength left my knees and I collapsed to the ground.

I knew what was going to happen.

That's why I said to stop –

No matter how much she yelled, the past wouldn't change.

Her hands felt wet. She opened her eyes.

'No!'

Haruka spoke without thinking. Her hands were dyed red with blood. Blood was steadily dripping from her fingertips.

'Haruka. You threw it far on purpose.'

Her sister stood in front of her eyes.

Her temple had split, and blood poured out endlessly, dyeing her white shirt collar red.

'Sorry. I didn't think it would end up like this... Sorry...'

'It's too late to make excuses.'

'That's not it. This isn't an excuse.'

'I'm dead... Because of you...'

At the same time that Ayaka said that, her body cracked into countless pieces like glasswork.

'No!'

Haruka jumped up at the same time that she called out.

Her clenched fists were sweaty. Her breathing was erratic.

My memories are returning. Retribution for my jealousy towards my sister.

My sin will never be forgiven –

While the sun had not yet fully risen, the area in front of one residential dumpsite was teeming with people.

There was only an iron fence and a net to scare off crows above it across from a telephone pole – not a particularly extraordinary place. Naturally, the people had not gathered to toss their rubbish. There was currently something that should not have been at the dumpsite.

The corpse of a female middle-school student.

A businessman who had come to put out his rubbish before work was the one who had found her.

Hata Hideyoshi knelt and looked down at the face of the girl who was not yet an adult. Her eyes were open, and her face was frozen in a surprised expression.

Matsumoto Miho-chan. Her whereabouts had been unknown since yesterday. Did she know that she was going to die in pain? That suddenly came to mind.

It was the job of the coroner to accept requests from the police to autopsy the corpse.

People were needlessly afraid of corpses. However, Hata had never felt that fear, even towards the goriest of corpses.

Hata was driven by a simple interest. How much blood has to flow out? From where? How much of an impact can be taken? Which organs can be taken out –

Before a person dies?

If people have souls, death would be the separation of the body and the soul. What, accordingly, ties the body and the soul together? At what moment do the body and soul separate?

People said he was perverted, but to Hata, it wasn't strange at all.

Didn't people want to know the divide between life and death?

'Look, they're serial.'

One of the detectives said that. Hata felt uncomfortable hearing those words.

'What is supposed to be serial with what?'

'Come on. I'm talking about the incident last month.'

'Ah, the one who was strangled and then thrown into the river.'

Hata remembered the incident immediately.

That had been a gory incident as well. A girl called Kinoshita Ayaka who went to the local middle school – she was the daughter of a doctor, if he remembered correctly.

On the way home from school, she had parted with her friends and then her whereabouts were unknown. The police started investigating it as a kidnapping, but a few days after, there were still no ransom demands, and her corpse was discovered at the water gate at Tama River.

It was believed that she was thrown into the Tama River after she was strangled.

She was carried by the strong current, so there were many small injuries on her body.

This girl had also disappeared a few days earlier when the police had been asked to look for her.

Following that, there had been no demands, and her body had been discovered. Last time, it was strangulation. This time, it was drowning. The reasons for death were strangely different, but the area the incidents had

occurred and the modus operandi of aiming for students heading home from school were certainly the same.

'It seems that there's another girl whose whereabouts are unknown.'

'Another one?'

'Yes, I got the confirmation now. She goes to the same school as Miho-chan, the victim this time, and her name is Katou Keiko-chan. There have been no demands since her disappearance.'

'No demands...'

If that were the case, it would make this a serial murder case with murder as the final goal.

What an unpleasant incident –

Hata stood up and left the scene of the crime, which was surrounded by blue sheets.

It wasn't a festival, so why were people making so much noise? If they wanted to see so badly, Hata thought they should just let them see.

The people making so much noise would shut up in an instant.

Unexpectedly, Hata felt a gaze that was obviously different from that of the curious onlookers.

A tall man wearing sunglasses. In the middle of the noisy bystanders, there was just one man with a thin sneer.

– The criminal will return to the scene of the crime.

Hata suddenly remembered something that the police were taught.

Ishii Yuutarou stood in front of the door after checking his tie countless times.

His heart was thumping loudly from nervousness.

'Calm down – first impressions are essential.'

While Ishii told himself that, he looked at the plate on the door. <Criminal Affairs Division: Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room>[2]. In a post that had just been created this month, Ishii had been assigned here starting today.

He hadn't thought such a day would come. Ishii was so excited he couldn't calm the loud beating of his heart.

On the other side of the door, there was a legendary detective who had led the way to the solution for many difficult cases.

A peculiar point of view and outstanding deductive powers. On top of that, he had a strange source of information.

It was said that he gathered his information from the spirits of the dead victims.

He was known as the psychic detective.

At first, he was the target of scorn. However, that changed with time to awe, and now, even the police had to acknowledge his power. Thus was born the Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room. There were a number of rumours, but that was what Ishii thought.

The police were forced to acknowledge the legendary psychic detective, Gotou Kazutoshi.

Ishii had always loved the occult. When he was in middle school, he watched a show which used clairvoyance to search for those who had disappeared, and it excited him from the innermost depths of his heart.

He had been deeply moved when faced with the mysterious powers that people held.

From then on, he read a great number of books related to the occult. Clairvoyance, telepathy, seeing spirits, special powers that science didn't explain – he believed they existed.

For Ishii, who felt so strongly about the occult, Gotou was naturally the object of his reverence.

He kept a picture he had secretly taken of Gotou in his notebook as a charm.

He had wanted to talk with him at leisure one day. To have been reassigned to Gotou's post made him truly glad that he became a detective.

OK, I'm going. While he murmured that in his mind, he knocked.

There was no response.

For a moment, he was perplexed, but soon, he shook away those feelings. He wasn't a guest. Starting today, he would be working here as a detective. What was the point of waiting for a response?

Do your best, Ishii Yuutarou. He gave himself some encouragement and resolutely opened the door.

'Excuse me. My name is Ishii Yuutarou, the policeman who will be working here from today on. Though I am inexperienced, I would like to ask for your guidance.'

He spoke up as he bowed.

There was no response. The room was completely silent.

He took a look around. In the wide eight-tatami room[3] with not even one window, there were two desks facing each other in a small space.

Nobody was there.

Shoot. He had shown up to work on time of all things. Gotou was a detective of such merit – he had definitely left to investigate already. Ah, what to do.

Ishii cursed his own foolishness.

Rooooooar.

The sound of something like the bellow of a beast reached the discouraged Ishii's ears.

What was that –

Timidly, he went to look for the source of the sound.

'Ah.'

Behind the desk, two chairs were lined up, and a man was using them as a bed. In contrast with his muscular body, his arm lay sloppily on the floor, and his mouth was wide open as he snored.

Detective Gotou –

His face was unshaven, and his shirt had turned yellow. Just looking at his appearance, there wasn't much difference between him and a drunk who had slept at the station.

No, that wasn't right. Detective Gotou, after all his hard work, was taking a breather.

That said, he couldn't leave the situation like this.

'E-er... Excuse me...'

Ishii approached the sleeping Gotou and shook his shoulders. Gotou brushed away Ishii's hand with his eyes still closed and turned over.

He fell from the chairs.

Surprised by the dull thunk, Ishii jumped away a step.

6

Ogouchi, an English lecturer at the university, gave a photo to the student sitting in front of him.

His name was Saitou Yakumo.

With sleepy eyes, he draped himself slovenly over the back of the chair. His attitude showed his apathy.

His hair looked mussed up from sleep, but it might have been the so-called bedhead hairstyle. His outfit consisted of worn-out jeans and a white shirt.

He had composure unusual for his age, or perhaps it could be called an enigmatic vibe.

Ogouchi couldn't calm down – he felt like Yakumo could see right to the bottom of his heart.

Yakumo gave the photo a glance and then smirked, like he understood.

'I see. I was wondering what task you had for me, but it was something like this.'

'It's gotten a bit terrible,' Ogouchi said with a weak smile.

He had handed Yakumo a photo that had been taken when he and his daughter went to a holiday house. His smiling daughter, Satoko, stood in front of a beech tree. At first glance, the photo wasn't anything special.

However, he'd noticed something strange when he put it in an album.

There was something that looked like a person's face in the trunk of the beech tree.

Ogouchi had heard a rumour about Saitou Yakumo from a student called Aizawa.

Yakumo had every spiritual ability, and he was the one who solved the murder incident last year which had been a disgrace for the university. Ogouchi was only half-convinced, but he knew that Saitou Yakumo's uncle was the chief priest at a temple, so he decided to consult Yakumo just in case.

'And?'

Yakumo let out a huge yawn.

'I heard that you were an expert in this sort of thing.'

'Since I'm a university student, my expertise is studying.'

'Well, that's true, but... Er, I was just wondering if you could give me your expert opinion of this photo.'

'I see.'

After Yakumo murmured that, he took another look at the photo and put his left index finger between his brows in thought.

'How is it?'

Ogouchi couldn't bear with the heavy silence and opened his mouth. Yakumo looked up from the photo and let out the breath he had been holding.

'Professor. This is extremely dangerous.'

'Dangerous?'

'Yes. Has anything strange occurred recently?'

'Anything strange?'

'Any little thing will do.'

Ogouchi recalled the past few days. There wasn't anything in particular that sprang to mind.

'No, not really...'

'Please try to remember. I feel a very strong sense of regret from this photo.'

'Come to think of it, yesterday, I slipped on the stairs and skinned my knee. But that's just...'

'That's it!'

Yakumo raised his voice and pointed his index at the tip of Ogouchi's nose, interrupting Ogouchi's words.

Ogouchi was startled for a moment.

'But that was just a little thing...'

It wasn't anything special. Slipping on the stairs was something that could happen to anybody on any day.

'If you continue overlooking it, it will eventually bring about a terrible catastrophe. With the situation like this, your daughter's life will also be in danger,' Yakumo said, peering up at Ogouchi.

His tone was indifferent. That only stirred Ogouchi's uneasiness up more.

'Really...'

'You can't treat this lightly. It'll be too late to regret after the fact.'

Ogouchi certainly had thought it was frightening, but for it to be a matter of life or death –

'What should I d-do...'

'I'll exorcise the spirit. I can't ignore this knowing that a catastrophe may occur.'

'But...'

Yakumo put up his hand to stop Ogouchi's words.

'I won't ask for money. I won't tell anybody about this either. However...'

'What?'

'I'm enrolled in your class, professor, but I've practically never shown up to class.'

'Really?'

'You know what I'm getting at, right?'

Yakumo said that like a reminder. After waiting for Ogouchi's nod, a faint smile graced his thin lips.

7

'Er, Detective Gotou.'

Ishii, who was sitting on the seat across from Gotou, spoke to the detective hesitantly. Gotou ignored him and turned his chair so his back faced Ishii.

It was Detective Ishii's first day on the job. He was doing everything wrong.

With a face that looked like it belonged to a delicate woman, his silver-rimmed glasses seemed a bit affected.

Ever since he came to the room, he had been squirming while looking over at Gotou.

When he opened his mouth, he would say things like 'What are your interests?' and 'What are your favourite foods?' – it wasn't a marriage interview. Gotou started suspecting that Ishii was gay.

Even under normal circumstances, Gotou could die of boredom after being thrown into this ridiculous newly-established post, but being stuck with this guy just depressed him further.

Though newly-established post had a nice ring to it, in the end, they were just getting rid of a troublemaker.

Currently, the police's solve rate for cases didn't reach twenty per cent. It was the job of this post to investigate those unsolved cases.

It sounded nice at first, but it was just organising files in the end.

It was too stupid to do.

'Er, Detective Gotou, could I ask you something?'

Ishii leant forward as he asked. Even though Gotou had gone out of his way to ignore him – the man should take a hint.

Just as Gotou clicked his tongue, the internal telephone rang with good timing.

He picked up at the first ring.

'Hello, this is the police department's something or other investigation room.'

<Say the name of your own room properly.>

It was his boss, the chief detective Ideuchi. He had goggle eyes and was always finger-pointing at the most trivial things.

He was an annoying man who put on airs, though he'd worked his way up too.

'What was it?'

<Eh?>

'The name of the room.'

<It's the Criminal Affairs Division: Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room.>

Ideuchi sounded displeased as he replied.

'Ah, right, that's it. Can't it be a bit shorter?'

<Good grief... Well, that's not important. Come to the conference room immediately.>

'Are we going to play shogi[4]?'

<We're obviously going to talk about work!>

Gotou unconsciously held the phone away because of Ideuchi's shrill yell. Hysterical men really were unsightly.

'Yeah, yeah. I'll go right now. I've got nothing else to do anyway.'

<Bring the new kid with you.>

Gotou turned around and looked at Ishii.

He was leaning over with a frivolous smile on his face. If he had a tail, he'd probably be wagging it wildly.

'That's a bit...'

<A bit what?>

'I'm not good with guys like him.'

<Stop whining and get over here!>

The call ended with a click.

'What a pain.'

While grumbling, Gotou grabbed the suit that had been draped over the back of the chair and stood up.

'E-er, Detective Gotou.'

Ishii had gotten up from his chair and was fidgeting. Man, what an irritating guy.

'What are you just standing there for? Let's go.'

'Yes sir!'

Ishii gave an energetic response, but then he stumbled over his own feet and fell.

Gotou could tell it was going to be hard going.

They went up the stairs to the fourth floor and opened the door to the conference room at the very end of the corridor. Ideuchi was at the conference table, looking tired of waiting.

'So what is it?'

'Well, sit down.'

Gotou sat down in a chair as asked. Ishii sat next to him.

While scratching at his receding hairline, Ideuchi sighed. From the looks of it, he didn't have good news.

'OK – don't go around telling people what I'm going to tell you now.'

A sudden change from the phone call earlier, Ideuchi was speaking in a low voice.

Since he had called him all the way to the conference room, Gotou had thought it would probably be something secretive, but it seemed that it was even more serious than he imagined. Perhaps –

“Is it about the serial abduction murders?’ asked Gotou, bringing his face closer to Ideuchi’s.

The current serial abduction murder case that was occurring under their jurisdiction.

Repulsive incidents were occurring wherein female middle school students were being abducted on the way home from school. Their corpses would be found before any demands were made.

Two girls had already been killed, and one had suddenly disappeared.

‘There’s no way I’d let somebody like you handle such an important case.’

Ideuchi was so blunt that Gotou didn’t get angry.

‘If that’s not it, what is it?’

‘This is a direct request from Chief Hijikata.’

‘Ah, that kokeshi[5].’

Chief Hijikata’s face came to mind as Gotou spoke.

Anybody who had seen the chief before would agree. From the structure of his face to his physique, he looked just like a kokeshi.

Ishii, who was sitting behind Gotou, pressed a hand against his mouth. His shoulders shook as he laughed.

When Ideuchi cleared his throat, Ishii stopped laughing immediately. Ideuchi said, ‘Good grief,’ sounding fed up, before continuing his story.

‘You know the chief has a daughter, right?’

‘Yes, she’s a new reporter at Hokutou Newspaper[6]. She’s got guts for a woman and she has a good perspective.’

Gotou recalled her appearance.

She didn't wear makeup, and her long hair was tied in the back. She wore a navy blue suit with sneakers and would run around frantically, but no matter how hard she tried, nobody would give her any information.

'Having the kokeshi as her dad doesn't pay off,' Gotou said without thinking.

'He's not a kokeshi. He's the chief,' said Ideuchi, while grinding his teeth.

'Whether he's a chief or a government secretary, a kokeshi is a kokeshi.'

'Stop saying "kokeshi" over and over again! Everyone's holding it in!'

Holding it in, eh. The sad story of middle management who couldn't say it even if they thought the same thing.

Ideuchi's goggle eyes were roving about.

Although he didn't make a sound, Ishii was holding his sides with laughter.

'What's so funny?'

With no outlet for his anger, Ideuchi blew up at Ishii. Ishii cowered, retracting his neck and stiffening his body like a turtle.

'Now, what about his daughter?'

Gotou waited for Ideuchi to calm down before returning to the conversation.

'Well, there've been a number of problems...'

'Did she cause an incident?'

'No, that's not it, but... er...'

Even though Ideuchi was the one who had brought the topic up, he was mumbling his words terribly.

'Please say it clearly.'

'The chief's daughter is possessed.'

'When you say possessed, do you mean....'

By a ghost?

'I didn't see it myself, but the chief's wife thinks that, at least.'

'Again, of all things to happen to the chief of the police's daughter. If the gossip magazines get wind of this, they'll write something interesting.'

'If the information gets out, you'll be the one I suspect first.'

Ideuchi was glaring at him with a serious expression.

'So, what are you telling me to?'

'You're an expert in that sort of stuff, so just go take a look.'

'I'm not an expert. You don't believe in ghosts in the first place, do you, Chief Ideuchi?'

'Stop complaining. Whatever the cause is, there's definitely something odd about the chief's daughter's condition. That's a problem in and of itself.'

Ideuchi talked on and on until his cheeks were red. Maybe he was troubled because of the strange story that was pushed towards him, but it was the same for Gotou.

He wasn't a spirit medium, so even if he went, he wouldn't be able to do anything. Plus –

'It has nothing to do with me.'

'Yes it does! This is an order!'

Ideuchi slammed both hands against the table and stood up. His goggle eyes looked like they would pop out with a boing.

It really wasn't really anything to pop eyes out over though. Well, nothing to be done.

'Understood. It'll be fine as long as I go, right?'

Things had really gotten troublesome.

8

Haruka absentmindedly looked out the window of the music room at the university.

The sunlight was pleasant. It had been chilly in the morning, so she had regretted leaving the house with a thin parka, but things turned out A-OK.

The cherry blossom tree in the courtyard had green leaves. The tightly closed buds would probably come into full bloom in a week.

The university had already entered spring break. Today was the last practice of the year for the orchestra circle[7] that Haruka was a member of.

On the platform, the conductor was giving a recap of their year. Though Haruka could hear his fervent voice, it slipped through her mind before she could understand.

She hadn't been able to concentrate during practice either and had made a series of mistakes.

She knew why.

The dream about my sister I had seen this morning –

Come to think of it, she felt like this was the first time in a while that she'd dreamt about her sister.

When had she last seen one?

If she remembered correctly, it was when she'd gotten mixed up in the case with the deserted house and met him for the first time.

He always had a sleepy look on his face, was blunt and not nice at all, and was kind of good-looking, but that was ruined by his cynicism.

Through his red eye that could see the spirits of the dead, she had met with her sister again and might have felt that her own sin had been forgiven.

Even though there's no way I would be forgiven –

What was he doing now? He was probably the same as always. She wanted to meet him. Her heart might feel a bit lighter after that.

Right. After practice was finished, she would go meet Saitou Yakumo.

He would probably let out a huge yawn and ask, 'What did you come for?' with eyes that were definitely sleepy even now.

Haruka laughed just imagining it.

'What are you so amused about?'

The conductor pointed a finger at her, so she quickly stifled her laughter.

Other people started laughing as well.

After the signal for the end of the practice, Haruka quickly finished cleaning up and put the music room behind her.

Now that she thought about it, she had made a promise with Yakumo before that next time, she would show her face when she had nothing troubling her. It seemed like that promise would be fulfilled.

Her gait was light, as if the leaden thoughts she had been accumulating since morning had been a lie.

'Haruka-chan.'

Just as she was about to leave the school building, somebody called out to her.

It was Mayuko, who was a member of the same circle as her.

Haruka played flute and Mayuko played violin. Since their parts were different, they had only spoken a couple of times before.

'What is it?'

'Do you have some time?'

'What for?'

'The truth is, there's something I want your advice about...'

Haruka wasn't friendly enough with Mayuko to be asked for advice, and she didn't know her well enough to give advice either.

Still, she couldn't refuse and vaguely replied, 'Ah, OK.' They ended up sitting side by side on a bench in the courtyard.

'This happened about three days ago, but – '

Mayuko's story, which began like that, didn't seem to need the common brand of advice about things like romance or future career paths.

Mayuko told of a terrible spiritual phenomenon she had witnessed.

On a rainy day, she had encountered a girl's ghost by the river. At the time, she had run away frantically, but ever since then, strange things kept happening to her.

She wouldn't be able to move when she woke up, and she'd feel the presence of somebody else in her room. She would hear a girl's voice saying, 'I'll curse you' –

'Please. Help me.'

After Mayuko finished her stories, she asked that with tears brimming in her eyes and trembling lips.

Haruka could understand how she felt, but –

'Why did you ask me?'

'After I asked Miki, she said that Haruka-chan would solve the problem if it was related to spirits.'

I'd been able to guess somehow once I'd heard some of what Mayuko had to say, but it really was Miki –

The story's been pretty distorted. At some point in time, I had been labelled with spiritual ability.

'I can't do anything.'

'But you solved the problem with Miki. Miki said that you can exorcise spirits.'

She really had no responsibility.

She hadn't been the one to solve Miki's case – Saitou Yakumo had.

His left eye, which had been red since the day he was born, had a special ability: it could see the spirits of the dead. He had solved the case using that.

However, Yakumo could only see the spirits of the dead. Accordingly, he couldn't exorcise spirits.

All he did was listen to the thoughts of the dead, determine the reason they were lingering and take away that reason.

Haruka opened her mouth to explain that, but she didn't put it in words.

Yakumo detested his red eye. Because of it, he was called a monster and even his own mother had tried to kill him.

She couldn't talk so freely about that ability, which could even be called his trauma.

While Haruka hadn't made her decision, Mayuko begged her with her two hands clasped. 'Please. I'll do anything.'

Haruka herself knew best that she was the type of person who couldn't refuse when somebody asked her for something. Overwhelmed, she ended up replying, 'Ah, OK.'

Mayuko bowed her head multiple times, saying, 'Thank you – really, thank you,' and started crying in relief. In this situation, it was too late for Haruka to refuse.

Now, she would have to break her promise and go to Yakumo with her troubles.

'This might be of some help.'

As Mayuko said that, she held out a folded handkerchief.

Haruka took it and unfolded it in her palm. There was a mobile phone strap inside.

Five dice-like shapes in a row each had one letter written in them.

<AYAKA>

Haruka felt her heart grow tight.

'On the day I met the ghost, I found this caught on the button on my sleeve after I returned home.'

Mayuko's voice seemed very far away.

The same name as Haruka's dead sister. It was probably just a coincidence. Even though Haruka knew that, she still couldn't stop thinking about it.

Ishii triumphantly sat in the driver's seat of the white police car.

Finally. He would finally be able to witness Detective Gotou's skill. On top of that, just imagining saving a woman possessed by a spirit got him all fired up.

Gotou sat lazily in the passenger seat and lit up a cigarette with his legs crossed.

Ishii was entranced by that brusque gesture. What a man. It was wild how his shirt revealed his chest underneath his loose tie.

If he had to say, Ishii was rather faint of heart and couldn't take action. He would always doubt other people's expressions and end up acting while wondering what they thought of him.

Gotou was the exact opposite of Ishii – he had a strong spirit. Ishii admired him for it, like earlier when he had been talking with Chief Ideuchi.

No matter whom Gotou was with, he would stick with his own beliefs, just like the Shinsengumi[8] who had run past the end of the Tokugawa shogunate.

'We will be going to the scene first, correct?' asked Ishii, as he turned the ignition key and started the car.

'Not yet.'

Gotou spoke while squinting through the smoke.

'Eh?'

'There's somewhere we'll be going first.'

'Where is it?'

'Stop asking about everything; it's annoying.'

'Even if you say I'm annoying, we won't be able to drive unless you tell me where to go, since I'm the one at the wheel.'

Gotou's cheeks twitched like a disgruntled cat's and he clicked his tongue.

Why was Detective Gotou angry? Had Ishii said something to rub him the wrong way?

'Head to the university.'

'Which university would you like me to head to?'

'Meisei University.'

'The university on top of the hill?'

'If you know which one, hurry and step on it.'

'Ah, yes sir.'

Ishii immediately stepped on the gas and started driving.

What on earth was at the university? Normally, in a situation like this, they should have headed to the scene.

Since it was Detective Gotou, he must have determined there was a clue at the university that would solve the case just from what Chief Ideuchi said earlier.

'Detective Gotou, may I ask a question?'

Ishii asked the question while driving. There was no response. Gotou just looked in front of him while the smoke from his cigarette wavered, as if he didn't hear him.

Taking that as a yes, Ishii continued speaking.

'Detective Gotou, you've solved many cases already.'

'Eh?'

'I know that you solved those cases with spiritual power. However, exactly what sort of power do you have, Detective Gotou?'

'What are you saying?'

Gotou lowered his eyebrows, like he had seen something unpleasant, and threw the cigarette in the ashtray.

'There's no point in hiding it.'

'I'm not hiding anything.'

'Can you see spirits? Can you speak with them? Have you been trained? Or was it hereditary?'

'Are you making fun of me?'

'I'm not. I'm serious,' Ishii said plainly.

In order to investigate together, he would have to understand what sort of power Detective Gotou had.

'OK, newbie. I don't know what you've misunderstood here, but I don't have any spiritual powers at all.'

Maybe Detective Gotou wanted to hide his special ability.

But –

'There's no need to hide it. Everyone knows that you're the psychic detective, Detective Gotou.'

He had solved so many cases. It wasn't something he could hide.

'Damn, you're annoying! Shut up for a bit and drive! You baldy!'

'Baldy? Sorry, but I'm not bald yet, though my father certainly has less hair than most. However, my father's father – that is, my grandfather – had hair until the day he died. It's called atavism. At the present stage, it would be too early to judge whether I'll be bald or...'

Just as he was about to finish speaking, something hit the top of his head.

He could see stars in front of his eyes.

'The next time you blabber on about something stupid, I'll go with rock,' said Gotou, holding out his clenched fist.

He should discover the answer to things he didn't know himself instead of asking. That was probably what Gotou was saying.

Ishii interpreted it that way and shut his mouth.

10

Haruka headed towards the prefabricated two-storey building behind Building B.

Ten small rooms of about four-and-a-half tatami lined each floor and were loaned out to students by the university for circle activities.

Haruka stood at the very end of the first floor in front of a door that had a plate on it which read <Movie Research Circle>.

Calling it a Movie Research Circle was a barefaced lie. He had fooled the university to borrow a room and had taken up residence. His secret hiding place.

She'd ended up coming here, but...

For a while now, Haruka had been repeatedly reaching for the doorknob only to retract her hand.

Maybe she should just stop. She'd really just wanted to show her face and chat, but because of Miki, she was in a strange state.

After the last incident, she'd promised Yakumo that she wouldn't bring any more trouble, but she'd clearly picked some up.

'What am I doing?'

She lowered her shoulders and smiled bitterly.

I'm just going to go home today without seeing Yakumo –

Though that would mean she'd be ignoring Mayuko's request, she wanted to keep her promise to Yakumo. She felt like she was just putting off the problem, but there was no helping it.

'Are you going to come in or not? Make up your mind.'

Just as Haruka had turned her back to the door, there was a voice.

'Eh?'

She reflexively turned around, but the door was still closed. There was nobody nearby either.

'What are you glancing around restlessly for? You look really suspicious. I'll report you to the police.'

This voice full of languidness was definitely Yakumo's.

She could hear him from the other side of the door, but could he see from there? Clairvoyance? There was no way.

In any case, if Yakumo knew she was here already, she couldn't just leave.

Haruka opened the door hesitantly.

Yakumo was there.

As usual, he had messy hair and sleepy eyes. He looked like he had just woken up and was sitting on the chair behind the square table in the middle of the room.

'Your indecisive attitude is disruptive.

He suddenly talked about what she was most worried about.

'I'm not indecisive.'

'You can't be helped if you don't recognise your problem yourself.'

Even though it was the first time they had met in a while, he was just saying whatever he wanted to.

'I don't need your help.'

Though she had spoken angrily, Yakumo wasn't concerned at all. He let out a huge yawn and raked a hand through his hair. Just like a cat.

Still –

'Hey, how did you know I was outside? Clairvoyance?'

Haruka sat on the folding chair across from Yakumo as she asked that.

'It seems you're stupider than you were the last time I saw you.'

'Calling me stupid is too much.'

'Then I'll change my wording. How about simpleton? I think it's perfect for you.'

He's really piling it on from one thing to the next –

'Forget it.'

'Look behind you,' Yakumo said while pointing at the door.

Following his finger, Haruka turned to focus her eyes on the door.

'Ah.'

It was simple once she understood.

It wasn't obvious from just a glance at the door, which had a poster for the movie *Sting* stuck on it, but there was a gaping hole the size of a fist.

In front of it, there was a mirror. She could see the other side of the door from here.

'It's a peephole,' said Yakumo proudly, folding his arms across each other.

'It's just a hole, isn't it? You can't see in from outside with a peephole.'

'Don't worry about the little things.'

It wasn't a little thing at all though.

'So what trouble do you have for me today?'

So he had figured it out.

She really had planned on showing up for the first time in a while to talk, but even if she said that, Yakumo definitely wouldn't believe her.

She suddenly remembered something Yakumo had said before. 'In this world, there are only two types of people: those who think my red eye is unsettling and those who try to use it.' When she'd heard that, she had decided that she, at least, would try to treat it differently.

That was why she decided to keep quiet about Mayuko.

'I just felt like coming by since I haven't been around in a while. I was wondering how you were.'

'You're worse at lying than you think you are,' said Yakumo, resting his chin in his hands.

She knew that even without him saying it.

'Hey, what were you doing?'

Haruka changed the topic before Yakumo said anything else.

'Studying English.'

Yakumo pointed at the photo on the table.

A smile woman in her early twenties was in the shot. She was a little plump, but she had a wonderful smile. It had probably been taken at some villa in the mountains.

'Is she your girlfriend, Yakumo-kun?'

'The screws in your head have gotten looser since the last time I saw you.'

Yakumo sighed, looking like he had seen the end of the world.

'The screws in my head? They haven't gotten looser at all!'

This person always said too much. He didn't care at all how she felt. She was an idiot for worrying.

'Take a closer look at the tree in the photo.'

Yakumo said that with his chin out. Haruka brought the photo closer to her and stared, but she couldn't find anything unusual.

'What about it? Stop putting on airs and just tell me.'

'There's something that looks like a human face in the tree trunk,' Yakumo replied while holding back a yawn.

Ah. She'd looked at it nonchalantly so she hadn't noticed, but she understood right after Yakumo told her.

The trunk of the tree in the background looked like it had a human face in it. It had its mouth open wide and appeared anguished, like Munch's painting *The Scream*.

'This is spirit photography then.'

'No, you're just seeing things.'

'Eh?'

That was different from what he said before. She felt a bit like she had been caught by a fox.

'The uneven tree trunk just looks like a face because of the lighting.'

'Really?'

'When the human brain recognises things, it compares them with things that are similar to it and identifies them.'

'True.'

She understood that intuitively.

It was the same as seeing a rabbit on the moon[9]. The shadowy parts of the moon looked similar to a rabbit, so people saw it as a rabbit.

'If the shape is similar, you'll unconsciously recognise it as a face even if it's something else entirely. Furthermore, if somebody says there's something that looks like a face there, you'll have the preconception that there's a person's face when you look and there'll be an immediate effect.'

'But that's...'

'That's how it works. Didn't you just prove it yourself? You couldn't tell from just looking, but the moment you heard that there was a person's face, you recognised the uneven tree trunk as a face, didn't you?'

That was true. That was what happened, now that he said it.

Spirit photography often showed up on television shows, but at first, she wouldn't be able to tell what the photos were of. However, once the narration said there was something like a face in the top left, she'd suddenly see a face.

But –

'How is this studying English?'

'Do you know Ogouchi, the English professor?'

'Yeah. The American-sized person, right?'

'That was a good way of putting it. The woman in this picture is his daughter, Satoko.'

'So you agreed to look at the photo to see if there was a spirit there.'

'Exactly.'

'It's unusual for you to poke your nose into this sort of thing though, Yakumo-kun.'

'I have my reasons,' Yakumo said with a smirk.

When Haruka looked at that expression, she understood why he had agreed to look at the photo.

'Don't tell me you did this in exchange for your English credit?'

'Your guess is right for once.'

Yakumo reclined on the chair with his arms folded in an arrogant manner.

'But this is just an optical illusion, right?'

'That's no problem. Since I said it'd become a catastrophe if it wasn't exorcised right away.'

'That's plain fraud!'

Haruka's tone immediately became harsher upon hearing about such an unfair method.

'Fraud? Listen – if I'd said it was just an optical illusion, he wouldn't have believed me. He would only have been more worried and brought the matter to exorcists more suspicious than I am. Isn't it better that I dealt with it nicely and said I exorcised the spirit for him?'

'It's not better at all!'

Haruka got up and lost her temper. Yakumo put his fingers in his ears to protest how loud her voice was.

It was a ridiculous reason. Why had she wanted to meet up with a guy like this?

She felt herself growing more and more irritated.

'I can understand when I look at you why people say youth these days get angry easily. You might have a calcium deficiency.'

'I'm not angry. I'm criticising your act of fraud. Do you think it's OK to trick people like this?'

Haruka pointed at the tip of Yakumo's nose as she continued her objections. However, it wasn't effective at all on Yakumo. He was completely expressionless, like it was someone else's problem.

'Please don't say things that will damage my reputation. I sold piece of mind. This is a splendid business.'

His twisted logic again –

'I'm going to interrupt your lover's quarrel.'

The door suddenly opened, and a figure with a bearlike large build entered the room.

It was Detective Gotou.

'Please return right now if you know you're interrupting.'

Yakumo replied without a moment's delay.

Gotou's large face twitched. However, his expression soon returned to normal, and he sat in the folding chair next to Haruka.

'Haruka-chan, it's been a while. Are you still seeing this obstinate idiot? If you don't cut it off soon, you'll be unmarried your whole life.'

'I'm just going to say this, but it's not my fault this woman doesn't have a boyfriend. It's a character problem.'

Yakumo immediately threw back a comment at Gotou's frivolous one.

He really was saying whatever he wanted right in front of the person he was insulting.

Who was the one with the character problem? And he just called me 'this woman'. Plus, even though neither of them had ever asked if I had a boyfriend or not, they're both talking with the assumption that I don't –

There were so many things she could retort to that she didn't even feel like opening her mouth.

'Er, Detective Gotou...'

She heard a voice that sounded so faint it could have faded out.

When she took a look, she noticed another person in front of the door.

It was a man who had vaguely delicate features and seemed intellectual, but he gave off the impression of being rather sensitive. Unlike Gotou, he wore a starched sleeved shirt and his tie was tied into a proper triangle.

'Who is that?'

Yakumo exchanged a look with Gotou.

'Ah, he's my subordinate, Ishii,' Gotou replied, looking up at the man standing at the door.

'My name is Ishii Yuutarou.'

Ishii bowed politely.

He seemed like the exact opposite of Gotou. Yakumo lowered his head slightly, as if to say, 'Nice to meet you.' Led along by the situation, Haruka bowed as well.

'Are you Gotou-san's subordinate? I won't say anything awful. You should ask for a job change right away.'

'A job change?'

Ishii responded nervously to Yakumo's sudden words.

'If you're with Gotou-san, your brain tissue will gradually change into muscle. You'll lose your ability to think and become an animal. You should change jobs while you still can.'

'Whose brain tissue are you calling muscle!?' Gotou said angrily, slamming the table.

Ishii didn't know what was happening and was fidgeting. It made sense. Anybody would be bewildered if they suddenly saw a scene like this.

Haruka had been confused at first too.

'So what trouble do you have for me this time?'

Unlike Gotou, who was agitated, Yakumo spoke in his usual lazy voice.

'Oh, that's right. You got that it was trouble right away.'

'There's no other reason for you to come here, is there, Gotou-san?'

'That's true. There's somewhere I want you to go with me.'

There was nothing timid about Gotou. Haruka couldn't suddenly get to the point like he did.

'OK.'

'Eh? OK?'

Gotou looked surprised at Yakumo's immediate response. Haruka, who had been listening, also thought Yakumo had accepted rather easily.

'What is it? Are you dissatisfied with something?'

'No, that's not it – I just thought you were being scarily obedient.'

'In exchange, please call it even with the incident from last time.'

'So you understand.'

Gotou smirked.

Ishii was still standing, looking blank. He might not have known why he was even here.

'However, today is no good.'

'Why? I thought we could go now.'

'Since I have some other trouble to deal with.'

Yakumo met Haruka's eyes.

She had planned on hiding it, but as expected, he'd seen through her.

Her chest felt tight. She didn't want to be lumped in with the people who just used Yakumo for his eye. She didn't see Yakumo that way.

'I just came to visit since I hadn't come by in a while. I said that I wouldn't bring any trouble the next time I came. Though I forgot the hot chocolate,' Haruka said quickly.

Yakumo stared at her with narrowed eyes. His eyes were sceptical. They were saying, 'That's not the truth.'

'Well, I'll be off then.'

Haruka knew that her face muscles were stiff and smiled before leaving the <Movie Research Circle> room, like she was making her escape.

She might have just made him more suspicious.

But it was fine like this.

It wasn't pity – she wanted to relate to Yakumo not as somebody who marvelled at his red eye or somebody who wanted to use it.

Haruka felt elated, as if she had won something, and started walking while looking at the perfectly clear blue sky.

11

After noon, there was an investigation meeting to report the results of the autopsy.

Hata stood on the rostrum and read out the results so far to the conference room where fifty members of the investigation team had gathered.

'The cause of the death of the first victim, Ayaka-chan, was suffocation due to pressure on her neck, as was reported before. The second victim, Miho-chan, didn't have any obvious injuries, and her lungs were filled with water. It is believed the cause of her death was drowning.'

The previously silent conference room was suddenly filled with the sound of people talking.

The second victim had been found at a dumpsite. She had died from drowning. They probably felt something was wrong.

'As well, water plants and freshwater bacteria were found in the second girl's lungs.'

'Can we take that to mean she drowned in a river somewhere?'

One of the investigation team members raised a hand and asked that.

'Though we cannot confirm that yet, the possibility is extremely high.'

Hata gave it a moment before starting his explanation again.

'Though the causes of death are different, there are lacerations on both of their right ankles that look like they are from something like a rope being bound around them, which links the two girls' cases together.'

'How likely is it that it was the same perpetrator?'

Another question came up.

Hata thought it was the job of the police to decide that rather than his, though it might have been inappropriate to put it that way.

'Currently, no bloodstains or hair from the criminal have been discovered.'

Hata evaded the question and finished his explanation.

He gave his position on the rostrum to Hijikata, the police chief, and sat on one of the chairs at the conference table, which had been set up so the investigation team members could face each other.

He suddenly felt overwhelmed with tiredness, like his nervousness had been unravelled. He didn't really like speaking in front of people.

He also thought there hadn't been any need for him, as the coroner, to participate in the investigation meeting just to read a report.

'Next, how is the investigation going?'

To respond to Hijikata, who was standing on the rostrum, the chief detective Ideuchi stood up as well.

Currently, we are gathering information near the location where the corpse was found, but we have not found any valuable information as of yet.'

Ideuchi bit his lower lip.

Hata couldn't decide whether that action was from anger towards the detestable murderer or regret that he couldn't make an appeal to the police chief.

'Ayaka-chan, the first victim, and Miho-chan, the second victim, and the currently missing Keiko-chan. All three of them disappeared on the way home from school, so we believe the perpetrator may be singling out girls from nearby schools.'

For what purpose?

Hata murmured that in his heart.

'Hereafter, we will be gathering information while focussing on nearby schools. As well, we are narrowing the number of suspects from those who have been arrested for molestation and other obscene acts.'

Hata understood that they could only rely on witnesses since not even one fingerprint or strand of hair had been found. However –

'As well, because we cannot deny the possibility that the female victims were involved in the incident because they took part in compensated dating[10], we are also reviewing the daily lives of the victims.'

Hata felt the words compensated dating were disproportionate for middle-school students, but that was just for a moment.

If this was a few years ago, mainly high school students would take part in compensated dating. However, the age bracket had lowered recently, and Hata had heard that it had even spread to middle-school students.

The girls would be bought by middle-aged men with daughters of about the same age.

The fathers might have been resolving their resentment at not being able to face their own daughters in a warped way.

The world really was a mystery.

'How is the correspondence with the victims' relatives going? Yesterday, the father of the second victim, Miho-chan, said on a television interview that the police hadn't made any apology to their family.'

The conference room stirred at Chief Hijikata's words.

Hata had seen that broadcast too. While the father had been angry at the police, the mother had been hunched over sobbing.

The reality that their daughter had died would never leave them.

This family carried the grief of having their daughter taken away from them irrationally and would probably continue to be eaten away by the stress that came from that for as long as they lived.

That was how Hata felt.

In any case, as long as they didn't know the murderer's goal, they couldn't narrow down the suspects.

Looking at it as the coroner, though he didn't dare to say this aloud, he thought that the investigation was veering terribly off course.

Even if they investigated previous offenders or compensated dating, there probably wouldn't be any results, since there was no indication that any of the female victims had been sexually assaulted.

However, that would mean that they didn't know the perpetrator's goal. It felt like it would be a long battle.

Hata murmured that to himself in his mind.

12

While driving, Ishii used the rear-view mirror to sneak glances at the young man called Yakumo sitting in the back.

He looked extremely bored, holding back yawns several times as he vacantly stared out the window.

However, Ishii thought that attitude might have been an act. He felt the young man had an indiscernible character.

Why did Detective Gotou bring him along in the first place?

It seemed like they knew each other from before, but he didn't understand their relationship at all. It felt like Detective Gotou treated Yakumo as a friend, and Yakumo seemed polite on the surface but was rude in intent – the end result was that Yakumo joked around with Detective Gotou even though Detective Gotou was part of the police force.

Most of all, Ishii felt uncomfortable having a civilian accompany them on their investigation of the incident.

Strictly speaking, an incident hadn't occurred yet, but there were secrets to be kept in their line of work, and it would also become a problem of responsibility if anything happened.

Ishii had objected to it many times, but Gotou had ignored him, and in the end, he'd wound up here with no explanation.

What on earth was Detective Gotou thinking –

He would only have to wait a little longer. It would probably become clear soon.

'Yakumo, was it really OK letting Haruka-chan leave like that?' Gotou said, breaking the silence.

Was Haruka the name of the girl who had been in that room?

Ishii recalled what Haruka looked like. Her image was still fresh in his mind.

She was a very cute young woman.

She had slightly slanted eyes that looked kind along with a pleasant smile. Her boyish outfit of a parka and jeans matched her short hair which went to the nape of her neck.

Having said that, she didn't give off the impression of being crude. Her feminine delicateness – or perhaps he should say her every gesture – had caught his eye.

Ishii's chest hurt when he thought about her.

'I don't know.'

Yakumo said that with a yawn, sounding bored.

'What a cold guy.'

'I just respected her intentions.'

'You'll end up losing her like that.'

Gotou started snickering as he teased Yakumo.

Judging from the flow of the conversation, was Haruka-chan Yakumo's girlfriend?

'I've said it many times, but she's just a troublemaker.'

'You say that, but you're really interested in her.'

'She's not my type.'

Yakumo snorted.

That was good. Whatever Yakumo's true feelings were, it seemed that they weren't dating.

'So you say. I'll ask you then – what's your type?'

Gotou turned around in the passenger seat with a smirk at the gossipy topic he brought up.

However, Yakumo looked uninterested.

'I don't mind telling you if you tell me how you first met your wife, Gotou-san.'

'Idiot. As if I could tell you that!'

Ishii found Gotou's flustered expression so funny he burst into laughter.

'What's so funny?'

Gotou was glaring fiercely. Ishii quickly stopped laughing and concentrated on driving.

'Well, you made me ride in the car without any explanation, but what trouble do you have for me this time?'

Just as they reached the large street in front of the station, Yakumo spoke up while running a hand through his hair.

'Oh, now that you mention it, I haven't explained.'

Gotou took a cigarette case from his chest pocket, drew out one cigarette and held it in his mouth.

'If you light that, I'll get off this car immediately.'

'All I did was put it in my mouth,' Gotou replied, putting the cigarette back in the case. He started his explanation. 'Seems like a woman's been possessed by a ghost or something.'

'Why are the police involving themselves with something like that?'

Yakumo raised one of his well-shaped eyebrows as he asked, like he couldn't understand.

'Normally, the police wouldn't budge for a case like this.'

'So why are you?'

'The girl who's been possessed is the police chief's daughter.'

He said it.

Ishii could accept that Gotou had spoken without mentioning any names, but he couldn't stay silent now that Gotou had shared this much information.

'Detective Gotou, it will be a problem if you share information about the investigation with a civilian.'

'It's fine, so just shut up and drive!'

Gotou replied angrily to Ishii's objection.

'But the chief detective said to keep this a secret...'

'This guy is an exception! I said it's fine, so it's fine!'

If Gotou said that much, Ishii couldn't say anything back.

'It's fine. I'll keep this secret, so I won't cause any trouble for you, Ishii-san.'

Yakumo was the one who followed up.

Things had ended up rather strange.

Though Ishii still didn't agree, all he could do was obediently absorb himself in driving.

'Plus, it seems like the girl who was possessed has been saying crazy things around the clock.'

'Like you, Gotou-san?'

At Yakumo's jab, Gotou replied, 'Shut up,' and continued his explanation again.

'The chief's wife was really worried about her daughter's stranger behaviour, so she went and called a spirit medium. Luckily, that medium was scared and ran away. Just...'

'Were you told to clean this up before it became public?'

'Well, that sort of thing.'

'You're being used pretty well as a maid.'

'Hey! Whose fault do you think it is that things turned out like this?'

Gotou turned around and bent forward as he yelled, but Yakumo was aloof as usual.

'A problem with your driving skill caused the accident, Gotou-san. It isn't my responsibility.'

'You brat! I'll kick you out of the car!'

'I wouldn't really mind.'

Yakumo smirked, probably to make the detective angrier.

Ishii listened to their exchange in mute amazement.

He was confused by the gap between what he had imagined and reality, and he felt an indescribable uneasiness at the drive which he couldn't envision the end of.

13

After leaving Yakumo's hiding place, Haruka walked while looking at her feet.

A strong wind that made her feel the advent of spring was blowing from in front of her, so her fringe would be mussed up and dirt would enter her eyes if she didn't look down.

But was that really all –

She felt that the winding slope to the station was longer than usual.

She stopped many times along the way to sigh.

She would have to tell Mayuko she couldn't do anything.

Since she couldn't consult Yakumo, there was nothing she could do. Haruka, unlike Yakumo, couldn't see the spirits of the dead. Even if she left the matter for longer, it would just be wasting her time.

But how should she refuse?

Even though it had been a misunderstanding in the first place, she had already agreed to help.

She recalled how relieved Mayuko had looked then. She had bowed her head multiple times while crying and thanking Haruka.

It'll be difficult to tell her –

Haruka sighed again.

Why did she always stick her neck into things when it wasn't necessary?

Why did she respond that way to Mayuko then?

She knew the reason.

Ever since her twin sister had died, she had always tried hard to be a good girl.

While pretending to live in a carefree manner, she always paid close attention to how people looked at her. She didn't complain about things she

didn't like, she never let her smile fade, and she always kept her wishes and desires closed off in her heart.

I was scared –

Of having someone say, 'It'd have been better if you died.'

That was why she would pay attention to others' opinions of her and try her best not to be hated. One day, her existence might be rejected. While thinking that –

She probably wanted somebody to say this to her.

It's fine for you to continue living –

Haruka suddenly stood still and took the phone strap out from her beige handbag.

It was the one she had received from Mayuko.

The strap that had AYAKA written on it – the same name as her sister's.

If this strap belonged to the ghost Mayuko saw, that girl was probably dead.

Why, after losing her life, was the girl still wandering in the river?

Yakumo had said this before. Ghosts weren't demons or a new type of life-form. They used to be living human beings.

Why did they die? Why were they wandering? By understanding the reason, the spirits of the dead could be released.

– What sort of feelings did my sister carry?

Haruka gripped the strap in her palm tightly.

She couldn't see the spirits of the dead like Yakumo, but she still might be able to feel something.

She would go to the river where Mayuko encountered the ghost.

It wouldn't be too late to refuse after that.

Haruka raised her head – she wouldn't lose to the strong wind – and took a deep breath before she started walking.

14

Gotou stood in front of a house.

The house was about ten minutes from the station and was at the entrance of the street.

In the line of cookie-cutter houses, this house cut a remarkably brilliant image, surrounded by white walls with tiled roofs and a set of double doors.

It was a mansion that a regular businessman would never be able to obtain, no matter how hard he worked.

'Damn, building such a huge house with taxpayers' money...'

Gotou kicked at the asphalt.

'You say that, Gotou-san, but your existence itself is a waste of taxpayers' money.'

Yakumo, standing next to him, gave him a fleeting glance as he spoke.

'What did you say!? Try saying that again!'

There was no point getting riled up over everything Yakumo said. He knew that, but there was no reason he had to put up with it.

'I'm saying you should work your salary's worth.'

'Same for you – why don't you go study your school fees' worth?'

'If there wasn't a detective throwing cases at me, I'd show up in class more often.'

He always jabbed at the sensitive points.

Gotou had nothing to reply to that.

'Sorry I'm late. I got lost.'

Ishii, who had gone to park the car, came back running like a girl.

Why did he even go search for a parking lot? He could've just parked on the road.

'You're so slow! How far did you go!?'

Gotou directed the anger that had piled up from talking with Yakumo towards Ishii.

'But it takes five minutes to walk from here to the closest parking lot, and I couldn't help being a bit lost since it's the first time I've been here,' Ishii replied. He took a deep breath and adjusted the position of his glasses with a finger.

Affected gestures like that got on Gotou's nerves.

'At least find out where you can park before coming.'

'But since we came here so suddenly, I didn't have the time...'

He keeps on making excuses. In my time, you'd admit that even your blood was blue if your senior said it was.

Well, whatever –

'Let's go.'

Gotou cheered himself up before he could feel completely depressed and passed through the gate first.

When he pressed the intercom at the entrance, a sliding door opened, and a woman of about fifty appeared.

She was a Japanese beauty. She was dressed smartly, like she was ready to go to a party at any time.

She was probably the police chief's wife.

'I'm Gotou, the detective.'

Gotou took his notebook from his jacket's inner pocket and showed his identity card.

Ishii also did the same with his notebook and introduced himself. 'My name is Ishii Yuutarou.'

'We have been waiting. I heard from my husband that you would be coming.'

The police chief's wife bowed politely from the waist and invited them in.

Gotou stepped into the entryway.

'How large. It's about the same size as my room.'

Yakumo, who had followed him in, was looking around the entryway while admiring it aloud.

'Excuse me, but who might you be?'

The police chief's wife gave Yakumo a very cautious look.

Her misgivings were natural. It might have passed in a television drama, but normally, no detective would wear a shirt and jeans. It wasn't an undercover investigation.

'Ah, he's a spirit psychology professor. He's currently cooperating with us.'

Gotou felt awkward lying to the police chief's wife, but he decided to just deceive her since he couldn't say that Yakumo was a university student who could see ghosts.

'Eh? You were a spirit psychology professor?'

Ishii turned around, extremely surprised. If he reacted like that, Gotou's lie would have been for nothing.

'Shut up.'

Gotou glared at Ishii.

'My name is Saitou. It's nice to meet you.'

Unlike Ishii, Yakumo knew how to react in situations like this, and he bowed formally without even changing his expression.

It was mysterious, but his dignified behaviour actually made him look the part.

'We'll be in your care then, professor.'

The police chief's wife didn't suspect anything and greeted Yakumo back. Then, she invited them down the corridor, saying, 'Please follow me.'

Gotou walked alongside Yakumo down the corridor, following the police chief's wife.

When he took a glance behind him, Ishii still looked like he didn't understand what was going on, but he was following them silently.

After they went up the stairs and reached the door right by them, the police chief's wife quietly said, 'Here we are.'

It might have just been the light, but she suddenly looked paler.

She rubbed her hands together in front of her stomach, like she was somewhere very cold.

'May we go in?'

When Gotou spoke up, the police chief's wife looked up in surprise. She looked a bit troubled, but then she said, 'Please do,' in a voice that sounded like it might fade out.

'Yakumo.'

'Let's go.'

Yakumo nodded.

It seemed that Yakumo could sense the strange atmosphere beyond the door. His expression was stiffer than usual.

'We're coming in.'

Gotou opened the door and stepped inside.

At that moment, the air suddenly changed.

It was difficult to breathe. He felt clammy. Shivers were running down his spine.

The lights were off, and the curtains were closed. The room was dark.

A woman sat on the bed by the window. That was —

Like all the strength had been taken from her body, her arms lay limply at her side and she hung her head, so Gotou could see the top of it. Her face was hidden by long hair.

She looked like she had lost her sense of self.

Though part of it might have been because he couldn't see her face, Gotou couldn't recognise the woman in front of him as Makoto.

He had met Makoto many times when she was working as a reporter. She wasn't naively cheerful, but she was an ambitious woman with a strong

heart.

However, the woman in front of him today was just like a doll.

'Is that it?'

At some point, Yakumo had stood next to him. He spoke while stroking his chin.

'Yeah, looks like it.'

'E-er, Detective Gotou, I...'

Ishii stood in front of the door and was looking around the room nervously.

'Stay there.'

'Ah, OK.'

Man, if he was so nervous when nothing had even happened yet, he wouldn't be any help at all.

'So Yakumo, what about it?'

Yakumo didn't reply to Gotou's question. After sighing deeply, he stepped up to the bed and stood in front of Makoto.

'Who are you?'

His voice was calm as asked Makoto that question.

No, perhaps that had been a question to the ghost inside Makoto –

There was no response.

'Please respond to the question. Who are you?'

Yakumo narrowed his eyes and asked again.

Suddenly, Makoto raised her head.

Like a bamboo screen, long hair covered her face. Her wide eyes were red and inflamed.

'Who are...'

'Aaaaooooooooo!'

Makoto interrupted Yakumo's words with a beastly howl.

Her teeth were bared and her eyebrows were raised – she looked like a demon.

Saliva was dripping from her mouth.

'Eek.'

He heard a short shriek.

It had been Ishii. He had fallen to the ground and was covering his mouth with a trembling hand.

'Be quiet.'

Gotou gave him a kick and then turned around to face Makoto again.

Her body was twitching convulsively.

It was just like a horror movie. He'd scolded Ishii earlier, but the truth was that Gotou was scared too.

'Can you not speak?'

Yakumo was the only one of them who wasn't perturbed. He spoke in the same tone as before and continued asking questions.

'Geeet ouuuut.'

This time, Makoto didn't scream, but instead spoke words with a clear meaning.

When he heard that voice which reverberated to the bottom of his stomach, Gotou felt that the woman in front of his eyes today wasn't the reporter Hijikata Makoto but somebody else entirely.

'How long have you been there?'

Yakumo continued asking questions.

In exchange, the woman's body started shaking, little by little.

Then, tears started flowing from those inflamed eyes.

Her jaw quivered, making her teeth chatter.

'... He... lp... me...'

A weak, hoarse voice, completely different from before.

Perhaps that was the voice of the real Hijikata Makoto –

'Shuuuuut uuuup!'

Then, the beastly voice yelled again, and her neck cracked forward and back. She collapsed onto the bed.

Gotou walked up to the bed and looked at Makoto.

She had fainted, but she was still breathing and she had a pulse. Did she lose consciousness?

'Oi. What just happened?'

Yakumo didn't reply to Gotou's words but instead pinched his brow, breathing deeply like he was in pain.

'Oi, Yakumo. What's wrong?'

Gotou tried to take a peek at his face, but Yakumo turned around so he wouldn't be able to.

'It's nothing,' Yakumo quietly replied. Then, he left the room briskly after excusing himself.

The confused police chief's wife asked what had happened, but Gotou shook her off and followed Yakumo out of the house.

He went through the gate and had just stepped on the road when he spotted Yakumo again.

He had his back against a telephone pole and was sitting while pressing against his left eye with both hands. A cold sweat ran down his cheeks. Gotou had seen Yakumo like this a few times before.

'You OK?'

'So even you worry about other people, Gotou-san,' Yakumo said hoarsely. He acted this way even at a time like this. Trying to look strong. He had a bitter smile.

'What happened?'

'It was a little intense.'

'Intense?'

Yakumo stood up while using the telephone pole for support.

'I said before that souls were like clusters of peoples' emotions.'

'Yeah.'

'My left eye can see those emotions. Naturally, the way I see them differs depending on how strong those emotions are. Accordingly, the stronger those emotions are, the greater the burden on my eye. It's like the pain you feel when looking at a bright light.'

I sort of understand, but I sort of don't –

No, there was no way he could understand. No matter how many words Yakumo used, the pain of seeing spirits of the dead was a cross that Yakumo would have to continue to bear alone.

He felt a pain in his heart, as if he had been pricked by a needle.

'W-w-what happened?'

Ishii flew out of the gate, a bit late.

He was sweating bullets for a different reason. Even though he'd been so interested, he'd ended up panicking when it came to the crunch.

'It's fine, so hurry and get the car.'

'Y-yes sir.'

As soon as Ishii answered, he started running frantically like he had been cornered by a bear in a forest.

'So what happened?'

Gotou turned towards Yakumo again.

'That woman has been possessed by a spirit of the dead. Though she looks like a woman on the outside, he's a man on the inside. On top of that, the situation is rather serious.'

'What do you mean?'

He drew closer to Yakumo.

'I've seen a number of people who have been possessed before, but this is the first case where the body has been so corroded.'

'Corroded?'

'To put it simply, that spirit is hijacking another person's body.'

'Is that possible?'

The cigarette fell out of Gotou's mouth in his surprise.

'Well, it's probably impossible. Even if the body is a spirit's vessel, it's not like any will do. It's like how organs can be rejected during transplants.'

'What? Then it's fine, isn't it?'

Gotou picked up the cigarette he had dropped and lit it.

It seemed that Yakumo was saying it wouldn't turn out like a horror movie where the body was completely taken over and became somebody else's.

'It's not fine.'

Yakumo spoke sharply, which was unusual for him.

'What?'

'Her body's being corroded from the possession. She already isn't eating properly.'

'What'll happen like this?'

'This might become debilitating – she could die.'

'Really?'

'Though that's just a possibility.'

This was becoming troublesome again.

They had to do something but –

'What are you going to do?'

'Who is the spirit that has possessed her? I need to look into that first.'

Yakumo placed his left index finger on his brow.

I understand what he's saying, but –

'How are you going to look into that?'

'Do you know when she became this way?'

'If I remember correctly, it was after she fainted at the scene of a traffic accident.'

'Was she in an accident?'

'No, that's not it. A man was hit by a car and she tried to save him, but she suddenly collapsed.'

'And the man at the accident?'

'He had died on impact...'

Oh – that was it! It was the man who died in that accident!

'We'll need to look into that man. It isn't at the level of somebody who is resentful because he died in a traffic accident. The roots are deeper. There's an attachment to life that's strong to the point of greed...'

Yakumo's words echoed oppressively in his heart.

'So, what to do?'

'First is gathering information. I want to know as much as possible about the situation, including the time of the accident.'

If that's how it is, it'd be quickest to talk to that old man –

He didn't really want to, but there was nothing to be done.

With perfect timing, the car Ishii was driving slid into view.

Gotou looked up at the window on the second floor that had its curtains closed.

He had thought he'd be able to just deal with this quickly, but things didn't look like they would turn out well.

15

Haruka walked along the embankment of Tama River, where Mayuko had seen the ghost.

There was a couple sitting together on the sloped lawn. A boat with a cheerful father and son pair on it floated along the river.

It was a relaxing landscape not even remotely appropriate for a ghost sighting.

After taking the elevated railway and walking about five hundred metres, the water gate came into view.

The large iron gate regulating the water level went across the river. There was a tower that looked like a fire lookout standing in the middle of the river.

White herons were flying around that tower.

'It should be around here.'

Haruka went down the lawn-covered embankment to the riverside.

There was a bent plastic umbrella.

Haruka slowly surveyed her surroundings and spotted a rock that rose about fifty metres from the water. Its surface was flat, but it had become wet from the water, and moss was growing on parts of it.

Haruka tried getting a bit closer. She put her bag on the riverbank and stepped towards that rock.

'Oi, missy. What are you doing over there?'

She turned around at the voice and saw a middle-aged man in work clothes carrying a bucket.

From his outfit, he was probably from the management office for the water gate. There was one more person too. A man of about the same age wearing grey slacks and a white shirt stood next to him.

'I was looking for something.'

She couldn't say she had come to see a ghost.

'What are you looking for?' asked the man in the white shirt.

His cheeks were hollow and there were bags under his eyes. He also looked pale. He felt sickly for some reason.

'Um... Er, my mobile phone...'

The phone strap suddenly came up in her mind and she lied at once.

'It's deep around there, so please be careful,' the man in the white shirt said.

'Ah, OK.'

'Give up – you should go home before it gets dark.'

The man in work clothes gave her that advice and then headed back towards the management office with the man in the white shirt.

When she looked up at the sky, she noticed that it had already started getting dark, like the two men had said.

She was wearing pumps today. She walked up the rock carefully so as not to lose her footing and stood at the tip.

She bent over just slightly and took a look at the river.

As the man in the white shirt had said, it seemed rather deep here.

The obscure surface of the water was moving slowly.

Haruka took the phone strap from her jeans pocket.

'Is your name Ayaka-chan...'

She tried asking her question towards the water, but there was no reply.

As she'd expected, there was no way she'd be able to resolve anything by coming here, since she couldn't see spirits.

'... St... p... eady...'

She heard a voice, but she wasn't sure from where.

She looked to the right and the left, but there was nobody there.

'Stop already...'

Again –

She couldn't tell the direction or the distance. The voice felt like it was talking directly to her head.

'Where is that coming from? Where are you?'

Haruka gripped the phone strap in front of her chest and spoke frantically.

Suddenly, she felt a presence –

It was at her feet.

She slowly lowered her gaze.

Gurgle. Gurgle.

Bubbles were coming up to the surface of the water.

Splash.

At the same time as the sound of the water spattering, a hand thrust out from the river.

A rotten purple hand.

The small hand that had not yet grown into an adult's one grabbed hold of Haruka's ankle.

'Aaah!'

She tried to fix her posture, but it was too late.

Haruka lost her balance and fell into the river in front of her –

The water was cold.

A numbing pain ran through her whole body.

She swallowed some water. She couldn't breathe. Her body felt heavy. She waved her hands about trying to find something to grab on to, but her hands found nothing.

A girl's face floated up in front of Haruka. She looked like she could cry at any moment.

The girl slowly sank to the river bottom.

She had to save her. She had to save that girl.

Haruka desperately stretched her arm out towards the girl, but she couldn't reach.

In a moment, all she could see was white.

There was a man. She couldn't see his face clearly. Who? Who was it?

The man's strangling her neck. It hurts. He's strangling my neck.

I can't see his face, but I know he's laughing.

Stop. It hurts. Save me.

Somebody.

Yakumo-kun.

Save me –

Her mind was growing hazy.

Am I going to die? I wonder if I can go to where my sister is –

Yakumo –

– Stop. Please, no more.

Haruka heard a girl's voice as she lost consciousness.

NOTES:

[1] 119 is the emergency number used in Japan (as well as a number of other Asian countries, such as Hong Kong).

[2] If anybody could kindly tell me what the accepted translation for the unsolved cases room is, I would greatly appreciate it!

[3] For a better mental picture, an eight-tatami room in the Nagano prefecture would be 3.64 m by 3.64 m, since the tatami size should be (according to my Google-based research that tells me Nagano isn't east of Shizuoka and thus has chuukyouma tatami) 910 mm by 1820 mm.

[4] Shogi is a Japanese game that is often said to correspond to chess. If you're interested, March Comes in Like a Lion is an excellent manga about a shogi player that covers matches in a fair amount of detail.

[5] Kokeshi are Japanese dolls that have a very distinctive shape and face.
Here
are some examples!

[6] Confirmed to be Hokutou!

[7] In Japan, universities have circles and clubs. In general, circles are more laidback and meet up less often, while clubs are strict and often have required practices throughout even the holidays.

[8] The Shinsengumi (are pretty popular nowadays so they might not need a note, but anyway) were a special police force in the late Tokugawa shogunate who were loyal to the Tokugawa bakufu even when everything was tumbling down around them and everyone else had abandoned ship. They have been heavily romanticised in everything from television shows to otome games to ridiculous gag manga. (Bit of a tangent: the police chief's family name is Hijikata, which was also the name of the vice-captain of the Shinsengumi.)

[9] In Japanese folklore, there is a rabbit that lives on the moon. The short version of the story is that there was a monkey, a fox and a rabbit who all lived in a mountain. They came across an old man who had collapsed and they went to get him food. The monkey and fox both succeeded but the rabbit couldn't find anything, so he got his friends to light a fire and offered himself as food, jumping into the fire. The old man was actually Sakra, lord of the devas, and he brought the rabbit to the moon so that the rabbit's act of compassion would go down to posterity. (There are other versions of the story as well, but this is the one I know.)

[10] Compensated dating, or enjokousai (援助交際) in Japanese, is when women are paid to accompany men on dates, though it does not necessarily include the exchange of sexual services.

Volume 2 Chapter 2: VOLUME 2 - THAT WHICH CONNECTS SOULS

Chapter 2

VOLUME 2 - THAT WHICH CONNECTS SOULS

file 02: exorcism (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

Why was he being treated like a maid? He had a lot of work to do since this was a serial abduction murder case .

Hata took a file out of the cabinet .

It was an autopsy report for a traffic accident that had occurred a few days earlier . Wasn't it just a regular old traffic accident? He didn't understand at all why something like this was necessary now .

The accident had occurred three days ago .

The male victim had ignored a red light and suddenly ran into the intersection .

There were reports from eyewitnesses as well . A housewife on the way home from shopping and a middle-aged man who worked at the management office for the water gate . However, the car was still at fault . The driver hadn't watched the road .

Didn't watch the road? If somebody suddenly ran into the intersection, you wouldn't be able to avoid it even if you had been watching .

Traffic law was written in a way that completely ignored human reaction time .

It could only be called bad luck .

The driver found at the scene of the accident had seemed serious . He had been extremely pale and just barely managed to stand .

It had hurt to look at his cowering figure as he spoke in a trembling voice . He might have been imagining his future .

Hata, who had seen scenes like that many times, had decided not to drive a car .

He knew how terrifying it was to have your life crumble down around you in an instant .

'We're coming in . '

At the same time as Hata heard that casually loud voice, the door opened and Gotou came into the room . Hata felt that it must have been suffocating for Gotou to come into the extremely narrow room lined with cabinets and shelves .

'Excuse me . '

A slim young man followed Gotou in .

A light bulb turned on over Hata's head – he didn't even need to hear an explanation . Since Gotou had brought him along regarding the case, there was no mistaking it .

'Might you be Saitou Yakumo-kun?'

'There's no might about it – that's correct . '

He gave a brusque reply to Hata's question .

During the previous case, they had only spoke on the phone, but he could still tell immediately from that tone of voice .

The young man had been born with an exceptional genetic make-up that allowed him to see the spirits of the dead .

Hata stood up and shook hands with Yakumo . His body temperature was normal .

Still holding his hand, Hata took a close look at Yakumo's face .

Oh – he usually wore contacts then . The size of his left and right eyeballs and pupils didn't appear to differ much .

He wanted to confirm how it felt . Hata reached towards Yakumo's left eye, but Gotou pushed that hand away .

'What are you doing?' Hata had been so close .

'Shut up! You perverted old man! Do you plan on dissecting it?'

'Will you let me?'

'Are you an idiot? Control yourself and stick to mice!' Gotou yelled, spitting as he did so .

What a noisy man .

Even if Hata didn't go so far as to dissect it, he wanted to thoroughly examine Yakumo's left eye one day .

That which connects the body and the soul, the barrier between the living and the dead . It was likely that Yakumo's left eye could see that . Yakumo knew the answer to the question Hata had been chasing for so many years .

Gotou plopped himself down on the folding chair by the wall, and Yakumo stood by the wall with his arms folded .

At that point, another person came in – a man who felt rather frail .

'Er, please excuse me . My name is Ishii Yuutarou, and I'm working as Detective Gotou's subordinate . '

Compared to Gotou, the man seemed so fragile it was pitiful .

He bowed from the waist – it was so polite it was stupid .

'You've been paired with Gotou-kun? My condolences . '

'Your condolences? You're the one who's got his feet stuck in the Sanzu River[1] . '

'My, what an annoying man . '

Hata laughed scornfully at Gotou's insolent words and tossed the file onto the table .

'That's the material you want . '

'Thanks . '

Gotou started flipping through the material on the table . Yakumo leant over to look as well . Since the room was too small, Ishii couldn't move and stayed by the door .

'There's no mistaking it . This is the man,' Yakumo said, pointing at the photo taken of the corpse's face at the time of the autopsy .

The skin from the cheek to the nose was cut . The blood had been wiped off before the photo was taken, but the flesh and bones still showed .

He was so thin it seemed sickly, and his face looked extremely nervous .

His name was Andou Takashi . He was twenty-five years old . His father was a member of the Kyushu prefectural assembly . He had been a legal apprentice until the end of last year, but he'd caused a little incident and had been unemployed at the time of his death .

'But why are you interested in an old traffic accident?'

He hadn't heard anything from Gotou before he came . Hata asked his question while sipping at the tea in his teacup .

'A number of reasons . '

Gotou crossed his arms standoffishly .

'I'm asking about those reasons . '

He should have guessed from the flow of the conversation, but this man was just too straight . Hata thought that it was more appropriate to call him an idiot than a hot-blooded detective .

'The spirit of the man who died in this accident has possessed a woman . '

Yakumo explained in Gotou's stead .

Hata then understood that Yakumo had probably stuck his neck into this case since they believed a ghost was involved .

'That is interesting . '

'This man has an attachment to life that knows no bounds . Furthermore, he also has very bad intentions . There must be something serious for a spirit of the dead to possess somebody living . I want to know what that something is . '

So it wasn't just seeing the spirits of the dead – he could feel so much?

It was becoming even more fascinating .

'Hata-san, was there anything you noticed?' Yakumo asked .

'Things I noticed, eh?'

He thought it over .

The cause of death was a cerebral contusion . There were no other injuries, and there had been no response from drugs . Nothing particularly strange had showed up during autopsy .

'Anything is fine . '

Even if he said that –

'There wasn't really anything . '

'I see . '

Yakumo raked a hand through his hair, looking irritated .

'Old man . Where's the corpse?'

Gotou asked an inappropriate question .

'It was cremated a long time ago . It's already been three days since his death . '

'Makes sense...'

'His family came to pick him up soon after . I think his flat's already been vacated . '

'His family must've been disturbed since their son died at such a young age in an unexpected traffic accident,' Gotou said seriously, looking through the materials .

At those words, Hata recalled his memories from three days ago anew . Andou's family hadn't been emotional like Gotou had suggested . On the contrary –

'It was so cold-hearted . They finished the paperwork in a business-like manner and that was the end of it . '

'Really?'

Gotou mulled over that .

'Seemed like he hadn't really been a member of the Andou family in the first place . '

'Kid from a previous marriage?'

'It's a bit more complicated than that . He and his mother had lived by themselves when he was young, but that mother killed herself about ten years ago so he was adopted into the Andou family . '

'Do you mean...'

Gotou was an idiot, but he had a good nose for this sort of thing from his experience as a detective .

'That's what I mean . Seems his birth mother had been a mistress . That makes him a blood-related son . '

'But why do you know so much about this, old man?' Gotou asked . His doubt was natural .

'At some point during the procedure, I got to contact his family . A servant gossiped away about this even though I hadn't asked . '

'What a disaster . '

'Well, I didn't mind since it was interesting . If you're interested, try giving a call . You'll hear much more from a servant than the family themselves . '

'Can't stop rumours, eh . '

Gotou leant back on his chair .

'After that, there was something a bit strange, though this might not be related . '

'What is it?'

It seemed like Yakumo had felt something, and he spoke with his brows furrowed .

'I think it was yesterday . A few of the things he'd had on him were returned – said they weren't their son's . '

'What were they?'

'If I remember correctly, there was a bible . A small one about the size of a notebook . There was also a key,' Hata replied as he recalled his memories .

'Where are those?'

This time, Gotou was the one who spoke up .

'In storage . '

'Ishii! Dash!'

Gotou yelled authoritatively, like he was calling a dog .

'Eh?'

Ishii had just been listening silently . He suddenly turned around and jumped in surprise . He was fidgeting like he didn't know what to do .

Gotou was awful at talking . He'd definitely just brought him along without explaining properly .

'Hurry and go bring it here!'

This time, Gotou stood up and pointed at the door as he yelled .

Ishii finally understood . It was nice how he responded with an 'Ah, yes sir!' and rushed out, but he might have been too hurried because he banged into the closed door .

'What are you doing? Get a move on!'

Gotou lost his temper at Ishii, who was crouching while pressing a hand against his nose .

Ishii replied, 'Yes sir,' in a nasal voice and left the room .

'It's a light blue envelope that has Andou written on it!'

Hata called out to Ishii's back .

He couldn't be sure whether he heard him .

'I feel really bad for your subordinate,' Hata muttered .

2

Gotou's irritation had reached its peak .

It had already been almost an hour since Ishii went out of the room . Hata had already left, saying he had some other work to do .

He acknowledged Ishii's enthusiasm, but he had probably run off in the wrong direction .

'That guy's late...'

'Then why not help him out?'

Yakumo looked up from the materials he was perusing as he sat in the seat Hata had been in it .

'If you're going to say that, you go . '

'Ishii-san is your subordinate, Gotou-san . I'm a complete stranger . '

'Ah, that's true . '

He really couldn't beat Yakumo in an argument .

'Gotou-san, you've been a bit strange lately,' Yakumo said, his lips turned up in a smirk .

Whenever Yakumo looked like that, he always had something unpleasant up his sleeve .

'I'm the same as usual . '

Gotou denied what Yakumo had said, but it was true .

It had only been one day so far, but being paired up with Ishii was driving him mad .

That guy had an unnatural interest in the occult, which ended up with him proclaiming that Gotou was a spirit detective or something .

'Gotou-san, why not be a bit nicer to Ishii-san?' Yakumo said with a big yawn .

'I never thought I'd hear about being nicer from you . '

'Gotou-san, have you really not noticed?'

'Notice? Notice what?'

Gotou put himself on guard, though he couldn't figure out what Yakumo was thinking .

'Ishii-san has feelings for you, Gotou-san . '

'He has earrings?'

'You said that on purpose . Feelings . I meant that he likes you, Gotou-san .
,

'W-w-w-wha – '

What was he saying? Gotou's heart was beating wildly . Why was it thumping so much? Calm down .

It wasn't like Yakumo's words didn't echo with him . When Ishii looked at Gotou, his eyes were like that of a puppy that had been given a treat . Gotou didn't know what to do when a man looked at him with eyes like that .

'Got this, Yakumo? There's a limit to how much you should joke . I'm a man . He's a man . Understand?'

'You have an unexpectedly obstinate way of thinking . If you like someone, gender doesn't matter . The important thing is how you feel, Gotou-san . '

Yakumo replied with a serious look .

'There's nothing to feel! I don't swing that way . '

A strange sweat ran down his forehead .

'Is that really true?'

'What do you want to say?'

Damn Yakumo . What the hell is he thinking? And why am I taking this so seriously?

'Nothing really . I'm just saying that it'd be better if you were honest with yourself . '

'I don't want to hear that from you . '

'Please answer honestly . Gotou-san, men or women – which do you prefer?'

'I obviously prefer women!'

Just as Gotou stood up and shouted, Ishii opened the door .

Ishii's mouth was gaping, and he stood stock still with a surprised expression on his face .

Yakumo was holding his stomach as he shook with laughter . He had just been making fun of Gotou to waste some time . What was he going to do with this atmosphere?

It'd just be annoying to explain everything .

'Was it there?' Gotou asked, sitting back then .

'Ah, yes . I f-found it,' Ishii said hesitantly, a light blue envelope in his hand .

'Let's confirm what's inside at once . '

Yakumo's face quickly turned serious, like nothing had happened .

Ishii put the contents of the envelope on the table . Just as Hata had said, there was a notebook-sized bible bound in black leather and a key that looked brand new .

Gotou reached out to take the bible, but Ishii had been thinking of doing the same thing, and their fingertips touched on top of the table .

'Ack . '

He hurriedly pulled his hand back .

For some reason, things felt a bit strange .

He couldn't look directly at Ishii's face . What was this hazy feeling?'

'Gotou-san . Let's stop those thoughts there . '

Yakumo's lips were turned up in a smirk .

That bastard . It's because you said something strange . You haven't even noticed Haruka-chan's feelings . I'll get you back someday –

Gotou bit his lower lip and changed his mind, taking the key on the table .

It was still new . There was a sticker with <E-3> written on it on the bow .
It was a key for a disc tumbler lock . It was probably for some room .

For a moment, he thought it might have been for the flat Andou lived in, but
it'd be strange for his relatives to return it if that were the case .

Yakumo took the bible in his hand and flipped through it .

Ishii looked like he didn't know what he should do, so he stood upright like
a kid who had been scolded .

Can we really save Makoto from the spirit by doing this –

'Gotou-san, please look at this . '

Yakumo broke the silence and placed a photo on the table .

It had probably been carried around for a while . The photo's corners were
worn .

There was a girl in the photo . Her hair was tied in a ponytail, and she wore
a school uniform with a blazer .

The photo looked like it had been taken in a room . There was a smile on
her lips . She looked happy at a glance, but her eyes weren't smiling .

Her eyes were wet, and it looked like she was afraid .

'Where'd you find that?'

'It was in between the bible's pages...'

Yakumo replied with his chin in his hands .

Why had Andou carried this photo with such devotion?

'T-t-this is Ayaka-chan!'

Suddenly, Ishii let out a loud voice which pierced Gotou's ears .

'You're so noisy . What are you making a fuss about?'

Ishii's behaviour was unusual . His body was shaking, and he was so agitated it felt like he could faint at any moment .

'But that's Ayaka-chan . '

'I heard you say that earlier . She somebody you know?'

'No, I don't know her, but... That's not it . This is the first victim from the serial abduction murder case...'

'W-what!?'

Gotou became agitated as well and stood up .

Ishii was talking about that Ayaka-chan –

The police were currently in a frenzy investigating that case .

It wasn't just Ayaka-chan . The other day, the corpse of the second victim, Miho-chan, was found at a dumpsite . Three days ago, Keiko-chan had disappeared .

It was a serious incident which had shaken society . A general mobilisation of the investigation team had been called and they were currently conducting an investigation, but since Gotou was being treated as an outsider, he hadn't seen a proper photo before .

But why would Andou, who'd died instantly in a traffic accident, have the photo of the female victim?

'His relatives might have thought this wasn't his because this photo was inside,' Yakumo said, tapping the photo with his fingertip .

Surely that was it . And old Hata had just put it away without looking inside .

Thinking about it logically, there wouldn't be a link between a traffic accident and a serial abduction murder case .

But –

'There might be something here . '

'Detective Gotou, what will you do?' Ishii said with a rare snort .

Even if he asked that, it wasn't something he could answer immediately .

A man who died in a traffic accident had a photo of a victim of a serial abduction murder case . It was incredibly suspicious, but that was the limit of it .

Should I go talk to investigations –

No, that wouldn't be necessary . They'd do it themselves .

'Ishii . Look into that Andou guy's background again . His friends, his upbringing – any detail will do . Just look into it . '

'Y-yes sir!'

Ishii stood up straight and responded energetically .

The way he responds is the only respectable thing about him though –

Gotou pinned down a tinge of anxiety and decided to start their investigation .

3

I could see a light –

A faint white light .

I can see someone's face .

Who could it be –

The person is saying something .

I can't hear .

I feel myself swaying .

Where am I?

I fell into the river, and then –

I couldn't breathe –

Am I dead?

'I'm glad . It looks like you're awake . '

Haruka heard a voice .

Upon hearing that voice, the mist lifted from Haruka's vision .

A middle-aged man with a long face was peering at her from above .

She remembered seeing him before . He had been at the river .

'Everything's OK now,' he said gently, smiling . His eyes closed when he smiled . Somehow, he made her feel at ease . 'I...'

Her voice was hoarse and didn't feel like her own .

'You nearly drowned in the river . Uchiyama from the management office at the water gate saved you . '

She recalled the middle-aged man in work clothes who had been at the river .

He was tan, with thick, forceful eyebrows and a sturdy body build .

That man saved her –

She was alive .

Haruka faintly but finally understood her own situation .

'Er...'

'Don't worry . I'm a doctor, and this is my hospital . '

So this man was a doctor .

She had been lucky .

An IV tube hung from her arm .

'My name is Kinoshita . What's your name?' Kinoshita asked .

'Ozawa... Haruka . '

Though she had regained consciousness, her body still felt heavy, and her voice wouldn't come out the way she wanted it to .

'You drank a lot of water . You should rest for today . '

'But...'

'Please don't worry about it . This is a private hospital and the nurses have gone home already, but if you need anything, press that button to call me and I'll come right away . '

She decided to obediently agree to Kinoshita's proposal .

She couldn't go home by herself in this state .

'Well, have a good rest . '

Kinoshita turned around and started to leave the hospital room .

'Um . '

Haruka called out to Kinoshita, forcing the sound out of her throat .

'What is it?'

'Thank you very much . '

Kinoshita smiled pleasantly .

'After you recover, please thank Uchiyama as well . '

Haruka responded with a nod . Then, Kinoshita turned off the lights and left .

In the moonlit twilight, Haruka realised that she was alive .

She couldn't tell if she was happy or sad, but tears flowed from her eyes and wet her pillow .

– Big sister . I'm still alive .

4

First thing in the morning, there was a regular investigation meeting .

Even though they conferred every day, they didn't have much to report .

While Hata rubbed at his sleepy eyes, he half-heartedly listened to their exchange .

'When we investigated the call history on the mobile phone of the second victim, Miho-chan, it showed in the browser history that she had accessed an online dating site...'

'Regarding the white station wagon that was sighted at the scene, we currently don't know who...'

'We obtained a list of customers for a pornography shop...'

'A former instructor who was arrested before for molestation was...'

The information was snarled . They couldn't narrow down the targets .

He knew that they were just taking all the possibilities into account, but they would just be overwhelmed by all the information they gathered .

If they couldn't find an opening, this stalemate would just continue .

Hata stifled a yawn as he mulled over these thoughts .

'What do you think, Hata-san?'

Suddenly, Chief Hijikata spoke to him .

He might have meant that as a reprimand towards someone who had yawned imprudently, but he was barking up the wrong tree . Hata was a coroner .

He autopsied corpses and showed up to investigation meetings like this, but strictly speaking, he wasn't part of the police .

Hata accepted requests from the police – a subcontractor, so to speak .

'Are you asking me?'

He'd try playing dumb . Hijikata stared directly at Hata .

What an obstinate man . Since it didn't seem like he would be able to get out of this, Hata reluctantly opened his mouth .

'If you are requesting my personal opinion, I think that the aim of this case's perpetrator is to kill . '

There were exclamations from every corner of the conference room .

Hata hadn't meant to say something so surprising .

'What do you mean?'

'I mean exactly what I said . '

'I don't understand . '

Hijikata looked sullen, like a child .

'From the impression I received after autopsying the corpses, there hadn't been any injuries that stood out or indications of sexual assault, yet the ankles had been bound by something like a rope . '

'Oi, couldn't he have been planning to assault them only to have them die before he could?'

'I don't know why he wouldn't have assaulted them immediately after binding them,' Hata replied, knowing his words would rub Hijikata the wrong way .

As usual, Hijikata was emotionally overwrought and had a bright red complexion .

'Then what is his goal?'

'I don't know . He isn't doing this to satisfy his libido or for money – something else . '

'A grudge?'

'That's probably not it . If it were a grudge, it would have been better for him to injure them more . Both their corpses were too clean . '

Hijikata glared at him like he had spotted a cockroach .

'Keep your hobby in check . I don't want to arrest you . '

At Hijikata's words, the conference room suddenly filled with laughter .

He didn't remember saying anything laugh-worthy . As long as a man like that was in command, it would be impossible to solve the case .

Shouldn't you be worrying about your daughter who's been possessed? It'd be faster if you left a case like this to Gotou and Yakumo .

Hata muttered those words in the back of his mind and smiled bitterly .

5

Ishii first headed towards the police station in front of the station, in order to meet with Sergeant Yoda, who had been in charge of the violent incident Andou caused a month ago .

Yesterday, Ishii had stayed up all night to investigate Andou .

Ishii found out about the violent incident through that . Andou hadn't been indicted or charged, but there was still a record of it with the police .

The truth was, Ishii should have come together with Detective Gotou, but the detective had refused bluntly, saying, 'Do something like that yourself . '

Detective Gotou had to be testing him . Would he be an appropriate partner? Ishii had to stand firm here to prove that .

'Excuse me . I'm Ishii from the detective department . '

He peeked inside from the police station's entrance .

It was a small space that might not have even been four tatami mats in size . A plump policeman of about forty or so was sitting on a chair at the desk in the middle of the room, and he looked up and grunted to acknowledge Ishii's presence .

It seemed that he was Sergeant Yoda .

'Well, please . Come in . '

Invited in by Yoda, Ishii sat on the folding chair opposite him .

'I am Sergeant Yoda Tarou . Thank you for taking time out of your busy schedule to come . '

Yoda showed the identification in his police notebook and introduced himself .

'Ah, please don't concern yourself with that . You must be busy with the serial murder case too . '

'Yes, well . '

Ishii was really an outsider, but Yoda ventured to reply vaguely without really saying anything .

'Er, you spoke about the Andou case, yes?'

While Yoda said that, he took out his work log from the desk drawer . He licked his fingers and then started flipping through the pages .

'That's right . '

'If the detective department is looking into it, does that mean Andou is the perpetrator?'

Such speculation was natural, but at this point, Ishii couldn't say yes or no .

'I could ask you the same thing . ' Ishii replied with a weak smile, which made Yoda scowl at him . He looked like he could start clicking his tongue at any moment . Ishii could almost hear Yoda's dissatisfaction at not being able to be informed about anything .

'Well, it's not a question we officers at the police station should be asking about,' Yoda replied, his expression once again mild .

'I'm sorry . '

'Why are you apologising?'

'Ah, er... even if you ask me why...'

'You have to be firmer . If you get flustered like that, even the perps will make fun of you . '

'Ah, yes . '

Ishii already knew what Yoda was telling him, but knowing and being able to do something about it were different stories .

Assertion was good, but what if that assertion was incorrect? He always ended up thinking about that . Naturally, that made him unable to say his own opinions .

He had ended up with his mouth shut many times because of that .

'It was unnecessary concern on my part . '

Maybe he had seen how Ishii was completely depressed, but Yoda went back to their original subject while drumming the back of his neck . 'The Andou case, right?'

'Yes . It'll be fine if you just say what you remember . '

'I remember it well . It was about one month ago... I had gone to the station because of some fuss with another incident and was returning from that . While I was going up the stairs, somebody called out to me saying, 'Officer, there's a molester . '

'A molester?'

Ishii cocked his head .

According to his data, Andou had caused a violent incident .

'That's right . She was a girl in middle school or so, and she had her hair in a ponytail . That girl said, "That man peeked up a girl's skirt . "'

'That man was Andou . '

'Yes . His eyes were wide as saucers in surprise . I couldn't leave things as they were since there was a female student in a skirt right in front of him, so I questioned him . '

'Did Andou really look up a skirt?'

'It's hard to find proof for molestation, so eyewitnesses and the victims' testimonies get precedence . It's easy to falsely accuse somebody of it . '

'Then Andou...'

'This is just my gut feeling, but he probably didn't do it . '

Yoda rubbed his double chin and stared into the air for a while, looking like he was pondering something, before continuing his story .

'Andou also insisted that he didn't do it . Well, it's not like the victim pressed charges, so I thought I'd just end it by warning him . '

'It didn't end . '

Yoda nodded at Ishii's words .

'That female student said this to Andou: "Liar . Just go die . "'

She said something like that to him –

They weren't words that should be said lightly to a stranger . It was an unbelievable thought, but it might not have been that surprising to hear on a news programme from a middle school student .

'When the guy heard that, his eyes suddenly looked different . They looked like they had been possessed by something . And then...'

'He assaulted that female middle school student?'

'Yeah . Since I held him back immediately, the girl wasn't harmed, but...'

'He was caught red-handed in his assault . '

'Just as you say . '

Yoda sat up in his chair, looking awkward, before continuing .

'I think that girl didn't see Andou molest anyone . She probably saw an officer nearby and decided to play a little prank, that's all . '

Ishii hadn't seen it happen, but it was probably as Yoda said .

Andou had been a legal apprentice . Even if he hadn't been arrested or charged, the event would have made his future life very difficult .

If he had been aiming to be a police officer or judge rather than a lawyer, he would have already been despairing .

Just one word closed the door on his dreams .

What feelings did Andou have afterwards?

While Ishii imagined them, he felt as depressed as if a dark cloud had been hanging over him .

'It wouldn't have ended like this if the guy had been just a bit calmer,' Yoda said with deep feeling, ending the discussion .

6

'Why do I have to go with you?'

While driving, Gotou took a peek at Yakumo, who had his arms crossed sullenly .

Yakumo's dissatisfaction was natural . Gotou didn't think that he should be bringing a civilian into the investigation either .

However, the case this time couldn't be solved without Yakumo .

They'd run into the serial murder case while pursuing the spirit possessing Makoto, but he had no idea where to go from there .

The reason Gotou had asked Yakumo to cooperate with him on the investigation wasn't just because he had the unique ability to see spirits .

Yakumo's insight and reasoning capability were essential for solving the case .

'Don't say that . You won't be able to accept things as they are yourself . '

Gotou held a cigarette in his mouth as he handled the wheel .

'You're the one who made me feel that way, Gotou-san . Also, if you light that up, I'm going home . '

'Ah, my bad . '

Yakumo really was fussy about everything . His hobby might have been making other people angry .

After they crossed the bridge over the Tama River and had just passed the shopping street in front of the station, a sign with the words <Kinoshita Surgery: Maternity and Gynaecology Department> .

'Oh, there it is . '

Gotou turned on his hazard lights and parked his car at the shoulder of the road beside the park .

The white-walled building had three floors and a flat roof . It was as big as an apartment building . Its scale was acceptable for a private hospital that also functioned as a residential building .

Gotou got off the car and headed towards the hospital's entrance . Yakumo followed after him, complaining the whole way .

A sign with the words <No Consultations> hung on the glass door, and the curtains were closed . Gotou stooped over to look inside through the window, but he couldn't make anything out .

When he pushed the door handle, it opened without any resistance – it hadn't been locked .

'We're coming in,' said Gotou, stepping into the hospital .

Nobody was in the lobby . Gotou took slippers from the shoe rack and changed into them before stepping up into the dim linoleum-tiled lobby .

'It seems like consultations are off for today only,' Yakumo said significantly as he followed after Gotou .

Gotou wondered to himself as he took a look at reception . There was nobody here either .

A hospital with no one in it was uncanny enough in itself .

'Anybody here?'

Gotou yelled in a loud voice that echoed through the hospital .

'Sorry, there are no consultations today . '

The door to the examination room ahead of the lobby opened, and a man dressed in white showed up .

'Are you Doctor Kinoshita?'

'Yes, I am, but...'

Kinoshita was a kind-looking man with an oval face and droopy eyes, but his cheeks were hollow and there were dark circles under his eyes – he appeared considerably worn out .

He was the father of the first victim of the serial abduction murder case .

The sorrow from the lingering memory of the incident surrounded him .

'My name is Gotou . I'm from the detective department . '

Gotou showed his identification .

Kinoshita sighed, looking like he might cry while smiling .

'What do you require from me?'

'I want to ask you something about the incident . '

'I see . Please come in . '

Kinoshita smiled amiably, an expression completely different from his earlier one, and invited them into the examination room .

Gotou went into the examination room where Kinoshita was together with Yakumo .

It was a dreary room with only a desk and a bed .

The room in the back behind the partition was probably an examination room with a bed or something in it .

Kinoshita lined up two round chairs on the opposite side of the desk and gestured at them to sit .

'Please forgive me . The nurses are all off today, and I'm the only one here . I can't be a good host...'

Kinoshita bowed his head several times, seeming apologetic .

'Don't worry about it . We're not here for a friendly visit . '

Gotou waved his hand like he was chasing away a fly .

Kinoshita had said that the nurses were all off today, but that probably wasn't actually it .

Gotou had heard a rumour that everyone from the nurses to the patients had stopped coming ever since the incident with Kinoshita's daughter . Sadly, that was the way of the world .

Even though it wasn't as if Kinoshita had become the father of the victim because he wanted to, he was receiving abuse from people who didn't care about his emotional state .

'May I ask who is accompanying you?'

Kinoshita gave Yakumo a strange look as he asked that .

Well, his misgivings were natural . Gotou should have made Yakumo wear a suit or something .

'He's a detective, even though he looks like that,' Gotou replied in a very matter-of-fact manner . Half-baked lies would be no good in a situation like this .

'A detective? You are very young . '

Kinoshita had his chin in his hand and appeared to be thinking about something .

'I am Saitou Yakumo from the detective department,' Yakumo replied, as if to shake off Kinoshita's suspicions .

'Saitou... Yakumo...'

Kinoshita repeated that name like he was ruminating .

He narrowed his eyes and looked like he was thinking about something again, but finally, he looked up in surprised realisation .

'Was your mother's name Azusa-san?'

'How do you know that?'

Yakumo looked at Kinoshita with searching eyes .

'I was right then! You're Saitou Yakumo!' Kinoshita said happily in a loud voice, clapping his hands together .

'You know him?' Gotou whispered .

Yakumo shook his head, appearing displeased .

'Ah, excuse me . I was too excited . So you're Yakumo-kun . You've gotten so big . I must have aged as well . '

Kinoshita crossed his arms and furrowed his brow, looking very emotional .

'Oi, looks like you do know him . '

'Like I said, I don't know him,' Yakumo replied, as if to stifle the line of questioning . Somehow, it felt like there was a gap in the conversation .

'It seems I've confused you – please forgive me . It's natural for Yakumo-kun to have forgotten me,' Kinoshita said with a pleasant smile .

'Excuse me, but do you really know me?'

Even Yakumo couldn't hide his bewilderment .

'Yes . Let me explain . I was the doctor present at your birth . '

Oi oi, that was surprising .

'You were...'

Unusual for him, Yakumo looked like a pigeon that had been hit by a peashooter .

'Still, you have a good memory . '

'Well, it left a deft impression, in a variety of ways . '

Kinoshita replied to Gotou with a nod .

He was probably talking about Yakumo's eye . His red left eye . Kinoshita was the first person in the world to see it .

'You're hiding it with a contact lens then?'

'Yes . '

Yakumo replied to Kinoshita's question clearly .

The confusion had left Yakumo's face, but he was stiff with tension .

Wow, what karma –

'To be honest, I'm happy that you've grown up like this . Please listen without taking offence . '

Yakumo nodded silently at Kinoshita, who had become talkative .

'When I picked you up, I thought you might not have been able to live . Part of it was for medical reasons, but more than that, people can be unimaginably cruel to those who are different from them, so... you see . You've had the support of many people as you grew up . '

Yakumo smiled bitterly, like he didn't understand Kinoshita's words .

'My mother tried to kill me . '

'She tried to kill you? You must be lying . '

Kinoshita's eyes went wide from shock .

'No, it's true,' Gotou interrupted .

Whether it was good luck or bad, Gotou happened to be present then . Kinoshita shook his head back and forth fervently, as if saying he couldn't believe it .

No matter how he tried to deny it, it was the truth .

'Why...'

'She probably loathed this left eye,' Yakumo replied, refusing Kinoshita's disavowals .

'There must have been some reason . I understand, since I've lost my daughter . A parent wouldn't kill their child just because of loathing . She must have had a reason for coming to that,' Kinoshita insisted with tears in his eyes .

Gotou could somewhat understand the doctor's feelings . From the perspective of a man who had had his beloved daughter cruelly taken away from him, it would be inconceivable to take the life of his child with his own hands .

On the other hand, from the perspective of Yakumo, whose mother had tried to kill him, the bond between a parent and a child didn't deserve his belief . If he didn't tell himself that, Yakumo's theory would fail .

Sadly, it wasn't possible for everyone in the world to live with the same values .

That was why crimes occurred . That was just how it was .

'If I meet with her again, I would love to hear why a woman would try to kill her own child . '

The corners of Yakumo's lips were turned up into a smile, but it didn't reach his eyes . They were looking forward with incredible force .

'That's true . No matter what reason she had, it isn't forgivable...'

Kinoshita looked up at the ceiling to escape Yakumo's gaze .

'Sorry, but could you have your emotional reunion some other time?' Gotou interrupted .

It wouldn't be good to let the two of them discuss any further . They would get even further off-track .

Their situations and positions were completely different . It wasn't about who was right – they were both truths, respectively .

'That's right . '

Kinoshita fixed his posture .

Yakumo mussed up his hair, like he was resetting his emotions, but the sharp look did not leave his face .

Well, nothing could be done about that .

'Actually, we came because there was something we wanted to show you today . It might be tough, but could you cooperate with us?'

Gotou asked Kinoshita again . Kinoshita nodded silently .

'First, there's this photo . '

Gotou handed over the photo that had been in the bible that was in Andou's possessions to Kinoshita .

In the photo, a girl in a ponytail was smiling while crying .

Did the girl know she was going to die when the photo was taken? That thought suddenly came to Gotou .

'Ayaka...' Kinoshita said, his voice hoarse . The hand holding the photo was trembling and his eyes were red .

'Do you recognise this photo?'

'It's the first time I've seen it . '

'Are you sure?'

'All the photos of my daughter are in albums . There's no mistaking it . '

It didn't sound like Kinoshita was lying .

Gotou noticed the photo in the silver frame on the desk .

Kinoshita's daughter, Ayaka-chan . There was a man about Kinoshita's age as well .

Had Kinoshita put this photo out after his daughter's death? Or was it from before? Gotou couldn't ask .

'Do you know about when this photo was taken?'

Upon hearing Gotou's words, Kinoshita rubbed at his eyes and moaned quietly while hunched over .

Gotou didn't want to press Kinoshita for an answer when he was trembling like that; he just waited for Kinoshita to lift his head .

'This is... a photo that was taken after my daughter disappeared . '

Kinoshita finally sat up and spoke, bright red all the way to his ears .

A balloon that was about to pop – that was what he looked like .

It felt like he was forcing himself to keep his unstoppable rage within himself . His emotion was so strong it was unfathomable to Gotou, who didn't have a child .

'How can you be certain?'

At Gotou's question, Kinoshita bit his lower lip so hard it looked like it would draw blood .

'There's a plaster on her ear . The night before she disappeared, she had gotten her ears pierced . I had opposed at first, but she said she really wanted to... My daughter usually wouldn't ask for much, so...'

Kinoshita was probably reliving the scene in his mind . He covered his face with his hands – he couldn't finish speaking .

This man blamed himself .

Even though his daughter had been taken away from him for no reason, he turned that resentment towards himself . He was hurting himself .

'I see...'

Gotou wasn't sure what he understood himself . There wasn't any special meaning to it . It was just that he couldn't think of anything else to say .

'Where did you find this picture?' Kinoshita asked in a shaking voice . He was looking down .

'Currently, I can only say that we found it during the investigation . '

For a while, Kinoshita just looked at his feet .

Gotou just waited for Kinoshita to move .

When he looked to the side, he saw Yakumo looking at Kinoshita seriously with a finger on his brow . That guy felt something . Though Gotou didn't know what it was .

'I understand . '

Finally, Kinoshita looked up with his red eyes and said just that .

'Actually, there's one more thing I'd like to show you .

Gotou took a key in a plastic bag out from his jacket pocket and handed it to Kinoshita .

Andou had also been holding this .

'What is it?'

'A key . Don't know what it's for . Does it look familiar to you?'

'Unfortunately...' Kinoshita said apologetically, and he handed the key back to Gotou .

They'd gotten no leads for the key, but if the photo really had been taken after the girl disappeared, they couldn't say that Andou had nothing to do with the case .

This is getting interesting –

Haruka was in the water –

For some reason, she didn't feel cold or pain .

She let herself be dragged along by the flow, and her body moved with the water .

Something surfaced in front of her .

It was the girl she had seen at the river . She was decaying – her skin had changed colour, and her flesh was falling off, exposing the bone .

Suddenly, the girl's eyes opened .

She's looking at me –

'Why... won't you save me...'

The girl grabbed Haruka .

'Why am I the only one who died?'

Blood dripped from the girl's face .

That face –

At some point, it changed to her sister's face .

– Big sister!

She wasn't in her room . Where was she? Haruka was confused for a moment, but she remembered soon afterwards . She had nearly drowned in the river and had been brought to this hospital .

She turned her gaze to the analogue clock on the wall .

It was already nearly ten in the morning .

Her body felt heavy, as if she had a weight on her back .

Her head ached with a throbbing pain .

But she couldn't just stay here forever . Haruka got up from the bed .

Haruka's belongings were gathered on the bedside table .

Haruka finished changing, picked up her things and left the room .

She didn't see anybody in the corridor . Not only that, but the lights were also off, so the corridor was dim .

'Excuse me . '

She tried calling out, but there was no response . It was a fairly quiet hospital .

She was forced to go to the reception desk, but there was nobody there either . She hadn't paid yet, so she couldn't just go home .

Suddenly, she heard voices talking . She strained her ears . The voices came from the examination room behind the reception .

She thought it would be rude to interrupt a consultation, but she couldn't calm down if she just stood in front of the door, since it felt like she was eavesdropping .

Haruka resolutely knocked on the door .

'Come in . '

She heard a voice . Haruka opened the door .

'You look better now . I'm glad . '

Kinoshita was sitting facing her and spoke with a smile .

'Thank you very much . '

Haruka bowed deeply . At the same time, the two people who had been sitting facing the other direction turned around .

'Eh?'

She was frozen in surprise .

Detective Gotou . And Yakumo –

Why were they here?

'What are you doing in a place like this?' Yakumo asked quietly, staring at her with sleepy eyes .

No, that was what she wanted to ask .

8

Haruka sat in the backseat .

She was being driven home by Gotou in an unmarked police car .

Yakumo, in the passenger seat, was gazing out the window with an expression full of displeasure .

For some reason, Haruka felt ashamed .

'Haruka-chan . Why'd you go to the river?'

While waiting for the light to change at the intersection, Gotou turned around and asked her a question .

Well, it was an expected question . Kinoshita, the doctor, had pretty much explained how she had nearly drowned in the Tama River and was brought to the hospital, but he hadn't explained the reason .

'I was asked by a friend . '

'To almost drown in a river?' Gotou asked with a serious look .

Where would you find a friend who would request something so commendable? Even if she had been asked to do that, she definitely wouldn't have accepted .

'That's not it . Er... I heard that she saw a ghost there... and then...'

'I see . I thought you might've been hiding something the last time I saw you, so that was it . '

It hurt to hear Gotou-san say that .

She hid her face in embarrassment .

'So you just stuck your neck in without thinking . '

Yakumo mercilessly lined up harsh words .

I did go there without thinking, but that was because I didn't want to cause trouble for Yakumo –

Even if she said that, it would just sound like an excuse .

'Come on, don't say it like that . Haruka-chan kept quiet because she didn't want to cause trouble for you . Isn't that praiseworthy?' Gotou said to pacify Yakumo .

'That is even more troublesome for me . If I'm just going to be brought into the situation in such a half-baked manner, it would have been easier for me if she had just spoken to me in the first place . '

'That's quite a mouth on you when you're the one who won't stop complaining about people making trouble for you . '

It was just as Gotou-san said . Haruka wanted to give him an award .

'Traffic light . It's green . '

'Ah!'

After Yakumo spoke, Gotou hurriedly stepped on the pedal .

'I'd like you to reflect a little . Though that's just if you actually have the ability to think,' Yakumo said disagreeably .

Haruka felt she was in the wrong, so she hadn't said anything, but the last bit had definitely been unnecessary .

'Hey . What do you mean by that?'

'Nothing in particular . Please take it exactly as I said it . '

He was the worst .

Why was he acting so high and mighty? Haruka had been in considerable trouble herself . He could have been a little nicer .

'It isn't as if I went there without thinking . '

'You're getting angry at me?'

'I know I can't do anything, but Gotou-san had brought in some trouble for you too, and if I troubled you on top of that...'

'Oi, oi . Now it's my fault?'

Gotou interrupted without a moment's delay .

'Sorry, that's not what I meant . '

'Well, don't worry about it . That guy's going to complain no matter what you do, so there's no point in worrying . Just ignore it and leave it to him . '

'The reason I suffer is because there are irresponsible people like you, Gotou-san,' Yakumo retorted in his annoyance .

'Hmph . You keep on running your mouth, but you're just worried . '

'It would be better for you to worry about your wife leaving you, Gotou-san . '

'My wife's got nothing to do with this!'

One sentence from Yakumo made Gotou raise his voice in anger .

'Eh? Has your wife left again, Gotou-san?' Haruka asked seriously .

'Shut up . That's not it . '

Gotou looked so cute in his franticness that Haruka ended up smiling slightly .

'It seems that Gotou-san recently started an exchange diary with his wife, even though it's unbecoming for his age . '

'Oi, what a minute! How do you know that, Yakumo?'

Even though Gotou was driving, he took his hands off the wheel to grab him .

'That's dangerous . '

At Yakumo's comment, Gotou cursed and took the wheel again .

'Gotou-san, you've got your cute points . '

'Haruka-chan, you too? Please stop . '

'If you don't look forward while driving, you'll get in an accident again,' said Yakumo, pointing forward .

'Again? What do you mean, again? Last time it was to save Haruka-chan . '

'Eh? It was my fault? That's...'

Haruka covered her face on purpose and made it look like she was sad .

'No, that's not it...'

Gotou looked flustered, like he had screwed up and didn't know what to do .

'Come on, Gotou-san . Look forward,' Yakumo said .

'Aah! Shut up!' Gotou yelled, hitting the wheel .

It was so funny Haruka laughed so hard she had to hold her stomach .

Ah, no matter what's said, I always end up being honest in front of these two . I realise that now .

It doesn't matter how other people see me . My sister doesn't have to switch places with me . I can get angry and smile and cry like I want to –

'Come tomorrow to explain properly . It would be troublesome if you died and came back to haunt me . '

Yakumo muttered that as Haruka got off Gotou's car .

He said one thing too much, but –

'I will . '

The car started at the same time as she responded .

While watching the car leave, Haruka murmured 'Thank you' in her heart .

9

'How was it?'

After Haruka got off the car, Gotou asked Yakumo that question while starting the car .

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair and spoke with a troubled expression .

'According to Doctor Kinoshita's story, that photo was taken after the disappearance . '

'Yeah, that's right . '

'That would make Andou, who died in the traffic accident, incredibly suspicious . '

'You think that too then . '

Gotou had also been thinking that .

The case with the serial abductions and murders of girls . He had a suspicion that Andou might be the culprit .

At this stage, he didn't even have one shred of evidence, but he was almost certain .

'But isn't that odd?' Yakumo said, looking up at the roof of the car .

'What?'

Gotou held a cigarette in his mouth .

'I won't talk if you light that up . '

'Damn . I got it . '

Gotou threw the cigarette onto his dashboard .

It's because there were people like Yakumo that smokers felt ashamed .

He didn't know about those separated seating places, but recently, there were even cafés that forbade smoking completely .

'If, hypothetically, Andou was the culprit, why did he only have Ayaka-chan's photo?' Yakumo said with a smirk .

'What do you mean?'

'The case this time involves serial abductions and murders . Why doesn't he have photos of the other girls?'

'That's...'

He had been going to rebut, but he couldn't find the words .

It was just as Yakumo said . If Andou was the culprit, it wouldn't be strange for him to have the photos of the other young women .

'There is another thing . '

'What?'

'There was a girl's spirit in that hospital . '

'The daughter's?'

'No . '

'Who was it?'

'I don't know . It was someone besides his daughter . '

Since Gotou couldn't see spirits, he couldn't comment .

Even if he could see them, he didn't feel like thinking about what that meant .

'But well, it's expected for a hospital to have one or two dead spirits...'

Yakumo spoke, almost to himself, and sighed .

'You might be right,' Gotou agreed half-heartedly .

'Now, where are we heading next?'

Yakumo yawned in his boredom .

It appeared that he knew Gotou had not planned on letting him go yet .

'We'll be going back a bit, but we're heading to the flat Andou lived in . '

'Hasn't everything been taken out already?'

'Seems like it . '

'Then wouldn't going be a waste of time?'

Thinking normally, what Yakumo said was correct, but Gotou had different intentions .

'If Andou's the culprit and his room was the scene of the murder, though there might not be any physical evidence left behind, there's the possibility that something else has remained . '

'So you are saying that the spirits of the girls who were killed might be there...'

'Exactly . '

'You really just do whatever you want . '

Though Yakumo complained, he didn't object .

He might've also thought the same thing –

The flat had a green roof and was by the river .

That was where Andou had lived . Gotou's suspicion that it was related to the crime was growing .

Gotou drove his car into the visitor's parking lot on the premises .

'Is it here?' said Yakumo, looking up at the apartment .

'Yeah,' Gotou replied, looking up as well . It was a family-oriented apartment with ten stories . It was aptly called Riverside Apartment .

'It's rather extravagant for someone who was a legal apprentice . '

It was just as Yakumo said .

'Plus it came with parking and he drove a black Benz . '

'He must have been of high status . '

'Damn, it's bigger than my flat . '

'Gotou-san, you have a flat?'

'Yeah, though it's company housing . '

It was a 2LDK[2] . All of the residents were part of the police .

In police work, which often had transferrals, a feat like purchasing a flat with your own money wasn't even remotely possible .

'What a waste,' said Yakumo as he got off the car .

'What is?'

'It's obvious that a wild bear should stay at a camp or the like . '

'Don't make it sound like I'm some monster cat that lives at a school . '

Even though Gotou had actually replied, Yakumo started walking towards the entrance, like he hadn't heard anything at all .

Damn, the guy just does whatever he wants .

They went to the management office near the entrance and were able to borrow the key to the flat Andou had lived in after they said they were further investigating the traffic accident .

Andou lived in a corner flat on the top floor .

When Gotou had heard from the manager that the rent was two hundred thousand yen, he thought his eyes were going to pop out . It felt kind of stupid to work so hard .

He rode the elevator with Yakumo and opened the door to Andou's flat .

Like he had heard before, there were no belongings left . Though the walls and floor had a few marks, it would look like new with some housecleaning .

It was a 2LDK like Gotou's company one, but each and every room was larger .

There were many windows to let light in, so it gave an open and bright impression .

They went around each room . Bathroom, kitchen, toilet –

As expected, they didn't find anything important .

'Hey, Yakumo . Can you see anything?'

Gotou asked Yakumo, who was looking out the window in the twenty-tatami living room .

'No, I see exactly the same thing that you do, Gotou-san . '

An immediate answer . He hadn't been expecting much in the first place . There was no point being disappointed . They would go to the next place .

He moved to leave, but Yakumo was frozen, staring out the window .

'What is it?'

'Gotou-san . Could you show me the key Andou had?'

'Why?'

'Please just hurry and let me see . '

After being urged, Gotou took the key in the plastic bag from his pocket and handed it to Yakumo . Yakumo took it and murmured while staring at it .

'E-3... I've found it . '

'What? Really? Where?'

Gotou looked around the living room frantically .

On the floor? The ceiling? The wall? Where? Where was it?'

'Are you trying to sniff it out?'

'Shut up! If you've got the time to make fun of me, hurry and tell me where it is . '

Yakumo's lips turned up into a victorious smile, and he slowly pointed out the window .

Gotou's eyes followed that finger .

He saw the river .

He also saw the water gate where the first victim, Ayaka-chan, had been found .

Yakumo was pointing a few hundred metres upstream .

He saw a building with a flat concrete roof . That was the old water gate . Then, he saw the large characters written in paint on the old water gate's wall .

The characters were, with no doubt –

'E-3,' Yakumo said .

Next, Ishii headed for the family restaurant in the neighbouring city, in order to meet with Andou Takashi's older sister, Hiroko .

Inside the restaurant, which wasn't anything special, he sat at a seat near the window . He ordered a coffee . His stomach was actually empty as well, but he hadn't come to eat .

Hiroko wasn't directly related to Takashi . Takashi was the mistress's son . Hiroko was the wife's daughter . It appeared that they did not have a good relationship .

When Ishii called Takashi's home in Fukuoka, a chatty servant talked freely even about things Ishii hadn't asked about . He also got the older sister's contact information from the servant . The servant had suggested he talk to the sister, who was married and lived there for her husband's job transfer .

The night before, Ishii had contacted Hiroko . After he had said, 'I want to talk to you about Andou Takashi-san,' she had abruptly hung up .

At that point, he had passed the baton to Detective Gotou, and he ended up getting her to agree to meet for just thirty minutes in the evening at a family restaurant away from her home . Ishii didn't know what sorts of negotiation methods were used, but that was Detective Gotou for you .

Five minutes after their arranged meeting time, Hiroko appeared at the family restaurant .

A slender woman with pale skin, she looked graceful at first glance, but her voice and choice of words were peculiarly malicious .

'So what did you want to ask?' Hiroko said, sitting in the seat opposite him .

'I apologise for taking up time in your busy sche...'

'If you think that way, forget about the niceties and get on with it,' Hiroko spoke, interrupting Ishii .

Haughty and overbearing . The type of woman Ishii didn't know how to deal with .

'I apologise . I would like to ask about Andou Takashi-san, but...'

'Oh, it's just you? Where's the detective I spoke with yesterday?'

This time, she changed the subject on her own . An inconsistent woman .

'Detective Gotou had another case, so...'

'Too bad . I wanted to meet him . I'm a sucker for aggressive men like him .
,

Hiroko drank her black coffee like she was in a trance .

What was she talking about?

'May I continue?'

'Go ahead . '

Hiroko lit up a cigarette and replied while the smoke spread .

'What sort of person was Takashi-san?'

'Scum!'

'Eh?'

Ishii didn't understand how she could cut down her younger brother with one word like that, even though they weren't directly related .

'Do you have another way of explaining his character to me which would be a bit easier for me to understand?'

'It's appropriate . He was always moping around . He was the mistress's son, but was there a need to adopt him? Since she was the one who went and gave birth to him, she should have gone and raised him . She just killed herself and handed him over to us – there's a limit to shamelessness . '

It was a horrible way to put it .

Even though he was the son of a mistress, being so awful about it was unwarranted .

'Why do you dislike him so much?'

'It's natural, isn't it? He tried to kill me before,' Hiroko said, baring her teeth .

'He tried to kill you?'

'He did . It was right after he came to the house . I tried to be friendly at first, but he was always moping around, so I said this to him: You should've died with your mother . Then, he suddenly put his hands around my neck . '

That didn't really seem sudden .

Saying to someone whose heart was damaged after his mother had killed herself that he should have died with her –

Hiroko hadn't even thought about how much her words could hurt the person who was listening .

'He was influenced by his mother's death . '

'That's not it . He was just crazy . '

That was her comment .

'Did you have no love for your younger brother?'

'Why would I? He was my sibling because I had the courtesy to accept him . We were only half-related by blood . Plus, isn't that suspicious? I don't know what that woman did or where she did it . '

What you're saying isn't courteous at all –

Ishii almost said that aloud .

'In the first place, we took him in because we had to . Even Father said again and again that he'd throw him out if he didn't become someone the Andou family wouldn't be ashamed of . '

Someone the Andou family wouldn't be ashamed of –

Who on earth could that be referring to?

Had he been saying that having a mistress and having a child with her was an appropriate act for the Andou family? Ishii didn't understand .

'Well, though he tried hard to become a legal apprentice, that all went up in smoke with the incident . What an idiot . Father was so angry he said he'd dissolve the adoption . '

What is so strange –

Even though only four days had passed since Andou Takashi's death, she was talking about it as if it was some event from the distant past .

Hiroko spent the next two hours after that letting out her pent-up resentment, flying by the thirty minutes they had agreed on .

Still, how could Andou have felt staying for so long in the same house as somebody who resented him?

After experiencing his mother's death, something must have taken root in Andou's damaged heart .

Then, he was cast out like his mother had been in the end .

Everything is warped –

That was what Ishii felt .

11

It was already dark when Gotou and Yakumo arrived at the old water gate .

Since it could be seen from the flat, they decided to leave the car and head there on foot, but when they tried to walk there, it was actually unexpectedly far .

It seemed that it had been built to observe the water level and was built like a small guardhouse .

Because of the large water gate that was built five hundred metres upstream, it wasn't in use .

Unlike the rusted iron door, only the keyhole was brand new .

The building itself wasn't in use and had been abandoned for a while, so it was considerably old . Somebody had probably installed the lock afterwards —

Gotou put the key in question into the keyhole and turned it .

There was a click . It opened .

'Bingo,' Yakumo said, standing behind him .

Gotou stepped in while opening the door .

There was something like a light switch on the wall by the entrance, so he tried pushing it, but there was no response .

It's dark —

The torch was in the car . He should have brought it . It'd be a pain to go back to get it now .

Gotou flicked his lighter and lit up the room .

It wasn't a reliable light, but there wasn't anything he couldn't see .

The stink of humidity tickled his nostrils .

There was a massive motor that had probably been used when opening and closing the gate .

Clang .

There was the sound of crashing metal .

Someone was there . Behind the motor . Yakumo tapped Gotou's shoulder . When he looked over, Yakumo was holding a iron pipe that he had picked up from who knows where . What kind of concern was that supposed to be?

Gotou switched the lighter to his left hand and gripped the iron pipe in his right .

– Gotou-san .

Yakumo lowered his voice as he pointed to the right of the motor .

Gotou nodded in response and turned to the right to head behind the motor .

Yakumo turned towards the left .

This way, they would attack from both sides .

Gotou put out his lighter . He'd be able to see once his eyes got used to the dark . He made sure not to make noise as he advanced while hiding himself behind the motor .

Rustle .

There was another noise . The sound of something being dragged .

Now, there was someone ahead . Gotou wiped the sweat from his palm on his trousers and gripped the steel pipe again . He took a deep breath and jumped out at the right time, brandishing the steel pipe over his head .

The source of the noise appeared .

'What the hell!?'

After Gotou threw down the steel pipe, he hurriedly rushed over and flicked open his lighter .

There was a long-haired girl .

She was emaciated – even her breath was faint . She perceived Gotou's figure with clouded eyes and her dry lips moved as if trying to say something .

'Yakumo!' yelled Gotou, but he didn't need to give instructions .

Yakumo ran at full strength .

'It's fine . You'll be OK . '

Gotou draped his coat over the girl and laid a hand on her head .

It was possible that this was Keiko-chan, the girl whose whereabouts were unknown .

What the hell had happened? Gotou was seething with a boiling-hot anger .

12

By the time Ishii rushed over, the scene was already crowded with patrol cars, police and curious onlookers .

His time was taken up looking for a place to park his car .

Since he was Detective Gotou's subordinate, he felt like a failure for not being able to be present at the time the case was solved .

'Where are you going? What's the point of you rubbernecking too?'

Just as Ishii was trying to push his way through the crowd, Gotou's baritone rang in his voice .

'Ah, Detective Gotou . '

Ishii spotted Gotou sitting slightly apart from the commotion on the stairs at the embankment, smoking a cigarette .

The young man called Yakumo was there too, beside him .

'What on earth has happened?'

He had heard that Detective Gotou was guarding the girl who'd disappeared and had come quickly, but he didn't know any of the details .

'Andou is definitely the culprit . '

'Is that the case?'

Although Gotou glanced over for a bit, he then blew out smoke towards the sky and didn't say anything more .

'The key Andou had . It was the key to the old water gate . '

Yakumo started explaining in Gotou's stead .

'Why did he have the old water gate's key?'

'Keiko-chan, the girl who would have been the third victim, had been confined in the old water gate . Though there had been no concrete evidence until now, something horrible had been left inside . '

Just as Yakumo finished speaking, he let out a huge yawn .

Ishii was happy that Yakumo had explained for him, but Yakumo's tone suggested he was the one who had found the answer to the case .

Even though Detective Gotou is the one who solved it –

'I see you're all together . '

Hata appeared abruptly out of the darkness .

Ishii swallowed the scream that had gone all the way up to his throat . Since the man himself was already ghastly, Ishii wished he would just show up normally . It was bad for his heart .

'Why're you here, old man?'

Gotou put out his cigarette with the heel of his shoe and threw away the cigarette butt .

'Don't just throw your cigarette butt away like that,' said Hata without a moment's delay .

With a click of his tongue, Gotou picked up the cigarette butt and put it in his pocket .

'Answer the question, old man . '

'I came because I heard there was a corpse, but isn't she still living? I came for no reason . '

'Old man, don't sound so disappointed . '

Hata didn't pay Gotou's words any mind and just giggled . He really was just like a demon .

However –

'It's surprising that she's fine . She's been trapped in there for four days already since Andou died,' Ishii said to Gotou .

He was partially talking about her physical strength, but it wouldn't have been strange if she had died of dehydration .

'There were plastic plates scattered around her . There had probably been water and food in those,' Yakumo replied .

'There were things like that?'

Gotou put a hand on his chin and cocked his head .

'Really, it's surprising that you can work as a detective with that humble power of perception . '

Yakumo's manner of speaking didn't bear decorum in mind .

It felt like their places were switched around .

'Shut up,' Gotou spat out, and he lit another cigarette .

'How was your investigation, Ishii-san?' Yakumo asked extremely matter-of-factly .

Why did he need to inform a university student of his investigation? Why wasn't Detective Gotou saying anything? Ishii couldn't understand, so he looked at both of their faces .

'Yakumo . What's the point of asking Ishii now? The case is already over,' Gotou said, scratching at his face .

'It hasn't ended . Have you forgotten your original objective, Gotou-san?'

'Original objective?' Gotou said shrilly .

Yakumo shook his head dramatically, like he didn't know what to do with Gotou .

'We weren't following the serial abduction and murder case, were we? Our original objective was to find out what to do with Andou's soul, which has possessed a woman . '

'Ah, that's right . '

'That was why we needed to know his motive for murder . '

'I see,' Gotou muttered, looking bitter .

That was certainly the case . Ishii had forgotten himself . Just as Yakumo said, their goal this time was to save a woman who had possessed by a ghost .

Saving the girl this time had only been a side-line event .

'So, Ishii . How was it?'

Gotou turned the conversation to Ishii .

'Ah, yes . '

Ishii took the memo from his inner suit pocket and spoke in as much detail as he could about what he had heard from Sergeant Yoda at the police station and Hiroko, Takashi's sister, while sharing his own thoughts .

'It feels a bit sloppy . '

That was the first thing Gotou said after he finished listening to Ishii's explanation .

Ishii felt the same way as Gotou . Even while he was explaining himself, he thought that the story didn't add up .

Hata was idly watching the investigation taking place at the old water gate, like he wasn't paying attention at all .

'Hey, Yakumo . You understand anything?' Gotou asked Yakumo, whose index finger was on his brow like he was thinking about something .

In response, Yakumo suddenly raised his lowered head .

His expression was so cold that Ishii trembled .

'Thanks to Ishii-san's investigation, I have begun to understand, though this is simply my reasoning,' Yakumo said quietly .

'Then tell us,' Gotou said, walking towards Yakumo without hesitation .

'This is only a guess, but... if we put everything we have learnt so far together, doesn't it seem like Andou had necrophobia?'

'Necra... caviar...?' Gotou said, sounding like he didn't understand .

'Necrophobia . You said that on purpose, didn't you?'

'You're so fussy . So what is it?'

'It is a psychological condition wherein one feels extreme fear towards corpses or death itself . '

'So, different from this perverted old man then?' Gotou said jokingly as he pointed at Hata .

'The exact opposite,' Yakumo confirmed indifferently .

Gotou made a 'hm' sound, like he didn't understand fully .

'It is an extreme fear towards specific subjects . They are nothing special to normal people, but they are frightening to the person with the phobia . In Andou's case, the subject was death . '

Ishii didn't know the specifics, but he had heard something like it before .

A type of phobia . An extreme fear would grip the heart when confronted with a specific subject or object .

In severe cases of the condition, some people would become panicked, have spasms or find it difficult to breathe .

Though most people knew about the fear of heights and the fear of pointy objects, it seemed that there was also a fear where death itself was the subject...

'So, what does that have to do with anything?' Gotou asked disinterestedly .

'Andou's mother committed suicide . We cannot know for certain without looking into it, but I think that the young Andou may have seen his mother die . That would have been very traumatic for him . '

His mother had committed suicide in front of him .

How much would that have hurt Andou? Ishii couldn't even imagine .

Inside his head, the image of a boy staring at his mother's hanging corpse appeared . Ishii shivered at that unsettling scene .

'After he was adopted by the Andou family, he lived in great fear of death . He must have tried fervently to be accepted as part of the Andou family so that he wouldn't be abandoned like his mother... In his eyes, which had seen his mother's death, abandonment probably equated to death . '

Yakumo continued to speak in his disinterested tone .

'In that sort of situation, his adopted sister had said this to him . 'You should've died with your mother . ' This was like a switch that made him go on a rampage . Those words were taboo to him . '

'I see,' said Gotou to show his comprehension .

'One wouldn't often hear the words "Go die" often if living normally . That happened at the violent incident one month ago . Andou's rampage switch was turned on again when the girl said, "Just go die . "'

In Ishii's mind, he recalled Sergeant Yoda's words: 'If the guy had been just a bit calmer . '

Andou must have known himself what would happen if he was reckless then, but he still couldn't stop himself –

'With that, Andou lost the confidence he had built up to live as a member of the Andou family . He was probably terrified that he would be abandoned and die like his mother . '

'But wouldn't that girl have been the target then?' Gotou asked immediately .

'Yes, that would have originally been the case . However, the police restrained him, correct?'

Yakumo turned his gaze to Ishii .

'Ah, y-yes . '

Ishii replied, feeling flustered at the sudden attention .

'Afterwards, Andou happened to find that girl . At the riverbank...'

'That was Ayaka-chan...' said Gotou, dumbfounded .

'Actually, it was Andou's misunderstanding . The girl that time was not Ayaka-chan . Just...'

Just what? Ishii wished Yakumo would stop putting on airs and just tell them .

'Ayaka-chan looked similar to the girl from the incident . '

'Oh, the ponytail . '

Ishii spoke up without thinking .

Right away, everyone turned to look at him . He felt like he would flush at all the attention .

'It is just as Ishii-san says . Andou mistook the girl's identity because of her hairstyle . '

That was right . Ayaka-chan had just been unlucky . She had just looked similar to the other girl .

'Andou, after abducting Ayaka-chan, probably interrogated her about the day his life had been ruined, but Ayaka-chan didn't know anything . At some moment, Ayaka-chan might have said, 'You should die,' to Andou . Then, Andou ended up killing Ayaka-chan . '

After he finished speaking, Yakumo bit his lip . His expression suggested that he regretted what he had said .

'Then what about the next incident?' Gotou said, putting out the cigarette he had smoked to the end with his heel .

'His objective must have changed after that . '

'His objective changed?'

'Yes . By killing Ayaka-chan, he must have felt the fear towards death that had filled him before be mitigated . His goal became killing to divert his fear . '

'What a disgusting guy,' Gotou said, clicking his tongue .

So Andou was killing to make himself feel better from the second person on —

'I feel the same way,' Yakumo said quietly, looking down .

'I understand that much . But what do we do now?' Gotou asked Yakumo .

Why was he doing this? He was the psychic detective . Yakumo was just a university student . Why was Detective Gotou asking Yakumo for instruction despite that?

'That's right...'

Yakumo started thinking and put his index finger to his brow again .

Nobody opened their mouth . Everyone's eyes were on Yakumo .

'I have thought of one method . If we can use his fear well...'

Finally, Yakumo spoke .

'OK, let's go with that!' Gotou said .

'I haven't said anything yet . You really are an irresponsible person . '

Yakumo gave Gotou a sidelong glance, looking like he felt that Gotou was making fun of him .

'Well, this is also the first time I've tried this method, so I can't guarantee its success . '

'I get it, so just tell us . '

'In this plan, Hata-san's cooperation will be indispensable . '

'Mine?'

Hata, who had suddenly been brought up in the conversation, pointed at himself and spoke in his confusion .

'Yes . I apologise for the inconvenience, but I would appreciate it if you would prepare what I ask of you as quickly as possible . '

What on earth was starting?

Ishii felt gooseflesh rise on his body .

13

The following afternoon, Haruka visited Yakumo's secret hiding place .

As usual, his hair made it look like he had just gotten out of bed, and his eyes looked so sleepy that Haruka almost suspected he had lost consciousness .

Then, once she arrived –

'You're late . Do you have no sense of time?'

He said something fault-finding like that .

'What do you mean, I'm late? I don't remember setting a time . '

Haruka sat on the chair facing Yakumo, who rubbed at his eyes and yawned . He looked like a cat washing its face .

'So tell me what happened in order . '

Haruka placed the phone strap she had received from Mayuko on the table and explained what had happened in the past two days in as much detail as

she could .

While she explained, Yakumo had his arms crossed, and his expression didn't change .

'So you put the ghost that appeared in the river and your older sister together and went crazy . '

'Went crazy? Don't make me sound like some wild ox . '

She objected, but she really had gone a bit crazy .

When she was chasing the girl's ghost, Ayaka had always been in a corner of her mind . That was why she had been more absorbed than necessary .

'Honestly . Even you have a head to think with, don't you? You're not Gotou-san, so I would appreciate it if you wouldn't act instinctively like an animal . '

'Yes, that's right . I was wrong . '

Haruka clenched her teeth angrily, but it had no effect at all .

'If you had just talked to me from the beginning, this wouldn't have caused so much trouble . '

'Sorry . '

She really did feel it was her fault .

She had tried hard on her own not to cause anybody trouble, but in the end, she had brought the case to Yakumo .

'In the first place, this incident is linked to the one Gotou-san brought in . '

'Eh?'

What did he mean, linked?

'You really are special, aren't you?'

She wasn't special at all .

'I'm saying that the ghost your friend saw is related to the case that Gotou-san brought it . '

'It is?'

'The case Gotou-san brought was about a woman who has been possessed by a spirit . When looking for the identity of the spirit possessing her, we found a man called Andou who had died in a traffic accident . '

From what Haruka had heard so far, she couldn't think of how it was related .

'In that man's possessions, there was a photo of the daughter of the doctor at Kinoshita Hospital who took you in . Gotou-san and I were looking into that . '

Ah, so that's how it is .

That's why the two of them were at the hospital too –

'Doctor Kinoshita's daughter was abducted and murdered a month ago . '

'Murdered?'

'Yes . She was murdered and thrown into the river, and she washed ashore at the water gate . '

'That's terrible...'

Haruka remembered Kinoshita's worn-out face .

The shadow that he was burdened with . That had been the cruel reality of his daughter's murder –

'His daughter's name was Ayaka . '

Yakumo pointed at the phone strap Haruka had brought .

She understood now . They were linked .

'I wonder if the ghost I saw at the river was the girl who had been murdered . '

'That's probably the case, from what I've heard,' Yakumo said with a yawn .
'Honestly . This might have been solved faster if you hadn't been so oddly secretive and just told me in the first place . '

'Even if you say that...'

There was nothing she could have done – she wouldn't even have thought in a dream that the two cases were linked .

'Still, something doesn't fit...'

'What doesn't fit?' Haruka asked, not quite understanding .

'Honestly . Are you a dinosaur?'

'Dinosaur?'

'I'm saying that your responses are slow . '

This monster cat always said too much –

'That girl's ghost said to “stop already”, right?'

Haruka nodded .

The girl had said that at the river then .

'That's what doesn't fit . What on earth did that girl want to stop?'

'That's...'

Haruka didn't know .

'She probably can't rest because of that something we don't know – what she wants to stop . '

Yakumo rested his chin in his hands .

'What are you going to do?'

'Well, there's no point just speculating . Anyway, first, we'll go there...'

'Let's go then . '

Haruka followed Yakumo's words and stood up .

14

There's somewhere I want to go before we head to the scene –

First, Yakumo went to the temple that his uncle lived in .

The last time Haruka came, she had had to wait at the door, but this time, since Yakumo didn't say anything, she followed him in past the gravel garden towards the priests' quarters .

Yakumo opened the sliding door at the entrance and had just taken off his shoes when he looked over at her, like he had just remembered something .

'Wait in the living room . '

'Excuse me – I'm coming in,' Haruka said to nobody in particular . Then, she took off her shoes at the entrance and went into the living room as she had been told to .

The room was at least eight tatami mats in size . Nobody appeared to be here .

'Sit over there and wait . '

After Yakumo said that, Haruka said, 'Excuse me,' and she sat at the horigotatsu[3] in the living room .

'Don't scamper about . '

After saying that, Yakumo left the room .

Scamper about? He was treating her like a child . She wished he would speak with her on a more equal footing . Plus, she didn't mind waiting, but he could have at least told her why they were here .

Yakumo just likes always being the only person who ever knows anything .

He doesn't care what anyone else thinks .

If someone comes, what excuse should I make –

When she was all alone in a quiet room, it made her feel a bit uneasy .

Haruka sighed .

Suddenly, she noticed somebody else was there and looked up .

'Ah!'

She had been surprised . At some point in time, a girl had sat right in front of her . She was probably around seven years old . She was a cute girl with big, round eyes and glossy black hair in a bob cut .

The girl didn't say anything and just had her chin in her hands as she stared at Haruka with a smile .

Who was she? Since she was in this house, was she Yakumo's cousin?

'Hello . '

Haruka tried speaking to the girl, but she didn't respond .

She's just looking at me with the same expression . Did she not hear me? Or does she just not want to respond –

Haruka didn't know what she should do . For a while, she just looked back at the girl .

'What's your name?'

She tried speaking to her again, but still there was no response .

While Haruka was still bewildered, the girl cocked her head curiously .

'Are you one of the children here?'

The girl still didn't answer .

'She's my cousin, Nao . '

At some point, Yakumo had returned to stand at the living room's entrance .

Once the girl called Nao saw Yakumo, she started clapping her hands and smiled without speaking .

'There's no use talking to her directly . '

'No use? What do you mean?'

'Nao can't hear . '

'Can't hear...'

I hadn't realised —

Even though this girl was burdened with a handicap, she was relentlessly cheerful . Unlike a certain somebody .

'You don't need sound if you want to speak with Nao . Try speaking with her in your head . '

Haruka didn't really understand what Yakumo was saying .

What did he mean by speak in her head? To test it out, Haruka said <Hello> to Nao without opening her mouth .

<Hello . >

'Eh?'

She had definitely heard a voice just now .

Nao hadn't opened her mouth . Yakumo hadn't spoken, but she felt like she had heard something directly in her head . Nao clapped her hands again and laughed .

The way she seemed so delighted made Haruka feel happy too .

'Nao, that's great . '

Yakumo patted Nao on the head . Nao nodded proudly .

'It's the way she communicates, since she can't hear . I don't understand the principle behind it, but she creates mutual understanding through a method besides sound waves, though she can't do this with everyone . '

Haruka felt like she understood at least some of it .

'OK, we're going . '

Haruka stood up after Yakumo spoke .

Then, Nao rushed over and clung tightly to Haruka's leg, looking up at her with a face that looked like it could cry at any moment .

'Seems like Nao likes you . '

After Yakumo said that, he bent down so that he was eye level with Nao .

He had a gentle expression on his face that Haruka had never seen before . The two of them were almost definitely talking about something .

Finally, Nao reluctantly let go of Haruka's leg .

'Good girl . '

Yakumo patted Nao's head and left the living room .

Haruka tried to follow Yakumo too, but she stopped and tried to speak to Nao once more in her head . <Bye bye . See you again . > Nao jumped and waved her hand . Her message had got across –

It made her feel cheerful, somehow .

'Oh? Haruka-chan was here too?'

When she left the living room, somebody called out to her .

She looked over to see Yakumo's uncle, Isshin, standing in the corridor in monks' working clothes . He had a red contact lens in his left eye as usual .

'Hello . Sorry for intruding . '

'That Yakumo didn't even say anything . If I knew, I would have poured you some tea . '

'Oh no, that's not necessary . You don't have to pay me any attention . '

'No, it's not too late . I'm going to get some tea, so relax a bit . '

'Eh, but...'

'There's youkan[4] in the fridge too . '

'Uncle . We don't have much time . '

Yakumo had his arms crossed sullenly in the entranceway .

'Spoilsport . '

Yakumo's uncle's lips were pursed like a sulky child .

'Honestly, Nao was more obedient . Uncle, you know the place, right?
Please don't forget, since you are the key man this time . '

'I get it, I get it . '

Yakumo's uncle spoke in a light tone . Haruka didn't know what they were talking about, but she felt like whatever she heard, it couldn't be counted on .

'We're going . '

Yakumo was rushing her, sounding irritated, so Haruka thanked Yakumo's uncle once more and followed Yakumo out .

15

'Old man, you did pretty well . '

At Gotou's words, the corners of Hata's mouth turned up in a proud smile .

To put it plainly, it was gross . Gotou slightly regretted praising him .

It felt like the old man would eat a person someday .

The unique atmosphere of the autopsy room might have strengthened that feeling .

The combined smell of disinfectant and blood irritated his nostrils, so he had been breathing with his mouth since earlier .

'Thanks to that, I had to stay up all night,' Hata grumbled, all the while triumphantly looking at what was on the stainless steel autopsy table .

On it was an elaborately reproduced model of a person from the neck up .

From the texture of the skin to the feel of the hair, it was just like the real thing .

'But you really made it well . '

'Since it's not my area of expertise, I wasn't confident . '

As Hata said that, he covered it with a cloth .

'What material did you use?'

'Synthetic resin . '

'What's that?'

'It's a rubber often used in films for special makeup . '

Gotou understood .

In old sci-fi films, you could tell right away that the makeup was fake, but the techniques had gotten better so you couldn't tell just by looking .

'Well, I'll expose the trick – I had help from an acquaintance who does special make-up for films . '

Hata's shoulders shook with laughter, like he found something funny .

But that would mean –

'Didn't that cost you money?'

'There was some give and take . '

Gotou didn't understand what a coroner and special make-up artist had to give and take . 'What do you mean?'

'Since my acquaintance said they wanted to study in order to make things more realistic, I agreed to let them witness a few autopsies . '

So the old man had done something like that secretly? Gotou was so shocked he couldn't even be angry .

'By the way, is that young man called Ishii all right?' Hata asked, like he had suddenly remembered about him .

'No idea . He's not a kid . He'll get by . '

'You're in an unpleasant mood, I see . '

'Unpleasant isn't the word I'd use!'

Of course he was in a bad temper .

Even though he had saved the girl and should've been praised, Ideuchi had gone on and on about how Gotou had stuck his neck into a case outside of his jurisdiction .

Well, Gotou could understand why Ideuchi wasn't happy . The whole investigation unit had run around wildly for this case . White station wagon, dating sites, people at schools who might have been clues – they'd gone around everywhere but found no leads .

Then, Gotou and company, who were completely unrelated to the case, had solved it somewhere completely unexpected .

However, Gotou couldn't agree with them taking all the credit .

Girl's dramatic rescue! That was how the press release put it . Gotou's existence had been completely erased .

It really pissed him off . Gotou's anger, which had no outlet, had been turned completely towards Ishii .

'Under no circumstances would I want to work under you,' Hata said, showing his yellow teeth .

'I wouldn't want you to either,' Gotou said brusquely, which made Hata's shoulders shake with laughter again for some reason .

Like I said, stop . It's gross –

16

Do your best, Ishii Yuutarou . You're a man, right?

Ishii encouraged himself and faced the door .

It was the same as the last time he came . A feeling of chilling oppression so strong it was difficult to breathe .

On the opposite side of the door, there was a woman who had been possessed by a ghost .

When Ishii thought that, the extremely ordinary door felt like a gigantic gate leading to hell .

Though the chief's wife had said that she was sleeping now, Ishii still couldn't relax .

He recalled the nightmare he had the day before yesterday of the first time he had seen her .

That voice that resonated to his stomach . Those wide-open inflamed eyes . It was no exaggeration to say that it was the most terrifying thing he had ever seen .

I really don't want to go .

But I have to –

Ishii wiped the sweat from his palms on his trousers and placed a hand on the doorknob .

He took care not to make any noise, turned the knob and slowly opened the door .

The dim room –

The suffocating atmosphere –

He saw Makoto sleeping face-up on the bed .

Her chest went up and down quietly with her breathing .

He definitely wouldn't have her notice him while he was here . Ishii matched his steps to the rhythm of her breathing as he approached her bed .

A wheelchair had been prepared by her bed .

Ishii had asked the chief's wife in advance to have it put in the room .

He just had to sit her in the chair and push her out . It wasn't anything difficult . Ishii repeated that to himself .

He put his hands on both sides of her and tried to pick her up . At that moment, Makoto's eyes opened .

She's awake . She woke up –

Ishii stopped thinking . His head went blank .

While he was frozen, Makoto twisted herself away and bit Ishii's arm .

'Gyaah!'

Ishii's scream echoed through the room .

17

Haruka went with Yakumo to the embankment of the Tama River .

There were white herons flying .

The little waves glittered with sunlight .

'It's beautiful,' she said while quickly glancing at Yakumo's face .

However, her words were drowned out by the sound of a Keio Line[5] train running along the overhead bridge .

'Did you say something?'

'No, it was nothing . '

Haruka shook her head .

Yakumo didn't ask any further either .

Haruka could see the water gate .

She remembered what Yakumo had said earlier .

That water gate was where the murdered Ayaka-chan had been found .
When she thought about that, somehow, that area alone looked stagnant with darkness .

Yakumo went down the embankment silently and climbed the rock that Haruka had been standing on the day before yesterday . He looked at the river from there .

Those narrowed eyes could definitely see something .

Something that only Yakumo can see –

Like a flashback in a film, the scene that she had seen in the water came back to her .

'Stop,' that girl had said . Even though she was dead, she kept asking this .
What did she want to stop?

After a while, Yakumo came back to the riverside .

He looked depressed .

'Did you find out anything?'

'You always rush to conclusions like that . It's because you try to reach a conclusion without looking at the whole picture that you do things like falling into rivers . '

The two things weren't related . He really was ridiculously cynical .

'But I've understood a few things . '

'What are they?'

'There certainly appears to be the spirit of a murdered girl wandering in this river . '

After Haruka heard Yakumo's words, her chest started feeling tight .

'Is the girl wandering because she resents having been murdered?'

She said exactly what she thought .

Yakumo raised a shoulder and made a face at her .

'Do you really think that?'

'I don't . '

'Then don't say that . '

It was just as he said .

When Haruka had been drawn into the river, she had felt like the girl's emotions were flowing through her .

They hadn't been hatred or resentment, but something mixed with sadness, though I can't explain properly what that something was –

'Something is keeping her in this place . '

'Something is keeping her?'

'Yes . A strong sentiment which is trapping her here... probably...'

Yakumo's last words sounded like they were meant for himself, and she couldn't hear until the end .

Yakumo probably hadn't put everything together yet himself .

'Missy, you were all right then?'

When Haruka turned around at the voice, she saw a man standing there in work clothes . He was Uchiyama-san, the man from the management office who had saved her .

'Thank you very much for saving me the other day . I apologise for being so late with my thanks,' Haruka said quickly, bowing her head .

'Really, I told you to be careful but you fell right in . Well, the most important thing is that you're OK . '

Uchiyama's smile filled his face .

The man's smile seemed to have the effect of easing wariness .

'I really don't know how to thank you...'

'It's fine . Ah, is this your boyfriend?' Uchiyama said, staring at Yakumo's face .

'It appears that you have taken care of my sister . I truly apologise . This girl is clumsier than the average person . '

Yakumo bowed his head . Did he hate being seen as her lover that much?

'Oh, you're her older brother? You look alike . '

There was no way they looked alike . They didn't even share one drop of blood .

'Anyway, try not to fall in again . '

Uchiyama started to leave with a smile on his face, but Yakumo called out to stop him .

'Excuse me . I'd like to ask one thing . '

'What is it?'

'Does Doctor Kinoshita come here often?'

For a moment, Uchiyama looked surprised, but then he started speaking after a sigh .

'Before, he would come once a week or so . He'd come with his daughter to take a stroll and invite me to dinner . '

'Is that so?'

'Ayaka-chan's cooking was incredibly delicious, like Kinoshita's wife's . I always looked forward to eating her cooking . '

'So you were acquaintances with Doctor Kinoshita from before . '

'Kinoshita and I were in the same class in middle school . He was the most successful of our classmates . He became a doctor, married the school idol and had a daughter with her...'

Uchiyama gave a self-derisive laugh .

'Childhood friends then . '

'Well, I guess that's right . I played a lot with Ayaka-chan as well . Especially after Kazumi... after his wife died, Kinoshita and I said stupidly that we'd raise his daughter with two fathers to make up for the mother she lost . '

Uchiyama's eyes were glistening with tears .

His voice was trembling a bit as well .

'I'm not joking – she really was like a daughter to me . That was...'

Uchiyama snivelled and took a towel from the pocket of his work clothes to wipe his face .

'Were you the one who found Ayaka-chan's corpse?' Yakumo asked, examining Uchiyama's response .

'I was . What a fate,' Uchiyama said quietly, biting his lip in frustration .

'Where did you find Ayaka-chan's corpse?'

'Ah, there's a control tower in the river, right?'

Uchiyama pointed at the concrete tower nearly at the centre of the river .

There was a cubic building on top of the tower and about one metre of walking space around it, which was surrounded by an iron fence . It was connected to the management office by an iron bridge .

'I found the corpse just underneath there when I was checking on the water level . '

'I see . '

'I couldn't forgive the person who did that . '

The conversation didn't go any further .

Haruka couldn't look directly at Uchiyama's face and just gazed out at the moving surface of the river .

Finally, Uchiyama laughed bitterly like he felt he had said too much . After saying, 'I've got work to do,' he got into the truck parked nearby and left .

That man had feelings for Ayaka-chan that were greater than just those towards a friend's daughter . That's what Haruka felt .

'Somehow, he seems so pitiful . '

'Losing somebody important isn't something that can be so easily put away with words,' Yakumo said . Haruka understood that all too well, since her older sister had died .

The feeling of loss wasn't temporary . It followed you forever .

It appeared that Yakumo had seen something near his feet, and he stooped over to pick it up and stare at it . It looked like a notebook .

'That's...'

'It's probably something Uchiyama-san from earlier dropped . '

If they had noticed earlier, they could have handed it right to him –

Yakumo opened the notebook . He shouldn't just look at other people's things – is what Haruka thought, but she ended up peeking too .

There was a photo on each of the pages the notebook was open to . One was of Uchiyama-san, twenty years younger than he was now, with a woman about the same age . The other was a photo of Ayaka-chan .

'Oh! So you really were here!'

A loud voice interrupted her thoughts, and she saw somebody waving from the top of the embankment . It was Detective Gotou .

'Please don't speak in such a loud voice . It's embarrassing,' Yakumo said, covering his ears pointedly .

'I'll push you into the river . '

'Please, do as you like . '

'This guy...'

Gotou was gnashing his teeth .

'So, have you finished with the preparations?'

'Yeah, everything's perfect . All that's left is you . '

'Then shall we go?'

Yakumo put the notebook he found earlier into his pocket .

'What will you do, Haruka-chan?' Gotou asked, pointing at her with his chin .

'What will I do?'

She didn't understand what the two of them were talking about at all .

'We're going to set a little trap,' Yakumo said .

'A trap?'

18

Haruka decided to follow Yakumo and Gotou without understanding the situation .

They drove to an autopsy room in the basement of a general hospital in the city .

In the centre of the windowless room, there was a stainless steel bed .

A mobile tray with tools for surgery was placed next to it .

On one side, there was a line of something that looked like doors to large refrigerators . She had seen them before in movies . Human corpses were stored inside them .

It felt much chillier than it had been outside, and gooseflesh had risen on her skin . That might have been because of the atmosphere of the autopsy room .

To be honest, Haruka had started regretting her decision .

'Are you scared?' Yakumo whispered in her ear . His mocking tone got on her nerves so she curtly retorted, 'Not really . '

'Oh, you're all together, I see . '

A small-framed old man in white appeared from the back of the room .

'This is the coroner, Hata-san . '

Gotou introduced him to Haruka .

'It's nice to meet you . '

Haruka bowed, but Hata didn't reply, like he didn't see her at all .

'Hata-san . Where is it?'

When Yakumo asked his question, Hata smiled proudly .

Though this old man had a rude way of speaking, he felt a bit like an apparition . Like he drank blood or something .

Hata opened one of the cold storages and pulled out a sliding bed .

'Eek!'

Haruka jumped and shrieked without thinking .

There was a man's corpse there . There was a large cut from the left cheek to the nose .

'Don't get surprised at everything . That's a fake . '

Yakumo's expression didn't change as he spoke, and then he approached the bed and turned over the white sheet that covered up to the neck .

Only the portion from the neck and up had been accurately reproduced, while the lower portion was just a mannequin .

'That perverted old man made it . Only the face has been constructed to be identical to the real thing . '

Gotou added to Yakumo's insufficient explanation .

'That's a fake . '

It was exquisitely created .

Just looking at the portion above the neck, anybody would think it was real .

'Hata-san, it's perfect . I didn't think it would be done so well . You truly are talented . '

Hata laughed happily like a child at Yakumo's words .

'Gotou-san . Please take that out . '

'OK . '

Gotou took a cage out from beneath the table by the bed .

There was a white mouse inside . A mouse? Things were just getting more cryptic . What on earth were these people trying to do?

Gotou put the mouse in the cage by the replica of a man .

'Now, our trap has been set . '

Yakumo covered the fake man up to his neck and said that, sounding satisfied . Gotou and Hata also smiled in the same way .

'Wait . What are you planning to do?' Haruka asked, unable to hold back .

Even she knew her voice was shaking . She felt like she had been caught by a fox .

'An exorcism,' Yakumo replied innocently .

'Exorcism? But Yakumo-kun, you...'

Can't do exorcisms . Yakumo had said that before .

During the last case, Yakumo himself had said, 'I can only see them . I can't pretend to be skilful enough to exorcise anything . It's hard to believe that chanting spells would make the spirits of the dead disappear . '

Despite that, he says he's going to do an exorcism –

'Just as you say, I did say before that I can't exorcise spirits . '

'Then what is this?'

'I said this before too, but the spirits of the dead aren't demons or a new species . Though there is the difference of physical life or death, in the end, they're still human beings . '

Haruka nodded . She certainly had heard that before .

'That's why I'm going to negotiate with the soul of the dead man and have him leave the physical body he's possessing now on his own . '

She didn't understand what he was saying at all .

'Well, it'll be quicker if you watch it happen rather than if you listen to my explanation,' Yakumo said, raking his fingers through his hair .

That might be true .

'Sorry . What should I do?'

Suddenly, the door opened, and Yakumo's uncle, Isshin, showed his face .

Instead of his usual monks' working clothes, he was wearing a proper robe[6] . It was natural since it was his actual job, but it looked good .

'Why are you saying something so inane all of a sudden? I gave you a proper explanation already, didn't I? You're the key man this time, Uncle . '

Yakumo walked towards Isshin .

'Don't put so much pressure on me . I don't do well when I'm nervous . '

Isshin scratched his head, embarrassed .

'Also, please remove that tasteless contact lens . That's my duty this time . '

'I like it though . '

While Isshin said that, he took the red contact lens out of his left eye .

'Now, preparations are complete . It's show time . '

'Yeah!' Gotou said loudly . He took out his mobile and made a call to somewhere .

'There's still time now . If you find this unpleasant, you can leave . '

Yakumo stood next to Haruka and whispered in her ear .

She really was frightened . She was frightened, but now that she had been shown such an incomprehensible scene, she couldn't just leave without seeing it end .

'I'm fine . '

'You should stand in the corner of the room so you don't stand out . '

Haruka obeyed Yakumo's instructions and stepped away from everyone .

'He'll come soon . '

Just as Gotou said that, tension filled the room .

After that, there was a long silence during which nobody opened their mouths .

Haruka held her chest – she could hear the sound of heart beating quickly in her nervousness .

After a while, there was the sound of a knock and the door opened .

Ishii stood in the doorway, pushing a wheelchair .

For some reason, there was a bruise on his eye, and his hair was all mussed up . His tie, which had been in a proper triangular knot, was also a

miserable sight .

A woman sat in the wheelchair Ishii was pushing .

She hung her head, so her long hair hid her face . Both her wrists were bound to the chair's armrests . This was the woman who had been possessed –

After Ishii carried the wheelchair into the room, he collapsed onto the floor right there .

Isshin walked until he stood in front of the woman in the wheelchair and he knelt there .

'You're Andou Takashi-san, aren't you?'

The woman's head slowly tilted up .

Inflamed eyes peered out from between strands of hair . Haruka shivered at the feeling of intimidation .

'Whooo aaare youuu?'

Her dry and cracked purple lips moved .

The voice was hoarse and low – it didn't sound like a woman's at all .

'I am a monk . My name is Saitou Isshin . '

Once she heard that, the woman's shoulders shook with laughter . She opened her mouth up wide, and spittle flew out .

It was a viscid laughter that followed you around .

'I'm not leaviiiing . Thiiis boody is miine . '

'Please do as you like,' Isshin said innocently . 'If you don't want to leave that body, you can just stay there . '

The woman cocked her head and stared at Isshin, like she found his words odd . Isshin accepted the gaze directly and even smiled .

'Today, I have come to give you a warning . '

The woman growled .

'It's fine that you've possessed another body, but it doesn't move like you want it to . Am I wrong?'

The woman didn't respond . All Haruka could hear was the sound of heavy breathing .

'There is only one soul in a person's body . That is the way of things in this world . Though the body is called the vessel of the soul, that does not mean that any soul will do . Though the body and the soul are seen as separate things, the truth is that they are the same . The body and the soul . They are connected as one . '

Isshin said that much and paused to check his listener's response .

'If a soul enters a body that is not its original vessel, in the end, that soul will disappear...' said Isshin quietly .

His tone of voice was perfect . Haruka couldn't tell if it was an act or the truth .

'Shuuut uuup . '

The woman raised her voice and her body squirmed left and right .

'Do you remember this person?'

Isshin gestured at Yakumo, who bowed and walked to Isshin's side .

'From the moment he was born, this man has had the unique ability to see the spirits of the dead . '

'Liies . '

'It isn't a lie . If it were, there would be no way for me to know that you are Andou Takashi . '

The woman started growling again .

'Yakumo . Show the proof . '

'Yes . '

Yakumo knelt in front of the woman and took out the contact lens in his left eye .

He looked at the woman with his completely red eye .

'Eeeeeek . '

There was an inappropriate shriek .

When Haruka took a look for the owner of the voice, every muscle in Ishii's face was stiff in shock .

That was right – he didn't know about Yakumo's red left eye . Gotou-san should have at least given him a bit of an explanation .

'Don't make such shameful noises . '

Gotou struck Ishii's head with all his strength .

'This red eye is better proof than anything else . Yakumo, do you see something?'

Isshin paid the outside commotion no mind and spoke to Yakumo .

'Yes . There are two spirits in one body . They are both resisting,' Yakumo said indifferently .

Isshin nodded several times at Yakumo's words .

'Now, Yakumo . What will happen if we leave this as is?'

'They will probably disappear . '

'They'll disappear?'

'Yes . The body has rejected the soul so it is considerably weakened . The situation is like a flame before a gust . If everything stays as is, it will not even last a day . '

'Shuuut uuup . '

The woman bent forward, and after she coughed several times, she vomited something onto the floor .

Shlop .

A dark red clump of blood .

'Uwaaaa . '

Haruka heard Ishii shriek again . Then, the sound of his head being hit . There was no point in even looking over .

'Hm, this is not good . '

'We do not even have a moment to waste,' Yakumo said, adding to Isshin's words .

'Andou-kun . I know a way to save you,' Isshin murmured into the woman's ears .

Perhaps those words had been a sign, because Gotou pushed the wheelchair the woman was sitting in over to the imitation corpse covered with a sheet .

In response to the movements around her, the woman started flailing .

Hata took the sheet off of the imitation corpse to reveal an exquisite face of a human being . Haruka felt uncomfortable no matter how many times she looked at it .

The woman stopped moving –

'This is your corpse, is it not? This corpse is no longer functioning, but it is still alive . It only appears to be dead . However, there has been a fair amount of time since it lost its soul . Soon...'

Isshin left a moment of silence .

'It will have reached its limit . '

The woman looked down and muttered something .

Haruka could understand just from looking . The spirit's heart was shaking . The scenario Yakumo had written, the work Gotou and Hata had constructed, and Isshin's realistic performance –

So this was the trap Yakumo had been referring to .

'What will you do?'

The woman muttered something at Isshin's question .

Haruka couldn't hear what she said .

'You have the choices . I will not force you . You should make your own decision . '

Isshin touched the woman's head with a hand holding a string of beads .

The woman shook her head back and forth, throwing her hair about .

'I see . You don't want to . There's nothing to do then . That is unfortunate .',

Isshin signalled with his eyes . Hata and Gotou put their hands on the bed .

'Then...'

Isshin whispered the finishing blow in the woman's ear .

'You should die . '

'Ooooo . '

At Isshin's one phrase, the woman screamed and started trembling .

Hata made a face and tried to push her down onto the bed .

'Not yet,' Yakumo said . Hata stopped his actions .

Yakumo looked at the woman with serious eyes .

The woman's body continued to convulse .

Everyone was waiting to see what would happen next, and the tension was so thick it felt like it could be cut with a knife .

Even Haruka's fists were clammy with sweat, though she hadn't done anything .

She could hear her heart beating loudly .

'Gyaaa . '

At the same time as her scream, the woman's body bent backwards . Hata and Gotou were restless .

'Not yet,' Yakumo said immediately .

Yakumo was waiting for the right timing for something .

Suddenly, the woman's body lost its strength and it pitched forward .

'Squeak . '

There was the cry of the mouse .

That was the trap .

'Now!' Yakumo shouted . Hata pushed the bed into the cold storage . Gotou kicked the door shut . To finish, Hata locked the door .

Silence –

Nobody said anything . It felt like they couldn't believe that the plan they had come up with had occurred before their eyes .

'Is it done?'

Finally, Gotou spoke, a thin layer of sweat covering his forehead .

'Yes . It's done . '

A smile appeared on Yakumo's lips .

'What happened to the man called Andou?' Hata asked with a sniff .

'His soul left her body and tried to return to its own . However...'

'He couldn't go back, since it was a doll . ' Gotou continued Yakumo's sentence .

'Exactly . Currently, he has probably possessed the nearby mouse . '

Yakumo raked his fingers through his hair and let out a deep breath, sounding exhausted .

'How was my performance?'

Isshin asked a question that was inappropriate for the situation .

Yakumo glared at him, but Haruka couldn't help but smile .

The tension that had built up had left her .

Ishii held his dizzy head and left the autopsy room to sit on the bench in the corridor .

He had heard from Gotou that they were going to exorcise the spirit from the woman today .

Then, just as he had said, the exorcism had taken place .

The exorcism had been drastically different from what he had imagined .

He didn't know how to explain it . Rather than an exorcism, it might have been more appropriate to call it bargaining or negotiation .

However, that was still more than enough to terrify him .

Especially the young man called Yakumo . What was that red eye?

It looked like something was burning in the back of his eye . Why was everyone OK with looking at it? He could excuse Gotou and Hata, but Ishii couldn't understand how even she was calm about it .

'Are you OK?'

Ishii raised his head when somebody called out to him .

Haruka stood in front of his eyes .

'Yes, I'm fine . Something of this level is nothing to worry about . '

Ishii was so surprised he stood up reflexively .

'You're bleeding . '

Haruka pointed at Ishii's right arm .

He had been so frantic he hadn't noticed at all . There were clearly teeth marks on his right arm, and blood was oozing out .

'I am . '

Even he thought his response was stupid .

Haruka burst into laughter . Ah, the way she looked when she laughed melted away his pain .

'Please use this . '

Haruka held out some gauze .

She treated even someone like him so kindly . What a gentle woman .

'There is a lot of gauze in that room . It should be fine if you use a little . '

'Th-th-th-thank you very much . '

'Ishii took the gauze from Haruka and pressed it against his wound .

'You should have it examined properly afterwards,' Haruka said, sitting down on the bench .

If Ishii sat down now, that would make it so that he was sitting side-by-side with Haruka-chan . Wouldn't they almost look like lovers then?

'Are you not going to sit?'

'Ah, no, I like standing!'

His mind had gone blank .

Ishii had gone to an ex-boys' middle and high school . When Ishii had enrolled, it had been co-ed, but the number of female students had been overwhelmingly low .

He had been in science and engineering for university as well, so most of the students had been male . He had been invited to mixers and things like that, but he had obstinately refused since university was a place to work hard on his studies – not to play .

He hadn't had many opportunities to interact with woman even at this age .
He had no immunity .

Ishii gave a sidelong glance at Haruka sitting next to him .

Ah, how lovely . She's just like an angel –

The door in front of him opened and Yakumo came out .

He was wearing a contact lens now, so his eye was black . Still, that red eye came up again inside Ishii's mind .

He hurriedly covered his mouth with both hands to stop himself from yelping .

'We're leaving . '

In response to Yakumo's words, Haruka stood up .

'Hey, give me a proper explanation about what happened . '

'I explained already, didn't I? Are you already trying to play the fool?'

What was he saying to Haruka-chan?

'Play the fool? ... That's not it – I'm saying explain it in a way that I can understand too . '

'Shall I draw you a picture book?'

'You – Stupid!'

Haruka rushed after Yakumo, who was walking away briskly .

Haruka-chan, don't . If you stay with that demon-like man, you'll become demon-like yourself –

Ishii's call in his heart didn't reach her .

'What are you spacing out for?'

Suddenly, he was hit in the back of his head .

When he turned around, he saw Gotou standing imposingly with a difficult expression on his face .

'We're going . '

After Gotou informed him of that, he went down the corridor with his long strides .

Ah, please wait –

Ishii hurried chased after Gotou .

I fell –

20

Hadn't it already ended?

Even Hata couldn't hide his surprise .

Andou was supposed to be the culprit .

That Andou had been exorcised by Yakumo yesterday .

In the first place, Andou had already been dead then .

Even if he hadn't been exorcised, he shouldn't have been able to commit another crime .

Despite that –

The scene of the crime was right in front of him . It was exactly the same as before . The early morning dumpsite . There was the drowned corpse of a fourteen-year-old girl .

There were lacerations on the ankle which suggested that something had bound it .

Her name was Hashimoto Rumi-chan .

After she left school yesterday, she didn't return home . She had stayed out overnight without giving notice many times before .

The parents had thought it was just her doing what she always did, so they hadn't asked for an investigation and had just waited for their daughter to return –

Then, this morning, she had been found as a corpse .

The other investigation team members probably thought the same thing . Everyone was silent . They didn't know how to accept the reality in front of them .

Hata suddenly felt somebody's gaze upon him .

Again . Somebody was looking at him again .

Hata focussed his eyes on the surrounding onlookers .

He's there –

It was him . He had been at the previous scene . The man in sunglasses .

He had a bold smile on his face . What was so funny in this turmoil? Once could have been overlooked, but twice –

Who on earth is he –

NOTES:

[1] To put it simply, the Sanzu River is the Buddhist equivalent of the River Styx .

[2] Japan uses letters in real estate to describe housing . 2LDK means that there are two rooms and an area which is used as the living room, dining room and kitchen . You can find some actual examples [HERE](#) .

[3] A horigotatsu (掘炬燵) is a type of kotatsu . It is a low, covered table – sometimes heated – that is placed over a hole in the floor, so one sits at it like one would on a regular chair . [HERE'S](#) an example of a heated one .

[4] Youkan (羊羹) is a type of Japanese dessert made of red bean paste, agar and sugar to form a jelly (the youkan) .

[5] The Keio (京王) Line is a railway line in western Tokyo, where the Tama River is .

[6] Isshin would have clothes for non-spiritual duties, called samue (作務衣) and proper robes for when he was doing spiritual duties, called houe (法衣) . Here is a [LINK](#) to a site that sells houe and accessories, while [THIS SITE](#) called Samue Life sells samue and accessories, so you can take a look at them (and gawk at prices, my heavens) .

Volume 2 Chapter 3: VOLUME 2 - THAT WHICH CONNECTS SOULS

Chapter 3

VOLUME 2 - THAT WHICH CONNECTS SOULS

file 03: resurrection (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

'Oi! Old man! What the hell is this?'

Gotou yelled as he opened the door to Hata's room .

'You're noisy . Can't you be a little quieter?'

Hata scowled in annoyance . To hell with his annoyance .

Gotou sat on the folding chair .

'How could I be quiet about this!? There's another corpse – what the hell is happening?'

'There's nothing to it . I'd like to ask myself,' Hata replied in a casual tone .

Even the demonic old man who was doing things at his own pace couldn't hide his irritation .

'Who's the vic?'

'Hashimoto Rumi-chan . Fourteen years old . After she drowned, her corpse was disposed of in a dumpsite . '

'Is it the same?' Gotou asked to check .

When a big incident like this occurred, there were sometimes copycat crimes . In order to prevent them, the police wouldn't share all the details of the crime until it was solved .

By doing so, cases could be classed .

'The murder method and situation with the corpse are the same as with the second victim, Miho-chan . On top of that, there are lacerations on the right ankle . Those were also found on the other two victims .

On the girl they saved, they had seen the same thing – the laceration on the right ankle had probably been caused by something like chains .

Hata flipped through the documents on his desk and spoke, almost to himself .

'She didn't go home yesterday . Her parents didn't worry about it since they thought it was just her doing her usual thing . There hadn't been any request when the corpse was found . It was reported in the news that the murderer had died . That might have put them at ease . '

Damn, this was a terrible police error .

But that would mean –

'Old man, you think Andou wasn't the perp?'

'I don't think that's it . There is a mountain of things we wouldn't be able to explain if Andou weren't the perpetrator . Though the investigation is still taking place, we found Andou's fingerprints at the ex-water gate and the first victim Ayaka-chan's bag and hair . No matter how I think about it, Andou is the murderer . '

'Then why's there a third corpse?'

'I don't know . It's my job to analyse . It's your job to investigate . '

The perverted old man really had a mouth on him .

In any case, it seemed like he'd have to ask for Yakumo's appearance again .

'Sorry to bother you . '

Gotou stood up and moved to leave but Hata called out to him .

'Do you remember seeing this man?'

While he said that, he handed a photo to Gotou .

In the photo was a middle-aged man wearing sunglasses . There was a faint smile on his pale face .

Gotou felt the blood in his body go cold .

This face . As if I could forget it . This man . He's —

'Oi, old man . Where's this photo from?'

'From the location where the corpse was found . He was there when the second victim Miho-chan was found too . And this time he was looking at me from a distance too . '

He was at the place the corpse was found . Did that mean he was connected to the case somehow?

That'd make this a serious affair . The overview of the fake murder case for insurance money a month ago came up in Gotou's head .

'Once could have been overlooked, but twice . And that faint smile . No matter how you look at it, that's not the face of a curious onlooker . I took a few photos . '

'Old man . I'm borrowing this photo . '

'Borrowing? Does that mean you've got a hint as to who he is?'

Gotou ignored Hata's question and left the room .

While walking with long strides, he looked at the photo again . It wasn't just a hint .

I didn't think we'd meet up again like this –

2

The next day, Haruka accompanied Yakumo to visit Kinoshita's hospital .

They had two objectives . One was thanking Kinoshita again for saving her . The other was to ask about the spirit of the girl who had appeared at the river .

Since there was the fuss with the exorcism yesterday, they were still in the middle of their conversation .

The reason why Ayaka-chan was still in the river even though the perpetrator had died .

They wanted to find out the meaning behind that .

Even though they had visited without notifying him beforehand, Kinoshita said, 'Thank you for coming,' and he invited Haruka and Yakumo into the examination room .

'Excuse us for coming by so suddenly . I wanted to thank you for the other day . I'm really very grateful . '

The first thing Haruka did upon entering the examination room was bow her head and express her gratitude .

'Don't worry about it . I just did my job,' said Kinoshita with a smile, and he urged Haruka and Yakumo to sit .

They took him up on his offer and sat down next to each other on the round chairs .

'I came today to ask you a few things,' Yakumo said, going right to the point .

'That's right – Yakumo-kun is a detective . You've grown up splendidly . '

Kinoshita nodded with a smile .

Eh? Yakumo was a detective? Since when?

He had definitely come up with a lie on the spot again .

'I have to apologise for that . '

'Hm?'

Kinoshita looked dubious .

'I am not a detective . When I came the other day, Gotou-san had just come up with an appropriate lie . '

'Is that so?'

'I am just a student . '

Even after finding out that Yakumo had deceived him about who he was, Kinoshita didn't look particularly angry .

'Then this isn't about my daughter . '

'Though this isn't an investigation, I would still like to ask about your daughter . '

Kinoshita gave Yakumo an evaluating look .

He would talk about his murdered daughter if the listening party was the police . It wasn't something he would talk about freely with somebody he

didn't know at all .

'Wasn't the case solved? I was contacted about that . '

'Yes, the perpetrator has been confirmed . '

'Then what do you want to know?'

Yakumo took a deep breath before speaking . It was unusual discretion for him .

'Kinoshita-san . What are you trying to do for your daughter?'

Kinoshita stared at Yakumo with his mouth half opened . He looked like he didn't understand what Yakumo was talking about .

'Did you promise your dead daughter something?'

'I did make a promise . '

For a moment, Kinoshita looked surprised, but his expression soon returned to normal and he answered Yakumo's question .

'But why do you know that?'

Yakumo took the black contact lens out of his left eye .

He turned his red left eye towards Kinoshita .

'You know about my eye . '

'Yes, of course . '

Eh? Of course? Doctor Kinoshita knew about Yakumo's eye from before?

Haruka felt like something had been left out of the conversation .

'This eye of mine isn't just red . '

'Meaning...'

'As a doctor, you might not believe this, but my eye can see the spirits of the dead . '

Kinoshita didn't confirm or deny Yakumo's words .

He just looked at Yakumo's eye silently .

'Yesterday, I met your daughter at the river where her corpse was found . '

The moment Kinoshita heard those words, his eyes opened wide and he gripped Yakumo's shoulders tightly .

'Really? Is that true? Then my daughter – Ayaka is really there!'

His face was red with excitement, like his calm demeanour from before had been a lie .

He won't deny it? He completely accepted Yakumo's ability to see the spirits of the dead .

Even though he's a doctor –

Why?

'Though this is very unstable so I shouldn't talk about it between people, if it's just a bit...'

Yakumo responded like he had been pressured into it by Kinoshita .

'So Ayaka – did Ayaka say anything!?'

Kinoshita was so agitated he started shaking Yakumo's shoulders .

'Please calm down,' Yakumo said, taking Kinoshita's hands off his shoulders .

Kinoshita might have realised he was more agitated than necessary, because he hung his head and muttered, 'Forgive me,' staring at his hands .

'Your daughter said “stop already”...'

Kinoshita looked up in response to those words .

'What does Ayaka-chan want to stop? Don't you know the answer to that?'

After Yakumo spoke, Kinoshita shook his head back and forth .

His shoulders were trembling a little . It felt like he'd collapse if Haruka touched him . He felt like Haruka's mother had when Haruka's older sister had died .

That was how it seemed to Haruka –

'You said this to me before . Your mother had tried to kill you...'

Haruka had heard that before this .

Kinoshita even knew about that?

'At that time, you asked me what excuse your mother could make . '

Yakumo nodded silently .

'To say the truth, I feel the same way . I can't possibly understand the feelings of a parent who would try to kill their own child . I don't understand... but I can understand the feeling of a parent who has lost their child as well as anyone else . '

Kinoshita stopped speaking then and bit his lip .

It looked like he was trying to bear the pain .

'To be honest, I was a failure as both a parent and a husband before . It was my dream to have my own hospital . I was stubborn and lost myself in that

dream . I didn't consider my family even once . On the contrary, I was even adverse to it . Then, my wife collapsed . It was cancer . '

'Cancer?' Yakumo repeated .

'Though I was a doctor, I didn't notice anything strange about her condition . When I noticed, the metastasis had already started... I was too late . '

Kinoshita's voice was filled with sadness, like he was letting out something that he had kept in for years .

'It's a truly shameful story . I couldn't save my wife... But I promised my wife something just before she died . I promised her that I would definitely protect Ayaka... How about that? I couldn't protect her...'

Kinoshita's tightly gripped fists were shaking with an anger he couldn't hold in .

That anger wasn't at the murderer but at himself .

'Why didn't I take her to and from school? Why didn't I call the police sooner? If I had looked after her properly, Ayaka might not have died...'

No . that wasn't true . It wasn't the doctor's fault .

Haruka wanted to yell those things out, but she just couldn't put the words in her mouth .

I know that even if I say anything, it wouldn't be any consolation .

He resents himself for not being able to save someone he loves –

Haruka had experienced it too . She felt responsible for her sister's death and blamed herself for thirteen years and did so even now . When she herself was like that, she couldn't tell Kinoshita not to blame himself .

'That's why I promised Ayaka... I told her... to wait, since I would definitely save her...'

'Then, you started researching how to resurrect the dead . '

Resurrect the dead? What was Yakumo saying? There was no way that was possible . Plus, Kinoshita-san was a doctor . He should have known that better than anyone .

'How do you know that?' Kinoshita asked with a gasp .

'The books in this room . The Definition of Soul and Body . The Cycle of Death and Reincarnation . All of the titles are related to the resurrection of the dead . '

Kinoshita didn't respond .

He just looked at Yakumo with tears in his eyes .

'No matter how much you research, you, as a doctor, should know best that it is impossible,' Yakumo said slowly .

That was right . No matter how you struggled, no matter how much you suffered, the dead wouldn't come back . Yakumo could see the spirits of the dead . However, even if he could see them, that was different from them being alive .

'Yakumo-kun . Could I ask you one thing?'

Yakumo nodded at Kinoshita's words .

'The connection between the body and the soul... What do you think it is?'

'I don't know . '

An immediate answer . Kinoshita looked puzzled at how quick the reply was .

'All my eye can do is see, so I don't know the answer to something that difficult . If I knew, I would be able to fix this eye . '

'I see...'

'However, I do recognise that a soul is a cluster of a person's emotions . '

'A person's emotions?'

Kinoshita slowly thought over Yakumo's words .

'I apologise for taking so much of your time . '

After Yakumo said that, he stood up by himself and headed towards the door .

Haruka hurriedly followed him .

'Could you let me ask one last thing?'

Kinoshita called out to Yakumo . Yakumo didn't turn around .

'What is it?'

'Earlier, we were talking about your mother, but don't you want to know who your father is?'

Yakumo's father –

Before, he had said his father didn't exist as long as he didn't remember him .

However, that was just a question of Yakumo's own feelings, and he couldn't have been born without his father .

'I'm not interested,' Yakumo said lightly, like he didn't care, and he left the room .

3

Ishii was idling in the Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room with nothing in particular to do .

He hadn't seen Detective Gotou since morning .

He had tried calling his mobile multiple times, but the phone just rang with no response .

An unauthorised absence? No, Detective Gotou wouldn't –

He might have used an enormous amount of spiritual energy to solve this case . No, that had to be it . There was no might about it .

Right now, Detective Gotou might have been suffering in a way that Ishii could not possibly understand . He couldn't just idle like this . Ishii knew where he lived . He would go check on him .

Just as Ishii stood up, he heard a knock .

After he said, 'Please come in,' the door opened .

Standing there was a young woman wearing a classy grey trouser suit with her long hair tied in the back .

There's no way I'd forget her . She's –

'Eek . '

Ishii was so shocked he jumped onto the desk .

This was the woman who had been possessed by a ghost . Hijikata Makoto .

It was unexpected that she had already gotten better to the point that she could walk by herself in such a short time .

She was pale and her cheeks were a bit hollow, but that matched her almond eyes and slender frame .

Looking at her like this, she could be called a beauty, but Ishii's frightful impression of her was too strong .

'I wanted to express my gratitude to you for saving me . '

Makoto bowed in a calm and delicate movement .

'A-ah, no, y-you don't have to thank us...'

Ishii had consciously tried to speak in a way that his voice wouldn't shake, but it was no use .

'Excuse me, but why are you on the desk?'

'Eh? Ah, no, this – I was going to clean...'

Because you're terrifying – he couldn't say that .

Ishii hurriedly jumped off the desk . He lost his balance and almost fell .

'It seems like that has only made it messier . '

Makoto covered her mouth as she laughed .

It was only natural, since he had jumped up in his shoes .

'That's true . '

Ishii forced himself to laugh .

'Ishii-san . '

'You know my name?'

'I was conscious at the time, though it was only in bits and pieces...'

Ishii understood . So that was how it was .

That odd point caught his interest .

'I did something awful to you, Ishii-san,' Makoto said quietly, sounding ashamed as she hung her head .

Perhaps she was talking about when he had brought Makoto out . That had been awful . She had bit and chewed on him . He really had gone through a lot .

'No, that's not... There was nothing you could have done . '

'You still have the injuries . Are you OK?'

Makoto reached out with a pale, slender finger towards Ishii's bruised left eye .

At that moment, Ishii's nightmare came up in his mind . Inflamed eyes .
Bared teeth . A low growl –

'Gyaah!'

Ishii yelped and jumped onto the desk again in response .

At the same time, the door opened and Gotou came in .

'What are you doing? Are you a monkey?'

'Ah, no, I have a good reason...'

Ishii got off the desk dejectedly .

'It's not the time for that! We're going!'

Was he going to do something even in this situation?

If he used any more spiritual energy, he would die . Ishii had to stop him .

'Even if you tell me to go, Detective Gotou, your spiritual energy...'

Just as he said that, Gotou's iron hammer of a fist fell on the crown of
Ishii's head .

If this were a manga, stars would have been circling above his head .

'What spiritual energy, you fool!? You read too much manga! I'll give you a
good wallop the next time you say something so idiotic!'

Hadn't he already walloped him?

Gotou grabbed the scruff of Ishii's neck and dragged him out into the corridor .

'E-er . Detective Gotou . I came to thank you for the other day . '

Ishii heard Makoto from behind them .

'Shut up! I'm busy now! Leave it for later!'

Detective Gotou waved his hand like he was chasing away a fly .

Still, Detective Gotou is in such a rush . What on earth happened –

4

'Hey – does Doctor Kinoshita know you from before?'

While they walked on the road by the river, Haruka asked this question to Yakumo, who was walking a little in front of her .

The way Kinoshita had spoken had certainly made it sound that way .

'I completely forgot . Or rather, I have no memory of it,' Yakumo said, facing forward .

He spoke so vaguely that Haruka didn't understand .

'What do you mean?'

She quickened her pace to walk beside Yakumo .

'Doctor Kinoshita was the doctor in charge at my birth . '

'Really?'

While she was surprised, she also understood . In that case, she could accept that he had forgotten .

'Well, that's all there is to it, so we're practically strangers . '

Yakumo yawned .

Haruka still had one more thing to ask –

'So what was that?

Yakumo's feet halted at Haruka's question, as if time had stopped .

'What's wrong?'

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair with a troubled expression and lowered brows as he started talking .

'That girl's spirit is bound to that river because of Doctor Kinoshita's strong emotions . '

'Emotions?'

'Yes . He irresponsibly promised that he would definitely save his dead daughter . That keeps her in that river . '

'How can we release her?'

Yakumo didn't reply and just gazed idly at the river .

Haruka did the same, turning her eyes to the moving surface of the river .

On the other shore, young men and women were having a barbecue . White herons were resting their wings in the sandbank .

How did Yakumo feel?

Haruka stole a glance at his profile .

The pencil-straight bridge of his nose, his tightly closed lips . Was there anything reflected in his narrowed almond eyes?

'Doctor Kinoshita will have to give up for the girl to be released . '

Finally, Yakumo spoke .

'Give up?'

'Yes . As long as he doesn't acknowledge that his daughter will not be coming back, she will stay in that place . '

'How can we make that happen?'

'I don't know that much . In any case, it won't work if he is still reading books about reviving the dead and reincarnation . '

Haruka grasped the gist of what Yakumo was saying .

When she had been in the river, Ayaka-chan had said this . 'Stop already' –

Those words had been for her father, Doctor Kinoshita .

'I wonder if things will work out . '

'If things were going to work out, they already would have . This is a problem of a person's heart . It's not something we can fix by talking . Doctor Kinoshita has to acknowledge it himself . '

It was just as Yakumo said .

Outsiders like them wouldn't change anything by explaining to a father who had lost his daughter that she wouldn't be coming back .

'Well, all we can do is see how things go,' Yakumo concluded .

Haruka caught herself before she said, 'That's right . ' That was dangerous . So many things had happened that she had almost forgotten the cause of all this trouble .

'Then what about the haunting Mayuko-chan is still worried about?'

'She's mistaken . '

Yakumo twisted his neck, making it crack as he spoke .

'Mistaken?'

'You saw it too, right? The spirit of the girl in the river . '

Haruka nodded .

'Which means the girl's soul is still in the river . She's not with your friend . Which means she's mistaken . '

'But she had sleep paralysis and saw a ghost of a girl . She said she heard voices...'

Yakumo scratched at the back of his neck, looking annoyed .

'Human beings have active imaginations . She had the terrifying experience of seeing a ghost of a girl in a river . That actually happened . Then she thought that she had been possessed by that ghost . However, that was a delusion . '

Haruka understand what Yakumo had said so far .

'After that, she lived her life suspicious of everything, thinking that there was a ghost near her . The result was that she thought something in a dark room that she couldn't make out was a girl . Small noises she couldn't discern became people's voices . '

'But that sort of thing...'

'Happens . Didn't you experience it yourself before?'

'Me?'

Did she do something like that? She couldn't remember at all .

'Honestly . It's because you don't learn that you always drag me into your trouble . '

He always said too much .

'It's because you always remember unnecessary things that people hate you, Yakumo-kun . '

Yakumo snorted at Haruka's cynicism .

'I'm talking about the spirit photography I showed you before . After I said that there was a person's face in the grooves of the tree, you saw a face, right? It's the same for the girl . She's living with the preconception that there may be a ghost . '

Oh . So that's how it was .

Finally, Haruka understood too . If there was a preconception, all thoughts would end up connecting to it .

I understand that . But –

'What should I do?'

Yakumo raised an eyebrow, like he was saying, How would I know?

'You might not like it, but the best method would be to tell her that everything's fine because the ghost has been exorcised . '

'That's a lie, right?'

Haruka flared up .

'Then tell her the truth . Say, “Everything you saw was an illusion . You're psychologically ill, so I recommend that you go to a hospital for counselling . ”’

'I will then . '

No matter how she thought about it, that was obviously the better method .

'However, if she doesn't accept that explanation, she'll bring her story to another spirit medium . If they're an unsavoury one, they'll take her money . '

To be honest, she wasn't confident Mayuko would understand if she told her the truth .

'If you can't say it, then telling her not to worry because the ghost has been exorcised will take away her fear . It's your choice . '

Haruka grabbed onto Yakumo's shirt as he tried to walk away .

Yakumo's cheek twitched in irritation like that of a cat whose sleep was disturbed .

'What?'

'Yakumo-kun . Please . '

Haruka looked up at Yakumo as she pleaded with him .

'Stop that – it's disturbing . '

Disturbing? How rude .

But she didn't say that aloud . She'd lose everything if he got angry at her here .

'Yakumo-kun . Please . Go explain . '

She pleaded with him again .

'I get it, so please don't look at me with such disgusting eyes . '

He said it again!

5

As Ishii drove, he looked at Gotou reclining in the passenger seat .

He had his arms crossed, and underneath his furrowed brows, there was a sharp glint in his eye like a hound's .

Just as Ishii had been wondering why he hadn't seen Gotou since morning, he had suddenly returned to take Ishii out, saying, 'We're going!' and now they were headed towards the university by car .

'Detective Gotou, what on earth happened?'

Ishii couldn't stand it – he asked a question .

'That's why you're useless!'

Gotou suddenly yelled at him angrily .

'But, um, since I haven't heard anything, it's natural for me not to know, or that's what I...'

'Can't you do anything without being told!? If you're a detective, perk up your ears and listen! That reporter woman's got a much levelled head on her shoulders!'

'I-I apologise...'

Ishii apologised though he didn't know why, pressured into it by Gotou's shouting .

The conversation stopped there, and then the only thing that could be heard in the car was the sound of the wind .

'This isn't public yet, but another one was found . '

Breaking the awful silence, Gotou spoke, as if to himself, while holding a cigarette in his mouth .

'Another one?'

Ishii didn't understand what Gotou was saying .

He asked his question while fixing the position of his glasses .

'Another girl's corpse . '

'Eh?'

Ishii's voice cracked at the unexpected news .

'The third victim . She was found at a dumpsite this morning .

A girl's corpse? Third victim? Dumpsite?

'You must be lying . I mean, Andou was the perpetrator, and that Andou is already dead, so the case is...'

Ishii replied quickly, like he was turning over the words he couldn't understand in his mind .

A new corpse shouldn't have been found if the perpetrator is dead –

'It's too late to be surprised! That's why I'm in a rush!'

Gotou's spittle flew through the car .

Oh . So that's why –

It's as Detective Gotou says . There's no time for careless worrying . I'm a failure as a detective for not noticing anything even in such a terrible situation .

But, with all that said, why are we going to meet the young man called Yakumo?

I couldn't understand that at all –

6

Once Haruka returned to her room, she lay on her bed, overwhelmed by exhaustion .

Was that really OK –

Haruka was assaulted by a sense of self-loathing . Even though it had been because she couldn't think of any other methods, she had ended up deceiving Mayuko .

After their talk, Haruka had gone together with Yakumo to Mayuko's flat .

The moment Yakumo entered the room, he had said, 'It's strong . I feel an extremely strong spiritual energy . ' Haruka had wanted to yell 'Liar!' but she'd swallowed her words .

In the end, Yakumo had said, 'I will exorcise the spirit now . I would appreciate it if you would leave for an hour because of the danger,' and that was the end of it .

Mayuko had asked, 'Hey, I've seen that person at the university before . Is he really an exorcist?'

Haruka had lied without thinking about it . 'It's fine . That person is from a well-known family of exorcists . '

What a ridiculous monkey show –

Right after Mayuko left the room, Yakumo said, 'Wake me up in an hour,' and he went to sleep, using a cushion as a pillow . Oi .

When Mayuko returned in an hour, Yakumo pressed his hands together in prayer and innocently said, 'It was an extremely strong spirit, but somehow I was able to remove it . That ghost will not appear in front of you again . ' Haruka couldn't interrupt to say he had only been sleeping .

Mayuko started sobbing in her happiness, like she had been released from her fear .

Haruka's feelings of guilt grew .

On top of that, Yakumo had received money from Mayuko .

She couldn't believe it . It was true that Mayuko was the one who had offered to pay as thanks, but would you normally accept it? Usually people would just wave it off, saying something like 'I wouldn't have been able to live with myself if I didn't help . '

This was outright fraud . And Haruka had been an accomplice .

Honestly . She felt angrier the more she thought about it .

After Haruka woke up, her mobile started ringing . It was from her mother .

<You haven't called lately – are you doing well?>

Her mother spoke in an unbelieving tone from the start of the phone call .

Haruka's anger dissipated . That was her mother for you . Just hearing the voice made her feel safer .

'Yup . I'm OK . '

<Did something happen? Your voice sounds strange . >

Her mother had seen through her .

Her anger at Yakumo had lessened . Her voice probably sounded strange because the conversation with Doctor Kinoshita still bothered her .

'Mum, were you sad when my sister died?'

Haruka didn't know why she'd asked that, but it had come out of her mouth . It had to be because she had heard Kinoshita and Yakumo talking .

<Of course I was . Why are you asking that all of a sudden?>

It was natural for her mother to be suspicious .

'I'm currently studying criminal psychology at school, and there was a lecture on the psychology of the parents of victims which caught my interest...'

Haruka said the first lie that came to mind .

Her mother replied, <I see,> but it seemed like she didn't know whether to believe Haruka .

'If my sister hadn't died in an accident but had been killed, how would you feel?

<What do you mean?>

'For example, would you hate the murderer?'

<That I would...>

Her mother replied to her question earnestly .

'Would you want to kill that murderer?'

What on earth am I asking my mother? Would you kill him? Would you not —

What am I planning to do if my mother says she would want to kill the murderer? I'm at fault for my sister's death .

When she finds out the truth, will my mother hate me? Will she want to kill me —

For a while, the silence continued .

'Hm, if killing the murderer would bring back my dead child, I might . '

My mother's voice was warm, but also cruel .

'Bring back?'

'Yes . I don't think a parent's feelings will change whether it's a murder, accident or illness . You don't think that their death can't be helped just because it's an illness . Though it's the same for a murder...'

That might be true –

'In any case, we want them to live . That's all . That's why I would kill as many murderers as I needed to if doing so would bring back my child . '

If it would bring back her child –

Doctor Kinoshita had said the same thing . His promise with his daughter wasn't to take revenge against the murderer but to save her .

If Kinoshita could go back to the past, he would probably kill Andou without thinking .

Haruka couldn't arrange her thoughts properly in her head, but that was probably how it was .

Then, a doubt came up in Haruka's mind .

A doubt that can't come up, but a doubt that has come up so many times before . If I were the one who died instead of my sister –

<Haruka . What are you thinking about?>

Even through the phone, her mother could probably feel the change in her mood .

Her mother sounded concerned .

But I can't say this to my mother . The truth about my sister's death will be my cross to bear forever –

<What's wrong?>

Her mother's voice felt far away .

If she knew I was at fault for my sister's death, how distressed would my mother be –

<Haruka . Are you blaming yourself again?>

Haruka suddenly couldn't breathe when she heard her mother's unforeseen words, just as she had when she had been drowning in the water .

<You think you're responsible for your sister's death, right?>

Why does my mother know that? I've never mentioned this to her once, and I haven't let her see me behaving like I do either .

And yet –

'Mum... You knew...'

That was all she could say .

<Of course I do . How long do you think I've been your mother?>

'Twenty years...'

<So you know . It's not your fault that your sister died . You were just playing around and you threw the ball a little far . It's not like you tried to kill your sister . That was an accident . >

Haruka knew that much .

I never told anybody . I thought I had hid it in my heart all this time –

Her nose felt prickly, and the corners of her eyes felt warm .

<Haruka . You are you . You're not your sister . A parent doesn't care about whether their children can study or play sports or things like that . They just want their children to live and be happy . Do you understand what I'm saying?>

Haruka silently nodded .

The warmth in her mother's words filled her entire body .

Something that had frozen over was slowly melting –

When she was younger, she had always been unhappy about her older twin sister, who was better than her at everything .

Haruka had thought that her mother hated her, since she was worse at everything – studying, sports, music...

After her sister died, she had been frantic in trying to be like her . She had been scared that somebody would say 'You should have died' if she didn't .

'Mum, how did you know...'

'I even know who your first love was . Ken-chan, right? He got married some time ago . '

That was right . Ken-chan . He had dark skin and was a shorty . He had been nimble and playful .

Her mother really knew everything .

'Oh...'

<You have someone you like now, right?>

Haruka's heart skipped a beat at her mother's sudden words .

'Why do you think that?'

<When you came back home, you were grinning about something you remembered . >

'I did that?'

<You did . What sort of person is he?>

She wasn't really aware of it herself, but it was probably him .

'He's incredibly contrary . He's selfish and not nice at all . '

<My, that sounds interesting . Tell me more . >

Her mother laughed, sounding like she was enjoying herself .

'OK . Next time I come home . '

Haruka hung up .

At the same time, tears started coming out like a dam had been broken, and she cried aloud . Haruka didn't know whether it was from pain, sadness or happiness .

Her body trembled, and her chest was so hot it felt like it would burn .

In that wave of emotion that made it hard for her to breathe, Haruka realised that the cross she had been carrying up until now had been an illusion –

7

How long did Detective Gotou plan on staying here?

While Ishii had that doubt, he couldn't say it aloud, so he just looked at Gotou, sitting on a folding chair with his legs crossed .

It had already been almost thirty minutes since they'd come to the young man called Yakumo's secret hideaway at the university .

Ishii couldn't understand at all why Gotou was so fixated on him .

'Damn that bastard . Where'd he run off to? It's a serious matter,' Gotou yelled, revealing his anger .

At the same time, the door opened and Yakumo came in .

'Finally back?'

Yakumo looked obviously displeased at Gotou, who had spoken .

'This is illegal trespassing . Ishii-san, please arrest this man now . '

Yakumo pointed at Gotou .

Arrest? In that case, Ishii was committing the same crime .

'Unfortunately, I don't have the time to banter with you . '

'What a coincidence . I was just thinking that I don't have the time to play with you either . '

'That's not what I meant . She was found . '

'Your wife?'

'Stop screwing around! A girl's corpse! The third victim was found!'

Gotou's voice which he couldn't hold in burst out .

At that moment, Yakumo's expression stiffened . Even Ishii understood that it wasn't because Gotou's outcry had surprised him .

'Please let me hear the details . '

Yakumo sat on his own chair and crossed his arms as he urged Gotou .

'The victim's name is Hashimoto Rumi-chan . She's fourteen, same as the other victims . Like with the second victim, Miho-chan, she was thrown into a dumpsite after she drowned . She was found this morning . She probably died last night . '

Gotou summed it up all in one go .

Yakumo didn't open his mouth . He furrowed his brow and looked down .

Silence –

'Does that mean Andou wasn't the murderer?'

Ishii spoke up .

Yakumo and Gotou both glared at him at the same time . Being glared at by these two was truly terrifying .

'Andou is definitely the murderer,' Yakumo said indifferently .

'I checked with old man Hata this morning . Andou's fingerprints and Ayaka-chan's hair were found at the building . '

So there was evidence –

'Detective Gotou . T-t-this is just a possibility . Could that evidence have been faked?'

'Who would do that and for what purpose?' Yakumo immediately rebutted .

After hearing Yakumo's words, Gotou put a photo on the table .

'How about this? This guy did it to hide his murder . '

Yakumo's eyes went wide when he took the photo into his hands .

His teeth were clenched together so tightly it seemed like they might break with a crack .

There was a tall man wearing sunglasses in the photo .

The bridge of his nose was straight, and he looked like he was smiling . On top of that, the man's face looked vaguely like Yakumo's .

'Gotou-san . Where did you get this photo?' asked Yakumo, looking at Gotou sharply .

Gotou's expression was equally stiff .

'Seems like he was in the crowd of onlookers when the corpse was found . For both the second victim Miho-chan and this time's Rumi-chan . Old man Hata thought he was suspicious so he took the photo . '

'If this man is connected to this case, this won't end easily . '

'I know . Thirteen years ago – and that fake murder case a month ago – this is going to be difficult . '

Thirteen years ago? A month ago? What were these two talking about?

They were talking like they knew this man from before .

'Gotou-san . Do you still have the corpse of the third victim?'

'You going?'

'Yes, let's go . '

Gotou and Yakumo stood up at the same time .

Right then, Yakumo's mobile started ringing .

Yakumo curtly answered the phone . 'What trouble do you have for me this time?'

8

Haruka didn't know why that had come up in her mind herself .

The soul of the girl, still in the river, with the same name as her sister .

Yakumo had said this . That girl was bound to the river by her father's strong emotions . Haruka wanted to save her if she could .

Before she noticed, she had pressed the call button on her phone .

<What trouble do you have for me this time?>

Once the call connected, she heard a curt voice .

'It's not trouble . I just wanted to ask you something . '

'That's revolting . '

Revolting –

'Honestly . I just want to ask about Doctor Kinoshita . '

<That was already solved, wasn't it?>

'That's true, but that girl will be stuck in the river like this . '

<That's right . >

'Can't anything be done?'

<No . >

It felt like he had planned on giving up from the start, or he might have thought it wasn't their problem .

'But the girl seems pitiful . '

<How meddlesome can you be? I said it was a problem of Doctor Kinoshita's heart . >

'I know, but... I was thinking of trying to get Doctor Kinoshita to understand once more . '

<Give up . Nothing's going to change just because you said something . >

Yakumo's opinion makes sense .

It's not something I can solve on my own . But –

'Can't you come with me?'

For a while, Yakumo didn't say anything .

Doctor Kinoshita said this . His daughter died because of him –

Haruka wouldn't say she had felt the same way, but she had lived her life up until now carrying similar feelings . 'Your daughter's death wasn't your fault . ' She wanted him to understand that, at least .

<How would you feel if you were in the position of the parent?>

Yakumo's tone changed slightly .

Other people might not have noticed if they heard it, but I can tell –

Haruka recalled something Isshin had said before . 'That boy is really kind, but he's bad at showing his emotions . '

'What do you mean?'

<Would you give up on your daughter if somebody explained the situation to you?>

That's –

'I think that'd be impossible . '

<Then you understand . Doctor Kinoshita has to solve this problem on his own . >

Haruka understood what Yakumo was saying .

But she still wanted to save that girl . Those strong feelings hadn't been changed .

The girl with the same name as her dead sister .

I probably want to do something to save her and be pardoned . I want to be released from the burden of having killed my sister .

I know that's just my own selfishness . But –

'I want to do something . '

<Fine . If you want to go, just go . But I can't help you right now . If you're going, you're going on your own . >

It sounded like Yakumo had given up .

'OK . '

Haruka nodded .

Now that she thought about it, it would feel like running away if she borrowed Yakumo's strength now .

<If you meet Doctor Kinoshita, tell him my message . >

'Your message?'

<Please let your daughter go . Your emotions are trapping your daughter in that dark river . What the dead want is for the living to be happy...'

What the dead want is for the living to be happy –

Those words pierced deep into her heart .

'Thank you...'

Haruka said that and hung up .

9

Kinoshita gasped, like his suffering was forcing its way out .

I failed again –

Why? What was wrong?

I promised my daughter . I promised I would definitely save her . And yet –

'Damn it!'

Kinoshita said those words like he had vomited them, and he stabbed a pen into his desk .

The plastic pen broke with a loud snap, but his anger still did not abate .

He stood up, picked up the chair he had been sitting on with two hands and threw it towards the wall .

The chair hit the cabinet and created a large dent before falling to the floor .

Blood flow invigorated him, and his temperature went up .

'Agh!'

He punched the wall with his fists .

The impact went along his arm, but he didn't feel any pain .

Lost in his anger, Kinoshita punched the wall again . He punched it again, again and again .

Not just with his fists – he also hit the wall with his head .

A crack split down his parched heart, and it started crumbling .

Emotions that weren't appeased –

The police had said the incident was over .

It was true that it had been determined who Ayaka-chan's killer was, and that killer had already died .

So what?

I already know that .

It isn't over yet for me . It's not a matter of who the murderer is . Nothing will be over under Ayaka comes back .

That which connects the soul and the body . That's the key .

Success isn't impossible if I can find the answer to that question .

But I don't have the time to wait for that .

I'm breaking –

Kinoshita felt it .

His phone started ringing . He had a call .

10

Hata was making preparations while waiting when Gotou brought Yakumo to the autopsy room .

The girl's corpse was on the autopsy table .

This very young girl –

Gotou's anger started building up again .

He looked at Yakumo standing beside him .

His face was white and proper like porcelain . At first glance, he left a composed and cold impression, but that didn't look at Yakumo's true nature .

If you brought trouble to him, he would complain a lot, but he could've just ignored it if he hated it so much .

However, he would talk on and on, but in the end, he would stick his neck in instead of letting it go . That was the type of person he was .

'Old man, sorry about this . '

'Don't worry about it . I wouldn't be able to sleep like this either . '

Hata let out an uncanny laugh .

Gotou walked with Yakumo to the side of the autopsy table .

The girl lying on the autopsy table was covered up to her shoulders with a white sheet . There weren't any noticeable injuries, but the lips on her swollen face, characteristic of drowning, had turned purple .

It didn't match up . That was how Gotou felt .

This girl's life and death were so different from each other .

Until the moment came, she might not have even thought that she would die .

She woke up in the morning, brushed her teeth, ate breakfast, went to school, talked with friends, thought about the person she liked, and now, she's here –

'Eeeeeek . '

An inappropriate shriek echoed through the tiled autopsy room .

I'd forgotten . Ishii's here too . Making such a disgusting scream . What's he so afraid of? Maybe –

'Is this the first time you've seen a corpse?'

'A-ah, yes,' Ishii replied, his teeth chattering .

Honestly – this fool . It made Gotou worry about the future . For now, Gotou just hit him .

Yakumo gazed upon the girl's face .

His brow was furrowed, and his eyes were serious . He was looking . Looking at something they couldn't see .

'You see something?'

Yakumo shook his head .

'It was no good . I thought that if the girl's spirit was still here, I might be able to grasp something, but...'

Yakumo bit his lip .

Things wouldn't be that simple .

But if he couldn't see anything, what would they do?

'There aren't any external injuries?' asked Yakumo, a hand on his chin .

Hata took the sheet off of the girl's ankles . The toenails were painted pink .
The ankle showed signs that suggested it had been bound .

'There's this laceration . That's all . '

'Hata-san, the girl drowned, correct?'

'There's a lot of water in her lungs . '

'Do you know where she drowned?'

'Probably a river somewhere . '

'A river?'

'After examining the water in her lungs, we found the eggs of freshwater fish mixed in it . '

'I see . A river, eh...'

Yakumo put a finger to his brow .

Unfortunately, all Gotou could do was wait . Yakumo was in charge of thinking . He was in charge of taking action .

Gotou suddenly looked over at Ishii . In that case, would he be in charge of playing the fool? Gotou didn't need somebody in charge of that .

'Something's odd, right?' Hata said, turning his neck round and round . It seemed like his neck would turn a full rotation from the momentum .

'Since I was drawn into this case from a completely different direction this time, I knew almost nothing about the chain of incidents, but the third

victim's cause of death is different, isn't it?'

'The first victim, Ayaka-chan, was strangled . The second victim, Miho-chan, and the third victim, Rumi-chan, drowned . '

Hata answered Yakumo's doubts .

'Gotou-san, there's something I would like to ask . '

'What?'

'Let us forget about whether Andou is the perpetrator or not for now . This girl was killed yesterday, correct?'

'Yeah . What about it?'

'Where was she killed?'

'The old water gate, right?'

What was Yakumo saying now?

'That's impossible . '

Yakumo had asked the question himself, but he denied the answer immediately .

'Why?'

'Please think about it . The police should be investigating the old water gate currently . Would the crime have been committed in front of the police?'

'Oh, now that you say that . '

That's right –

Silence filled the room .

Suddenly, Hata brought his hands together, like he had remembered something .

'About that old water gate . The first victim, Ayaka-chan, and the girl who was in danger of losing her life, Keiko-chan – their DNA was found at the site, but...'

'The second and third victims' weren't found, correct?'

Yakumo continued Hata's words .

'Right . '

Hata crossed his arms and nodded .

'As I thought, that's how it was...'

Yakumo looked down and spat those words out unpleasantly .

Gotou didn't understand at all about what was 'how it was' .

'Oi, Yakumo . What are you talking about?'

'That would mean there is another perpetrator . '

Yakumo lifted his head and spoke like what he said was obvious .

'Another perpetrator!? An accomplice?'

'Not an accomplice . '

'You were the one who said it . '

Gotou drew closer to Yakumo .

'What I said was that there is another perpetrator . '

'Stop acting so important and just say it already!'

Gotou grabbed Yakumo by the collar and glared at him .

'What a violent attitude . Maybe I will just stop talking . '

Damn, this contrary little –

'Ah, I sincerely apologise . Please explain this to me . '

Gotou let go of Yakumo and bowed his head .

'I don't feel your sincerity, but I'll forgive you . We, as well as the investigation department, have made a huge mistake . '

'A mistake?'

'Yes . A mistake . First, the investigation department's title needs to be changed . '

'What?'

Who cared about the investigation department's name?

Really, what an irritating guy .

'I said this before, but the case this time has two different cases, and there are two perpetrators with different goals . '

'Eh? Really now . '

Ishii spoke before Gotou, sounding like he was playing dumb .

'There really isn't anything to be surprised about . If we take away our preconceptions and use the process of elimination, that is the only possible answer . No matter how difficult a truth it is to believe . '

Yakumo's eyes narrowed, and he stared at the autopsy wall almost as if someone was there .

'Explain it so even I can understand . '

In his irritation, Gotou put a cigarette in his mouth, but Hata immediately complained – 'This is a no-smoking area' – so he couldn't light it up .

'First, the one who killed Ayaka-chan and abducted Keiko-chan was Andou . There is no doubt about it . Evidence has been found . However, the second victim, Miho-chan . The third victim, Rumi-chan, could not have been killed by Andou . '

'Why not?'

'As you know, Andou had already died when Rumi-chan was killed . '

'Then how about Miho-chan?'

'You would understand if you think about the purpose of the murder . Though this is just my reasoning, I explained about Andou's psychological state before . '

Gotou nodded . Yakumo had said that Andou had a fear towards death that could even be called a disorder because he had seen his mother's suicide . When the girl said that he should die, those words lit the fear in his heart .

'If my reasoning is correct, it was important for Andou to kill the victim himself . '

'I see . Miho-chan and Rumi-chan died from drowning . They weren't killed by the murderer,' Hata said with crossed arms, sounding like he agreed .

'No, wait a second . Can't you kill someone by drowning them?'

Gotou interrupted the conversation .

'How so?'

'Well, you push them from the back like this...'

After Yakumo spoke, Gotou took Ishii, who had been beside him, and pushed the back of his neck forward to show an example . Ishii flailed about, surprised by the suddenness .

'Weren't you listening to what we were saying early?' Hata said, snorting .

'Shut up, perverted old man . '

'Perverted was unnecessary . I explained this before, but the girls who were drowned only had lacerations on their ankles . '

'What about it?'

'If someone pushed their necks down like you're doing now, there would be signs of pressure applied there . '

'Ah . '

Gotou understood what Hata said and took his hand off of Ishii . That's right . That's certainly true . Then that would mean –

'Then how were they killed?'

Gotou tried cocking his head, but no valuable thoughts came to him .

'From the state of the corpses, weights were probably attached to the girls' ankles so they would sink into the river,' said Yakumo, pointing at the ankles .

'That's...'

At this point, Gotou could get the gist of it .

Chains or ropes had been tied to the girls' feet . On the ends of those, there had been weights, and they had been thrown into the river . Then they wouldn't have been able to float to the top of the river, so they drowned .

If that was the method, it would mean that Andou wouldn't have killed them himself .

In short, there were two murder methods from the start .

There were also two perpetrators .

Since it was a unique situation where girls of the same age were abducted in the same area and their corpses were found without any requests, the police had ended up investigating it as a serial abduction murder case .

From the start, if looking at there being two perpetrators with separate cases, the third victim found after Andou's death still wasn't anything odd .

But –

'Then what's the second perp's motive?'

'I don't know . '

Yakumo replied immediately to Gotou's question .

Well, that made sense . It wasn't something that they'd understand just from talking about it . Since there were two cases, the investigation would have to start again .

A heavy silence filled the room .

With this strange situation in front of them, they wouldn't open their mouths quickly .

'But this murder method...'

Hata spoke with his mouth turned down at the corners .

'What about it?'

Hata smiled bitterly at Gotou's question . It seemed like he didn't plan on saying it aloud .

He ran a hand down his white hair before starting to speak reluctantly .

'I just thought that this killing method is similar to some sort of ritual for a sacrifice . '

'A sacrifice?'

Honestly . Of all things, this perverted old man –

'Ah, I thought that too . '

Ishii spoke up while raising his hand .

He had bright eyes, like a primary school student who'd solved a question on a test . What was up with that face –

'A sacrifice...'

This time, Yakumo was the one to murmur .

'Oi, oi . cut it out . '

Gotou couldn't hold it in any longer and spoke up .

'Please throw away your preconceptions,' said Yakumo, his eyes narrowed like he thought Gotou was being a fool .

'I don't have any preconceptions, but what you're saying is just some occult stuff . '

'What you blurted out is a preconception . Even if you don't believe in the occult, Gotou-san, there are people in this world who do . In the case of these people, saying that what you don't believe in doesn't exist is heading down the wrong direction, just as the investigation did this time . '

Gotou clicked his teeth and stopped objecting .

He wouldn't win even if he argued with Yakumo . He would just get knocked about by Yakumo's hair-splitting .

'If this is some sort of ritual...'

Yakumo looked down and furrowed his brow as he said something .

Hata and Ishii were roused up in a creepy conversation about people's heads and goat blood or something like that .

Even though the others were the ones being strange, Gotou felt like he had been left out .

Why did he have to feel so ashamed? He felt more and more irritated .

'Perhaps this is...'

Yakumo suddenly raised his head like he had thought of something . After a moment, his face turned pale and he ran out of the autopsy room .

'Oi, Yakumo . What's wrong?'

Gotou chased after Yakumo into the corridor .

That guy . He didn't even turn around . Yakumo had definitely thought of something . But what was it? And why was he in such a rush?

Yakumo took his mobile out of his pocket and started making a call .

However, whoever he was calling didn't answer . He made a 'tsk' sound and stuck the mobile back in his pocket .

'What happened?'

Gotou grabbed hold of Yakumo's shoulders as he tried to walk away and stopped him by force .

Yakumo's eyes were bloodshot, and it looked like he might jump at any moment .

'Do you think you know who the perp is?'

Yakumo was just taking deep breaths, like he was trying to hold back his agitation, and he didn't answer .

'What's wrong?'

Gotou shook Yakumo's shoulders .

'Just now, a terrible thought came to me . I would like to prove it wrong if I can,' Yakumo said, his voice strained .

Gotou didn't know what terrible thought Yakumo was talking about .

Yakumo probably wouldn't tell him even if he asked, but now that he'd come here, all he could do was go with him to the end .

'Then how do we check whether your thought is correct?'

For a moment, Yakumo's eyes went wide in surprise .

His distrust towards other people was too strong .

That was why he always looked like this when other people tried to do anything for him . Gotou didn't hate it when Yakumo looked like that .

'Are you holding back? It's not like you . '

'It's not like you to worry about others, Gotou-san . '

Honestly, this guy was always like this . Not cute at all .

'Just tell me already . '

'First, I need to ask somebody something . '

No trouble at all .

'Ishii, the car!'

Gotou shouted, but there was no response . That idiot .

'Oi! Ishii!' roared Gotou angrily .

'Y-yessir!'

The door to the autopsy room opened, and Ishii came out, looking surprised .

Honestly – for a detective, he was a really careless guy .

'What are you doing!? We're going! Run!'

Ishii replied energetically with a 'Yessir!' and started running down the corridor .

He tripped –

11

Haruka went to visit Doctor Kinoshita again .

Like before, Kinoshita invited Haruka into the examination room without even the slightest bit of unpleasantness and offered her coffee .

However, Haruka didn't know how to talk to him, let alone confront him . While she was thinking, Kinoshita started speaking .

'You've come at a good time . I was just planning on looking for you myself . '

'For me?'

'Yes . There is something I would like to request of you . '

'A request for me?'

What could it be? There isn't much I can do even if I'm asked .

And still, I'm bad at saying no –

'Yes, but let me leave that matter for later . Please go ahead first . '

'Ah, yes . Er...'

Haruka's words got caught in her throat when it was important .

However, she had to tell him this: You are not responsible for your daughter's death . As long as you don't give up, your daughter will continue wandering in the same place .

'Doctor Kinoshita . I understand your feelings, even if that's only slightly . '

There was no use keeping quiet . She started speaking, saying the thoughts she had organised as they came up to her .

'My feelings, you say?'

Kinoshita furrowed his eyebrows, looking troubled .

'When I was young, I lost my older sister to a traffic accident . My sister had tried to catch a ball I'd thrown and was then hit by a car . '

Haruka met Kinoshita's eyes .

However, he looked back at her silently without speaking .

'I've always thought that my sister's death was my fault . If I hadn't thrown the ball then... I'm the same as you, Doctor . I blamed myself, regretted it and was always suffering . '

'Is that so?'

'Naturally, I think that the pain you're feeling is many times greater than mine . I know that I don't have the right to say this, but Ayaka-chan's death wasn't your fault, Doctor . '

Haruka took a pause there to calm down .

'It must have been very difficult for you . '

Kinoshita's voice was kind, like he was trying to console her .

'I apologise for suddenly talking about something like this . '

Haruka bowed her head . It sort of felt like she had just forced her opinion on him .

She remembered what Yakumo had said .

Doctor Kinoshita's emotions are binding her to the river –

Wasn't that the same for me? I thought I was responsible for my sister's death and was always blaming myself, so wasn't I tying my sister's soul down?

I feel like I sort of understood why I had gotten so involved with this case .

It was the same with me . Ayaka-chan, who had died in pain, and my sister, Ayaka . Doctor Kinoshita, blaming himself for his daughter's death, and me, blaming myself for my sister's death –

'You are a kind person . '

Kinoshita smiled gently .

'That isn't true . '

I wasn't being humble .

I was just running away from the burden I carried on my back –

'As you say, I do blame myself . You might be able to understand that . However, there is a definite difference between us . '

Kinoshita appeared full of confidence .

'A difference?'

'Yes . You have already given up . However, I have not . '

'What have you not given up on?'

Something felt slightly off .

She couldn't explain it clearly, but that was what she felt .

'I will bring my daughter Ayaka back to life . '

'Eh?'

Did he really believe he could bring someone dead back to life?

Doctor Kinoshita was a doctor, one way or another .

Bringing someone dead back to life was physically impossible .

Gooseflesh rose on Haruka's skin .

'After I lost my daughter and was in despair, a man came to me . That man took me to the river and showed my daughter's soul to me there . '

Kinoshita's face was blank, like he was wearing a Noh mask[1] .

What is he saying –

'My daughter was suffering . She was suffering greatly . Since her physical body had died, the pain her soul felt was even greater . '

Kinoshita's eyes were bloodshot, like he had been possessed by something .

'That's...'

'Do you understand? Ayaka has been suffering even after she died . I have only been watching . I can't do anything...'

As if he was fighting his rising anger, Kinoshita scratched his fingernails against the desk .

An unpleasant noise that made your hair stand on end –

'I have been frantically trying to find a way to save my daughter . That man showed me several books . I found out while I was researching them . There are many people in this world who have died and came back to life . '

'But...'

Haruka started speaking, but she didn't say any more words .

She wasn't Yakumo . She didn't have the knowledge to refute the statement directly .

It might have been because she had been thinking too much .

Her head hurt like something was pressing against it .

'Humans have souls . I reached the conclusion that it is something like the aggregation of those humans' thoughts or feelings . In short, even if the body is dead, the soul still lives...'

Haruka had heard that way of thinking before .

Yakumo had said the same thing .

Her vision was cloudy, like a fog had covered it .

She blinked, but the blurred world did not return –

'The body and the soul are originally different things . If you think that way, the death of the body isn't a major problem . To use the computer as an analogy, the body is the hardware while the soul is the software . If the body, as the hardware, is broken, the soul, as software, can just be put into new hardware . '

Haruka understood the theory .

But that was all it was .

In the first place, it was wrong to replace the human body and soul with a computer's hardware and software .

Haruka had seen many times with her own eyes what happened to souls that took over bodies that weren't their own .

Miki . And that woman .

That couldn't be called living .

That was —

It was no use . Her thoughts were growing duller .

'What are you trying... to say?' Haruka asked Kinoshita .

Her voice sounded far away, and she could hear it trembling terribly .

She noticed that her thoughts about Doctor Kinoshita were changing . The depths of his heart were much, much darker and deeper than she had imagined .

'You and Yakumo both say that my daughter will not return again, but that is incorrect . My daughter's soul is still alive . '

Yes, it is alive .

And you're the one keeping her alive with your strong emotions . That's why I have to stop this .

What is this —

'Doctor Kinoshita... Ayaka-chan... your...'

Her mouth wouldn't move properly .

Her eyelids were so heavy she couldn't open them .

Her mobile was ringing in her bag .

Who is it? I have to pick up .

The floor is shaking .

It hurts... Why... is this...

Haruka fell into a deep sleep –

12

'We're coming in!

Gotou opened the door to Kinoshita Hospital and yelled .

However, just like last time, there was nobody at the reception or in the corridor .

'Doctor Kinoshita probably isn't here,' Yakumo said, a step behind Gotou .

'How do you know?'

'The garage is empty . '

'I see . Why don't you become a detective?'

Gotou said that to Yakumo, but Yakumo didn't hear him at all .

He was rapidly looking around him .

He was like a cat on the lookout for people . The guy probably felt something .

'Oi . Yakumo . '

Yakumo ignored Gotou's call and suddenly started running . He rushed into the examination room they had met Kinoshita in before at full speed .

Gotou didn't know what was happening, but it seemed like Yakumo's hurry had transferred to him as well . He ran to the examination room like he had been dragged along .

'Detective Gotou, what is it?' said Ishii, in charge of playing the fool . He had come late and sounded carefree .

Didn't he feel the tension?

Gotou sighed and looked around the examination room .

Kinoshita wasn't there .

However, there were signs that somebody had been there just a little while ago . The lights were on . There were two coffee cups on Doctor Kinoshita's desk .

Yakumo went through the documents on Doctor Kinoshita's desk chaotically and he opened the drawer on one side to look for something .

What was he looking for? Gotou, who didn't understand what Yakumo was thinking, could only watch him .

'Er, Detective Gotou . This is clearly unlawful trespassing . We have to stop him . '

Ishii spoke up from behind Gotou . That guy was really –

'Shut up! I'll take responsibility . '

He can't possibly think that –

A thought suddenly came to Gotou .

'Damn it!'

Maybe Yakumo had found something, because he shouted as he slammed his hand against the desk .

Gotou walked up beside Yakumo .

There were two sets of clinical records on the desk .

(Matsumoto Miho: incompatible... Blood type mismatch thought to be the cause . Disposed .)

(Hashimoto Rumi: incompatible... Cause unknown . Disposed .)

'W-what? This is...'

Gotou's voice came out unconsciously .

The clinical records for the second and third serial abduction murder victims .

This was a maternity and gynaecology department . It wouldn't have been strange if the two of them had been born here .

But what did disposal mean?

'Oi . Yakumo . '

Yakumo didn't have any response to Gotou's words, and this time he pulled open the accordion curtain that separated the examination room and the consultation room .

There was a bed for pregnant women . Until a little while ago, the room had been used for consultations, but it didn't look that way now .

– What was going on?

Books were scattered about the room . The Mystery of the Body, The World of the Soul, The Reincarnating Soul . It wasn't at the level of ten or twenty books . There was one more digit .

Copies of newspapers that were probably foreign were also scattered on the floor .

The wall was even worse .

Photos were pasted up to the point that the wall couldn't be seen .

At first glance, it could look like a piece of art, but it wasn't anything so pleasant .

The photos were all of people's corpses .

Shivers went down his spine just from standing there .

On the table in the middle of the room, chart paper was rolled out . Words such as body, soul and transplant were written in a graph with circles and symbols in an unrivalled scrawl .

What the hell had that doctor been doing here?

'Gotou-san, let's hurry . '

For a moment, Yakumo looked like he had also been stunned by the sight, but he spoke with a voice full of tension .

'Where are we hurrying to?'

'Doctor Kinoshita is the other perpetrator for this case . '

'W-w-what?'

Why would Kinoshita need to kill anyone? Kinoshita was the father of the victim .

Gotou was just about to ask Yakumo that when a mobile phone started ringing –

13

Kinoshita was driving .

Evening approached . Unlucky for him, it was rush hour .

Normally, operations went on late at night .

It was because he needed to take great care to avoid being noticed .

Other people probably wouldn't understand him . His past self wouldn't have understood him either .

Those ahead of their time were the targets of persecution, no matter what time they were from .

Leonardo da Vinci was a good example . In order to draw people in more detail, he autopsied bodies because he thought it was necessary to understand the construction of the body better .

He avoided being seen and dug up graves, so he was treated as a lunatic .

However, he built the foundation for art or possibly medicine, and that had continued to present day .

Will I be treated as a lunatic?

But the day that my actions will be considered great will come .

For now, it is safest for me to wait until night .

But I can't wait any longer —

He had no more time .

That man had told him . His daughter's soul would disappear —

His daughter might disappear while he waited .

And yet, and yet .

He was caught in a traffic jam on a bridge and couldn't move .

He was irritated .

There was always a traffic jam on this bridge .

Even though I can see it right in front of me —

He had to hurry .

Kinoshita took the handle forcefully and started his car in the middle of the cars .

The other cars started honking .

Some people stuck their heads out of their windows to jeer .

He couldn't stop for something like that though .

Kinoshita's car quickly went past the congested bridge .

He forced his way onto the road by the embankment .

It was right by it .

He reached the management office for the water gate .

When he got off the car, Uchiyama from the management office walked towards him .

It looked like he was just about to leave . He was wearing outside clothes – jeans and a white fleece jacket . Ayaka had bought him that fleece jacket .

'Hey, Kinoshita . What are you doing here at this time of night?'

Perfect timing . He could ask Uchiyama to help .

He had taken his time before, but he had to hurry today .

'I'd like your help . '

Kinoshita opened the car trunk .

'Kinoshita . This is...'

Uchiyama's eyes were wide in shock .

'Help me carry this . '

'What are you thinking? What are you trying to do?'

Uchiyama sounded scared .

Why is he scared –

'I understand the pain you feel from losing Ayaka, but even so... This woman has nothing to do with it . '

What is this man saying? Has he misunderstood something?

Saying he understands the pain I feel from losing Ayaka –

If he understood, why was he trying to stop him? Even though he was a friend, a man who had no children couldn't understand .

'Kinoshita . I won't say anything bad . Let this girl go and head home . '

Let her go –

'I can't do that . '

'Kinoshita, listen to what I'm saying . If you won't, I'll call the police . '

Call the police –

Why? Is Uchiyama saying he'll get in my way? Didn't he lend me the water gate key when I told him I wanted to meet my daughter?

Didn't he say Ayaka was like a daughter to him?

Even though I thought he was my friend –

Will you get in my way?

If you're going to get in my way –

Kinoshita took the block he had used as a weight from the trunk and smacked it against Uchiyama's head .

Uchiyama collapsed to the ground .

Kinoshita wiped the blood that had spurted out from Uchiyama off his cheek with his palm and started his work again .

14

Yakumo answered the ringing mobile –

Haruka's number was displayed on the screen .

'Are you OK?'

He asked that the moment he picked up .

At the same time, he heard a quiet laugh . It was a man's voice –

&It's the first time we've talked like this . >

The voice was emotionless, almost as if it had been machine-generated .

This is his voice –

It wasn't his reason . He knew it instinctively .

'So it was you, as I expected . I didn't think that Doctor Kinoshita would have thought of such a method himself...'

A phone call with this timing .

He had to be watching them from somewhere . Yakumo looked at his surroundings, but he couldn't feel anybody's presence, let alone see anyone .

<So you have arrived at the truth . It seems that you also made great efforts during the last case as well . I'm happy to hear it . >

'Making you happy doesn't make me happy . '

<Is that something you should be saying to your father?>

'I have never thought of you as my father . The case is already over .
Obediently show yourself . '

<Do you really think that?>

Yakumo had a bad feeling .

I know what he's implying . He's answering her phone, which means –

<It seemed like you were about to reach the truth, so I laid a little trap . >

Yakumo clenched his teeth .

'What trap?'

<I said this to Doctor Kinoshita yesterday . 'I found a body compatible with
your daughter's . ' Her name... I wonder if it's fine that I said it was Ozawa
Haruka-san . >

'You bastard . '

Even though he had expected it, when he was told directly like this, it felt
like his chest had been stabbed with a stake .

<When people lose something important to them, their true nature comes
out . Like Doctor Kinoshita . I wonder what sort of reaction you'll show
me? I look forward to seeing which kind of person you are . >

He hung up the moment he finished talking .

He was the only one Yakumo wouldn't forgive – only him!

But it wasn't the time to be chasing after him . Currently, they were in the
worst-possible scenario that Yakumo had predicted .

Being even a second late would bring about a situation that could not be
undone .

'Gotou-san . Please drive . '

While Yakumo said that, he ran out of the examination room at full speed .

15

My body feels heavy –

It felt like her body was made of lead .

Her thoughts felt slow .

Where am I?

I was talking with Doctor Kinoshita up until a little while ago –

In the middle of that, my head started feeling heavy –

When she tried to think, there was a pain behind her eyes which felt like something was gripping her head .

It was only faintly, but she knew that there was someone in front of her .

Who –

Their lips moved to say something .

However, she couldn't hear anything .

The person in front of her gradually became clear –

A tall, oval-faced man .

It's Doctor Kinoshita –

16

Urged by Gotou, Ishii turned on the police siren and drove the car at a furious speed .

'Why did Kinoshita need to kill the girls?'

Sitting in the passenger seat, Gotou asked this question to Yakumo, sitting in the back .

Ishii wanted to know too . Yakumo had said that Kinoshita was the culprit, but Ishii didn't know why .

There's no reason for Doctor Kinoshita to kill anyone . He's related to the victim . He should understand the pain of losing someone better than anyone . To make someone else feel that pain –

'In order to bring his daughter back from the dead,' Yakumo said, raking a hand through his messy hair in his irritation .

'Back from the dead?'

Gotou spoke in a strange voice, but Ishii could see where Yakumo was getting at just from the one sentence .

He had seen a horror movie before . It was about a scientist who was searching for a way to resurrect the dead . There was a whole mountain of stories like that .

Is Doctor Kinoshita trying to do that? But with what method –

He was a doctor, one way or another . He probably wouldn't be chanting spells .

As if he were answering Ishii's doubts, Yakumo started his explanation .

'After finding out that his daughter's soul was wandering at the water gate, Doctor Kinoshita searched for a method to save that soul . Everything scattered about that room was about spiritual phenomena – in particular, books about bringing souls of the dead back to life . '

Ishii remembered the strange scene at Doctor Kinoshita's consultation room .

It had exceeded the level of just gathering materials as a hobby . It was like he had been possessed by something .

'Was he really thinking about that?'

'It isn't particularly unusual – rather, he thought that way because he is a doctor . '

Yakumo's tone of voice wasn't cool like it always was .

Ishii could hear the agitation and irritation at points of his speech .

Ishii, who had thought that Yakumo might not have had emotions, was perplexed by this unexpected side of his .

'Because he's a doctor?'

Gotou cocked his head, like he didn't understand .

'Yes . Do you know of the Japanese Psychic Science Association[2]?'

'What is that tongue twister of a name?'

Gotou frowned .

'It is a foundation that researches spiritual phenomena . Its members are by no means suspicious mediums . It is a gathering of psychiatry and psychology professors with doctorates . '

Ishii knew about that too .

While watching television, he would see scientists denying the existence of spiritual phenomena, but it wasn't actually true .

There were scientists who seriously researched spiritual phenomena .

'Science cannot yet explain the existence of the human soul . However, just because it has not been explained does not mean it is impossible . Formerly,

science didn't explain that the earth revolved around the sun, but even at that time, the earth revolved . '

'Ah, forget it . Stop the complicated explanation here . '

Gotou waved a hand to interrupt .

'In short, what I want to say is that simply being a doctor does not mean that he would deny the existence of the soul . Hata-san is a good example . Even though he is a coroner, he believes that the soul exists . '

'But even if Kinoshita believes that there's a soul, that wouldn't lead to him trying to bring his daughter back . '

Gotou clearly looked like he had indigestion, but the conversation continued .

'Please listen to this hypothesis . There is the idea of reincarnation . '

'Ah, I know about that . After dying, the soul leaves the body and is born again in a different body – that thing, right?'

Gotou's gaze was wandering as he spoke, like he was trying to pull in his memories .

'Though that isn't exactly it, it's about right . With reincarnation, the body and the soul are separate things . The body is only the soul's vessel . Though this is only one interpretation, in that way of thinking, the soul still lives on even if the body dies . '

'Well, that's right . '

'To put it another way, for those who believe in the existence of ghosts, their theory would fail if the body and soul weren't separate . '

It was just as Yakumo said .

As somebody who believed in ghosts, Ishii felt that himself . If the death of the body meant the death of the soul, the very existence of ghosts would be

denied .

They had to be separate .

'Doctor Kinoshita thought that if the body died, as long as the soul was alive, that soul could just be transplanted to a different body . '

'That's ridiculous . '

Gotou cocked his head like he couldn't believe Yakumo's explanation .

'It doesn't matter if it is ridiculous or not . Doctor Kinoshita had reason to believe it . He had almost definitely seen his daughter's soul . As well, in the newspaper clippings in that room, there were stories of people who had been resurrected in the past . '

'Did that really happen...'

Gotou looked incredulous .

There was one thing Ishii couldn't understand, separate from the case .

Why is Detective Gotou so sceptical about spiritual phenomena? Isn't he the psychic detective –

'Yes . Though it isn't well known in Japan, it is considered rather major overseas . There is something called responsive xenoglossy which is famous .

'What the hell is that?'

Gotou frowned like he had seen something filthy .

'Detective Gotou, do you really not know?'

Ishii couldn't help but speak .

'So you do?'

'There are some people who can speak languages they shouldn't know under hypnotism . It is said that memories from before birth are in the deep psyche . In India, there was a report of a girl who had all those memories from the past . '

Though Ishii said something naturally knew, Gotou looked surprised and said, 'Why do you know that?'

'It is as Ishii-san says . If this story is true, it would have to mean that the soul was born in a different body . '

Yakumo finished there .

'So I don't have to agree, but you're telling me to understand...' muttered Gotou, a cigarette in his mouth .

'But did Kinoshita use black magic or something?'

Ishii wanted to know that as well . What method was he trying to use –

'No, the method he used wasn't anything magical . He wouldn't jump that far . There is a more realistic and extremely primitive method . '

'Primitive?'

Gotou tilted his head at Yakumo's words .

Ishii felt the same as Gotou . Even if Yakumo said primitive, Ishii couldn't think of the method .

'Excuse me, Ishii-san . Could you drive a little more quickly?'

Yakumo ignored Gotou's question and spoke while leaning forward .

Even if he asked him to speed up, he was already speeding quite a bit . Plus, they might get caught in the traffic jam on the bridge up ahead like this .

'Oi, Yakumo . Answer my question . '

Gotou returned to the conversation .

'Gotou-san, you saw as well, did you not? There was a large piece of chart paper in that room . '

'Yeah, that thing with some sort of diagram on it . '

'Yes . That is the method Doctor Kinoshita used . '

'Is it a sacrifice?'

Ishii recalled how the room looked and said the thought that came to him .

'Correct . The method is similar to the live sacrifices conducted in the past . He knows that his daughter's soul is at the bottom of the river . He wants to bring his daughter back from the dead . He will make the soul he wants to resurrect possess a body...'

'Like Andou?'

'Yes . '

'How stupid...'

Gotou kicked the dashboard in his anger .

'On top of that, this time, Doctor Kinoshita chose her for his daughter's body...'

Yakumo bit his lip and tightened his hands into fists as he said that .

'Wha – you can't mean Haruka-chan!?' shouted Gotou, turning to face the backseat .

'I do . '

'But why her? She's the wrong age...'

'That man is connected to this case . He knows we're here, so he thought of a little test and told Doctor Kinoshita that her body might be compatible with his daughter's soul . '

'Why would he do that?'

'Like I said, it's a test . He wants to know what sort of response I'll show him after she dies . '

At the same time as he finished speaking, Yakumo punched the seat .

'Just for that...'

'Yes . For that man, my existence is just something to experiment with . What will my child become? He probably wanted to see that . '

'So that man was involved from the start?'

'That's likely . '

'Then he's an accomplice to murder!' Gotou shouted .

'Do you have any proof?'

After a while, Yakumo started speaking again .

'It is the same as last time . He didn't say anything about killing himself . If we are talking about things he actually did, all he did was show Doctor Kinoshita his daughter's soul and give a one-sided lecture on a theory about the soul and the body . The rest was just Doctor Kinoshita's rampage that came about because of his feelings for his daughter...'

'Damn it!'

Gotou kicked the dashboard again .

Ishii was completely lost as to what Gotou and Yakumo were saying .

Who was the man they were talking about? However, he understood that Haruka-chan was in danger .

This is a serious affair . We have to hurry and save her –

I don't want to never see her smile again . But –

In opposition to his impatient feelings, Ishii slammed the brakes at the foot of the bridge .

'Why are you stopping!? Hurry up! We've got the siren on!' yelled Gotou as he hit the dashboard .

'I know, but...'

There was a traffic jam . Even if they went to the sides, the opposite lane had another line of cars .

It wasn't that he didn't want to force his way through, but they would just take more time if they caused an accident .

'You idiot! Make a U-turn! Turn around!'

'It's no good . '

The decision was too late .

The road behind them was blocked off as well . They couldn't move around . Even though they could see the water gate they were aiming for –

'Damn it!'

Gotou threw the cigarette he had been holding in his mouth at the windshield .

Like that had been a signal, the back door opened and Yakumo leapt out . Like that, he started running .

'That'll be faster,' Gotou muttered, and he ran, following Yakumo .

They went and left me behind –

17

I could see the river .

In the night, the river was pitch-black .

Was this the river's surface? No .

This was probably the top of the water gate's control tower .

The river was about ten metres below .

Though she had regained consciousness, her body still wouldn't move like she wanted it to .

She tried to stand up, but it was no use .

It was like her body and mind were cut off from each other –

'The drug is doing its work . You won't be able to move yet . '

Doctor Kinoshita peered at her from the ground as he said that . His words seemed very slow to her –

'... Why... did you... do this...'

Her tongue wouldn't turn properly .

It was almost like it wasn't her own voice .

'Isn't it obvious that I'm doing this for my daughter...' said Kinoshita with a smile .

I don't understand .

What on earth is this person trying to do for his daughter?

Why did he need to abduct me and bring me here –

Could this be what Ayaka-chan wanted to stop –

'She doesn't... want... this... Ayaka... chan...'

'Shut up! Ayaka didn't want to die!'

This person had already become someone else .

Haruka suddenly remembered her mother's words . If it would bring back their child, a parent would happily become a murderer –

I wonder if I'm going to be killed –

Haruka imagined her death, like it didn't concern her at all .

* * *

In the dark, the water gate came into view .

Gotou was running at full speed on the road by the embankment .

He saw the iron bridge that connected the management office and the tower in the middle of the river that controlled the opening and closing of the water gate .

Just a little bit more .

Still, Yakumo was really fast .

Gotou had started running to try to catch up to Yakumo, but rather than catching up, Yakumo's back was just getting farther away .

Before he noticed, Yakumo had already entered the premises of the water gate management office .

Even though he doesn't look like he exercises normally –

Gotou gasped for air .

Even though Gotou used to be able to run faster, he was already getting old . The moment he thought that, his feet got tangled and he fell forward .

He tried to get up immediately afterwards, but his knees buckled and wouldn't move the way he wanted them to .

'Damn it!'

This wasn't a joke . He had a backbone .

Gotou pushed against his thighs with his fists and forced himself up .

He took a deep breath and started running again before he let it out .

'Please . Be safe,' Gotou murmured .

That contrary Yakumo had changed so much . If anything happened to Haruka-chan, he would revert to how he was before .

Gotou wouldn't let that happen .

– Why did you save me?

Words that Yakumo had said to him before came up in the back of his mind .

He might have wanted to die, but I saved him . I didn't leave him alone .

That's why I'm going to make sure Yakumo walks a proper path .

That's my responsibility, since I saved him from being killed by his mother
–

Gotou urged his feet to run faster .

* * *

Ishii had forcibly pulled his car to the side and stopped it on the bridge .

Honks came from behind him .

It wasn't acceptable to stop a car in the middle of a traffic jam like this .

However, a person's life was at stake . On top of that, it was Haruka-chan's
—

He didn't have the time to look for a parking spot .

I'll save her . No matter what, I'll save Haruka-chan .

He muttered that countless times to himself in his mind .

Ishii ran through the gaps between cars and turned left once he crossed the bridge to enter the road by the embankment .

Even he thought it was a reckless choice .

But no matter how many times I'm called a fool or an idiot, I know what should take priority, and I also know that there are some times when a man has to act like a man .

She won't die from something like this .

If something happened to make her die, I – I would –

It was no good . He couldn't think about awful things like that .

Run, Ishii Yuutarou .

Do your best, Ishii Yuutarou .

Ishii encouraged himself and just sprinted determinedly –

* * *

An iron shackle was clamped to Haruka's right ankle .

A chain went through that iron shackle . On one end of that chain, there was a concrete block, and on the other end, there was a hook on an iron railing about as tall as her waist .

Haruka didn't understand what Doctor Kinoshita was trying to do .

Like he had finished his preparations, Kinoshita grabbed Haruka's arm and tried to force her to stand up, but it didn't go well and both of them fell to the iron floor .

Clang!

It made a piercing noise .

She didn't feel much pain, which might have been because her senses were dulled .

'Damn it . '

Kinoshita cursed and tried to force Haruka to stand up again .

This time, he wasn't pulling her up but pushing her up .

Somehow, Kinoshita managed to make Haruka stand up, and he picked her up and sat her on the iron railing .

Now, Haruka understood what Kinoshita was trying to do .

Though Kinoshita was holding her up now, if he let go, Haruka would fall headlong into the river . The concrete block was probably a weight to sink Haruka's body .

I'm going to be killed . That realisation filled Haruka's head .

Mum, I'm sorry . It looks like I'm going to die too –

Even though I finally found out your true feelings –

Even though there are so many things I want to talk about and do still –

Yakumo will probably be angry . He'll say something like 'It's because you just went and did what you wanted' .

I want to meet him once more –

Then I want to talk to him properly .

Even though I want to meet Yakumo without any trouble, it's always like this –

She hated it . She didn't want to die .

She didn't want to die without telling anybody anything .

She was going to live . She was going to live no matter what .

Haruka focussed her concentration on her numb hands and gripped the iron railing . She wouldn't let go . She would live and meet Yakumo once more .

She heard somebody's voice yelling . A voice she had heard before .

The hand Kinoshita had been holding her up with let go .

The wind was strong . Her body, jolted by the wind, was swaying .

She definitely wouldn't let go .

But then, Kinoshita heartlessly pushed against Haruka's body with both of his hands .

No matter how strong her thoughts were, they were powerless in the face of reality . Haruka's hands let go of the railing and she fell headlong towards the river ten metres below .

While she was falling, she saw Yakumo running towards her .

But that has to be an illusion –

The next moment, her body hit the water .

* * *

After Gotou entered the premises of the water gate management office, he saw Yakumo standing still . His shoulders moved with his breathing .

'Oi, Yakumo! What are you doing!? If you don't hurry...'

Gotou's words got caught in his throat .

He saw the figure at Yakumo's feet . It couldn't be . Were they already too late?

'It can't be...'

'You're wrong . '

Wrong? Is that right –

Gotou peered at the figure collapsed at Yakumo's feet .

There was a middle-aged man . Blood was flowing from his head, and his white fleece jacket was dyed red .

That's bad –

'He's alive . He's just lost consciousness,' said Yakumo, addressing Gotou's concerns .

Almost as if he were proving those words, the man let out a groan .

If he was alive, Gotou was sorry, but he was just going to leave him for now .

Clang!

There was the sound of something hitting something else .

There was somebody on the control tower across the iron bridge that stretched out from the management office .

That's where she is!

Just as Gotou thought that, Yakumo had already started running .

Gotou ran after him .

The iron bridge's entrance was open, though it should have been locked .

They ran down the road which was wide enough for one .

Gotou saw someone near the control tower's iron railing beyond Yakumo's back .

That was it!

'Wait!'

Gotou yelled, but it was too late .

The person he saw fell towards the river –

Damn . Where? Where did she fall?

While Gotou was thinking, Yakumo used the iron railing as a springboard and dived into the river with no hesitation .

'You idiot!'

Gotou stopped in his tracks and leaned over the railing as he yelled, but it was too late .

Yakumo landed cleanly in the water, headfirst, and started swimming .
Yakumo was probably only in such a rush because the one who had fallen was Haruka-chan . All that remained was –

'Kinoshitaaa!'

Gotou yelled as he charged towards Kinoshita in the control tower like a raging bull .

Kinoshita's face was stiff with shock .

It appeared that he hadn't expected them to show up .

Gotou lowered his centre of gravity and tackled Kinoshita, aiming at his solar plexus .

'Uaargh!'

Kinoshita turned a somersault and hit the railing as he fell .

'You idiot!'

Gotou hit Kinoshita's face forcefully .

It sounded like bamboo breaking . He might have broken his nose .
Suddenly, Kinoshita's mouth was bloody .

Somehow, hitting Kinoshita hurt Gotou .

He was different from the usual culprit . What he had done was the worst,
but he loved his daughter from the bottom of his heart .

He lost the one he loved to a murder . The one who caused those
circumstances was a madman like Andou .

He could also be a victim .

But still, he could never be forgiven .

I know that . I know that, but –

Gotou turned his anger with no outlet towards the railing and kicked it as
hard as he could . He would think later . He had to do something about
Yakumo and Haruka-chan in the river first .

Gotou leant over the railing and called out .

'Oi! You two OK?'

* * *

Exposed to the cold water, Haruka's senses suddenly awoke .

Her heart felt like it was being crushed . Her skin stung with pain .

She tried to float up, but her body wouldn't move the way she wanted it to .

Dragged down by the weight on her right ankle, her body was going deeper and deeper into the water –

Into the pitch-black water –

I want to live .

With that frantic thought, Haruka thrust her hands upwards, but her fingertips couldn't feel open air .

It might already be too late .

The moment she thought that, she lost her strength .

I'm just going to sink in this dark water –

The moment she accepted that, somebody grabbed her wrist .

Then, she was pulled out forcefully .

It was slow, but her body started floating up .

Who? Who is it –

Finally, her head came out of the water .

She choked on the air rushing into her lungs all at once .

'You're alive . '

That voice is Yakumo's –

Yakumo was trying to carry her body with only his right arm .

It was impossible . If he continued like this, it wouldn't just be Haruka – Yakumo would die as well .

'Oi! You two! Are you OK?'

A familiar loud voice reached her eyes .

She saw somebody peering down at them from the top of the control tower .

It was dark so she couldn't see his face clearly, but it was probably Gotou-san .

'Gotou-san! Please pull up the chain!'

After Yakumo yelled, he wrapped the chain around his left arm and tightly gripped it .

'Got it . Wait . '

Gotou took the hook off of the railing .

'OK – hold on tight,' Yakumo said .

She wanted to, but there was no strength in her arm .

'OK? I'm going to pull it up!'

Gotou started pulling up the chain .

At the same time, Yakumo went up the iron ladder step by step . The chains were digging into Yakumo's arm .

'Sorry...'

Even though he was always complaining, he didn't mind throwing away his life .

For someone like me –

'You're noisy . Be quiet and hold on . '

As expected, he had a complaint .

'You OK?'

Gotou leant over to shout .

When she looked up, she saw a figure standing behind Gotou .

'Gotou-san – behind you!'

Haruka's voice didn't reach Gotou .

Kinoshita struck Gotou's head with an iron pipe .

'Agh!'

Gotou fell and disappeared from her vision .

Then, the chain fell from his hand .

Haruka and Yakumo both fell –

But they didn't sink into the water .

Yakumo, with the chain still wrapped around his arm, held on to the ladder, and his face was just barely above the water .

'Yakumo-kun, forget about me – let go of my hand...' Haruka pleaded .

'You're annoying . '

That was Yakumo's reply .

Why?

If he let go, at least you'll be saved .

I'm begging you – please let go . If you don't, I'll –

She couldn't say any more .

She was at the limits of her strength .

Despite Haruka's wish, the hand that Yakumo had been using to grip onto the ladder let go –

* * *

Ishii finally reached the parking lot for the water gate management office .

He didn't see Gotou or Yakumo anyway . Where on earth did they disappear to?

Before he arrived, he had twice heard the sound of something loud falling into the water .

It couldn't be –

He looked around restlessly .

Suddenly, a man with blood covering his head appeared in front of Ishii's eyes .

'Ack!'

Ishii let out a shriek in surprise mixed with fear .

The man sat down there while holding his head .

'Are you OK?'

Ishii knelt down and looked at the man's face .

'I'm fine, but somebody has to save the girl over there...'

The man pointed at the control tower that was connected to the bridge while bearing with the pain .

So that was where Haruka-chan was .

'I will come back later . '

After Ishii said that, he ran towards the control tower .

'Uaargh!'

Just as he had started crossing the bridge, he heard a shout . He saw two people .

One was lying still against the railing .

The other leant over the railing and yelled, 'Are you OK?'

That voice . It's Detective Gotou . Then the person collapsed there is Doctor Kinoshita –

Gotou took the chain that had been hooked to the railing and started pulling it up . Then there was a large movement behind him .

'Detective Gotou! Behind you!'

The call had been a step too late .

Kinoshita hit Gotou's head with the iron pipe .

Gotou fell forward and let go of the chain .

'Ooooh!'

Do your best, Ishii Yuutarou! You're a man! While Ishii let out a yell, he charged into Kinoshita, who was holding the pipe .

Kinoshita's pipe turned towards Ishii .

He was just about to be hit when he avoided it by rolling to the side .

'Ishii, the chain . Yakumo and Haruka-chan are on the other end . '

Gotou spoke up . His ear was covered in blood, and he was collapsed on the ground .

Haruka-chan! Ishii instinctively grabbed the chain, wrapped it around his arm and pulled at it with all his strength .

The next moment, a sharp pain ran through his shoulders . Next, it was his back . Then, his side . His arm . Kinoshita was striking his entire body with the pipe .

'Don't get in my way! Don't get in my way! Don't get in my way!'

Kinoshita is yelling . As if I could let go . I definitely won't let go .

Haruka-chan is on the other end . If I let go, Haruka-chan will –

Ishii gritted his teeth and bore the pain .

Kinoshita raised the pipe, aiming for Ishii's head .

Aah, he was going to die! But he wouldn't let go . Ishii shut his eyes to await the impact .

'Don't get too carried away, you idiot!'

Gotou's voice . The sound of something hitting bone . Then, the pipe fell together with Kinoshita to the floor .

'You can let go . I'll pull . '

Gotou took over holding the chain for Ishii .

Ishii suddenly lost all his strength and collapsed right there .

'You've got some guts for a guy in charge of playing the fool,' Gotou muttered .

'I'm sorry I couldn't be of help...'

'No, you did good . '

He was struck with awe . Detective Gotou had praised him . Life was worth living –

'Thank you... very... mu...'

Ah, but he might die –

Like that, he lost consciousness .

18

Gotou's ear was covered in blood . He was sitting on the railing .

Blood was dripping from Kinoshita's nose, dyeing his face red, and he just sat in a stupor .

Ishii was collapsed on the ground, face-down and unmoving .

In the water, Yakumo and Haruka, were in a strange situation where they could see everything clearly .

'Why... are you getting in my way...'

Kinoshita spoke with a hoarse voice .

'Get in your way? That's not it . Your experiment will not succeed no matter how many times you try . I came to tell you that . '

Yakumo stood in front of Kinoshita .

'That's not true . I will definitely bring my daughter back from the dead . '

'By transplanting your daughter's soul into another body?'

'Yes . '

'I will also acknowledge the existence of the soul . There are also cases where those souls will possess other people . In order to resurrect your daughter, you decided to abduct girls and drown them in the water, waiting for your daughter to possess them, but this method will definitely not bring your daughter back from the dead . '

'That's a lie!'

Kinoshita yelled with a shaking voice . It was probably impossible for him to just agree and say, 'Yes, that's true . '

Yakumo started his explanation calmly .

'There are two reasons . The first is that souls and bodies cannot be easily replaced . You should understand this as a doctor . It is the same with organ transplants, is it not? The more complex the construction, the fewer the compatible donors there are due to organ rejection . I acknowledge that a soul is like a cluster of a person's thoughts and emotions . Accordingly, the organ of the body which governs that is the most complex one in the human body – the brain . There isn't anybody who can be a compatible donor . '

'I won't give up until a body that is compatible appears . '

Kinoshita looked up at Yakumo to glare .

'How many billions of people do you plan to kill?'

Yakumo stood face-to-face with Kinoshita and met his eyes .

His red left eye with the contact lens out looked like it was aflame .

'There is one more reason . Even if transplanting souls were possible, this method won't work . '

'This method?'

Kinoshita's blood-smeared lips frowned .

'Please think about it calmly . Using this method kills the previous body . '

That was right . It was just as Yakumo said . Even if it was possible to transplant souls, the body it was transplanted to had drowned .

'I...'

Kinoshita started speaking, but in the end, he didn't finish .

'You have lost the ability to make decisions calmly . What you have done is simply murder . '

Kinoshita's eyes opened wide .

The muscles in his face were twitching . Kinoshita had realised . What he had done was meaningless –

'I sympathise with your circumstances . However, by no means will you be forgiven . You know how it feels to lose a child . You have increased the number of people who are burdened with the same suffering and sadness that you are . You ended the lives of children who had futures like your daughter did . '

People were so foolish –

Haruka found it harder to breathe . Kinoshita's actions were based on the deep love he had for his child . That love had been so deep that he thought lightly of others' lives .

To the onlooker, it just seemed mad, but –

'Why did you go so far? You should have had many chances to stop . '

Yakumo looked like he was holding back his anger .

What on earth was that anger directed towards?

'Yakumo-kun . This isn't a reason... Not everyone is as strong as you . Even if they know it in their head, their emotions won't yield...' said Kinoshita slowly, gazing at Yakumo .

For a while, Yakumo looked back at him, like he was a mirror reflecting Kinoshita's gaze, but he finally stood up .

'Ignoring whether I am a strong person or not, saying that someone's emotions won't yield even if they know something in their head? Do you think you can use that as an excuse? If you can be forgiven like that, shall I also forgive Andou, who killed your daughter because of emotions that couldn't be controlled by reason?'

Dumbfounded, Kinoshita just stared up at Yakumo .

Those eyes were flickering wildly .

It was just as Yakumo said . Doctor Kinoshita had probably been so sad that he had forgotten that people besides him also had emotions . And then that arrogance drove him mad –

Kinoshita finally cocked his head silently .

His shoulders were shaking . Not just his shoulders . His whole body was shaking like electricity was running through it .

He had probably realised now . The weight of the crimes he committed –

'Ayaka... Dad... couldn't save you... Sorry...'

Kinoshita spoke with a constricted voice .

His words stopped together with his shaking . Something fell from Doctor Kinoshita's shoulders .

This person couldn't say that one thing and continued to blame and corner himself . It was too late now already –

Yakumo put a finger to his brow .

'Doctor Kinoshita . Your daughter has come . '

Kinoshita looked up at Yakumo's words .

His eyes went wide .

Crying loudly, Kinoshita thrust his two arms forwards .

That doglike howl was full of sadness that was so deep there was no end to it .

Haruka could also see Ayaka-chan standing there .

She had a ponytail and she smiled with dimples on her cheeks . It was a very gentle smile .

Like it was announcing the conclusion of the case, there was the sound of a distant ambulance's siren .

Doctor Kinoshita's crime wouldn't be forgiven, but his daughter Ayaka-chan alone might forgive him .

If she told Yakumo this, he'd probably get angry and say she was too naive, but Haruka still wanted to think this .

Even if it's just a little, I want to find redemption .

Since people are sentimental and selfish creatures –

NOTES:

[1] Noh is a traditional form of Japanese musical drama which has very characteristic masks for different roles . HERE is an example of the masks in use .

[2] It really exists -THIS is its homepage .

Volume 2 Chapter 4: Epilogue

VOLUME 2 - THAT WHICH CONNECTS SOULS epilogue ()

One week later –

Haruka headed for the prefabricated building in the back of Building B.

She had really wanted to show her face sooner, but she hadn't been able to. She had been hospitalised.

Though she was only hospitalised for three days, her mother had rushed over from home and shut Haruka in her room to force her to rest.

This morning, her mother finally returned home.

Haruka had talked a lot with her mother for the first time in a long, long time.

More than half of what they talked about was stories from when her older sister was alive. The time at home after that had been halted without her knowing it.

Laughing, crying and getting angry from the bottom of my heart. I haven't done that in a while.

I feel like I always live while holding myself back because of my sister.

I've noticed something from this case.

Like with Doctor Kinoshita, blaming myself for my sister's death has tied her down –

But even if I know that, I can't stop blaming myself.

I will always regret my sister's death, but I think I can look forward, little by little.

I'll try to live more as myself.

Well, it's easier said than done –

She stood in front of the door with the plate <Movie Research Circle> on it.

Still, Yakumo didn't come to visit her at the hospital even once. Even though she had kind of been hoping for it.

Though it might have just become troublesome since he would have suddenly run into her mother.

Plus, she would have felt uncomfortable for making him worry.

Ah, but maybe she could just make one complaint.

'Yakumo-kun. Are you here?' said Haruka, opening the door.

He was here. His hair looked mussed up from sleep as usual. Even though it was the first time they had seen each other in a while, he replied half-heartedly, 'Oh, it's you?' Honestly, this person.

'Hey, are you going out?'

Yakumo was dressed for something.

'Good timing. Are you going too?' asked Yakumo with a yawn.

What did he mean, going –

'Where to?'

'To check on Ishii-san.'

'When you say Ishii-san, do you mean that Ishii-san?'

'Yes. That Ishii-san.'

'Is he injured?'

When she was saved, Ishii had been collapsed faced down and wasn't moving, as if he had died.

'It's not at the level of "injured". His upper left arm, his right clavicle and three ribs on top of that are fractured. He is seriously wounded from the full-body beating.'

'Is it that awful?'

I didn't know –

'At the time, Ishii-san was the one who held us up with the chain we were on, in Gotou-san's stead, since he was attacked. Ishii-san didn't let go even when Doctor Kinoshita was hitting him with an iron pipe.'

Even though they had only met a few times, Ishii had only left a vaguely weak impression.

That Ishii did –

'In a manner of speaking, Ishii-san saved our lives.'

Haruka nodded. She hadn't known that was what happened at all. He had protected them with his body.

'I really wanted to go sooner as well, but there were a variety of things I needed to look into.'

Though Haruka had just arrived, she left the room together with Yakumo.

* * *

Hata fled from his room to the autopsy room.

Nobody would come here. He couldn't stand the noise.

It was the same with the questions from the guys in investigation who couldn't wrap up the case, but even though it was a week since the case ended, the press was only growing more energetic, to say nothing of dying down.

Doctor Kinoshita's madness –

Society was making a fuss about it, but how much of its true nature did they grasp?

Hata understood the idea behind Kinoshita's actions well. He might have done the same thing. Though Kinoshita chose the wrong method, Hata still thought he had been composed.

Hata sat on the chair by the wall.

In any case, a long trial was going to start.

It would probably be torture for Kinoshita. He would have to calmly look at what he had done. It was too harsh a reality to sum up by calling it an infraction of the law.

Will he be able to bear it in the end –

No, he would have to. That was the only path left for him.

He would have to atone for his crimes for the rest of his life. It seemed that there were some people who were worried that Kinoshita might commit suicide, but Hata wasn't concerned.

Naturally, for somebody who believed the soul existed, the death of the body wouldn't bring respite or an end.

Death wasn't a place to escape to.

Humans, who existed to live and to die, had to think about something.

Having a soul meant that dying wasn't the end.

Still, I'm interested in that man with the sunglasses –

In this case as well, it was like the man had not even existed.

What on earth was that man's goal? Yakumo had said it was an experiment, but Hata couldn't help but think there was something more –

* * *

Before we go to the hospital where Ishii-san is, there's somewhere I have to go first.

The place they arrived at after Yakumo said that to Haruka was the water gate management office.

'It's you two. What is it?'

Just as they reached the parking lot, Uchiyama called out to them from inside the office. A bandage was wrapped around his head – an injury from the case.

Haruka had heard from Yakumo on the way here that Uchiyama had been hit in the head by Kinoshita with a block.

Uchiyama had to be confused right now, with the death of the girl he had loved as a daughter and the incident that girl's father – his friend, Doctor Kinoshita – caused.

Haruka thought that his heart might be more hurt than his head was.

'Uchiyama-san, I have a little business with you,' Yakumo said, his expression blank.

Haruka felt the atmosphere change alarmingly then. Uchiyama also felt it. The friendly smile quickly disappeared from his face.

Yakumo entered the management office silently.

Though Haruka didn't understand, she followed after him.

'Business with me, you say?'

Uchiyama urged Yakumo to sit across from him.

'No, I don't mind standing.'

With his hands in his pockets, Yakumo stood in front of Uchiyama. Haruka, who felt nervous because of the strange atmosphere, stopped a step behind the two of them.

'So, what is it?' Uchiyama asked.

'I will say this first. What I say after this is all my conjecture, with no proof to it at all.'

Though Yakumo said it was conjecture, he spoke with clear purpose.

'What is it?'

Uchiyama spoke cautiously.

'I will go right to the point. Uchiyama-san, I think that you killed Andou-san.'

Wait – what's he saying all of a sudden?

Haruka could only be shocked by Yakumo's unexpected outburst. She thought that Uchiyama would have felt the same, but she was wrong –

Rather than looking perturbed, there was a smile on his face.

'What are you saying? I don't understand what you mean.'

'I mean exactly what I said. Even after Doctor Kinoshita was arrested, there were still many things in my head that I did not understand, so I started my investigation anew.'

'What did you find out?'

Uchiyama took a cigarette from his shirt pocket and lit it up.

He was playing the fool. That was what Haruka felt.

'One: Andou's accidental death. According to the eyewitness' testimonies, he staggered into the pedestrian crossing with a red light. He had not been drunk. He had not been chased by anyone. Then why would Andou have rushed out into the intersection?'

'Who knows? I don't understand either.'

Uchiyama spread his arms wide and shook his head in an exaggerated manner.

'I found your name in the list of eyewitnesses. Don't you think that is too much of a coincidence?'

'Well, I was there. It's an amazing coincidence. But how would that make me Andou's killer?'

Uchiyama's smile made the corner of his eyes wrinkle, like he thought what Yakumo was saying was stupid.

'You chose a good time to push Andou-san from behind.'

'Why would I do something like that? There's no reason for me to, right?'

He was right. It was just as Uchiyama-san said.

There was no reason for him to kill Andou. What was Yakumo thinking, saying something with no basis for it?

'No, you do have a reason. Andou-san was the murderer who killed Ayaka-chan.'

'Are you saying that I knew the murderer?'

'I am.'

Yakumo replied immediately to Uchiyama's question with no change in his expression.

'You have a lot of confidence about something you said was just conjecture.'

'I have looked at the materials from that case many times. Ayaka-chan was killed at the water gate upstream from here. However, she was found at this water gate. Why do you think that is the case?'

'Isn't that... because she was carried here by the current?'

Uchiyama looked up at the ceiling and answered after a bit of thinking.

His voice sounded like it was trembling.

'No, that isn't right. If she had been carried by the current, Ayaka-chan's corpse should have had numerous injuries on it. However, there weren't any. Ayaka-chan was killed at the old water gate and then disposed of here in order to hide Andou's hideaway.'

'I see; so that's how it is... But how is that connected to my apparently knowing the murderer?'

Uchiyama restlessly spat out his cigarette.

'It is connected. When Ayaka-chan was disposed of here, she was submerged with a weight attached to her ankle.'

'And what about it?'

'She was submerged in the river. If you didn't see her corpse being disposed of, you wouldn't have been able to find her corpse so quickly.'

'You have an amazing imagination.'

Uchiyama nodded multiple times, like he thought it admirable.

However, it just looked like an act to Haruka.

'From a little ways away, you saw someone disposing of something in the river by chance. When you went to look, Ayaka-chan's corpse was there. At that time, you saw the murderer's face, or perhaps you looked for Andou by care. Naturally, you didn't say any of this to the police, so that you could find the murderer yourself and have your revenge...'

Uchiyama started laughing aloud.

'That is quite the masterpiece. You're amazing. Detective Columbo[1] would be white as a sheet. That said, the world would be a mess if everyone went to get revenge when their friends' children were killed.'

'Yes. That is, if she was just the daughter of a friend to you...'

Yakumo took a pause there.

The two of them looked at each other without saying anything. The first to look away was Uchiyama.

'There's something I planned on returning to you today.'

Like he had been waiting for this moment, Yakumo took a black notebook from his pocket and handed it to Uchiyama.

'T-this is...'

Uchiyama's expression changed completely.

'This is something you dropped at the river when we met you before.'

There had been two photos inside. One of them had been of Ayaka-chan. The other had been of Uchiyama and another woman.

'I conducted a little investigation. The woman in this photo with you is Doctor Kinoshita's dead wife. Ayaka-chan's mother.'

Gripping the notebook tightly, Uchiyama said nothing.

'Before she married Doctor Kinoshita, it seems she was acquainted with you. I don't know if something happened between the two of you, and I have no plans on investigating that far. However, I believe that carrying such an old photo with you even now is evidence that your feelings towards Ayaka-chan are greater than those one would have towards a friend's daughter.'

Uchiyama made no reply.

However, the silence was the same as affirming Yakumo's theory.

'Why did you think I was suspicious?'

After a silence, Uchiyama spoke.

'The first time I met you, you said this. "I couldn't forgive the person who did that." You spoke like everything was already over...'

'I see... But even if that's true, what you're saying is just conjecture.'

'It is as you say. This is all my conjecture. I have no physical proof,' said Yakumo plainly.

'The police?'

'I haven't told them this. I probably won't tell them anything about this case in the future either. It's up to you what to do next.'

So Yakumo had come here just to do this. Haruka didn't understand his intentions.

Uchiyama furrowed his brows, looking troubled, like he felt the same way as Haruka.

'However, please just don't forget that somebody else has taken the blame for killing Andou in a driving accident,' Yakumo said, sounding like he was completely at ease.

Finally, Haruka could also see Yakumo's intentions.

Though it was certainly up to Uchiyama what to do next, his choice would greatly change what would happen to the driver of the car that caused the accident.

Don't involve other people in your revenge –

That was probably what Yakumo indirectly wanted to say.

'We're going.'

Yakumo said that and promptly left the management office.

'Eh? Wait a second.'

Haruka followed Yakumo out the management office, escaping the suffocating atmosphere inside.

When she turned around in the middle of leaving, she saw Uchiyama hanging his head.

What choice will he make? It's not something I'll find out by thinking about it.

I hoped in my heart that he would make the nice choice.

But which choice is the right one –

* * *

Ishii was on the bed, contemplating the case.

He had a lot of time. He had thought it over a hundred times already, but he still didn't know.

How could this case have been averted –

There was a knock on the door, interrupting his thoughts.

'Please come in.'

After Ishii spoke up, a large bear-like figure came in.

It's Detective Gotou. I'm honoured. Detective Gotou came to visit me –

'Sorry. I really wanted to come earlier, but there was a lot of paperwork to do to wrap up the case.'

Gotou scratched his bristly chin awkwardly.

That was to be expected.

The case time had been solved completely separate from the investigation department.

The information was complicated, so everyone was probably in a great turmoil.

Gotou sighed loudly and sat on the round chair by the bed. There were shadows under his eyes, his shirt was slightly soiled, and his hair was messed up. He probably hadn't slept –

'Oh – even you have someone who'll bring you flowers?'

Gotou looked at the vase with a flower in it by the bed.

'No, that's not it. The chief's daughter came to visit me.'

'Oh, you're pretty good,' Gotou said, poking fun at him.

'Please stop. To be honest, I'm troubled since she comes every day.'

On top of that, the fear towards her still hadn't left his heart.

She hadn't done anything wrong, but despite that, every time he looked at her face, the terrible memory from when she had been possessed came back to him.

'That's great. You're definitely headed for a promotion.'

'Please give me a break. It means much more to me to have you come visit, Detective Gotou.'

When Ishii candidly shared his emotions, Gotou looked openly disagreeable.

What does he dislike so much?

So I have made him hate me –

'Hey, Ishii, I'm just going to say this, but I'm not gay.'

'Yes, I know.'

What was he saying all of a sudden?

If Detective Gotou were gay – Ishii felt bad for thinking this, but he would have found it disagreeable.

'So... I mean... you're a man too...'

'What is it you want to say?'

Gotou cleared his throat awkwardly.

'In short, I'm telling you to shape up as a man.'

'That was my plan from the beginning. I want to become a manly detective such as yourself, Detective Gotou.'

'Eh? You're not gay?'

'By no means. That isn't true at all. There is even a woman in my heart.'

Ishii didn't understand the point of Gotou's question.

'That Yakumo...' Gotou muttered with gritted teeth.

Yakumo. That mysterious young man –

'Detective Gotou, there's just one thing I would like to ask, but who is that young man called Yakumo?'

Gotou looked puzzled at Ishii's question.

Even if he looked like that, Ishii wouldn't understand the things he didn't understand.

'Oh, I didn't say anything to you. His left eye can see the spirits of the dead.'

'Eh!? Really?' Ishii exclaimed in surprise.

He put too much strength in it, so a current of pain ran through his body.

'You're so noisy.'

'Is that true?'

'It's true. I wouldn't drag him along to investigate civilians if it weren't.'

Gotou's words made sense. After he said that, the things Ishii hadn't understood before started lining up.

But that would mean –

'Forgive me for asking something so impolite, but aren't you the psychic detective, Detective Gotou?'

'That stupid – you're talking about that again!? I said you were wrong from the very start!' yelled Gotou, crossing his arms.

'Then, this case...'

'Not just this case – the one before this one and the one before that – Yakumo was the one who solved all of them.'

'T-that's...'

'That's what I said from the very start. I didn't do anything.'

Something shattered inside Ishii.

Ah, what is this –

What would he do from now on? He was tearing up.

'Ah, right, right. Come to think of it, that Yakumo and Haruka-chan said they were coming to visit.'

'Eh? Haruka-chan is!?'

Ishii was assaulted by pain the moment he shouted.

Haruka-chan was coming to visit. That blew away the shock.

Gotou's eyes narrowed as he smirked.

'Oi, Ishii. You mentioned that you had a woman in your heart early – were you talking about Haruka-chan?'

'Eh? No, that's... but... er...'

When Gotou suddenly cut straight to the point, Ishii became flustered.

He wasn't used to things like this.

'I see, I see. This'll be interesting.'

'What will be interesting?'

'Got this, Ishii? In order to catch Haruka-chan, you'll need to defeat a ridiculously formidable enemy.'

'A formidable enemy?'

'Yes. Yakumo.'

As I thought, that young man –

He would never accept that. He couldn't forgive that young man's attitude towards Haruka-chan. He couldn't stand watching Haruka-chan being treated that way.

She seemed pitiful like that.

'Ishii. I'll help you out.'

'Really?'

'Yeah, leave it to me.'

Gotou said that reassuringly and smirked again.

* * *

After leaving the water gate management office, they walked along the road by the irrigation channel that led to the hospital.

It had become so warm it couldn't be compared to a week ago.

Along the irrigation channel, the cherry blossoms were in full bloom.

Countless pink petals were floating on the surface of the water –

'It's beautiful.'

She stopped walking to look up at the cherry blossoms.

Yakumo, who had been walking beside her, also stopped and looked up the cherry blossom tree, like he had just noticed it.

That brusque, contrary young man with sleepy eyes who wasn't kind at all showed a side of himself that was different from usual at the water gate.

When I was in danger, he came to save me without any hesitation.

His left hand is still red from where the chain dug into it.

Proof that he held on to my life –

'Let's go.'

Yakumo started walking while still looking up at the cherry blossoms.

Haruka followed him and, for only a moment, she nonchalantly brushed the mark from the chain with the back of her hand.

– Thank you.

She murmured that in her heart.

If she said it aloud, he would definitely say something to ruin it, like 'It's not like I did it for you'.

This contrary man!

'Hey, wait.'

When he turned around at her voice, a boy of about elementary-school age ran towards him.

The boy ran around Yakumo and handed him a folded-up scrap of paper and necklace.

'An uncle with black glasses told me to give this to you.'

Yakumo looked dubiously at the folded-up scrap of paper and necklace that had been placed in his palm.

The necklace looked like it belonged to a woman, a simple one that just has a round stone on a thin chain.

That stone glowed red like a blazing flame, just like Yakumo's left eye.

'I gave it to you then,' said the boy, and then he ran off.

Yakumo unfolded the scrap of paper and looked over what was written on it.

At that moment, his expression changed.

He frantically looked around, but he finally let out his breath, like he had given up.

What was written on the page? She felt bad about it even as she did it, but she stole a look at the scrap of paper from the side.

There was only one sentence written on it –

Before too long, again...

Haruka would finally come to know the dreadful meaning of these words –

[1] Columbo is an American detective mystery television series which is special in that the perpetrator is revealed to the viewer at the beginning. has it.

Volume 3 Chapter 0: Prologue

VOLUME 3 - THE LIGHT BEYOND THE DARKNESS prologue

It was a quiet night.

Ozawa Keiko was driving.

The dark forest road turned and twisted with trees on both sides but not even one lamppost.

Though it was the shortest route home, she always tried not to take it since it was spooky.

However, today was different. She had to return home as quickly as she could to share the news.

Keiko put her hand on her belly. Though there was no bump now, new life dwelled within this belly.

This happiness she had never tasted before was far more exalting than she had imagined.

Her husband Kazuhiro would probably cry.

When Keiko glanced forward, a tree by the road shook with a rustle, and a dark shadow jumped out onto the road.

A person –

Keiko automatically stepped on the brakes.

The car stopped suddenly with an ear-splitting screech from the brakes and white smoke from the tires.

Though it had been an automatic reaction, the car did not hit anything.

– It's fine.

Keiko said that to herself, opened the door with a shaking hand and stepped out. She saw that someone had fallen, illuminated by the headlights.

There was a woman with long hair lying face down about five metres from the car.

'Are you OK?'

Keiko rushed over.

'Please hang in there.'

Keiko put her arms around the woman who was facedown and helped her up.

Her skin was incredibly pale. The bridge of her nose was pencil-straight. The woman was shockingly beautiful.

The hem of the skirt she was wearing was torn, and her shirt was also smeared with mud.

That wasn't all. The woman wasn't wearing shoes. Her bare feet were covered with dirt, and they were grazed all over.

She ran on a mountain road in her bare feet?

Why –

'Are you OK?'

Though Keiko had some doubts, she spoke to the woman once more.

The woman twisted her body in a way that looked painful and moaned.

She was alive.

'Please hang on. I will bring you to a hospital immediately.'

The woman slowly opened her eyes, like she was responding to Keiko's words. Though she was beautiful, she didn't feel alive. Her eyes looked like they belonged to a doll.

'... Save me... that man is coming...'

The woman's lips moved.

— That man?

'What happened?'

At Keiko's questions, the woman opened her eyes wide and distorted her face. She clung on to Keiko.

'That man...'

Her fingernails dug in as she spoke with a hoarse voice.

'That man?'

'I have to run, I have to run, I have to run...'

The woman's body was shaking in fear as she said the same thing over and over.

'Calm down. Please calm down.'

Keiko embraced the woman tightly.

'I have to run... That man...'

The woman stopped speaking and suddenly fainted.

Rustle.

Keiko looked in front at the sound of a shaking tree.

A man stood on the road, lit up by the car's headlights.

He wore a black suit and dark sunglasses, even though he was on a mountain in the night.

Gooseflesh rose all over Keiko's skin.

This woman was probably running away from this man. It was not a thought. She felt that instinctually.

It's dangerous. I have to run –

Though Keiko thought that, she couldn't move, like she had been caught in the man's gaze.

Sweat ran down her brow.

– The true nature of the human soul is darkness.

When the man said that lazily, the corners of his lips turned up.

– That woman's child proves that.

After the man said that, he slowly took off his glasses.

Both of his eyes glowed bright red like a blazing flame.

* * *

It was a sweltering night –

She was walking on the road that led to her apartment.

Because of the heat and the humidity, her back was moist with sweat. She wanted to return home quickly to take a shower. She naturally quickened

her pace.

A tepid wind blew.

Just as she reached the apartment's courtyard, she suddenly stopped.

– Hey. Why?

She could hear someone whispering in the wind.

Where?

She looked for the source of the voice.

'Ah.'

Her voice just came out. She could see a figure on the rooftop of the seven-storey apartment.

Because it was dark, she couldn't clearly see their appearance, but they were definitely human.

Why is there someone there – she thought, and at the same time, that figure fell.

She was so shocked she could not even scream.

The figure, who had become a dark mass, made a dull thump as they hit the asphalt, pulled down by gravity.

The vibration that shook her feet turned into horror and ran up her body.

The person who fell was a woman with long hair.

The woman's arms and legs were bent at unnatural angles, and her head had sunken into the asphalt. A large amount of blood was coming out.

It was obvious that the woman was no longer alive.

– Why...

A voice reached her ears in her silent shock.

A low, growling voice.

She felt a freezing chill. She had a bad feeling.

– Why... I...

The voice continued.

'Noo!'

She held her breath and stepped back.

She knew whose voice had spoken.

The twisted arms and legs of the woman who had fallen started moving.

Though the woman had fallen from the top of the apartment, she slowly stood up, like a new-born foal.

'No way!'

It was impossible. She shook her head frantically to deny what was happening in front of her eyes, but the reality in front of her did not disappear.

The woman who had stood up let her arms hang languidly, and dragged her feet as she started walking with unnatural, zombie-like movements towards the apartment's entrance.

– Why, why, why...

The woman kept on muttering the same words.

Finally, the woman disappeared through the apartment's entrance.

Her thighs were shaking, and she sat down with a thump right there.
Released from her unimaginable fear, tears were spilling out of her eyes.

Her mind was completely blank, and she was at a complete loss for what to do next.

How much time passed?

Why...

She heard the woman's voice again.

– It can't be.

She looked up at the apartment.

There was a figure on the roof.

And then –

The woman fell again.

The blood splattered on to her cheek.

– Why...

The woman opened her mouth again and slowly stood up.

Her eyes met with the blood-stained woman.

Eyes that were so fathomlessly dark it was like they were tunnels to hell –

– Hey. Why can't I die?

The woman spat out blood as she spoke.

'Noo!'

Her scream cut through the summer night.

Volume 3 Chapter 1: VOLUME 3 - THE LIGHT BEYOND THE DARKNESS

Chapter 1

VOLUME 3 - THE LIGHT BEYOND THE DARKNESS

file 01: disappearance (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

Hijikata Makoto stopped the taxi in front of a multi-tenant building to see a small illuminated sign that read <Snake> .

Makoto paid and quickly descended the stairs to the basement .

It was already almost an hour past the appointed time . Her work always dragged on at times like this . Irritated, Makoto pushed open the heavy wooden door and entered the bar .

There were four table seats and a counter that could seat five . Using indirect lighting with blue as its premise, jazz played throughout the bar .

Though the place wasn't large, it had a good atmosphere .

Makoto looked around and soon found Asami, whom she had arranged to meet . She was smoking a slim cigarette at the table by the entrance .

‘Sorry I’m late...’

Makoto clapped Asami on the shoulder .

'You're too late . '

Asami pouted with her puffy lips .

It had been a while since they last met . Makoto felt that Asami had changed quite a lot . During university, Asami hadn't smoked, and she had had a stronger healthy impression . It might have been because of the makeup, but now it looked like there were shadows somewhere .

However, one thing that didn't change was her beauty .

'I'm really sorry . '

Makoto put her hands together as she asked for forgiveness .

'It's OK . It'd be a different matter if it was because of a man, but you had work, right?'

'Yup . Well . '

'It was your goal, right? Working at a newspaper agency . '

Makoto somehow managed to smile back, but she couldn't actually smile honestly . It'd be difficult to say that even though she was employed at a news agency, it had been because her father was the chief of police rather than because of her own aptitude .

'Anyway, it's really been a while . When'd we last see each other?'

Makoto changed the topic .

'Hm – university?'

Now that Asami said it, Makoto felt that was right . After graduating, Asami had returned to her home in Nagano and they hadn't met directly like this since, though they had sent emails and New Year's cards .

That would mean she hadn't seen Asami in three years .

'So the last time was at the graduation ceremony . '

'I didn't go to the ceremony, so...'

Asami's expression went a bit stiff . Makoto tried tracing back in her memory .

That was right . If she remembered correctly, Asami had taken a one-month break around graduation because her health had worsened, and then graduation had come . Makoto had asked something she shouldn't have .

'That's right . Sorry . '

'Don't worry about it,' Asami said nonchalantly . She put out the cigarette she had been smoking in the ashtray .

'So when'd you come here?'

'Last month . I transferred for work . '

'So that's how it was . Then we'll be able to meet up for drinks again . '

'I won't let you get away . '

Asami just smiled . The old Asami would have laughed aloud . People could change a lot in three years .

'Anyway, sit down . '

Asami urged Makoto to sit, but there were two men she didn't know in the opposite seats .

The first was in his early thirties and had a casual feel to him, wearing a beige jacket with jeans . The other was a young man in his early twenties with a hip-hop artist's fashion sense . They were a somewhat unbalanced pair .

'Good evening . '

The man in the jacket bowed his head politely . The young man in hip-hop fashion also nodded, following the older man .

Makoto sat next to Asami and touched her elbow to ask for an explanation .

'Ah, that's right . '

Asami started introducing everyone .

The man in the jacket was called Shinichi . He worked at an event planning company . The other younger man was Yuuya . He was Shinichi's pal and was in his third year of university . It seemed that he did part-time at Shinichi's event planning company .

Makoto also greeted the two of them simply .

'We got to know each other while waiting for you, Makoto . You don't mind if the two of them join us, right?'

'Not at all,' Makoto replied, though she was puzzled .

During university, Asami hadn't been the type to drink with men she didn't know who called out to her at a bar .

Since she wasn't a naive middle school student, it probably wasn't anything to worry about .

'What would you like to order?'

The long-haired bartender, who had been waiting for their conversation to halt, brought a menu and came to take their order, wearing a black apron .

The bartender was expressionless and calm .

Makoto looked at the menu, but in the end, she just ordered gin, like she always did .

At the time, Makoto couldn't even imagine what was going to happen afterwards –

2

Gotou reclined on the car seat and tied his necktie while holding a cigarette in his mouth .

In the passenger seat, Ishii was carelessly chomping down a hamburger . Thanks to that, the car was filled with the smell of burger .

Gotou was going to complain, but he changed his mind . Conversing with Ishii was as tiring as conversing with Yakumo .

<I'm counting on you to focus . >

He heard a voice from the wireless earphone he had on .

Even though she was a woman, she had a voice that reverberated in the bottom of your belly . Her name was Shimamura Eriko .

From the perspective of Gotou, who had parked his car on the road in front of the park, she was directly diagonal from him . He could see her stooping in the forest behind the park .

In stature, size and attitude, she was heavyweight all around . She was completely visible .

'Who are you saying that to?'

<You, obviously . >

Shimamura rebutted immediately .

Why was he surrounded by so many impudent people? Gotou clicked his tongue .

<I'm the one who wants to click her tongue . I really need you to focus, since you've always been missing a few screws . You're the same with

Atsuko, aren't you?>

'Shut up! That has nothing to do with you!' shouted Gotou, flaring up .

She talked on and on about unnecessary things . Why had his wife come up in conversation?

<It does have something to do with me . Who do you think introduced her to you?>

'I truly regret it . '

Gotou had met with his wife Atsuko because Shimamura, who had been at the police academy at the same time as him, had introduced her .

His wife's best friend and his co-worker . Thanks to that, his private life had been made public in the police . Not just the police either . Even Yakumo knew about it through old man Hata .

<What are you saying? I'm the one who regrets it . >

'What did you say?'

<I'm saying I shouldn't have introduced her to you . >

'What do you mean?'

<Every time she fights with you, she comes crying to me – it's troublesome . After this case is finished, come over and pick her up . >

He could hear sniggers from other investigation team members from the earphone .

That Shimamura . She was just doing this to pass the time . Gotou bit his lip and hit Ishii's head in retaliation .

'D-D-Detective Gotou, what are you doing?'

The tomato fell from Ishii's burger .

'Shut up!'

He glared at Ishii for responding .

Gotou could tell it would be hard going .

'Why do we have to be dragged into work outside of our jurisdiction?' grumbled Gotou .

'But it's true that we don't have any work . We might as well offer assistance at least,' replied Ishii, with his stupid diligence .

'I know that . '

Just as Ishii said, the Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room was named such because they responded to unsolved cases, but in reality, they just organised the backlog of documents .

On top of that, the other divisions thought they had a lot of free time on their hands, so they were often used as supplementary personnel for stakeouts and such .

Even now, they were staking out the park on the corner of this residential street because of a serial female assault case – though it was just some perverted guy cutting women's skirts with scissors .

This is the same as being put out in the cold –

Gotou muttered that in his heart and snorted .

On top of that, there was this stationing . If the perp ran, they hadn't surrounded the routes . Forget about his career – why did he have to obey some brat who was younger than him? It really riled him up .

<Someone who could be the suspect has been spotted... Height is about 160 cm . Green jumper, black knitted hat... It matches with the testimony .
>

A nervous voice came in through his earphone .

<He's by the public toilet . >

Gotou looked in the direction indicated .

He was there! Directly in front of his gaze, there was a suspicious person with his back to the wall of the toilet facing the road . He kept glancing at the road .

<Shimamura . Go around from the side and question him . >

<Roger . >

<Gotou, Ishii – wait in the car . >

'What do you mean, wait? If Shimamura goes around, the back will be wide open,' Gotou retorted, putting his cigarette out in the ashtray . He opened the door and rushed out .

'Detective Gotou, the instructions were to wait here . '

Still holding his burger, Ishii called out to Gotou to stop .

'You're annoying . I know that . '

'Then...'

'Do you know the word “adaptability”?’

'Yes . It refers to the ability to change depending on the situation . That's what was written in the Koujien[1] . '

'This is that situation . '

While Gotou said that, he headed towards the forest in the back of the park . It was a terrible mistake to move Shimamura . Did they really think the perp would just run for the road?

'Detective Gotou, this is bad . '

Ishii hesitantly followed Gotou, like a puppy .

'Go back to the car if you think that . '

'B-but...'

Honestly, this useless guy .

'Don't come over here!'

A yell resounded .

Gotou looked toward the public toilet . The man from earlier was waving a pair of scissors about agitatedly as he screamed .

Investigation team members sidled up from both sides .

After the man looked to his left and right, he turned away from the road and fled towards the forest like a frightened rabbit .

'Wait!' yelled one of the investigation members .

See?

'Ishii, let's go!'

Gotou immediately ran after the man .

'Ouch!'

Ishii tripped .

That idiot! Gotou ignored Ishii, who had fallen and had his hands on his thighs as he got back up, and chased the man .

'Wait! I'll kill you!'

The man turned at Gotou's yell .

'D-don't come over!' the man screamed, looking like he could cry at any moment .

He was a timid and chubby middle-aged man that any crowded train stank with . Honestly, what a miserable face . It made it seem like Gotou was attacking him .

'Damn it!'

Gotou reached out to grab the scruff of his neck and drag him to the ground .

The man fell backwards and started coughing from the impact . Gotou climbed on top of him and raised his right fist .

Like he had lost all will to flee at that moment, the man pressed both hands against his face and started crying, repeating, 'I'm sorry, I'm sorry...'

Gotou muttered, 'Damn,' and hit the ground with his fist in his anger .

If he was going to cry about it, he shouldn't have done it in the first place .

The first words of the novice officer in charge who arrived late at the scene were —

'Why did you leave your station?'

Honestly, everyone was just —

3

It had been almost an hour since Makoto arrived at the bar .

Since it had been the first time she'd seen Asami in a while and there were Shinichi and Yuuya, whom she had just met, it had been an awkward question-and-answer session at first, but now, the atmosphere was less reserved .

It was easy talking with the man named Shinichi . He was a good listener, or rather, she ended up telling him about a variety of things .

Instead of assertively enlivening the conversation, Yuuya would laugh as he listened and respond at the appropriate times . He might have been a serious young man despite his appearances .

'Just going to go to the ladies' . '

At a lull in the conversation, Asami took her bag and stood up .

'Makoto-san, are you seeing anyone?'

After Asami left for the lavatory, Shinichi asked Makoto this question while looking directly at her eyes .

'I'm not . '

'Really?' Shinichi said in disbelief .

'Really . I'm being pushed around at work right now . Plus, I have no luck with men . '

Makoto shrugged .

Though she didn't have a boyfriend, there was somebody she harboured feelings for . However, she didn't say that aloud .

He was a detective who was so serious it was idiotic . She had made up reasons to contact and approach him, but he hadn't noticed at all, though he hadn't rejected her .

In the meantime, she had lost her excuses, so lately she hadn't seen him .

'Is that so? If it were me, I wouldn't leave you alone, Makoto-san . '

Shinichi smoothly said those words which could have been a pick-up line .

'You probably say that to every woman you meet . '

'Of course not . Right, bartender?

After Makoto said that as a joke, Shinichi turned the conversation to the bartender, who had come to put down a glass .

The bartender gave a vague reply and escaped by walking away .

'Yuuya, you think Makoto-san is beautiful too, right?'

Shinichi poked Yuuya's shoulder .

While Yuuya drank the whiskey in his glass, he just smiled frivolously and said nothing . He might have felt it was awkward, because he looked at his wristwatch and said, 'Asami-san's been a while . '

Immediately after that –

'Aaah!'

Makoto heard Asami scream from the toilet in the back of the bar .

'Asami?'

Makoto stood up right away and ran to the lavatory .

'What happened?'

She called out in the direction of the lavatory door . There was no response . Shinichi and Yuuya came by too because they were concerned .

'Hey, Asami . What happened?'

Makoto asked again as she knocked on the door .

However, there was no response, as if nobody was inside .

Makoto put her ear against the door to try to listen for sounds from inside, but it was no use .

'Excuse me . '

The bartender cut through as he said that .

The bartender quickly took a key from his pocket and opened the door, saying, 'I'm opening the door . '

The lights were off in the dim lavatory .

Asami sat on the tiled floor and was trembling as she hugged her own shoulders .

'Asami . You OK?'

Makoto went inside the lavatory and walked up to Asami to shake her shoulders with both of her hands .

The colour drained from Asami's face, which just earlier had been flushed because of alcohol, leaving her extremely pale .

'Hey, what happened?'

At Makoto's question, Asami pointed at the mirror in front of her with a trembling finger .

All the people there turned their eyes to the dark mirror, their gazes led by that finger .

At the same time –

Inside the mirror, a faint image of a woman appeared . Long black hair hung from her head, and the left half of her face was covered in blood .

That woman's body shook like it had been jolted .

Her cracked purple lips slowly moved .

– Die .

Her low growl made the air quiver .

Nobody there was able to keep their senses, and their screams echoed through the bar .

4

Haruka, whose lecture had finished, went towards the prefabricated two-storey building in the back of Building B .

There were ten rooms of about four and a half tatami on each floor . The university lent them out for student circle activities .

She was going to meet with Japan's representative for contrariness, Saitou Yakumo .

She didn't really have any trouble for him . She was just going to meet him .

Haruka thought it was amazing progress . No, she couldn't call this progress . What she had been doing before had been strange . She had always been accompanied by trouble every time she went to visit Yakumo . It was the pattern for Yakumo to say something sarcastic to her and make her depressed every time they met .

– But today is OK .

Haruka stood in front of the door at the end of the first floor . The door had a plate which read <Movie Research Circle> .

However, that was a downright lie . Yakumo had deceived the university to borrow this room and was using it as his secret hiding place .

'Hey,' Haruka said, opening the door .

At the same time, a wave of hot air rushed out at her . She resisted the urge to cough and looked inside .

'You again?'

As usual, his hair looked like he had just gotten out of bed, and his eyes were sleepy . Yakumo, reclining on the chair in the front, sounded annoyed as he said that .

He had unbuttoned down to the third button of his shirt and was fanning himself with a fan .

There were beads of sweat from his forehead to the nape of his neck .

'I'm just going to say this, but this isn't a place for you to kill time . '

'I don't have as much free time as you think, Yakumo-kun . I've got reports to do and I have a part-time job too, and I often get invited out...'

She stopped speaking . He wouldn't listen . Yakumo stretched his neck as he let out a huge yawn, and then he scratched his neck . His actions were just like that of a cat's .

Haruka went inside, took a bottle of tea from the refrigerator in the back of the room and drank it .

'When did you bring that in here?' said Yakumo, looking dissatisfied .

'The last time I came . There's chocolate too . Want some?'

Haruka took out a box of almond chocolate from the refrigerator and showed it to Yakumo .

'This is my room . Don't just make it your own . '

'This is the Movie Research Circle room . '

'You aren't a member . '

She had thought that was where the conversation would go . Haruka made a victorious pose in her mind at one-upping Yakumo .

'Too bad for you, but I'm a member of the Movie Research Circle too . '

'What?'

'Yesterday, I went to the student affairs office and wrote my name on the registration list .

Even Yakumo had nothing to say as he gaped .

– How about that? Got you there, right?

'Why would you do something like...'

'OK, OK . '

Haruka interrupted Yakumo and sat on the chair .

She felt like she had won .

'Still, how can you stay in such a hot room? Isn't there air conditioning?'

Haruka took a handkerchief out of her bag and wiped her forehead . Even though she had just come in, it was already covered in sweat .

If she stayed here the whole day, she might get heatstroke .

'The fan is broken . '

Yakumo pointed at the corner of the ceiling with his fan .

An electric fan covered with cobwebs was hanging there .

'You could just buy a new one . '

'I don't have the money for that . '

'How are you planning on getting through this summer? It's going to get hotter . '

Copying Yakumo, Haruka took her notebook from her bag and used it as a fan .

'Can't you just go home if you're going to complain?'

'What? I came all this way to visit you . '

'I don't remember asking you to . '

'Oh, is that so . '

Haruka gritted her teeth and gave Yakumo a menacing look .

Then, there was the sound of a knock . For a moment, Haruka thought it might have been Detective Gotou, but if it had been him, he wouldn't have knocked – he would have just suddenly said, 'I'm coming in,' and entered .

'Please come in . The door is unlocked . '

Yakumo ran his fingers through his hair and called out in the direction of the door .

'Please excuse me . '

A beautiful long-haired woman in a navy blue suit opened the door and came in .

'Who might you be and where are you from?'

'I'm a fourth-year student at this university . My name is Iida Mizuho . '

She replied firmly to Yakumo's question . She seemed too mature to be a university student .

Haruka gave her seat to Mizuho and unfolded a folding chair that was in the corner of the room . She sat down next to Yakumo .

'So what can I do for you?'

'Er, I apologise for visiting in such a rude manner . I actually have something I would like to discuss and thought it might be bothersome, but...'

'Leave the introduction at that and get to the main question,' Yakumo said curtly, interrupting Mizuho to make her get to the point .

Ah, it was the same the first time for me too . Haruka remembered the first time she had come to this room a few months ago .

'Ah, yes . The truth is, I have been troubled by a spiritual phenomenon –'

'A spiritual phenomenon?'

Yakumo frowned as he raked through his hand with his fingers .

'Will you listen to my story?'

'I don't mind if I'm only listening to it . '

At Yakumo's prompting, Mizuho's expression suddenly brightened .

After that, Mizuho talked about a ghost of a woman that appeared at an apartment .

– Why can't I die?

While the female ghost muttered that, she jumped off the apartment building . After a while, she stood back up and dragged her body into the apartment . And then –

She jumped again .

The ghost of a woman who kept on committing suicide –

Why did she want to die so much? There was no way Haruka would understand .

Mizuho appealed politely to Yakumo, saying that after seeing that woman's ghost, it had been so terrifying that Mizuho couldn't sleep at night, and besought him to solve the case .

Since it was Yakumo, he would definitely say something cold like 'It's none of my business' or 'Please try your best' .

Ah, you poor thing . Haruka looked at Mizuho sympathetically .

However, what Yakumo said was completely different from what she had imagined .

'That must be worrying you . I understand . Let me accept your request . '

Eh? Wait . What? You had a completely different attitude when I asked you . Haruka swallowed the words that she almost said aloud .

'Will you help me?'

For a moment, Mizuho looked surprised, and then she relaxed, like she was exhausted .

Haruka was the one who wanted to be surprised .

'However, that does not mean it will be free . '

'How much will it be?'

Mizuho looked at Yakumo to sound him out .

'Would the regular price of twenty thousand yen plus expenses be acceptable?'

Isn't that cheaper than it had been for me? What the heck is that –

'Yes, thank you very much . '

Mizuho bowed her head deeply .

Was it OK for her to trust such an irresponsible guy so easily? She should be a bit suspicious .

This guy was just a fake who took advantage of people's weaknesses .

Since Mizuho couldn't hear Haruka's thoughts, she wrote down the address of the apartment where she had seen the ghost as well as her contact information . Then, she bowed her head again and left the room .

'You accepted that pretty easily . '

The moment the door closed, she rested her chin in her hands and said that . Since she had been holding back, her tone was a bit harsh .

'I want a new fan,' Yakumo said with a yawn .

Well, it would be hard to get through the summer in the prefabricated building with new air conditioning, but –

'The price is lower than the one you gave me . '

'There's a campaign right now . '

'Is that a campaign that gives discounts to good-looking woman? After all, I'm...'

'What's gotten you into such a bad mood?'

Really, it's just as Yakumo said .

What am I saying? Even while Haruka was thinking that, she couldn't stop the next words from coming out of her mouth .

'Her breasts were big too . '

'What – do you want to boast about your small ones?'

'Small!? ... They're still C-cups, you know . '

'What sort of joke is that?'

Yakumo raised an eyebrow .

'It's not a joke! You've never even looked at them!'

'I can tell well enough even if you're wearing clothes on top . '

Did he not know the word delicacy!? Honestly, she was so angry!

Ignoring Haruka's inner turmoil, Yakumo stretched out his arms behind him .

5

'What on earth are you doing!?'

Chief Ideuchi's yell stabbed at Ishii's ears .

His forehead with its receding hairline was bright red in agitation . He looked just like a boiled octopus .

Ishii had been prepared to be scolded after he was called to the meeting room, but Ideuchi's indignation exceeded his expectations .

It was true that they hadn't obeyed orders, but because of that, they caught the criminal, so Ishii thought that Ideuchi could have at considered that a little .

'The officer in charge is a greenhorn . '

Instead of being afraid of Ideuchi's anger, Gotou flared up .

'Watch what you say . '

'I just called him a greenhorn because he's a greenhorn . '

'Know your place!'

Ideuchi and Gotou's conversation heated up .

This always happened . Gotou took an impolite attitude towards everyone . However, Ishii thought that Gotou's attitude towards Ideuchi greatly differed from his attitude towards other people .

They didn't get on well .

'Haven't you reflected on what you did!?'

'I apologise for arresting the criminal!' said Gotou in a voice dripping with sarcasm as he bowed his head and turned away . He was acting just like a rebellious child .

At many points, Ishii opened his mouth to mediate, but he was too flustered, overwhelmed by their intensity .

'What you should reflect on is how you didn't obey orders!'

'You saying it'd have been better if I listened to some greenhorn's orders, just waited in the car and let the criminal get away?'

Though Gotou's objection was extreme, this time he was right . In a situation that required adaptability, grandstanding was sometimes necessary .

Putting aside whether he would be able to do that himself, even Ishii understood that much .

'I didn't say that . '

'Then what are you saying?'

'I'm saying that if you're also a member of the police, don't glare at the people above you . This is also for your sake . '

'The job of the police is to keep public order – not to butter the boss up . '

'In order for an organisation to work, sometimes that is necessary . '

'Don't force your reasoning onto me!'

Gotou's angry voice was so loud the glass in the window shook .

Ideuchi lost his words and looked at Gotou like he was an alien .

It wasn't an exaggeration . Their ways of thinking were really that different, or so Ishii thought .

'Forget it . Get back to work . '

After a silence, Ideuchi shook his head and said that, giving up .

'Wasting my time with something so pointless,' Gotou muttered as he stood up .

'If you keep up that attitude, you won't get a promotion . '

Ideuchi said one last thing to Gotou, who was exiting the room .

'I never wanted one in the first place,' Gotou said, and then he left the room .

'You're unlucky,' Ideuchi said, casting a pitying look on Ishii .

Ishii didn't feel there was any reason to be pitied .

'I don't really...'

'If it's what you want, you can consider getting a transfer,' Ideuchi said, interrupting Ishii's objection .

'A transfer? Why would I?'

Ishii raised his eyebrows and pushed up his silver-framed glasses .

'Your future shouldn't be shut down for being Gotou's subordinate . '

Ishii couldn't understand Ideuchi's words . He had never felt bitter about working as Gotou's subordinate .

'I don't mind working where I am,' Ishii responded firmly . Then, he said, 'Please excuse me,' stood up, bowed and ran after Gotou .

He fell –

* * *

After leaving the meeting room, Gotou kicked the wall .

– I'm really pissed off .

What at? Ideuchi? No, that wasn't all .

He was angry at himself .

He hadn't been like this when he had first entered the force .

It might have been childish, but he had been filled with a sense of justice and duty . He had been drunk on fantasies that wouldn't lose even to Ishii's . He had believed without doubt that he would be able to save a lot of people .

However, that dream crumbled after just a few years .

No, that wasn't it . He had just been naive in the first place . It was impossible to solve every case like some cool anime hero .

If every person who committed a crime was a detestable villain, this would be so easy –

The real world neither rewarded good nor punished evil .

People had different perspectives and ways of thinking . Cases weren't just matters of vics and perps – they had effects on all the people around them .

Every day, people surrendered themselves to anger, resentment, sadness, jealousy – every possible negative emotion .

Senior detectives had often said this to him . 'Don't worry so much . If you don't just accept that that's how it is, you're the one who'll suffer . ' Gotou thought it was just as they said .

However, Gotou couldn't do that .

He felt the same as the people involved in the crime and he called out in anger and sadness . Like that, he dug his nails into an unchangeable society .

Revolting against the large organisation that was the police who knew they were in way over their head, and he gradually became isolated .

Even so, he couldn't leave the force .

Promotions were just showing off . The investigation team could get worked up about them if they liked, but they couldn't involve the perps and the vics .

With out-and-out careerism, no matter how he tried to cooperate with officers who were trying work their way up, he knew what would happen . A power game .

There wasn't any meaning in aiming for the top in an appearance-only organisation that had lost sight of its duty .

Finally, these past years police scandals continued one after another and the number of suicides in-house was through the roof .

An organisation like this should just go belly up . Gotou truly thought that .

Why am I still in this organisation if I think that –

He didn't know . That was why he was angry .

'Damn it!'

6

Even while she was working, Makoto couldn't get what happened at the bar the night before out of her mind .

The long-haired woman reflected in the lavatory mirror –

If she were the only one who had seen it, she could have put it away as an optical illusion, but the five people there had seen exactly the same thing .

Even if she denied it, the fearful experience that happened a few months ago came back to her .

At the time, a dead man's soul possessed Makoto and ate away at her mind . She couldn't forget the fear she had felt then even if she tried .

If that had been a ghost, it could have been somebody who died at that bar in the past .

In order to know even just a little about that spiritual phenomenon, Makoto accessed the company database when there was a spare moment at work and tried searching for women who had died nearby, but the answer was no .

Pulled along by the spiritual phenomenon with cause unknown, she lacked concentration for her work and made a series of basic mistakes .

She had just been targeted by her boss too, who had ended it with the usual line . 'And you're supposed to be the police chief's daughter . '

No matter where she went, her father's title was waved about .

When she was in university, the boy she liked stopped contacting her once he learnt about her father's occupation, and her friends had become reserved too .

'You look a bit pale . Why don't you head home for today?' said Kazue, the clerk sitting beside Makoto .

Though it wasn't as if she was feeling unwell, she would definitely be laughed at if she explained the reason .

Then, her mobile phone rang . It was from Asami .

'I'll be fine if I rest a bit,' Makoto replied with a smile . She took her mobile and headed towards the lavatory .

After she entered, Asami had hung up, but when Makoto called back, Asami picked up on the first ring .

'Hello, it's Makoto . '

There was no response even when she started speaking .

She just heard rough breathing from the mobile .

'Hello, Asami? Can you hear me?'

<... I'm scared . >

Asami's shaking voice came through .

She's scared –

'What's wrong? Did something happen?'

<I'm scared . Please . Help me . >

Asami spoke quickly .

'Calm down . What happened?'

Makoto consciously spoke calmly, to try to alleviate Asami's agitation even if just a little .

<There's someone in my room . >

Asami sounded like she was crying .

'Someone... What do you mean?'

Makoto couldn't immediately understand what Asami was saying .

<I can't see them, but I can feel someone there . >

'Feel?'

<Yes . I can hear footsteps and the sound of running water . It's so creepy I can't stand it...>

Makoto suddenly turned pale .

There was nothing definite . It could all be Asami's misunderstanding .
However, Makoto didn't think that .

Makoto had experienced the horror of a dead person's spirit first-hand . On top of that, there was the thing from last night .

'Hey, Asami . Are you home right now?'

<I'm out . I'm too scared to stay at home . Please, Makoto . I can't bear with this alone . Please come . >

Asami sounded like she was at her wit's end . There was no way Makoto could leave her alone .

'I get it . I'll finish work as quickly as I can and come over . '

<OK . >

'Don't go back to your room 'til then, OK? Stay somewhere else . '

After Makoto said that, she hung up .

There's someone who thinks I'm looking under the weather, so I'll watch my timing and leave as soon as possible .

7

Haruka followed Yakumo and went up the stairs to the apartment courtyard .

It was a fifteen-minute walk from the station . The apartment had been forcibly built, cutting away at the high ground . The steep steps were what remained .

Because of the dizzying sunlight, going up the steps was rather tiring .

'Hey, walk a bit more slowly . '

Haruka wiped the sweat off her forehead and complained to Yakumo .

'Are you a turtle?'

'The rabbit loses to the turtle in the end . '

'No matter how I try, I can't think that you'll catch up to me . '

'That's why I asked you to walk a bit more slowly . '

'Why are you following me anyway? I don't remember telling you to come with me . '

Yakumo didn't slow his pace or turn around .

It was true that Yakumo hadn't asked her to come, but Haruka couldn't remember him saying not to either . Haruka had interpreted that the way she wanted to and followed .

When she climbed to the top of the stairs, there was a park right in front of her .

A lawn spread out, surrounded by benches . A few toddlers were running around while letting out shrieks of delight . Behind the park, five seven-storey apartments were lined up diagonally .

Yakumo stood at the entrance of the first apartment and looked up at the roof .

It was an unusually serious gaze .

Haruka stood beside Yakumo and looked up at the roof as well .

All she could see was a brilliant blue sky and cumulonimbi rising up into the sky like columns of smoke . However, it was different for Yakumo .

He had a red left eye that could see the spirits of the dead . He loathed his unique ability and usually hid that eye with a black contact lens .

That ability had caused much of Yakumo's contrary personality .

His own mother tried to kill him and the people around him found his eye altogether uncomfortable, so he ended up closing off his heart .

That eye filled with so many sad memories was lonely but warm .

'Hey, can you see anything?'

Yakumo didn't reply .

Well, she hadn't been expecting a reply in the first place .

'There is a woman with long hair . '

Suddenly, she heard a voice .

It hadn't been Yakumo's . As proof, Yakumo also looked surprised . Haruka turned around to where the voice had come from and saw one man standing there .

He wore a black suit and white shirt inappropriate for this season . He had no tie and he had long flowing hair .

He had firm shoulders and dark skin like a surfer . His finely chiselled features were unlike that of a Japanese person's .

Though their appearances were different, he had the same atmosphere as Yakumo . Haruka felt that even if she didn't know the reason .

'And you are?'

Yakumo narrowed his eyes, like he was evaluating the man .

'Sorry for interrupting all of a sudden . My name is Kamiyama . I'm an exorcist . '

Kamiyama made a smile and proffered Yakumo a business card .

– This person is an exorcist .

He had a very different impression from what Haruka thought exorcists looked like .

Exorcism was Yakumo's most hated type of industry .

Yakumo, who could actually see the spirits of the dead, defined them as clusters of people's emotions . That was why he thought it was an uncivilised method – to him, exorcising spirits with the power of chanting was idiotic and the same as giving someone a beating .

'You think I'm suspicious . Well, that's not unexpected . '

Kamiyama smiled bitterly at Yakumo who didn't move to take the business card .

He had a low voice and a soothing way of speaking .

'I can't do anything if you doubt me, but I can see them . The spirits of the dead . '

'Eh?'

Haruka spoke in surprise without thinking .

Kamiyama just said that he could see the spirits of the dead . If that was true, that would mean he had the same ability as Yakumo .

But anybody could say that . On the contrary, if there were exorcists who couldn't see the spirits of the dead, they wouldn't be able to make money even in a bogus business .

How did Yakumo see it? Haruka turned to look at him .

His expression hadn't changed – he was just looking at Kamiyama silently .

'She killed herself...' said Kamiyama, looking up at the apartment .

Yakumo neither affirmed nor denied it . Kamiyama continued without delay .

'A woman in her early twenties . She jumped from there at the limit of her despair . '

Kamiyama pointed at one of the corners of the apartment's roof .

Yakumo's mouth moved slowly . Haruka didn't know what he was saying .

'She has a violent hatred . A strong hatred that can't even be healed by death... A deep darkness . '

Kamiyama closed his eyes and took in a deep breath before turning his gaze to Yakumo again .

'You can see them too, can't you? The same things as me . '

Yakumo's eyes turned sharp, but his lips were still pressed thinly together .

– Is this exorcist telling the truth?

Haruka restrained the impulse to ask .

'Don't you think sometimes that being able to see is a cruelty?'

Though Yakumo didn't reply to Kamiyama's question, he narrowed his eyes, looking displeased .

However, to Haruka, those eyes looked like they were saying something, and Kamiyama continued talking like he had taken Yakumo's silence as a response .

'You learn about things you don't need to know about . The spirits of the dead are people's passions unbound by morals . Looking at them directly is too painful . My heart breaks every time I see them . '

Yakumo's gaze met Kamiyama's, and a wave of tension spread .

Haruka forgot to breathe as she stared at the two of them .

After a silence, Kamiyama smiled bitterly and said, 'Sorry for suddenly bringing up such an odd topic . '

Haruka was finally able to let out the breath she had been holding .

'No, not at all . '

Yakumo ran his fingers through his hair .

'I feel like I'll meet you again . '

Kamiyama left those parting words and walked at an easy pace away from the apartment .

Haruka realised why she felt like Kamiyama and Yakumo had a similar atmosphere when she saw his retreating back . His back felt like it was burdened with a heavy, sorrowful shadow .

When they could no longer see Kamiyama, Yakumo's eyes returned to their usual sleepy look and he let out a big yawn .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . About what that man said...'

For a moment, Yakumo's expression changed at Haruka's question .

Though she didn't know what emotions he had hidden away, it was a complicated expression she had never seen before .

'Putting aside whether he is a real exorcist or not, there is a spirit of a dead woman here, as he said . '

Does that mean that exorcist is the real thing –

Come to think of it, Yakumo had said this before . 'My ability to see the spirits of the dead is just part of my disposition . ' If that was the case, it

wouldn't be strange if other people had the same disposition .

'Yakumo-kun...'

Yakumo ignored Haruka and started to make a call on his mobile .

8

When Ishii returned from the meeting room to the Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room, Gotou was snoring loudly as he reclined on the chair .

It looked like his quarrel with Ideuchi earlier hadn't really struck home .

– I was silly for worrying .

Ishii let out a huge sigh .

Gotou and Ishii were the only ones posted at the Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room, which used to be a storehouse . Since nobody would see them, nobody would blame them if they took naps .

That said, Ishii didn't know what to think about dozing right in the open at noon, but he didn't have the courage to wake Gotou up .

In this situation, all Ishii could do was devote himself to whittling time away .

What he had been doing lately was reading the dossiers for unsolved cases that occurred in the past and reasoning out who the perpetrators were on his own .

Since he couldn't report them to anybody, it was only self-satisfaction, but it was fairly interesting, since it felt like he had become a famous detective such as Sherlock Holmes .

Then, a mobile phone started ringing .

Gotou got up and answered the phone without even checking who it was, still half-asleep .

'Who's this?'

Did Detective Gotou talk like that to everyone? Ishii thought that he should act a bit more polite since he was an adult .

However, there was no way he could have said that aloud .

'Eh? When did I become your gofer?'

The person Detective Gotou was talking to on the phone had to have plenty of guts to try to use him as a gofer .

Perhaps –

'You want me to lend... That really is all you can be counted on for... I got it . '

While Gotou complained, he started taking notes for some reason .

'Shut up . I don't need your concern . '

Gotou left a sharp parting remark and hung up .

'What was it?' Ishii asked, leaning forward in curiosity .

'Work,' said Gotou, and he handed a memo with an address written on it to Ishii .

'What is this?'

'There's an apartment at the address here – look up whether there are incidents in the past near there where somebody died . '

'Where somebody died?'

'Murder, accident, suicide . Anything's fine as long as they're dead . '

It was an awfully vague instruction .

'Is that all?'

'If somebody did die, look into them more so you know their personal history . '

'What case is this for?'

'It's not a case,' Gotou said bluntly .

– It isn't a case?

'It isn't?'

'It's a request from that brat . '

– By that brat, perhaps he meant...

'From Saitou Yakumo-shi?'

'Yeah . There's a ghost at that apartment . '

So it was that demon-like man .

The terrible experience from a few months ago came back to Ishii's heart, and a chill ran from the crown of his head to his toes .

He didn't want to feel that way again .

'I unconditionally disagree to this . '

'Stop whinging and go look into it . '

Gotou's fist fell down on Ishii's head .

* * *

'So, did you find out anything?' Haruka asked Yakumo, who had ended his phone call .

Yakumo looked at Haruka like she was making a fool of him .

'You haven't progressed at all, as usual . '

'What?'

'All I know now is that there is a woman's ghost at this apartment . There wouldn't be a conclusion to this so suddenly . '

'Didn't that exorcist earlier say it was a suicide?'

'You believe him?'

Yakumo's expression turned stiff .

Haruka, who couldn't see the spirits of the dead, had no way of judging whether Kamiyama's words were true or not .

'I don't know . '

'I don't know either . '

'Then...'

'That's why we can't let ourselves be caught by any preconceptions before we know whether what he said was true or not . '

Yakumo's lips went into a thin line after he spoke .

There was the sound of a mosquito buzzing far away in the silence . The light reflected from the asphalt was scorching and felt like it could burn skin .

Yakumo's argument was sound . But —

'What are you going to do now?'

'Go back . After that, I wait for the results of the investigation . '

After Yakumo said that, he started walking away briskly .

Haruka hurriedly followed after him .

As she thought, Yakumo was a bit strange after meeting that exorcist earlier .

She wouldn't be able to say specifically what it was if asked, but she couldn't feel strong determination from his eyes .

– He's perplexed .

Just after they descended the stairs in front of the apartment, Yakumo suddenly stopped .

'When do you think a person would take their own life?' asked Yakumo, turning around .

His eyes were narrowed . Is it because of the sunlight or –

Haruka had no answer for such an abrupt question . Despite that, she racked her mind to find one .

'Maybe to run away...'

Haruka said the words that came to her .

'To run . '

'I think that everyone has their own reasons, but maybe they were using death to try to escape, or rather, be released from pain or sadness that they couldn't bear .

Unusual for Yakumo, he listened to Haruka's words patiently .

Haruka thought that his eyes looked they carried a strange sorrow, but it was probably just a misunderstanding .

'Dying won't bring release . '

That was all Yakumo said . Haruka thought he was right .

If the dead had souls, those emotions would still remain in this world even if they died .

If they chose death as a way to escape, it was a big mistake . Whether they chose to live or die, people couldn't run from their own heart .

Still, the number of people who chose to take their own lives was endless . It was a sad truth .

A humid wind blew .

'Let's run . It's going to rain . '

Yakumo suddenly broke into a run . Haruka hurriedly started running too . Immediately after she did, rain started pouring down loudly .

9

When Makoto finished work, she hurriedly headed towards the place where she had arranged to meet with Asami .

Though it was a family restaurant about a five-minute walk from the station, she ended up going by taxi because of the rain that was coming down in buckets .

After Makoto entered the restaurant, she found Asami at a seat by the window .

She was looking around like she couldn't calm down and was afraid of something .

'Sorry, I wanted to come earlier,' said Makoto, sitting in the seat opposite Asami . The moment Asami looked at Makoto's face, she shook her head vehemently .

Asami covered her face with her hands and mumbled, 'I was really scared... I can't go home anymore...'

Makoto understood Asami's fear well .

Though her situation had been different, she had been possessed by a ghost a few months ago . A soul that wasn't hers had eaten away at her .

She would probably never forget the terror she felt then .

'It's OK, it's OK . '

Makoto moved to the seat beside Asami and hugged her shoulders tightly, which made Asami burst into tears .

Makoto stroked Asami's head and patiently waited for her to stop crying .

After a while, Asami calmed down a bit and started talking in spurts about what had been happening around her .

'I always felt somebody's presence . '

'Presence?'

'Mm... I'd hear footsteps behind me when I sat on the sofa, and when I took a shower, somebody would touch my hair...'

Makoto took Asami's hand as she listened to her story .

'But I told myself I was just misunderstanding things . When I slept, I felt like I heard somebody's voice and looked out the window...'

After saying this much, Asami lost her breath .

Makoto could feel Asami's nervousness and fear . She didn't want to hear any more . While thinking that, she urged Asami to continue, asking, 'Then?'

'She was there . '

'Who was?'

'That woman . The one who had been at the toilet in the bar last night...'

After Asami said that, she closed her eyes tightly .

Makoto also remembered the blood-covered woman who had been reflected in the lavatory mirror and felt a chill down her spine .

'I live on the ninth floor of my apartment, but that woman was standing outside my window, smiling...'

Asami held her chest as her erratic breathing shook her shoulders .

'It's OK . Calm down and take deep breaths . '

Makoto rubbed Asami's back and took calm, deep breaths as an example .

After a while, Asami regained her composure and lifted her face to begin talking again .

'I was so scared I consulted an exorcist . '

'An exorcist?'

'Yeah . '

'Are they someone you can trust?'

Normal people couldn't see ghosts . Consequently, it'd be considerably difficult to judge whether that exorcist was the real thing or a fake .

While there were people who were saved, it was also true that it was a breeding ground for fraud .

'Since it's just a name I've heard from a friend... Makoto, I want you to meet him with me . '

'When you say you want me to meet him with you, do you mean you're meeting him now?'

Asami nodded, her gaze holding Makoto .

'Excuse me . Would you be Inoue Asami-san...'

While Makoto was hesitating on her decision, somebody suddenly called out to them .

When she looked over, there was a man in a black suit standing by their table . He had chiselled features, his long hair was swept back, and he looked composed .

Asami replied, 'That would be me . '

'My name is Kamiyama . I received your phone call . '

The man gave his name and bowed his head .

This man is the exorcist Asami made her request to –

In front of Kamiyama, Asami talked about the spiritual phenomena she experienced again, but Asami's agitation was more pronounced than it has been earlier, and there were many parts that were incoherent .

In the end, Makoto had to give an additional explanation including the event that occurred at the bar last night .

After Makoto finished talking, a smile appeared on Kamiyama's face, and he said, 'I see . I have understood most of the story . '

Asami ducked her head and her gaze wandered anxiously . She couldn't make calm decisions right now . Makoto would have to judge whether this exorcist was the real thing or not – that was how Makoto felt .

'Deducing from this story, I believe this may be a wandering spirit . '

'A wandering spirit?' Makoto asked .

She had heard the term before, but she didn't know what it actually meant .

'There are a variety of types of spirits with different characteristics . Many have been recognised by exorcists, but they have been split into residual spirits and wandering spirits . '

'Residual spirits and wandering spirits...'

She had heard of both of them, but she didn't know what the difference was .

'Yes . Residual spirits, as suggested by the name, are spirits that are bound after death to a specific place or thing . '

'Bound?'

'Yes . It might be easy to understand if I said they were captured by emotions . Hatred, sadness, anger – they are kept in this world by these negative emotions . '

'Lingering emotions...'

'That's right . They are often the ones who committed suicide or were killed . It is said that residual ghosts can escape that binding by possessing a living person . '

Did that mean last time Makoto had been possessed by a residual spirit –

'The other type, the wandering spirit, is also exactly what it sounds like . They are spirits that cannot rest in peace, so they wander . There are many cases where they do not know they are dead or want somebody to know they are there .

Kamiyama's explanation was logical and easy to understand, as if Makoto were listening to a class at school .

Moreover, he didn't say anything to surprise them as a joke or fan their anxiety .

'They're wandering...'

'Yes . It's likely that the wandering spirit just happened to be in the bar when the two of you saw it . Then, when Asami-san didn't notice, she brought that wandering spirit home with her . '

'Will I be OK?'

Asami drew near Kamiyama and gripped his arm tightly .

Kamiyama wasn't perturbed by it and said kindly, 'Please calm down . Wandering spirits simply wander, so they will not inflict harm . '

'Is that true?'

'Yes . If you are still uneasy, I can go to your room now, Asami-san, and exorcise the spirit . '

'Please do . '

Asami replied immediately to Kamiyama's suggestion .

Then, she grasped Makoto's hand tightly and said, 'Makoto, you come too . '

Makoto responded with a nod, since there was no way she could have refused .

10

Why do I have to do this –

Ishii unhappily searched through past data on a laptop .

He had never heard of police investigating at the request of a civilian, let alone a university student .

Saitou Yakumo – to Ishii, he was an unfamiliar puzzle of a living thing .

With Yakumo's aloof attitude, there was nothing Ishii could get a hold of . He didn't know how to connect to him . On top of that, there was that red

left eye .

His body trembled just from remembering it .

The greatest puzzle for Ishii was why Haruka was together with that demon-like man .

Ishii didn't know what to think of Yakumo who would order the police around like it was completely natural, but it perplexed Ishii even more that Gotou accepted Yakumo's request so easily .

That Gotou was reclining on a chair behind him and whistling while plucking out nostril hairs . Furthermore, he was scattering the nostril hairs he plucked onto the floor, which was –

While Ishii was mulling over his thoughts, the data he had been looking for showed up on his monitor .

'Detective Gotou, I've found it . '

Gotou responded to Ishii's voice and peeked at the monitor from behind him .

'April, five years ago – a woman's corpse was found in this apartment's courtyard . '

Ishii read the information displayed on the monitor .

'A murder?'

Gotou rubbed at the stubble on his chin .

'Er... The final report states that it was a suicide . '

'That's certain?'

Gotou held a cigarette in his mouth and lit it as he spoke .

'Though no note was found, it was judged to be a suicide from circumstantial evidence . '

'Circumstantial evidence?'

Gotou frowned and spat out his cigarette .

'Yes . Half a year before she committed suicide, she was the victim of an assault . '

'Assault?'

Gotou's voice cracked . He was openly discomfited .

Ishii was of the same mental state . Rape was one of the most repugnant crimes . It was not as if the perpetrator had a grudge . They had no distinct reason for why they had to do it .

It was a base and filthy crime that one-sidedly hurt women for their own lust .

'A victim report was submitted to the police . '

A suicide from psychological shock –

Though Ishii didn't know what sort of person she was, considering her feelings, she could definitely have been thinking about committing suicide . He had heard of women in the same situation who had actually killed themselves .

'Do you know her name?'

'Er... Sawaguchi Rika . She had been twenty- two at the time . '

The moment Ishii said that name, Gotou's expression stiffened .

'I can't believe it was this case...'

Gotou spoke in a quiet voice that was almost inaudible .

'Excuse me, Detective Gotou...'

'Print out that info for me,' Gotou said quickly, interrupting Ishii .

Ishii immediately printed out the documents for the case and handed them to Gotou .

'Excuse me, Detective Gotou...'

– Do you know this woman?

Ishii wanted to continue with that, but Gotou left the room before he could finish speaking .

Ishii felt something serious from that murmur .

11

'Sorry to disturb you . '

Gotou opened the door to Yakumo's secret hiding place .

A wave of hot air assaulted Gotou's face . How could anybody stand to stay in this sauna of a room? Yakumo was sitting in the chair in front of him, with sleepy eyes as usual .

'If you know you're disturbing me, please head home,' Yakumo said, not even looking at him .

What a remark .

'You're the one who called me . '

'I just said that there was something I wanted you to look into . '

'And I brought the documents you asked for . '

Gotou sat in the chair opposite Yakumo and threw an envelope with the documents in it at Yakumo .

'I appreciate your efforts . '

Yakumo finally looked up . He took the documents out of the envelope and lined them up on the table .

'So there really was a woman who committed suicide at that apartment...'
Yakumo said while looking over the documents .

'Yeah,' Gotou replied curtly, and he looked down at his feet while putting a cigarette into his mouth .

'Gotou-san...'

'I know . I won't light up . '

Gotou interrupted Yakumo before he said it .

'You're in a bad temper,' Yakumo said with a sigh . Gotou searched for words to deny it but he didn't find any .

I'm so angry I can't do anything about it . My stomach is queasy like I've got a hangover .

This anger is at myself –

'Her death was partly my fault,' Gotou said, though it was the opposite of his intention .

'Did you commit adultery?'

'That's not it . '

And he had blurted it out in front of the most troublesome guy ever too .

'What happened?'

Yakumo looked at Gotou with serious eyes – perhaps he understood the severity of the situation .

Gotou couldn't keep his mouth shut after he had come so far . He hit his own cheek with his palm to change his mood .

'She was the victim of an assault half a year before her suicide . She was a fourth-year university student and was going to graduate soon . '

What sort of future did Sawaguchi Rika picture for herself –

She might have already decided on her occupation by that time . She probably had a boyfriend whom she talked about her future with .

It became harder to breathe the more Gotou thought about it .

'And then?'

'She was abducted on the way home from her part-time job and assaulted . She probably resisted furiously . There are several signs that she was hit in the face . After the assault, she was thrown out at the park . It was awful . '

Though Yakumo was feigning a blank expression, Gotou could tell that he was gritting his back teeth .

Gotou felt the same way . Any man who had truly loved a woman even once would never commit such an idiotic crime .

He would never be able to forgive the same thing happening to the woman he cherished .

'Then what did she do?' Yakumo pressed, running his fingers through his hair .

'What did she do?'

'Rape is a crime that requires a formal complaint from the victim to prosecute, yes?'

He really was sharp . It was just as Yakumo said . Rape required a formal complaint to prosecute . Unless there were multiple perpetrators, the police wouldn't move unless the victim pressed charges .

That could sometimes be troublesome .

Almost all of the victims ended up keeping their mouths shut in order to seal away their abhorrent memories . They wanted to forget the experience as quickly as they could and return to everyday life . That wasn't bad . It was even natural to think that way .

However, that made it so that many rapes were left unreported . Naturally, the perpetrators foresaw that .

'We were about to give up when she agreed to cooperate with the investigation . '

'Were you the one in charge then, Gotou-san?'

'To be more accurate, my partner then – a female detective called Shimamura – was the one who corresponded with her . '

Usually, female investigators would be in charge of rape cases .

Well, it was to be expected . It meant that Gotou hadn't actually directly talked to Sawaguchi Rika .

He had just seen her face in the documents .

Gotou couldn't forget Rika's face in the photo even now .

A blue bruise had surrounded her left eye . There had been a laceration on her cheek which made it look like she had been dragged, and blood had oozed from the corners of her lips .

It was a photo you would unconsciously avert your eyes from . However, Rika wasn't frightened or terrified in the photo . She was simply looking forward with strong intent .

Her will hadn't been broken .

He would drag the criminal out no matter what he had to do . Gotou had vowed that then –

'She cooperated with the investigation then . '

'Yeah . '

'Why would a person like that commit suicide...'

Yakumo was extremely doubtful .

There was a huge difference between pressing charges and not pressing charges afterwards .

The victims of assault were severely wounded emotionally, so they would lose their memories of the incident, re-experience the incident through flashbacks, suffer insomnia – a variety of stressful barriers .

There were also some people who excessively blamed themselves and felt that they brought the incident upon themselves .

Assault caused women incredible psychological damage .

In the middle of that, she faced the case on her own with a strong heart and tried to overcome it despite her injuries .

That's certain . But –

'Do you know the phrase “second rape”?’

'Yes . It refers to a psychological rape that occurs due to police interviews and slander from thoughtless people . '

This guy really was different from somebody like Ishii – the conversation went quickly .

'That's right . For her, it was the police investigation . '

'That is the worst . '

'You're right . “You're not a virgin – you brought it on yourself, didn't you? What colour was your underwear? It could be seen, couldn't it? How was

your first sexual encounter?" It wasn't how the victim should have been corresponded with at all . '

Gotou hit the desk with his fist in his anger, which had built up .

There was a limit even to insensibility . They had completely ignored the victim's emotions . It was like slashing at the victim's weakened heart .

This could be called the crime of the police .

'You weren't the one who asked such vulgar questions, Gotou-san . '

'Of course not!'

'That would mean you were left out of the initial stages of the investigation .
,

Gotou couldn't answer Yakumo's query and clenched his fists tightly .

His chest hurt like he had been stabbed with a needle .

'The day right after her case, a murdered corpse was found at a flat . '

'And you were sent over there?'

Ideuchi had been his boss then too .

Gotou, who couldn't understand, had naturally opposed it . However, Ideuchi didn't comply with him . At the time, Ideuchi had said, 'If you don't want to be put out to dry, obediently listen to what I have to say . Investigation is teamwork . '

It was a natural decision from the police's standpoint . They didn't have enough members to do all the investigations equally . They had no choice but to prioritise investigations .

Now it was too late to regret it .

'Me and the female detective Shimamura were left out and two newbies were sent in...'

'And then she committed suicide . '

Yakumo said just that, and suddenly Gotou's heart was throbbing .

That's right . She killed herself –

Why did I give up then? She might have died even if I had been in charge, but I might still have been able to treat her better .

No, that was wrong . Inside my heart, she wouldn't have died . That's what I thought –

No matter how many words he lined up grandly, the truth was that he didn't understand the victim's emotions .

The weight of regret clung to Gotou, and though he carried it now, it wouldn't leave .

Now that he thought about it, that had been the start of the antagonism between Gotou and Ideuchi .

After that case, Gotou wouldn't obey instructions and would cut him off whenever he could, all the while enforcing his will for an investigation that he trusted .

If he could return to that time, he would probably take charge of her investigation even if he had to punch Ideuchi to do it .

However, that was just a story of possibilities . The past couldn't be changed .

'Gotou-san, it is too late to regret it now . Let us at least save her spirit . '

This guy, putting on airs .

But it's just as Yakumo says . A life that's been lost won't come back, so at least –

'You don't have to tell me,' Gotou said with a snort .

'In order to do that, we must find the reason her spirit is wandering . '

'OK . '

'Was the perpetrator arrested?'

'Yeah, but after she killed herself . Ironically, her parents used her suicide to tell the press how awful the police's response had been . They said their daughter had been killed by the police... The press found that laughable and made a fuss . With all that excitement, a full-blown investigation got started . '

As Gotou said that, it left a terrible aftertaste in his mouth that was hard to bear .

'That investigation bore fruit then . '

'No, that's not it . Though there was info on the criminal, it was a complete coincidence that he was caught . Oori Kazushi . He had been twenty-five at the time . A regular company employee . When he was inspected to see if he had been drinking, he had been a bit strange, and when his car was investigated, there was a picture that was believed to have been taken at the time of the assault . '

'If the perpetrator has been found, there is another reason for her wandering then . '

'For example?'

'Maybe she has something she wants to tell her parents... What happened to her parents?'

Here, Gotou felt a heavy weight on his shoulders again .

'Maybe because of all the anxiety she'd felt, her mother died of heart failure right after the criminal was arrested . Her father moved out of their flat and is renting now . '

'Is that so?'

Yakumo put a finger to his brow and looked like he was thinking about something, but looked up at the ceiling in exhaustion, like his thoughts hadn't come together .

'Well, though it may be troublesome, it seems like the only thing to do is to reconsider the situation of the case . '

After a silence, Yakumo said just this .

'Yeah . '

Just as Yakumo said, it didn't seem like there was any other method .

12

Asami's apartment was by a large street .

It was nine storeys tall and in the shape of a left-facing square bracket . It had undressed concrete walls and a red line on the border of the floor .

It was one of those designer apartments that were so popular now .

Led by Asami, Makoto and Kamiyama took the elevator up to the ninth and highest floor and went along the outdoor corridor with Asami showing them the way .

It seemed the apartment only had an elevator on one end, so they had to walk down the long outdoor corridor .

After turning two corners, there was Asami's room at the very end .

Though Asami had been fine until she opened the door, she refused to go inside and turned away from the room while shaking .

Makoto felt afraid too, but because Asami was in such a state, she was able to bear it .

'Please forgive my intrusion,' said Kamiyama . He turned on the light and entered the room .

'Wait here,' Makoto told Asami, and then she followed Kamiyama into the room .

Since they had just met again yesterday, this was the first time she had gone to Asami's room .

Makoto took off her pumps in the entrance that only had enough room for one person to stand and went down the hall that also functions as the kitchen . The door at the end of the hall was an eight-tatami room .

Asami had said she had just moved in, and it looked like it – the room didn't feel lived in at all .

While Kamiyama mumbled something or other, he looked around the room slowly, at the veranda, the modular bathroom and the closet .

It looked more like the exorcist was inspecting the room's facilities than looking at spirits .

'So it's just as I thought . '

After he was done looking around, Kamiyama crossed his arms like he had understood something .

'Did you find something out?'

'Yes . There is no issue . '

Kamiyama gave a short reply to Makoto's question and briskly returned to the entrance .

'Asami-san, it's fine for you to come in as well . '

When Kamiyama called out to her, Asami turned around, looking surprised .

'Is it really OK?'

Makoto spoke for the doubts Asami was feeling .

'I said this before as well, but the spirit that had been Asami-san's room is probably a wandering spirit . '

'Is it OK because it's a wandering spirit?'

Makoto drew closer to Kamiyama .

'It did not have any hatred for Asami-san personally . Asami-san experienced the spiritual phenomena, so its goal has been accomplished . That's all . '

'Is that true?'

Asami's gaze clung to Kamiyama .

Kamiyama was completely unperturbed, and he calmly repeated, 'It's fine . ' Asami, perhaps in her relief, sat down with a thump in the corridor like she had collapsed .

Somehow, Makoto felt like she had been deceived .

It might have been a let-down since she had been more terrified than necessary .

However, it was also true that a great uneasiness was spreading in the back of Makoto's mind, though it was obscure .

Is this really the end –

After Haruka took a shower and returned to her room, her mobile phone started ringing .

This was rare . No, it might have been the first time . The person calling was Yakumo .

If she answered right away, it'd be like she had been waiting for a call . Haruka took her time drying her hair and then called Yakumo .

'Sorry, I was taking a shower . What is it?'

<It's about the apartment we went to today . >

Yakumo skipped exchanging greetings and started with the topic at hand .

Gotou-san had probably given him the results of the investigation . Now that she thought about it, Yakumo wouldn't call her without a reason .

Well, it was nice that he was giving her an explanation about the case without her having to ask him for one .

'Did you find something out?'

<Yeah . There really was a woman who committed suicide at that apartment . >

'Really?'

That would mean what the exorcist called Kamiyama said was true .

However, Haruka didn't dare to say that aloud .

<Her name is Sawaguchi Rika . I also tentatively know the reason for her suicide . >

'Tentatively?'

Yakumo's tone felt a bit negligent for some reason .

<Accordingly, I'd like to hear your opinion as a woman . >

'If you're fine with me . '

It made Haruka happy to hear Yakumo say <as a woman> .

However, she didn't say that aloud or let it show in her attitude . Yakumo, being contrary, would definitely say something sarcastic to ruin it . <Only biologically> or something like that .

<A few months before that woman killed herself, she was raped . >

Haruka felt a discomfort in her abdomen .

For a woman, that word had a very cold and heavy sound . Every woman had probably thought about it once .

If it had been me –

'Is that why she killed herself?'

'Well, that's how it's become formally . But something doesn't fit . '

'Doesn't fit?'

Haruka didn't understand what didn't fit for Yakumo .

If she thought about how she would feel if she had been the one who was assaulted, she understood very well the feelings of a woman who would want to die, and the number of people who actually did commit suicide wasn't small either .

Though the physical injuries would heal, the injuries of the heart from the assault would stay with them until they died .

<After that woman was assaulted, she cooperated with the police investigation . >

Yakumo said that to respond to Haruka's doubts .

She could see what Yakumo meant .

Cooperating with the police investigation meant that she wanted to officially announce what happened herself . That meant she had a lot of courage . She had to have been very strong mentally .

For a person like that to commit suicide –

Haruka also understood why something didn't fit for Yakumo .

<When the police were investigating, it seems that they said awful things to her . There is a possibility that that became the trigger . >

Haruka knew about that too .

She had heard a bit about it in her criminal psychology lecture . The mental contempt that was called second rape .

Why did victims have to remember terrible memories and have salt rubbed in their wounds?

'That's unforgiveable,' Haruka said without thinking, her anger rising .

<Looking at it as a woman, what do you think was her cause for suicide?>

Yakumo's words sounded terribly funny to Haruka .

Though the gears in Yakumo's head always turned quickly, he would think about human emotions like chemical reactions, perhaps because he had shut off his heart .

Human emotions didn't adhere to fixed laws .

'I don't think there was one clear reason though . '

<What do you mean?>

'They wouldn't lead to suicide if you think about everything separately, but I think I can understand well enough if you put everything together . '

Since Yakumo was listening silently for once, Haruka continued her explanation .

'For example, if you listen to the story of why a couple broke up, there usually isn't a specific reason – it might have been the trigger, but in the end, it's because a variety of things piled up . '

<So the composited minor factors drove her into a wall?>

When Yakumo said it, it sounded like an abstruse mathematical formula .

'Well, something like that . I think people reach their limits all at once . '

<I see . >

'But there might be some factor that we don't know about . '

Haruka didn't want to think about it, but there was a possibility that the woman got pregnant from the rape .

A man probably couldn't understand how much pain a woman would suffer psychologically if that was the case .

<As you say, there may be some reason we don't know about . In that sense, we can't throw away the possibility that it wasn't suicide . >

Really? Did that mean Yakumo thought it was possible it wasn't suicide?

It couldn't be a murder disguised as a suicide, could it? That exorcist's words came back to Haruka in her head . 'She has a violent hatred . ' If it had been a murder, Haruka could understand what that exorcist had said .

Yakumo might have been thinking about the same thing .

<Thank you . That was useful . >

Haruka couldn't believe her ears .

That Yakumo said <Thank you> to her .

She endured the feeling of wanting to jump up and down and said, extremely naturally, 'No problem . '

<That's right . I've got a request for you . >

'A request?'

<You helped me with this once before too . A simple investigation . >

It didn't feel bad having Yakumo ask her for something, but why did she have an unbelievably bad feeling?

14

Gotou arrived at the door to the police quarters and drew back his hand, which had been about to press the intercom button .

Just as Yakumo said, the only way to save her spirit was to re-examine the case .

He knew it would be finished up in a hurry if he talked to Shimamura Eriko, who had first been in charge of the case .

The reason Gotou was hesitating was that his wife, Atsuko, might have been behind this door .

She had left home this time because Gotou had forgotten their wedding anniversary .

He hadn't forgotten . He had actually remembered it clearly . However, that didn't mean he could do something like buy flowers and bring them home . It wasn't in Gotou's character .

It might have been fine if he just apologised honestly, but a man wasn't that sort of creature . Even though he had a number of excuses, in the end, it might have just been embarrassing .

Though he didn't remember when he had first met his wife Atsuko, he could still remember clearly the clothes she had been wearing and her

hairstyle .

When he'd first met her, he had thought, 'I'm going to marry this woman . '

What was he getting so worked up about? There was no reason for him to be restrained around his own wife .

Gotou shook his head to clear his mind and pressed the intercom button .

'Yes?'

The door opened immediately, and a large woman appeared . She was Shimamura Eriko .

She had a candid personality like her appearance . Atsuko had said that Gotou and Eriko were like siblings .

Gotou raised his hand and said, 'Hi . '

'Unfortunately, Atsuko's returned home . Some make-up is arriving by mail order . '

Gotou heaved a sigh in relief .

His wife wasn't here, and she had returned home . He was relieved about both those things .

'Oh . '

'Honestly, you two should really let it up . You shouldn't be fighting so much at this age,' Eriko grumbled .

This woman really went on . That's why her husband ran off . Well, Gotou wasn't in a situation where he could say anything about anyone else .

'More importantly, I want to talk to you about work . '

'What? Are you thinking about switching jobs?'

'I'm serious . '

Eriko opened the door wide and urged him inside, perhaps because she had seen how earnest his gaze had been .

They went through a living room with bottles of alcohol and sweets wrappers scattered about .

They were really spread out . Even a man living alone wouldn't have made such a mess .

'Why don't you clean up a bit?'

'I'm just going to say this, but this is all your wife's work . I do at least clean up . '

Gotou had planned on saying something sarcastic, but he received a harsh comeback .

It made his head hurt when he thought about two women getting excited over speaking ill of their husbands .

Eriko threw the magazines on the sofa to the floor and made space for herself to sit .

'So, what did you want to talk about?'

'Do you remember that case?'

While Gotou answered Shimamura's question with a question, he sat cross-legged on the cushion on the floor .

'Which case? You never explain enough . That's why Atsuko...'

'Sawaguchi Rika . '

When Gotou said the name, Eriko's face turned stiff .

As he thought, Shimamura hadn't forgotten either . Cases with bad aftertastes stayed in your heart .

'Why are you talking about that now?'

Eriko's suspicions were natural . That case was already over .

The victim committed suicide . The criminal was arrested . That had been the end of it .

I'll have to talk about Yakumo to explain the whole story, but will she believe me –

Although Gotou broached the topic, he was at a loss for an answer .

'Could this be related to that young man you're acquainted with who can see ghosts?'

Eriko brought up the subject while looking at him with searching eyes .

This was unexpected .

'Oi, why do you know about Yakumo?'

'I heard from Hata-san . '

Hata was the perverted old man who asserted that his job as a coroner was his hobby .

They had worked together on a number of cases and he knew about Yakumo . Though his skill was excellent, he had loose lips on top of being weird .

'That old man, spouting off about...'

'Hey, is it true?'

Eriko leaned forward in immense curiosity .

'Is what true?'

'That the young man can see ghosts . '

He couldn't deny it after coming this far .

'It's true . You don't need to force yourself to believe it, but me and Yakumo are unfortunately inseparable . He's cooperated on a number of cases with his ability to see ghosts . '

Gotou lit a cigarette .

Eriko looked displeased, but she placed an empty can in front of Gotou .

'I believe you . When you do this sort of work, you experience this sort of thing even if you don't want to,' said Eriko jokingly .

'The explanation will go quickly then . '

'So you think there's still another side to that case?'

'I don't know, but according to Yakumo, that girl's spirit is still wandering...'

'Wandering?'

'Yeah . I want to know the reason too . It's already been five years since then, so why is she still wandering?'

After Eriko's gaze wandered like she was thinking about something, she gulped down the can of beer in her hand .

'That case had been full of things I didn't understand from the very beginning . It was unnatural . '

'Unnatural?'

'Wasn't it? Why did we get left out of the investigation?'

Eriko was clearly agitated .

'We were put to another investigation . '

'But it was just a lack of common sense to put two detectives new to assault cases in charge – and two men on top of that .

'That's true . '

'Plus, in the files, it said there was no note left behind, but one of the investigation members who went to the scene said they'd seen a note . Everyone felt uncomfortable since that disappeared . '

'Really...'

This was the first time Gotou had heard that .

'There's more . After she killed herself, her parents called the police killers, right? The criminal was caught right after that, when there hadn't been a proper investigation up until then . The timing is too good!'

Eriko forcefully slammed her fist on the table .

Her breathing was erratic . It felt like she had vented all the resentment she had kept until now .

In the vertically structured police, you had to obey the instructions from above even if you couldn't understand them at all .

On top of that, cases just kept on coming . Even if you didn't understand, you had to shelve those feelings away . Resentment piled up even if you didn't want it to .

Gotou himself had experienced many hardships –

In any case, Eriko's words just now made Gotou's suspicions swell tremendously .

'Hey, I've got a request I want to make for old times' sake . '

'You asking me to re-examine the assault case?'

'Yeah . I'll look into the background of the case . Look into the detectives in charge at the time indirectly for me . '

Eriko bit her thick lips . Was she hesitating?

'Do you not want to?'

'Of course I'm going to do it . '

Eriko answered Gotou's question with a puffed chest . Though the woman had no charm, she was reliable .

15

Yuuya lay sprawled on the sofa, absentmindedly listening to music .

He wasn't doing anything or thinking about anything – he just really liked this feeling of rocking like he was on water .

Though his home was nearby, he almost never returned since he'd met Shinichi . He was completely freeloading at Shinichi's flat .

He didn't get along with his father . Especially after his mother had died – they'd run into each other more often at home, which made it worse .

It wasn't like they had big fights . Yuuya didn't know what to talk about . It was probably the same for the other party .

That was why his father hadn't made even one complaint about his not returning home .

– Since living alone in a 2LDK is wearisome .

Shinichi took Yuuya in quickly too, and loved him like a younger brother .

A light wind blew . He looked over and saw the curtains moving . Had the window been open? Yuuya raised his head and looked at the window that

connected to the veranda .

Rattle . Something passed behind him .

Eh, but Shinichi-san wasn't supposed to be home yet . Yuuya sat up .

This time, he felt like something had passed by outside the window . What could it be? Yuuya stood up, slowly approached the window and drew open the curtains .

Suddenly, the lights in the room went out .

In the semi-darkness, a pallid light reflected in the window .

In that light, there was a figure of a person standing –

'Aagh!'

Yuuya fell down backwards while screaming .

There was a woman outside the window .

A woman whose face was dyed bright red with blood .

The woman who had been reflected in the mirror in the lavatory at the bar last night .

Yuuya crawled towards the entrance to leave the room .

When he reached the entrance, the door suddenly opened and Shinichi came in .

'Help . The woman – the woman,' Yuuya begged, clinging to Shinichi's feet .

'What are you so excited about?'

Shinichi shook Yuuya's shoulders, but Yuuya couldn't give a proper answer to Shinichi's question in his upset state .

– You die too!

Suddenly, a voice came down upon them .

Shinichi and Yuuya went stiff for a moment . After they both looked at each other, they screamed and rushed out of the room .

* * *

The bartender at Bar <Snake> was cleaning up after the bar had closed for the night with a cigarette in his mouth .

He didn't have the surplus to hire workers . The bar was barely scraping by financially .

It hadn't been like this a few years ago . He got as much money as he wanted if he asked his parents for it . Even without doing work, he enjoyed a life of leisure with dignity .

Now, he had to stock, serve customers and even clean the shop himself .

He knew that lamenting wouldn't bring back his past life .

It was just that he'd had some extraordinary income lately .

He hadn't thought that something inherited from the past could be changed into a product . Putting it out all at once would make things difficult later . He'd look for the right time to make a bit of money .

Clank . There was the sound of something falling .

'What is it?'

The bartender walked out from the counter and looked around the bar . The mop that had been leaning against the wall had fallen . Looked like he had forgotten to put it away .

The bartender picked up the mop and opened the locker by the lavatory –

His breath got caught in his throat in his surprise so he couldn't even breathe .

There was a woman in the locker .

Her face was covered in blood and long hair hung over her face .

– Die!

That's what the woman said .

'Aaahh!'

The bartender hurriedly shut the locker door and jumped back .

His eyes must have deceived him . He said that to himself .

The fuss last night had just gotten on his nerves . It'd be clear if he just opened the locker door again .

– Die .

Just when he had put his hand on the locker's door handle, he heard a voice from behind him .

A cold sweat ran down his body .

He cautiously turned around .

The same blood-covered woman he saw earlier was there –

'Aaaaahh!'

On the floor, the bartender went down on his hands and knees . Then, he rushed out of the bar .

16

Ishii left the police quarters and headed for the parking lot in the back .

He had waited until the date changed at midnight, but Detective Gotou hadn't come back .

He'd tried calling his mobile a few times but he hadn't gotten a message back, so there was nothing for him to do but go home .

But recently, he'd been wondering if things were really OK like this . Other investigation team members would work to the point that they didn't even have time to sleep –

That said, he didn't like intense cases like the serial abduction case they had last time . Thrilling and exciting cases .

Just as Ishii opened the car door on the driver's side, somebody suddenly appeared in front of him .

'Excuse me, Ishii-san . '

'Eek . '

Ishii shrieked without thinking .

'Ah, sorry . It's me . Makoto . '

Makoto walked in front of Ishii and bowed her head .

'A-ah, Makoto-san . What are you doing here at this time of night?'

Though Ishii spoke as calmly as he could, his heart was still beating furiously .

Plus, Ishii was traumatised by what Makoto in her possessed state had done to him last case .

Of course, he knew it wasn't her fault, but he still felt scared .

'Actually, there is something I would like to consult you about, Ishii-san, so I decided on my own to wait for you . '

'Until this time of night?'

'Sorry - I must be troubling you . '

Makoto cast down her almond eyes .

'Ah, no, that's not it . I just thought that if you called me, I wouldn't have made you wait so long,' Ishii hurriedly explained, overcome by a strange feeling of guilt .

'I thought it would be rude to interrupt your work . That is, it's a personal matter . '

'A personal matter... is it?'

'Yes . It won't take that much time . '

Makoto bowed her head again .

'Ah, if you're fine with me, please tell me . Since it's already this late, I'll drive you home as well . '

Makoto was the daughter of the chief of the police . He couldn't turn her request down flat . Plus, it would be a problem if he let her go home alone at this time and anything happened .

'Sorry for this . '

'Please don't worry about it . '

After waiting for Makoto to get in the passenger's seat, Ishii started the car .

'So what did you want to talk about?' Ishii asked, his hands on the wheel .

'The truth is that there is something I would like to ask your opinion about, Ishii-san . '

'My opinion?'

'Yes . '

After Makoto nodded, she started talking about the spiritual phenomena at the bar and the exorcist she met this evening .

Without thinking, Ishii was lost in what Makoto was saying . He really did like this sort of thing .

However, actually experiencing it was a different matter . He had fully realised that last case . He enjoyed this because he was listening as an outsider .

'What do you think, Ishii-san?'

After she finished talking, Makoto asked for his opinion in the end .

'What exactly do you mean?'

'I can't explain this clearly, but I have a very bad feeling for some reason . '

A breath escaped Makoto's glossy lips .

She hung her head . The nape of her neck was pale and captivating, reflected in Ishii's eyes almost like a different creature entirely .

'However, that exorcist said that there was no need to worry any more since it was a wandering spirit . '

'Yes, but...'

Ishii understood well what Makoto was trying to say . It wasn't something that could easily be agreed to with 'Yes, I see' after being told 'It's fine now' .

'Well, since an expert said it, I think that it's fine . '

'Is it really fine?'

Makoto looked at Ishii worriedly and grasped Ishii's hand .

Her hand was cold . In the back of Ishii's mind, that terror came back to him .

'Eek . '

Ishii shrieked instinctively and slammed the brakes .

For a moment, Ishii's head went blank . Cold sweat dripped down his forehead .

'Is something the matter?'

Makoto looked at Ishii in surprise .

'Ah, no, er, a cat suddenly...'

Ishii hurriedly wiped the sweat from his forehead and fixed the position of his glasses with the tip of his finger .

'A cat? Was there one there?'

'Ah, no, that's . Ahaha . '

While Ishii was lost for a reply, a mobile phone started ringing .

Makoto took her mobile from her bag and picked up after saying, 'Please excuse me for a bit . '

'Asami? What's wrong?'

Asami... Was it the woman from the story earlier who experienced the spiritual phenomena?

'Hey, calm down . '

Makoto sounded cornered .

'Leave that room as soon as you can... eh, you can't leave...'

Ishii had a very bad feeling .

'Got it . I'll go right away . '

Makoto hung up just as she finished speaking .

'Ishii-san, excuse me . Thank you for today . '

Ishii stopped Makoto as she was about to open the door .

It's not as if there was any official report, but it seems like something serious is happening . I am a policeman, so I can't let this pass .

Detective Gotou had said this . Adaptability –

'Please tell me the location . '

For a moment, Makoto looked perplexed, but she bowed her head right after and said, 'Please . '

17

Ishii, who stopped his car in front of the apartment temporarily to let Makoto off, went to visitor parking to park his car and followed her immediately .

Makoto was saying something to the interphone in front of the apartment's entrance .

Though she normally seemed like a calm woman, she was considerably agitated now and her voice sounded hysterical .

Then, a man in a black suit came in .

The moment Makoto saw him, she let out an 'Ah!' . The man also nodded like they knew each other .

'Makoto-san, yes? Did you also come to see Asami-san?' he said to Makoto, his breath also feeble .

'Yes . '

While Makoto was answering, the auto-lock glass front door opened .

'I was also called by Asami-san . '

The man wiped the thin layer of sweat from his brow and went through the entrance .

Both Ishii and Makoto followed .

The man pressed the button for the only elevator and looked at Ishii after breathing deeply . His gaze was piercing .

Even though Ishii hadn't done anything wrong, he felt ill at ease .

'Ishii-san, this person is the exorcist I mentioned earlier – '

Inferring the mood, Makoto introduced the man to Ishii . So this man was the exorcist –

'My name is Kamiyama . '

Following Makoto's words, Kamiyama bowed his head politely .

'My name is Ishii . I'm a detective . '

Ishii bowed his head like Kamiyama .

'Police?'

Kamiyama spoke like he hadn't heard correctly . Why is the police here – he looked like he wanted to ask that .

Just as Makoto opened her mouth to explain, a mobile phone started ringing .

'Asami!'

Makoto answered right away .

'...You OK? I'm just about to get on the elevator...'

At that point, the elevator arrived .

Makoto, Ishii and finally Kamiyama got in, and he pushed the button for the ninth floor .

With the sound of the winch, the elevator started going up .

'... Hello? Hello?'

<Aaaah!>

A woman's scream came through Makoto's phone's speaker .

Right after that, the call ended .

Makoto gripped her mobile and looked up at the ceiling anxiously .

'I apologise . This is my responsibility . '

Kamiyama looked up at the ceiling as he said that . Who was he saying it to? He bit his lower lip and looked like he was enduring the pain .

In this box full of tension, it felt like somehow only Ishii had been left behind .

When the elevator door opened, Kamiyama flew out first . Then, Makoto followed . Ishii didn't understand what was happening but he ran after the two of them .

It was a narrow passage that could only let one person through at a time .

They went through the outside corridor straight in front of the elevator they got off of and turned right after three rooms . They turned right again after three more rooms .

Makoto suddenly stopped .

Ishii almost ran into her back but stopped himself just on the verge of it .

They were in front of the room at the very end of the corridor .

'Asami-san . Are you all right?' said Kamiyama while pressing the intercom button and rattling the doorknob .

'Asami, you OK?'

Makoto couldn't bear it and butted in from the side .

Kamiyama lost his balance and stumbled, dropping to his knees .

However, Makoto didn't seem to notice – she turned the doorknob and hammered on the door . Ishii just watched, not knowing what to do .

'Asami, you're here, right? Talk to me!' Makoto shouted . However, there was no response .

'Asami-san! Are you all right? Asami-san! Asami-san!'

After standing up, Kamiyama switched places with Makoto and knocked on the door while yelling .

Makoto took out her mobile and made a call .

'Quiet,' Makoto commanded .

Though it was faint, there was the sound of a phone ringing from inside the flat .

Now Ishii understood . Makoto was calling Asami's mobile . It was certain that she was inside the room .

'Ishii-san, could you borrow the key?' Makoto suggested .

This was an emergency situation . He could probably borrow a key if he went to the management office and showed his ID .

'Understood . '

Ishii nodded and ran .

What on earth was happening? Though Ishii didn't like experiencing things like this first-hand, but things didn't look good for him .

Ishii took the elevator back to the first floor and went to the management office to say he was a policeman . He explained the situation and borrowed the master key .

Ishii returned with the key and, urged by Makoto's and Kamiyama's gazes, put the key into the doorknob without even time to breathe .

A cold sweat was slowly coming down his forehead .

– I can't open this door .

He heard someone's voice . It was his cowardly other self . However, he couldn't run away now .

'I'm opening the door,' Ishii declared, and he turned the key .

The key turned with a click . Opening the door now .

But I'm scared . I'm really scared –

What on earth was behind this door? While Ishii was thinking, Makoto pushed in from the side and opened the door forcefully .

Though Ishii didn't shriek, he did jump back from the door .

'Asami!'

Makoto ran into the room .

Kamiyama followed her . There was no way Ishii could stay outside .

He slowly passed through the door and looked around the room from the entrance . The lights were on . There were no signs of a struggle .

There was no sign in the room of a woman who could be Asami .

It was completely empty .

'Ah!'

Makoto raised her voice .

This wasn't the time to be frightened . After taking off his shoes, Ishii entered the room and went up to Makoto .

Makoto was pointing at a point on the floor . On top of the carpet by the bed .

A mobile phone red with blood had fallen there . It wasn't dry yet . Wet blood –

Ishii couldn't make a sound in his shock .

'Asami! Asami!'

Makoto's voice rose nearly to a shriek . There was no response .

Ishii couldn't understand at all .

Right before they came here, Makoto had been talking to Asami on her mobile .

The call had cut off partway through on the elevator, but they hadn't even taken a minute to reach the room .

After they arrived at the room, Ishii left to get the key, but Makoto and Kamiyama had been in front of the room .

Naturally, nobody sneaked into the room, and nobody had left .

'Asami disappeared...' Makoto said, collapsing to her knees .

That's ridiculous –

Ishii fervently looked around the room in order to deny his unbelievable thoughts .

The key to the room was on the table .

The window that led to the veranda was also locked from the inside . There was no space for somebody to hide – not in the modular bath, the closet or above the ceiling .

Ishii's hopes were crushed .

This situation is –

A woman disappeared from a locked room –

Ridiculous . Impossible .

'If I had noticed earlier...'

Kamiyama bit his lips and he looked remorseful . Noticed? What was he talking about? Kamiyama continued talking like he was addressing Ishii's doubts .

'It hadn't been a wandering spirit that was following Asami-san . It was a residual spirit with a strong and deep hatred...'

Kamiyama's words echoed in Ishii's eyes .

So that means this is the work of a ghost –

Gotou parked his car in front of the entrance of the apartment Ishii had mentioned to him .

It was a private one-room apartment and was strangely shaped like a left-facing square bracket, as if it had been forcibly built on the narrow plot of land .

He called management to have them open the auto-lock and took the elevator .

'Damn, calling me at this time,' grumbled Gotou towards the ceiling,

However, inside his heart, he was worried . Ishii's scared voice over the phone hadn't been normal .

No matter how many times he yelled at him to calm down, Ishii kept on crying that somebody had disappeared and that some vengeful ghost had done something .

After going up to the ninth floor, Gotou went down the long outdoor corridor and pressed the button for the intercom outside the room that Ishii had mentioned .

'Hey . You got dragged into this too?'

Makoto just nodded seriously at Gotou's words .

Why did everyone look like they'd just gotten home from a funeral?
Though Gotou was dissatisfied, he passed through the entrance to the room .

Ishii was sitting, hugging his knees .

'Oi, what happened? Give me a proper explanation . '

Gotou gave Ishii's head a light push .

Normally Ishii would miserably say 'What are you doing?', but he slowly looked up at Gotou and gaped at him without saying anything .

They'd get nowhere like this .

'I don't care who – somebody, explain . '

After Gotou said that loudly, somebody appeared at the window connected to the veranda . He was a man in his late thirties with long, flowing hair and wearing a black suit .

'Let me explain . '

The man spoke calmly but clearly .

'Fine by me, but who are you?'

There was an embarrassed smile on the man's face, like he felt he had been careless . He held out his business card .

Exorcist, Kamiyama Eiji –

That was what it said on the business card . A detective, a newspaper reporter and an exorcist . What a combination .

'I'm Detective...'

'Detective Gotou, yes?' interrupted Kamiyama .

'Why do you know my name?'

'I asked Ishii-san earlier . '

The guy felt suspicious somehow . There were many things Gotou wanted to say, but he had to confirm the situation first .

'What happened?'

Gotou urged Kamiyama to continue .

'Today, Inoue Asami, the owner of this room, consulted me about spiritual phenomena that occurred in her room . '

'Spiritual phenomena?'

'Yes . Asami-san and Makoto-san were friends at university, so the three of us met once in the evening, and then I came to investigate the spiritual phenomena in this room . '

Unlike Ishii, Kamiyama gave an indifferent and competent explanation .

Gotou looked at Makoto, who was standing in a corner of the room . She nodded silently to affirm Kamiyama's explanation .

'Then?'

It felt like it'd be a long explanation . Gotou sat down cross-legged, lit a cigarette and urged Kamiyama to say more .

'At the time, I couldn't confirm the existence of the spirit and left temporarily . However, about one hour before, Asami-san contacted me . She said that spiritual phenomena had occurred again and that she wanted me to save her . I hurriedly came here and met with Makoto-san and Ishii-san at the entrance .

'Ishii, why were you here too?'

Gotou glared at Ishii .

He knew why Makoto and Kamiyama, the exorcist, were here, but Ishii had no reason to be .

Ishii's shoulders shuddered as he tried to say something but no words came out .

'Um, I went to consult Ishii-san about the spiritual phenomena,' Makoto interrupted .

He decided not to boorishly ask why she would go to consult Ishii .

'And?'

'When I went to consult Ishii-san, Asami called me asking for help...'

After saying that much, Makoto's words trailed off .

'So where was the owner of the room who'd asked for help?'

'S-she disappeared...' Ishii said, looking like he was going to cry .

'Reply seriously!'

Gotou hit Ishii's head .

'No, what Ishii-san said is the truth,' Kamiyama said with a puffed chest, like he was proud .

This exorcist was pretty shameless even though he was talking to police .

'Even idiots should think carefully before speaking . '

'No, it's true,' Makoto insisted .

Everyone was saying –

'There's no way a person would disappear . '

'Why can you assert that?'

Kamiyama looked down at Gotou with narrowed eyes .

Gotou didn't like being looked down on . He stood up and glared back .

'Tell me in detail what you mean . '

After glaring at Kamiyama for a while, Gotou turned the conversation to Makoto .

With Ishii like that, she looked like the one who would explain the best .

'After Asami called me, I came with Ishii-san to the apartment . When we arrived at the entrance, we met Kamiyama-san . '

'What time was that?'

'I think it was about twelve thirty . We pressed for the intercom and Asami opened the auto-lock entrance for us . '

'So the woman called Asami was in her room then . '

'Yes . While waiting for the elevator, Asami called me on my mobile phone . She screamed and hung up when we were riding the elevator up . '

'Then?'

'When we reached the room, the door was locked . I asked Ishii-san to borrow the room key the management office . When we unlocked the door and went inside, Asami wasn't there...'

After Makoto said that, she handed something wrapped in a handkerchief to Gotou .

'What is this?'

'That was left in the room . '

Gotou took it and opened the handkerchief .

It was a flip phone . There was a dark red stain on it . It was a bloodstain .

When he looked at it carefully, there was a bloody fingerprint as well .

Is what they're saying true –

Gotou looked at everyone's faces slowly . He really had suspicions that this was a tasteless prank and that one of them might burst out laughing .

However, everyone there looked uniformly serious .

'How about the key to the room? Couldn't she just have gone out?'

'That is...'

Makoto looked to the table .

There was a key there with some small stuffed animal – a cat or a dog – attached to it on a strap .

It was a key for a pin-tumbler lock . The notches of the key were in a complex elliptical shape that would be difficult to reproduce .

'She didn't leave through the window?'

'No, the window was also locked from the inside . '

Makoto rejected Gotou's idea .

'On top of that, even if she did go to the veranda through the window, this is the ninth floor . It is not a height she could have jumped from . I checked earlier, but it also is not connected to the neighbouring veranda,' Kamiyama explained in a much more detective-like manner than Ishii .

Then there had to be another possibility . It was absolutely impossible for someone to disappear .

'Couldn't somebody have taken that woman out of the room while you were riding the elevator?'

'It was at most thirty seconds from when we lost contact with Asami-san to when we arrived in front of this room . Detective Gotou, I think you should understand better than us that that wouldn't be enough time for someone to take somebody who was resisting out of the room and leave without our discovering them,' Kamiyama replied disinterestedly .

The man himself probably didn't mean it that way, but that just sounded sarcastic to Gotou .

'I know that . I'm just going through all the possibilities . Speaking of possibilities, you're the most suspicious . Most exorcists are frauds, right?'

'That is true . '

Gotou had been unprepared for Kamiyama's unexpected answer .

'Y-you...'

'Just as you say, Detective Gotou, there really are many exorcists who are frauds . In particular, those who are affiliated with religions are suspicious .
,

'Why?'

Gotou felt it was the other way around .

'Since in Buddhism and Christianity, it is not believed that the spirits of the dead wander . '

Going off and denying himself .

'Then what about you?'

'I am not affiliated with any religion . However, as an exorcist, I may be a fraud in a sense . '

'What?'

'My method of exorcism is very different from that of other exorcists . '

'Shouldn't everyone be the same?'

'No . I don't know if you will believe me, but I do not exorcise spirits through using charms or chanting spells . '

'Then how do you exorcise them?'

'I have the ability to see spirits . I speak to them and remove their reason for staying where they are . To put it simply, I persuade them . '

'W-what...'

Gotou lost his words .

He had heard what Kamiyama said many times before . His theory was exactly the same as Yakumo's .

At that moment, the lights suddenly went out and the room was blanketed in darkness .

'Eek . '

Ishii's shriek went through the room .

What? What happened –

Something suddenly leapt into Gotou's vision in his confusion .

A woman with long hair –

The left half of her face was covered in blood .

In the dim light, only that woman appeared faintly luminescent .

– Die .

Her cracked voice reverberated .

'You...'

After Gotou said that, the lights went on again .

He closed his eyes for a moment because it was bright, and when he opened his eyes again, the woman was gone .

Where? Where did she go?

She had been standing near the window that went to the veranda . Gotou opened the window and rushed out to the veranda .

However, there was no sign that anybody had been there .

'There is no point following her . She has no body,' Kamiyama said expressionlessly . He did not seem puzzled at all .

Did someone really disappear from a grudge, just as Kamiyama said?

NOTES:

[1] The Koujien (広辞苑, meaning wide garden of words) is a Japanese dictionary which is considered to be the authority on Japanese definitions – the Japanese equivalent of the Oxford English Dictionary .

Volume 3 Chapter 2: VOLUME 3 - THE LIGHT BEYOND THE DARKNESS

Chapter 2

VOLUME 3 - THE LIGHT BEYOND THE DARKNESS

file 02: curse (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

‘Old man, you here?’

Gotou opened the door by force .

He found the person he was looking for right away . He was sipping tea at his desk by the wall in the room of about four and a half tatami in size .

He was Hata Hideyoshi, the perverted old man whose job as a coroner was his hobby .

Once Hata looked at Gotou’s face, he let out an ostentatious sigh .

Gotou was surrounded by guys like this . Wasn’t there anyone who was more honest and serious?

Ishii’s face showed up in Gotou’s grumbling mind . He was no good . Though he was serious, there was a problem with his level of it .

After shaking his head, Gotou sat on the round chair opposite Hata .

'What do you need from me this early in the morning? I don't have the time to babysit you,' said Hata, a frown on his wrinkled face .

This guy was annoying . Gotou didn't have the time to drink tea with a demon either .

'There's something I want you to look into . '

'If it's an investigation, make a request through the proper channels . Last time I went in on my own, yes? I got quite a talking to for that . '

Hata let out a high-pitched giggle that didn't sound human at all .

We don't have the time to be laughing . It's really creepy, so could you stop, you demonic old man –

'But I came all this way because it isn't a request that I could make through the proper channels . '

'You like picking up trouble too, don't you?'

Of course he didn't pick up trouble because he wanted to .

Restraining his irritation, Gotou put a plastic bag with the mobile phone inside on Hata's desk . It was their only clue right now .

The blood-stained mobile phone that had been left in Asami's room .

'What's this?'

'A mobile phone . '

'I can tell that by looking . I'm asking what the details behind it are . You really are an idiot . '

This old man just went and said whatever he liked . Gotou was at the point where he wanted to break his neck, but he didn't have the time for that now .

'Yesterday, a woman living in an apartment suddenly disappeared . '

'A disappearance? Then why don't you just investigate it normally?'

'It's a bit of a messy situation . '

'Messy?'

'Yeah . Seems like Ishii had been at the scene too . That woman had been talking on that mobile until right before they got to the room, but the door was locked .

'Meaning...'

'It was a locked room . '

If he told someone else that somebody had disappeared from a locked room, they'd probably laugh at him, but this old man – just him – was different .

This subject made Hata's eyes sparkle like a child's .

'Oh! Then this mobile phone was left at the scene . That is interesting . '

'Don't get so happy, old man . It's indiscreet . '

'But isn't it interesting? I rarely see things like this . '

Hata let out another high-pitched giggle .

'I don't know anything for sure yet . It could easily be somebody's trick . '

'But Ishii-kun was at the scene as well, yes? If it were a trick, Ishii would probably have noticed . '

'That fool's like a decoration . He wouldn't notice even if a murder happened right in front of his eyes . '

Gotou felt exhausted thinking about that scared face Ishii had .

If Ishii were more reliable, he might have heard a different story, but since he was a fool, he only got information from the reporter Makoto and the exorcist Kamiyama .

He couldn't know if the information had been distorted .

Gotou remembered the spiritual phenomenon he'd experienced in that room, but he decided not to mention it .

Inconsistent with his occupation, Hata showed an extreme interest in the occult . It might have given him a strange perspective .

'So what is Ishii-kun doing today?'

'i made him wait outside . We have to move on to the next place fast . '

'I see . I just have to analyse the blood on this mobile phone . '

'Exactly . This'll be wrapped up quickly if it isn't human blood . '

Hata picked up the plastic bag and looked at it with fish eyes . It felt like he'd stick out a long tongue and eat it if Gotou looked away .

'Well, anyway, that's all I ask,' Gotou said finally, and he left the room . Now, after the demonic old man was the monster cat .

2

'I'm coming in . '

Gotou opened the door to the <Movie Research Circle> .

Yakumo was sleeping curled up in a corner of the room . He really was like a cat .

'Oi, wake up!' said Gotou, sitting down and clapping his hands .

Yakumo stirred restlessly . Just his right eye opened to look up at Gotou, but then he closed his eye again right after .

'Oi!'

'Gotou-san, just by waking me up you've ruined my entire day,' said Yakumo, still curled up .

Honestly, was this guy like this right after he woke up too?

'I don't care – just wake up!' urged Gotou, repressing his anger .

However, it still didn't seem like Yakumo was going to get up .

'That's enough . '

'I'm still sleepy . You have something to say, correct? Please go ahead – I'll listen like this . '

Gotou raised a fist, ready to punch him, but he stopped himself . A hole would open up in his stomach if he tried to deal with Yakumo fair and square .

Well, fine . Yakumo and old man Hata were essentially the same . If he talked a bit about the case, Yakumo should eat it up like a fish caught by bait .

'Hey, Yakumo . There are some mysterious things in this world . '

'What are you babbling about?'

'Last night, somebody disappeared from a locked room in an apartment . '

'I thought that you had grown a bit, but I was too naive . '

'That wasn't a joke . Somebody really disappeared . There were witnesses too . On top of that, it seems like a ghost made her disappear...'

Yakumo arched up like a zombie .

The monster cat was coming for the bait .

In a better mood, Gotou explained what happened last night in detail, including Kamiyama, the exorcist .

After Gotou finished talking, Yakumo sat down on the chair opposite him, still in a T-shirt and a jersey, while running a hand through his bedhead .

His left eye was naked so his red eye was exposed .

It was really a good thing he hadn't brought Ishii . He would've made a huge fuss again .

'What do you think?' Gotou asked Yakumo, who was rubbing at his eyes like a cat washing its face .

'I've never seen anything like that, at the very least . '

'It's the first time for me as well . '

To be honest, Gotou still didn't believe it .

The suspicion that he was being tricked hadn't gone away .

'Under my reasoning, it is impossible for spirits of the dead to make somebody living disappear . '

'Ghosts are clusters of human emotions and have no physical influence...' said Gotou, remembering what Yakumo often said .

'Yes, but that reasoning of mine has not been proven scientifically . To put it simply, it is only my guess,' Yakumo said with a bitter smile .

'So are you saying it's possible for a ghost to make somebody living disappear?'

'I did not go that far, but it would be wrong to think that what one does not believe does not exist . Even I would change my way of thinking if I were shown definite proof . '

'I see . '

There were many things about ghosts that hadn't been explained yet . Since they could only infer from experiences, it meant there were countless possibilities .

'Well, putting aside whether the phenomenon truly happened, I have met that exorcist before . '

'W-w-what did you say?'

'Please don't speak so loudly in the morning,' Yakumo said, plugging his ears .

'When and where did you meet?'

'Yesterday, when I was investigating the apartment where the ghost I mentioned had appeared . '

'So what do you think? Do you really see him as an exorcist?'

'I don't know . Even if he says he can see ghosts, that is a problem of subjectivity since nobody can completely turn into him . '

'How appropriate . '

'However, it is a fact that there was a spirit where he said there was one,' said Yakumo, his brow furrowed . No matter what he said, it seemed like he was concerned . Well, for Yakumo, it'd be weirder if he weren't .

'Which would mean he's the same as you . '

'That would be the case,' said Yakumo disinterestedly . He let out a huge yawn .

'This isn't the time to yawn carelessly . '

'Why not?'

'Well, there's a guy with the same power as you!'

'And?'

”“And”, you say...”

Unlike Gotou, who was agitated, Yakumo sighed, as if to say 'Honestly' .

'I mentioned this before, but being able to see the spirits of the dead is just part of my disposition . It is only a little rare . It wouldn't be strange if there were other people with the same disposition . '

Now that Yakumo mentioned it, it was just as he said .

It wasn't like it was certain that Yakumo was the only person in this world who could see the spirits of the dead . Actually, Gotou knew another .

A man with two red eyes . A man who called himself Yakumo's father .

Though it was true that there were many exorcists who were suspicious, Gotou couldn't assert that they were all frauds .

'What do you want to do then, Gotou-san?' Yakumo asked while stretching .

'What do I want to do? I want to find out why somebody disappeared . '

Seeing Yakumo's attitude, it made how agitated he had been earlier seem stupid .

'Then just speaking here is pointless . At any rate, the place where – '

'We're going,' Gotou interrupted .

'That will be one favour . '

Honestly, this guy was only reliable for that .

3

Ishii was sitting on the white bench right inside the school gates of Meisei University .

He was waiting for Gotou, who had gone to see Yakumo .

The truth was he should have gone with him . However, Ishii didn't know how to deal with Yakumo . No, 'didn't know how to deal with' wasn't the right phrase . To be honest, he was scared of him . He didn't want to have anything to do with him if possible .

However, they definitely needed Yakumo's help for this case .

The event from last night replayed in his head .

No matter how many times he simulated it, he didn't find anything unnatural .

Somebody disappeared from a locked room in front of everyone . He remembered a horror movie he had watched before . A vengeful ghost dragging person after person into the dark . How terrible . He could be next .

Ishii felt something run past him .

'Ah, could it be Ishii-san?'

Haruka stood in front of Ishii, who had turned around at the voice .

'H-H-Haruka-chan . '

'It's been a while . '

Haruka bowed her head with a smile .

She matched her denim miniskirt with a pink camisole . It was a summery and refreshing outfit .

Ishii was captivated by the nape of her neck, which shimmered with a faint layer of sweat .

'What is it?'

'No, it's nothing . '

His face red, Ishii hurriedly turned his gaze to his feet .

'Why are you here today?' Haruka said, sitting across from Ishii . Ishii's neck snapped around in his nervousness .

A refreshing citrus aroma tickled his nose .

'Ah, I, um, Detective Gotou asked, that Yakumo-shi, er...'

'There was some incident then . So he went to see Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka leant forward a bit and looked at Ishii's face .

Ah, that wasn't good . Haruka-chan . She was too defenceless . With that posture, he would be able to see her undergarments .

'Yes, well . That's right . '

Ishii, who didn't know where to look, pointlessly looked up at the sky .

'Aren't you going to go, Ishii-san?'

It hurt to have her say that .

'Er, I, um...'

'Could it be that you're afraid of Yakumo-kun?'

'No, er...'

He was lost for words since she had hit the bull's-eye .

'Could it be that you really are afraid?' said Haruka, like she thought it was unexpected .

It wasn't really unexpected . It would be stranger if Ishii could connect to him normally .

'Haruka-chan, er, aren't you afraid?'

'Of Yakumo-kun?'

'Yes . '

Haruka stared afar, like she was thinking about something .

If Ishii had to say, her young face, for that moment, looked like an adult's .

'Nope . I've never felt afraid of him . '

'I-is that so?'

'Though there've been many times I thought he would hit me,' Haruka said, raising her right hand in a fist to imitate him .

Just as I thought, Yakumo habitually torments Haruka-chan . That's –

'That's unforgiveable . I will defeat your enemy, Haruka-chan,' said Ishii, standing up in his irritation .

For a second, Haruka looked blank, and then she suddenly covered her mouth and started laughing .

'Ishii-san, you're interesting . '

Ishii didn't understand what was interesting .

'Interesting, is it?'

'Sorry . It's rude to say something like that . '

'No, not at all . That's not what I...'

The atmosphere had become somewhat awkward .

He really didn't understand women's thoughts . Ishii's shoulders drooped like he had withered and he sat back down on the bench .

'Ishii-san, I think that you've definitely misunderstood Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka suddenly started speaking . Though she was smiling, the tone of her voice was firm and serious .

'Misunderstood... him?'

'Yes . Because of that ability, Yakumo-kun has suffered in a way we could never understand, and that has made him like a misanthrope . '

'Eh . '

Ishii had felt that too .

In front of Yakumo, there was a wall that stopped other people from getting near him . Without showing his heart to anyone, he observed others from the outside .

'But... for this reason, he's straightforward and can be very kind . '

Kind? Him?

It was difficult for Ishii to believe what Haruka was saying when he still doubted whether Yakumo even had feelings .

Rather, Haruka was much kinder for defending him even though he treated him that way .

'Is that how it is?'

'But since he isn't honest, he behaved that way . When you become used to it, unexpectedly, he has his cute points . '

Haruka smiled happily .

Ishii didn't understand even one millimetre of Yakumo's cuteness, but at least he understood very well how cute Haruka's smiling face was .

'What are you grinning about? It's creepy . '

Gotou's fist came down on Ishii's crown in his happiness .

'D-Detective Gotou . '

Ishii stood up instinctively .

Yakumo was behind Gotou as well . He had sleepy eyes as usual, and Ishii couldn't understand what he was thinking at all .

No matter what Haruka said about his being kind, Yakumo was a mystery to Ishii .

'Gotou-san, it's been a while . '

Haruka stood up and bowed her head .

'Oh, it's Haruka-chan . So that's why Ishii was grinning . '

'No, I wasn't really...'

Ishii made an excuse, but he shut up at Gotou's glare .

'Did you bring trouble for Yakumo-kun again?'

Haruka said that sulkily and with a pout .

That expression was cute too . Ishii couldn't help but grin a little again .

'You can't really talk about other people . '

'Please don't put me together with you, since I have no trouble this time . '

Haruka puffed her chest in pride .

'Ah, that so?'

Gotou snorted and then let his cigarette .

'Ah, Gotou-san . Smoking is forbidden on the school premises . '

'You're too fussy . You're becoming more and more like Yakumo . You won't be able to become a bride . '

Gotou left that sharp parting remark and walked away briskly . Yakumo sighed and then followed him .

'Ah, wait, Yakumo-kun . Are you going to go?'

'Yeah . '

Yakumo replied flatly to Haruka's question .

'About what you requested...'

'How was it?'

'It was just as you expected, Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka gave a proud thumbs up .

Yakumo looked like he was thinking for a while, but he finally raised an eyebrow like he had thought of something .

'There's something else I'd like you to look into . '

After walking over to Haruka, Yakumo brought his face close to hers and talked to her quietly .

What on earth was he saying? Ishii indirectly approached them and strained his ears .

'Eh, that's impossible . '

When the explanation was finished, Haruka objected loudly, but Yakumo continued talking like he didn't care .

'The address is in the documents in my room, so pick it up from there . '

'Like I said, it's impossible for me . '

'Don't think about it too hard . You just have to go take a look . '

'But what will I do if I get caught?'

'You can just say sorry and run away . '

'That's...'

Yakumo ignored Haruka's anxious expression and clapped a hand lightly on her shoulder, saying, 'I'm counting on you,' and then he walked after Gotou .

– What on earth did he ask her to do?

Ishii wanted to know . Led by that impulse, Ishii tried to call out to Haruka .

'Ishii! We're going!'

Gotou's angry voice echoed from far away .

Ishii wasn't sure which to prioritise, but he didn't have enough courage to speak to Haruka so he followed Gotou's instruction and started running .

He fell –

4

In order to change her mood, Makoto put aside her work and went to the lavatory .

Though there was a mountain of things she had to do, like checking manuscripts, the event from last night kept replaying in her head so she couldn't concentrate .

She sighed, looking at her reflection in the mirror about the sink .

Where did Asami go –

If somebody abducted her, how did they take Asami out of the locked room?

Did she really get taken away by a ghost like Kamiyama said?

She didn't understand anything .

She wanted to find Asami as quickly as she could, but right now all she could do was entrust the investigation to Gotou and Ishii .

She was irritated at herself for not being able to do anything during her friend's crisis .

After sighing countless times, something suddenly passed behind her .

A chill went down her spine .

It wasn't as if she had seen it clearly, but she had felt it .

Makoto stopped breathing and timidly turned around, but there was nobody there . She had merely been mistaken .

Her nerves might have been oversensitive .

Makoto let out her breath and looked at the mirror again when her mobile phone rang . Though the number was withheld, Makoto hurriedly answered, thinking, 'Could it be?'

'Hello . '

She heard a noise that sounded like rain from the receiver .

'Hello . Asami?'

Makoto called out, but there was no reply .

However, she felt someone on the other end .

'Hey, who is this? Respond...'

Makoto called out again, but she was interrupted by a groan from the receiver .

She couldn't tell whether the voice belonged to a man or a woman .

An ominous voice that sounded like it was struggling with pain –

'...Who is this?'

Though she was shaking in a strange terror, Makoto called out towards the phone .

<Diiiiiiieeeee . >

The hoarse voice jolted her eardrums .

She could clearly tell this time . That was a woman's voice .

Makoto threw her mobile phone in her surplus of emotions . It fell onto the tiled floor .

Her heart was beating so furiously it felt like it would burst out of her chest, and she was covered in a cold sweat .

Makoto crouched . Though she wanted to run away, she couldn't move for a while .

How much time had passed? Her mobile phone was ringing again .

A paralysing fear ran through her body .

Makoto timidly took her mobile phone from the floor . The number displayed on the monitor was that of the exorcist Kamiyama .

– He might have found something out .

Makoto wiped away her cold sweat and answered the phone .

'Hello?'

<My name is Kamiyama . Do you mind my calling your mobile phone, Makoto-san?>

She could hear Kamiyama's characteristic calm voice .

'Not at all . '

A request –

'For me?'

<Yes . You mentioned that the first time there was a spiritual phenomenon, it was at a bar . >

'Yes, that's correct . '

<Would it be possible to gather the members who had been at the scene then?>

Since she had exchanged email addresses with Shinichi then, she would be able to contact him . She could just have him talk to Yuuya .

'I think it'd be fine . '

<If we solve the mystery of the spiritual phenomenon, we will be able to save Asami-san . >

Kamiyama's voice was filled with confidence .

5

Gotou looked up at the apartment Asami had disappeared from with a cigarette in his mouth .

Since something like that had happened, to him, it looked like there was a heavy atmosphere hanging over only the building and its surroundings .

Next to him, Yakumo was looking up at the apartment in the same way .

There was no way for Gotou to know if anything was reflected in those eyes, which were narrowed like they were looking at something bright .

'You see anything?'

'The sky and the clouds,' Yakumo replied bluntly .

'I know that even without you telling me . '

'Then please don't ask . '

As usual, only his mouth was skilful . He had completely sidestepped the point of his question .

Gotou clicked his tongue and turned around to see that Ishii already had tears in his eyes from fright .

Honestly, what a useless guy . There was no way for a person to disappear anyway .

'So this really isn't some sort of prank?'

Gotou looked to Yakumo for agreement .

'If that were the case, Makoto-san, the reporter, and Ishii-san as well would be complicit . '

It was just as Yakumo said . Ishii and Makoto had been there . At the present stage, that was what it would mean .

Putting Makoto aside, Ishii isn't the sort of guy who'd do that . But –

'The medium might've planned it . '

'At this point, he does not have a motive . '

'Well there's that . Obviously he'd get some money with fraudulent exorcism . '

Gotou said the first thing that came to mind .

'It would have been different if he had saved her in the nick of time, but currently he would become the exorcist who failed to exorcise the spirit and let a woman be taken away by a vengeful spirit . '

It really was just as Yakumo said .

It would be unnatural to bring about his own failure on purpose . The best method would have been to save Asami just as she was about to be taken away, if he had wanted to trick them .

'The location is nearby,' Yakumo muttered .

'The location?'

'Yes . The apartment with Rika-san's ghost is nearby . '

'You saying there's a connection?'

'I don't know . I just said that it was nearby . '

'You're quibbling...'

'Incidentally, Ishii-san, that exorcist came to this apartment before Asami-san disappeared, yes?'

Yakumo ignored Gotou's objection and turned the conversation to Ishii .

'Ah, yes . He mentioned that . He came by that evening, but he thought it was a wandering spirit since there was nothing there...'

Ishii responded stiffly, as if he were talking to the chief of the police or something .

What was he getting so nervous for talking to a university student? He should hurry up and get used to him . Gotou restrained his feelings of wanting to hit Ishii .

'Perhaps he reached the same conclusion as I did,' said Yakumo, narrowing his eyes a little .

The same conclusion –

'What do you mean?'

'There is no spirit here . '

Yakumo gave a firm response to Gotou's question .

'Then you're saying that exorcist called Kamiyama is the real deal?'

'Why are you so hasty in jumping to conclusions?' Yakumo complained, and then he stood in front of the automatic door with the auto-lock .

'If you'd just let me say – '

Gotou was riled up, but Yakumo was not concerned at all .

'Please hurry and open the door,' Yakumo said with a yawn .

Gotou opened the door with the key he had borrowed from management the night before and took the elevator right by the entrance .

Yakumo and Ishii followed after him .

They went up to the ninth floor silently and went along the long and narrow corridor to stand in front of Asami's room .

'I'm opening the door,' Gotou said, and he opened the door .

Hot air rushed out from the room at his face, but he took off his shoes at the entrance and stepped inside the room .

Yakumo, who came into the room afterwards, walked about the room while running a hand through his messy hair .

Gotou sat cross-legged in the centre of the room and followed Yakumo's movements with his eyes .

A square space of eight tatami in size . There was a bed, a sideboard and a television on the wooden floor – a normal room that could be found anywhere .

Since it was rented, it didn't seem like there would be any secret passageways .

'Nothing stands out . '

Yakumo gave up after a while and sat with his legs stretched out across from Gotou .

'No good?'

'It's no good . '

Yakumo's brow was furrowed, and he ran his hand through his hair in his irritation .

'Damn, what's happening...'

'That's right . Ishii-san . '

Yakumo turned around and called out, cutting short Gotou's grumbling .

Gotou turned to look for Ishii too, but he wasn't there .

'But he was here just a moment ago . '

Yakumo cocked his head in curiosity . That guy probably left the room in his terror .

'Oi! Ishii!' yelled Gotou towards the entrance . At the same time, there was the sound of footsteps on the floor, and then Ishii peeked in .

'W-were you calling me?'

'Don't say "Were you calling me?", you fool!'

'Y-yes sir . '

Ishii straightened his spine so he was standing still and straight .

After shaking his head like he didn't know what to do with the two of them, he said, 'When you came into this room, Ishii-san, the door was locked, correct?'

'Y-yes . The door to the entrance and the window connected to the veranda were all locked . '

'And the door chain?'

'It wasn't on . '

'Did you find Asami's key?'

'Yes . It was on the table...'

'Nobody left the room . '

'That's correct . At that time, there were three people in the room, just like now . I think it would have been difficult for somebody to leave the room without our noticing . '

Perhaps Yakumo might have thought that somebody had been hiding in the room and then escaped afterwards, but it was impossible in that situation .

It really was a locked room .

Yakumo put his finger to his brow . The expression in his eyes changed .

'So it really is like that... but then she... am I wrong...'

He kept murmuring to himself .

'Did you realise something?'

'No, not at all . '

Yakumo shrugged dramatically at Gotou's question .

'Don't lie! Didn't you just say "So it really is like that"?''

Though Gotou drew closer to him, Yakumo didn't move . He put his fingers in his ears to complain about the noise .

'You'll annoy the neighbours . '

'It's your fault for not talking properly . '

'I have no proof . '

'Just tell me the theory . '

'What came to my mind is only a possibility . If we head forward recklessly, we will be misled like with the last case . '

Gotou couldn't deny that .

There was nothing more dangerous for a case than having preconceptions . If they didn't look at all the possibilities, the carpet could be pulled out from underneath them .

But –

'What are you planning to do?'

'There isn't anything to do but continue to straightforwardly investigate all areas, is there?' Yakumo said with a yawn .

Well, it wouldn't be as convenient as solving the case just from seeing the apartment . He wasn't that discouraged, but he was still heavy-hearted .

'No going about it – I'll reconsider everyone involved . Yakumo, you help too . '

'I would rather not . '

An immediate reply . Even if he was going to refuse, there had to be a better way to put it .

'Aren't you curious?'

'I am curious, but I'm busy . '

'Busy? All you do is sleep,' Gotou complained, a cigarette in his mouth .

'Honestly, have you already forgotten?'

Yakumo took the cigarette in Gotou's mouth and handed it to Ishii .

'Forgotten what?'

'I have another case . '

That's right –

The ghost of Sawaguchi Rika, who had committed suicide . Though Gotou hadn't been the one to make the request, he couldn't say he was unrelated .

Damn . This was really becoming troublesome .

6

'Honestly, he just does whatever he wants . '

Haruka walked down the road by the railroad as she looked at a memo .

Though she was half-hearted, she was following Yakumo's instructions and going to meet the father of the woman called Sawaguchi Rika, who had committed suicide .

A train roared past, bringing a wave of hot air with it .

Yakumo had asked her to go talk to him while pretending to be a friend, but would she be able to do it well? She wasn't proud of it, but she wasn't the type of person who could adlib .

While dissatisfied at Yakumo, Haruka reached the place she was aiming for .

An old two-storey apartment made of wood . Sawaguchi Rika's father lived in the corner room on the first floor .

Haruka kept looking back at the memo to make sure she hadn't gotten the address wrong .

There'd be no problem if she acted naturally . She was just going to ask him a few questions .

Plus, she always caused trouble for Yakumo, so she should help out every once in a while .

'OK!'

Haruka gathered her determination and pressed the buzzer at the entrance with a trembling finger .

After waiting for a while, the door opened, and an old man with white stubble appeared .

He had an extremely stubborn-looking face and there were deep wrinkles on his forehead .

'U-um, is this Sawaguchi-san's home?'

He nodded without saying anything .

'Ah, h-hello . My name is Ozawa Haruka . I was Rika-san's friend . I was in the area so I wanted to put out incense for her... . '

He stared at Haruka with a sharp gaze, and Haruka's words fizzled out under that pressure .

– Yakumo, this is really bad .

Haruka restrained the impulse to run away deep into her heart .

After looking at Haruka like he was evaluating her, he clicked his tongue .

She really had been found out . The feeling of wanting to give up spread through Haruka .

However, he kept the door open and turned away from Haruka to walk inside .

Did that mean he wanted her to come in?

'You're putting out incense, right?'

While Haruka was hesitating, she heard his voice from the back of the room .

'Please excuse me . I'm coming in . '

Haruka went into the entrance after bowing, passed through the corridor and stepped into the tatami room at the back .

The room was six tatami in size with a Buddhist altar in it .

There were two tablets . One was Rika's . The other was Rika's dead mother's .

There were white chrysanthemum flowers and manjuu[1] at the altar . It was well maintained .

Haruka felt bad for lying but she knelt in front of the altar .

There was a photo of a smiling woman .

She's Sawaguchi Rika –

She had a smart and firm look, a cheerful and bright woman . That was the impression Haruka got .

When the photo had been taken, the woman probably had no idea what the future had in store for her .

That collapsed for her in an instant .

When Haruka thought about that, it made it hard to breath .

'What did you really come here to do?'

He said that while sitting cross-legged to Haruka, who had finished placing the incense and praying .

'Eh?'

Haruka couldn't find the words to reply in her surprise . She really couldn't do adlib .

'You're not Rika's friend, right?'

'Why... do you think that?'

'You're too young to be her friend . If she were alive, she'd already be twenty-seven . '

Now that he mentioned it, it was true . Haruka looked for an excuse, but she couldn't find one . Plus, she had a question . If he knew she wasn't a friend

—

'Why...'

Why did he let Haruka into his home?

Haruka spoke, though she thought she would be crushed by her anxiety .

'You're too nervous . I felt like Rika told me to let you in . '

His eyes narrowed and a sad expression appeared on his face .

She wasn't sure if he would believe her, but she couldn't lie to him . Haruka prepared herself to tell the truth .

'I am not acquainted with Rika-san . I'm really sorry for lying . '

She thought he would be angry, but she was wrong .

He looked at Haruka's eyes silently . It seemed like he was waiting for her to continue .

Haruka took a deep breath and then started explaining the events that had brought her here .

Rika-san's ghost was still wandering at the apartment .

If possible, she wanted to set her free, but she needed to find out why she died in order to do that .

She wanted him to tell her what he knew – anything was fine . If she had left anything behind, she wanted him to show her .

She didn't think she explained it well like Yakumo, but she did the best she could .

'That's ridiculous . '

When Haruka finished her explanation, he spat that out .

As she expected, it was no good .

Her feelings sank like she had fallen into a bottomless swamp –

'I had an older twin sister . '

Those words spilled out of Haruka's mouth unconsciously .

Haruka herself didn't understand why she had suddenly started talking about this . Though she felt doubtful, she couldn't stop .

'But she died in an accident... I thought my sister might have resented me, so I've always been suffering . But recently, I finally found out my sister's true feelings . You might wonder what this has to do anything . But even though the dead won't come back, don't you want to know the feelings the left behind?'

His lips were in a thin line and he didn't reply .

'Perhaps your daughter – Rika-san – didn't commit suicide . '

Haruka said the last bit like she was clearing out something that had been caught in her chest .

At first, she had been an outsider who was cooperating with Yakumo's request, but at some point, she had empathised with Rika and really hoped that they would find out the truth .

'I want to know the truth, but how would someone like you that I don't know anything about find out what I couldn't for five years?'

'I can't guarantee it . '

He snorted at Haruka's reply like he had been made a fool of .

'Why are you doing something like this in the first place when it won't do you any good?'

Haruka couldn't reply . There would be no point in saying something hypocritical like 'I want to save her' even if those were her true feelings .

'This is pointless,' he said, refusing her bluntly, and stood up to leave the room .

My explanation really was no good –

It'd be fine if it was just her who was depressed, but she might have hurt him .

Haruka bit her lips to keep in the feelings building up inside her .

'Oi . '

She looked up at the voice to see him standing there, when he had just left .
He had a notebook with a red cover in his hand .

'Take it,' he said curtly, and he held the notebook out towards Haruka .

Haruka accepted it, though she didn't understand what was going on .

'What is this?'

'Rika's diary . '

'Why are you giving me something so important?'

'I still don't believe that Rika killed herself . Something horrible did happen to her, but Rika reported it to the police and was trying to get past it . Rika was so stout-hearted . She wouldn't...'

His eyes were red, and he covered his face as he rubbed at his nose .

His feelings pierced through Haruka's chest .

'I still think that Rika was killed – she didn't kill herself, though the police didn't believe me . Rika was a strong daughter . You're the first person who's told me that Rika didn't kill herself . That's why...'

His hoarse voice trailed off .

However, she understood even without hearing it . That's why he was giving the diary to Haruka .

He had probably tried countless times to find out the truth behind the incident .

But he couldn't do it . He still hadn't given up now, after five years .

She was somebody he'd just met who might not know anything, but he saw a slight hope there .

'Please allow me to borrow this . '

Haruka stood up, bowed her head deeply and left the room .

7

After splitting up with Yakumo, Gotou first called Hata .

He wanted to know the results of the mobile phone's bloodstain analysis .

<I thought you'd be contacting me soon . Since you're impatient . >

After answering the call, Hata let out a strange giggle .

That was creepy . Demonic old man .

'So how was it?'

<That was genuine human blood . >

'W-what did you say...'

For Gotou, who had been hoping somewhere in his heart that the disappearance of the woman called Asami had been a prank, those were analysis results that denied it .

<Blood type O . Is that the same as the woman who disappeared?>

'Yeah . '

He felt dizzy as he replied .

<Though it'll take some time, should I do a DNA test?>

'Yeah, thanks,' Gotou said weakly, and he hung up the phone .

'Oi, Ishii . What do you think?'

Even though Gotou thought there was no point, he asked that question to Ishii in the driver's seat .

Like he had been waiting for that, Ishii's face lit up like a puppy's before it got a treat .

'I think that she was whisked off to the spirit world by the vengeful ghost's strong spiritual power . '

'Hah?'

'The spirit world . Where people who have died go . The world after death . ,

'You know . '

'In the past, there have been people who have gone to the spirit world temporarily while they were living . The gate that connects this world and that world is distorted somehow...'

What the hell is the spirit world? He should say something more convincing .

So, what to do now –

Gotou mulled over his thoughts while lighting his cigarette .

The beginning of this case was a get-together at a bar . Maybe he'd gather the members that had been there and talk to them .

Gotou called Makoto's mobile phone the moment that came to his mind .

<Hello, this is Hijikata . >

After a few rings, Makoto answered the phone .

'It's Gotou . You free now?'

<Actually, I was just thinking of calling you, Detective Gotou . >

Makoto's tone was hurried .

If she was thinking of contacting me herself –

'Did something happen?'

<Kamiyama-san just called me, actually . >

'That exorcist?'

Gotou thought of the exorcist, black from head to toe .

Was he really the real thing? Gotou hadn't arrived at that answer yet .

<Yes . He asked me to gather all the related parties in order to investigate the spiritual phenomenon . >

He can't be thinking of doing the same thing –

'So what are you going to do?'

<I have contacted them to arrange a good time . If possible, Detective Gotou, I would appreciate it if you came as well...>

He had planned on going even if she hadn't asked .

'Time and place?'

<It has been decided that we will meet at eight this evening in the bar . I will email you the address afterwards . >

'Thanks . '

Gotou spat out his cigarette and hung up .

If Kamiyama was there too, he had to call Yakumo again to have him check the situation .

Gotou called Yakumo's number from his mobile .

8

Haruka tottered along while looking at her fingernails .

Though she'd gotten a big lead, that didn't mean she was in high spirits .

Can we really find out the reason why Rika's ghost is still wandering?

This diary is too heavy for me –

'You'll fall if you walk like that . '

Haruka stopped at the voice .

She didn't need to check . That voice and that tone – it was Yakumo .
Yakumo stood in front of Haruka . She hadn't noticed his arrival .

'Are you already done with what Gotou-san asked?'

'I thought it'd be dangerous with you by yourself . I came to check on you .
,

Yakumo yawned .

'That so . '

'Well, with you looking like that, it seems like you were turned away . '

With a bitter smile, Yakumo ran his fingers through his messy hair .

She would normally get angry, but she didn't feel like it right now .

Haruka handed the diary to Yakumo silently .

'What's this?'

Yakumo was surprised – a first .

'Rika-san's diary . '

'I see...' Yakumo murmured as he took the diary .

The face of Rika's father came up in Haruka's head .

He still hadn't accepted his daughter's death after five years .

Following that image, her mother's crying face on the day of her twin sister's death came up .

'Rika-san's father said his daughter didn't commit suicide... but nobody believed him...'

'Does he have any basis for saying that it isn't a suicide?' Yakumo said disinterestedly .

Haruka felt incredibly angry . It wasn't about basis or proof .

'That's not it!' she yelled, forgetting that she was at the side of a road .

'Rika-san's father has been suffering by himself for so long... so...'

Haruka didn't even know what she wanted to say herself .

Yakumo said something, but it was drowned out by the roar of the passing train and didn't reach Haruka's ears .

'I...'

Tears fell from Haruka's ears .

Why was she crying? She didn't know . She didn't know, but she couldn't clear away the tight feeling in her chest or the feeling that a hole had opened up inside of her .

'My bad . '

Yakumo said that gently, completely different from how he usually spoke .
He drew Haruka close so her head rested against his chest .

Her legs shook at the unexpected action .

'Yakumo-kun...'

'I gave you a tough time . '

She heard Yakumo's voice close to her ear .

Though he normally wasn't honest at all, the warmth of this contrary person slowly spread to her very core .

Haruka surrendered herself to that warmth and cried with all her heart .

9

Ishii parked his car in a coin-operated parking space .

He saw the entrance to Bar <Snake>, where the incident had begun, about ten metres ahead of him .

The neon sign with its red letters and black snake design gave an uncanny glow .

Gotou, in the passenger seat, tried to contact Yakumo countless times, but it seemed that he hadn't been able to reach him .

Even though Ishii didn't know how to deal with Yakumo, he had hoped that he would be with them this time . While he was a mystery to him, even Ishii understood that Yakumo's insight and ability to see the spirits of the dead were indispensable to solving this case .

'That guy, running off at the crucial moment... well, fine . We're going,'
Gotou said, glancing at his wristwatch .

'Er... do I really have to go?'

'Of course you do, idiot . '

Gotou's fist came down on Ishii's head .

Of course I do –

'Don't dawdle . '

Gotou got off the car with a cigarette in his mouth .

'Y-yes sir . '

Ishii followed after him immediately .

There was nothing he could do this time . He would just be a hindrance . He had to be useful, even if just a little bit .

Ishii had gathered his emotions and started walking, but with timing like a surprise attack, something hit his shoulder from behind .

'Aaagh!'

He shrieked in his surprise .

When he turned around, he saw Kamiyama standing there .

When he stood in the dim lighting with his black suit, it was uncanny how only his chiselled features stood out .

'So you came as well, detectives . '

'Ah, well...'

Before Ishii could finish his vague reply, Gotou cut in .

'We're keeping watch to make sure you don't pull any tricks,' Gotou threatened, glaring at Kamiyama .

However, Kamiyama just accepted it with a smile .

'I won't pull any tricks . I don't have any expensive items to sell either . '

Just as he said, Kamiyama's hands were empty .

Conversely, that made Ishii anxious .

'What's your reason for sticking your neck in if you're not selling stuff?'
Gotou asked, lighting his cigarette .

'At the first stage, I misunderstood the situation . Because of that, this is what the situation has become . Since I feel responsible, I would like to solve this case if I can . That's all . '

'I hope that's the truth . '

Gotou said that and then briskly went down the stairs that led to the bar in the basement .

'I wonder if he dislikes me . '

Kamiyama smiled self-derisively .

'Er, is this really OK?' Ishii asked, turning his anxiety towards Kamiyama .

'What are you talking about?'

'If you're going to be exorcising the spirit, won't you need tools?'

'I said this before as well, but I can see the spirits of the dead . If anything, that is my tool . '

Kamiyama, looking full of confidence, followed Gotou down the stairs to the bar .

Please don't leave me by myself –

Ishii followed the two of them down the stairs .

While Haruka boiled water in the kitchen, she looked at the six-tatami room . Even though she should have been used to her own flat, she felt a strange sense of discomfort . The reason for that was the person who was sitting while leaning against the bed – Yakumo .

He was flipping through the pages of the diary with a serious gaze .

Now that she thought more about it, they had known each other for more than half a year, but it was the first time that Yakumo had come into her room .

That made her a bit nervous .

Haruka took out two mugs, made hot cocoa for two and carried the mugs to her room .

'What is this?'

'Hot cocoa . '

'Even though it's swelteringly hot?' said Yakumo with a sigh .

He wasn't cute at all . Haruka returned to the kitchen without saying anything, took out ice from the fridge and threw a large amount into Yakumo's mug .

'Iced cocoa . '

Yakumo scowled and drank the cocoa .

Afterwards, he let out an 'Oh!' in surprise and stared at his mug . She thought he was going to say something, but he just flipped through the diary pages and immersed himself in his task .

Does it taste good? Bad? Say something –

Haruka washed down her dissatisfaction with cocoa and sat on the cushion opposite Yakumo .

Then, she remembered how she had buried her head in Yakumo's chest and cried earlier, and she went red all the way to her ears .

Though it had been embarrassing, at the same time, she had felt an enveloping warmth .

Did Yakumo think nothing of it at all?

Interrupting Haruka's thoughts, Yakumo's mobile phone started vibrating on the table .

'Your mobile's ringing . '

'It's Gotou-san . '

Yakumo didn't look away from the diary .

'Is it OK for you not to answer?'

'It's fine . That person should think by himself a bit more . '

'That's strict of you . '

'That is a difference in opinion . This is also a form of kindness . '

That was a nice way of putting it .

After the mobile stopped vibrating, Yakumo stopped flipping the pages of the diary .

It seemed that he had found something .

Haruka peeked at it as well from the side . Rather than words, there was a design of a cross with something like a black cord coiled around it .

'What's this?'

'Who knows,' Yakumo said, running his fingers through his hair .

'I wonder if it has anything to do with her suicide . '

'I don't know, but it seems like it is related to the assault . '

'Why?'

'This date . It's the day she was assaulted . '

Yakumo pointed at the date written in the diary .

However, even if it seemed to be related at the current stage, they didn't know what it meant .

Yakumo started flipping through the pages of the diary again . Haruka silently watched Yakumo .

With the page that the design was drawn on as a boundary, Yakumo's expression became more suspicious . The contents of the diary had probably made an about-face after that date . Regardless of the actual person's hopes and intentions, her life had changed .

Every day had probably been painful and difficult .

She felt a tight feeling in her abdomen just from imagining it, but that still was not even a fragment of the pain of a woman who had actually experienced it .

Even though the crime left such great injuries on its victims, the penalty imposed on the assailants was only a three-year sentence . If it was the first offence, there was a high chance that they would get a suspended sentence, which was equivalent to essentially nothing .

Finally, Yakumo took a deep breath and shut the diary .

Even Yakumo looked exhausted . He pinched his brow with his fingers and appeared to be thinking about something, but he suddenly looked up like he had thought of something .

'There's something I'd like to ask you to do,' Yakumo said with his eyes narrowed .

Eh, again –

Haruka readied herself . Since she had been helped so many times before, she didn't mind helping out some, but she would like to hold back from something as difficult as the request Yakumo had made earlier .

'Don't look so worried . It's not anything difficult . '

It wasn't something she could believe so easily .

'Really?'

'However, it's slightly troublesome but simple work . '

Her sad nature as a woman was not being able to clearly refuse .

11

Gotou crossed his arms at the entrance of the bar and looked around .

Makoto, Shinichi and Yuuya, who had been at the scene, were sitting at the same table they had been that night, and the bartender was behind the counter, just as he had been .

Ishii, who looked like he couldn't find a place for himself, was walking about nervously with shrugged shoulders .

In the centre of the bar stood Kamiyama .

It felt like he was going to put on a show .

'Now . '

Kamiyama clapped his hands together loudly and started speaking .

'Yesterday, everyone experienced a spiritual phenomenon here . Is that correct?'

Nobody replied to his question . However, Kamiyama didn't appear to pay any attention to that and continued speaking .

'I believe you may already know, but Asami-san's whereabouts became unknown last night . Suddenly, from a locked room...'

Kamiyama slowly started walking towards the table where the three of them sat .

Makoto's face was pale, and she stared at him without moving . Shinichi was smoking with an unpleasant expression on his face, while Yuuya was tapping his foot like he couldn't calm down .

After a beat, Kamiyama said, 'She disappeared . '

'She disappeared? There's no way something as stupid as that happened . '

In his irritation, Shinichi put out his cigarette in the ashtray .

'No, this isn't a lie . This is the work of a strong vengeful spirit . There are witnesses as well . Isn't that right, Mr Detective?'

Kamiyama looked at Ishii sharply .

Ishii froze like his hands and feet had been bound, and he moved his lips like a fish, incapable of making a response .

'Asami did disappear from the room, but...'

Makoto answered for Ishii .

'I-is that true?' asked the bartender from behind the counter, leaning forward as he did so .

'A woman did disappear, but that's all . I don't remember the police ever saying that a vengeful spirit did it!'

If he left the situation as it was, they would all be caught up in Kamiyama's mood .

Gotou spoke wildly .

'In your position, Detective Gotou, you cannot help but say that, I see . '

Kamiyama's smile was provocative .

It was infuriating, but Gotou closed his mouth, since he felt he would just get more caught up in Kamiyama's words the more he objected .

'I will continue talking then . Regardless of the opinion of the police, I believe that Asami-san's disappearance was the work of a vengeful spirit . Accordingly, I think it may be related to the spiritual phenomenon that you all experienced here . '

Kamiyama looked around at the faces of the people in the bar .

Everyone turned their eyes away from Kamiyama . There was an unpleasant silence .

'What do you want to say?'

Gotou cut in, unable to stand it .

'If my thinking is correct, everyone is in terrible danger . '

The bar grew noisy at Kamiyama's words .

'This is just tasteless fraud, isn't it?'

Shinichi's language was harsh as he glared at Kamiyama .

'I have no intention of doing such . '

'You can't be counted on . Nobody would honestly say they were going to .
,

Shinichi's complaint was natural . Nobody would reply 'Yes, I am' if asked 'Are you a fraud?' .

'Well, it isn't to be unexpected that you will not believe me . However, it is the truth . '

'Ridiculous,' Shinichi muttered .

Kamiyama accepted those words with a bitter smile .

'There is one thing I would like to ask everyone . Could it be that strange phenomena have already started happening around you?'

At Kamiyama's words, everyone started rustling .

'Something has happened, has it not?'

Kamiyama looked to the bartender, Makoto and Shinichi . Then, he looked to Yuuya, the youngest –

'A w-w-woman...'

Yuuya spoke, his gaze desperate .

'Shut it . '

Shinichi interrupted Yuuya without a moment's delay .

However, Yuuya couldn't stop now that he had opened his mouth .

'That woman was in my room and looked at me... “You die too!” That's what she said...'

At the same time as he finished speaking, Yuuya held his head in his hands and let it hit the table .

'Um, actually I also got a call on my mobile phone today from an unknown number, and the person said, “Die . ”'

Makoto spoke up to add to what Yuuya said .

'Er, I also heard the same words everyone else did last night at that locker . '

Even the bartender continued, pointing towards a locker by the lavatory .

I don't want to accept it, but if everybody experienced the same thing –

Gotou lit his cigarette .

'I see . Then there is almost no mistaking it . '

Kamiyama looked up at the ceiling .

'Do you think you know what's happening?'

Makoto stood up .

'Yes . Yesterday, I coincidentally met a woman's ghost at an apartment . She held a very strong as well as deep resentment . '

'A woman's ghost...'

'Her name was Sawaguchi Rika...'

'W-why's she coming up?'

Gotou spoke up without thinking and drew closer to Kamiyama .

'It seems you know her . '

'You can't be saying that Sawaguchi Rika's the cause of this chain of spiritual phenomena . '

'That is exactly what I am saying . The spiritual phenomena that have been occurring around everyone are all her work . '

'Don't be ridiculous! It's not related at all!' Gotou yelled, wanting to deny it wholeheartedly .

However, Kamiyama's expression did not change a whit, and he looked straight back at him .

'I am not joking . She is wandering . Can you see them? Her pain, and her resentment . '

Kamiyama looked down and then opened each of his eyes with his hand and took something out .

'I can see them . '

He had taken out contact lenses . Upon looking up again, Kamiyama's eyes were a flaming red .

This guy has red eyes too –

'Eek . '

Ishii's shriek echoed through the bar .

Gotou reflexively hit Ishii's head and turned back to Kamiyama .

'Your eyes...'

'The spirits of the dead are reflected in my eyes . '

Kamiyama narrowed his eyes in the dim bar .

'You're kidding . '

'I think that it is not a coincidence that everyone had gathered here . '

'What do you mean?'

Kamiyama smiled at Gotou's question .

'I mean that one of the people here is the cause for her resentment . Of course, I won't ask them to come forward . However, the person should know who they are . To disclose the truth...'

'That's enough!'

Shinichi interrupted Kamiyama's speech by hitting the table .

However, unlike Shinichi, who was agitated, Kamiyama did not seem concerned at all . He looked like he was observing a reaction he had expected –

'The missing Asami-san . She was carried off to the world after death, which is filled with suffering . '

'That's insane . '

Gotou tried to oppose Kamiyama .

'It is the truth . Unfortunately, she will not return . That is how strong and deep Sawaguchi Rika-san's vengeance is . '

'If you don't stop this, I'll send you to prison!' threatened Gotou, grabbing Kamiyama by the collar .

'I wouldn't mind, as long as you take responsibility for appeasing the anger of Sawaguchi Rika-san's spirit then . '

'What did you say?'

'If you do not, there will undeniably be another victim!'

Gotou couldn't decide whether Kamiyama's words were truth or lies . He had unwittingly been caught up in his words .

He unthinkingly let go of Kamiyama .

Kamiyama fixed his collar and again looked at the people in the bar .

'You may be next . No, it may be you...'

Nobody met Kamiyama's eyes .

Though the air conditioning should have been working, the bar felt enveloped in a heavy and damp air .

In the silence, the lights in the bar suddenly went out all at once .

It was impossible to see anything . A complete darkness .

– Damn . What’s happening?

In the confusion, there was the sound of something falling with a clang .

A pale light appeared in the darkness .

'Eeeek . '

Ishii’s shriek reverberated .

In the pale light, there was a woman .

That woman, with the left half of her face covered in blood and long black hair –

It had to be fake . He’d find out what it really was . Gotou had just started rushing towards the woman when the lights went on again .

He closed his eyes – it was like a smokescreen had gone up .

When Gotou opened his eyes again, the woman had disappeared completely, like she had never been there in the first place .

Just like Kamiyama said, something is really trying to cause something, no doubt about it –

'Everyone saw that, correct? The woman with her deep resentment . '

'Aaaaagh!'

Just as Kamiyama finished speaking, there was a scream . When Gotou looked, Shinichi was cowering and clutching his arm .

'Are you all right?'

Makoto approached him .

'What's wrong?'

Gotou spoke as well .

Kamiyama slowly walked towards him, and the bartender also came out from behind the counter .

The right sleeve of Shinichi's white shirt was dyed red .

'Who did it?' Gotou asked as he rolled up the sleeve . There was a deep cut on Shinichi's right upper arm .

'I-I don't know... When I noticed...'

Shinichi's forehead was covered in sweat as he spoke while withstanding the pain .

'Please take this . '

Gotou took the handkerchief Makoto held out and wrapped it around the cut on Shinichi's arm .

There was a tattoo on his arm of a cross with a snake coiled around it . Blood had trickled there, making it look as if the snake had been given sacrificial blood .

12

Yuuya was shaking outside the bar .

The fear swelling in the bottom of his stomach . It felt ready to explode . It seemed like no matter where or when, somebody was watching him .

The injury that appeared on Shinichi's arm earlier –

What should he do now? Did he have to live every day in fear of that woman?

He could have borne it if it were just fear, but Asami had disappeared from the locked room and was still missing .

Where on earth has she been taken –

Had she gone to the world after death from which she wouldn't return, like the exorcist called Kamiyama said?

A horror movie he had seen with Shinichi some time ago came up in the back of Yuuya's mind .

It was about a pale woman with long hair disappearing with the characters one by one .

He had laughed at the time, but he hadn't thought it would actually happen to him .

'Are you all right?'

At some point, the exorcist Kamiyama had walked up to stand in front of him .

Yuuya shook his head at Kamiyama's words . No matter what, he couldn't say that he was all right .

'Actually, I have something I'd like to discuss with you,' Kamiyama said calmly .

'To discuss...'

Yuuya replied in a shaking voice .

'That is correct . I would like to save you if possible . '

'Save me?'

Was the exorcist saying that he wanted to save him from the ghost of that woman?

If he was, Yuuya would definitely accept .

'I anticipate that, unfortunately, you will be the next victim if the situation continues like this . '

The tone of Kamiyama's voice was strict .

That... hadn't been a joke .

Yuuya didn't know anything and hadn't done anything either .

He didn't want to become the next victim . He wouldn't .

'I definitely don't want that . '

'Yes, which is why I said I would save you . '

'Do you really mean it?'

Yuuya clung to Kamiyama and begged him, throwing away his pride . Even if he put his head to the ground, his life was irreplaceable .

'Please calm down . I said this earlier as well, but I would like to save you even without your asking me to . '

'Really?'

'Yes, really... However, in order to do that...'

13

Ishii was walking through the corridor in order to go to work when he heard a shout from the Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room .

Ishii rushed in to see what was happening and saw Gotou and Ideuchi yelling at each other .

'What are you planning to do!?' shouted Ideuchi .

'What do you mean, what? Of course I'm going to investigate,' Gotou spat out, holding a cigarette in his mouth .

Ideuchi turned around, bluntly showing his discomfort with his body .

'E-er, what is this?' Ishii interrupted, though he was puzzled .

'Ishii . Did you know too?'

'Eh, what am I supposed to have known?'

The conversation had suddenly turned to him, but he didn't know what on earth they were talking about .

'The assault case five years ago . '

'The assault case...'

He was talking about the case which Gotou had asked him to take the documents out for . He remembered immediately, but he wasn't sure whether he should say that aloud .

'Why are you dragging out a case that was already solved ages ago?'

'Er...'

Ideuchi drew closer to Ishii, who was lost for a reply .

'Oh, it's been solved? I didn't notice . I'll be more careful in the future,' said Gotou, his attitude all the more impudent as he spat out his cigarette .

'Be serious!'

'You're noisy . '

'What kind of attitude are you taking towards your boss!?'

'My boss, eh...' said Gotou, like he didn't want to talk any more . Then, he put out his cigarette in the ashtray, took his jacket from the chair and headed for the door .

Ideuchi called out to him .

'Where are you going?'

'To investigate, obviously . '

'Weren't you listening? The case from five years ago is...'

'I'm investigating another case,' Gotou interrupted .

'A different case?'

'The daughter of the chief of police was talking about a ghost . There's no problem with that, right?'

'You...'

Gotou ignored Ideuchi, who seemed like he still wanted to talk, and left the room .

'Ah, yes . '

Ishii hurriedly chased after Gotou, who had left the room .

'Er, why was Chief Ideuchi so angry?'

'No idea . He's just hysterical . '

Gotou's words were harsh .

Certainly, Ideuchi could sometimes be hysterical, but it still appeared that Gotou was excessively defiant towards him .

Ishii drew up his courage and asked, 'Er, Detective Gotou, do you hate Chief Ideuchi?'

Gotou suddenly stopped in his tracks and glared at Ishii with a furrowed brow .

'Yeah, he's the guy I hate most . Next to you . '

'T-that can't be...'

Ishii's head went blank . His knees threatened to buckle .

It can't be true . Detective Gotou says he hates me . What am I supposed to now that I'm hated by somebody I respect?

Detective Gotou, tell me it's a lie –

'More importantly, Ishii . I'm counting on you for that . '

'For that?'

'Honestly, you fool . I talked to you about it yesterday . I'm going to meet the exorcist from yesterday with Yakumo . You're going to look into the backgrounds of the people there yesterday . '

Gotou jabbed Ishii's chest with his finger .

That was right . He had been so shocked he almost forgot completely .

'Ah, yes, I remember . '

'Bye . '

Ishii watched as Gotou walked away with a wide stride .

14

'I'm coming in . '

Gotou opened the door for the <Movie Research Circle>, which Yakumo was using as his secret hiding place .

Yakumo was sleeping with his arms crossed while reclining in his chair .

How could he sleep in this sauna of a room?

'Oi! What time are you going to sleep until? Wake up!'

'I said before that by waking me up you ruin my entire day, Gotou-san,' said Yakumo with his eyes closed . This guy really wasn't cute at all . While grumbling in his heart, Gotou sat in the chair opposite him .

'It's because you didn't answer the phone yesterday that everything's such a big mess . '

'Did your wife run away from you again?'

– As if I'd ever consult you about my wife leaving home .

'I'll kill you if you make another boring joke . '

'My, my . A policeman is announcing that he will kill somebody – what a dangerous time this is . '

Yakumo finally opened his eyes and stretched .

'I don't want to be a comedian – I don't feel like playing the straight man . '

'Why don't you try?'

'Try what?'

'Being a comedian . If you pair up with Ishii-san, you would definitely be popular . '

'Just die already!'

Honestly, he just kept on interrupting .

He didn't come to joke around . Gotou took a breath to clear his head and started speaking .

'I met somebody with two red eyes . '

The moment Gotou said that, Yakumo's expression changed .

He really was sensitive about this topic .

'What do you mean?'

Gotou explained what happened last night at the bar to answer Yakumo's question .

He described what happened as accurately as he could, of course mentioning the impossible spiritual phenomenon that occurred inside the bar, as well as the atmosphere of the bar, what the people there were wearing and even the design of Shinichi's tattoo .

In particular, he spoke as accurately as he could about what he remembered of Kamiyama .

Yakumo did not interrupt much, but his eyes narrowed slightly in doubt when Gotou said that the ghost that appeared in the bar was Sawaguchi Rika and that Kamiyama's two eyes were red .

'This has become another troublesome affair,' Yakumo said tiredly after Gotou had finished speaking .

'It really is a pain . '

'Why didn't you call me from the start?'

This one sentence of Yakumo's brought the anger in Gotou's stomach to a boiling point .

'You're the one who didn't answer the phone!'

However, Yakumo just sleepily scratched at the back of his neck even while he looked at Gotou raising his fists . He didn't seem nervous at all . It made Gotou feel stupid for being angry .

'Gotou-san, could the tattoo on the arm of the man named Shinichi that you mentioned earlier be...'

While Yakumo spoke, he took a piece of paper that was nearby and drew something with a marker .

'Was it this?'

Yakumo showed what he had drawn to Gotou .

Something like cord coiled around a cross . Though there were slight differences, the contour was exactly the same as what had been on Shinichi's arm .

'No doubt about it . This is it . Why do you know about it?'

'The explanation would be long, so I'll omit it . '

'Don't omit it . I don't understand . '

'I understand, so it's fine . '

'You know...'

Gotou started speaking, but he didn't end up saying the rest .

There was no point saying anything to Yakumo . No matter how much he asked, Yakumo would just speak in riddles . All he could do was wait for Yakumo to bring the topic up himself .

'Let us return to the topic at hand . '

'Just do what you want . '

'In any case, it seems that we need to meet that exorcist once more . '

'Yeah, I was planning on doing that from the start . '

In order to get a breakthrough to solving our current trouble, we have to decide whether the exorcist named Kamiyama is the real deal or a fake –

And Yakumo was the only one who could judge that .

15

Ishii checked his notebook again after entering the reference room .

Gotou had written the names and contact addresses of everyone who had been there last night .

That was Detective Gotou for you . Ishii had been so disturbed by the event that he had just been flustered and hadn't thought that far .

Five people's names were written down . However, they knew Makoto's background .

Gotou had said he would directly meet with Kamiyama, so he just had to investigate Murase Shinichi, Ide Yuuya and the bartender Yagi Keita .

Ishii started up the computer used for searching, entered the names of each of them and started to investigate for previous offences .

If anybody's name came up, it would make the rest of the investigation easier .

That said, it wouldn't be so easy – after searching up their names, none of them had a previous offence .

Now, what would he do next?

It was impossible for one person to check three people's backgrounds in the first place .

Usually, the work would have been split up .

No, he didn't have the time to be timid . Ishii had done nothing good at all this case . He felt like he had been doing nothing but shrieking .

Inside Ishii's head, he remembered something Gotou had said to him during the last case . 'You've got some guts for a guy in charge of playing the fool . You did good . ' He felt a warm feeling in his heart just from remembering it .

For a repeat of that emotion .

– Do your best, Ishii Yuutarou .

16

'Hey, Yakumo . Why are you helping me out?'

While driving the car, Gotou asked Yakumo in the passenger seat this question .

Yakumo looked surprised . It made sense . Gotou wasn't sure why he was suddenly asking that either . He wasn't thinking straight .

However, he couldn't help but feel suspicious . Though he had complained about everything, Yakumo was helping him , even to the point of risking danger to himself . Why was that?

Yakumo could have just ignored him and been done with it .

Actually, Gotou might have been directing that question to himself .

Like Ideuchi had said, why was he sticking his neck into an unrelated investigation? What would come out of it?

That was no good . Lately, he kept on thinking about useless things .

'Never mind . Forget about it . '

Gotou took back his question with a bitter smile . Yakumo smiled bitterly as well .

'Gotou-san, isn't it time for you to stop blaming yourself?'

'Hah? Blaming myself? What do you mean?'

What was this guy talking about?

'I mean exactly what I said . It hurts to watch you, Gotou-san . '

'It hurts?'

'Yes . Gotou-san, you quickly empathise with the victims and assailants . Accordingly, you rile up, shout and cry together with them . Usually, these should be cordoned off by saying something such as “This is how it is” . '

Gotou felt like he had been stabbed where it hurt most, but he didn't want to acknowledge it honestly and also felt that it wasn't something he could do .

'That's not true . '

'Feel free to deny it, but you've noticed yourself, have you not? When you empathise and then reach a conclusion that you do not desire, you blame yourself, saying that if you had done better, it wouldn't have turned out the way it did . '

'I said you're wrong . '

Gotou's voice was getting louder .

However, something like that wouldn't work on Yakumo .

'In the first place, the flow of fate cannot be changed by the power of one person alone . No matter how hard you work, undesirable conclusions will come your way . To blame yourself for that would be foolish . '

Gotou wanted to object, but he couldn't find the words .

He had no plans for great justice, but like Yakumo said, Gotou always thought after a case ended .

Couldn't there have been a better ending –

If he had noticed earlier, couldn't there have been a different path?

But, like Yakumo said, that was foolish . It was nothing more than regret .

'However . '

After a silence, Yakumo started speaking again . With eyes full of intent, he continued while staring straight ahead .

'However, even if one cannot change everything about the results, it might be possible to find respite, even if it is incredibly slight . '

Gotou looked at Yakumo's face in his surprise .

It was mysterious – this curt, unsociable and contrary person appeared, somehow, to be filled with kindness .

'That is why I am helping with your investigation, Gotou-san . I might be the same type of person as you . '

The moment Gotou heard Yakumo finish speaking, he started laughing at how odd it was .

'What is so funny?'

He didn't feel like responding to Yakumo's question, but it amused him so much he continued laughing with his stomach in knots .

'Let me withdraw what I said . Please make this the last time you drag me into one of your cases . '

Sulking, Yakumo turned his face away .

What a cute guy . He used to be a man whose eyes looked down on everything in the world, but he had changed . It was Haruka-chan's doing . That was youth for you .

The face of Gotou's wife, Atsuko, appeared in his mind . He shouldn't laugh at other people . It had probably been the same for him .

When I lose sight of myself and am at the ready, she leaves home like she's been watching me, but when I'm completely absorbed in the case and everything starts to storm, she unexpectedly comes back .

Women are terrifying, really –

* * *

Kamiyama's office was in the next city .

It was on the first floor of an apartment in the residential area . There was no sign . There was only a plate on the door which read <Kamiyama Psychic Research Institute> .

A while after Gotou pressed the intercom button, there was a reply: <Who is it?>

'Gotou, the detective . '

<Please wait a moment . I will open the door . >

After the door opened, Kamiyama stood there . Like yesterday, his clothes were black from top to bottom . However, his shirt was ironed stiff, unlike Gotou's .

'There's something I want to ask . '

'Please go ahead and come in, though the space is small . '

Gotou thought he'd be refused since he had come without an appointment, but Kamiyama quickly opened the door and invited Gotou in .

'He's not with the police, but there's someone I want to bring with me . You mind?'

When Gotou finished talking, Yakumo walked a step forward from behind him .

'Ah, you're from that time . '

Yakumo curtly replied with only a 'Hello' to Kamiyama's surprised exclamation .

Gotou and Yakumo went into a living room that was ten tatami in size .

The walls were lined with bookshelves full of materials related to psychic phenomena, and there was a reception area in the middle of the room, but that was all .

It didn't feel lived in . Well, that made sense if it was used as an office .

Gotou sat next to Yakumo on the sofa at the reception . Kamiyama took out cold tea and sat on the opposite sofa .

'Is it no smoking here?' Gotou asked, taking a cigarette from his pocket .

'Please go ahead,' Kamiyama replied . He took an ashtray from below the table and placed it in front of Gotou .

It was great that they had gotten this far, but what to talk about now? Gotou lit his cigarette and took in a deep breath of smoke while he mulled over his thoughts .

'You probably want to know who I am . '

Kamiyama was the one who broke the silence . Gotou felt a bit troubled when he was so direct about it, but it would go more smoothly if Kamiyama started the conversation himself .

'That's it . With the trouble this time, your existence, to put it frankly, feels out of place . '

Kamiyama smiled pleasantly at Gotou's words .

'I like people like you, Detective Gotou . '

'Eh?'

'You are a person who cannot lie . '

His attitude made it feel like he had seen right through him . Gotou couldn't relax .

Gotou looked towards Yakumo sitting next to him, but he was just looking blankly at Kamiyama . It didn't feel like he would add to the conversation .

'I gain nothing from being liked by you . Anyway, when'd you start being an exorcist?'

'About five or six years ago...'

Kamiyama replied calmly .

'What did you do before then?'

'It might surprise you to hear that I used to be a teacher . '

'Eh?'

'It's true . I don't mind if you check for yourself . I was a high school teacher . '

Teacher and exorcist – there wasn't any connection .

'Why did you decide to become an exorcist?'

At Gotou's words, Kamiyama glanced at Yakumo . Whether or not Yakumo felt Kamiyama's gaze, his expression was still blank .

'I was not able to see the spirits of the dead in the past either . I lived a peaceful life as a very normal teacher . However, at some point, I was assaulted by a terrible dizziness . I was hospitalised for a while . '

Kamiyama stopped speaking there and took a sip of tea .

'It had been a heart attack from overwork . I wandered the boundary between life and death . When I woke up, for some reason, my two eyes had been dyed red . '

Yakumo's cheek twitched in reaction to Kamiyama's words .

'The doctor did not know why either . As nothing in particular was wrong with my body, I was discharged from hospital . It was ever since then that I could see the spirits of the dead . At first, I thought that my eyes were deceiving me . However, it was no illusion . '

Yakumo's left eye had been red from birth . Was Kamiyama saying his two red eyes had been acquired?

'And then you became an exorcist?'

Gotou put out his cigarette in the ashtray .

'Regardless of one's intentions, if it is an ability that one has been endowed with, one should use it . Do you not think that it would be a great loss if one did not? It is the same as not learning music when one has perfect pitch . '

'Isn't it up to the person whether they use it or not? There are guys in this world who've got classy cars but don't drive them . '

Kamiyama laughed out loud at Gotou's response .

It was an overdramatic response . Everything he did got on Gotou's nerves .

'Detective Gotou, you truly are an interesting person . That is one way of looking at it . What do you think?'

Kamiyama's question was directed towards Yakumo .

Gotou wanted to know the answer to that as well .

'Why do you ask me?'

Yakumo's expression didn't change .

'I said this before, but it is because you have the same ability as I . Am I incorrect?'

'Why do you think that?' Yakumo replied in a low voice .

'I feel it . It might be better to say that we call out to each other . '

Yakumo snorted at Kamiyama's words .

'Please tell me the truth . '

'As expected, I've been found out . It's a simple story . There is a contact lens in your left eyes, correct? A black one . I wear those as well . On top of that, when I met you at that apartment, you followed the ghost of the woman who was falling from the rooftop with your eyes . If somebody else had been looking, there would have been nothing there . That's why I thought that you could see spirits . '

'It is as you imagine . I can see them . '

At Yakumo's response, Kamiyama smiled in satisfaction .

'I want to ask you as somebody who has the same ability . Asami-san's disappearance this time, and the serial spiritual phenomena . How do you see it?'

'What do you think?' Yakumo responded .

'I think that the ghost of Sawaguchi Rika-san, who committed suicide, wants revenge because of her furious hatred . I do not know the recipient of that hatred, but they are probably somebody who was at that bar . '

'Revenge...'

Yakumo said that quietly .

'Asami-san did something unfortunate . She was simply involved . If we do not appease the anger of Rika-san's spirit, there will be another victim . '

'Are you saying that the spirit of that woman made the woman called Asami-san disappear?'

Kamiyama nodded at Yakumo's question .

'I was at the scene . That is all I can think of . I have told you my thoughts . What are yours?'

Yakumo bit his lower lip and looked about, seeming slightly troubled, before he started talking .

'I recognise that the spirits of the dead are clusters of that person's emotions . '

'I think the same way . '

'No . In my thinking, the spirits of the dead exert no physical influence on the living . '

'Which would mean that the ghost could not have made Asami-san disappear . '

Kamiyama's expression, which had been calm until now, changed .

There was a feeling of challenge floating in the air . It was a natural response since his reasoning had been denied outright .

'Though this is only my pet theory...'

'Then how did Asami-san disappear?'

'I do not have the answer to that . '

'Then you should not be able to deny my thoughts . '

'That is correct . '

Yakumo readily affirmed what Kamiyama said . Was he accepting defeat?

'I have experienced many things since becoming an exorcist . From those experiences, I believe that the stronger the dead person's thoughts, the greater the physical influence they exert . '

'Do you have an actual example?'

'For example, lovers can feel their partners' emotions even without hearing them in words, yes? Do you not think that is a demonstration of the physical influence of emotions?'

'Calling that physical influence would be an incorrect definition . Moreover, you are making too great a leap in logic . It is the same as saying that people would be able to fly if they wished for it .

To Gotou, it looked like Yakumo was irritated .

'Then, let me ask you once more . Why did Asami-san disappear?'

'I said this earlier as well . I do not have the answer to that . '

'Then would you cooperate with me?'

'W-what?'

Gotou had just been listening, but he spoke in surprise at Kamiyama's extremely abrupt words .

He glanced over to his side to see that Yakumo looked surprised as well .

'I also have not had that much experience . It would be a bit too heavy for me to carry this case alone . It would be reassuring to have you there with me as someone with the same ability, but...'

'Good results will not be borne from the cooperation of those with differences in opinion, regardless of whether or not they have the same ability . '

After Yakumo said that, he stood up on his own .

At this point, it didn't seem like they could get any more information out of Kamiyama . Gotou stood up with Yakumo .

'Sorry to both you, sensei . '

'I do not like being called that . '

Kamiyama smiled bitterly at Gotou's words .

'That's right, Yakumo-kun . Do you know a man who has two red eyes like I do?'

Oi, wait a minute . A man with two red eyes?

'Oi, you know that man?'

Gotou grabbed Kamiyama by his collar in his agitation .

'Yes, though even if I say that I know him, I have only met him once . '

'Where?'

'Togakushi[2] in Nagano . When I was studying because I was thinking of becoming an exorcist, he called out to me . '

'Don't tell me he's the one who suggested it . '

Kamiyama shook his head .

'No, certainly not . Please stop it . Do you know that man?'

'Yeah . '

They didn't just know him – they were quite indebted .

'Then you understand, yes? There is no man more terrifying than him . I understood that the moment I met him . Those eyes have a darkness that swallows everything . There is not even a fragment of human emotion . His very existence is evil . That is how I saw it . I do not want to have him as an enemy or an ally . '

When Gotou let go, Kamiyama shook his head left and right in relief .

Gotou glanced over, but Yakumo had already left the room .

Makoto sat on a chair in the conference room and held her head in hands while looking down .

Outrageous events had been occurring in succession . However, nothing about them was clear . Everything was shrouded in mystery, including Asami's disappearance .

Gotou had said to leave the investigation to the police, but she couldn't just watch . Newspapers had a different information network than the police .

A short man with a hunched back opened the door and came in .

'I'm Takizawa, but are you Hijikata-san?'

'Yes . '

Makoto stood up from her chair to bow, and then she urged Takizawa to sit in the chair opposite her .

'I sincerely apologise for asking you to come so suddenly . '

'Don't worry about it . You can't write a good story if you hold back . '

Takizawa let out a hearty laugh that did not suit his stature .

Makoto had passed by him countless times in the corridor, but it was the first time she'd faced him directly like this . He had seemed somewhat shady to her, but that laugh swept that impression away completely .

'The truth is, there is something I would like to ask you . '

'No problem, as long as it's something I can answer . '

Takizawa lit his cigarette and took an ashtray for portable use from his pocket, grumbling, 'Can't walk with my head held high with the company being non-smoking . ' Though the conference room was actually still non-

smoking even if he brought a portable ashtray, Makoto didn't say that aloud .

'The case with Sawaguchi Rika-san that occurred five years ago . Do you remember it?'

That was the very reason Makoto had asked Takizawa to come .

Five years ago, Takizawa had been in charge of the series of articles after Sawaguchi Rika's suicide five years ago that attacked the police investigation until the criminal was arrested .

Takizawa rubbed the stubble growing on his chin and moved his shoulders in circles .

'I remember . Not just Sawaguchi Rika's case – I remember all the incidents I've been in charge of . You should beat all the articles you've written into your head too . They'll become your own info source and food for writing good articles . '

'Ah, yes . '

Makoto gave an indifferent response without thinking .

At the news agency, it seemed like there were many people who would go on boasting like this . It might have been because they had seen such a variety of things and had knowledge about them .

'So, why's that case got your interest now?'

'I'm currently pursuing an article about women after they have been victims of assault and became interested in Rika-san's case . '

Makoto gave the reply that she had thought up .

'If she talked about spiritual phenomena now, it would take a long explanation, and there was the chance that he might not believe her .

She made the more reliable choice .

'Damn . '

Takizawa put his hand on the back of his neck and released his breath .

'Truth is, I've been looking into that case again too . '

'Is that true!?'

Makoto exclaimed in surprise, since she hadn't expected Takizawa's response .

'Yeah . '

'Was there something suspicious about it?'

Takizawa didn't reply – he just groaned .

It was natural for him to not want to talk about it if they were both pursuing the same topic, but she wanted to know if Takizawa had any new information .

'Well, I guess it's fine since our topics don't overlap . '

Takizawa put out his cigarette in his portable ashtray .

'What on earth is it?'

'There's a porn site that's been popular online lately . '

What Takizawa was talking about seemed to be the complete opposite of assault cases, but Makoto didn't say that aloud and simply nodded to urge him to continue .

'It caught my interest so I went to take a look . It's an image and video download site with a membership system, but the contents weren't normal .',

Takizawa lit his second cigarette .

There were some people who couldn't stop smoking once they started smoking – perhaps Takizawa was one of them .

'There're the so-called rape ones, but they're not actually that rare . It's just that virtually all the ones on the market are fake . They use anonymous actresses, put a mosaic on their face and just make it look like the real thing . That's natural, since it'd be a crime if they actually did it . '

'Could it be that that site had...'

Makoto's heart felt tight .

Putting up images of real assaults for entertainment – nothing could be more unforgiveable . If the victims found out... But –

'How did you know they were real?'

'I said this earlier, right? I remember all the articles I was in charge of . They become my original info source . '

It can't be –

The blood drained from Makoto's face . What would someone have to be thinking to do something so terrible?

Her fingers wouldn't stop trembling in her rage and fear .

'You catch on quicker than you look . It's just as you imagine . I saw a certain face on that site . '

'Sawaguchi Rika...'

'That's right . Since it was a home video, the date was right on the screen – there's no doubt about it .

How horrible –

Makoto's hands were in fists .

'Worse still, there was a caption in the opening saying "April 2000, suicide by jumping from her apartment" . Can you believe it?'

Takizawa's eyes were red as he stared straight at Makoto .

Makoto shook her head . She didn't want to believe it . At the same time, tears welled up in her eyes .

She felt like she had been touched by a fragment of the suffering and sadness of Rika, who was being disgraced even after her death . The humiliation that smeared her was so great that simply from imagining it, she couldn't look anyone in the eyes .

If somebody had really thought of doing something like this, they could not be normal .

It wouldn't have been strange at all if they were murderous .

'I don't think I've got a particularly strong sense of justice, but this I can't forgive . '

'I feel the same way . '

'I'm going to block off all their escape routes and make this into a story . '

Takizawa's voice was full of a strong intent .

18

Honestly, what was happening?

Gotou's irritation had reached its peak . Yakumo had been silent ever since they left Kamiyama's office, and he just kept on saying 'I cannot say anything until there is more information' no matter what Gotou asked .

Since he couldn't do anything else, he brought Yakumo back to his secret hiding place and ended up doing the rest of the investigation alone .

He easily understood Yakumo's reason for suddenly leaving . The existence of Yakumo's father – the man with two red eyes . Was that man wrapped up in this case?

No, no . Gotou shook away his thoughts .

His already panicked head would be even more confused if he thought about that here and now . Anyway, he would just do the investigation he was responsible for .

Gotou visited the high school in the city that Kamiyama had been employed at .

It was the first time he'd gone, but he knew the name . It was famous – kids with heads somewhat different from Gotou's attended it .

He entered the school building from the front gate and switched in to a pair of slippers for visitors[3] .

It had been twenty years since he'd gone into a school . Schools were mysterious things . Even though this wasn't his old school, he felt nostalgic .

Upon entering, he found a plate with the words <Staff Room> on it to his right .

When he slowly opened the door, the teachers inside the room all looked at Gotou at the same time . It made him remember his days as a student, whether he wanted to or not .

'I'm Gotou – I contacted this morning . Is the teach called Mamiya here?'

Because he had been flooded with sentiment, he ended up using strange vocabulary .

'Ah, you must be Detective Gotou . Please come in . '

A thin middle-aged woman raised her hand at the back of the room . She was an oval-faced woman with tortoiseshell glasses . It felt like she might

say 'zamasu'[4] at any moment .

The teachers in the room started whispering . That's a detective? It felt like he'd start hearing voices saying that .

He could have just accepted it boldly, but he felt like a student who'd been called out and ended up walking in a clumsy manner .

'Please sit down . '

Urged by Mamiya, Gotou sat down on the seat next to her .

'Now, you mentioned that you wanted to ask about Kamiyama-sensei . '

'Ah, that's right . '

'I would like to ask this first, but has Kamiyama-sensei...'

He knew what she wanted to say even if she didn't say the words aloud . Anyone would have that response if police came to ask about their old colleague .

'He hasn't done anything . This is just for confirmation . The police are an unexpectedly troublesome organisation . Even if we know there's nothing, there're a bunch of things we have to look into for reports . You probably don't just visit the homes of problem kids when you're making house calls, right?'

'I understand what you want to say, Detective, but that is also so that families can come to know the teachers . '

Mamiya sounded indignant .

He'd said something bothersome . He didn't feel like talking about education right now .

'Sorry about that . Well, anyway, I wanted to know what sort of person Kamiyama was . '

'Though it is not as if I know about his private life, he was rather popular with the students . Have you met him before, Detective?'

'Yeah . '

'Then I think you should understand . He was a very kind teacher . He would listen seriously even to the trivial stories of students, and he was sharp – he understood the students' feelings well . '

Kamiyama as a teacher, and Kamiyama as an exorcist now –

To be honest, Gotou had expected that Kamiyama would be a completely different person . He'd thought that would be a starting point for the investigation .

However, there wasn't much of a difference in his impression from listening to what Mamiya said .

'There was one student who was particularly passionate . A beautiful young girl with long hair – if I remember correctly, her name was... Kawaguchi-san? No, maybe it was Yamaguchi-san...'

Mamiya pat her wrinkled cheek as he thought .

'I heard that he quit because he'd fainted from an illness . '

The conversation would veer off topic if he let it continue . Gotou forcefully put it back on track .

'Yes . He had seemed to be overworking since a little while before, but one day, he was suddenly hospitalised . He retired then . '

'What illness?'

'It had been so sudden that I couldn't ask about the details . '

There were no inconsistencies with what Kamiyama said .

At the present stage, he could say that Kamiyama had been speaking the truth .

'I see . I said this before, but this is just a formality . It seems like this was a wasted trip, so I'll excuse myself,' said Gotou, standing up .

He didn't have to hurry so much, but Gotou didn't know how to deal with this female teacher called Mamiya . He felt it'd be better to leave before she started talking about some other nonsense .

'Excuse me, Detective . '

Mamiya called out to Gotou .

'What?'

'What is Kamiyama-sensei doing now?'

Didn't she know? Well, maybe that made sense .

'He's an exorcist . '

Upon hearing Gotou's words, Mamiya looked flabbergasted .

It was a bit dramatic, but that response made sense too –

19

Ideuchi dragged himself to his apartment door .

The weight his body felt from overwork had accumulated over the years and would not budge .

He wasn't finished work now either . He had just come home to change and would have to head back in an hour .

He didn't believe in ghosts like Gotou did, but he wondered sometimes whether the weight on his body wasn't overwork but curses from people related to the cases he had handled .

He lived burdened with their hatred .

For Ideuchi, Gotou was only a troublemaker, but he sometimes felt envious . How much easier it would be for him if he could let his emotions burst out as Gotou did without being bound by the organisation .

Killing his emotions ate away at his spirit more than he had imagined it would .

When Ideuchi opened the door, the lights were on . Had he come back today? Ideuchi noticed that he had hesitated for a moment .

Why did he have to restrain himself around his own child? Ideuchi walked into the living room with deliberately loud footsteps, but he didn't see anybody . Was he in his room? Ideuchi dropped the bag on his shoulders onto the floor and sank into the sofa .

Since when? When had he started refusing to come home –

Unnecessary thoughts passed through his head . It wasn't as if he and his son were on particularly bad terms . It just always felt awkward when they saw each other .

'Dad . '

Ideuchi was taken aback when he suddenly heard his son's voice . He couldn't see him from his position, but his son was probably at the entrance to the living room .

'Oh . You were here?'

Ideuchi replied from where he was .

Didn't he already know that he was here? Even he thought what he was saying was strange .

'I've got something to talk to you about . '

Talk? With him? He was probably just asking for money again . Ideuchi had thought he'd be fine since his son had started working part-time, but it seemed like that wasn't the case .

'What? I'm not going to give you allowance anymore . '

'That's not it . '

After saying that, his son came around from behind him and sat opposite Ideuchi .

How many years had it been since he had last sat with his son like this?

Did he get more piercings again? Was it so cool to wear clothes that didn't fit him? He had many things that he wanted to say, but he didn't know how to say them . He'd used being busy as an excuse to leave all the childrearing to his wife . His wife was no longer around .

What was I trying to protect –

'I actually want your advice . '

His son's eyebrows were lowered as he spoke in a shaky voice . The expression was very similar to Ideuchi's own . Not just the expression . His cowardliness and timidity were also exactly like him .

Ideuchi smiled bitterly .

'Go ahead, but I don't have much time . Keep it short . '

'I've been cursed . '

What was he saying?

The damp uneasiness inside Ideuchi's heart grew –

20

Ishii sat by himself in a booth of a real estate agency .

Coffee had been placed on the table, but he didn't feel like drinking it .

Nobody had been in the data for people with criminal records, but he hadn't been discouraged .

He had just met them once, but he didn't think any of them would commit a crime .

Next, Ishii contacted the place Shinichi worked at .

It was a small event planning company, and according to the woman at the office who answered, it seemed like Shinichi had started working two years ago, but he had a good work attitude and could become a pillar of the company .

It was also correct that the young man called Yuuya had started working part-time as well a few months ago at Shinichi's introduction .

Contrary to his appearance, he had a reputation as a serious young man .

From the conversation, the woman at the office particularly favoured Shinichi .

When he said that the police were investigating the two of them, she had been awfully disturbed and had persistently made sure that he hadn't done anything .

Next, Ishii went to the real estate agency for the apartment the two lived in . His goal was to ask about details such as the rent and the contract .

He could find out their economic situation from the rent, and he could see if the guarantor lived nearby .

'Excuse me, I apologise for the wait . '

The manager, who had left the seat, brought back an envelope .

'No, there's no need to apologise . '

The manager sat across from Ishii and handed him the envelope, only to grab Ishii's arm when he reached out for it .

'I said this earlier as well, but this is not actually something I can show you . Please do keep that in mind . '

Recently, with privacy protection acts as such, even if you said you were police, you couldn't easily get documents and investigations were delayed .

'That is fine . It is not as if I will take it out with me . '

The manager said, 'I see,' and let go of Ishii's arm, but there was still a feeling of anxiety there .

It seemed like it would be better to look at it before the manager's mind changed .

Ishii took the contract documents for the flat out of the envelope and flipped through the pages . The rent for the flat they lived in was one hundred fifty thousand a month .

It was an appropriate amount for a relatively new 2LDK outside of the twenty-three wards of Tokyo .

He flipped through some more pages .

When he looked at the leaseholder column, he suddenly let out an 'Ah' of surprise .

The manager looked over to see what had happened .

Ishii went back to the page to check the address, apartment name and room number . It was definitely the one he had received last night .

'Excuse me . This contract is definitely for that room, correct?'

'Yes . '

'This is definitely the leaseholder's name as well . '

'Yes . '

'Are you certain?'

'A copy of a licence is attached at the very end,' said the manager, sounding tired at Ishii's insistent questioning .

'Licence . '

Ishii opened up to the last page like he had been told to .

Just as the person in charge had said, there was a copy of a licence attached . The ink was blurred and the photo wasn't clear, so he couldn't confirm it . However, he could confirm the name .

'What is this...'

Ishii stood up in his agitation .

The person in charge looked at Ishii blankly .

Ishii had just found something serious . He couldn't pin down the agitation boiling up inside him .

21

'Yakumo-kun, you here?'

Haruka visited Yakumo's secret hiding place and found Yakumo staring at something seriously .

That gaze was on a necklace with a red stone on top of the table .

He had received that necklace along with a letter from a boy on a road by the river after the last case .

'What? You again?'

Yakumo noticed Haruka and said that with a yawn . Really, what was with his attitude?

'I'll leave then . Even though I went all this way to help you with what you asked . '

'You should say that first . '

What? It sounded like he was saying she shouldn't come unless she had something to do .

Though Haruka felt dissatisfied, she took the seat opposite Yakumo and handed over the diary and memo .

'I'm done, but I couldn't do all of it . I left some parts out since I didn't understand them . '

'That's more than enough . You've helped me out . '

Without checking the contents, Yakumo took them and placed them in his shirt's breast pocket .

For some reason, he didn't seem like the usual Yakumo .

'Hey, what are you thinking?'

'I was lamenting the future of somebody as carefree as you . '

This person was just – he really thought of the most impudent things .

'You don't have to worry – a bright future's waiting for me . '

After Haruka said that, something suddenly came to mind .

What would Yakumo's future be like? What was he planning to do after graduating from university? He was burdened with a painful and sad past, and his future would involve seeing the spirits of the dead whether he wanted to or not .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun, what are you planning on doing after you graduate?'

'Who knows? I'll think about it when the time comes . '

Haruka didn't think those were Yakumo's true feelings .

She wanted to see what was in the depths of his heart, but he definitely wouldn't tell her even if she asked .

'Why not become an exorcist like that person we met?'

She thought he might get mad, but she was wrong .

Yakumo took a deep breath and closed his eyes .

'Sometimes, I don't know . '

Rare for Yakumo, he spoke slowly and his voice sounded helpless .

It was like a cloud floating in the sky .

'Don't know what?'

'This left eye which can see the spirits of the dead . Sometimes I wonder if it's all just an illusion and I can't actually see anything . '

'Of course not . '

Like he hadn't heard Haruka at all, Yakumo continued speaking .

'Maybe I'm just making up convenient stories to satisfy my ego, even though the truth lies elsewhere...'

'Yakumo...kun . '

'The truth is that what I and that man see are different, even if we have the same eyes . Even though I see it as sadness, he sees it as hatred . He looks at souls and sees darkness as humanity's true nature, regardless of whether they are dead or alive . I also can't deny it . '

'That's too depressing,' Haruka said, finding it hard to breathe .

She didn't want to think that the true nature of humanity was simply darkness .

'I know . My eye can see a small point of light past the darkness... I wonder which of us is correct...'

It was like he was reciting a philosophy book .

Haruka felt like she had seen Yakumo's true nature in those words .

Yakumo was always complaining and never went easy on her, but no matter what he said, he would always try his best for others .

It had to be because Yakumo believed that there was a light beyond the darkness, no matter how trying, sad or painful the darkness was .

It didn't matter whether he was wrong or correct . Even if it was just his wish, he was Yakumo because he could see that light .

'What you see isn't an illusion, Yakumo-kun . You're definitely wrong . I can guarantee it,' said Haruka, nodding multiple times .

Yakumo looked at Haruka and snorted . He looked embarrassed as he ran a hand through his hair .

'Honestly, how carefree can you be?'

'What do you mean?'

'Even things that are true would become false if you guaranteed them . '

This person really is –

'You're so contrary . '

'Well, in any case, I'll take your advice and stop thinking about boring things . '

After saying that, Yakumo picked up the necklace by its chain and stared at the red stone dangling from it .

'This time, I doubted what I saw because of him . There will be an answer if I connect what I saw as it was, without doubting it . '

It was like there was a light of strong intent at the back of Yakumo's sleepy eyes . Haruka stared at that light like she was being sucked in .

It felt like she had gotten a little closer – just a little – to Yakumo's heart .

'What are you looking at? It's creepy . '

This person, just by saying one thing, would completely ruin the mood .

'What do you mean, creepy? I was just looking at that necklace because I thought it was pretty,' Haruka said, clenching her teeth .

Yakumo sighed and flicked the red stone with his finger .

'It really is a beautiful colour . I wonder what the stone is . '

'It's probably topaz . '

'There are red topazes?'

'They're incredibly rare . It costs as much as a work of art . '

'Really...'

'Topaz is said to increase creativity and psychic ability . '

After saying that curtly, Yakumo tossed the necklace towards Haruka .

She lost her balance since it was so sudden, but Haruka caught it with both hands .

'If you like it, I'll give it to you . '

'Eh? But isn't this important to you?'

'My mother used to wear it . '

How could she accept something like that blithely?

'Don't you have to return it to your mother, Yakumo-kun?'

When Haruka asked that, Yakumo smiled bitterly .

What did that expression mean?

'It's fine . I want you to have it . She can't wear that anymore anyway . '

When Yakumo said that, his eyes were a sad colour, like that of a deep ocean .

Could that possibly mean –

22

After returning to the police quarters, Gotou was walking down the corridor to head back to his post .

He'd gotten zero info . He wasn't really hoping for anything, but it didn't seem like there was anything to do but wait for the results of Ishii's investigation .

It felt like a lot of things were connected but they didn't connect . It felt illogical .

If they were to put this case in order and explain it, what Kamiyama said seemed the most correct . Rika was cursing unrelated people in her resentment .

If she still had a grudge against someone, there was no saving them . Saving who? Her?

No . I'm the one who can't be saved –

'Where did you go? I was looking for you,' Erika said in exasperation . She grabbed Gotou's arm and pulled him into a nearby investigation room .

'Why are we going in here?'

'It's obviously because I don't want to be overheard . You really are slow . '

Yeah, yeah, he was slow .

In his anger, he crossed his arms and leant against the wall .

'So?'

'I put the screws on one of the guys in charge at the time and had him tell me some things . '

Put the screws on really wasn't something a woman should be saying .

'Chief Ideuchi said a bunch of things, and it took some time since I couldn't make my move, but it looks like the case was deliberately abandoned . '

'Deliberately?'

'Your voice is too loud . '

Eriko hurriedly covered Gotou's mouth .

'There was no clear statement, but it seems like there were orders with that nuance . '

'Seems like there's more to this than meets the eye,' said Gotou, pushing away Eriko's hand .

'Seems so . It stinks . '

'Why?'

'Don't know . That's what you should investigate,' said Eriko with a shrug .

One possibility was that there hadn't enough people .

At the same time, they had had a murder case that would affect the police's dignity if they hadn't solve it quickly .

They hadn't had the freedom to split up the detectives for an assault case . That was why Gotou and Eriko had been taken out and some newbies had been put in charge .

They'd shaken her up, gotten the case to be put away, and that'd been the end of that .

They didn't have enough people for all the cases – that was how it was with the police now . It was also a fact that they had to think about the power balance between cases of varying levels of importance .

However, if that was how it was, that meant that a woman died as a result of that policy .

'And there's another thing . '

'What?'

'I asked the person who first arrived on the scene when the suicide was discovered – seems like there really was a note . '

'You sure?'

'Yes . The guy turned the notebook that was used in the time inside out while looking through it . '

Evidence that hadn't been in the documents .

Somebody stole it . On top of that, it had to have been an inside job .

However, that would mean Gotou's idea about not enough people would be rejected .

'Somebody hushed up the fact that she killed herself . '

Gotou said the words as they came to him .

'What for?'

Eriko gave an immediate reply . It was as she said . Gotou felt like nobody would gain anything from concealing the suicide . Plus, evidence proved that it was a suicide in the end .

Maybe there hadn't been a note in the first place .

Somebody killed her and made it look like a suicide . The note was a diversion –

There's no use . It doesn't connect –

Damn . The case was really irritating .

Gotou kicked the nearby chair as hard as he could .

23

It wasn't a problem she could keep to herself . Makoto felt that way so she went to the police, even though her concern might be misplaced .

After talking with Takizawa, Makoto went to see the site for herself .

She wanted what he said to be a lie . She had hoped for that, but her computer monitor displayed the truth .

Everyone was unforgiveable .

The person who had done this . The people who sold the images . Also, the people who enjoyed looking at these images .

Makoto felt so much hatred just as a bystander . From Rika's perspective as an actual victim, it wouldn't be strange if she found everything she saw detestable .

Makoto was probably part of what Rika had seen .

Her endless hatred had even enfolded Asami . The moment she thought that, Makoto saw something in that image that she remembered seeing before .

Makoto decided to hand over this information to Gotou and Ishii-san .

Takizawa might criticise her terribly, but it wasn't the time to worry about that .

Makoto was passing in front of the investigation rooms when she heard the sound of something falling . She stopped walking in her surprise .

A door to one of the investigation rooms opened and Gotou suddenly came out while roaring like a beast .

'You're so noisy . Keep it down a bit . '

A woman with the same physique as Gotou came out while complaining .

Makoto remembered seeing her before . If she remembered correctly, she was an investigation member named Shimamura .

'As if I could!'

Her eyes met with Gotou's as he yelled in his irritation .

Makoto bowed her head deeply and walked towards Gotou . Shimamura might have been taking her into consideration because she quickly left after hitting Gotou's shoulder .

'Unfortunately, we haven't found your friend yet . '

Gotou turned his gaze away from Gotou, like he felt uncomfortable .

Makoto thought that his speech and behaviour didn't match with his real self . His sense of justice and responsibility were absurdly strong and he was kind on top of it, but it felt like he was ashamed to show it openly .

'No, that isn't it . There is some information about Sawaguchi Rika-san's case that I would like to discuss with you . '

'Information? What is it?'

'Yes, er, but here would be a little...'

It wasn't something they could talk about while standing .

She had brought her computer to explain . She wanted him to see it if possible . Gotou might have guessed that, because he started walking and gestured for her to follow .

* * *

Ishii returned to the police quarters in high and proud spirits .

Detective Gotou would definitely be happy . Ishii's expression naturally relaxed just from imagining it .

'Detective Gotou, I did it!'

Ishii opened the door with vigour .

Gotou just glared at him like he was noisy . Ishii froze .

'What are you standing there for?'

Ishii hurriedly entered the room after Gotou said that .

Makoto was there as well . Ishii sat on the round chair beside Gotou .

'A-ah, Makoto-san, w-what has brought you here?'

Ishii had planned on saying that as naturally as he could, but he was clearly stammering .

He always ended up nervous when talking with Makoto because of the memory of his terror .

'Perfect timing . You listen too . '

'Listen?'

'You're so thick-headed . She's here with info on the Sawaguchi Rika case .
,

Detective Gotou, I have essential and important information too – but Ishii couldn't say that in this situation .

Ishii couldn't do anything but follow Gotou's instructions .

Makoto was using the laptop computer on the desk . Gotou and Ishii lined up their shoulders and looked at the monitor .

The monitor displayed the words <Rape Club> .

Ishii knew there were sites where fanatical people gathered, but he hadn't thought there was something so tasteless and blatant .

'Isn't this porn?'

It seemed like it was just as Gotou said .

Thinking about it, it was really strange for two male detectives and a female reporter to be looking at something like this together .

'That was what I thought at first as well . '

Makoto replied without taking her eyes away from the screen . Her voice was shaking .

'Could this be real?'

Real? Of course not – there was no way . Rape was a crime .

'Unfortunately...'

'But how do you know it's real? Aren't they just making it look real?'

Makoto didn't reply to Gotou's question . She just moved the mouse to navigate through the site .

Finally, a list was displayed on the monitor . They could probably images and videos by selecting from the list .

The slowly moving cursor stopped on one name .

Sawaguchi Rika –

That . It couldn't be . It was impossible .

When Makoto clicked on the name, the site displayed a picture of Sawaguchi Rika's face along with detailed information .

<Sawaguchi Rika . 22 years old at the time . Certain place in the metropolitan area . Can't get enough of her expression as she endures the disgrace like a champ . April 2000, suicide by jumping from her apartment .
>

The comment was disgusting . Ishii was seized with a feeling of nausea .

'What kind of idiot would do this!?' yelled Gotou, who couldn't help but hit the table .

The woman who had taken her life because of this case was being humiliated even after her death . This was completely unforgiveable .

'I feel the same way . '

Makoto's words were heavy .

The emotion she felt might have been closer to hatred than anger .

Makoto clicked Sawaguchi Rika's name again .

No . He couldn't – he couldn't look at something so cruel . Ishii's knees were shaking so much it felt like they would buckle .

An image in a frame popped up and started moving . There was a woman walking down a street . The camera was probably following Sawaguchi Rika . From the image, it seemed like there was a camera affixed to the passenger seat of a car .

In an area void of people, the car stopped and there was the sound of a door opening .

A man ran after Rika . The man covered Rika's mouth and dragged her forcefully as she resisted fiercely .

The scene changed . It appeared to be a room in a basement .

The wall was bare concrete . The room appeared fairly large, but there was nothing in it that stood out . Rika had her arms and legs bound with packing tape so she couldn't move . She was looking in fear at the camera .

A man came into the frame . He was wearing a knit mask so his face couldn't be seen .

Here, Makoto stopped the video .

'What is this?'

Gotou covered his face with his hands . He could still speak . What Ishii had seen was burnt freshly into his mind, and when he imagined what happened afterwards, there was just this feeling of agony that felt like it would crush his abdomen .

Makoto turned around and looked at Gotou's and Ishii's faces fiercely .

'Please arrest the administrator of this site no matter what . '

'You don't have to tell me . '

Gotou was grinding his teeth out of anger .

'But currently we are concerned with Rika-san . Please look here . '

Makoto looked to the monitor again, moved the cursor and zoomed in on the arm of the man who had come into the frame .

'This pattern . Haven't you seen it before?'

There was a tattoo of a cross with a snake coiled around it .

I've seen this pattern before –

'So that really is how it was!' exclaimed Ishii in his agitation .

'Don't be so loud right next to my ear . '

Gotou hit Ishii's head .

'Eh, but – but – this pattern...'

'Calm down and explain . '

After Gotou said that, Ishii took a deep breath and took out his memo .

'Actually, I was looking into the person called Murase Shinichi, but the name of the person living in his flat is the name of the person who assaulted Rika-san: Oori Kazushi . '

'So there was a connection,' Makoto said, coming to grips with what was being said . 'I was also concerned with this tattoo when I saw this video, so I came here . Last night, this tattoo was on Shinichi-san's arm . '

Gotou yelled, 'Move over!' and pushed Ishii aside to take documents from his desk drawer and spread them out . Oori Kazushi's photo was there .

All of them were frozen by the photo .

The hair was different . The shape of the eyebrows was different . The eyelids were one-fold and two-fold . Shinichi was about ten kilograms skinnier .

However, the differences between Oori Kazushi and Murase Shinichi could easily be changed with makeup, plastic surgery and diet .

Ishii's heart was beating wildly .

'Damn! So that's how it was!?'

Gotou slammed his fist into the desk .

'Murase Shinichi and Oori Kazushi were the same person,' Ishii said with confidence .

Oori's prison term ended two years ago . He had changed his identity then and started living as Shinichi .

That had to be it . That was the only thing that made sense . Then everything added up .

Rika's spirit was aiming for Murase Shinichi and Oori Kazushi in hatred . That hatred had run wild and swallowed up Asami .

Makoto had started crying without anyone's noticing .

Ishii felt startled as he looked at her back .

There was no way for Ishii with his meagre experience with woman to tell whether her tears were from sadness or relief .

All he knew was that it showed her kindness towards others . He might have been looking at her with prejudice up until now .

'You here, Gotou?'

Ideuchi's voice cut through the suffocating atmosphere and he looked in from the doorway .

That moment, Gotou openly clicked his tongue .

'What?'

'You got time?'

'I'm busy now . If you want to lecture me, do it another time . '

Gotou refused him bluntly .

Normally, Ideuchi would start yelling . Ishii stiffened, but what he actually heard was different from what he imagined .

'I'm not here to lecture you . I just want to talk . '

Gotou probably sensed something from Ideuchi's attitude, which was different from usual, because he just said, 'Get his fingerprints to confirm,' and then he left the room together with Ideuchi .

In the now quiet room, a mobile phone started ringing . Ishii leaped in surprise at the noise which he hadn't expected .

'Yes, this is Hijikata . '

Makoto answered the phone . While the conversation continued, her expression grew increasingly grim .

Ishii felt a strange apprehension –

24

Gotou fixed his stare on Ideuchi's receding hairline .

How many times had he met with Ideuchi in the conference room like this before? He probably couldn't even count the number .

This man was pitiful too . Gotou was to blame for half of the hair that had fallen out . Gotou smiled self-derisively .

'What's so funny?'

'No, it's nothing .

Gotou fixed his posture .

'Now, let me listen to that not-lecture of yours . '

'You really don't ever change . I'm envious . '

His tone let Gotou down somewhat .

In the first place, it didn't sound convincing at all if he said he was envious since he had made a fool of him so many times before .

'I don't know what you're being all sentimental about, but please keep it short . '

'That's right . I actually want to ask you for advice . '

Ideuchi looked at his feet while he spoke .

His hands had been squirming about too like he couldn't calm down . He might have been confused as to about why he had put the words 'Gotou' and 'advice' together .

Gotou felt the same way . He quarrelled all the time with this man . Hearing that he wanted to talk with him now was unpleasant .

'Please ask for romantic advice elsewhere . That's out of my jurisdiction,' Gotou joked, unable to stand the atmosphere .

'Of course that's not it . I just want to talk a little about my son . '

'That's really out of my jurisdiction . I don't have children . '

This man had a kid?

Gotou felt a bit surprised, but when he thought about it again, it was natural for Ideuchi's age . He just hadn't had any interest at all in Ideuchi's private life up until now .

'It's an embarrassing story, but my son came to me today to ask for money .
,

'Why not just give him allowance? You've got the money, don't you?'

'You've got quite the mouth . You should know how much I make . Plus, it wasn't at the level of allowance . '

Well, if comparing to what he had to do, a police officer's salary was surprisingly low .

'And?'

'I asked him why he needed so much money . '

Here, Ideuchi raised his head .

Deep wrinkles, shadows around his eyes and pale skin . He looked visibly older than people of the same age . As a part of management, his nerves might have been worn away more than was imaginable .

'My son said he had been possessed by a woman's ghost . '

'A ghost?'

'It seems like an exorcist said that if he didn't pay money, he would die . I didn't think he could be tricked by something like that, but I might not have supervised him well enough . This is your field of expertise, right?'

Of all people, this man's son .

'You telling me to look for that exorcist?'

After biting his lip, Ideuchi nodded .

As if Gotou knew about that sort of thing . He should at least wipe the ass of his own son . That's what he wanted to say, but for some reason, Gotou pitied Ideuchi .

'Give me some info . That's right – first, the name of your son and that exorcist . '

'Sorry about this...'

Ideuchi said those words like they had been squeezed out of his throat, and then he handed Gotou a business card .

– Kamiyama Eiji .

That was what was written on the business card .

'Where'd you get this?'

'I took the business card from my son . '

Gotou suddenly remembered the members at the bar last night . Makoto, the bartender, their current problem Shinichi – probably Oori . And then there was the young man who called himself Ide Yuuya .

'Could your son's name be Yuuya?'

'You know him?'

'No, I heard it from somebody before...' Gotou replied vaguely .

So it really was that young man . Ideuchi and Ide – what a half-baked alias .

But now, Kamiyama's goal was clear . Money . He'd talked all high and mighty, but he was just a hyena like the other exorcists .

It'd be easy to tell Ideuchi what he knew now, but doing that would mean bringing Ideuchi into the case .

It was obvious that if he did, he wouldn't be able to move as freely . It would be a better plan to keep quiet .

'Detective Gotou, it's terrible!'

Suddenly, the door opened and Ishii flew into the room like he was falling .

'What happened?' asked Gotou, but Ishii's breath had escaped him and he couldn't speak .

Honestly . Then there was no meaning in rushing here .

'E-e-excuse me... Earlier, the exorcist contacted Makoto-san saying another person disappeared from a locked room...'

Ishii finally spoke .

This was the second person –

'D-disappeared? Who?'

'The young man called Ide Yuuya who was at the bar last night . '

Ideuchi stood up in reaction to Ishii's words .

This idiot . His timing was the worst .

'Oi, Ishii . Tell me in detail about what you just said . '

Ideuchi seemed to have sensed the situation right away and drew closer to Ishii . Ishii replied with an energetic 'Yes sir!' and tried to continue .

'It's nothing!'

Gotou jumped up from the sofa and covered Ishii's mouth .

'I was asking Ishii . '

Ideuchi drew closer, like he felt something .

Ishii still didn't seem to understand the situation . It'd be best for them to get out of here as quickly as they could .

'It's really nothing,' Gotou said, and then he dragged Ishii out of the room .

He wanted to avoid having Ideuchi crawling around them at least . In the worst situation, he might forcefully make them wash their hands of the case .

Gotou couldn't hide it forever, but he wanted to stretch the time as much as he could .

'Ishii, we're running . '

'Eh? Running? What do you mean?'

'I don't have the time to explain . We're going before this becomes troublesome . '

Gotou started running . Ishii started running after him as well .

He fell –

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Gotou, who had run from Ideuchi, brought Ishii and Makoto straight away to Meisei University, so that they could meet one of the most contrary people in history, who had taken up residence at the university .

'What did you come here for so late at night?'

Yakumo was complaining as usual, but when Gotou started explaining the situation, he pinched his brow with his fingers and listened without saying a word .

Ishii and Makoto might not have been able to calm down, because they were standing next to each other by the wall instead of sitting down .

It took some time for Gotou to share all the information he knew .

It had felt like he'd understood the situation, hazy as it was, but when he explained from the start like this, he noticed that everything was actually still half-baked .

After Gotou finished talking, Yakumo thought for a while, but he finally gave Gotou a sharp look and started speaking .

'Did anyone see Yuuya-san disappear?'

'Nobody here did . Seems like Shinichi who I talked about just now was there with him . She called to check . '

Makoto nodded silently to confirm what Gotou said .

'There is a possibility that the person called Shinichi-san may be the same person as Oori Kazushi-san from the assault case then . '

'Yeah, that's right . '

They didn't have fingerprints or any physical evidence, but that had to be it if they looked at it from the situation .

'Then the exorcist, Kamiyama-san, declared that this series of incidents was caused by Sawaguchi Rika-san's grudge . '

'Yeah, that's right . '

Yakumo put his index finger to his brow .

'I've got it,' he said quietly .

'W-w-wha – you've got it?'

He wasn't Ishii, but Gotou had to stutter in a loud voice in his surprise .

'I've said this before – please don't speak so loudly . At this distance, I can hear you if you just speak normally . '

Yakumo was covering his ears as usual to show how loud he thought Gotou was . Even though he had to know how important what he had said was .

'Have you really got it?'

'Please don't make me say it again . Well, there are some parts that I don't understand, but I've roughly grasped the situation with this series of incidents . '

'Explain it then!'

Even if Yakumo complained about his loud voice, Gotou couldn't calm down .

It appeared that Ishii and Makoto felt the same way . The mood had been painful, but the two of them were now leaning forward, eating up the conversation .

'You really are a hasty person . This is just my conjecture – I have no proof at all . If we make a big fuss without proof, he'll get away .

That's true –

'To say nothing of how there haven't been any victims that seem like victims in this case . The police wouldn't move for something like this . '

Well, what Yakumo said made sense .

It would be a different story if the police would acknowledge that a ghost made somebody disappear, but as long as they wouldn't, they wouldn't move at all .

But then –

'What should we do?'

'It will be troublesome, but you should investigate more . Once we have all our cards, all we can do is go to the scene . '

The corners of Yakumo's lips turned up in a smirk .

Even if Gotou asked him more, Yakumo would just be as slippery as an eel without saying anything at all . It was mortifying, but it seemed like all Gotou could do was obey Yakumo's instructions .

'Then what should we be investigating exactly?'

'First, there is something I would like you to confirm . '

'What?'

Gotou slackened his tie because he found it hard to breathe .

'The investigation has not been finished yet . Please look into the bartender's personal history . Oori Kazushi's as well . He is working at an event planning company, correct? Please look into all the work he has done .

Gotou understood why he should look into the bartender .

However, he didn't understand why he should look into Oori Kazushi's work . It didn't seem like looking into something like that would be of any use .

'Now, Ishii-san . '

Yakumo took a nearby notebook and wrote something with his pen . He ripped the page out and handed it to Ishii .

Ishii took the memo nervously .

'It may be a bit troublesome, but please prepare the items listed there as quickly as you can . '

'What on earth is this?'

Yakumo waved away Ishii's words .

'Please don't ask me right now . If there is anything you don't know, please try asking Hata-san . He should know . '

Ishii consented with a sigh .

'E-excuse me, but is there anything I can do to help?'

Makoto stepped forward and spoke up . Yakumo looked at Makoto with a raised eyebrow . Makoto flinched, but she continued speaking .

'Asami – my friend – has gone missing . Please let me do something as well . '

Gotou understood Makoto's feelings well, so he said, 'Why not let her help Ishii? She'll do better with that too . '

Yakumo ran his fingers through his hair like he thought it troublesome .

'Please don't say something so idiotic . I will say this now, but Makoto-san is in an extremely dangerous situation . '

'What do you mean!?' Gotou shouted .

'Like I said, please don't speak so loudly . '

'Shut up! What do you mean, dangerous?'

'I mean exactly what I said . '

Yakumo responded to Gotou's question with an extremely natural expression .

'Currently, two people are missing . You are likely the next target, Makoto-san . '

Yakumo pointed at Makoto .

At that moment, the blood drained from Makoto's face . It looked like Yakumo had drained Makoto's vitality himself .

Does that mean Makoto's going to disappear too –

26

Ishii was driving the car .

Gotou was in the passenger seat and Makoto was in the backseat .

Ishii didn't understand what Yakumo was thinking at all .

However, they couldn't ignore Yakumo after he'd said Makoto would be the next target, so they were driving her home .

Gotou was smoking one cigarette after another, while Makoto was looking down and rubbing her hands on top of her lap, like she was cold .

Nobody spoke .

'Is the air conditioning too strong?' said Ishii, unable to bear with suffocating atmosphere in the car, but Makoto just shook her head .

It really had become a serious state of affairs .

From the way Yakumo was talking, it sounded like the case would be over soon, but unfortunately, Ishii didn't think it would .

The series of incidents this time couldn't be settled simply with just victims and assailants .

If it was like Kamiyama said and Rika's grudge had caused these incidents, there would never be an end .

No matter what words they used to console her, her hatred couldn't be cured .

'You can just leave me at the next corner,' Makoto said from the backseat .

Her father was the chief of the police . It would be unfortunate in a number of ways if they ran into him . Makoto was probably looking out for them .

Ishii looked to Gotou for a decision .

'The next corner then . '

Gotou put out his cigarette in the ashtray .

Ishii listened to Gotou's instructions and stopped the car at the intersection with the hazard lights on . He saw a white van parked ten metres ahead of them .

It looked like somebody was in it, but the engine wasn't on .

'Really, thank you very much . '

After Makoto bowed her head deeply and got off the car, she turned left at the intersection and walked away .

A man got off the van and walked in the same direction as Makoto .

The car's licence plate was covered with black tape so it couldn't be read .

'Detective Gotou, look...'

Ishii's heart was thumping as he pointed at the back of the man turning the corner .

'What?'

'Just now, a man walked in the same direction as Makoto-san . '

'A man?'

Gotou was too slow, so when he turned his eyes, the man had already turned the corner .

Ishii remembered the feeling that was rising in the pit of his stomach . He had a bad feeling about this .

'I'm going to go check on the situation . '

'What situation?'

Ishii turned away from Gotou's question and got off the car . He started walking briskly towards Makoto and the man .

The further he went into the dark, the faster his heart pounded . His back was coated in sweat .

The residential area at night was blanketed in silence .

The streetlights placed at intervals made it all the more eerie .

Makoto's house was about fifty metres down the road, after turning the corner at the park .

When he approached the park, there was the sound of a tree branch rustling . Ishii jumped up in terror like a fish that had been caught and reeled .

He took deep breaths and looked over to see somebody's figure standing across from the shrubs .

'W-w-who's there?' Ishii called, his voice shaking .

The figure threw what he was holding – something like an iron pipe – and ran in the other direction .

Should he make chase? While Ishii was trying to come to a decision, the figure disappeared into the dark .

It was too late to start the chase now . Ishii gave up and slowly went into the park . He looked around, but Makoto was nowhere to be found .

Maybe she had gone ahead and had already gotten home . Well, that would be good .

His tension eased .

The next moment –

Something grabbed onto Ishii's right ankle .

There was a woman with blood coming out of her head by Ishii's feet .

'Aaaaahh!'

Ishii let out a bloodcurdling shriek .

'Stay away . Stay away . '

He was trying to shake off the hand gripping to his ankle when he kicked the woman's head with his left foot .

The woman lost her strength and suddenly collapsed .

Eh, could it be –

Ishii's bad feeling struck home . The bleeding woman who had collapsed was Makoto .

I know I was surprised, but what have I done –

* * *

Gotou was staring out absentmindedly from the passenger seat of the car .

What's got Ishii so worked up –

Just as he had lit up his umpteenth cigarette, he saw a man run around the intersection corner . He looked to be in a hurry, and he got in the white van that had been parked there since earlier .

The image of the assault he had seen earlier suddenly came up in Gotou's head .

The car that had been tailing Sawaguchi Rika had been a white van . The same model that was parked in front of him .

On top of that, the number was hidden with tape . It was suspicious . Maybe he should question him –

Gotou got out of the car immediately and briskly approached the white van .

'Oi . You . Show me your licence . '

Gotou peered into the white van to see the driver seat and was startled . The man in the driver's seat was wearing a black mask .

'Show me your face . '

At the same time as Gotou said that, the car engine started .

'Wait! Hey!' yelled Gotou, but the white van drove off into the dark night .

'Damn it!'

Gotou kicked the asphalt in his anger .

– It hurts .

NOTES:

[1] Manjuu (まんじゅう or 饅頭) are steamed buns with fillings .

[2] Togakushi (戸隠) is a small village with only four thousand people, though there used to be ten thousand . It has a SHRINE and has mountains, which have a SKI RESORT .

[3] It is customary to take off your shoes in Japanese schools, so slippers are prepared for visitors . Here are some PLASTIC SLIPPERS put out for a school festival . People (such as parents) may bring their OWN FANCIER SLIPPERS .

[4] Zamasu is an ending for sentences that originated in Edo . Though it is part of the YAMANOTE DIALECT, it seems that it is not often heard outside of anime and manga . It is considered polite and a bit hoity-toity . Pointy glasses like the ones Mamiya wear used to be called ZAMASU GLASSES (ざますメガネ or zamasu megane) .

Volume 3 Chapter 3: VOLUME 3 - THE LIGHT BEYOND THE DARKNESS

Chapter 3

VOLUME 3 - THE LIGHT BEYOND THE DARKNESS

file 03: grudge (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

In the morning, Haruka visited Yakumo's secret hiding place .

She was wearing the necklace she had received from Yakumo yesterday, of course . She wanted to see how he would react .

That said, the fixture that connected the chain of the necklace she had brought home had broken, so she couldn't wear it as it was .

She just went and switched it with a leather cord from another necklace she had at home .

She thought it matched pretty well .

Yakumo was sitting in the chair he always did with his bedhead and sleepy eyes as usual, and he said, sounding like a fizzy drink that had gone flat, 'You again?'

It wasn't just his words – not even his expression changed . He didn't notice even when she tried .

'You look sleepy as usual . '

Though she felt disappointed, Haruka sat down across from Yakumo .

'I'm busy . '

'I can't tell . '

'There's somewhere I have to go after this . '

'Really . Even though I thought I'd keep you company since you were free .
,

'It's the opposite,' said Yakumo in the same tone of voice, and then he slowly stood up .

So he really was heading out . Haruka was going to give up when Yakumo called out to her .

'Will you go too?'

'Go where?'

She asked that, but the truth was it didn't matter where .

Since Yakumo had gone out of his way to invite her, of course she would go .

'The continuation of the case . There's something I have to investigate . '

Ah, so that's what it was —

That case wasn't finished yet . Since she had been entrusted with the diary, she had a duty to see the case to the end .

'Of course I'll go . '

They walked from the university to the station, took a cab and walked another fifteen minutes .

When they reached the apartment they were aiming for, Haruka was covered in enough sweat to warrant a change of clothes .

Yakumo talked the manager into unlocking the auto-lock and lending them the key to the roof of the apartment . Then, they took the elevator up to the seventh floor and took the stairs up from there to the roof .

There was no railing or fence – the edge was just a little bit taller, like it had been folded back .

Haruka stood in front of that edge and narrowed her eyes .

She had an unbroken view of the town, cutting through the mountain like a miniature garden .

When she looked at it like this, it didn't feel like anybody lived there .

A scene with only buildings lined up inhumanly and irregularly . However, many people's emotions existed there .

Before Sawaguchi Rika-san jumped from this rooftop, what did she feel –

With his hands in his pockets, Yakumo jumped onto the highest edge . It scared Haruka to look at him .

'Why do you think she jumped from here?'

Yakumo spoke to the air .

'Because she had decided to die...'

'Correct . That was not an impulsive decision . She had decided to die with a strong intent . '

'Why do you think that?'

'Her family lived on the fifth floor of this apartment . If it had been an impulsive decision, she would have jumped from there . '

'I see...'

'However, she didn't do that . She purposefully went up the stairs, somehow opened the locked door to the rooftop and stood here . '

It was just as Yakumo said . In order to come here, she would have had to borrow the key from the manager . That would take a lot of effort . It didn't feel impulsive – it felt planned .

Yakumo looked up at the sky .

Haruka looked at the sky in the same way . A clear blue sky, discrepant with the situation, spread out above them .

The clouds carried by the wind looked like waves .

'Is there some meaning to this place?' Yakumo said, still looking up at the sky .

'Maybe it has some special memories . '

'That may be it . She might have come here in her pain to be soothed rather than to die . '

Yakumo turned his gaze to the town that spread out below them . His eyes seemed incredibly sad .

Yakumo didn't often put his own feelings honestly into words, so his eyes did a surprising amount of talking for him .

'So you really were still here,' said Yakumo as he turned around .

He was looking directly behind Haruka . Was someone there?

Haruka turned around, but she couldn't see anything . She turned back to look at Yakumo for an answer .

'Sawaguchi Rika-san, yes?' said Yakumo .

Oh, so she came here?

That was what Yakumo saw .

After a silence, Yakumo jumped off the edge and slowly started walking .

He passed by Haruka and proceeded straight forward, towards where Haruka thought Rika was .

The photo of Rika she had seen at the altar came up in Haruka's mind .

When she was in the photo, she had been about the same age as Haruka and she had smiled really happily, showing her teeth .

Haruka couldn't feel any shadow of death from it .

What sort of expression did she have here now?

Haruka followed Yakumo's back with her gaze . Even though she couldn't see her, Rika was in front of that gaze .

'Let's put an end to this already . '

Yakumo spoke in a gentle tone, like he was speaking to a child .

'Death won't bring release,' Yakumo continued .

The cry of the cicada sounded frightfully loud .

Because of the heat which scorched her skin, sweat came down from her forehead and dripped from her chin to the concrete .

'Stop already!'

Yakumo's voice drowned out the cry of the cicadas .

For a while, Yakumo stood as still as if time had stopped, but finally, he gave up and shook his head while looking down .

'It's no use . As I thought, my voice won't reach her . '

'What do you mean?' asked Haruka, who couldn't understand what he'd said .

'It looks like I really will have to have him exorcise her . '

After saying that, Yakumo took out his mobile phone .

By him, does he mean that that exorcist we met before –

2

Gotou visited Hata's hospital . He was sipping tea in his usual heedless manner .

'You look really tired . '

'I don't enjoy my work as much as you enjoy yours, old man,' said Gotou as he handed Hata a memo .

It was the one Yakumo handed to Ishii yesterday . This should have been Ishii's job, but he couldn't come since he was busy elsewhere .

Honestly . Kicking the face of the chief's daughter – there was a limit even to clumsiness .

Thanks to that, Ishii was being wrongfully doubted and was probably strictly restrained right now, even though he had gone to help Makoto .

'What is this?' asked Hata, looking at the memo with a complex expression on his face .

'I want you to collect the items on that list . And make it fast . '

'What are you going to do once you've got them?'

'I want to ask that myself . '

Gotou crossed his arms as he tossed out that comment .

Hata brought his face closer to Gotou's and looked at him with cloudy eyes, as if he were tasting him . It was creepy . Did Hata want to autopsy him?

'You should take some time off,' said Hata, finally letting his face muscles go slack . He spoke gently, like he was looking out for his kid .

'What are you saying all of a sudden?'

'I'd thought of saying it before, but you're not suited to being a detective . Why not take some time off and think about it?'

'Huh?'

Not suited to being a detective, he says –

Nobody had ever told him that before, and the thought had never crossed his mind .

'It hurts to look at you . You're rebelling against the police, an organisation you can't win against, and you empathise with the victims of each of your cases and your anger just explodes . It's like you're hurting yourself . '

'I'm not that masochistic . '

'Then why are you blaming yourself? You'll just be worn out if you keep putting the burden for everything on your shoulders even when you could just let it go . '

'Mind your own business . '

'Why are you still a detective after all that?'

Damn this perverted old man for saying the same thing as Yakumo .

Do I look like I'm suffering that much? They're wrong . I'm not suffering . Reason being –

'I just rebel against the organisation because I find it frustrating . You say I empathise with the victims? Of course I do! If you asked me, it'd be stranger to look at them like a bystander!'

Gotou talked at length in his agitation .

He wasn't trying to look good or anything – that was how he really felt .

Hata sighed like he was tired of Gotou . What's with that look of pity?
Gotou didn't have the right to have people look at him with pity .

Most victims were angry at their assailants, but they couldn't let it out .
Sawaguchi Rika was a good example .

She had even taken her life because of all that she suffered .

Gotou couldn't silently watch that . That was all .

He didn't know why . That was just the sort of person he was .

'Well, fine . All I have to do is prepare the items written on here, correct?'

'Does it look like it'll work out?'

'I won't be able to do it by myself, but nothing looks like it'll make for a wild goose chase .

'I'll come again this evening . '

After saying that, Gotou left the room .

The previous case and the current one with Sawaguchi Rika . There had so much happening lately that he might have been lost in thought, which was unlike him .

It was the end for Gotou though if even this old geezer was worrying about him .

There was no point dwelling on it . He just had to work now .

Gotou left the hospital and got into the car he had parked in the parking lot when his mobile phone started ringing .

It was from Yakumo . There were a number of things he had to tell him, so the timing was perfect .

<How is the situation?>

Yakumo spoke without even greeting him first .

He was the one who was always complaining about how Gotou didn't have good phone manners . Well, conversely, it would feel creepy if that guy greeted him politely .

'Yakumo, we can't treat this lightly . Makoto was assaulted last night,' said Gotou .

<I wasn't treating this lightly . That was why I warned you . >

'Shut up!'

It was just as Yakumo said . He might have been the one treating the situation lightly .

He regretted not sending her all the way home .

<Is she all right?>

'She's in hospital . It appears that her head was hit, but she'll be fine . Seems like the perp was wearing a mask, but there was a message which said, "Don't stick your neck in any more than this . "'

He left out how Ishii had kicked Makoto's face . If he told Yakumo, he'd tease Ishii until he fainted . Right now, the guy was as depressed as if he had seen the end of the world .

<A police warning?>

'Yeah . And Makoto didn't see the guy's face, but she remembers seeing that tattoo on his arm . '

<The snake and the cross?>

'That's right . '

Makoto had just started looking into the assault case from five years ago again . With this timing, Oori Kazushi was probably the one who had assaulted her .

It'd be great if he could just stop his roundabout investigation and arrest Oori .

<And how is the investigation I asked you to conduct?>

'Ah, I looked into the bartender called Yagi . '

Gotou took a memo from his pocket .

Gotou hadn't had the time to investigate with the incident last night, so he asked Eriko to . She'd replied first thing in the morning .

<How was it?>

'The bartender Yagi Keita is the son of Yagi Yasushi, the former Diet member . '

'And?' Yakumo pressed .

'Yasushi was arrested three years ago for the embezzlement of his secretary's wages and lost his standing . '

<Ah, that case . >

Yakumo sounded like he knew about it .

Gotou hadn't, but it seemed like it had been a pretty big deal . Eriko had also gotten the results of the investigation so quickly because she

remembered Yasushi's name .

'After he lost his standing, he ate himself out of his fortune, but Yasushi passed away two years ago due to cancer . That bar was left behind as his son's only inheritance . '

<Is that so? And how about Oori-san's work?>

'I'm just about to head there . '

So slow – Gotou readied himself for that complaint, but Yakumo responded differently than what he had expected .

<I understand . Gotou-san, could you put off the matter with Oori-san and meet with Makoto-san?>

She'd just needed three stitches for her head injury . She was just in the hospital for a check-up now, so meeting her should be possible .

'OK . '

<I see . Please come pick me up . I am at the apartment Rika-san used to live in . >

'Am I a taxi?'

<You're something like it, aren't you?>

This guy . How much more am I supposed to take –

The call ended before Gotou could let out his anger .

3

When Gotou's car reached the front of the apartment, Yakumo got into the passenger seat .

Then, Haruka got into the back seat . She shouldn't have had anything to do with the case, but –

'You on a date?'

Gotou made fun of Yakumo with his usual response .

'If you are going to make such boring and false assumptions, I'll get off the car immediately . '

'My bad . '

Was he kidding? Like Gotou would let him do that . Gotou started the car before Yakumo could change his mind .

I'm glad we're regrouping, but –

'Yakumo, what do you want to ask Makoto?'

'There's nothing in particular that I want to ask . '

Yakumo yawned in boredom at Gotou's question .

'You're the one who said you wanted to see her . '

'That's why I'm going to see her . '

'What for?'

'Because she's in hospital . '

Gotou started grinding his teeth loudly in his irritation .

Sorry, Makoto, but Yakumo should've known better than anyone that they didn't have the time to take it easy with a visit to the hospital .

'Tell me the truth . '

'Gotou-san, it's useless . I asked him many times myself, but he won't tell me anything . '

Haruka replied in Yakumo's stead .

'You've gotten wrapped up in this too, Haruka-chan?'

'That's right . He asked me to help out with various parts of the investigation . '

Haruka said that with a sour look, but Gotou felt like she probably didn't really feel that way on the inside .

She was probably happy that she'd been promoted from the usual troublemaker to the assistant .

'Yakumo, you know the truth behind the case, right?'

'Right – why don't you just tell us?'

Haruka agreed with Gotou, who wouldn't stop pressing the issue .

'You two always come to your own conclusions right away . That's why you always call me in for your troubles . '

'Shut up!' said Gotou and Haruka at the same time .

The three of them went through the hospital entrance to see Ishii sitting on the sofa while cradling his head .

'What are you doing?'

'Ah, yes, er, apologising to Makoto-san...'

Ishii leapt up . His gaze darted everywhere – it seemed like he couldn't relax .

'Did you?'

'That's... er...'

Ishii looked at his feet and stopped talking .

Honestly . What a pathetic guy .

'Hurry up and go!'

Ishii's shoulders shook at Gotou's yell .

'Gotou-san, don't yell at him – he looks so pitiful,' Haruka interrupted .

Ishii's forehead was covered in sweat, and he kept on fixing the position of his glasses with his finger . He really was a pathetic guy – a girl younger than him had to stand up for him .

'Ishii-san, let's go together . We are heading to see her as well,' said Yakumo .

'Y-yes . '

Ishii finally raised his head and replied .

Honestly . It was the end for him if he needed to be saved by a university student . In any case, Gotou hit the back of Ishii's head .

They asked the employee at the reception desk where Makoto's room was and headed for the hospital room together .

'We're coming in!' said Gotou loudly while going into the room .

Yakumo followed him . The private room was about four tatami in size . When your dad was well-known, there really were differences in how you were treated for things like this .

'Ah, Detective Gotou . '

Makoto sat up on the bed .

Her head was bandaged, but she looked much better than he'd imagined she would .

'Hey . We're just here to check up on you . '

Gotou raised his hand, pulled out a round chair from below the bed and sat down . Yakumo stood by the bed with a blank expression without sitting .

'Oh, you didn't have to –I've only been hospitalised for a check-up, so I'll be let out this evening . '

Gotou was glad it wasn't a big deal .

'Sorry about my partner – Ishii . '

Gotou called for him, so Ishii finally came in with a completely red face . Haruka followed after him .

Gotou couldn't tell who had been the one who was hospitalised .

'Come on, Ishii-san . '

Haruka pushed him forward, so Ishii staggered towards Makoto's bed and bowed deeply .

'I am truly sorry . '

His voice was trembling like he would start crying at any moment .

'No, please don't worry about it so much . '

'No, but I did something awful...' said Ishii, his head still bowed .

Was he reflecting on his actions, or was he unable to look at Makoto's face... Gotou couldn't suppress the feeling that it was the latter .

'I'll apologise too . Sorry about that . '

Gotou bowed his head as well .

'It isn't as if Ishii-san had any ill will . Please raise your heads . '

Makoto, seeming flustered, placed a hand on Ishii's shoulder .

'I'm no good as a detective . I planned to save you, but...'

'That's not true at all . '

Makoto comforted Ishii, who sounded like he was going to cry .

What a pathetic scene .

'Excuse me, but since there isn't much time, could I advance the conversation?'

Yakumo interrupted the apologies while running a hand through his hair .

'Oh, that's right,' Gotou said while pushing Ishii aside .

Yakumo walked forward into the now empty space .

'Actually, there is something I would like to ask you, Makoto-san . '

'Ah, yes . If I could be of any help . '

Makoto corrected her posture on the bed . Her expression was stiff, like she was going to undergo an interrogation .

'I want to ask about Asami-san, who has disappeared . '

'About Asami?'

'She was in the same year as you when you were in university, yes?'

'Yes, she was . '

'Sickness or injury, any reason is fine . Did she ever take an extended break from school?'

'She did,' replied Makoto with a surprised expression on her face .

'When was that?'

'During our fourth year of university . Because of an illness, I couldn't contact her for about a month . '

'So that was the case then . '

Yakumo nodded in satisfaction, but Gotou didn't understand .

'Oi . Yakumo . '

'Please be quiet,' Yakumo said, cutting him off . 'How was she after that?'

'That's... Asami returned home after that . I only communicated with her through email and New Year's cards after that and didn't meet with her directly until we met again at the bar . '

'Was Asami-san the one who said to meet at the bar?'

'Yes . She had been relocated to Tokyo for work . '

'I see,' murmured Yakumo .

'Does that have something to do with this case?'

Makoto urged Yakumo for an answer, but he didn't reply .

'May I ask you one more thing?'

'Yes...'

'The tattoo with that pattern was on the arm of the person who assaulted you, yes?'

Makoto nodded to answer Yakumo's question .

'Yakumo . Our perp has to be Oori Kazushi . We have to go and —'

'I did say to please be quiet . '

Yakumo looked at Gotou, who had interrupted, with an incredibly annoyed expression .

He was unusually irritated . Gotou had thought Yakumo hadn't cared much about this case, but he had been wrong .

'The tattoo was there,' said Makoto firmly .

'Was that on the right arm or the left arm?'

'Left... I think . '

'I see . '

'Now that you mention it, Kamiyama-san asked the same thing about the tattoo just earlier . '

The moment Yakumo heard that, his cheek twitched and he looked unusually suspicious .

Why did Kamiyama come here –

'Does Kamiyama-shi know about this incident as well?'

'Yes . He kept on apologising, saying "I'm sorry" again and again . '

After Yakumo heard Makoto's response, he sighed, seeming troubled .

That exorcist apologised to Makoto . Why? Does he have a reason to apologise –

'Gotou-san, a change of plans . Preparations are not in order yet, but let us go to the exorcism . '

'Exorcism?'

Gotou's voice cracked because what Yakumo said had been so unexpected .

He hadn't thought he'd hear the word exorcism from Yakumo, who believed that that ghosts were clusters of the emotions of the dead .

'As well, Makoto-san, I have a request . '

'A request...?'

Makoto cocked her head .

Yakumo didn't pay any attention to her response and whispered something into Makoto's ear .

'Would that be possible?'

'I think it would be fine . '

Makoto replied firmly to Yakumo's request .

For some reason, it seemed like they were in a rush all of a sudden .

'Ishii-san, please help Makoto-san . '

'Eh, ah, yes . '

Ishii gave a flustered reply .

'Now, Gotou-san, we're going . '

We're going, he says –

'Where to?'

'Please, there is no time to lose . '

Yakumo briskly headed for the hospital room door .

It annoyed him to be ordered around by a university student, but there was no helping it this time . Gotou responded with a 'Got it' and followed Yakumo .

'Wait, Yakumo-kun . How about me?'

Haruka, the only one with no instructions, grabbed onto the arm of Yakumo, who had been trying to leave hurriedly .

'You can go home already . '

'Wait, Yakumo-kun . '

Yakumo ignored Haruka and left the room .

He really just did whatever he wanted .

Gotou was grumbling on the inside, but he left the hospital room after Yakumo .

4

Before he took off in the car, Gotou contacted Hata through his mobile phone .

Of course, at Yakumo's instruction .

'Old man . You got the stuff on the memo?' said Gotou once Hata picked up .

<Don't make it sound so easy . I've only got one . The others will have to wait until tomorrow . >

'Can't you hurry it up?'

<I have other work too . Don't be so selfish . And this is all out of my jurisdiction in the first place . >

Hata was quite right .

Since Gotou had just made the request this morning, there was no way Hata would be done preparing in only a few hours .

'Says he's only got one . What're you going to do?'

Gotou covered the receiver and asked Yakumo beside him this question .

'What does he have prepared?'

'Old man, what do you have prepared?'

Gotou repeated Yakumo's words .

<The light . >

It sounded like a baseball position[1] .

'Says he's got the light . '

'That's sufficient . The rest will work out somehow or other...'

Yakumo was muttering something .

'Then what are you going to do?'

'Please tell Hata-san to bring that to Inoue Asami-san's apartment . '

Did Yakumo plan to go there now?

Gotou didn't know what Yakumo was doing, but he wasn't going to grumble after coming this far . He'd go with him to the end .

'Oi, old man . I want you to bring that where I tell you to . '

<I refuse . I said this earlier – I'm busy . >

This damn old man . Gotou would go pull his head off his shoulders .

While Gotou was seething with rage, Yakumo took the mobile phone from beside him .

'Hata-san, this is Yakumo... Could I make a request? I am going to perform an exorcism now... Yes . The solution to the locked room case . '

Yakumo smirked as he talked .

'Thank you very much . '

After he said that, he threw the mobile phone back to Gotou . If he was going to interrupt, he should just talk himself in the first place, honestly .

'Gotou-san, please tell Hata-san the address . '

Yes, yes, he would be delighted to .

* * *

When Gotou arrived in front of the apartment where Asami disappeared, an old man in white was standing in front of the entrance .

He had a paper bag in his right hand .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . It's been a while . '

Hata looked over Yakumo with eyes full of curiosity .

It really was creepy, so Gotou wished he would stop . If he took his eyes off this old man, he might go and dissect Yakumo right then .

'Hata-san, the thing we mentioned?'

Hata showed Yakumo what was inside the paper bag . Gotou had given the memo to Hata without checking its contents, so he didn't know what had been written .

He'd said 'light' earlier, but if it were just a normal light, Yakumo wouldn't have had to go out of his way to ask for it .

'This is fine, yes?'

'Yes, thank you very much . Gotou-san, what are you staring so vacantly for? We're going . '

Honestly, using a detective like a gopher . Gotou would definitely take a swing at him once this case was over . Gotou vowed that in his heart, opened the door with the key he had borrowed and went through the entrance with Yakumo and Hata .

When he pressed the elevator, the lift was fortunately on the first floor so the door opened right away .

Yakumo got into the elevator and made a call on his mobile phone while pressing the 'Open' button .

'Please keep it like this for a bit . '

Yakumo addressed the person on the other side of the phone .

Gotou heard the person on the other end say <What on earth is it?> . She was probably Haruka .

'Gotou-san, could you watch the time?'

After Yakumo said that, Gotou turned his eyes to the second hand of his wristwatch .

'OK . '

At the same time as Gotou replied, Yakumo pressed the '9' and then the 'Close' buttons .

There was the sound of the winch winding up as the elevator started moving .

'The call ended . How many seconds was it?'

Yakumo spoke at around the same time as the display showed that they were on the third floor .

'Eleven seconds . '

The elevator continued going up .

They arrived at the ninth floor . Yakumo ran out the moment the door opened .

Gotou followed after him . He headed straight out of the elevator and then turned right . Another right . It wasn't so noticeable when walking, but it was a narrow path .

'How many seconds has it been now?'

After reaching Asami's room door, Yakumo spoke . Gotou turned his eyes to his wristwatch immediately .

'Forty-five seconds . '

'Thirty-four seconds since the call cut off then? It isn't an impossible number . '

'What on earth are you doing?'

Hata had leisurely walked up to them .

Gotou had no idea either . He turned his gaze to Yakumo .

'This is an experiment related to the locked room disappearance phenomenon,' said Yakumo with narrowed eyes .

'Yakumo-kun, is that really possible?'

Yakumo shook his head at Hata's question .

'Hata-san, if you are asking whether it was a spiritual phenomenon, the answer to your question is no . If you are asking whether a person could have done it, the answer is yes . I proved it just now . '

'Y-you proved it?'

'Like I've said before, please do not speak so loudly next to my ear . '

Yakumo complained about the volume of Gotou's voice again, but it would be stranger if he had heard what Yakumo said and been calm .

'Yakumo . What do you mean?'

'More importantly, Gotou-san, do you have the key to this room?'

More importantly, this guy said .

Gotou withstood the urge to stamp his feet in frustration and handed the key to Asami's room to Yakumo .

Yakumo quickly unlocked the door and went into the room . Gotou and then Hata followed after him .

The room had been left as it was after Asami's disappearance –

'Hey, Yakumo . It's about time for an explanation . What on earth happened?' said Gotou, unable to bear it .

'Have you not noticed yet?'

'I'm asking because I haven't!' yelled Gotou angrily .

'All the spiritual phenomena this time have been tricks . '

Yakumo put his index finger to his brow as he said that .

'Tricks?'

Was he saying that Asami's disappearance from a locked room and the ghost he saw in this room – that all of these were tricks?

'Correct . I will prove that now . Hata-san . '

After Yakumo said that, Hata took something that looked like a torch out of the paper bag and handed it to Yakumo .

It had the shape of a fluorescent lampstand, but the fluorescent tube was a deep bluish purple instead of the white colour he usually saw .

'Gotou-san, you saw the ghost near that window, yes?'

Yakumo pointed at the glass in the window that connected to the veranda .

That's right . That's where . The longhaired woman covered in blood had glared at me from that window . Those eyes had been filled with a strong hatred –

After Gotou responded with a nod, Yakumo plugged the light into a nearby socket .

'Please take a good look . '

Yakumo flicked the switch for the light . A bluish purple light hit the window .

At the same time, a faint image of a woman appeared on the window .

The woman from that time –

'W-wha – this – '

'So that's how it was!'

Hata drowned out Gotou's surprise with his wonder .

Did the old man understand already? Gotou didn't understand at all .

'What is this!?'

'You really don't know anything . This is a black light . '

Hata crossed his arms as he made fun of him .

'Black light?'

'Yes . It's made like a fluorescent light, but it uses bluish purple glass and cuts out a fixed portion of visible light . '

Hata was speaking triumphantly, but Gotou didn't understand what he meant .

'Explain it so I'll understand . '

'In short, images and words drawn using special fluorescent pigments can't normally be seen, but you can see them if you shine a black light on them,' Hata said with a snort .

'You often see it in karaoke rooms,' offered Yakumo as an additional explanation . When Gotou heard that, he finally understood the situation .

So the picture of the woman was drawn on the window so she showed up in the window when a black light was shone on it .

'If the paint is tinted, can't you tell?'

'In the past, these fluorescent pigments came only in white, but recently transparent ones have been developed . It can only be seen faintly now, but when you saw this picture, Gotou-san, it was night, and the lights had been off before the woman appeared . Is that correct?'

'Yeah, that's right . '

Gotou recalled what had happened then .

Before the woman's ghost appeared, the lights had been off . Then, the ghost appeared and the lights came back on while he was surprised .

If he'd looked longer, he probably would have noticed that it was a picture, but there had only been a short period of time .

That was the main point of the production .

'There should be a remote control switch separate from the switch on the wall to turn on and off the lights . The voice that said "Die" should have

come from a small speaker somewhere . It will be difficult to search for it now without a tool, but...’

The room itself is like a haunted mansion –

Now, Gotou had a question .

‘Wait a minute . If this was all set up from before...’

An unbelievable idea was growing in Gotou’s mind .

‘That’s right . The person who lives here, Asami-san, knew about it . ’

Yakumo cast his eyes down slightly as he said that .

‘Why didn’t Asami say anything if she knew?’

‘Let’s ask the person herself,’ said Yakumo with an expression that looked sad . Did he know where she was?

Plus, the mystery of the ghost had been solved, but Asami’s disappearance from a locked room was still a mystery . Did he plan to ask her directly for that too?

Confusion and irritation – a variety of emotions were mixed up and about to burst within Gotou .

5

Gotou gripped the handle with a hunched back in his displeasure .

Yakumo was yawning in the passenger seat . Hata was grinning in the back .

‘So how will you solve the disappearance?’

Gotou looked at Yakumo in the passenger seat .

‘Have you still not noticed?’

Yakumo smirked, and Hata followed with a creepy giggle .

Somehow, the two of them looked like demons .

'You're slow as usual,' said Hata with shaking shoulders .

'Old man, you don't know either, right?'

'Don't use your head as a reference . If I know it's a trick, it's simple . '

Hata gave an immediate reply to Gotou's objection .

'Do you really understand?'

'You did the experiment earlier, yes? There was more than enough time . '

Hata shook his head boastfully .

So Gotou was the only one who didn't understand . That was irritating .

'Gotou-san, it took thirty-four seconds to reach Asami-san's room after the call cut off . '

Maybe he pitied Gotou, because Yakumo started explaining with sleepy eyes .

'Ah, yeah about that long . '

'If the major premise is that Asami-san knew about the trick, there is one answer . '

Yakumo paused .

Gotou's mouth felt dry, so he cleared his throat and swallowed .

'After the call cut off, she smeared her mobile phone with blood and left the room by herself . '

'W-what!?'

Gotou was so shocked he slammed the breaks . Yakumo and Hata pitched forward .

'That's dangerous!' shrieked Hata in objection from the back seat . The cars driving behind them honked as well .

'My bad . '

Gotou gave an honest apology and started the car, but Hata was the strange one for being so calm after hearing that just now . He should have been surprised .

'Then you're saying she caused her own disappearance?'

Gotou asked to organise his thoughts .

'That's right,' Yakumo replied immediately .

'That's stupid . Putting aside that exorcist, Ishii and Makoto were at the scene too . How would she disappear in the middle of that?'

'Gotou-san, if you say that, you have already fallen for the trick . '

'What do you mean?'

'Asami-san, who disappeared, is the victim . Then, Ishii-san and Makoto-san should have seen the scene . That preconception is the spirit behind this trick . '

'Asami's not the victim?'

'No, she is not . Though I had not understood why she had done this up until now, I discovered that reason from what Makoto-san said earlier, though it is still my inference . '

'That so...'

'Yes . Asami-san had a goal and left the room of her own volition,' declared Yakumo .

Just as Yakumo said, he had been thinking with the presupposition that Inoue Asami disappeared against her will .

Asami was Makoto's friend, which may have been the reason for that preconception .

That was why the disappearance from the locked room had troubled him .

However, if she left the room on her own, there was no problem at all . Had she deceived all of them with her one-woman play? There was still something Gotou didn't understand though .

'She could leave the room if there were thirty-four seconds, but the time from when they get off the elevator to when they saw her room should've been shorter . Plus, she shouldn't have had the time to lock the door .

Yakumo spread out his hands and sighed in a melodramatic manner .

What was with his attitude? Gotou hadn't planned on saying anything funny .

'Gotou-san, the wool has been pulled over your eyes . '

'What?'

This brat is unbelievable –

'Please remember well . Immediately after getting off the elevator, did you see the door to Asami-san's room?'

Gotou recalled the experiment he'd done with Yakumo earlier .

They couldn't get to Asami's room without turning twice in the corridor shaped like a right-facing bracket .

On top of that, the path was narrow, and Yakumo, who'd been running in front, had blocked his way, so he hadn't seen much until they reached the door to the room .

'Which means...'

'That's right . That night, the three people who headed for Asami-san's room were Ishii-san, Makoto-san and Kamiyama-shi . In order to perform this trick, the order in which they headed for the room was also important . '

'The order...'

'Yes . The person who ran in front had two roles . '

'Roles?'

'Correct . The first was to block the vision of the people behind him and to regulate the timing with which they would arrive . '

'Really . '

The guy who ran in front blocked the vision of the people behind him and made sure Asami was hidden .

If she'd left late, he could take up time by stopping or falling .

'There is one more . The role of locking the door . '

'Locking the door?'

'Just as you say Gotou-san, there was not much time to leave the room, let alone lock the door . Accordingly, trying to lock the door in a rush would be a great risk . '

'So the guy in front...'

Yakumo responded with a nod .

After fleeing from the room, Asami left the key by the door and hid herself in the emergency stairs or something .

Then, the person in front took the key, locked the door while pretending to check the doorknob and hid the key in his pocket .

After borrowing the key from the manager and entering the room, he could just leave the key casually on the table .

Now that I understand, it's a simple trick –

'And the person who had run in front then was...'

Yakumo's gaze turned sharp .

That was right . Ishii had said that the person who ran in front then was –

6

Ishii sat next to Haruka on the bench in the corridor in front of Makoto's hospital room .

What on earth is Yakumo thinking –

Ishii wanted to know the truth behind this case that was full of puzzles too, so he didn't mind helping out . However, he wouldn't have minded a bit more of an explanation .

'I don't really understand,' said Haruka as she sat beside him, like she had read Ishii's heart .

'Ah, yes . But Haruka-chan, it'd be better if you returned...'

'I definitely won't!' said Haruka, interrupting Ishii's sentence .

'No, but...'

Haruka had been told by Yakumo to go home .

On top of that, if there was any awful trouble in the case, she would get involved in the danger . Makoto had already been assaulted .

Ishii wanted to avoid that no matter what .

'I'm not unrelated to this case . '

'Eh, is that so...'

This was the first time Ishii had heard what Haruka said .

'I promised Sawaguchi Rika-san's father that I'd find the truth behind her death...'

'I see...'

'That's why I can't go home by myself partway through,' said Haruka firmly .

She was surprisingly stubborn . Once she'd made her decision, she went with it until the end . Ishii was envious of that strength .

He tried to run away at every opportunity .

'I understand . I'll take responsibility for you and protect you . '

'I'll be in your care,' replied Ishii with a puffed chest .

Haruka bowed her head with a smile .

She really is cute –

'I apologise for the wait . '

Makoto came out of the hospital room . She had finished changing .

Her head was still wrapped with bandages and there was a dark red bloodstain on the collar of the white shirt she had changed into .

'Um... are you really all right?'

'Yes . It hurts slightly, but... In any case, let's go . '

'U-um...'

Ishii called out to stop Makoto, who had started walking down the hallway .

'Yes?'

'Where are you going?'

Yakumo had whispered the instructions in Makoto's ear, so Ishii didn't know what he was supposed to do, even though he had been asked to help .

Makoto appeared to realise and clapped her hands together, as if to say 'That's right' .

'Yakumo-kun told me to bring my father . '

'Eh!?' exclaimed Ishii, taken aback .

'Why would he ask for your father, Makoto-san?'

Haruka cocked her head in her puzzlement .

'Makoto-san's father is the chief of the police . '

'Wow, that's amazing . '

After Ishii explained, Haruka spoke in her surprise, but then she looked troubled .

'Why would he ask for the chief of the police?'

'That... is something I don't know either,' Makoto said nonchalantly .

In his head, Ishii was saying, 'No, no, no . ' He'd be too frightened .

'We can't just call out the chief of the police without knowing the reason . '

Even if it was his daughter's request, he wouldn't come without an explanation . '

'But since Yakumo-kun said to do so, isn't it necessary?'

'I think the same way . '

Makoto agreed with Haruka's irresponsible words .

What were these two doing? Why were these women so reckless even though they didn't have a plan? Haruka and Makoto didn't pay any attention to Ishii and walked farther down the corridor .

'P-please wait . '

Ishii hurriedly ran after the two them .

He fell –

7

Gotou parked his car in front of Kamiyama's office .

The last time they came, it had felt like Yakumo was being pulled along by Kamiyama . Gotou had felt it wasn't like him .

However, it felt like there'd be some sort of match this time . If not, they wouldn't have come all the way here .

Gotou pressed the intercom button, but there was no response . Maybe he was out –

While he thought there was no point, he tried turning the doorknob . For some reason, it wasn't locked . He looked to Yakumo, who returned a nod .

That was right . It'd be illegal trespassing, but there was no point just standing in front of the door like this .

'We're coming in . '

While he said that, Gotou opened the door and stepped into the room .

Yakumo and Hata followed after him . The lights were on in the room, but there was no one there . They passed the kitchen and stepped into the living room .

There were two partially drunk coffee cups on the reception table .

There had to have been somebody here just earlier .

'Kamiyama! You here?'

Gotou called out towards the room in the back, but there was no response .

Even if he had been there, he wouldn't have just showed his face honestly .

'It seems Kamiyama-san isn't present . '

Yakumo walked in front .

'How do you know?'

'There weren't any shoes . '

Hata replied for Yakumo .

Gotou hadn't noticed at all . There was nothing he could do about being made a fool of if he wasn't attentive .

'You're here, are you not? Inoue Asami-san . '

Yakumo spoke towards the door at the back of the living room .

'W-what!? She's here?'

'Isn't it natural? As you know from the trick with the locked room, Kamiyama-san and Asami-san were accomplices . '

Yakumo shook his head like he couldn't believe Gotou as he continued .

'Furthermore, she was also the person who came to me with the name Iida Mizuho to request that I investigate a spiritual phenomenon . '

Iida Mizuho –

The other case Yakumo was investigating . That was how he'd become connected to Sawaguchi Rika .

'I looked into the university's name register . There is nobody named Iida Mizuho . Asami-san, you pretended that it was a coincidence and involved me in this case,' continued Yakumo .

So that's what Haruka was investigating –

After a while, the door to the room in the back opened . A woman walked out into the living room .

She's Inoue Asami –

It was the first time Gotou had seen her face-to-face .

Her long hair was tied in the back and she was looking down where she stood . Her face was so pale he almost doubted whether she was alive .

However, those eyes seemed to have a strong light in them .

Asami bowed politely, almost as if she had known that this had been going to be the outcome .

There was a bandage around her left arm . The blood left on the mobile phone at the scene had been real . She had cut her own arm and left her blood at the scene .

She had wanted to do something to the point of doing that .

'What sort of stupid game are you playing!?'

Gotou drew closer to Asami .

When he thought about how Makoto had run about in her worry for her, a hot anger boiled up in the bottom of his stomach .

'It isn't a game . '

Yakumo placed a hand on Gotou's shoulder to pacify him .

'Not a game? What is it then? Working together with that exorcist for fraud?'

'That is wrong as well . '

'Then why did she do this!?'

Gotou brushed Yakumo aside and gripped Asami by her collar .

She didn't resist and just let him grip her collar . Her downcast eyes were still alight like a candle that could go out at any moment .

Why is she looking at me with those eyes –

'Stop it, you idiot . '

Hata grabbed Gotou's arm from behind .

Gotou thought of tearing Hata's arm off by force, but he restrained himself . If he shook off this delicate old man, he could very well die .

'Their goal was not fraud but revenge,' Yakumo said quietly .

Revenge, he says –

Revenge for what? Gotou didn't know .

Yakumo turned back to Asami and looked at her directly before starting to speak again, answering Gotou's doubts .

'You were a victim as well . Isn't that right, Asami-san?'

At Yakumo's quiet words, Asami collapsed like her soul had been taken out of her . A trickle of tears went down her face as she sat on the floor .

That response proved that Yakumo's words were correct .

'Oi . Yakumo . By victim, you don't mean...'

'Correct . Like Sawaguchi Rika-san, she was also the victim of an assault . The assailant is the same as well . In Asami-san's case, since she did not press charges, it didn't come out, but...'

'How did you know?'

'Please remember what Makoto-san said earlier . In the fourth year of university, she couldn't contact Asami-san for about one month . That was probably when it happened . To tell the truth, it was a bit of a stretch in logic, but I couldn't think of any reason for her to cooperate in this series of events . '

After coming here, Gotou could obscurely see the outline of the case .

Asami, who had been assaulted, conspired with Kamiyama, the exorcist, and caused the spiritual phenomena . Their goal was revenge .

She must have done something so elaborate because she had been cornered psychologically and needed to make known the weight of what had been done to her –

That was why she'd used the story of the grudge of Rika, who'd also undergone an assault and killed herself because of it .

'When I heard of your disappearance, I immediately thought of the possibility that you were a conspirator . However, I did not have a clear reason . '

Yakumo had a sour expression on his face .

Gotou finally put everything together .

They had been dragged around by a trick, but it was more important to reveal how everyone was related in order to break through this case .

'... It had been an average day . The same tomorrow as usual should have come, but...'

Asami put her two hands on the floor and talked while hanging her head .

Her voice was filled with so much sadness it was painful .

'It was so sudden I couldn't fight back . I just had to bear it until it was over...'

'You...'

Yakumo got the better of Gotou who had started to talk .

He didn't say anything, but those eyes asked him to let her speak .

'The female detective I first met after that said this . "Why didn't you resist? That's the same as consent, isn't it?" ... I'm not a policewoman . How could I have fought back against a man with a knife...'

Asami's words were heavy on Gotou's shoulders as a policeman .

Currently, victims of assault cases in Japan were often treated as having given consent unless they actively resisted .

But, like Asami said, how many people would fight back if their lives were in danger –

Anger which had no outlet ran through his body with his blood .

'So you didn't press charges . No, you couldn't press charges,' said Yakumo, kneeling in front of Asami .

She nodded as her tears fell to the floor .

'However, since you have made revenge your goal, you have ended up bound . You understand what I am saying, yes?' said Yakumo gently .

Asami nodded again .

'Please tell me . Where is Kamiyama-san?'

'That's...'

Asami raised her tearstained face .

'You might already know, but I am the real thing . '

As Yakumo said that, he took the contact lens out of his left eye .

He turned his deep red eye towards Asami .

'Though the method will be different, your goal will be attained . '

'Do you know everything?'

Asami looked right at Yakumo . He answered with a nod .

'And there is something I have to tell him . The real reason for Sawaguchi Rika-san's death...'

'The real reason?'

'Yes . My goal is to save Rika-san and Kamiyama-san . '

'He went to the bar . The situation took a sudden turn, so he plans to use force . Please, somehow...'

Gotou didn't know what Yakumo's real intention was, but it seemed like it had gotten through to Asami .

'I understand . '

Yakumo stood up .

Gotou knew what was going to happen next . They were going to go .
Gotou just said 'I'm sorry' to Asami, who had fixed her posture .

Gotou himself wasn't sure what he was sorry for, but Asami gave a silent nod .

'Hata-san, please take care of her . Now, could you see that Chief Ideuchi comes to the bar called Snake?'

Yakumo's words made Gotou remember something important .

Ideuchi's son is gone too . He's not working with them too, is he –

'I don't mind, but will he come?'

'If he doesn't want to, please say that you know where his son is . '

'That true?'

Yakumo showed Gotou a smirk and left the office .

Gotou looked at Asami again .

However, he couldn't say anything . He was too clumsy with words to comfort her . All he could was show it with his actions .

He got a grip on his emotions and followed Yakumo .

8

Gotou stood in front of the multi-tenant four-storey building that the bar was in .

The sun had started to set so the white walls of the building were dyed orange .

Yakumo, standing next to him, had a difficult expression on his face, which was unusual . He hadn't spoken a word on the ride here either .

Gotou understood, since he had known him for a long time . When he looked like this –

'You in two minds?'

Yakumo looked at Gotou with his red left eye .

'I might be . '

Even though he'd usually put up a strong front, Yakumo readily acknowledged the truth .

'Well, aren't you being unusually honest . '

'I am always honest . '

It was amusing to hear that from the world's most contrary person .

'So what are you in two minds about after coming all the way here?'

'I'm wondering whether there is a need to stop this series of incidents...'

'What do you mean?'

'They haven't committed any actual crimes . No, there'll be a crime soon enough, but still, if I think about their emotions, it seems natural . I wonder whether I have the right to stop them...'

Yakumo's gaze wavered, emulating his emotions .

Since Gotou only grasped the outline of what was happening, he couldn't understand what Yakumo meant . However, there was just one thing he could say .

'To hell with rights . It's not some judgement about good and evil . I can't just leave it like this though . It's the same for you, right?'

Yakumo laughed aloud at Gotou's words .

What the hell was he laughing at?

'That's just like you, Gotou-san . That's right . I'll stop thinking about unnecessary things . '

After Yakumo said that and stopped laughing, he turned his gaze directly to the building .

It appeared that he had been able to change his mood . That was good . He was ready and had put on airs, but Yakumo couldn't be feeling that different from how Gotou was feeling .

'OK – going then?'

Gotou hit his cheeks with both hands to motivate himself and took the first step forward . That moment, a mobile phone started ringing as if to stop him .

What bad timing –

<E-excuse me, it's Ishii . >

He heard Ishii's voice from the phone . It sounded like he could start crying at any moment .

'What?'

<U-um... Where should we take the chief?>

'Oi, Yakumo . Are you really going to call out the chief?'

Gotou covered the mouthpiece and asked Yakumo that .

'Yes . I made that request to Makoto-san earlier . '

So that was what he said at the hospital then .

Chief Ideuchi and the chief of the police . What was he going to start by gathering them? Well, there was no point thinking about it now . Gotou had placed his bets on Yakumo .

'So, where should they bring him?'

'Obviously, they should bring him here . '

That made sense .

'The bar . '

Gotou said that and hung up .

Now –

'Going?'

'Yes, let's go . '

Gotou started walking before Yakumo answered . He took the stairs down to the bar in the basement and placed his hand on the doorknob . It was locked and wouldn't open .

'Please open it,' Yakumo said, as a matter of course .

Yeah, yeah, he got it .

Like a locked door would stop Gotou . He kicked the door with all his strength .

However, the wooden doorframe only warped a bit .

Gotou kicked it a second and third time .

'Damn! What a door!'

The door opened on the fourth kick .

'Isn't there a way to enter more quietly?'

'Shut up!'

Gotou intercepted Yakumo's comment with a yell and stepped into the bar .

The lights were off and the bar was completely dark . However, he felt somebody there .

Gotou advanced to the back of the bar without hesitation .

Clatter .

Gotou's ears caught a noise .

Just as he had put himself on guard, a violent shock came down on his head .

Crack . There was the sound of something breaking . It seemed like he'd been hit by something like a pole .

He saw somebody moving at the edge of his vision .

'Did you think you'd knock me out with something like that!?'

Gotou threw the hardest punch he could at that shadow . He hit it . After a yowl like that of a cat whose tail had gotten stepped on, there was the sound of something thumping against the floor .

Suddenly, everything lit up, so he put up his hands to shield his eyes from the brightness .

'You could have walked in after turning on the lights . Gotou-san, you really are an idiot beyond my imagination . '

Yeah, he was an idiot .

'Stop grumbling . If I turned on the lights, the guy inside would've noticed, right?'

'The person would have noticed the moment you kicked down the door . You really are unreasonable . '

This brat went on and on about everything –

'Shut up! I can do what I want!'

Gotou turned around and grabbed Yakumo's collar .

'You're bleeding . A fair amount at that,' said Yakumo with a smile .

Blood – Gotou put his hand to his forehead . It was wet . When he looked, his hand was covered in blood . There was a broken mop by his feet .

Damn, who the hell had done that?

Gotou grabbed the hair of the person who had fallen facedown and pulled him up to check his face .

There was blood all around the man's nose, but Gotou could tell . It was that bastard rapist who used the fake name Murase Shinichi, Oori Kazushi –

Sobbing .

Gotou heard a voice that wasn't a groan or a yell .

He'd thought it was Oori, but he was wrong . It appeared Yakumo had promptly noticed where the noise had come from . He pointed towards the lavatory in the corner of the bar .

Telling me to go then –

Gotou let go of Oori, and weaved through the space between the tables towards the lavatory .

Gotou stopped in front of the door . Makoto had said that the woman's ghost had been reflected in the lavatory mirror .

Will something appear –

Gotou opened the door forcefully .

That moment, a person who seemed to have collapsed fell out . His mouth was covered with tape and his arms and legs were bound with rope . There were bruises all over his face and his nose was bleeding, like somebody had hit him .

He was Yagi Keita, the bartender here .

His face was drenched with sweat and he was shaking in fear .

'You OK?'

While Gotou said that, he ripped the tape of the bartender's mouth all at once .

'A woman – a woman! I-I'm going to be killed!'

The bartender Yagi was as noisy as a child having a tantrum .

When Gotou looked at the back of the lavatory, there was a faint image of a woman's face in the mirror hanging there .

That's Sawaguchi Rika –

Was she wandering because she had unresolved hatred?

Gotou turned around to see Yakumo .

'Gotou-san, please break that mirror,' said Yakumo, a faint smile on his lips .

No trouble at all . Gotou picked up a nearby chair and threw it at the lavatory mirror . It broke with a piercing crack .

'Can't you break it a little more quietly?'

Yakumo looked exasperated . He always had so much to say .

When Gotou turned back to look into the lavatory, Sawaguchi Rika was still on the opposite side of the mirror .

'Yakumo . Explain . '

'Please take a good look . That is an LCD monitor . '

As he was instructed, he took another look . He hadn't realised at first glance, but it was an LCD monitor and an image was projected on it .

'This is...'

'A trick . '

'A trick . '

'Yes . The mirror you broke earlier was a one-way mirror . When that monitor is off, it is a normal mirror, but when an image is projected there, that light faintly produces her image . '

Gotou recalled the one-way mirror in the interrogation room and understood .

A one-way mirror was a semi-transmissive mirror which split two rooms . When one room was lit up and the other made dark, it would appear to be a mirror from the bright room and would be a glass from the dark one . If both were bright, then it would be simply glass .

If the monitor in the lavatory were turned off, it would be dark behind the mirror so it would appear to be a mirror . However, if the monitor were on, both sides would be bright because of the light so the woman would appear in the glass .

'The other spiritual phenomena were probably also done with one-way mirrors and black lights . '

It was a simple trick now that it had been explained .

'Damn, doing something so stupidly elaborate . '

Gotou dragged the monitor out and flung it to the floor .

The monitor was cracked, but it still showed an image of a woman .

'Why don't you come out already? Kamiyama Eiji-san . '

Yakumo spoke while looking from the lavatory to the counter .

That was right . Inoue Asami said that Kamiyama was here . Where was here? Where was that fake exorcist?

Gotou looked around the bar .

'Inoue Asami-san came clean . Your spiritual ability will not fool me . '

Yakumo's voice echoed through the bar .

In response to that, the small door behind the counter opened and Kamiyama came out .

He was in a black suit as usual, and his two eyes were a bright red .

'I knew that you would come, Saitou Yakumo-kun . '

Even though he was cornered, Kamiyama's tone didn't feel hurried or angry .

There was even a calm and composed smile on his lips . Was he still scheming something?

'Of course . You made Asami-san use a fake name and purposefully involved me in this case . Even my actions now are a part of your plan... isn't that right?'

Yakumo's cool tone wouldn't lose to Kamiyama's .

'Just as expected, your perception is sharp . '

'I don't know if you are praising me or mocking me,' said Yakumo, slowly approaching Kamiyama .

'I'm praising you . No, I may have underestimated you . '

'What do you mean?'

'It is still too early for your entrance . '

Yakumo and Kamiyama looked straight at each other . The air of tension made it feel like sparks would fly .

These two are the only ones who understand everything –

However, Gotou didn't . From the way it seemed, Asami had conspired with the exorcist Kamiyama to cause these incidents in order to take revenge against the rapist Oori .

But looking at these two, Gotou felt like it wasn't that simple .

Why would Kamiyama participate in Asami's plan? Why did he involve Yagi and Ideuchi's son?

Plus, Yakumo had called the chief of police and Ideuchi here . What for?

'Oi, Yakumo . Give an explanation already . '

'Gotou-san, it would be better if you made a habit of taking a proper look at the data . '

'What? This isn't the time to be complaining about things like that . Don't keep me hanging . '

In response to Gotou's irritation, Yakumo smiled wryly as he ran a hand through his hair .

'I suppose it's fine . But before I begin the explanation – Kamiyama-san, please take off those tasteless contacts . '

Yakumo turned back to Kamiyama .

Those red eyes were fake? Gotou had seen it though . Kamiyama had taken contacts off his black eyes and they'd turned red .

'Oi, Yakumo, but he...'

'It's called palming . A rudimentary magic technique for hiding things like coins in your palm . '

'It's a magic trick?'

'Yes . He made it look like he had taken off his contacts, when he had in fact put red ones in . On top of that, after making it appear like he'd taken them out, all he would have to do is show the contacts hidden in his palm,' explained Yakumo while turning around .

Kamiyama let out an amused laugh as he heard that . That was proof that he acknowledged it .

'I rather like them, personally . '

After Kamiyama said that, he took out the red contacts . He'd taken them in .

'Now, let's continue the conversation . '

Yakumo put his index finger to his brow .

'First, there is something I would like to confirm . If this is wrong, then my reasoning will completely collapse . '

Oi oi, Yakumo . Why was he showing all his cards?

If he spoke with that as the premise, the person he was talking to could change his answer to anything he wanted . He could just bluff as he usually did, couldn't he? Yakumo continued speaking, ignoring Gotou's concerns .

'I said this before, but this is only the way I perceive it . I have no hard evidence at all . However, Kamiyama-san . You were Sawaguchi Rika-san's lover . Am I wrong?'

'Though you say you have no hard proof, you sound rather confident . '

Kamiyama rubbed his nose like he was embarrassed .

'That true?' asked Gotou . Yakumo glared at him like he thought he was annoying .

'Kamiyama-san . Please answer . Is it yes? Or...'

'Why do you think that?'

'Right, Yakumo . Why?'

Gotou repeated Kamiyama's question .

'Like I said, Gotou-san, you should take a proper look at the data . '

That had nothing to do with what they were saying now, right?

'Sawaguchi Rika's lover's name wasn't written in the data . What the hell are you talking about?'

'I said it was my reasoning, did I not? It is just the conclusion that anyone would arrive at if they looked at the data . '

'I have no idea what you're talking about . '

Irritation was building up in Gotou and about to burst .

'Kamiyama-san used to be a teacher . At the same school that Sawaguchi Rika attended . '

Was that how it was? Gotou hadn't noticed at all . But just being a teacher and student at the same school didn't make them lovers .

Like he had read Gotou's mind, Yakumo continued speaking .

'That isn't all . Kamiyama-san himself brought up the topic of the ghost of Sawaguchi Rika-san who committed suicide, but he didn't behave like he knew her at all . That is unnatural . Isn't it normal to think he is hiding something?'

Now that he mentioned it, it was just as Yakumo said .

Even if the class was different, he should have known her name and face – he wouldn't have thought nothing of it .

'The time he quit his job at the school is the exact same period that she committed suicide . If we think further along these lines, you heard that there was a female student who had pursued Kamiyama-sensei then . Gotou-san, what was that student's name?'

'If I remember correctly, it was Kawaguchi or Yamaguchi... Ah!'

Gotou let out his voice without thinking .

That was right . The memories of the teacher Mamiya had been vague .

'It seems you've noticed . It might be a stretch, but it was probably Sawaguchi . '

Kamiyama let out a long sigh and walked out from the counter to the floor .

Even if he didn't say it aloud, Gotou knew . Kamiyama had given up on denying Yakumo's reasoning –

'Rika was very kind . She dreamed of becoming a teacher . She had thought that from watching me, which made me happy . She was a bit stubborn sometimes, but she had a strong will and tried to move forward . '

Kamiyama kept talking, like he was reading from a textbook .

However, Gotou felt like he was doing it purposefully rather than naturally .

'You created this plan in order for Rika-san's revenge then . '

Kamiyama smiled bitterly at Yakumo's question .

'Oi, Yakumo . Didn't that Asami make this plan?'

'No, she didn't . '

Yakumo gave an immediate reply .

'Kamiyama-san created this plan himself . Kamiyama-san gathered everyone involved in this case and enacted this plan . '

'Aaagh . '

Gotou heard a groan .

Oori, who had been on the floor since earlier, got up shakily, sat on the nearby chair and hung his head .

Maybe his mind was in a daze or he had given up on running – his movements were extremely sluggish .

'Everything started with his lust then . '

Gotou glared angrily at Oori .

One punch didn't cut it . He wanted to hit him two or three more times .

'Gotou-san, that's wrong . He's on Kamiyama-san's side . '

'Eh?'

This guy is the culprit behind the assaults . He'd ruined someone's life, sold the pictures of his crime, and still lived peacefully, this bastard .

Why would he pair up with Kamiyama –

'Perfect timing . Since it seems our guest has arrived, let us talk with him . '

Yakumo looked to the entrance . Gotou did the same .

Ideuchi was there .

9

Earlier, Yakumo had told Hata to bring Ideuchi here .

However, he seemed like an out-of-place guest to Gotou .

'Gotou . What on earth is going on? I came because I heard Yuuya was here, but who are they?' said Ideuchi while looking around the room .

See, look . He was out of place .

'He knows where your son is . '

Yakumo pointed at Kamiyama .

'You... What did you do to my son!??'

Suddenly, Ideuchi rushed at Kamiyama . It was the first time Gotou had seen Ideuchi lose control so badly .

So after all's said and done, he's still someone's dad, huh –

'Gotou-san, please stop him . '

Honestly, when he'd been the one to egg him on in the first place .

Gotou stood in front of Ideuchi and held him in place .

'Let go, you bastard!'

Ideuchi flailed his arms like a child in a fight, but there was no way he could win in a contest of strength against Gotou .

Gotou knocked him down to the floor .

'Calm down!'

Ideuchi rolled on the floor and looked dazed .

'I-I am calm,' said Ideuchi while standing up . It appeared that he was more composed – maybe he was out of breath .

'Oi, Yakumo . Why'd you call him here?'

'Obviously because he is related to the case,' Yakumo said, like it was extremely obvious .

However, Gotou didn't understand . Yakumo didn't seem to care as he walked towards Yagi, whose arms and legs were bound .

'Gotou-san, please help over here as well . '

Yakumo started untying the rope around Yagi's legs .

Gotou put his hands on the rope around his hands when Yakumo said, 'It would be better if you didn't take those off . '

Gotou didn't feel like asking any more questions . He helped untie the ropes around Yagi's legs, left his arms as is and sat him on a chair .

'Now, the point of this case is that everyone is sorted into two sides: the side which lay the trap and the side that was trapped . '

Yakumo looked around at everyone present .

Sides? Does he mean the perps and the vics –

'I will say this first . The people who attended the drinking party and witnessed the fake spiritual phenomenon were gathered intentionally . Everyone had a role . In short, the members had to be those members . The members were carefully gathered under the preliminary arrangements . '

'Forget about that . Tell me where Yuuya is . And who are you anyway!?'
'You're sure talking big!'

Ideuchi hit the table and interrupted Yakumo's explanation .

Yakumo did not flinch – all he did was raise an eyebrow and make an openly displeased face .

'Gotou-san, this person is annoying . Is he always like this?'

'To the point that he's being more obedient than usual,' said Gotou after clicking his tongue .

What was with that attitude when he was the one who called him here? And when that guy was here, things always got more complicated .

Yakumo sighed like he thought there was nothing to be done and then slowly approached Ideuchi to put his face close to his ear .

'As it appears you have not noticed, let me introduce you . His face has changed from plastic surgery, but this is Oori Kazushi-san . '

While Yakumo murmured, he pointed at Oori .

That moment, Ideuchi's expression changed . Surprise – no, that was wrong . To Gotou, Ideuchi looked afraid .

Yakumo nodded with a feeling of satisfaction after seeing that .

'Since Ideuchi-san has become quiet as well, I will continue speaking . Gotou-san, when you saw the images published on that website, there was a tattoo on the assailant's arm, correct?'

'Yeah . '

A tattoo of a cross with a snake coiling around it –

'The same pattern was also drawn in Sawaguchi Rika-san's diary . Perhaps she had drawn it as a clue for the assault case . '

That was right . That was how they found out Oori and Shinichi were the same person .

'Yakumo walked towards Oori .

'Oori-san . Could you show us your arm?'

After Yakumo said that to Oori, Oori pulled up his shirt sleeve and showed his right arm without any hesitation . There was no tattoo there –

What was going on?

'Gotou-san, I said this earlier as well, but you wouldn't be deceived by things like this if you would look at the data properly . '

'What did you say?'

'If Oori Kazushi-san had also had the tattoo, it should have been recorded in the data for his physical features since he was the perpetrator of an assault . However, it wasn't mentioned . '

That was right . Normally, when they made an arrest, they'd record everything about the guy – weight and fingerprints, of course, but they'd note physical features like moles and tattoos too .

However, Oori's tattoo hadn't been mentioned anywhere .

'But earlier...'

'The tattoo you saw was painted . On top of that, it was not on the right arm but the left . '

Which meant, maybe –

An uneasy feeling spread throughout Gotou .

'Oori-san's arm had been injured from the spiritual phenomenon, yes?'

'Yeah . '

When Gotou came to the bar last time, Oori's arm had suddenly started bleeding in the dark .

'That was a trick that occurred because he was Kamiyama-san's side . The truth is that something like that is impossible . I will say this again and again, but the spirits of the dead are clusters of emotions and virtually all have no physical influence . '

After Yakumo said that much, he glanced at Kamiyama .

Gotou recalled how Kamiyama and Yakumo had discussed the definition of a ghost's existence before . It had sounded like the odds were with Kamiyama then, but now the situation had completely flipped around .

Maybe the reason Yakumo hadn't wanted to persist in talking about his reasoning this time was related to that .

Gotou hadn't said it aloud, but he had wondered whether Yakumo's definition of a ghost had been wrong . Otherwise he would have reached the truth immediately .

If you applied Yakumo's definition to the spiritual phenomena that occurred this time, they were just farces .

Gotou had been drawn right along too though, so he couldn't say anything .

'They wanted to show that tattoo purposefully by enacting that spiritual phenomenon, in order to shake the heart of their true target . An appeal to say "We know everything" . '

'Oi, Yakumo . Who's that true target you're talking about?'

Without answer Gotou's question, Yakumo slowly walked towards Yagi, the bartender .

Yagi stood up in fear and backed up towards the side of the room .

'I won't let you escape,' said Yakumo, staring at Yagi .

Yagi lost his will to run with that red left eye glaring at him . Yagi hung his head limply as Yakumo took his arm and rolled up the sleeve .

There it was . The tattoo of the cross with a snake coiling around it .

'It can't be that he's the real culprit behind the assault . '

Gotou couldn't stop himself from approaching Yagi .

'He is . He is also the one who assaulted Asami-san . That image is proof . Also, I dare say that before this place became a bar, it was the scene of the crime...'

Which means –

'Oori-san was falsely charged . '

Yakumo said that at a noticeably louder volume .

Those words made Gotou's footing unsteady .

'You... you...'

Oori stood up while muttering . His face was bright red and there were traces of tears in his eyes .

'Aaaahh!'

Oori suddenly let out a beastly yell and, using the table as a diving board, jumped towards Ideuchi .

It was so sudden that Ideuchi, defenceless, fell into a chair and then the floor . Oori was on top of him .

'Stop!'

Gotou rushed towards them immediately and pulled Oori off of Ideuchi .

There wasn't as much resistance as he thought there would be . Oori fell to the floor and cried with shaking shoulders .

'Oi, Yakumo . Is it true that he was falsely accused?'

'Unfortunately... it took me a while to notice which side he was on . '

'Why did you notice?'

'There were a number of things that would not hold true unless Oori-san was on Kamiyama-san's side . If he was falsely accused, I could understand both his reason for aiding Kamiyama-san in his plan and his reason for involving himself with the young man called Yuuya . '

'Falsely accused? That's ridiculous . '

Ideuchi, who had collapsed, used the table to help himself stand up . Contrary to his words, his face was drained of blood .

Yakumo's red left eye stared at him .

'I have no physical evidence . However, the circumstantial evidence is complete . '

After Yakumo said that, he suddenly walked towards Ideuchi .

Ideuchi silently averted his gaze .

'Yagi Keita-san's father was a Diet member . Sawaguchi Rika-san's case occurred during the period when he was aiming for re-election . '

'What of it? That has nothing to do with the police . '

Ideuchi was averting his gaze as he spoke .

No matter how much of a strong front he put up, that voice was shaking unreliably .

'Yagi-san didn't think that the police would mobilise . He had made light of the situation, thinking nobody was going to say anything, so all he had done was put on a mask . If an investigation actually started, it was only a matter of time before he was caught . Then, he clung to his father . '

Gotou left Oori with his head hanging low as he cried and stood up to look at Ideuchi's face .

Even though they thought differently, he was a man in the same organisation who he'd worked together with . If he had to say, he didn't like

him, but Gotou had understood somewhere in his heart that people like him were necessary in an organisation .

'His father was incredibly pressed since it was election time . His son's scandal would have been fatal . Then, he thought of hushing up the incident and consulted an acquaintance of his in the police . '

That was impossible . It couldn't happen .

'The person in the police who he consulted decided to try to have the charges withdrawn . Then, this person took the detectives who had been in charge off the case and put in novices who shook up Rika-san during their questioning . In order to have her withdraw charges . '

'Yakumo! Stop screwing around! Are you saying the police hushed this up on purpose!? That's ridiculous!' yelled Gotou .

However, Yakumo's expression didn't change a whit . He continued talking like nothing had happened .

'However, Rika-san did not withdraw the charges – she committed suicide . Then, her parents called the police killers, and the press used that to attack . Rather than hushing it up, the situation became such that the only way to settle to it was to arrest the culprit . '

'I said to stop screwing around!'

Gotou grabbed Yakumo's collar .

However, Yakumo's expression still didn't change .

'Gotou-san, please be a little bit quieter . You understand already, don't you?'

He had never seen Yakumo's eyes look so cold .

He was right . Just as Yakumo said, Gotou understood already . But he couldn't accept it .

'Even if what you said so far is true, Yagi could just have been arrested then . There was no point in involving Oori!'

Gotou was still holding on . Yakumo brushed off Gotou's hand, his expression still blank .

'They couldn't arrest Yagi Keita . If they did, the fact that the police and a Diet member had done a backroom deal . In that meaning, it didn't have to be Oori-san . He was just unlucky . '

Gotou looked at Oori's hunched back .

His shoulders were still shaking . The guy had been unlucky . That was the only reason he had been imprisoned for three years and had been branded as a rapist . He'd been living with that?

Eriko had said that the timing of the arrest was too good .

They had found a picture in his car when he had been caught for drunk driving . It seemed like definite evidence, but anything could be true if the police had arranged it .

'My life was ruined because of that incident...'

Oori spoke in a trembling voice .

Gotou knew what he was going to say next even if he didn't say it aloud . He became a rapist who brought a woman to her death . That would follow him everywhere .

No matter how much he wiped, it would come back out to ruin his life .

'He was not the only one whose life was ruined . '

'What?'

'Please think about Asami-san . She had been assaulted three years before . Do you understand what that means?'

Gotou no longer had anything to say back .

Oori had been let out two years ago . He had been in prison three years ago . Oori couldn't have been the culprit .

That wasn't all . They had let the true culprit run free while knowing that .

Because of that, she – Asami had been raped . Her life after that grossly warped .

There was the true reason Kamiyama, Oori and Asami didn't directly take revenge .

As long as the police were involved, it would just be hushed up if they made a fuss about the case . They would just be oppressed if they used force .

They put on these fake spiritual phenomena so the police wouldn't get involved –

'Ideuchi-san . '

Yakumo's eyes were full of anger as they looked at Ideuchi .

'I said this earlier as well, but I do not have any physical evidence . You can deny it if you want . However, if you do, your son will not return again . '

Gotou looked at Ideuchi too .

The man looked older than he was because of the overwork that had built up . Please . Deny it . Gotou was begging him to do so in a corner of his heart .

'Please return my son to me...'

Ideuchi lowered his head as he said that desperately .

That was the sign that he admitted everything –

'That is what he has said . What will you do, Kamiyama-san?'

Yakumo turned his gaze to Kamiyama .

Kamiyama smiled triumphantly .

'Yuuya-kun has been entrusted to a new religious organisation under the pretext of exorcising evil spirits . '

So that's how it is –

Now that he thought about it, Kamiyama and Oori were the reasons they thought Yuuya had disappeared .

He hadn't been abducted or cursed . He'd been left at a religious organisation with the pretext of escaping a ghost's curse – they'd just raised a fuss about his disappearance after that .

'Is Yuuya safe?' Ideuchi said with pleading eyes .

'Yes . He is doing well . '

'That isn't all, is it?'

Yakumo replied to Kamiyama's words .

'You've seen through me, then... As expected . In order to participate in that training, he made an offering of about five million yen . '

'W-where'd he get that money?'

'There are organisations that would happily lend out money to the son of the chief of police . I think it was ten per cent interest every ten days?'

Yakumo answered Ideuchi's question . That moment, Ideuchi collapsed .

So that was how it was . That was their goal . To have the son of the chief of police borrow five million from the yakuza .

There was no method that was more effective in tormenting Ideuchi this much . He would go at full speed to his ruin .

'But why did they assault Makoto?'

Yakumo looked at Gotou like he was an idiot .

'The one who assaulted Makoto-san was Yagi-san . '

'Why?'

'Because he was afraid . That day, the woman he had assaulted in the past came to the bar as a guest . Then, a strange spiritual phenomenon occurred in the bar, he heard that Asami-san disappeared from a locked room, an exorcist appeared, and the name of the woman who had committed suicide because he assaulted her came up . '

'It shook his nerves . '

'On top of that, a reporter and the police came to investigate... Though it was like him to attack Makoto-san instead of Kamiyama-san or Oori-san...'

Yakumo bit his lip .

Gotou understood now . Makoto had been the start of it, but they had all just been there as a gallery to make the spiritual phenomena appear true .

If they had statements from a reporter and the police, even something that was difficult to believe like a person's disappearance could hold true .

'Now, Saitou Yakumo-kun . What are you going to do from here on?'

Kamiyama narrowed his eyes and looked at Yakumo challengingly .

'What are you trying to say?'

Gotou couldn't stand that triumphant attitude . He interrupted for Yakumo .

'We went mad because of their egoism . Would it have been correct for us to give up because there was nothing to be done? They should be punished . Don't you think so?' asked Kamiyama . It sounded like his pointed comment wasn't aimed just at Yakumo but at everyone there .

'I thought that at first too . It would be fine if the truth came out after your revenge played out . Nobody would blame you...'

So Yakumo had been calculating his timing .

When he had seen through the case, that had marked the end of Kamiyama's revenge . Maybe he had been thinking of seeing their revenge through to the end .

'Then why did you get in our way?'

Even with Kamiyama's challenging gaze, Yakumo's expression didn't change at all .

'In order to explain that reason, there is something else I need to bring to light . '

Yakumo spoke slowly . The tone made it sound like everything that had happened up until now was just a sideshow .

'What is it?'

Kamiyama also spoke calmly .

Like boxers with their fists up, the two of them appeared to be enjoying the atmosphere .

'The truth behind Rika-san's death . '

'She was physically raped by that man, psychologically raped by the police and driven to her death . '

To Gotou, it looked like there a pale flame of anger had lit in Kamiyama's cool expression .

'That is not all . When I first met you, you said this . The spirit of a woman who committed suicide is here, and she had a strong hatred...'

'I remember something like that . '

'That conversation confused me slightly . '

'What do you mean?'

'Rika-san's spirit certainly had been there, but it looked different to me . '

Yakumo paused . There was silence –

It felt like time had stopped .

'To me, it looked like she was filled with sadness rather than hatred . '

Kamiyama made no response . Kamiyama had no way of ascertaining whether Yakumo's words were correct or not since he himself couldn't have seen it .

'If that person won't accept me, is there any reason for me to live...'

'What is that?' asked Gotou .

'This is a part of Rika-san's suicide note, which had been lost . '

So her suicide note really did exist?

But how did Yakumo know what was in it? Where'd he get his hands on it?

'Did you not reject her as a woman after she was assaulted? Many women who are assaulted think of themselves as impure . How painful do you think it was for her when the person she loved turned his back on her?'

Kamiyama closed his eyes calmly without saying anything at Yakumo's words .

'I see... That was the true reason Rika committed suicide...'

'There could be no other trigger for her suicide . You were the trigger . '

Yakumo said that one sentence at the end .

Tears were falling from the corners of Kamiyama's eyes .

Gotou would've responded too if the person he loved had been assaulted .
He imagined his wife's face and thought about it .

The answer's obvious . I'd want to support her with all my strength in order to save her .

But would it go that well? I might understand it in my head, but wouldn't I end up inadvertently rejecting her like Kamiyama did Rika?

People are weak creatures —

'Kamiyama-san, she is still suffering . Even after her death, she has not been released from her pain and is still committing suicide in the same place . '

This man had also been on the wrong path . People never noticed the important things in front of their eyes .

And so tragedies repeated .

'You are probably the only one who can stop her . '

At Yakumo's last words, Kamiyama fell to the ground and started sobbing .

10

Nobody said anything as they looked at the floor .

Assault cases . Under criminal law, the greatest penalty was just a few years of prison time .

However, that had ruined so many people's lives . It was the same for other crimes . They didn't just affect the people there . It became a large wave that enveloped everyone involved and engulfed them without any mercy .

Gotou had no place to vent his anger so he restrained himself by clenching his fists .

'I came here because I knew how she felt . In order to end your act of revenge . '

'Before I resented anybody, I should have embraced her...' replied Kamiyama, his eyes bright red .

His expression was gentle, like he was a completely different person than he had been before .

'Yakumo-kun, I wish I had met you first and not your father . '

'As I expected, that man did participate then . '

Yakumo's eyes changed .

That man was Yakumo's father, who had two red eyes . Kamiyama had said before that he'd met a man with two red eyes .

'He said this to me . The true nature of a person's soul is darkness . Rika's soul was filled with hatred even after death . That there was no other way to save her besides clearing that hatred . '

'If it is nonsense to say that there is always hope, it is also nonsense to say that everything is darkness . People's feelings cannot all be the same way . '

Yakumo's words were full of a strong will without any clouds .

'That's right . It appears I've been trifled with . '

Kamiyama took a plastic container out from behind the counter and started pouring it out .

The bar quickly filled with an irritating odour .

After Kamiyama threw away the plastic container that was now empty, he took a knife from his pocket, walked up to Yagi, who was hunched up on

the chair . He bound his arms behind his back and made him stand .

'Oi! What are you doing!?'

When Gotou tried to approach him, Kamiyama put the blade of the knife to Yagi's neck .

'Aah!'

Yagi's shriek echoed through the bar .

'Oi! Get away!'

Kamiyama didn't react to Gotou's words . He then took a Zippo lighter from his pocket and lit it up .

Just from that, Gotou understood what Kamiyama was trying to do .

The liquid on the floor had to be flammable .

'Yakumo-kun, I understand what you are saying . If I had accepted her, she wouldn't have died . However, even if she hadn't died, the fact that she would have suffered all her life wouldn't have changed . '

'I do not deny that,' said Yakumo in a voice that sounded like it would fade away .

Gotou couldn't deny it either . Even if she didn't die then, she would have had to continue living with that injury for the rest of her life .

Rape was a crime that injured the heart .

'She had her rest stolen from her . I just can't forgive this man . '

'Oi! Don't do anything stupid! We know everything now . Yagi will be sent to prison!'

Gotou shorted the distance between him and Kamiyama .

Kamiyama shook his head, pointing the tip of the knife towards Gotou .

'I looked at the video of Rika being assaulted countless times . Every time, I was hit by a pain that felt like it would cut through my chest and thought I would go mad . In that video, she had called out my name while bearing with the humiliation, but no matter how I try, I can't go there...'

Tears were falling from Kamiyama's eyes again .

Even if he could think about it in his head, it was no more than his imagination . If he didn't want to think about it, he could run away at any time by thinking it was a fantasy .

Kamiyama had accepted it as the truth because he couldn't do otherwise .

'Detective, could you forgive it if it were you? If the person you loved was not only assaulted but had images of her humiliation uploaded to the internet for tens of thousands of people to see after her death, just for a cheap way of getting money . '

After a pause, Kamiyama asked Gotou the same question again .

'Could you forgive it if it were you?'

No, he couldn't . He couldn't stop this guy .

That was how Gotou felt . Rather, he felt like this Yagi guy should die . He wasn't going to reform anyway .

At least he could let Kamiyama kill him .

'I'll apologize to her in that world . Then, I will forget everything and accept her . '

After Kamiyama said that, he dropped the lighter to the ground .

Flames started dancing up at once . On the other side of the fire, Yagi screamed while struggling .

The flame was spreading every second and the bar was filling with smoke .

Ideuchi and Oori rushed towards the exits, but Gotou didn't move as the flames spread .

What was that? How disgusting .

'Gotou-san! What are you just standing there for? Please save him!'

Yakumo was the one who yelled . He was still here too?

'When did the police start forgiving revenge? Gotou-san, no matter who it is, you aren't the sort of person who would let someone die without helping, correct?'

Yakumo's lips turned up in a smile .

That was right . It was just as Yakumo said . What had he been doing?

No matter what sort of villain they were, killing somebody was unforgiveable . He didn't understand the difficult things, but that was the road he believed in .

He'd almost done something that he would have regretted for the rest of his life .

'That's right . That was right . '

'Then please hurry up and save him . Oh, but bears are afraid of fires, aren't they?'

That Yakumo – saying too much even at a time like this .

Gotou would definitely punch him after this was over . He'd remember .

'Don't think that a fire like this could stop me!'

Gotou stooped and ran into the fire .

He broke through the wall of flames and hit Kamiyama . Gotou, Kamiyama and Yagi – the three of them fell over together .

Gotou stood up immediately, grabbed Yagi first and pushed him out of the flames with all his strength . Thump! There was a loud sound .

He might've hit the ground strangely . Well, that's better than dying . Next –

'Why are you getting in my way?' asked Kamiyama, slowly getting up .

Why? The answer was obvious, right?

'I won't let anybody get killed in front of me . I won't let anybody die . That's the sort of guy I am!'

'But you couldn't save my lover... Rika . '

Just as Kamiyama says, I couldn't save her . But that's why I have to do this –

'I'm going to save you!'

'You are fascinating people . It was only a brief time, but it was a very enjoyable one . It will become a good tale to tell her . '

After Kamiyama said that, he thrust Gotou away .

Gotou was suddenly knocked out of the flames .

'Damn . '

The moment Gotou was about to jump back into the flames, the ceiling board fell down right in front of him .

The flames engulfed it .

Kamiyama was staring at something through the gap .

His gaze was on Yakumo .

The two of them were looking straight at each other . They didn't say anything, but it was like they were talking .

Finally, Kamiyama smiled . He smiled – he looked truly happy .

'Gotou-san, it has reached the limit . Let us go . '

Yakumo shook his head and gripped Gotou's arm .

'He's still inside...'

'This is the path he has chosen . Even if we save him now, he will do the same thing . Moreover, we will be in a dangerous position if we stay here . '

The strength of the fire had increased, the bar was filled with smoke and they could not see Kamiyama any longer .

'Why? Why won't you try to live!?' yelled Gotou .

That yell was aimed towards Kamiyama, but it was also aimed towards Rika, who already wouldn't return .

11

When Ishii, who had brought Makoto, the chief of the police and Haruka, arrived at the building with the bar, the building was enveloped in smoke .

People had started gathering and there was the sound of a fire engine .

Oori Kazushi and, for some reason, Ideuchi were outside the building .

They're coughing like they were in the smoke . What on earth happened –

Ishii rushed towards Ideuchi .

'Chief . Where is Detective Gotou?'

Ideuchi couldn't say anything – he just looked at the stairs that led to the bar in the basement . It couldn't be . He wasn't still inside, was he?

'Hey, Ishii-san, what happened? Where's Yakumo-kun?'

Haruka looked worried as she tugged on Ishii's sleeve .

If Detective Gotou is inside, then Yakumo is probably –

Ishii wanted to say something, but he couldn't think of the words .

The fire engine arrived in front of the building and started extinguishing the fire . One firefighter tried to enter but returned because the fire was too strong .

Ah, Detective Gotou . He had been a splendid detective . Ishii respected him more than anybody else . Farewell, Detective Gotou .

Ishii Yuutarou would carry his spirit forward .

'Yakumo-kun!' shouted Haruka as she ran towards the entrance .

That was no good . Ishii grabbed Haruka's shoulders to stop her from trying to go down the stairs now .

'Haruka-chan . It's no good . '

'Please let go . Yakumo-kun is still inside!'

Tears were falling from Haruka's eyes . Ishii's chest felt tight upon seeing that .

Even now, her feelings for him –

He understood how she felt, but he couldn't let her go .

'Haruka-chan, if you go inside, you'll die as well . It is very unfortunate about Detective Gotou and Yakumo-shi, but even if their bodies have perished, their spirits will always be in our hearts...'

Something hit Ishii's head with an incredible force and he unthinkingly bit his tongue .

'Don't just go and kill me off!'

'D-D-Detective Gotou . '

It seemed that he was still alive . Ishii was glad . Really, he was glad .

Ishii was so happy that he hugged Gotou, who was covered in soot .

'You're disgusting!'

Gotou thrust Ishii away and then put down the man he was carrying over his shoulders .

This man, if Ishii remembered correctly, was the bartender, Yagi Keita .

'Yakumo-kun . '

Yakumo was standing next to Gotou .

Haruka immediately ran over to him .

'What? Are you crying again?'

'That's because...'

'Tell me why you're crying so much some other time,' said Yakumo, running a hand through his hair .

What on earth was with that attitude, as usual? The anger gathered in Ishii's chest . He thought of saying something, but before he could, Haruka kicked Yakumo .

'I want to ask you one thing . '

Gotou stepped forward and glared at Ideuchi with the expression of a demon .

Ideuchi didn't make any reply . What was this tension? What on earth had happened inside?

Ishii just held in his breath, unable to understand the situation .

'Why did you do something so stupid?'

Ideuchi would normally have lost his temper if Gotou talked to him like this, but he just hung his head silently .

'My wife... had cancer . I needed... money . '

After a silence, he started speaking like a skipping record .

'You ruined my life for money!?' yelled Oori suddenly, raising his fists towards Ideuchi . This is dangerous –

Gotou had stepped between them much more quickly than Ishii could have acted and pushed Oori down .

'Got this? If you hit him now, that'll be assault . We just cleared your name . Leave him to me . '

Oori obeyed Gotou's words .

Gotou pat Oori lightly on the shoulder .

'I really am sorry . '

Oori looked up at Gotou in surprise and then silently nodded .

'Your wife's sickness must have been tough . It costs some money to treat cancer – a detective's cheap monthly salary wouldn't have been enough . '

While Gotou said that, he cracked his knuckles and rolled his right shoulder .

He couldn't . He couldn't . What was Detective Gotou planning on doing?

Uneasiness spread throughout Ishii . And then, that uneasiness hit the mark .

'Aaagh!'

With a yell, Gotou punched Ideuchi in the face as hard as he could .

Ideuchi fell down and rolled twice .

W-w-what is he doing –

Ishii tried to rush over to Ideuchi after he fell but Gotou went before him to step on Ideuchi's head .

'Got this? Listen up! I sympathise, but that's no reason to screw up someone else's life! You fool!'

Gotou's angry voice shook the air .

'Gotou-kun, what on earth are you doing?'

Hijikata, the chief of the police, had come over from hearing the commotion . His daughter Makoto was next to him .

'Huh?'

Gotou looked at the chief of the police with contempt .

He was just like some juvenile delinquent loitering at a train station . Ishii was flustered by everything that was happening .

'I'm saying to explain what's happened,' the police chief said in a forceful tone .

'Chief Ideuchi was asked with money to hide the assault case that happened five years ago . On top of driving the victim to her suicide, the crime was put on the head of somebody who was completely unrelated . '

Yakumo was the one who explained .

So that was what happened . That was what happened in this case . While Ishii had been away, there had been so many rapid developments in the case that Ishii couldn't follow .

'Who are you?'

The police chief looked at Yakumo . His suspicions were natural .

'Even if you ask me who I am, I am just a university student who happened to pass by . '

This young man has that attitude even in front of the police chief –

'Is what he's saying true?'

The police chief pushed Gotou aside, pulled up Ideuchi's upper body and asked him that .

Ideuchi wiped the blood around his lips off and then said quietly, '... I sincerely apologise . '

The chief of the police stood up with a sigh .

'I'll listen to the details after . Then I'll announce it officially,' he said coldly .

The police chief tried to leave after that, but Gotou blocked his way .

'Don't tell me you're planning on hiding this again . '

Gotou glared at the police chief sharply, but the police chief didn't try to look him back in the eye and just looked fed up .

'You should understand this a bit better . If something like this became public, the police organisation itself would shake . '

'What about it?'

'You still don't understand it? It's said that scandals should be kept as small as possible . '

'Oh . I get it . You'll clear Oori's name but say it was because of an investigation mistake . '

'For the sake of all the police in the country . '

'That's wrong,' said Gotou while rolling his neck .

He couldn't . Detective Gotou . When Ishii thought that, it was already too late .

Gotou's head rammed into the chief of the police's face .

'What the hell do you mean by “for the sake of all the police in the country”? You kokeshi doll! You're just protecting your own ass!'

While Gotou yelled, he tried to give the police chief a final blow .

The chief of the police's front tooth stabbed into Detective Gotou's forehead . He couldn't do any more .

Ishii tried to jump at Gotou from behind to pin him down .

However, unlike what Ishii had expected, his body floated away . Eh? Ah, Detective Gotou hurled him away . Just as he thought that, his back hit the ground .

He lost consciousness –

NOTES:

[1] The word light was written in katakana (raito or ライト) which is the same way the position of right fielder is written in Japanese .

Volume 3 Chapter 4: Epilogue.

VOLUME 3 - THE LIGHT BEYOND THE DARKNESS epilogue ()

Ishii had come to the door that had the plate which read <Movie Research Circle> on it.

He was here to discuss what happened after the incident. Though this was usually Gotou's job, that wasn't the situation now.

'I'm not going to bite. Why not come in?'

Ishii was startled when a voice suddenly called out to him.

He restrained his fear and opened the door. The owner of the room was sitting in a chair with sleepy eyes, as usual. His hair was all mussed up.

'Ah, hello.'

'Please sit.'

Unlike Ishii, who was hesitant, Yakumo was calm.

Ishii sat as he was told. Yakumo yawned, stood up and opened the refrigerator in the corner of the room.

'Ishii-san, would tea be acceptable?'

'Ah, yes.'

Yakumo brought back two plastic bottles of tea.

'Now, what has happened?'

Yakumo drank a mouthful of tea from one of the plastic bottles and sat in the chair.

'You may already know...'

'You're stiff.'

'Ishii-san, since you are older than me, you don't need to speak so politely.'

'Ah – oh...'

Ishii would try, but it wasn't something he could do something about right away even if he was told to fix it.

Perhaps he empathised with Ishii, who didn't know what to say next, because Yakumo said, 'Well, it's fine,' urging him to continue.

'Makoto-san has reported on the series of police scandals, so nothing can be hidden any longer.'

Makoto's article had been taken up to the top.

After that, there had been a grand journalism war from all news outlets, and it continued even a week after the incident. It had developed into a huge scandal.

It was ironic, now that he thought about it. A scandal from police history had been reported by the daughter of the chief of the police.

Yesterday, Makoto had called him and said that she had finally been disinherited.

She had said she felt better, but Ishii thought that wasn't true.

Just the one case had showered sparks on so many people and warped their lives.

However, Ishii thought this now. If Gotou and Yakumo hadn't been there, that warping might have become even greater.

'I read in the newspaper that the chief of the police resigned. How about the others?'

'Chief Ideuchi was given a disciplinary dismissal. Currently, there is an investigation.'

It was a natural punishment, but Ishii had complicated feelings on it.

What Ideuchi had done had been completely unforgiveable, but was it really fine to reject all of Ideuchi as evil because of it?

'How about his son?'

'Ah, yes. He was taken back yesterday. The situation was explained to him, but it was too much for him to understand. He felt a bit like Urashima Tarou[1].'

'How amusing.'

Yakumo forced a smile at Ishii's boring joke.

He spoke so smoothly that Ishii felt stupid for bracing himself.

In Ishii's head, he suddenly remembered something Haruka had said. 'Yakumo can be very kind.' She might have really understood him.

'Well, how about the middle-aged man?'

Yakumo put out the most important question.

To be honest, it was difficult for Ishii to answer.

'We don't know yet. Detective Gotou hasn't done anything wrong this time, but... well, there was the thing where he rammed his head into the chief of the police.'

'That was interesting.'

Yakumo let out a laugh – maybe he was remembering the scene.

'It isn't something to laugh about.'

'No, it is. I mean, the police chief's front tooth stabbed into Gotou-san's forehead. Do you know what Detective Gotou did afterwards?

'Who knows?'

Ishii had been knocked out of the way by Gotou and lost consciousness, so he didn't know the circumstances after that very well.

'Gotou-san took out the tooth stuck in his forehead, put it back in the mouth of the police chief, who had his eyes wide open, and said, "Yakumo, glue." He tried to cover it up.'

Yakumo laughed even more loudly.

No, no, that really wasn't something to laugh about.

'In any case, if the detective who exposed an internal scandal is fired in front of society, it would be rather bad for them, so there probably won't be any particular punishment, but...'

The problem was what would happen next.

'Gotou-san is a traitor to the organisation now.'

'Yes.'

He really was sharp. Even if there wasn't any official punishment, he would be labelled as the man who sold his colleagues.

He wouldn't be able to escape as long as he was in the police.

'I have no idea what Detective Gotou will do now.'

'Well, no matter what that middle-aged man chooses, it isn't any concern of mine. Rather, it would be less trouble for me if he quit the police,' said Yakumo with a yawn.

What was he saying? Ishii had started thinking that Yakumo might be kind, but there was no doubt that he was, as he thought, a cold man.

'And how about Kamiyama-shi?'

After laughing for a while, Yakumo narrowed his eyes and spoke.

'When the firefighters went in, he was already...'

'I see.'

Yakumo's expression didn't change, but it felt like there was a shadow in his eyes.

Ishii felt like Kamiyama himself had been a residual spirit.

A sad man who tied his own soul down for revenge –

However, if he hadn't done that, he wouldn't have been able to deal with his own emotions.

'Er, actually, there was something I wanted to ask.'

'What is it?'

To say the truth, they were more Gotou's doubts than Ishii's.

In the basement bar, Yakumo had read a portion of Rika's suicide note, which had been lost. However, that note had not been found at Ideuchi's house.

Ideuchi had snatched it since he suspected the note might have had something that would connect it to the culprit.

However, the contents of that note weren't written anywhere. He had wanted to return it when it was safe, but he had lost his chance.

If Kamiyama had seen the suicide note – if he had known Rika's true intention – this case might not have happened. When Ishii thought about

that, it really was complicated.

A minor misunderstanding could bring about such darkness.

Putting that aside, what Gotou and Ishii wanted to know was why Yakumo knew about the contents of the note.

'About the suicide note. Where did you find out its contents?'

'I read the heart,' said Yakumo with a sharp gaze.

Ishii was startled. He could read people's hearts? No. That was terrifying. Was he reading Ishii's heart now?

Ishii's mouth felt parched.

Yakumo smiled when he saw how openly afraid Ishii was.

'It's a joke. Please don't mind so much.'

'Please stop it, really.'

Ishii uncapped the plastic bottle and drank tea to wet his throat.

Yakumo stretched out his hand, picked up Rika's diary from the shelf by him and opened up to a page for Ishii to see.

There were signs that a page had been ripped out.

'She probably took the feelings she wrote into her diary and used them as they were for a suicide note. You can faintly read the words on the next page from the strokes. I looked at those strokes one by one to come up with the note.'

'Oh,' Ishii said in his admiration.

'Why are you saying that so proudly? I was the one who did the work.'

The person who had come in while criticising Yakumo was Haruka.

'H-Haruka-chan.'

'It's simple work that could have been done by anyone.'

Yakumo scratched at his head like he found Haruka annoying.

'Treating people like idiots again. I won't help you ever again.'

Haruka stuck out her tongue. That expression was cute too.

'Oh, don't say that. That necklace matches you fairly well, doesn't it?' said Yakumo, his voice devoid of emotion.

'What? It's too late to say that now. Ah! You're drinking my tea!'

'Eh?'

Ishii's heart skipped a beat at Haruka's words.

Could it be? Ishii looked at the plastic bottle in his hand.

'I-I-I sincerely apologise. I...'

Ishii stood up to bow his head deeply.

'Ishii-san, you did nothing wrong. He's at fault.'

Haruka glared at Yakumo.

'You're the one using somebody's fridge without permission,' said Yakumo while stifling a yawn.

'Honestly! That's enough of that.'

Haruka approached Yakumo.

'Aah! You're so loud!'

A yell echoed through the room. This voice was –

Everyone's gazes fixed on the entrance.

In a wrinkled-up shirt and loose tie, the bearlike figure of Gotou stood there.

'What's with all of you? It's creepy!' complained Gotou, as he always did.

'D-D-Detective Gotou, I was worried.'

Ishii clung on to Gotou.

'Worried about what?'

'I thought that you might quit the police, Detective Gotou.'

'Why?'

'That is, er...'

Ishii's words were caught in his throat.

'Ishii-san was worrying pointlessly that you would become independent of the police organisation and leave, Gotou-san.'

Yakumo added his explanation in Ishii's stead.

'Why are you saying something so idiotic? I've always been independent of them!' yelled Gotou, hitting Ishii.

That wasn't something to say with a puffed chest. 'Anyway, this isn't the time to play around. Ishii, we're going!'

Gotou grabbed Ishii's arm and pulled at him.

'Go? Where are we going to?'

'To the case, obviously!'

Gotou was yelling again. Case. But it had just finished –

'Oi! Yakumo. You come too!'

'I refuse.'

Yakumo gave an immediate answer to Gotou's words.

'What did you say?'

'Currently, I have done you two favours. I refuse to allow any more advances.'

'You're so annoying! Ah, that's right. I remembered. I promised I'd punch you once the case was over.'

Gotou leapt at Yakumo.

Ishii clung to Gotou frantically to stop him. Yakumo reclined on his chair like he didn't care.

Haruka-chan laughed happily as she watched them.

Please, give a man a break!

At the time, Ishii hadn't noticed the large shadow drawing near him. -

[1] Urashima Tarou is similar to Rip Van Winkle, in that he is allowed to visit the palace of the dragon god in the sea for three days and comes back to find that three hundred years have passed.

Volume 4 Chapter 0: Prologue

VOLUME 4 - FEELINGS TO PROTECT prologue

It should have been a night like any other –

Miyagawa Hideya went up the winding slope and stopped the car by the road.

He saw the three-storey home that he was headed for beyond the front glass. It felt like it could appear in a horror movie.

‘Honestly. The rich just build these crazy-huge houses. This is Japan.’

Miyagawa picked up the radio his car was equipped with.

‘This is Seta-chou 152. I arrived at the scene. I’ll go look at the situation.’

<Roger.>

‘I really never get a break.’

Miyagawa sighed as he cut off the radio.

He’d been so busy with cases recently he was practically never home. Just when he’d thought he’d be able to go home early for the first time in a while, he’d heard the radio.

Once he’d heard the radio, he couldn’t ignore it. Even he thought that his personality was unfavourable.

When Miyagawa had advanced to the gate, he saw a middle-aged woman standing there.

She had a cardigan on top of her nightclothes. She also had no make-up on. It felt like she had rushed out of her house in a hurry.

'I'm Miyagawa from the Seta-chou precinct.'

When he displayed his police ID, the woman relaxed.

'You live here?'

The woman shook her head at Miyagawa's words.

'I was the one who called. I heard a terrible scream and was so afraid...'

Miyagawa understood the situation.

'Stand back. I'm going to look inside.'

After saying that, Miyagawa opened the iron gate.

'Excuse me... Detective, are you alone?' said the woman, sounding afraid.

'Backup will be here soon.'

Amateurs shouldn't worry so much. It's depressing.

Miyagawa swallowed the words he was about to say and then walked across the neatly growing lawn towards the entrance.

'It's huge.'

When he looked up at the building at such a close distance, he felt again how large it was.

The curtains were closed so he couldn't see inside, but the lights were on.

Miyagawa rang the doorbell at the entrance. The beautiful sound of the bell could be heard outside.

However, there was no response –

'This is the police. Is anyone here?'

I'll try knocking. As I expected, there's no response –

His heart started beating noisily.

'Police – anyone here?'

Miyagawa raised his voice and placed his hand on the doorknob.

It opened.

'Anyone? Respond.'

He slowly stepped into the entrance while calling out.

The atmosphere was heavy. He'd stepped into a different world – that was what it felt like.

And there was this smell.

'This is...'

The corridor went straight forward from the entrance.

The door at the end of the corridor was slightly open.

Splash. Splash.

There was the sound of water falling, but he only heard it intermittently.

Miyagawa took the special police baton from his waist and went down the corridor in his shoes, slowly walking towards that door.

His heartbeat naturally grew quicker.

It's dangerous. His instinct was screaming that.

Miyagawa used the tip of his police baton to push open the door.

What he saw right in front of him was the anguished face of a middle-aged man.

Miyagawa knew without checking that he was dead.

He wasn't the only one collapsed there.

A man and a woman in their sixties. Plus, a woman probably in her thirties. They were in a heap, covered with blood.

There was a pool of blood on the floor.

It was like a painting of a scene in Hell –

What on earth had happened?

Miyagawa barely managed to keep calm and immediately turned around to call for backup.

'Oh!'

He cowered in his shock.

A man was standing right in front of his eyes.

His long hair flowed down his back, and he wore a black suit with sunglasses. He had a child of about elementary school age next to him.

The chest area of the white pyjamas the child was wearing was dyed bright red.

What? What on earth happened here?

In his confusion, Miyagawa slowly stepped back to put distance between them. However, he stepped on something and fell face-up.

The man in the suit smiled and slowly took off his glasses.

Both of his eyes glowed red like a blazing flame.

* * *

There was a rumour in that elementary school –

When night fell, you could hear the sound of a child's voice.

It's hot, it's hot –

Even if you heard the voice, you couldn't turn around.

Otherwise, you'd be scorched to the bone.

It might sound like a common school ghost story.

However, there was proof behind this tale.

It went back twenty-odd years.

One child started a fire in the PE storeroom as a prank. That fire, which had been small at first, spread very quickly and swallowed that boy up.

Then, the fire swallowed up the firefighter who went to try to save that boy as well.

Afterwards, the PE storeroom was torn down and was now a pool, so that such a tragedy would not occur again...

However, the boy wasn't released from his suffering...

Volume 4 Chapter 1: VOLUME 4 - FEELINGS TO PROTECT

Chapter 1

VOLUME 4 - FEELINGS TO PROTECT

file 01: ignition (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

When Yokouchi Kazuhito came out of the staff entrance in the back of the school building, it was already past ten .

He looked up at a beautiful moon .

A full moon –

It took more time than expected to lock up the school, which was something he wasn't accustomed to doing .

Normally, locking up at the end of the day was the caretaker's job, but the caretaker was off due to a cold .

Of course, the troublesome work fell to the rookie teacher .

Perhaps it was different for private schools, but the world of public school teachers was still firmly rooted in the old seniority system . Even if he was dissatisfied with it, he wasn't in a situation where he could say it aloud .

‘This is really annoying...’

Yokouchi walked the path between the school building and the pool while grumbling . He still had to lock the school gates .

He wanted to go home as quickly as possible . That impulse quickened Yokouchi's pace .

Plop –

There was the sound of something falling into the water .

When he turned his eyes to the pool, there were ripples in the moonlit water .

He saw a black shadow on the diving board in the third lane .

'A person...' murmured Yokouchi as he stared .

He couldn't see the face well, but it appeared to be a middle-aged man from the physique .

Sneaking into the school pool at this time – and it was autumn now, on top of that .

There had been a number of incidents within the school recently . If he left it like this, it'd become a problem of responsibility .

'Er, excuse me . '

Yokouchi mustered his courage and called out to the man .

The man made no response . Had his voice not reached him?

'Hey! You over there! What are you doing?'

Yokouchi put his hand by his mouth and raised his voice .

It looked like he heard him this time .

The man slowly turned his neck to look towards Yokouchi . However, he immediately turned back .

Honestly, what was it?

'Excuse me! Please leave!' said Yokouchi as he walked towards the pool fence .

However, the man still did not move .

'I will call the police!'

Yokouchi took the mobile phone out of the pocket of his slacks .

The man would definitely run now that Yokouchi had played that card . That was what Yokouchi thought, but it was no good .

Now there was nothing to do but actually call .

'I really will call . '

Yokouchi made one more warning and then pressed the buttons 1, 1 and 0 .

Eh? It won't go through –

Was the connection bad? He took a look at his mobile phone display .

It was out of range .

There was nothing he could do . Maybe he'd go back to the staffroom and call .

Yokouchi was just about to turn his heels around when somebody grabbed his jacket hem .

When he looked, he saw a boy of about ten who had gotten next to him at some point in time . He didn't remember the face . Was he from a kid from one of the classes?

At any rate, it was a problem for an elementary school student to be loitering at school at this hour .

Indifferent to Yokouchi's thoughts, the boy slowly pointed at the diving board where the man stood .

Yokouchi's eyes were led to the pool again .

The man on the diving board looked like he was glowing .

What?

While Yokouchi was being bewildered, a bright red pillar of flame rose from the man's stomach .

Sparks flew everywhere . The fire eddied up like a dragon climbing to the heavens and swallowed the man's body in a flash .

Even though the man was swallowed up by the flames, he didn't move .

Finally, he fell into the pool, raising a sheet of spray .

Why? How?

Yokouchi was so shocked by what happened that these natural suspicions didn't even cross his mind .

Horror just crept up from his feet and stole the freedom from his body .

He lost the strength in his legs and he sank down to the floor right there .

The boy from earlier peered worriedly at Yokouchi .

Why is this kid so calm? Somebody burned up in front of your eyes –

While Yokouchi was seized with fear, the boy's face started glowing .

It can't be –

His bad feeling struck home .

Just when he thought a small blaze was in the boy's cheek, his entire face started burning with the intensity of a paper being eaten away by flames .

The inflamed skin dripped .

That crackling blaze swallowed the boy whole in no time at all .

Just like the man earlier –

Yokouchi didn't think of trying to save him .

He just heard a voice in his ear as he tried to scuttle away in his fear –

It's hot... Help...

'Aaahh!'

Yokouchi's scream echoed through the school at night .

2

Ozawa Haruka stood in front of the lavatory sink and looked at her reflection in the mirror .

I look startlingly pale –

No matter how strong she acted, her body showed her nervousness honestly .

With today, it had been a week since she started her training as a teacher at this elementary school .

She had matched the names with the faces of all the children in the class she was in charge of and was used to that atmosphere as well .

No matter how used to it she was, today was different .

It would be stranger not to be nervous, though it was true that she also felt exhilarated .

It was similar to how she felt before a performance .

'Ah, here you were . Ozawa-san, we have to go soon . '

The person who peeked in from the lavatory door was the teacher in charge of Haruka, Komai Hiromi .

'Ah, please excuse me . I'll be out soon . '

'I'll wait outside then . '

Komai gave her a friendly smile .

There's no point complaining now . I have to do it . I'll be fine .

Haruka told her mirror self that and, after forcing the corners of her lips up in a smile, left the lavatory .

'Well, shall we go?'

'Yes . '

After Haruka replied, she started walking down the corridor beside Komai .

Even though she had readied herself, when she approached the classroom, her heartbeat was so loud it hurt her ears .

'Are you nervous?' asked Komai, turning to look at Haruka .

'Yes . Only a little,' Haruka replied honestly .

For a moment, Komai was surprised, and then she laughed happily .

It might have been rude for her to put it this way, but that expression was cute . Though the teacher was in her mid-thirties, it didn't look like that at all to Haruka .

When she actually spoke to her, the contents and method of her speech made her seem like an adult woman, but it wouldn't be strange at all to say she looked to be the same age as Haruka just from her appearance .

She had also said that she would be getting married soon, so that might have been the cause of it .

There was a small diamond ring glittering on the ring finger of the hand that combed up her hair .

'You looked relaxed to me though . '

Komai shrugged .

'Is that so? I feel like my heart will leap out of my mouth . '

'If you can say that, you're fine . '

After nodding a few times, Komai clapped a hand on Haruka's shoulders .

Recently, it felt like the way people evaluated her had changed .

Though she wouldn't be able to reply with a firm answer if asked how it had changed, when compared to before, she wasn't as timid, or perhaps she could say she felt like she had her own opinions .

It had been that way for her choice of the elementary school she would train at .

There were many students who would choose their alma mater when undergoing training . However, Haruka didn't dare to do that .

Her reason was that she didn't want to depend on the kindness of a school that she was familiar with .

This elementary had thirty students per class and five classes per year .

There were nine hundred children . It was smack in the middle of a residential area, so the scale and environment were completely different

from the elementary school in the countryside that Haruka graduated from .

Since she had entered the education department, she aspired to become a teacher .

However, she'd wanted to see how serious she was in this completely different environment .

Her previous self probably wouldn't have thought of placing herself in adversity .

It might be because of him –

'That brings me back . For my first class, I couldn't do it until the end because I was nervous,' said Komai, looking up at the ceiling .

'You couldn't, Komai-sensei?'

Komai narrowed her eyes at Haruka's surprised expression .

She looked like a prankster who was scheming something .

'Is that unexpected?'

'Yes . '

'Why?'

'Sensei, your classes are really easy to understand and fair . I can't imagine that at all . '

'Everyone fails at first . '

'Yes . '

Haruka stopped walking to reply .

She felt like some of the tension had left her shoulders .

Just as Komai said, nothing went well for everybody from the very beginning . People grew as they made mistakes .

'It took me ten years to get here . '

'Ten years...'

There was still a long path ahead . She'd have to work hard .

When Haruka raised her head, she saw a plate that said <Class 5-4> .

This was the class Haruka was in charge of during training .

She could tell that the classroom was unusually noisy even from the corridor .

The children also knew that today was Haruka's first class . Perhaps the children felt anxious like she did .

'Are you prepared?'

'Yes . '

Haruka took in a deep breath before replying to Komai .

'Now, do your best . '

Komai hit Haruka's back like she was sending her off .

Haruka gripped a necklace with a red stone tightly in her left hand . It was the necklace Yakumo had given her .

Please . Lend me a little strength –

After praying silently in her heart, she opened the door .

Suddenly, the children gave a thunderous cheer . There were some children who were clapping and whistling .

Haruka went blank at the unexpected reception .

'Look at the blackboard,' said Komai .

She was still astonished as she looked over and saw the words 'Haruka-sensei, do your best!' written in chalk across the chalkboard .

It was decorated with paper flowers and ribbons .

The corners of Haruka's eyes felt warm, her chest full of surprise and joy .

'Everyone, thank you . I'll be in your care today . '

When Haruka bowed, the children cheered again .

Haruka straightened her back and stood at the platform .

When she had been in elementary school, the teacher standing at the platform had looked very tall to her . She wondered what the children thought of her now .

As Haruka looked around the children in the classroom again, Haruka's eyes stopped at one of the boys .

Oomori Masato . He was carving something into the desk with the needle of a compass, as if Haruka's existence was completely irrelevant to him .

It looked like he was the only one who was cut off .

He was always like this . Not just in class – even during break and after school, he would be outside of the circle of the class .

Should I keep an eye on him –

'Now, start the class . '

While Haruka was troubled about what to do, Komai spoke up while erasing the words on the blackboard .

That was right . She should concentrate on class now .

'OK, let's start . '

Haruka put that behind her and opened the textbook .

3

Ishii Yuutarou was running at full speed down a pitch-black road .

It's hard to breathe –

Ishii didn't know why or to where he was running himself .

However, he was frantically chasing the back of the senior detective running in front of him, Gotou .

'Detective Gotou, where are you going?'

Gotou didn't even turn around at Ishii's voice .

How far had they run? Gotou suddenly came to a stop .

'Excuse me... Detective Gotou . '

Just as Ishii spoke up, Gotou's bearlike figure fell backwards .

'Detective Gotou, what has happened?'

Ishii approached because he was worried, but he was startled when he saw Gotou's face .

His eyes were wide and his face was as pale as a dead man's . And – his white shirt was dyed red at the chest .

– It's blood .

'Detective Gotou, please hold on . '

Ishii put up with his trembling legs and shook Gotou vigorously .

However, there was no response at all .

He's dead – as if to deny that thought, Ishii shook his head .

'Detective Gotou! Please wake up!'

Ishii gathered strength in the bottom of his stomach and raised his voice .

'Shut up, you fool!'

Something hit Ishii's head and he jumped up to his feet .

What he saw before him was completely different from what he had seen earlier .

Eh, this is my desk . And it's not night –

'Wake up already!'

Another fist came down on Ishii's head .

When he looked up, he saw Gotou standing there, though he had been dead earlier .

There was no blood on the white shirt so shabby it would make even Detective Columbo grimace .

He stood imposingly in front of Ishii with that demonic stature .

Oh, that was a dream –

Ishii finally understood . He had worked all night yesterday and thought he'd take a nap at dawn and rested his head on the desk .

Maybe that was why he'd seen such a dream .

'How long are you going to doze off for!?'

As Gotou yelled, he raised his fist again .

'Eek . S-s-sorry . '

Ishii instinctively covered his head and let out a voice close to a shriek .

'It seems like you're enjoying yourselves considerably . '

There was a voice from the doorway . The characteristic thick voice of somebody who has been drinking .

When he looked over, he saw Miyagawa, the chief, standing there .

He had taken over for the previous chief, Ideuchi, who had quit because of the incident three months ago .

He was a middle-aged man of a small stature, but he didn't give the impression of being frail . He had the face of a Buddhist priest and thick eyebrows . Underneath that were a pair of piercing eyes .

He could be mistaken for somebody of that sort[1] .

This person might kill a bear with his bare hands . Ishii really thought that .

'Of course we're not enjoying ourselves . We didn't sleep last night . '

Gotou looked incredibly listless .

'You're paying the tab for slacking off up 'til now . '

There was reason behind Miyagawa's comment .

The Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room that had only Gotou and Ishii stationed there was, unlike its grand name, used for odd jobs . Half the time, they just acted as supporting members for other departments .

That had been fine with the previous chief, but after Miyagawa came in, the situation had made a complete about-face .

They had been ordered to look into unsolved cases, which was the actual work of this department .

It might sound like it wasn't that much work .

However, the police arrest rate was steadily declining every year and was now hanging around twenty per cent .

Currently, six million cases occurred in Japan annually . Of course, the responsibility was split up by jurisdiction, but it was still an amazing amount .

'So, what did you come here to do? Please leave if you're just here to jeer . '

Gotou had his finger in his ear as he said that unpleasantly .

'I don't have so much free time that I can jeer at you,' said Miyagawa with a snort .

Their exchange sounded rude, but there was no ill will there . To Ishii, it seemed like they were joking around .

He'd heard that Miyagawa had been partnered with Gotou back when they were rookie detectives .

They were probably very familiar with each other .

'If you're not here to jeer, what is it?'

Gotou took a cigarette from his pocket and lit it .

Miyagawa glared at Gotou .

'You lighting up knowing that I quit smoking?'

'Why not just smoke if you want to?'

Gotou held his cigarette out towards Miyagawa, but he looked away like he was trying to run away from it .

'My grandkid... hates it when I smell like cigarettes . '

'People can change, gramps,' said Gotou, making fun of Miyagawa .

'Shut up!'

Miyagawa poked Gotou's chest with his finger as he yelled in his irritation .
Ishii's legs shook under the pressure .

'So what did you really come here for?'

Gotou urged Miyagawa to talk as he put out the cigarette in the ashtray .

'There's actually some work I want you guys to do . '

Miyagawa flung the documents in his hand at Gotou .

'Why not get the detective department to do it?'

'I'm just going to say this, but you guys are part of the detective department too . '

'Oh, that's right . '

Gotou sulked like a child . Then, he spread out the documents he had been given .

'Isn't this the Tobe Kengo case?'

Gotou stopped flipping through the documents and muttered .

Ishii knew that case too .

The man who had beat his own father to death with a hammer one month ago –

After the crime, he had been arrested at once still at the scene . At the questioning afterwards, he displayed signs of insanity and had been taken from the prosecution to a medical specialist for an examination .

And then, during that examination, Tobe escaped –

The female doctor in charge at the time had been assaulted, but she resisted and stabbed Tobe with the scissors that had been nearby .

There had been a lot of blood left at the scene, which was the medical examination room .

They had persisted in searching for him since he could not have run far with his injuries, and there had been a large search, but they had gotten no news of him even after one month .

'I want you guys to help out with the investigation too . '

'Are you seriously asking that? It's not something that will be fixed just by adding more people . '

'I'm not telling you to help with the physical investigation . '

Miyagawa rejecting Gotou's displeasure .

'If it's not legwork, should we be putting up flyers?' said Gotou, poking fun .

'Are you an idiot?'

Just as Miyagawa said that, he smacked his palm against the back of Gotou's head .

'Aaah!'

Ishii couldn't help but shout at the unbelievable sight .

For him to raise a hand towards Detective Gotou – what a terrifying person .

'The gutsy female doctor who slashed Tobe asked the police for help . '

'Questioning?'

'No . Pro... fi... fi, fi...'

'Profiling . '

Ishii supplied the word Miyagawa was trying to say .

'Oh, that's it . Profiling . She said the culprit might be found that way . '

'You're not telling me to go with her, are you?'

Gotou's discomfort was apparent .

Profiling was used daily for investigations by police overseas .

However, Japanese police were considerably slower in comparison to police in foreign countries .

As per Gotou's response right now, profiling was still firmly recognised as an unknown .

'Her contact info's written in those documents . Go meet her . '

'She's just an amateur butting in!'

Gotou hit the desk in his irritation .

'Now, now . Don't say that . Anyway, I'm counting on you . Put in a report whenever . '

Miyagawa pat Gotou's shoulders like he was appeasing him and then left the room briskly .

A person just like a storm –

'Damn, pushing annoying work to me . I'm already worn out . '

Gotou flung the documents on the desk as he complained .

However, Ishii felt that Gotou's emotions were the opposite of what he'd said .

After Miyagawa had come, the content of their work had become incomparably harder, and while Gotou expressed his discontent, it was a fact that his eyes were brighter now .

Gotou was probably the type of person who had to be busy .

'Oi! Ishii! We're going!'

At some point Gotou had moved to the door .

'Ah, yes sir . '

Ishii hurriedly rushed over .

He fell –

4

The chime signalling that four hours were over rang –

'I'll stop here then . '

At the same time as Haruka finished speaking, the tension left her shoulders like the air from a balloon .

Somehow, she had managed to finish the morning class, but unfortunately, she couldn't say it had gone well .

At points, her head went completely blank and she was stiff . Each time, Komai gave her advice quietly from the side .

If she hadn't, the class would have become self-study partway through .

'I apologise for causing you trouble . '

'It was a good performance for your first time . You'll get used to it sooner or later . '

Komai smiled and encouraged Haruka, who was looking down .

'Really?'

Haruka felt there were people who were suitable and unsuitable for working in front of people, let alone children .

I wonder if I'm suitable for being a teacher –

She quickly ended up thinking that way .

While Haruka was buried in thought, the children put their desks together, carried the trays with side dishes on them and tableware and prepared for their school lunches .

'Haruka-sensei, come to our group today . '

Two girls pulled at her hand . Maiko and Eri .

They were always together and looked like twins .

'Ah, OK . '

'Come quick!'

Haruka was dragged by Maiko and Eri and sat down in the low chair that had been prepared for her .

'Hey, sensei, do you have a boyfriend?'

The one who asked was Maiko . She suddenly asked such an amazing question .

'I'm taking applications right now . '

For a moment, somebody crossed Haruka's mind, but she shook that away and answered .

'Hey, what sort of person's your type?'

This time it was Eri .

When Haruka was in fifth grade, she'd had a boy she liked, but she hadn't had the concept of boyfriend or girlfriend .

'Hm . A kind person would be nice?'

If she were to say more, somebody who was a bit contrary but dependable when it was important .

There was a parade of questions that made her falter after that, like 'When was your first date?' and 'When did you kiss?' .

It was honestly difficult to reply to questions like this . Even though they were children, they probably wouldn't accept vague answers or lies .

While Haruka was being attacked with tough questions, the children who had finished setting the table had all sat down .

'Everyone's together then . '

At Komai's voice, the children replied together: 'Yes!'

'Sensei, Masato-kun isn't here . '

A little later, Maiko spoke up from beside Haruka .

Haruka glanced over – the seat diagonal from Haruka was empty . Come to think of it, Masato had already been gone by the time Haruka had sat down .

'Eh, again?'

'Who cares? Let's eat . '

'He's creepy . '

'Yeah . He said he can see ghosts . '

'Eh! No way!'

Voices called out from various parts of the classroom . Komai sighed like she was tired of it .

From that response, it appeared that something like this had happened numerous times in the past .

Haruka stood up, walked over to Komai and said, 'I'll look for him . '

Komai appeared to think it over for a while, but then she replied, 'Please do . '

'I understand . '

After replying, she tried to leave but then heard unhappy cries of 'Ehh' from the group of children she had been sitting with .

'You can just ignore someone like him,' someone said .

That was bullying . She couldn't stay silent after hearing that . Just when Haruka thought that, Komai stood up .

'You promised not to say things like that, right? Everyone in this class is friends . Wouldn't it be sad if somebody said the same to you?'

Rather than speaking to anybody in particular, Komai spoke to the whole class .

That was Komai-sensei for you, Haruka thought . There were some children who looked displeased, but the classroom was so quiet the fuss earlier seemed like a lie .

'Ozawa-san, please go ahead . '

'Yes,' replied Haruka, and then she left the classroom .

Where did that child go –

Oomori Masato's face came up in Haruka's mind .

She had not spoken to him even once .

However, she was concerned about him . He felt obviously different from the other children . He was always spacing out by himself away from the group .

He had cold eyes, unlike those of an elementary student .

He might have been troubled with a big problem .

She was also concerned about what the other children had said earlier .

– He can see ghosts .

Was that true?

If it were, Haruka might have been overlapping Masato with that guy .

In any case, she had to hurry . Haruka put those thoughts aside and quickened her pace .

5

After Gotou sat down in the passenger seat of the white Crown, an unmarked patrol car, he lit up his cigarette .

Damn, this was annoying .

Recently, everyone made a huge fuss about psychological analysis and profiling because of the influence of television dramas .

It wasn't a problem of numbers – he wouldn't have to work so hard if they could know who the perps were just by using a calculator .

The basis of investigation was straightforwardly getting info .

Well, it riled him up, but this let him stick his neck into the investigation .
He'd been stuck organising files up until now, and he'd gotten out of shape .
This was a good opportunity .

'I wonder what sort of person she is . '

From the driver's seat, Ishii spoke with a lazy expression .

'Who?'

'Sasaki-sensei, the psychiatrist, of course . '

'You're very curious . '

'There's nothing I can do about it . I looked at her personal history earlier –
it seems like she studied criminal psychology in America . '

'So what?'

'Eh?'

Ishii looked blank .

'Just because she can study for tests doesn't mean she can catch criminals .
Forget about that and drive!'

At Gotou's yell, Ishii's shoulders shivered in fear and he hurriedly started
the car .

Honestly . Gotou wished this fool would grow up a bit . He just kept on
cowering and wasn't useful at all .

Ishii might have been suitable to be a detective . Gotou might have to find
some time to talk to him seriously . It was for Ishii's sake as well .

After sighing, Gotou spread out the documents for the Tobe Kengo case on
his lap .

Tobe Kengo . Thirty-eight . Unemployed –

The left half of his face had been damaged in his childhood by fire so the skin was scarred and reddish purple in colour .

The eyes underneath that were so expressionless it was uncanny . It was like they were fake .

'I wonder why Tobe killed his father,' said Ishii to himself .

'He was angry?' Gotou replied curtly, putting his cigarette out in the ashtray .

'But that's so extreme . Would he kill the father he had lived with for so many years for something simple?'

'Couldn't he have had some deep grudge we don't know about because they lived together for so long? It's not like it's uncommon . '

Children kill their parents . On the other hand, parents kill their children . Nowadays, he often heard about bloody cases like that .

Something was off . He felt that way more often now .

'But something is strange,' said Ishii . He shifted about, like his seat wasn't comfortable .

'What do you mean by something?'

'Tobe's father had terminal cancer . '

When Ishii said that, Gotou looked at the documents again .

It was as he said . Tobe Kengo's father, Masashi, had had terminal cancer .

Even if he hadn't acted on his own, the man would have died soon enough . Nevertheless, Tobe had gone out of his way to knock his dad's brains out .

It really was unnatural . But —

'Maybe he just wanted to do it himself,' said Gotou as he looked at the photo taken of the scene .

It was a disastrous scene that made you want to turn his head away .

Tobe Masashi had been hit dozens of times with a hammer . His mouth and nose were completely crushed and his face was sunken in .

If he'd just wanted to kill him, there was no need to go this far . He'd cleared years of hatred with his own hand . The ill intent came through the photo .

'Is that how it is?'

Ishii cocked his head, seeming dissatisfied . Gotou thought about showing him the photo of the scene, but he decided not to . If he showed Ishii this now, he'd be startled and would definitely cause an accident .

'That's how it is . '

Gotou threw the documents towards the backseat and reclined in his seat, exhausted .

There was something Gotou was more interested in than the motive for the crime .

How could Tobe escape –

He'd been cuffed and police had been there to guard him . If you thought about it normally, there was no way he could have escaped .

He'd looked through the documents, but there were many parts he wasn't satisfied with . Plus, Gotou only believed in the things he saw and heard himself .

He'd have to check that out before profiling when he met up with the psychiatrist, decided Gotou .

Haruka searched in every nook and cranny of the school building, from the fourth floor with Class 5-4's classroom to the first floor .

Of course, she checked the lavatory, library and school infirmary – everywhere that wasn't locked .

However, she couldn't find Masato .

The teachers in charge would have noticed if he had sneaked into another class . Where on earth had he gone?

The only places she hadn't looked at yet were the schoolyard and the PE storeroom .

Haruka took her pumps from the staff shoe cupboard and went out into the schoolyard .

She had been looking around the schoolyard and just turned around to the back of the school building when she spotted Masato .

He had his back against the wall of the school building and was staring at the pool .

Haruka was relieved . She was about to approach him when she recognised the middle-aged man standing in front of Masato and stopped in her tracks .

The man had grizzled hair and was thin to the point of sickliness . He had goggling eyes . He was the vice-principal, Konno .

Konno was saying something while pointing his finger at Masato .

What should I do at a time like this –

While Haruka was undecided about what to do, Konno jabbed Masato's chest .

Masato lost his balance and fell on his behind .

That's awful –

'Please stop!' shouted Haruka as she rushed towards Masato .

'Masato-kun, are you all right?'

Haruka spoke up to him, but Masato stood up with a blank expression and brushed off his trousers .

'Are you OK? You're not hurt, are you?'

Haruka met Masato's eyes as she spoke to him .

Masato didn't seem disturbed – he just looked back at Haruka without saying anything .

His eyes were very cold .

What Konno had done was still unforgiveable .

Haruka turned towards Konno and glared at his sunken eyes .

'Why did you do such a thing?'

Her tone was harsh as her emotions seeped through .

'Who on earth are you? You just cut in so suddenly,' said Konno, crossing his arms in his displeasure .

I greeted him on my first day, and we see each other's faces at the staff meeting, but he still doesn't remember –

'I'm the trainee teacher, Ozawa . '

Konno made a cluck with his tongue in response .

He was the very definition of arrogance . Even if he was of higher rank than she was, there were things that were OK to do and things that weren't .

'Please answer my question . Why did you do such a thing?'

Haruka didn't flinch as she talked back to her superior .

'You're a trainee teacher, and I'm the vice-principal . '

'That is not an answer to my question . '

Did he think everyone would listen to him if he used his authority as a shield?

Whether it was the principal or vice-principal, it wasn't right to use violence against a child .

'Obviously, I was educating him,' said Konno shamelessly .

Konno had thrust Masato away . That action wasn't scolding – it was clearly violence .

'What are you saying he did?'

Konno heaved a sigh at Haruka's words .

'What did he do? He stole something from me . Stealing can't just be forgiven as some children's prank . It's plainly a crime . Do you understand?'

Stealing? That can't be –

'That must be a lie . Of course he wouldn't do something like that!'

Haruka spoke up before checking with Masato .

It had been one week since she started looking over Masato's class . She didn't know him well enough to affirm it, but Haruka still felt strongly that she wanted to believe him .

'Take out what you stole from me earlier . '

Konno brushed Haruka aside and approached Masato .

Masato seemed resigned as he stuck his hand into his parka pocket, took something out of it and handed it to Konno .

Konno accepted it with satisfaction and put it in his suit pocket .

This has to be a lie –

'You understand now, right? Don't be so shameless when you don't know anything . '

Konno brought his face close to Haruka's with a jerk . He said that with a voice dripping in sarcasm and then walked away briskly .

Haruka had no reply and just bit her lip .

Haruka consciously put a smile on her face instead of suddenly scolding Masato as she turned to face him .

'You were OK then,' she said .

He didn't make any reply and just stood there with an expression of mixed surprise and bewilderment .

'Hey, Masato-un . '

Haruka tried to grasp Masato's hand .

'Don't touch me!'

Like his reticence up until now had been a lie, Masato suddenly spoke up in a loud voice and warded off Haruka's hand .

'Masato-kun...'

Masato glared at Haruka with hostile eyes .

I have nothing to say back when he looks at me with eyes like that –

'I'm cursed . Everyone who touches me dies . '

'Eh?'

Masato gave the bewildered Haruka a glance, turned on his heels and ran away .

Haruka just watched his back silently .

What on earth is his small back burdened with –

Haruka was irritated with her inexperience, unable to guess how he was feeling .

7

'This is definitely the right place?'

Gotou's question made Ishii feel unsure .

A tiled five-storey building . There was a cafe with an open terrace on the first floor, and there was a Greek pattern on the pillars .

The building made one think of a boutique in Omotesando .

Ishii understood why Gotou would doubt that a psychiatry clinic would really be in a place like this .

'This is definitely the address...' said Ishii, looking at the documents in his hand again .

Once Gotou heard that, he walked towards the building's entrance .

Ishii hurriedly followed after Gotou and they took the elevator directly in front of the entrance .

'What floor?' asked Gotou, sounding displeased .

'Er... the third floor . '

After Ishii checked the documents, he pressed the button for the third floor .
The elevator slowly started going up .

When the elevator doors opened, there was a wooden door right in front of his eyes with the plate <Sasaki Mental Health> on it .

'This is definitely the place . '

While Ishii was confirming this, Gotou had already opened the door without any hesitation and gone in .

Gotou appeared to be the type who moved before he spoke .

I have to learn from him –

Ishii followed after him .

The room had glaringly white walls with a dark green carpet . It felt like they were standing in a grassy field .

Green was said to relax people, but from Ishii's perspective, it felt a bit much .

Gotou picked up the extension telephone at the reception counter .

'I'm Gotou, a detective from the Setamachi precinct . Is Sasaki here?'

He was taking a highhanded attitude towards a doctor .

Ishii thought that, but he didn't have the guts to tell Gotou his opinion .

Gotou curtly said, 'Ah, I see,' and then he put the phone on the receiver .
After that, he opened the door by the reception and briskly headed down the path that led to the back .

Did he get permission to go in?

Ishii felt anxious, but he started walking after Gotou .

When Gotou reached the door at the end of the path, he said, 'I'm coming in,' opening the door without knocking .

That was just bad manners .

'Please forgive the introduction . '

After bowing his head deeply, Ishii entered the room .

It was about ten tatami in size .

There was a set of brown leather sofas in front of him and plants were placed in the corners of the room . Light came in from the large windows .

In the back of the room, there was a wooden desk and a woman was sitting there while typing away on the keyboard at the computer .

'I've been waiting . '

The woman stopped typing and stood up with a smile .

She's probably Sasaki Anna, the psychiatrist –

She had a slender frame, straight facial features and pale, delicate skin . She had a beauty that felt appropriate for fashion magazine covers .

Her age had been listed as thirty-three in the documents, but her appearance made her seem in her early twenties .

Ishii's expression unconsciously slackened .

'Don't smile like that,' muttered Gotou, jabbing Ishii's side .

His breath caught at the surprise attack .

That was right . He'd almost forgotten his duty . Plus, he already had Haruka-chan in his heart .

Ishii braced himself and stood up straight .

'Are you Sasaki Anna?'

'Yes . '

Anna replied to Gotou's question in a clear voice .

'I'm Gotou . He's...'

'My name is Ishii Yuutarou!'

Gotou's fist came down on Ishii's head .

'Your voice is loud!'

Anna covered her mouth with her hand as she giggled at their exchange .

'You are an interesting pair . I had the impression that detectives would be tougher . '

After Anna said that in an amused tone, she undid her hair that had been tied behind her . Her long and glossy black hair fell down her back .

Ishii's heart skipped a beat .

She's different from Haruka-chan . The elegant beauty of an adult woman –

'Please sit down . '

At Anna's suggestion, Ishii and Gotou sat down on the sofa .

'I will bring out some drinks now then . '

'Don't worry about that . We don't plan on staying long . '

'I can't be the only one drinking though . '

Anna replied to Gotou's words with a smile and left the room .

* * *

Gotou had thought every doctor wore white .

However, Anna, sitting in front of him, looked more like a receptionist at some company than a doctor in her white blouse and above-knee skirt .

'I did think it was unreasonable for me to offer my cooperation, but I thought that I was also responsible as well . '

Anna brought up the topic first .

What, so she knows herself –

Gotou cursed in his heart . The police sometimes asked psychiatrists to cooperate with investigations, but never the reverse .

'Is this place non-smoking?'

Though Gotou asked that, he lit his cigarette so there was no point in arguing about it .

'Please go ahead . If you would allow me to as well?'

Anna placed an ashtray in front of Gotou, took a thin menthol cigarette out and lit it .

There was a sweet smell from the smoke .

'I think the police must've asked you this countless times already, but do you mind if I ask you a few things first?'

'Not at all . Please ask away . '

Anna replied with a smile, crossed her legs and leant back on her chair .

Gotou glanced at Ishii beside him . This fool . His face had been strange for a while now .

He'd beat him half to death when they went back .

'When Tobe escaped, you were examining him in this room . '

'Yes, that's right . '

'Was anyone else here?'

'Of course . The guards were here . Two of them were outside the door .
There were two standing at the wall in the back as well . '

Anna pointed behind Gotou with a slender finger .

They had probably been blocking the door .

'He did well in getting away in a situation like that . '

Gotou felt like there was a shadow in Anna's almond eyes at his words .

'When I was examining him, the fire alarm went off . '

Anna put her cigarette on top of the ashtray . The smoke drifted up from it .

'Fire alarm?'

'Yes . It was a false alarm, but... because of it, the two guards in the
corridor went outside to look at the situation, and the two in the room went
into the corridor .

What idiots —

If there were two guards in the corridor, they didn't need to go out and look
themselves . It was an idiot's mistake .

Gotou put out his cigarette in the ashtray in his irritation .

'Then what did Tobe do?'

'He used that opening to lock the door from the inside... I was really
afraid...'

Anna hugged her shoulders as her body shook .

Even that gesture was captivating .

'So did he assault you?'

'No . He tried to escape . From that window...'

Anna pointed at the large window behind her desk .

'I see . '

Anna pressed her hand against her brow and hung her head, looking pained .

'I tried to stop him . Then, he suddenly rushed at me and strangled my neck,' said Anna, slowly raising her face .

Talking about it again had probably brought up those memories . She was so pale it looked like she might faint .

'And then you stabbed Tobe?'

Gotou chose to put on a hard expression .

Anna nodded silently . Gotou heard Ishii swallow beside him .

'Where'd you get those scissors?'

'While I was struggling, I touched the scissors on the desk . Then, when I frantically turned to resist... I hadn't thought of hurting him...'

Anna's voice grew fainter as she talked and finally disappeared .

The tips of her fingers were trembling . Even if she tried to behave stout-heartedly, it must have been terrible for her . Normally, it wouldn't be strange to start crying, but her self-restraint was incredible .

'A-a-are you all right?' asked Ishii hesitantly .

Anna said, 'I'm fine,' with a smile, but her expression was stiff .

'Ishii-san, you're kind . '

As she said that, she looked directly at Ishii's eyes .

'Ah, no... er...'

'I've got most of the situation . Now it's your turn . You said you'd cooperate with the investigation, but I want to ask what your true motive is .',

The atmosphere had gotten a bit strange, so Gotou forcefully changed the topic .

Anna brushed her hair and sat up straight .

'My true motive?'

'Your questioning's over . You've already cooperated enough in that sense . You didn't remember some new testimony, right? Then what do you plan to do?' said Gotou, lighting up a new cigarette .

'Of course, I was wondering if I could cooperate with the investigation from a profiling perspective . '

'Do you really think something like that will catch the perp?'

He decided to reply bluntly .

'The police have a misunderstanding about profiling . '

Anna's expression was stiff as she gave a firm reply .

'Misunderstanding?'

'Yes . Profiling isn't something as unscientific as television dramas make it out to be, wherein one can discover the names of criminals and ambush them . '

'That so...'

Gotou wavered a bit at the unexpected reply .

'Profiling analyses the criminal's personality and features with behavioural science and infers from statistics . '

'Make that easier for me to understand . '

'In short, profiling, rather than finding out the criminal's whereabouts, analyses the criminal profile and analyses with statistics what sort of person the criminal is . '

'Then that's not really different from actually investigating the scene,' Gotou said .

In actual investigation, they reasoned out the criminal profile from the contents of the crime daily .

If money was stolen from the corpse that was found, the possibility was high that it was a robbery or there was some grudge –

'That is exactly it . In order to use what is garnered from the investigation of the scene more effectively, profiling takes it and studies it from a psychological point of view . '

Anna's expression became softer as she spoke .

'However, Doctor Sasaki, you studied criminal psychology in America . '

Ishii leant forward as he brought up his doubts .

'In America or in England, investigation is only the information gathering of the police . If a psychiatric examination would solve everything, it wouldn't be so difficult . What we do is only one part of the materials that make up the investigation, in order to make that information gathering more efficient . '

When Gotou heard what Anna said, he put aside the preconception in his head and decided to try listening to what she had to say .

'Then let me hear about that investigation material . '

Gotou put out his cigarette in the ashtray and crossed his arms .

'Yes . First, you do know what happened with the psychiatric examination of Tobe-san on the investigation end, yes?'

Gotou nodded .

He'd given a different name during the investigation and suddenly let out a strange voice and went wild – Gotou had heard there was a big fuss .

The investigation had suspicions that he was insane so he had been brought to an expert .

That was the situation, so the motive for why he beat his father to death was still unknown .

'When I met him, he called himself not Tobe Kengo but Ushijima Atsushi . '

'Ushijima, eh...'

'In the documents, it was written that he was suspected to have dissociative identity disorder – that is, multiple personalities . If that was the case, it would not be strange for him to have multiple names . '

'And?'

'The left side of his face had been burnt when he was young . It could be believed that this was a complex that sprang from that...'

Here, Anna closed her mouth like she was hesitating .

'Doctor, could it be that you do not think that is the case?'

Ishii interrupted the silence .

His eyes are sparkling . He's a coward, but he jumps right in for topics like this . I don't get him –

'Please listen to this as one possibility . '

'What?'

'In the past, dissociative identity disorder – that is, multiple personality disorder – was not very well-known . However, it is now spread through the media and many people know about it . '

Anna spoke slowly and was watching Gotou's expression .

'And?'

When Gotou urged her to continue, Anna nodded, licked her lips and continued .

'Since I have also only met him a number of times, I cannot say this with certainty . However, while his symptoms are extremely similar to dissociative identity disorder, he does not have the characteristic memory loss . '

'Memory loss?'

'In the case of dissociative identity disorder, when personality A comes out, personality B does not have memories from then . However, Tobe-san keeps all his memories even when his personality changes . '

'What do you want to say?'

'There is the possibility that this was an incredibly intellectual crime of intent . '

'Ehhh!'

Ishii was extremely taken aback .

'You're noisy!'

Gotou smacked the back of Ishii's head .

This fool is too surprised –

'What's your basis for thinking that?'

'I said this earlier, but for multiple personalities, when the personality switches, the other personalities are asleep and have absolutely no memory of that time . However, Tobe-san, at least when I talked to him, did not seem to have lost his memories . Moreover...'

Anna suddenly stood up . She returned to her own desk, took a B5 notebook out from the drawer and placed it on the table .

It was an elementary school anthology made of straw paper, rarely seen today .

Anna opened the anthology on the table to the page that was bookmarked .

'This is a composition from when Tobe-san was in third grade . '

The page was titled 'Dream for the Future' .

Anna pointed at a point on the page . Tobe Kengo's name was written there .

<I want to become a company president like my dad – >

What irony . Even though he had a dream like this, he did that to his father .

'Please look here as well . '

Anna's finger moved along and stopped at a name . This was the dream written there .

< I want to become Tobe-kun – Ushijima Atsushi >

Gotou looked at Anna, taken aback .

Anna nodded with a serious expression .

'That's right . This is the other name he gave . '

'What does this mean?'

Gotou was a bit confused .

'I do not know for certain . However, this anthology and Tobe-san's burn were from about the same time period . '

'This is...'

Gotou felt something a shiver run down his spine .

'Whether he has multiple personalities or not, I believe this Ushijima-san holds the key . '

Something serious is going to happen –

It was vague, but that was how Gotou felt .

8

When Haruka had finished writing the journal for today, it was already past seven at night .

The other trainees appeared to have trouble with the journal as well, but not as much as Haruka .

When she'd noticed, the meeting room left open for trainees to use had been empty except for Haruka .

It wouldn't have taken so much time to write the journal if she just had to write her thoughts and actions . However, Haruka could not reach a decision .

What she had seen at lunch break when she had gone to look for Masato –

The time had flown by while Haruka couldn't decide whether to tell Komai about it .

After pondering over it, she didn't mention Masato in the journal and decided not to talk to Komai about it either .

When Haruka left the meeting room, she knocked on the door to the staff room .

After opening the door, she saw Komai doing office work at her desk .

There was nobody except her . It appeared that Haruka had made her wait .

When Komai noticed Haruka, she waved her hand with a smile .

'I apologise that this is so late . '

While bowing her head, she handed the journal to Komai with both hands .

'Don't worry about it . '

Komai opened the journal to today's page and looked at it .

After a silence, Komai closed the journal loudly and sighed .

Was there a problem –

While Haruka was thinking, Komai put the journal in her desk drawer, picked up her bag and stood up .

'Haruka-san, you're heading back now, right?'

'Ah, yes . '

'Right . Then let's go together . '

After Komai said that, she started walking towards the exit .

'Ah, OK . '

Haruka gave a vague response and followed Komai .

Even though she'd said to go together, Komai walked silently like she was thinking about something .

Haruka felt that Komai seemed strange, but she didn't ask any questions, and they headed for the staff shoe cupboard on the first floor .

'Hey, Haruka-san . '

Komai finally spoke when they were switching shoes .

'Yes?'

'Why didn't you report about lunch break?'

Komai's voice didn't sound accusing . That sentence just made Haruka's chest feel tight .

It made sense .

There had been such a fuss, so even if Haruka kept her mouth shut, so it was natural that Konno, who had been there, would tell Komai himself .

Maybe Komai had been waiting for Haruka to talk about it .

I betrayed her expectation –

'I apologise . '

Haruka clenched her teeth to restrain the feelings welling up within her .

'Did you think I would be angry if you told me?'

'That isn't it . Just...'

'What?'

'I didn't see what happened directly, and I just couldn't believe that Masato-kun stole something from the vice-principal...'

Haruka had her hands in fists as she appealed to Komai .

'I feel the same way . I just can't believe it . But that's why I wanted you to talk to me . Did you think I'd scold Masato-kun without confirming the truth?'

'No . '

Now, Haruka felt her concerns were really selfish .

I misunderstood so much . I'm inexperienced as a person –

'Don't worry about this time . You'll make sure to talk to me properly next time, right?'

'I am truly sorry . '

Haruka bowed her head deeply .

When Komai saw her, she laughed aloud .

'You really are so honest it's unusual . It's not a beneficial personality . '

'Is that how it is?'

Haruka gave a vague reply .

'Well, I have to talk to Masato-kun properly . '

Komai made a cluck with her tongue, sounding embarrassed .

'Is there some sort of problem?'

'Mhm . Rather than a problem, he's just been strange lately . He didn't use to be like this . '

'Is that so?'

'Yup . Ah, that's right . There's something I want you to take a look at . '

After Komai said that, she took a bundle of Japanese writing paper out of her bag and handed it to Haruka .

'What is this?'

Komai looked bitter when she heard Haruka's question .

'Do you remember when I asked the students to write about their fathers last week?'

'Yes . '

That had been the first day Haruka had been training, if she remembered correctly .

'This is Masato-kun's composition, but the contents are a bit...'

'The contents?'

'Read it . I want to hear your thoughts . That kid definitely has a big worry in his heart . '

'I will . Thank you very much . '

After Haruka replied, she put the writing paper in her bag .

They started walking out of the school building together, but Komai stopped like she had spotted something .

Her eyes were directed at the pool . Led by her gaze, Haruka looked the same way .

Masato-kun was there —

He stood in front of the fence as he stared at the pool on the other side .

'Masato-kun, what are you looking at?'

Komai spoke up before Haruka .

Masato slowly turned his face . His eyes were vacant . It felt like his heart wasn't here .

'A ghost . '

That was all Masato said .

'A ghost? There's no way something like that is here . '

'There is . '

Masato immediately denied what Komai said .

'In this pool . I've been cursed by that ghost . '

Masato said that expressionlessly and then ran off . '

'Hey, Masato-kun!'

Komai hurriedly called out to stop him, but Masato didn't turn around, disappearing into the night .

All Haruka could do was watch silently .

Can this child really see ghosts –

That was the only thought in her head .

'Er... Masato-kun said that he could see ghosts...'

Haruka spoke up, unable to hold back .

'There's a rumour about here from before . '

Komai sighed, sounding troubled .

'A... rumour?'

'This used to be a storeroom . There was a fire and a kid died . Then...'

Komai prevaricated .

She was probably the type who didn't believe in ghosts .

'Do the children know about that rumour as well?'

'Yup . You know Yokouchi-sensei from the class beside ours, right?'

'Yes . '

'He made a fuss about how he saw a ghost here when he was going home from school . Masato-kun probably heard him and said what he did . '

Haruka looked towards the pool again .

The moon reflected in the dirty surface was moving gently .

Unfortunately, Haruka couldn't confirm whether that rumour was true –

9

After Haruka returned to her own room, she collapsed onto the bed .

Her body felt heavy . She was really tired today . Haruka was the type of clumsy person who couldn't do two things at once .

When a lot of things piled up, it would really tire her out psychologically .

'That kid's lonely without his mother . '

While walking home from school, Komai explained Masato's home situation .

Masato's mother had fallen in love with one of the employees at her part-time job one year ago and left her husband and son .

She didn't even say goodbye –

It seemed that Masato and his father did not get along well, and he had closed his heart off ever since then .

His father worked at a bicycle repair shop while raising Masato, but that had bankrupted a few months ago .

Komai didn't explain in detail, but it seemed like the manager had been arrested .

Masato's father hadn't been related at all, but the rumour had stuck with him .

He couldn't find another job, so, with the family finances in a pressing situation, he sold their house, and now the father and son lived in a small flat .

Though Haruka hadn't actually seen how he lived, but she imagined it definitely wouldn't be satisfying if compared with the other children in the class .

Even though he'd done nothing wrong at all, he was suffering .

Children were powerless against this sort of bad luck . All they could was bear it silently .

'I want to do something for him . There aren't many things a teacher can actually do . '

Komai's last words pierced Haruka's heart .

I wonder if there really isn't anything we can do –

Masato's cold expression, so inappropriate for a child, came up in Haruka's mind .

How on earth did that child feel about the unluckiness that had befallen him?

He must have forced himself to keep it all in that small body .

Even though it would be easier for him if he let all his complaints and displeasures out at somebody, he didn't .

Though he's putting on a brave front, I think he's a strong and kind child .

Just like that guy –

Yakumo was also burdened with a great unluckiness .

Though he normally hid it with a coloured contact lens, his left eye was red from birth . That eye had the special ability to see the spirits of the dead .

Consequently, those around him despised him and even his own mother tried to kill him .

He didn't talk about it much, but he had experienced suffering that the likes of Haruka could not even imagine .

Rather than an inexperienced trainee teacher like me, Yakumo might better understand Masato's feelings as somebody who has walked the same path .

'I can see ghosts . '

Masato had said that in front of the pool .

Is that the truth –

Yakumo was also the only person who could confirm that .

Fortunately, tomorrow was Saturday so there was no school . He might not like it, but Haruka would go consult him . He would definitely find a clue .

Haruka suddenly remembered the composition that Komai had handed to her . She took it the paper out of her bag .

Masato's composition was only one line .

<My dad isn't here anymore . I killed him – >

10

After returning to the police quarters, Ishii sat on a chair, exhausted .

He'd walked around for the first time in a while, and he'd been more tired than he thought he would be . It might be better if he exercised a bit more .

'Honestly, this is getting to be a pain . '

Sitting in front of him, Gotou lit up a cigarette as he complained .

It certainly had become something troublesome . However, it could also at the same time be called a big development .

'However, I think we have found a trail . '

'Somehow . '

Gotou was sceptical . However, Ishii didn't feel that way .

Anna showed the possibility that Tobe could be faking his dissociative identity disorder .

Supporting that claim, the other name Tobe gave for his personality, Ushijima, actually existed .

They had run about all day following that trail .

First, they checked Tobe's composition .

There had been a child called Ushijima Atsushi at that elementary school, but he had already died . He had lost his life in a fire at the school .

They found out that Ushijima had been an illegitimate child and had had no father .

There they turned their investigation around and started looking for Ushijima's parents .

They checked the family register at city hall and asked for Ushijima's address, but there was none . Then, they went and asked around and found out that Ushijima's mother was currently in a care home .

They were going to go to that care home tomorrow .

'We might actually arrive at the culprit . '

Ishii said that excitedly, but then the internal line rang and interrupted the conversation .

'Who's it?'

Gotou did not even try to hide his displeasure when he answered the phone .

That was much too arrogant an attitude, but Ishii didn't have the courage to point it out .

'I'm heading out . '

After Gotou hung up, he suddenly stood up .

'Eh? Where to?'

'Chief's call . I'll leave the report to you . '

Gotou left the room with a cigarette in his mouth .

He said that he'd leave the report to Ishii, but Gotou had not drawn up a report even once up until now .

Ishii didn't feel dissatisfied about that .

Though it was strange for him to say it himself, he wasn't usually very useful . If he didn't do this much, he wouldn't know why he was even here .

Ishii spread the report out on the desk and brought the Tobe Kengo documents close to him . After adjusting the position of his glasses with his finger, he looked at his details again .

Thirty-eight years old . Unmarried . His mother died twenty years ago of diabetes .

He received the burn scar on his face when he was ten, so he changed elementary schools to one in the next town after that .

That had probably been out of concern for the child who received such a shock from the fire .

But if they had been going to change environments, moving farther away would have been better –

Or so he thought, but Ishii soon waved that thought away .

The Tobe family managed a real estate company there, so it probably wouldn't have been easy to move so far away .

His father, Masashi, had been adopted into the family . Perhaps that was related .

No, no . He had to hurry up and finish the report .

Ishii flipped through the pages of the documents .

Suddenly, the bloody face of an old man popped out at Ishii .

This was the murdered Tobe Masashi .

'Eek!'

Ishii unconsciously shrieked .

Beating your own father's face so terribly is definitely not normal .

What sort of person could Tobe Kengo possibly be –

Haruka stood in the prefabricated two-storey building in the back of the university's Building B .

She was in front of the door with the plate <Movie Research Circle> on it in the very back of the first floor .

In order to meet Saitou Yakumo –

Since it had been a while, she felt a bit nervous .

'Hey . '

Haruka opened the door without knocking .

He's here –

Yakumo, sitting in the chair at the front, was running his hands through his usual bedhead and yawning dramatically .

It felt like he'd just woken up . Well, it was always like that for him .

'You again? Do you have so much free time?'

Yakumo looked as displeased as if the end of the world had come .

Is this person incapable of greeting someone directly –

Haruka was half-astonished as she sat in the chair opposite him .

'I keep on saying this, but I don't have that much free time . '

'Though you don't look that busy to me . '

Yakumo snorted like she was a fool .

Honestly, this person is –

'I really am busy . I'm a trainee teacher right now,' objected Haruka as she restrained her irritation .

'That starts from fourth year, right? Also, this isn't the place you're training at, and I'm not one of the kids you're watching over, nor do I want to be . '

Was he going to mock her no matter what she said? Then she'd just take it standing .

She didn't have any basis for it, but she felt somehow like she could win today . Her fighting spirit was flaring up .

'At our uni, third-year students can participate in training too . Plus, today's Saturday so school's out . Your sense of the week is off . I'm training at an elementary school . Since contrary university students aren't covered . '

Led by that force, Haruka spoke all at once .

How about that? She struck a victory pose in her heart .

'Which means, in the end, that you have free time right now . '

It was just as he said . A turnabout KO .

Fine . There was no way she'd win against Yakumo in an argument anyway . Haruka's shoulders slumped .

'So what troubles do you have today?'

Yakumo changed the topic while yawning .

Haruka stared at Yakumo, who had suddenly hit the core .

'How did you know?'

Yakumo looked away and ran his fingers through his hair in irritation .

'You didn't sleep last night, right? There are dark shadows under your eyes .
,

When he said that, Haruka hurriedly put her hands under her eyes .

She couldn't check if she had dark shadows under her eyes by touching, but it was true that she hadn't slept enough .

'Moreover, your eyes were hollow when you came into the room . You were probably thinking about something else . Furthermore, you always force yourself to smile and say “Hey” when you bring trouble in . Please stop it – it's unsettling . '

Unsettling, he says – how rude .

'Well, since it's you, you probably picked up some trouble while training . Then you came here . Am I wrong?'

She had nothing to say when he'd pointed everything out so correctly . His observation abilities were amazing as usual .

'Will you listen to what I have to say?'

'What are you saying now? Don't you always talk on and on without asking?'

Ah, she was really riled up . She'd definitely punch him one day .

In order to stave her anger, Haruka took deep breaths before starting to speak .

'At school, there's a small problem – or rather, a child with a problem...'

'You're quite the problem child yourself,' interrupted Yakumo as he rubbed his eyes .

She wouldn't be able to stand it if she replied to every comment he made . Haruka ignored him and continued .

'In the class I'm with, there's a boy called Masato-kun, but that boy said he can see ghosts . '

Haruka felt like Yakumo's expression suddenly stiffened .

Yakumo, who could see the spirits of the dead, was sensitive towards the topic .

'He can see ghosts . Did he say that himself?'

Haruka nodded .

When she met him at the pool, Masato had said himself that there was a ghost .

Haruka felt like Masato's problem was related to that .

'And that boy said he was cursed . '

'A curse?'

Yakumo narrowed his eyes like he was under a glaring sun .

'Yup . A curse . '

'Does he mean your behaviour? The curse . Because of your stupidity . '

'Listen to me seriously!'

'I'm always serious . If I were a natural airhead like you, I would be so much happier . '

Yakumo, after replying cynically to Haruka's objection, pinched his brow and started thinking about something while looking down .

Even though he said so much, it appeared that he was concerned .

If Masato's words were true, he would be in the same circumstances as Yakumo .

'Hey, what do you think? Can Masato-kun see ghosts?'

She decided to try to ask .

'His saying it himself isn't any proof at all . '

Yakumo raised his head .

His eyes looked sleepy as usual, but Haruka could see a faint waver in the back of his eyes . Though it might be her mistake –

'But I've heard that the teacher from the next class saw a ghost in the same place . It seems there was a fire there before and a child died . That's why I think it's probably true . '

Haruka talked about what she'd heard from Komai .

Why was she taking this so seriously? It was like she wanted Masato to be able to see ghosts .

'You've made a great misunderstanding . '

Unlike Haruka, Yakumo sounded very reserved .

'Misunderstanding?'

'Yes . If there was a rumour like that, it enforces how there is no proof that he can see ghosts . Rather, it makes it doubtful . '

Haruka understood what he meant .

If there was a rumour, that would mean that Masato knew about it . If he knew about it, he could say anything . There was no proof at all that it was the truth .

'Well, put aside whether he can see ghosts or not . That kid seems to have other problems . '

That was his calm power of reasoning for you .

It hurt to say it, but he was very different from Haruka, who would be led astray by the situation in front of her .

Haruka sat up and explained everything in detail . Of course, she discussed how Masato was at school usually . She also mentioned how he'd run out from the classroom at lunch break, how he'd been cornered by Konno, the vice-principal, for stealing, and also how Masato hadn't acted like a child then .

Yakumo crossed his eyes and listened to Haruka seriously .

Normally, Yakumo would say something like 'It's none of my business' and reject her, but this time was a bit different .

'Do you know what he stole?'

Haruka couldn't answer Yakumo's question .

'I don't know anything, since I couldn't see it . '

He'd usually say something sarcastic like 'Don't you have any eyes?', but Yakumo just let out a sigh, like he'd given up .

'It'd be something that would fit in a child's hand,' muttered Yakumo, and he looked up at the low ceiling with his arms still crossed .

'Hey, are there really curses?' asked Haruka, ready for a denial .

'There are curses . '

'Eh?'

Her voice sounded strange when she heard the unexpected response .

Yakumo, who could see the spirits of the dead, had created, from his experience, the theory that ghosts were clusters of emotions .

That was why he didn't believe in exorcism that expelled spirits with chants – he was prejudiced against them .

That Yakumo had affirmed the existence of curses .

'Curses are real,' repeated Yakumo, narrowing his eyes .

'So is that boy really cursed?'

'You really are an idiot . '

What did he mean, idiot? He called her an idiot .

'But you just said so, Yakumo-kun . That there are curses . '

'That's why I said you're an idiot . It's the same as what I said before . Just because there are curses, that doesn't mean that kid is cursed . '

Unfortunately, it's just as Yakumo says . I'm an idiot and a blockhead –

'Moreover, the curses I mentioned are different from what you imagine . '

Different?

'What do you mean?'

'I'll tell you when you're old enough to understand . '

He was treating her like an idiot again! She would definitely punch him one day!

Yakumo ignored Haruka's anger and stretched his arms out towards the ceiling . Then, he suddenly stood up .

'There's no point thinking about things here . Anyway, to the place where that ghost comes out . '

'Let's go . '

Haruka finished Yakumo's words .

Gotou and Ishii visited the care home about twenty minutes from the station .

Built alone atop a hill, it had an unbroken view of the town .

The cream-coloured outer walls made it look at first glance like an apartment, and there were benches in the grassy courtyard .

It was fairly different from what he'd imagined .

'Is she really here?'

Ishii adjusted the position of his glasses with his finger in an affected manner .

'She'll be here if she's not dead . '

'Well, that's true...'

'You want to say something?'

'Ah, no...'

Ishii's shoulders slumped like he had withered .

Honestly, this guy couldn't put anything clearly .

Gotou snorted and walked down the brick road towards the front entrance .

Talking with the psychiatrist yesterday hadn't necessarily been useless .

Gotou had thought that profiling was something like a superpower which could suddenly point out where the culprit was .

Miyagawa probably thought the same way . That was why he'd pushed the annoyance to Gotou .

However, the profiling Anna talked about used statistics to analyse the reasoning of the investigation of the scene .

Japan's police force was slower to use profiling than other countries' . Several years ago, there had been a criminology support research department in the police force, but it hadn't done anything but minor support for investigations since there hadn't been enough people and there had been differences in opinion .

Because of that situation, the incorrect knowledge of profiling had firmly taken root in the police .

Gotou had had that opinion himself .

However, it didn't change the fact that the situation right now was like trying to catch a cloud .

Is there any point to this investigation –

It was also true that he had that doubt .

Well, there was no point thinking so much . He wasn't good at thinking in the first place .

Gotou quickly went up the slope and headed for the reception in the back of the entrance . He proved his identity to the middle-aged man who was the care worker who came out . When he asked to meet with the person called Ushijima Harue, he was directed to the sofa to wait .

He sat with Ishii on the sofa .

Gotou thought of lighting up, but then he saw a sign that said the entire facility was non-smoking . It really felt shameful to be a smoker .

With time on his hands, Gotou unconsciously looked at Ishii's profile .

Ishii was always like this, but he was twisting his neck to look around like he couldn't relax . Just like a pigeon trying to group together in front of the station .

Can this guy really continue at the front of the battlefield –

Gotou was doubtful .

'Is anything the matter?'

Ishii looked dubious .

He was careless . What this guy was missing most could be a sense of danger .

'It's nothing!' spat out Gotou, crossing his arms .

'Excuse me . I apologise for the wait . Please follow me . '

The care worker from before came to call them in .

Now, what's going to come? Gotou stood up and followed after the care worker .

13

In order to confirm whether what Masato said was true, Haruka headed to the elementary school .

Of course, Yakumo was with her .

Along the way, Haruka explained Masato's home situation as she had heard it from Komai .

Yakumo didn't frown, but he looked like he didn't understand .

'What is it?'

Unable to bear it, Haruka directed the question to Yakumo's profile .

'Don't you think it's strange?'

He asked a question back .

'What?'

'Honestly . Being so thick-headed must be blissful . '

'Are you making fun of me?'

'I'm just giving my extremely honest evaluation . '

In her irritation, Haruka jabbed Yakumo's side with her finger .

Yakumo jolted and leapt back like a startled cat .

Recently, Haruka had found out that Yakumo's weak point was his side .
When he wouldn't stop saying awful things, she would fight back this way .

Haruka looked away from Yakumo, who was glaring at her .

'Well, in any case . You heard the information about that boy from his homeroom teacher, right?'

Maybe he felt awkward, because Yakumo went back to the original topic after a silence .

'Yup . That's not really strange though, is it?'

Yakumo sighed while shaking his head .

Even if he took that attitude, she wouldn't understand the things she didn't understand . And Yakumo never explained enough .

'She knows too much . '

Perhaps he'd sensed Haruka's feelings, because Yakumo said just that .

'Do you mean Komai-sensei about Masato-kun?'

'That's right . '

'I think it's normal...'

'Then I'll ask this – normally, would an elementary school teacher know the details of all the children's family situations?'

'I think Komai-sensei probably thought Masato-kun had a few problems so she was concerned . '

Haruka herself was concerned about Masato .

If she hadn't heard from Komai, she might have looked into it herself .

'Even if that is the case . Well, by looking into it a bit, you'd find out that he's got one parent and that his dad lost his job . '

'Then there's no problem, right?'

'But where did she find out about his mother's infidelity, her partner and even the situation when she had left home?'

Now that he mentioned it, she did feel like she knew too much .

To find out about his mother's infidelity and her partner, she would have had to dive considerably far into the matter .

Maybe she went around asking the people nearby like a detective –

Before Haruka gave that answer, they arrived at the elementary school's gates .

She'd thought that the gates would definitely be closed, but she saw children in the courtyard yelling in delight as they played soccer . They were participating in club activities .

This made it difficult for them to enter the school .

It'd be fine for Haruka, but it would be troublesome if Yakumo were spotted . There had been a number of incidents at the school, so they were sensitive about visitors .

'Oh, is that you, Ozawa-sensei?'

Suddenly, somebody called out to her . When she turned to look, she saw a man in a jersey holding a ball .

It was the teacher from the class next to hers, Yokouchi . The one who said he'd seen a ghost –

'Ah, Yokouchi-sensei . Good afternoon . '

Haruka put a smile on her face and bowed .

'Today...'

Yokouchi started speaking but then moved his gaze to Yakumo with a surprised expression . Then, a joking smile appeared on his face .

'Oh, a date?'

'No, that is absolutely not the case . '

While Haruka was thinking of an excuse, Yakumo firmly denied Yokouchi's assumption .

He always did it, but it was depressing how he didn't hesitate at all to deny it completely .

'Er...'

Yokouchi raised his eyebrows in his bewilderment .

It made sense . That would mean he didn't know who Yakumo was . However, Yakumo didn't seem concerned at all .

'I was slow in introducing myself . My name is Saitou Yakumo, and I am an exorcist, though I am still inexperienced . '

As Yakumo said that, he pressed his hands together in prayer .

'Exorcist?'

Yokouchi sounded surprised .

That would surprise him . It was extremely unnatural for an exorcist to be in a shirt and jeans .

'Yes . I heard the rumour that a ghost has been sighted at this school from this person named Ozawa-san . '

Huh . He just keeps on making things up .

Plus, Yakumo said himself that he hates people who call themselves exorcists, but he's calling himself that now –

Normally, that would make it sound like a lie .

'S-so that's really how it is?' said Yokouchi, clearly panicked .

It felt like he was overreacting, but from Yokouchi's perspective, he probably wanted any help he could get since he had experienced the spiritual phenomenon himself .

'I feel a strong and wicked spiritual power . Ah, around there . '

Yakumo spoke like he was enacting a play as he pointed with his right index finger in one direction .

He was pointing right at the pool behind the school building .

'That's right . That's where it was . I saw a ghost there . '

Yokouchi was so agitated it felt like he would leap up .

'Could you show me the way?'

'Yes, with pleasure . '

Thus, Yakumo entered the school premises unreservedly from the front entrance .

Should I call him sly, or –

14

Ishii followed the care worker down the corridor .

Just like the exterior, the interior of the institution was scrupulously maintained and more beautiful than he imagined it would be .

'I wonder what sort of person she is . '

He spoke to Gotou, who was walking beside him .

'You'll find out once you meet her . '

Gotou's tone was thoughtless . He might have been a bit irritated .

'That's true . '

Ishii shut his mouth and followed the care worker .

They walked to the end of the long corridor to find a place that looked like a conference room .

There was a large window in the wall which let the sunlight in . A line of cherry blossom trees could be seen outside . Though the leaves were fallen in this season, you'd be able to see the cherry blossoms in full bloom from this room come spring .

There were sofas and tables, and about ten seniors were passing the time as they pleased .

At first glance, it felt like a cafe .

'Ushijima-san, you have guests . '

The care worker who showed them in spoke to a woman sitting at the table by the window .

This person is Ushijima Harue –

Her cheeks were hollow, her wrinkles were deep and her hair was considerably thin . She looked much older than her age .

Despite that, her clothes and makeup were as flashy as that of a woman who worked at a nightclub .

'Who could you be?'

Harue raised her chin and narrowed her eyes .

'I'm Gotou from the Setamachi precinct . '

Gotou put his police ID in front of Harue's eyes .

That moment, Harue's expression stiffened . Ishii could tell they weren't welcome even if she didn't say it aloud .

'Can I sit?'

Gotou sat down on the opposite sofa without waiting for Harue's reply .
Ishii followed him and sat down too .

He could smell Harue's perfume .

He could tell that she was trying frantically not to lose her dignity as a woman even at that age .

'I came today because there was something I wanted to ask you . '

Gotou spoke after clearing his throat .

'I didn't do anything . That guy was at fault . '

Harue's expression suddenly twisted as she spoke .

'What are you talking about?'

'The food here is so disgusting I couldn't eat it . That's why I threw it . '

The conversation didn't mesh .

It appeared that Harue had caused some sort of problem and mistakenly thought that the police had come because of that .

'Hey, Ushijima-san . I came here to talk about your son . '

Gotou's tone was like one that you'd use towards a child .

'My son...'

Harue's cheek twitched .

Ishii had no way of knowing what emotion lay in that response .

'That's right . Your son Atsushi-kun . '

'There's nothing to say . That child is dead . '

Harue's words were pointed .

'I know that . We want to know what sort of person your son was . '

'Why now?'

Harue puffed her cheeks like a child and turned away .

What an impolite attitude . It felt like Gotou would snap, but he persevered and continued the conversation .

'We're looking for a certain man . He was in the same grade as your son . '

'That's no concern of mine . '

'Don't say that . That man called himself the name of your son . He might be related somehow . '

'My son was killed!'

Harue suddenly declared that –

Ushijima Atsushi died in a fire . Was Harue saying that from a persecution complex?

While Ishii was mulling that over in his head, Gotou continued talking .

'Killed? By who?'

'Tobe, obviously!'

Harue let out an ear-splitting shriek as she hit the table with her palm .

Ishii's body shook in his surprise .

Was the Tobe Harue talking about the dead Tobe Masashi – if that was the case, the nature of the case would change drastically .

'What do you mean?'

'You're police – investigate it yourself . '

'If you think your kid was killed, you'd want the culprit to be caught, right? Tell us what you know . '

'It's too late now . It doesn't matter anymore . '

Harue frowned .

'It doesn't matter anymore? What do you mean?'

Gotou's tone which he was forcing to sound calm was tinged with irritation .

'Well, it was refreshing when that burden of a brat died . So it doesn't matter anymore . '

How awful –

There were some things you couldn't say even as a joke .

'Calling it refreshing is...'

Ishii couldn't help but interrupt .

'What? You have a problem with that? I didn't give birth to him because I wanted to either!'

'No, but...'

'That fretful brat . He cost money and wailed everyday – it really was a good thing he died . '

Harue kept on going with a biting force . Ishii was pushed down by that pressure and unconsciously leant backwards .

How can she say so many awful things –

Ishii turned his eyes towards Gotou, sitting next to him . Gotou suddenly stood up without saying anything and slammed his right fist into the table .

It made an amazing noise .

'Ahh!'

Harue jumped up in her surprise and slipped from her chair to land on her behind .

Gotou put his face so close to Harue's that the tips of their noses were almost touching and glared at her .

'Got this, you damned old woman? Doesn't matter whether you wanted it or not . Once the kid's been born, the parent raises it . To be happy about your kid's death – you're not human, let alone a parent . There isn't anybody in this world who should die . '

Gotou spoke slowly in a low voice .

Ishii felt a pressure one hundred times stronger than Gotou's usual angry voice . Gotou didn't wait for Harue's reply and walked away briskly .

Ishii bowed towards Harue and then hurried followed Gotou .

He fell –

15

Led by Yokouchi, Haruka walked to the pool behind the school building .

She took a peek at Yakumo, who was walking beside her . His eyes were sleepy as usual . She felt silly for being nervous .

'That's where I saw it . '

Yokouchi pointed at the diving board for the pool's third lane .

Haruka looked over, but she saw nothing there now .

Just the moving of the dirty surface of the water .

However, it was different for Yakumo . There was a wrinkle in his brow, and his gaze was unusually sharp . From that response, he might have seen something .

'Could you tell me in detail the situation at the time?' said Yakumo, still staring at the pool's diving board .

Yokouchi nodded several times with a triumphant air and started talking .

'That day, I was locking up instead of the caretaker and ended up staying fairly late . '

'About what time?'

'It was probably after ten... I came out of the back entrance and passed by here on the way back when I saw someone at the pool . '

'What sort of person was it?'

'I couldn't see his face clearly, but I think he was a middle-aged man . Recently, there've been a number of incidents, right? So I thought he might've been a pervert and called out to him . Then...'

Perhaps it was because Yokouchi was remembering what happened, but his face became paler before her eyes and he couldn't say the last part because his voice was shaking .

Haruka had thought he'd just seen a ghost, but from how he looked, it felt like there was more to the story .

'It's fine . I'm accompanying you . '

Yakumo placed a hand on Yokouchi's shoulders and urged him to continue .

'After I called out to him, that man... he suddenly burst into flames . '

'Burst into flames?'

Haruka couldn't imagine it and spoke up without thinking . Without a moment's delay, Yakumo glared at her, as if to say 'Be quiet' .

Ooh, scary –

'Could you please tell me in more detail?'

At Yakumo's words, Yokouchi wiped the sweat off his brow and continued .

'How should I put it – fire erupted from his body and enveloped his body in no time . '

Yokouchi's explanation was combined with gestures .

'I see . '

After Yakumo said that while rubbing the back of his neck, he turned towards the school building like he had felt something .

Haruka turned to look as well, but she saw nothing .

However, Yakumo, with his left eye, should have been able to see something that they couldn't see .

'Sensei, there's more to the story, is there not?'

After turning around in a slow and deliberate manner, Yakumo asked Yokouchi that question .

It seemed he'd hit the mark . Yokouchi's eyes went as wide as saucers in his surprise . No, perhaps it was fear .

'Y-yes . That's right . Afterwards, I tried to run away, but a boy suddenly appeared . That boy clung to my jacket sleeve and then, that boy also...'

'Burst into flames . '

Yakumo finished Yokouchi's cut-off sentence .

Haruka had no way of determining whether what he said was true or an illusion .

'Sensei, is it true that there was a fire here in the past?'

Yakumo put his left index finger to his brow .

'Yes, though I don't know the details either...'

'I see . '

After Yakumo said that, he briskly walked towards the pool fence and skilfully climbed over the fence about as high as his chest .

'I'm going to take a look . '

After Haruka spoke to Yokouchi, she followed Yakumo and climbed over the fence .

'Hey, wait . '

Haruka jogged over to Yakumo's side .

'What?'

What, he said .

'Did you see something?'

'Yeah, I saw something . '

'Eh?'

Which meant there was a spirit of the dead nearby . The moment she thought that, she felt cold and gooseflesh rose on her skin .

'You don't have to follow me if you're scared,' murmured Yakumo as he looked at Haruka who was clearly afraid .

It was mysterious how she wanted to do the opposite of what Yakumo said when he told her that . Plus, she had a backbone . She couldn't turn back now .

'I'm fine . '

Haruka replied with a smile and then gripped Yakumo's shirt sleeve so he wouldn't notice .

Yakumo walked to the opposite side of the fence without looking at the pool and slipped into the narrow path behind the washing place .

The path was so narrow they'd have to go one at a time . Haruka walked along, hidden by Yakumo's back .

Where was Yakumo headed?

She thought of asking, but she stopped herself . If she said it aloud, he would definitely say something like 'Please shut your mouth' .

'Watch out . '

Even though she nodded at Yakumo's words, she wasn't sure where to watch out for .

Her heartbeat quickened in her nervousness and anxiety .

Then, the next moment, the ground that should have been under Haruka's feet disappeared . She lost her footing and fell forwards .

'Ah!'

Everything in front of her shook violently, and before she noticed, she was on all fours . It seemed that she had slipped from the steps .

It hurt . Her knees stung .

'Honestly . How clumsy can you be? I told you to watch out . I almost fell as well . '

When she looked up, she saw Yakumo staring down at her with his arms crossed in displeasure . Even if he said that...

'You didn't say there were steps!'

'What sort of accusation is that?'

Just as he said, it was Haruka's fault for not looking at her feet even after she was warned, but he could have at least been a bit worried .

The corners of her eyes felt warm from her mortification and pain . She had clenched her teeth together tightly and tried to stand up when Yakumo put out his hand .

OK, she was prepared .

Haruka gripped Yakumo's hand and used it to help herself up .

When she looked around again, she saw that the path was surrounded by concrete . What was the point of coming to a place like this?

While Haruka was thinking, Yakumo continued forward .

Haruka's legs hurt, so he could have waited a bit . Haruka swallowed her dissatisfaction and followed Yakumo's back .

'Watch your head,' said Yakumo from ahead .

Head? What?

Thump!

Something hit Haruka's forehead with a dull thud .

For a moment, everything in front of her went dark .

It hurt so much she let out a strange cry of 'Oof!' and pressed her forehead .

Maybe she had a concussion because her head felt dizzy .

'Didn't I say to watch your head?'

She heard Yakumo's voice .

He had said that . It was her fault for being clumsy . She wanted to reply, but she couldn't speak in her dizziness .

'You OK?'

At the same time as he spoke, Yakumo's palm touched Haruka's forehead .

The throbbing pain left, but then she felt Yakumo's warmth through her forehead .

It was mysterious . When he held his hand against her forehead like this, it felt like her pain lessened .

It was rare for Yakumo to be kind to her . She thought of staying like this for a while, but she remembered that Yokouchi was waiting for them outside and hurriedly stood up .

'Thanks . I'm fine now . '

Haruka put a smile on her face .

'The first failure is an experience, but failing again in the same way is foolish . '

After Yakumo said that, he stooped over and continued down the path with its low ceiling .

This person is just so – ! Just when we had a good mood going, why does he ruin everything by talking? Idiot!

After yelling that in her heart, Haruka continued after Yakumo, watching her head this time .

Only the path's entrance had a low ceiling . It seemed like there was no worry of hitting her head even if she stood up ahead .

When she looked up, she saw a number of wide pipes running above her head . Were they for the water supply?

After going about fifty metres ahead, Yakumo stopped .

When she took a peek past Yakumo's back, she saw a metal door . There was a plate on the door which read Pump Room .

'Stay here . '

Yakumo spoke in a harder tone than usual and put his hand on the doorknob .

Normally, places like this should have been locked . Haruka thought there was no way it'd open, but when Yakumo pulled at the door, it opened readily .

There was a bizarre smell that made her want to cough .

What could this smell be –

'Don't move . '

Yakumo gave Haruka another reminder and then went inside, covering his nose and mouth with his arm .

The unfortunate quality of humanity was that being told not to do something conversely made them more interested . She wouldn't stand for just waiting after all the pain she'd gone through to get here .

Haruka took a peek inside through the gap left by the half-closed door .

She saw Yakumo's stooped back .

There was a strange smell of something raw and something burning that she didn't know what to call, so she covered her mouth and nose with her sleeve .

What was Yakumo doing?

Haruka moved herself to take a closer look .

'Aah!'

She shrieked in her surprise . Yakumo stood up immediately and pushed Haruka aside to leave the room .

'I told you not to look!' said Yakumo, clearly angry . Even if he said that, she'd already looked .

'A-ah, wha, tha...'

She had taken in too much air . Plus, her throat was shaking so much she couldn't speak .

What on earth was that –

Something burnt completely black like charcoal had fallen to the concrete floor . It was in the shape of a human being .

Then, from the corner of the room, a left hand only from the wrist up had fallen .

'Spontaneous human combustion,' said Yakumo with a hard look in his eyes .

NOTES:

[1] A closely cropped haircut is sometimes associated with the yakuza .

Volume 4 Chapter 2: VOLUME 4 - FEELINGS TO PROTECT

Chapter 2

VOLUME 4 - FEELINGS TO PROTECT

file 02: blaze (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

‘What is this?’

Those were Hata Hideyoshi’s honest feelings when he saw the scene .

He had been a doctor for thirty-five years . He’d autopsied strange corpses as a coroner for more than ten years . He had seen countless corpses up until now .

Corpses with their limbs cut off . He’d seen so many drowned corpses and of course burnt corpses too . He wasn’t surprised by much .

However, this was different from the corpses he had seen until now .

Detectives and examiners are walking around the scene to look at it very carefully, but I wonder how many people noticed how odd this corpse is –

Most of them definitely thought it was just a burnt corpse .

The ones like Gotou, who had left the room earlier, must have had no suspicions at all .

Hata stooped over the corpse and observed it carefully .

It was splayed spread-eagle on the floor and there was crushed charcoal spread on top of it . That was what it looked like .

'What a splendid way of burning,' said an examiner who had stooped over the corpse like Hata .

It wasn't at the level of splendid . Clothes and hair were natural, but the flesh and bones had also burnt completely and carbonised .

From somebody who didn't know, they might think that was what burnt corpses were like .

However, somebody with a bit of medical background would know this was strange .

On top of that, he was interested in why just the portion of the body above the left wrist hadn't been burnt . Why did just that part of the body not burn —

It wasn't just the corpse that was strange .

The whole floor was covered in a yellow and sticky glue-like liquid . That let out an awful smell, making it uncomfortable just to breathe .

There were many other things he didn't understand .

'Where did the fire start?'

Hata voiced one of his doubts .

'That... Nothing that looks like it could have been the start of the fire has been found . '

The examiner shook his head .

Why did the body burn in a place that didn't feel like it could have a fire?

'Is this room really the only place that burnt?'

'It appears that way . '

Hata looked around the concrete-surrounded room once more .

Black soot was drizzled on the room's walls like it had sprayed on .

Though it was a concrete room, how could the fire have spread to the point that it burnt human bone?

He had more doubts the more that he thought .

What on earth happened here –

Hata felt a shiver down his spine .

How many years had it been since he felt this way?

Come to think of it, he felt like he'd seen the same sort of thing before .

What was that? He couldn't remember .

2

After Gotou left the pump room, he stretched and then lit a cigarette .

Honestly, everything was so confusing . He'd come after being told 'Come to the school right away' only to find a burnt corpse .

When he shifted his gaze, he saw the person who'd called him out .

Saitou Yakumo –

He was by the pool fence and looking vacantly with sleepy eyes at the investigation members milling about .

'I didn't want to see your face for a while . '

Gotou walked up to Yakumo .

'The feeling is mutual . I didn't want to see you again for the rest of my life . '

As Yakumo spoke with his usual tone, he ran a hand through his messy hair .

Damn, this brat isn't cute at all –

'By the way, how'd you get wrapped up in this?'

'As is her habit, a repeat trouble-bringer paid me a visit . '

Yakumo looked behind Gotou .

When he turned around, he saw Haruka sitting by the school building while shivering . Ishii was beside her, looking concerned .

Now Gotou understood . Well, Yakumo wouldn't just stick his head into trouble on his own . Haruka must have picked up something about ghosts somewhere and brought it to Yakumo .

'So what do you think about the incident?'

'The duty of a virtuous citizen is just to report to the police . What comes next is your job, Gotou-san . '

This guy and his impertinent mouth – he could throw him in the pool right now .

'My, my . You're all together . '

A small-framed man in white hobbled over to them .

Hata, the coroner –

Even though he'd just seen a corpse, he was smiling so happily .

He really was a creepy old man .

'Gotou . You're a blockhead, as usual . '

Hata looked up at Gotou's face and let out a demonic giggle .

Honestly, what sort of greeting was that?

'If you don't stop that, I'll fold you into quarters and stuff you in a rubbish bin . '

'I won't burn, so put me in with the oversize garbage[1] . '

Saying he won't burn after seeing a burnt corpse – what a tasteless joke .

'By the way, Yakumo-kun . '

After he giggled, Hata turned the conversation around .

'What is it with the corpse this time? I've done this work for a long time, but I've never seen that before . '

'Did you notice?'

To Hata, who was speaking seriously for once, Yakumo replied with an equally serious gaze .

Gotou had seen the corpse earlier too . It was strange for a burnt corpse to be discovered at an elementary school pool .

However, it appeared that what Hata said about having never seen it before was regarding the corpse itself .

'Isn't it just a burnt corpse?'

Hata and Yakumo sighed simultaneously .

Were they making fun of him?

'Gotou-san, did you really not notice anything?'

Yakumo's eyes were narrowed with disdain .

'What?'

'You must be blind not to notice . How pitiful . '

Hata shook his head emphatically .

'You! Who'd you say was blind?'

'You!'

'Hata-san, that's incorrect . Gotou-san is just an idiot,' said Yakumo .

Hata nodded, like he understood .

Both of them – they were the worst combination .

He didn't even feel like objecting now .

'Forget about my stupidity . Tell me what's strange . '

'There are three suspicious points regarding the corpse and the scene which are suspicious . '

Yakumo put up his fingers as he started to explain .

'Three?'

'Yes . First, there was nothing at the scene which could have started the fire . '

That was right . It was a pool pump room, after all .

'Maybe it was just covered in gasoline and lit up? Maybe the guy did it or someone else did . '

Yakumo didn't respond, let alone refute Gotou's logic . He continued his explanation .

'Second, even though the person burnt so completely, the fire didn't spread to the building . '

Now that he mentioned it, that was true .

For now, they would put aside whether the burnt corpse was a suicide, murder or accident .

The room was concrete, so it would be difficult for the fire to spread, but if somebody had burnt so completely, it must have been a considerable fire .

It was unnatural for the room to escape just with soot on the walls –

'And the third problem . This is just something I have reasoned by looking at the corpse, so I would like to ask for your opinion, Hata-san . '

Yakumo turned the conversation to Hata .

'I haven't autopsied it yet either, so I can't say anything definite, but I dare say my reasoning is the same as yours, Yakumo-kun . '

Hata nodded at Yakumo .

'Is that so...'

After Yakumo murmured in a discouraged voice, he pinched his brow with his fingers .

Gotou cleared his throat and waited for Yakumo to continue .

However, both Yakumo and Hata seemed to be thinking about something and didn't say any more .

'Oi! What's that reasoning!?' Gotou yelled, unable to keep it in .

'Even the bones of that corpse were burnt,' said Hata, sounding fed up .

He said it like it was obvious, but Gotou didn't understand why that was unnatural .

It was a burnt corpse, so of course it burnt .

'What's strange about that?'

'You really are an idiot,' Hata replied without a moment's delay .

'What did you say!? This old man! You want to test it yourself?'

Gotou's head was hot as he pulled up Hata by the collar .

However, Hata, instead of being afraid, actually laughed in enjoyment .

'There is no need to test it . '

Yakumo was the one who said that .

'What do you mean?'

Gotou let go of Hata and turned his gaze to Yakumo .

Though Yakumo was a man of pale and delicate features, sometimes he would have a frightening expression that would give you shivers . This was one of those times .

'Even if a person is burnt for cremation, the bones are left behind . '

'Yeah . '

The bones left behind were shut in funerary urns, so it'd be a problem if they were burnt up . '

'That is about nine hundred to a thousand degrees . '

Even if Yakumo mentioned a temperature of that level, Gotou couldn't actually understand it .

The conversation had as little real meaning to Gotou as talking about foreign exchange rates . He had no way of converting that temperature into something he recognised .

'Explain it in a way that makes it easier to understand . '

'All right... There are past examples of somebody carbonising like the corpse we saw earlier . '

Yakumo's eyes seemed to be far away as he answered the question Gotou had spat out in his irritation .

'What, so it's happened before?'

Hata let out another creepy giggle after Gotou said that with a snort .

Damn, he was making fun of him again . Maybe he'd pull off his head .

'The past examples I am referring to occurred at the hypocentre of an atomic bomb,' said Yakumo, giving Gotou a sidelong glance .

'Wha!? Atomic bomb? You...'

Gotou couldn't think of what to say next .

It was impossible to think of such a tremendous heat occurring in that room .

'In short, if we are to come to a conclusion about the burnt corpse at the scene, all we can say is that it is impossible . '

Yakumo's expression when he brought that to a finish was so twisted it seemed like he could cry at any moment .

Gotou also finally understood how serious the situation was .

What on earth happened here –

There was no way Gotou could understand something Yakumo and Hata couldn't .

Before he'd noticed, the cigarette in his fingers had burnt up and all that was left was the filter .

'Hot!'

3

With complicated feelings, Ishii looked at Haruka, who was sitting with her back to the wall of the school building .

He was happy that he had met her for the first time in a while, but he couldn't see the usual smile in her profile . Her face was pale and it looked like she was holding back her pain .

It wasn't unreasonable . Anybody would be shocked from seeing a corpse .

Ishii himself had shrieked many times . The only people who could look fine after that were the team of three demonic men talking on the other side of the fence, starting with Gotou .

Ishii wanted to cheer Haruka up somehow, but he didn't know what to say to a woman at a time like this . He had no experience .

That made him irritated at himself .

Indifferent to Ishii's thoughts, Haruka hit her cheeks with her hands and suddenly stood up .

'A-ah, Haruka-chan, a-are you all right?' said Ishii, flustered .

'Yes, I'm all right . I apologise for worrying you . '

Haruka smiled .

Even Ishii could tell that smile wasn't natural .

'No, not at all . But it'd be better if you didn't push yourself . '

'I'm fine . Forget about me – Ishii-san, don't you have to go to the scene?'

Ishii couldn't say anything to what Haruka had pointed out .

He was worried about Haruka . That wasn't a lie . However, at the same time, it was also true that he didn't want to go to the scene .

As a detective, he had a duty to go to the scene . He knew that .

But if he went to the scene, there'd be a corpse .

To see that – it frightened him .

'What's wrong?'

'No, it's nothing . Er... I'm waiting for my turn right now . '

He'd said something strange .

'You're... waiting for your turn?'

Haruka cocked her head like she thought it was curious . Her doubts were natural .

'Yes . Er... the scene is small and there are many people there right now, so I am waiting for my turn . Ah, I hope my turn comes soon . '

Haruka laughed aloud at what he said .

A real smile, different from the one she'd put on before . Ah, he'd wanted to see her smile .

'Ishii-san, you really are an interesting person . '

Haruka brushed her hair behind her ear with her fingers .

That gesture made Ishii's heart skip a beat . Haruka-chan really was cute .

'What are you doing here?'

A slim middle-aged man walked towards them with a wide stride .

He had sensitive-looking features and wore an outfit – chino pants and polo shirt – which made him look like he was returning from a game of golf .

'Vice Principal . '

Haruka looked surprised .

'Answer my question . I asked what a trainee teacher is doing at school on a day off . '

'Er... I...'

'You know that you have to notify us in advance if you're coming to school a day off, right?'

Even though he was the vice principal, that was a very arrogant attitude .
Ishii looked for words to defend Haruka but couldn't find any .

It felt like there were sparks in the air between them .

'She was the first person to see the corpse and was cooperating with the investigation . Who are you?'

Gotou walked over with good timing .

Yakumo was next to him as well .

'I'm the vice principal . I'm asking why she's here on a day off . '

Konno flared up at Gotou .

There were some people whose positions at work overflowed into their private life . This man was the definition of one of that type .

'That's our job to investigate as the police – not yours . I don't care whether you're the vice principal or whoever – keep out of it!'

Gotou approached Konno as he threatened him .

When Gotou was like this, he had as much pressure as a yakuza . Not many people could strike back .

Konno bit his lip for a while, but then he turned around and walked away silently, like he'd decided he was out of luck .

'You were of a great help to me . Thank you very much . '

Haruka put her hands to her chest as she bowed at Gotou .

'Don't worry about it . '

Gotou waved his hand like it was nothing .

'But what a high-handed person he was,' said Ishii in his relief .

'It's true . He's always like that...'

'He probably thinks he's some big shot,' said Gotou with a frown, lighting up his cigarette .

'Gotou-san, the school premises are non-smoking,' interrupted Haruka without a moment's delay .

'You're so fussy . The police are exempt . '

After saying something selfish, Gotou blew out smoke for show .

'Don't play around – we should head back already . '

Yakumo yawned, like he was signalling the end of the situation .

It made Ishii angry to see Yakumo treat Haruka like she was his possession, but he couldn't express that aloud .

'I wasn't playing around . '

Haruka stuck her tongue out at Yakumo .

Yakumo snorted scornfully and walked away briskly .

'You guys really love trouble,' muttered Gotou, looking up at the clear autumn sky .

'Gotou-san, please don't start talking like Yakumo-kun too . '

'I'm just saying the truth . '

'If you say things like that, your wife will leave you again . '

'Shut up! That's unnecessary concern! And my wife's properly at home... probably . '

Perhaps he felt awkward, because Gotou stuck his hands in his pockets and turned around from Haruka .

'Well, I'm leaving then . '

Haruka bowed with a smile .

Ishii just felt Haruka was pitiful, as she acted so strong even though she'd not only gotten wrapped up in trouble but also had to listen to the endless comments of insensitive men .

'That's right, Ishii . You look at the scene too,' said Gotou suddenly .

'Eh, do I really have to go?'

'Of course you do, fool . What would a detective do if he didn't go look at the scene?'

'Of course...'

Ishii tried to think of a reason not to go look at the scene, but it was useless .

4

Haruka finally caught up to Yakumo just before he was about to pass through the school gates .

He could've waited a bit –

'You all right?' said Yakumo with his back to her .

She froze automatically at those unexpected words .

So even this blunt guy was a bit worried –

What she had seen in the room was still fresh in her mind, but she felt a bit better just from Yakumo's remark .

'How long are you just going to stand there?'

Yakumo turned around, looking exasperated .

It was mysterious how gentle his eyes looked, even though they were just as sleepy as usual .

'Ah, right . '

Haruka walked up to Yakumo and rammed into him forcefully .

Yakumo lost his balance and almost fell forward .

'What?'

'Nothing . '

She ignored Yakumo who looked like he didn't understand and continued walking .

She thought that he would say something cynical, but Yakumo didn't say anything .

For some reason, it felt kind of nice . She had been down, but now she was incredibly lively .

'So what's up with this case then?'

Deciding that Yakumo's silence was a good thing, she tried asking him a question .

'Why do you always...'

'Rush to a conclusion? That's what you want to say, right?'

She said it before Yakumo could . She was in a good mood today .

'Don't ask if you understand that . '

'Can't you just explain the situation?'

Yakumo just looked up at the sky while walking, not answering Haruka's question . The air around Yakumo felt more suffocating than usual .

'This is just my explanation of the situation . Don't get ahead of yourself . '

After running a hand through his messy hair and saying that, Yakumo started his explanation in a reluctant manner .

'Just as that boy of yours said, there was a spirit there . '

There was –

Yakumo followed that spirit of the dead and found the corpse .

'I saw two spirits there . '

'Two?'

'The first was a middle-aged man . I followed that spirit to that place . '

'And the other?'

'The spirit was right beside you . Looked like a kid of elementary or middle school age . '

'So is there one more corpse?'

Haruka unconsciously gripped Yakumo's arm .

'I don't know . From the clothes, I feel like that spirit's from a different time...'

'I see...'

'This is just my gut feeling, but I think it might be the kid that died in the fire before . '

If that was the case, it'd mean the spirit had been there for a very long time .

Yakumo had said this before . The spirits of the dead wander because of feelings that have not been dispelled – what sort of feelings did that boy have?

'Hey, what are you going to do now?' Haruka asked, prepared to hear a response like 'Think about it yourself' .

'First, I requested that Gotou-san look into the fire that occurred at the school . '

'You move quick, just as expected . '

'Don't make fun of me . There were various details about the corpse that was found today that are worth thinking about, but I'll have to wait until Hata-san has finished his autopsy...'

'Hey . Isn't there anything I can do?'

When Haruka asked that, Yakumo suddenly pulled her arm towards him with a jerk .

The movement was so sudden that Haruka staggered .

Then, at a distance where the tips of their noses were almost touching, there was Yakumo's face .

Eh, wait –

Her heart was beating furiously at this sudden development . The blood rushed to her head, making her feel dizzy .

'Continue to walk straight like this,' Yakumo whispered into her ear .

'What do you mean?'

She asked him that question, but Yakumo didn't reply . He just continued walking while pulling at Haruka's arm . It felt like he was walking at a slower pace than usual .

Finally, Yakumo stopped when they'd reached the intersection .

'Look at the mirror,' said Yakumo quietly .

She did as he said and looked at the mirror at the intersection . She could see the warped reflection of themselves in the convex mirror . She could also see a boy a little bit behind them hiding behind the telephone pole .

That's –

'Masato-kun!'

Haruka called out as she turned around .

Their eyes met . Masato froze with his eyes as wide as saucers .

Why was he here?

Haruka took a step towards Masato . At the same time, Masato jumped back like the repelling side of a magnet .

'Hey, wait!'

She took another step .

Masato turned around and fled like a rabbit .

Why was he running?

Haruka chased after Masato . However, she soon stumbled and fell .

– It hurts .

When she stood up, her hands on her knees, Masato had already disappeared .

'Honestly, are your reflexes dull? Or are you clumsy?' said Yakumo with a yawn .

She couldn't find the words to object . Since she was probably both –

'I wonder why Masato-kun ran . '

Haruka threw that question at Yakumo .

'Because he was following us,' replied Yakumo staring at the street which Masato had run down .

'Following us? Since when?'

'I noticed right as we left the school gates . At first I thought I was mistaken, but since he was so suspicious, I tried shaking him up a bit . If you hadn't yelled, I would have caught him once we turned the corner .

'I see . My bad . '

'So you understand,' said Yakumo with a raised eyebrow .

Ah, honestly . That attitude really riled her up .

'But why was he following us...'

'It's your duty as his homeroom teacher to confirm that, though you are still a trainee . '

Just as Yakumo says, that is my duty .

Putting aside whether I can do it or not –

5

The day after the corpse was found, Gotou headed for the university's <Movie Research Circle> room .

He came to meet Saitou Yakumo, who lived here, using it as his secret hiding place .

'Sorry to bother you . '

When he opened the door, Yakumo greeted him with a yawn .

The guy really was like a cat . What sort of daily life was he living?

'I've said this many times, but if you know you're being a bother, please leave . '

'Stop nagging . '

Gotou sat on the folding chair opposite Yakumo .

'Gotou-san, you have a slight smell to you . '

Yakumo wrinkled his nose purposefully .

Honestly, suddenly complaining –

'Shut up!'

Of course he had a slight smell to him . He hadn't been home since yesterday .

Yakumo was the one who was strange for not smelling at all, considering he lived in a place without a bath or a water supply .

'Where is Ishii-san today?'

'He's working another case . We don't have enough hands either . '

'Isn't that because you skip out on work, Gotou-san? Ishii-san must be tired of it . '

Honestly . This guy said whatever the hell he wanted to . Gotou was the one who was pitiful with that useless subordinate . Gotou was forced to do unnecessary things .

Yesterday, Ishii had fainted the moment he'd seen the burnt corpse .

In the end, Gotou had to take him home .

'Say what you want,' said Gotou, finding it too troublesome to explain .

'So what did you discover?' said Yakumo, with his chin in his hands and a vacant look in his eyes .

He's acting like he's not interested, but it feels like he actually really wants to know . Honestly, he could just be a bit more honest –

Gotou placed the documents he'd brought on the table . Yakumo took those documents in his hands and flipped through the pages .

'First, it's true that there was a fire at that school . Seems to have happened twenty-eight years ago . '

Even though Gotou was going out of his way to explain, Yakumo just glanced up without saying anything .

Honestly, this wasn't worth it . He sort of understood why his wife complained every time they ate . Next time, maybe he'd comment on how delicious the food was .

Gotou threw himself into continuing the explanation .

'The fire started in the PE storeroom . It's been taken down and now it's the pool . Which means that's the location . It started because some kids were playing with fire . Somebody nearby saw the smoke and reported it . Then the firefighters came . '

After saying this much, Gotou paused . Explaining what came next would be difficult . Where on earth should he start?

'I don't care what order you explain this in, so please hurry up,' said Yakumo while tapping his brow with his finger . So he'd seen right through him? He really was an unpleasant guy .

'When the firefighters got here, there were still two kids inside . One had his face burnt but it wasn't life-threatening, but it was too late for the other . '

'So that was the kid who'd died then...'

Yakumo looked up at the ceiling, as if there were something there .

Gotou waited, thinking Yakumo might say something, but he didn't say anything else .

Honestly . He shouldn't just speak so meaningfully . It was confusing .

'This is the problem . The kid who lived transferred to a school in the next town after that . His name was Tobe Kengo... Actually, that man...'

'Killed his father and escaped during his psychiatric examination . '

Even though Gotou had been building up to an explanation, Yakumo went and said the punch line . He was probably the type of guy who was disliked .

'You know about it?'

'Even I read the newspaper . And then?'

That made sense . Not just the newspaper – it was broadcast almost daily on television . It'd be odder not to notice .

'We're following that Tobe case . '

'I know that the police also have insufficient personnel, but they must be incredibly shorthanded if they're going to make you investigate, Gotou-san,' said Yakumo with a smirk .

Couldn't this guy just quietly listen to somebody talk? Gotou felt angry, but he swallowed that anger since it would just come back to bite him if let it out .

'We met the lady who did Tobe's examination, but that lady says there's a possibility Tobe's psychological state is an act . '

'He is thought to have dissociative identity disorder, yes?'

There was a bit of force in Yakumo's sleepy gaze .

'That's right . He didn't seem to reflect at all during the questioning, and he called himself Ushijima Atsushi instead of Tobe Kengo...'

'Could that Ushijima Atsushi be the name of the boy who died in the fire?'

'Bingo . '

This guy really caught on quick .

'That doctor lady had some compositions written at Tobe's elementary school . Ushijima's name was in those compositions, and he'd written this: I want to become Tobe-kun . '

'I see . '

Yakumo pinched his brow with his fingers and listened to Gotou's explanation . It was the pose he struck when pondering over a difficult problem .

'And one more thing . '

Yakumo lifted his head just slightly at Gotou's words .

'What is it?'

'We went to see Ushijima Atsushi's mum yesterday, but she said her son was killed by Tobe . '

He didn't understand what she had said then .

But it was different now . The fire twenty-eight years ago . Had that really just started from playing with fire – Harue doubted that .

However, it was difficult to say whether Harue hated Tobe for that .

That woman had said it was a good thing her son died . She was a failure not just as a mother but as a human being for saying something like that .

Without saying anything, Yakumo started reading the documents .

I'm counting on you, Yakumo . Gotou yelled that at the bottom of his heart . That fool Ishii couldn't be relied on, and Gotou couldn't think of anything either after going through the information .

'Gotou-san, could you obtain the composition in question? I don't mind if it's a copy . '

Yakumo spoke with his eyes still on the documents .

'Ah, probably . '

Anna had them . He could just borrow them .

'As well, please reinvestigate the fire from twenty-eight years ago . I would like you not to just look at documents but to also talk to the people who were at the scene . '

'The people at the scene?'

'Yes . There should be people who lived nearby and the people from the fire department . Please hurry . '

Got it – is what Gotou was about to reply, but he came to his senses .

'You sound so high and mighty . When'd you become my boss?'

Yakumo looked nonchalant even under Gotou's glare .

'If you don't want to, it's fine by me . I just won't ever cooperate with you again . '

Yakumo smirked .

6

Ishii visited Sasaki Mental Health .

Like the day before, he was sitting stiffly on the sofa in the counselling room .

Gotou told Ishii to inform the psychiatrist Anna about what they had found out so far to ask her opinion .

Will I be all right on my own –

He took a handkerchief, wiped the sweat on his forehead which came from anxiety and adjusted the position of his glasses with a finger . He just couldn't relax .

'I apologise for the wait . '

Anna, who'd left her seat, came back holding coffee .

Ishii sprung up and bowed his head deeply .

'Please don't be so formal . '

Though Anna said that with a smile, he couldn't just change his behaviour because of that . Ishii sat on the sofa again with his back straight .

'It's because I didn't have any medical examinations today . I apologise for my attire . '

Anna said that while sitting in front of him . Unlike the calming clothes she had worn the day before, she had on a casual outfit of a white blouse and jeans .

It was mysterious – at first glance, the clothes seemed boyish, but they seemed provocative when she wore them .

He could just see her bra because her blouse was unbuttoned down to her chest .

It was too much for Ishii, who had no immunity against things like this . He didn't know where to look so he stared at the coffee cup in front of him .

'Is something the matter?'

While Anna said that, she touched Ishii's arm and peered at his face . There was a sweet scent .

'I'm fine . It's nothing . '

Ishii leant against the back of the sofa and put distance between him and Anna .

This was no good . Somehow, he couldn't focus in front of this person .

'You're alone today . '

Anna's almond eyes looked at Ishii from behind long eyelashes .

'Yes . Detective Gotou has another case . '

'I've heard that it was a rule for detectives to work in pairs, but it seems that isn't the case . '

Just as Anna said, the rule was to work in twos, but rules didn't work on Gotou .

'Today is an exception . Detective Gotou had something that he had to do . '

Ishii quickly made an excuse . It would be troublesome if she mentioned it to the higher-ups .

'I see... So why are you here today?'

At Anna's question, Ishii hurriedly tried to take his notebook out of his suit, but he fumbled and dropped it .

'Ah, actually, I was going to explain what we have found out from the investigation . '

Ishii quickly picked up the notebook .

'Are you all right?'

'Please forgive me . I'm actually here to request your opinion on the matter...'

'Ishii-san . Have you been worrying about something recently?'

Anna interrupted Ishii .

When he looked at Anna's eyes, which were looking straight at him, it felt like his mind would slip far away from him .

'I-I wonder? I don't think I have any...'

Anna's fingers touched Ishii's hands, which he had clenched into fists in his nervousness . Ishii's body shivered like an electric pulse had gone through it

.

'I am an expert . Please don't restrain yourself . '

'N-no, I'm really not . '

Ishii's forehead felt sweaty .

It was the first time Ishii had been touched by a woman like this .

'Are you pushing yourself too much at work?'

'No, that's...'

Just as Anna said, he really was pushing himself . He frantically chased after Gotou – but he always messed up .

He couldn't help but dislike the person he was .

'There is no need to hide it . '

Anna placed her palm on Ishii's shoulders . His stiff shoulder relaxed in that warmth, like melting ice .

'I see... a dream . '

Ishii opened his mouth unconsciously .

'What sort of dream?'

'A very frightening dream... In a dark place, I run after Detective Gotou frantically, but I can't catch up at all . Just when I think I have...'

Ishii's words caught in his throat partway .

If he said what came next, he had a vague fear that it would become true .

'Ishii-san, it is only a dream . What happens afterwards?'

Anna smiled, like she had sensed Ishii's feelings . He felt relieved .

That's right . This is a dream –

'When I catch up, Detective Gotou... is dead . '

'It seems that you are severely overworking yourself . '

Anna looked down .

'I-is that so...'

'Dreams reflect a person's mental state . Ishii-san, it appears that you want to become a person like Detective Gotou, but that has become a burden on your mind . '

He did want to become like Gotou, just as Anna said . However, he didn't think of it as a burden . If you asked him why, it was because he wanted to be like that of his own volition .

'I...'

Anna put a finger to Ishii's mouth, which had opened to object .

'Ishii-san, you are you . '

I am me –

That was obvious . However, it appeared he had forgotten that .

'Ishii-san, you are very competent . By trying to be somebody you are not, you are wasting your talents . '

'I...'

7

Haruka walked with her worries –

Though there was a problem, was it really all right for a teacher to involve herself so much with one student?

It might set the other children against him . However, that didn't mean she could leave him alone .

– You're a trainee teacher .

She suddenly remembered what Konno had said .

At the time, she had been very angry, but now that she thought about it again, there were things she couldn't deny .

She wasn't their official homeroom teacher – she was a trainee . She would be gone in two weeks . Even if she did all this now, she couldn't take responsibility until the end .

Haruka stopped once she reached the intersection .

When she looked up at the sky, she saw the clear blue sky, so unlike her emotions .

Masato's cold expression, inappropriate for a child, flashed across her mind .

He was obviously suffering . Haruka just couldn't overlook that .

I should stop grumbling . I'm not Yakumo, but I'll go take a look .

I'll just think about what comes next afterwards –

Haruka turned right at the intersection .

She saw a small children's park . About ten metres ahead was the apartment where Masato lived .

Haruka checked the map again as she stopped in front of the children's park .

I see it . That's it .

An old wooden apartment, portions of it had come off and the entire building seemed to be slanted .

Masato's flat was at the corner of the first floor . Haruka had planned on walking right up to it, but she hesitated when she saw that somebody was already standing in front of the door .

It was Komai . She was knocking on the door and saying something .

Something like that had happened, so Komai was probably also worried about Masato and had come to check up on him .

Haruka thought about calling out to her, but it wouldn't have been a good thing for Komai if her trainee teacher went to a child's home without the teacher in charge .

Haruka just watched from where she stood .

Finally, Komai gave up and turned around to start walking .

Oh no, she's coming this way –

Haruka quickly hid behind the public lavatory at the children's park . She let out a sigh of relief .

Rustle .

The bushes in front of Haruka shook unnaturally, though there was no wind .

Somebody's here –

She stooped and peeked behind the bushes .

'Masato-kun!'

When Haruka unconsciously called out, Masato put his finger in front of his mouth, as if to tell her to be quiet .

Haruka replied with a nod and squatted .

'Hey, why are you hiding?' asked Haruka quietly .

“Cause she came . ’

Masato stuck out his neck to look at the road .

'By she, do you mean Komai-sensei?'

Masato didn't affirm or deny it .

'Komai-sensei came because she's worried about you, Masato-kun . ’

Haruka said that admonishingly, but Masato looked away from Haruka .

'You don't know anything . ’

She felt like his small eyes were hiding something .

She'd heard something like that before .

It had been when she'd first met Yakumo . Haruka really hadn't known anything . However, she couldn't know anything if he wouldn't tell her anything .

'Just as you say, Masato-kun, I don't know anything . So tell me . ’

Masato froze at Haruka's words . His shoulders were shaking slightly .

He looked like a lamb afraid of a wolf .

'Hey, Masato-kun . ’

After saying that, Haruka touched Masato's shoulder .

'Let go!' yelled Masato, like he'd lost his temper, and he brushed Haruka's hand away .

'Masato-kun...'

'Don't come over here . '

Masato stood up and backed into the fallen leaves behind him .

'Hey, Masato-kun . '

'I'm cursed . '

'What do you mean by curse?'

'Don't come over here!'

At the same time as he yelled, Masato ran off .

What was he burdened with?

8

I don't feel like heading home right away –

Haruka arrived at Yakumo's secret hiding place in the back of Building B at the university, like she'd been drawn there .

Yakumo would just say something cynical if she met him, so why had she come?

Unable to come up with an answer to her own question, Haruka opened the door .

Yakumo, sitting in his usual spot, welcomed Haruka with a yawn .

'You really do have a lot of free time . '

She didn't feel angry at Yakumo, who was saying sarcastic things as always .

After sitting opposite Yakumo, she rested her head on the table, exhausted .

I wonder why? It's just a folding chair and a table that's like scrap wood, but I feel so relaxed –

'Hey, let me stay here for a while,' said Haruka, still on the table .

Yakumo didn't reply . Well, whatever . She'd stay here even if he said no .

'Hey, am I really meddlesome?'

She didn't expect an answer . She just wanted to say it .

'What, so you know?'

Haruka sat up and looked at Yakumo . He was reclining with a smile, as if amused .

'That's right . I'm meddlesome . '

Haruka's expression soured as she put her chin in her hands .

Yakumo stopped smiling and raised an eyebrow as he ran a hand through his messy hair .

'When I was in middle school, I had a teacher as meddlesome as you . '

It felt like Yakumo's eyes were elsewhere as he suddenly started talking .

How had Yakumo's time in middle school been?

Haruka made Yakumo wear a gakuran[2] in her head . Hm . It didn't suit him . She frantically held back her urge to laugh .

'What sort of teacher?'

'I just said – weren't you listening? The teacher was as meddlesome as you .
,

'And?'

'That's all . '

Even though Haruka wanted to hear what came next, Yakumo stopped there .

Maybe Yakumo didn't want to talk about it, but Haruka wanted to hear more .

'What did you think about that teacher, Yakumo-kun?'

Haruka continued her questions .

Yakumo frowned, looking troubled for once . Haruka still stared back at Yakumo .

After a while, Yakumo opened his mouth like he'd given up .

'I thought my teacher did pretty well . '

'Were you the teacher's pet?'

'That's not it,' Yakumo said curtly, looking away .

It looks like there are traces of tears in his eyes . I might just be seeing things though –

'I wonder what Masato-kun thinks of me?'

'He obviously thinks you're meddlesome and a pain in the neck,' replied Yakumo immediately .

He was the worst . Couldn't he have said something nicer?

'That's right . I'm...'

'I thought that teacher was meddlesome and a pain in the neck too . '

Yakumo interrupted Haruka's words .

'And?'

'I wondered why my teacher was trying so hard for a complete stranger – my teacher didn't know anything but did so much . '

In view of Yakumo's past, it made sense for him to think that way .

He might not have been able to believe somebody would selflessly do something for him .

'That's because your teacher was worried about you, Yakumo-kun . '

'Why?'

'That's your teacher's kindness . Your teacher couldn't leave a child in pain alone . '

After he heard Haruka's words, Yakumo's shoulders relaxed and he smiled slightly .

So Yakumo could smile like that too . That was what Haruka's mind was strangely preoccupied with .

'My teacher was kind . But I couldn't understand that simple kindness . '

There, Yakumo paused and looked up at the ceiling, like he was thinking about something .

Maybe he was thinking about his teacher .

'I learnt about selfless kindness from that teacher . '

Yakumo slowly looked at Haruka .

What sad eyes –

'That boy called Masato is probably afraid too . Without knowing your true intentions . '

She had no basis for it, but she felt like Yakumo and Masato were similar .

'True intentions?'

'Yes . So you should just teach him . About selfless kindness . '

Yakumo stopped there .

Taking in the slight kindness shown by Yakumo, who was normally blunt and unparalleled in his contrariness, Haruka nodded .

9

When Gotou returned to the station, it was already past ten .

He was able to find a firefighter who had been at the scene twenty-eight years ago and ask what happened, as Yakumo had asked him to .

The elderly man had just retired last year and might have had a lot of free time, since Gotou ended up having to listen to a number of war stories that he hadn't wanted to hear .

Gotou sank into the chair and lit his cigarette .

He was exhausted . The only good thing was that the firefighter's memories had been clear even though the event had happened so long ago .

He glanced over at the seat opposite him .

Ishii wasn't there . If he had just been going to talk to Anna, it shouldn't have taken so long . He couldn't have ended up getting counselling himself, right?

Maybe he'd call him . Just as Gotou picked up the phone, the door opened .

He thought it was Ishii, but he was wrong . The one who came in was Miyagawa .

'Hey . You look tuckered out . '

As Miyagawa said that, sounding amused, he walked briskly up to Gotou .

The way he swaggered was just like a hoodlum's .

'Whose fault do you think that is? It's already been three days . '

Miyagawa smirked as he saw Gotou grumbling with his loosened necktie .

'If you can still talk so much, you're fine . So what's happened with that lady doctor?'

'There's been no progress after that . '

'That so...'

Miyagawa was fidgety, which was unlike him .

'What is it?'

Gotou was no good with atmospheres like this . He urged Miyagawa to continue .

'When you discovered the corpse at the school, you said you got a report from a civilian . '

'Yes, I coincidentally ran into a friend . '

'Could that acquaintance perhaps be the kid who can see ghosts?'

Why does Miyagawa know about Yakumo –

Gotou was only confused for a moment .

Miyagawa had met Yakumo before . He had seen that power during the case that occurred six years ago .

Now that he thought about it, that was the first case he'd solved with Yakumo .

'That's right . That's the brat . He's a university student now . '

'Already, eh... I'm getting old . '

Miyagawa laughed, sounding embarrassed .

Gotou also felt sentimental as he thought of Yakumo in middle school .

Yakumo had denied everything in the world then . He had even wanted his own existence to disappear .

He'd had the eyes of a dead fish . But he's different now –

'Though we don't know anything for certain yet...'

Miyagawa's slowly spoken words brought Gotou back to reality .

'What is it?'

'We know the identity of the burnt corpse . '

They'd done pretty well with what they'd had .

Yesterday, he'd heard that even the bones had turned to charcoal . In that situation, it'd probably be difficult to check the DNA with the dental records, let alone fingerprints .

'So who was it?'

'Tobe Kengo . '

The name Miyagawa said shook Gotou's mind .

Why'd the guy who escaped end up burnt to a crisp there –

It was unnatural . That was what Gotou felt . He didn't have any basis for it . He felt it instinctively .

'What do you mean?'

'The corpse . The left hand didn't burn, right? The fingerprints matched Tobe Kengo's exactly . '

'Then, in any case one thing's wrapped up,' said Gotou, though he didn't mean it .

'Well, that's how it is . Tomorrow morning, the chief of the police is going to meet with the press, saying that we don't know why he died but it's likely he committed suicide . '

Making announcement at this stage seemed premature, but Gotou understood that they wanted to stop the media from ganging up on them for letting a murderer escape as soon as possible .

Looks like Miyagawa doesn't agree though . It feels like there's more to this story –

'So what are you telling me to do?'

With a laugh, Miyagawa said, 'You're sharp,' and he continued with what he had to say .

'I heard about the autopsy, but according to Hata-san, it's impossible for people's bodies to burn up like that normally . '

'Yes, that seems to be the case . '

Gotou had heard that too yesterday .

'I can't think of this as the work of a person . '

'Not the work of a person?'

Gotou furrowed his brows at Miyagawa's extraordinary statement .

'That's right . Ghost or demon or whatever . It's something we don't know about . '

'You're joking, right?'

'I'm serious . But I'm only saying this 'cause it's you . If I said this to the other guys, they'd think I was going nuts . '

Well, it made sense .

If the investigation team say their chief stand in front of them and say something like 'The culprit is a demon', it'd be a joke .

'Could you be telling me to investigate?'

Miyagawa nodded .

'The investigation's still going to go on to find out the truth, but the team's going to be cut down and it's just going to be an investigation on paper . But I want to know . What happened there?'

'I want to know as well, but it isn't something that we can do on our own . '

When Gotou flared up, Miyagawa's lips turned up in a smile .

'Don't you have an expert cooperating with you?'

So that was how it was . Gotou finally understood why Miyagawa had brought up Yakumo .

Set a thief to catch a thief . So he was telling him to use Yakumo to find out the truth .

Miyagawa had misunderstood Yakumo though . Yakumo could see the spirits of the dead . However, that was all .

He couldn't do things you'd see in a manga like use spiritual powers or exorcise spirits . The person said so himself, but he didn't have any exceptional power – just the ability to see them .

Gotou was troubled as to whether he should explain, but he finally stopped . He could tell Miyagawa would just say something like 'It's the same, right?' . Plus, he didn't think he could explain properly .

'I'll do what I can . '

'Appreciate it . '

He was probably satisfied with Gotou's answer . Miyagawa stood up and quickly headed for the door, but he came back like he'd remembered something .

'I forgot . I have one more request . '

After coming this far, getting one or two more requests didn't make much of a difference .

'What is it?'

'Truth is, the police have to hold a meeting for the children's guardians tomorrow afternoon . '

'You can't be asking what I think you're asking . '

He didn't want to . Standing up in front of people to explain something? Was he kidding? PR could do that .

'I'm counting on you,' Miyagawa said, and then he escaped from the room .

Somehow, Gotou felt ill at ease .

'I saw Chief Miyagawa run out, but did something happen?'

Changing places with Miyagawa, Ishii returned to the room .

'He just had something to talk to me about . '

Gotou looked up, feeling exhausted .

'What sort of talk?'

'A talk about how we're going to work through the night again today . '

'Eh!? Again?'

Ishii threw his head back in exaggerated surprise .

10

Gotou visited the university in the morning .

He instructed Ishii to wait in the car and then headed for Yakumo's secret hiding place .

When he opened the door, Yakumo wasn't where he was usually – instead, he was sleeping in a sleeping bag in the corner of the dark room .

He looked so damn comfortable . Unfortunately, Gotou wasn't nice enough to let him sleep like that .

Gotou stooped over, put his face close to the sleeping Yakumo's eye and took in a deep breath .

'Oi! Wake up!'

In response to Gotou's voice, Yakumo's body jolted up like a fish hooked out of water .

That was payback for how he always acted . Served him right .

Feeling pleased with himself, Gotou sat on the chair and waited for Yakumo to get up .

'Please don't speak so loudly in the morning . It is troublesome for the neighbours,' said Yakumo, his eyes still closed as he stayed in the sleeping bag .

'You're the only one who'd live in a place like this . '

'Going to somebody's home without permission is trespassing,' said Yakumo, still wrapped up in his sleeping bag .

He had quite the mouth for somebody who'd just woken up .

'Living somewhere without permission is called unlawful occupation . '

After Gotou made that retort, Yakumo started squirming around .

Gotou thought that Yakumo was finally getting up, but he had been completely wrong . Yakumo took out his mobile phone and started dialling .

'What are you doing?'

'I'm calling the police . To tell them there's a trespasser . '

Yakumo replied to Gotou's question while rubbing at his eyes .

This guy was really calling .

'You're not going to stop!?'

Gotou snatched the mobile away from Yakumo .

<Is anything the matter?>

He heard a voice from the other end . The call had already gone through . Damn . What a frightening guy .

'This is Gotou from the Setamachi precinct . Called the wrong number . Don't worry about it . '

Gotou say that one-sidedly and hung up .

'What is it called when you've done something bad?'

Yakumo sat up and ran a hand through his bedhead, which was even messier than usual .

'Shut up! How would I know!?'

'I see . Good night . '

Yakumo tried to return to his sleeping bag .

Damn . He was such a pain when he sulked .

'Ah, wait . My bad . Sorry, sorry . '

Gotou hurriedly apologised, which made Yakumo stop for a moment, but then he shook his head like he was dissatisfied and went back into his sleeping bag .

'Gotou-san, is that how your parents taught you?'

What a comment .

His impulse was to hit Yakumo, but they'd get nowhere if he made Yakumo's mood any worse .

'I-I apologise . '

Gotou bowed his head while bearing with the humiliation .

'So you can do it if you try . '

After Yakumo nodded in satisfaction, he finally got out of the sleeping bag and sat in the chair opposite Gotou after yawning .

Rather than his usual shirt and jeans, he was wearing a navy jersey on top and bottom .

He looked at Gotou while mumbling incoherently . It made Gotou doubt whether Yakumo was really awake .

'So what do you need from me this early in the morning?'

Yakumo rubbed at his eyes like a cat .

They'd wasted some time with a boring exchange . He'd bring up the topic at hand now .

'We found out the identity of the body . '

Yakumo stopped moving and his gaze became sharp .

OK . The monster cat took the bait .

'That corpse was Tobe Kengo . '

Gotou had thought that Yakumo would be a bit surprised, but Yakumo yawned and scratched his back, looking comfortable .

This guy . Didn't he hear him?

'So it's come to that...'

Just when Gotou was going to confirm Yakumo was listening, Yakumo said that sentence .

It wasn't like they were playing shogi, so it hadn't come to this or come to that .

'You're not surprised?'

Gotou decided to ask anyway .

'Would being surprised solve the case?'

'That's not what I'm say...'

Gotou stopped himself . Yakumo was scratching at his neck while holding back a yawn . He wouldn't listen to what Gotou had to say . As Gotou had thought, he was more of a dog person .

'So, Gotou-san, what do you plan to do now?'

'Find out why he died . '

'Is that so? Do your best . '

He's playing dumb even though he knows –

No matter how much Yakumo didn't like it, Gotou wouldn't let him get away . He'd get him to stick with him until the end .

11

'Haruka-san . You OK?'

When Haruka went to work and got to the staff room, Komai's expression changed as she walked over .

'Ah, yes . I'm fine . '

After giving Haruka an evaluating look, Komai relaxed .

'Honestly . I was so worried . When I heard that you were the first person to find... It would've been OK if you didn't come today,' murmured Komai, like she found it difficult to say .

It would have been a lie if she said she hadn't been shocked . However, there was something weighing more heavily on Haruka's mind .

'I'm fine . I apologise for causing trouble . '

'I'm glad . '

Komai patted Haruka's shoulder with a smile .

Haruka was troubled as to whether she should ask about what happened yesterday, but in the end, she said nothing .

If she said it aloud, she would also have to explain why she'd gone to Masato's home .

Though the morning meeting was supposed to start soon, the staff room was not as calm as it usually was .

The staff members were noisy like children waiting for test results . It felt unreal .

There was no helping it .

Police were standing at the school gates, and a blue plastic sheet covered the area surrounding the pool .

The media were crowding about too – a number of microphones were thrust towards Haruka before she entered the school gates .

There was an incomparable atmosphere . It spread through the whole school .

'Silence, please . It is time for the morning assembly . '

The teacher on duty that day spoke up with a clap .

The staff members sat down, still noisy, and formed a circle along the walls . Konno, the vice-principal, stood at the apex of the circle .

He had his arms crossed behind his back and his eyes closed .

When the voices quieted and the room was enveloped in silence, Konno spoke .

'I believe everyone already knows, but on Saturday, a corpse was found on the school premises . '

Konno took a pause and glared at Haruka .

It was like he was saying it was her fault . Being treated like the culprit was depressing .

'Today's classes will go as planned . However, homeroom teachers should explain the incident to the children while avoiding direct expressions . '

The staffroom which had become quiet started to become noisy again .

Haruka wanted to speak up herself . If they avoided direct expressions, how were they supposed to explain to the children?

When she looked at Komai beside her, she was troubled too .

'Silence!' said Konno with intimidating force .

At the same time, the room silenced like a wave had come over it .

'Some of the children are shocked . Choose an appropriate response without overlooking that . '

I wonder what would be an appropriate response to somebody who thrust away a child –

The discomfort spread through the room .

'In the afternoon, there will be a briefing for guardians from the police . The PTA will contact them, but everyone should participate . That is all . '

After Konno said only what was required of them in that business-like manner, he briskly returned to his own seat .

Haruka just couldn't bring herself to like that person .

'Haruka-san, let's go . '

Komai patted the shoulder of Haruka, who was holding in her anger .

'Yes,' she replied, and they left the staff room .

'I'll talk about the incident,' said Komai as she walked down the corridor .

Haruka bowed her head and said, 'Thank you . ' Someone with as little as experience as her would not know how to respond .

'Komai-sensei, Ozawa-san . '

Yokouchi called out to them .

He had jogged over with a happy expression on his face .

'What is it?'

'There was one, right? A ghost . '

Yokouchi gave an agitated reply to Komai's question .

'What are you talking about?'

'An exorcist found the corpse . Right, Ozawa-san?'

Though she had expected this, Haruka didn't know what to do, so she nodded and replied vaguely, 'Ah, yes...'

'Please don't joke around . '

'I'm not lying . You should be careful too, sensei,' said Yokouchi meaningfully, and then he walked down the corridor with light footsteps .

Haruka knew that he was happy because he could prove what he said, but she felt he had gone a bit too far .

'I wonder if he's all right,' murmured Komai, sounding a bit stunned .

12

Gotou arrived at Hata's hospital with Yakumo and Ishii in tow .

They bypassed the entrance, took the stairs down to the basement, went down the corridor lit with fluorescent lighting and opened the door to the room in the very back .

In a space about six tatami in size, the desk and cabinets were lined up closely . The room was untidy as usual .

Hata was sitting at his desk and sipping tea in a carefree manner .

Gotou sat on the round chair – the only one for visitors in the room .

Yakumo and Ishii stood by the door .

'A noisy bunch has come again . '

Hata's greeting was rushed – he was obviously displeased .

People didn't say these sorts of things aloud, demonic old man .

Gotou changed the topic instead of objecting .

'Did you find out anything?'

'Is that the attitude you take when asking somebody for something?'

Though Hata kept complaining, he took a file out from his drawer .

'I don't know what you're expecting, but there hasn't been much progress . It's the first time I've seen a corpse like this . '

Gotou recalled what he had seen at the scene . Pitch-black charcoal in the shape of a human being – that was what he honestly thought .

'And?'

'Seems they've determined it's Tobe Kengo from the fingerprints, but looking at the body, everything's unclear – age, gender, cause of death, when he died . To say more, from the autopsy, it's unclear what caused the fire too . We've sent in a request to the fire lab . Well, that's where we are . '

'Oi!'

Gotou got up from his chair and yelled .

'Do you have a complaint?' said Hata, unabashed . Gotou had a mountain of complaints .

'In the end, you don't know anything . I came all this way, but it was just a waste of time . '

'You're the one who came without checking . '

He stabbed him where it hurt .

'Shut up . There's no progress 'cause you don't do your work properly . '

'You don't understand . The corpse is in that condition . Estimated time of death is something we find out from bone analysis or rigor mortis . With that corpse, we can't do anything . '

What Hata was saying made sense .

However, if they didn't know the cause of death, it meant they didn't even know whether it was suicide, murder or natural death .

'Hata-san . Do you know about spontaneous human combustion?'

The one who interrupted was Yakumo .

His arms were crossed, and, though he didn't look troubled, it felt like he had thought of something .

'Of course . '

'I know about it too . '

Ishii spoke up after Hata .

However, Gotou didn't know about it . It was the first time he'd heard the phrase .

'What? What is that?'

'By the blast of God they perish, and by the breath of his nostrils are they consumed – '

Ishii replied to Gotou's question .

Contrary to how he usually was, there appeared to a sparkle in his eyes behind his glasses .

'What is that? It sounds like some spell . '

He felt like he was even more confused .

'It's a line from the Book of Job in the bible . '

'Bible?'

Gotou felt like the conversation had derailed .

'Ishii-san, it's a bit of a jump to mention the bible now . Please put that aside for now,' said Yakumo as he ran a hand through his hair .

'So what is it?'

Gotou looked at Yakumo and repeated his question .

'Spontaneous human combustion is, as its name suggests, the phenomenon wherein the body of a human being suddenly burns up in a place with no sign of fire . There have been a number of reports of it in the past . It is rather famous in those circles . '

The way he said 'those circles' is a bit odd –

'So you're saying this has actually happened?'

'Yes . Though not in Japan, there have been reports in places such as America, England and Italy . There are many stories, such as how it was due to plasma or alien invasion,' replied Ishii, sounding incredibly interested .

When this guy talked about it, it sounded really suspicious . Hadn't he just read too much stuff about the occult?

Gotou looked at Yakumo suspiciously to confirm .

'What Ishii-san says is true . '

Yakumo understood what Gotou was doing and answered clearly .

'That's idiotic . So you're saying that Tobe suddenly burned up and died from that spontaneous whatchamacallit?'

'You're making a leap in logic . '

'Eh?'

'I just want to say that the condition of the corpse matches the characteristics of spontaneous human combustion,' said Yakumo disinterestedly .

He was different from the likes of Ishii . He eliminated his preconceptions and analysed .

'Characteristics?'

'Yes . There are three main characteristics of spontaneous human combustion . The first is that the body ignites in a location with no sign of fire . The second is that the fire does not spread to the surroundings . Then the third is that even the bones of the body are burnt,' explained Yakumo, putting up one finger at a time .

Gotou understood now . Tobe's corpse fulfilled those three characteristics .

'That caught my interest too . Just as Yakumo-kun says, there are many common features . However, if we acknowledge that, this case becomes the entrance to a maze,' said Hata, drinking his tea leisurely .

'Entrance to a maze? What do you mean?'

'Even now, we still don't know the truth behind human combustion . '

After Hata said that, he giggled with shaking shoulders . The old man was really creepy .

A heavy silence spread through the room –

After a while, Yakumo put his left index finger to his brow . There was energy in his eyes .

It seemed he had thought of something . Gotou waited for Yakumo to speak .

'Hata-san . There's something I would like you to look into . '

'Ask away . '

Hata nodded .

'This is just my reasoning, but I think it could have been adipocere . '

'Adipocere... I see; that'd make it possible . '

Hata hit the table like everything was suddenly clear to him .

What the hell were they talking about so suddenly? Who was this Addie guy –

Gotou's mobile phone rang, interrupting Gotou's confusion .

'What!?' answered Gotou, clearly irritated .

<That's quite a response . >

Miyagawa was on the other side .

'What? Is it Miyagawa-san? What do you need?'

<Honestly . Don't ask me what I need . Don't tell me you forgot . >

'Eh? What are you talking about?'

<You're supposed to explain the case at the school today, right?'

Shit . He'd completely forgotten . He looked at his watch . There were only ten minutes before the set time .

'I'm going there now . '

Gotou said that one-sidedly and hung up without waiting for a response .

'Oi, Ishii! We're going!'

'Going – where to?'

Ishii had a blank look on his face .

'The school, obviously . '

'The school?'

Unfortunately, he didn't have the time to explain in detail now . Gotou dragged Ishii out the room by the ear .

'Gotou-san, if you're heading to the school, please take me with you as well . '

The one who spoke was Yakumo –

13

Haruka peeked in from the side of the gymnasium stage to see how things were going .

There were an amazing number of people . Even though they had put out all the chairs they had, it still wasn't nearly enough and there were people standing and people peering in from outside since they couldn't get in .

However, there was nobody at the podium and the stage was deserted .

Somebody from the police was supposed to come explain the incident, but it was already twenty minutes past the scheduled time .

The guardians who had gathered would probably get tired of waiting soon .

'Hey . '

Somebody suddenly hit Haruka's shoulders, which made her body jolt . When she turned around, somebody she hadn't expected was standing there .

'Y-Yakumo-kun . What are you doing here?'

'I'm a chaperon today . '

Yakumo turned around . Gotou and Ishii were there .

'Could the detectives who are explaining the situation to the guardians be...'

'It seems that way,' replied Yakumo with a shrug .

'As it appears the police have arrived, we will leave the explanation to the detectives . '

Yokouchi, standing under the stage, spoke into the microphone .

The noisy gymnasium quieted down like they had been splashed with water .

Gotou and Ishii were talking about something . It looked like children were joking around, and not at all like they were reflecting on their late arrival .

'Now, Detective Gotou from the Setamachi precinct, if you would . '

With Yokouchi's words as the signal, Gotou pushed Ishii forward forcefully . Ishii stumbled from the side of the stage to the podium and – he fell .

It was laughable, but unfortunately, the atmosphere didn't allow for that .

Only Ishii smiled stiffly as he got back up .

'Ishii, good luck . '

Gotou sent a quiet yell Ishii's way .

'Wait, Gotou-san . Aren't you the one who's going to explain?'

Haruka approached Gotou, surprised by his outrageous behaviour .

'It's fine . The people here won't be able to tell Gotou from Ishii . '

'That isn't the problem . '

Gotou snorted and crossed his arms . Honestly, how selfish .

Ishii hobbled towards the podium like he had given up and stood in front of the microphone .

'I-I-I am the detective naaamed...'

Ishii's voice cracked as he started speaking, and his pronunciation and intonation were completely off .

When Gotou heard that, rather than being worried, he laughed aloud .

Ah, this is a mess –

When Haruka sighed, Yakumo pulled at her arm .

'The boy who can see ghosts . Could I meet him?'

He'd said that he was Gotou's chaperon, but that was the true reason Yakumo had come here .

Haruka wanted Yakumo to meet Masato directly if possible, but –

'Classes are already over today . He might've gone home already...'

'I see...'

'But want to try looking anyway?'

'Yeah . There's something I want to look into too . '

Haruka and Yakumo left the gymnasium without anybody noticing .

She walked with Yakumo through the passage and went into the school building .

When she walked next to Yakumo in the school like this, it made her feel like she'd returned to her days as a student .

I wonder if Yakumo walked around the school next to somebody like this when he was a student –

She wanted to know, but she didn't want to imagine it . What on earth was she thinking? She felt like her face was getting warm all of a sudden .

They went down the corridor and took the stairs up . When they reached the first landing, Yakumo suddenly stopped .

His gaze was on a picture –

A wilted cherry blossom tree was drawn in it . If Haruka remembered correctly, it had been selected for a school picture contest .

'What is it?'

With a bitter smile, Yakumo replied, 'It's nothing,' and then he continued going up the stairs .

They went up to the fourth floor and stepped into the classroom for Class 5-4 .

There was nobody in the classroom .

'This is my class . '

Yakumo entered the classroom silently and looked around with his arms crossed .

Haruka peered at the fish tank in the corner of the room .

There were three killifish – Hey, do you know where Masato-kun is? Of course they don't know .

'Which is his seat?' said Yakumo .

'The third from the back in the row by the window . '

Yakumo walked up to that seat and sat down in the chair too small for his body . He touched the desk with his palm slowly, like he was checking something .

'Curse...'

Yakumo furrowed his eyebrows .

'Curse?'

'Here . '

Yakumo pointed at part of the desk .

When she glanced at it, she saw the word 'Curse' written on it .

It hadn't been written with a pencil or pen but scraped into the desk with something sharp .

Haruka remembered how Masato had been using a compass needle to carve something during class .

Was he doing this –

Ignoring Haruka's surprise, Yakumo put his chin in his hands and looked out the window .

Yakumo might have looked out the window the same way when he was an elementary student, with much too horrible a reality on his shoulders –

Haruka wondered what she would have done if she had been in the same class as Yakumo .

What would she have said when she saw him staring out the window?

She might have been swept up by her surroundings and ended up hating him without trying to see who he truly was . Though they had met differently, the emotions after that would change so much .

Even though we're all human beings, why can't we understand each other –

'Found him . '

Haruka was brought back to reality by Yakumo's voice .

'Do you mean Masato-kun?'

'Yeah . '

'Where?'

Haruka looked up, but didn't see anybody, let alone Masato .

'On the roof . '

Yakumo raised an eyebrow .

'The roof?'

There was no way he could have seen the roof from inside the building .

'Look out the room . '

Yakumo pointed out the window . Haruka followed the finger with her eyes .

She saw the pool where the corpse had been found . It was still covered with a blue plastic sheet, and there was detectives standing guard .

However, Masato was nowhere to be found .

'The shadow,' Yakumo said, perhaps sensing her confusion .

Shadow –

'Ah! There!'

Haruka finally understood what Yakumo was saying .

The school building cast a shadow between the pool and itself, and there was definitely a person's shadow on the roof .

She couldn't tell who it was, since it was a shadow .

But it had to be Masato . She was sure of it .

'Let's go . '

'K . '

Haruka left the classroom with Yakumo .

14

Haruka opened the door to the roof . A dry wind touched her cheeks .

When she looked over, she saw a boy clinging to the fence with his backpack on .

There's no mistaking it . That's Masato –

His back, the same size as the other children's, was burdened with something .

'That him?' asked Yakumo quietly from beside her . Haruka responded with a nod .

Yakumo breathed out and then walked straight for Masato . Haruka followed with a little distance between them .

'I heard you can see ghosts . '

Yakumo stood next to Masato . He might have been surprised by how sudden it was, because his shoulders jolted before he looked up .

'I can see them too . Ghosts . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair, like he felt self-conscious .

'You don't know anything . '

With his hands in fists, Masato glared at Yakumo .

'Yeah, that's right . I just know your name . So tell me about you . '

Yakumo's tone was kind and consoling .

It was the first time Haruka had seen Yakumo talking this way .

'I'm cursed . If you're with me, you'll die . '

Masato raised his chin and said that while looking up . He'd said something similar before .

She hadn't thought about what the words meant before, but now that she thought about it, he might have actually wanted to play with everyone else .

However, he couldn't do that since he was cursed . Something bad would happen if he did .

He might have distanced himself because of that .

'I see . Actually, I'm cursed too . '

Yakumo crouched there and took Masato's hand to turn him around .

Masato looked away from Yakumo's gaze, seeming troubled .

'Let me tell you something good . People who are cursed can hang out together, no problem . '

Yakumo put his index finger to Masato's chest .

'That's a lie . '

Masato's body trembled, but Haruka could tell from where she was that his heart was faltering .

'It's true . I can promise that . '

Masato bit his lips at Yakumo's words . It looked just like he was trying to bear with pain . The expression didn't befit an elementary school student .

'It's true . '

Finally, Masato spoke with a cracking voice .

'You're smart . '

After Yakumo said that, he gently patted Masato on the head .

Masato stared at Yakumo's face . It was a child's expression .

While Haruka thought that it really was a good thing she'd brought Yakumo and Masato together, she also painfully understood how useless she had been, unable to do anything .

Yakumo was much more suited to being a teacher than someone like her .

'That's right . Let me tell you another good thing . '

'A good thing?'

Masato cocked his head .

'Yup . The way to lift a curse . '

'That's impossible . '

Masato shook his head with damp eyes .

'It's possible . You know, for curses . The person who's cursed didn't do anything wrong – the person who curses someone else is the bad one . So if you get the person who cursed you, the curse will be lifted . '

'Really?'

'Really . I'll get them for you, so tell me who cursed you . '

Though he looked troubled, Masato's lips slowly parted .

'Haruka-san, what are you doing there?'

Haruka turned around when she was suddenly called out to and saw Komai at the door .

What terrible timing . Komai appeared to notice that Masato was standing by the fence .

'Masato-kun too... what are you doing?'

Komai approached her .

Haruka didn't know how to respond and looked at both Komai and Yakumo .

Perhaps she was exasperated with Haruka who wouldn't say anything, because Komai walked up to Masato and Yakumo .

'Masato-kun, school's already over . What are you doing here?'

Masato's expression, which had relaxed earlier, became stiff again .

Komai gripped Masato's wrist . Right as she did that, Masato bit Komai's hand .

'Ouch! Hey, stop that . '

Komai pushed away Masato's face to get her hand away .

'Don't come near me . You'll die next!'

Masato pitched forward as he yelled that and pointed at Komai .

Haruka didn't hear Masato's words as a joke or random remark . She had no basis for it, but it echoed in her ears like a true prediction .

'You shouldn't say something like that so lightly . '

Shaking free from Komai who was admonishing him, Masato ran off .

Komai shook her head in exasperation and then looked at Yakumo .

This was bad . Bringing an outsider into the school building was a considerable problem .

I can't excuse him as an exorcist to Komai . What should I do –

'Who might you be?' asked Komai cautiously .

'I apologise for the late introduction . I am the subordinate of Detective Gotou, who came here today . My name is Ishii,' said Yakumo with an innocent look, and then he bowed . How did he have the nerve –

'I see . So you're a detective?'

Though Komai said that, she gave Yakumo an evaluating look .

She was probably suspicious . It made sense . It wasn't some detective drama – she'd probably never seen a detective in jeans and a shirt .

'There was something that caught my interest, so I requested that this civilian allow me inside . Would you like to make an enquiry?'

It seemed Yakumo had noticed Komai's suspicions, as he spread his two hands jokingly .

'No, that won't be necessary... Please excuse me . '

Komai probably felt awkward for being so suspicious . She left the roof as if running away .

Just as Haruka felt relieved, she also felt exhausted .

'How was it?'

After Haruka sighed, she walked up to Yakumo by the fence and asked him that question .

'Since I was interrupted, the conversation was stopped partway . I can't say anything right now . '

Yakumo leant against the fence and looked up at the sky .

If only there were a bit more time, Haruka thought .

A thin white cloud hung in the clear blue sky .

Yakumo pinched something like a white capsule between his fingers and raised it to his eyes .

'What is that?'

'The boy earlier dropped it . '

She hadn't noticed at all . Yakumo really was sharp .

'Is it related somehow?'

'Who knows? I'm going to look into that now . '

'That so . '

'Putting aside whether he can see ghosts or not, that kid is definitely hiding something and keeping it to himself . '

'I wonder what he's shouldering...'

'I don't know, but the truth is, he wants to talk to somebody about it . '

15

After Haruka saw off Yakumo and the others, she returned to the meeting room for trainee teachers to pick up her things .

When she opened the door, she saw Komai waiting there .

'You're heading home, right? Let's go together . '

Komai smiled . However, it was easy to tell it was forced .

It felt like she wanted to probe into what had happened earlier .

A number of things had happened, and time had passed, but Haruka's impression of Komai had changed .

Though I wouldn't know how to answer if you asked me how it's changed –

'Yes, let's . '

With trembling emotions in the pit of her stomach, Haruka quickly gathered up her things and followed Komai out the meeting room .

'What did you talk to the detective about?'

Once they'd gotten into the corridor, Komai brought up that topic .

Unlike her earlier smile, her tone felt pointed .

'I didn't... It was just because I had been on the scene that day...'

In the first place, Yakumo wasn't a member of the police . She couldn't think of a good excuse and felt awkward .

'What did you talk to Masato-kun about?'

Komai asked more questions .

'No, I had just been nearby and didn't actually talk...'

Of course that was a lie . She had actually heard everything .

Her palms felt sweaty . Her heart wouldn't calm down, and it felt like she was walking in mid-air .

'Why would the police talk to that child?'

Komai put a finger to her round chin .

Haruka was more interested in why Komai wanted to know so much .

It was natural for a homeroom teacher to be concerned if one of her students was talking with a detective, but Komai's attitude right now felt completely different .

If Masato talked, something disadvantageous to her would occur . She was trying frantically to hide it .

That was just what Haruka thought, but that was how she felt .

Maybe it has something to do with yesterday –

Though Haruka knew it was unjust suspicion, she couldn't stop herself from asking .

'Um, Komai-sensei . You went to Masato-kun's house yesterday, right?'

Komai gaped at Haruka .

'Why do you know that...'

Komai gripped Haruka's arms .

Her doubt was natural, but that confusion seemed beyond that .

'With what happened before, I was concerned . Since I had happened to be nearby...'

'I see . I felt the same as you . You've developed a sense as a teacher too . '

Komai let go of Haruka and smiled . Another forced smile –

'Is that so?'

Though she replied, that didn't mean Haruka had accepted Komai's answer .

'That's right . I think I've forgotten something . You can go on first . '

After Komai said that quickly, she turned on her heels and walked away briskly .

She's hiding something –

Haruka had no basis for it, but she had that suspicion .

But even if she thought Komai was hiding something, what on earth was she hiding? Haruka didn't know . While she thought about it, Haruka walked to the shoe cupboard, changed into her pumps and went outside .

Rustle .

The bushes by the pool were shaking unnaturally .

Haruka stopped and looked cautiously, when somebody came out from the shrubs .

Haruka immediately hid behind a pillar .

It was Konno .

He was holding something like a paper bag carefully in front of his chest .
After he looked around cautiously, he walked away .

The police had said nobody was allowed near the pool .

What was Konno doing there –

Haruka wanted to know, but she didn't think of calling out to stop him .

Ever since the corpse was found, strange things have been happening one after the other . I hate it –

Haruka walked away with a quickly beating heart .

Suddenly, she felt somebody watching her and looked up .

She saw a boy peering out from one of the windows on the second storey of the school building .

He had a carefree smile on his face as he gave a big wave .

She'd never seen him before . What class was he from?

Haruka was doubtful, but she waved back .

When she did, the boy disappeared like he had melted .

Were my eyes playing tricks on me, or was that –

While Ishii drove the car, he took a sidelong glance at Gotou in the passenger seat .

He was still laughing . He was telling Yakumo in the backseat about Ishii's huge blunder .

However, it wasn't funny to Ishii .

He had never disliked Gotou as much as he had today .

Ishii had been thrust in front of such a large audience with no explanation whatsoever – of course he couldn't explain the case, even if he was told to .

It had been really terrible .

It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say it was the most embarrassing moment of Ishii's life .

He'd made an unparalleled blunder .

It wasn't an excuse, but he'd been frightened to death .

He'd planned on talking as well as he could, but the words didn't come out . The guardians had made a clamour about that .

The abuse the guardians hurled had reverberated in his head, and then –

He'd fainted .

When Ishii came to, the gymnasium had been empty . There would definitely be a flood of complaints for the police after this .

His head hurt just thinking about it .

The only good thing was that Haruka hadn't seen that blunder .

'Oi, Ishii . You angry?' said Gotou as he wiped the tears that had come up from laughing too much .

'I'm not angry . '

Ishii gripped the wheel tightly . His driving was erratic .

'You are angry . '

'That's incorrect . It's just that because of what happened, many civilians now feel that the police are unreliable . I am concerned about that . '

'Just leave that be and it'll work itself out . '

'Detective Gotou, do you not think about anything?'

Ishii spoke in a voice so loud it even surprised himself .

'Oi, oi . You rebelling?'

'No I'm not . '

Gotou smirked when Ishii denied it .

'You're becoming more and more like a detective . '

Gotou poked Ishii's shoulders .

'Why do you think that?'

'You can voice your own opinions now . '

Putting aside whether voicing your own opinions made you a better detective, the reason he could do that was because of Anna's counselling .

It felt like his emotions were more erratic than usual .

'By the way, Yakumo . How was your side of things?'

Gotou turned to the backseat and changed the topic .

'Unfortunately, there have been no leaps in progress,' said Yakumo with a yawn .

Though he had refined features, there was no expression on them and Ishii couldn't tell what he was thinking .

He could tell a few things though, after knowing Yakumo for a few months .

Though Yakumo had said there wasn't much progress, that wasn't actually true .

Yakumo wouldn't give any vague reasoning if he hadn't gathered all the information .

However, in that head, he was putting together theories and running simulations while pursuing the truth .

'Then there's no point in the investigation . '

With or without knowing Yakumo's personality, Gotou crossed his arms in irritation .

'Gotou-san, how is the investigation I asked you to do?'

When Yakumo said that, Gotou opened the glove compartment, took an old booklet from it and threw it towards the backseat .

'While Ishii was unconscious, I got the teacher called Yokochin or something to get it . '

'Isn't it Yokouchi? Please at least remember people's names,' Yakumo remarked immediately .

'Stop being so fussy...'

'How about the matter with the firefighters?'

Yakumo continued speaking, ignoring Gotou's grumblings .

'Right . That's right . I forgot about that . '

This time, Gotou took a notebook from his pocket .

However, no matter how many times Ishii saw this, it felt strange . A civilian – and a university student at that – was using a detective for his own purposes .

Plus, that was a detective as high-handed and unconventional as Gotou .

Ignoring Ishii's thoughts, Gotou started explaining while looking at the notebook .

'On the day of the incident, according to what the firefighter who went to put out the fire said, it was already a sea of fire when they got there . One kid was crying outside . After they talked to him, they'd rushed inside they heard there were still two kids inside . '

It appeared that Gotou was talking about the fire that had occurred at the elementary school twenty-eight years ago .

'And then?' Yakumo urged .

'There were two kids collapsed inside, but they'd been able to tell that one was beyond help at one look . His body was burning . They saved the kid who was injured but still alive first . That kid was Tobe Kengo . '

'How did they know it was Tobe Kengo?' asked Yakumo .

'Seems the kid said so himself . Plus, he had a toy in his hand with his name on it . The dad confirmed it when he came too .

Gotou finished speaking and closed the notebook .

When Ishii glanced at the back mirror, he saw Yakumo pinching his brow with his fingers while looking down .

That was the pose he took when he was thinking .

To be honest, Ishii was often irritated by Yakumo's attitude and words .

He especially couldn't forgive how Yakumo acted towards Haruka .
However, nobody was more reliable for their ability to think .

Yakumo's peculiar perspective had brought many cases to their solution .

It was true that there were some cases they could have solved without Yakumo .

However, it would be difficult to say that they would have been able to solve it in the same amount of time . Lives had been saved because Yakumo was there .

'Gotou-san . There's something I would like you to investigate in addition to that . '

Yakumo raised his pale face like he'd thought of something .

'Oi, oi . Again?'

Gotou's cheek twitched as he spoke up, displeased .

'It's fine if you don't want to . It doesn't matter to me if the case goes unsolved . '

After Yakumo said that in his usual tone, he put his hands behind his head with composure .

When it came to this, there wasn't any chance of Gotou winning .

'Fine, fine . I'll investigate whatever . '

'Please say that from the beginning . It's a waste of time . '

Gotou was clearly angry at those words and shouted 'You bastard!' as he turned around and raised his fist towards the backseat, but Yakumo was calm .

'Detective Gotou, please stop it . '

Ishii gripped Gotou's shoulders and frantically tried to pacify him .

'Yakumo, I'll definitely punch you someday!'

Gotou left that childlike remark and turned back forward, but perhaps he had nowhere to turn his anger because he gave Ishii's chest a horizontal chop .

'Oof . '

Ishii coughed at the surprise attack .

What a hit .

'So what do you want me to investigate?' said Gotou recklessly .

Yakumo replied, 'Please look into the background of the father of the boy called Oomori Masato . I'd also like details about Ushijima Atsushi-kun's mother, Harue, as soon as possible . '

Where on earth is this case headed –

Ishii felt vaguely anxious .

17

Haruka couldn't fall asleep after getting in bed .

When she closed her eyes, a flashback appeared behind her eyelids .

The whispered rumour about ghosts . The burnt corpse they found when they'd gone to confirm whether that rumour was true –

Was Masato related to that case somehow?

Yakumo had said that Masato was hiding something . He'd also said that Masato wanted to talk about that to somebody .

I want to listen to him if I can .

Why am I trying so hard for Masato –

While pondering these things, Haruka turned over and curled up so she was hugging her knees .

It had to be because Haruka carried a shadow of her own –

The death of her twin sister, Ayaka .

Haruka's older sister had died because of her . However, she couldn't tell anyone and lived with that shut away in her heart .

Yakumo was the one who had listened to her .

Haruka had been released from her curse then .

If Masato was cursed like Haruka was, she wanted to release him from that .

– I'm cursed .

When Masato had said that, the sad expression on his face had looked like Yakumo's .

I'm probably overlapping Masato with Yakumo . That's why I'm so absorbed –

Interrupting her endless thoughts, her mobile phone rang .

Who could it be at this hour?

Haruka reached out a hand from her bed to pick up the mobile phone on the table . The number displayed on it was Yokouchi's .

There was the possibility that he was contacting her in an emergency . Haruka sat up and answered .

'Hello, this is Ozawa . '

<Ah, Ozawa-san . I'm sorry for calling at this hour, but...>

His tone was dark . She could guess just from that that it wasn't good news .

'What's wrong?'

<I was just contacted earlier, but... er...>

Yokouchi's unclear words invited irritation .

Haruka's heart started beating more quickly .

'What happened?'

<Komai-sensei... I heard that she passed away . >

'Eh?'

Haruka felt suspended, as if she had fallen from a high place, and the blood drained from her face .

She lost her strength and dropped her mobile phone unconsciously .

'Why... Why?'

<I don't know the situation . I heard she was found collapsed outside her apartment...>

Haruka recalled the scene on the roof .

Masato had pointed straight at Komai and proclaimed –

'You'll die next!'

I can't believe that became reality –

NOTES:

[1] Japan separates its rubbish into combustible, incombustible and oversize (among others; it's confusing) .

[2] A gakuran is one version of the Japanese male school uniform, usually black . HERE's one being sold by COSPA .

Volume 4 Chapter 3: VOLUME 4 - FEELINGS TO PROTECT

Chapter 3

VOLUME 4 - FEELINGS TO PROTECT

file 03: embers (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

At the morning meeting, the vice-principal Konno informed them that Komai had passed away .

However, Haruka just couldn't believe it was real . She had been talking to her just yesterday .

The business-like manner in which Konno stated the facts made it feel even less real .

Komai's flat was on the eighth floor of her apartment . The front door had been closed and it seemed that she had jumped from the veranda .

There were no signs of struggle and a note that read 'I'm tired' had been found, so it appeared to be an impulsive suicide .

Haruka had only worked together with Komai for a week, so it wasn't like she knew everything about her . However, she had been happy about her upcoming wedding . Would somebody like that kill herself –

Something might have happened with her lover .

Haruka was probably hung up because of what Masato had said .

– You’ll die next .

'Ozawa-san . '

When Yokouchi tapped her on the shoulder, Haruka returned to reality .

'Eh, ah, yes . '

Haruka raised her head, flustered .

'No questions, right?'

Yokouchi asked for agreement with an exasperated look on his face .

'Er...'

She couldn't think of a response because she didn't understand the point of the question .

'Honestly, please get a grip . Everyone's had a shock . '

Yokouchi normally felt gentle, but he was unusually irritated today .

'Please forgive me . '

'The vice-principal will inform the students . Other teachers will help out in shifts for class . Please look after the children in the classroom . '

'Yes, I understand . '

'Get a grip, OK?'

'Please forgive me . I just can't believe that Komai-sensei committed suicide...'

Haruka looked at her feet .

She knew that she had to keep her head up at times like this, but she felt like there was a weight on her head .

'I think it's possible though . '

Yokouchi said just that .

Haruka looked up at Yokouchi, surprised by his words .

'What do you mean?'

'Ah, Ozawa-san, you wouldn't know . '

'What about?'

'I've heard that Komai-sensei had an affair . '

'An affair?'

'I don't know the details either, but there was this whole rumour about how she'd had an affair with the dad of one of the kids . Maybe she was troubled because of that . '

'An affair?'

Yokouchi nodded .

Komai, who had been thinking about marriage, had had an affair –

Troubled because of the affair, she committed suicide . It sounded persuasive, but it felt like it just didn't link to Komai .

'Are you ready?' said Konno .

Yokouchi made his escape .

'Yes . Thank you very much . '

Haruka bowed her head politely towards Konno .

However, Konno didn't even reply and just looked at her scornfully .

She really couldn't bring herself to like this person .

Haruka buried her emotions in the pit of her stomach and left the room with Konno .

2

'Sorry to bother you . '

Gotou said that as he opened the door to the university <Movie Research Circle>, which was Yakumo's secret hiding place .

'If you know you're a bother, please leave immediately . Honestly, please don't make me say that so many times . '

Sleepy-eyed Yakumo was sitting in his usual seat while running a hand through his hair .

This time, he really did look like he hadn't gotten enough sleep . There were faint shadows underneath his eyes .

'Stop whining . I don't have the time to listen to you either . '

However, Gotou also hadn't gotten enough sleep .

He'd said that to get rid of the irritation he'd accumulated .

'What a coincidence . I also don't have time to waste talking with you . '

'What did you say?'

'The exit is over there . '

Yakumo pointed at the door with a yawn .

Damn, only his tongue was in good health . If Gotou talked to Yakumo any more, he'd just become more irritated . It'd probably be better to get the

point quickly .

'Old man Hata called . Told me to bring you too . '

'Is that so...'

Yakumo looked up at the ceiling in exhaustion and sighed, as if he were some young man in love .

Yakumo was probably troubled too, for once .

'So you have troubles like other people do too,' teased Gotou, since it was a rare opportunity .

'It makes me truly envious of you, Gotou-san, since you have no troubles . '

'I have troubles too . '

'About what to eat?'

This bastard –

'Of course not . '

'Then, about your wife running away . '

'My wife is at home... probably . '

Gotou hung his head and put his hands on the table .

He shouldn't have said anything . He felt exhausted now .

The truth was, he didn't know where to start with this case . It was suffocating .

This case was really hateful .

'What are you dawdling for?' said Yakumo as he suddenly stood up .

'Huh?'

'If we're going, let's hurry up and go . Or can you not move from hunger?'

'You making fun of me?'

'No, I'm mocking you . '

This brat –

Yakumo quickly evaded Gotou, who had leapt for him, and left the room .

After the case was over, he'd definitely give Yakumo a good punch .

* * *

Ishii thought over the details of what had happened so far while sitting in the driver's seat .

It really was an unsolvable case .

It should have been surprising for an escaped murderer to be found as a burnt corpse, but what was the most complicated was the state of that corpse .

Hata and Yakumo both said it, but was it spontaneous human combustion –

If it were, they probably wouldn't be able to get even a clue as to how to solve the case with the investigation methods they've used until now . They'd have to add experts to the investigation team .

Ishii conjectured that the possibility of alien invasion regarding spontaneous human combustion was extremely high .

They definitely burnt humans, bones and all, using weapons humans couldn't even think of .

They should bring the matter to NASA . He would suggest that to Gotou .

Just as Ishii's delusions were reaching a peak, the passenger door opened and Gotou came in . Then, Yakumo sat in the backseat .

He'd thought they wouldn't return for an hour, since that was the usual pattern, but they came back more quickly than he'd imagined .

'Start the car . '

'Ah, yes sir . '

Ishii started the car as told by Gotou .

'Gotou-san, how is the investigation I requested?' said Yakumo while looking out the window . He looked unusually tired .

'I've investigated a lot about Ushijima Harue . Still investigating that brat's dad . '

While Gotou started explaining, he took a file out from the glove compartment and threw it towards the backseat .

Yakumo started flipping through the pages silently .

Gotou began a supplementary explanation .

'Ushijima Harue . Fifty-eight years old . After graduating from high school, she worked at a hostess at clubs and bars, but she stopped in her early twenties . '

'The reason being?'

'I don't know the details, but it seemed she was kept by her lover . After quitting her hostess job, she didn't do anything like work . '

'And the person who kept her?'

Yakumo furrowed his brows .

'Still investigating . According to a woman living nearby, the guy would change . '

Gotou was talking like he'd been the one who'd seen it through, but Ishii was the person who'd actually investigated .

After returning from the elementary school yesterday, he'd gone to question people who lived near the apartment where Ushijima Harue lived .

You could find gossip-loving housewives everywhere .

They'd told him in detail about how she used to be a hostess, how a man that looked like a father would sometimes visit with his kid, and how another man – much younger – would go in and out too .

When he thought about how the neighbours were watching so closely, it was exceedingly frightening .

'Then how about Oomori Masato's father?'

'All I know is the place he used to work . '

'Which is?' urged Yakumo as he looked at the documents .

'Oomori Hironori worked at a bike repair shop . He was skilful, but the manager caused some problem and was arrested, so he lost his job . He started doing part-time after that . '

'Could that be when he got his divorce?'

'Ah, that's right . '

'I see...'

Yakumo's sorrowful eyes looked at the low car ceiling .

He's realised something – that was what Ishii felt .

Haruka went into the classroom for Class 5-4 with a hard expression and stood at the front next to Konno .

The children shouldn't have known about Komai's death yet .

However, it seemed they'd felt the unrest that flowed through the whole school, because the whole classroom was unsteady .

Haruka turned her eyes to Masato, who sat by the window .

He had his chin in his hands and was looking out the window, but his eyes were puffy like he had cried, and he appeared to be holding back his pain .

That child knows something –

'Silence . '

Konno raised his voice . It was no different from the tone he'd used to reprimand teachers in the staff room . The noisy classroom was blanketed in silence .

The children were waiting for Konno's next words as they looked right at him .

If it were her, how would she explain Komai's death to the children –

The death of somebody close to them . They would experience that sometime in their life, but they couldn't just throw that reality at children who were unprepared for it .

While Haruka was thinking, Konno cleared his throat and opened his mouth .

'Komai-sensei committed suicide . '

'Eh?'

Haruka said that without thinking and looked at Konno . He looked as arrogant as always –

Haruka couldn't believe it . How could he use the word 'suicide' of all things?

The children were noisy again .

There were some children talking among themselves, and some children, who already knew the meaning of the word, were shaking and had started crying .

'Sensei, what's suicide?'

Eri, who sat in front of Masato, raised her hand and asked that question .

'Suicide means killing yourself...'

'Vice Principal . Please stop it . '

Haruka couldn't stop herself – she grabbed Konno's arms and interrupted him .

'They'll find out eventually . What's the point in hiding it?'

Konno glared at Haruka, as if he were looking at something filthy .

Did he think that doing that would make everyone do as he said? She wouldn't yield to that arrogance . Haruka glared back at Konno forcefully .

'That isn't the problem . The problem is how you expressed it . '

'You're just a trainee teacher . '

Konno brushed off Haruka's hand .

'You're the vice principal – don't you understand the children's feelings?'

'Don't talk like you do!'

Konno's angry voice, inappropriate for a classroom, echoed .

At that, Eri covered her face with her hands and started crying . Maiko comforted her from the neighbouring seat .

'What's up with him?'

'He's so annoying . '

The children started criticising Konno .

'Silence!'

Konno raised his voice again as he hit the teacher's desk .

It didn't matter that this person was the vice principal . Haruka couldn't let him stay in the classroom any longer .

'Would you please leave the classroom?'

Haruka stepped in front of Konno and looked straight at his muddy eyes as she said that .

Even though she was trying to chase the vice principal out of the classroom, she wasn't nervous or afraid at all, to the point she even surprised herself .

Konno's breathing was ragged, having gone too far to back down .

'This conversation is finished, Vice Principal . Please leave . '

Haruka didn't take even one step back and said that firmly .

They glared at each other for a while, but perhaps Konno decided Haruka wouldn't back down, because he left the classroom with a click of his tongue .

The problem is what comes next –

Haruka went back to the front of the classroom and sighed as she looked at the children's faces .

'Everyone, listen to what Sensei has to say . '

To tell the truth, she didn't know what she should say in this situation, but she couldn't leave it as it was .

The children's hearts weren't mature yet . The injuries their hearts received now wouldn't heal through their whole life .

Haruka had experienced that herself .

– You can do it .

Next to her, Haruka felt like she heard Komai whisper .

4

After Gotou went into Hata's room, he sat on the only round chair in the room, as he had done last time .

Yakumo and Ishii stood by the wall and Hata sipped his tea at his desk . This was also the same as last time .

'Now, the wait is over . '

Hata rubbed his wrinkled hands together . He was just like a fly that gathered around excrement .

'Stop showing off and talk . '

Gotou crossed his arms . Hata let out his usual creepy giggle .

'As usual, the idiot is hasty . '

'What did you say!?'

Gotou leant towards Hata, but he didn't seem to care .

Yakumo and the old man – he really couldn't compete with them .

'Well, anyway, take a look at this . '

Hata laid out for photos on the desk, as if he was going to start playing cards . Everyone looked at them .

The photos on the desk were all of burnt corpses .

'Eek . '

Ishii jolted and let out a shriek .

'Shut up . '

Gotou hit Ishii's head and looked at the photos once more .

They were different from the photos of the scene they were at before, but the state of the corpses was very similar . Even the bones were burnt, and everything had turned into ash .

One photo caught Gotou's attention .

Though the body had turned into ash, the feet, with the shoes on, were left behind . This was incredibly like Tobe's corpse .

'Are these photos of that spontaneous human what's it you mentioned before?'

'Spontaneous human combustion . At least remember that . '

Hata shook his head melodramatically . The old man always got on his nerves .

'So does that combustion have something to do with this case?'

'Yes, that's exactly it . '

At Gotou's question, Hata smiled happily, showing his yellow teeth . This old man really was creepy .

But wait a minute . If that was the case, it would contradict with what they'd said earlier .

'Old man, the last time I came, didn't you say that spontaneous human combustion hadn't been explained yet?'

'That's right . Spontaneous human combustion hasn't been explained . '

Hata looked composed . What was the old man putting on airs for?

'Then isn't that a contradiction?'

Gotou stood up and stared down at Hata .

'Gotou-san, please calm down,' said Yakumo .

Normally, Yakumo should've noticed a contradiction like this first, but –

'I am calm . What this old man is saying is strange . '

'It isn't strange . Hata-san hasn't said that this case involves spontaneous human combustion . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair like he thought Gotou was troublesome .

'What?'

'Gotou-san, you asked whether spontaneous human combustion has something to do with this case, so Hata-san just said that it does . '

'That's the same thing, right?'

'It isn't . I said this before as well, but spontaneous human combustion has three main characteristics . Do you remember?'

'Yeah . '

Gotou nodded .

The fire started in a place with no sign of fire . The fire didn't spread to the surroundings . The whole body including the bones was burnt –

He knew that .

'The first characteristic of fire suddenly starting in a place with no sign of fire has not yet been explained, though there are baseless theories such as plasma and alien invasion . '

'So we don't understand it, right?'

'However, if we take away that first characteristic, we can explain it . '

'Ah, so that's what it is!'

Ishii seemed to have understood Yakumo's explanation because he spoke up while clapping his hands together .

However, Gotou didn't understand . Perhaps Yakumo thought Gotou looked pitiful as he held his head in his hands, because he supplemented his explanation .

'In short, it isn't clear how the fire suddenly starts, but if we think of methods which could burn a body including the bones without the fire spreading to its surroundings, it is possible under certain conditions . '

'Is that how it is?'

Finally, Gotou understood as well .

Nobody had seen the fire start with this case . So, they could put that aside for now and think about how the bones had burnt .

But they needed a temperature of over six thousand degrees to burn a body including the bones . Is that possible –

'Hata-san, I leave the rest to you . '

Yakumo handed the explanation over to Hata, crossed his arms nonchalantly and leant against the wall .

Hata nodded and began the explanation .

'I should have remembered the moment I saw the corpse . My memory's gotten worse with age . Also, burnt corpses aren't my forte . I like them raw . '

'Shut up! You perverted old man!'

Gotou rejected Hata's introduction, which was extremely indiscreet .

However, Hata didn't reflect on it – rather, he laughed in his creepy voice with shaking shoulders .

'Yakumo gave a hint when he said adipocere . '

'Addie what? Who's that?'

Come to think of it, they'd mentioned the same guy before .

'Honestly . Do I have to start the explanation from there?'

Hata's face was sullen, like he had eaten something sour .

'I can explain adipocere,' interrupted Ishii – maybe he couldn't keep watching .

'Ishii-kun, thank you . '

At Hata's words, Ishii walked to the centre of the room energetically .

'Adipocere comes from adipose, as in body fat, and cera, the Latin word for wax, like in candles[1] . '

Which makes adipocere –

'Body fat candles?'

'That isn't it . After a person dies, if they are left under specific temperature conditions, such as a hot and humid location, the fat decomposes, becomes fatty acid, binds with the calcium or magnesium in the water and the whole body becomes something like soap . '

'Soap?'

It didn't really fit in Gotou's mind .

'Yes . In that state, the human body becomes like a wax figure and can be kept in that shape without decaying . '

Wasn't this completely occult?

'Oi, old man!'

Gotou spoke up in disbelief .

'It's true . It's not sorcery or witchcraft – it's been proven in the medical field and is completely accepted,' said Hata as he sipped his tea .

Is that so – he hadn't known .

No, that was wrong . Though it made sense for Hata, Yakumo and Ishii were the strange ones for knowing something like this .

Well, in any case he understood adipocere now . However, he still didn't understand .

'What does that have to do with burning bones?'

'In order to burn a body including the bones, there are two methods . The first is burning the body at above six thousand degrees, as mentioned before . '

Hata raised a finger .

'And the other?'

'Burning the body at a low temperature for a long time . Well, it would be about ten hours . '

Ten hours –

'If there was a fire for that long there, it would've definitely spread to the school . '

Hata let out a creepy giggle at Gotou's objection .

'You know about candles, right?'

'Of course I do . '

'Wax wraps around the string that makes the wick . When you light the wick, the wax melts as the wick slowly burns . '

Even Gotou understood that . But –

'People aren't candles . '

'Gotou-san, you should study a bit more,' interrupted Yakumo as he raked his fingers through his hair .

'What did you say?'

'Just that your knowledge is inadequate, Gotou-san . The human body is built incredibly similar to a candle . '

'What do you mean?'

'You can think of the fat underneath the skin of the human body as wax and the clothes a person wears as the wick,' said Yakumo, as if it were obvious .

So the wick was on the outside? It was the opposite of a normal candle . When the clothes caught fire, that heat would burn human body fat and it would burn out like a candle .

'But would it be that easy?'

'If thinking about it normally, it probably wouldn't go that well, no matter how similar the two are . Though it was different in the past, the clothes that are supposed to make up the wick are now made of materials that are difficult to burn,' said Hata as he scratched his chin .

'Then it won't work, right?'

'Now we return to the topic of adipocere . '

Yakumo put his index finger to his brow .

'Adipocere...'

'The fat in that corpse had probably saponified into adipocere . '

'Ah!'

Gotou unconsciously raised his voice at Yakumo's explanation .

I see . The fat in the body decomposed by becoming adipocere, seeped into the clothes and made them easy to burn .

But –

'Why didn't the fire spread?'

Even if the fire started from the adipocere, there should have been other things to burn .

'It was a low-temperature fire,' replied Hata matter-of-factly . There he went again, using a term Gotou didn't understand –

'Explain . '

'You know that fire needs oxygen to burn, right?'

Hata was treating him too much like an idiot . Even an elementary school student would know that .

'Of course . '

'When there is a low concentration of oxygen, the force of the fire weakens and won't spread to its surroundings . '

Hata looked up at Gotou's expression .

Gotou replied with a nod .

'However, that doesn't mean that the fire is extinguished . Even if there is no flame, it continues to burn slowly . That's a low-temperature fire . '

Gotou recalled the pump room as he listened to the explanation .

A room surrounded by concrete underneath the pool . The humidity and temperature for the fat in a human body to saponify into adipocere . On top of that, the concentration of oxygen needed for a low-temperature fire .

Those elements brought about that burnt corpse .

Wait . That would mean –

'Doesn't that mean Tobe was already dead before he was burnt?'

'That's right . '

Gotou was surprised, but Hata spoke like it was obvious .

'So what was the cause of death?'

'I don't know . The corpse is in that state, after all,' said Hata readily . Well, it probably was difficult to decide the cause of death from that state .

'Then what caused the fire?'

'Have you forgotten? I'm employed as a coroner – not an investigator . That's your job, right?'

It was just as Hata said . Gotou was lost for words .

'Well, if there's nothing there to start the fire, somebody probably lit it,' said Yakumo with a sigh .

Gotou looked at Yakumo with a snarl, but Yakumo just yawned, not nervous at all .

This guy . Doesn't he understand the importance of what he said –

'If what you say is true, this is a murder . '

'Gotou-san, are you really a detective?'

Yakumo gave Gotou his usual mocking sidelong glance .

'Yeah, unfortunately . '

After Gotou spat that out, Yakumo shook his head, like he didn't know what to do with Gotou .

'I said that somebody might have lit the fire . I said this earlier as well, but that corpse was dead before it burned . Lighting it on fire would only be the mutilation of the corpse . Until we know the cause for death, we cannot determine that it was a murder . '

Ah, that was right .

There was nothing wrong with what Yakumo was saying, but that sort of irritated Gotou .

Gotou couldn't think of anything to reply so he just clicked his tongue .

'By the way, Hata-san . I actually have something I would like to request of you . '

Yakumo changed the topic, ignoring Gotou, who was sulking .

'If it's a request from you, Yakumo-kun, there's no way I could refuse . '

Hata let out a demonic laugh .

Yakumo took a white capsule from his pocket and handed it to Hata .

Hata looked at it under a fluorescent lamp .

'This is?'

'This is something that was pilfered from a certain person . I want to ask you to analyse its composition, but...'

Pilfered? Wasn't that a crime?

How did he have the nerve to be so shameless in front of the police?

'Normally, that would be out of my expertise, but I'll ask an acquaintance . '

Hata put the capsule in an envelope on the desk .

'So what are we going to do now?'

Yakumo and Hata both looked scornfully at Gotou, who was crossing his arms .

'What? Did I say something strange?'

'Yes, you did . Isn't it the detective's job to decide what to do next?'

Yakumo pointed at Gotou's nose .

This guy . Making fun of him . Even though he'd instructed him to do this and that so many times before . He just ran away when the situation was bad .

'Er... Detective Gotou . Could I suggest asking for Sasaki-sensei's opinion?'

Ishii interrupted while raising his hand like an elementary school student .

It appeared Ishii was enthusiastic about profiling, but Gotou was different . He just couldn't bring himself to like that woman .

'Well, it doesn't matter to me what method of investigation you choose, but please make sure to properly investigate what I asked of you,' said Yakumo, like it was none of his business . He rubbed at his eyes while he yawned .

'Then you help with the investigation too!'

'I would rather not . '

An immediate answer .

It felt like he was lost at sea . However, this always happened .

'Why not? It's not like you have anything to do,' said Gotou, still holding on .

'I am visiting a grave today . '

After declaring that, Yakumo left the room .

Honestly . What a transparent lie .

A man who can see ghosts visiting a grave? That's hysterical –

5

Komai's vigil was held at a funeral hall near the elementary school .

A number of teachers from the school attended, starting with Haruka . None of the children came . That was the decision of the Board of Education .

It appeared the suspicion that it was a suicide had had a great influence .

After passing the reception, Haruka sat on a chair in the lobby and thought about what had happened .

'Oh, I was wondering who it was – is that you, Haruka-chan?'

An enrobed monk waved as he approached .

Why would a monk know my name –

She thought it dubious, but that was only for a moment . When she saw the monk's face, she immediately understood .

A calm face that made one think of the Maitreya . On top of that, the red contact lens in his left eye .

It was Saitou Isshin, the chief priest at a Buddhist temple and Yakumo's uncle and honorary parent .

'It's been a while . '

Haruka took a formal bow .

'Was the person who passed away somebody you knew?'

Isshin had probably noticed from Haruka's expression, because he asked that with a stiff expression .

'Yes . I'm training at an elementary school, and she took care of me . '

'I see . I'm sorry for your loss...'

Isshin put his hands together and bowed his head .

'But seeing you made me feel a bit better, Isshin-san . '

'It flatters me to hear you say that . '

Isshin's narrow eyes became even narrower when he smiled .

It wasn't flattery – it was how she truly felt . Seeing Isshin's gentle face made her feel just a bit more at ease .

She hurriedly held back the tears that had welled up the moment she relaxed .

In order to change her mood, she purposefully let out a sigh, when she noticed somebody looking at her and raised her head .

Over by the crowd of people at the reception, there was a boy staring their way .

That's –

'Masato-kun . '

Haruka started walking towards Masato .

Why was Masato here –

It might have just been a wrong impression, but Haruka felt like he was trying to express something .

Just as they were almost close enough to touch, Masato noticed Haruka, took in a breath and backed up .

'Wait, Masato-kun . '

Masato turned around and ran off .

Should I chase him –

Isshin stood next to Haruka as she was lost for a decision .

'Is that child someone you know?'

'Yes . He's one of the children from my class...'

'That child...'

Isshin smiled awkwardly after he started speaking .

'What is it?'

'I thought that he looked similar . '

'Looked similar?'

'Yes . He looks similar to Yakumo when he was young . '

Isshin's gaze was far away . He was probably thinking about the past .

He was Yakumo's uncle and also the person who'd raised him, so Haruka felt like her thoughts weren't altogether wrong .

That child was shouldering something heavy, just as Yakumo was .

6

At Ishii's suggestion, Gotou visited Sasaki Mental Health again .

He sat on the same sofa as last time and looked at Anna .

The truth was he didn't really want to, but if Yakumo wouldn't do anything, it was true that Gotou had nobody else to rely on since thinking was his weak point .

'I want to hear what you think today . '

He'd come here already, so he'd get nowhere by griping . Gotou brought up the topic at hand .

'If I can be of any help . '

Anna smiled amiably .

Ishii had met up with Anna once without Gotou, but he couldn't tell how much information she knew .

It would be a pain to check, so Gotou decided to explain from the beginning .

At the elementary school that had a fire twenty-eight years ago, Tobe Kengo had been found as a burnt corpse and the cause of death was unknown .

However, they thought that somebody had started the fire after he died –

Also, Ushijima's mother seemed to think that her son was killed by Tobe, but she'd said that it was a good thing he died .

Anna listened silently, but when he said that the burnt corpse was Tobe, tears welled up in her eyes .

It had been in the news too, so it probably wasn't the first time she'd heard it .

It appeared that she felt guilty that he died since she had been the one to let him escape .

'In short, what I want to ask is who set Tobe's corpse on fire, in this situation . '

Gotou ended his explanation with a question .

'Would you mind if I smoke?'

After Anna excused herself, she snapped a cigarette filter with her fingernails and lit it .

She was probably trying to calm down . Her fingers were shaking slightly .

Gotou took his cigarette case out of his pocket so he could smoke too, but it was empty .

Damn . After Gotou crushed his cigarette case, Anna offered her own cigarettes .

'Sorry about this . '

Gotou took a cigarette from her case . Just as he put it in his mouth, she flicked open a lighter in front of his eyes .

A thin silver Zippo lighter .

Gotou stuck his face out so that his cigarette could be light . He felt sort of like he was in a cabaret club .

'I can't say anything at this stage . However, I believe that the person who lit the fire had a violent hatred towards Tobe-san and has some sort of attachment to fire,' said Anna, slowly blowing out smoke .

That made sense . Putting together what Yakumo and Hata said, the person had lit somebody who was already dead on fire .

Plus, they'd waited for adipocere to form . It wasn't normal –

'I have a guess as to who the culprit could be...' said Anna with upturned eyes after putting out her cigarette in the ashtray .

'W-what? Really?'

Gotou tried to keep his calm, but he raised his voice despite that .

'Yes . Though this is only a theory...'

'I don't care – just tell me . '

'It isn't a very difficult rationalisation . You should come to the same conclusion if you analyse the situation, Detective . '

Anna smiled mischievously .

She really looked a lot younger than she was . Gotou felt that all over again .

'Of course! That's how it is!'

Ishii hadn't said anything up until now, but he let out a shout and stood up .

'Sit down, fool . '

Gotou pulled Ishii's arm and forced him down . Ishii looked so displeased it was almost impertinent .

'Explain . '

Menthol cigarettes were really awful .

Gotou crushed the cigarette which still had more than half left in the ashtray and urged Anna to continue .

'Isn't there only one person? Somebody who holds a hatred for Tobe-san and has an attachment to fire...'

Anna avoided saying the name directly and gave another hint .

That hint was more than enough –

In Gotou's mind, there was the face of one woman .

A woman with flashy clothes and flashy makeup . She believed that her son was killed in the fire twenty-eight years ago .

So she got revenge by burning Tobe then –

'Ushijima Harue...'

When Anna heard the name Gotou said, her face stiffened and she drew in her chin . Though she didn't say it clearly, that response was sufficient .

Ushijima Harue –

Seemed they'd need to meet up again .

7

'Yakumo is coming home today too, so you should come by since you haven't in a while . Nao will be happy too . '

Invited by Isshin, Haruka walked to the temple at the top of the slope .

Maybe Yakumo would be angry that she had come of her own accord again, but so many things had happened and she didn't want to be in her room

alone . She also wanted to consult Yakumo about something .

After going to the living room in the priests' quarters, Haruka knelt on the cushion and thought over what had happened .

When Isshin came back with tea and sat down opposite Haruka .

He wasn't wearing his robes anymore – he'd changed into his working clothes . The impression Haruka got from him changed a lot depending on what he wore .

'I should have bought some sweets . '

After Isshin sipped his tea, he scratched his ear, seeming a bit embarrassed .

'No, I'm the one who's come at such a late hour...'

'Don't worry about it . I'm the one who invited you . Yakumo should be back soon, so don't be so stiff and relax . '

Isshin smiled . This person's smile had the mysterious power to easily calm someone's nerves .

He was completely different from Yakumo, who was cynical towards everyone .

Haruka relaxed and breathed out . Her stiff shoulders relaxed as well .

'It's unusual for Yakumo-kun to return . '

Yakumo almost never returned home, since he lived in the little prefabricated room at the university .

For Yakumo, who could see the spirits of the dead, this place with its graves was too noisy for him .

Yakumo had said this himself before .

'I'm only saying this because it's you, Haruka-chan, but today's is actually the anniversary of somebody's death . '

Haruka couldn't believe what Isshin had said .

She couldn't imagine Yakumo going to visit somebody's grave, when she compared it to how his usual speech and conduct .

Who on earth did Yakumo think so much of?

'Um, whose death anniversary is it?'

She couldn't stop her impulse of wanting to know, so she ended up saying that aloud .

'That's right . It'd be better to talk to you about it . That Yakumo will never talk about it himself anyway . '

Isshin's eyes narrowed as he thought about something .

Haruka felt like it was a warm and gentle memory .

'This was back when Yakumo was still a middle school student...'

Just as Isshin said that, the sliding door to the living room opened .

'Uncle, don't talk about unnecessary things without permission . '

Yakumo stood there with a displeased expression on his face .

'A little bit's fine, right?'

'No . '

Yakumo crossed his arms and shook his head at Isshin's needling .

It appeared that he didn't want her to know no matter what, but it was human nature to become more curious when things were hidden .

'You're so petty-minded . '

'That isn't the problem . '

Yakumo was being unusually stubborn .

'I'll let you know in secret from Yakumo next time,' whispered Isshin, so that Yakumo wouldn't hear .

'Why are you here anyway? I don't remember inviting you . '

Ah, an expected development –

In the past, she would have been seriously depressed, but she wasn't even surprised by it now .

'I invited her . '

'Why do you always do things like this without asking?'

Unlike Isshin, who had spoken nonchalantly, Yakumo was irritated as he objected while raking his fingers through his hair .

'This is my house . I can invite somebody if I want, right?'

You could tell Isshin had raised Yakumo . He wouldn't lose to Yakumo in an argument .

Haruka laughed without thinking at the amusing scene . Yakumo glared at her without a moment's delay .

Ooh, scary –

'Honestly...'

Now that he had been talked down, Yakumo bit his lower lip .

While they had been talking, somebody's face peered out from behind Yakumo's back .

'Nao-chan!'

It was Nao, Yakumo's niece .

Nao appeared to have noticed Haruka too, because a bright smile appeared on her face as she leapt towards her .

Rushed at by a seven-year-old girl, Haruka lost her balance and fell backwards .

Nao didn't seem to care as she moved her hands and feet about on top of Haruka's body . When Haruka saw that adorable smile, she felt happier too .

This child, who seemed so innocent at first glance, was burdened with heavy shackles .

Nao was deaf .

Yakumo said this before . People compensate for the abilities they're lacking with other abilities –

While patting Nao's head, Haruka said Good evening in her head .

– Good evening .

Nao's voice reached Haruka's mind .

Even if she couldn't hear with her ears, Nao could exchange words through her mind .

8

Tired from playing, Nao was asleep, using Haruka's lap as a pillow .

Nao had a smile on her face even while she slept .

'Oh, Nao's gone and fallen asleep . '

Isshin stood up to shake Nao awake .

'It's fine . Please let her sleep here,' replied Haruka, brushing Nao's glossy hair . Nao turned her head as if it tickled .

'Haruka-chan, sorry about this . '

'Please don't worry about it . '

'She's such a troublesome child . She's so pampered...'

It looked like there were tears in Isshin's eyes .

I wonder where her mother is –

That doubt suddenly came to Haruka . Now that she thought about it, she'd never seen Nao's mother .

Perhaps this child's mother is already –

'So what happened this time?' said Yakumo, interrupting Haruka's thoughts .

He'd seen right through her then . It appeared that she couldn't hide the emotions on her face .

'Komai-sensei passed away . '

She spoke in a quiet voice that was difficult even for her to hear .

She felt as if each time she said it, that truth became heavier .

'Would that teacher be the person we met on the roof before?'

When Haruka nodded, Yakumo's eyes narrowed as if he were staring at something bright .

It appeared that Yakumo was thinking about what Masato said too, even without her mentioning it .

– You'll die next .

'I don't know what I should do...'

Haruka knew herself that her voice was shaking .

She had planned on being psychologically stronger . Komai's death had been a shock, and she was very sad . But she'd thought that she would be able to withstand it .

But now that I'm in front of Yakumo, why –

Tears welled up in her eyes and fell onto Nao's cheek .

Haruka hurried wiped the tears away with both hands . Were they tears of sadness? Fear? Anxiety? Her shoulders shook with emotions she couldn't define herself .

'I'll let Nao sleep on the futon . '

Isshin picked Nao up from Haruka's lap .

'Sorry...'

'Don't worry about it . '

Isshin replied with a smile and took Nao, still asleep, out of the room .

Haruka frantically wiped away the tears that were welling up against her will and looked at Yakumo with her cloudy vision .

'I understand that you want to cry, but there's no time for that,' said Yakumo expressionlessly .

There was no sympathy at all for Haruka's feelings there . His tone was blunt .

'Time?'

Haruka snivelled .

'It's certain that that boy had some role in this chain of events . Our goal is to lift the curse on him . In that meaning, we don't understand anything yet .
,

Yakumo scratched the tip of his nose awkwardly .

She knew what he wanted to say next even without him saying it . Before they lifted the curse on Masato, it wasn't the time or place to cry .

Strict but kind words –

In her heart, Haruka said, 'Thank you . ' If she said it aloud, she felt like she would start crying again .

'Now, let's continue . '

Yakumo raked his fingers through his hair .

'All right . '

'First – why did that teacher die?'

'A suicide, apparently... it seems she jumped from her flat's veranda . '

She hadn't seen it herself, but in her head, she could see Komai, collapsed on the ground with blood flowing from her head .

'There must have been a reason to determine it was a suicide at this stage . '

That was Yakumo for you – he was accustomed to cases .

'There was a note in the room that read "I'm tired" . Also, this is just a rumour, but I've heard that she was having an affair... but to me, Komai-sensei didn't seem like she was so troubled she would try to kill herself . '

'Nobody can know for certain the reason somebody commits suicide except for that person . At this stage, it could be completely unrelated, for all that we know . '

Yakumo might have been right .

Everyone had different perspectives . Even if some people might find something laughable, for the person, it could have been troubling enough to commit suicide .

'Yakumo-kun, what do you think?'

'I understand a number of the tricks, but I haven't grasped the flow of everything...' muttered Yakumo, and he ran both hands through his hair .

'I see...'

'Twenty-eight years ago, there was a fire at the elementary school . I feel like that's the key, but...'

Yakumo looked bitter as he pinched his brow with his fingers .

'If it's about the fire twenty-eight years ago, I know a lot about it . '

The person who interrupted was Isshin .

It seemed that he'd put Nao to sleep and had returned at some time to the living room entrance .

Yakumo opened his almond eyes and looked up at Isshin .

Isshin didn't continue, instead sitting cross-legged with a nonchalant expression .

'Uncle!' said Yakumo in his irritation .

'You shouldn't be so hasty . '

'I'll listen to your scolding later . '

'You'd understand if you thought about it normally though . I graduated from that elementary school where the fire occurred . I was also in the same grade as Ushijima Atsushi-kun, the boy who died then . '

'Eh, is that so?'

Haruka's eyes were wide in surprise .

Isn't he the wrong age – is what Haruka thought, but now that she thought about it, she had never asked for Isshin's age .

She had just thought that he was much older because of his calm demeanour .

Which means Isshin is in his late thirties –

Haruka was stuck on that odd point .

'Why didn't you say that earlier?'

'You never asked me about it . '

Unlike Yakumo, who made a strong objection, Isshin wasn't concerned at all .

'Then did you know Tobe Kengo too?'

Yakumo threw that question out after swearing .

The murderer who killed his own father, Tobe Kengo –

When Isshin heard that name, his face become just a bit stiff as he nodded .

'Kengo-kun was a really good friend . I can't believe he'd turn out like that... Before that fire, he'd been such a gentle boy...'

As he reminisced, Isshin suddenly clapped his hands together like he'd remembered something, stood up and left the room .

'Honestly . Can't see the forest for the trees,' murmured Yakumo bitterly as he watched Isshin leave .

'Ah, sorry for the wait . '

Isshin brought an old album back with him, placed it on the table and flipped through the pages .

Haruka and Yakumo leant forward to peer at that album .

'Ah, about here . '

Isshin stopped flipping the pages .

It appeared to be a picture of a field trip . In the photo, there were children in gym uniforms wearing rucksacks .

'This is Kengo-kun . '

Isshin pointed at a photo .

There were two boys standing shoulder to shoulder . One was probably Isshin . His gentle expression hadn't changed even after twenty-eight years .

Tobe Kengo beside him had a gentle expression that wouldn't lose to Isshin's .

For this child to kill his own father –

Time really was a terrifying thing .

The faces of the children in her own class came up in Haruka's mind .

She didn't want them to turn out like that . Tobe Kengo's homeroom teacher must have felt the same way .

'Who's this?'

Yakumo pointed at another photo .

There were two other boys in that photo .

'This is Ushijima Atsushi-kun,' said Isshin as he pointed at the photo .

Ushijima Atsushi's face looked very similar to Tobe Kengo's, but his mood was the complete opposite . The shadow and light of the same thing . That was how it felt .

'His mother treated him awfully,' said Yakumo, his hands in tight fists .

'How can you tell?'

'Look at his arms and legs . Those are awful bruises . '

Just as Yakumo said, there were dark bruises on his arms and thighs . There was also a round burn on the back of his hand . That had probably been from a cigarette .

That's awful –

'But how do you know it was his mother?'

Haruka asked another question .

They could confirm that there were bruises, but it was difficult to say it was the work of the mother just from a photograph .

It could've been the father, and it could also have been bullying from the other kids .

'He doesn't have a father . Also, when Gotou-san met with his mother, it seemed she was incredibly prejudiced against her son . Though I hadn't thought she would go so far...'

Yakumo's expression was twisted to the point Haruka thought he might have felt unwell .

'I don't know the details either, but it's as Yakumo says . '

Isshin was the one who spoke .

'These injuries are already not that bad . When he took off his shirt to change into his gym uniform, sometimes his whole body would be covered

in welts . ’

'That's...'

Haruka's chest felt tight .

'Even if we asked why, he wouldn't say anything . He probably just took it silently . A kid that age would have nowhere to go but home...'

Isshin looked pained .

'Who's next to Ushijima-kun?'

Yakumo pointed at the other boy to clear the suffocating atmosphere .

'He's Oomori Hironori . ’

Isshin answered after checking the photo . The boy looked a bit like Masato
—

'So that kid's dad was also in the same grade... Seems possible . ’

Yakumo had a sharp look in his eyes .

What Yakumo said just now — so he really was Masato's father? The moment she looked at the album again to check the photo, Haruka saw someone else whose face was similar .

'The person in this photo...'

Haruka pointed at the teacher standing in the middle of the group photo .

'That's the homeroom teacher Konno-sensei . ’

Haruka swallowed her breath when she heard Isshin's answer . Was this just a coincidence —

'What is it?'

When Yakumo looked at the album, he immediately noticed Konno and furrowed his brows .

'This guy is the vice principal...'

Haruka nodded .

'Konno-sensei became the vice principal?'

'He's a pretty arrogant guy . How was he when he was your homeroom teacher?'

'Konno-sensei was always like that . He scolded me a number of times too . Plus, there were some girls who said Konno-sensei molested them...' said Isshin to nobody in particular as he scratched his chin .

'Tobe Kengo, Ushijima Atsushi, Oomori Hironori and the vice principal . For the people related to the case to all be present...'

Yakumo put his index finger to his brow .

9

Ishii was running –

He was frantically running after Gotou, but he couldn't catch up no matter how much he ran .

His back was drenched in sweat . It hurt to breathe . His legs were trembling .

'Ishii-san, you are you . '

He heard Anna's voice in his ears .

A doubt had sprouted within Ishii because of those words .

Why was he chasing after Gotou?

No matter how much he ran, he couldn't catch him . The reason for that was simple – he wasn't Gotou .

The person called Ishii Yuutarou could never become Gotou Kazutoshi .

The moment he had that doubt, he lost his footing and fell forwards .

Gotou's back was getting farther and farther away –

But Ishii didn't have the willpower to stand up and chase Gotou .

– I am Ishii Yuutarou .

He slowly stood up, turned around and started walking down the road he had taken .

His gait was light .

Suddenly, a dark shadow appeared in Ishii's path, blocking his way .

Gotou stood imposingly, occupying Ishii's route .

'D-Detective Gotou...'

Ishii stepped back .

'Why didn't you follow me...'

Gotou's voice shook the air and reverberated to the bottom of Ishii's stomach .

'No, I, er...'

He couldn't think of an excuse – he was just confused .

'Because of you...'

When he said that, the stomach area of Gotou's white shirt was dyed red before his eyes .

That's blood –

'D-Detective Gotou . '

'Because of you, I...'

Before he finished his words, Gotou collapsed, face-up .

'D-Detective Gotouuu!' shouted Ishii as he jumped up .

'You're so noisy in the morning!'

Gotou's fist fell upon Ishii's head .

Ishii's wavering consciousness was brought back to reality . When he looked around, he saw that he was in the usual Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room .

A dream –

It appeared that he'd worked until morning and fallen asleep at his desk . This was the second time he'd seen this dream . He had a bad feeling about it .

'I'm heading out . '

Gotou grabbed his jacket and headed for the door .

'W-where to?'

'Yakumo's . '

'Ah, but the questioning...'

'Do it yourself,' said Gotou one-sidedly, and then he briskly left the room .

Ishii just watched his back leave silently –

In the morning, classes were to be held as normal .

Though Komai's funeral service was in the afternoon, only Haruka and the year-head teacher were to attend .

The guardians were notified through letters that another teacher would come next week .

Until then, other teachers would take Class 5-4 in turns, and Haruka's training would continue as well .

Haruka felt uncomfortable with how people were acting as if nothing had happened when she attended the morning meeting .

'Is this really OK?'

Haruka asked that question to Yokouchi, who stood beside her .

'Unfortunately, this is the normal response,' replied Yokouchi with a shrug .

At the board meeting, it appeared that the question was not the teacher's motivations or sadness but whether there was any danger to the children .

Haruka felt that was the right way of looking at it .

However, she just couldn't accept how the homeroom teacher's death had just been vaguely cleared away .

'Please engage in class without relaxing your attention . '

With that remark from Konno, the morning meeting came to an end .

What an odd expression . Would anybody relax their attention after somebody they knew died –

As if he had heard what Haruka was saying in her heart, Konno turned his gaze towards her .

It wasn't like she had anything to be guilty of, but she felt a chill down her spine .

'Trainee teacher . '

'Yes . '

Haruka stood up straight and accepted Konno's cold gaze .

'This is an important time . Don't cause any more problems . '

It felt like he was saying everything was her fault .

She wanted to object, but this person wasn't the type to listen to other people . If she gave her opinion, she would just get into a fight .

'Yes sir . '

She gave Konno a fierce look, the most defiance she could muster .

Konno made a loud click with his tongue and walked past Haruka .

'Ozawa-san, let's go . '

Yokouchi spoke up to her .

'Eh?'

'Honestly, please get it together . I'm in charge of class for first period . '

'Ah, sorry . '

Haruka hurriedly left the staff room with Yokouchi .

While walking down the corridor, she recalled the conversation she had had with Yakumo last night .

They had found out many new facts, but that didn't mean they could see the truth .

It felt like they were walking in circles in a forest blanketed with fog .

A vague anxiety spread through her heart like ripples –

After entering the classroom, Haruka stood at the teacher's desk and took in a deep breath .

'Good morning . '

She consciously acted cheerfully . However, the children didn't have much of a reaction . Just a few of them responded in quiet voices .

She looked at the third seat from the back by the window .

Masato had his head on the desk . His shoulders were shaking, as if he were cold .

11

'Sorry to bother!'

Gotou opened the door to Yakumo's secret hiding place .

'How many times do I...'

'Shut up . I'm tired of hearing it . '

Gotou interrupted Yakumo's words .

Damn, he knows already, but he keeps on saying the same thing –

'So what did you come here for?' said Yakumo with a yawn .

This brat –

'You're the one who called me here!'

Yakumo put his fingers in his ears pointedly as he looked at Gotou, who was yelling to the point veins were popping out .

For somebody who'd asked Gotou to come because it was an emergency, Yakumo was incredibly calm .

'What a poor mind you must have if you can't understand jokes . I pity you .',

Ah, he just said whatever the hell he wanted to . It had been a joke? It was just harassment .

Gotou sat on the chair and crossed his legs .

'Just say what you want . '

'By the way, is Ishii-san not with you?'

Yakumo combed his fringe .

'Hey . I headed off by myself because you called me out so suddenly . We've got a lot of things to do too . '

Yakumo replied to Gotou's grumbling with a yawn .

Honestly . Gotou wished Yakumo would take things a bit more seriously .

'Other investigation? What are you doing?' asked Yakumo, sounding incredibly disinterested .

Gotou wanted to tell him not to ask if he didn't care, but he restrained himself .

'Ushijima Harue . '

'What do you plan to ask her?'

The corners of Yakumo's lips twisted, like he had eaten something unpleasant .

'Harue thinks her son was killed by Tobe in the fire twenty-eight years ago .',

'Do you suspect her?'

'Yeah . No physical evidence for it . Anyway, I plan on talking to the workers at the care home she's at . '

Yakumo raised an eyebrow while listening to Gotou's explanation .

'Is that your opinion or that of the rumoured psychiatrist?'

He really was sharp .

'The opinion of the psychiatrist lady . '

'I see... More importantly, how is the matter I asked you to do?'

Yakumo continued talking, though he looked discontent .

This morning, Yakumo requested that he look into people related to the Tobe family and call for them .

'I got some info so I went all the way there to look into it . '

'Thank you for your hard work . '

Everything this guy said was irritating .

'I contacted the woman who used to be the Tobe family housekeeper . '

Since somebody in the investigation department had gone to talk to her before for the chain of incidents, Gotou was able to confirm the address right away .

'Well done . '

'An investigation team member already talked to her though . '

'That's fine . I'm the one who wants to talk to her . '

'You plan on meeting her?'

'That is the plan . '

Yakumo stood up with a yawn .

Since Gotou had figured out that was what Yakumo meant when he said to call for them, he wasn't surprised .

But I don't understand –

'Is that housekeeper related to the case somehow?'

Yakumo didn't reply – the corners of his lips just turned up in a smirk .

That response – could it be?

'D-did you already figure out the puzzle behind the case?'

Gotou approached Yakumo with ragged breathing .

'I'm going to say this first, but my objective isn't solving the case . '

'Eh?'

'It's to lift the curse on a boy called Masato . '

Oi, oi – was that a joke?

Gotou had been cooperating since he thought that Yakumo would help solve the puzzle behind the case, but this was a waste of his efforts .

'You better stop underestimating the police . I don't care about some curse on some kid,' said Gotou, clearly angry .

'In order to lift the curse, I need to solve the puzzle behind the case . '

What a slow way of saying things .

I'm tired of being waved around –

After Ishii arrived at the care home, he went to the drawing room by the reception area .

'I met you before too, didn't I? My name is Yonemitsu . '

The care worker that had showed him to Harue last time he came was sitting on the opposite sofa .

Perhaps it was the uniform, but he seemed gentle and friendly .

'My name is Ishii . I'm from the Setamachi precinct . Thank you for meeting with me today . '

Ishii returned the greeting and introduced himself again .

'This is about Ushijima Harue, yes?'

Ishii had been wondering how to explain, but Yonemitsu brought the topic up himself, which helped Ishii out .

'Yes . Has there been anything odd about her lately?'

Even while he said it, he thought the question was vague .

You needed to be good at talking to get information from the other party for an investigation . However, Ishii had no sense for conversation .

He couldn't read the other party . He didn't know when to pause . He didn't know when to withdraw either, which was fatal .

'Rather than recently, er, she's been strange ever since she came here . '

That was somebody who usually talked to the elderly for you .

Yonemitsu took Ishii's awkward words and gave a firm reply .

'Could you tell specific examples?'

'She often leaves without permission . '

Yonemitsu covered his head with his hands, like he really felt troubled .

'Leaves?'

'Yes . She wasn't there when I went to her room this morning . '

'Does she leave by herself?'

'Yes . The police have called in the night before . That was why I was nervous when you came last time – I thought maybe she had done something again . '

The hidden meaning behind Yonemitsu's words was that Harue could leave at any time .

That made Anna's theory more plausible .

'How frequently does this occur on average?'

'Hm...' Yonemitsu's gaze wandered as he thought .

'She disappears about three times a week . '

Three times a week – that was fairly frequent .

'Is there anything else?'

'Of course . Ah, we're really troubled . If she had a family, I'd have a complaint or two . '

Yonemitsu looked truly troubled as he scratched the back of his neck .

'Would you let me hear about it?'

Ishii leant forward .

'Actually, er, we haven't told the police about this before but well... fire . '

'Fire, is it?'

'Yes, fire . I don't know where she got it, but she lights the sheets and desk with a lighter . '

'Arson...'

'Our facility is non-smoking, so we have heat-sensitive fire alarms . It wasn't anything major, but we really are troubled...'

Ishii was agitated and listened to Yonemitsu with open eyes .

This was an amazing find . There was almost no doubt about it now .

Ushijima Harue was the one who lit Tobe's corpse . She had always been waiting for a chance for revenge for her son .

When Tobe was pursued by the police, her chance came –

He had circumstantial evidence . All he needed now was physical evidence . Even if he couldn't find any, with Anna's cooperation, it would be possible to build a case .

This had become something amazing .

13

The old woman keeps going on and on –

That was Gotou's first impression of Noda Fumiko, the previous housekeeper for the Tobe family .

Even though she was almost seventy already, she kept on talking about pointless things .

It had already been thirty minutes since he'd gone into the house of Fumiko, who lived alone after her husband died five years ago .

He had no interest in the story of her eloping with her husband, but she gave him no chance to bring up his topic .

Even Yakumo had a bitter smile on his face .

'You think so too, yes?'

Fumiko pressed Gotou for agreement .

Even if she asked that, he didn't know how to respond since he hadn't been listening .

'Ah, well, that's right . '

He gave a vague response .

However, that seemed to rub Fumiko the wrong way, since she turned away with a displeased expression .

'Ma'am, this person is a blockhead whose only worth is his savageness, so talking to him is a waste of time . '

Yakumo smiled faintly as he mocked Gotou .

Who was a blockhead? He was talking pretty big for a monster cat whose only worth was his cynicism .

'He's obviously a blockhead . He's in the way just by being here . Just like my husband was . '

Oi, old woman . If you say any more, I'll turn you into a dust cloth!

Gotou yelled in his heart . After Yakumo glanced at Gotou, who was restraining his anger, he finally brought up the topic at hand .

'By the way, ma'am . I heard that the Tobe husband and wife had a wonderful romance and marriage, just like you . '

'Who said something like that? He was a money-monger . The young miss was unlucky to be caught by a man like that . '

Fumiko slapped her thighs, like she was going to start a comic story .

'Is that so?'

Yakumo looked purposefully surprised .

It really made Gotou admire him . Normally, Yakumo was blunt and didn't mince matters, but when necessary, he could act as he needed to for the other party .

'That man tricked the young miss and wormed his way into to the Tobe family to do whatever he wanted . He became an executive in the company, but he just lazed about all year round . '

'What an awful man . '

Yakumo's cheek twitched in plain displeasure .

It was probably an act to get info from the other party .

'On top of that, he was unrivalled in his womanising ways . He even asked for me a number of times . '

'If it were you, Fumiko-san, I'd do the same . '

Oi, oi . Was that really OK, Yakumo? Haruka-chan would cry from shock if she heard that .

'It doesn't matter anymore . Fortunately, I'm an unmarried woman now . '

'I see,' said Yakumo with a smile, humouring her, and then he put the conversation back on track .

'But why didn't the young miss divorce him?'

'The young miss had a big heart . And sometimes the worse the man is, the better they look . My husband was the same . He drank and gambled...'

'The master must have disliked it . '

The conversation was going off-topic again, but Yakumo forced it back .

'Of course . The master knew very well what sort of man that man was, after all . He tried to persuade the young miss many a time . '

'Is that so...'

'He didn't want the inheritance to go to that man . That's why he transferred the right of inheritance in his will to his grandson, Kengo-kun, and had a trustee take care of it until he was of age . '

'He didn't want to hand over the inheritance no matter what,' muttered Gotou .

'That's right . It was so thorough that if Kengo-kun died before he was of age, all of it would be donated to charity . '

If, like this old woman said, Tobe Kengo's father, Tobe Masashi, had married for the inheritance, that will would have derailed his plans .

'Why the grandson rather than the daughter?'

Yakumo voiced his doubts .

That was odd . If he didn't want to give the inheritance to his son-in-law, he could have just made his daughter the inheritor .

'The young miss had fallen ill from terrible diabetes a little while after giving birth to Kengo-kun . To say the truth, she could have died at any time . '

'Diabetes...'

'On top of that, since she had such a big heart, he might have been able to cajole her into giving it over . '

'I see . '

Yakumo scratched his chin and then nodded like he understood .

It appeared that the Tobe family had been a very complex household, but did that have anything to do with the case?

In contrast to Gotou's doubt, Yakumo put his left index finger to his brow and smiled in satisfaction –

14

Gotou left Fumiko's home . The moment he got into the car, his mobile phone rang .

'Who is it!?'

<E-er, this is the detective Ishii . >

He heard Ishii's hesitant voice from his mobile .

What an idiot, as usual . Of course –

'I know that!'

<Ah, yes . Please excuse me . >

Gotou didn't care about the chitchat – he just wanted him to get to the point already . Honestly . He'd smack Ishii if he were in front of him .

'So what is it?'

Gotou took his cigarette case from his pocket and took a cigarette out with his mouth, but Yakumo from the passenger seat immediately reached out .

What? One was OK, wasn't it?

<Er, actually according to the care worker, Harue-san frequently leaves the care home without permission . Also, she has set fire to the sheets and desk before . >

'What did you say!?'

If what Ishii said were true, Anna's theory would be spot on .

<Er... Detective Gotou, have you found any new information?>

Ishii asked his question as hesitant as always .

'No luck here . '

Gotou glanced at Yakumo in the passenger seat . He let out a big yawn, like he didn't know what Gotou was thinking .

What came next was up to Yakumo .

<E-er... I was thinking of going to Sasaki Mental Health to ask for the doctor's opinion...>

Just this time, that sounded more credible than Yakumo .

'Got it . Go ahead . '

Gotou hung up .

'Gotou-san, is that psychiatrist somebody that is usually requested?'

Yakumo looked sour, like there was something he didn't agree with .

'Who knows? I'm not sure . '

Normally, if they thought the suspect wasn't of sound mind, there would be a simple evaluation . If it couldn't be determined from that, the prosecutor would call in an expert .

Gotou had no way of knowing what criteria they used to select their experts .

'Gotou-san, could you confirm whether that psychiatrist is somebody that is usually requested, or if that isn't the case, by what method was she requested?'

If he asked Miyagawa, he could probably ask the prosecutor . But –

'Why is that necessary?'

'It's piqued my interest . '

Honestly, it was tiring having to do all this for such a vague reason .

Though Gotou was dissatisfied, he took out his mobile phone and punched in Miyagawa's number .

15

Haruka ran in her irritation .

Come lunchtime, Masato disappeared from the classroom –

It was time for her to leave school for Komai's funeral service, but she was struck by the impulse to find Masato and bring him back .

She explained the situation simply to the year-head teacher who had planned on going with her and ran down the corridor to look for Masato .

She had an idea as to where he was .

She ran up all the stairs at once and went out onto the rooftop .

Just as I thought –

She spotted Masato's back . He was looking out while leaning against the fence . His back really was like Yakumo's .

'What can you see from there?'

Haruka called out while approaching .

She thought that he'd be a bit surprised, but Masato had no response, as if he had known Haruka would come .

Haruka stood beside Masato and looked at the same view .

Looking at the town from a tall place like this made it seem like what she was looking at was a picture . It didn't feel real .

'Do you like it here?'

She couldn't expect an answer . Haruka had known that when she said it .

'Don't come any more...' said Masato, in a voice that sounded as if it would disappear at any moment . Rather than a refusal, his words sounded like a plea .

'Why?'

'I'm cursed . You'll die too, sensei . '

Masato was looking down . His shoulders shook like he was holding back tears .

Haruka hugged Masato's shaking shoulders, enveloping them .

'It's all right . Your curse will be lifted, Masato-kun . '

Haruka murmured into Masato's ears .

'You're lying! That's just a lie!'

Masato yelled in a temper and waved his limbs about to get away from Haruka .

'It isn't a lie . '

'It is... I'm a killer . Since you've never killed anyone, sensei, there's no way you can understand me...'

Masato's words struck Haruka's core, and the pain spread through her body .

Did this child really kill someone –

I don't understand the situation, so I don't know what to say . But –

'I've killed someone before too . '

Masato gaped, and his eyes were as big as saucers as he looked up at Haruka .

It's true . I've killed someone before .

I killed my older twin sister . Because of my childish jealousy, I threw a ball far away to trouble her . When she went to get it, she was hit by a car and died .

My evil heart killed my sister –

'I'm cursed like you are, Masato-kun . '

Ever since that accident, Haruka had carried the sin of having killed her sister . She hadn't told anybody, and had lived with that shut away in her heart .

I can't become happy . I can't do what I want .

After all, I stole my sister's happiness – Haruka lived while blaming herself .

That was Haruka's curse –

'But that guy, you know . Yakumo . He lifted my curse . '

The curse Haruka had carried for so many years had been lifted by meeting Yakumo .

That contrary person had released her from the curse, as if by magic .

'You remember too, right, Masato-kun? The man with terrible bedhead that you met before . He'll definitely lift your curse too . So...'

Haruka crouched to look Masato in the eyes and tried to hug those small shoulders .

However, Masato put his hands in front of him to stop her .

'It's too late . Everything's going to end today anyway...'

Masato turned around and ran off .

Haruka couldn't move a step, as if she had been frozen in place .

It's too late –

Those words of Masato echoed again and again in her ears .

Are we unable to lift his curse – that couldn't be . There had to still be time .

Right, Yakumo?

16

Ishii sat across from Anna in the counselling room .

How many times have I come to this room –

While telling Anna the information he'd heard at the care home, that thought suddenly came across Ishii's mind .

When he came to this room, Ishii felt fulfilled . He felt at home .

He could speak so smoothly, as if his hesitant self with no confidence was a lie . Rather than the mood of the room, it might have been Anna that made him feel that way .

That was a psychiatrist for you .

'So that really was the case . '

When Ishii finished talking, Anna murmured with strong emotions on her face .

With a slow and delicate movement, she took a cigarette in her fingers, lit it with a silver lighter and blew out smoke from her full lips .

Perhaps she wasn't conscious of it herself, but every one of those gestures was filled with fascinating charm .

'By the way, Ishii-san . Where is Detective Gotou today?'

She had asked the same thing before . It really was troubling .

Gotou didn't like Anna much . That was what Ishii felt . That's why he'd gone out of his way to do another investigation .

'Detective Gotou is, er, busy with another matter . '

'What exactly is that other matter?'

'An investigation . '

'What investigation is it?'

Ishii had planned on being vague, but Anna pressed for more .

'That is...'

'What is he investigating?'

Of course he couldn't talk freely about the secrets of the investigation .

In front of Ishii's troubled eyes, there was a small flame .

Anna had lit her silver lighter and put it in front of Ishii's eyes .

The flame quivered . Perhaps it was because Ishii hadn't slept much lately, but that made his eyes blink repeatedly .

'I'll ask once more . What are the contents of the investigation?'

Anna's voice sounded far away .

'I...'

'You can't hide something from me . '

That was right . Anna was cooperating with the case . There was no need to hide anything .

'Detective Gotou is questioning somebody . '

'Who?'

'I don't know . '

There was a buzzing in his ears . His body felt heavy .

He was in a hazy state . It was as if he wasn't the one who was talking .

'You don't know?'

'I don't . '

Ishii hadn't heard the details either .

'Is Detective Gotou investigating that alone?'

'No . '

'Somebody is investigating with him . '

'Yes . '

'Who is that?'

Ishii really couldn't say that a detective was conducting an investigation under the orders of a civilian, let alone a university student .

'A certain person . '

'Who?'

Anna was relentless in her questions .

Why does she want to know that –

17

Next, Gotou visited an apartment on the corner of a residential street .

There was a bouquet of flowers by the bushes right after he entered the grounds . Did somebody die –

'Hey, Yakumo . What are you investigating?'

Gotou parked his car in the parking lot and turned his eyes towards Yakumo in the passenger seat .

However, Yakumo got off the car briskly without answering .

Ignoring me, eh –

Gotou got off the car as well and followed Yakumo .

Yakumo stopped in front of the automatic doors and crossed his arms in displeasure .

'Gotou-san, it's an automatic lock . Please open it . '

Yakumo pointed at the door with his chin .

That really wasn't the attitude you were supposed to take when asking somebody for a favour .

'If you want me to open it, give me a proper explanation . What are you investigating?'

Yakumo sighed, sounding exasperated .

'Gotou-san, do you really not know?'

'What?'

'Yesterday, a woman committed suicide by jumping from this apartment . '

As if I'd know something like that . My hands are full with the current case – I can't concern myself with others .

Plus, it's a suicide, right? That's even more irrelevant . But –

'How're that suicide and this case related?'

'I'm investigating whether they are . '

Yakumo looked at Gotou like he couldn't believe he didn't even understand that .

'I'm asking what you know . '

'The woman who committed suicide by jumping was the homeroom teacher of the boy I mentioned before . As well, that boy predicted that homeroom teacher's death in front of me...'

And then she really died –

So that was how it was . It made sense for Yakumo to think they were related .

'What do you think?'

Yakumo gave Gotou a strong look for his question .

'It is impossible to predict the future . '

'Of course . '

'But it is also true that the homeroom teacher died just as the boy said .
Either it was a coincidence or that boy knew that she was going to die . '

'I see . '

'If it is the latter, I want to know why the boy knew his teacher was going to die . '

Gotou wants to find out himself .

When Gotou was going to go borrow a key from management, his mobile phone started ringing .

Just when he'd been motivated too – what a pain .

'Who's it?'

<Hee hee hee . That's quite a reception . >

Hata said that with a ghastly giggle . He was as creepy as he usually was .

'Old man, what is it? I'm busy . '

<I've got the analysis results for the medicine that Yakumo-kun requested .
I thought I'd let you know . >

'Don't put on airs and just tell me . '

Damn . What a patronising tone .

Gotou glanced to his side . Yakumo was listening, like he knew what they were talking about .

<It's zopiclone . >

'What? That a clone of some wild animal?'

<Zopiclone . The sleep-inducing drug . Are your ears already bad at your age? How pitiful . >

'Shut up . '

There was no reason for him to be pitied by an old man who didn't have much longer to live .

Yakumo stole Gotou's mobile phone from the side and started talking .

'Hata-san, it's Yakumo . There's something I would like to ask... Have people died after taking that zopiclone?'

'Oi, Yakumo . What are you talking about?'

Gotou spoke, but Yakumo held up his hand to control him .

Yes, yes, Gotou would keep his mouth shut .

'Is that so? Is that drug sold on the market... Then the only way to obtain it without a prescription would be to steal it... I see . Thank you very much . '

Yakumo hung up and threw the phone back at Gotou .

'Gotou-san, please open up quickly . '

Not even thanking him, Yakumo said that calmly .

I'll definitely smack him once the case is over –

Gotou buried his irritation in his stomach and proceeded to the management office with Yakumo .

He told the management he was with the police and explained the situation simply to get the key to Komai's room .

Komai's room was on the eighth floor .

It was a one-room flat of ten tatami in size . Cardboard boxes were strewn across the wooden floor .

It looked like the owner was preparing to move .

Her bereaved family were probably in the middle of organising her things .

Yakumo casually began searching through those cardboard boxes, like a cat looking for dinner .

'Oi, Yakumo . Don't tamper with it too much . What are you going to do if somebody comes back?'

Yakumo stopped for a moment at Gotou's voice . Even though he was with the police, there was no excuse for if they were spotted going through the deceased's belongings without permission from the bereaved family .

'It's fine . They won't come back for a while,' said Yakumo, moving his hands again .

'How do you know that?'

'They should be in the middle of the funeral service now . '

Now Gotou understood . So Yakumo had planned the order for the investigation too .

'What if it ends earlier than expected?'

'That's fine . Though it might end later, it won't end earlier . '

Yakumo started going through the second cardboard box .

'Confident, aren't you?'

'The person reading the sutras at the funeral service today is somebody I know . I requested that he drag it out as long as possible . '

'Isshin...?'

'That's correct . '

So that was how it was . Isshin, Yakumo's uncle, was the chief priest at a temple . Then there was no worry of anybody returning any time soon .

Gotou took a cigarette from his pocket .

'Gotou-san, if you have the time to smoke and harm your health, please help out . '

Yakumo's eyes narrowed as he combed back his hair .

Honestly . The guy acted like a brother-in-law .

'Even if you tell me to help, what am I supposed to look for?'

'Something that links the woman with this case . '

That was a vague answer even for Yakumo .

Well, there was no helping it . Gotou would help out . He didn't know what he was looking for, but he'd look for it .

Gotou took off his jacket, rolled up his sleeves and put his hands on a cardboard box that Yakumo hadn't touched yet .

'Gotou-san, I found it . '

What? Just when Gotou had gone out of his way to motivate himself .

'What'd you find?'

Yakumo held out a photo .

In the photo, there were a man and woman who looked to be in their thirties .

'Who are they?'

There was no response to Gotou's question .

That was because Yakumo's mobile phone rang and he answered it in the middle of their conversation .

'What? It's you ...'

18

Haruka left the funeral home partway through the service .

After talking with Masato on the roof, she had gone to Komai's funeral, but she couldn't help but be concerned about him .

The year-head teacher sitting beside her had looked at her critically .
Haruka had come late and was leaving partway through, so it made sense for her to be looked at that way .

– I killed someone .

The words Masato said wouldn't leave her head .

Does he really mean that, or –

No matter how much Haruka thought, she couldn't find an answer . But, if it were Yakumo...

After Haruka went out into the parking lot, she took her mobile out of her bag and punched in Yakumo's number . After two rings, the call connected .

'Hello . '

<What? It's you...>

Yakumo's flat voice came through .

'There's something that concerns me about Masato-kun . '

<Keep it short . >

Yakumo's voice was harder than usual .

'Masato-kun said something strange . '

<What?>

'I killed someone, he said...'

There was a short silence . Haruka felt it was very long .

On the other side of the phone, Yakumo had to be thinking something .
Haruka gripped her mobile phone tightly and waited for an answer .

<Did that kid really say that?>

'Yeah . '

<I killed someone...>

Yakumo mulled over those words .

'Hey, is it true?'

<I can't say anything at this stage . >

She really wanted him to deny it, but just as Yakumo said, they had nothing to determine whether it was true or not .

'Of course...'

<Did he say anything else?>

Haruka recalled the conversation she'd had with Masato . Even something little would be okay – she just wanted a clue . It was a desperate thought .

That's right –

'Everything's going to end today... He said that . '

<Everything's going to end today...>

'Yup . '

< That's bad . >

The tone of Yakumo's voice had clearly changed .

Even through a phone, it was obvious that he was in a hurry .

'Yakumo-kun, is there anything I can do?'

<OK, listen well . There's only one thing you can do . >

'What is it?'

<Go right home and stay there . Don't even think about doing anything . >

Yakumo's tone made it sound like he was giving an order .

'Hey, what's going to happen to Masato-kun?'

<Anyway, go home . >

Yakumo forced the conversation to end by hanging up .

The dry wind howled as it passed Haruka by . She had a bad feeling about this –

Haruka couldn't just stay still . She started running like something was chasing her .

19

'What's wrong?'

Gotou spoke after Yakumo hung up .

Yakumo had probably been talking to Haruka . From Yakumo's expression, it was probably about the boy called Masato .

'No, it's nothing . It seemed like a troublemaker was going to go on a rampage, so I gave her a warning . '

Yakumo looked down while pinching his brow with his fingers and started muttering .

'Escape... burnt corpse... sleep medication... left hand... curse...'

Gotou didn't know what that list of words meant .

Yakumo's muttering stopped .

Yakumo looked up suddenly with a grim expression that made him look like a different person .

That keen gaze shot through Gotou, making him feel a shiver down his spine .

Could this guy have –

'Solved the puzzle?'

'No, not yet . However, I can now see the general framework of the case . '

'Really?'

'Yes . '

'Explain . '

Gotou gripped Yakumo's shoulders and shook them .

'I'll explain on the way . There isn't much time . '

Yakumo brushed aside Gotou's hands and left the room .

Honestly . The guy just did whatever he wanted . Gotou hurriedly followed after him .

After Gotou left the apartment, he sat in the driver seat of his car and looked at Yakumo in the passenger seat . He still looked grim .

'So where should we go?'

'Our first priority is to protect the boy called Masato . '

Gotou could tell from Yakumo's voice that his nerves were on edge .

'Do you know his address?'

'The apartment in front of the park on 3-chome . '

Gotou stepped on the accelerator instead of replying .

'Is that boy in danger?'

'This is just my reasoning, but at this rate, he'll die . He knows that himself .
,

Yakumo said something awful in a disinterested voice .

Gotou couldn't tell from Yakumo's expression whether the kid's knowledge of his death meant that someone was going to kill him or that he was going to kill himself .

'Can you explain what you mean?'

'The beginning of this case goes back twenty-eight years . '

The fire that occurred at the elementary school –

So that really was the start? But that made the theory Anna said seem more real .

'So the culprit is Harue?'

'That's wrong . '

An immediate answer .

Yakumo wouldn't put any theories he wasn't confident of into words . If he said it, there was probably no doubt about it .

'What do you mean?'

'Tobe Kengo is Ushijima Atsushi . '

'So Tobe did have dissociative identity disorder?'

'Like I said, that's wrong . '

Yakumo ran his hand through his hair in his irritation .

'Explain it in a way I can understand!' Gotou flared up at Yakumo in his anger .

Exasperated, Yakumo shook his head and started explaining, though he seemed reluctant .

'Tobe Kengo died in the fire twenty-eight years ago . '

'What?'

'That is, the person who the police believe to be Tobe Kengo is Ushijima Atsushi . They switched places during the fire twenty-eight years ago . '

Gotou's face froze in his surprise .

What was he saying? That was ridiculous . Yakumo's idea was too extraordinary .

'There's no way they could just switch places so easily . What proof do you have to say that?'

'There are several reasons . It'll be troublesome to explain them all, so I will show you something conclusive . '

After Yakumo declared that, he took a photo out of his pocket and placed it on the dashboard . While driving with one hand, Gotou took the photo with the other .

It was an old photo . It seemed to have been taken during a field trip or something . There were four boys .

'From the right, there's Masato's father, Oomori Hironori, Ushijima Atsushi, Tobe Kengo and my uncle on the left . '

So he'd gotten it from Isshin? It was the first time Gotou had seen a photo of the young Tobe Kengo and Ushijima Atsushi, but their faces were very similar .

The difference that stood out was the mole on the cheek .

Mole – wait a second .

While handling the wheel, Gotou opened the glove compartment and tried to take the case file out . However, his hand slipped and most of the contents spilled out into the car .

Luckily, he was able to get what he was aiming for .

The photo of Tobe Kengo that was taken when he was arrested .

Though the left half of his face was burnt, there was a mole on his cheek . In the photo of his childhood, the one with the mole on the cheek was – not Tobe Kengo, but Ushijima Atsushi .

For a moment, his vision went blank .

'You've noticed then . '

Yakumo smirked .

What the hell? Gotou's hands were shaking . He hadn't even thought of people switching places . A cold sweat ran down his forehead .

'But how...'

Finally, Gotou said just that .

'First, please recall the testimony of the firefighter . When the firefighter went in, one of the boys was already burnt . '

'Yeah . '

'Then, the firefighter was able to determine that the one who was still alive was Tobe Kengo from the toy he was holding, which had the name written on it, and because the boy himself had called himself that . '

That was right . The firefighter had said that .

It could be explained if Ushijima Atsushi stole the toy from Tobe Kengo .
But –

'Even if the firefighter said that, the people around should've noticed . '

'Have you forgotten? Half his face was burnt . That became his camouflage . Then, he changed schools and didn't approach the friends he had been close to . '

The way Yakumo said it, it might have been possible to trick the people nearby . But –

'His family would've noticed, right?'

'Tobe's mother had severe diabetes . She probably had the symptoms of diabetic retinopathy and could see virtually nothing . '

'She couldn't see...'

'Probably not . Furthermore, since it was near the end, she was probably so weak she couldn't move . If that was the case, she wouldn't have been able

to confirm properly . ’

It sounded more and more plausible, but there was still a hole in Yakumo’s argument .

‘Then how about the dad? He should’ve been healthy . ’

Since he was agitated, the hand he gripped the wheel with was sweaty .

‘Of course the father knew that his son had been switched . ’

Gotou was so surprised that he didn’t see the traffic light and cut through a red light . Honks rang all around .

‘Don’t be ridiculous . You saying he knew but kept quiet?’ shouted Gotou angrily as he hit the wheel .

He himself didn’t know what he was angry at .

‘Please recall what Fumiko-san the housekeeper said . ’

Yakumo was extremely calm .

‘What about that old woman?’

‘Tobe Kengo’s father, Masashi-san, would have been in a bad situation if his son died . ’

‘The inheritance...’

‘That’s right . ’

The Tobe family inheritance was to go to the grandson, Kengo, skipping over the son-in-law, Masashi .

If his wife and son died, the inheritance would be donated . That was why he kept quiet .

'Are you saying he lived with some other person's kid for money even though his own son had died?'

'That is slightly incorrect . '

Gotou was once again confused by Yakumo's words .

'What's incorrect about it? That's what you said . '

'This is my theory, but I think that Tobe Kengo and Ushijima Atsushi had the same father . In short, both were Masashi's children . '

Gotou recalled Ushijima Harue's history .

She'd had a lover . Had he been Tobe Kengo –

But if that was the case, it would explain a number of things .

'After the two changed, there was a complete change in Kengo's personality, but it was vaguely accepted as something caused by the shock from the fire . '

'Treating him with kid gloves then?'

'Furthermore, nobody looked too closely at that face, which had been so terribly burnt . '

A number of coincidences overlapped, and this terrible swap occurred –

Gotou felt sick just thinking about it .

'Why did Ushijima Atsushi call himself Tobe Kengo when he was rescued from the fire?'

'It's in that composition . '

'I want to become Tobe-kun...'

'Yes . Ushijima Atsushi wanted to be Tobe Kengo . He was attached to him .
,

'Why?'

'Though they were the children of the same father, one of them lived in great comfort while the other was abused daily by his mother . He probably felt a great contradiction in that difference, which warped his mind . '

So Ushijima Atsushi's childhood aspiration had been fulfilled –

20

It was dark by the time Haruka returned to the school .

Only the staff room was lit .

Yakumo had told Haruka to go straight home, but there was no way she could do that .

Masato had said that everything would end today . Was that child going to suddenly disappear from in front of her? That worry wouldn't leave Haruka's head . She couldn't stay still .

Even though she'd returned to the school, it wasn't as if she had a clue as to how to solve the case .

When Haruka started going up the stairs to head to the staff room, she suddenly felt a gaze on her and looked up .

There was a boy on the second floor landing .

It wasn't Masato .

That boy looked down at Haruka with a smile .

'Hurry home . '

When she spoke to him, the boy beckoned her .

He's telling me to come –

The boy hopped up a number of stairs and then turned around to beckon her again .

Haruka followed that boy up the stairs, just as he invited her to .

'Hey, wait . '

Even though Haruka called out to him, the boy didn't stop and just continued going up the stairs .

I've seen this child before –

It was the child who had been looking down at her from the second floor window .

Finally, they climbed up to the fourth floor and went out into the corridor . The boy stood about five metres ahead of Haruka in the corridor and was smiling as always .

Mysteriously, the boy's body was faintly lit up even though they were in the dark .

'Hey, what's your name?'

When Haruka called out to him, the boy started running .

'Hey, wait a minute . '

Haruka started running too, but she stopped and turned around because she felt something was odd .

Even though the boy should have been in front of her, she heard laughter from behind her .

She turned around again in her confusion . The boy hopped in place and beckoned her, as if to say, 'Faster, faster!'

He was in front of Class 5-4's classroom .

'Hey, what are you doing?'

The boy didn't reply to Haruka's question . He went into the classroom, as if he disappeared .

That child didn't open the door –

Haruka gripped the necklace with the red stone she was wearing and slowly and determinedly opened the door .

Nobody was in the moonlit room .

Had that child been a ghost?

Bewildered, Haruka looked at the classroom with its neatly lined-up desks .

Suddenly, she noticed something white on top of a desk . It was Masato's seat by the window .

Haruka went between the desks and walked up to Masato's seat .

It was a white envelope . 'To Haruka-sensei' was written on it in tottering pencil letters .

'To me...'

Haruka unsealed the letter and took the single piece of paper that had been inside .

<I killed someone . Sorry . >

That was the only thing that was written .

'Masato-kun...'

Haruka's body shook like electricity had gone through it .

It didn't matter whether this sentence was true or false . Masato was asking her to save him . That was how she felt .

Not just now . He must have always been looking for someone to save him .

Masato probably waited for everyone to go home to put the letter here . Then he might still be around .

Gripping the envelope, Haruka flew out of the room .

I promised him that I'd lift the curse – it's not a problem of whether I can do something or not . I want to do something for him .

The words Yakumo said rang through her head .

– He doesn't understand what kindness is . So you should just teach him .

21

Gotou stood with Yakumo in front of the door to the flat Masato lived in .

Looking at it from the outside, it appeared to be a flat for a single person . It felt too small for a parent and child .

'The lights are off . '

Yakumo peered in from the window .

Are they out – well, it'd be quicker to check rather than to think about it .

Gotou pressed the intercom button by the door .

He waited for a while, but there was no response .

'I'm with the Setamachi precinct . Anyone here?'

He called out while knocking, but that was no good either .

They were definitely out then . He gave the doorknob a try .

It opened –

There was a dark room beyond the door .

Right after entering, there was a kitchen, and ahead was a six-tatami room .

Yakumo left Gotou's side and entered the room .

He had some nerve trespassing right in front of a detective's eyes .

Gotou flicked the switch on the wall .

'What the hell is this?'

Gotou unconsciously spoke up when he saw the kitchen in the light .

This is surprising – the kitchen was empty . The fridge and microwave were of course, but there wasn't any cookware or tableware .

Gotou had heard that lately there were more people who wouldn't cook and would just eat convenience store lunchboxes or eat out, but this wasn't at that level .

Gotou took off his shoes and then headed into the room beyond the kitchen .

He tried the switch by the door, but the lights didn't turn on . When he looked, he noticed that there wasn't any light fixture and that there was just a plug .

He could tell that it was just as clean and Spartan as the kitchen even in the dimness .

Yakumo stood in the room with a grim expression on his face .

'They must have moved somewhere . Should we look for where they've moved to?'

'It's no use . '

Yakumo rejected Gotou's proposal .

'What do you mean, no use?'

'He probably won't show up again . That was the original goal, after all . '

Goal?

'Oi . Explain properly . '

Yakumo didn't reply to Gotou's question . Instead, he pinched his brow with his fingers while looking down and started muttering .

It was as if he was chanting a spell .

'That kid is somewhere... Why did he have to wait until today... He should have been able to move sooner... Did he have another goal... What... What is it...'

Gotou listened to everything Yakumo said to try to understand, but it was no use .

It seemed all he could do was wait for Yakumo to finish his train of thought .

Gotou took his cigarette case from his pocket and tried to take a cigarette out, but it was empty .

When he turned the case over, brown dregs fell down .

'Damn it . '

Gotou crushed the cigarette case and threw it .

'I've got it . '

Yakumo suddenly raised his head .

'What? Figured it out?'

Yakumo ignored Gotou again and took his mobile phone out .

22

Haruka went out in the corridor to look for Masato, but she didn't know where to start .

Maybe he's on the roof again like before – but she didn't have the time to think idly .

When Haruka started walking, her mobile phone rang .

It was from Yakumo . He might have found a clue .

'Hello . '

<There's something I want to confirm . Where are you?>

That was the first thing Yakumo said after opening his mouth .

'The school . '

She thought he would complain since she had stayed behind at the school even though he'd told her to go straight home, but it wasn't the time to be hiding things .

<I see . Will you listen to my request?>

Yakumo replied readily . And a request too –

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . I'll listen to any request, but I want to know where Masato-kun is first,' said Haruka, gripping the letter Masato had left .

<My request concerns where that Masato is . >

'Eh?'

<Will you listen?>

'Got it . '

Yakumo probably had a clue as to where Masato was .

<You said before that Masato stole something from the vice principal . >

'Yeah . '

Konno had approached Masato for that and thrust him away .

She still didn't know what Masato had tried to steal .

<Also, you saw that vice principal take something from the pool . Right?>

'Yeah . '

She'd seen it . Something in a paper bag –

<I want you to confirm what that is . >

'How am I supposed to confirm it?'

<It's simple . Just sneak into the staff room and borrow it for a bit . >

That's absurd . Is he telling me to steal it? Plus –

'Finding Masato-kun comes first, right?'

<Masato is probably searching for the same thing . >

'What do you mean?'

<There's no time to explain in detail . I'm counting on you . >

The conversation felt like a wild goose chase .

'Is this really OK?'

<This is my gut feeling, but as long as you have it, Masato won't die . >

She didn't understand even a bit of what Yakumo said, but all she could do now was believe him .

'Got it . '

<I'm heading there too now . >

'OK . '

<Let's lift that boy's curse . >

Yakumo's strong words shook Haruka's heart, and the corner of her eyes felt warm .

Even though Yakumo always made complaints, he helped her with her troubles to the end .

'Thank you...'

When Haruka said that, she hung up .

The dark corridor continued in front of her eyes .

Haruka started running towards that darkness –

23

Gotou rushed back to the car at Yakumo's insistence and quickly started the car .

'Could you explain already? My head feels like it's going to split because there's too much I don't understand . '

Unable to hold back, Gotou pressed Yakumo for answers .

'Before that, how is the matter with the psychiatrist?'

It seemed he didn't feel like talking right away .

Gotou connected an earphone with a microphone to his mobile phone and called Miyagawa .

<I was just going to call you . >

The call connected after one ring, and he heard Miyagawa's deep voice .

It appeared that he had results .

'So, how is it?'

There was the sound of documents being flipped through from the other end of the phone .

<Honestly . You've got some guts, making your boss work for you . Be prepared – I'm going to beat you into shape after this . >

'Please do as you will . '

Gotou accepted Miyagawa's words with a wry smile .

Yakumo, the university student who had ordered around the police, was listening beside him .

<Seems that the psychiatrist this time isn't the one the prosecutors usually call . The usual doctor was busy and recommended this one . >

'Did anybody meet with that psychiatrist before?'

Yakumo was the one who interrupted .

<Seems that way... Oi . Who are you?>

Though Miyagawa replied to the sudden question, he also retorted .

However, Yakumo continued talking regardless .

'So there wasn't a direct investigation . '

<That's probably the case... and I said, who are you!?!>

Miyagawa shouted in anger .

'I apologise . I'll explain when I return . '

Since it seemed like it'd become troublesome, Gotou said that one-sidedly and hung up .

He looked at Yakumo again .

He was as pale as a dead man, and he was biting down hard on his lower lip .

There was a faint layer of sweat on his forehead .

'Ishii-san went to see that psychiatrist, correct?'

'Yeah, that's right . '

But he'd just gone to explain the situation . He should have returned already .

While Gotou was thinking, Yakumo took Gotou's mobile phone and started making a call .

'Who're you calling?'

'Ishii-san . '

Yakumo gave Gotou a sharp look .

He probably wanted to say that it was obvious, but Gotou didn't understand why .

'What do you want from Ishii?'

'If we don't call back Ishii-san immediately, the matter will become serious . '

Call back? What did he mean?

It seemed like Ishii hadn't answered the phone . After swearing, Yakumo redialled .

Yakumo's impatience infected Gotou . He felt like his skin was tingling .

'What happened?'

'You still don't understand? That doctor is a fake . '

Yakumo's lips twisted into a frown .

A fake –

'Explain in Japanese . '

Just as Gotou said that, the call connected .

24

Haruka descended to the second floor, where the staffroom was, and looked down the corridor .

The lights were off . It appeared the teachers had already gone home .

Paying attention to her surroundings, Haruka slowly walked towards the staff room while concealing the sound of her footsteps .

When she reached the door, she took in a deep breath . Before letting that breath out, she put her hand on the door handle and slowly opened the door .

She opened the door just wide enough for her body to go through, and she slipped through that gap .

Clatter –

There was the sound of something falling . Haruka jumped and looked instinctively towards where the sound had come from .

She could see a shadow that looked like a boy there .

'Masato-kun?'

Haruka spoke up .

She couldn't see his face in the darkness, but she couldn't think of anybody else .

The shadow didn't reply to Haruka's question . He just stood there while looking down .

After Haruka slowly approached him, she could tell it was definitely Masato .

Masato was standing at Konno's seat .

– Masato is looking for the same thing .

Yakumo had said that . He had probably tried to steal something from Konno .

Haruka stood in front of Masato, squeezed between the desks and looked at him .

There was a grim air about Masato as he stood there, stock still .

'Masato-kun, I was worried . '

Haruka reached out to touch Masato's shoulder .

He was shivering slightly . It felt like he'd break if she put even the slightest bit of force into it . He was gripping something in his hand .

This is what Masato was searching for –

'Sensei's looking for the same thing you are, Masato-kun . The man from before said we need it to lift your curse . '

Masato looked up .

His eyes were inflamed and his eyelids were puffy . There were traces of tears on his cheeks .

This child had cried a lot without anybody knowing . though Haruka didn't know what had happened to him, he must have been crying the whole time in his pain and sadness, wanting somebody to save him .

I'm sorry I couldn't save you until now –

'Hey, Masato-kun . Could you give what you're holding in that hand to me?'

Masato just looked at his tightly gripped small fists without responding .

'I promise I'll lift your curse, Masato-kun . '

Don't make promises you can't keep . She felt like she could hear Yakumo saying that .

But she wasn't saying that carelessly . Haruka was prepared to follow through .

'Really...?' said Masato with a snivel .

'Really . Do you know about pinky promises?'

Haruka held out her right little finger towards Masato . Masato nodded and linked it with his own .

That moment, the lights turned on in the staff room . For a moment, Haruka's vision went right because it was so bright . Somebody had come .

Haruka blinked a few times and then looked at the door .

'Why are you getting in my way?'

Konno was standing there . His cheek was twitching .

'Why are you getting in the way of my fun?'

Konno went in between the desks straight for them .

'Konno-sensei . '

'I need to discipline you two . '

When Konno was right by them, he raised his right hand .

That hand was gripping a hammer .

'We're going to run . '

The moment Haruka said that, she gripped Masato's hand, turned around and started running .

She flew into the corridor from the other door .

When she looked around, she saw Konno following right behind them .

Yakumo's going to be here soon . I need to hold on until then somehow –

25

I can hear an intermittent electronic sound –

Ishii was vacantly aware . After a while, the sound stopped with a snap .

His vision became clearer like a focussing camera .

He rubbed his eyes and looked around . He recognised this room . He was sitting on the sofa in Anna's counselling room .

He appeared to have fallen asleep .

When had he fallen asleep? He couldn't remember . His head kind of hurt .

Anna wasn't in the room .

The electronic sound started again . His mobile phone was ringing in his pocket .

Ishii took out the phone and saw Gotou's name on the display . Come to think of it, he hadn't contacted him at all . Ishii hurriedly answered the phone .

'Hello, Ishii speaking . '

<Are you OK?>

The voice he heard from the phone was not Gotou's but Yakumo's .

'Eh?'

<It's me . Yakumo . Ishii-san, are you OK?>

Why was Yakumo using Gotou's mobile phone, and what did he mean by OK?

'E-er... I'm OK,' answered Ishii, though he didn't understand .

Yakumo sighed in relief .

<Ishii-san, where are you right now?>

'Ah, er, I'm at Sasaki Mental Health . '

<Please leave the building immediately . >

Yakumo-shi sounded cornered, which was unusual for him .

Normally, he was aloof, so for him to be so impatient –

'E-er... did something happen?'

<Just get out of there right now, please . Ishii-san, you are in incredible danger right now . >

Danger? I am? Why?

Doubts kept coming up in Ishii's head .

'I think I'm very much safe though . '

<Listen, the psychiatrist called Sasaki is a fake . She's an imposter . >

Imposter – Anna was? That's ridiculous . I mean, that person –

Ishii felt a presence behind him and turned around .

Anna was standing behind him with a wide smile .

'Doctor...'

Anna took the mobile from Ishii's hand as he started to speak and spoke on the phone herself .

What on earth –

'So you're Yakumo-kun...'

Anna started speaking, ignoring Ishii's confusion .

'Who am I, you ask... ? I'll tell you if you come alone... I'll be waiting here with Ishii-san . '

After Anna said that, she put the mobile phone on the carpet, raised her left foot and stepped on it with her heel .

'W-what are you...'

Ishii hurriedly picked up the mobile, but it had split in half and the screen was broken – it couldn't be used .

Anna gracefully sat down on the opposite sofa, crossed her long and supple legs and combed back her black hair .

'It seems that I will have to bid you farewell, Ishii-san . '

The eyes looking at Ishii didn't even have a whit of the gentleness that they'd had before .

The eyes were so cold they chilled Ishii's body to the core .

Anna lit a cigarette and blew a thin line of smoke from her glossy lips .

Was Yakumo telling the truth earlier –

Then who was the person in front of him?

Though it was delayed, a strange terror came over him and he half-rose to his feet .

At that moment, there was a dull thump .

Ishii's head shook and he fell to the carpet .

He felt a dull pain in his head . While pressing a hand against it, he looked up to see Anna standing with a cigarette in her mouth and a glass ashtray in her hand .

Did she hit me with that –

His hand felt wet . When he looked at it, he saw that his palm was dyed red .

This is – my blood .

Anna looked down scornfully at Ishii on his hands and knees . Her eyes were filled with disgust, as if she were looking at a cockroach .

'Please settle down . Men in a fluster are unsightly . '

'Damn it!'

Yakumo threw the mobile phone forcefully .

The mobile phone hit the front glass and split in half .

'You bastard! How many times do you have to break my mobile before you're satisfied!?'

Gotou shouted in anger, but Yakumo just covered his face with his hands and looked up at the ceiling .

This is unusual – did something happen to Ishii?

'Yakumo, what happened?'

After Gotou calmed down, he asked that question .

'Ishii-san's been caught . '

'Caught? By who?'

'The psychiatrist . '

'That's ridiculous...'

'It's the truth . '

'What for?'

Gotou was so agitated he grabbed Yakumo's arm and pulled at it .

'I'll explain, so please look forward and drive properly . '

'What?'

When he looked forward, he saw a red light .

Gotou slammed the brakes . The tires screeched and smoked as the car stopped . He'd almost driven through it .

'So what do you mean?'

Gotou wiped the sweat from his forehead .

'As I said earlier, that psychiatrist is an imposter . I can't say what method she used unless I look into it, but... that's how it is . '

So that was what he'd been checking with Miyagawa earlier?

That psychiatrist had been recommended and then employed . Nobody had met her before . That meant nobody knew what she looked like .

'But she'd been recommended by the psychiatrist they always request . '

'This is my theory . The doctor who was requested by the prosecutor for Tobe Kengo's psychological examination couldn't fit it in their schedule . Then, they contacted a doctor they knew . '

'And?'

'What if that psychiatrist contacted the doctor they knew through email? And then that email was manipulated and reached somebody else?'

What Yakumo was saying was only a theory, but when Gotou heard it, he felt a chill down his spine .

Who've we been talking to up until now –

'Why'd you think the doctor was a fake?' asked Gotou, since he couldn't believe it .

'At first it was only a theory . When I heard you talk, Gotou-san, what that psychiatrist said sounded odd to me . Particularly the part about dissociative identity disorder . '

'What about it?'

Gotou didn't think Anna's explanation was unnatural .

'When one personality is active, the others are sleeping... She said that, correct?'

'Right . '

'You wouldn't be able to say it wasn't dissociative identity disorder just from that . It differs depending on the case, but there are some cases wherein even when the personalities change, they are active and keep all their memories . '

'Maybe she didn't know?'

'That would be just as unnatural as a police officer not knowing traffic regulations . '

That would be unnatural .

After checking that the light was green, Gotou stepped on the pedal .

'As well, her diagnosis of Ushijima Harue-san was also strange . It would be impossible for a psychiatrist to analyse the personality of somebody they have never met . '

Gotou recalled the conversation he'd had with Yakumo about the psychiatrist .

– Is that the psychiatrist's opinion?

Yakumo had looked discontent when he said that .

So Yakumo had already doubted her then?

'Furthermore, the matter of the murderer's escape is also unnatural . '

Yakumo continued his explanation .

'Would both guards leave the room just because there was an alarm?'

That had bothered Gotou too .

'But that really happened . '

Yakumo raked his fingers through his hair in his irritation .

'Please listen to this as one possibility . She isn't a psychiatrist, but I think she may be a hypnotherapist or have some knowledge of the kind . '

'Hypnotherapy – like hypnotism?'

Gotou's voice cracked . Something bothersome had come up again .

He hated unrealistic psychic abilities like this .

'I'm just going to say this, but hypnotherapy isn't a psychic ability . '

Yakumo gave Gotou a glance, like he had seen right through his thoughts .

'It isn't?'

'Hypnotherapy is a legitimate form of psychotherapy . There's no need to put somebody to sleep as they do on television . As long as they are relaxed, it's easy to give simple suggestions . '

'Suggestions?'

'In other words, go out when the alarm goes off . She probably gave a suggestion like that . '

That would explain the unnatural movements of the two guards at the scene .

When the bell rang, they unconsciously responded like Pavlov's drooling dogs –

'But what for?'

'Isn't it obvious? It was to let him escape . '

'So they were accomplices?'

'That's correct . '

'But if it's like you said, why'd she cooperate with our investigation and put herself in danger?'

Yakumo shook his head .

'You still don't understand? She wasn't cooperating . She was just guiding your investigation . '

'So that's how it was...'

Now that he thought about it, Anna had been obstinately stuck on the fire that occurred twenty-eight years ago .

Then, they continued the investigation as they were told to .

'We thought Ushijima Harue was the culprit...'

'That was her goal . '

So she's been playing with us . But then –

'Who burnt the corpse?'

27

After Haruka and Masato went down to the first floor, they ran into the nearby school infirmary, closed the door and locked it .

They shouldn't have been seen going into this room . This way, they could buy some time .

Haruka's heart hurt so much it felt like it would stop . How long had it been since she'd run so hard?

'You OK?'

Haruka spoke to Masato .

Though Masato's shoulders were heaving, he nodded .

Haruka's strength left her body all at once and she sat on the floor .

'Hey, Masato-kun . What were you looking for?'

Masato walked up to Haruka and held out his left hand in a fist .

'This...'

As he murmured that, Masato opened his hand .

On his palm, there was an SD card, which could be used for digital camera storage and the like .

Haruka pinched the SD card with her fingers and looked at it from different angles . However, there didn't seem to be anything strange .

Why did Masato want the SD card so much, and why had Konno been so insistent on taking it back?

It felt like the key to solving that was in the data .

Rattle!

The door shook loudly .

Haruka instinctively hugged Masato and held her breath .

It was OK . If they were quiet, their presence in the room shouldn't be noticed . A cold sweat ran down her back .

Rattle rattle –

The door continued to shake loudly .

They just waited, hunched together, for him to pass .

Finally, the door stopped shaking .

Thump thump –

She heard footsteps which sounded further and further away until she couldn't hear them any longer .

Haruka let out the breath she had been holding .

She just needed to tell Yakumo where they were .

Gotou was probably with him, so he'd do something . Haruka took her mobile out from her pocket, when –

The footsteps drew nearer again .

Thump thump thump .

She could see somebody on the other side of the ground glass . So they had been noticed .

Haruka pulled Masato's hand and they hid underneath the bed .

The door opened right after .

Thump thump thump .

She could see feet walking around the room . Her heart was beating wildly from terror and nervousness .

The feet stopped in front of the bed .

– Please . Don't notice .

Haruka's plea was futile . A hand reached out and grabbed the bed, flipping it right over .

Konno stood there .

He had a twisted smile on his face, a hammer in his right hand and a ring of keys hanging from his left hand .

'Getting in the way of my hobby? I really can't forgive you . '

Haruka stood in front of Masato as a shield .

Konno held up the hammer .

It's too late –

Haruka's body stiffened as she closed her eyes tightly . However, there was no pain or impact .

She timidly opened her eyes .

Konno's eyes were wide open as he stood there . The hammer fell from his hand and he fell forward like that .

Somebody else appeared before Haruka's eyes .

'Yakumo-kun... it's not you...'

That person opened ghastly bloodshot eyes in the dark .

28

'Ushijima Atsushi was the one who burnt that corpse . '

Yakumo gritted his teeth .

However, Gotou didn't understand what Yakumo said .

'Ushijima Atsushi switched places with Tobe Kengo twenty-eight years ago in the fire, right? I'm asking who killed Ushijima Atsushi . '

'Like I said, Ushijima Atsushi . In the first place, that corpse isn't Ushijima Atsushi . '

'W-w-what did you say!?'

Gotou was so shocked he let go of the wheel . The car suddenly started veering .

Shit . Gotou hurriedly grabbed the wheel .

'I knew from the very beginning that the burnt corpse wasn't the murderer who escaped,' said Yakumo nonchalantly .

He knew from the very beginning –

'What do you mean?'

'I can see the spirits of the dead . Have you forgotten?'

'I know that . '

'I found that corpse by pursuing its ghost . At that stage, I realised that the corpse was not the same person as the murderer in the photo you had shown me, Gotou-san . '

Why was he acting so high and mighty?

'Then you should've said so in the first place!'

'I don't remember ever saying that the corpse was the murderer who escaped . '

That wasn't the problem, but there was no point arguing about that now .

'Then who is it?'

Yakumo threw a photo onto the dashboard .

It was the photo they'd found at Komai's flat .

'The man's name was Oomori Hironori-san . He was in the same grade as Tobe-san and Ushijima . '

'He's that corpse?'

'That's correct . Furthermore, this person was that boy's father and also the lover of the teacher Komai Hiromi . Now that I've said so much, you understand, yes?'

'How would I understand from an explanation like that, you fool!?'

Gotou hit the horn in his anger .

'Ushijima Atsushi, after his escape, tried to impersonate another person, just as he did twenty-eight years ago . '

'He tried to change places...'

'That's right . He had his sights set on Oomori Hironori . Ushijima Atsushi murdered him . He used a low-temperature fire to burn him in the pool's pump room . '

There was no way Gotou could understand from that explanation .

'How about the fingerprints?'

'He cut off his own left hand and left it at the scene in order to make it look like he had died . '

'Why would he go all that way...'

'He couldn't make himself die if the corpse couldn't be identified, right? In that sense, the psychiatrist stabbed Tobe as preparation for this situation . What was really cut was the left wrist . '

He'd gone that far? Why'd he go so far to become somebody else? Your life was something you made yourself, right? It definitely wasn't something you got from somebody else .

But if it was as Yakumo said, there was something Gotou just couldn't understand .

'But his son would notice, right?'

'Yes . That was what I was most troubled by . However, I've solved the puzzle . It appears that Oomori Hironori-san and his son Masato-kun did not have a good relationship in the first place . Ushijima took advantage of that . '

'Took advantage of? How?'

'He probably approached Masato-kun right after he had a fight with his father and said something like "I'll give you magical medicine that will make your father disappear" while giving him that medicine . '

And then that boy gave that medicine to his father .

In Gotou's youth, he had also wished sometimes that his parents would disappear .

However, he hadn't understand the true meaning of disappear . It was on the same level of being angry at a friend .

The boy must have understood the meaning of that word for the first time when he gave the medicine to his father and saw him stop moving .

He wouldn't have been able to say he killed his own father no matter what . Using that, he was made out to be an accomplice .

Putting such a heavy burden on such a small heart was inhuman .

A hot rage boiled up in the pit of Gotou's stomach .

'That boy's incomprehensible behaviour came from his knowledge of the crime and his fear . He wanted to be saved, but he couldn't say that . He shut all of that in his small heart . He must have suffered...'

Yakumo had a fierce look in his eyes . They looked faintly wet .

This guy knows better than anyone about irrational suffering . That's probably why he got so into this case, which is unusual for him .

But can we save the heart of a boy who killed his father –

'Please stop . '

Gotou stepped on the brakes after Yakumo said that .

The school gate was right beside them . He had been so focussed on his thoughts that he'd almost driven past it .

'Gotou-san, I leave Ishii-san to you . '

After Yakumo said that, he jumped out and ran off .

This might be the last time I see Yakumo –

For some reason, that thought came up in Gotou's mind .

'Hmph . There's no way he'd kick the bucket . '

He didn't have the time for boring thoughts . He had to do something about that fool .

Gotou stepped on the accelerator and spun the wheel around .

29

The left half of that man's face had been burnt and the skin was scarred .

There was also nothing beyond his left wrist .

The man looked at Haruka and Masato and laughed .

The laugh was a cold one, like frozen soil that would never melt .

This man is empty . There's nothing there – that was how Haruka felt . It was terrifying .

There was nowhere to run in this situation . Masato gripped Haruka's hand tightly . She could feel his shivering and fear through her skin .

I need to protect this child –

Haruka gripped Masato's hand back and brought the hammer that had fallen on the floor closer with her foot, making sure that the man wouldn't notice .

The man slowly approached .

Now!

Haruka quickly stooped, picked up the hammer and hit the man's toes .

Snap .

There was the sound of a plastic container or something breaking .

'Agh!'

The man let out a beastly howl and crouched, clutching his leg . Haruka was disturbed by the stronger-than-expected effect and she dropped the hammer to the floor .

'Masato-kun . Let's go . '

Haruka pulled Masato's hand, passed by the man and flew out the infirmary .

She went out the corridor and climbed up the stairs in front of her .

The man chased after them, dragging his foot .

They ran in the dark . She was reaching her limit . The muscles in her legs were screaming .

When they reached the third floor, Haruka turned around . She could hear footsteps but couldn't see anybody . It appeared they'd gotten fairly far .

Masato was almost in tears .

He was probably afraid . Truthfully, Haruka was afraid herself . If she hadn't been gripping Masato's hand, she would have already been crying .

'You can do it!'

Haruka encouraged Masato and ran down the third floor corridor . She put her hand on a door that she spotted .

In any case, she had to buy time until Yakumo got here .

Please open!

Her wish got through . Haruka and Masato flew into the room, closed the door and locked it from inside .

She looked around . Wooden bookshelves were lined up neatly . It was the library .

She sighed in a moment of relief when she heard the approaching sound of a foot being dragged .

Haruka hugged Masato tightly . She could feel Masato's heart beating quickly .

Please . Pass by us .

Going against Haruka's wish, her mobile phone rang . It was so sudden she thought her heart would stop .

Haruka pressed the call button and stopped the ringing .

Silence –

Good . He didn't appear to have noticed .

<Where are you now?>

When she put the phone to her ear, she heard Yakumo's voice .

Her nervousness left her all at once . She held back from crying .

'The third floor library . Please hurry . '

Haruka covered her mouth with her hand so that her voice wouldn't carry .

<I'm at the entrance now . I'll be there soon, so wait . >

He hung up .

They were saved . Yakumo was coming .

As if to smash Haruka's relief, the opposite door opened .

She saw a man peek in from the gap between the bookshelves and walk closer, dragging his foot behind him .

Even though Yakumo was almost here, they were going to be found .

Masato was shaking as he held his head in his arms . The moment Haruka saw that, she realised what she had to do .

Strangely, she didn't hesitate .

She gripped the red stone on her necklace tightly .

Yakumo . Lend me just a bit of courage again .

'Masato-kun, the man you met before is going to come here soon, so just wait 'til then, OK?'

After Haruka patted Masato's head, she jumped out from the bookshelves before she heard his response .

The man's burnt face was right in front of her .

He had been much closer than she thought . She stopped breathing in her surprise .

Haruka backed away, putting distance between them .

When the man reached out to try to grab Haruka, she stooped, ran around the bookshelf and appeared behind the man .

The man immediately turned around and chased after Haruka .

Haruka went to the door, keeping a certain distance between her and the man .

A bit more . I need to keep his attention –

Haruka opened the library door behind her with her hand and went out into the corridor .

'Agh!'

The man screamed and tried to strike her .

Haruka dodged and started running .

When she looked behind her, the man was chasing her with an incredibly enraged expression, even while dragging his foot .

It went well . She wanted to put as much distance between Masato and that man as possible .

She went down the stairs frantically . There were two sets of stairs – one on the north side and one on the south side of the school building . If she were lucky, she might meet Yakumo on the way up .

However, she discarded that hope when she got to the second floor .

If Yakumo had been coming up this set of stairs, they would have met already . But she was almost at the first floor . It'd work out somehow if she got outside .

The moment Haruka thought that and relaxed, she tripped .

She lost her balance, tumbled down the stairs and collapsed in the corridor with her face to the ground .

I need to get away quickly –

Just as she pushed herself off the ground and stood up, somebody grabbed her hair from behind her .

'Let go . '

Haruka turned around, but it was no use . The man dragged her down the corridor .

I think it's too late for me –

30

– Haruka-sensei left .

Masato hugged his knees as he shook in fear .

Why did Haruka-sensei try to save someone like me? Why –

He asked that in his heart, but nobody responded to his question .

I'm a cursed kid . I don't need to be saved . It's natural for me to die – but then why am I shaking here –

– Haruka-sensei's going to be killed by that guy . Like Komai-sensei .

It's all my fault .

It's because I wanted Dad to disappear –

After Mum left, Dad started hitting me .

He must have been lonely . Dad didn't hit me when Mum was around .

If Mum comes back, Dad won't hit me anymore . That's what I thought .

And I was lonely too .

Mum disappeared so suddenly .

I couldn't ask why –

After a few months, Komai-sensei started coming to my house .

Dad stopped being violent .

There was still a hole in my heart .

'Could Sensei become your mum?'

Komai-sensei said that .

I said, 'No way . '

It wasn't because I hated Sensei . It's just that only one person can be my mum .

I want to meet Mum –

I thought that Dad knew where she was, so I took a peek at Dad's notebook when he was out and found Mum's address .

I sneaked out of school and went to meet her in secret .

Mum was in the next city . I went suddenly to surprise her, but I couldn't .

Mum was with a man I didn't know . And she was smiling –

I was so lonely and had cried so much, but Mum was smiling .

I realised that Mum wouldn't ever come back .

Then, I met that guy .

I'd fought with Dad and was crying in the park .

'If you make him take this medicine, your dad will disappear . '

That's what he said when he gave me a bottle full of medicine .

'Really?'

'Really . Then your mum will come back . '

'Mum will...'

Come back –

If Dad disappears and Mum comes back, nothing would be better .

I did as that guy said and put the medicine in the beer Dad drank .

When Dad drank the beer, he fell to his side and stopped moving . I was panicking when that guy came .

'What a bad boy . You killed your father . '

'Killed... I did...'

'That's right . You made him take that medicine and killed him . You're a cursed kid . '

I didn't think that disappearing meant dying . But –

I just wanted to live normally like I had before .

What should I have done?

My stomach hurts . My chest stings . I feel like my head's going to split in half .

– Somebody, save me . Please save me .

Something black is swelling up inside of me . If this continues –

I think I'll break .

31

Gotou parked his car in front of the building with <Sasaki Mental Health>, went up three flights of stairs and opened the door .

The lights were on .

He passed the reception to stand in front of the counselling room in the back .

'I'm coming in,' said Gotou as he opened the door .

Ishii was standing by the window . He was gagged and his left hand was handcuffed to the window frame .

He's in awful condition –

When Gotou tried to approach him, Ishii squirmed about as if to tell him not to .

He was yelling something from behind his gag, but Gotou couldn't hear him .

'Calm down . '

Gotou walked to Ishii and stooped over .

'Good evening . '

Somebody spoke from behind him . This voice –

When he turned around, he saw Anna smiling there . This woman . She looked so damn composed .

'Everything's over already . '

Gotou stood up and approached her .

The next moment, he felt something cold in his stomach .

It went through his skin deep into his flesh .

The red-hot pain ran through his whole body .

The cold changed to burning heat in the blink of an eye . When he looked down, he saw a knife stabbing into the left side of his stomach .

The blood coming out dyed his white shirt red .

Anna pulled the knife out of Gotou's stomach .

At the same time as a paralysing pain, blood burst out like a fountain .

This was no good . The strength was leaving his body . Gotou collapsed to his knees on the carpet, unable to take it .

When he looked up while putting pressure on the wound on his stomach, he saw Anna looking down at him like she found the scene amusing . This sadist –

'You know, I hate people who don't keep promises . I remember telling Yakumo-kun to come alone . '

Anna poked Gotou's forehead with her finger .

She was a completely different person from before . A wolf in sheep's clothing then?

Anna stabbed the bloody knife into the table . It looked just like a gravestone .

I felt like I wouldn't meet Yakumo again before I came here . Is that what it meant –

'Ishii-san, this is just like your dream . '

Anna looked at Ishii and let out a vulgar giggle .

Ishii looked down and averted his teary eyes .

What an idiot . You were supposed to glare right back at the other party at times like this . You'd be looked down on otherwise .

'The plan we'd laid out has all gone to waste because of you . In exchange, please let me have some fun . '

Anna mercilessly kicked Gotou's nose with her foot .

Gotou couldn't brace himself and fell backwards .

'Da...mn...'

Damn . He couldn't speak .

Anna looked down at Gotou .

'My, how pitiful . It must hurt . Your body won't move like you want it to, right?'

Damn . Damn . Damn . This woman . He'd definitely give her a good punch!

'Ishii-san can't reach the phone . Gotou-san won't be able to move at all in this condition . It's a desperate situation . Will you be able to escape?'

Anna crossed her arms and smiled victoriously .

Oi, oi . Was this a joke? Gotou tried to stand up . Just as he got the top half of his body up, he lost his balance and fell back down .

'My, you're more energetic than I expected . '

After Anna said that, she stepped on Gotou's stomach wound twice with her heel .

'Aagh . '

That hurts, you bastard .

He tried to shout, but blood came out of his mouth .

'Ah, that's right . There's something I wanted to say to Yakumo-kun . Could you tell him for me? Ah, but Gotou-san will be no good . Since you're going to die . '

Anna walked to Ishii and murmured something in his ear .

The moment he heard it, Ishii's eyes went wide in shock .

What? What the hell did she say? While Gotou was thinking, Anna said, 'Well, good luck,' and she left the room briskly .

With a face that could cry any minute now, Ishii looked at Gotou .

A cold sweat ran down his body . His vision was becoming hazier and he was losing consciousness .

This is seriously bad –

32

Yakumo took the stairs up to the third floor and rushed into the library .

The bookshelves were lined up and he couldn't see anybody .

'Where are you?'

He spoke, but there was no response .

When he strained his ears, he could faintly hear somebody stifling tears .

Relying on the voice, Yakumo went to the bookshelf in the very back and peered behind it . He saw Masato sitting there hugging his news .

He's OK –

'Hey . I came to lift your curse, like I promised . '

When Yakumo spoke, Masato lifted his tearstained face .

This kid had really had a ridiculous burden on his shoulders . When Yakumo saw the boy's expression, he felt that all over again .

'That's a lie! A lie! My curse can't be lifted!' yelled Masato in a temper .

'There's no curse that can't be lifted . '

'Everyone dies! I killed them! Dad and Komai-sensei too! I killed everyone!'

As Masato shouted even more, he hit Yakumo's chest with both hands .

Yakumo accepted the hits and embraced Masato tightly .

The darkness this boy is burdened with is, just like she said, similar to mine .

But who he's really like isn't me but her .

This kid was cursed because he killed his father . She was cursed because she killed her older sister .

That's why I couldn't leave this kid alone . Unconsciously, I put the darkness this kid's in together with the darkness I used to have .

'OK? Listen up . You didn't kill anyone . '

Yakumo said that while still hugging Masato . At the same time, Masato stopped moving .

'I...'

'Masato . What you made your father take was just regular sleeping medicine . That was a trap to make you think you killed your father . '

'A trap...'

Yakumo nodded silently .

'Masato, you didn't kill anybody . '

It was clear from Hata's component analysis .

The medicine this kid had had just been a sleep-inducing drug . However, Ushijima Atsushi used that to make it seem like Masato had killed his own father .

Kids of this age would probably think at least once that it'd be better if their fathers disappeared, without knowing the true meaning .

He'd cowardly used that chance .

He'd probably planned on killing this kid too if he was in the way . Like he killed his own father – who would he have tried to change into then?

Yakumo buried his anger in the pit of his stomach and wiped away Masato's tears with his finger .

This kid had really done his best .

This little body had suffered so much it wouldn't have been strange if he cracked . Yakumo had suffered a lot himself, but he'd had Isshin beside him .

But this kid was alone . No, that's not right . She was there –

That meddler might have been this kid's support, even if it was just a little .

'Where'd she go?'

'She told me to stay here... She left the classroom... Because of me, Sensei...'

Masato's expression twisted again . Tears started welling up too .

'Don't cry any more . It's something she chose to do herself . It's not your fault . '

Yakumo patted Masato's head .

That idiot . She could've stuck around a bit longer . Did she act as a decoy to protect Masato?

Since she's so slow, there's a strong possibility that she got caught . Now, what to do –

There was no time to search the huge school building . He'd have to get them to come out then .

Yakumo gripped Masato's two shoulders with resolve .

'I said this before, but I'm cursed just like you . '

'Cursed?'

Yakumo nodded, took out the contact lens in his left eye and looked at Masato with his deep red eye .

Masato was so surprised his body jolted . However, he didn't seem scared . There was envy in his gaze .

'OK, Masato? Curses are in people's hearts . '

'Hearts?'

Masato repeated Yakumo's words .

'That's right . Hearts . '

Yakumo put his finger to Masato's chest .

'Whether you lift the curse or not is up to your heart . Got it?'

Masato nodded silently .

All right . What a strong kid –

33

Haruka lay beside Konno on the infirmary floor .

Her mouth was covered with packing tape and her hands and legs were bound with that packing tape as well . She couldn't move .

A caterpillar could have moved more freely than she could .

The muscles in her body hurt . That man had kicked her a number of times while still holding on to her hair and dragged her here .

Nausea and the chills assaulted her in turns . She didn't have the will to fight back any more .

I wonder if Yakumo met up with Masato – that was her only concern .

The man brought rectangular cans from somewhere . Of course he spilled the liquid inside on the floor, but he poured it on Konno and Haruka too .

She could tell what that liquid was without asking from the smell . It was gasoline –

When Haruka realised what that man was trying to do, she felt like cold water had been dumped on her .

He was probably going to burn the whole school down, along with Haruka and Konno .

Terror rushed through her . She felt like giving up .

Konno let out a groan beside her and was shifting about in an attempt to escape .

However, the man spotted him immediately .

Without any hesitation, the man stomped on Konno's face . Again and again . He stomped on him until he stopped moving .

I was taken prisoner like this before . Yakumo saved my life then .

But it really might not work this time –

Crackle .

The sound of static came out from the installed speaker .

The man's hand stopped as he looked around .

After the static, there was a click sound and then a voice came out of the speaker .

<Ah, ah... Seems like it's working . >

This was Yakumo's voice . He really had come .

He was probably using the emergency building announcement system in the staff room .

<Ushijima Atsushi-san, you're there, right?>

The man responded visibly to Yakumo's voice .

This man's name is Ushijima Atsushi – but that person should have died twenty-eight years ago .

<I have a proposal for you . Could you return the clumsy girl you've got there? If you do, I'll hand over Oomori Masato-kun and the VTR data . >

What was Yakumo saying?

Exchange with Masato? If they did that, he'd be killed . She tried to say that, but she couldn't since her mouth was covered .

Even if she could say it, her voice wouldn't reach him .

<Let's both stop playing tricks . If you kill her before we meet, I'll immediately inform the police . Of course, if you follow through with your promise, I will never disclose what I know . What do you think? It isn't a bad proposal . >

The man stared at the speaker on the wall seriously .

<I'll be waiting by the pool outside . Within ten minutes... click . >

The voice was cut off .

What was Yakumo thinking?

Haruka didn't want to be saved if Masato's life would be sacrificed .

Was Yakumo OK with that?

Haruka's thoughts were interrupted when somebody suddenly grabbed her hair .

The man took the packing tape off of Haruka's feet, forced her to stand and dragged her out of the infirmary .

34

Why did things turn out like this –

Ishii lost himself in a sea of regret .

He had spent the most time with Anna, but she'd made him dance around without him even noticing her true nature .

Plus, if he had just run away immediately when he got the call from Yakumo, things wouldn't have ended up like this .

His mistake would be paid for with Gotou's life . Ishii couldn't stand it .

Ishii pulled his handcuffed left hand with as much strength as he could muster . He pulled at it again and again .

Each time, the handcuff dug into his wrist, making a wave of pain shoot through him . However, the essential handcuff and the window frame it was attached to didn't budge at all .

Even if he wanted to call for help, the closest phone was on the desk .

He stretched his arm out so far he thought it would snap, but he couldn't even reach it with his fingers . It was no good –

For the past while, Gotou hadn't been moving from his collapsed position .

Ishii could tell he was barely alive, since his arm would move up and down faintly .

The blood loss was awful . If he was left like this, he probably wouldn't hang on much longer .

Ishii crouched on the carpet and dug his fingernails into it, feeling helpless .

His body shook and tears spilled from his eyes .

– How can I be so powerless?

In front of Ishii's eyes was the knife, sticking up from the table .

His hand could probably reach that knife .

Now that he thought about it, all he had done was cause Gotou trouble .

He'd tried his best to be even the slightest bit useful, but every time, he'd just spun his wheels around fruitlessly and tripped . Then, Gotou saved him again .

It was just an endless cycle of that .

Even though Gotou complained, he didn't abandon Ishii – he kept with him .

Ishii couldn't let somebody who'd saved him die .

Compared to Gotou's life, a left hand or two of his is nothing .

With strong determination, Ishii used his feet to get close to the table . All right . It went well .

He took the knife out of the table with his right hand and put it to his left wrist .

His hand was shaking . It would probably hurt . A lot of blood would come out too . But this was the only way to get out of this situation .

Ishii gripped the knife tightly .

A cold feeling ran through his skin . He was scared – but he had to do it .

The moment Ishii was about to draw the knife, a dull shock came down on the crown of his head . When he looked up, he saw Gotou standing there .

'Do . . n't... do some...thing...stu...pid . '

Gotou said that in feeble breaths . Then, he took the gag off of Ishii .

'D-Detective Gotou!'

Gotou didn't respond to Ishii's shout . He just staggered over to the desk, picked up the phone and threw it at Ishii .

Clunk . The phone fell within Ishii's reach .

Gotou smiled in satisfaction and then collapsed backwards .

'D-Detective Gotou!'

35

The man dragged Haruka by the hair past the locker room to the first lane of the pool .

The round moon was reflected on the dirty water surface and rippled .

The man let go of Haruka . Her strength left her and she fell right to the ground . There was a large puddle there .

It appeared that Yakumo and Masato weren't here yet . She couldn't see them .

To tell the truth, Haruka didn't want to die either, but she also wished that Yakumo and Masato wouldn't come .

The man had stood still for a moment, but then he grabbed Haruka's hair and pulled her along again .

It appeared that he didn't like the location . This was the only entrance to the pool . If Yakumo and Masato came, they'd definitely run into them . That was probably why .

The man went to the sixth lane, pushed Haruka down there and skilfully bound Haruka's feet with packing tape using only his right hand .

When he was doing that, he took out a cloth cord and tied it to Haruka's left foot .

'It appears that I have made you wait . '

It was Yakumo's voice .

Yakumo appeared at the entrance like he had risen to the surface .

Masato was next to him . His hands were behind his back . Did Yakumo tie his hands so he wouldn't run –

The man stared at Yakumo, who stood in front of the first lane .

It looked like he was smiling slightly .

– Please! Don't come here!

Haruka tried to scream, but the packing tape got in the way and her words were unclear .

'Tobe Kengo-san . Ah, that's incorrect . Ushijima Atsushi-san, correct? No, that's wrong too...'

It was like Yakumo was speaking to himself .

'Shut up...' said the man in a low voice .

'You aren't anybody . '

Yakumo pointed straight at the man .

Like the man was sensitive to the meaning of those words, his shoulders were heaving in agitation . However, Yakumo paid that no attention and continued talking .

'Well, it doesn't matter who you are . In any case, let us deal with business . How about we both leave our prisoners where they are and switch places?'

After thinking, the man nodded silently .

Yakumo took the SD card that Masato had had out of his pocket, showed it to the man, and the put it in Masato's trouser pocket .

'I will say this again, but let's both not play any tricks . '

Yakumo stepped forward .

The man took one step forward in response .

The two of them slowly closed the distance between then .

The two passed each other at the third lane . That moment, the man turned around with a victorious smile .

Haruka thought back on what had happened and looked at her own feet . There was a cloth cord tied there .

The man was holding onto the end of the cord . Her body was drenched in gasoline . This was a fuse –

Yakumo continued walking towards her with no expression on his face .

– Yakumo-kun, don't!

Haruka's shout didn't become words .

'Honestly . You're such a pain . '

Yakumo had his finger in his ear and the usual sleepy expression on his face .

– That's not it, Yakumo-kun .

Yakumo helped Haruka up from where she had collapsed on the floor .

The man had reached Masato . Then, he turned around and, though he didn't laugh aloud, he was definitely smiling .

The man took out a lighter . It's dangerous –

Haruka squirmed frantically .

'Like I said, you're such a pain . '

Yakumo took the packing tape off Haruka's mouth all at once . It hurt, but it wasn't the time for that .

'My body's doused in gasoline! A fuse is attached to my foot! Run! Get away from me!'

In response to Haruka's frantic scream, Yakumo smirked and said one thing –

'I know . '

'Eh?'

The man lit the cord .

The fire ran towards them .

Yakumo picked Haruka up and then threw her .

She felt like her body was floating when she landed in the water .

Water rushed in through her nose . Her hands and legs were bound . She was going to drown like this .

She was struggling when her feet reached the pool's bottom . When she stood up, her chest and up was out of the water .

This was an elementary school pool . An adult could stand normally, so she wouldn't drown .

Yakumo reached out from the side of the pool and pulled Haruka out .

Yakumo laughed as he saw Haruka, completely drenched and having a coughing fit .

What a person . Wasn't there a better way to save her? He must have done it on purpose .

'It's unfortunate . Your plot was transparent . '

Yakumo turned towards the man and looked at him with contempt . She could tell the man was tightly gripping his right fist .

Yakumo, you can't provoke him . Masato is still there .

'Masato-kun! Run!'

Masato just looked down when Haruka yelled . He didn't make any response . Why wouldn't he run –

'You've misunderstood something . '

Eh?'

'Did you think that I would really exchange hostages?'

'That's...'

'Don't misjudge me . '

Yakumo said just that and then turned to Masato again .

'Masato! Do it now!' Yakumo yelled .

Masato looked up at the voice . He had the face of a determined and tense man .

Masato raised the two hands that had been behind his back .

Now Haruka understood . Yakumo hadn't tied Masato's hands . He had them behind his back so it would look like that .

In Masato's hands was something that looked like a black cord . Masato threw the end of that cord to the man's feet .

There was a snapping sound .

After the man's body shook, he fell down face-up –

There was a puddle there . Masato had been holding an electric cord . So that was what they were doing . Haruka finally understood .

'I wanted to make it seem as if we came late, but I actually arranged this before the announcement,' said Yakumo as he undid the packing tape around Haruka's hands and feet .

I see –

Haruka had had nothing to worry about . Everything had been part of Yakumo's plan .

Now that her hands and feet were free, Haruka looked up to see Masato slowly approaching her .

Masato walked up to Haruka and stopped there, looking down . His shoulders were shaking slightly .

'You did really well . You lifted your curse yourself . You can cry now . '

Yakumo smiled gently as he patted Masato's head .

At that, Masato burst into tears and flew into Haruka's arms .

Haruka hugged him tightly and stroked Masato's back .

It's all right now . You don't have to hold back any more .

Haruka looked up and saw that man's face in front of her .

At some point, he had regained consciousness . His bloodshot eyes were wide open and he was shaking with anger as he raised his right hand .

He was gripping a knife .

That's –

'Let's end this already . '

Yakumo stood between Haruka and the man as a wall .

'Yakumo-kun, run . '

Yakumo turned his head at Haruka's shout and then grabbed the man's wrist . Then –

'You wanted love, right?'

He said that in a sorrowful voice .

That moment, the man's eyes, which had been glaring up until now, seemed to lose all their strength .

'You weren't loved by your mother . She abused you terribly . Though he had the same father, he lived in a completely different family environment . That's why you wanted to become Tobe Kengo . '

Haruka didn't know what was going on with this case .

However, Yakumo probably understood everything . This man might have also been carrying a terrible darkness, even if he hadn't intended on doing so .

'What do you know...'

The man said that to Yakumo's question .

Unexpectedly, his voice was hoarse and weak .

'I hate your face . I hate your voice . She said that and then hit me, kicked me, pulled my hair, burnt me with cigarettes . If I cried, she hit me again, but if I kept quiet, she kicked me . Every day, every day, every day that continued . What do you know?'

'I wasn't loved by my parents either . My mother tried to kill me . '

'Wha...'

The man looked surprised .

Yakumo was also somebody who had a dark past even though he hadn't wanted it .

'However, I can't understand your feelings at all . '

Yakumo had overcome that suffering, so the excuse 'I wasn't loved' wouldn't work .

Haruka looked up past Yakumo's back at the man's face .

His burnt cheek was twitching .

'I just wanted to live normally . Normally, without being hit or kicked . I'm just a person like everyone else, so what's wrong with that!?'

Anybody chased into painful circumstances would think the same as this man . Why is it only me –

'Is that why you killed them? You must have noticed yourself . Even if you impersonate other people, you wouldn't gain love . It's impossible to change somebody just by changing their name . You aren't Oomori Hironori or Tobe Kengo . '

'You're wrong! You're wrong!'

The man shook free of Yakumo's arms and raised the knife again while yelling .

'Then who are you?' said Yakumo sharply .

The man stopped moving . He just stared at Yakumo's eyes .

'No matter how undesirable the circumstances, people just have to live with it . '

After Yakumo said that, he took Masato's hand and made him stand up opposite the man .

'Please take a good look at this kid . '

The man looked dubious .

It was like he didn't understand what Yakumo was saying . Haruka herself wasn't sure what Yakumo was trying to do .

'This kid's mother left home with the lover she had an affair with . His father took out his anger on this kid by hitting him . Even so, this kid didn't run away – he continued living his own life . '

Masato had his hands in tight fists . That was right . This child had been burdened with terrible hardships and kept it inside himself as he fervently

fought back .

'This kid suffered the same as you did, but you burdened him with more suffering . Do you understand what you've done?'

'I won't run . It's hard and it's painful, but... I won't run!' yelled Masato, squaring his shoulders .

'Aaah!'

The man howled, like he was trying to erase those words .

However, Yakumo and Masato were unfazed as they stood there .

'I will ask once more . Who are you?'

At Yakumo's last words, the hand that the man had been holding up – dropped the knife .

'I'm... Atsushi . Ushijima Atsushi...'

After the man muttered that, he crouched there and started sobbing . He looked as frail as a child being scolded by his mother .

'Everything's OK now . '

Yakumo turned back towards Haruka and held out his hand .

'Thank you . '

Haruka took Yakumo's hand and stood up .

'Masato . You did well . The curse had been lifted . '

Masato shook his head at Yakumo's words . His eyes were brimming with tears .

'I tried to kill Dad . Even if I didn't actually kill him, I wanted him to die . So, so...'

Haruka didn't know the details of the case .

Nevertheless, she understood how Masato felt .

He probably participated some way in his father's death . That childish hate had sprouted from the pain of not being loved .

Haruka hugged Masato as tightly as she could .

'I said this before, OK? I... also killed somebody . '

Masato's body jolted at Haruka's words .

Haruka had thought that she was comparing Masato to Yakumo, but she had been wrong . The darkness Masato held was the same as her own .

'I killed my sister . I was jealous of my older twin sister and threw the ball a bit far away to trouble her . My sister went to get it and was hit by a car...'

She said all that at once and then looked at Masato's face .

He was biting his lower lip and looking straight at Haruka's eyes . She was able to face Masato for the first time . That was how she felt .

However, she didn't know what to say next .

'Masato . No matter who it is, everyone has some degree of hate . However, there's a big difference between people who act on it and people who don't . Do you understand?'

Yakumo expressed Haruka's feelings for her . Masato nodded .

'Masato, you might have thought it'd be OK if your dad disappeared, but you didn't want him to die . Right?'

Masato nodded .

Suddenly, Haruka saw a boy standing by the pool entrance .

It was the child who led Haruka to the classroom .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . That child...'

For a moment, Yakumo was surprised by what Haruka said, but then he had his usual sleepy expression on his face .

'You can see him too?'

Yakumo took a pause before continuing .

'That's the kid who died in the fire twenty-eight years ago . The real Tobe Kengo . He finally got back the name that was stolen for him . Though it's a bit late...'

That boy smiled from cheek to cheek and then disappeared .

Then, a burnt Ultraman doll fell where the boy had been standing .

Haruka didn't understand what Yakumo said .

That kid had probably been released from what had been binding him . That was how she felt –

NOTES:

[1] In the novel, they use the kanji for shirou (屍蠟) here wherein shi means corpse and rou means wax .

Volume 4 Chapter 4: Epilogue.

Volume 5 Chapter 0: Prologue

VOLUME 5 – CONNECTED FEELINGS prologue ()

‘Fifteen years ago, a terrible and bizarre murder occurred at this house.’

At the sign of Hoshino, the cameraman and director, Yuki, the reporter, started speaking towards the camera.

Though it was a camera, it wasn’t one for business use but a home-use Handycam[1], often used when variety shows shot on location. There was nothing a late-night show with a low budget could do.

Maruyama took a cross out from the pocket of his worship clothes and gripped it with both hands.

A cold wind was blowing –

Having a psychic special at a time like this could only be a prank. However, he had to endure it. Appearing on television like this was good publicity.

Maruyama sniffled and stood firm.

‘Today, not a single person has approached this house.’

Yuki looked up at the second floor and pointed. Maruyama looked up as well.

It was a huge house.

He didn’t know what sort of plan the owner had had, but to put it plainly, it was creepy. The house had a pointed roof and the wooden pillars were showing.

It looked like some church from the Middle Ages. It didn't match the Japanese scenery.

'There is a rumour that a ghost lurks within this house. Is this the grudge of the murdered victim? Or did the murder occur because this house had been cursed from before?'

Yuki's almond eyes narrowed as she asked these questions.

Hoshino shook the dead branches in front of the garden as planned.

Rustle –

'The answer will be revealed tonight,' said Yuki with a hard expression.

Maruyama looked at the talent called Yuki for the first time. It was mysterious how she had never showed up on stage before.

Skin as pale as porcelain and a straight-edged nose. At first glance, she seemed tidy and trim, but the almond eyes underneath her brow looked like they were challenging men.

Her beauty would make most talents run away with their tails between their legs.

She wasn't bad at speaking either. Of course she recited her lines smoothly, but her voice had a dignified tone to it.

'Today, the exorcist Maruyama-sensei has graced us with his presence.'

Yuki welcomed him.

Maruyama fixed the sleeves of his worship clothes, put on a quiet expression and walked into the frame in front of Yuki.

'My name is Maruyama.'

He bowed with purposeful solemnity.

'Sensei, what is your impression of this house after looking at it?'

After Yuki asked that, Maruyama gripped the cross in front of his chest and closed his eyes silently.

He counted to three in his head and then opened his eyes.

'It's strong. I feel an incredibly strong grudge.'

Maruyama turned his gaze to the house.

'So there really is a ghost in this house?'

Maruyama nodded at Yuki's words.

However, it wasn't as if he really thought that.

Of course Maruyama didn't believe in ghosts, but he didn't believe in gods or devils either. He was gripping a cross, but he thought even the miracle of Christ was idiotic.

He had been in this business for a long time, but he'd never encountered a ghost.

They were just wrong impressions and obsessions. That was what Maruyama felt.

The reason Maruyama was working as an exorcist was that it was profitable. If he said that the people who came to consult him were possessed by evil spirits, they'd pay any amount of money.

He took advantage of people's weaknesses and stole their money. Maruyama knew that he was a swindler.

'There is a spirit here. Please step away from me. It is incredibly dangerous.'

Maruyama stared at the camera as he said those words that he didn't mean.

'Yes, OK. Let's hurry to the next shoot.'

At Hoshino's sign, the camera stopped and they moved to the entrance of the house.

'OK, Yuki-chan, open the door. Then, Sensei, please head in first. We'll decide what to do next from the flow.'

After those incredibly vague instructions, Hoshi handed the key to Yuki and started filming again.

'Now, I'd like to head inside immediately.'

As Yuki said that, she put the key in the keyhole and turned it slowly.

The rusted metal made a scraping sound as the door unlocked.

Yuki looked over pressingly.

Maruyama responded with a nod and slowly pulled the doorknob.

Screech –

It sounded like fingernails on a chalkboard. In response to that, the sparrows in the dead branches let out a sharp cry and flew off all at once.

'Ah!'

Yuki let out a short scream and clung to Maruyama's arm.

Her face was pale. It was like she was actually scared. If he conducted himself well, he might make some delicious memories.

Maruyama buried his wicked thoughts in the pit of his stomach and stepped into the house.

The white light installed on the camera lit the path.

The entrance was an atrium, and the corridor led straight. To the left there was a set of stairs.

Dry leaves and dust had piled up to the point that it couldn't be distinguished from the ground. The walls had yellowed with age and parts of it were peeling off.

Even though it was winter, the air felt damp. However, that just came from the atmosphere.

Maruyama gathered his thoughts and walked straight down the corridor as instructed by Yuki and Hoshino.

Creak, creak, creak –

Every time he stepped on the ground, it creaked.

Maruyama walked to the end of the corridor and stopped.

There was a door in front of him.

'I feel great spiritual power from the other side of this door.'

Maruyama gestured at the door.

The truth was he didn't feel any spiritual power. He'd heard at the meeting that the corpse was found in the living room at the end of the corridor, so he was just matching up with that.

Slip.

There was the sound of something falling down.

Yuki was trembling convulsively.

'... W-who is it?' squeaked Yuki. She sounded like a completely different person.

'What's wrong?'

'J-just now, s-somebody touched m-my shoulder...'

Yuki's eyes were filled with tears.

Maruyama looked around, but besides Hoshino with the camera, nobody was there. Sometimes, people hallucinated things that weren't there because they were caught up by the atmosphere. Yuki was probably that type of person.

Maruyama said that to himself as his heartbeat started accelerating.

'Aahh!'

Suddenly, Hoshino yelled as he jumped.

'What is it?' asked Maruyama, acting calm.

'Just now, somebody touched my neck.'

Hoshino's eyes were wide open in shock.

Was this a joke? It had to be a hallucination. Mass hysteria or something. It was idiotic.

Click.

Maruyama looked towards the sound.

The door at the end of the corridor that had been closed up until now slowly opened –

This had to be a lie. There was no way something like this was happening. These guys were just taking Maruyama for a ride. He wouldn't be tricked.

Maruyama took deep breaths as he looked into the room.

The light shone down on the floor.

He was startled by what he saw.

The whole floor was dyed black. It was the trace of blood.

Did a murder really happen here?

'No! Stay away!'

Yuki let out a shriek and gripped Maruyama's arm so tightly it hurt.

'It's fine. I'm here.'

Yuki didn't respond to Maruyama's words at all, and her body started convulsing.

The trembling grew stronger and stronger, and she fell to her knees.

'What's wrong?'

Yuki didn't respond to Maruyama's question. She vomited right there and collapsed while clutching at her chest.

Oi, oi. This wasn't happening, right?

As if ridiculing Maruyama in his disturbed state, the lights went out.

It was so dark he couldn't see his fingers –

What was happening? What on earth had happened?

Clang, clang, clang, clang.

The sound of something hitting metal echoed.

'Aah! Stop!'

Hoshino's shout pierced Maruyama's ears.

There, there was a loud noise, but within ten seconds, there was silence.

'Hoshino-san... Hoshino-san...'

Maruyama called out to Hoshino, who had been here just now, and he put both his hands out to look for him.

Clunk.

There was the sound of something falling to the floor.

Maruyama was drenched with sweat. It was hard to breathe.

What is this feeling –

Maruyama had completely lost himself in the dark.

Something brushed Maruyama's back.

Haa, haa, haa –

Maruyama was breathing erratically. He started running, not knowing where he was going. However, he soon tripped on something and fell forward.

He didn't feel any pain.

Anyway, he had to get out of here as soon as he could.

Maruyama raised his head as he tried to get up, and in front of his eyes – a woman's face came hazily into view.

That face was covered in blood.

He had reached his limit.

'Aaaaahh!'

Maruyama screamed and fainted.

[1] A Handycam is a brand of camcorders made by Sony. is the Sony Japan website for it.

Volume 5 Chapter 1: VOLUME 5 – CONNECTED FEELINGS

Chapter 1

VOLUME 5 – CONNECTED FEELINGS

file 01: missing (TRANSLATION NOTES)

—

1

Hijikata Makoto treaded firmly along the sloping road .

The road was narrow and winding . Fallen branches narrowed the road, making it seem thick .

A wind was blowing —

She wore a down coat and gloves, but her exposed ears hurt so much it felt like they might come off .

Makoto stopped walking and turned around . The shopping district and apartment buildings looked like miniatures .

She took a hand warmer out from her pocket and put it against her cheek and ear . After she had warmed up a bit, she started walking again .

She would arrive at her destination soon .

Makoto was going to a house where a murder occurred fifteen years ago .

Her boss had instructed her through email to take photos of the scene .

If possible, she wanted to write the story . She typed a reply email along those lines, but she hadn't gotten a response .

Until half a year ago, she had been a police reporter . However, that had been because her father was the chief of police rather than because of her own ability .

To prove that, when her father resigned from the police, she was taken out of the journalism scene and put into the planning department .

There was no sense of emergency . She gathered material for suspicious articles that might not even be used and her boss assigned her tasks that were essentially odd jobs .

She was going in a considerably different direction than the one she had aimed for . However, that didn't mean she cut corners . That would make her just the daughter of the ex-chief of the police .

While Makoto was being sentimental, she saw the end of the sloping road .

She saw a house with a brick wall and black iron gate .

It was much bigger than she had imagined .

She had walked because she'd thought there would be no place to park, but she could have just driven here .

The building that imitated a Tudor Renaissance church had a pointed roof and showed its wooden pillars .

It was in an area of heavy snowfall so it had been built to be strong against snow . A building of this sort had double walls to keep in the heat, but each of those walls was thin . It wasn't strong and didn't have good soundproofing .

So they could hear the screams outside —

Makoto took a digital camera out of her bag and took many shots, changing the angle and zooming .

She checked the images she took on the screen .

The house was built like a church . The large premises encompassed it . Coupled with the lone tree in its autumn colours in the corner of the garden, it was just like a painting .

Did a murder really occur here fifteen years ago – it made you doubt that .

It began with a report from A-ko-san who lived on the corner .

Fifteen years ago, February tenth . 12:07 AM . A-ko-san reported to the police that she heard a scream from the next house .

At the time, Nanase Kanji and his wife lived in this house, along with their eldest son Katsuaki and his wife . Katsuaki's daughter Miyuki also lived there to make five .

The Nanase family had owned the nearby land for generations . Kanji had made a name for himself as the director of the private middle school . There had even been rumours he would step into the world of politics .

The first to arrive at the scene was Detective Miyagawa, on his way back .

He met with A-ko-san at the scene and received an explanation of the events .

Miyagawa determined that it was an emergency and went to the Nanase premises to confirm the situation before reinforcement arrived .

However, there was no response . Since the front door was open, Miyagawa went inside through the entrance .

In the living room at the end of the corridor, he found the bodies of men and women who had been stabbed repeatedly –

They were Nanase Kanji and his wife and his son Katsuaki and his wife .

Just as Miyagawa was heading for the entrance to call for help, he spotted Miyuki, Katsuaki's daughter . He tried to secure her, but someone hit his head and he fainted .

Reinforcements found him collapsed in the corridor and he was taken to the hospital . Fortunately, it wasn't life threatening .

However, by the time reinforcements arrived, they couldn't find Miyuki and was thought to have been kidnapped by the perpetrator .

The investigation division was immediately mobilised, and an investigation from a robbery and enmity angle started .

Miyagawa had seen the perpetrator, so a speedy resolution had been expected, but because of his head injury, he had lost the memory of the incident .

Makoto passed the gate and walked down a brick path to the entrance .

The garden had probably had grass growing in it, but now it was knee-high with weeds .

After that case, nobody would buy this house .

Not only that – there was a rumour that you could hear screams when the time of the murder rolled around, and the first person to report the crime, A-ko-san, moved away as well .

Since nothing valuable had been stolen, the police earnestly continuing the investigation narrowed it down to possible suspects with grudges .

There were many people who disliked Nanase Kanji, so the names of many suspects came up .

Finally, they found conclusive evidence .

Fingerprints left at the scene matched one of the suspects, Takeda Shunsuke, who had been thirty at the time .

Furthermore, the victim's blood had been on the fingerprint, so it was clear that Takeda had been there after the crime occurred .

Takeda also didn't go along voluntarily for questioning from the police during the investigation .

He had no clear alibi, and they got testimony that said he had visited the victim's house on the day of the incident .

The police determined that Takeda Shunsuke was the murderer . They got an arrest warrant and went to the apartment where Takeda lived . However, Takeda had already disappeared .

A knife with the blood of the victim was found at his flat . The police put Takeda on the nationwide wanted list .

However, the earnest investigation was futile . Even now, there was no news of Miyuki, let alone any trace of Takeda .

After reaching the entrance, Makoto took another photo with her camera .

The formerly white walls were now completely yellow with age and spotted with black .

If it were raining and thundering, it would look like it had come out of a horror movie .

Creak .

There was the sound of metal on metal . When she looked over, she saw that the front door was slightly open .

But I was told that it'd be locked and I wouldn't be able to go inside –

Makoto peeked inside through the gap between the door and the wall . However, she couldn't see well in the dark .

She took out her handkerchief, wrapped it around the doorknob and slowly pulled the door open .

The outside light lit up the stairs to the second floor and the dusty corridor .

When Makoto squinted, she spotted footsteps going down the corridor .

‘Is anyone here?’

Just as Makoto spoke up, there was the sound of something falling .

‘Ah!’

She leapt reflexively from surprise .

– Somebody’s inside .

Makoto pulled herself together and walked through the front door .

She felt something at her feet . She looked down to see a Handycam video camera .

Why’s something like this here –

She stooped to pick it up when somebody passed behind her .

Something cold pierced through to her core .

Though she was terrified, Makoto slowly raised her head and looked forward .

She saw something black at the end of the hall .

What is that?

While she was thinking, that object fell sideways and changed direction .

It’s a person . A woman – she was very weak and her face was pale .

Her eyes met Makoto’s . Her cracked, purple lips moved slightly .

‘He... lp... me...’

After orchestra circle practice ended, Haruka quickly put her beloved flute away in its case and left the music room .

She refused a friend's invitation to lunch and headed on foot to the prefabricated two-storey building in the back of Building B .

Each floor of the building was lined with ten small rooms which were lent out for circle activity use by the university .

The room she was headed for was at the very back of the first floor .

There was a plate on the door which read <Movie Research Circle>, but that was just a cover – no circle activities were held .

Here stayed the eccentric man Saitou Yakumo . He had tricked the school and was living here .

Normally, he hid it with a colour contact lens, but Yakumo's left eye was red and had the unique ability to see the spirits of the dead .

Haruka had first met Yakumo about a year ago –

She had become acquainted with him when he helped her with her friend Miki, who had been possessed by a ghost .

Every time she met up with him, he complained, saying things like 'Do you have nothing better to do?' and 'Are you an idiot?' , but to Haruka, being together with Yakumo was as natural and comfortable as watching television with her family .

Perhaps it was because she didn't have to pretend with him .

Still, why was it?

Her heart was beating wildly and her palms were sweaty . Why was she nervous to meet him?

It wasn't that difficult . She just had to say one thing: 'We're putting on a performance soon, so come if you have the time . '

Since it was him, he'd just say something like 'I refuse' and that'd be the end of it .

She was nervous because she had strange hopes . But if she knew she was going to get rejected, why was she asking – she didn't know herself .

The only reason she felt strange now was because she had been thinking about bringing up that topic .

And what would happen if he came to the performance anyway? It didn't matter anymore . Haruka forced the contradiction within her to the pit of her stomach and forcefully opened the door .

Yakumo's here –

He sat in his usual chair and had sleepy eyes and messy hair as usual . Even though he was inside a room, he was wearing a down coat and was shivering .

He could just buy a heater . That was what Haruka thought, but she didn't say it aloud . He'd definitely say 'Then you buy one' if she did .

'H-hey . '

Haruka greeted him in a bright voice and sat in the opposite chair .

Yakumo raised his left eyebrow in response . He looked displeased, like a cat that had had its nap disturbed .

'Yes, yes, I have a lot of time on my hands,' said Haruka before he could say anything .

How about that? Was he stumped? Haruka could tell what Yakumo wanted to say easily now that she'd known him for a year .

Yakumo scratched his head, put his chin in his hands and looked the other way, seeming irritated that his line was stolen from him .

He was sulking .

'So what trouble do you have for me today?' asked Yakumo was a yawn .

'Stop making it sound like I'm a troublemaker . '

Yakumo spread his hands wide and shook his head exaggeratedly .

'Do you know how many times you've brought trouble to me?'

'That's... I've asked you for help a number of times, but...'

'Five times in a year . Do you understand? Even Michael Jackson doesn't make as much fuss as you do . If you're not a troublemaker, who is?'

Yakumo smirked triumphantly .

'I'm just going to say this, but I didn't bring trouble this time,' said Haruka sharply .

'If it isn't trouble, what are you hiding?'

He really was sharp .

'I-I'm not hiding anything... Why do you think that?'

'Replying to a question with a question is against the rules . '

'You're saying that? That's your special ability, Yakumo-kun . '

Yakumo's cheek twitched and he had an unpleasant expression on his face .

'I said this before, but when you come into the room saying something like "Hey" in a bright voice, it's usually trouble . You force yourself to act cheerful because you've got a guilty conscience . '

What did he mean, guilty conscience?

It really riled her up .

'I don't have a guilty conscience . '

'Then what did you come here for?'

'There's a performance coming up and I just thought I'd ask you to come if you have time . '

She'd ended up saying that in a strong tone .

'Performance? Whose?'

Yakumo's brow was furrowed and he looked grim, like he was facing the mystery of the century .

'Mine . '

'Yours?'

'Didn't I mention this before? I'm in the orchestra circle . '

'I know that . But I don't understand...'

Yakumo crossed his arms like he was pondering something .

'What don't you understand?'

'The reason I would go to your performance . '

The way he said it, it was like he was thinking about the motive behind a murder .

'Obviously it's because we're friends . '

Yakumo's eyes went wide at Haruka's words, like he was surprised .

'Friends? Who?'

'Me and you, Yakumo-kun . Was I wrong...?'

When he said it like that, she felt a bit anxious .

What on earth did Yakumo think of her anyway? Did he really think of her just as a troublemaker?

It was true that she'd brought him a lot of trouble up until now . But she'd done a lot of other things too . She'd helped out with investigations before, and –

Haruka sighed . She didn't care anymore .

She lay down on the table and glared up at Yakumo's face . He was still thinking .

'Even though I thought we were friends all this time...'

She hadn't planned on saying that, but it just came out .

It felt like tears were going to come out too .

'You and I are friends, eh... I've never thought about that . '

Yakumo covered his eyes and scratched at his cheek, like he felt awkward .

Come to think of it, Yakumo had said before that there were only two types of people in this world: those who were afraid of him and those who used him .

He'd been treated badly because of his unique ability ever since he was young . Because of that trauma, he'd built a wall in his heart to separate him from other people .

The decisive event concerned his mother .

When Yakumo was young, his mother tried to kill him . A detective, Gotou, had happened to pass by the scene and saved him . Though Yakumo's life had been saved, his heart had been fatally wounded .

In one year, Haruka had thought she'd gotten a bit closer to Yakumo, but she might have been the only one who thought that way .

'It's fine . I'm leaving . '

Haruka put a smile on her face and stood up .

'When is it?'

Yakumo scratched at the tip of his nose with his finger .

'Eh?'

'Didn't you hear me? I asked what date the performance is on . '

Haruka's expression became less stiff .

'Next Saturday . '

Haruka leant forward in her excitement .

'Where?'

'The school hall . '

'If by some chance I am so bored I could die then and happen for some reason to be nearby, I might go . '

What a roundabout way of saying it . He really wasn't honest at all . But Haruka was happy .

That contrary Yakumo had agreed to her invitation .

'Got it . Come if you're so bored you could die . I'll bring a ticket next time . '

She felt like she had gotten closer to Yakumo, just a tiny bit .

'It's creepy, so wipe that grin off your face now . '

Yakumo frowned at her like he was looking at something dirty .

This person really – wasn't honest .

3

He was really riled up .

Gotou leant back in the passenger seat of the car . He lit his cigarette and threw the lighter at the dashboard .

In the driver's seat, Ishii adjusted the position of his silver-framed glasses with his finger and turned his frightened gaze towards Gotou .

'What're you looking at?'

Gotou's words were close to a threat . Ishii hurriedly looked away .

'Ah, no, nothing in...'

Ishii was flustered, as he always was .

'Say it clearly!'

'Ah, yes sir . Er, you appear to be rather angry...'

Gotou's anger flared up again at Ishii's words .

The Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room that Gotou was assigned to was under the jurisdiction of the police . His work was meant to be the investigation of unsolved cases, as per the name .

However, the instructions this time were for the investigation of a suspicious character near a building that was being demolished .

This was supposed to be the work of uniformed officers at the police station . Since Chief Miyagawa had directly given these instructions, he had to be making them do this on purpose .

He either thought they had a lot of free time or didn't like them .

'Aren't you riled up?'

'Chief Miyagawa is being considerate . '

Ishii was as optimistic as usual .

'Considerate?'

'Yes . Recently, we've just been organising documents so we haven't had a chance to go out . '

'How's that being considerate?'

'Ah, no... . that's...'

Ishii's shoulders went up, like a turtle hiding in his shell .

'What? Just say it already . '

Gotou grabbed Ishii's neck .

'No, er, Chief Miyagawa said that recently you... were... er...'

Ishii's mouth was moving, but Gotou didn't hear the important part .

The guy wasn't reliable at all .

'Say it clearly!'

Gotou's fist paid Ishii's head a visit .

Aaack –

Ishii let out a scream like a cat that had had its tail stepped on . Maybe Gotou would grab him by the collar too .

'That is, er, Miyagawa said that he'd send you out for some exercise...'

'Am I a dog? Don't make it sound like he's taking me for a walk . '

'No, but...'

'What?'

'Chief Miyagawa said that ever since you were hospitalised, Detective Gotou, er... you've gotten fat...'

– Fat .

Gotou looked at his own belly .

There wasn't too much of it, but it wasn't slim . He'd gone up two belt holes . His shirt buttons wouldn't close . His slacks were snug .

He pinched his belly . It was as soft as touching a marshmallow . It felt kind of nice .

'What do you think?'

Gotou looked towards Ishii for his opinion .

'What do I think about what?'

Ishii repeated the question, acting confused .

When the bastard actually knows already –

'Did I, er... get fat?' said Gotou with a cough .

'Honestly?'

'Honestly . '

'You won't hit me?'

'Just get to the point!'

Ishii gave him a distrustful gaze, but he reluctantly opened his mouth .

'I feel that there may be significantly more weight to you than there was before . '

He said it politely, but the meaning didn't change .

Gotou reflexively raised a fist towards Ishii . Ishii's shoulders stiffened as he let out a strange shriek .

'Y-you promised that you wouldn't hit me, didn't you?'

'I haven't hit you yet, right!?'

Gotou glared at Ishii and used his raised hand to scratch his head .

'Am I that much fatter?'

While throwing his cigarette into his portable ashtray, he repeated his question .

'No, it isn't anything to worry about . Don't bears eat large amounts before hibernating in the winter? In order to survive the winter, they need a lot of fat...'

Gotou couldn't hold back any more . Who cared about a stupid promise?

Gotou hit Ishii's head with his fist .

'What do you mean, bear!? Hibernation!? You fool!'

His yell rang through the car . Gotou grabbed Ishii's collar and shook him .

'Detective Gotou, please stop it . It's dangerous . '

'Shut up! You keep going on and on...'

Before Gotou finished speaking, Ishii stepped on the brakes . Gotou tried to brace himself in his unnatural stance, but he fell forward and hit his head against the dashboard .

'Don't step on the brakes all of a sudden!'

He gave Ishii's thin chest a horizontal chop .

'E-er, Detective Gotou, we've arrived,' said Ishii, looking pained as he gripped his chest .

Gotou looked – they had arrived, just as Ishii said .

Around the premises, there were plates that had construction dates and contact information printed on them .

Gotou snorted and got off the car .

It's cold –

The cold felt like it went right to his heart .

While breathing out white puffs of air, Gotou went to the galvanised sheet iron door and opened it, entering the premises .

It was an iron and concrete five-storey building .

Including the premises, it was probably about three hundred tsubo[1] . The inside demolition work was done, but the outer wall was completely untouched .

In the corner of the premises, the demolished rubble had piled up .

Gotou passed through the overgrown premises and stood in front of the building's front entrance . The door had already been taken off .

He avoided the cords that hung down like ivy and went through the entrance .

The revealed concrete was cracked and the floor was covered in dust . The ceiling boards showed through as well .

Crack .

He'd stepped on some glass .

Thanks to that, memories that had been buried deep in Gotou's mind suddenly came up again .

I've come here before –

Fifteen years before – on a night when it was raining buckets .

Gotou had been a uniformed detective at a police station when somebody had told him a kid was going to be killed . Then, he'd headed for this building .

I'd had a bad feeling –

When he went inside the building with a torch, he spotted a woman's crouching back .

That woman had been bent over, strangling a kid .

He stopped her, though she resisted violently, and finally he was able to get the woman to get away from the kid . However, before he'd noticed, the woman had disappeared .

He found this out later, but the woman had tried to kill her own kid .

The words the woman had said then were still fresh in his ears .

– This child will kill! If I don't kill him now, he'll kill, just like him . '

Gotou still didn't know why she'd thought a baby would become a killer in the future .

All he knew was that the kid from then had grown into a bratty young man .

That guy was still living with the burden of that event .

'What is it?'

Ishii called out to him, bringing Gotou back to reality .

'Nothing . Let's go . '

Cutting off the thread to the past, Gotou went deeper into the building .

When he reached the pillar at the very back of the building, Gotou spotted something . He crouched and picked it up .

A puff of white dust came up .

'Is that a... blanket?'

Ishii peered from behind Gotou .

'Yeah . '

'Was somebody here?'

'Looks that way . '

Besides the blanket, empty cans were strewn about .

Had construction workers left it behind, or was somebody else living here?

Gotou put the blanket on the floor and stood up .

Thump .

There was the sound of something falling .

Gotou instinctively looked to the building's entrance .

A man was standing there .

He wore a green half-length coat with jeans and had a heavy-looking Boston bag on his shoulders .

Was this the guy who was living here?

'We're from the Setamachi precinct . We've got a few things we want to ask you . '

Gotou held up his police ID and approached the man .

Then, he saw the man's face clearly . A slightly wide face with thick eyebrows . Sharp eyes that looked straight forwards .

I've seen this face before . Where was it –

'Ah! Aah!'

Ishii shouted in Gotou's ear, interrupting his thoughts .

'You're so loud!'

Gotou smacked the back of Ishii's head .

'B-but . '

Ishii was still agitated .

'But what?'

'Isn't that Takeda Shunsuke?' Ishii said quickly .

'Takeda Shunsuke? The soccer player?'

'That's incorrect . And you're mixing up the players' names . '

'Then who is it?'

'Fifteen years ago, he was the suspect for the brutal murder at the house on top of the hill – Takeda Shunsuke!'

Ishii stamped his feet in irritation as he shouted .

The man looked taken aback by Ishii's words .

Gotou thought about that case . He hadn't been directly related since he'd still been working at a police station then, but he'd seen that face on the wanted list a number of times .

It did look like him .

'Oi . You Takeda Shunsuke?'

When Gotou asked that, the man turned around and ran off .

'Wait!'

Gotou ran right after Takeda .

Damn it! Why hadn't he noticed earlier!? Ishii had had to tell him – he'd never been more ashamed in his life!

Gotou ran off the premises and turned at the first corner when his side started hurting .

It was hard to breathe . His body felt heavy .

Ishii passed Gotou as he was trying to stand up .

Damn! Why did he have to be passed by the fool Ishii!? He could still run!

Gotou tried to up his pace, but his feet were as heavy as if they were in water . Finally, he sank to the floor .

He had only run two hundred metres, so why was he like this? What had happened to his body?

Gotou forced himself to stand up and started running again, though he was staggering .

After passing the second intersection, he saw Ishii's back .

Ishii was frantically looking around a dead-end road .

'Ishii? Where's the guy?'

– Haa, haa, haa .

Gotou put both hands on his knees and was panting like a dog as he asked .

'That's... I saw him turn into this street, but – '

Ishii was restless as he answered .

'Did you lose him?'

'Rather than lose him... er... he disappeared . '

'Disappeared!?!'

'Yes . '

In his anger, Gotou grabbed Ishii's collar .

'There's no way somebody could disappear! I'll beat you up if you make stupid excuses!'

'I-I apologise,' said Ishii, his face twitching .

Gotou thought about giving Ishii a punch, but his body was at its limit . His knees lost their strength and he sank to the ground .

Sweat was coming down his forehead like somebody had splashed him with a bucket of water .

– Even though I definitely would've been able to catch him before .

'Damn it!'

Gotou howled towards the sun .

4

When Makoto went into the hospital room, the woman on the bed slowly opened her eyes .

It was the woman who had fainted at the scene of the murder fifteen years ago .

After Makoto found her, she immediately called for an ambulance to take her to the hospital .

She was very weak, but there were no obvious injuries and she was clearly conscious . She could be let out of hospital after two or three days of treatment . Now, she had an IV drip with nutrients .

'Are you all right?'

When Makoto spoke to her, the woman tried to sit up .

'Please don't strain yourself . '

Makoto urged the woman to lie down and sat on the round chair by the bed .

'You saved me . Thank you very much,' said the woman in a hoarse voice .

'I was just passing by,' said Makoto as she shook her head . She looked at the woman's face again .

She had a pencil-straight nose and almond-shaped eyes . Though her makeup had come off, she was still very attractive .

'My name is Murakami Yuki . '

'I'm Hijikata Makoto . '

'Why were you at that place?'

The woman asked the question first .

'I work at a newspaper agency . I was gathering material on the case that happened fifteen years ago . '

'So that's why you were there...'

Yuki nodded in understanding .

From that reaction, it seemed like Yuki knew that something had happened there in the past .

'Murakami-san, why were you there?'

Yuki's expression stiffened at Makoto's question . It seemed like she didn't want to say .

Makoto couldn't force somebody to speak when they'd just met, so she looked for another conversation topic .

'I work as a television reporter,' said Yuki, breaking the silence .

'Is that so?'

Makoto followed up, though she was confused .

'Though it's just a local cable channel...'

'Were you there to gather material as well?'

'Yes, well . But it was something more vulgar than gathering material . '

Yuki smiled bitterly .

'Vulgar?'

'There is a rumour that there are ghosts there, so with the plan of chasing after the mystery of the spiritual phenomena, I went there with a director and an exorcist . '

'Is that how it was?'

Makoto understood the situation, but there was something else she didn't understand now .

If they had gone there for a show, why had the staff left Yuki there –

'What on earth happened there?'

'I... was so scared... Everyone ran away, and I was the only one left...'

Yuki's voice was shaking and there were tears in her eyes .

Makoto regretted asking her question so suddenly .

She might've been wrapped up in some sort of incident . An incident that caused her psychological damage as a woman –

In Makoto's mind, she recalled the repulsive circumstances of an incident she was involved in in the past, and she felt her chest tighten .

'Are you all right?'

Yuki covered her face with her hands as she took deep breaths .

Makoto couldn't think of the words to say so she touched Yuki's shoulder – all she could do was wait for her to calm down .

'I don't know if you'll believe my story, but...'

'What is it?'

After a silence, Yuki wiped away her tears and started speaking .

'I saw something terrible there...'

'Something terrible?'

'Yes . I was surrounded by people covered in the blood, and they told me to die too...'

Yuki's eyes were wide, as if she were seeing the scene play out right in front of her .

'You didn't run?'

'I tried to run away with everyone, but it was like my body was paralysed...'

Yuki's voice was becoming quieter, and it trailed off at the end .

Nobody would believe her . She was hiding that resignation on her face .

However, Makoto didn't doubt Yuki's story . She had experienced something similar herself .

The incident one year ago – a dead person's spirit had entered Makoto's body and stolen her freedom .

She felt the chills just thinking about it .

'I believe you . I've experienced it myself . '

Makoto gripped Yuki's hand .

Yuki's eyes were filled with confusion . Makoto nodded silently . She felt like Yuki's expression relaxed just a bit .

Still, Makoto felt extremely angry at the staff who had left Yuki there and didn't go to help her .

'Have you contacted the staff?'

Yuki shook her head .

'Actually, I called the company, but it turns out that the company hasn't been able to contact the staff since yesterday...'

'Eh?'

They've disappeared – no, it was too early to come to that conclusion .

Makoto erased that thought from her mind .

'I have a very bad feeling,' murmured Yuki .

'A bad feeling...'

'Yes . '

Yuki nodded and looked to the Handycam on the table by the bed .

'Did you use that to film?'

'It might be recorded on it . '

Yuki turned hollow eyes towards the ceiling . It was like her soul was being sucked out of her .

'It?'

'What we saw . '

5

– What on earth?

When Miyagawa Hideya received the call, he almost dropped the phone .

Takeda Shunsuke –

These fifteen years, never once had he forgotten that name .

That day, Miyagawa had been the first on the scene .

In the living room at the end of the corridor, there were four people collapsed on each other . He didn't need to check – he could tell that they were dead . There was no sign of life there .

An overwhelming death –

How many times had they had stabbed? There were countless wounds and the blood from them was on the wooden floor and had even gotten on the white walls .

Thinking theoretically wasn't Miyagawa's strong suit, so he couldn't explain it . However, he'd felt that the scene had been different from other murder scenes .

Rather than calling it strong, it might have been passionate . He hadn't felt hatred or resentment there . It had been so inhuman –

The murderer had destroyed the people the way he would break a toy . That was the impression it left .

'Tsuda, Baba, Shimizu . Come here right now!'

Miyagawa slammed the phone down and yelled .

The detectives in charge came immediately to Miyagawa's desk, surrounding it .

'The suspect from the case fifteen years ago, Takeda Shunsuke, has been spotted . '

The three of them look like they had met with the dead .

'He escaped, but there's a strong possibility that he's hiding nearby . You know what to do . '

Nobody responded, but each of them knew their roles . Their gazes were as sharp as hunters watching their prey .

'Catch him no matter what . There are five days until the statute of limitations . '

When Miyagawa finished talking, the three detectives in charge went to the detective office . Shouts flew about – it was as loud as a festival .

After Miyagawa found the corpses, he encountered a man thought to be the murderer . He had been standing together with Miyuki, whose location was currently unknown .

The moment Miyagawa faced that man, he'd thought that he would be killed . He was just about to run when he was hit in the head and fainted .

That impact had made it so that he couldn't clearly remember that man's face even now .

However, that dark fire of oppression had stuck to his brain . And those eyes...

When he saw Takeda's face in a photo, there had just been something off . Is this really the guy I saw at the scene? He'd talked to his boss, but nobody listened . It made sense . There was no point listening to somebody who couldn't remember the guy's face .

But it'd still felt off . Was that really...

Miyagawa decided to stop thinking about unnecessary things . If they caught Takeda Shunsuke, everything would become clear .

He didn't have the time to be sitting about . The investigation this time wouldn't get by with just the detectives . They'd need to mobilise everyone to catch the guy . There was no time .

Miyagawa took the phone to call the other departments for support .

6

It was already ten PM by the time Makoto finished organising her material .

Her work was delayed when she unexpectedly saved Yuki .

After sighing, Makoto turned off her computer and stood up .

Around this time, the people on the press floor would have been running about getting ready for the morning edition, but the planning floor Makoto was on was quiet .

She picked up her bag from under her desk when her eyes landed on the Handycam camera beside it .

– What we saw might be recorded on it .

Yuki's words echoed in her head .

– Could you check the video to see what was recorded?

She had gripped Makoto's arm as she asked that .

– I'm too afraid to watch it .

Makoto ended up taking the camera, since she couldn't look at Yuki's teary eyes .

To tell the truth, Makoto was interested in what was recorded . She might also be able to find out what happened there fifteen years ago .

Of course she was afraid, but that made her want to watch it more .

Makoto turned on the video camera .

There was still battery left . She wouldn't have to connect it to the computer . The camera had a moveable camera attached to it .

Makoto put down her bag, sat down again and pressed the play button .

The sound was quiet so she couldn't hear it clearly, but Yuki and a man in worship clothes were talking together calmly . It was probably set up like an appointment .

Makoto pressed fast forward .

Like scenery from the window of a car, the video sped along .

Makoto pressed play again when the house showed up .

Yuki stood in front of the house with a microphone and spoke as if she was giving a speech .

<Fifteen years ago, a terrible and bizarre murder occurred at this house...>

When she finished her explanation, Yuki invited the exorcist over .

After they talked with each other, a voice said 'OK' and the screen went dark .

When the video started again, Yuki and the exorcist were standing in front of the front door .

<Now, I'd like to head inside immediately . >

Yuki and the exorcist opened the door and walked inside .

<I feel great spiritual power from the other side of this door . >

The exorcist spoke in front of the door at the end of the corridor .

Yuki was looking around restlessly like she sensed something . Her face was also pale .

The camera shook, as if Yuki's anxiety had been contagious .

Even through a monitor, there was a strange atmosphere .

Finally, the lights suddenly went out –

The screen was completely black . However, the video was still playing .

In the dark, something was moving rapidly .

Clang, clang, clang, clang .

There was the sound of something hitting metal .

<Aah!>

<Stop!>

There was a voice that sounded like both a yell and a scream .

Then, the bloody face of a woman filled the screen .

'No!'

Makoto screamed and leapt up from her seat .

The woman's eyes were wide open and so was her mouth as she looked out of the monitor .

Blood dripped down the right side of her face .

'This is what she saw...'

The moment Makoto said that, the video stopped –

This is what Yuki saw –

7

Ishii sat on the lumber left on the building premises and let out a sigh .

He looked beside him – Gotou sat on the lumber as well .

His necktie hung around his neck in a sloppy manner, and his shabby old coat was pitiful . He looked just like the protagonist from a hardboiled detective story of the sixties .

After Gotou reported that they'd seen Takeda Shunsuke, a fully mobilised large-scale investigation started .

Of course the Shinkansen stations were investigated, and the citizens in the neighbourhood were questioned . There was even a special telephone number for information from eyewitnesses .

Naturally, the building premises they were at now were closed off . Lights were brought in for an expert inspection .

'Things have become serious . '

Though Ishii spoke up, Gotou didn't reply . He just glanced over at him, seeming completely exhausted .

Ishii's legs were screaming from all the running he'd did too . He couldn't walk another step .

'Worn out already? Pathetic . '

Chief Miyagawa made a rude, bowlegged entrance . Though he was short, his bald head and sharp gaze made him look like a thug .

'Chief Miyagawa, thank you very much for your hard work . '

Ishii hurriedly stood up and bowed .

'Stop being so formal,' said Miyagawa in a thick voice as he waved his hand like he was chasing away a fly .

'Ah, yes . '

'Just sit down . '

'Yes sir . '

Ishii sat on the lumber, just as Miyagawa told him to .

'What do you want?' said Gotou with a glare .

'That's quite a greeting . '

'You're just going to lecture us because we let him get away, aren't you?'

Gotou clicked his tongue .

'Well, I want to, but to be frank, I was the one who let him get away fifteen years ago . '

Miyagawa rubbed his head as he laughed self-derisively .

'Eh!? Is that so!?'

Ishii leant forward in his surprise .

He'd heard that the detective who went to the scene fifteen years ago encountered the culprit . He fainted after being hit by the culprit and was taken to the hospital by reinforcements .

That had been Miyagawa –

'Why you so surprised? I make mistakes sometimes too . '

Miyagawa's eyes narrowed as he remembered the event .

'You're quite something . '

Gotou snorted .

'Don't get ahead of yourself!'

Miyagawa smacked Gotou's head .

'That hurts . '

'I was being nice 'cause I thought you were down, but aren't you going to reflect at all?'

'I reflected enough . '

Gotou rubbed at his head as he looked up at Miyagawa .

'Hmph . Guess so . '

Miyagawa took an artificial cigarette out of his jacket . Gotou followed up by lighting a cigarette in his mouth .

Miyagawa seemed vexed as he bit down on his artificial cigarette, but he said nothing .

'How is the investigation going?' asked Gotou as he blew smoke out his nose .

Ishii wanted to know too .

'No developments for the investigation or inspection . He disappeared like smoke . But it seems like a bunch of people in the area saw Takeda . '

'Then...'

'You were probably right . The guy you saw was Takeda Shunsuke . '

Miyagawa's expression hardened as he said that .

So it really was him –

When Ishii realised that, he felt even more mortified that they let him get away .

'But why would he come back now?'

Gotou cocked his head .

Ishii didn't know either . Probably everyone related to the investigation felt that way .

The statute of limitations would have been finished in five more days for Takeda .

They couldn't find him at all after the case . The investigation team for the case had been closed for it a few years back, so if he had just kept in hiding, the statute of limitations would have passed .

So why would Takeda come back to this town despite that danger –

Even if he had a reason that he had to come here, why now?

'I don't know . I'll ask when we catch him . '

Miyagawa's eyes as he said that shone like those of a beast chasing prey . Even though he was in management now, Miyagawa's body was still indelibly stained with the blood at the scene .

Ishii looked at Miyagawa with respect .

'Of course . '

Gotou stretched his arms up above his head, and Ishii stood up . Gotou was probably planning to continue questioning the people in the area .

'You guys can just go home,' said Miyagawa, stopping them before they could start .

'It's fine . We're still good as new . '

'I'm not worried about your health . '

Miyagawa waved his hand, like he thought the very idea ridiculous .

'What do you mean?'

Gotou seemed to sense something as he approached Miyagawa .

'Go back to your regular work . '

'Are you seriously saying that?'

Gotou's voice cracked as he spoke .

'Of course . '

'Why?'

'Since it's out of your jurisdiction . '

'I won't accept that . '

Gotou wouldn't back down .

Though Gotou was riled up, Miyagawa was calm .

'You don't have to accept it . Just think about my situation for a bit . '

'Your situation?'

'This time it'll be infiltration tactics with a focus on teamwork . There'll be a bunch of problems if I let you guys loiter around . '

Gotou didn't appear to accept it, but Ishii understood even without Miyagawa saying all of it .

He was talking about the case half a year ago . Gotou and Ishii had disclosed the crime of the previous chief .

Because of that, there was an arrest in the police and police chief had been forced to resign .

They had done the right thing, but in the loyal organisation that was the police, that had been a betrayal .

If Gotou and Ishii were added to the investigation, the morale might drop .

'As if I care about that!' shouted Gotou, his face red .

Ishii understood Gotou's anger very well . They had been the first to discover the suspect, but they couldn't be a part of the investigation .
However –

'D-Detective Gotou...'

Ishii tried to pacify Gotou, who looked like he'd spring on Miyagawa .

'Let me go, you fool!'

Gotou hit him –

'Anyway, even if you tell me I can't, I won't stop . '

'Don't say that . '

Miyagawa refused Gotou flat . He turned around and started walking away right after the conversation finished .

Gotou's tightly gripped fists were shaking .

'You bastard! I'm going to kill you one day!'

Gotou howled at the night . Then, in his highly strung state, he hit Ishii's head with his fist .

Ishii's glasses fell off his head from the incredible force .

Ishii was trying to pick up the glasses from the ground when his mobile phone rang .

'Hello, this is Ishii speaking . '

<I apologise for not contacting in so long . >

The person on the other end was the newspaper reporter, Makoto .

He had met her because of a case with a ghost, and she was also the daughter of the old chief of the police .

'Ah, h-hello . Is it Makoto-san?'

Ishii had an unpleasant memory of Makoto . Whenever he heard her voice, he always ended up nervous .

It wasn't that he disliked Makoto . However, she had been possessed by a ghost before . She had attacked Ishii in a number of ways then .

Even though he knew that that had been the ghost rather than Makoto, he just couldn't erase the fear from his heart .

<I apologise for my rudeness, but I actually have a request . >

A request? For me?

Anxiety spread through Ishii's chest .

'W-w-what is it?'

<There is something I would like you to look at . >

'...What is it?'

<A video . >

Ishii could feel his heart thumping .

I can't watch this video – it was vague, but he had that premonition .

8

The next morning, Gotou took Ishii with him to the <Movie Research Circle> clubroom at Meisei University .

He was there to meet the contrary university student Saitou Yakumo .

Last night, Gotou had been furious at being left out of the investigation, but the call to Ishii had been an unexpected save .

A video taken at the house where the incident occurred fifteen years ago –

Gotou hadn't seen it yet either, but apparently there was a terrifying image in it .

Even if they couldn't take a part in the Takeda investigation, by following the puzzle of the spiritual phenomenon in the puzzle, they might be able to catch Takeda as a result .

However, in order to follow a puzzle regarding spiritual phenomena, Yakumo would be necessary .

The guy was always sarcastic whenever they met, but the red left eye Yakumo had been born with could see the spirits of the dead .

Without that ability, they wouldn't be able to continue their investigation .

Yakumo was like a cat – he only did as much as he absolutely needed to . He'd definitely say something like 'That's not my job' this time too .

However, Gotou definitely wouldn't let him go . He'd make him cooperate no matter what .

In the worst case scenario, he'd drag him out by the scruff of his neck .

'Sorry to intrude . '

Gotou opened the <Movie Research Circle> door without knocking .

Yakumo sat in the chair at the front and was reading while running a hand through his hair .

'Please leave if you know you are intruding . Honestly . How many times do I have to say it before you'll understand?'

Yakumo complained like a brother-in-law without taking his eyes off the book .

The guy had a comeback for everything .

'Yeah, my bad . '

Gotou clicked his tongue and sat in the folding chair in front of Yakumo .

Ishii stood completely straight next to the door, like a plant . It looked like he was afraid of Yakumo as usual .

'I've got something I want to talk to you about . '

'I refuse . '

Gotou hadn't even said anything when Yakumo turned him down . Just like usual –

'Why not? It's just a small thing . You look like you've got some free time . '

Yakumo looked up just a bit at Gotou's words .

'I'm just going to say this, but I am a student . There are exams next week . I don't have the time to play around with you . '

'What do you mean, play around? I'm doing my work seriously!'

Even though Yakumo was just acting like he normally did, Gotou still got riled up .

His voice was louder too .

'You're talking rather big . '

'Eh?'

'Though you say you're working, haven't you gained a lot of weight? You're more like a pig than a bear now . '

Yakumo snorted .

'My weight's got nothing to do with it! Don't look down on the police!'

'Aren't you the one looking down on the police the most, Gotou-san?'

'What?'

'You said that detectives who ask civilians to investigate are incompetent and depraved . Do you have no pride or morals as a detective?'

This guy . He just keeps on saying whatever the hell he wants –

Gotou's anger reached the boiling point . He slammed both of his hands on the table .

'Shut up! I don't want to ask somebody like you for help either!'

'The exit is over there . '

Yakumo's expression didn't change at Gotou's loud voice . He pointed at the door .

'Stop blabbing and just help!'

Gotou leant forward and gripped Yakumo's by the collar, but Yakumo just scowled with his fingers in his ears .

The guy isn't cute at all –

'Gotou-san, what is one supposed to say when asking for a favour?'

The corners of Yakumo's lips were turned up in a smirk .

Anger boiled up in Gotou's stomach . He resisted the urge to acquaint Yakumo's well-defined nose with his fist .

If he got angry at Yakumo now, he'd lose everything . Restraint . Restraint .
Gotou repeated that word to himself .

'I-I sincerely apologise for coming at a busy time for you, but would you do me the favour of cooperating with the investigation?'

Gotou let go of Yakumo and looked down at his feet as he spoke .

'Isn't there one more thing you should say?' urged Yakumo, his arms crossed .

'P-please . '

Gotou gritted his teeth and lowered his head as he bore with the disgrace .

'Well done . '

Yakumo clapped mockingly .

– Ah, I really want to punch him .

'That makes four favours . '

Yakumo held up four fingers in an impressive manner .

What did he mean, favours? Who did he think saved him when his mother was about to kill him? What an ungrateful bastard .

Gotou's shoulders slumped and he sat back down in the chair, exhausted .

'So what do you plan on making me do this time?'

'Oi, Ishii . Explain . '

He'd get a hole in his stomach from stress if he talked to Yakumo anymore .

Gotou turned the conversation to Ishii .

Perhaps he was startled, because Ishii turned right and left and bowed, like a broken robot .

'Stop acting like an idiot and explain!'

Gotou gave Ishii a horizontal chop .

He was fixed –

'A-ah, yes . Er... Where should I start the explanation from?' said Ishii, as hesitant as always .

'Think about that yourself!' Gotou yelled .

Ishii leapt back with his head in his hands, like he thought Gotou was going to hit him .

'Ishii-san, there's no need to pay any attention to the words of a sea lion who hasn't gotten enough exercise . Please just talk normally in a chronological order . '

Yakumo yawned, like he was bored .

– Who's a sea lion, you monster cat!?

Gotou forcefully restrained the urge to yell .

Ishii appeared to have relaxed now that Yakumo told him how to speak . He adjusted the position of his glasses, though they hadn't slipped, and started to speak .

'The story starts fifteen years ago...'

It sounded like he was talking about some old folktale .

'I will show you the documents afterwards, but a family of four were killed at a house and the granddaughter was abducted – it was an atrocious case . '

Is this OK? Ishii seemed to be asking that as he looked at Gotou and Yakumo's faces .

'Please continue . '

After hearing Yakumo's response, Ishii breathed out and continued talking .

'The investigation after that put the suspect on the national wanted list, but the police could not find him . '

'Since it has been fifteen years, that means...'

Yakumo looked up .

'Yes . The statute of limitations is up in four days . Then, when we went to an abandoned building on another investigation yesterday, we ran into that suspect . '

'Were you able to catch him?'

Ishii was lost for words when Yakumo interrupted, and he looked to Gotou for help .

Ah, what a pain . Since it was Yakumo, he'd probably figured it out already and asked that on purpose .

'I let him get away,' said Gotou, swallowing his irritation .

'I couldn't hear you clearly . Could you say that once more?'

Yakumo put his hand to his ear, like he really hadn't heard .

Yakumo always complained about how loud Gotou's voice was . He really was an infuriating guy .

'I said... I let him get away!'

'I see . As a detective with short legs and insufficient exercise, it's natural that you let him escape . '

Yakumo laughed aloud even though he said that himself .

Gotou didn't even feel like rebutting any more . His mouth was a thin line across his face as he looked to the side with his arms crossed .

'And then?'

After Yakumo laughed for a while, he urged Ishii to continue .

'Ah, yes . Detective Gotou and I were left out of the investigation . After that, we received a call from Makoto-san . '

'Makoto-san would be the newspaper reporter, yes?'

Ishii nodded .

'Yes, that Makoto-san . She had gone to the scene for material and found a video there . '

'A video... is it?'

'Yes . The owner is a certain video company . It appears that they were filming a paranormal programme there . '

'Paranormal, eh?'

Yakumo frowned for just a moment .

For Yakumo, who could actually see ghosts, programmes that joked around with the matter were probably not interesting .

'I haven't seen the video yet myself, but according to Makoto-san, the ghost of a woman was recorded . '

After saying that much, Ishii wiped the sweat from his forehead .

'Four people died at the place where that video was taken, yes? It wouldn't be unnatural for a ghost to be recorded . '

Yakumo yawned .

'Yes, but...'

'If you've determined a suspect, I wouldn't be able to do anything even if I went now . Well, there is still the question of why the culprit returned to the town where he committed the crime right before the statute of limitations was up, but it's the police's job to investigate that . '

Yakumo rubbed at his eyes like a cat and propped up his chin with his hand .

He looked completely uninterested .

From the way the conversation had gone so far, there really was nothing to do . But there was still more –

Gotou stood up and put both hands in his pockets .

'Is there something else?'

'That's what we thought at first, but according to the woman reporter, the ghost in the video – she's definitely not one of the victims . '

When Yakumo heard Gotou's last words, his expression changed .

9

Haruka used her lunch break to head towards the <Movie Research Circle> .

He had been incredibly contrary about it, but that Yakumo had agreed to go to her performance .

That Yakumo had agreed . This could be called a case of its own .

But since it was Yakumo, he'd probably fall asleep like a cat in the sun during the performance . Still, it'd make her happy if he just went to the hall .

Haruka's pace quickened .

She was almost running by the time she got to the prefabricated building .

Haruka stopped in front of the door .

If she went in with accelerated breathing, it'd be like she hurried here . She took deep breaths to calm her ragged breathing .

– OK, let's go .

When Haruka tried to put her hand on the doorknob, the door opened .

She jumped back in her surprise . A bearlike figure suddenly appeared in front of her .

'D-Detective Gotou!' exclaimed Haruka .

Perhaps it was because he was wearing a coat, but Gotou looked a size larger than the last time she'd seen him .

'Oh, Haruka-chan . '

'I apologise for not keeping in touch . '

'If you don't cut your ties with Yakumo soon, you won't be able to become a bride,' said Gotou listlessly as he sleepily scratched his neck .

'I don't want to hear that from somebody who lets his wife run away . '

Gotou snorted at Haruka's retort with a cigarette in his mouth .

If Gotou was here, that meant –

'Since you are rather large, please don't stand in the entrance . '

Yakumo pushed Gotou aside to leave the clubroom, running a hand through his messy hair all the while .

'What are you doing?' said Yakumo, the moment his eyes met Haruka's .

'Even if you ask me what I'm doing...'

Haruka was lost for words when Ishii came out of the room too .

'Ah, H-Haruka-chan, i-it's been a while . '

Ishii bowed in a stupidly formal manner .

'Hello, Ishii-san . '

There was no mistaking it now .

Gotou had probably brought Yakumo another troublesome case .

'Is it a case?'

'Well, something like that . '

After Gotou replied, he started walking away .

'Hey, what'd he mean by "something like that"?'

Haruka asked that question to Yakumo and Ishii .

Yakumo yawned – it didn't feel like he wanted to reply . Ishii seemed divided as to whether he should talk .

'Oi! Hurry up!'

Gotou's yell echoed back to them .

'Ah, yes sir . I'm coming now . '

Ishii started running from a conditioned reflex .

– He fell .

He got up immediately and started running again .

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair as he followed him .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . '

Yakumo turned around .

'I brought the ticket for the performance I mentioned yesterday...'

'Leave it on the table . '

Yakumo started walking again .

Why is it – Haruka felt that back was very far away .

Her heart felt strange . What was this feeling? She'd felt it before . When her friend got involved in a case and died –

She had a bad feeling for some reason .

'Hey!'

Haruka called out to Yakumo's back, unable to bear it .

'What?'

Though Yakumo stopped walking, he didn't turn around .

'Er, um... Be careful . '

Haruka put the anxiety in her heart into words .

'It's rare for you to worry about me . Do you have a fever or something?'

Yakumo shrugged and started to walk again .

– He'll be fine .

Haruka gripped the red stone on her necklace tightly .

Ishii's expression was still soft as he sat in the driver's seat .

– Ah, Haruka-chan was really cute .

Just by seeing that face, the uneasiness in his heart lessened . Her hair had grown out a bit, so he felt like she seemed more mature now .

Gotou's fist came down on Ishii's fantasising head .

'How long are you going to keep smirking like that!? Hurry up and start the car!'

'I-I apologise . '

Ishii bore with the pain as he started the engine .

'When was the video we are going to watch filmed?' asked Yakumo from the back of the car, his arms crossed .

'I don't know very much about it myself . '

Ishii looked at Yakumo using the mirror .

Makoto hadn't actually heard the details about when the video was filmed either .

'I see . '

Yakumo leant back on the seat and looked up .

'Er... Would you find something out by knowing when the video was taken?'

Ishii didn't understand why Yakumo wanted to know .

'There's a possibility . The video was put out by a video company . '

Ishii understood from that, even if Yakumo didn't say any more .

'What are you talking about?' asked Gotou, turning around in the passenger seat .

'If time has passed since the video was filmed, we won't be able to determine whether the video was faked . '

'Composite videos or CG or something?'

'Yes . Nowadays, it's incredibly simple to edit videos just by using a computer . There are a number of those in the videos of ghosts that are shown on television . '

Yakumo gave a supplementary explanation .

It was true that it was easy to edit videos using a computer now . Unlike the composite videos of the past, it would be difficult to determine authenticity if CG was used .

A question suddenly came to Ishii .

'E-er, there's something I would like to ask . '

'What is it?'

Yakumo's eyes narrowed .

When Yakumo looked at him like that, Ishii couldn't calm down – it felt like Yakumo was seeing straight to the bottom of his heart .

'Er... in photos and videos, ghosts you can't see with your actual eyes are clearly recorded . Why is that?'

'You don't even understand that?'

Gotou hit Ishii's head, like he thought he was an idiot .

'Do you know, Detective Gotou?'

'It's that... That... Yakumo, I'll leave the rest to you . '

Gotou pushed the responsibility to Yakumo .

Yakumo ran his hand through his hair like he thought the matter troublesome, but he started an explanation .

'First, it is necessary to define what a ghost is . '

'The definition of a ghost, is it?'

'This is only my theory, but ghosts are not demons or some new life form . They are originally human . '

'That's right . '

Ishii nodded in understanding .

In horror films, they were often portrayed as strange life forms that exceeded human understanding, but when he thought about it more, it was just as Yakumo said – they were originally human .

'Even after the human body dies, their emotions remain . I believe that the cluster of emotions that remains is the true form of the ghost . '

'A cluster of emotions... is it?'

Ishii thought over Yakumo's words .

It'd be difficult to explain if he was asked to, but he understood what Yakumo meant .

'There are two conditions for seeing these spirits of the dead . To put it simply, they are transmission and reception . '

'Transmission and reception?'

'Correct . The spirit of the dead transmits . The stronger those emotions are, the easier it is for them to transmit to people . Please think of it like mobile phone radio emissions . '

'So if the radio emissions are weak, people won't receive them?'

Yakumo nodded in satisfaction at Ishii's response .

'Exactly . The same could be said for reception . Depending on the person, they will receive the transmission better or worse . That is where the difference between seeing and not seeing comes about . Though the surrounding environment has an effect...'

Ishii understood . When the wavelengths from the transmitter and the receiver agreed and the surrounding environment was appropriate, the spirits of the dead could be seen by human eyes .

Then Yakumo's left eye could be called a high quality receiver .

However, this explanation didn't explain why ghosts could be seen in videos .

Perhaps he sensed Ishii's concern, because Yakumo started speaking again .

'Human eyes read electromagnetic waves and send the information about colour and shape to the brain . However, there are only some wavelengths that can be recognised . '

Ishii knew that as well .

It was called the visible spectrum . People could only recognise a certain range of electromagnetic waves . That was why people couldn't see ultraviolet rays or infrared .

However, cameras were different . People couldn't see the infrared from the television remote control, but cameras could recognise that a red light was being emitted –

'I see! So it's a problem of electromagnetic wavelengths . Cameras can see things the eye can't . So that's how it is . '

Ishii almost turned around in his agitation . Yakumo nodded in satisfaction again .

'Though this is just a theory . '

Contrary to his words, Yakumo's expression was full of confidence .

Yakumo's left eye could probably see a wider range of electromagnetic waves than the normal eye, which is why he could see the spirits of the dead .

It wasn't just Yakumo . The wavelengths people could see differed between people .

Some people found them easier to see and some people found them harder . Similarly, there were wavelengths for spirits of the dead . Some people's eyes spotted them more easily while others' didn't .

Along the same lines, there was a difference between how eyes and cameras recognised light . From that difference, cameras could see ghosts more easily than human eyes could .

Using Yakumo, science might be able to understand ghosts – Ishii certainly felt that way .

Gotou's fist came down on Ishii's agitated head .

'Stop spacing out! You were supposed to turn right just now!'

– Oh no . He'd missed the road .

Ishii hurriedly stepped on the brakes and made a U-turn .

He parked the car in the guest parking at the newspaper company and they got off the car together .

Ishii explained their purpose at the reception . It seemed that reception already knew they were coming, and they were taken to the conference room on the second floor .

'Ishii-san, I've been waiting . '

Makoto was already in the conference room . Her expression brightened as she greeted him .

Her long hair was tied up and she wore a grey pantsuit . She seemed somehow dignified – it felt like she had changed a bit .

It might have been because of her makeup, but she seemed much more mature .

'Ah, hello . I apologise for not keeping in contact . '

Ishii returned the greeting .

'Hey, it's been a while . You been doing OK?'

Gotou came in the room, acting like he always did .

'Yes, thanks to your help . '

Makoto smiled with her whole face . The way she smiled seemed different from before too .

Ishii wouldn't be able to explain if he was asked to, but the incident half a year ago might have had a great effect on her psychological state .

'Hello . '

Yakumo came in while rubbing his eyes .

'Yakumo-san, you're here as well?'

Yakumo yawned in response to Makoto's greeting and sat on the chair closest to the door .

That's enough with the greetings, so let's get started . It felt like he was saying that .

Gotou threw his coat on to the desk and sat next to Yakumo .

'Ishii-san, please sit down as well . You'll see the video soon . '

After Makoto said that, she walked to the television on the rack and started the Handycam camera that was attached to the television with a cable .

Ishii sat down next to Gotou as he was told .

'Is it true that the person in the video isn't one of the vics?' asked Gotou as he lit his cigarette .

'This is a non-smoking facility . '

Yakumo pointed at the <No Smoking> sign on the wall .

Gotou clicked his tongue and put out his cigarette in his portable ashtray .

'I would like you to confirm that,' said Makoto . She took remote control, turned off the lights and sat next to Ishii .

'Before we watch this video, please tell us the events that brought it into your possession,' said Yakumo, interrupting Makoto from pressing the remote control .

'This was taken by a video company . They were making a local cable television show . '

'I see . '

'When this was taken, it appears there were three people there: a reporter, an exorcist and the director . When they saw the spiritual phenomenon, the two besides the reporter ran off . '

'Leaving the video camera behind?' asked Yakumo .

'It seems to be the case . After that, I went to the house by chance to gather material and found the reporter collapsed there with this video . '

'Has the video company been contacted?'

'The reporter Murakami-san contacted them . '

Yakumo didn't seem to be satisfied with Makoto's explanation . There was a furrow in his brow as he ran a hand through his hair .

'Well, we can just look into the details later . Let's see the video first,' said Gotou, sounding irritated .

Ishii agreed with Gotou's opinion . It would be better to make an opinion after seeing the video .

'Then I will replay it . '

Makoto pressed a button on the remote control .

Ishii gulped .

The video that was going to play had a spiritual phenomenon on it . When he thought about that, his hands became sweaty in his nervousness .

An old house appeared on screen –

They'd gone to take a look yesterday, so he had seen the place before .

In front of the house gates, a woman and a middle-aged man in worship clothes were talking calmly .

She was probably the female reporter who had fainted .

The video stopped . Then, the house exterior showed on screen .

Then, the setting changed again . There were burst shots of the female reporter . The director gave a signal . At the same time, the woman started speaking .

<Fifteen years ago, a terrible and bizarre murder occurred at this house . . >

'I feel like I've seen this woman somewhere before,' said Gotou with a sharp look .

'It's because she's a talent . It wouldn't be strange for you to have seen her somewhere before . '

In reply to Ishii, Gotou mumbled, 'Makes sense . '

After that, nobody spoke . In the tense atmosphere, they kept their eyes on the video .

Finally, the camera followed the exorcist into the house –

Then, when they arrived at the door at the end of the corridor, the disaster occurred .

The female reporter insisted that somebody had touched her .

It wasn't just the reporter – the cameraman appeared to sense something as well .

The electrifyingly tense atmosphere came through the screen .

'Please rewind a bit . '

Suddenly, Yakumo spoke in a sharp voice .

His gaze was so sharp it felt like they could cut .

'What?'

'Quiet!'

Yakumo refused to answer Gotou .

'Where should I rewind to?' asked Makoto .

'When they went through the entrance . And please raise the volume . '

Yakumo quickly gave instructions .

Makoto rewound to the part of the video where they were at the entrance, raised the volume and pressed the play button again .

This tension – Yakumo had definitely noticed something in the video earlier .

Ishii leant forward to look at the video .

On the television screen, there were the backs of the reporter and the exorcist as they walked down the corridor .

– Kill me too .

There was suddenly a voice . Like a whisper in the ear .

'Eek!' shrieked Ishii . He leapt out of his chair .

He felt a shiver down his spine . Gooseflesh had risen on his skin .

– What was that voice?

Makoto looked shocked as she pressed the pause button .

Normally, Gotou's fist would be flying at a shriek like that, but even Gotou had his mouth wide open . He couldn't speak .

Ishii turned his eyes to Yakumo for an answer .

Yakumo's lips were in a thin line . He had his left index finger on his brow and appeared to be thinking about something .

A suffocating silence continued in the conference room .

'What the hell was that just now?'

Gotou was the first to speak .

'I don't know yet,' Yakumo said grimly .

'You don't know, you say...'

'In any case, let us view the rest of the video . '

At Yakumo's instruction, Makoto pressed play .

The reporter and the exorcist stood in front of the door . It was where they had watched up to .

<I feel great spiritual power from the other side of this door . >

The exorcist spoke .

Right after that, the reporter insisted that somebody had touched her . Then, the cameraman said the same thing .

The exorcist was more frightened than necessary . Yakumo had had his doubts before, but this video wasn't staged . After the video shook furiously, the lights suddenly went out .

The screen went black .

However, the video was still playing .

There was the sound of somebody moving around .

Clang, clang, clang, clang .

The sound of something hitting metal echoed .

Then, there was a loud sound – like something falling – and noise ran across the screen . The camera had probably been dropped .

Then –

A blood-covered woman filled the screen .

Her wide eyes were red and her mouth was wide open . It seemed like she would jump out from the television .

'Eek!'

Ishii threw his body back as he screamed and fell from his chair .

'You're so damn noisy!'

Ishii hurriedly sat back on the chair with the encouragement of Gotou's fist .

After that, the video stopped .

Nobody opened their mouth . They were in mute amazement .

Even Yakumo, the most composed of all of them, was looking down with his face in his hands .

It looked like his shoulders were shaking slightly .

It certainly had been a frightful video . However, for Yakumo, who could see the spirits of the dead, it shouldn't have been anything for him to be afraid of .

What on earth has made him like this –

There was no way for Ishii to know .

After a silence, Yakumo stood up soundlessly .

He had always been pale, but his face was at a different level from that now . It was completely white, as if all the blood had left his face .

'What's wrong?'

Yakumo left the conference room, as if he hadn't heard Gotou's words .

He looked like a living corpse .

'I wonder what happened,' said Ishii to nobody in particular .

'Probably couldn't hold his bladder,' said Gotou lightly, stretching his arms out behind him .

Though Ishii didn't deny it, he felt that it was a different matter .

After that, Yakumo didn't return to the conference room again –

11

After Haruka came out of the bath, her mobile phone started vibrating on the table .

Who could it be? Her hair wasn't even dry yet .

She had been planning on calling back afterwards, but she changed her mind when she saw who was calling .

It was from Yakumo . It was almost a miracle for him to be the one to call her .

Haruka dried her hands on a towel and answered the phone .

'Hellooo . '

<You sound like you've got a lot of free time on your hands, as usual . >

Yakumo made a scornful reply .

How could he say something like that all of a sudden when he was the one who'd called?

'I just got out of the bath . My hair isn't dry yet and I've got to take care of my skin too, so I'm busy . '

<Those are pointless measures . >

Honestly . Yakumo had no delicacy at all .

'I don't need to hear that from you . Why not try fixing your bedhead?'

<I'm just going to say this, but it's not bedhead . My hair grows that way . >

'It's definitely bedhead . '

<You probably wouldn't be able to understand it with your sense . >

She heard Yakumo yawn on the other side of the phone .

He just kept on saying whatever he wanted . Haruka wasn't good with comebacks, so in a way, she admired him .

'So what task do you have for me?'

Haruka brought up the topic at hand .

It hurt her to admit it, but Yakumo wasn't the sort of person who'd call her just to talk . Did he want her to help with another case?

She felt suspicious because of her past experiences .

<I wouldn't call it a task, but...>

Yakumo's enunciation was somewhat off .

'What is it?'

<I need to apologise to you . >

'Apologise?'

– Who was? To whom? Why?

Haruka was confused by Yakumo's completely unexpected words .

She couldn't think of Yakumo apologising to someone else . And he hadn't done anything that would need apologising .

Did he hit his head on something?

<About your performance...>

'Ah, OK . '

Haruka didn't understand where Yakumo was going, so she ended up sounding hesitant .

<Something came up, so I might not be able to go . >

It felt very out of place –

Yakumo's attitude was completely different than it was usually . Plus, he hadn't even promised to go, so he didn't actually need to apologise .

'When you say something came up, do you mean the case Gotou-san brought to you?'

<Well, something like that . Sorry . >

Yakumo spoke in a low voice .

It really was strange . Haruka couldn't shake that feeling away .

'Hey, did something happen?' asked Haruka as she leant on the bed .

<Something?>

'You sound different . '

<Nothing's different about me . >

She heard Yakumo sigh from the other end of the phone .

'You're lying . '

<How can you be so sure of that?>

'Women's intuition . '

Plus, I've been looking at Yakumo for a whole year –

Haruka swallowed those last words and waited for Yakumo's reply .

<Your intuition can't be counted on either . >

Yakumo laughed .

'What do you mean by that?'

<Exactly what I said . Anyway, I'm sorry I couldn't keep my promise . I wanted to see what sort of foolish concert you'd perform...>

'You know, I can perform properly . '

This is what happened if she was a little nice to him . Even though she'd been worried about him, she felt like she'd lost somehow .

<Anyway, sorry for everything . >

Yakumo ended with that and hung up without waiting for Haruka's reply .

After Haruka hung up, she still couldn't shake that strange feeling .

It sort of felt like he'd been saying goodbye –

12

While driving, Ishii looked over at Gotou in the passenger seat .

He had an unlit cigarette in his mouth as he flicked his hundred-yen lighter on and off . Ishii could understand why Gotou was irritated .

Yakumo didn't come back after that no matter how long they waited .

They walked around the newspaper agency to look for Yakumo, but they couldn't find him .

Even when they contacted him by mobile, the phone just kept ringing – Yakumo didn't answer .

They thought he might have gone home by himself, so they went to his secret hiding place, but he hadn't been there . Thinking that he'd come back if they waited, they'd sat there until night, but it had been of no use .

'I wonder where Yakumo-shi has gone,' said Ishii with a disappointed sigh .

'How would I know!?'

Gotou threw his lighter at the front glass .

'What are we going to do now?'

'We won't do anything . It's all over without Yakumo . '

Gotou's resigned voice echoed through the car .

It wasn't like Gotou . Yakumo's sudden disappearance was probably a part of it, but being left out of the investigation was probably taking a toll on Gotou .

He'd been treated this way a number of times before .

It had been particularly bad with the previous chief, Ideuchi . The <Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room> had been a post in name only – it had really been a do-nothing job .

However, Gotou still hadn't been discouraged . It didn't matter what people he hated said . He'd go his own path . He was that strong .

But this time, Miyagawa had been the one who'd told him to keep out of the investigation .

Miyagawa had been Gotou's boss before – Ishii had heard that Miyagawa had been the one who'd taught Gotou the investigation ABCs . Gotou had the greatest confidence in Miyagawa .

That was why he was so irritated . That was probably it .

'If we discuss with Chief Miyagawa once more...'

'It's obviously no use!' yelled Gotou, drowning out Ishii's words .

'But Chief Miyagawa had no ill will...'

'I don't need you to tell me that . '

Gotou clicked his tongue and reclined on his chair . He crossed his arms and closed his eyes .

All Ishii could do was silently devote himself to driving .

– Ever since we spotted Takeda, the gears haven't been turning correctly .

It was a sudden realisation, but that was how Ishii felt . Like it was an omen that something unfortunate was going to happen .

Gotou didn't move at all – he kept his eyes closed until they reached the police parking lot . Did he fall asleep –

'Detective Gotou, we've arrived . '

Ishii shook Gotou's shoulder .

Gotou took in a deep breath and opened his eyes . His expression was weak – he looked ten years older .

'Maybe I'm not fit to be a detective,' Gotou said, his voice hoarse .

– What are you saying? The police need people like you .

Ishii wanted to say that, but the words wouldn't come out, as if something was caught in his throat .

He just stared at the darkness on the other side of the front glass .

Knock knock .

There was a knock on the side window . It was Miyagawa . He peered in from the passenger side .

'Do you need something?'

Gotou opened the window and said that, sounding annoyed . Like a rebellious child .

'Come with me for a bit . '

Miyagawa pointed his chin out, gesturing for Gotou to get off the car .

Gotou frowned but moved to open the car door, like he didn't think there was any way out of it .

'E-er, Detective Gotou . '

Ishii had seen their exchange the other day, so he felt a bit anxious and called out to Gotou .

If he let the two go like this, it might end up in a fight .

'What?'

'Shall I come with you?'

'Go home first,' Gotou replied curtly . Then, he walked away, shoulder-to-shoulder with Miyagawa .

Ishii watched the two of their backs grow farther away through the front glass .

Finally, the darkness swallowed them up and he couldn't see them anymore .

– What if Gotou disappears like this?

That thought crossed Ishii's mind –

13

Makoto spread out the documents on her desk and turned once again towards the case of fifteen years ago .

There had to be another story to this case . She believed that .

It wasn't that she thought the true culprit was somebody else . It was probably Takeda Shunsuke .

A knife thought to be the murder weapon was found at Takeda's flat .

Blood was on it . The blood matches the victims', and the shape of the knife matched the wound .

Furthermore, clothes with a large amount of blood on them had also been found .

The possibility that somebody had hid them in Takeda's flat couldn't be denied, but the decisive proof was that Takeda's fingerprints had been found on the wall at the scene . And the victims' blood had been mixed in .

It was clear that Takeda had touched the wall after he touched the bleeding victims .

Takeda's refusal to go with the police and his escape also corroborated the crime .

Though they hadn't been able to get testimony from him, he had a motive .

Takeda had been following a case as a newspaper reporter . He ended up going to a certain case .

At the middle school that Nanase Kanji was director of and that his son Katsuaki was employed at, there was a suicide from bullying .

That father accused Katsuaki, the homeroom teacher, of participating in the bullying .

Takeda had written a number of articles supporting that father before .

However, the charge ended with the school's win .

Still, Takeda continued writing the article .

Katsuaki thought that disagreeable, so he put pressure on the newspaper agency behind the scenes .

Though they were a newspaper agency, as long as they were managed as a company, those sorts of things would happen .

The agency told Takeda not to pursue the matter further, but he didn't comply . He knew that he couldn't write the article, but he persisted in gathering material .

In the end, he was dismissed from the agency .

Afterwards, Takeda had to take out a number of loans .

They did not know this for certain, but Takeda insisted that he was unfairly burdened with loans at Katsuaki's instigation .

– Moving the story forward .

Takeda's ex-colleague said that Takeda had headed for the Nanase house on the day of the crime .

There was no way to determine what they discussed .

Then – the incident occurred .

'What on earth happened?' murmured Makoto, pressing against her eyes .

There had definitely been strife between Katsuaki and Takeda . He might have lost himself because of something and ended up committing murder .

Even though there shouldn't have been anything to doubt about this case – something didn't fit .

One of the reasons Makoto felt that way was Kanji's granddaughter, Miyuki .

Why had Takeda taken Miyuki with him without killing her?

Escaping with a young child would be rather risky .

There was the possibility that she had already been killed, but her corpse hadn't been found . But why wouldn't he have killed her at the crime scene then?

And the biggest puzzle – why did he show up again just a few days before the statute of limitations was up?

Since they hadn't been able to get Yakumo's analysis, they couldn't say anything for certain, but if there was a ghost there, it meant that somebody else had died in that place fifteen years ago .

And Yakumo's behaviour then had clearly been off .

Though he hadn't said it aloud, he had definitely felt something from that image .

Something unbelievably frightening is happening without our knowing it –

14

Miyagawa brought Gotou through the entrance of a small counter-only bar .

This was unexpected, since Gotou had thought that he would be reprimanded in the meeting room .

The ceiling's beams stuck out . It was so low that Gotou might hit his head if he stood up straighter . There were no patrons except for Gotou and Miyagawa .

At Miyagawa's suggestion, Gotou sat on a crude round chair that could often be found at counters .

'Could you take the bottle out for me?'

After Miyagawa said that, the bartender, cigarette in his mouth as he stood on the other side of the counter, disagreeably took a bottle of potato shochu from the shelf behind him and placed it on the counter .

'And please just get us something else . '

The bartender didn't reply to Miyagawa's order . He just took a bowl from the refrigerator and placed it on the counter .

It was boiled daikon that had changed colour from sitting in the broth for too long .

Meanwhile, Miyagawa took two glasses from on top of the counter, poured out shochu and placed one glass in front of Gotou .

'There's nothing to celebrate, so I'm not going to say cheers,' said Miyagawa, and he gulped down a mouthful .

What was he doing, taking him to a place like this all of a sudden?

Gotou didn't understand, but he didn't dare to mention it aloud . He took a gulp of shochu . The cheaper the alcohol the better it worked . He did have an empty stomach, but he felt his stomach warm up in an instant .

'Yesterday was my bad...' mumbled Miyagawa . He finished the rest of the glass .

'What are you talking about?'

When Gotou asked his question, Miyagawa stared at his glass and muttered, 'Damn . '

Gotou had been afraid of and looked up to the demon that Miyagawa had been in the past, but the back of the man he had followed looked smaller

now .

'About how I left you out of the investigation,' said Miyagawa as he held the shochu bottle at a slant .

'What? You were worried about that? That's not like you . '

Miyagawa snorted at Gotou's attempt to poke fun .

Gotou had acted like that then, but it wasn't like he didn't understand Miyagawa's position .

He could've just acted freely in the past, as somebody at the scene, but Miyagawa couldn't do that anymore .

He had to lead dozens of investigation members while stifling his own emotions .

Teamwork was the priority . It was the right decision to leave Gotou out, since he was somebody who stood up .

Gotou had been the one who'd chased the chief of the detectives to retirement and arrested the old chief .

The people who thought that Gotou's very existence was a nuisance were not few in number .

'Calling me a chief makes me sound high and mighty, but I'm just middle management . I've become a useless old man . '

'That's not...'

Gotou swallowed his words .

He was no good with situations like this . Work before grumbling . That was the only way Gotou knew how to live .

'It was fun working the scene with you, but it's not fun at all now . '

Miyagawa hit the counter, like his emotions had reached their limit .

'There's nothing you can do, right? In your position . '

Miyagawa glared at Gotou sharply, like he hadn't liked his words .
However, he didn't say anything . He emptied his glass again .

To Gotou, Miyagawa was definitely somebody he could trust .

However, he felt that that relationship of trust had changed a lot . It was unfortunate, but it couldn't be helped . He knew that .

'Oi . Got a cig?' asked Miyagawa, after pouring his third glass of shochu .

'Didn't you stop smoking?'

'Shut up! Just give me one . '

It was practically extortion . Gotou gave Miyagawa a cigarette, just as he was asked, and lit it for him . Miyagawa slowly took in the smoke .

'I'm going to say this just 'cause it's you . '

Miyagawa made that his preface before beginning .

'I forgot the face of the guy when he hit my head during that case . '

'It's laughable . '

Gotou had heard that Miyagawa had been the first on the scene for Takeda's case .

'Shut up . I forgot his face, but there's one thing I remember...'

Miyagawa slapped his hand against his neck . It seemed like it was difficult for him to say .

'What is it?'

'His eyes . '

'Eyes?'

Gotou raised his eyebrows .

Miyagawa took another deep breath of smoke .

'The man's eyes were red like fire . '

'W-w-w-what did you say!?' yelled Gotou from the bottom of his stomach, standing up .

A man with two red eyes . Could that guy be connected to the case –

'Do you have any ideas?'

'No...'

'Those eyes weren't human eyes . That was... a demon in human skin . '

If the person Miyagawa was talking about was the person Gotou was thinking of, the word 'demon' was perfect .

But –

'Why are you bringing that up?'

Gotou sat down again and drank his shochu .

'I wonder... Something just bothers me about that case . '

'You're investigating it now, right?'

'That's not it,' said Miyagawa disagreeably . He put his cigarette out in the ashtray .

After coming this far, even Gotou could tell what Miyagawa was trying to say .

'... Are you telling me to investigate along a different route?'

Miyagawa finished his glass of shochu without replying .

Damn . No matter what he said, the old man was cunning .

15

The next morning, Ishii went together with Gotou to the house where the incident occurred .

Nobody had touched it for years, so the house had been left alone –

Even though it should have already died, there was an overwhelming feeling of existence from the house for some reason . The sound of the wind sounded like the house's roar .

He had heard before that scenes where there had been murders had a unique smell, so maybe this was it .

His knees were shaking, but it wasn't from the cold .

'Er, Detective Gotou, are we really going in?'

Ishii called out to Gotou's back .

'Of course . '

Gotou threw down the cigarette that had been in his mouth and crushed it with his foot before walking towards the entrance .

Gotou had been sulking so much the day before, so when he'd said 'We're going to the house where the crime occurred!' this morning, Ishii had honestly been happy .

But I really don't want to go inside this house –

Especially after he'd seen the video yesterday and they didn't have Yakumo to rely on, this was near suicide .

This wasn't just a house . There had been the horrific murder case fifteen years ago, and a ghost had been caught on video . It could be called a real haunted house .

'Er, wouldn't it be better to wait for another day?' suggested Ishii as he followed Gotou .

'You're so obstinate . Things'll work out even without Yakumo . '

'But we can't see ghosts . We should go together with Yakumo-shi . '

'Yakumo's not here . Nothing we can do about it . '

'That's true, but...'

Gotou had called Yakumo a number of times this morning and had visited Yakumo's secret hiding place before coming here just in case, but in the end, he hadn't been able to contact him .

'Things'll work out even if we don't see the ghost . '

'But...'

Ishii was lost for words . He was just afraid .

Gotou placed his hand on the door knob and slowly pulled . The door opened with something that sounded like a shriek .

That was enough to make Ishii want to shriek himself .

Perhaps because all the shutters were closed, the house was completely dark even though it was day .

Gotou turned on the torch in his hand .

That light lit up the way from the wide entrance . Ishii could see a long corridor . It was covered in dust and there were footsteps in the fallen leaves .

At the end of the corridor, there was an old wooden door .

That was – the door they'd seen in the video .

'Detective Gotou, we really...'

Gotou's fist fell on Ishii's head, interrupting his words . He bit his tongue .

'Stop whining . You don't have to come if you're so afraid . '

Ishii knew that he should say, 'I'm fine . I'll go . ' However, his fear stopped him from speaking .

He couldn't look at Gotou's face, so he looked at his feet .

– I'm so useless .

'Though you'd be no use,' muttered Gotou .

Normally, Gotou would yell and hit him with his fist . But –

Ishii felt something was off so he lifted his head .

Gotou had already gone inside and was walking down the corridor .

– I've been left behind .

Ishii gathered his courage and took the first step after Gotou .

At the same time, the wind blew loudly and the front door slammed shut with a bang .

It was like it was telling him not to come in .

Ishii didn't have the courage to open the door again .

* * *

Gotou turned around at the sound of the door shutting .

He'd been sure Ishii would follow him, but it seemed like he'd been wrong .

So he really was going to wait outside . That fool . Gotou would punch him once he got back .

Gotou clicked his tongue and started walking down the corridor again .

Creak .

The floor groaned underneath him .

Maybe it was worn out . Or maybe it was because of his weight . Well, it didn't matter .

His breath was white when he breathed out . He'd thought it'd be better inside the house, but it was colder inside than out . Gotou blew on his hands and rubbed them together .

– Now, what's going to coming out?

Gotou went straight down the corridor until the door at the end .

All the corpses had been found in the living room on the other side of this door .

From the situation, it seemed that they'd all been killed in the same room rather than carried there from other rooms . There was something Gotou didn't understand .

– Why didn't anybody run?

Since there'd been four of them, even if it'd been a brawny guy, at least one of them should've gotten away, but they'd all been killed . None of them had been able to get past the door .

Well, there was no point thinking about it . Gotou knew best that he wasn't the type to come up with theories and put his logic to work .

He'd go to the scene . Look with his eyes, listen with his ears, feel with his skin and just go with his gut .

Gotou licked his lips and opened the door .

The door opened with an unpleasant creak .

It stank . The air was stagnant .

Gotou covered his nose with his coat sleeve and entered the room .

It was darker than the corridor had been . The clammy air wrapped around him .

There had been a sofa, table and television on the day of the crime, but now it was just a wide space with nothing in it .

He could see that the floor in the middle of the room was stained .

The four corpses had been found piled up there .

Gotou stooped in front of the dark stain and lit up his surroundings to look around .

There were dark stains on parts of the floor and wall . That was – blood .

Miyagawa had said this yesterday .

– It was hell .

And the guy he'd seen there . The man with two red eyes . Had it been that man, or had Miyagawa's eyes just been playing tricks on him?

Gotou wanted him to be wrong .

That man's methods made Gotou want to vomit .

The bastard wouldn't stick his own hands into matters . He'd get close to people with his way with words and manipulate their hearts . He provoked

people's weak points and drove them to crime .

He'd used this trick a number of times in cases, but Gotou had never caught him . Even if he did catch him, he wouldn't go to trial .

The bastard hadn't done anything . That was why he infuriated Gotou . All his cases left a bad aftertaste .

It was ironic that the bastard's son, Yakumo, was the one plucking the seeds he sowed .

The moment Yakumo had seen the video this time, he'd disappeared – what the hell was he thinking?

The man with the red eyes . And that video –

Gotou suddenly thought of something while musing .

– I see . So that's why Yakumo ran off .

Gotou clapped his hands together in his excitement and stood up .

If what he was thinking was correct, things were going to get serious .
Gotou took up his mobile .

That moment – he felt somebody behind him .

– That idiot Ishii . So he's finally come? Honestly .

'What are you standing there for? Hurry up and come over . '

There was no response to Gotou's yell .

Even though he'd normally respond right away and run over like one of Pavlov's dogs –

The footsteps slowly approached .

– Oi, oi . This some kind of joke?

Right before Gotou could turn around, something cold was thrust against his neck . Ishii didn't have the guts to fool around like this .

'Who's there? What are you doing here?'

There was no reply .

All Gotou could hear was ragged breathing, like the person was agitated .

A druggie – if that was the case, Gotou wouldn't be able to talk to them . He'd have to use force .

Gotou prepared himself .

'I don't plan on resisting . Let's talk a bit . '

A growl came instead of a response .

– What a creep .

And where'd the guy come in from? Ishii should've been at the entrance .

Maybe Ishii could've been easily held down, but it'd taken way too little time . The guy might've been in the room from the very beginning .

'OK, I'm going to turn around . '

Gotou raised both hands to show he had no intention of resisting and slowly turned around .

He was confident that things would work out somehow if they faced each other .

He'd grab the arm with the weapon and twist it away . Since they were so close, that would be the quickest method no matter what weapon it was .

'I'm just going to turn around . I'm not going to do anything,' Gotou repeated .

For just a moment, he felt whatever was against his neck lift away .

– Now!

Gotou tried to turn around, but he had only let down his guard .

An impact ran through his body, making him bend over .

Gotou didn't even have the time to feel pain before his consciousness disappeared into a deep darkness –

16

After her morning lecture, Haruka headed towards the <Movie Research Circle> club room .

The conversation she'd had with Yakumo the night before wouldn't leave her head .

It was also strange that Yakumo would call her himself, and it wasn't like he'd promised to go to the performance . Something really was off .

That feeling only grew as time passed .

– Sorry for everything .

It didn't sound like he was just talking about the performance .

I might just be thinking too much, but it'd sounded like he was saying goodbye –

That negative thought came to Haruka during her lecture .

If she was going to worry about her own delusions, it'd be better to ask the person directly . Haruka decided to come here for this reason .

She took deep breaths in front of the door .

If she opened the door, Yakumo would be there . He'd definitely say 'What did you come here for?' like he always did .

'Hey!'

Haruka put a smile on her face and opened the door .

– No one's here .

The clubroom was dark and quiet .

– Is he sleeping?

Haruka looked to the back of the room, but the sleeping bag was empty .

The ticket Haruka had brought yesterday had been left on the table .

Haruka sat on the folding chair and stared at that ticket .

If this was left here, does that mean he hasn't come back ever since he left with Gotou –

She almost relaxed, thinking that he'd gone to lecture or was investigating the case with Gotou, but the phone call from yesterday had definitely been off .

Haruka took her mobile from her bag and tried calling Yakumo .

<The number you have called is unavailable...>

The automated voice that came through sounded more hollow than usual .

Haruka had come here to reassure herself, but now she was even more anxious .

Maybe something happened to Yakumo –

Her thoughts were becoming more negative .

'No, that's impossible for Yakumo,' said Haruka, cheering herself up .

She was just thinking too much . It wasn't the first time she'd come to this room when Yakumo wasn't here .

She felt a chill down her spine –

Haruka reflexively turned around, since she felt like somebody was watching her .

She felt like she saw a black shadow run off in the corner of her vision .

However, when she got up to look around, she didn't see anybody .

Are my eyes playing tricks on me –

'Honestly, where'd he go...'

Haruka sat back down and picked the ticket up with her fingers .

17

The sparrows on the tree flew up all at once .

'Eek!'

Ishii jumped with a shriek .

He had stayed outside because he was too afraid, but he felt anxious since Gotou still hadn't come out .

He felt guilty for letting Gotou go alone too .

– I should really go inside the house too .

Ishii gulped and brought his hand close to the front door .

Jolt .

'Ack!'

A shock ran through Ishii's fingertips, making him stand up straight .

His heart was throbbing . His breathing was ragged .

– Do your best, Ishii Yuutarou .

Ishii encouraged himself and stood in front of the door again .

He slowly reached out and touched the doorknob . This time, there was no shock .

Creak .

There was a metallic shriek as the door opened .

He had to calm down . That was just because of a rusty hinge . Ishii told himself that as he walked through the entrance .

The door shut with a slam .

It was so dark that he couldn't see his feet clearly .

– I should've brought a torch .

Ishii took his mobile out of his pocket and lit up the floor with its faint light before continuing down the corridor .

Every time he took a step, it got harder to breathe and his body felt heavier . It was like he was underwater .

His palms were sweaty and his knees were shaking .

Clang, clang, clang, clang .

Suddenly, there was the sound of something hitting metal .

Ishii turned around at the sound . At some point, the front door had opened .

Fear and anxiety made his head feel dizzy .

The floor was shaking .

His ears were ringing .

– What? What? Isn't this just like that video?

Ishii couldn't stand it . He fell to his knees .

'Calm down, calm down . '

He shut his eyes and told himself that while taking deep breaths .

He felt a bit better after doing that .

Ishii stood up again and looked down the corridor . The door at the end of the corridor . He just had to go there .

'Detective Gotou . '

Ishii called out . However, there was no response .

'Detective Gotou!'

He leant forward and spoke more loudly .

He didn't hear anything at all .

'Detective Gotou!'

Ishii raised his voice even further, but there was still no response .

Could something have happened to Gotou – no, that was impossible .

'Detective Gotou, please respond . '

Silence .

The floor creaked .

His forehead was drenched in sweat . The image he'd seen in the video kept flashing back in his head . He really was afraid . His knees were shaking terribly . He had to use the wall to support himself .

'Detective Gotou! Please respond!'

There was still no response . Oh . He could use his phone . Ishii called Gotou's number using his mobile .

However, it seemed like there was no service here, so the call didn't connect .

Ishii bit down on his fear, focussed on his shaking legs and slowly took steps forward . Every time he took a step, the floor creaked underneath him . It made Ishii feel even more afraid .

He was terrified . But he had to go . Something might have happened to Gotou . With the wall as support, Ishii walked to the door .

On the opposite side of the door . Ishii's throat was dry . He wiped the sweat off his forehead and adjusted the position of his glasses before placing his hand on the doorknob . His heart was beating furiously . He slowly opened the door .

Creeeeek .

There was nothing . The room was empty .

A torch had fallen in the centre of the room . And a mobile phone beside it . The moment he saw that, Ishii's fear vanished .

He walked to the centre of the room and yelled .

'Detective Gotou! Where are you? Please respond!'

He looked around frantically, but he couldn't spot Gotou anywhere .

He picked up the torch and the mobile and looked in every corner of the room, but Gotou was nowhere to be found .

There was only one door to the room . And all the windows were shut .

Had somebody come into the room while Ishii was standing outside? Did Gotou leave the torch and mobile here on purpose? That made no sense . Then where was he?

Ishii suddenly felt somebody's presence in a corner of the room .

'Detective Gotou...'

Ishii turned around . A woman stood there . A woman in a black dress . She was looking down so he couldn't see her face . Ishii was frozen in his fear .

'Ee...'

He couldn't even scream – his breath had caught in his throat . The woman slowly approached Ishii .

Stay away . Stay away . Stay away!

There was no way for the woman to hear the screams in Ishii's heart . She walked up to him and suddenly raised his face .

Her cloudy eyes were wide open as they stared at Ishii . Then, she opened her mouth so wide it felt like her chin would come off and vomited a large amount of liquid .

Ishii frantically wiped the liquid off of his face . When he looked at his hands, they were dyed red . It was blood . It was too late . He was going to be killed .

No . I don't want to die . I don't want to die . I don't want to die .

NOTES:

[1] A tsubo is a unit of measurement used for buildings and is equivalent to 3 . 31 square metres .

Volume 5 Chapter 2: VOLUME 5 – CONNECTED FEELINGS

Chapter 2

VOLUME 5 – CONNECTED FEELINGS

file 02: touching (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

Haruka opened her eyes . Her chest felt like it was being crushed .

In the dim light, she saw the ceiling .

Dawn didn't appear to have come yet –

Even though there was no wind, the pink curtain was waving .

The suffocating feeling didn't leave her even after she opened her eyes .
She pressed her hands to her chest and turned over .

The moment she turned, she noticed that her mobile's green light was
blinking on the table . It seemed she had a message .

She checked the alarm clock on the table . Four in the morning –

When she woke up at dawn, something bad always happened . Haruka shut
her eyes to cut off the bad memories .

– Can you hear my voice?

A voice whispered in her ear .

Haruka sat up, startled .

She saw a black shadow .

Somebody was standing in front of door that went out to the hallway .
Probably a man .

Who are you? Where'd you come in from? What are you doing there?

She had so many questions, but she couldn't speak . Her eyes were ringing
—

The man slowly approached .

She could vaguely see the man's face . As pale as porcelain and as
expressionless as a mannequin .

'S-stay away . '

Haruka wrung those words out of her throat .

But the man kept coming closer . Haruka gripped the blanket tightly and put
her back to the wall .

The man stopped in front of the table .

— Can you hear my voice?

The man's mouth moved slowly . He spoke calmly, as if he was giving a
speech .

A cold sweat ran down Haruka's forehead . Her chest hurt — it felt like she
had been stabbed by needles . Her body was shaking from fear .

'Calm down,' Haruka said to herself .

She had to get out of this room . Haruka looked around for a way to escape .

She spotted scissors on top of the table .

She didn't actually have to hurt him . If she could just make him flinch for a moment, she could get out of the room .

Things would work out somehow if she got out . She just needed to find good timing .

Haruka put the scissors in the corner of her vision and watched the man's movements .

– I'll ask once more . Can you hear my voice?

The man spoke .

He covered his face, as if he were tired of Haruka's refusal to respond .

– Now!

Haruka leapt from the bed and quickly grabbed the scissors on top of the table . She thrust them at the man .

The man tried to approach Haruka .

'Please . Stay away . '

Her voice was cracking .

The hand she was holding the scissors with was shaking . Her heart felt like it would burst out of her chest .

– Please . Just go away .

Perhaps Haruka's frantic plea had reached him, because the man shook his head, like he had given up, and turned around .

– You're looking for Saitou Yakumo-kun, aren't you?

'... Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka spoke without thinking .

Why does this man know Yakumo's name? And looking for him, he says –

– I can't save him .

The man's words reverberated in Haruka's ears .

'Save him, you say... Did something happen to Yakumo-kun?'

Haruka let go of the scissors and spoke in a voice near a cry .

I have a lot of questions . Who is this person? Why does he know about Yakumo? How did he get here? But I don't care about that right now .

The way the man said that makes it sound like something happened to Yakumo .

I want to know . What happened to Yakumo? And where is he now –

– He is probably in Nagano .

'Nagano? Why is he there?'

– Because that is the place where it began .

What did he mean?

– If you don't hurry, he...

The man walked away silently before Haruka could voice her question .

'Wait . '

I don't know anything . Tell me . What happened to Yakumo?

Haruka hurriedly chased after the man into the corridor .

However, the man had disappeared .

Just as Makoto was leaving work, the internal line rang .

The timing was so good – as if she was being watched .

Makoto picked up the telephone with her coat still on .

<Hey, it's been a while . I heard you got dropped to planning?>

She heard Takizawa's voice from the receiver . The way he spoke without holding back wasn't disagreeable – rather, it was pleasant .

Takizawa helped her with the case half of a year ago .

It was an unforgettable case for Makoto . Takizawa had given all the material he had gathered himself to Makoto then .

He put revealing the truth ahead of getting an exclusive scoop . That was the type of person he was .

'It's been a while . "Dropped" is the wrong word though . I'm satisfied with the situation,' said Makoto with a laugh . It wasn't just a front – that was actually how she felt .

<You're fine if you can say that much . But it really sucks . Somebody with guts like you should be in journalism . And the new guys here...>

Takizawa started grumbling .

Newspaper agencies tended to have longwinded people . Gathering material started from dragging out stories . That habit didn't leave them . It was an occupational disease .

'What are you calling for today?' asked Makoto, interrupting Takizawa .

He began by chatting, but they weren't close enough for him to just call using the internal line for no reason . It was clear that he had some intention .

<Ah, that's right . >

Takizawa seemed to have just recalled what he'd wanted to say . He cleared his throat and then brought up the topic at hand in a low voice .

<You know the detective called Gotou, right?>

'Yes . '

She didn't only know him – they'd just met last night .

<The police've put out a gag order so this is off-record . >

'That's all right . Did something happen to Detective Gotou?'

Her heart was beating uncomfortably .

<Seems he's disappeared . >

'Disappeared,' repeated Makoto . She didn't understand what he'd meant .

It didn't sound like something a reporter used to cases would say .

<Right . Seems he disappeared during an investigation . Don't know why . Apparently there's the possibility that somebody abducted him . >

'What did you say?'

Makoto's voice went one octave higher in surprise .

Gotou had probably made many enemies in his line of work – he lived side by side with danger .

But she just couldn't understand why a detective would be abducted . Why would anybody need to do something with such a high risk, and for what reason? There wasn't anybody more troublesome for a hostage than a detective .

And abducting Gotou wouldn't have been an easy task .

Especially if he had been in the middle of an investigation . Detectives didn't work alone . Ishii should have been there too .

– Not him too?

Takizawa sighed .

He probably sensed how deep their relationship was from Makoto's response .

'Er, when was that?'

This was no good . She had to stay calm . Right now, she wanted more information, even if it was just a little . Makoto restrained her agitation and focussed on her trembling throat as she asked the question .

<Yesterday . >

'Was it only Detective Gotou who was abducted?'

<Nobody's sure he was abducted yet . Don't know what happened to his partner either . >

'How is the scene? The investigation?'

Ishii might be together with Gotou . When Makoto thought about that, she couldn't stop herself from throwing out questions .

<Oi, oi . Calm down . We don't know the details yet . >

Makoto came to her senses after Takizawa tried to pacify her . She was gripping the phone so tightly that her fingers were white .

'Sorry, I just...'

Makoto consciously relaxed her shoulders .

<Anyway, that's how it is . Do what you like with that . >

After Takizawa said that, he hung up without waiting for Makoto's answer .

Makoto put the phone down and thought over Takizawa's words . He probably meant that she should try looking into the matter herself, now that he'd given her the info .

First, she would confirm that Ishii was safe . If Ishii was safe, she might be able to get some information from him .

Makoto took out her bag and called a number from her contacts .

Please be safe . She wished for that in her heart .

3

Ishii lay on his desk in a stupor .

He remembered up until his face was showered in blood .

He couldn't remember anything after that .

When he came to, he had been collapsed in the garden . He had probably run out of the room in his fear .

He'd hurriedly wiped at his face, but there was no blood .

Was that a delusion –

Ishii had been bewildered, but he remembered about Gotou immediately and called for help from the precinct .

He met up with the police officers who came afterwards and searched the site, but they couldn't find Gotou in the end .

Investigators searched the site through the night, but nothing came up . No, that was wrong . They couldn't actually find anything specific .

That site was famous on the net for being haunted, and it appeared that a number of fanatics of the kind had stepped in and out .

There had been fingerprints and footprints, but it would take a huge amount of time to examine them .

Just earlier, the investigators had placed Gotou's mobile phone and torch, still in a plastic bag, on Ishii's desk .

There was no way Gotou would go missing .

Not just Gotou . It was extremely strange for a detective on an investigation to go missing, leaving just a mobile phone behind . It would probably be appropriate to think that somebody had abducted him .

But why was he abducted? And how?

Nobody was foolish enough to abduct a detective for no reason . There must have been a goal .

And it wouldn't have been easy to abduct Gotou . It would probably require at least three people .

There were other things Ishii didn't understand . He'd been standing at the front door then . How did the group of culprits get in and how did they get out –

Ishii raised his face in his confusion . He was so irritated he could scream .

– Things wouldn't have ended up like this if I'd gone with him then .

A wave of regret tore at Ishii's heart .

Suddenly, the door opened . Miyagawa came in and approached Ishii with an incredibly angry face .

Ishii stood up reflexively, led by that pressure .

'Explain!'

Miyagawa's thick voice shook the bottom of Ishii's stomach .

'I-I don't u-understand either . '

"“I don't understand” isn't gonna cut it! Tell me! What happened!”

Miyagawa gripped Ishii by the collar .

Veins popped out on his forehead . It felt like Miyagawa might strangle Ishii depending on his reply .

'Detective Gotou and I heard about the spiritual phenomenon that occurred at that house... Er, we thought that it might be a lead, so yesterday, we went to the site...'

Ishii's throat was dry from nerves as he explained .

It felt like all the blood in his body had been drawn to his neck .

'And?'

'Ah, yes . Detective Gotou went inside the house . As he took a while to return, I went inside, and... er, he had disappeared . '

'Why didn't you go in with Gotou?'

Miyagawa's fierce look shot through Ishii .

'Er... That's...'

'Stop squirming! Say it clearly!'

Miyagawa's yell made Ishii shrink . Sweat ran down his forehead .

'I stayed outside because I was scared!'

'Scared? You seriously telling me that?'

'Y-yes sir . '

'Scared isn't gonna cut it either! You fool!'

Miyagawa thrust Ishii away with both hands .

Ishii couldn't brace himself, so he tumbled to the desk . The office supplies clattered against the floor .

Ishii couldn't retort – all he could do was bite his lip and stare at the floor .

'So what've you been doing since yesterday?'

Miyagawa made Ishii stand up again and brought his face so close that their noses were almost touching .

His eyes were blazing with rage . Ishii felt anew the affection Miyagawa had for Gotou deep in his heart, no matter how Miyagawa acted towards him .

On the other hand, I –

Ishii cursed his own weakness .

'I was here . '

'Hah? What'd you say?'

Miyagawa glared at Ishii in disbelief .

'I was here this whole time . '

'You were spaced out at your desk since yesterday?'

Ishii bit his lip, his hands in tight fists .

After determining that Gotou wasn't at home, he returned to the precinct and had, as Miyagawa said, been at his desk in a stupor .

I didn't know what to do – no, that's wrong .

I couldn't do anything alone .

'Answer me!'

Miyagawa's yell rang deep in Ishii's ears . Ishii acted like he yearned to be like Gotou, but the truth was that he just clung to him and let Gotou spoil and protect him .

'I-I apologise . '

The moment he said that, Miyagawa rammed his head into Ishii's nose .

Ishii fell to the ground in a rush of pain and pressed a hand against his head .

The lenses of his glasses had broken and were scattered on the floor .

Blood dripped onto the floor . It was mixed with tears .

Ishii dug his fingernails into the floor .

It wasn't from the pain . It wasn't from mortification . It was from anger . Anger towards himself . He couldn't forgive himself . He was so angry he wished he himself would disappear .

'There's a message from Gotou's wife . '

'A-ah...'

Ishii looked up at the unexpected words .

Miyagawa looked down at Ishii, as if Ishii were a maggot .

"I leave my husband to you . " That's what she said . '

'Eh?'

'What do you mean, eh!? Listen up! That's not a message to me or to the investigation department! That message was entrusted to you personally!'

'To me personally...'

'Do you know what these words mean!?'

The various emotions that had welled up within him erupted all at once .

Tears kept falling from his eyes .

Ishii lay on the floor, sobbing .

'If you've got the time to wail, go find Gotou, no matter what you have to do . I'll never forgive you if anything happens to him . '

Miyagawa said those words calmly, one by one .

They echoed much more heavily in Ishii's heart than his yells .

What on earth should I do –

I've always only been a burden . It's impossible for me to find Gotou on my own .

All Ishii could do was cower in his shell like a turtle .

4

Haruka climbed the steep slope up to the temple .

The events of this morning had replayed over and over again in her head .

Who was that man? What did he mean by save Yakumo? And he had said that Yakumo was in Nagano .

Questions were whirling about in her head .

She waited for morning and then went to Yakumo's secret hiding place, the clubroom for the <Movie Research Circle> .

However, Yakumo hadn't been there . The ticket Haruka had given him was still on the table .

That's proof that he hasn't returned yet –

She called Gotou's mobile to see if he knew anything, but it didn't connect .
She didn't know Ishii's contact information .

She had only one clue left .

– That person must know something .

Haruka couldn't restrain her impatience, so she ran up the slope and went through the gate of the temple at the top .

She passed the gravel garden and stopped at the priests' quarters at the back of the premises .

She took deep breaths to regulate her breathing .

Yakumo normally lived in the school clubroom, but this temple was his home .

She was just jumping to conclusions . Something had happened and Yakumo had returned to his home . If she opened the door, Yakumo would be there, and he'd say something like 'The scatterbrain is here' .

With that hope, Haruka rang the door chime by the sliding door .

After a moment, Isshin, the uncle who had raised Yakumo, showed up .

'Hey, Haruka-chan . Thanks for coming . '

In his working clothes, Isshin had a gentle smile reminiscent of Maitreya .

When she saw that gentle smile, Haruka felt all her worries fly away .

'I apologise for coming by so suddenly . Actually, er...'

Haruka apologised for her rudeness and tried to explain the whole story, but she couldn't find the words .

'You're looking for Yakumo then,' said Isshin, as if he had seen to the bottom of Haruka's heart .

– The way he says that, it sounds like he knows something .

'Where is Yakumo-kun now?'

Haruka, feeling suddenly emotional, gripped Isshin's arm .

'Calm down . '

Isshin touched Haruka's shoulders and spoke in a pacifying tone .

'E-excuse me . '

Haruka came to her senses and let go of Isshin's arm .

So many things happened that I lost my cool . This is really embarrassing –

'It's cold out . Let's talk inside . '

Haruka accepted Isshin's invitation honestly .

She was led to the living room, and then she sat across from Isshin, with a kotatsu[1] between them .

'Where's Yakumo-kun?' said Haruka, stopping Isshin before he could prepare tea .

She appreciated the gesture, but she wanted to find out about Yakumo as quickly as she could .

'Unfortunately, I don't know . '

'Eh?'

'Truth is, I'm searching for Yakumo too . '

Haruka had hoped he would be in this house, but that wish easily collapsed .

And –

'Isshin-san, why are you looking for...'

'The day before yesterday, Yakumo popped by . He was really odd then . '

'What do you mean?'

'He asked about his mother . About what sort of person she was . '

'His mother...'

If Yakumo had really asked about that, it certainly would have been unnatural .

Yakumo detested his mother .

His mother had tried to kill him when he was small . After she had failed, his mother went missing and was still missing now .

Why did his own mother try to kill him – Yakumo lived with that question . His mind wouldn't hold up if he took that squarely and thought about it .

Yakumo's logic was that he could balance his heart by hating his mother .

Perhaps because of that, Yakumo didn't bring up his mother himself, and when he talked about his mother, he always spoke recklessly and on edge .

'It appears that Yakumo is interested in the period when she tried to kill him . '

As Isshin said that, his eyes seemed to be looking far away .

'Why did his mother try to kill him... Is he looking for that reason?'

Haruka put the theory she'd come up with into words .

'Actually, I was thinking the same thing,' said Isshin with a nod .

Yakumo was chasing after his own mother . That was why he went off by himself without saying anything .

She could accept that reasoning, but then more questions came up .

'Why so suddenly?'

'I thought that you might know, Haruka-chan...' said Isshin with a bitter smile, scratching at his cheek .

She didn't have any clear proof, but she did have an idea as to where they could find out .

'Detective Gotou might know . '

'Gotou-kun...'

Isshin's brow furrowed into a difficult expression .

'I don't know the details, but the day before yesterday, Gotou-san came to visit Yakumo-kun . '

'Is Gotou-kun still dragging Yakumo into cases...'

Isshin's shoulders slumped in disappointment .

When she'd called Gotou earlier, the call hadn't connected, but it might connect if she tried now .

'I'm going to try to contact him once more . '

Haruka inputted Gotou's number on her phone .

Contrary to her hopes, the phone didn't ring – it went straight to voicemail .

'There's no need to be anxious . '

'But...'

'Let's think about it from the beginning again . There might be a hint . '

'Yes . '

Haruka gripped the red stone on her necklace tightly .

The necklace I got from Yakumo . And the necklace Yakumo's mother wore

—

'Haruka-chan, why are you looking for Yakumo?' Isshin said, as if beginning a speech .

For a moment, Haruka wasn't sure whether she should mention what happened this morning . She didn't even completely believe it herself, but Isshin would believe her . That was how she felt .

'This morning, a man suddenly came into my room...'

'Somebody you know?'

'No . '

Haruka shook her head .

'Did he come to visit?'

'No . The window was unlocked, so he probably came in from there . '

'Haruka-chan...'

Isshin's expression hardened .

He didn't say anything outright, but a man had broken into the room of a woman living by herself . She knew what he meant even if he didn't say it aloud .

'I'm all right,' Haruka said firmly, sweeping away Isshin's worries . Isshin's expression relaxed once he saw how she responded .

Just when Haruka was about to continue her explanation, her mobile phone rang .

5

Ishii stared at the glasses on his desk .

The right lens was cracked like a spider web . The left only had shards of the lens remaining in the frame .

– Just like my heart .

Ishii bit his lip in shame .

He couldn't do anything . He had been able to move forward even though he was a burden because Gotou had been there for him up until now .

Without Gotou, he was just a dead weight . An existence that just sank to the bottom of the deep sea .

He really should have quit the force after the last case .

He had been so happy when Gotou stopped him that he'd stayed on the force, but because of that, this was how things had ended up .

A sudden knock on the door interrupted Ishii's thoughts .

He turned around and stared at the door . He didn't respond . He didn't want to see anybody right now . He wanted them to leave .

But the door opened, contrary to Ishii's desire .

'Hello . '

A woman's voice . Since he didn't have his glasses on, his vision was fuzzy and he couldn't discern who it was .

'I heard about Detective Gotou . '

It was Makoto's voice .

Why does she know about Gotou – for a moment, Ishii was confused, but he soon understood .

She was a newspaper reporter . Although reporting it was restricted, she could probably still get the information .

She was the sort of person who could be considerate of others . She had probably come all the way here because she was worried, but to Ishii right now, that was just a bother .

He didn't want to talk to anybody now . Ishii said nothing and turned his back to Makoto .

'Ishii-san, are you not going to search for Detective Gotou?'

Makoto probably didn't intend it to sound this way, but Ishii felt like those words were pointed .

'I already searched for him . '

Ishii lay on his desk and covered his ears .

He wanted to cut off all his senses . He wanted to feel nothing, like a rock on the side of the road . He wanted to be something that nobody would notice .

'Ishii-san . '

Makoto touched Ishii's shoulder .

'Please leave me alone!'

Ishii stood up and brushed away Makoto's hand .

He thought that she would leave, but Makoto just stood there . Without his glasses, Ishii couldn't tell what expression she had on her face .

Just from facing her, he felt how wretched his own existence was .

– Please just leave a useless person like me alone .

Ishii sat back down in his chair, covering his face with his hands .

'Ishii-san, let's look for Detective Gotou,' said Makoto .

'It's impossible . I can't do it . '

'Why not?'

Makoto's words sounded cruel to Ishii .

There was only one reason he couldn't look for Gotou . Because he was a coward .

'It's impossible, so I said it's impossible . '

Ishii could tell his voice was shaking .

'You can do it . '

– Don't say that so easily .

'Even though you're telling me to look for him, where and how should I search? I have absolutely no idea where Detective Gotou might have disappeared to . '

Ishii raised his head to look at Makoto .

He really couldn't see her expression . But he felt her gaze acutely .

'There must be a connection between Detective Gotou's disappearance and the case, so if you follow the case, you should reach Detective Gotou . '

Makoto spoke calmly and gently .

I know what she's trying to say . I also know that that is the only lead I have to look for Gotou . But –

'I can't do anything alone . '

'You aren't alone . '

'...'

'I will look for Detective Gotou with you . '

After Makoto said that, she took Ishii's hand . Ishii, who had no immunity towards women, moved away from Makoto in order to escape .

'Ishii-san, it's all right . You can do it . '

Makoto took Ishii's hand again, this time in both of her hands . It felt like she was showing her determination .

However, Ishii didn't understand . Why was Makoto doing so much –

No, not just Makoto . Gotou and Yakumo too hadn't abandoned somebody as useless as him – they had worked with him . Why –

Ishii's heart faltered .

'I don't know what to do...'

'First, let's solve the puzzle of that video . There's no guarantee that we will find Detective Gotou, but there is nothing else we can do . '

Makoto gripped Ishii's hands even more tightly .

It was like she was holding on frantically to Ishii who was about to fall off a cliff .

'... But I probably can't solve it . '

'I probably can't either . We might not be able to do anything in the end . But this is better than doing nothing and regretting it afterwards . '

Makoto's words weighed heavily on Ishii's chest .

What she said made sense . But as long as they had no way to look for him, it was certain they would regret it .

'It really is impossible . '

He felt more and more what a useless man he was . But there was no helping it . This was who he was . Please disdain him .

Ishii turned his gaze to the floor .

However, what Makoto said next was not what Ishii had expected .

'Ishii-san, please have more confidence . You are not as helpless as you think you are . '

He didn't want to hear that consolation .

'We can't do anything alone . '

'It might be impossible with us alone, but if we ask Yakumo-san to help, the possibility goes much higher . '

It was true that his unique ability to see ghosts and his keen mind might be able to spot a clue .

That was how they had solved a number of cases in the past . But –

'I haven't been able to contact Yakumo-shi . '

That was why Gotou and Ishii had gone to the site of the mansion alone yesterday .

'Is that so?'

'I have no idea where he is now . '

Though Ishii was disappointed, Makoto was indifferent .

'That's fine . Isn't there somebody who might know where Yakumo-san is?'

After Makoto said that, Ishii gasped . That was right –

'If we ask Haruka-chan...'

'That's right . '

Makoto nodded .

Right . He had been so upset he hadn't thought that far .

'Do you know her contact information?' asked Makoto .

'Yes . I think that the number is in Detective Gotou's mobile . '

Ishii took Gotou's mobile out of the plastic bag . He turned it on and searched through the address book .

– There it is .

He found the name Ozawa Haruka in the address book . He noted down the number and picked up the phone .

6

What a strange line-up –

Haruka felt that way when she looked at the faces that had gathered at Isshin's house . It was like a drama that was missing its main character . The ratings would be awful .

Haruka sat next to Isshin . Ishii and Makoto were opposite them .

All the people here were related somehow to Yakumo and Gotou, but it was the first time they'd met up without them .

While Haruka was talking with Isshin, her phone had rung .

Ishii had been the one who called her . She had hoped that he might have some sort of clue, but instead she heard that Gotou had also gone missing .

While Haruka had just been bewildered, Isshin arranged for the four of them to meet .

'Now, let's begin . '

Isshin broke the silence .

He was appropriate for the role . Unfortunately, the rest of them weren't leader types .

'Gotou-kun went missing yesterday then . '

Isshin looked towards Ishii . Ishii hung his head, as if to deny those words . His glasses were cracked for some reason .

'Is anything the matter?'

'No, er, um...'

Ishii wiped the sweat off his forehead and hunched his back as he pressed his hands against his stomach .

'Er, I'll explain . Much of what happened resulted from my actions . '

Makoto spoke up for Ishii .

'Please do . '

Urged on by Isshin, Makoto began her explanation .

'We were looking into the puzzle of a spiritual phenomenon in a video . It was put out by a video company and there had been the ghost of a woman in it . At the location, four people had been brutally murdered fifteen years ago, and one had gone missing – it was a repulsive case . '

'I know about that case as well . Wasn't the suspect who escaped spotted the other day?'

Isshin hit his knee .

'That's right . Gotou-san and Ishii-san were the one who spotted the escaped suspect . '

'I see . So that was why Yakumo was dragged into the case,' said Isshin grimly .

It felt like Isshin's tone was pointed, which was rare for him . It didn't show in his expression, but it felt like Isshin didn't think well of Gotou, who involved Yakumo in his cases .

Rather than disliking his personality, it felt like he was anxious for Yakumo .

'Yes . Yakumo-san saw the video once . But right after he finished watching, he left without saying anything . '

Yakumo sometimes acted that way .

At times like that, he had grasped almost all the threads of the case . However, Yakumo, who hated making his final judgements based on his reasoning, would leave to act on his own without saying anything .

'After that, Ishii-san and Gotou-san went to the house to try to solve the case alone . Then...'

'Gotou-kun went missing...'

'Yes . '

Makoto nodded .

There was something Haruka didn't understand from the explanation .

'Ishii-san was with Gotou-san, yes?'

When Ishii heard Haruka's question, a jolt ran through his body and he looked up . He looked frightened, like an abandoned puppy .

'N-no . Er, I was...'

Ishii's forehead was covered in sweat . He seemed flustered .

'Ishii-san, nobody blames you . Please calm down and speak . '

Isshin turned his usual gentle smile towards Ishii .

'Ishii-san, it's all right . '

Makoto placed her hand on Ishii's tightly gripped fist . She acted just like a mother . Ishii appeared to calm down slightly, and he nodded before starting to speak .

'It shames me to say that I was outside the house because I was frightened . Detective Gotou took a long time inside the house, so I was anxious and went inside, but then, it was already...'

When he finished speaking, Ishii hung his head, as if there was a weight on it .

'I see . '

Isshin crossed his arms and nodded .

'If I had gone with Detective Gotou then, this wouldn't have...'

Ishii's hands were in tight fists, and the words sounded like they had been strangled out of him .

Haruka did not blame Ishii, just as Isshin had said .

There was no helping it . If he knew this was going to happen, Ishii would have gone with Gotou no matter how afraid he was .

That was the way of regret –

If Haruka had known that Yakumo was going to go missing, she would have done something when he called .

'Yakumo and Gotou-kun both went missing . It may be dangerous to speculate, but I still think that the two events are related,' said Isshin quietly . Though his tone was different, what he said was exactly like how Yakumo would have said it .

Even though their outward personalities were different, the roots of his ideas, or rather, the way they thought was very similar . Haruka realised that anew .

'I think that too,' said Makoto .

Haruka nodded as well . Ishii only kept his head down in silence .

'And even though Gotou-kun looks like that, he isn't a reckless man . If he went to the scene of the crime, it probably means he had thought of something, even though he didn't say it aloud . '

Isshin's words made Ishii look up in surprise .

'What is it?'

'No, it's nothing . '

Ishii shook his head and looked down again .

Isshin seemed to sense something from that response, as his eyes narrowed, but in the end, he said nothing .

'Would you allow me to see that video?' said Haruka, leaning forward .

'I would appreciate it if you did . May I borrow the TV?'

'Please go ahead . '

After receiving Isshin's permission, Makoto took a video camera and cable out of her bag and quickly started connecting them .

Ishii couldn't calm down – he was looking around like a chicken . It was probably a terrifying video .

The truth was, Haruka didn't want to see something frightening either, but if she looked away, she wouldn't be able to find out if Yakumo was safe .

'May I start?'

After Makoto finished setting up, she slowly looked at each of their faces as she asked that question .

Everyone nodded silently .

Makoto pressed the play button and a video showed up on the television .

The building looked like a church . Somebody who looked like a reporter and somebody who looked like an exorcist in worship clothes were talking outside . Then, they entered the house .

The reporter seemed to feel something strange, because she looked around, frightened .

Suddenly, the lights went out and the screen went black .

It sounded like there were footsteps .

There were yells and screams .

The tense atmosphere came right through .

A moment of silence –

Then, the bloody face of a woman filled the screen .

It felt like the anguished face was going to come out of the television and chase her .

Though she didn't scream, Haruka covered her mouth and leant away from the screen .

Finally, the woman's face disappeared into the dark and the video stopped .

Nobody said anything .

It was certain that Yakumo had felt something from this video .

It was possible that Yakumo, who could see the spirits of the dead, might have felt something in this video that others couldn't see .

Haruka recalled the face of the woman .

The face that suddenly appeared on screen . It wasn't anything tangible, but the moment the face appeared, the atmosphere had changed . What was it? This strange feeling .

'I see . '

Isshin was the one who broke the silence .

'If Yakumo saw this video, I can understand his inexplicable actions . '

With his arms crossed, Isshin spoke, looking at the television with a sharp glance he didn't usually show .

'What do you mean?' said Haruka quickly, unable to restrain her agitation .

'The ghost in this video is my older sister . '

The words Isshin said quietly shook Haruka's heart .

The words were a shock . If she was Isshin's older sister, that would mean she was Yakumo's mother .

Then, just as Isshin said, Haruka could understand Yakumo's inexplicable actions .

When Yakumo saw this video, it piqued his interest in his mother . Then, he went to investigate alone .

Because he thought it was something personal, he didn't tell anybody .

'If she was captured on a video as a ghost, it means that my sister is already...'

Isshin's expression twisted as he spoke in a feeble voice like the dying flame of a candle .

Haruka knew what he was going to say even if he didn't finish his sentence . If she had been a ghost, it meant she was already dead .

Isshin had probably believed somewhere in his heart that his older sister was still alive . Then, he found out about her death in such an unbelievable manner .

It was so sad –

'If she is Yakumo-san's mother, why would she be in the video of this house?'

Makoto leant forward slightly as she proposed her question .

It certainly might be the gap they needed to solve the puzzle of the case .

Haruka was interested in how Isshin felt, so she took a glance at him .

Isshin was pinching his brow and appeared to be thinking about something . Yakumo had the same habit when he ran across a difficult problem . The two really were alike .

Finally, Isshin raised his head .

There seemed to be resignation in the back of his narrow eyes .

'Would you mind if I talk a bit about my sister?'

Nobody objected to Isshin's suggestion .

'My sister was abducted by a man twenty-two years ago and kept captive . Since my sister never said anything, I don't know what happened to her there . After two weeks of confinement, she barely escaped with her life and was taken in for protection . '

'That's...'

Makoto looked like she would cry at any moment .

'Yes . She became pregnant with Yakumo then . '

Haruka found it hard to breathe .

She'd got the general idea about Yakumo's birth through occasional conversations she'd heard before, but it was the first time she had heard it clearly like this .

That reality always tormented Yakumo .

He had been born unwanted . Then, his mother had tried to kill him . He was an unnecessary human being .

The darkness that spread within Yakumo's heart –

What had Yakumo been feeling as he chased after his mother?

'I have averted my eyes from what happened to my sister until now . I shouldn't touch the matter . That was what I thought . It wasn't something I could ask about . '

Nobody interrupted Isshin . They simply listened .

Now that Haruka thought about it, tragedy had befallen Yakumo's mother as well . Sudden misfortune had changed her fate .

'However, that might have just been running away . I didn't touch the matter because she seemed pitiful . With that excuse, I might have been avoiding facing her directly . If I had faced her directly then, she might not have tried to kill Yakumo . She might not have gone missing, and she might still be walking her own path . '

Isshin's mouth was in a thin line as he slowly closed his eyes .

Haruka understood his feelings of regret, but this was different . When Haruka thought that, she opened her mouth to speak .

'Isshin-san, you weren't incorrect . As a woman, she wouldn't have wanted to be asked about that – she would have wanted to forget it, so...'

After saying that much, Haruka noticed that everyone's gazes were focussed on her, and she stiffened .

Isshin started chuckling .

'Did I say something funny?' said Haruka, looking at Isshin anxiously .

'No, that's not it . I just thought that was to be expected . '

'Expected?'

'Yes . Yakumo's completely under your thumb . '

She was even more confused now . Haruka didn't remember ever having Yakumo under her thumb . It appeared that Isshin had a strange misunderstanding, but Haruka couldn't think of how to deny his words .

'Anyway, it's just as Haruka-chan says . There's no point regretting the past now . We need to think of what to do now . '

Isshin's expression stiffened .

'Yes . '

'I'm going to share my reasoning, but I think that the cases are connected .
The murders fifteen years ago . The suspect from that case showed up
again, my sister showed up in the video, Yakumo went missing, and Gotou-
kun disappeared . '

That was right . These cases were connected .

'What we can do is find the thread that connects these cases . '

The thread that connects them –

'That's right . It seems that's all we can do now . '

Makoto gave her agreement .

'In short, we gather information again and see if any data seems to
correspond?'

Ishii looked up at Isshin . He seemed extremely unconfident .

'Ishii-san, Hijikata-san, I apologise for the trouble, but would you look
through the data again?'

'I understand,' replied Makoto .

'I have a few ideas myself, so I will go look into them . '

As Isshin brought the conversation to a close, Makoto stood up .

'Ishii-san, let's go . '

Despite Makoto's call, Ishii did not stand up .

Ishii had always been timid, but Haruka still felt this was unlike him .
Perhaps it was from the shock of Gotou going missing –

'Ishii-san . '

When Makoto hurried him, Ishii shook his head .

'Will we really find Detective Gotou by doing something like this?' said Ishii quietly . They were apathetic words .

– Why are you saying that?

The discomfort in Haruka's heart spread .

'I think it would be better if we left everything to the police instead of going ourselves . If we report Yakumo-shi's disappearance as well...'

'How many missing persons does the police look for every year and how many do they find? To say more, how many cases do investigators actually look into?'

Isshin cast out harsh questions to drown out Ishii's negativity .

Haruka didn't know the actual numbers either, but she understood what Isshin was trying to say .

For missing persons without clear cases, there were no searches . There weren't enough police to search for missing persons .

Setting Gotou aside, if they reported Yakumo as missing, it would probably be filed away with the police saying that Yakumo had disappeared of his will .

'... But with Detective Gotou and Yakumo-shi, it wasn't an abduction – there was no ransom . Which means they might already...' mumbled Ishii, looking down .

Emotions boiled up in Haruka's chest .

From the way Ishii was speaking, it was like he was telling them to give up because Gotou and Yakumo were already dead .

'Already what?'

Haruka glared at Ishii . She knew herself that her voice was angry .

'... It is probably... already too late for the two of them . '

'What do you mean by too late?'

'I'm saying that they're probably already dead...'

'How can you say that so easily? Don't just kill them off!' yelled Haruka, drowning out Ishii's words . At the same time, whatever had frozen over inside her broke and tears came falling out .

'No, er...'

Ishii seemed uneasy as he looked around frantically .

Haruka took that chance to land the final blow . Her emotions had reached tipping point and she couldn't control herself .

'Ishii-san, are you saying that we should give up because they're already dead?'

'That isn't what I...'

'Then what do you mean?'

'That's...'

Haruka's anger only grew as she saw Ishii squirming .

'Yakumo-kun saved me – he didn't give up until the end! That's why I won't give up either! Hasn't Gotou-san risked his life countless times to protect you, Ishii-san!? Then why are you giving up? Hey! Why!?'

Haruka's throat was trembling .

It hurt . She had thought Ishii was her ally, but she felt like he'd betrayed her .

They might be dead . She knew that it was a possibility . But if she accepted that, then Yakumo and Gotou really wouldn't come back .

I won't stand for that! As long as there's even the slightest possibility, I definitely won't give up!

'Haruka-chan, it's all right already . Ishii-san doesn't really think that way either . He's just saying that we need to be prepared . '

Isshin touched Haruka's shoulder .

That moment, Haruka lost her footing and collapsed into Isshin, clinging to him as she sobbed .

I don't want Yakumo to disappear – I don't want him to .

Why did he disappear without saying anything?

I hate him!

Once more . I want to see you once more –

Having lost herself to the feelings that had welled up, Haruka continued to cry into Isshin's chest .

7

Led out by Makoto, Ishii escaped to the car .

Even after sitting in the driver's seat, he felt weightless, as if he were in a dream . It didn't feel real .

The words that the woman he loved had levelled at him had pierced more deeply in his heart than anything else . His chest stung, as if somebody had poured salt on his wound .

– What on earth am I doing? How could I say that?

Self-hatred boiled up within Ishii and went straight to his core .

It was just as Haruka said . Gotou had saved him so many times before, but now that Gotou was in a pinch, he didn't try to do anything and gave up by saying it was impossible for him .

– It's unforgiveable! I can't forgive myself!

Ishii wanted to destroy everything and kept on hitting his head against the steering wheel .

'Aaaargh!'

His shriek felt like it would tear through his throat .

His breathing was ragged .

His tears and snot dripped onto the steering wheel .

– What a useless man I am .

Even though Haruka, a university student, was trying so hard, he had shut himself out because he was a coward .

He had been waiting for somebody to save him .

Doing nothing was the same as making the possibility drop to zero himself .

If there was still one per cent chance, he couldn't give up .

'Ishii-san, are you all right?'

Makoto handed Ishii a handkerchief from the passenger seat .

Normally, she didn't show her emotions on her face . However, Ishii realised once more that she was considerate and caring at the bottom of her heart .

He had thought her bothersome up until earlier, but now he appreciated her kindness .

Ishii didn't take the proffered handkerchief . Instead, he wiped his tears on the sleeve of his suit .

Especially because he appreciated her kindness, he couldn't allow her to spoil him . He had to walk forward on his own now .

'I'm fine . '

Ishii snivelled and looked straight at Makoto .

No matter how wretched his circumstances, he couldn't look away . Ishii felt that strongly .

'You might be angry if I put it this way, but Ishii-san, you just don't have any self-confidence,' said Makoto, as if to herself .

Those words woke up a sleeping memory in Ishii's mind .

I had been in middle school . At the time, I'd dreamt of being a manga artist .

When my father found out, he came into my room with the face of a demon and threw all of the manga pages that I had worked so hard on into the bin .

I couldn't stop him – I just watched him silently .

– Don't have such a stupid dream . Know your own abilities .

My father kept saying that .

My strict father was a policeman, so he might not have been able to understand my dream .

No, he might have said that because he didn't want to see me every day after I failed in my dream and fell down .

My father scorned my dream and crushed it .

That hadn't been the first time my father had done something like that . He had done that ever since my childhood .

At some point, I became somebody who doubted himself, feared being yelled at and didn't put his own thoughts into words .

This wasn't just at home – it was the same at school too . Other kids bullied me and called me 'glasses monkey' .

Just as my father said, I'm an ordinary person – I can't do anything special . So I don't say anything . I don't do anything .

In the end, I decided to become a detective because of something that happened in high school .

It felt like my father was satisfied with that . But –

'My father was... No, I was wrong . '

However, Ishii had just shifted the responsibility to his father without his knowing .

How could he know it was impossible without doing anything? He had to believe in his own ability now and do something .

'This isn't the time to stop!' yelled Ishii, looking up .

In the back of his mind, an electric switch he hadn't used before switched on .

– I can do it . No, I have to do it .

It was like his blood was flowing in the other direction . He felt exhilarated . He had never felt this way before .

'I will definitely find the two of them,' declared Ishii to Makoto .

'That's the spirit . '

Makoto smiled .

'Please wait, Detective Gotou . I will definitely find you . '

The newly budded determination in Ishii firmly rooted his shaking heart .

8

How much did I cry –

Haruka had kept on crying heedless of her surroundings, like a child .

Yakumo was going to disappear . Just from thinking that, she was hit with an indescribable wave of sadness . She had felt the same sadness when she lost her twin sister .

Yakumo wasn't just a friend .

Yakumo was the one who had filled in the hole left in Haruka's heart when her sister died .

– Yakumo is my better half . If I lose him, I'll break .

'Have you calmed down?'

She looked up at the voice and saw Isshin's gentle face .

'Sorry . '

Haruka quickly wiped her tears and lowered her head . She sat up properly .

'Don't worry about it . But you should apologise to Ishii-san afterwards . He didn't mean any harm,' Isshin said gently, placing a hand on Haruka's shoulder .

Just as Isshin said, she had said something awful to Ishii, thought that had been because of her pent-up emotions .

Ishii had to be suffering too from Gotou's disappearance, but she had only been thinking of herself .

'Yes, I will . '

Isshin nodded in satisfaction at Haruka's response .

It was mysterious how Haruka felt like all was forgiven once Isshin looked at her .

It was said that Maitreya was the Buddha of salvation . Haruka felt like it wasn't just Isshin's appearance that was similar .

'Still, Yakumo has to start thinking differently,' said Isshin seriously as he scratched his chin .

'What do you mean?'

Haruka didn't understand the meaning behind Isshin's words .

'Because that happened to Yakumo, he thinks that nobody will love him . He's lost his meaning for living and sometimes acts in a way that treats his life lightly . '

Isshin's opinion struck Haruka too .

Sometimes, Yakumo really was reckless . He put himself in danger – it even felt like he sometimes wanted to do so when he leapt in .

Because he could see the spirits of the dead, he was more sensitive to the lives of others, but he didn't treat his own life the same way .

He wants to die – it made her feel that way .

'I've thought that too . '

Haruka put her thoughts into words . Isshin nodded a number of times .

'But there are two people here who are worried about Yakumo and feel like their hearts have been wrenched open . I wish Yakumo would realise that . '

Isshin smiled in a truly happy manner .

Haruka felt the same way as Isshin . No matter what anyone said, to Isshin and Haruka, Yakumo was an important and irreplaceable existence in their hearts .

'Do you think Yakumo-kun is all right?'

The moment Haruka relaxed, the anxiety that had been in her chest came out .

By not saying it aloud, she had been keeping the anxiety inside .

'I don't know . Yakumo might have just gone off to chase his mother himself, so we can't contact him, or he might have been caught up in some incident . '

'Yes . '

'Whichever it is, all we can do now is believe in him . '

Isshin laughed like a child .

It was true that all they could do now was believe in him . But –

'Isn't there anything I can do?'

Haruka couldn't just wait quietly .

'Of course there is . '

Isshin nodded, as if he had been waiting for those words .

'Please tell me . What should I do?'

'Well, don't be in such a rush . Before that, I want you to know a bit more about my sister, Haruka-chan . '

– Yakumo's mother .

Haruka barely knew anything about what sort of person that woman was . The only thing she knew was that she had tried to kill Yakumo .

However, that was only one action of hers . She couldn't pinpoint everything about her just from that .

And why did Yakumo's mother want to kill Yakumo as a child anyway?

She wanted to know the reason too .

'Yes . '

Perhaps Isshin sensed how Haruka was feeling, because he started his story .

'This might sound like the partiality of a relative, but my sister was a very kind person . Though part of it was because we were far apart in age, she always took care of me . '

The bloody and anguished face came up in Haruka's head when she heard Isshin's words .

– I can't do that . I can't have any preconceptions .

Haruka shook the image out of her head and focussed on listening to Isshin .

'Though my sister was kind, it is also true that she wasn't very strong psychologically . When anything tough happens, she ended up worrying about it herself . '

Isshin crossed his arms and seemed to be looking far away . He appeared to be gathering his memories .

Haruka also tried to imagine Isshin's sister, rather than the woman who had tried to kill Yakumo .

'When I was in high school, that incident occurred . I returned home from to school to find my parents extremely worried since they couldn't contact my sister . '

'Did you contact the police?'

'We contacted them immediately and filed a report for missing persons, but they just asked about the situation and it ended there . '

Isshin paused . It looked like he was forcibly restraining his emotions .

It made Haruka remember what Isshin had said to Ishii-san earlier .

If there wasn't a clear case for the missing person, the police wouldn't move . Isshin had probably experienced that himself then .

'In the end, all we could do was ask around town . I still wonder now if there was anything else we could have done . '

Isshin sighed . It sounded like it was filled with regret .

But it would probably be difficult to say if there was anything else Isshin could have done then .

'My sister was found two weeks after . Somebody found her wandering on a mountain road in Nagano prefecture . '

'Nagano prefecture...'

Haruka reacted sensitively to the location Isshin mentioned .

'Do you know it?'

– More than just knowing .

'That's where I'm from!'

'I see, so Haruka-chan is from Nagano...'

Isshin's eyes narrowed, like he was thinking deeply about something .

'Yes . And the man who came this morning said that Yakumo-kun was in Nagano . Perhaps...'

There might be some relation .

'I see . Something might be there . '

Isshin appeared to have the same opinion .

'Er, do you know exactly where in Nagano prefecture it was?'

'It was Togakushi . '

'Togakushi – is that true!?' exclaimed Haruka in her agitation .

'That should be right,' said Isshin clearly .

– This is an amazing coincidence .

'My family is from Togakushi in Nagano prefecture . '

'What did you say!?'

Even Isshin was surprised as his eyes went as wide as saucers .

That said, Haruka's heart was beating quickly too in her excitement . She was being called . That was how she felt .

For a while, Isshin looked up at the ceiling as if thinking, but then he narrowed his eyes like he had thought of something .

'This is an abrupt question, but your family name is Ozawa, right, Haruka-chan?'

'Yes . '

'I see... Could your mother's name be Keiko-san?'

'Eh?'

– Why does Isshin know my mother's name?

She had never said her mother's name to Isshin or Yakumo before . Haruka almost fainted in her confusion .

'So it is Keiko-san,' repeated Isshin .

Haruka's throat was dry – she couldn't speak . She just nodded silently .

– What does this mean?

'So that really is the case? What a coincidence . No, perhaps it's fate . In any case, I have to feel that this is some sort of destiny,' said Isshin to himself as he stood up .

Haruka felt like she had been left behind and looked up at Isshin's face to ask for an answer .

'Wait here . '

Without responding to Haruka's question, Isshin left the room .

After being left behind, all Haruka could do was wait with her overwhelming questions .

9

After Ishii returned to the precinct, he headed for the police quarters' common room .

When he went inside, the investigation members all glared at him .

– What did you come here for?

The gazes of the veterans seemed like jeers .

However, it wasn't the time or place to falter from something like that . No matter how he was ridiculed or reprimanded, he had to move forward to find Gotou .

Ishii prepared himself and walked straight to the desk in the very back of the room that belonged to Chief Miyagawa .

'Did you find Gotou?'

Once Ishii reached the front of the desk, Miyagawa said that, full of hostility .

Ishii felt like he had a sword to his neck . Normally, Ishii would have run away in fear, but today was different .

'I haven't yet . '

'Then why are you here?'

Miyagawa's thick voice was lower than usual, and it fanned up Ishii's fear .

A cold sweat ran down his back, but Ishii still faced Miyagawa directly .

'I came here today because I have a request!' said Ishii loudly, his voice coming from the bottom of his stomach so that he wouldn't be defeated by emotion .

'What?'

'I would appreciate it if you would allow me to see the dossier and related documents for the Takeda Shunsuke case . '

'Can't do it . What do you want something like that for?'

Miyagawa turned his chair around and looked to the side . It was a strong display of refusal .

'In order to find Detective Gotou, they are absolutely necessary . Please . '

Ishii bent his waist and bowed so that his head almost reached the desk .

'The whole mess is because you stuck your noses into other people's business!'

Though he wasn't sure where it came from, somebody jeered at Ishii, and sniggers echoed through the room in agreement .

Still, Ishii kept his head down in a bow .

He didn't care what anybody said . Something like this wouldn't make him give in . He wasn't the Ishii Yuutarou he'd always been . If it was to save Gotou, he'd do anything . He didn't care what anybody thought .

'Please!'

Ishii spoke up once again .

'Not a chance! I told you to look for Gotou, but I don't remember telling you to stick your neck where it doesn't belong!'

Miyagawa turned to face him again and hit his desk as he yelled .

Ishii didn't falter – he looked up and stared straight at Miyagawa's face . It was so tense it felt like sparks were flying .

'My goal is to find Detective Gotou . I do not plan on obstructing the investigation . '

'Then...'

'However, in order to search for Detective Gotou's location, it is absolutely necessary to investigate that case once more . '

'You'll get in the way if you're loitering about! No matter how many times you lower your head, things that are no good are no good!'

Miyagawa slammed his fist into his desk again .

So it really was no good? It really wouldn't be easy to convince this person . Disappointment spread throughout Ishii .

But he couldn't give up . If he couldn't get permission through official means, he would have to steal it . He would definitely be dismissed if it were found out, but that meant nothing when compared to Gotou's life .

'I understand . Please excuse me . '

Ishii bowed once more to Miyagawa and turned on his heels .

The investigation members' pitying looks washed over him . Mysteriously though, he didn't care . Ishii felt anew that this was what following a path he believed in felt .

'Ishii!'

Just as Ishii was about to start walking, Miyagawa called out to him .

'What is it?'

Ishii turned around . Miyagawa had his arms crossed and seemed to be thinking as he stared at Ishii .

'If you've got enough free time to stick your neck into an unrelated case, I'll give you some work to do . '

'Work... is it?'

Right now, he had to search for Gotou – he didn't have the time to do any other work . Miyagawa should have understood that .

Ishii didn't understand Miyagawa's true intention .

'The fourth floor toilet is dirty . Go clean it!'

Miyagawa's words made the room erupt in laughter .

This made even Ishii angry .

Wasn't Miyagawa worried about Gotou –

Miyagawa had the one who reprimanded Ishii for holing up in his room, so Ishii found Miyagawa's words hard to understand .

Ishii gripped his hands into such tight fists it felt like his fingernails would tear through his skin in his vexation .

'Especially the stall in the very back . The back of the tank is dirty . I'll go check it in an hour, so you better do it properly . '

After Miyagawa added that, he raised his left eyebrow and there was a faint smile on his lips .

When Ishii saw that expression, he understood everything .

– I see . So that's how it is .

He felt ashamed for doubting Miyagawa for even a moment .

'Understood . I will clean the toilets thoroughly . '

Ishii made a polite bow to Miyagawa and walked out of the room with long strides .

10

Why does Isshin know the name of my mother –

That question was circling Haruka's head .

Isshin had said it was fate . What had he meant by that?

'Sorry for the wait . '

When Isshin returned to the living room, he was holding a long white envelope .

It looked fairly old – the colour was dull .

Is the answer to my question in that envelope – Haruka was on the balls of her feet, but Isshin was calm . He sat cross-legged on the floor .

'Excuse me...'

Haruka leant forward, unable to contain herself .

'Don't be in such a hurry . Let's talk in the proper order . '

Just as Isshin said, there was no point hurrying .

Even though she understood that, her body still reacted the way it did .
Haruka put a hand to her chest and sighed .

Isshin slid the envelope across the table . <Saitou Azusa-sama> was written on it .

Azusa . That's Yakumo's mother's name –

'Just as I said earlier, my sister was kept in a mountain cottage in Togakushi, Nagano when she went missing . '

In Haruka's hometown, Togakushi, on the mountain used for skiing and mountain climbing, there were various mountain cottages .

Virtually all of them were only used during the appropriate seasons, so it was a lonely place that nobody approached during the off-seasons . It could be called the ideal location for keeping somebody captive without being found .

'My sister used a ski that the man had overlooked to thrust her way out of the cottage . She went through the forest, down the mountain and out onto the road to look for help .

Unconsciously, the image of a woman trying to escape came up in Haruka's mind .

Without knowing where she was, she was afraid of the man coming after her – her psychological state had probably been at its limit .

Just imagining it made it hard to breath .

'At the time, one of the people who lived there happened to pass by and saved my sister . '

'Could you mean...'

Could it be – that thought spread in Haruka's head .

'That person had been very concerned about my sister, perhaps because they were close in age . Even after the incident, she regularly sent letters to contact her . '

Haruka's eyes went wide and she stared at Isshin's face .

'When my sister went missing, all of her belongings were disposed of, but this was in the mailbox . It had probably arrived after she disappeared . The person who wrote the letter was the one who had saved my sister after that incident . '

This letter . Isshin flipped over the envelope . The sender's name was written there .

– Ozawa Keiko .

'No way...'

Haruka spoke up unconsciously .

The letters in the top left corner were unmistakeably her mother's .

She'd thought it was the case partway through the story, but seeing it with her eyes like this made her shiver .

Haruka didn't know what emotion that came from .

'Mum...'

'This is really a mysterious connection . I just feel like Yakumo and you were meant to meet, Haruka-chan . '

That might have been the case . A number of feelings were welling up within Haruka, and the corners of her eyes felt warm .

Yakumo and Haruka's meeting hadn't been anything dramatic .

Because of a spiritual phenomenon, Haruka had gone to Yakumo's clubroom for the first time .

But now that she thought about it, it felt like that had had to happen .

Without their knowing, their two lives had been connected . Then, they had been drawn to their meeting .

'I was going to ask you to look for the person who wrote this letter, Haruka-chan, but it seems that isn't necessary . '

Isshin scratched his head awkwardly .

'It seems so . '

Haruka stared at the letter .

If Haruka could talk to Keiko, she might be able to find out what sort of person Azusa was and why she tried to kill Yakumo .

That wasn't all . The reason for Azusa's disappearance and her location . Then she'd be able to grasp where Yakumo might have gone .

Here, Haruka realised something .

'Has the envelope not been opened?'

The envelope was firmly shut, and it had no signs of ever having been open .

'I couldn't open it... That might be a more correct way of putting it . '

Isshin looked away, seeming uncomfortable .

'You couldn't open it?'

'If I felt like it, I could have opened that letter, looked for that woman and talked to her, but I didn't . '

'Why is that?'

If he looked at what was written in the letter, it could have been a clue towards looking for where Azusa had gone . Then why? Haruka stated her question as it came up in her head .

'Because my sister tried to kill Yakumo . '

The words Isshin said quietly left a strong impact and shook Haruka's heart .

If she had just gone missing regularly, Isshin probably would have opened the letter and searched for Azusa .

However, Azusa had tried to kill Yakumo, her own child, and she had disappeared after she failed in doing that .

'If Azusa had been found, she would have been taken in for attempted murder . And when I thought about how Yakumo would respond if my sister returned...'

– He was afraid .

Isshin sniffed and wiped at his eye with his finger .

Yakumo hated Azusa . If the object of his hate came back – it was certainly scary to think about what might happen next .

Isshin didn't say it aloud, but Haruka could imagine that there had been painful discord within Isshin . After thinking about it, he had decided to wait .

But –

'There might have been a special reason behind why she tried to kill Yakumo . '

'What if that reason was because of his red eye?'

The blood left Haruka's face once she heard what Isshin said .

It was just as he said . If that fact thrust itself in front of Yakumo's eyes again, Haruka couldn't imagine what would happen .

Yakumo probably wouldn't react that way now, but he had been an elementary school student at the time .

If a young boy was rejected by his parent like that – Haruka grew quiet just from thinking about it .

'I decided to take Yakumo in and love him instead of searching for my sister or finding out why she tried to kill Yakumo . '

That was a very Isshin way of thinking .

In his dilemma, Isshin had chosen the young Yakumo .

'That's why I didn't open the letter . I didn't want to know anything . Well, even if I put it so nicely, I might've just been afraid of knowing the truth . Knowing the truth is filled with danger . '

Haruka thought that Isshin's decision wasn't wrong .

In the world, just knowing the truth wasn't everything . Because Yakumo had had Isshin's love, even though he held a darkness within him, he had a kind and strong heart . That was how Haruka wanted to think .

'Haruka-chan, I'll leave it to you to decide what to do with that letter . Now is different from then . '

Haruka put the letter to her chest and closed her eyes .

She felt like a flame of hope had been lit .

– Yakumo . Wait . I'll definitely find you .

11

After Makoto returned to the newspaper agency, she went straight to the storeroom in the basement .

The whole basement was a storeroom, lined with ceiling-high cabinets .

The cabinet shelves were lined with cardboard boxes labelled with the date which had past articles stuffed in them in a disorderly fashion .

However, Makoto's goal wasn't the cabinet . If she opened all the boxes to search through them, she wouldn't find what she wanted even if she spent years looking .

There was a booth right by the entrance . There were two tables, each with a computer terminal .

Makoto stuck her staff card into the terminal, input her ID and password and accessed the server . With this terminal, she would be able to look at the past articles saved in PDF form .

Input boxes for search terms showed up on the monitor . First, the date . She put the beginning as the date the incident occurred fifteen years ago and put no time limit . It had been such a big incident . There had been follow-up articles every time anything occurred .

She didn't choose morning or evening edition either . For the search terms, she typed in 'murder case' and 'Nanase', the family name of the victims, and then she started the search .

There would probably be a great number of articles . It would take a lot of time to check all of them, and even if she did, there was no guarantee that she would find any new information .

But she had to do it . Makoto had made up her mind .

– I won't give up .

What Haruka had said had repeated in Makoto's head again and again . That one sentence had brought Ishii back to his senses . It had been the same for Makoto .

She had planned on encouraging Yakumo, but unconsciously, in the bottom of her heart, Makoto had also given up on Gotou .

Taking the situation into account, the possibility that he was alive was extremely low . But if she went with that as a premise, it would be impossible to find Gotou .

No matter what the situation, she had to act while believing he was alive .

Makoto didn't know much about Haruka .

She had just thought of her as a slightly cute and pampered female university student who could be found anywhere .

Makoto hadn't been able to understand why Ishii was so infatuated with her .

Because of that shallow jealousy, Makoto had found Haruka hard to deal with and had had the preconceived notion that she was a weak woman who couldn't do anything on her own .

However, Makoto realised that she had been wrong from what happened this time .

Haruka hadn't been the superficial woman who tried to please everyone that Makoto had thought she was .

Makoto didn't know what sort of life Haruka had had up until now, but she was pure and honest in a way that didn't seem appropriate for her age . On top of that, she had a strong heart .

The search results displayed on the monitor, interrupting Makoto's thoughts .

'What an amazing number...'

Makoto inadvertently spoke aloud .

There were more than three hundred results . She encouraged her withering spirit and followed the displayed titles with her eyes as she scrolled down .

– Brutal murder on the hill!

– Grave police error!

– Culprit still at large!

Impactful titles leapt out of the screen .

Makoto stopped scrolling halfway down .

She'd thought she'd misread and checked again, but she hadn't .

There was a title there that was clearly different from the others .

– Apology for Nanase family murder case article misprint .

When she opened the article, it took a rather large frame . If it had just been a one-word misprint, it wouldn't have needed to be so large . They'd written so many articles on just one night . One or two misprints were inevitable .

If this much had been written, it felt like something might be there .

Makoto felt that way, so she immediately printed the article .

12

Exactly one hour after, Ishii went to the fourth-floor toilet that Miyagawa had mentioned .

After confirming that no one was there, he went to the cubicle in the back and shut the door .

When he reached behind the tank, he found something stuck there with packing tape .

He looked from above, but he couldn't see well, so in the end, he put his face to the tile floor and peered up from below .

'There it is . '

After a hard struggle, Ishii succeeded in taking the A4 size thick envelope that had been stuck there .

He sat on the toilet and checked what was inside .

It wasn't just a dossier .

There was even a handwritten copy – probably by Miyagawa – of the investigation materials .

– He did so much .

Something came up in Ishii's chest .

Knock .

Somebody knocked on the cubicle door .

Ishii leapt up . Careful not to make any noise, he peered through the gap between the door .

He saw a bald man taking care of his business at the urinal .

'Don't be so nervous . It's me . '

That thick voice filled with pressure . It was Miyagawa .

'Chief Miyagawa! Thank you very much!'

'Don't be so loud . '

After Miyagawa said that, Ishii hurriedly covered his mouth with both hands and then dropped the envelope with the documents in it into the toilet .

'Aah!'

Ishii hurriedly stuck his hand in to pick it up . Though there wasn't much damage to the documents, his suit was soaked .

'You're so noisy . I'm going to say something now, so shut up and listen . '

Miyagawa said that first before starting to speak .

'It'll be a problem if you sniff around and talk to the investigation members that were on the case fifteen years ago, so you'd better not do it . '

Even Ishii knew that without being told . With the response of the common room earlier, Ishii knew it would be a most reckless course of action .

'But I don't care if you talk to people outside of the police . '

'What do you mean?'

'I told you not to talk . '

Miyagawa rejected Ishii's question .

'I-I apologise . '

'The coroner who was in charge of the autopsies for that case was that perverted old man . '

If Hata had been in charge of the autopsies, Ishii might be able to hear about the case from him .

'And I've written down Gotou's wife's contact info too . '

Ishii had spotted a mobile phone number on the back of the envelope .

'Just whenever you have time . Call her yourself . '

Miyagawa's words put a new weight on Ishii's shoulders .

Will I really be able to do that –

Ishii didn't know what he should say to Gotou's wife .

– No, that's wrong . There's no need to make excuses . I will definitely find Gotou . So please don't worry . I can just say that .

'Ishii . You have to find Gotou . '

Miyagawa's last words felt laboured, unlike his earlier enraged ones .

After the sound of flowing water, his footsteps grew quieter and quieter .

– Thank you very much .

Ishii repeated those words again and again in his heart .

13

After Haruka returned to her own room, she looked once more at the envelope .

The postmark is from fifteen years ago –

She had been six then, so her twin sister had still been alive .

She was curious about what was written in the letter, but the letter had been written for a specific person and was probably confidential .

When she thought about that, she hesitated about opening the seal .

After contemplating, Haruka decided to call her mother, Keiko, first .

In order to explain the situation, Haruka would have to talk about the letter . She could check with her mother then .

She picked up her mobile and called home .

After a number of rings, Keiko answered brightly: <Ozawa residence . >

'Mum, it's me . '

<Oh, it's rare for you to call . >

'Do you have time to talk now?'

<Something happened, didn't it . >

The tone of Keiko's voice changed .

It seemed that she'd noticed something from just one sentence . That was a mother for you . Haruka marvelled over that and began her story .

'There was something I wanted to ask . '

<What is it?>

'It's a bit difficult to say...'

<You don't know how the boy feels?>

Keiko said that, sounding amused . She appeared to have mistaken Haruka's call as a request for romantic advice .

'Mum, do you know someone called Saitou Azusa-san?'

Haruka went straight to the point .

She heard Keiko gulp on the other end of the phone .

Haruka could tell her mother was confused . She probably hadn't thought that she would hear that name from her daughter's mouth .

<Yes, I do, though I don't know if she's the same person you're talking about . >

Saitou Azusa . It certainly wasn't a particularly uncommon name .

'Azusa, written with the radical for wood and the word for bitter[2] . '

<Eh?>

'The person who you wrote letters to about fifteen years ago . '

<Why do you know that, Haruka?>

Keiko's voice was hard .

'One of my friends from university is that person's son . '

<You're kidding! You go to the same university as Yakumo-kun?>

'Yes . '

<I see, so he's the same age as Haruka . >

Keiko's tone made it sound like what Haruka had said had hit home .

– My mother knew about Yakumo before I did .

Haruka realised that with complicated feelings .

<That's amazing . What a coincidence . Is Yakumo-kun doing well? How about Azusa-san? This is so nostalgic . >

Keiko sounded excited .

For her to respond in such a way even after fifteen years, it showed how deep their relationship was .

'Yakumo-kun's fine...'

Haruka felt that her words were off .

– Is Yakumo really fine?

Unconsciously, she had gripped the red stone on the necklace she was wearing .

<Yakumo is, you say... Did something happen to Azusa-san?>

Haruka hadn't said it that way on purpose, but Keiko had heard the difference in nuance .

Haruka wanted to hide it if she could, but it would be difficult with her personality . And if she hid that, she wouldn't be able to continue with the conversation .

'Azusa-san is missing . '

<Missing... Why?>

Keiko's voice went up an octave .

'I don't know... After she tried to kill Yakumo-kun, she disappeared . '

When Haruka said that again, she felt the cruelty of that act on her skin .

A parent killing their child –

The past few years, she often heard about such cases on the news, but she felt like it was an area that people couldn't step into .

Haruka felt a chill down her spine .

<Haruka, there are things you can say and things you can't . >

Keiko spoke slowly . She was probably doing it on purpose . Her words sounded pointed .

Azusa had been Keiko's friend . It wouldn't be easy for her to accept the reality that her friend had tried to kill her child .

Haruka understood that . But –

'It's true . I heard it from Yakumo-kun and his uncle, Isshin-san . I don't know why things ended up like that, but she's been missing ever since...'

<Haruka . >

'That's why I want to know why things ended up the way they did . '

<So it's true . >

'This isn't something I could lie or joke about . '

Haruka heard Keiko sigh on the other end .

For a while after that, a silence continued .

No matter how Keiko and Azusa met, they had been friends .

Keiko was probably in a dilemma, because as a mother, she couldn't forgive the act of laying a hand on a child .

<I was so sure that Azusa-san was living happily...>

'Happily?'

That word didn't match with the image Haruka had of Azusa .

<Azusa-san had plans to get married . >

'Married...'

Haruka raised her eyebrows .

It was the first time she'd heard that . Yakumo and Isshin hadn't said anything about that . Did they not know about it –

<That's right . Azusa-san sent me a photo of Yakumo-kun, herself and her fiancé . >

Haruka was too confused to arrange her thoughts .

If what Keiko said was true, then the image Haruka had had up until now would lose its foundation .

She'd thought that Azusa had been worrying and suffering by herself . From what she'd heard today, Isshin appeared to think the same way .

However, if somebody had been there to support Azusa, the story would be different .

That would mean that Azusa had stood up again after the incident and that she had been walking towards a new life . Then why did she try to kill Yakumo –

'Mum, do you still have that photo?'

<Yes . I think I'd be able to find it if I look . >

– I want to see it .

Young Yakumo . And his mother, Azusa . Then, the man that would have become Yakumo's father .

It would definitely be a thread towards grasping Yakumo's location . When Haruka thought that, she couldn't contain herself .

'Mum, I'll go look at the photo . '

<When?>

'Tomorrow . '

<Eh?>

Keiko's voice was hysterical .

14

Even after Miyagawa left, Ishii stayed in the toilet stall .

He gripped his mobile and stared at the name Gotou Atsuko and the phone number written on the envelope .

Even though he had vowed that he would definitely save Gotou earlier, his fingers wouldn't move for some reason .

It was easy to keep it in his heart, but the moment he said it aloud, he would be responsible for it and wouldn't be able to take it back . He might have been afraid of that .

– What are you doing, Ishii Yuutarou? You already vowed to do it!

Ishii reprimanded himself and pushed in the number written on the back of the envelope .

He put the phone to his ear with a rising heartbeat .

<Hello, Gotou speaking . >

After one ring, somebody picked up . It was a woman who spoke with a calm tone .

During the last case, he had met her just once in front of the hospital . She was definitely Gotou Atsuko .

'E-er . I am Ishii Yuutarou from the detective department . '

Ishii wiped his suddenly sweaty forehead with his wet suit sleeve and spoke firmly .

<My husband is always in your care . >

Ishii could tell that Atsuko had bowed her head on the other side of the phone .

Even though her husband was missing, she didn't seem distracted .

'No, not at all . I'm the one in his care . '

No . He didn't have the time to exchange polite greetings .

Ishii swallowed, his throat as parched as a desert, and brought up the topic at hand .

'I am truly sorry for what has happened this time . '

<It isn't your fault, Ishii-san . >

'No, it is my fault . If I had been more responsible, this wouldn't have happened . '

The shame that had sunken welled up again .

<No, my useless husband just did something reckless again . There is no need for you to feel responsible, Ishii-san . >

Atsuko spoke firmly .

As a detective's wife, she might have been prepared for something like this to happen .

That was somebody strong enough to have Gotou under her thumb .

'I...'

Ishii started speaking, but his voice wouldn't come out afterwards .

Even though he'd decided on what he was going to say already, he was silent, as if his mouth was covered .

<Ishii-san, I know it is wrong of me to ask you to do this . >

'If it's something I can do, anything...'

<Please don't forsake my useless husband . >

Ishii could feel on his skin that a great anxiety was hiding in the shadows of that dignified voice .

His body was shaking . He felt uplifted . Ishii was prepared .

'I will definitely save Detective Gotou!'

He was no longer afraid . Ishii made his declaration in a ringing voice .

15

After Makoto returned to her seat, she immediately picked up the telephone for the internal line .

She had looked through all the articles, but she hadn't found anything special .

The thing that felt the most off was that article about the misprint . She didn't know what it showed, but she wanted as much information as she could get . That was how she felt .

<'Lo . >

As if he had just woken up, Takizawa's faint voice came through the receiver . He might have actually been asleep .

'I apologise for calling when you're busy . It's Hijikata . '

<Oh, it's you? Did you find what you were looking for?>

There was the sound of documents being ruffled through on the other side of phone .

'No, not yet . Actually, there was something I wanted to ask you about . '

<I'll answer if I can . >

'Takizawa-san, you wrote a follow-up article for the brutal murder of a family fifteen years ago, right?'

Takizawa was the one who had written the article about the misprint .

Makoto didn't mean to attack him for it . The contents of the article just bothered her, like a small bone stuck in her throat .

In the article, there had been the testimony of A-ko-san, the person who had notified the police, as it was originally .

<I did . >

'I wanted to ask you in detail about the time period when A-ko-san reported the incident . '

When Takizawa heard Makoto's words, he clicked his tongue .

<That was... After that article came out, everything got tangled up . There was a complaint from the police too . In the end, I had to apologise for it as a misprint . >

From Takizawa's tone, it didn't sound like just a misprint .

'Was it really a misprint?' asked Makoto daringly .

<Don't be stupid . I'm not defending myself, but all I did was accurately reproduce the contents of the interview . That was definitely not a misprint . I'm not such an irresponsible guy . You can tell from looking at the content, right? It can't just be shelved away as a misprint . >

Takizawa said that all at once .

He had probably remembered afresh the anger he had felt at that time .

Makoto also thought that it was as Takizawa said . It wasn't a problem that could be shelved away as a misprint . That was why it had felt off .

In Takizawa's article, it said that A-ko-san reported the incident to the police at about nine PM .

However, at the police presentation, they had said it was 12:07 AM . The difference between these times was the problem .

If only the time had been written in the article, it could have been just a misprint, but the story changed when looking at what was written before and after that .

A-ko-san finished dinner and heard a scream while watching a TV drama at about nine PM .

At first, she had thought it was the television, but then there was the sound of a struggle and she kept hearing screams, so she thought it was strange and went out .

A-ko-san confirmed that the noise was coming from the house next door and reported it to the police immediately . That was what was in the article .

On the same day as the incident, the TV drama A-ko-san mentioned was broadcast at nine PM, just as her testimony said .

She had been watching the drama from nine PM and heard the scream, so she reported it immediately to the police . They said that was at twelve AM .

There was a huge difference in time –

'Is there the possibility that A-ko-san gave false testimony...'

<For what purpose?>

Takizawa spoke over Makoto's words .

It was just as he said . There was no reason for A-ko-san to give false testimony .

Perhaps if she had been a suspect, but A-ko-san had never been treated that way . There was no point in her changing the time on purpose .

Perhaps she was covering for someone –

But if that were the case, she could have just testified that she heard the scream at twelve AM .

<If you're that curious, ask yourself . >

'Do you know her contact information?'

Makoto couldn't hide her surprise at Takizawa's words .

There was the sound of a drawer being opened and something falling from the other side of the phone .

<Yeah . Damn . Can't find it right now, so I'll message you it later . >

'That'll be a great help . '

<But be careful how you handle her . It's an annoying time we're in . >

Takizawa said that in an unpleasant tone .

'I'll be very careful . Thank you very much . '

Makoto bowed her head, the phone still in her hand .

16

Ishii went to the hospital early in the morning .

He passed through the entrance, opened the door to the stairwell by the elevator hall, and took the stairs down to the basement .

The dim corridor stretched out in front of him .

The door he was headed for was at the very end . Every footstep he made echoed, making it sound like somebody was following him .

I'm scared – but I'll bear it .

Ishii told himself that as he walked to the door at the very end .

When he knocked on the door, a hoarse voice called out: 'It's open . '

'Please excuse me . '

'Oh, Ishii-kun . I was wondering who you were because of your glasses . '

When Ishii opened the door, an old man in white waved from where he was seated at the desk right by the entrance .

It was Hata, the coroner . Though he was skilful, there was a bit of a problem with his taste .

Perhaps he had stayed up all night, because his eyes were red . They made Hata's demonic appearance stand out more .

'It's been a while . '

Ishii bowed towards Hata .

'Sit somewhere over there . '

Ishii looked around the room, as Hata told him to, but there were cabinets and cardboard boxes everywhere – he couldn't spot a place to sit other than Hata's desk .

In the end, he decided to stand with his back against the wall .

'So did you find it?' asked Hata as he sipped his tea .

'What do you mean by it?'

'Gotou's corpse . '

With shaking shoulders, Hata giggled, sounding amused .

Ishii didn't understand what was so amusing .

'Detective Gotou isn't dead yet!' exclaimed Ishii, in a voice so loud it even surprised himself .

However, Hata wasn't surprised – his expression didn't even change .
Maybe it had been just the right volume for speaking to a senior .

'On what basis are you saying that?'

Hata's sunken eyes seemed to glitter .

'That is...'

Ishii wanted to deny it, but he didn't have any basis for it, so his voice ended up fading off .

'If you find Gotou's corpse, bring it to me . I'll check how degenerated his brain is . '

Hata giggled .

Ishii had thought that Hata and Gotou had had a relationship of trust, but it appeared that he had been wrong .

It appeared that Hata had only helped them with investigations outside of work to satisfy his own curiosity .

'But if you didn't bring Gotou's corpse, then what did you come here for, Ishii-kun?'

It felt reluctant, but Hata had brought up the matter at hand .

'Actually, I wanted to ask you about the results of the autopsy for the brutal murder case fifteen years ago . '

When Ishii mentioned the topic, Hata looked up to the ceiling as he brushed his hair back .

That response . There was something there .

'That case, eh?' said Hata, his voice so faint it sounded like he could die at any moment .

'Do you remember it?'

'That was the first corpse I took care of as a coroner . Normally, my boss would've taken charge, but there'd been four corpses, so I was asked to lend a hand . '

Ishii was inwardly surprised .

Ishii had suspected that Hata might not have been able to remember the incident fifteen years ago accurately since he autopsied corpses every day .

However, from what Hata said now, it appeared that it was clearly engraved in his memory .

'Did that case have, er... anything questionable or strange?'

Even as he said it himself, he felt disappointed in what a vague question it was .

Ishii wanted to hear a more specific recollection . That was why he had stayed up all night to read the documents from Miyagawa .

However, nothing resulted from it .

'There was... something strange,' said Hata, spinning once in his chair like he had thought of something .

'Is that true?'

Hata looked at Ishii, who had edged in towards him .

Hata's eyes were like that of a demon watching his prey for a chance to attack .

Perhaps Hata was irritated, because he didn't say anything . He gulped down his tea .

'Please tell me!'

Ishii moved towards Hata in his agitation .

'There was a disagreement about the time of death . '

'What do you mean?'

Ishii didn't understand what Hata meant .

'Exactly what I said . According to the file, the corpses were carried in around one in the morning . Which means that they'd been killed within two hours of that . '

'Yes . '

Ishii nodded .

Since the time of the crime had been reported in the documents as about twelve AM, that would be right .

'But livor mortis was spotted on the corpses and they were stiff from rigor mortis . The body temperature was also very low . '

'Really?' said Ishii in his surprise .

Livor mortis was when blood settled in the body because of its weight . It appeared two hours after death .

If livor mortis had already been there when the corpses were brought in, that would mean that two hours had already passed by then .

It was the same for rigor mortis . Of course it depended on the person, but rigor mortis started after two hours and took about twelve hours to appear in the whole body .

'Really . From my diagnosis, I'd say they'd been dead four to six hours . '

'But in the file...'

In the file, the time of death had been said to be about twelve AM, but according to Hata's analysis, it was from seven to nine PM .

'That's why I said there was a disagreement . The police checked a lot of things, like whether that was really the time of death .

– I see .

At the time of the crime, A-ko-san, the person living next door, had heard a scream and contacted the police at twelve AM, according to the police report . After that, Miyagawa went to the scene and met the culprit . That was definitely fact .

When the autopsy results were compared with the facts, there was a definite difference in time .

'Since it didn't match the scene, were there instructions to alter it?'

Ishii knew that that couldn't have happened, but he couldn't think of anything else .

'Even they wouldn't tell me to do that . '

'Then...'

'Livor mortis and rigor mortis aren't definite . There're differences with different people, and if there'd been some special circumstances for the temperature, sometimes the temperature dissipates more quickly . It could happen if we look at it that way . '

When Hata finished talking, he snorted .

So they made it coherent by using a broad interpretation –

However, that could be called a black hole . It felt like there had been a large distortion of time .

– This might be a breakthrough .

Nothing concrete had come out, but Ishii definitely felt a response .

'Hey, Ishii-kun . Do you really think you can find Gotou by doing this?' said Hata, wrinkling his face like he'd eaten something sour .

'I don't know . However, I will not give up as long as there is a chance!' declared Ishii loudly .

'Here's some friendly advice: give it up . '

Hata sounded like an old man who had gone through many phases of life .

'What do you mean by give it up?'

'I'm saying that with you in mind . Think about it . '

'With me... in mind?'

'Do you really think Gotou is alive?'

'Of course I do!' replied Ishii with vigour .

When Hata saw that, he shook his head sadly .

'You must know if you're not an idiot . Gotou isn't some young woman . If this isn't a kidnapping for ransom, what would be the point in abducting him?'

Hata's fish-like eyes stared at Ishii's face .

'That is...'

'Give up your foolish hope . If you don't, when the time comes, your heart will break . '

It might be just as Hata says . Gotou could already –

Tears welled up in Ishii's eyes just from thinking about it .

But it didn't mean that there was no chance . Ishii shook away his negative thoughts .

'No . Detective Gotou is still alive!'

After Ishii said that clearly, Hata let out an uncanny demonic giggle .

'Honestly, you've become a bull-headed detective like Gotou . '

'That is because I respect him . '

'Do as you like . '

Hata waved his hand, like he was chasing away some fly .

17

Haruka stood at the station for the Shinkansen bound for Nagano .

Even though it was a weekday morning, there weren't many people .

Before she left her home, she called Isshin to tell him the general situation . While Haruka's emotions had welled up, Isshin seemed to accept the facts reluctantly .

That person was probably prepared . That was how it seemed to Haruka .

Prepared to meet whatever ending was coming and receive it face-on . However, Haruka didn't have that readiness .

Yakumo would be safe and she would meet him again . Haruka couldn't accept any other ending .

Perhaps the inspection of the train had been completed, because the entrance to the stopped Shinkansen opened .

Haruka picked up her bag and boarded the Shinkansen .

She went through the narrow aisle and took a window seat in the middle of the carriage . She put her luggage on the baggage rack, took off her coat and sat down .

– Will I really be able to get closer to Yakumo by going to Nagano?

She was doubtful, but all she could do was believe that now .

The matter with Yakumo's mother, Azusa . And Haruka's mother, Keiko .

Furthermore, the man who had appeared yesterday morning . Everything led to the same place . Yakumo had to be there .

Haruka took the envelope out of her coat pocket .

In the end, she opened the envelope last night without her mother's permission . There was a letter inside and a photo .

To Azusa-san –

Congratulations on your marriage .

I am really as happy as if I were the one who was getting married . I saw the photo too . I was truly relieved to see you looking so happy, Azusa-san .

Many good things must be awaiting you .

I'm glad . I'm really glad...

She wasn't talented at composition, but Keiko's honest feelings for Azusa came through . Haruka could tell that Keiko wasn't just writing letters to Azusa out of sympathy .

The photo had been taken at the New Year's shrine visit, and Haruka and her dead twin sister, Ayaka, were in it .

Ayaka was smiling at the camera, but Haruka had fallen and gotten her kimono dirty, so she was unhappy about it and had her head hung low .

A short paragraph was written on the back of the photo .

<My twins have grown up so much . It'd be nice if they could meet Yakumo-kun one day . >

After this, events had befallen each family and they'd taken a detour, but at an unexpected place, Yakumo and Haruka had met .

Haruka suddenly recalled the first meeting between Yakumo and her .

His hair had been a mess and his eyes had been sleepy . A contrary person who mocked people with his words and actions . What an unpleasant guy! That had been her first impression .

She hadn't believed that he had the unique ability to see the spirits of the dead, and she'd even suspected that he didn't have a heart .

However, after a number of experiences, Haruka realised –

Yakumo's attitude was a front to make people keep away from him, and he was actually completely different .

After she realised that, Yakumo's sarcasm seemed cute .

And she enjoyed how his expression would soften into a troubled one when she was nice to him . He wasn't used to people treating him that way . He wasn't honest at all .

Yakumo had also been the one who saved Haruka when she was about to die at the river .

At the time, Yakumo had jumped into the river with no hesitation at all . He had been really cool .

I'd thought I was going to die during the last case too –

But in the end, Yakumo came to save her . Though there'd been a bit of a problem in the way he saved her .

– Hey, Yakumo . Will I never meet you again?

The Shinkansen started with a groan .

Haruka felt disheartened when a red light flashed in her eyes .

The necklace with the red stone was shining red because of the light from the window .

It was Azusa's necklace, which Haruka had received from Yakumo .

That's right . I can't be disheartened now . I'll find Yakumo no matter what I have to do . I decided that .

Haruka tightly gripped the red stone .

NOTES:

[1] A kotatsu (炬燵) is a low table with a blanket on top of it and a heater underneath, used in the winter to keep warm . HERE are some very lovely ones .

[2] Haruka describes the kanji used to write Azusa by breaking it up into parts, which is very common for names . Azusa is written like 梓, and on the left there is the tree radical (木) and on the right there is the character 辛, which means many things including spicy, hot and bitter .

Volume 5 Chapter 3: VOLUME 5 – CONNECTED FEELINGS

Chapter 3

VOLUME 5 – CONNECTED FEELINGS

file 03: yearning (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

We found Takeda Shunsuke –

Miyagawa received that news at about noon . He moved to the wireless to give instructions immediately .

‘Report the situation!’

He yelled at the wireless . The other investigation team members who were still in the room gathered round as well .

The nerves in the detective room had peaked .

<Arai spotted him in the back of a building by the scene and is chasing him
. >

The one who answered was the detective in command at the scene, Shimizu .

Shimizu and the team had received information from an eyewitness who had sighted Takeda and had been questioning civilians near the abandoned building . They had spotted him coincidentally .

'Were you able to confirm it was Takeda?'

<No, it isn't clear...>

Miyagawa felt irritated by the vague response .

'Was there anyone else who saw him?'

<There was not . Only Arai did . >

'Weren't any other investigation members nearby?'

<He had just happened to go elsewhere for a task and spotted Takeda then, so...>

Shimizu was being completely unclear . Well, fine . They'd give their undivided attention to catching Takeda now .

Miyagawa cleared his mind of his irritation .

'Where are you stationed?'

<He was sighted escaping northward on a prefecture road in 3-chome . Naitou and I are following after Arai . >

Miyagawa followed the location with his finger on the enlarged map on his desk .

He was spotted near this building, went onto the prefectural road and headed north – if it went well, they might catch up .

'I'll send reinforcements . '

When Miyagawa pointed at the map, the four investigation members by his desk ran out of the room .

If they went ahead and blockaded the escape routes, they would definitely be able to stop him .

'I won't let him get away . '

Miyagawa gritted his teeth .

<We will reach him soon . >

A message came from Shimizu over the wireless .

– I'll finally be able to catch Takeda .

The event that took fifteen years would come to an end . When Miyagawa thought that, he felt exhilarated .

There was silence –

They might be able to secure Takeda before reinforcements arrived .

Sweat rolled down Miyagawa's back in his nervous state .

<This is Shimizu . >

The hesitant voice made Miyagawa's heart beat more quickly .

'What happened?'

<Er... That is...>

'What!? Say it clearly!' yelled Miyagawa .

<It seems we have lost him...>

'Lost?'

<I sincerely apologise . >

'You bastard! Do you know what you're saying? You're not playing tag!'

It felt like his head would pop like a balloon from his anger .

'Explain what you mean!'

<That is... Arai had been following him, and according to what he said, he suddenly lost sight of Takeda...>

Those words added oil to the fire that was Miyagawa's anger .

Making such stupid excuses at a time like this!

'Come back here right now!'

Even after the transmission ended, Miyagawa's anger did not abate .

He picked up a nearby chair and threw it with all his strength out the window .

2

After leaving Hata's hospital, Ishii turned his car into the parking lot at the precinct .

He shut off the engine and leant back in his seat .

He had been working with no sleep or rest since last night . His joints were stiff . His body was heavy, as if he had become an old man . He felt like he would be drawn into sleep .

But he didn't have the time to rest . Just by delaying the investigation, Gotou's survival chances dropped . There was still a mountain of things to do .

Ishii forced his body up and got off the car .

What he'd heard from Hata was extremely interesting . The problem was how to use that as a foothold to level the case .

Investigating around with no purpose would just waste time .

It would be quickest to make a hypothesis like Yakumo and prove it .

However, he hadn't constructed that crucial hypothesis .

A feeling of helplessness ate away at his body .

'Think, Ishii Yuutarou . '

Just as Ishii was encouraging himself, his mobile phone rang .

'Ishii speaking . '

<U-um, it's Makoto . >

It sounded like Makoto was walking somewhere . Ishii could hear the rhythm of her footsteps .

'Makoto-san, what is it?'

<Ishii-san, you seem a bit different . >

Makoto laughed as she said that .

Even if she said that, Ishii didn't feel like anything was different .

'Is that so?'

<Yes . It's like you're a different person from the one you were yesterday .
>

The only thing that had changed was that he was determined now . More importantly –

'What is it?'

<Ah, that's right . Actually, I was investigating the case and found something very interesting . >

'What is it?'

There was the chance that it would be timely help for Ishii, who had reached a standstill .

<It's about the testimony of A-ko-san, the person who reported the incident . >

'Was anything suspicious about it?'

<Yes . Rather than suspicious, I can't explain it very well . Ishii-san, where are you currently?>

'I've just returned to the precinct . '

<That's great . Actually, I've just arrived at the precinct as well . Shall we speak in person?>

– Arrived at the precinct?

Ishii turned around and looked at the front entrance .

He spotted Makoto there with mobile in hand .

'Ah, I see you . '

Ishii hung up and waved at Makoto .

Makoto noticed Ishii too and walked toward him with a smile .

Crack!

There was the sound of breaking glass from up in the sky .

What is it – Ishii looked up .

A chair was falling . Why was a chair –

The chair smashed right into Ishii's confused face .

Blood spurted out of his nose into the air .

Haruka got off the Shinkansen at Nagano Station .

She passed through the gate . The moment she went out to the station traffic circle, she heard the short honk of a horn . Haruka spotted Keiko leaning out of the window of a white minivan and waving her hand .

Even though Haruka hadn't given a proper explanation, Keiko had gone along with her daughter's whim and even come to pick her up . Keiko's kindness made Haruka lower her head .

She ran up to the car and sat in the passenger's seat .

'Welcome back,' said Keiko kindly .

Haruka couldn't look at Keiko's face properly .

'I'm home . '

Keiko gave Haruka's face a pinch when she replied without looking up .

'Ey, tha hurs, Mum . '

Keiko ignored Haruka's resistance and pinched her daughter's cheek even harder, looking like she was having fun .

— It hurts, it hurts .

Haruka flapped about to resist and somehow escaped Keiko's hand .

'Honestly, what are you doing all of a sudden?'

Keiko laughed as she looked at Haruka with a hand against her cheek in her protest .

'OK, OK . If you're that energetic, you're fine . '

Keiko patted Haruka's shoulder, put the car out of park and started the engine .

She must have been worried . When Haruka was troubled, it showed in her attitude . Haruka's chest suddenly hurt the way it did when she told a lie .

'So why are you looking for Azusa-san all of a sudden?'

Keiko looked at Haruka while driving .

Haruka didn't know how to answer the question, but she had to .

'I said that I go to the same university as Azusa-san's son, Yakumo-kun, right?'

'Yup, you told me . What sort of child is Yakumo-kun?' said Keiko with excited eyes .

Since he was the child of a friend who she hadn't heard from in fifteen years, it was natural for her to be interested .

'Even if you ask me what sort of child he is...'

Haruka was lost for words . It was difficult to explain Yakumo in one word .

'Is he cool?'

Even though her mother was going to be fifty soon, she was acting rather like an idol-obsessed girl .

'Well, in a way . '

'I've only seen photos of him as a child, but I thought he'd definitely grow up to be cool . Which Johnny's[1] member is he like?'

'Why would you use Johnny's as an example?'

'If you're talking about cool, it's Johnny's, right? Korean groups are no good . I can't bring myself to like them because they feel too perfect . '

Haruka was the one who felt embarrassed when she looked at Keiko, who was as excited as a teenage girl .

She would have preferred it if her mother liked something more tasteful such as Ishihara Gundan[2] .

'He doesn't look like anybody in Johnny's . '

Keiko covered her mouth and smiled when she heard Haruka's refusal .

'Hey, can I say what I think?'

'What?'

'The reason you're looking for Azusa-san . '

Haruka didn't know what Keiko was thinking, but she seemed to be having fun .

Before Haruka responded, Keiko started talking on her own .

'Haruka, you and Yakumo-kun truly love each other and vowed to marry . '

'What are you saying?'

Haruka objected loudly, but Keiko wasn't listening .

'Well, just listen . You're looking for Yakumo-kun's mother, Azusa-san, so you can tell her about your marriage . Right?'

There was a limit even to delusions .

Haruka was so astonished by her own mother that she couldn't say anything . Her head hurt .

'Of course not!'

Haruka said that angrily, but Keiko was nonchalant .

It was like Haruka was talking with Yakumo .

'But you like him, right?'

'Who?'

'Yakumo-kun . '

Keiko smiled knowingly .

'I hate him . He's a really unpleasant guy . '

Haruka hadn't been planning on responding, but it just came out of her mouth .

'Oh, is that so?'

'It is . He's contrary and he's always making fun of me . He says things like "Do you want to be clumsy or stupid? Make up your mind . " He was really awful the other day too . He threw me into a pool . '

Haruka objectively listened to the words that kept coming out of her mouth .

The more she said, the more hollow she felt . Like she was talking about somebody who was already gone –

She had been holding it back until now, but the feeling that she might never meet him again was spreading .

'What? So you really do like him, don't you?' said Keiko, sounding exasperated .

'I said I hated him, didn't I!?' said Haruka, in a voice so loud it even surprised herself .

– Why am I getting so worked up?

Haruka couldn't find the answer to that question .

'I see...'

After Keiko murmured that, she parked the car by the sidewalk and turned off the engine .

The cars passing them sounded extremely loud .

Haruka had her hands in fists on her lap . Keiko laid a hand on top of them . It was warm .

Her mother accepted her . When Haruka felt that, she relaxed from the sense of relief and the check she had put on her feelings stopped working .

'I really hate that guy . He disappeared without saying anything . Don't you think that's horrible? Even though I believe in Yakumo-kun, he's always alone . He'd be fine even if I weren't there...'

Tears started falling from her closed eyes .

– I'm frustrated .

Haruka realised that . She was frustrated that Yakumo had disappeared without saying anything .

The distance between Yakumo and her had been much, much farther than she had thought . She had been forced to feel that anew .

'Did Yakumo-kun go to search for his mother?'

Keiko pulled Haruka closer to her by the shoulder and hugged her .

Haruka's body relaxed and she nodded, resting against Keiko's chest .

'And you're searching for Azusa-san to find Yakumo-kun then?'

Haruka nodded again .

'Yakumo-kun might be dead . '

Haruka gripped Keiko's hand tightly .

'What are you saying? You're searching for him because you haven't given up, right?'

As Keiko rubbed Haruka's back, Haruka could smell her mother's scent .

It's warm –

The anxiety she had held by herself until she had felt like she was going to burst was softening .

– I haven't given up . I will definitely find Yakumo and give him a good punch .

Haruka decided that again while in Keiko's arms .

4

Ishii sat at his desk and looked at the mirror he had borrowed from Makoto .

His glasses were cracked . There was gauze on his nose . A piercing pain in his nose made him wrinkle his brow . Even he thought he looked terrible .

'Are you really all right? You should go to the hospital...' said Makoto, looking troubled .

'I'm fine . '

Ishii returned the mirror to Makoto . He didn't care about his appearance at all right now .

'Why did a chair fall?'

Ishii didn't know either . It was an interesting mystery, but he didn't have the time to concern himself with that .

'More importantly, could you tell me what you were talking about, Makoto-san?'

Ishii changed the topic while bearing his pain .

Makoto still looked worried, but she reluctantly opened her notebook .

'Actually, today, I met with A-ko-san, who was the one who reported the crime . She lives near the precinct . '

I see, so that was why she called from in front of the precinct . But –

'Why did you meet with A-ko-san?'

For a moment, Makoto looked troubled by Ishii's question, but she started speaking after licking her lips .

'Actually, there was a small contradiction in her testimony . '

'Contradiction?'

'Yes . According to her testimony, on the day of the crime at nine PM, she heard a scream from next door while she was watching a television drama .
,

'If I remember correctly, the dossier said that the report came in at twelve AM...'

Ishii's lips narrowed into a thin line .

'That's right . She claimed it was at nine PM, but actually, the report came in at twelve AM...'

'If what she said is correct, that would mean she reported the incident three hours after she heard the scream . '

A distortion of time –

Ishii flipped through the files he had received from Miyagawa, found the page had A-ko-san's testimony and followed it with his finger .

It really did read 12:07 AM .

– No, that's wrong .

It had been written over, stamped with a thumbprint and changed . Before the change, the time had been written as 9:10 PM .

'The police pointed out that contradiction to her and in the end, she said that her memory might have been playing tricks on her and that it might have been at twelve AM, changing her testimony . '

'She changed it...'

'But from how it felt when I was talking to her today, she appears to still doubt that . '

'I see! So that's how it is!'

Ishii stood up in his agitation . In A-ko-san's testimony, there was the same distortion of time that had resulted from Hata's autopsy .

'Ishii-san, what is it?'

Makoto's mouth was agape as she looked at Ishii .

'Actually, I just heard something similar this morning . '

'Something similar?'

'That's right . The coroner, Hata-san, was told that the time of death he gave, seven to nine PM, contradicted with the scene of the crime and had had to change it to about twelve AM using a broad interpretation of the facts . '

Makoto appeared to have understood the situation and put a hand over her mouth in her surprise .

Ishii could have jumped in his agitation .

'Now there's no more doubt about it . The actual time of death was much earlier than twelve AM . '

It was probably past nine PM –

'But how about the time of the report and the detective's testimony? And even if the time of the murder was different, what would change?'

Just as Makoto said, even if the time of the murder changed, the situation wouldn't change much .

– No, wait a second .

Ishii started diligently following the investigation materials with his finger again .

He found the passage he was looking for immediately . It was a log of Takeda's actions from the day of the crime .

They hadn't been able to get Takeda's testimony, but the testimony of those around him had been collection .

'This!'

Ishii hit the desk in his delight .

'What is it?'

Makoto looked at Ishii's face in concern .

He wasn't insane .

'Please look at this . '

Ishii pointed at the passage as he showed Makoto the document .

As Makoto looked at the paper, her expression hardened before Ishii's eyes . Then, her eyes went wide and looked up at Ishii's face .

'I see . In this testimony, Takeda's ex-colleague, C-san, was together with Takeda until about nine . Then, Takeda revealed that he was going to talk things out with Katsuaki . '

'Which means...'

'That's right . If A-ko-san did hear a scream past nine, like she said in her testimony, then Takeda has an alibi . '

Even though Ishii had meant to express his reasoning confidently, Makoto looked depressed . She had a complex expression on her face, like the food she had eaten wasn't as delicious as it looked .

'But why is there a difference in time? Why did A-ko-san report the incident to the police three hours after hearing the scream?'

It was just as Makoto said .

Nine PM and twelve AM . No matter which time they chose, it wasn't consistent .

It would make more sense if A-ko-san had mistaken the time and they looked at the autopsy results with a broad interpretation, as the police ended up doing .

But there was another way of looking at it .

'What if somebody faked the time of death to pin the crime on Takeda?'

'Would that mean A-ko-san was an accomplice?'

'Yes . She gave a false testimony in order to cover for her accomplice . '

– That was the only way this would make sense .

'But isn't that strange?'

Makoto immediately denied Ishii's suggestion .

'Strange?'

'A-ko-san testified that it was nine PM . The police were the ones who changed that to twelve AM . '

That was certainly true . Whichever time it was, it would be difficult to think of A-ko-san as an accomplice .

'Also, the detective met the culprit at the scene . It would make the idea that the time of the crime was faked suspicious . '

It was just as Makoto said .

There was no point in faking the time of the crime if the culprit stayed at the scene .

Ishii's theory went back to the drawing board . Dispirited, he organised the documents . His head felt heavy . He felt somewhat irritated . He wanted to have a smoke .

'I also thought A-ko-san's testimony was unnatural, but I can't think of anything beyond that . '

'Right . '

'If A-ko-san's testimony is true, that would mean she heard the scream past nine PM, lost consciousness for about three hours and then called the police without noticing that .

Lost consciousness – ?

Something clicked in Ishii's head, and the gears started turning .

The various information he had gathered up until now started coming together, leading him to one theory .

– What on earth? Is that how it is?

'Makoto-san! You're a genius!'

In his agitation, Ishii leant forward, grabbed Makoto's shoulders and shook her .

If the theory he had just constructed now was true, this was very serious .

'E-er . Ishii-san, what's wrong?'

Makoto looked at Ishii like she was looking at something unpleasant .

Please don't look like that . I mean, I –

'I've figured it out! The puzzle of this case!'

Ishii yelled that in a ringing voice .

5

Togakushi Soba <Ozawa> - that was Haruka's home .

Her father Kazuhiro was waiting in the garden when they parked the car in the parking lot behind the shop .

He wore an apron and had his neck out like an ostrich as he looked about . It seemed he sensed something from his daughter's sudden return .

However, he didn't approach Haruka even after she got off the car with her luggage . Even though he had many things he wanted to ask, he didn't put them into words . He was that sort of person .

'I'm home . '

Haruka called out to Kazuhiro .

'Oh, you're back?' said Kazuhiro curtly . Then, he went back into the shop .

Fathers really were afraid of their daughters –

'Honestly . Why is he running away?' said Keiko exasperatedly before entering the house through the backdoor .

Haruka followed after her .

She took the stairs by the front entrance, opened the sliding door and went into the room .

It was six tatami in size – a dreary room with only a desk and a dresser .

Still, being in her own house really did calm her down . The fatigue and anxiety that Haruka had had for so long seemed to dissipate slightly .

She put down her bag, hung up her coat and sat on the tatami .

'Sorry for the wait . '

Keiko entered the room .

She had a bundle of envelopes held together with a rubber band . Those were the letters that Yakumo's mother had sent Keiko .

Keiko sat across from Haruka and held out the bundle .

'There are a lot of letters . '

'There are . I didn't pity her because of what happened – I was just on the same wavelength as Azusa-san,' said Keiko earnestly .

Haruka felt like she understood . If they had only met because of the case, the relationship wouldn't have continued for so long .

Haruka and Yakumo were the same . Regardless of how they met, in the end, they seemed to be on the same wavelength .

'So I feel like I understand why you'd be charmed by Yakumo-kun,' said Keiko . When she said it like that, Haruka didn't want to admit it .

'Like I said, it isn't like that . '

'Big words for somebody who was crying like a baby earlier . '

Keiko laughed as she elbowed Haruka's arm .

When Keiko said that, unfortunately, Haruka could make no reply .

'Now, now, don't be angry . You have to look for Yakumo-kun, right?'

'Right . '

Haruka cleared her mind .

Just as Keiko said, she didn't have the time to get angry .

'Azusa-san said that she had a lover,' said Keiko .

Haruka also felt that that was a good thread to start from .

If Azusa had a lover, there was a good chance that that person might know where Azusa was if they could find him .

'Er, which was it...' murmured Keiko as she checked the envelopes .

A question suddenly came to Haruka .

'Mum . '

'What is it?'

'Why didn't you look for Azusa-san?'

– Oh no .

After Haruka said it, she thought what she said had been careless . That was because Keiko suddenly looked regretful when she heard Haruka's words .

'I didn't think that Azusa-san was so cornered that she would lay a hand on her son,' replied Keiko with sad eyes .

'That makes sense . '

'She said that she was getting married, so I thought that somebody like me who knew her past would get in the way, so I gave up . That's why I didn't even think of looking for her . I was a bit lonely, but I thought there was nothing to be done...'

Haruka could understand why Keiko felt that way .

If Azusa hadn't talked to the person she was going to marry about her past, it wouldn't be unnatural for her to think of keeping a distance from the friends who knew her past .

'I asked something strange . Sorry . '

'Don't worry about it . Plus, Yakumo-kun went somewhere to chase his mother, right?'

'Probably . '

'Which means that if we chase Yakumo-kun, I might also be able to meet Azusa-san, right?'

Keiko laughed pleasantly .

– Azusa-san might already be dead .

Haruka didn't have the courage to tell Keiko that .

However, Keiko seemed to understand everything from looking at Haruka, who had kept silent, and she bit her lower lip as if vexed .

'I want to know too . '

'Want to know?'

'Yes . Why did Azusa-san try to kill Yakumo-kun? A parent wouldn't normally be able to think of killing their own child . There must have been a great reason for things to end up that way . '

As Keiko said that, she looked troubled . Like Isshin, her emotions were probably divided .

Perhaps what Yakumo was looking for wasn't his mother but the reason why his mother had tried to kill him .

Haruka suddenly felt that might have been the case .

'Oh, my hands have stopped . It's a bad habit . I have to look through these quickly . '

Keiko sniffled and went back to checking what was inside the envelopes .
The ability to clear her mind so quickly was one of Keiko's amazing talents .

When Haruka's older twin sister had died, the first to smile again had also been Keiko .

It wasn't that the sadness had left her . She had been thinking of Haruka .

Even under normal circumstances, Haruka had had a complex about her older sister Ayaka . And Haruka had been the cause of Ayaka's death –

The sadder Keiko acted, the more it would make Haruka suffer . Keiko had known that .

'Haruka! Look at this!'

Keiko took a letter and a photo out excitedly .

Haruka took the photo and looked at it .

A child who looked to be one year old was sleeping on top of a cushion . He was sucking on his right thumb and looked happy .

His skin was pale like a girl's .

'Could this be – '

'Yup, it's Yakumo-kun . He's cute, right?'

Haruka unconsciously grinned .

She hadn't ever thought that she'd get to see a photo of Yakumo like this . His cheeks were as puffy as marshmallows, and his expression wasn't as harsh as it was now .

Even Yakumo had had a time like this . Somehow, it was strange to imagine it .

She took a look at the letter too .

<Yakumo is one now too . He cries when I'm not near him . He's so spoiled – it's troublesome...>

It's different – Haruka felt that immediately .

The contents of the letter were incredibly different from the image Haruka had had of Azusa . Even in the short passage, her love for her child came through .

However, the only image Haruka had had of Azusa in the first place was the fact that she had failed in trying to kill Yakumo and had gone missing after that .

That had been such a strong episode that it decided the image .

Perhaps it was the same for Yakumo too .

His own mother put her hands around his neck – wouldn't that vivid memory have erased all the other ones?

'Found it . This one . The three of them are in it . '

While Haruka was thinking about the photo and letter from the past, Keiko found the photo she was looking for .

Keiko held the photo and was looking at it nostalgically .

– I want to see it right away .

Led by that impulse, Haruka moved to Keiko's side and peered at the photo .

The photo was taken somewhere like a lake .

Yakumo was probably the one standing in the centre . If the photo was taken fifteen years ago, he was about six years old . Yakumo had been short then . His eyes were narrowed from how bright it was .

Azusa was on the left . She had almond eyes and well-defined features – she was a very beautiful person .

She did look like she was carrying some shadows, but it felt like that doubled her charm .

Yakumo resembled his mother .

On the other side was the person who would have become Yakumo's father –

'Ah!'

Haruka thought she would stop breathing from the shock .

'What is it?'

'I know this person . '

– He is probably in Nagano .

It was the man who had shown up in Haruka's room the morning before .

Haruka took out her mobile phone .

6

After Ishii parted from Makoto, he called Miyagawa through the internal line .

Even though they could have met in person, Ishii had experienced the attitude the detectives had towards him yesterday . He didn't want to encourage that .

<It's Miyagawa . >

He heard Miyagawa's clearly displeased voice .

'This is Ishii . '

<It's you...?>

'I apologise for calling when you are busy . I would like to ask you something regarding the matter we discussed before . '

<Did you find anything out?>

Miyagawa's tone suddenly lowered . He was probably concerned about the investigation members around him .

'Nothing is certain yet . '

Then don't call . That feeling came right through the receiver .

Usually, Ishii would have been swallowed up by that feeling and hung up after apologising, but he was different now .

'However, I have grasped an important clue . In order to advance in the investigation, there is something I would like to confirm . '

<What?>

Miyagawa spoke after a silence .

'Were there any suspects besides Takeda in the case fifteen years ago? If there were, I would like to see the documents regarding that . '

<What the hell are you thinking!?!>

Miyagawa let out a loud voice all at once from the bottom of his belly .

'It is absolutely necessary . '

<What you trying to do by investigating that now?>

Miyagawa lowered his voice again .

He had probably gathered attention because of his loud voice earlier .

'Even if you say that... it would take a long time to explain . However, it is definitely related to the search for Detective Gotou . '

Miyagawa didn't reply .

All Ishii heard was the quiet sound of Miyagawa's breathing .

'Please . Please believe in me . '

Ishii bowed his head to pray .

<I'll go over there once I've finished up, so wait there . >

'Thank you very much!'

Before Ishii finished saying that, Miyagawa hung up . The strength suddenly left Ishii's shoulders and he leant against the back of the chair .

He'd told Miyagawa to believe in him, but was his theory really correct?

To be honest, Ishii was unsure . If what he was thinking was wrong, he wouldn't be able to find Gotou .

However, still, all he could do was believe and follow that faint possibility .

The mobile phone in his suit's inner pocket rang . When he looked at the display, he saw Haruka's name .

The events of yesterday passed through Ishii's head and he hesitated before answering .

– This is no good . If I stop here, it'll end up like before again .

He gathered his emotions and answered the phone .

'I apologise for the wait . Ishii speaking . '

<Ishii-san, there's something I would like you to look into . >

Ishii had been about to apologise, but Haruka had started speaking before he even had a chance to take a breath . He completely lost his chance .

Furthermore, it felt like Haruka had completely forgotten what had happened at Isshin's house .

'Something you would like me to look into?'

<Yes . I will send you a photo of a person afterwards . I would like you to search for him . >

Haruka was speaking quickly .

– Searching for someone .

It was probably somebody related to the case, but it would be difficult to look for somebody with only a photo .

Putting aside whether he even had the time to search, he would at least take a look .

It depended on how much information there was besides the photo, but it could possibly work out if he asked Makoto to help too .

'What sort of person am I looking for?'

<The lover of Yakumo-kun's mother . >

Yakumo's mother had been in that video as a ghost . He didn't know what role she played, but it was certain that she was involved in this case somehow .

There was a good chance that her lover might have some new information .

'Understood . I will do as much as I can . I'll say my email address now, so please send it there . Also, please give me as much information about that person as you can . '

After that, Ishii checked his email address while reading it to Haruka over the phone .

<I'll message you right away . >

'Er...'

Ishii stopped Haruka, who had been about to hang up .

'I am truly sorry for yesterday . '

Ishii held his breath as he bowed his head deeply .

There was a long silence –

Ishii silently waited for Haruka to reply . He wouldn't mind even if she jeered –he was prepared for it .

<I'm sorry too . I said something awful to you, Ishii-san . >

What Haruka said was very far from what Ishii had expected .

– She's going to forgive me?

'Something was wrong with me then . Let's save Yakumo-shi and Detective Gotou with our own hands no matter what!'

<Yes . >

Haruka gave a firm reply .

Ishii closed his eyes in his happiness and grinned unconsciously as he imagined Haruka's smiling figure .

Oops, he didn't have the time to space out . Ishii came to his senses and started his laptop .

Since it was an old model, it took a full minute to load up .

He connected to the internet and opened the mail software to check for new mail .

It seemed Haruka had sent it from her mobile phone . The email had already arrived .

The subject was <This is the person> . The mail said <Yesterday, I met this person . I don't know his name . >

There was too little information . He didn't know how to search from just this . It wasn't impossible, but it would take some time .

He opened the attached image .

The photo had probably been taken with a mobile phone camera . The image was small on the screen and difficult to make out . Ishii maximised it to fill the monitor .

'T-this man is...'

Ishii thought his chin would fall off from his surprise .

This man is Takeda Shunsuke –

Ishii immediately took out his mobile phone and called Haruka's number .

7

Makoto met with the hypnotherapist named Hayashi in the booth that was sectioned off as a reception space .

He was wearing a casual suit with no tie . He was tall and solidly built, but he didn't seem intimidating .

He had a gentle demeanour and seemed like a good listener .

He even listened seriously to Makoto's crazy story .

That said, it wasn't actually something Makoto had thought up . The crazy story was all Ishii's theory .

Even Makoto had been surprised when she had heard Ishii's reasoning . She had thought it was very removed from reality .

'I see . I understand what you're saying . '

After Makoto finished talking, Hayashi thought silently for a while, but then he rubbed his two hands together and spoke .

'First, regarding whether what you discussed is possible or impossible, it is possible under several conditions . '

'Eh? It's possible?'

Unconsciously, Makoto half-rose from her seat .

Since she had doubted Ishii's theory, she was even more surprised .

'Well, please calm down . '

After Hayashi pacified Makoto, she sat back on the chair with a red face . Hayashi waited for her to finish before speaking again .

'The person who thought of this method is very intelligent . They understand the characteristics of hypnotic suggestion and are using it effectively . '

As Hayashi said that, he smiled bitterly .

'Characteristics?'

'Yes . Many people misunderstand this, but hypnotic suggestion cannot be used to control people freely . '

'Which means?'

'Those actions come from that person's own intentions, so it is impossible to make somebody act in a way they do not want to . '

Makoto also knew that hypnotic suggestion couldn't control people freely .

On television, she often saw hypnotists making people fall asleep with a snap of their fingers and telling those people what to do, but those were just shows .

However, then there was a contradiction in what they had said so far .

'But earlier, you said that the method was possible . Isn't it impossible to control people?'

'It is a little bit different . Even if you were hypnotised somebody and told to kill somebody once you opened your eyes, that would be absolutely impossible . '

'Why is that?'

'Because their morals wouldn't allow it . Actions that go against one's morals will not stick . '

Makoto nodded . She understood that much .

Even though they would be hypnotised, that didn't mean their personality would disappear . Accordingly, somebody wouldn't act if they didn't want to, even if forced .

'Hypnotic suggestion must stay within the range allowed by one's morals . '

Under that meaning, the trick in the method this time hadn't required anybody to directly kill somebody, so it could be said to be within the range allowed by one's morals . However –

'Wouldn't that mean anything was possible if it was morally acceptable?'

Hayashi crossed his arms at Makoto's words .

'That isn't exactly right . Being put under hypnotic suggestion is like being guided by one's intentions . '

'Yes . '

'Rather than an order, it's guidance . This is important . For example, what do you think one should say to tell somebody they could no longer lift their arm?'

Hayashi was good at explaining . Makoto was engrossed .

'Your arm will not go up . Saying that would be no good . There is a weight on your arm now . A very large and heavy weight . A weight that nobody would be able to lift, no matter how strong they were . That is the sort of image you would give . '

By giving the brain a reason and making that an image, you could guide the actions .

'Then that would mean somebody was there giving hypnotic suggestion . '

'That wouldn't be necessary,' said Hayashi firmly .

'Is it possible to put somebody under hypnotic suggestion from a distance?'

'This is a little different . The method of hypnotic suggestion is done so that the suggestion is triggered by something . '

'Huh...'

Makoto didn't understand yet .

'For example, spin at the sound of a bell . If that were the hypnotic suggestion, the person who was hypnotised would spin at the sound of a bell even if the hypnotist was not there . '

But Hayashi himself had said that even if somebody was under hypnotic suggestion, they were still conscious when hypnotised .

That would mean that they remembered being put under hypnotic suggestion .

'Wouldn't there be no point if the person under hypnotic suggestion could remember what happened?'

Makoto voiced the question as it came to her .

'It is just as you say . Another point is necessary for hypnotic suggestion . '

Hayashi held up his index finger .

'What is it?'

'That is to tell the person going under hypnotic suggestion to forget that they were under at the same time . It is called hypnotic amnesia . '

'Hypnotic amnesia?'

'Yes . In short, people are conscious when hypnotised . They remember what they do even when guided . There would be no meaning to it then . That is why it is necessary to also give the suggestion to forget what happened under hypnosis afterwards . '

Makoto could feel her heart racing as she listened to Hayashi's explanation .

'Is that possible?'

'Yes, it is . '

This was proof . Makoto had a real response .

Putting aside whether this actually happened or not, Ishii's theory was possible .

However, if it was possible, did it really –

'That's frightening . '

Makoto said that unconsciously .

Hayashi's expression had been gentle up until now, but it turned grim .

'I apologise . '

Makoto gave an honest apology for her careless words .

'No, it's fine . But I would like for you not to misunderstand – hypnotic suggestion comes down to how it is used . '

'How it is used...'

'Yes . We hypnotherapists use hypnotic suggestion to treat the mind . We heal traumas that people do not know they have and relieve people of their psychological stress . Please don't treat us all as criminals . '

It was just as Hayashi said .

They studied hypnotic suggestion to heal people's hearts . They weren't using it for crime .

'It's the same for surgeons, isn't it? It is their job to cure people's bodies with their scalpels . However, it would be incorrect to blame their scalpels because they could be used for crime . Everything depends on how something is used . '

Makoto regretted her foolish remark and bowed her head deeply again .

It was wrong to reject everything because of one example of misuse . Even the medicine from hospitals would become poison if used incorrectly .

Furthermore, what happened this time had occurred from a number of coincidences and wasn't something that somebody could do that easily .

Makoto had been doubtful at first, but now she agreed with Ishii's theory and was certain that the true culprit of the case fifteen years ago was

somebody different .

8

When Haruka heard the information about the man in the photo from Ishii, she was stunned .

Yakumo had probably realised everything from the very start .

That the woman in the video was his own mother, and the suspect for the crime that occurred where the video was taken was the man who was supposed to become his father –

The place Haruka had finally arrived at had just been the starting line for Yakumo .

Disappointment welled up within Haruka . At this pace, it didn't seem like she would ever catch up to Yakumo .

'What's wrong?'

Haruka came back to her senses when Keiko called out to her .

'This man's name . It's Takeda Shunsuke-san,' said Haruka, pointing at the photo .

Keiko didn't appear to understand the significance of that and replied shortly, 'I see . '

'Takeda Shunsuke-san was the suspect for a murder case fifteen years ago and is on the run now...'

'Eh?'

Keiko finally understood the situation and snatched the photo back from Haruka, putting it so close to her face that her nose almost touched it .

Even though the truth wouldn't change even if she looked at it from close up or far away, Haruka understood why Keiko would do that .

She couldn't believe it, nor did she want to .

If this is true, then what sort of fate did Azusa bear on her shoulders –

One day, she was suddenly abducted and confined, and she was assaulted physically and psychologically . She ended up bearing a child that she did not want .

Still, she forced herself to stand up again and live her life .

Then, just when she finally found a partner to support her and was about to embark on her new life, that person ended up being chased by the police as the culprit to a murder case .

She must have wanted everything to be a dream . She must have wished for that countless times . But the truth was mercilessly there .

A cruel truth that was everywhere –

If Haruka had been in the same position, she might have even given up on living .

'I can't believe that this person...'

Keiko shook her head like she didn't understand .

He didn't look like the sort of person who would do such a thing . Haruka had the same impression . And there were other things she didn't understand .

If Takeda was the suspect for a murder case and the police were after him, why didn't the investigation go to Azusa –

She must have noticed .

'Mum, do you know how Takeda-san and Azusa-san met?'

'I do . When I got the letter about her marriage, I was so happy I called her .
,

Keiko smiled . Her eyes seemed to be looking far away .

She was probably recalling how she felt then . Being able to share one's feelings with somebody was really amazing .

'This person was a newspaper reporter and called out to Azusa-san and Yakumo-kun when they were at the park . Asked them to let him take a photo . That was how they met . '

'I see...'

Haruka imagined Azusa and Yakumo playing at a park .

What sort of expressions did they have on their faces then –

Takeda had chosen them for a photo, so they must have been smiling .

'They probably had a lot in common . They decided to marry a month after meeting . '

'A month!?'

Haruka's voice jumped an octave .

That was a huge difference from somebody who hadn't been able to express her feelings for over a year .

Even though she did think that was fast, it wasn't like it was impossible, and there really were people like that . Dating for months and years wasn't proof of the bond between two people .

The short time period probably hid their relationship .

That was why Isshin and the police hadn't found out .

That meant that Azusa had told Keiko about her marriage before her own brother, Isshin .

It showed how much she'd trusted her .

Haruka was even more confused now though . Why hadn't Azusa consulted Keiko even once before she was so cornered she would lay a hand on her own son?

If she had, she might not have thought of trying to kill Yakumo .

Had she been unable to talk about it because she trusted Keiko?

– No . That isn't it .

Haruka felt that something was off .

9

After Miyagawa left the room, he went down the corridor to the door to the <Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room> at the very end, opposite the toilet .

When he went inside, Ishii was on his mobile . He said, 'I will call again later,' hung up, and stood straight .

'Just sit down . '

After Miyagawa said that, he sat at Gotou's seat opposite Ishii .

'I apologise for asking for something unreasonable . '

Ishii bowed his head, and he was sitting frankly for once .

– He's had a good look these past couple of days .

When Miyagawa looked at Ishii's face directly, he thought that keenly .

Up until yesterday, Miyagawa had just thought of him as a beansprout that only knew how to wail, but this case might have drawn out his sleeping ability .

Still, what was with the gauze covering his nose?

'What happened to your nose?'

'Ah, er, you might not believe this, but a chair fell down from the sky . '

– Crap . It's my fault .

'How unlucky . '

Miyagawa didn't think it was necessary to give his name, so he just let the conversation flow .

Ishii looked at Miyagawa like he wanted something .

It was like Ishii was telling him to take the documents out already . But Miyagawa couldn't just hand them over without knowing what was going on .

'Why do you need documents about suspects for a case that's already had a culprit determined?'

Miyagawa fixed Ishii with a strong gaze .

'Because there is the possibility that he isn't the true culprit . '

Miyagawa was so shocked he couldn't even be angry .

'Don't say something stupid with no basis for it . '

'I do have a basis for it . '

Miyagawa had planned on cutting Ishii down, but Ishii leant forward with a challenging gaze .

There might actually be something there if this coward was going to say this much . Miyagawa faltered .

'Try telling me . '

'Yes . Just earlier, I received a report of confirmation from an expert over the phone,' said Ishii, looking pleased . He was like a child who'd received a toy .

'Expert? In what?'

'Hypnotism . '

This guy really did have a habit of deluding himself .

'Don't make me laugh . You're not saying that somebody was hypnotised to kill somebody, right?'

Miyagawa had said that coldly, but Ishii still did not flinch . Where did this confidence come from?

'It is impossible to make somebody kill someone else with hypnotism . '

'Doesn't that not match up with what you're saying?'

'The point is that case comes from the testimony fifteen years ago . '

Ishii adjusted his glasses with his finger and declared that in a ringing voice before starting his explanation .

'A-ko-san reported the incident at twelve AM . There is no doubt about it . However, A-ko-san actually heard the scream three hours earlier at nine PM . '

'The dossier says it was twelve AM, right?' interrupted Miyagawa .

'That's correct . However, A-ko-san first testified that it was at nine PM . '

Ishii laid out the copy of the files that Miyagawa had handed over to him earlier and pointed at a passage .

Just as Ishii said, it had read nine PM, but it had been changed to twelve AM .

'Isn't that strange? That'd mean that she heard the scream at nine and called the police right away at twelve AM . Did she use a carrier pigeon or something?'

Ishii laughed while clutching his stomach at Miyagawa's light sarcasm .

It irritated Miyagawa since he felt like he was being made fun of, but he bore with it .

'Carrier pigeon? How amusing . However, that is unfortunately not the case . '

'What is it then?'

'In short, this . A-ko-san heard the scream at nine PM . After that, somebody guided her into a deep hypnotic state . '

– Was he serious?

Miyagawa glared at Ishii, but Ishii continued speaking, paying him no heed .

'Then, at some sort of signal, she woke up after three hours and reported the incident to the police . A-ko-san lost the memory of the three hours she was hypnotised for, so she thought that she had called immediately after she heard the scream . '

'Isn't that just your delusion?'

'It isn't a delusion . I said this earlier as well, but I have confirmed this with an expert . The trick I just discussed is actually possible . '

– Really?

If what Ishii said was true, that would get rid of the bumbling time difference they'd had up until now all at once . But –

'Is it really possible?'

'It is . It is called hypnotic amnesia . One is put into a deep hypnotic state and made to forget that one was hypnotised using a suggestion . '

It wasn't coming together for Miyagawa .

'I don't get it . '

'For example, when somebody faints, what was just a moment to them could actually have been many hours . It is the same sort of thing . '

Miyagawa had experienced that himself .

Fifteen years ago, Miyagawa woke up in the hospital after having his head hit . It had been just a moment for him, but it had actually been six hours .

'But how about the autopsy? The time of death was said to be around twelve AM . '

'I checked with Hata-san . The final time of death was decided based on the scene of the crime . He had taken a look at the situation and used a broad interpretation of the autopsy results . '

'What did you say...'

'In short, Hata-san's analysis put the time of death for the corpses from seven to nine PM . '

Miyagawa stood up unconsciously in his agitation .

'Why would anybody need to do something so troublesome?'

'In order to change the time of the crime and give the culprit an alibi . '

If the method Ishii discussed was possible and actually happened, it would be a great way to make an alibi .

However, there was something Miyagawa just couldn't accept .

'I was the first at the scene then . I saw the guy who did it there . If he was trying to give himself an alibi, why'd the culprit be there? Isn't that strange?'

Ishii's eyes narrowed behind his glasses .

'Perhaps – this is just a possibility, but, what if he wasn't the culprit?'

Miyagawa wanted to rebut Ishii's words, but he couldn't speak .

His forehead was drenched in sweat . How many years had it been since he'd sweated as unpleasantly as this?

Miyagawa had been hit in the head then and he'd fainted .

Because of that, he couldn't remember the culprit's face clearly, but the fear he'd felt then had filled his body .

He'd felt instinctively that that man wasn't Takeda .

The reason was that Takeda was human . He might have had hatred and anger, but those were peanuts compared to what Miyagawa had seen there .

An oppressive evil . He didn't believe in a god, but if he had to give an example, that had been the devil .

'Chief Miyagawa . Would you allow me to see the documents?'

Miyagawa handed the documents over to Ishii before replying .

The documents had the details for two names that had come up as suspects before the police had decided that Takeda was the culprit .

Ishii immediately started looking through the documents .

A number of things happened during that case and the police got the time of the crime wrong .

Was my testimony one of the reasons for that –

Miyagawa felt like his legs would collapse underneath him .

If what Ishii said was true, that would mean they'd been chasing an innocent for fifteen years .

But he didn't understand . Why didn't Takeda agree to be taken in for questioning?

He'd run off without agreeing, which had been one of the reasons the police had decided Takeda was the culprit .

'I've got it! I've got it!'

Ishii suddenly shouted and jumped up .

'Calm down!'

Ishii smiled even more at Miyagawa's yell .

'I can't be calm . I've finally found the true culprit . '

'What did you say!?'

He determined the culprit from the two suspects? But on what basis?

Miyagawa wanted to ask these questions, but before he could, Ishii ran out .

'Where are you going!?'

'To investigate, of course,' said Ishii, turning around as he did so .

He fell –

10

Haruka looked at the photo again .

– I can't think of anything no matter how hard I try .

She hadn't been able to question Yakumo when she'd noticed he sounded strange when he called her . It might have already been too late then .

The corners of her eyes felt warm . Tears were welling up . This was no good . She felt like she wouldn't be able to meet Yakumo again if these tears fell .

Haruka bit her lip and gripped the red stone on her necklace with both hands .

– I can't give up .

She spurred on her crumbling heart .

There had to be something she'd missed . Something very important –

'Haruka . You said you met Takeda-san, right?' said Keiko, putting a hand on Haruka's lap .

Haruka knew who he was now, but it was still a puzzle as to why he'd come to see Haruka .

'Yeah . '

'What did he say?'

'He wanted me to save Yakumo-kun . And that Yakumo-kun was in Nagano . '

'Why did he ask that of you? Hasn't Takeda-san met Yakumo-kun?'

Haruka had the same doubts as Keiko .

And how did he know I was searching for Yakumo? Why didn't he meet Yakumo directly?

The questions in Haruka's head suddenly brought up a memory .

The day she went to the <Movie Research Circle> to search for Yakumo, she'd felt somebody's gaze . That hadn't been her imagination .

– Takeda was watching me .

Takeda must have gone to meet Yakumo as well . There, he saw Haruka .

However, that didn't explain why Takeda hadn't gone to save Yakumo himself .

'If what Takeda-san said is true and Yakumo-kun is in Nagano, doesn't that mean Azusa-san is also in Nagano?'

Keiko proposed another question while Haruka was pondering .

The moment she heard that, the image from the video came back to her .

She felt like her head was being squeezed .

And then – she was led to a conclusion .

'That's right, Mum!'

Haruka's voice was close to a yell .

Keiko was taken aback by the suddenness of it .

Haruka had thought something was strange when she saw that video .

The moment the video became completely dark, she'd heard the faint sound of something like footsteps .

Isn't that from two videos being edited together –

In short, the first half and second half of that video had been taken at different places and put together .

Which meant that the second half with Azusa – she didn't know where it was taken .

No, that was wrong . She had to calm down and think .

Supposing that Yakumo realised that too, Yakumo searched for that place .
Then, he arrived in Nagano –

She didn't have any basis for it, but those two lines of thought led her to one place .

'Hey, Mum, Do you know where the incident with Azusa-san occurred?'

'Ah, er... I know the area,' replied Keiko, a bit lost for words .

Keiko didn't understand what Haruka was thinking and looked like she had been caught by a fox .

'Please, Mum . Take me there,' begged Haruka as she gripped Keiko's two hands .

11

Ishii drove his car quickly .

Urgency and exhilaration were mixed together, making his blood run wild .

There was no margin for doubt any more . The background and actions on the day of the crime of the two suspects had been in the documents Miyagawa showed him .

Ishii had realised immediately when he saw them . If his theory was correct, that narrowed the suspects down to one .

'Oi, you're driving too fast!'

Miyagawa gripped Ishii's shoulder from the passenger seat .

Ishii didn't understand why Miyagawa had come along .

The moment Ishii started the car, Miyagawa had stopped him, standing in front of the car with his two arms spread wide . Ishii had thought Miyagawa

would try to hold him back, but he'd sat in the passenger seat without a word .

The statute of limitations was almost up for Takeda, so who was going to direct the investigation of the scene? Ishii had that question, but he didn't dare to ask .

'Even if you tell me that I am driving too quickly, I am in a hurry...'

'Stop whining! You don't have the police siren on so obey the speed limit!' said Miyagawa indignantly .

'Um, could I turn it on?'

'What?'

'The siren . '

The moment Ishii said that, Miyagawa raised his hand . However, he didn't hit Ishii .

Ishii thought that Gotou and Miyagawa were very similar . There was just one thing decisively different about them . It was power . It was partly physical, but Gotou's power to rush at something overwhelmingly exceeded Miyagawa's .

This was one of those instances . If it were Gotou, he would have hit Ishii's head without any hesitation .

For some reason, I feel like something's lacking –

'And where are you heading in the first place?'

Miyagawa finally asked that question .

Ishii had been sure that Miyagawa had stepped into the car knowing that, so he let out a surprised 'Eh?'

'Isn't it obvious that I'm going to the place where the true culprit is?'

'So where is that? There were two suspects, right?'

Miyagawa stamped his foot in his irritation .

There certainly had been two suspects . One was Uematsu Shouichi . He had borrowed money from Kanji . Then, he'd been asked to return the money and they had had a rather troubling dispute .

The reason for the loan had been a failed business . However, Uematsu claimed that the failure was Kanji's fault .

The other suspect was Honda Yutaka . He had fought with the middle school Nanase Kanji was director of in court .

Honda's daughter committed suicide because of bullying . Her father, Yutaka, pressed charges, saying that his daughter's death laid with the homeroom teacher who had tolerated the bullying, Kanji's son Katsuaki .

The case was Honda's loss —

He hadn't been able to prove positive proof that the school had tolerated the bullying .

Then, there was a reporter who had followed that case vigorously . That was Takeda . This wasn't just a coincidence .

'It is Honda, of course . '

'How can you be sure? Don't you have to investigate both of them again?'

If thinking about it normally, Miyagawa's opinion was correct .

'I have two reasons . The first is that the crime probably occurred past nine PM . It isn't necessary to reinvestigate everything . All I have to do is see who doesn't have an alibi then . '

'And what's the other?'

'Chief Miyagawa, I said this earlier, but in order for the trick with the lapse in time to be realised, there is an essential condition . '

'Condition?'

Looking confused, Miyagawa parroted Ishii's words back at him .

'Knowledge of hypnotism as well as the ability to use it . '

Miyagawa's expression turned grim at Ishii's words .

It appeared he understood . The suspect Honda hadn't been able to stand up again after his daughter's death and had been troubled by insomnia, so he had undergone hypnotherapy .

'But Honda had been treated as a patient with hypnotherapy . That's different from being able to use it . '

What Miyagawa said made sense . But there was also another way of looking at it .

'Patients undergoing hypnotherapy receive an explanation about the basics of hypnotism in order to remove any preconceptions . Mightn't he have become interested in hypnotism because of that? He might have gone to lectures or taken an online course – there are countless ways he could have learnt . '

'That vague theory's just conjecture . '

'But the other suspect, Uematsu, has no connection to hypnotism . '

Miyagawa glanced at Ishii .

It was like he was saying he thought it was suspicious . Ishii didn't care if Miyagawa didn't believe him . To be honest, Ishii didn't have much confidence in this theory either .

However, if he just stayed here, nothing would change .

In order to save Gotou, he would have to rush forward, knowing it was reckless .

'Do you think Gotou's at Honda's too?' said Miyagawa, closing his eyes and crossing his arms .

Ishii nodded firmly . It wasn't a bluff – he was confident .

Something caused Gotou to realise that Honda was the real culprit . That was why Honda had abducted him . To shut his mouth –

'You think Gotou's still OK?' said Miyagawa, looking out the window . It felt like he didn't want to know the answer . However, Ishii knew .

'Detective Gotou is fine!'

Miyagawa looked at Ishii in surprise . His eyes seemed to be asking for an explanation .

'Honda is definitely keeping Detective Gotou alive . '

That wasn't Ishii's groundless wish .

'Why do you think that?'

'It's because Honda's goal is to pass the statute of limitations . All he has to do is keep Detective Gotou until the statute of limitation passes . If he killed him, that would mean he would have to flee for another fifteen years . It wouldn't be worth it . '

Ishii and Miyagawa looked at each other and smiled silently .

Ishii knew even if Miyagawa didn't say anything . Miyagawa had completely accepted Ishii's theory .

'But what do you plan to do? We don't have the time to investigate . The statute of limitations is up in a day . '

Miyagawa looked at Ishii with searching eyes .

Just as Miyagawa said, they definitely wouldn't make it if they went to get evidence now .

It would be so easy if they could find the culprit and prevent the statute of limitations from finishing, like in some detective drama .

In reality, after capturing the culprit, the police would write up a file, collect evidence and then send it to the prosecution .

Then, the prosecution would judge whether it was appropriate . If it was, then they would write an indictment, bring it to court, and then the first accepted accusation would be finished at court .

The time lag for that would be long .

If they had Takeda as the culprit, the evidence was already gathered . Sometimes the police would make the necessary arrangements with the prosecution so that they could present an indictment to the court immediately after arrest . However, that wouldn't work if the culprit were anyone besides Takeda .

They would need to make the file and start with getting the prosecution to judge it . They couldn't waste even a second, so there was only one they could do –

'I will meet with the person himself and make him confess,' said Ishii clearly .

Miyagawa stared at Ishii's profile .

The silence continued –

Ishii knew what Miyagawa wanted to say . The chances that somebody who had been on the run for fifteen years would confess to a detective who didn't even have a warrant were close to zero .

To tell the truth, Ishii couldn't care less about arresting the culprit . Even if the statute of limitations passed, he'd be satisfied as long as he could save Gotou .

In the end, Miyagawa didn't say anything . He just opened the window and put the siren that had been on the dashboard onto the top of the car .

A piercing siren started to ring –

'Chief Miyagawa . '

'Step on it . '

'Yes sir!'

As Ishii said that, he floored the accelerator .

12

The car went down the dark road .

Even with the headlights on, it was impossible to see down the road, because of the way it wound . Furthermore, snow had piled up on the road, so it was also impossible to drive quickly .

Looking at the white road, Haruka felt like this road might not actually lead anywhere .

But all she could do was go down this road .

'I'm really sorry . '

Haruka bowed her head towards Keiko, who had gone along with Haruka's selfish request without even one complaint and was now driving the car .

Since they would need to drive on a snowy road, Keiko had even borrowed an acquaintance's four-wheel drive .

'Ah, aren't you being honest for a change? It'd be nice if you were always like this . '

Keiko smiled at Haruka's words, making light of them . Just from that, Haruka's feelings lightened .

'You make it sound like I'm never honest . '

'That's how you are . You're stubborn and not honest at all . That's why you always end up with a broken heart . '

She went straight for the things that bother me the most –

In Haruka's opinion, it was stranger that someone could act so spoiled in front of the person they liked .

'Stop saying so much and just drive . '

Keiko grinned as she looked at Haruka, who had forcibly changed the topic .

The way Keiko retorted was like Yakumo .

'OK, OK . We'll be there soon . '

After Keiko said that, Haruka leant forward and focussed her eyes on the dark .

However, all she could see were tall cedar trees on both sides and the snowy white road .

After driving further, Keiko turned on the hazard lights and parked the car by the side of the road .

'Are we there?'

'It's been twenty years since then already,' said Keiko, looking out at the road .

Haruka couldn't even imagine what feelings were hidden in those words .

She didn't have the time to think . Anyway, she had to go right now . Haruka took a torch and got off the car .

The air was so cold it hurt .

Her breath came out in white puffs .

The snow crunched underneath her shoes . Haruka carefully walked forward .

'Azusa-san collapsed right there . '

Keiko came after Haruka and pointed at a point on the road with a hand in a thick glove .

It wasn't as if there was some sort of sign there . Everybody would have passed the spot without noticing –

Haruka tried standing in that spot .

Everything had started in this place with nothing in it .

When she met Yakumo at the university, that had actually been the second time . Actually, they had first met here, both still in the bellies of their mothers .

It would be spoilt if she put it into words, but it really did seem destined .

We went the long way around to arrive here –

'Azusa-san suddenly burst out from that forest . '

Her mother pointed at a narrow road between the trees .

Haruka turned on the torch and lit the way .

There were footsteps on the white road . Somebody had definitely walked down this road recently .

'Mum, wait here . I'll be right back . '

After Haruka said that, she made her way towards the road .

'Wait a second . '

Keiko took off her gloves and gave them to Haruka . She would probably be angry if Haruka refused .

'Thank you . '

Haruka put on Keiko's gloves and walked through the snow .

Fwoop .

Her foot sank into the snow, but it wasn't as deep as she imagined . Her ankle was still out of the snow . Though it was troubling to have the snow in her shoe, she could probably continue walking like this .

Haruka looked once more at the footsteps that continued down the white road .

She couldn't see what was ahead, since it had been swallowed up by the darkness .

The place where Azusa had been held captive was ahead of her . Yakumo had to have gone there . These footsteps were Yakumo's . Now, Haruka was following those footsteps .

She brushed aside the tree branches and proceeded down the road . It was difficult to walk, and there was a slope ahead .

She had to put her hands to the ground and crawl ahead . It was really a good thing that she had gloves .

Haruka cleared her mind and devoted herself to climbing up the road with all her efforts .

She was short of breath . Her head felt dizzy and she was sweating .

How far did this road go? It can't go to the top of the mountain, can it –

She hadn't made any preparations at all . She wouldn't be able to camp out all night, and it could easily become a disaster if she wasn't careful .

Plus, she had left Keiko alone . She was definitely worried .

Just when Haruka's anxiety reached a peak, the road ended and she arrived at a flat, open lot .

There was a house there .

Surrounded by trees, it was a small, deserted house built like a hut . It was built out of logs – a log house then .

It appeared to have been abandoned for many years . The wood was rotten and the house was leaning .

This was probably where Azusa had been held captive .

What could be inside? Haruka didn't know . Because she didn't know, all she could do was go .

Haruka calmed her breathing and started walking again .

13

Honda's house was at the outskirts of the factory zone .

It was three storeys tall and had a garage on the first floor – a house built during the bubble .

The lights were on . That meant he was home . Things would've gotten troublesome if he hadn't been .

– Please wait . I will definitely save you .

Ishii put a hand to his chest and whispered that in his heart .

Ishii opened the door on the driver's side, got off the car and went up the stairs outside of the house to the second-floor entrance .

'Wait a second!'

Miyagawa had run up after Ishii and gripped him by the lapels .

'What is it?'

'Don't you say "What is it" . What are you planning on saying?'

That –

'I haven't decided . '

Ishii hadn't thought that far . However, he didn't think there was any way to go but from the front .

'You're just a smart idiot . '

Miyagawa's shoulders fell in his exasperation .

'Chief Miyagawa, there is a contradiction in what you said . 'Smart' and 'idiot' are antonyms . '

'That's something a smart idiot would say . '

Miyagawa clicked his tongue .

'Huh...'

Ishii made a vague reply, but that didn't mean he understood .

'Anyway, leave this to me . '

Miyagawa forced himself in front of Ishii and pressed the intercom button .

'Who is it?'

A voice came through the intercom .

'Ah, excuse me . I am Miyagawa from the Setamachi precinct . There are a few things that I would like to ask,' said Miyagawa, stooping to speak into the intercom .

After a while, the door opened .

A man in his fifties with a good physique showed up at the door . He had a long face with dark circles around his eyes, and he was pale and haggard .

'Honda-san, yes? My name is Miyagawa . I met you once fifteen years ago .
,

At first, Honda looked confused, but that was for just a moment . Perhaps he remembered, because he pointed at Miyagawa and said, 'Ah . '

'As you probably know, the statute of limitations has almost passed for that case . '

'Is that so...'

'There are a few things that need to be checked for that case before then . '

Miyagawa scratched at his head, seeming apologetic . The conversation was flowing naturally . That was Miyagawa for you .

When Ishii tried to peer into the back of the room through the gap between the door and the wall, Honda shifted .

For a moment, Honda's eyes met Ishii's .

'If I can be of help,' said Honda . He put on his sandals and stepped outside, closing the door behind him .

– Did he notice?

Ishii felt suspicious .

'Oh, it's nothing important . We're just confirming the situation . I apologise for the inconvenience . Are you alone now?'

Honda let out a short breath at Miyagawa's words .

His eyes were narrowed, and he looked at Miyagawa and Ishii with a cold gaze . It was like he was saying 'It's your fault' .

'I am alone . Right after that case, I had a divorce with my wife . '

'How about your work?'

'I'm still working . '

'Have you been at home these past few days?' said Miyagawa nonchalantly .

– It's a bluff .

It implied that they knew everything .

'Yes, well, I've taken a few days off work . '

'Why is that?'

Miyagawa pressed further .

Honda rubbed his palms on his trousers . He couldn't calm down – his gaze was wandering .

'Well, a bunch of things...'

'What do you mean, a bunch of things?'

Miyagawa was disinterestedly but steadily cornering Honda .

'Er, well, I caught a cold...'

It was a weak excuse .

– Just one more push .

'Is that so? I understand . I apologise for bothering you . '

Contrary to Ishii's inner voice, Miyagawa readily ended the conversation .

Ishii didn't understand Miyagawa's true intentions .

'Please take care of your cold . '

After Miyagawa said that, he pulled Ishii's arm .

— The conversation isn't over .

Ishii wanted to resist, but Honda had already disappeared through the entrance .

'Why did you stop? With only a bit more...'

Miyagawa covered Ishii's mouth so he wasn't able to finish his sentence .

Miyagawa pulled Ishii forcibly by the arm to the car he had parked on the road .

'Get in!' said Miyagawa sharply, but Ishii just didn't understand .

'I don't want to . '

'Stop complaining . The guy's watching . '

Miyagawa exchanged a look with Ishii .

Ishii took a quick glance at the house . Somebody was standing by the window and watching them .

'Hurry up . '

Ishii reluctantly got into the driver's seat at Miyagawa's behest .

'Drive . '

The moment Miyagawa sat in the passenger's seat, he spoke, not letting Ishii ask his questions .

Ishii started the engine and drove .

'Honda's definitely hiding something . '

'I think so as well . '

Ishii agreed with the words Miyagawa had said in an unpleasant temper .

'Check with his company to see whether he'd asked for the days off in advance or the day of . Then we'll know if it was because of a cold . '

Normally, Ishii would definitely have been agitated, but he wasn't now .

Gotou's life depends on this –

'That would be too slow . Honda is clearly hiding something . We should step in immediately . '

'When did you start telling me what to do!?'

'But...'

'We can't do whatever the hell we want just because we're police! Illegal investigations are useless in court! Don't you know that much!?'

Miyagawa's yell echoed through the car .

Ishii slammed on the brakes, stopping the car . It wasn't because he was surprised . It was because he couldn't agree with Miyagawa's opinion .

'I don't care about the court . I just want to save Detective Gotou . '

'It's the same for me!'

Miyagawa hit the side window with all his strength, baring his emotions .

Normally, Ishii would have yelped in fear, but he had a determination in the bottom of his stomach that would not waver no matter what .

'It isn't the same . Chief Miyagawa, you only want to save Detective Gotou as part of the police . '

'What did you say!?'

Miyagawa gripped the collar of Ishii's jacket threateningly .

'I am different . I want to save Detective Gotou as a regular person!' shouted Ishii, brushing Miyagawa's arms aside .

'Are you prepared for that?'

– He had been prepared a long time ago .

Ishii took his police ID out of his jacket pocket and threw it against the dashboard .

Miyagawa looked at Ishii with a bewildered expression .

'What are you planning?'

'I'm not planning anything . I said this earlier . As a regular person, I can't abandon Detective Gotou . '

After Ishii declared that, he opened the door and got off the car .

Miyagawa didn't try to stop him . Even if he did, Ishii wouldn't have listened .

In order to save Gotou, he would drop his identity as a police officer with no regrets if it became a burden . There were things men had to do no matter what they would lose . This was one of those times .

– Detective Gotou . Please wait . I am going to save you now .

Ishii started to run at full speed in the freezing cold .

Haruka advanced through the snow and climbed up to the entrance to the log house .

Creak –

The floor was rotten . It felt like it could break at any moment .

The door was slightly open .

She tried to use her torch to light up the inside through the gap, but all she saw was a dusty floor .

Nervousness and fear made her heart beat so loudly it felt like it would burst through her chest .

– It's OK . Calm down .

Haruka encouraged herself and slowly pushed open the door .

There was the unique smell of mould mixed with dust .

Right after she went in, there was a space that was probably the living room .

It was about ten tatami in size . By the wall, there was a shelf of the same kind she had at home . There was a large table in the middle .

The glass in the window was shattered, so all that was left was the frame .

Snow fluttered in, together with the wind .

'Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka focussed on her shivering throat and spoke up .

The only reply was the howl of the wind .

– My reasoning might have been wrong .

Doubt passed through her mind .

– I can't step down now .

Haruka shook her head to clear her head of bad thoughts .

'Yakumo-kun . Aren't you here?'

As she called out, she looked around with the faint light from the torch .

She spotted a door in the very back of the room .

While confirming the feel of the rotten floor, she slowly walked to the door .

Scritch .

Something moved .

'Aah!'

Haruka leapt back instinctively .

When she pointed her torch down, she saw a mouse running across the floor .

'Honestly, don't do that . '

She lit up the door again .

There was a hook-shaped clasp on it . She tried to undo it, but her hands were shivering too much .

Haruka herself didn't know whether it was from cold or fear .

She took off her gloves . She clenched her fist and unclenched it so that she could make her fingers work the way she wanted them to . Then, she undid the clasp and opened the door .

Beyond it was a small room, like a storehouse .

There was only a large object in the middle covered with a green sheet .

Compared to how old the house was, this sheet was clearly new .

Rustle .

Haruka felt like she saw the object move slightly .

She hurriedly covered her mouth and swallowed her scream .

– Something’s in there . I’m scared . I’m scared, but I have to check –

Haruka shut her eyes and took deep breaths . She gripped the sheet with trembling hands .

Then, she pulled it off all at once .

She was so surprised she couldn’t speak .

Underneath the sheet was the person she had been looking for .

‘Yakumo-kun!’

Yakumo was sitting on a wooden arm chair . Both his arms and legs were bound with rope .

His head drooped like a doll’s and he didn’t budge at all . There was a dark red stain on his red shirt .

It’s blood –

‘Yakumo-kun! Hang in there! Yakumo-kun!’

Haruka embraced Yakumo and shook him while yelling with all her might .

However, Yakumo didn’t respond .

'Yakumo-kun! Please! Talk to me!'

Haruka felt like she was falling into a deep darkness .

A darkness that went on forever –

Her eyes welled up with tears .

– Even though we finally met up again . Why is this happening?

While crying, Haruka undid the ropes that bound Yakumo .

Because they were tied tightly, it wasn't going well .

Her fingernails snapped and her fingers were bleeding . But she didn't have the time to worry about that . She just wanted to get Yakumo out as quickly as she could .

Finally, she undid Yakumo's bindings and was able to hug him .

His body was cold .

– Am I too late?

Why did this happen? Why?

No matter how she tried, Haruka couldn't find the answer to that .

I wanted to talk to you once more . But . But –

Why?

'Yakumo-kun . Why?'

The hole in Haruka's heart spread as she was overwhelmed by a variety of emotions .

Haruka hugged Yakumo as tightly as she could .

To the point it felt like his body was a part of her own . She hugged him with all her strength .

That was all she could do –

15

Ishii reached the intersection where Honda's house was .

He hid behind a telephone pole and looked at the house .

If he tried to go in from the front entrance, he would probably be stopped .

He didn't even think Honda would open the door for him . Then there was only one path Ishii could take . The first floor garage .

– Was this really OK?

Ishii asked himself that .

What he was going to try to do now was illegal trespassing . It was a definite crime . He was even going to trespass when the owner was on the property .

He'd be forced to quit if this got out .

But he didn't care about that . He'd thrown away his ID earlier . He was saving Gotou as a regular person – not a police officer . He would save Gotou . That was all .

– I'm a man too . Do your best, Ishii Yuutarou .

Ishii looked around to check that nobody was there and then ran straight for the garage .

He pressed his back against the shutter door and caught his breath .

Ishii put his hand to the shutter door, but it wouldn't open . It appeared to be locked .

Things wouldn't go that easily for him .

He sidled along the wall to the back of the house .

He found a ventilation window . He could break in from there . He put his hand on it, but it also wouldn't open . It seemed like he'd have to break the glass and unlock it .

Ishii looked around to find a handy rock .

He couldn't make any loud noises . A small rock would be better .

'There . '

Ishii picked up a rock the size of a marble and threw it at the window .

Click .

It made a small noise and bounced back .

No good . I need a larger rock –

How about this one? This time Ishii picked up a rock about the size of a basketball and threw it at the window again .

Because he didn't put enough strength in his throw, it fell on his own toes .

'Agh . '

Ishii gritted his teeth and endured the pain . He writhed on the floor, gripping his toes with his hands .

– This time .

Ishii picked up a rock the size of his fist and threw that at the window .

Clang .

The rock broke through the glass . It sounded like it hit something metal . It must have hit the car .

'Oh no . '

Ishii crouched and lowered his breathing .

Silence –

Fortunately, it seemed like he hadn't been noticed .

Ishii put his hand through the broken window and unlocked it .

He looked around once more to check that nobody was there before opening the window and climbing into the garage, using the window frame for support .

'Agh . '

Ishii missed his landing and fell on his back, putting him in agony .

The garage was dark .

It was filled with the smell of petrol and dust .

Ishii took a penlight from his pocket and used its faint light to look around .

The trunk of the black sedan parked there was dented, and the rock was on top of it .

– Ah, I've really done it .

Ishii rolled and took the rock off the trunk .

It seemed like the lock of the trunk had broken from the rock's impact, and the trunk popped open .

Ishii turned his penlight towards the trunk in his surprise . Inside, there was a blue vinyl sheet covering something large .

'It can't be!'

Ishii frantically tried to rip the sheet away .

It was wrapped with vinyl tape, so it wasn't going the way Ishii wanted it to .

'What is this...'

Finally, Ishii was able to rip off part of the vinyl sheet .

Underneath it was Gotou's face . It was covered in black spots .

This was – blood . His face was ghastly pale .

'Detective Gotou! Please hang in there!'

Ishii slapped Gotou's cheeks as he called out frantically .

However, there was no reply .

– Was I too late? I can't accept that . Why?

The emotions Ishii had been holding back came up all at once .

Despondency and powerlessness made him lose his strength, and he fell to the concrete floor on his knees .

'Detective Gotou, I'm sorry . I...'

Interrupting Ishii's words, the lights in the garage turned on .

The brightness made everything turn white for a moment .

Ishii blinked a number of times and looked up to see Honda standing there .

He had a golf club in his hands . A nine iron . He wouldn't be able to do anything if he was hit with that .

Honda's narrowed eyes made his expression demonic, as if he were possessed by something .

Honda held the hand with the golf club above his head .

– My fate will be the same as Gotou's . That isn't too bad .

That thought came unbidden to Ishii's mind .

16

Haruka caressed Yakumo's cheek as she hugged him .

'I'm sorry . If I had come sooner...'

She couldn't say the rest because she was crying .

The cold and quiet made her sadness deeper –

What should I do now?

If I'd never met you – If I'd never known you – I wouldn't have experienced this sadness .

But I found out about you .

And through the time I spent with you, I found out – about your warmth .

I can't go back now –

What should I do? I can't carry this sadness with me .

Haruka couldn't stop the downward spiral of her feelings or her falling tears .

The howl of the wind sounded like crying .

People always understand how important something is after they've lost it .

How stupid –

'I... ha... '

Suddenly, Haruka felt like she heard Yakumo's voice .

Her ears hadn't been tricking her . It had been faint, but his voice had definitely reached Haruka's ears .

Yakumo's eyes were slightly open .

Haruka put her ears to his purple lips .

Haa, haa .

It was weak, but she could hear the sound of breathing .

'Yakumo-kun . You're alive . '

She was glad . She was so glad .

Haruka hugged Yakumo with all her strength as relief spread out from a corner in her heart .

'It... hurts...'

Yakumo let out a groan .

She had been so excited she put a bit too much strength into her hug .

Yakumo was alive, but he had definitely sustained serious injuries .

'Yakumo-kun . Are you OK?'

'I'm not... You can tell... by looking, can't you?'

After Yakumo said that in a faint voice, he started coughing .

He spoke like that even in a time like this . He really was an idiot .

'I thought you'd really died . '

'Don't just kill me off...'

Yakumo clenched his teeth as he spoke .

She didn't care what he said to her now . He was alive . That was enough .

Haruka gripped Yakumo's hand .

'Why are... you here?'

'Isn't it obvious? Because I'm meddlesome . '

Yakumo smiled slightly at Haruka's words .

Just from seeing that smile, the hardships Haruka had experienced until now all flew away .

Nothing could replace being able to see Yakumo alive again .

'Aagh . '

Yakumo groaned and bent over .

She couldn't linger now . If she didn't get Yakumo to a hospital right away, his life would be in danger .

However, it would be impossible for Haruka to carry Yakumo on her own .

She would get Keiko to come here and carry Yakumo with her . Haruka tried to contact her mother with her mobile, but it was no good . She was out of range .

Haruka would head back to the car and bring Keiko back here with her . It would take time, but it seemed like that was the only way .

'Yakumo-kun, wait . I'm going to get help . '

Haruka hugged Yakumo again and whispered that in his ear .

Just as she was about to leave, a cold wind suddenly blew into the room .

The door was open, and a man stood in it . A slender, tall man in a black suit with long hair that went down his back .

Even though he was on a mountain in the middle of the night, he was wearing sunglasses .

Though he was just standing there, he had an oppressive presence . It felt like the space around him was enveloped in a dark and malicious atmosphere .

He smiled, showing his white teeth, and started walking towards them slowly .

Terror –

That was the only word that could express Haruka's emotional state .

'Run . '

Yakumo's expression twisted as he said that .

Haruka didn't know who he was, but she couldn't stay here . She had to run . Haruka felt that instinctively .

Haruka tried to pick Yakumo up, but she couldn't do it well .

She lost her balance and the two of them fell to the floor .

Haruka tried to help Yakumo up, but Yakumo brushed Haruka's hand away .

Leave me here . He was probably saying that .

But Haruka couldn't do that . She had experienced the sadness that came from losing Yakumo .

No matter what happened, she wouldn't leave Yakumo .

Haruka became even more frantic in her attempts to help Yakumo up .

The man soon reached them .

'Your existence is not good for Yakumo . '

The man's low growl of a voice echoed .

– My existence is not good for Yakumo?

What did that mean? Haruka couldn't think of the reply to that question no matter how she tried .

The man took his sunglasses off slowly, as if putting himself on display .

His two eyes glowed red like a blazing flame .

This man is Yakumo's father –

The man smiled again .

17

The moment Honda started to bring the golf club down, something snapped in Ishii's head .

He didn't have the time to resign himself to his death so carelessly . This man had put Gotou in this state . Could he forgive that?

Even if they ended up stabbing each other, Ishii would definitely not forgive this man .

The club seemed to come down in slow motion .

Ishii bent down like a short-distance runner at the starting line and moved his head a bit to the left .

The impact missed the top of his head, but it grazed his ear and slammed into this right shoulder .

His bone might have broken, but he didn't feel any pain in his anger and agitation .

Ishii rushed right at Honda .

They fell to the concrete floor .

Before he'd noticed, Ishii was on top of Honda .

The tables are turned –

He would never forgive this guy . Ishii tried to raise his right fist, but he couldn't . He couldn't feel it .

– If my right arm isn't working, I'll use my left .

Ishii's left fist went down towards Honda's face .

Thump .

There was a dull sound .

Ishii's fist didn't hit Honda's face and slammed against the concrete floor instead . That put Ishii in pain instead . He bent back unconsciously .

In that one moment, when Ishii let his guard down, Honda thrust Ishii off of him . The back of Ishii's head hit the car's bumper .

Ishii's head was dizzy . He couldn't move, like he had received a concussion .

Honda stood up immediately and picked up the golf club .

'Don't get in my way . There's only one day left . Then I'll be free . '

As Honda said that, he started walking towards Ishii slowly .

His cheek was twitching and his shoulders heaved as he breathed . He's scared – that was what Ishii felt .

When Takeda showed up again, Honda must have been terrified that he'd be revealed as the true culprit .

Honda stood in front of Ishii and raised the golf club again .

– Can I not even get revenge for Gotou?

Ishii's eyes welled up with tears in his vexation .

That moment, someone came between Ishii and Honda .

He knocked away the golf club Honda was holding with his hand and then, with the same hand, punched Honda in the solar plexus .

It was all at lightning speed . It only took a moment .

Honda's body went stiff, as if time had stopped . Then, he threw up and fell forward, his face buried in his own vomit .

The intimidating back of a man stood in front of Ishii .

– Could this back be...

'Got this, Ishii? You're supposed to punch from your back . '

As he said that, Miyagawa turned around .

'Chief Miyagawa... Why?'

'Don't ask . '

Miyagawa turned around again at Ishii's words .

He sighed and shook his head .

'My bad . I wanted to save Gotou too . In the car, those were just the pathetic words of a guy in middle management . Forget what I said . '

'No . '

He wasn't pathetic at all . Rather, he was cool . Ishii gazed at Miyagawa's back in envy .

'How's Gotou?' asked Miyagawa .

That was right . Ishii came back to his senses and walked to the car .

Gotou was still in the trunk, wrapped up in the sheet .

'Detective Gotou... I'm sorry . If I had noticed earlier...'

The experiences Ishii had had with Gotou flashed through his head .

Feeling both regret and sadness, his snot and tears fell to the floor .

His heart was empty . His body shook .

– Even though I vowed to save you .

'Detective Gotou... I'm sorry . '

'Ishii . '

Miyagawa placed a hand on Ishii's shoulder .

'I...'

'Cry later . Let's get Gotou out of here right away . '

It was just as Miyagawa said .

They couldn't leave Gotou's corpse in this truck forever . Ishii sniffled and nodded .

'Let's go . One, two, three . '

At Miyagawa's call, they tried to pick Gotou up out of the trunk .

However, Ishii let go accidentally from the pain in his shoulder .

Thump .

Gotou's head hit the concrete floor loudly .

'That hurts! You fool!'

Gotou's eyes snapped open as he howled .

'Eh?'

'Let me out of here already!'

Gotou was flailing about as he shouted .

'You're alive...'

And energetic at that .

Ishii's eyes met Miyagawa's and they both laughed loudly .

'What the hell are you laughing at!? Are you the one who dropped me just now!?'

Gotou's shouts echoed through the garage .

18

All Haruka could do was hug Yakumo tightly .

– I'm going to be killed .

Not just her body . Her soul was going to be broken into pieces and she was going to die . She had no basis for that, but that was how Haruka felt .

There was enough malice in that man's red eyes to make her feel that way .

Even though they were the same colour, they were clearly different from Yakumo's eye .

She wanted to get out of here right now, but she couldn't leave Yakumo . Haruka shut away the terror bubbling up in her heart .

'If you weren't here, Yakumo would have gone down a different path . Why did you get in my way?'

The man crouched in front of Haruka and looked at her as he said that in his low, echoing voice .

Haruka couldn't respond, as she didn't even understand what his words meant .

The man took something out of his inner suit pocket .

A thin silver knife . Its tip glittered in the faint light .

The man slowly flicked it about in front of Haruka's eyes .

'The easiest method to make humans obey is pain . You understand, yes?'

The man quickly snapped his wrist .

The tip of the knife was on the verge of stabbing Haruka's eye . She couldn't even scream in her terror .

'Stop it!' yelled Yakumo, straining his voice .

Seeming satisfied by that, the man smiled with his white teeth showing .

The man doesn't want to hurt me but Yakumo . By tormenting me, he's making Yakumo suffer psychologically .

That was what Haruka felt .

'First, let's gouge out your eyes . Humans become doubly afraid when light is stolen away from them . '

The man was making Haruka imagine the act on purpose .

He was making her afraid by doing that .

Even though Haruka knew his plans, she imagined that knife plunging into her eyes .

The intense pain and the flowing blood – and the world enveloped by darkness .

She could feel strength in her body .

'Next would be the legs . I'll cut your Achilles tendon so you can't run away . I wonder how much you will be able to withstand?'

There was no strength in her lower body .

It's too late . I'm going to die –

Haruka was resigned to that .

But if I'm with Yakumo – I'm sorry . I came to save you, but it seems like it was no good . If I'm with you, I'll be OK wherever I am .

Haruka hugged Yakumo tightly .

She was together with Yakumo . Just from that, she no longer felt fear .

She shut her eyes and resigned herself to the end .

But – nothing happened .

There was an uncanny silence .

Haruka timidly opened her eyes .

The man was still in the room . She was glaring at Haruka .

– No .

The man wasn't looking at Haruka .

Haruka couldn't see it with her eyes, but she felt that somebody was standing in the man's way .

Somebody with a warm and strong will –

'Mother...' murmured Yakumo .

So that was how it was . Azusa's spirit was standing in front of them . That was why the man wasn't approaching .

– Is she protecting us?

The man's lips twisted into a smile, and he turned away silently .

Then, he walked away into the darkness .

– We're saved .

The moment she relaxed, she felt Yakumo's body suddenly grow heavy in her arms .

Yakumo had fainted .

'Yakumo-kun . Hey, Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka shook Yakumo but there was no response .

She put her ear to his mouth . His breathing was faint .

'Yakumo-kun . You can't do this . Wake up . '

She had to bring Yakumo to a hospital quickly . Haruka frantically tried to pick Yakumo up .

There was no strength in her arms . What should she do?

– Please! Someone . Someone . Help me!

Haruka felt like she had been left all alone .

'Haruka, where are you?'

She heard somebody's voice, carried by the wind .

It was Keiko's voice . A flame of hope lit in Haruka's chest .

'Come quickly! Yakumo-kun is! Yakumo-kun is!'

Haruka yelled as loudly as she could and tried once more to pick Yakumo up .

'Haruka!'

Keiko ran into the room .

'Mum...'

19

– Please wake up .

Who was that? He was sleeping so pleasantly . When Ishii opened his eyes, he saw a nurse standing there .

It was a slightly chubby middle-aged nurse .

It appeared that he'd fallen asleep in the hospital waiting room .

'It's troublesome for us if you fall asleep here,' said the nurse without hiding her displeasure .

'Er, is Detective Gotou all right?'

Ishii came to his senses and asked that, gripping the nurse's arms .

'W-why are you asking that all of a sudden? I don't know . '

The nurse backed away, perhaps feeling pressured by Ishii .

'Relax . Gotou's fine . '

Ishii turned around at the voice and saw Miyagawa walking towards him with his bowlegs .

– That's great . Really great . My job is over now .

Ishii sat on the waiting room sofa in his exhaustion .

'He's got some bruises and scrapes, but he's fit as a fiddle . The worst injury is the egg on his head you gave him when you dropped him . '

Miyagawa sat down next to Ishii while laughing .

'Ah, that's...'

Ishii scratched his head . He couldn't laugh at that joke .

'We found a stun gun in the shape of a pen in Honda's room . He probably got Gotou with that . Gotou thought it was a gun . '

'I see...'

Even Gotou would be helpless against a stun gun with thousands of volts .

'You're much worse off than he is . '

Ishii looked at his right shoulder .

Fortunately, it hadn't been broken, but there was a crack in the bone . He couldn't move it .

'How is Honda?' asked Ishii, looking at his wristwatch .

It was already eleven PM .

The culprit for the case fifteen years ago had changed . There wasn't enough time to put out an indictment .

Furthermore, it would be difficult to gather physical evidence, so if they didn't get a confession now, the statute of limitations would pass .

'At first he'd been reluctant . Seemed to want to wait for the statute of limitations to pass . '

So that really was the case . Then they couldn't charge Honda with the case that occurred fifteen years ago . Even though they'd saved Gotou, Ishii felt regretful . His shoulders slumped .

'Don't look so depressed . I said "at first", didn't I? He gave in . '

'Eh?'

Why would he suddenly confess?

'Article 225 . '

Miyagawa grinned, perhaps sensing Ishii's question .

'Criminal law article 255 – suspension of the statute of limitations .

If the perpetrator was out of the country or in hiding, it was possible to suspend the advancement of the statute of limitations for that period .

All culprits would hide, which would suggest that the statute of limitations could never pass on any case . People often thought that way, but in reality, it was necessary to prove that the culprit had been in hiding .

However, since the police hadn't arrested him, all they could do was rely on the testimony of the culprit as to whether or not they had been in hiding .

Nobody would honestly admit that they had run in a situation like that . That was why it was impossible to prove .

'You're smart, so think a bit . That guy was in America for a month for training . '

'I see!'

Ishii stood up unconsciously .

If the culprit was out of the country, the statute of limitations would be suspended . Which meant that there was a month until Honda's was over .

Was that why Honda gave in? Even if he could have lasted a day, a month would have been impossible .

'Fifteen years ago, Honda went to the Nanase household . Just as you said, it was nine PM...'

'As I thought . '

'He lost in case, but what Honda wanted wasn't money . He just wanted Katsuaki to apologise,' said Miyagawa quietly .

Even though Ishii didn't have children, he felt like he could understand how Honda felt .

The death of one's child wasn't something that could be cleaned up with money . He had probably wanted to say that .

'Honda hadn't been planning on killing them at first, but when Katsuaki saw Honda asking for an apology, he'd laughed . To hell with your dumb daughter . He said that and laughed...'

'That's awful . '

'Yeah, he was a shitty guy . His family was watching then and they'd laughed quietly too . Seems he can't remember anything after that . Then he was in a sea of blood...'

Miyagawa's hands were in fists .

It was like he was crushing the personal anger in his heart .

Ishii felt the same way as Miyagawa . Having your daughter's death laughed at was probably the limit for a parent .

'What he did is definitely unforgiveable . But Katsuaki can't be forgiven either . '

Miyagawa's brows furrowed .

Ishii knew the motive now, but there was still something he didn't understand .

'Chief Miyagawa, did Honda really not have the intention of killing them in the first place?'

Ishii voiced the question as it came to him .

'What do you mean?'

'But isn't it the case? The alibi trick this time used hypnotism . It would be impossible if it wasn't set up in advance . '

'Which means...'

'Honda planned the murder from the beginning...'

Miyagawa stood up just as Ishii said the last word of his sentence .

Ishii thought that Miyagawa would get angry and put himself on guard, but Miyagawa just hit Ishii's shoulder lightly .

It was his injured shoulder . Ishii cowered, pressing a hand against his shoulder .

'I see . There's reason behind your opinion . I'll look into it again . '

'Thank you very much . '

Ishii looked up at Miyagawa's face .

'Why are you thanking me? That's my line . I, er... underrated you a little . My bad . '

Miyagawa bowed his head slightly towards Ishii, put his hands in his pockets and walked towards the exit with a bowlegged gait .

So cool . Ishii almost cried in his excitement .

Miyagawa stopped before he passed through the automatic door .

'That's right . Gotou wanted to see you earlier . You should go there quick since he's making a fuss . '

'Y-yes sir!'

Ishii ran to Gotou's hospital room without watching Miyagawa leave .

'Please don't run in the hospital!'

Ishii heard the nurse's voice, but he ignored it .

20

The sun is bright –

When Haruka opened her eyes, a pure white wall spread out in front of her .

– Eh, where am I?

For a moment, Haruka was confused, but she soon came to her senses .

This was a hospital room . She had fallen asleep on her chair .

She rubbed at her eyes . Her fuzzy vision became clearer . She saw Yakumo sleeping in the bed in front of her .

– It wasn't a dream . I'm really glad .

According to his doctor, his left Achilles tendon had been severed, there were cuts and bruises all over his body, and he was severely weakened, but there was no threat to his life .

The doctor had made it sound like he had undergone terrible torture .

Haruka didn't want to think of the meaning of those words . In any case, Yakumo was alive . That was enough for now .

Wouldn't he wake up soon? She'd complain all she could as payback for everything up until now .

When Haruka stretched her arms, a blanket fell to the floor .

She hadn't noticed . Keiko must have put it on her . Haruka really had to express her gratitude, since Keiko had accompanied her to the very end .

Haruka picked up the blanket and walked to Yakumo's bed .

He was sleeping well . It was strange . His mouth was half-open . So this was the face Yakumo made when he was asleep .

A mischievous desire sprouted in Haruka's heart and she pinched his cheek .

'Hey . Trying to steal his lips when he's asleep? That's a disgrace to women everywhere . '

Keiko stood in the doorway to the hospital room and was covering her mouth as she laughed .

— This is the worst .

'That's not what I'm doing!' objected Haruka firmly .

'Getting worked up makes it even more suspicious . '

Keiko was grinning .

Why was Haruka surrounded by people like this?

'It's not suspicious at all . '

Keiko ignored Haruka's anger like it was nothing .

'Anyway, I told Dad about Yakumo-kun earlier . '

'Huh?'

What was her mother saying all of a sudden?

Haruka cocked her head .

'He got very angry and said, "Bring that boy here right now!" Dad might be coming now . '

'Why is Dad coming?'

'He said he'd crush Yakumo-kun . '

Keiko laughed again .

'Wait, Mum . What did you tell Dad?'

'That's a secret . '

Keiko poked Haruka's nose with her finger .

Haruka could imagine the gist of what Keiko had said . Keiko had always been a bit too playful . Kazuhiro had known her for so long already; Haruka wished that he'd stop getting pulled along by Keiko's pranks .

'You're so noisy . I was sleeping so well too . '

Those were Yakumo's first words after waking up .

Honestly . He was the same as always . Haruka met Keiko's eyes and smiled .

'Are you finally awake?' said Haruka disagreeably .

'You must be very narrow-minded if you won't even sympathise with somebody who's been injured . '

Yakumo spoke in his usual tone .

So he was going to be like this right after waking up? He would've been easier to deal with if he'd just stayed asleep .

'It's nice to meet you, Yakumo-kun . I'm Haruka's mother,' said Keiko, looking at Yakumo's face, which was still blank .

Even Yakumo appeared to be taken aback, and his expression stiffened .

'It must be difficult dealing with Haruka, since she's duller than most . '

After Keiko said that, she winked at Yakumo .

– What is she saying right in front of me?

'It's true . She doesn't listen to what people say and she trips all the time – it's hard work . '

Yakumo took advantage of the opportunity to complain more . Haruka didn't even feel like retorting any more .

'Right? My daughter will trip even when nothing is there . And she cries easily too . '

'That's true . It's baffling . '

Why were the two being so frank with each other all of a sudden? And it was all badmouthing Haruka . It was the worst . She shouldn't have saved him .

'Honestly, stop it already . It was hard work for me too . Yakumo-kun disappeared, and then Gotou-san went missing too...'

– Ah, I’m about to cry .

When Yakumo heard Haruka’s words, his expression turned grim .

He ran a hand through his messy bedhead and tried to sit up .

However, perhaps the pain had been too much, because he suddenly showed an anguished expression .

‘Wait, don’t move yet . Your wounds will open . ’

Haruka tried to stop him, but Yakumo refused .

‘I’m fine . More importantly, what happened with the case?’ said Yakumo, his expression still twisted . The case Yakumo was talking about was probably what Ishii had told her about last night .

‘The true culprit was arrested . Also, Gotou went missing, but it seems he’s been saved safely . The case is settled . ’

Haruka thought that Yakumo would relax at her words, but she was wrong .

‘Damn it,’ spat Yakumo, and then he forced his body up .

‘Wait, Yakumo-kun . I said you can’t move yet . ’

‘I have to go . ’

Yakumo tried to get off the bed .

‘Wait, Yakumo-kun . Go where? The case is already over . ’

Yakumo looked at Haruka with sharp eyes .

‘Nothing is over yet . ’

Nothing is over – what does he mean?

Haruka didn’t understand, so all she could do was stare, dumbfounded .

'Anyway, you just need to return to Tokyo, right?' said Keiko in a proud tone of voice as she spun a car key in her fingers .

'Mum . '

'I've come this far, so I'll accompany you to the end . '

Haruka thought her smiling mother looked reliable .

21

Gotou looked at the ceiling absentmindedly .

Can't believe I was saved by Ishii – I've fallen .

At some time, I became unable to move as freely as I did before . Not just my body, but my heart too –

No . Can't become weak at a time like this . Ishii was better than I ever thought he was . Let's leave it as that .

'Please excuse me . '

Ishii opened the door to the hospital room and came in .

'Hey . Sorry for the fuss . '

The moment Gotou raised his hand, Ishii started crying, pulled Gotou up and hugged him .

It's heavy, it hurts, and –

'That's gross . '

Gotou hit Ishii's head .

Maybe he'd hit somewhere bad, because Ishii collapsed to the floor .

Honestly, this guy . He really was just a fool . Being saved by a guy like this was the biggest blunder of his life .

'D-Detective Gotou... I'm so glad you're all right . '

Ishii stood up while pressing a hand against his head .

'Of course I am, you fool! Did you think I'd kick the bucket so easily?'

'No . I believed in you . '

Ishii straightened his spine and saluted .

Miyagawa had said that he'd been astonished by Ishii's growth, but Gotou didn't see it .

'But Detective Gotou, it is amazing how you realised the truth behind the case,' said Ishii, sitting on the chair for visitors .

Gotou had heard the outline of the case from Miyagawa .

It appeared to have become something unbelievable . There had been another culprit to the case they'd been following for fifteen years .

'I don't know what you're misunderstanding, but I didn't know the truth behind any case . '

'You are as humble as always . '

Ishii stuck out his lip in some form of pout .

'I don't know the things I don't know,' said Gotou firmly .

'Then why were you abducted by Honda?'

'I don't know!'

Gotou wanted to ask himself .

That day, at that house, he was shocked from behind . When he opened his eyes, his body had been bound and he'd been in the trunk of that care .

He'd been in that trunk the whole time after that .

When he opened his eyes, he'd writhe about to try to escape, but then Honda would come and shock him again with the stun gun . That just kept repeating .

Gotou himself didn't know why he had been abducted .

The mobile phone on the bedside table rang .

Yakumo's name was displayed .

'Yakumo, where are you, you bastard!? I had to go through a lot because of you!'

Gotou yelled the moment he answered the phone .

<Weren't you abducted? Didn't that allow you to go on a bit of a diet?>

Yakumo said that disinterestedly .

'You making fun of me!?'>

<Well done; you realised . >

'What did you say!?'>

<In the first place, Gotou-san, you were abducted because you were clumsy . It isn't my fault . >

This guy . Did he call just to make fun of him!?'>

'It ended up like this because you wouldn't help out!'

<Are you putting the blame on me? How childish . >

Gotou was grinding his teeth in his anger .

This guy really just got on his nerves . He didn't want to talk to him anymore .

'You can just go die!'

Gotou tried to hang up .

<Gotou-san, I have a request . >

Yakumo suddenly spoke in a formal tone .

That contrary guy has a request –

22

The car ran down the highway .

Since it was lunch on a weekday, there weren't many other cars . They could probably arrive in three hours if the situation continued like this .

Keiko didn't ask anything and was focussing on driving, but Haruka couldn't help but be interested .

She hadn't been able to confirm what they were talking about, but Yakumo had spoken on the phone with Gotou for a rather long time .

What on earth was Yakumo planning?

'Hey, what are you trying to do?'

Haruka looked at the backseat and asked that question .

Yakumo was still in a hospital gown and had his crutch under his arm as he stared out the window .

'Returning the favour,' said Yakumo expressionlessly .

'Favour?'

'I was played like a puppet this time . Just being deceived would irritate me . '

Yakumo turned his narrowed eyes to Haruka .

Was his red eye filled with anger or sadness? Haruka couldn't tell, but she felt her chest tighten .

– Nothing is over yet .

The words Yakumo said earlier passed through her head .

Just as he said, there was still a mystery in this case .

Why did Yakumo go through that? Who had done it? And just as Isshin had said, she didn't understand the connection to what happened to Gotou .

Isshin-san –

'Aaahh! Oh no!'

Haruka realised that she had forgotten something unbelievable and almost jumped up as she shouted .

'You're so noisy,' said Yakumo and Keiko at the same time .

'What are you so worked up about?' said Yakumo, looking displeased as he ran a hand through his bird's nest of a head .

It wasn't an excuse, but so many things had happened that she'd completely forgotten .

'I didn't contact Isshin-san to say that Yakumo-kun was OK . '

'Isshin-san is Yakumo-kun's uncle, right?'

Haruka nodded at Keiko's question .

'What are you doing? Hurry up and contact him . '

Urged by Keiko, Haruka hurriedly took out her mobile phone .

'Honestly, you're as clumsy as usual . '

Haruka almost said 'Sorry' in response to Yakumo .

Wait a second? What was Yakumo sounding so high and mighty for?

Isshin had been so worried about him . Now that she thought about it, Yakumo was the one who should call .

'Yakumo-kun, call him yourself . '

'I don't want to . You're the one he asked . '

'What sort of tone is that?'

'And, because of certain circumstances, I can't use my mobile,' said Yakumo matter-of-factly .

Can't use your mobile? You were talking with Gotou just earlier –

'Right . Haruka, hurry up and call . '

Keiko spoke before Haruka could object .

Honestly, she hated these two!

23

Gotou switched into a suit and sat on the bench in front of the reception at the precinct as he smoked a cigarette .

His injuries weren't that serious .

His back hurt because he'd been stuck in a small space, but he didn't need to be hospitalised . Gotou ignored the doctor who had frantically tried to

stop him and escaped from the hospital .

He checked his wristwatch .

Yakumo had contacted him to say he'd gotten off the interchange fifteen minutes ago, so he would probably arrive soon .

– But what is that Yakumo thinking?

Gotou couldn't see Yakumo's true intentions . He was made to explain what he knew in detail, but it hadn't seemed like enough so he gave the phone to Ishii partway through and they'd talked for a considerable length of time .

– Isn't the case over already?

As usual, Yakumo just gave out instructions without explaining the crucial bits .

'Damn, that guy is useless . '

Gotou ended up saying that aloud unconsciously in his irritation .

'Who are you saying is useless?'

Yakumo was standing right in front of him .

He was still in a hospital gown and there was no contact lens in his left eye either .

Not just that – there was scratches all over his face and he had a crutch . It looked like he wouldn't have been able to stand if Haruka hadn't been beside him for support .

He was wounded all over .

'I'm obviously talking about you . '

Gotou threw his cigarette into the ashtray on the side of the bench and stood up .

'Please do that sort of thing after looking at the reflection in the mirror . '

Gotou thought Yakumo would be a bit quieter, but he was mouthy even in this state .

'Shut up – you're injured!'

'You are as well, aren't you?'

'You're much worse off . '

It was so strange Gotou ended up smiling .

'Still, Gotou-san, you look fairly unharmed for somebody who was abducted . Were you just skiving?'

'What'd you say!?!'

Gotou gripped Yakumo by the collar .

– Making being tortured sound like work .

However, Yakumo was disinterested in Gotou's anger .

'By the way, how is the favour I asked of you?'

'Ishii's on it right now . '

Gotou felt stupid for getting angry and let go of Yakumo .

'That's good . Even you can do it if you try, Gotou-san . '

When Haruka heard Yakumo's words, she let out a laugh .

'You just keep saying whatever the hell you want!'

'Now, let's go then . '

With Haruka's support, Yakumo used his crutch to walk towards the elevator .

'That guy really gets on my nerves,' grumbled Gotou, and he followed Yakumo into the elevator .

'Gotou-san, I'm relieved to see you so energetic,' said Haruka with a smile .

'Thanks to you guys . Anyway, I heard that you were the one who saved Yakumo, Haruka-chan . '

'I was . Even though I went out of my way to save him, he started acting the same way he usually does the moment he woke up . '

'What an ungrateful bastard . '

Gotou snorted .

'He is . I kind of regret saving him,' replied Haruka, her cheeks puffed out .

However, no matter what gripes she gave, Gotou could tell from looking at her expression . The happiness she felt from being able to hear Yakumo's sarcastic remarks was written all over her face .

Haruka's tenacity had made it possible to find Yakumo and save him .

The value Haruka had in Gotou's head had grown a lot higher .

– Yakumo won't be able to get away any more .

Gotou unconsciously smirked when he imagined the two of them married . Yakumo might unexpectedly end up under Haruka's thumb .

'That's disturbing; please don't smile . '

Yakumo glanced at him .

'Shut up,' muttered Gotou, wiping the smile off his face .

They arrived at the seventh floor and the elevator doors opened .

When they went out into the corridor, Miyagawa was waiting there .

'You're going to explain properly, right?'

Miyagawa approached Gotou with his bowlegged gait .

However, Gotou had just received the request from Yakumo – he didn't know the details . He glanced at Yakumo to escape Miyagawa's question .

'You must be Miyagawa-san . It's been a while . '

Yakumo hopped out to stand in front of Miyagawa and bow .

Miyagawa looked bewildered .

The last time they had met, Yakumo had still been in middle school . He had grown much taller since then, and his features had changed . It made sense that Miyagawa didn't recognise him .

'This guy's the brat who can see ghosts . '

'Ah, from that case . You're much bigger now . '

Miyagawa raised his hand, perhaps to give Yakumo a pat on the shoulder at the long-awaited reunion . However, he changed his mind when he saw how his injuries were and ended up letting his hand dangle in mid-air .

'Could I ask you one thing?'

Yakumo's eyes narrowed as he looked at Miyagawa .

'What is it?' replied Miyagawa, sounding confused .

'Is it true that the eyes of the man you saw at the crime scene fifteen years ago were red?'

Miyagawa turned a sharp gaze to Gotou, as if to complain about his loose mouth .

Gotou felt awkward and pretended to fix his shoelaces .

'Just as you say . But what's that got to do with anything?' responded Miyagawa, sounding reluctant .

'If possible, I would like to talk about the situation with the suspect, Honda-san,' said Yakumo .

Miyagawa looked like he couldn't decide what to do and looked at Gotou for help .

'Please believe in him,' said Gotou, his voice full of confidence .

Yakumo was an annoying guy, but when he tried to do something like this, he was never wrong .

This was how he'd solved the cases up until now .

Miyagawa crossed his arms . His face was wrinkled in thought .

In the past, he would have given his OK immediately, but his decision was delayed by the responsibility he had in his position of middle management .

'Got it . '

Miyagawa's expression changed – it appeared he was prepared .

'Thank you very much . '

Yakumo bowed his head honestly .

'But this is completely off-record . It won't be a walk in the park if people find out we let a civilian interrogate a suspect . '

'I will forget that we met here . '

Yakumo smiled .

'And I want as little people inside as possible . '

Miyagawa looked at Haruka .

That made sense . Yakumo understood what Miyagawa meant immediately, gave his crutch to Haruka and hopped on one foot towards the interrogation room .

Yakumo lost his balance .

Gotou instinctively supported Yakumo from behind . Crap . He'd inadvertently saved him . He should have just let him fall .

Even though Gotou didn't say that aloud, Yakumo turned around and glared .

24

The sun set in the valley of buildings, bathing it in its faint orange light .

In the driver's seat, Ishii's eyes narrowed as he lay down on the wheel .

He had stopped his car on the road in front of the newspaper agency and had started his stakeout . It had already been three hours .

– Why do I have to hold a stakeout?

Ishii didn't understand .

Since Yakumo had asked, there must have been some reasoning behind it, but Ishii just didn't understand his instructions .

At the hospital, Gotou and Yakumo had talked on the phone for a rather long while .

Because Yakumo wanted to hear the details of the case, Ishii took the phone partway through to explain .

Yakumo's questions were very detailed – it had felt like Ishii was undergoing an interrogation .

– The case isn't over yet .

Yakumo had said that at the very end of the conversation . Did he mean exactly what he said –

The case was dotted with questions .

But why would he need to stake out Makoto? Ishii just didn't understand .

Was Yakumo saying Makoto had a part in this?

'There's no way . '

Ishii said that aloud to erase his doubts .

Makoto had supported Ishii when he had been about to collapse . She had cooperated with him – she couldn't be the opposite .

Ishii believed that . But there was something that he was concerned about .

The other instruction Yakumo gave –

The investigation of the video company that made the video this time . It was simple . He only had to make one call .

It seemed to be a small company, since when Ishii called, the company president answered .

There were three things he had to check . Was a video taken at that house? If they had gone there, when did they go?

And then, the last question regarded the purpose of the video –

Ishii just couldn't ignore what the president's response .

His head was jumbled . It was really irritating . He wanted to take his mind off it, but he couldn't . He felt like he sort of understood the feelings of a smoker .

'Ah!'

When Ishii looked up, he saw the person he was looking for and unconsciously called out .

Makoto came out of the automatic door at the front .

Finally . When Ishii thought that, his heart started beating quickly .

Ishii followed Makoto with his eyes and started the engine .

Makoto went fifty metres forward into the fenced parking lot .

After a while, a red family car came out of the parking lot .

Ishii confirmed that Makoto was the one driving and started his own car .

He sped up to close the distance and then matched their speeds, following her from ten metres behind .

The success rate of tailing depended greatly on whether the person being tailed was on guard .

Makoto had probably never even imagined that she would be under surveillance .

Even at this distance, there was no need to worry about being noticed unless something extreme occurred .

– I want her to be unrelated .

Ishii wished for that in his heart as he continued following her .

After Gotou went into the interrogation room, he sat across from Honda .

Yakumo was in the seat beside him . Miyagawa stood in front of the door .

Normally, a clerk would be present for the interrogation, sitting by the wall to note down the testimony, but there wasn't one now . This was going to be a completely unofficial interrogation .

However, it was great that they'd gotten so far, but how were they going to explain Yakumo to Honda? Gotou couldn't think of a good way .

It would be all right with just the two detectives, but anybody would be confused if he saw a young man covered in wounds in a hospital gown sitting in front of them .

'Honda-san, the suddenness of this may surprise you, but this is not an interrogation, and I am not a detective,' said Yakumo, scratching his head .

– Oi, oi, why are you telling the truth all of the sudden?

If Yakumo said that, Honda could refuse to cooperate . However, Yakumo continued speaking, ignoring Gotou's concern .

'However, what I am about to say is not unbeneficial to you . Would you cooperate with me for your own sake?'

Honda made no reply . He looked like a child who was sulking after the teacher had yelled at him .

It appeared he was still confused .

However, there was no point chitchatting after coming this far .

'Yakumo . Explain already . '

Gotou stuck out his chin .

Yakumo scratched the back of his neck and sighed .

'You abducted this blockhead of a detective, yes? Why did you do that?'

Yakumo pointed at Gotou .

'Oi . Am I the blockhead?'

'Is there anyone else here?'

'What did you say?'

'Could you please be quiet?'

Yakumo glanced at Gotou .

That was some nerve when he was the one who'd be picking a fight . Gotou snorted and crossed his arms .

'If what I am about to say is incorrect, please say so . '

Yakumo turned towards Honda again . Honda said nothing, just furrowing his brows grimly .

'You knew that a detective was reinvestigating the case that occurred fifteen years ago . That was this blockhead of a detective . Then, you suddenly thought that that detective was coming close to discovering the truth, so you decided to keep him captive until the statute of limitations passed . Is that correct?'

Yakumo continued to talk disinterestedly .

'Honda testified to that . '

Miyagawa replied for Honda, who remained silent .

Yakumo glanced at Miyagawa and nodded before looking to Honda again .

'Then I have one more question . Why did you think this blockhead of a detective was coming close to discovering the truth?'

– You don't need to keep calling me a blockhead .

Gotou buried his dissatisfaction in the pit of his stomach and watched Honda .

There was a wrinkle between Honda's brows . Rather than not wanting to answer, it felt more like he didn't know how to .

A slight smile appeared on Yakumo's lips . It looked like the smile of the devil to Gotou .

'You won't answer this question . That isn't because you don't want to but because you don't have the answer . Isn't that right?'

Yakumo's eyes narrowed as he said that triumphantly .

Honda's expression changed . His mouth was agape and he was shaking .

Finally, he held his head in both hands . It looked like he was trying his best to remember something, but he couldn't remember it . That irritation came through .

'Yakumo . Explain . '

Gotou didn't think Honda would talk, so asked Yakumo .

'You don't understand?'

'I'm asking because I don't . '

'Honda-san was made to think that you, a detective he had never met before, might know the truth . '

— I don't understand at all .

Unlike Gotou, who didn't get what Yakumo was saying, Honda seemed to realise something and looked up .

His gaze was wavering .

'Put it more simply . '

'I will explain properly afterwards . Anyway, let us put that aside for now . '

Yakumo changed the topic on his own .

'Is this really OK?' interrupted Miyagawa .

Since Miyagawa didn't know how Yakumo usually talked, that had probably been a nonsensical exchange to him .

However, that was just how Yakumo talked . Afterwards, they would understand what he had meant .

'It's all right . I only have one more question . '

Yakumo showed Miyagawa a composed smile .

Miyagawa's cheek twitched, as if he was angry .

'Gotou, this brat...'

'Well, please just watch . '

Gotou interrupted Miyagawa and urged Yakumo to continue .

– I'm really counting on you .

Gotou murmured that in his heart .

'This is my last question . What did you do with Miyuki-san, Nanase Katsuaki's daughter?'

'I took her back and killed her... I think . '

That was unexpected . Honda responded to Yakumo's question .

But why'd he say something as vague as 'I think'? Honda had confessed that he'd done everything .

'Why did you kill her after taking her back?'

'I didn't plan on killing the daughter . The child didn't do anything wrong . '

Honda looked down, pressing a hand against his temple .

'The child didn't do anything wrong . You thought that, but you still killed her . Why is that?'

'She was noisy when I took her back... . so I killed her . '

Honda gritted his teeth . It looked like he was withstanding pain .

His breathing was ragged, and there were tears in his eyes .

'How did you kill her? Where did you do it? And when was it? What did you do with the corpse?'

Yakumo used this chance to attack and asked all his questions at once .

'Uuugh... . '

Honda moaned and hugged his head before lying on the table .

Yakumo looked at him with a serious gaze . He looked just like a scientist waiting for a chemical reaction .

Finally, the reaction he was waiting for occurred .

When Honda looked up, his expression was like that of a different person .

'It's not true . I didn't do it . I don't know where the daughter is . '

Honda leant forward and clung to Yakumo's body . Gotou hurriedly tried to separate them, but Yakumo himself got the better of him .

'Honda-san, I understand . You didn't kill anybody . '

Perhaps Yakumo's words had calmed him, because tears started rolling down Honda's cheeks .

– What the hell is happening?

Gotou didn't understand . Yakumo had said this to Honda: 'You didn't kill anybody . ' Was that true?

Gotou was just about to ask when his mobile phone rang .

26

The surroundings were completely dark –

Ishii continued to tail Makoto .

Makoto's car passed the shopping street in front of the train station and started climbing the slope of a residential street .

There was only one road here, which few cars frequented . It was very possible that he would be noticed . Ishii slowed down and distanced himself further .

It made it easier to lose Makoto, but after coming this far, Ishii could guess where Makoto was going .

The top of this slope was the house where the murders occurred .

Ishii put his mobile phone on speaker and called Gotou .

<What?>

Gotou's voice was clearly displeased .

'This is Ishii . Makoto-san appears to be heading for that house . '

<The house where the murders occurred?>

'Yes . '

When Ishii replied, he heard something being said quietly . Gotou had probably met up with Yakumo and was now consulting him .

<Ishii-san, it's Yakumo . >

Just as he thought, after there was the sound of something being moved, Yakumo's voice came through .

<Is she alone?>

'Yes, she is . '

What role did Makoto play in this case – Ishii was struck with the impulse to ask, but Yakumo didn't give him the chance .

<How is the other investigation I requested?>

'It seems that the video really was filmed there . '

<The contents of the film?>

Yakumo immediately asked his next question .

'Yes . It wasn't a show following spiritual phenomena but a candid-camera show to trick dishonest exorcists . '

<So that really was the case . >

Yakumo's voice sounded constricted . Ishii understood how he felt .

If that was taken for candid camera, that would mean the reporter's actions were an act .

The person who brought that video in was Makoto .

<I understand . I will call you again afterwards . >

After Yakumo said that, he hung up .

When Yakumo looked up, he saw that house on the other side of the front window .

It might have been because of what happened, but the air around the house felt stagnant .

Ishii was about to up the speed when his mobile phone rang .

Yakumo's number was displayed .

Did he forget to ask something?

'Ishii speaking . '

He answered the phone .

<Ishii-san, where are you right now?>

'I'm near the house...'

I just explained that – Ishii was thinking that as he responded .

<I see . We really were tricked by Makoto-san . >

Yakumo had been ambiguous before, but now he was implying that Makoto was related .

'Is that so? I can't believe it . '

<That is the truth, even if you don't believe it . >

'No, but...'

<Anyway, we're heading for that house now too . >

Yakumo interrupted Ishii's objection .

'Ah, yes . '

<Ishii-san, please refrain from doing anything forward . >

Yakumo's words were unusually strong .

'Yes . '

<Do you understand? No matter what happens, please do not do anything – wait until we arrive . >

Yakumo gave that reminder to Ishii again before hanging up .

Ishii couldn't shake away the unnaturalness of the conversation with Yakumo . Perhaps Yakumo was mistaken about the case .

While he was thinking, Makoto's hazard lights went on and the car stopped on the road in front of the house .

Ishii parked his car too at a distance from hers .

Makoto got off the car .

Yakumo had told him not to do anything until he arrived . Ishii knew that was the better decision to make . But –

– I want to check with my own eyes .

Led by a feeling close to curiosity, Ishii got off his car .

27

'Shall we go then?'

Yakumo put his mobile phone in his pocket and got up with the help of the table .

Gotou didn't understand why Yakumo had called Ishii back with his own mobile .

That wasn't all Gotou didn't understand .

'Go where?'

'What a dull-witted person you are . It's obvious that we are going to where Makoto-san is,' said Yakumo, running a hand through his hair like he thought Gotou troublesome . Then, he left the investigation room .

– Oi, oi . Wait a sec .

Gotou hurriedly followed Yakumo into the corridor .

He saw Yakumo hopping down the corridor on one foot .

'What are you going to do with Honda?'

'I have no more questions for Honda-san . '

Yakumo didn't stop . In the end, Gotou had to run after him .

'No more questions? What do you mean?'

'I mean exactly what I said,' said Yakumo, pressing the elevator button .

'You never explain enough!'

Yakumo raised an eyebrow .

– You annoyed? I'm one hundred times angrier at you!

'You heard as well, did you not, Gotou-san? Honda-san is not the true perpetrator of the case fifteen years ago . '

'I'm asking why!'

The elevator arrived and the door opened .

'Oi, Gotou! What was that? Explain!'

Miyagawa burst out into the corridor, screaming . He looked like a demon .

It made sense . Gotou had asked him to help and suddenly run off without an explanation .

Yakumo didn't pay any heed to the fuss and hopped into the elevator .

'Say something!'

Miyagawa let out another howl .

'I'll explain later! Later!'

Gotou shouted and escaped into the elevator . Yakumo smiled like he was enjoying this and pressed the 'Close' button .

What was so funny? This brat . Gotou was going to get yelled at again .

They got off the elevator and met with Haruka, who was sitting on the bench at the reception .

The three of them headed for the back exit and got in the unmarked car that was parked in the parking lot .

Gotou sat in the driver's seat, Yakumo in the passenger's and Haruka in the back – their usual positions .

'I won't drive until you explain properly,' said Gotou, glaring at Yakumo .

'Is it all right to say something so laidback?'

Yakumo smirked and looked at the rear-view mirror .

Led by Yakumo's gaze, Gotou looked as well . Miyagawa was running at them at full speed . Just like a zombie –

Gotou pretended not to hear Miyagawa's yells and quickly started the car .

This had become an unimaginable disaster because of Yakumo .

'Stop acting so high and mighty and explain already . '

Gotou spoke up when he couldn't see Miyagawa anymore .

'You really don't understand . '

'What?'

'I said this earlier, didn't I? Honda-san didn't kill anybody . '

'How can you say that? Ishii investigated and made sure that Honda was the perp . Honda confessed his own crime too . Wasn't that the end of it?'

Gotou's tone was wild in his irritation .

'Gotou-san, do you really think that?'

'I'm saying that because I do!'

Yakumo sighed mockingly .

'Honda-san was just made to think that he did it himself . '

Oi, oi . He wasn't Ishii . Did Yakumo watch too many sci-fi films?

'You saying somebody played with Honda's brain and put in some new memories?'

'That isn't possible . '

'You're the one who said it!'

Gotou was so agitated that he hit the handle .

Yakumo looked at Gotou coldly .

'Please listen properly to what people say . I said he was made to think that way . '

– Isn't that the same thing?

As if he had heard what Gotou asked in his heart, Yakumo shook his head .

'In Honda-san's testimony, he headed to the scene on the day of the incident and got into an argument with Katsuaki . '

'Right . '

'Then, before he noticed, the four of them were dead . Don't you understand that this is unnatural?'

'I don't,' spat out Gotou .

Nothing was strange . What was the problem?

'That's incredibly unnatural . '

The one who spoke was Haruka, in the backseat .

'Haruka-chan, what's unnatural about it?'

Even if Gotou asked Yakumo, he probably wouldn't answer, so he directed the conversation to Haruka .

Haruka looked a bit surprised at having the conversation turned to her so suddenly, but she started speaking, like there was no way she could avoid it .

'I don't know the details, so I can't say much, but that person killed four people, yes?'

'Right . '

'Isn't that a bit too many if he was just in a rage?'

Now that she said that, Gotou thought the same way .

It would take a lot of work and time to kill four people . It would be difficult to do that unconsciously .

'Almost completely correct . That's well done for you,' said Yakumo with a yawn .

'I feel like I'm being made fun of . '

Haruka puffed out her cheeks .

'Well, to add a bit more, there were four people at the scene . If he had been killing in a rage, why didn't anybody stop him?'

There was that too . But the same thing could be said even if the culprit wasn't Honda .

'That doesn't prove Honda didn't do it . '

'Then let's return to the main topic . '

After Yakumo declared that, he started his explanation again .

'First, Honda-san went to the scene that day and argued with Katsuaki-san . That is true . After that, Honda-san was led into a hypnotic state by somebody . '

It had come up in their last case, so Gotou knew about hypnotic suggestion too .

Yakumo couldn't be saying that Honda killed them because he was hypnotised into doing it, could he?

People often thought that hypnotism made people fall asleep, but it wasn't true . They were conscious .

That was why it was impossible to play people like puppets even if they were hypnotised .

Furthermore, it was impossible to make people do things against their moral code no matter what suggestions were given to them .

'Honda-san, in his deep hypnotic state, was led to the corpses and told that he was the one who did it . '

Gotou understood . Honda was shown the corpses in his hypnotised state and made to think he did it then .

That could be possible .

'Gotou-san was abducted in the same manner . Honda-san was put into a hypnotic state and told that there was a detective who realised the truth of the case fifteen years ago . '

Gotou remembered the exchange that occurred in the interrogation room earlier .

– One day, you suddenly thought that there was a detective who was coming close to discovering the truth .

When Yakumo said that, Honda started behaving strangely . Honda was led into doubting himself by Yakumo .

Gotou understood the flow of the conversation . But –

'How can you be certain of that?'

Yakumo's put his left index finger to his brow .

'First, I was talking from a theory . However, the testimony about Katsuaki-san's daughter was decisive . '

'His daughter?'

Honda's testimony had changed completely then .

'Correct . Even if hypnotised, people's memories cannot be fabricated . Honda-san saw the corpses himself at that house . That is why he ended up believing he did it when he was told that under hypnotic suggestion . However...'

Yakumo's words faded out and he looked at Gotou with narrowed eyes .

'You saying he didn't see the daughter's corpse?'

'Correct . '

So that was how it was . Honda had started doubting his own memories from what Yakumo said at first, and then, when asked about the daughter, the story had crumbled .

Making him think he killed her without seeing the corpse was the same as making a new memory, so it had been impossible .

The theory that Honda had been hypnotised by someone and made to think he'd done the act was coherent .

But that meant –

'Then who the hell killed those four people? Was it really Takeda? And where'd the daughter Miyuki go?'

'Takeda-san is not the perpetrator . '

Yakumo declared that while looking straight ahead .

'Who is then?'

'Well, please calm down . '

Yakumo yawned . He wasn't nervous at all .

'How could I calm down!? I've got other questions too! Who did something so troublesome, and why!? And why was I abducted!?'

Gotou said that all at once, overwhelmed by his emotions .

More questions came up . His head felt like it would burst from confusion .

'We are going to solve that mystery now . '

When Yakumo said that, Gotou couldn't say anything anymore .

While that had been happening, they had arrived at the house .

There were two cars parked by the road . Both were empty .

'That fool...'

Gotou clicked his tongue .

Even though Yakumo had told Ishii to wait, it appeared that Ishii had followed Makoto .

'Gotou-san, please drive the car up to the premises . '

'Why?'

Gotou tried asking .

'Obviously, it's because I have an idea,' Yakumo replied curtly .

– Of course .

28

Ishii was stooped over and taking care to walk quietly as he followed Makoto at a distance .

My forehead's all sweaty –

If Makoto turned around, everything would be over . There was nowhere to hide .

He'd thought about hiding himself in the trees by the road, but, though it might have been possible in the summer, in this season, the leaves on the floor would rustle when he stepped on them and he would be found out .

He silenced his breath and just prayed that she wouldn't turn around .

Makoto passed through the metal gates and went onto the premises . Ishii counted to three in his heart and then ran up to the wall all at once, plastering his back to it . He felt like a ninja .

After his breathing had regulated, he leant out and peered to the back of the premises .

Makoto stood in front of the entrance . She turned around, checking her surroundings .

Ishii immediately hid himself . It felt like his heart was being crushed .

When Ishii peered out again, Makoto opened the entrance door and went inside .

– Now what are you going to do, Ishii Yuutarou?

Yakumo had told him to wait . Ishii thought that was a good plan too, and he also wanted to wait outside because he was afraid . But –

It was because of his weak will that the worst had happened last time .

– I'll check what happened with my own eyes .

With strong determination, Ishii jogged up to the entrance door, still stooped over .

His adrenaline was at a high, leaving him agitated .

Ishii tried to look inside through the keyhole, but it was too dark to see anything .

There were no entrances to this house beside the front entrance . It was very possible that he'd be found if he went inside .

'What to do?'

Ishii asked himself that question .

Why didn't he want to be found anyway? He could just ask the person herself without dancing around like this .

'Aaah!'

A scream from inside the house interrupted Ishii's thoughts .

The sparrows in the trees flew away all at once .

– Did something happen to Makoto?

Ishii opened the door before thinking .

A dark corridor continued in front of him . It was just like the path to Hades . He couldn't go down it . He felt that way .

He remembered the spiritual phenomena he had experienced in the past, and a shiver went down his spine .

– Calm down . I have to go ahead .

The scream just now was definitely Makoto's . If he stayed here, he would feel the same regret that he had felt before .

Ishii took the penlight out of his pocket and lit up the corridor .

At the end of the straight corridor, there was the door to the living room .

And that door was open –

Ishii slowly started walking .

That moment, he stepped on something and almost fell . He pointed his light down and saw a can .

There was the distinct smell of gasoline .

– Why here?

With that question in his head, Ishii headed down the corridor and stood at the entrance to the room .

He lit it up with his light .

'That's...'

He saw somebody lying face down in the centre of the room .

It was Makoto –

'Makoto-san!'

Ishii rushed towards Makoto .

'Are you all right? Please hang in there . '

As Ishii called out to Makoto, he shook her body, but there was no response .

He tried putting his mouth to her ear . She was breathing . It appeared that she had just fainted .

'Please wait . I'll call for help now,' said Ishii . He stood up and turned around .

'Wah!'

Somebody was standing in front of him . A woman –

– Who is that? How long has she been there?

The woman held out a knife in front of Ishii's confused eyes .

He was so surprised he dropped his light to the floor .

Ishii's body stiffened, and he gulped . A cold sweat ran down his body .

– I really should have listened to Yakumo .

Ishii was hit with a strong wave of regret .

'Who are you?'

Ishii asked that in a hoarse voice, but the woman just smiled silently .

Then, his eyes adjusted to the darkness, and the woman's face appeared in front of him, though obscure .

'You are...'

Interrupting the words Ishii was about to say, the woman went around Ishii, covered his mouth and put the knife against his neck .

If he moved even a little, his carotid artery would be cut and a lot of blood would floor .

– It's too late . I'm going to die .

Ishii resigned himself to his death .

The next moment, a glaring light hit his face . Ishii's eyes narrowed from the brightness .

The light came from a torch . Somebody was there .

It was Yakumo and Gotou .

'That was fairly quick . Were you waiting?' said the woman .

'Would you let go of Ishii-san?' said Yakumo calmly, as he entered the room with his crutch .

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– What the hell is this?

Gotou couldn't hide his surprise at the scene in front of him .

The moment he entered the living room with Yakumo, he saw Makoto on the floor and Ishii with a knife to his neck, held by the woman behind him .

However, Gotou remembered seeing the woman holding the knife somewhere .

'Yakumo . What's going on? That's the woman reporter,' muttered Gotou in Yakumo's ear .

'Correct . She's the woman who was in the video . '

'What's she doing here?'

'Let me explain in order . First, her name is Nanase Miyuki-san . '

Yakumo pointed at the woman with his crutch .

'That's ridiculous!'

Gotou's eyes went wide .

Nanase Miyuki was the girl who'd disappeared fifteen years ago during that case . What was she doing here?

'Oh no . So you really did find out . '

The woman sneered at Gotou and stuck out her tongue like a child whose prank had been revealed .

– Is this really Nanase Miyuki?

'Explain . '

Gotou muttered in Yakumo's ear again .

Yakumo looked clearly displeased and waved his hand as if swatting a fly .

'Please don't put your face so close to mine; it's disturbing . You don't have to say everything quietly . '

'What did you say?'

'I'll say it again . Please let go of Ishii-san . You can no longer escape . '

Yakumo continued talking, ignoring Gotou's objections .

Miyuki looked down, as if contemplating, but then she suddenly let go of Ishii and thrust him forward .

Ishii fell face-forward onto the floor but got up immediately and hurried to Makoto .

– She's letting her hostage get away?

Gotou glared at Miyuki in his suspicion .

Miyuki didn't appear to care . She put her hands on her waist and smiled .
What a ghastly woman .

'Ishii-san, she's fine . She probably just lost consciousness from being shocked with a stun gun . '

After Yakumo said that, Ishii let out a sigh in his relief .

'Now, let's explain the situation, to respond to Gotou-san's request . '

Yakumo cleared his throat . He sounded like a teacher who was about to start class .

'First . The true culprit of the murder case fifteen years ago is the person in front of you right now: Nanase Miyuki-san . '

Yakumo's words were so sudden that Gotou couldn't understand them for a while . Ishii seemed to be the same – he just gaped at Yakumo .

'T-t-that's ridiculous! Nanase Miyuki is Katsuaki's daughter! She was just ten then! For her to have killed the four people in her family, that's...'

'Possible . '

Miyuki was the one who spoke .

With the gait of a model, she approached Gotou .

'But I didn't kill four people – I killed three . '

Miyuki flicked Gotou's nose with her fingers . Gotou was frozen by this completely unexpected childish action .

'Why did you kill them...'

That was all he could say .

'You want to know why I killed them?'

'Yeah... Why?'

Miyuki nodded, seeming satisfied .

'That family was broken . You understand?'

'I don't . '

'I was really Nanase Kanji's kid . Grandpa's kid . My mum Fuyumi was Grandpa's lover . '

Miyuki said that proudly as she slowly walked around Gotou .

'You...'

'Grandpa and Dad both knew . But they pretended they didn't . '

That really was broken . The titles of father, wife and family hadn't been performing their proper roles .

They had pretended to know nothing . It was like some love triangle in a drama .

'That's not all . My father on the family register – that is, Katsuaki – would rape me at night, maybe in some sort of revenge . I was only ten...'

'What...'

A father raping his daughter – his young one, at that .

A child who had lost their home as a place to escape had nowhere to go . It was supposed to be the parents' job to protect their children . But –

Rage boiled up in the pit of Gotou's stomach .

'Grandma was my only ally . But Grandma broke too . '

'Broke?'

'Yup . She found out . She found out what was happening at home... I told her . '

For a just a moment, it felt like a shadow passed Miyuki's eyes .

'You broke her . '

'Yup . That day, Grandma went mad and grabbed a kitchen knife . '

'Wha...'

Gotou swallowed his breath .

'What do you think the others did when they saw that? Everyone forced Grandma down and stabbed her . '

Miyuki acted it out, putting her hand to her chest and looking up at the ceiling as if she were a singer in a musical .

Her gaze was so cold it sent a chill down Gotou's spine .

'They didn't just kill Grandma – they started to talk about how to hide her . They said bad things about her – it was awful to watch . That's why I broke all of them . '

She chose the word 'break' instead of 'kill' .

To Miyuki, her family excepting her grandmother were probably no longer people to her . But –

'There's no way you could've killed the three of them by yourself . '

Gotou shook his head .

She was just ten at the time . It was impossible .

'It's simple . Kanji and Katsuaki left the room to get a cloth to wrap Grandma up and a saw to cut her . I cut Fuyumi's throat then . '

Miyuki's eyes seemed to be in a trance as she looked at the tip of the knife .

'You've got some guts killing your own mother...'

'A woman who watched silently as her husband raped her daughter isn't a mother!'

Miyuki's shrill shriek reverberated through the room .

'You...'

Gotou wanted to retort, but he couldn't find the words .

'Next, I stabbed Kanji when he came back with a cloth . Then Katsuaki came back with a saw... A ten-year-old child wouldn't be able to kill him . That preconception lost him his life . '

Miyuki's triumphant voice hurt Gotou's ears .

'But even if you did kill your family, what did you do after that?'

Gotou looked at Yakumo .

'She wasn't alone . '

Yakumo had been silent until now, but he said just that .

– She wasn't alone .

When Gotou heard that, information from the back of Gotou's memories was suddenly drawn back out .

Miyagawa had said that a man with two red eyes had been at the scene –

'That man?'

'Yes . That man took care of the scene . It was a two-fold trick . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair .

'A two-fold trick?'

'He didn't just make Takeda-san seem like the culprit . He also made Honda-san think he was the true culprit . '

'What for?'

'It was insurance for if Takeda-san was proven innocent . '

What the hell . Takeda and Honda had just been incredibly unlucky . Which meant –

'Then I was abducted to...'

Gotou didn't want to believe it, but no other thought came to him .

'It is just as you are thinking, Gotou-san . There was the possibility that his own crime would be revealed because of Takeda-san's reappearance . He used you as insurance . He made Honda-san abduct you and led Ishii-san there . '

So that really was how it was .

'Eh, then I...'

Ishii's mouth flapped like a goldfish that wasn't getting enough oxygen .

'Correct . Gotou-san was used to lure you out, Ishii-san – bait to lead you to Honda . In that sense, it didn't matter which of you was abducted, though you might have been easier to lead . '

Damn it . Using a guy as a lure . Gotou was furious .

'But why's Ishii easier to lead?'

'It's obviously because you're an idiot, Gotou-san . '

'You brat...'

He'd definitely punch him one day .

'Furthermore, when Honda-san abducted you, Gotou-san, that made him definitively suspicious . '

It was just as Yakumo said .

Even if the investigation had led them to Honda, it would've been difficult to arrest him just from that .

The case happened fifteen years ago . There wasn't much evidence .

However, since he'd abducted Gotou, that put all the suspicion on him .

– So we were completely played .

Ishii looked like he would cry at any moment . He'd tried his best this time, but he had actually just been being led around . When Gotou thought that, even he felt depressed .

It was mortifying, but now he understood why he had been abducted . But –

'Why were you abducted?'

When Gotou said that, Yakumo's expression twisted, like he had eaten something bitter .

'It was very probable that I would notice the truth behind the case, so it was necessary for me to be taken away from the stage . That was why the video came about . '

It had become clear from Ishii's investigation . The ghost video had been taken as a candid-camera plan to set up the exorcist .

The video of Yakumo's mother in the end had been added in later .

Disguised as a reporter, Miyuki had given the video to Makoto .

'Was that video bait?'

'Unfortunately, it is just as you say . When I saw that video, I noticed that the person in the video was my mother and acted on my own to chase that mystery . However, that was just a trap to lead me away from the case . '

Even Yakumo lost his coolheaded deduction ability when faced with a picture of his missing mother .

And Yakumo's mother had tried to kill him . Why did she do that? He had probably been looking for that reason too .

'She waited for me to show a chink in my armour . Then, when I arrived at the log house, she shocked me with a stun gun . '

Though Yakumo's teeth were gritted, Miyuki was smiling in her amusement, showing her white teeth .

She was probably happy to have hoodwinked him .

'However, the torture was unnecessary . If you had just let me sleep, I might have taken longer to notice who you were . '

Yakumo glanced at Miyuki .

Gotou looked at Yakumo's body again .

A cast on his leg . Cuts and bruises all over his body . She had probably been careful while hurting him so he wouldn't faint .

Miyuki licked her lips . This woman was an incredible sadist .

'Amazing . No wonder that person acknowledges you . You really are excellent . You're so excellent it makes me want to kill you . '

Miyuki gave Yakumo a round of applause .

'It doesn't make me happy to be acknowledged by that man . '

Yakumo's eyes were fierce .

'That might be the case for you, but it's different for me . That man is my father – the person I love . He saved me from that hell of a house and gave me a new life . '

Miyuki spread her arms and looked up as she declared that loudly .

When Gotou saw how intoxicated Miyuki look, a chill went down his spine . The person who was the most broken was Miyuki .

'Do you really think that?'

Yakumo's one sentence made Miyuki freeze .

'What do you mean?'

'The incident fifteen years ago was only devised by that man to isolate my mother and corner her psychologically . You were only a by-product of that . '

There was a wrinkle in Yakumo's forehead .

– So that's how it is?

When Gotou heard Yakumo's words, he felt like he'd solved the many puzzles he'd dragged along with him .

When Gotou met Azusa fifteen years ago, her mind was completely broken .

– This child will kill people!

Azusa's scream was as fresh in his mind as if he had heard it yesterday .

From her perspective, it must have been an unbelievable reality . She had overcome her suffering and had almost caught a chance at happiness when the man who had accepted her and her child ended up pursued by the police as the culprit to a murder case .

However, that man's true goal had been Yakumo .

By confusing Yakumo's mother, he caught up to Yakumo and tried to draw him over . Though Yakumo didn't say it, he had also noticed .

'Shut up!'

Miyuki suddenly put her hands in her hair and crouched, screaming in a constricted voice .

'I know that! I know that even without you telling me! That person only ever looks at you! Is being related by blood and having a red eye so amazing?'

Miyuki's eyes were bloodshot and as she shouted, spit came flying out . She was like a completely different person .

Envy towards Yakumo –

Gotou could feel it . The man she worshipped only showed interest in Yakumo . She resented that .

Yakumo and Miyuki might have had a relationship like siblings –

– Older sister?

The old wound in Gotou's stomach twitched .

He looked at Miyuki's face again . He'd seen this face somewhere before – so that was it!

'Yakumo, could she be – '

'That's right . Though she has changed her face with cosmetic surgery, this is the person who called herself my older sister in the last case . '

So that really was the case . They'd finally met again . He'd properly thank her for the injury she'd given him . But –

'Why didn't you say that earlier!?'

'I was sure that you would notice, Gotou-san . '

'Why?'

'Didn't you say when you watched the video that you remembered seeing this woman before?'

He had said that . But he'd completely forgotten .

'Your biggest mistake this time was leaving me alive . '

Miyuki lifted her head the moment she heard Yakumo's words .

'That's right . I think that too . That man told me not to kill you – told me to leave you alive, but it really would be better if you died . '

Miyuki brushed her hair back and smiled fearlessly .

That was quite some composure she had in this situation . Gotou would definitely not let him get away this time .

Gotou stepped towards Miyuki .

However, Miyuki leapt backwards with quick footwork to evade him .

Gotou wouldn't let her get away . Just as Gotou readied himself to rush at him, Miyuki ran out of the living room and shut the door .

– You think that's going to stop me?

Gotou rammed his shoulder into the door with all his strength .

However, the door didn't even budge .

'It's useless,' said Yakumo .

Gotou looked at the door . Unlike last time, the door was metal . It seemed to have been changed .

– Have we been shut in?

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– What on earth?

All Ishii could do was stare, dumbfounded by the exchange between Gotou, Yakumo and Miyuki .

Even though he had thought he'd found Gotou and saved him with his own determination, that had all been calculated .

He had completely been played . When he thought about that, he realised how small his existence was .

'Open up! Come on!'

Gotou howled at the door as he kicked it .

'Detective Gotou, it's no use,' said Ishii without thinking .

'What did you say!?'

'If the door's shape warps, it will become even more difficult to open . '

'Then what are you saying we should do!?' said Gotou, kicking the door once more .

'Please calm down,' said Yakumo with a nonchalant yawn .

'What are you acting all composed for? Come on – what the hell is this?'

'There's nothing to it . Please think about this seriously . Why do you think she spoke so freely?'

A very unpleasant thought came to Ishii's head upon hearing Yakumo's words .

'She plans to gather us in one place and kill us,' said Ishii with a shiver .

'Exactly . How clear-headed of you, Ishii-san . '

Unlike Ishii, who was terrified, Yakumo spoke calmly .

'W-w-what did you say!?' yelled Gotou .

Yakumo put his fingers in his ears to show how loud he thought Gotou was .

'Please don't speak so loudly next to my ears . You really are easily unsettled for somebody of your stature . '

'You idiot . How could I be calm now?'

Ishii agreed with Gotou's opinion . Yakumo was the strange one for being so disinterested at a time like this .

Still –

'We've been completely trapped then,' said Ishii with a disappointed sigh .

'Correct . Makoto-san was bait . She might have been told to return the video or that there was a new truth to the case . It doesn't matter . Miyuki

called Makoto out that way, since Makoto has a good heart, and drew us here . ’

Yakumo scratched the tip of his nose with his finger .

‘But isn’t that strange? How’d that woman know Ishii was tailing the reporter lady?’

Gotou’s question made sense .

Miyuki had used Makoto as bait because she knew she was being watched .

Yakumo had been the one who told him to watch Makoto . Why was that necessary –

Yakumo held his finger in front of his mouth to quiet them .

Though Gotou and Ishii were confused by Yakumo’s sudden action, they looked at each other and then shut their mouths .

Yakumo nodded once more and then took his mobile out from the pocket of his pocket gown . He opened the cover for the battery and took out something that looked like a one-centimetre rectangular card .

Yakumo pinched it with his fingers, showed it to Gotou and Ishii . Then, he dropped it to the floor and crushed it with his crutch .

‘Could that be a listening device?’

‘Correct, Ishii-san . ’

Yakumo put up his thumb, looking satisfied .

‘When’d you notice that!?’

‘From the very start . That was put there when I was abducted . ’

Yakumo spoke indifferently, without flinching at Gotou’s angry yell .

– From the very start .

Ishii recalled the exchange they'd had when he was tailing Makoto .

In order to explain the situation, he'd called Gotou's mobile, but for some reason, Yakumo had gone out of his way to call again from his own phone to discuss the same thing .

– We're heading there now too .

That hadn't been a message to Ishii . That had been to tell Miyuki they were going there now .

'But why did you act like you didn't notice?'

'You understand as well, don't you, Ishii-san? That woman is tenacious . If we didn't face off in this manner, she would surround us with traps again and cut off our heads one by one as we slept . '

– I see . So that's how it was .

Yakumo took Miyuki's trap and forced Miyuki's hand .

However, in this situation, that meant his plan had also failed .

Ishii smelt something burning and lifted his head .

Smoke was coming in from the gap between the door and the floor .

'So she really is going to set fire to the house,' said Yakumo, running a hand through his hair .

Ishii recalled the can he had stepped on when he came into the house .
Though it was too late to realise that now –

'We're going to burn to crisps here! That woman's gonna get away! What the hell are we going to do!?'

Gotou stamped on the floor like a child throwing a tantrum .

'Honestly . I'll make you stand in the hallway for being an unruly child . '

'I'll hit you, you bastard!'

Gotou raised his voice and yelled, but Yakumo didn't pay him any attention .

'Please calm down . She won't run . She must be making obstructive preparations so that the fire engines cannot arrive . '

Ishii thought that Yakumo was right .

If fire engines showed up to put out the fire, her efforts would have been in vain . She needed to obstruct their arrival no matter what .

'That's even worse! At this rate...'

In the middle of speaking, Gotou breathed in some smoke and started coughing violently .

The room was considerably filled with smoke .

At this rate, they would soon die of carbon monoxide poisoning .

Contrary to Ishii's anxiety, Yakumo was the picture of calm . He seemed to have a secret plan to escape .

Yakumo used his mobile to call somewhere .

Even if he called the fire department, the fire engines would be obstructed . Yakumo had said that himself . What on earth was he planning?

'It's me . It's your time to shine... Calm down . It's a simple job; just do it the way I instructed you . Press the accelerator down as much as you can and move the brake lever . That's all . Got it?'

Yakumo gave out instructions in a flat voice .

Who was he talking to? Ishii had no idea .

'It's fine . You can do it . Don't forget to put on your seatbelt...'

'Yakumo, I got it . So that's it? That's why you made me park the car there .
,

Gotou clapped his hands together – he appeared to have realised what Yakumo was planning .

'If you get it, hurry up and move Makoto-san . The location she is in now is dangerous . '

Gotou walked over and picked up Makoto's legs . Ishii didn't understand but he decided to just do as he was told .

Ishii lifted Makoto's head, and at the count of three, they moved Makoto to the door .

After Yakumo confirmed that, he nodded .

'Now! Go!'

Right after Yakumo spoke, there was an incredible sound and dust flew up into the air .

A car broke through the wall and flew into the room .

'Aah!'

Ishii shouted in his excitement and surprise as he saw this scene that seemed to have come right out of an action movie .

– But who's driving that car?

To answer Ishii's question, the driver, whose face was buried in the air bag, looked up while pressing a hand against her head .

It was Haruka –

How reckless .

'The walls are so thin that the house next door could hear the screams . Just as I thought,' said Yakumo triumphantly .

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Gotou ran out of the house through the broken wall and looked for Miyuki .

'There she is!'

He spotted Miyuki standing at the front entrance with a dumbfounded expression .

Their eyes met . Gotou thought she'd run, but Miyuki just stood there with a faint smile .

– Did she give up? No, I can't let my guard down .

He had suddenly been caught from behind last time .

Gotou guardedly sidled up to Miyuki . However, Miyuki dropped her knife to the ground and put up both her hands .

'It's my loss . '

Miyuki winked .

– This woman's challenging me . Just what I want .

Gotou took out handcuffs and quickened his pace, walking up to Miyuki .

'Not going to let you get away again . '

'Right . Hurry up and arrest me . '

Miyuki put her two wrists together and held them out towards Gotou .

– How honest . Did she really give up?

A doubt sprouted in Gotou's mind .

'What's wrong? Not going to arrest me?'

Miyuki cocked her head, as if she was confused .

'I'm going to do that even if you don't tell me to . '

Gotou reached out to handcuff Miyuki .

That moment, Miyuki slightly lowered her right wrist . Something like a black box slid out from her sleeve into her palm .

Gotou didn't miss it .

– It's a stun gun .

Miyuki thrust the pulsing stun gun towards Gotou .

'As if I'd be caught by the same attack again!'

Gotou twisted back and evaded the attack, grabbing Miyuki's wrist in the same action .

'Let me go, you blockhead!' shrieked Miyuki, twisting about violently . Her resistance was useless . Gotou wouldn't lose in strength .

'I've a rule about not raising my hand towards women, but you're an exception!'

Gotou ripped the stun gun out of Miyuki's hand . He grabbed her hair and forced her to lean forward before kneeing her .

She responded appropriately .

Miyuki hugged her stomach, bent over and vomited .

'Have you finished?'

Yakumo walked towards him, supported by Haruka .

Damn, this guy was carefree . He could've told Gotou that he had a plan .
The chills had been unbearable .

'... If I had killed you . '

Miyuki's nails dug into the ground as she glared at Yakumo with a gaze full of hatred .

'No, that isn't your only mistake . '

Miyuki's brows furrowed at Yakumo's words .

'You underestimated her . That was the cause of your defeat . '

As Yakumo said that, he gave Haruka a glance .

Rare for him, his eyes were kind .

Haruka really might have been Miyuki's miscalculation .

Miyuki had misread what actions Haruka would take when it became clear that Yakumo was missing and how strong Haruka's feelings towards Yakumo were .

Even Miyuki hadn't expected Haruka to find Yakumo so quickly . She had been the biggest wild card .

More than that, her driving technique earlier had been pretty great . It was unexpected from her appearance, but the girl went at things with all her heart .

Gotou ended up smiling unconsciously . Yakumo saw that and ended up smiling too .

However, when Haruka saw their faces, she was sulking, like she didn't understand what was going on .

'I'm going to kill you . I'm going to kill all of you...'

Even at this stage, Miyuki bit her lip and expressed her hatred .

– She's as tough as a zombie .

'Gotou-san, she's annoying . Please put her to sleep,' said Yakumo .

Gotou agreed with Yakumo . He had his grudge from before .

'Die!'

Miyuki quickly picked up the knife from the ground and leaped towards him .

Gotou bent back to evade the attack and then pressed the stun gun against Miyuki's neck and pressed the switch .

There was a zap .

Miyuki collapsed to the ground just as the house came burning down –

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It was a very clear day –

The day after the incident, Haruka was being driven by Keiko to the place Yakumo designated .

Haruka hadn't heard the details from Yakumo; he had just said that he was going to meet somebody .

In the backseat, Yakumo had the same sleepy eyes as usual . However, they looked a bit sad .

In front of them, there was just a half-demolished building with its concrete frame .

'Yakumo-kun, is this really the right place?'

Yakumo's only reply was a short 'Yeah' as he bit his lip .

Keiko parked the car a little bit ahead of the building .

After Haruka got off the car, she helped Yakumo out and walked towards the building's premises as directed .

She heard Yakumo's breath in her ears .

She'd heard from Gotou yesterday . This building was where Yakumo's mother, Azusa, had tried to kill him fifteen years earlier .

– I wonder what Yakumo is feeling and thinking today .

'Oh, you finally came?'

Sitting on the road facing the building, Gotou was smoking a cigarette . He raised his hand and stood up .

'It is forbidden to smoke on the streets . How can the police set an example by breaking the rules?'

Yakumo's remarks were sarcastic, as usual .

'Shut up!'

Gotou went onto the premises through the entrance, which had a leaning door .

Yakumo and Haruka followed him .

The abandoned building rose above them .

Yakumo looked up at the building's roof silently .

'Will we really meet Takeda if we come here?' said Gotou, putting his cigarette out in a portable ashtray .

Takeda Shunsuke –

In the murder case fifteen years ago, he was made to look like the culprit and was still on the run . He had also been Azusa's lover .

He was the person who might have become Yakumo's father –

Did Yakumo come to meet Takeda?

'He's already here,' murmured Yakumo .

Haruka looked around, but she couldn't see him earlier . Gotou looked around in the same fashion but he didn't appear to find him either .

'Where is he?' said Gotou, sounding displeased .

'He is right in front of you now . Though he is already starting to disappear...'

– Oh, so that's how it was .

From Yakumo's one utterance, Haruka understood everything . It was a sad truth .

'You making fun of me?'

Gotou suddenly brought his face close to Yakumo's . He didn't understand yet .

'I'm not making fun of you . '

'Then what?'

'You still don't understand? Takeda-san is dead . He died fifteen years ago...'

'Dea...'

Gotou finally understood and became lost for words .

Takeda was dead –

The person that had appeared in front of Haruka had been Takeda's ghost .
That was how he could break into a locked home .

Takeda, as a ghost, couldn't save Yakumo, so he had asked Haruka to do it .

That was also why the police couldn't find him no matter how they searched .

A number of people had seen him, but nobody had directly touched him .

'Takeda-san was killed immediately after that case and buried under a building that was under construction at the time . '

Yakumo continued to speak as he pointed at the mountain of rubble with his crutch .

'But why now...'

Gotou furrowed his brow . Haruka had that question too .

'He was unburied when the building was demolished . If you look through the place where they have put all the scrap material, you should find the corpse . '

Haruka looked at the mountain of rubble .

Takeda was sleeping in that mountain –

'I see . So nobody could catch him . Ishii said he'd disappeared, but I guess that wasn't a lie . '

Gotou took out another cigarette and lit it .

'Correct . When the corpse was dug up, his soul, which had been sleeping, was dragged out of the ground for the first time in fifteen years,' said Yakumo, his head hung .

'I see . '

'Nanase Miyuki knew that and feared that Takeda-san would contact me, so this happened . '

'Because the truth would come out the moment he met you...'

'Yes . '

'Takeda was frantic to prove he was innocent, huh . '

Gotou spat out his cigarette with a frown .

'That isn't it,' said Yakumo, still looking down .

'What?'

'Takeda-san didn't care at all about his own crime . '

'Didn't care at all? What the hell are you talking about?'

Yakumo didn't respond to Gotou's question .

He looked up and stared at the mountain of rubble .

Haruka felt like, for a moment, she saw a man standing in front of that gaze . His eyes crinkled in a kind smile .

'Until the end, you cared about...'

Yakumo's voice was so quiet it was nearly inaudible .

When Haruka heard him, she understood what Takeda had been trying to do .

To Takeda, there was something much more important than his proving his innocence or getting revenge on the person who killed him . That was –

Haruka looked at Yakumo .

Yakumo's narrowed eyes were just a little bit wet .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . Takeda-san was...'

'I know . '

Yakumo shut his eyes and interrupted Haruka .

– That's right . Yakumo knows much better than me .

Even if his eye was red and he wasn't his own child, there was somebody in Yakumo's past who had wanted to become his father .

Even after this person died, he still cared about Yakumo and Azusa .

Though it was only a month – they had only known each other for a short time – it had to have been a very happy month for Yakumo and Azusa .

Haruka hoped it was true .

– Oh no . I'm going to cry .

Haruka wiped her tears with her finger .

The wind blew . Though it was still cold now, it wouldn't be cold forever . Spring would come in the end .

So –

'Let's go,' said Yakumo, looking up at the sky .

The cloud that had passed over the sun was blown away by the wind, and a brilliant light shone down on them .

That's right . Let's go .

– Somebody is waiting for us .

NOTES:

[1] Johnny's Entertainment is a talent agency with music groups such as Arashi and KAT-TUN which comprise good-looking male idols . They apparently have an EnglishHOMEPAGE promoting their groups too .

[2] Ishihara Gundan is the pet name of the group of mostly older male actors in Ishihara Promotion, founded by late actor Ishihara Yuujirou . Their HOMEPAGE has pictures of the actors .

Volume 5 Chapter 4: Epilogue.

VOLUME 5 – CONNECTED FEELINGS epilogue

– Because of the case, I didn't have a lot of time to practise.

However, in the two days before the performance, Haruka put all her energy into practising and was able to finish the performance properly.

At the conductor's signal, she stood up and bowed at the audience.

In the very back seat, Keiko waved her hand.

Sitting next to her, Yakumo was sleeping with his arms crossed.

Keiko kneed Yakumo and woke him up.

– My mother really does some amazing things.

At Keiko's urging, Yakumo rubbed at his eyes and lifted his head. He might have just been stretching.

Haruka thought the sight of Yakumo and Keiko sitting together was very strange.

Keiko must have taken Yakumo out of the hospital forcibly.

Keiko had ended up staying at Haruka's flat ever since that day. Kazuhiro must have been dancing around at home.

Keiko's interest seemed to have been piqued by Yakumo, the son of her old friend, and she'd sneaked into his hospital room.

Then, she'd met Isshin and ended up interested in him too. Finally, she said that both would be hard to throw away, which was cryptic to Haruka.

If Kazuhiro heard that, he'd definitely faint.

Though the case this time had really been tough, Haruka thought that the gain was worth it.

A bond that had been cut for fifteen years had been connected again –

Haruka gave a slight wave and then left for the wings of the stage.

After she finished cleaning up, she left the school, only to hear the sound of a car horn.

She spotted Keiko waiting there with her car. Yakumo was in the backseat too.

'What is it?' asked Haruka as she approached. Keiko stuck her face out of the window.

'Yakumo-kun said he's going to Nagano to pick up something he forgot, so I'm going to drive him back since I'm heading there anywhere. What will you do, Haruka?'

Of course –

'I'll go!'

There was actually a meeting after the performance, but she was going to skip that today.

Haruka quickly stepped into the passenger seat. Right after she did, the car started.

'Hey, Yakumo-kun, what did you forget?' asked Haruka as she turned around.

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair, seeming bothered.

'Something I've been looking for this whole time.'

Perhaps he wasn't feeling well, because after he yawned like he always did, he lay down in the backseat and shut his eyes.

Within five minutes, he started sleeping.

'Haruka, Yakumo-kun really is such a nice boy,' said Keiko earnestly.

Haruka looked at the backseat through the rear-view mirror. Yakumo's eyes were shut, completely still.

'He is. But Yakumo-kun doesn't understand a girl's heart at all. He's too thick-headed.'

Yakumo's eyebrow twitched. He seemed to have heard. However, he didn't say anything.

Since he was pretending to sleep, it felt like Haruka shouldn't wake him up.

– It's a nice feeling.

Haruka met Keiko's gaze and smiled.

* * *

Ishii had so much paperwork to do –

With the story getting as huge as this, the police had to present some sort of opinion.

However, the situation made it difficult to present, and fifteen years had passed. There had been a search at the scene, but since the house had burnt down, that wasn't certain either.

Ishii thought that the case wasn't exemplary – the first investigation had been misread.

There was no point blaming anybody now, but if they had focussed more on why the testimony had been off, this wouldn't have happened.

However, that was just what people did, not just police. The people in charge weren't perfect.

They couldn't charge Miyuki with the case that occurred fifteen years ago.

Partly it was because the statute of limitations was up, but at the time, she had been a ten-year-old girl. She couldn't be charged for a crime.

However, the murders fifteen years ago hadn't been Miyuki's only crimes. Starting with the attempted murder of Yakumo, she had put her hand to many crimes.

They would have to start putting together cases for each of those.

If possible, Ishii wanted Miyuki to spend the rest of her life in prison.

In any case, if he didn't hurry to finish these reports, Miyagawa would yell at him again. Ishii focussed on his work.

– I wish Gotou would help a little.

Ishii looked up at Gotou, who had an unlit cigarette in his mouth.

Ever since that case, Gotou would often sit like this to think.

At first, Ishii had thought that Gotou was thinking over what had happened, but recently, Ishii started to believe that wasn't the case.

Still, Ishii had no way of knowing what Gotou was thinking.

Suddenly, Gotou stood up.

'Ishii. I've decided,' declared Gotou loudly.

'What have you decided?'

The menu for lunch? They always got Chinese delivered, so pizza would be OK once in a while. Contrary to Ishii's idle musings, Gotou's eyes were the picture of seriousness.

'I'm gonna quit the force.'

'Huh?'

Ishii's voice squeaked.

Quit the force? Gotou? What is he saying –

'Please don't joke a time like this.'

'Shut up. I've decided.'

'No, but...'

'Bye. Keep fit.'

Indifferent to Ishii's confusion, Gotou grabbed his jacket from the chair and left the room briskly.

– Eh, now? He's kidding, right?

'Detective Gotou, please wait.'

Ishii hurriedly ran after Gotou.

He fell –

* * *

Haruka supported Yakumo, who was using his crutch, as they climbed the slope through the forest.

Keiko was also pushing Yakumo from behind.

Like that, they finally reached the log house.

Since something like that had happened here, it looked uncanny even at noon.

Haruka opened the door together with Yakumo and went in.

– I wonder what he forgot.

Haruka looked around, but she didn't say anything.

Yakumo hopped away from Haruka to the storeroom where he had been shut in.

Then, he picked up a metal rod and hit the wall of the storeroom.

He kept hitting the wall.

Dust flew up and the wood snapped.

Yakumo put his hand in the gap and tore off the wood forcibly. There seemed to be something in the back.

Haruka helped Yakumo to tear off the wood. Keiko joined them and they put all their effort into breaking the wall.

After a while, a space appeared on the other side of the wall.

– Could this be?

Keiko lit up the other side of the wall with her torch.

There was a human skeleton lying there.

Yakumo didn't say anything, but Haruka understood even without an explanation.

This person is definitely –

So she hadn't been mistaken. Somebody had come to save Yakumo and stand against the man with the red eyes, standing between them to protect

him.

That must have been this person –

As Keiko held the torch, she cried silently.

Yakumo looked at the skeleton with a blank expression. He had finally found what he was looking for. However, it was in an incredibly depressing state.

Haruka's chest hurt and she gripped the red stone on her necklace tightly.

I wonder what Yakumo is thinking now –

Yakumo had always kept the fact that Azusa had tried to kill him in the bottom of his heart. Now, they had met again. What could he be thinking –

Suddenly, Haruka noticed that the skeleton was gripping something.

'Hey, Yakumo-kun. That's...'

When Haruka said that, Yakumo reached out and picked it up.

It was a silver locket.

Yakumo appeared to have noticed it as well, and he opened the locket. There was a photo inside.

In the photo, Azusa and her child, Yakumo, were smiling, their cheeks pressed together.

They're smiling really happily –

This might have been the photo that Takeda took.

'I forgot that there'd been a time like this...'

Yakumo said just that, closing his eyes.

Haruka had no way of knowing what had happened in Azusa's heart.

However, there was one thing she was certain of. At least at the moment this photo was taken, Azusa had been happy.

'Yakumo-kun...'

'I know. Don't say anything.'

Yakumo interrupted Haruka's words.

Right. He had remembered something he had forgotten, so that was enough.

Yakumo put the locket in his pocket.

'Goodbye, Mother.'

Eyes brimming with tears, Yakumo bid his mother farewell.

Volume 6 Chapter 0: Prologue

VOLUME 6 – TO THE LIMITS OF DESPAIR (1) prologue

The fair moon radiated a cold light –

Ishida Naoto felt suffocated, as if a weight was on his chest, and opened his eyes.

He looked at the clock. It was just past three in the morning. He had woken up too early. He closed his eyes to try to fall asleep again.

However, Ishida was bothered by the sound of other people sleeping on the opposite side of the divider curtain and was unable to fall asleep again.

– Let's try something else.

Ishida slowly got up.

At that moment, he felt a slight pain in his side. It was the place where he had stitches from the surgery three days ago.

The doctor had told him to move as little as possible the day after the surgery. That would make it recover faster.

Ishida unsteadily got up from the bed and left the hospital room.

The corridor went straight down. It was empty.

The corridor was lit up by the green emergency light, which gave it an uncanny atmosphere.

He had seen a similar corridor in a horror film before. In the story, a strange contagious disease had spread through the hospital and people had died one after another.

– What was the title of that movie?

Ishida searched his memories, but in the end, he couldn't remember the title.

Instead, he remembered something the nurse had said yesterday.

The ghost of a girl with no face was wandering the hospital. She always asked the people she met the same question.

– When are you going to die?

The people whom she asked this question always died soon afterwards.

It was a common story that could have been found at any hospital.

Ishida thought that the nurse whose eyes had been sparkling when telling the story was scarier. She had been plump and quite his type, but his emotions had cooled all at once.

Ishida walked into the lavatory at the end of the corridor.

He stood in front of the sink and put his hands at the faucet.

The sensor reacted and water started flowing. He used his hands to take that water and washed his face.

He repeated that a number of times and felt a bit better.

He wiped his eyes with the sleeve of his pyjamas and looked at the mirror.

– Hey.

Suddenly, he heard a voice.

Ishida hurriedly turned around, but there was nobody there.

He decided it was his imagination and turned towards the mirror again.

When Ishida saw what was reflected in the mirror, he jumped, like he had been splashed with cold water.

There was a girl behind Ishida in the mirror.

A girl in a red dress. She was looking down so he couldn't see her face.

'Don't surprise me.'

Ishida turned around. However, nobody was there.

'Eh?'

He looked at the mirror again.

The girl was definitely there –

A cold sweat ran down his whole body.

– Hey, mister.

As the girl said that, she slowly lifted her face.

Her face was completely hidden by a black shadow, as if it were smeared with ink.

Ishida was so shocked he couldn't even scream –

His heart was beating wildly, thumping against his ribcage.

– When are you going to die?

When the girl said that, she thrust her two hands forward.

Ishida couldn't breathe.

Hah, hah, hah, hah.

Ishida ran out of the lavatory blindly.

He didn't have the courage to turn around. With the corridor's wall as support, he just went as far as his legs would take him.

– Hurry. Back to my hospital room. Almost there, just a bit more...

Just as the hospital door appeared in front of him, Ishida felt somebody's presence and stopped moving.

– Hey, when are you going to die?

The girl spoke.

She was in front of the hospital room.

'Augh!' Ishida screamed and went back down the corridor.

– Where should I run to?

Ishida, in his confusion, spotted an elevator.

He ran as quickly as he could to the elevator and hit the button again and again.

– Hurry, hurry, hurry!

However, the elevator was taking its time to show up.

When he looked down the corridor, he saw the girl slowly walking towards him.

– It's no good!

Ishida gave up on the elevator and headed towards the stairs ahead of them.

He turned around.

The girl was approaching quickly.

Ishida took a step to go down the stairs.

– When are you going to die?

The girl was waiting for Ishida at the bottom of the stairs.

Ishida's body froze.

– Ah!

The moment he thought that, it was already too late.

Ishida lost his balance and tumbled down the stairs.

A sharp pain ran through his thigh and his back.

Ishida's consciousness fell into a pitch-black darkness –

Volume 6 Chapter 1: VOLUME 6 – TO THE LIMITS OF DESPAIR (1)

Chapter 1

VOLUME 6 – TO THE LIMITS OF DESPAIR (1)

file 01: prophecy (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

Dawn had not come yet .

The dim interior of the temple was blanketed in silence .

A wooden statue of Gautama Buddha was enshrined at the front .

Saitou Isshin was sitting in the standard lotus position and hands in Dhyana mudra[1] . He was sitting straight up .

He was looking forward, and then he lowered his gaze, eyes half-closed .

– One, two, three...

While counting in his mind, he slowly readied his breathing .

Next, he readied his mind .

– Ensou[2] .

One cannot see correctly if one does not ready one's mind .

The basic ideology of Zen .

However, Isshin felt this was incredibly difficult .

No matter how he tried to attain mu[3], worldly thoughts passed through his head .

Trivial things form his everyday life, or negative emotions like envy, resentment and jealous, or the feeling of an empty stomach and the desire to sleep –

Most of Isshin's mind was occupied by that man .

He sometimes forgot in his regular daily life, but when he sat in meditation like this, a strong image would always come up .

However, the man that appeared never had a face .

This was because, though Isshin knew what that man was like and what he had done, he had never once met him in person .

He was in completely black, as if painted in shadow, but his two eyes glittered, dyed in red .

When Isshin thought about that man, his heart wavered .

– Hatred .

That feeling was definitely there . But it was also true that it couldn't be split up into a simple emotion when he thought about how Yakumo and Nao wouldn't be in this world without that man .

– Can I forgive him?

If he asked that question, he would probably immediately reply no .

At the same time, however, he felt something like karma .

That man stole an important person from Isshin and also gave him back someone equally as important .

He could say that that man had brought about Isshin's life now .

He always thought about the same thing, but he couldn't find an answer .

'Hm . '

Isshin opened his eyes .

– I was controlled by worldly thoughts again .

After smiling self-derisively, Isshin slowly stood up and exited the temple .

The sun had risen and bathed the world in its refreshing morning rays .

Isshin looked at the cherry blossom tree in the garden .

He saw small pink buds on its branches .

Though it was still chilly, spring would come soon . Then this garden would probably be in full bloom .

'Maybe I'll have a flower viewing,' said Isshin to himself .

'Ah!'

In response to the voice, Isshin looked and saw Nao running to him .

In Nao's smile, Isshin could see her face . The only woman Isshin had ever given his heart to . Isshin didn't know how much that smile had supported him .

Isshin naturally smiled as he waited for Nao to arrive .

However, before Nao reached him, he was assaulted with a fierce pain in his head, and he fell to his knees .

His forehead was drenched in sweat .

Recently, these awful headaches came often . While enduring the pain that came to him intermittently, he looked up .

'Oh!'

The smile left Nao's face . She peered anxiously at Isshin .

'I'm fine,' said Isshin with a smile as he patted Nao's head .

– Once the flowers bloom, let's view the flowers with everyone .

He placed a hand on Nao's shoulder as he murmured that in his heart .

2

I'm bored .

Ishii Yuutarou stifled his yawn as he looked at the documents .

March was finally approaching and it was much warmer now . When he did simple document organisation, he became sleepy, even though he knew he couldn't .

Ishii's hands stopped . He took off his silver-framed glasses and rolled his head .

Since he had been in the same position for so long, his neck cracked loudly .

The <Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room> where Ishii was stationed was one of the departments of the police force . Though its name was splendid, in actuality, all he did was organise the files for cases that had been left behind and help other departments .

Ishii felt very dissatisfied with the situation .

– Could the <Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room> just be a dead-end job?

He had been thinking that recently .

Though it was imprudent, since he had finally joined the police force he had been yearning for, he wanted to take part in a stimulating case .

That said, he didn't want to have a case like the one last month with Takeda Shunsuke which had been bloody and had required him to investigate alone .

He had managed somehow then, but if something like that happened again, his heart would definitely break .

– Won't a safe and stylish case come my way?

Ishii put his glasses back on as he daydreamed .

Suddenly, he saw Gotou in front of him .

He had on a wrinkled shirt and a loose tie . He was reclining on his chair with his mouth wide open as he snored in his sleep . He didn't look much different from a drunkard sleeping on a bench outside the station .

– He could help out a bit .

Though he thought that, Ishii didn't have the courage to say it aloud .

Just as Ishii sighed, the door opened .

'Hey . '

Chief Miyagawa came into the room .

Though he was of small stature, he had a bald head and a hard, sharp gaze . At first glance, he looked more like somebody on the other side than a detective .

'T-t-thank you for your hard work!'

Ishii stood up energetically and straightened his spine as he saluted .

'Where's Gotou?'

'Er, um, he is here, but...'

Ishii's reply fizzled out as he looked at Gotou, sleeping in his chair .

Miyagawa clicked his tongue and walked briskly towards Gotou

'How long's this fool been sleeping?'

'He fell asleep immediately after lunch . '

When Miyagawa glared at him, Ishii replied simply, unable to resist .

The next moment, Miyagawa raised his right fist and dropped it on Gotou's head .

Thunk –

The dull sound reverberated through the room .

Ishii felt as though he himself had been hit and unconsciously cowered .

'That hurts!'

Gotou howled as he slipped out of the chair, falling to the floor .

'E-er, are you all right?'

Ishii immediately approached Gotou .

Gotou looked up .

Their eyes met .

– Eh? He can't think that...

When Ishii thought that, it was already too late .

Gotou rose abruptly and grabbed Ishii's shirt .

'Ishii! You bastard! When'd you get so mighty that you'd raise your hand against me? Eh?'

'T-that isn't it... It wasn't me . '

'Stop complaining . '

'No, but...'

Gotou didn't listen to Ishii's explanation and tightened his grip .

'Won't you stop!?'

Miyagawa hit the back of Gotou's head .

'You bastard! What the hell are you... doing, sir...'

Gotou turned around reflexively, but when he noticed it was Miyagawa, he immediately toned down .

'What? So it's you, Miyagawa-san?'

Gotou leapt away from Ishii .

– I was this close to choking .

As Ishii coughed, he fixed the collar of his jacket .

'When'd you get so mighty that you'd sleep during work?'

'Even if you ask me when, I've always been doing this . '

Gotou picked his nose as Miyagawa questioned him .

'Don't just shrug it off,' complained Miyagawa . He walked to a nearby chair and sat down . Then, he took a cigarette case out of his pocket and held it out towards Gotou .

Gotou took a cigarette . Then, the two of them both lit up and had a smoke .

No matter what they said, the two got along .

When Gotou said before that he was going to quit the police, Miyagawa had been the one who'd stopped him, saying, 'Don't screw with me!'

They were scathing to each other, but they were deeply connected .

– This is a friendship between men .

Ishii gazed at them enviously as he sat down .

'So what are you here for today?'

Gotou crossed his legs and leant back on his chair lazily .

This really wasn't the attitude one should be taking towards a boss .
However, Miyagawa didn't seem to mind and brought up his topic .

'There's somewhere I want you guys to go . '

– Are we going to help out another department?

That was what Ishii thought, but when he saw Miyagawa's grim expression, his thoughts changed .

Though it was vague, he became anxious that something unbelievable was happening .

'Even though we look like this, we are busy . Please ask elsewhere . '

Perhaps Gotou didn't sense the strange atmosphere, because he waved his hand as if swatting a fly .

'You're busy napping?'

'Well, yes . '

'You're fired if you don't go . '

When Miyagawa said it, it didn't sound like a joke .

'Please feel free to do so . '

Gotou didn't budge . He spat his cigarette out towards the ceiling .

Miyagawa's fist would fly with Gotou's attitude like that . That was what Ishii thought, but it didn't happen .

Miyagawa's eyebrows lowered and he sighed, which wasn't like him .

'I don't want to make you guys go either . '

'What do you mean?'

– Don't want to make us go .

Ishii interrupted because those words had sounded off .

'It's troublesome, but you guys were designated first . '

'Designated? We were? This isn't a cabaret club – what are you planning?'

said Gotou, his attitude the same as always .

'Nanase Miyuki asked for an interview with you . '

After a silence, Miyagawa said that calmly .

– Nanase Miyuki .

The moment Ishii heard that name, his body jolted, as if electricity had run through him .

Cold sweat came out from every pore of his body .

'Why...'

Ishii put his thoughts into a question .

Nanase Miyuki was a woman who had killed her whole family when she was only ten years old .

After that, she disappeared with the man with two red eyes, Yakumo's father, and was involved with a number of cases .

They wouldn't involve themselves directly . They played with the negative emotions in the bottom of people's hearts like hatred and jealousy and led them around .

– It's more frightening then directly killing somebody .

If there were existences in this world that were evil from birth, they would be considered part of those existences . Ishii felt like all other criminals were overshadowed by her absolute malice .

During Takeda Shunsuke's case, they had finally arrested her . Currently, she was in detention and awaiting trial .

– Why would she ask for that?

Ishii wiped his sweat, which wasn't stopping .

'What does Nanase Miyuki want now?'

Gotou stretched his back and glared at Miyagawa .

Even Gotou wouldn't joke around once her name was brought up .

'Nanase Miyuki seems to have told her lawyer that there is another murder that the police do not know about . '

Miyagawa said that in a terribly flat voice .

'A murder we don't know about?'

Gotou casually put out a cigarette in the ashtray .

The smoke swayed .

'She said she would only talk about the details with you two . '

'W-why us?' asked Ishii .

Since it was Miyuki, it wouldn't be strange if she had killed one or two more people .

What I don't understand is why she would talk about that now –

He also didn't understand why she would only talk to Gotou and Ishii .

'I don't understand either . Even when we asked the lawyer, all we got was that she only planned on talking to you two . '

Miyagawa covered his face with both hands as he sighed .

Ishii understood the situation . That said, he didn't want to see Miyuki .

There was just one reason . He was afraid .

Ishii licked his dry lips and looked to Gotou for help .

With a grim face, Gotou poked himself in his left side .

Several months ago, Gotou had been stabbed with a knife there . Miyuki had been the one who did it .

– Please refuse .

Ishii hoped Gotou would do that .

He really was afraid of meeting Miyuki . Since she was stuck in detention, they probably wouldn't be in direct danger, but he was still afraid .

'I guess there's no helping it . '

Gotou said that and stood up . Then, he grabbed his jacket from the back of the chair .

'Detective Gotou, you can't . This is definitely a trap,' pleaded Ishii .

If Miyuki was acting in such a roundabout way, there had to be something behind it .

'I know that even without you telling me . '

Gotou snorted .

'If you know that, why?'

'If we don't fall for it, we won't know what the trap is, right?'

After Gotou said that, he left the room briskly with a wide gait .

— I need to follow him .

Though Ishii knew that, for some reason, his body didn't move .

'Ishii . '

Miyagawa said that in a murmur .

'Y-yes sir . '

'I leave Gotou to you . '

'Eh?'

It was so unexpected that Ishii thought his ears were playing tricks on him .

'He doesn't have anything to protect, so sometimes he loses himself . '

— Loses himself .

When Ishii heard those words, he felt like there was a truth to them .

He knew what Miyagawa was saying . But –

'I can't do anything...'

Ishii knew he was only a burden .

'You don't have to do anything in particular . Just stay with him . '

'Yes sir . '

Ishii stood up as he replied .

Even though his body had been frozen earlier, it was now so light that it felt like that had been a lie .

Ishii left the room and ran after Gotou .

He stumbled .

He fell –

3

After finishing the morning lecture, Ozawa Haruka went to the prefabricated building in the back of Building B .

She was going to meet Saitou Yakumo .

She walked to the courtyard and turned her eyes to the cherry blossom tree which had started to bud .

– The flowers are going to blossom soon .

She looked up at the sky, where lines of clouds were blowing by . Spring was going to come soon .

So it's already that season – she nodded and started walking again .

It had been a year and a half since Haruka met Yakumo –

It had started when her friend Miki was possessed by a ghost .

She had been troubled about what to do when she had a rumour about Yakumo's expertise in spiritual phenomena, so she decided to go meet him .

Her first impression was the worst .

He was contrary and discourteous – he treated people like idiots .

Yakumo normally hid his left eye behind a black contact lens, but it was red, with the unique ability to see the spirits of the dead .

He had used that ability during that incident too . He hadn't only saved Miki from her possession – he had even solved the murder case without it becoming an issue .

That was the start of Haruka's involvement in a number of cases .

A lot of things had happened . She had been abducted, almost drowned in a river, held at knifepoint – she couldn't count them .

It was almost mysterious how she had managed to live until now .

While these cases piled up, her impression of Yakumo, who she had just thought of as fishy and contrary, changed .

Because of Yakumo's red eye, he had endured more sadness than most .

Because of that, he had built a wall around his heart and tried not to let people get close . He still did that sometimes .

However, Haruka thought he had gotten better now than he had been when they'd met .

While Haruka was thinking, she spotted the prefabricated building she was looking for .

There were ten small rooms of four and a half tatami in size on each floor .
The building was lent out by the university for club and circle activities .

At the very back of the first floor, Yakumo lived in the room with the plate that read <Movie Research Circle> .

That wasn't an exaggeration . The name Movie Research Circle was a barefaced lie . Yakumo had deceived the university and was living in this prefabricated building like it was his own .

'Yakumo-kun, you here?'

Haruka called out as she opened the door .

Normally, Yakumo would be sitting at the chair facing the door and complain – 'What did you come here to do?' – with eyes that looked like they would fall asleep at any moment, but the room was so silent it was creepy .

– Is he sleeping?

Haruka looked at the sleeping bag near the wall, but it was empty .

'What? You're not here?' said Haruka in her dissatisfaction to nobody in particular .

– Maybe he'll come back soon .

Haruka opened the refrigerator in the back of the room, took out a bottle of tea and some almond chocolate, and sat on the chair .

'What are you doing?'

Surprised by the sudden voice, Haruka stood up and turned to look at the door .

Yakumo was standing there .

As usual, he was wearing a white shirt and jeans, and he had terrible bedhead .

'Ah, Yakumo-kun . '

'You barged into somebody's room but are acting like you owned the place . Do you not know the word "restraint"?' complained Yakumo as he sat down in his usual chair . He looked as displeased as a cat whose nap had been disturbed .

'How long have you been there?' asked Haruka, sitting down again .

'Since you were smirking up at the sky like an idiot . '

Yakumo yawned like a cat .

Haruka had looked up at the sky when she was in the courtyard . Which meant –

'You were following me that whole time?'

'Don't let the screws in your head get looser every time we meet . I'm just going to say this, but this is my room . I was only heading back to my own room . I don't have enough free time to stalk you . '

Though what he was saying wasn't wrong, he always said one thing too much . Plus –

'Then you could have called out to me . '

'Why?'

'Even if you ask me why...'

Haruka was lost for words .

She had felt like the distance between her and Yakumo had grown shorter after going through so many things together, but sometimes he would say things like this .

Her friends would sometimes ask if they were dating, but the answer was no .

It wasn't like she wanted to date . She felt like that would waste too much of her time .

She didn't want to ruin their relationship by bringing that up .

Just as Haruka sighed, the door opened .

'Hello . '

The person who showed up at the door was Yakumo's uncle and the person who had raised him, Saitou Isshin .

He had on black robes and a monk's stole . Since Haruka was used to his usual work attire, he had a different impression than he usually did .

However, his smile as gentle as Maitreya's and red eye were the same as always .

Though Yakumo's red eye was from birth, Isshin's was different .

He had put on a red contact lens to make his left eye red . He received strange looks so that he could try to understand Yakumo's feelings, even just a little .

Isshin's love for Yakumo was that deep .

Haruka thought that Isshin was the reason Yakumo was able to overcome the experience of having his mother try to kill him when he was young and didn't cross the line .

'It's been a while . '

Haruka stood up and bowed .

'Ah, it has been a while . You could come by once in a while . Nao'd be happy too,' replied Isshin in a dignified voice, still smiling .

'Yes, I'll take you up on your offer . '

Then, Haruka gestured at her chair . 'Please sit down . '

'Ah, it's fine . I'll stand . '

Isshin showed his usual restraint and refused .

'It's more troublesome in a situation like this if you stand,' rebuked Yakumo .

'That so?' said Isshin . He rubbed his shaved head and sat down on the chair, seeming embarrassed .

Haruka took the round chair in the corner of the room and sat next to Yakumo .

Yakumo's cheek twitched and he looked a bit displeased, but Haruka pretended not to notice . It'd be best not to pay him any attention since he'd probably just complain anyway .

'So what are you here for?'

Yakumo put his chin in his hand as he asked Isshin that, looking as melancholic as if he had seen the end of the world .

'I came to consult you about something,' said Isshin with a sigh .

– Consult?

Haruka was surprised, though she didn't express that surprise aloud .

Haruka had never heard of Isshin consulting Yakumo before .

She looked to Yakumo .

'You can't be consulting me about spirits, could you?' drawled Yakumo, chin still in his hand .

Isshin clapped his hands together .

'You really are sharp . '

'What do you mean, sharp? You know I hate trouble of that kind . '

'Really?'

'Having one troublemaker is enough,' said Yakumo, glancing at Haruka .

It was a rude way of saying it, but she'd never see the end of it if she got angry at every little thing . Haruka pretended she didn't hear him .

'So you really won't help me?' said Isshin .

'No,' Yakumo said firmly . He crossed his arms in his displeasure .

When he became like this, Yakumo wouldn't budge .

Isshin knew Yakumo's personality, so he gave up readily . 'There's no helping it . '

But, putting Isshin aside, Haruka had no plans of letting it end like this .

Isshin had never brought up ghosts before . Rather, he knew that Yakumo didn't like his unique ability, so he avoided the topic .

For Isshin to bring up the topic, it must have been a very special situation .

'Hey, why not just listen to him?'

When Haruka said that, Yakumo glared at her immediately .

'I refuse . '

'So cheap . '

'I don't want to hear that from you . '

'What? You can just listen . '

'If I listen to it, I won't be able to leave it alone,' said Yakumo irritably .

– I see .

Haruka clapped her hands together in realisation . If she flipped those words around, it meant that Yakumo would take on the trouble if he heard the story .

Though that was just a convenient way of looking at it, she didn't care .

'Isshin-san, please let me hear what you have to say . '

'I said I wouldn't listen to it,' interrupted Yakumo immediately .

'I'm talking to Isshin-san . If you don't want to listen, you can leave . '

'Do whatever you want,' Yakumo said recklessly, and he leant back on his chair, seeming exhausted .

4

– This is a pain .

Gotou cursed in his heart after arriving at the reception area of the detention room .

The detention room was very different than what Gotou knew of them .

Renovated with the concept of a detention room with no walls, its appearance, outside and inside, reminded him of a general hospital .

Gotou wrote his name in the interview request document at the reception and put it through the window . Then, he sat on the sofa in the waiting room .

The prosecuted persecutor left the hands of the police, went from being the suspect to the accused, was taken into custody by the prosecution and was

waiting for the trial in the detention room .

The police couldn't freely visit people in detention .

Though it was a pain, he had to do the usual interview procedures .

Next to Gotou, Ishii was fidgeting, like he was trying to keep his bladder in check .

After waiting more than long enough, a voice called them in from the speaker .

Gotou and Ishii took the lift to the fourth floor . They followed the instructions of the uniformed guard, entered the room and sat down .

Protective glass divided the room in half . Each side had its own entrance so that the accused and the visitor could not directly touch .

Sitting next to Gotou, Ishii was looking around, unable to calm down, as usual .

Gotou hit Ishii's head casually .

'Ack . '

Ishii yelped like a dog whose tail had been stepped on and held his head in his hands .

It wasn't like Gotou didn't understand how Ishii felt, but they couldn't act disturbed in front of Miyuki .

Gotou crossed his arms and snorted .

At the same time, the door on the other side of the protective glass opened and the guard brought Miyuki in .

Since she was still the accused, she wasn't wearing prison clothes . She had on casual clothes – a white blouse and jeans .

The moment Gotou saw Miyuki, an unpleasant feeling welled up in his stomach .

– Miyuki doesn't regret what she's done .

He felt that way .

Though many people would falter when taken into detention because of the sudden change in environment, Miyuki hadn't changed at all since she was arrested .

On the contrary, when her eyes met Gotou's, her glossy red lips turned up in a smile .

Miyuki sat down as gracefully as a queen in the chair that the guard directed her to .

'My, if it isn't Gotou-san . Even Ishii-san – what is it?'

Miyuki turned towards Gotou and Ishii, sitting like the woman in the Mona Lisa as she said that with half-closed eyes .

Gotou shuddered just from looking at those eyes . Ishii looked at his feet, like he couldn't bear the gaze .

– Don't get caught up at her pace .

Gotou told himself that and glared at Miyuki with his hands in fists on his lap .

'What is it? You're the one who called us here . '

'My, is that so?'

Miyuki hid her mouth with her hand and laughed with shaking shoulders .

– She's enjoying this .

'If you don't need anything, we're leaving . '

'That's fine by me, but somebody important to you will die . '

Miyuki's voice was so empty of intonation it was uncanny .

'That's not what you said . You killed somebody else and were going to tell us about that . Isn't that what you said?'

Gotou leant forward .

– There is another murder .

That was what Miyagawa said, but from what Miyuki said just now, it sounded like that murder hadn't happened yet .

'It seems like the message wasn't carried to you properly . '

The smile left Miyuki's face .

Her expression was as inhuman as a wax figure's, but her eyes alone were sparkling . It was creepy .

'I'm going to kill somebody – that's what I said . '

'That's ridiculous!' yelled Gotou, overwhelmed by his emotions .

However, Miyuki didn't raise even one eyebrow . She continued to speak disinterestedly .

'It isn't impossible for me . '

'Don't make fun of us! You're in prison . There's no way you could kill anybody . Understand the position you're in,' said Gotou all at once, his nose so close to the glass it was almost touching .

Miyuki was imprisoned in the newly built Tokyo Detention House . It couldn't be compared with the old system .

All of the windows were protective glass . The door was made of steel and wouldn't open without both a key and fingerprint recognition . Furthermore,

the security cameras everywhere were always on .

– It's definitely impossible for her to kill someone in this situation .

Miyuki had to be challenging them, saying she'd kill somebody because she was bored from being imprisoned . That was how she entertained herself .

'You think I can't do it . '

Miyuki looked at Gotou with eyes full of pity .

'Of course I don't . '

'Unfortunately, I can . '

'Hah?'

'Even while I'm here, I can kill somebody outside . '

'There's a limit to how far you can take a joke!' spat out Gotou .

However, even while he denied her claims, the anxiety in his chest was stuck there, like gum at the bottom of a shoe .

The reason for that was Miyuki's eyes . Even though what she was saying was absolutely impossible, there was no doubt in those eyes . On the contrary, they appeared filled with confidence .

'I thought that was what you'd say, Gotou-san . '

Miyuki's lips turned up in a smile . Then, she slowly pointed at Ishii .

'But what do you think, Ishii-san? DO you think I can kill somebody elsewhere while I'm in the detention house?'

The conversation suddenly turned to Ishii, and his mouth fell agape as he froze . He was going completely at Miyuki's pace .

– Don't fall for it!

Instead of speaking aloud, Gotou hit Ishii's back .

Ishii came back to his senses, recoiling like a spring .

'I-I don't...'

Ishii fixed the position of his glasses as he looked at his feet .

– There's no point talking any further .

'We don't have the time to go along with your stupid joke,' said Gotou with a click of his tongue . He got up from his seat .

Miyuki stood up as well, as if she were a reflection in a mirror .

Their eyes met through the glass .

The pupils of her narrowed eyes glittered like a drawn sword .

'I don't mind if you think I'm playing around . People won't acknowledge the importance of something until it's happened . '

Gotou couldn't think of a reply .

He knew in his mind that there was no way somebody in detention could kill somebody outside . But what was that numb feeling?

Could this woman really kill somebody at a distance?

A line of sweat ran down Gotou's back .

'It's time . '

The guard walked towards Miyuki . Gotou came back to his senses .

The guard stood in meetings to check that there was no issue with what was being discussed . Despite that –

Miyuki had been discussing a murder plan . It was definitely unnatural for the guard just to stand there like nothing had happened .

'Wait a second!'

Gotou called out at the guard who had tried to leave the room together with Miyuki .

The guard slowly turned around . Those eyes were hollow – it was like they didn't see Gotou .

'What are you planning to do? This woman...'

Gotou hit the glass with his hand .

'Gotou-san . '

Miyuki interrupted Gotou .

'I forgot to say the crucial point . '

'What?'

'The name of the person I'm going to kill...'

'You can't be aiming for Yakumo again, right?'

Gotou said the first thing that came to mind .

Miyuki was so focussed on Yakumo it was extraordinary . If she was going to kill somebody, Yakumo was the only person Gotou could think of .

'Nope . I can't kill Yakumo-kun . '

Miyuki shook her head .

'Then who? Who the hell are you planning to kill?'

Miyuki paused purposefully and then licked her lips, like a snake .

Gotou gulped .

'Saitou Isshin . '

'W-what?'

Gotou's voice caught at the unexpected name .

'I'm going to kill Saitou Isshin from inside this detention house . '

After licking her red lips, Miyuki smiled twistedly .

– Why? Why does she need to kill Isshin?

Gotou thought furiously, but he couldn't find the answer .

Miyuki walked out the door with the guard .

'Oi! Wait! We're not done talking!'

The door closed loudly, interrupting Gotou's frantic yell .

5

Haruka went together with Yakumo and Isshin to the hospital where the spiritual phenomenon occurred .

A number of affiliated hospitals in the city had combined and were rebuilt into a general hospital .

The glass-sided lobby looked at first glance like a high-class restaurant . Haruka had thought it'd be more eerie, so it was a bit anticlimactic .

Isshin went to the reception to call out his friend, the one who had told him about this .

Haruka sat with Yakumo on the bench in the waiting area .

Yakumo had his hands in his pockets and was staring forward, looking displeased .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . Do you think the story earlier was true?'

Haruka recalled the story Isshin had told them earlier .

It was about a girl's ghost who appeared every night in the hospital .

That girl wandered the hospital and would ask patients a question if she found them .

– When are you going to die?

The people who were asked this question always died soon afterwards .

Yakumo's expression was grim, but finally, he opened his mouth while running a hand through his hair .

'I've said this countless times, but the spirits of the dead are clusters of people's emotions . Therefore...'

'They have no physical effect on the living . '

Haruka finished Yakumo's sentence .

He had explained this to her again and again before .

Yakumo could see the spirits of the dead with his red left eye . It was a notion he had come up with from his experiences .

Since spirits of the dead were only clusters of people's emotions, they had no physical influence at all .

Accordingly, they couldn't curse people to death or directly harm them . The actions of exorcists were pointless . That was Yakumo's theory .

'But people actually died, right?'

Haruka said the first thing that came to mind . If the rumour were true, everyone whom the girl asked that question died .

However, Yakumo shook his head in his exasperation .

'You're such an idiot you could be in the Guinness World Book of Records .
,

– When'd my idiocy become world-class?

'Did I say something so strange?'

'You did . '

'But the rumour...'

'That's why I said you're an idiot . Rumours are rumours . '

'But...'

'Plus, this is a hospital . It isn't strange for people to die . '

'Right . My bad . '

Haruka understood what Yakumo was saying, but his tone annoyed her . In the past, she would've cried herself to sleep, but now, Haruka had a trick to fight back .

Haruka waited for a chance to poke Yakumo in the side .

A jolt ran through Yakumo's body and he stood up from the bench .

He looked so strange Haruka couldn't help but laugh .

Yakumo opened his mouth like he wanted to say something when Isshin came back . He was together with a woman in a white and a female nurse .

'Let me introduce her . This is Arai Mao-san, one of my friends from university,' said Isshin, gesturing at the woman in white .

'It's nice to meet you . My name is Arai Mao,' said Mao with good enunciation . Then, she smiled with dimples .

When Haruka heard the story from Isshin, she had thought that his friend was male, so she was a bit surprised .

Mao had an intellectual air to her, but perhaps because of her small frame and skin as smooth as an egg, she looked young .

'My name is Ozawa Haruka . '

Yakumo bowed silently while yawning .

'You must be Yakumo-kun . I've heard about you from Isshin-kun . '

Mao held her hand out towards Yakumo for a handshake .

However, Yakumo didn't appear to notice the hand, and just said, 'Nice to meet you . '

He might have disliked being talked about without his knowing .

'Sorry, Yakumo can be difficult,' said Isshin, smoothing things over .

'More importantly, please let me hear about the spiritual phenomenon . '

Yakumo brought up the main topic while running his fingers through his hair .

Pointless conversations are unnecessary – it was like he was saying that .

'She knows about it in more detail than I do, so do you mind if she explains?'

Mao smiled wryly as she looked at the nurse with her .

'Go ahead . '

Yakumo yawned, seeming uninterested in Mao's suggestion .

'Then Furukawa-san, I leave the rest to you . '

'Yes . '

After replying quietly, Furukawa took a step forward .

Her height wasn't much different from Mao's, but she was a size larger .

She had defined, childish features, but she looked somehow afraid .

'My name is Furukawa . It's nice to meet you . '

'It's nice to meet you as well . '

Haruka bowed politely .

However, Yakumo didn't bow – rather, he looked away .

He was looking at Isshin and Mao, speaking quietly between themselves .

'... discussed... results of the examination...'

Haruka could faintly hear Mao's lowered voice .

– Results of the examination?

Perhaps it was something to do with Yakumo's red eye .

'We're going,' said Yakumo, interrupting Haruka's thoughts .

She saw that Yakumo and Furukawa had already started walking .

'Ah, wait . '

Haruka started walking after Yakumo .

6

– I'm scared .

Ishii finally reached the parking lot .

The distance of only a few dozen metres had felt considerably longer to Ishii .

His ears had been buzzing ever since he heard Miyuki's voice . He was dizzy and his feet were unsteady, as if he had had a bout of anaemia .

Ishii dropped his key a number of times from his shaking hand and finally opened the door to the white Crown to get into the driver's seat .

He leant back on the chair and could tell that his back was damp .

Miyuki's faint smile wouldn't leave his retinas .

Her eyes, mouth and voice – her very existence was the object of terror .

Ishii looked at himself in the rear-view mirror .

– I look awful .

His face was as pale as a dead man's . His eyes were bloodshot .

'Stop spacing out . '

Gotou got into the passenger's seat and hit Ishii's head .

'E-e-excuse me...'

Though Ishii apologised, his feelings didn't change .

– Even while I'm here, I can kill somebody outside .

Miyuki had said that .

Thinking about it normally, that was impossible .

However, Miyuki's eyes then had been filled with confidence, like those of a magician about to show his audience a marvel . Ishii was sure she was

planning something incredible .

'E-er, Detective Gotou . About earlier...'

I want somebody to deny it – that was Ishii's wish as he asked his question .

'It's obviously a lie!' spat out Gotou, in a foul mood .

Though Gotou's words normally reassured Ishii, now they just sounded like a strong front .

'But she didn't look like she was lying . '

Ishii couldn't erase his anxiety .

'Listen – use your common sense . That woman's imprisoned in the Tokyo Detention House . She's locked in a room and is being watched twenty-four hours a day . It's definitely for making an alibi . '

Just as Gotou said, as long as she was imprisoned, committing a crime would be impossible .

Ishii understood that, but something in the back of his mind wouldn't accept that .

Miyuki had trapped them many times up until now . Mightn't she be able to overcome physical convention – thought Ishii .

'She might have a method that we don't know...'

He put his anxiety as it was into words .

'Give it up already . Of course she can't . The story'd be different if she could walk through walls or something,' said Gotou recklessly, lighting up a cigarette .

That moment, a light came on in Ishii's head . A bolt out of the blue –

'Detective Gotou! That's it! That!'

Ishii was so agitated he leant towards Gotou .

'You're so noisy! Calm down!'

Gotou pushed Ishii away from him as he said that .

'I understand! I know how she's going to commit the murder!'

'W-what?'

Even Gotou couldn't hide his surprise as he looked at Ishii with wide eyes .

It made sense for Gotou to be surprised, but Ishii couldn't think of any other method . Ishii was confident in his thoughts .

'Explain,' said Gotou, looking straight at Ishii's eyes .

Gotou's eyes seemed doubtful, but once he heard Ishii's explanation, that would probably change .

'It's simple . The hint was what you said about walking through walls, Detective Gotou . '

Gotou's brows furrowed, and his lips turned down in doubt .

It was such an interesting expression, but Gotou would probably get angry if Ishii laughed so he continued his explanation in a disinterested matter .

'You don't understand? Just as you said, Detective Gotou, she plans on walking through the walls . '

'Hah?'

Gotou cocked his head .

'I'm saying that she has the special ability to walk through walls . From her perspective, it doesn't matter how strictly guarded the detention house is . I mean, she can walk through walls,' declared Ishii clearly .

He was that confident in his own thoughts .

'Ishii . You seriously saying that?'

'Yes . Of course . Walking through walls is possible . I saw it on television before . A man with supernatural powers named David Copperfield...'

As Ishii continued explaining, Gotou's fist came down on his head .

It hurt so much that Ishii couldn't even scream – he just held his head in his hands .

'The next time you say something so stupid, I'm going to kill you,' said Gotou, spitting out his cigarette .

7

– I'm always chasing after him .

Haruka finally caught up to Yakumo and Furukawa at the lift .

It would be more correct to say they were waiting there .

'You're the type who would run away too late during a fire . '

When Haruka got in the lift, Yakumo said that in his usual tone .

He always said one thing too much .

– I don't need to hear that from you .

Haruka muttered that in her heart .

They went up to the third floor and then walked up to the men's lavatory in front of the nurse centre at Furukawa's direction .

'It's here,' said Furukawa, pointing at the door .

After hearing that a ghost was spotted here, the simple door looked like the gateway to hell .

Yakumo opened the door without any hesitation, flipped the light switch by the entrance and went inside .

Haruka and Furukawa stood at the entrance, peering inside .

It was a clean lavatory, surrounded by white walls . Urinals were on the walls with three stalls at the end .

'About a week ago, a young man hospitalised for a stomach ulcer saw a ghost here . '

Furukawa's voice was shaking .

It was like she had experienced it herself .

'Where did he see the ghost?' asked Yakumo .

'At the sink,' replied Furukawa .

'Here?'

Yakumo stood in front of the sink .

'Yes . '

'Then?'

'When he was washing his face, he turned around at the sound of someone's voice . '

Yakumo turned around at Furukawa's words .

His gaze was on the white wall of the lavatory .

'Then?'

'Nobody was there, but when he looked at the mirror again, there was a girl standing behind him . '

'A girl...' said Haruka as she imagined the scene .

When he looked at the mirror, the girl's ghost was standing there . How frightening –

'That girl asked him a question . '

'A question?'

Yakumo raised an eyebrow .

'Yes . '

'What sort of question?'

'When are you going to die – she asked him that,' said Furukawa, opening her eyes wide .

Haruka felt gooseflesh rise on her skin .

– When are you going to die?

Haruka was more frightened by the words the girl's ghost had left .

It made it sound like she wished for that person's death . When she thought about how it was a young girl who'd said that, it made it even more terrible .

'Then what happened to him afterwards?' asked Yakumo lazily after a silence .

'He hurriedly ran out of the lavatory and tried to return to his hospital room, but the girl's ghost was there... and then he headed for the stairs...'

Furukawa left the lavatory entrance and walked towards the stairs .

Haruka and Yakumo followed her .

'Here . '

Furukawa stopped in front of the stairs .

The difference in level was minimal . The stairs were wide and there were landings as the stairway turned .

'The girl's ghost came upon him and he fell here . '

As Furukawa explained, she clasped her hands in front of her chest .

'Then?' urged Yakumo .

'He hit his head, and when we found him, it was already too late...'

Furukawa covered her face with her hands as she finished .

Haruka looked down the stairs . For just a moment, she felt like she could see a bleeding man collapsed at the bottom of the stairs .

Yakumo pinched his brow with his fingers and looked down, as if thinking .

'Can you see anything?'

Yakumo shook his head at Haruka's question .

'I don't see anything now . '

'Then...'

'You make mistakes because you jump to conclusions like that . '

'Can't you say that differently?'

Haruka looked angry, but Yakumo didn't appear to care as he turned back to Furukawa .

'I understand . I'll investigate . '

Yakumo said just that and turned around on his heels . He started walking briskly .

Haruka wasn't sure what to do, so she bowed at Furukawa and chased after Yakumo .

'Hey, did you find out anything?'

Haruka spoke up to Yakumo, but he walked silently to the lift; it didn't seem like he wanted to respond .

'Hey, why are you in such a bad mood?'

She asked Yakumo another question as they waited for the lift to move .

Yakumo sighed and then scowled .

'Listening to that would put anyone in a bad mood . '

'Why?'

'What do you mean, why? Don't you think it's strange?'

Haruka looked up at the ceiling as she thought, but she couldn't think of anything in particular .

'I was an idiot for asking you,' said Yakumo as the lift doors opened . Then he walked briskly to the exit .

Haruka chased after Yakumo's back again .

'Explain properly . '

'Have you really not noticed?'

'I haven't . '

'The young man died after falling down the stairs . '

'What's strange about that?'

'That young man died . '

'Yes . '

'Then why would the nurse know what the ghost said to the young man?'

'Ah!'

Now that Yakumo said it, Haruka finally understood .

If that young man really died, there was no way the nurse could know what the ghost said to him .

'Furthermore, why wasn't it in the news?'

'That's...'

'If a patient died after falling down the stairs in a hospital, there would be a fuss . '

'Right . '

'There are other points that are strange . '

'What?'

'That hospital has been built for half a year . The way the nurse put it, a number of people have died mysterious deaths . '

'She did say that . '

'If that many people have died mysterious deaths, the responsibility of the management would be questioned . '

Yakumo's voice was filled with anger .

After hearing what Yakumo said, an uneasy feeling spread through Haruka's chest .

'Could it be...'

'Correct . That was just gossip . Though it seems like the nurse called Furukawa believes it...'

Yakumo stopped in front of the automatic door as he said that with a disappointed expression .

'How about Isshin-san?'

– Does he know this is just gossip?

Haruka was concerned about that .

'Of course he knows it's gossip . '

'Then why did he go out of his way to consult Yakumo-kun?'

'When that person sees somebody who's troubled, he can't leave them alone . '

'Right . '

Haruka felt that too .

No matter the situation, Isshin was the type of person who couldn't leave somebody who was troubled alone .

'He knew it was gossip and got me to pretend to be an exorcist to control the situation . '

'Really?'

'And that doctor called Mao doesn't believe in the ghost either . '

'Eh?'

'That's why neither she nor Uncle came along . '

'Ah...'

– Come to think of it .

Haruka clapped her hands in understanding .

Yakumo walked through the automatic doors and went outside .

'Hey, where are you going?'

Haruka immediately ran after him .

'Back, obviously . '

'You're not going to wait for Isshin-san?'

'My work is done . '

Yakumo walked away without turning around .

8

Ishii walked through the corridor in the basement of the hospital where the coroner Hata Hideyoshi worked .

The fluorescent lighting was dirty and broken at points, so the corridor was dim and uncanny .

Ishii didn't want to come to a place like this by himself, but he couldn't say something like that .

Gotou was frantically looking for Yakumo and couldn't get away from his work . Plus, the person who'd suggested that they ask Hata's opinion was none other than Ishii .

Ishii stood in front of the door at the very end and knocked as he pinned down his wildly beating heart .

'It's open . '

There was a reply in a hoarse voice .

With the mood of the corridor, that voice sounded more uncanny than usual .

'P-please excuse me . '

Ishii timidly opened the door and went inside .

The room was about six tatami in size . Cabinets lined the walls, while Hata was at the desk in the back .

With white hair and a face that was wrinkled like a dried persimmon, Hata had goggling eyes which were sparkling like those of a child .

He looked just like a demon .

Hata was a perverted coroner who professed that 'corpses had to be raw' .

Gotou always said that Hata would commit a crime someday, but Ishii thought that what Hata said came from an innocent interest in the matter as a doctor .

Hata was unusually interested in the threshold between life and death .

However, just because Ishii thought that didn't mean Hata wasn't frightening .

'Oh, it's you, Ishii-kun?'

Hata took a leisurely sip of his tea .

'Ah, h-hello . '

'The bear isn't with you?'

– Bear?

For a moment, Ishii was confused, but then he realised that Hata was talking about Gotou .

'Detective Gotou is busy with another case...'

'I see . Why not sit down?'

Hata looked at the round chair in the centre of the room .

'Ah, I don't mind standing . '

'Then we can't relax and talk . '

'I-I'm sorry . '

Ishii hurriedly sat down in the chair after Hata said that, sounding depressed .

When they sat in front of each other like this, Hata seemed even more like a demon .

– He really is scary .

'So what are you here for today? You come to ask for a way to kill the bear?'

'T-that's... How could I kill Detective Gotou...'

'That idiot won't get better unless he dies,' said Hata . He seemed to find it funny as he leant backwards and giggled .

Ishii looked at him fearfully, wondering whether his chin might dislocate .

'Actually, I wanted to consult you about something,' said Ishii after Hata finished laughing .

'Consult? All I can help with is corpses . '

'I understand . '

Ishii adjusted the position of his glasses and looked straight at Hata .

Hata seemed to sense something different from usual so he looked back with a serious expression and urged Ishii to continue: 'Try telling me . '

'We went to the detention house today to meet Nanase Miyuki . '

'That must've been a trial . '

Hata's eyes popped out like a fish's .

Even Hata couldn't remain indifferent after hearing her name .

'We were called there . By her...'

'Then?'

'She gave us advance notice that she would kill Saitou Isshin from within the detention house . No, perhaps it was a prophecy . '

'Advance notice of a murder, eh...'

Hata looked grim as he rubbed the white stubble on his chin .

Even Hata was troubled by the situation .

'So I wanted to borrow your knowledge, Hata-san...'

'The method somebody would use to kill somebody else from within a detention house – that's what you want to know . '

'Yes . '

'There's no such method,' said Hata firmly .

The response was so quick that it was anticlimactic .

'No, but...'

'If it were a one-room flat, there could be some sort of trick, but it's different for a detention house . '

Ishii also understood what Hata was saying .

The detention house was fortified with metal walls . It couldn't be left or entered easily . Ishii knew that .

However, that didn't mean he accepted it .

Ishii didn't think that Miyuki had just gave them advance notice of a murder she couldn't do to kill time . She must have been thinking something that Ishii couldn't understand .

'Can you not think of a method besides a trick?'

'Besides a trick?'

'YES . For example, supernatural powers or curses...'

'Curses...'

'Yes . Do you know anything of them?'

'I hear many rumours of that sort, but they're all scams . '

'But...'

'The only real thing I've seen up until now is Yakumo . '

Hata snorted .

It was the same for Ishii, but he still thought there might be something .

'We are dealing with Nanase Miyuki . She might have a special ability . '

'If she is going to kill somebody with supernatural powers or curses – we have no means to stop her . '

Hata gulped down all the tea in his teacup .

'That's...'

Ishii felt like he had fallen into hell .

It was just as Hata said . If she used supernatural powers or curses, even if they knew her method, they, as normal people, had no way to stop her .

'This is just my gut talking, but is Nanase Miyuki's goal murder?' drawled Hata .

'What do you mean?'

'Exactly what I said . '

After Hata said that, he slowly looked up at the fluorescent lights on the ceiling .

Ishii couldn't understand the true meaning behind Hata's words –

9

'Sorry to bother . '

Gotou opened the door to Yakumo's secret hiding place, the <Movie Research Circle> . .

The dim and cold room was silent .

It seemed like Yakumo had gone out without locking the door . Gotou thought it was careless, but then he realised there was nothing to steal from the dreary room .

Gotou sat down on a chair .

– I will kill Saitou Isshin from within the detention house .

Miyuki's words kept repeating in Gotou's head .

It was absolutely impossible . Gotou understood that, but he just couldn't wipe the anxiety away from his heart .

That was why he wanted to hear Yakumo's opinion .

No, he might have just wanted to hear the words 'Killing somebody from within a detention house is impossible' from Yakumo's mouth .

However, Yakumo didn't answer no matter how many times Gotou called .

Gotou had come to Yakumo's secret hiding place because of that, but the room was empty .

'You monster cat . What are you doing at a time like this?'

Gotou clicked his tongue and cursed . Then, his mobile phone started vibrating to tell him he had a call .

– Yakumo!?

'You bastard! Where the hell have you walked off to!?!'

Gotou answered the mobile without checking the display and yelled at the receiver .

<What did you say?>

The voice he heard from the other end of the phone was the thick one of Miyagawa .

'What? It's you, Miyagawa-san?'

<What do you mean, what? Honestly...>

Gotou heard Miyagawa sigh .

'What is it then?'

<What do you mean, what is it? I'm calling about Nanase Miyuki's murder . >

'Did you figure something out?' snapped Gotou .

<No, we don't know the details at all . >

'I see...'

They wouldn't have to put up with so much if they could find stuff out that easily . Gotou understood that, but he couldn't do anything about his rapidly withering feelings .

<There's one piece of bad news . >

'What is it?'

<Regarding the matter of Saitou Isshin's bodyguard...>

The moment Gotou left the detention house, he told Miyagawa the situation and requested that a bodyguard stay with Saitou Isshin for the next little while .

'What happened?'

From the tone of Miyagawa's voice, Gotou could easily imagine what the police had decided, but he decided to ask anyway .

'The guys at the top decided to keep an eye on the situation . '

– As I thought .

'Why?' asked Gotou, though he knew the answer .

<There's no way a murder can occur from within a detention house – that's what they decided . >

'Idiotic . It'll be too late if something happens,' spat out Gotou, disappointed in the answer he had expected .

It was certainly impossible to kill somebody from within a detention house .
Gotou understood that . But there was always the possibility .

It would be too late once it happened .

However, the organisation that was the police wouldn't move their fat bottoms until something happened .

There was a mountain of cases wherein they had the information from the victim but no concrete action was taken .

<We'll need people to guard him . And if the press hear about the police moving because somebody gave advance notice of a murder from within a detention house, it'd be a mess . '

Gotou understood what Miyagawa was saying .

If the police moved now, that would mean they recognised what Miyuki said . Then the press would get all stirred up .

But –

'Who the hell cares? Somebody might get killed!'

<Calm down . >

'How could I be calm?'

<You idiot! Before you go flapping your mouth off, there's something you have to do!'

Miyagawa yelled so loudly Gotou thought the speaker would break .

Gotou's breath caught at the pressure from that voice .

<I told you the decision from the guys on the top . >

'Miyagawa-san...'

<You go protect the monk who's got that murder notice . >

Miyagawa's words changed the anger eddying in the bottom of Gotou's stomach into a sense of duty .

– I'll protect him!

Gotou engraved that determination into his heart .

'I planned on doing that even if you didn't tell me to . '

<We'll look into the background of the guard who was watching when you had your interview . >

Gotou recalled the face of the guard who had watched as he met with Miyuki .

He had left Miyuki alone when she gave advance notice of a murder right in front of him . That attitude was clearly strange . There was a chance it was related to the case somehow .

'Thank you . '

After he said that, Gotou hung up . At the same time, another call came in .

This time it was –

'Who is it?'

<Ah, er, this is Ishii Yuutarou . >

He heard Ishii's hesitant voice .

'What do you want?'

<I just left Hata-san's hospital . >

'And?'

<Unfortunately, I have no new information . >

'You're useless!'

<I-I apologise...>

Even through the phone, Gotou could tell that Ishii was bowing his head .

'Anyway, come right now . '

<Er... Where to?>

'To that monk's place, of course!'

Gotou yelled at the receiver and then hung up .

– I have to protect him .

'I won't let any get killed in front of me . I won't let anyone die . '

Gotou murmured that to incite his own morale and then opened the door to leave the room .

10

– Yakumo really went back .

After deliberation, Haruka decided to wait for Isshin on the bench in the waiting room .

Since Isshin had been the one who asked them to come investigate, Haruka didn't think they should leave without talking to him .

Just as Yakumo said, Isshin might have known that the ghost sighting was just a rumour, but those were two different matters .

Plus, Haruka was interested in why Isshin had taken the request .

She was sure he had some sort of special reason .

While Haruka thought about that, gazing idly at the opposite side of the glass, she suddenly felt somebody's gaze .

She looked up and saw a girl of about middle-school age in front of her .

Her glossy black hair went to her shoulders . Perhaps because of her hollow cheeks, her eyes were goggling .

She just looked at Haruka without saying anything .

'What is it?'

However, the girl stood there without even a twitch, as if she hadn't heard anything .

'Haruka-chan . '

Isshin called out to her as he walked over .

'Ah, Isshin-san . '

Haruka looked up at Isshin .

Isshin noticed the girl in front of Haruka . He looked surprised .

'Yoshiko-chan . '

Isshin called out to the girl .

'Is she somebody you know?'

'She's a patient at this hospital . We were together during the examination earlier . '

'I see...'

'What are you doing here?' said Isshin, crouching down .

Yoshiko's eyes, which had been blank until now, seemed to light up a bit .

That was Isshin for you, thought Haruka . Isshin found a place in your heart no matter who you were .

'I'm looking...' said Yoshiko in a hard voice .

'What are you looking for?'

'Dad . '

Yoshiko's expression clouded over again .

'Your father, eh... You'll definitely find him . '

'Yoshiko-chan . '

A nurse called out and walked over to interrupt them .

Yoshiko turned around in response to that .

'So this is where you were . Come on, let's go back to your room . '

The nurse took Yoshiko's hand .

Yoshiko nodded weakly and was led away by the nurse .

'Her heart is weak,' said Isshin, his eyes narrowed as he watched Yoshiko leave .

'Eh?'

'When we were waiting to get our blood drawn, I talked with Yoshiko-chan a bit . '

'Is that so?'

'I was concerned because she looked so sad, so afterwards I asked the nurse, who said her heart was failing...'

Isshin's eyes looked distant as he said that .

Perhaps he was thinking about Nao .

'By the way, where's Yakumo?' said Isshin, changing the topic .

'He left earlier . '

Haruka shrugged her shoulders .

'I wanted to talk to him a bit, but I guess there's no helping it . '

Isshin knew Yakumo's selfish personality well . That said, he couldn't hide his disappointment .

Somehow, Haruka felt apologetic .

'I'm sorry . '

'No, no, there's no reason for you to apologise, Haruka-chan . '

'But...'

'Now, we should get going too . '

A carefree smile appeared on Isshin's face, and he started walking slowly .

Haruka followed after him .

When they passed through the automatic doors to go outside, the wind blew by them lowly .

That wind felt warmer than usual . Spring was coming soon .

'Yakumo-kun could have said something too . '

Haruka looked at Isshin's profile .

Normally, Yakumo lived in the room for the <Movie Research Circle> at the university, and he rarely visited Isshin's temple, though Isshin was the one who had raised him .

Earlier, Isshin had said there was no helping it, but Haruka could tell that Isshin was regretful .

'Yakumo is a cloud,' Isshin said seriously .

'A cloud?'

'Yes . He won't be bound by anything . When somebody tries to grab him, he slips out of their grasp . '

Isshin had stopped in his tracks . He reached out towards the sky and gripped his fingers, as if trying to grab a cloud .

'That might be true . '

Though Haruka was smiling, those words had stabbed deep in her heart .

– He won't be bound by anything .

It really could be true, but that meant Haruka might have been tying Yakumo down by chasing after him so frantically .

It could be terribly annoying to Yakumo .

Haruka knew it was a bad habit to think so negatively, but she couldn't help but be concerned .

– What does Yakumo think of me?

She felt like the distance between them had closed more than before, but she also felt like there was a wall in front of her that she just couldn't scale .

More than friends, less than lovers – it was a setting that might work out if this were a drama, but being put in this position in reality made her dissatisfied and anxious .

'Are you all right?' asked Isshin, sounding concerned .

Haruka's face heated up – she felt like he had seen through to the bottom of her heart .

'Yes . '

'Did I say something unnecessary?'

'No, that isn't it . '

'Yakumo isn't good at expressing his feelings . He should be a bit sweeter to you ,Haruka-chan . '

– Yakumo being sweet?

Haruka couldn't imagine it at all . She unconsciously started laughing .

'It'd be creepy if he acted that way . '

'Hm, that might be true . '

Isshin scratched his chin and nodded .

'I know very well about Yakumo-kun's contrary act . '

'Right . You might know him better than I do, Haruka-chan . '

Isshin smiled .

It was mysterious how Haruka felt like her worries had been silly just from seeing that gentle smile .

'No, I don't think so . '

'I do though . As long as you're there for him, Haruka-chan, Yakumo will be fine . '

Isshin looked up at the sky and said that cheerfully .

Perhaps putting it this way would be an exaggeration, but he looked like a father seeing his child leaving the nest .

Haruka looked up at the sky as well .

The cloudy sky was dyed a brilliant red .

In the middle of the sky was a single line of clouds, like a brush had artlessly drawn them .

Isshin's eyes looked a bit wet as he stood next to her .

'Did something happen?' said Haruka, looking at Isshin's forlorn profile .

– He's going to disappear .

Isshin looked so fleeting then that Haruka felt that way .

'No, it's nothing . '

'If you're sure . '

Haruka didn't accept that answer, but she couldn't ask further . Haruka felt that way so she looked away from Isshin .

After that, Haruka parted with Isshin at the train station .

'Haruka-chan, from now on, I'll leave Yakumo to you . '

When they parted, Isshin said that with a solemn expression .

Haruka felt like those words had a special meaning to them, but she didn't ask what it was . She just replied, 'Yes . '

Only afterwards did Haruka realise what those words meant –

11

– To hell with it!

Gotou cursed in his heart as he leant back on the passenger seat with a cigarette in his mouth .

He had called Yakumo earlier, but his phone appeared to be off so all Gotou's calls had gone to voicemail .

Yakumo wasn't the only person he couldn't get a hold of .

Gotou went to the temple to guard Isshin, but he had also been out .

The car was parked in front of the temple gates, but all Gotou could do was wait for the person he was supposed to protect .

That just increased his irritation .

Gotou lit up his cigarette to try to calm down .

'Er, Detective Gotou...'

In the driver's seat, Ishii spoke up, sounding troubled .

'Eh?'

'What do you think Nanase Miyuki's goal is?'

'What are you saying?'

Gotou cocked his head .

Her goal was clear . I will kill Saitou Isshin – Miyuki had declared that . That was her goal .

'Hata-san said this . '

'What?'

“Is her goal really murder?”

Ishii adjusted the position of his glasses with his fingers and looked forward .

'Idiot . Don't take that demonic old man seriously . '

Gotou hit Ishii .

However, now that Ishii said that, Gotou realised that there were a number of things that were off .

– Why Saitou Isshin?

Gotou didn't think that Miyuki had a reason to kill Isshin .

If she had a grudge, it would have been Yakumo, who had cornered Miyuki, or Gotou, who had arrested her .

'What do you think?' said Gotou without thinking .

That very moment, Ishii raised his head with sparkling eyes .

'I think it's an experiment . '

'An experiment?'

'Yes . Nanase Miyuki found a way to kill with a supernatural power and she wants to try it on Saitou Isshin...'

Gotou dropped his fist on Ishii's head before he finished speaking .

– I was an idiot for asking .

Ishii had saved Gotou during the last case . Gotou had thought that Ishii had grown a bit, but it appeared he had been mistaken .

'There's no way supernatural powers could kill somebody,' said Gotou with a click of his tongue, putting his cigarette out in the ashtray .

He leant back on the seat and was about to light another cigarette when Ishii suddenly sat up .

'He's here . '

Gotou looked out the window .

He saw somebody climbing the long slope to the temple gates .

– No doubt about it . It's Isshin .

He was walking slowly in his robes and monk's stole as he held Nao's hand .

Gotou leapt out of the car and ran to Isshin .

Isshin may have been surprised to see Gotou running at him at full speed, because he stopped in his tracks with wide eyes, but he soon started smiling gently again as he usually did .

'This is unexpected . Even Ishii-kun is here . What is it?' said Isshin casually, as he looked at Gotou and Ishii, who had arrived a bit later .

'That's not the issue . Where'd you go?'

The irritation that had piled up within Gotou exploded .

Nao winced at that and hid herself behind Isshin, peeking out with just her face .

'I had some business today . I left Nao with an acquaintance, so I went to pick her up . '

'I-I see...'

'Why are you in such a hurry?'

Gotou felt like Isshin's disinterested tone sounded reprimanding .

'There's trouble . '

Gotou took a deep breath to gather himself and then looked straight at Isshin .

'Trouble?'

The smile left Isshin's face; perhaps he felt something unusual from Gotou's gaze .

'Nanase Miyuki gave advance notice of a murder . '

'She's the culprit from last time, yes?'

'Right . '

'Isn't she in the detention house?'

'Yeah . She said she'd kill somebody from inside there . '

'Oh, that'd be quite a feat,' said Isshin .

Isshin, who didn't know the situation, was talking about it as if it were unrelated to him .

'That isn't the problem . '

'Which means?'

'The problem is who she said she's going to kill . '

'It can't be Yakumo, could it?'

There was a glint in Isshin's eyes .

Because he was normally so gentle, the face was so frightening it made Gotou want to step back .

Isshin was always kind, but he couldn't remain calm when it came to Yakumo . However, Miyuki's target wasn't Yakumo .

'It's you . '

Gotou said that, but Isshin didn't seem to understand . He stood there with his mouth half-open .

'Nanase Miyuki said she'd kill you,' repeated Gotou .

This time, Nao seemed to sense something, though she couldn't hear, and she gripped Isshin's hand tightly and looked up .

12

In the living room of the temple's priests' quarters, Ishii knelt on a cushion .

Gotou was sitting cross-legged next to him, and Isshin was across the table from them .

Gotou explained the details of the situation so far to Isshin .

'I understand the gist of it,' said Isshin after Gotou finished .

'Eh?'

Ishii looked up without thinking .

Isshin's expression was as gentle as always as he sipped from his teacup .

– Does he really understand?

Ishii wasn't sure .

Isshin was calm even though his life was in danger .

'You might be killed,' said Gotou forcefully, leaning forward .

Ishii understood how he felt .

Isshin wasn't nervous at all . Perhaps it was so sudden that he hadn't seriously accepted it .

'I know that . '

'Then when?'

'Would panicking here solve the problem?'

Isshin kept his calm even while Gotou was agitated .

'That's not the problem! If you get killed, what would Yakumo and Nao do?'

Gotou smashed his fist against the table angrily .

Still, Isshin did not even move his eyebrow .

– This person understands .

As Ishii watched the exchange, he felt that Isshin did understand the situation he was in .

Isshin knew he was in danger and was preserving his calm .

After a silence, Isshin quietly said, 'I'll leave Yakumo and Nao in your care then . '

'Please don't say that . '

That sounded like a will to Ishii . He looked at Isshin pleadingly .

– I don't want you to die .

It wasn't as if he and Isshin had a particularly deep relationship, but Ishii still sincerely meant that .

'Fine, you damn monk!'

Gotou stood up . His yell shook the whole room .

His face was bright red from anger .

'Don't talk so loudly . '

Isshin smiled wryly .

'It's your fault for saying something morbid!'

'Is that what it sounded like to you?'

Isshin played dumb .

'It did . You idiot . And you don't like me, right? You'll leave the rest to me?
What's wrong with you?'

Gotou crossed his arms and sat .

'It's true that at first I didn't think well of you . '

Ishii was surprised to hear Isshin's words .

It was unexpected – it was the first time Ishii had heard that Isshin didn't like Gotou . Ishii couldn't imagine Isshin not liking anyone .

More than anything, Ishii didn't understand the reason .

'See?'

Gotou snorted angrily .

'Gotou-kun, you made Yakumo, a civilian, cooperate in your investigations of murders . I thought you were an unbelievable detective . '

'That isn't true . Detective Gotou didn't blindly involve Yakumo in cases,' interrupted Ishii, unable to stay silent .

There was an absolute trust between Gotou and Yakumo that others couldn't come into . Ishii felt that painfully as somebody who got to see it up close .

Furthermore, Gotou felt conflicted about involving Yakumo too .

'It is just as you say, Ishii-kun . Gotou-kun has a good subordinate,' said Isshin with a nod .

When Isshin accepted what he said so easily, it felt a bit anticlimactic .

'But earlier...'

When Ishii said that, Isshin's expression became gentler as he looked up at the ceiling .

'By taking part in classes with Gotou-kun, Yakumo became somebody who faces his own fate,' said Isshin seriously .

Ishii had felt that Yakumo had changed too, however slightly . At first, he'd made every complaint he could think of even though he did cooperate, and it had felt like he was being forced into helping against his will .

However, recently, it seemed to Ishii that Yakumo was helping because he wanted to .

'Yes . '

'Recently, I was forced to realise that Gotou-kun has always been thinking of Yakumo and watching over him . '

'What are you saying now?'

Gotou clicked his tongue .

'I think you are a man I can trust . '

'I'm not . '

Gotou looked at the floor awkwardly .

'I don't dislike your boorishness . '

'Don't say something so unpleasant!' said Gotou forcefully, but Isshin smiled like he was enjoying the scene .

Though they were two completely different types of people, they were deeply connected through Yakumo .

To Ishii, Gotou and Isshin looked like very old friends .

'I should get going soon . '

Now that the conversation had calmed down, Isshin sat up .

'Where to?' said Gotou immediately .

'I'm going to do my daily mediation, but will you join me?'

'Don't joke with me,' said Gotou . Then, Isshin nodded and left the room .

His back looked somewhat sad .

'Ishii . '

Gotou stuck out his chin .

Watch Isshin – that was probably what he meant .

'Yes sir . '

Ishii gave a bright reply, but as he stood up, his legs stung from kneeling too long .

Before he took his first step, he fell –

13

The guard Ishikawa was patrolling the building with his subordinate, Sudou .

It had just passed six in the evening, so the lights in the rooms were still on .

Patrolling was much easier at the new detention house .

There was a rectangle of protection glass in the steel doors, so they could check inside just by walking down the corridor .

There was no need to go up to each door to peer in like before .

'Do you know about Number 607?' Sudou said with a smirk .

He was still young . Ishikawa could tell because he would say something like that .

In room 607 was the defendant named Nanase Miyuki . In front of her beauty, everyone stopped .

However, Ishikawa felt afraid of her .

Though she was beautiful, there had to be something dark eddying behind that smile . Plus –

'Do you know what that woman did?'

Though Ishikawa's expression was hard, Sudou was still smirking .

'She's a murderer . '

'Right . '

Because of juvenile law, she couldn't be tried, but she had brutally killed her family when she was just ten years old .

It wasn't something a proper human being would do .

If there were people in this world who were born as criminals, she would probably be one of them .

'But I don't think she did it . '

'That's not something for us to decide . '

'But she said that before . '

When Ishikawa heard Sudou's words, he stopped in his tracks .

'Don't talk to the defendants . I said that . '

Ishikawa walked right up to Sudou .

– Don't talk to the defendants .

Back when he'd just become a guard, Ishikawa was told that by his superior .

There were some defendants who would use words to entice guards . Then the guards would be used and fall down the slope to destruction .

Ishikawa had seen a colleague run errands for defendants before .

That was why Ishikawa was warning Sudou too .

'A little bit is fine, right?' said Sudou, with no concern whatsoever .

The truth was that Ishikawa wanted to say more, but Sudou probably wouldn't listen . Ishikawa gave up and sighed before starting to walk again .

Thump, thump, thump –

The sound of something hitting something echoed through the corridor .

It kept repeating .

Thump, thump, thump –

Ishikawa looked at Sudou . Then, they ran towards the source of the sound .

Thump, thump, thump –

The sound was coming from room 607 .

– What is going on?

Ishikawa stood in front of the door and looked inside through the glass .

It wasn't time for the lights to be turned out, but the lights were off .
Ishikawa couldn't see inside clearly .

He took the torch from his waist and turned it on .

He saw something squirming in the back of the room .

'What's wrong?' he said, pointing the torch's light at the corner of the room .

There, Number 607 was lying down and convulsing like a fish out of water .

Those four limbs were hitting the walls, making the sounds they'd heard earlier .

– What is going on?

'Calm down!' said Ishikawa frantically, but there was no response .

He wanted to carry her to the infirmary immediately, but because of security, the patrols didn't carry room keys .

'W-what should we do?' said Sudou, face pale .

'Call for aid! Quickly!'

'Y-yes sir!'

Sudou hurriedly called for aid on the wireless .

Ishikawa used his torch to watch what was happening inside the room .

Number 607 wasn't moving at all .

It seemed that she had coughed up blood – the floor was covered in it .

– What on earth happened?

All Ishikawa could do was wait for aid to arrive .

Finally, a number of men with the medical officer reached the room .

'What is the situation?' asked the jailer in charge as he unlocked the door .

Ishikawa quickly told him that he had been on patrol when he saw that the defendant had fainted and appeared to have coughed up blood .

When he finished speaking, the door opened .

He went inside with the medical officer and walked up to Number 607 .

The area around her was dyed red with blood .

'Stay with me . '

When the medical officer spoke to Number 607, she opened her eyes slightly .

'... Ki... ll... ed . '

Number 607's mouth moved faintly as she said something .

– What? What is she saying?

Ishikawa put his ear closer to try to hear her .

That moment, Number 607 opened her eyes completely and she gripped Ishikawa's arm .

'I just killed somebody . '

Her weak tone from earlier changed completely – her words were clear .

– What is she saying?

Indifferent to Ishikawa's confusion, Number 607 was put on a stretcher and carried out of the room .

14

In the temple, Isshin sat on the wooden floor to meditate .

The light of the candle was trembling .

A moth scattered its scales as it fluttered about .

Isshin took a deep breath to the bottom of his stomach and went into a half-asleep state .

Doing this calmed his mental state, so that man naturally passed by a corner of his heart .

– The man with two red eyes .

However, his nature was different from usual today .

Mysteriously, Isshin didn't feel hatred or resentment .

He didn't think that things he couldn't even try to make disappear would disappear so easily .

The teachings of Zen did not acknowledge the spirits of the dead .

Believing in the existence of the soul would create an attachment to life and would become an obstruction to discipline . He now actually felt the things he had understood in his head .

– Don't you hate me?

He heard a voice deep in his ear .

Isshin couldn't determine whether that was real or an illusion, but it didn't matter .

'Up until this morning, I thought I hated you,' Isshin said to the candle flame, still sitting in the lotus position .

– Everyone lives with hatred .

The voice spoke .

'That isn't always true . I decided not to hate . '

– Will you always be able to?

The voice was challenging .

However, Isshin's heart still did not waver .

'Forever...'

– Yakumo will fall into darkness ahead .

'He won't fall . '

– No, he will definitely fall . Into a deep darkness .

'It's pointless . No matter how you struggle, you won't be able to capture Yakumo . '

Isshin confirmed that today .

Yakumo was tied with a bond stronger than blood .

They shared with each other the things they each lacked .

At first glance, it looked like a frail relationship wherein they licked each other's wounds, but that wasn't it . It was a firm bond – they supported each other, understood each other and walked together .

Yakumo had found the road he was supposed to take .

Clunk –

There was the sound of something falling . Isshin was brought back to reality .

He opened his eyes .

The flame of the candle was flickering in the wind .

Isshin felt somebody behind him and stood up slowly .

'Who is it?' he said, but nobody replied .

However, he felt an electrifying pressure .

– A thirst for blood .

'Have you really come to kill me?'

Isshin slowly turned around .

In the dim light of the candle, he saw glittering eyes .

There was no hatred in those eyes . A stronger emotion –

'Love...'

Isshin said that in a murmur .

Then, those glittering eyes moved .

The cold flash of a blade thrust forward .

Isshin felt no fear .

Dying here is my fate –

But he wished that he could see the faces of the children he loved once more .

Nao, and Yakumo –

15

– For some reason, my heart's beating strangely .

With crossed legs, Gotou looked out the living room window .

He saw Ishii keeping guard outside the temple . He should've been able to tell if there were any intruders .

Gotou took a cigarette out of his shirt pocket and lit it with his lighter .

He felt the heavy air fill his lungs .

Though Isshin would probably complain – smoking was forbidden – if Gotou didn't smoke a cigarette, he would feel itchy from sitting .

Gotou blew out smoke as he thought about what to do next .

He didn't really think somebody in a detention house could kill somebody in another place, but Miyuki must have had some sort of scheme .

– What the hell is she scheming?

'Ah, damn it!' spat out Gotou, mussing up his hair .

Thinking had never been his strong point . He moved according to instinct .

– If only Yakumo were here .

Just as Gotou clicked his tongue, his mobile phone rang . On the display was the number for Yakumo, who he'd been waiting for .

'Why didn't you answer!?'

Gotou let out all the dissatisfaction that had built up .

<Please don't speak so loudly . >

He heard Yakumo's usual drawl through the phone .

It riled Gotou up to hear Yakumo sounding completely unconcerned .

'I don't have enough time to banter with you!'

<I feel the same way . If that's all then . >

'Wait! Listen to what I'm saying!'

Gotou hurriedly stopped Yakumo from hanging up .

<I said, please don't speak so loudly . >

Yakumo spoke in a disagreeable tone .

However, no matter how disagreeable he found it, Gotou couldn't hang up now .

'Nanase Miyuki said she's going to kill somebody . '

Gotou quickly told Yakumo the main point .

<What do you mean?>

Yakumo returned a question .

Even Yakumo couldn't hide his surprise at the unexpected development .

'She said she's going to kill somebody from inside the detention house . '

<That's impossible . Isn't this sort of faking her specialty?>

Yakumo let out a dry laugh in his exasperation .

'The problem is what comes next . '

<Next?>

'Yeah . The person Nanase Miyuki said she's going to kill – is Saitou Isshin . '

The other end of the phone was so silent it made Gotou doubt whether anybody was listening, but Yakumo was definitely there .

Gotou cleared his throat and swallowed as he patiently awaited the next words .

<Uncle...>

After a long silence, Yakumo finally said just that .

'Yeah . '

There was another silence .

– Where'd that joking attitude go?

Gotou gripped the mobile phone tightly with a sweaty hand .

This was different from making an alibi . Killing somebody from inside a detention house was physically impossible – please say that .

<Gotou-san, where are you now?>

'Isshin's temple . '

<You've told my uncle the situation then . >

'Yeah . '

Gotou could tell that Yakumo's voice was becoming more agitated .

Yakumo, who was normally calm, was clearly disturbed .

<Where is my uncle now?>

– What’s wrong, Yakumo? This isn’t like you .

Gotou murmured that in his heart to shake off his uneasiness .

'Meditating in the temple . '

He looked out the window again as he said that . Ishii was standing as still as a statue, like he had been before .

<In the temple by himself?>

'He said he had to do his daily meditation . Ishii’s guarding the entrance now . '

The moment Gotou finished saying that, the sliding door to the living room opened and Nao rushed in with a panicked expression .

Nao was completely white and half in tears as she tugged at Gotou’s shirt .

'What’s wrong? Calm down . '

Gotou patted Nao’s head to try to pacify her, but it was no use .

She shook her head and ran out of the living room .

– What happened?

<Gotou-san, please go to the temple right now!>

Yakumo’s voice was close to a shout .

Gotou sprang up .

'The temple?'

<Just go!>

Gotou didn’t understand, but he ran out of the living room after Nao .

'What's going on?'

<Nanase Miyuki knows that my uncle is alone when he does his daily meditation!>

The blood left Gotou's face the moment he heard Yakumo say that .

If she knew in advance that Isshin would be alone, she wouldn't need to wait for a chance .

She could just wait there ahead of time .

Gotou ran in bare feet past Nao, pushed Ishii away and went up the wooden stairs to the temple .

His heart was pounding . His blood pulsed through his veins .

– Don't screw with me . As if I'd let something so stupid happen!

Gotou pushed open the sliding door in one swift movement .

For a moment, time stopped .

'...'

He couldn't speak .

– Damn it! What the hell!

The unreliable flame of the candle lit up Isshin's body, collapsed on the floor .

Stabbed into his stomach like a gravestone was a knife with a silver design .

The blood from the wound pooled on the floor, outlining the contours of Isshin's body in dark red .

'Ishii! Ambulance! Now!'

Gotou approached Isshin as he yelled that .

He picked up Isshin's wrist to check his pulse . It was very weak, but it was still there .

Then, he put his ear near Isshin's mouth to check his breathing . Though it was faint, he was still breathing too .

– It's OK . He's still alive .

'Oi! Can you hear me? Give me a response!'

Gotou called out to try to wake Isshin up as he looked at the wound in his stomach .

The knife was below his left rib and thrust in up to the hilt . If he took the knife out unskilfully, it would injure him even further .

From the length of the design, the blade was probably ten to fifteen centimetres .

'It's OK . You won't die from something like this!' said Gotou, as if reprimanding his own weakness .

– Anyway, I have to stop the blood .

He ripped his shirt sleeve, scrunched it up and pressed it against the wound .

The shirt was soon dyed a deep red .

Isshin's expression twisted as he opened his eyes slightly .

Did he wake up?

'Oi! What the hell are you sleeping for!? Wake up!' said Gotou all at once .

Isshin's face was twisted from pain, but he moved his mouth slightly . He was trying to say something .

However, it didn't make it into words .

'What is it? What do you want to say?'

Gotou put his ear closer to try to hear the words, but Isshin closed his eyes again .

'Idiot! If you've got something you want to say, say it clearly!'

He hit Isshin's cheek with his flat palm .

However, there was no response .

– Damn . Did he faint?

Gotou heard a child crying .

He looked to the temple entrance and saw Nao standing there while crying .

'Don't cry! It's fine! He won't die! I definitely won't let him die! So don't cry!'

Partly because Gotou was in chaos, he made it sound like a threat .

In response, Nao nodded firmly, though she couldn't hear .

'Right . That's good . '

– Nao, you're a strong girl .

Gotou even felt angry when he saw her brave figure . It was anger towards Isshin .

'Oi! You'd better not die! You absolutely can't do something to make that girl sad! You've got a family you have to protect! No matter what happens, you have to live! If you die, I'll kill you again! Got it!?'

Gotou's veins stuck out as he frantically yelled at Isshin in his anger .

However, Isshin didn't open his eyes again .

NOTES:

[1] Dhyana mudra is the gesture for meditation in Buddhism, called hokkai jouin (法界定印) in Japanese . THIS is an example of what it looks like .

[2] An ensou (円相) is a circle drawn in one stroke in Zen buddhism and symbolises enlightenment and the universe . It is written with the kanji for circle and appearance in this book but the latter can be exchanged for the kanji meaning window (窓) . HERE is one being sold on Rakuten .

[3] Mu (無) is a Buddhist term meaning without or nonexistence . It comes up in a Zen koan which goes something like as follows: 'Does a dog have Buddha-nature or not (無)?' 'Not (無) . '

Volume 6 Chapter 2: VOLUME 6 – TO THE LIMITS OF DESPAIR (1)

Chapter 2

VOLUME 6 – TO THE LIMITS OF DESPAIR (1)

file 02: fluctuation (yin) (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

– I can't believe it .

Haruka dressed herself hurriedly, left the flat and rushed into a cab .

Even after she told the driver the address, it felt unreal, like she was watching a television drama .

The city scenery passing her by in the window that should have been familiar also looked like something from a different world .

Her fingers were trembling slightly .

– Why did this happen?

<Isshin-san was stabbed and taken to the hospital . >

When Ishii told her that, all she could say was 'Is that so?' because she hadn't known what to reply since it was so unexpected .

How was his condition? Why did something like this happen? And who did it?

She had many questions, but at that moment, all of them flew out of her head .

– This is a dream .

She thought that many times . Even now, as she rode in the cab, she still wondered if she would wake up .

There was no reason for Isshin to be stabbed .

He was the sort of person who others would be grateful for rather than begrudge .

– Then why?

Haruka clasped her hands together and just prayed that Isshin would be all right .

When she got to the bed, Isshin would be lying on the bed and smile, saying, 'I'm fine . It's just a graze . ' Then, Yakumo would complain, saying, 'Uncle, you shouldn't scare people like that . '

– Right . That's how it'll go . Please let it go that way .

The more Haruka wished, the more the uneasiness in her heart grew .

Finally, the cab arrived at the hospital entrance .

It was the hospital she had visited with Yakumo and Isshin today . She hadn't thought she would return like this .

Haruka paid the driver the fare and got off the cab to go into the hospital's night entrance .

She went through the passage and stepped into the dim and quiet lobby .

She saw people sitting next to each other on the bench in the corridor .

It was Gotou and Nao .

Gotou had his head hung low, and his shirt was dyed deep red .

Nao was hugging her knees as she sat .

– This really isn't a dream .

'Detective Gotou . '

Haruka put strength into her body and called out to Gotou .

Gotou slowly looked up .

His usual hearty demeanour was gone – he looked like he could die at any moment .

'Oh, it's you, Haruka-chan?' replied Gotou, raising his right hand .

Nao looked up as well .

Her eyes were filled with tears, but she was biting her lip to keep them from falling .

It hurt to look at her trying to act strong .

'Nao-chan, you OK?' said Haruka, sitting down next to her .

Nao's face was red from holding in her emotions .

'You can cry,' said Gotou, patting Nao on the head .

With that, Nao flew towards Haruka .

Haruka accepted Nao and hugged her tightly .

Nao sobbed, shoulders shaking . Haruka's shirt was wet with Nao's tears .

Haruka gently rubbed Nao's back .

'It's fine . It'll be fine,' murmured Haruka, hugging Nao more tightly .

Since Haruka hadn't heard the situation, there was no evidence behind those words, but all they could do now was believe in them .

After crying for a while, Nao calmed down .

Finally, she wiped her tears and sat back down on the bench, hugging her knees .

'Damn, what a strong girl,' said Gotou with a wry smile .

'It's true . Nao-chan is a strong girl,' agreed Haruka .

'This girl was there too . She was crying because of what happened, and I told her not to . Then, she completely stopped and had held it in until now .
,

Gotou appeared to be regretting what he said .

'Nao-chan, you did well . '

Haruka patted Nao's hair and gripped her hand .

Nao gripped Haruka's hand too .

It was a small but very strong hand .

'How is Isshin-san's condition?'

Haruka said the thing highest up on her mind .

'Still in surgery . I don't know anything either . '

Gotou gave a vague response .

However, from looking at the blood on his shirt, Haruka could easily imagine that the situation wasn't good .

– But it'll be fine . Isshin-san won't die so easily . '

'Where's Yakumo-kun?'

She'd thought he'd be here first, but she didn't see him .

'Ishii went to pick him up . '

'I see...' murmured Haruka, looking at her feet .

After that, nobody spoke .

The silence made it feel like even time was in a stupor .

I wonder how much time has passed –

The sound of footsteps echoed through the lobby .

Haruka looked up .

Yakumo was there, like he had come out of the darkness .

He didn't appear rushed . He walked slowly, like he was checking every step .

'Yakumo-kun...'

Haruka stood up and called out to him .

However, she didn't know what to say next, so she shut her mouth .

Yakumo walked up to them with a blank expression and patted Nao lightly on the head .

Though his mouth didn't open, it looked like the two of them, who were facing each other, were saying something to each other .

'How's Uncle?' said Yakumo to nobody in particular .

'In surgery . He lost consciousness, but he was breathing,' explained Gotou in a plain tone .

'Is that so?'

Yakumo said just that and then fell silent .

'I'm sorry that happened while I was there . '

Gotou stood up and bowed deeply towards Yakumo .

However, Yakumo made no response, as if he hadn't heard anything . It was like his spirit had left him .

Ishii returned, a little late .

'How is the situation?'

Ishii ran in and spoke in an inappropriately loud voice .

'Quiet!' said Gotou . He put a cigarette in his mouth and sat on the bench .

Haruka wanted to say something to Ishii, who looked confused, but she couldn't bring herself up to it .

Haruka silently looked down again .

'Are you relatives?'

After a while, a man in a green operating gown spoke to them .

His oval face looked exhausted . He was so pale somebody might suspect he was a patient .

'I am the doctor on duty, Sakakibara . '

The man in the operating gown gave his name .

A nurse was behind him . It was Furukawa, the nurse who had shown the around the hospital for the ghost sighting .

'Oi! How's his condition?'

Gotou was the first to speak .

Yakumo was standing and looking forward, like he had been before .

'He escaped death, but he hasn't woken up yet . We cannot say anything for certain until we observe his condition for longer . '

'Is he OK?'

Gotou stood up forcefully .

'We don't know . At this stage, he cannot breathe automatically,' said Sakakibara quickly, perhaps disturbed by Gotou's fierceness .

'What do you mean, you don't know!? Aren't you supposed to be a doctor?'

Gotou gripped Sakakibara by the collar and shook him threateningly .

'Please calm down . '

Furukawa stepped between them to try to stop him, but she was thrust away .

'Shut up! If anything happens to him, I'll kill you instead!' threatened Gotou further .

Things couldn't keep going like this . Haruka stood up to stop Gotou, but Yakumo spoke up before she could .

'Gotou-san, please stop . '

Though he didn't speak loudly, that one sentence made everyone stop moving .

Gotou lost his force, like a balloon leaking air, and he let go of Sakakibara's collar .

Yakumo bowed towards Sakakibara, saying, 'I apologise . '

'Anyway, the patient will be moved to the ICU . At this stage, we cannot allow visits, but you can look from outside .

'I will show you the way,' said Furukawa .

'Damn it!'

Gotou kicked the bench, letting his anger out at something since it had nowhere to go . The loud noise reverberated through the loudly .

Yakumo's murmur blended into the sound .

– I couldn't save anyone this time either .

2

– I couldn't save him, even though I was right there .

Gotou's anger was directed towards his own weak-mindedness .

The anger couldn't have been settled by kicking a bench . He knew that, but if he hadn't done it, he might have collapsed .

Gotou's life operated like this .

– I won't let anyone be killed . I won't let anyone die .

He had come so far believing that, but those thoughts never reached the whole way .

He saw Yakumo and the others walking down the corridor, led by the nurse .

However, Gotou didn't feel like following them .

He was frozen in the corridor like he had become a rock .

– Even though I vowed to protect him no matter what, I couldn't do anything .

He felt close to despair as the strength left his body .

He looked at his palms – they were dyed dark red with Isshin's blood .

'Damn it . '

Regretting wouldn't turn back the clock, but he still couldn't help but think about it .

– Why did I leave Isshin by himself?

'It isn't your fault, Detective Gotou,' said Ishii, looking like he might start crying at any moment .

The trite consolation made Gotou even angrier .

'Then whose fault is it?'

'Eh?'

Ishii stepped back when Gotou glared at him .

'If it's not my fault, whose is it?'

'That's...'

Ishii looked frightened, but Gotou approached him more .

'Is it your fault?'

'I...'

'Who? Whose fault is it?'

'No... I...'

'Tell me!' yelled Gotou, lifting Ishii by his shirt .

Normally, Ishii would have shrieked, but his mouth turned into a hard line and he took Gotou's anger head-on .

'That's right . It's my fault . '

Ishii's shoulders shook . There were tears in his eyes .

– Don't make that face .

'You...'

Though Gotou said that, he felt his anger rapidly dissipating .

Ishii was suffering himself because he felt responsible, but he had still spoken to Gotou in his consideration .

Gotou hadn't thought he'd need a weak man like Ishii to be considerate of him .

– What am I doing?

He felt very small for blaming himself and stopping .

He could regret as much as he wanted later, but there were other things he had to do now .

'If I had noticed something in the temple, Isshin-san wouldn't have been stabbed . It was my fault . Everything was my fault . '

Ishii's face was wet with tears as he spoke pleadingly .

'Don't cry!'

Gotou hit Ishii's head .

It felt like something had been woken from its sleep .

– There are things I still have to do .

He remembered .

He needed to reveal the truth of the case and make Miyuki pay for it . That wasn't all .

– I'll leave Yakumo and Nao in your care then .

Isshin's words came up in Gotou's head .

– He left Yakumo and Nao to me .

When Gotou thought that, he was stirred up by a strong force .

'It wouldn't have mattered if somebody like you were there or not . '

Gotou let go of Ishii and clicked his tongue .

Ishii staggered backwards .

'What are you spacing out for?'

Gotou hit Ishii's head again .

At first, Ishii shrugged in pain, but when he looked at Gotou, his expression became brighter immediately .

'I-I apologise . '

'There are things we've still got to do . We'll regret later . '

Gotou said that to Ishii, but the words were actually also directed to himself .

It wasn't like him to regret the past and think about questions with no answers . He'd move, move and move .

– That's the sort of guy I am .

'Yes sir . '

Ishii stood up straight .

He'd never live down letting Ishii notice the important things before him .

Gotou hit Ishii once more .

'We're going . '

Gotou spoke up loudly and then he started walking after Yakumo .

3

Haruka walked down the corridor, holding Nao's hand .

More than being considerate of Nao, it felt like Haruka would lose herself if she didn't hold onto somebody .

She looked at Yakumo, walking ahead of them .

His back wasn't crying or angry .

– Yakumo's empty shell .

It wasn't an exaggeration – Haruka really felt that way .

Finally, they reached the ICU with Furukawa's guidance .

Through a thick glass, Haruka could see Isshin lying on a bed .

Machines such as an ECG and EEG surrounded him, their many cords and tubes stretching over Isshin's body .

A respirator covered his mouth and nose, so Haruka couldn't see his face clearly .

Sakakibara and a number of nurses kept going in and out . It appeared that they were working hard to treat him .

Nao's eyes were completely red as she pressed herself against the glass to look through it .

The difficult reality that was happening in front of her eyes –

Haruka's chest hurt when she saw Nao accepting that and bearing it .

– Does Nao have any relatives besides Isshin?

That question suddenly came up in Haruka's head .

Nao wasn't old enough to live on her own . On top of that, she was deaf .

'How's his condition?'

A voice interrupted Haruka's thoughts .

She turned around to see Gotou standing there . Ishii was behind him .

'We cannot make any predictions yet . '

Furukawa spoke instead of Haruka .

'You better not die . '

Gotou said that threateningly to Isshin through the glass .

'Isshin-san won't die and leave Nao-chan behind,' said Haruka, clutching Nao's hand .

Nao nodded in response .

When Gotou saw that, he seemed to become determined and he patted Nao's head with a nod .

'Hey, Yakumo . '

Gotou looked at Yakumo .

Yakumo slowly raised his pale face . Though he didn't respond, Gotou continued .

'I'll take care of Nao . '

Haruka's eyes went wide at those unexpected words as she looked at Gotou .

Even Yakumo appeared surprised . He gaped at Gotou .

'I'll leave Nao in your care – that's what Isshin said to me . '

Gotou scratched his head awkwardly and sat in front of Nao .

'Hey . That's OK, right?'

Gotou turned a gentle smile that Haruka had never seen before towards Nao as he asked for her agreement .

Nao nodded, though Haruka didn't know if she heard the words .

Gotou patted Nao's head and then stood up .

He had to stay firm . Though Gotou didn't say that aloud, Haruka felt that from Gotou .

'Yakumo . You don't have any complaints either, right?'

Yakumo nodded silently at Gotou's question .

Yakumo was always calmer than anybody and distant no matter where or when, but right now, he was like a piece of glass that would break if you touched it .

– Can I do anything at a time like this?

Haruka thought about it, but she couldn't find an answer .

'I would like to discuss the patient with a relative...'

Sakakibara came out of the ICU and called out to them .

Yakumo silently nodded .

'Would you come to the first-floor examination room? Let's talk there . '

After Sakakibara said that, he looked at all of them, bowed and then stuck his hands in the pocket of his white coat before walking down the corridor .

Even after Sakakibara left, Yakumo just looked down the corridor .

As if something was there –

Haruka looked down the corridor as well .

– What's that?

She was so surprised she couldn't speak .

A girl stood there .

Only her face was enveloped in a black shadow, as if it were dyed with ink .

– She isn't from this world .

Haruka felt that immediately . She could see through the girl .

Perhaps that's the ghost in the rumour that's spreading through the hospital

–

That girl opened her mouth .

'... die... soon... too...'

With the noise, Haruka couldn't clearly hear what she said .

Finally, the girl disappeared, as if she had been swallowed by the darkness .

Nao looked at Yakumo questioningly .

She might have heard something .

'Yakumo-kun . That...'

Though Haruka spoke to him, there was no response from Yakumo .

Yakumo took out the black contact lens in his left eye .

Yakumo's vivid red left eye was exposed .

'This...'

After murmuring that, Yakumo dropped his contact lens to the floor and stepped on it .

Crack –

The sound of the lens breaking sounded incredibly loud to Haruka .

'Yakumo-kun...'

Yakumo was clearly acting strange .

– Yakumo's going to disappear .

Haruka spoke up in her uneasiness .

'Take care of Nao for me,' muttered Yakumo . Then, he walked towards the darkness down the corridor .

– You're OK, right, Yakumo?

Haruka murmured that in her heart .

4

Gotou was driving the car .

He looked at the rear-view mirror and saw Haruka and Nao sitting in the backseat .

They seemed afraid of something .

'OK?' said Gotou, turning around after stopping the car at the red light .

– Is what OK?

He had just been trying to put them at ease, but even he thought it was a stupid question .

However, Haruka seemed to understand Gotou's feelings and showed him a smile .

'Yes . '

Though she had a stiff smile instead of her usual bright one, it made him feel a bit better .

'I see...'

Gotou said just that and started the car .

'Er... is it all right not to say anything to your wife?' asked Haruka, sounding concerned .

'It's not a big deal . '

Gotou shrugged with a smile .

However, the truth was that Gotou had no idea how his wife Atsuko would react .

There was no time to make a fuss about it – would be his excuse .

It wouldn't be the first time he used it .

– When did that start?

He found the answer to that immediately .

It was when Atsuko had had a miscarriage . Because of that, she could no longer bear children .

– Sorry .

Atsuko had said that to Gotou as an apology .

– Why are you apologising? Having no children isn't a big deal . I'm fine as long as I have you .

That was what Gotou had really felt .

However, for some reason, he hadn't said it aloud .

At the time, all Gotou had done was nod silently .

– Idiot!

Gotou had yelled that at himself, but he just couldn't honestly express his feelings .

After that, the number of conversations he had with his wife rapidly lessened .

'What a stupid man...'

He unconsciously spoke aloud .

'Eh?' said Haruka .

'Nothing,' responded Gotou with a wry smile . Then, he parked his car in the parking lot for the police residence, where he lived .

'We're here . '

Gotou turned off the engine and got off the car . Then, he looked up at the fourth-floor window for his flat .

The light was on .

It was always like this . No matter how late Gotou returned, the light would still be on .

When his relationship with Atsuko began, he had once mentioned that lonely it was living alone and returning to a dark room .

Now that he thought about it, it had implicitly suggested that he wanted to marry her .

Atsuko still hadn't forgotten that conversation – she always kept the light on .

'OK, let's go,' said Gotou, waiting for Haruka and Nao to get off the car .

He didn't know how Atsuko would react, but there was no point grumbling now .

Determined, Gotou went through the entrance, took the elevator up to the fourth floor and stood in front of the door to his flat .

He never pressed the intercom button .

Whether Atsuko was asleep or awake, he'd unlock the door with his own key and go inside . However, today, the situation was different .

Gotou took a deep breath and pressed the intercom button .

Soon there was a sound and the door opened .

Atsuko didn't look surprised even after seeing Haruka and Nao at Gotou's side .

'Oh, what is it?' said Atsuko without any delay .

'We're taking care of this girl for the next little while,' said Gotou quickly, pulling Nao towards him .

For some reason, his hand was shaking .

'OK,' said Atsuko, crouching to greet Nao with a smile .

Nao smiled back .

Even though it was an unreasonable request, Atsuko just accepted it, without asking anything . Though Gotou felt grateful to her, he didn't know how to express it .

This wasn't the first time for that either .

He was always grateful to Atsuko, but he never said anything . That had become natural for him .

Despite that, Atsuko never asked for a divorce .

– Why does she stay with me?

Sometimes Gotou wondered about that .

What was fun about being with somebody like him who never considered the home like him? Wouldn't Atsuko have preferred a different life?

Gotou didn't have the courage to ask .

'I'm going back to the precinct now . Ask Haruka-chan for the details . '

'Eh?'

Haruka sounded confused, but Gotou pretended not to hear and left to escape .

– Why am I running?

He didn't know .

After he reached the elevator, his feet suddenly stopped and turned around .

It looked like Atsuko and the others had already gone inside – he couldn't see them .

– What am I doing?

Gotou clicked his tongue and went into the elevator .

5

After Ishii returned to the precinct, he sank into his chair .

– I couldn't do anything .

That sense of helplessness made him feel even more exhausted .

The image of Isshin bleeding on the floor kept flashing in front of his eyes .

I should have been able to save him . But –

Interrupting Ishii's thoughts, which were becoming increasingly negative, his mobile phone rang . The number on the display was Hijikata Makoto's .

'Hello, Ishii speaking . '

Ishii answered the phone with a heavy heart .

<The situation has become serious . >

That was the first thing Makoto said .

Makoto, who was a newspaper reporter, had probably heard that Isshin had been stabbed .

'Yes...'

Ishii gave a flat reply .

<Are you all right?>

Makoto's worried voice reverberated in Ishii's weakened heart .

'It's my fault...'

He hadn't planned on saying it, but he'd let it out of his mouth before he noticed .

The first impression Ishii had of Makoto was fear .

However, after a number of cases, he had come to know her and that impression had changed greatly .

Makoto was somebody who could be attentive of others . During the last case, Makoto had been the one who held out her hand towards Ishii, who had lost his way .

<What's wrong?>

Makoto spoke in a gentle voice .

'I was at the scene . I was guarding Isshin-san, but...'

<Ishii-san...>

'That's why everything's my fault . '

<That's not true!>

Makoto let out a loud voice on the other side of the phone .

'Eh?'

<If anybody is responsible, it's the culprit . Don't you think so?>

'Yes,' replied Ishii, pressured by Makoto's forceful tone .

<Let's work our hardest to arrest the culprit . I'll help as well . >

'I understand . Thank you very much . '

After saying his thanks, Ishii hung up .

He felt like his spirits were just a bit refreshed .

Just as Makoto said, I have to work my hardest to arrest the culprit now –
Ishii felt like he had cleared his mind .

Just as Ishii turned back to the desk with a fresh mind, the door opened .

'You were back?'

Miyagawa came into the room .

Though he didn't say anything, there was regret on his face .

– If I'd put out more guards .

His thoughts were clear on his face .

'Yes sir . '

'Then where's Gotou?' asked Miyagawa, looking at the chair across from
Ishii .

'He returned to the official residence . '

'Hm?'

Miyagawa frowned . He looked dubious .

'E-er, um... He took in the victim's daughter, so...'

Ishii quickly gave an explanation . Miyagawa's frown deepened .

When Gotou said he would take Nao in, Ishii had been surprised too . He
hadn't thought Gotou would say that .

However, now that he thought about it, it was like Gotou .

Gotou was more soft-hearted than anyone . He wasn't somebody who could refuse when asked to do something .

'Gotou took in the victim's doctor?'

'Yes . The victim, Saitou Isshin-san, said he would leave the rest to Detective Gotou...'

'I see...'

Miyagawa looked up at the ceiling with great feeling and lit a cigarette .

The smoke slowly rose .

'Right . I almost forgot something important . '

After a silence, Miyagawa threw a file onto the desk .

'What is this?'

'The background of the guard on duty during the interview . '

'Ah,' said Ishii in understanding .

The guard had been silently when Miyuki announced that she was going to kill somebody . Gotou had said it was suspicious and asked Miyagawa to look into his background .

Ishii flipped through the pages and looked at the documents .

Yamamura Mikio . Twenty-six years old . After graduating high school, he passed the examination to become a guard and took that on as his job .

'Ah!'

Ishii had been disappointed, but he unconsciously spoke up when he saw the address .

'What?'

Miyagawa probably felt something . His eyes were sharp .

'It's Yamamura's address . '

'Address?'

'Yes . It's ○ ○ . On the map...'

Ishii searched through his drawer, took out an atlas and spread it out on the desk .

He flipped through the pages to find ○ ○ .

'Here,' said Ishii, pointing at a spot on the map .

Right then, Miyagawa's expression completely changed .

'That's where Nanase Miyuki's case occurred fifteen years ago...'

Tension ran across Miyagawa's face .

The place Yamamura lived and the place Miyuki lived were only a hundred metres apart, though the town names were different .

Though Ishii had no idea what that meant, he couldn't write it off as just a coincidence .

'Perhaps Nanase Miyuki and Yamamura might have interacted when they were younger . '

By saying that aloud, Ishii became agitated .

He adjusted the position of his glasses with his finger and looked at the map again .

Their ages were close, so it was very possible .

If he imagined a bit further, he couldn't deny the possibility that they had kept in contact even after the incident fifteen years ago .

'We can't say anything with just this . It might just be a coincidence,' growled Miyagawa, scratching his chin .

'Right...'

Ishii had no reply to that .

When he thought about it more, it was too hasty to think that Yamamura might be a conspirator just because he lived close by .

'But it's too good to ignore . '

Miyagawa smirked at Ishii .

Ishii had been withering, but that was enough to make him swell up .

'Yes sir . '

'All right . I'll look into Yamamura some more in the detective department . You and Gotou can look into other lines for me . '

'Other lines?'

'Any trivial thing is fine . Look into what happened at the scene again . '

'Yes sir . '

They had been at the scene .

Did we miss something – by looking into their memories again, they might be able to make new discoveries .

'I'm counting on you . '

Miyagawa picked up the documents and left the room .

– I'm counting on you .

The last thing Miyagawa said circled in Ishii's mind .

Ishii had virtually never been counted on to do something in his life before .
The exhilaration he had never felt before naturally brought a smile to his face .

6

Yakumo left the hospital through the night exit .

His body was heavy .

It felt like he would sink into the floor if he stopped even shortly .

Where should I head – without the answer to that question, Yakumo started walking .

He treaded along the asphalt road .

The sound of the passing cars was discomfiting .

He wanted to stifle his five stimulating senses and go to a world with nobody in it .

However, no such place existed .

No matter how much he ran, he would not be able to escape .

When Sakakibara informed him of Isshin's condition, he could not possibly accept it . He wanted to believe it wasn't the case .

– Why did this happen?

In Yakumo's heart, rather than pondering over that question, he thought about how it was his fault that Isshin was in this situation .

Before he noticed, he had reached an empty lot .

It had originally been a building – but now it had been demolished, its rubble left behind .

– I should have died here .

Fifteen years ago, Yakumo's own mother strangled him here and brought him near death .

However, he did not die .

To put it correctly, he was saved by one man .

– If I had died then .

That thought had passed Yakumo's head countless times .

It is not as if I resent anybody . But perhaps I would have been happier if I had not existed – he would think that way .

He had seen the lives and deaths of many people up until now .

He had thought that he would become accustomed to it, but the wounds they carved into him grew deeper each day .

If he had died then, he would not have lost the people important to him .

He might not have suffered this way .

Naturally, he had experienced happiness in his life, but he felt that it had come together with the unhappiness of others .

My own cursed existence continues to make those around me unhappy –

Yakumo looked up at the sky .

The moon was out .

Its pale light was dazzling .

'What should I do?'

Nobody answered his question .

Yakumo started walking again in pursue of that answer .

He passed the shopping street in front of the train station and silently climbed the slope up to the university .

He finally reached the university .

In the moonlight, the lone school building stood like a gravestone .

Yakumo went around the back to the prefabricated building in Building B .

He opened the door to the <Movie Research Circle> and the very end of the first floor and stepped inside .

It was a dreary room, furnished with only a table, a refrigerator and a sleeping bag, but he had many memories here .

He had not had any memories until a year and a half ago .

However, her existence had made memories in this inhuman place .

Like being submerged in lukewarm water, he had even felt like his own existence had been recognised .

– That is a delusion .

He heard a voice .

Yakumo was uncertain as to whether it was his own inner voice or somebody else's .

– Your red left eye is cursed . It makes everyone around you unhappy .

'Then what should I do?'

Yakumo looked up at the sky and asked that question to nobody in particular .

– The fleeting illusion of being loved will make you suffer .

'This voice...'

Yakumo realised the voice was not his inner one but that of a third party .

This voice's owner was outside the room .

Yakumo immediately flew out of the room to look around .

However, all that was there was a pitch-black darkness .

7

Haruka woke up with a gasp .

Her hands were clammy with sweat .

She must have had an incredible nightmare, but she couldn't remember what happened in it .

Nothing was clear . It was like her brain was refusing to accept what was happening .

Haruka was lying on top of a beige sofa .

Wind blew in from the window, moving the white lace curtain .

She didn't recognise the room .

— Where am I?

Haruka slowly sat up .

'Are you all right? It seems like you've had quite the nightmare . '

She heard someone's voice .

Haruka looked up to see a woman come into the room .

She looked to be in her late thirties . Her almond eyes seemed a bit strict, but she was a beautiful woman with a tidy air .

Haruka finally realised where she was when she saw this woman's face .

She was Gotou's wife, Atsuko .

When Haruka remembered that, the memories of last night came afresh to her mind .

Haruka couldn't leave Nao alone when she looked so anxious, so she had come with her .

Gotou told Atsuko that they would be taking care of Nao for a while and left without explaining the details .

However, Atsuko hadn't thought anything of it despite that .

— Welcome .

She had taken Haruka and Nao into her home with a smile, prepared a futon and kept busy until Nao fell asleep .

Once things calmed down, Haruka explained what had happened up until now .

It had taken longer than she thought it would . Gotou didn't seem to have explained anything about the case yet, so Haruka had had to start from everyone's relationships .

It seemed like Haruka had fallen asleep in her exhaustion .

To be honest, she wasn't even sure how much she had explained .

'I'm sorry . It looks like I fell asleep . '

'Oh, don't worry about it . '

'How much did I explain?'

'You were kind enough to explain to the end,' said Atsuko, sticking up her thumb .

'I see... I'm sorry . '

'Ah, that's right . You'll eat breakfast, won't you?'

Atsuko wiped her hands on her blue apron and tied up her hair as she said that .

From just their faces, it felt like Beauty and the Beast, but her brisk way of talking was very similar to Gotou's .

They really are married – Haruka felt strangely touched by that .

'No, I'm sorry for staying so long . I should go soon...' said Haruka quickly, getting up .

'That's no good . '

'Eh?'

'I've already made it, so you have to take responsibility . '

If Atsuko said that much, Haruka couldn't refuse .

'I really am sorry . '

Haruka bowed her head .

Atsuko put a hand on her waist and looked at Haruka like she thought her mysterious .

'What a strange girl . Why are you apologising?'

'Even if you ask me... why...'

She didn't have a reason .

Apologising had always been her habit .

'Taking things on yourself, blaming yourself and apologising . '

– That's tedious .

Atsuko's words had that echo to them .

Haruka couldn't deny it . She knew she took things on herself .

'That might be the case...'

'If you blame yourself for everything, you'll end up like my husband,' said Atsuko, sticking out her tongue .

When Haruka saw that, she couldn't help but laugh .

'Is Gotou-san also like that?'

'He is . Even though I'm not concerned about it myself, he'll say "Sorry" with a grumpy face . '

'Really?'

'Like an idiot, isn't he?'

'That's...'

'If he's worried, he can just say it aloud . Little things like this don't surprise me anymore,' said Atsuko .

It was true that Gotou did tend to take things on by himself . Now that Haruka thought about it, Isshin was the same too . The worst of them was Yakumo .

Without saying anything to anyone, he took everything on . Even if he suffered, he wouldn't talk to anybody .

They might have all gathered because of their similarities .

'Honestly . What's so fun about taking everything on yourself?'

Haruka felt like there was a bit of a shadow on Atsuko's face as she said that .

– She wants them to understand each other .

Haruka felt that when she looked at Atsuko's profile .

Happy things, sad things and painful things – she wanted to share them with the person she loved, but he wouldn't say anything, taking everything on by himself .

He might not have wanted to trouble her, but that wasn't what she wanted .

'I'm sorry . '

'See, you're apologising again . '

Atsuko made an angry face .

'I am . '

Haruka smiled wryly .

'Women have to be reliable, especially during troubling times . Men just complain and don't do anything at all . '

Atsuko snorted .

Even though so many things were happening, Atsuko wasn't bothered at all .

Perhaps she had always been a strong woman, or maybe she had become stronger from living with Gotou, but it appeared that she wasn't too concerned about the matter this time either .

'That's right . '

Haruka nodded .

'Anyway, at times like this, let's work together and do our best,' said Atsuko, gripping Haruka's hand . Atsuko's hand was a bit cold .

'Yes . '

Haruka felt a bit better after talking to Atsuko .

8

'T-that's ridiculous!' yelled Gotou, unable to understand the reality in front of him .

Ishii leapt up in surprise from his seat across from Gotou .

Miyagawa, who had spoken up first, just glared at Gotou with his arms crossed .

Gotou could tell Miyagawa wasn't joking from seeing his eyes, but he just couldn't accept what Miyagawa said .

In the report that Miyagawa brought in this morning, there was something Gotou had to be surprised by .

– The fingerprints on the knife Isshin was stabbed with were a perfect match with Nanase Miyuki's .

'Are they really Miyuki's fingerprints? There must have been a mistake,' said Gotou again, unable to accept it .

'They're the fingerprints we got when she was arrested . No doubt about it,' said Miyagawa flatly .

– What the hell is going on?

Though he was surprised, if the fingerprints matched, there was no doubt about it .

'Let's arrest Nanase Miyuki right now . '

Gotou stood up forcefully .

'Can't do that,' said Miyagawa, shaking his eye .

'Why not? It's simple!'

Gotou slammed his fist into the desk as he said that .

He didn't understand why they were hesitating .

'Did you forget? Miyuki has a cast-iron alibi . '

'A crime from within the detention centre is impossible... is what you mean then,' added Ishii .

– I forgot the most crucial point .

Miyuki was being held in the detention house . It'd be understandable if Miyuki had escaped the detention house and gone to stab Isshin .

However, that wasn't the case . Miyuki was still in the detention house now .

'Er... Would it be possible for her to have left once and returned?'

'How?'

'By walking through walls, she...'

Before Ishii could finish speaking, Gotou dropped his fist on Ishii's head .

'It's not as simple as heading home . '

By saying it aloud, Gotou accepted the fact and felt horror .

How the hell did Miyuki stab Isshin from the detention house – as long as that puzzle remained unsolved, they couldn't arrest her .

– Damn it .

Gotou clicked his tongue .

'Haven't we got anything?'

Gotou gritted his teeth .

'If Yakumo-shi were here...' said Ishii while scratching his head .

– That's right . Yakumo might be able to solve this puzzle .

Gotou recalled how Yakumo had looked last night .

Yakumo had been like an empty shell then . There was no life in his face, and his eyes had been hollow – it was like he hadn't been there .

Gotou had found some time to call him, but Yakumo hadn't answered .

'He'd be no help right now,' said Gotou, disappointed .

'I don't know if this'll help, but...'

Miyagawa spoke up, brushing away the stagnant mood .

'What is it?'

'Looks like there was a bit of a fuss at the detention house yesterday . '

'Fuss?'

'Yeah . Nanase Miyuki was coughing up blood in her room and then told a guard that she'd just killed somebody . '

'Killed somebody...'

Gotou had thought it might be a breakthrough, but he felt even more confused .

What Miyuki said to the guard last night had to be affirming that she'd killed Isshin at a distance .

'Ah! I see! So that's how it is! Detective Gotou!' yelled Ishii, suddenly standing up .

'What? You're so noisy . '

Gotou was immediately suspicious, what with Ishii's wrong guess earlier .

Ishii's reasoning was always off . Gotou would regret it if he took Ishii too seriously – he always talked about things that made no sense like magic .

'Chief Miyagawa . How was Miyuki after she coughed up blood?' asked Ishii agitatedly, fixing the position of his glasses even though they weren't off .

'She was taken to the infirmary . '

'I see . I see . So that really is the case . Do you know when she was taken to the infirmary?'

Ishii wriggled as he continued asking questions .

'Past six in the evening . She rested in the infirmary for a night and was brought back to her room in the morning . '

'Just as I thought!'

Ishii clapped his hands together and smiled triumphantly .

'What's just as you thought?' asked Gotou while glaring at Ishii .

Having only one person understand made Gotou strangely irritated .

'At the time of the crime, Nanase Miyuki was not in her room . '

'What about it?'

Gotou was becoming even more confused about why Ishii was so agitated .

'Nanase Miyuki was taken to the infirmary past six in the evening . Saitou Isshin-san was stabbed at nine in at night . That's a three-hour delay . '

'I see . That's a good point . '

It seemed like Miyagawa also understood what Ishii was trying to say – he was smirking .

However, Gotou still didn't understand .

'What are you talking about?'

'After she was taken to the infirmary, she escaped the detention room, stabbed Saitou Isshin-san and returned . '

Ishii was shaking in excitement .

'She couldn't get out so easily . '

'It would be possible if she had an accomplice . '

'Accomplice?'

'Yes . The man named Yamamura we discussed last night . '

Gotou finally understood when he heard the name .

Yamamura was the guard who had been silently watching as Miyuki gave her advance notice of murder .

'I see . '

Gotou clapped his hands together in understanding .

It'd be difficult to escape from her room, but it might have been possible from the infirmary .

That was well done for Ishii . This was possible .

'Miyagawa-san, I have a request . '

'I get it . Questioning at the detention house, right? I'll get permission,' responded Miyagawa, clapping Gotou on the shoulder .

– He's reliable as usual .

'Ishii! We're going!'

Gotou grabbed his jacket while he said that and ran out the room .

9

– I can't breathe .

Ishii sat in the chair in the visiting room of the detention house as he wiped the sweat on his forehead with his sleeve .

He'd corner Miyuki and reveal her trick when he got out of the precinct – that was what he had thought, but now that the meeting with Miyuki was actually looming, that thought left his head, and he just had the impulse to run .

He had planned on cornering her, but he felt like they were the ones who had actually been cornered .

'How long do we have to wait?'

Sitting next to Ishii, Gotou was unable to hide his irritation – he had been bouncing his knee for a while now .

Ishii had never seen Gotou with a stiffer expression than the one he had now .

– Can we really win against her?

That question came up in Ishii's head .

Finally, the door on the opposite side of the glass opened and Miyuki came in .

The man who brought her in was the same as last time – Yamamura .

Ishii and Gotou thought that he was an accomplice .

Miyuki sat down gracefully with the tips of her lips turned up into a smile .

When Ishii saw that, a jolt went down his spine .

Normally, a smile would comfort a person, but Miyuki's didn't .

It was cold, insidious and full of malice . It agitated the anxiety at the bottom of a person's heart .

'What's so funny?' said Gotou, glaring at Miyuki .

Though Gotou didn't yell, his voice shook the bottom of Ishii's stomach . It oozed with irrepressible anger .

'You don't know?'

Miyuki licked her lips .

'What?'

'Isn't it obvious that I'm happy?'

'What did you say?'

'My plan succeeded . '

Miyuki crossed her legs and looked at them scornfully .

– She's challenging us .

That was how Ishii felt .

'Too bad for you . Isshin's still alive . '

Gotou leant forward, bringing his face close to the glass .

Gotou's and Miyuki's gazes met .

Ishii gulped as he watched them .

'Oh, is that so? I should've stabbed him deeper,' said Miyuki with a dissatisfied pout .

'What did you say!?'

Gotou stood up, unable to control himself .

However, if he got riled up here, they would just be going along with Miyuki's plan .

'Excuse me . '

Ishii repressed his fear and interrupted the conversation .

'From what you just said, we can determine that you admit your crime against Isshin-san . '

'Yup,' agreed Miyuki readily .

'You admit it then . '

'Of course . I'm the one who stabbed Saitou Isshin . There were fingerprints, right?'

'Why do you know that?' interrupted Gotou harshly .

Gotou's question made sense . Information was limited in the detention house . There was no way for Miyuki to know that fingerprints were analysed from the weapon .

Furthermore, because of its importance, the information about the analysed fingerprints wasn't even released to the press .

'I wonder?'

Miyuki's gaze was close to a glare .

She was probably trying to provoke them .

'Perhaps you had an accomplice in the police?'

Ishii said the first thing that came to mind .

'Ishii-san, you really are interesting . '

Miyuki laughed with shaking shoulders .

'Of course not!' said Gotou with a red face, before dropping his fist on Ishii's head .

'Ack . '

Ishii bit down the urge to yell from the pain .

'Gotou-san, you're not imaginative enough . '

Gotou's eyes went wide at Miyuki's words .

'What?'

'Just as Ishii-san said, I might have an accomplice in the police . '

'Don't be ridiculous!' yelled Gotou, slamming his hand against the protective glass .

Ishii half-stood up from surprise, but Miyuki just kept sitting with the same smile on her face .

'Why not check for yourself?'

Miyuki crossed her stretched out legs again as she said that .

'What the hell did you say!?'

Gotou yelled even louder as he hit the glass again and again .

– Oh no . We're completely at her pace .

'D-Detective Gotou, please calm down . '

Ishii grabbed Gotou's arm .

'Calm down? It's your fault for saying something unnecessary!'

Gotou hit Ishii's head .

'But I just...'

'Don't talk back . '

Gotou hit Ishii once more .

'You really are an interesting combo . '

Miyuki covered her mouth with a hand and started laughing .

'What's so funny?' said Gotou threateningly, but Miyuki still didn't stop laughing .

'Isn't it funny? It's like watching a comedy show . '

'Who's a comedy show? I've always been a detective . '

Miyuki snorted at Gotou's claim .

'If you're a detective, you should understand why I know about the prints on the knife . '

Ishii finally solved the puzzle when he heard Miyuki's words .

'You left the fingerprints on the knife on purpose,' said Ishii, looking straight at Miyuki's eyes .

It seemed that Ishii had lost his reasoning ability after being played with by Miyuki .

'That's right . I gripped the knife with my bare hand . '

Miyuki licked her full lips .

She had gripped the knife with her bare hand . It was natural that her fingerprints had been lifted .

But the question was –

'Why? Why did you leave your fingerprints on purpose?'

'Because you wouldn't have acknowledged that I did it otherwise, right?' said Miyuki jokingly .

'That's true, but...'

'When magicians teleport coins, they sign it with the magic, yes? It's the same thing . '

Miyuki said that with no hesitation .

'Fingerprints were found on the knife . You've confessed . You better be prepared, 'cause I'm getting an arrest warrant now,' threatened Gotou .

However, it appeared to have no effect on Miyuki . She had the same smile on her face as she had had before .

'I wonder if you'll be able to do that?'

Miyuki narrowed her eyes and stuck out her chin .

'What do you mean?'

Gotou raised an eyebrow .

'Exactly what I said . There certainly were fingerprints on the weapon . I also confessed . But at the time of the crime, I was inside the detention house . I wonder what decision the police will come to then?'

Miyuki's words were heavy on Ishii's heart .

Miyuki had confessed that she stabbed Isshin, and her fingerprints had been found on the weapon .

However, she had an iron-clad alibi – she had been held in the detention house .

If they didn't have decisive evidence that she had left the detention house at that time, she couldn't be arrested for assault against Saitou Isshin .

At first glance, it seemed like a game they couldn't win, but their chances of success weren't zero .

– There's an unaccounted time .

She had had a spasm and been taken to the infirmary at the time of the crime .

– What happened then?

If they could find out, they could break Miyuki's iron-clad alibi .

'It's time . '

The guard, Yamamura, suddenly announced the end of their interview .

Unfortunately, she was the accused, currently in detention . They could only meet her under the rules of the detention house .

'Please bring Yakumo-kun the next time you come,' said Miyuki as she stood up .

'What did you say?'

'I want to see Yakumo-kun suffering . '

'Don't tell me you stabbed Isshin to make Yakumo suffer?' said Gotou, sounding almost hesitant .

'That's right . '

As Miyuki replied, she spread her two hands why .

'Then why didn't you attack Yakumo directly?'

'There's no point to that, right? It's not like I want to kill Yakumo-kun . '

'You don't want to kill him?'

Gotou's brow furrowed . He didn't understand . That was how he looked .

However, Ishii understood what Miyuki was thinking .

Her goal wasn't to take Yakumo's life . She wanted to smile scornfully as she made him suffer – to watch as he submitted to her .

Miyuki had said this when she announced that she would kill Saitou Isshin .

– I can't kill Yakumo-kun .

I hadn't understood then, but is this what she meant –

– What an unbelievable sadist .

Ishii felt afraid of Miyuki all over again .

'That's why you should bring Yakumo-kun next time . '

'What's your purpose in making Yakumo suffer?' asked Gotou, stuck to the glass .

'I just want that person to understand that I'm better than he is . '

When Miyuki said 'that person', she probably meant Yakumo's father, the man with two red eyes .

Fifteen years ago – Miyuki, who had brutally murdered her own family, went to live with the man with two eyes .

She had come to love and respect him as a father, or perhaps as a man . However, no matter how Miyuki tried, she just couldn't win against Yakumo .

The emotion eddying within Miyuki was probably a dark flame of jealousy .

'Just for that...' said Gotou, almost in a gasp .

Miyuki had been about to leave the room, but when she heard those words, her complexion completely changed and she whirled around .

'Just for that, you say? That's everything to me!'

'What...'

'No matter how much I love him, whenever that person opens his mouth, it's Yakumo, Yakumo, Yakumo! I'm sick of it! Is being related by blood so great? Is having a red eye that important?'

Miyuki stuck to the glass like a spider as she screamed .

Even Yamamura the guard must have been panicked as he pinned Miyuki's arms behind her back and pulled her away from the glass .

While Yamamura pulled her away, Miyuki started laughing aloud, as if she found something funny .

Her laughs were maniacal .

Even after Miyuki disappeared through the door, her laughter wouldn't leave Ishii's ears .

To show off her existence .

She had stabbed Isshin for that sole reason .

– Terrifying . Truly, she's terrifying .

10

Haruka sat next to Nao on the bench in the hospital waiting room .

Nao's legs were shaking as she stared at the floor .

It was the first time Haruka had seen Nao so dispirited .

– I can't do anything for her .

All Haruka could do was hold Nao's hand silently .

'Sorry for the wait . '

Atsuko ran back to them .

She had gone to check at the reception whether Isshin was allowed visitors .

'How was it?' asked Haruka as she stood up .

'They said that he's still unconscious, but we can go into meet him . '

Nao looked up at Atsuko's words .

Nao couldn't hear . Instead, she excelled at reading the atmosphere .

'Ah!'

Nao raised her voice .

– I want to see him anyway .

To Haruka, that was what it sounded like Nao was saying .

'Then shall we go?'

Atsuko crouched in front of Nao with a wide smile on her face .

Nao was led into smiling back .

It was mysterious how they looked like a real mother and child this way .

Atsuko took Nao's hand and started walking . Haruka followed after them .

'I'm really glad that you're here, Atsuko-san,' said Haruka honestly .

She had been saved by Atsuko's brightness and energy since last night . If Haruka had been by herself, she probably would only have been able to hang her head next to Nao .

'Oh, you flatter me . '

'It isn't flattery . '

'I'm glad that the two of you are here too . '

'Eh?'

Haruka was confused by the unexpected answer .

'Don't worry about it,' said Atsuko with a shrug .

Meanwhile, they arrived at the ICU .

Haruka recalled the scene from last night and was hesitant to step inside .

'Let's go then . '

Atsuko led the way . After disinfecting her hands and putting on a mask, she stepped into the ICU .

– She really is strong .

Haruka followed after Atsuko .

Isshin was lying on the bed, like he had been yesterday .

There was an intravenous tube in his arm and an artificial respirator attached to him . Cords stretched over his body for various machines, such as the ECG and the EEG .

Though visits were allowed now, that didn't mean Isshin was better . Haruka was forced to feel that anew .

Perhaps they shouldn't have brought Nao .

Right as Haruka thought that, Nao let go of Atsuko's hand and walked up to Isshin .

Then, she took Isshin's hand .

As Nao held onto Isshin's hand, she was – smiling .

'Ah, ah . '

Nao spoke in excited tones, as if urging Isshin to do something .

Haruka and Atsuko looked at each other . Then, they walked up to Isshin, brought in by the voice .

Nao gripped Haruka's wrist and brought it to Isshin's hand .

Haruka's fingers brushed Isshin's hand .

– He's warm .

Haruka felt the words Nao was trying to say with her body .

He's still warm . That meant Isshin was still alive . Nao must have been trying to say that .

'Isn't that great?'

Atsuko hugged Nao's shoulders from behind her . Nao nodded in response .

– That's right . Isshin is still alive .

Since it was him, he would definitely wake up randomly and say 'I'm sorry for worrying you' with a smile .

Having a hopeful perspective made her heart brighter .

Just as Haruka let out a sigh of relief, she was assaulted by the feeling of something sinking in her stomach .

– What?

She looked about and spotted a girl standing in the corridor through the window .

The girl wore a red dress and had long hair . Her face was dark, as if smeared in ink .

The same girl I saw in the corridor last night –

She was probably the ghost that was said to appear around the hospital .

– When... are you going to die...

Rather than in her eardrum, the voice went straight to her head .

It was probably the girl's voice .

Haruka recalled the rumour that the hospital was in a fuss over . The people whom the girl asked this question all died .

Haruka looked at Isshin .

– I can't accept that .

'Ah!'

Suddenly, Nao yelled loudly .

Her two hands were in fists . It looked like she was shaking in anger . Her eyes were on the ghost of the girl in the corridor .

– Can Nao see her?

As if answering Haruka's question, Nao ran out into the corridor .

'What's wrong?' called out Atsuko in concern .

'Ah, that's...'

Unable to explain well, Haruka also ran out into the corridor to follow Nao .

The ghost of the girl from earlier had already disappeared .

Nao was looking around frantically in the place where the girl had been standing .

Though I can't explain it, something incredibly awful is going to happen – that premonition alone whirled about in Haruka's head .

11

After Gotou left the visiting room, Ishii stood up as well and they walked to the infirmary .

A guard led them down the dreary corridor .

Every ten metres, there was a steel door . The guard unlocked each with a key and fingerprint, and they continued onwards .

They turned into many similar corridors, so Gotou had no idea of where he even was .

Under such strict defence, it wouldn't be easy to escape . Gotou felt that anew .

After about ten minutes, they finally arrived at the infirmary .

Though it was a rather complicated process in getting here, the inside of the infirmary was made unexpectedly like a regular hospital examination room .

'Please sit . '

Urged by the white-haired doctor who was waiting, Gotou and Ishii sat on round chairs .

'I'm from the precinct . My name's Gotou . '

Gotou showed his police IC to the white-haired man .

'My name is Komatsu . I'm the medical officer . '

Komatsu fished through the desk drawer and took out a dirty business card .

While accepting it, Gotou looked once more at Komatsu's face . He was probably about fifty years old . He had a long thin face and looked like he had a nervous personality .

'I'd like to get straight to the point and ask you about last night . '

'If it's something I know,' said Komatsu . He spoke in a very prudent manner, appropriate for a doctor .

'Tell me in detail about when Nanase Miyuki was brought in . '

'Even if you ask me to tell you in detail...'

Komatsu's attitude seemed like a refusal towards Gotou's question .

Gotou kept his irritation in check .

Normally, police wouldn't be able to ask around the detention house like this .

When Gotou thought about Miyagawa, who'd gone through so much to make the necessary arrangements, he decided it would be a bad idea to make a fuss .

'What were her symptoms?' asked Gotou after clearing his throat .

'She was convulsing and vomiting blood . She underwent much examination, but there weren't any abnormalities, besides the increase in white blood cells . It probably came from stress . '

Miyuki hadn't looked stressed to Gotou .

'It wasn't an act . '

Gotou didn't accept what the medical officer said, but he didn't dare to say that aloud . Instead, he asked another question .

'Wasn't there anything else that caught your attention?'

'Hm, even if you ask that...'

Komatsu looked sullen as he ran a hand through his white hair .

It didn't seem like he wanted to cooperate with the investigation at all . It felt like every time Gotou's bones would slowly break every time he asked a question .

While Gotou was pondering, Ishii interrupted: 'Excuse me . '

'When Nanase Miyuki was brought here, what time was it exactly?'

Behind Ishii's glasses, his eyes were glittering more brightly than usual .

– I'll try letting Ishii talk for a bit .

Gotou crossed his arms and focussed on watching Komatsu's movements .

'It was probably past six,' replied Komatsu, looking up at the ceiling as he searched his memories .

'Then when did she return to her room?'

'I think it was around seven this morning . '

'I see . '

Ishii fixed the position of his glasses with his finger .

There was almost a thirteen-hour gap . With that, it would be possible for Miyuki to stab Isshin and return, as Ishii had said before .

'What treatment did she undergo?'

'We took a blood sample, put her on a drip and let her sleep there . '

Komatsu pointed at the beds in the back of the room .

There were four beds in total . Each was divided from the room with a curtain .

'Were you the only person who administered treatment?'

'I was the only one here, so yes . '

Perhaps Komatsu felt like he was under suspicion, because his expression became stiff in a twinkling . '

'Was there a guard in the infirmary?'

Ishii continued his questions in a disinterested manner .

'Nobody was in the infirmary . Guards circle the corridors . '

'Then the only person here was you . '

'Yes, but... what're you trying to say?'

Komatsu's tone changed .

'There are partition curtains around the beds . '

'Yeah . '

'How frequently did you look inside?'

'How would I remember that... What are you really saying? If you've got something you want to say, just say it clearly . '

Komatsu's voice was ragged; perhaps he couldn't restrain it any longer .

– Well done, Ishii .

They might be able to get something unexpectedly good .

Gotou turned an expectant gaze towards Ishii . When Ishii noticed, he nodded .

'In short, it was possible for Nanase Miyuki to have escaped your gaze, left the room, stabbed Saitou Isshin and returned – that is what I want to say . '

'Are you serious?'

Komatsu snorted scornfully .

'Of course . '

'That's idiotic . '

Komatsu shook his head in astonishment .

'However, it would have been possible for her,' said Ishii in a triumphant manner .

'What do you mean?'

'She used supernatural powers to walk through the walls of the detention house . '

The moment Ishii said that, Gotou dropped his fist on Ishii's head .

– He's deluding himself again .

'Don't talk anymore,' snapped Gotou .

Ishii pouted in dissatisfaction .

Even if he made that face, it was no use . If he talked any more about supernatural powers, people would think he was nuts .

They wouldn't be able to hear the things they needed to .

'Sorry . Let's get back on topic . '

Gotou spoke up again .

'Ah, yes . '

'In short, we think that Nanase Miyuki got out of the detention house somehow . Otherwise, we can't explain this case . '

Gotou stopped the roundabout explanation and pinpointed the crucial point .

There were a number of cases in the past when somebody held in a detention house had escaped .

Even a few years ago, there was a fuss with an incident when a group of foreigners escaped .

'Detective, what you are talking about refers to old detention houses, correct?'

Komatsu plainly sighed .

It was true that the escape incidents might have been in the era of old detention houses .

'Can you say that it's definitely impossible?'

'It's definitely impossible,' declared Komatsu .

It looked like there was absolute confidence there .

'How can you be sure?'

'You saw it for yourself, did you not, Detective? You passed through a number of doors, yes? You can't even run ten metres . '

'Ah...'

Gotou remembered the path he took to get here .

Just as Komatsu said, there hadn't just been one or two doors . He hadn't even been able to walk forward properly .

'Furthermore, those doors are all locked with a key and fingerprint recognition . It is a double-layer lock . Furthermore, there are security cameras everywhere . '

To pass through the door, a key wouldn't be all you need – your fingerprints would have to be registered too .

Even if you got past both of those with somebody's guidance, there was no way to escape the security cameras .

Though Gotou knew that, he still couldn't throw away the escape theory .

'She could've escaped from a window . '

'Perhaps in the era of metal grids on windows . Now they have protective glass on them . It wouldn't crack even if it were punched with a fist . '

A metal grid could have been sawed away to escape . However, with protective glass, escaping from the window wasn't a chase .

– Is it really no good?

Even Gotou looked up at the ceiling in resignation .

'The only ones who can come and go are the guards, and there is still a limit to that,' finished Komatsu in a triumphant tone .

So it was a situation where it was completely impossible to escape . It wouldn't go as simply as in a television drama .

'E-Excuse me...'

Just as the conversation had come to a half, Ishii raised his hand as he asked for permission to speak in an apologetic manner .

'What?' asked Gotou . When he did so, Ishii's face brightened immediately, like a child's .

'There is one thing I would like to ask, but didn't any workers come to check on Nanase Miyuki's condition?'

Gotou understood immediately what Ishii was aiming for .

They had come to this theory for Miyuki's escape because they had thought about this possibility in the beginning .

'Did somebody come by...'

Komatsu looked about for a while before yelping, as if he had suddenly remembered something .

'So somebody came . '

Gotou stood up in his agitation .

'Yes . '

'Who?'

Gotou approached Komatsu suddenly .

Perhaps Komatsu had been surprised, because he backed away and gave one man's name .

It was the person they had predicted it would be, Yamamura Mikio –

12

'Haruka-san... right?'

Just as Haruka was leaving the hospital, somebody called out to her .

Standing there was Mao, the doctor .

'Yes . '

'Things have become rather serious...' said Mao, looking troubled .

She probably didn't think that things would become like this yesterday either .

'They have...'

'Do you have some time? There's something I'd like to talk to you about . '

'To... me?'

Haruka cocked her head in confusion .

She couldn't imagine what Mao would have to say to her . She only knew Mao as Isshin's friend .

'It's about Yakumo-kun,' said Mao, perhaps sensing how Haruka felt .

'About Yakumo-kun?'

'Yes . '

After saying that, Mao turned her gaze to her feet .

It appeared to be something she didn't want other people to hear .

'We'll head back first . '

Atsuko tactfully took Nao's hand and walked away .

'Ah, yes . '

Haruka watched Atsuko and Nao leave .

'Let's go to my examination room . '

After waiting for the two of them to disappear, Mao slowly started walking .

— What does she have to say about Yakumo?

Haruka pondered that while walking after Mao .

At Mao's guidance, Haruka passed by the reception and went to the examination room at the end of the corridor .

'Sit there,' said Mao, sitting at her desk while pointing at the round chair facing it .

'Er... what do you want to talk about?' said Haruka as she sat down .

A strange anxiety gripped her heart and she couldn't calm down for some reason .

'Actually, I want to contact Yakumo-kun immediately regarding Isshin-kun .
,

'Yakumo-kun?'

'Yes . '

'I haven't seen him since yesterday . '

Haruka bit her lip .

With the commotion, she hadn't contacted Yakumo since yesterday .

She recalled how Yakumo had walked straight down the pitch-black corridor . Though it was only a corridor, it had seemed as dangerous as tightrope walking .

– I wonder what Yakumo is doing now?

'I see... You haven't seen him either . '

Mao let out a sigh in her disappointment .

'I'm sorry . '

'No, it's fine . I'll try elsewhere . '

'Er, why are you looking for Yakumo-kun?' asked Haruka, curious .

'Yesterday, Doctor Sakakibara explained Isshin-kun's condition, but that changed greatly upon the results of the examination . '

'Examination?'

'Yes . That's why I said I wanted him to come to the hospital today, but...'

'Yakumo-kun didn't come?'

'He didn't . '

– Yakumo had to be concerned about Isshin's condition too . He should have come right away .

Did something happen?

'I'll think about where he might be . '

'Thank you . That would be a great help . '

Mao's expression softened just a bit .

'Then how is Isshin-san's condition?' asked Haruka, leaning forward .

Mao's expression went stiff again and she looked away .

Haruka could easily imagine that his condition wasn't very good from Mao's response . She felt dizzy from her dark thoughts .

After thinking for some time, Mao said, 'I shouldn't actually talk to anybody but relatives, but... you're Yakumo-kun's fiancée, right?'

– I'm his fiancée?

'Isshin-san told you that?'

'Yes . '

Haruka frowned with complicated feelings .

She was surprised that Isshin saw it that way .

If it had been another situation, she would have denied it – 'Yakumo-kun and I aren't like that' – but she didn't have the energy for it .

'I...'

Haruka looked down, neither agreeing nor denying .

'We suspect that Isshin-kun may be brain-dead . '

After a silence, Mao said that in a quiet voice .

– Brain-dead .

Haruka pressed her hand against her chest . She felt like a sharp blade had gouged it out .

Her heart was pounding . Her whole body was numb .

'Brain-dead... is it?'

– I don't want to believe it .

With that feeling filling her heart, she asked that question .

'It's still just a possibility...'

'That's...'

'When Isshin-kun was carried in, he had stopped breathing for a while . There's the possibility that his brain underwent a great deal of damage when he wasn't taking in oxygen .

– It's a lie . It's a lie . That has to be a lie .

This had to be a dream . It was obviously a lie . Haruka wanted to convince herself of that, but Mao's words mercilessly flew into her ears .

If this were true, Isshin wouldn't be able to breathe on his own, let alone walk and talk .

Not just that – the thoughts and memories that he was made up of would already be gone .

– I couldn't possibly believe that .

Haruka put her head on the table .

'Are you all right?'

Mao placed a hand on Haruka's shoulder .

'Is Isshin-san not going to get better...?'

Tears fell from Haruka's eyes naturally .

Once they started, she couldn't stop them . Haruka started to sob .

'Steady . '

'Please tell me he'll get better . If Isshin-san is gone, we'll...' pleaded Haruka, raising her head .

Then, her eyes met Mao's . Her eyes were also wet with tears .

'I was in the same seminar as Isshin-kun in university,' said Mao with a sniffle .

'Is that so...'

Haruka looked down in shame with closed eyes .

She had just been thinking of herself . She'd forgotten that Mao was Isshin's friend too .

'I always liked Isshin-kun, but because of who he is, we never became anything more than friends . '

Mao laughed as she shrugged .

Even though it must have been tough for her, she was stifling that feeling and doing her very best . When Haruka realised that, she wiped away her tears and took in a deep breath .

'I'm sorry . '

'It's fine . I don't want to believe this is happening either . '

Haruka silently bit her lip .

'I wonder why things turned out like this...'

Mao closed her eyes, looking like she was reminiscing .

Why did things turn out like this – Haruka had no way of knowing either .

13

– I'm worn out .

After returning to the precinct, Ishii collapsed into his chair at his desk .

His shoulders were heavy and his back felt sluggish . Furthermore, his consciousness was blurry . It was like that time he caught a cold .

He'd exhausted himself a fair amount in just a day and a half .

Gotou came in afterwards, a lit cigarette in his mouth . He sat down on the chair and crossed his arms .

Though he looked the same as always, his eyes were hollow .

'How was it?'

Miyagawa came in while calling out in a loud voice . His timing was so good it was like he'd been waiting for them to come back .

Ishii looked up at the voice, but he didn't know what to say .

It appeared that Gotou felt the same way . He just looked up without saying anything .

'This isn't a funeral – what happened?'

Miyagawa spread his two hands exaggeratedly .

Gotou looked at Miyagawa like he was something dirty and then said, 'Ishii,' looking at him .

Gotou was probably telling him to explain .

'Ah, er...'

Ishii was at a loss for words .

'Hurry up and speak,' said Miyagawa, lighting a cigarette .

'Yes sir . '

Ishii dragged his heavy body up and started reporting the information they had gathered at the detention house in order .

He started with how Miyuki had confessed to stabbing Saitou Isshin and then discussed the situation at the infirmary on the day of the incident, which they had heard from the medical officer Komatsu . Then, he explained the particulars, including how Yamamura Mikio had visited the infirmary .

Ishii just tried his best to not to include any personal theories .

He wanted to know what Miyagawa thought .

After Ishii finished, Miyagawa nodded and said, 'I see . '

'From the situation, it's highly likely that the guard Yamamura is related somehow, like we thought . '

'You think that as well?' said Ishii happily .

So it wasn't just his own impression . Yamamura was suspicious .

'But we can't do anything at this stage . '

Miyagawa scratched his chin .

'Yes . '

Unfortunately, it was just as Miyagawa said .

Though Yamamura was certainly suspicious, that was all . If asked, Ishii wouldn't be able to say specifically how he was suspicious .

They had no evidence that Yamamura had tried to do something . He had just been near Miyuki .

In this situation, searching recklessly might just destroy the evidence .

It was unfortunate, but they would need to focus on gathering information and find out how Yamamura was related to the case .

'If we drag him in and wallop him, he'd cough the truth up, wouldn't he?' said Gotou curtly as he lit a cigarette .

It really wasn't something Ishii thought a detective would say .

'If we did that, the police and prosecutors would have a full-out war,' retorted Miyagawa coldly .

'A war in space or a war between monsters – neither have anything to do with me . '

Gotou put his feet on top of the desk loudly .

He was acting like a rebellious high-school student .

'Leave this idiot alone, Ishii . What do you think?'

Miyagawa glared at Ishii .

'I believe that Nanase Miyuki used a certain method to escape the detention house . However, unfortunately, the method...'

Though Ishii had been the one giving his own opinion, he hesitated without continuing .

'It's impossible to escape the detention house . '

Miyagawa readily rejected Ishii's opinion .

'I think that Yamamura guided her somehow...'

Though Ishii said that, he didn't know the method . In the end, he had just returned to the beginning .

'That's not what I'm saying . '

'Eh?'

'Let's say that guy called Yamamura did guide her somehow . Though he doesn't have the key to the room, he has the key to the passage, so it'd be possible for him to take her out of the infirmary . '

'Yes . '

Though Miyagawa had denied Ishii's theory earlier, now he was agreeing with it .

Ishii felt that there was a contradiction, but he replied anyway .

'But if Yamamura took her out like that, there must've been an eyewitness . '

'That's right . '

Ishii had been stuck there too .

If Yamamura took a prisoner out without permission and loitered about, somebody would probably call out to stop him immediately . Even if he didn't meet anybody, there were security cameras .

– It really doesn't seem like it would work .

Ishii had started to give up when he suddenly got an idea .

'I see!'

'What?'

'If transporting packages was used as a diversion or Miyuki put on a guard uniform as a deception – wouldn't a method like that be possible?'

Then it would have been possible for them to leave without standing out .

Ishii had said that with confidence, but Miyagawa's reaction was lacking .

'Let's say they did use that method to let her escape . There's one more problem here . How'd she get back?'

'That's...'

Ishii couldn't think of an answer right away .

'And why did she have to return?'

'That's true...'

Ishii's answer trailed off .

That was a blind spot . If she had escaped the detention house, there was no need for her to risk returning .

She could have just escaped, but she didn't .

'Chief Miyagawa, how do you think she tried to kill him?'

Ishii tried asking a question back .

After Miyagawa hmm-ed and rubbed his bald head, he suddenly looked up, as if he had thought of something .

'This is just something that came to me, but maybe she didn't need to escape?'

'What do you mean?'

Gotou had been looking down since earlier, but the conversation suddenly caught his attention .

'That is, Miyuki set something up before coming into the detention house and used that to commit the crime – wouldn't that work?'

'Set something up... you say?'

'Right . Like using something similar to a bow and arrow to throw the knife...'

Miyagawa's voice grew quieter . Perhaps he had lost his confidence .

However, Ishii thought Miyagawa's theory was possible .

'That is possible . With a specific action, she could set off a mechanism to throw the knife . '

Ishii had read something like this in a mystery novel before . A knife was put into a bow gun, a booby trap was set up to activate once the door opened and the crime was committed that way .

Then, the criminal could create an alibi to prove they weren't related to the case and move the mechanism elsewhere .

If that method were used, Miyuki wouldn't need to escape the detention house .

'Then what sort of gadget did she use to do that?' said Gotou while stifling a yawn .

'If we knew that, the case would be solved already . '

Miyagawa pressed his cigarette into the ashtray .

This idea felt like it would be tossed out, but it wasn't that way for Ishii .

Breaking through a situation where they were stuck wasn't half bad .

'Chief Miyagawa, let's investigate the scene once more . '

'Yeah . '

Miyagawa agreed with Ishii's suggestion .

'It was the first time somebody had honestly accepted Ishii's opinion . He felt a bit moved .

'No way about it . We've got nothing to lose, right?'"

Gotou threw his cigarette into the ashtray and stood up slowly .

'Gotou, you can forget about it . '

Miyagawa shook his head .

'I'm telling you to go home for today,' said Miyagawa, poking his finger into Gotou's chest .

'W-w-what are you saying?'

Unable to accept it, Gotou flared up at Miyagawa's comment .

'I heard about what was going on from Ishii . You took in the victim's daughter, right?'

Miyagawa's gaze was serious, which was unusual for him .

'What about it? It's got nothing to do with the case, right?'

'It's got everything to do with it!'

Miyagawa's words were close to a threat .

Ishii felt surprised just from standing next to him .

'Please don't speak so loudly . '

'Listen up – you don't have enough self-awareness . Taking in a kid is a big responsibility . You think just feeding her dinner's gonna be enough? She's not a dog . At least head home early today . '

Miyagawa pushed Gotou in the chest .

Gotou staggered backwards .

'Even if I went back, I wouldn't be able to do anything . Instead I should hurry and catch the...'

'Shut up! Stop complaining! This is an order!'

Miyagawa's yell drowned out Gotou's words .

The difference in response might have been the difference between those who had children and those who didn't . That was what Ishii thought .

Even Gotou couldn't respond .

'Don't worry about the investigation . I'm more than enough to fill in for you,' said Miyagawa, turning his back to Gotou .

– So cool .

Ishii unconsciously found himself enraptured by that back .

'Right! Ishii! We're going!'

As Miyagawa said that, he left the room .

'Eh?'

Ishii finally realised .

If Miyagawa was filling in for Gotou, that meant that Ishii would pair up with Miyagawa .

This happened last time too . Whenever he paired up with Miyagawa, something terrible always happened to Ishii .

Tormented by melancholy, Ishii ran after Miyagawa regardless .

His feet tangled .

He fell –

14

– I feel down .

Haruka stopped in front of the prefabricated building in the back of Building B .

It was completely dark around her .

However, there was no light on in the <Movie Research Circle> room .

After leaving the hospital, Haruka had called Yakumo's mobile countless times, but the call tone had just gone on and Yakumo hadn't answered .

She had left a voicemail, but there hadn't even been a return call .

Haruka opened the door, went inside and turned on the light .

Yakumo really wasn't here .

She had come here to search for Yakumo, but if he wasn't here, she unfortunately had no more ideas .

'Where are you?' she asked, but there was no response .

It was a small, dreary room with only a table, sleeping bag and refrigerator, but she had many memories here .

Really, a great number of things had happened . Normally, she could relax here, but sitting by herself like this just made her anxious .

She recalled what had happened during the last case .

That time as well, Haruka had chased after Yakumo, who had suddenly disappeared, and came to this room and sat down on this chair .

Yakumo often took on things by himself .

Even if he was troubled, he didn't show it on his face, and he wouldn't respond if Haruka asked .

He especially had a tendency to run amok when his relatives were involved .

– It's my fault...

The words Yakumo said in the hospital ran through Haruka's head .

The words might not have been in regards to this case but rather everything that had happened up until now .

Yakumo had fought fiercely up until now .

Against the people who despised his red left eye which could see the spirits of the dead . The spirits he saw against his will with no reward .

And then the man with two red eyes –

He had undergone much more than most and experienced many hardships and sorrows .

Yakumo had said this before .

– No matter how obscure the darkness, a small light can always be seen ahead of it .

By believing in that, Yakumo retained his psychological balance and walked forward .

However, no matter how much he advanced, the same things happened . One person couldn't change the world, so he continued to fight people's resentment and hatred .

Not just that – he couldn't save the people close to him .

It was the same this time .

Yakumo hadn't been able to save Isshin . The cause of the incident was probably the woman called Nanase Miyuki's grudge .

Even though they were just walking the paths they believed in, because everyone thinks differently, that changed into resentment and hatred .

Yakumo, who could see the spirits of the dead, might have felt that more strongly than anyone .

Was he tired of the unending and recurring chain of negative emotions?

— That isn't it, right?

Haruka prayed silently in her heart as she tightly gripped the necklace hanging from her neck .

The main reason Yakumo had so far never stepped off the path a human should take no matter what he suffered was probably Isshin's influence .

Because Yakumo had had Isshin's support, Yakumo had been able to walk forward up until now .

If Yakumo lost Isshin, what would he become?

Haruka felt incredibly afraid when she imagined it .

Haruka held the red stone on her necklace with both hands and closed her eyes, as if praying .

In the silence, a thought came to Haruka .

It was about Yakumo's father, the man with red eyes .

He had always been a puzzle .

Why did he play with people's emotions and induce them into committing crimes?

He could see the spirits of the dead, like Yakumo .

Did that make him act the way he did?

Since Haruka didn't know much about psychology, it was just a theory, but she couldn't help but feel that way .

Because of those red eyes, he lost many important things, took in those feelings with no reward all by himself . Then, bearing those feelings, he fell into an absolute darkness –

Though those were just her thoughts, maybe he had been in a similar situation to Yakumo? If that were the case –

Would Yakumo fall into the pitch-black darkness again?

Haruka shook her head to clear away her negative thoughts .

– There's no way .

She continued to pray in her heart, but her anxiety just wouldn't go away .

– Yakumo, where are you trying to go?

Haruka murmured that in her heart .

Of course, there was no answer .

Haruka took her mobile phone out of her bag and typed out a text .

Though it was only one-way communication, she still wanted to convey something to Yakumo .

She typed in a sentence, deleted it, typed in a sentence, deleted it –

That was the cycle .

After thinking over it, she finally only typed in one sentence .

<I want to see you . >

She didn't need any other words . She just wanted to see Yakumo .

After typing her text, Haruka took her necklace off and held it in front of her eyes .

The swaying red stone glinted with a sharp light .

Gotou stood in front of the door to his home .

He had lived in this flat from his work for five years already .

However, it was the first time in his memory that he had returned home so early .

Miyagawa had practically chased him out, but Gotou himself was concerned about Atsuko and Nao too .

That said, if Miyagawa hadn't said all that, Gotou probably wouldn't have left the investigation and gone home .

Gotou was about to open the door when he noticed that his hand was shaking slightly .

It was like he had returned home with a guilty conscience after an affair .

– Idiotic . What am I getting worked up for when I'm just returning to my own home?

Gotou encouraged himself and forcefully opened the door .

'I'm back . '

High-pitched laughter from the living room drowned out Gotou's voice .

He knew immediately that it was Atsuko's laughter . She really sounded like she was enjoying herself –

Atsuko often laughed like this in a high-pitched voice before they married .

Gotou liked the way Atsuko laughed . He would fool around just to make her laugh .

However, after they started living together, that laughter grew quiet and they soon didn't even talk any more .

A cold relationship where they only lived together –

Gotou thought that the start of that was when Atsuko had a miscarriage . If he had faced her properly after that, they might have had a different future .

However, Gotou hadn't been able to do that . He stuck himself to his work and ran away .

Still feeling guilty, Gotou took off his shoes at the entrance and headed for the living room .

The laughter still continued .

As he stood in front of the door to the living room, he hesitated to open it .

If I open the door now, that laughter might stop – that was what he thought .

– Why am I hesitating?

Gotou told himself that as he opened the door .

A different scene from the usual flew into Gotou's eyes .

Atsuko was sitting on the sofa and Nao was on her lap . They were using drawing paper to talk .

Both of them were smiling innocently .

The air felt warm .

Nao pointed at the drawing paper and spoke falteringly: 'Ah, ah . '

Since Nao couldn't hear, she couldn't speak clearly, but Atsuko seemed to understand everything she said as she nodded a number of times .

Gotou felt like he had wandered into somebody else's home .

However, he didn't feel uncomfortable . He wanted to look at Atsuko's and Nao's smiling faces forever . He even felt that way .

'Oh my, you're back?'

Atsuko noticed Gotou was there and looked up .

The smile on her face didn't waver .

'Y-yeah . '

How many years had it been since Atsuko had welcomed him home with a smile?

Gotou felt awkward as he walked to the sofa where Atsuko and Nao were .

'What's so funny?'

Gotou sat down cross-legged in front of the sofa .

Nao and Atsuko looked at each other and laughed .

'There's no helping it, so shall we show him?'

Atsuko spoke with Nao and then held out the drawing paper .

A man was drawn on it in crayon .

He wore something like a suit, but his whole body was fuzzy and he had his mouth wide open, baring his teeth .

'What is this?'

Gotou said the first thing that came to mind .

'It's you . '

Atsuko's shoulders shook as she laughed .

– This is me?

'This is practically a bear . '

When Gotou said that, even he started becoming amused .

A smile naturally appeared on his face .

'Oi, Nao . Am I a bear?'

Gotou pretended to roar – 'Gaooo!' – and then pinched Nao's nose .

Nao shrieked with laughter and swung her legs .

When Gotou looked at that smiling face, he felt all his exhaustion fly away .

– Do I want to be a dad?

Gotou was surprised to find that wish at the bottom of his heart .

Gotou's eyes were half-closed as he looked at Nao as if in a trance, but then he noticed Atsuko looking at him curiously and covered up by clearing his throat .

'So how was it?'

It was the first time in a while that Gotou had spoken to Atsuko like this .

Gotou thought that Atsuko might be a bit confused, but she just started talking about what had happened today with Nao still on her map .

It was a regular conversation – she just told him that they went to visit Isshin and that Nao had helped prepare dinner . However, Atsuko's eyes sparkled like those of a child talking about an adventure .

When Atsuko's words reached Gotou's ears, he realised . Atsuko had been lonely all this time –

She sent off her husband who selfishly ran off however he wanted and had lived with her loneliness alone in this home .

It was imprudent, but Gotou wouldn't have realised such a simple thing if this hadn't happened .

He was a useless man who only knew how to thump his chest .

Perhaps Nao had grown tired of laughing, because she let out a yawn on top of the sofa .

'She must be tired . '

'Well, that happened...'

'Now, let's go to the futon . '

Atsuko picked Nao up and headed for the bedroom .

Gotou lit his cigarette as she watched them .

He felt like the smoke didn't just go to his lungs but to the deep parts of his heart .

After a while, Atsuko returned to the living room .

'Sorry,' said Gotou as he looked at Atsuko's face .

'It's fine . Something like this is nothing to worry about . Nao-chan's a strong girl too,' replied Atsuko lightly .

The 'Sorry' Gotou wanted to say hadn't just been for today but everything up until now .

'That's right . She's a strong girl,' said Gotou without explaining his intention .

– This part of myself is irritating .

Gotou laughed self-deprecatingly and slowly blew out smoke .

' ...Do you think the culprit will be caught?'

After Atsuko said that, she looked like she wanted to say, 'Oh no . '

It was the first time she'd asked about a case . He'd thought that she wasn't interested, but that probably wasn't it .

She wanted to know, but she hadn't asked because she thought that she would be disliked if she asked .

'We don't know anything yet . This case has very deep roots,' said Gotou as if it were natural .

He had no proof . He wanted somebody to listen to him now – that was how he felt .

Perhaps Atsuko was happy about getting a response, because her eyes were as bright as a girl's .

'What do you mean when you say the roots are deep?'

'It'll take a while to explain . '

Gotou felt somewhat embarrassed when Atsuko looked at him like that .

To escape Atsuko's gaze, he played with the carpet .

'I don't mind if it takes a while,' said Atsuko .

Because Gotou was looking down, he didn't know what sort of expression she was making .

Talking to Atsuko wouldn't find them the culprit .

There was the last case too . If he talked to Atsuko, he'd probably make her worry . However, his desire to let her know was still stronger .

'Could you get a beer?' said Gotou, pressing his cigarette into the ashtray .

'Mind if I have one too?'

After Atsuko said that, she headed for the kitchen without waiting for Gotou's reply and brought back two cans of beer from the refrigerator .

Gotou lit a new cigarette and took a sip of beer . Then, he started explaining the connections regarding the case .

It started fifteen years ago, when Gotou saved a boy .

He had always been bad at explaining to people, so he took a while, unable to summarise the story concisely .

However, Atsuko still listened to his story silently .

How many years has it been since I talked for so long to Atsuko –

It was a mysterious feeling, like telling an old tale to a child .

16

Ishii took a can of beer in both hands and passed through the gate to the temple .

The wind that blew through was cold .

Even though it would soon be spring, the night really was cold .

The temple stood out in the darkness, as if it were itself emitting light .

The outdoor lamps lit up the temple as the investigation was underway .

Though Ishii understood, it still looked creepy to him .

– What method did Nanase Miyuki use to stab Isshin?

That puzzle was still unsolved .

Ishii sighed . Then, somebody passed by him .

'Ah!'

He'd seen the face before – it was Saitou Yakumo .

'Er, Yakumo-shi . '

Yakumo might have an ingenious plan .

Ishii called out to him, but Yakumo silently walked towards the cemetery as if he hadn't heard anything .

His profile was paler than usual – he looked like a living corpse .

– I wonder what happened .

In Ishii's confusion, Yakumo disappeared, as if swallowed by the darkness .

– Was that an illusion just now?

It was to the point that Ishii thought his eyes might have been playing tricks on him .

'Oi, Ishii . What're you standing there for!?'

Miyagawa shouted from the front of the temple .

Ishii hurriedly ran towards Miyagawa .

'E-e-excuse me . '

Ishii held out two cans of coffee for Miyagawa .

'You an idiot? One of them's yours . '

'T-thank you very much . '

Miyagawa took just one can from Ishii and pulled open the tab .

'Well, sit down . '

'Ah, yes . '

Urged by Miyagawa, Ishii sat on the steps, holding the can of coffee in his hands without opening it .

'Don't be so stiff . You underestimate yourself . '

'Underestimate... is it?'

It was the first time in his life that he had ever been told that .

He'd been called idiot and blockhead countless times .

He didn't feel frustrated or angry about it . That was because he thought it was true .

That was why he didn't understand when Miyagawa said he was underestimating himself .

'You should be more confident . '

'Ah, but...'

Miyagawa said it so simply, but it was difficult .

He wasn't hesitant because he wanted to be . He just couldn't believe in his own thoughts .

When he heard other people's opinions, he always ended up thinking that they were correct . He couldn't be decisive .

That was all .

'Want a smoke?'

Miyagawa took out a cigarette case .

'I don't smoke,' said Ishii, waving a hand .

He had tried smoking before, but it made him cough terribly . It didn't agree with him .

'I see,' murmured Miyagawa . Meanwhile, he put a cigarette in his mouth and lit it .

'Has there been any new information?' asked Ishii as he watched the investigation team move about .

'The window in the back of the temple was broken . Nanase Miyuki's fingerprints were found there,' said Miyagawa with a depressed expression .

'Was that the route she used to break in?'

'They were relatively new fingerprints so that's probably right . '

'I see . '

'But that means...'

Miyagawa trailed off .

'Ah, that's right...'

Ishii nodded, sensing how Miyagawa felt .

If they specified the back window as the break-in route, the crime using a trap that Miyagawa suggested would naturally be eliminated .

Miyagawa seemed to think it unfortunate from the expression on his profile . When Ishii looked at it, a question came up in his head .

– Is the back really the break-in route?

Ishii thought carefully about the day of the crime .

Isshin went to the temple to meditate, and Gotou told Ishii to guard the entrance .

But –

'I didn't hear anything . '

When Ishii declared that, Miyagawa's eyebrow twitched .

'What do you mean?'

'I was standing here the whole time,' explained Ishii as he climbed the stairs to stand at the temple's sliding door .

'OK . '

'I was listening so that I would be able to move immediately if there were anything out of the ordinary . However...'

'You didn't hear the window break . '

Ishii responded with a nod .

It had been a quiet, windless night . If there had been the sound of a window breaking, he would have definitely noticed .

'At least the window was not broken at the time of the crime,' finished Ishii .

'Then when was the window broken?'

'That is...'

Ishii didn't know at this stage .

'Since Miyuki's fingerprints were on it, she has to be the one who broke it .
,

'Please wait a moment . '

Ishii took out a memo pad and started writing a time schedule to organise his thoughts .

Miyuki was carried to the infirmary past six PM –

Then, Isshin was stabbed at nine PM –

Ishii predicted that Miyuki escaped the detention house and committed the crime in those three hours . He put that with the information he had gathered until now .

Yamamura showed up at the infirmary at about seven PM –

Furthermore, Isshin went into the temple at eight thirty PM –

The time frame was fairly narrow .

'From seven PM to eight thirty PM, Miyuki left the detention house, broke the temple window and went in...' said Miyagawa as he peeked at Ishii's mirror .

If the investigated within this hour and a half, it would be much more effective .

'Miyagawa-san, do you have a moment?'

As the conversation came to a lull, a man in a blue uniform from investigations came towards them and spoke up .

'What?'

Miyagawa pressed his cigarette into a portable ashtray and followed the man from investigations into the temple .

Ishii's interest was piqued, so he followed after Miyagawa too .

The inside of the temple was also lit up to the point it was glaring .

'Please look at this . '

The man from investigations held up the plastic bag in his hand to show them .

In the bag there was something like a thin wire .

'What's that?' said Miyagawa, picking the bag up .

'It was caught on that statue of the Buddha . '

The man from investigations pointed at the statute of the Buddha at the front .

It was a wooden statue of Gautama Buddha . It frightened Ishii – the half – open eyes seemed to see through to the bottom of his heart .

'Though it is faint, there are also traces of blood . '

The man from investigations pointed at part of the wire in the plastic bag .

It certainly was dyed dark red .

– Wait a second .

When Ishii saw that, another thought came to mind .

Earlier, he had thought that the fingerprints on the window disproved the theory of crime by some sort of device .

However, if he thought about it differently, Miyuki might have purposefully left the fingerprints on the back window to hide the trap she used to commit the crime .

She had done the same sort of thing during a past incident . Miyuki often used this trick .

But what device could stab Isshin with a knife – Ishii didn't know .

Yakumo stood in front of a gravestone .

The engraved name stood out in the moonlight .

– Takagishi Family Grave .

The person sleeping under here was Yakumo's middle-school teacher and Nao's mother . She was also the person who might have become his mother

–

He couldn't save her either .

– But why can my eye see?

Yakumo touched the gravestone with his fingertips .

It was hard and cold to the touch . It was just a stone; there was no way it would answer .

His body trembled .

'Is it really my fault...' said Yakumo in a voice that trailed off .

The words were not directed to anybody in particular . He had not said them expecting an answer .

However, a response came back from the darkness .

– Yes . Everything is your fault .

Yakumo shut his eyes and sighed .

He realised immediately whose voice it was .

In the past, he had desperately prayed that he would never meet him, and now he was frantically searching for him .

'Come out . '

Yakumo's eyes snapped open as he said that in a hard tone .

'If you wish . '

At the same time as that voice, a man walked out of the darkness .

He wore a black suit and his long hair flowed down his back . Even though it was night, he wore dark sunglasses, and his pale skin stood out .

It was the first time Yakumo had confronted this man like this .

However, he knew who it was immediately .

He didn't determine it from seeing him . The blood flowing through Yakumo's veins told him so .

'So it really was you?'

'That tone of voice isn't very appropriate when talking to your father . '

'I've never thought of you as my father . '

'It's not a problem of whether you think so or not . Doesn't that red eye of yours prove it? The bond between you and me . '

The man slowly took off his sunglasses .

The moonlight illuminated his deep red eyes, making it look as if they were glittering .

'Uncle is my father,' Yakumo said shortly .

He didn't want to acknowledge it . That the same blood that flowed through this man flowed through himself –

'But you couldn't save him . '

'You're wrong . '

'Not just him . Your mother and that woman – you couldn't save them either . '

'I...'

'Because of you, everyone died . '

The man's sentence seemed to pierce through to Yakumo's core .

– Everyone died .

Everyone important to me dies – that reality crushed Yakumo's heart .

'Your blood is cursed . You can't escape it . '

The man walked towards Yakumo like he was floating across the ground .

I want to run – that impulse made Yakumo turn away .

'Hiding won't change reality . '

A cool smile graced the man's lips .

'That's...'

'I have had a number of children up until now, but the only one who has inherited my genetics – my red eye – and remains living... is you . '

'... I don't want to understand,' said Yakumo, as if the words were strangled out of him .

However, that voice did not echo . The darkness swallowed it .

'No, you should already understand . '

'I can't understand,' said Yakumo with a furious expression .

However, that serious thought was also swallowed up by that man's red eyes .

'Seeing the spirits of the dead makes you suffer, doesn't it? It hurts, doesn't it? You end up seeing things you don't have to see . You know things you don't have to know . '

'So what?'

'Even if you can escape for a moment, it happens again . '

Yakumo gritted his teeth .

– I can't listen to what this man says .

With strong conviction, Yakumo opposed him . After all, it was just ego to justify himself .

But –

The other person hidden in the depths of his heart understood what this man said . And he agreed .

Nothing would change from trying by himself .

People were powerless .

The same thing would happen .

Then, people would die –

The resentment and hatred of the dead wandered the world .

He saw it .

Even though he didn't want to – he saw it .

Yakumo bit the inside of his lip .

Pain and the taste of blood filled his mouth .

With that he was finally able to come to his senses .

'That's why you kill people?'

The man smiled at Yakumo's words .

'Kill? Me? I haven't killed anyone . All I have done is fulfil desires . I just lend a hand . Isn't that right?'

– It's just as he says .

This man had had a hand in a number of cases .

However, he had never directly done anything . He had just given a few backs a push .

With his guidance, people were shaken by their desires; as a result, people died .

Yakumo didn't know what was right any more .

'I don't want to see my son suffer any more . '

'Suffer?'

'That's right . Isshin doesn't know your true feelings – he just says platitudes and misleads you . What Isshin says is only an illusion . You know that too, right?'

– So that really was it?

Isshin really was stabbed because of him .

When Yakumo realised that, he felt himself falling into a deep darkness .

– If I weren't here, this wouldn't have happened .

That thought ran about his head .

When his own existence was denied, Yakumo's heart lost even its usual composure and transfigured into something terribly fragile .

'What are you telling me to do...' Yakumo asked the man .

Yakumo had lost his way – he appeared to be pleading .

When the man saw Yakumo like that, he smiled broadly, as if he could not have expected anything better .

'Come with me . I'll teach you...'

The man slowly walked into the darkness .

– What is in that darkness?

Yakumo didn't know, but he felt like he would be released from his suffering if he followed the man .

In his doubt, he took the first step forward .

That moment, the mobile phone in his pocket rang to tell him he had a text .

Yakumo took out his mobile .

'Throw that away,' said the man, turning around .

'Throw it away?'

'Yes . It causes troublesome involvements which change into doubts . '

– It really was true .

Yakumo was about to throw his mobile phone when the wind blew .

– Don't throw it away .

It felt like it was saying that .

Yakumo opened the text that had arrived .

It was a text from Haruka .

Just one sentence .

– I want to see you .

That short sentence shook Yakumo's heart .

'What's wrong?' asked the man .

– I...

The wind blew again .

A cloud of dust danced by and went into Yakumo's left eye .

He pressed his hand against the left eye from the pain .

'What are you hesitating for? We're going . '

The man pressed forward .

Yakumo lifted his face, still pressing a hand against his left eye .

He heard something beating in his chest .

Yakumo took the hand off his eye and looked at the man again .

– I see . So that's how it is .

At this moment, Yakumo understood everything that had been a puzzle to him up until now .

18

Before Haruka knew it, she was at the temple .

She was standing on the wooden floor with bare feet . She looked up and saw a statue of Gautama Buddha enshrined in front of her .

She stepped towards the solemn figure, as if drawn in .

Creak –

With every step, the floorboards creaked underneath her .

After walking so close she could touch the Buddha statue, she noticed somebody's presence behind her .

Haruka turned around, startled .

She saw somebody standing in the temple entrance .

He had terrible bedhead and wore a white shirt and jeans .

That's –

'Yakumo-kun,' said Haruka in her delight .

She had looked for him since yesterday . She was finally able to meet him .

With no response, Yakumo stood there like a statue .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun, where were you?'

Haruka walked towards Yakumo as she called out to him, but Yakumo didn't respond .

Clang –

Something slipped out of Yakumo's hand .

'Hey!'

Haruka looked at his feet and exclaimed in surprise .

Fallen there was a knife covered in blood .

'The true nature of humanity... is darkness . '

Yakumo's eyes were narrowed as he smiled, like he was in a trance .

'Yakumo-kun... right?'

Yakumo didn't reply to Haruka's question .

He just smiled uncannily, turned around on his heels and walked towards the exit .

'Wait, Yakumo-kun!'

Haruka hurriedly chased after Yakumo .

It was strange – even though Haruka was running after him, she couldn't catch up to Yakumo, who was walking .

Yakumo's back kept moving farther away –

'Yakumo-kun! Wait!'

Even though she was running and running, the distance between them kept growing .

'Don't go!' yelled Haruka from the bottom of her stomach, and then she sat straight up .

'You're so noisy . '

– Eh?

Haruka was quickly brought back to reality by that voice .

She couldn't see clearly since it was so bright . After blinking a number of times, she finally saw who was standing in the white light .

'Could it be you, Yakumo-kun?' asked Haruka, confused .

'There's no "could" about it . '

That blunt way of speaking – it had to be Yakumo .

'Why are you here, Yakumo-kun?'

'This is my room . It's natural for me to be here . '

'Eh?'

'Don't "eh" me . On top of worming your way into my room, you're making false accusations in your sleep . How can you be such a dunce?'

Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair and yawned .

His left eye was a vivid red .

Now, Haruka finally realised that what she had seen earlier was a dream .

Yesterday, she had been waiting for Yakumo in this room and had fallen asleep at some point with her head on the table .

'Where did you go!? I was worried!' protested Haruka, her emotions tipping over as she pointed a finger at Yakumo .

Even though she had been so worried, Yakumo was acting so nonchalant . It irritated her .

'Don't shout,' said Yakumo fingers in his ears .

'I want to shout . When you suddenly disappear at a serious time . I...'

Haruka furiously held back the tears that were threatening to spill out .

Happiness and frustration stirred up her gloomy heart .

'My bad . In a number of ways . I had some things I had to think about,' said Yakumo as he turned his back to Haruka .

Haruka hit his back .

'Don't think by yourself, idiot . '

'That's quite the tone when you're an idiot yourself . I apologised properly, didn't I?'

Yakumo turned back to her and ran a hand through his hair in exasperation .

'Shut up . Idiot . I definitely won't forgive you . '

Even though she was so happy that Yakumo had returned that she didn't know what to do, in her stubbornness, she couldn't act honestly happy .

– I'm the idiot .

I might be the reason the distance between Yakumo and me doesn't shorten – so Haruka ended up thinking .

'How can I cheer you up? Should I buy you some chocolate?' said Yakumo lightly .

– He's making fun of me .

'I don't want chocolate!'

'Then what do you want?'

'I don't want anything . Just don't go off somewhere without my permission again!'

'I'm not your possession . '

'I know that! But I don't like it!'

Before she knew it, she was crying .

Showing her tears made it feel like she had lost . She bit her lip in mortification .

However, the more she tried to hold the tears in, the more came out .

Finally, Haruka covered her face with both hands and started sobbing .

'I get it . I'll tell you next time . '

Yakumo stood up and lightly touched Haruka's shoulder .

His white fingers seemed to trace Haruka's contours as they went from her shoulder to her neck .

Haruka's body trembled – it felt strange, like the strength was leaving her body . At the same time, she felt her heart melt, though it had been hard up until earlier .

Haruka looked at Yakumo's red eye .

– It really is beautiful .

As she thought that, she naturally closed her eyes .

It was a pleasant silence . If only time would stop now – so she thought .

Yakumo's breath brushed Haruka's earlobe .

'You saved me again,' said Yakumo, faintly – very faintly .

Yakumo's presence suddenly disappeared into the dark .

– Is this a dream too?

Haruka hurriedly opened her eyes .

Yakumo was right in front of her eyes, but he was putting something on .

'What are you doing?'

'Going out?'

'Where to?'

Haruka stood up as she wiped her tears .

'Where? Obviously to solve the mystery behind the case . '

'R-really...'

Yakumo said that in a matter-of-fact manner, but there was no way for Haruka to understand without an explanation .

'I'm going to leave you behind if you don't hurry,' said Yakumo as he ran a hand through his hair . Then, he left the room briskly .

Though Yakumo was the same as always, Haruka felt like something was wrong .

– He's too normal .

Yakumo should know Isshin's condition too, so how could he be so calm?

'Aren't you coming?'

Haruka's thoughts were interrupted when she heard Yakumo urging her .

– There's no point thinking about these things now .

Haruka followed Yakumo out of the room .

19

The first thing Gotou saw at work was Ishii, sleeping with his head on the desk .

Tools like scissors and screwdrivers were scattered about .

– What the hell is he using these for?

'You can't... Please stop it already...'

Ishii shook his head back and forth as he mumbled incoherently in his sleep .

– He's probably having some stupid dream .

Gotou had gone home early at Miyagawa's behest yesterday . It appeared that Ishii had stayed up all night working after that .

When Gotou thought about that, though he didn't feel guilty, he still didn't like listening to the strange sleeptalk .

'Wake up!'

Gotou hit Ishii's head .

'Ack!' yelled Ishii as he jumped up like a frog .

'You're so noisy,' complained Gotou . He put a cigarette in his mouth and sat in his own seat .

Ishii rubbed his bloodshot eyes, put on the glasses that had been on the table . After confirming it was Gotou in front of him, he said awkwardly, 'D-Detective Gotou... I apologise; it seems I fell asleep . '

Even though it had only been one day, Ishii's face looked a bit hollow .

It looked like he'd made Ishii bear the burden by himself at a difficult time .

'My bad about yesterday . '

Gotou apologised honestly .

However, Ishii didn't seem to understand . He just stared blankly for a while .

'Er, I mean, because I went home early...' said Gotou, lighting his cigarette .

Ishii looked like he finally understood . He clapped his hands together .

'Oh, I'm fine . More importantly, how is Nao-chan?'

'She's calmed down . '

Gotou would be embarrassed explaining everything that happened yesterday, so he left it at that .

'So how's the investigation?' asked Gotou . Ishii's expression clouded over instantly .

– This guy's really easy to understand .

'That is... rather difficult... regarding the method the crime was committed... er... well . '

Ishii's replies never gave him the important points .

Gotou felt, a bit late, that this characteristic of his irritated people .

'It's not like I thought the case would suddenly be solved . Tell me what you know now . '

'Ah, y-yes sir . '

Ishii took a memo pad from his jacket and started explaining the situation with the investigation .

'A broken window was found in the back of the temple, and Nanase Miyuki's fingerprints were found there as well . '

'I see . '

That made it very likely that Miyuki had gotten in from the back of the temple .

– But is that really how it happened?

'However, since I did not hear the sound of breaking glass on the night of the crime, I feel like it happened earlier,' added Ishii, as if he had expected Gotou's question .

'That'd be possible,' agreed Gotou . He was about to tap the ashes off his cigarette but he couldn't find an ashtray .

– Where is it?

Gotou looked about the room as he listened to Ishii .

'Something like a wire was also found at the temple . '

'A wire, eh...'

Gotou found the ashtray in a cabinet with glass doors .

– Why's it here?

With that question in his mind, Gotou put his hand on the cabinet to take the ashtray out .

'Ah! Detective Gotou! You can't!' shouted Ishii, standing up .

But he was too late –

When Gotou opened the door, there was a popping sound .

At the same time, something flew out .

Gotou was so surprised he couldn't avoid it .

It was a direct hit on his forehead .

'Ow . '

He put his hand to his forehead . Something was stuck there .

It didn't hurt as much as he thought it did .

– The hell is this?

Gotou pulled it off his head with another pop .

Its tip was a suction cup – a toy arrow for children .

'That's why I said that you can't open the cabinet . '

Half in tears, Ishii approached Gotou .

'Ishii, were you playing around while I was gone?'

The part of Gotou that had felt sorry earlier now felt angry . He grabbed Ishii by the lapels and shook him .

'That isn't it,' objected Ishii, shaking his head .

'What isn't it!? Eh?'

'It was an experiment . '

'Experimenting to see how I'd respond to a prank!?'

'It was an experiment since we think Nanase Miyuki's crime might not have been committed by her escaping the detention house but by using a trap like this . '

– I see .

Gotou finally understood what Ishii was trying to say .

When the door opened, an arrow flew out . If Miyuki made a trap like this, she could make a knife fly out and stab Isshin instead .

If she used this method, she wouldn't have to go out of her way to escape the detention house .

Gotou understood that . But –

'Then why didn't you say that first!?'

'Because you opened the door before I could say it, Detective Gotou . '

'Shut up!'

'You're a hundred times noisier . '

Along with the voice, something hit the back of Gotou's head .

– Who the hell would suddenly hit somebody's head like this?

Gotou let go of Ishii and turned around with a furious expression .

Standing there was Miyagawa .

'Honestly . I can't tell if you guys are serious or playing around,'
complained Miyagawa . He crossed his arms and sat on a nearby chair .

'What are you saying? We are always serious . '

'You don't say,' said Miyagawa with suspicious eyes .

'What are you here for, Miyagawa-san?'

'I finished preparing what Ishii asked for so I came all the way here for that
' . '

– Ishii asked for something?

Gotou felt something was off .

He couldn't imagine Ishii asking Miyagawa for anything .

'Is that so? Thank you very much . '

Ishii's eyes were sparkling .

'What did you ask for?'

'I requested for the footage from the security cameras at the detention house,' said Ishii energetically .

'I've got it set up in the conference room . '

After declaring just that, Miyagawa stood up and left the room briskly .

'Why do you need the security camera footage?'

'If she escaped the detention house, she might be in that footage . '

As usual, Ishii was excited .

However, Gotou felt there was a contradiction in that answer .

'Didn't Miyuki use a trap to stab Isshin?'

'There is that possibility . '

'Then she didn't need to leave the detention house, right?'

'That's right . '

'Then why are we looking at the security camera footage?'

Ishii's brows furrowed at Gotou's question .

'Well, that is... I feel like the trap theory is plausible, but the escape theory is also difficult to abandon... so...'

Though Ishii didn't say it clearly, in short he couldn't decide which one it was .

Normally, Gotou would hit Ishii's head and say, 'Make up your mind!'
However, Gotou couldn't come to a decision either .

Right now, thinking about it wouldn't bring about an answer .

If he looked at it a different way, checking the security camera footage would make it clear whether Miyuki escaped or not .

– We can think about what comes next after .

'Got it . Let's go . '

Gotou came to a decision and stood up .

20

– Solve the mystery .

Led by Yakumo, who had said those words, Haruka went to the hospital where Isshin was hospitalised .

Haruka was a bit confused by this unexpected development .

In order to solve the mystery, they'd need to meet up with Gotou and Ishii first to gather information – is what she thought .

'Is this really the right place?' asked Haruka, though she knew it was unnecessary concern .

'Does it look like I'm lost? I'm not you,' replied Yakumo with a yawn .

'Don't make it sound like I have no sense of direction . '

'Was I wrong?'

'That's not the point...'

While Haruka was talking, Yakumo briskly went into the hospital .

– He's always like this .

Haruka pinned down her irritation and followed Yakumo into the hospital .

Once inside the hospital, Yakumo went straight to the reception, declared, 'I have an appointment with Doctor Arai Mao,' and was instructed to wait on the bench in the waiting room .

When Haruka heard Mao's name, she remembered something important .

'I met Mao-sensei yesterday . '

'That so,' said Yakumo disinterestedly . He sat on the bench .

Haruka sat next to him .

'She asked me to search for Yakumo-kun so she could talk to you about Isshin-san . '

'I'm going to see her now . '

That was true, but there was something Haruka didn't understand .

'Before you solve the mystery, you're going to see Mao-sensei about Isshin-san,' said Haruka to confirm .

'Both . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair .

'What do you mean by both?'

'You have so many questions . More importantly, how's Nao?'

Yakumo's expression clouded over .

Though Yakumo was unsociable, Nao alone was special . Yakumo always had a gentle smile in front of her .

That was how deep his affection for her was .

'Though it seemed like she was shocked, she's calmed down a bit now . '

'I see...'

'Gotou-san's wife is reliable – Nao-chan likes her too...'

'That's great . '

Yakumo half-closed his eyes and looked up at the ceiling .

'Go visit them,' said Haruka while looking at her right hand .

It made her remember grasping Nao's small hand .

Though Nao didn't show it, it must have actually been tough on her . She must have been sad and in pain .

Yakumo was the only one who could heal her heart .

'Right...' murmured Yakumo .

Then, there was an announcement: 'Saitou Yakumo-san, please head to examination room number three . '

'OK, shall we go?'

Yakumo rubbed his hands together as he said that and briskly walked towards the corridor .

Haruka still had questions as she followed after Yakumo .

They went down the corridor by the reception desk and stopped in front of a room with a plate that read 'Examination Room #3' .

It was the same place Haruka had come to yesterday .

'It's Saitou Yakumo,' said Yakumo towards the door as he knocked .

'Please come in . '

Mao's voice came from inside .

Yakumo opened the door and went inside . Haruka followed him .

'You finally came . '

Mao was sitting at her desk . Once she saw Yakumo's face, her expression softened in relief .

'Did you bring him here?'

Mao looked at Haruka .

Unfortunately, Haruka had forgotten about Mao's request until she came to the hospital .

'No, I didn't,' replied Haruka, which made Mao look confused .

'Yakumo-kun came on his own . I didn't...'

'That doesn't matter,' interrupted Yakumo, seeming displeased .

'Anyway, sit down . '

Mao tried to change the mood and urged them to sit on the round chairs .

Haruka and Yakumo sat down .

'Now, where should I start...'

Mao spread out the doctor's chart on her desk and spun a pen in her fingers as she mumbled .

The heavy atmosphere filled the examination room . Though she was a doctor, it probably was difficult to tell relatives things they did not want to hear .

'Is my uncle's condition the same?' said Yakumo expressionlessly .

'It is . I think that Doctor Sakakibara explained this as well, but we suspect that Isshin-kun may be brain-dead . '

Hearing that once more hurt Haruka, like she had been stabbed in the chest with a needle .

'Is that so,' Yakumo replied curtly .

Haruka looked at his profile . His expression hadn't changed .

However, that didn't mean he didn't feel anything . Yakumo was holding back his feelings .

'We cannot say anything for certain until we examine him more closely, but his condition is serious . '

Haruka wanted to cover her ears when she heard this continuation of things she couldn't believe, but she knew that doing so wouldn't change the situation .

Isshin had been fine until the day before yesterday .

Now, he could only live with the aid of a respirator –

'Then what are you telling me to do?' asked Yakumo with narrowed eyes .

It was like he suspected something .

Perhaps Yakumo doubted the fact that Isshin was brain-dead . It seemed that way to Haruka .

'It isn't a question of what to do . I just wanted to tell you the situation . '

'You didn't look for me just to tell me the situation, right?' said Yakumo disinterestedly as he yawned .

With that one sentence, the atmosphere suddenly became heavier .

For a while, Mao just sat there, but then she opened her desk drawer and took a card out .

The card had a cute picture of an angel on it .

Haruka recalled seeing that card somewhere .

– An organ donor card[1] .

Also called a donor card . If you died or were in a brain-dead state, it showed whether you agreed to donate your organs or not .

'Isshin-kun is registered as a donor . '

Mao's voice was so faint it felt like it would disappear at any moment .

Haruka thought it was like Isshin to make that choice . He was incredibly self-sacrificing .

'So you want my consent – that's it, isn't it?'

Yakumo's expression didn't change .

Even if Isshin was registered as a donor, his organs couldn't be donated without his family's consent .

It appeared that the reason Mao was searching for Yakumo was to receive his consent .

Now that Haruka knew that, she had complicated feelings .

Choosing to follow up with the organ donation meant that Mao had already given up on Isshin's recovery .

'With your consent, Yakumo-kun, we will contact the donor coordinator and formally determine his brain death,' said Mao in a business-like manner, her fingernails clawing into the desk .

It was obvious she was angry .

– What are you going to do?

Haruka looked at Yakumo .

just for a moment, Yakumo's cheek twitched, but that was all .

'I will think about it,' said Yakumo shortly . He gave the card back to Mao .

Mao silently looked at the card .

– It hurts me too .

It felt like she was saying that .

Finally, Yakumo ran a hand through his hair and said, 'You still have something to say to me, right?'

When Mao heard that, she opened her mouth for a moment, but she finally shook her head .

'That's all I have to say,' she said quietly .

What was that? Haruka didn't understand what they were talking about .

– Finding out each other's intentions .

That was what it felt like to Haruka .

'I understand . I'll excuse myself for today . '

Perhaps Yakumo had given up, because he stood up and headed for the door in an extremely slow manner .

Haruka stood up too, bowed towards Mao and then followed Yakumo .

'Yakumo-kun . '

Just as Yakumo opened the door, Mao called out to him .

Haruka turned around at the voice, but Yakumo didn't .

'A tumour was found in Isshin-kun's brain . '

'A tumour in his brain?'

Haruka's voice jumped an octave .

At the same time, she recalled how Mao and Isshin had been talking about an exam the day before yesterday .

'Though it wasn't malignant, there was a problem with where it was, which made it difficult to remove in surgery . '

Mao lowered her eyelashes .

Yakumo turned around .

'Uncle would have died in any case . Is that what you want to say?' whispered Yakumo .

However, his red left eye was filled with anger .

'That isn't it . '

'Then what is it?'

'I just wanted you to know . That's all . '

When Mao said that while looking down, it just sounded like an excuse .

Yakumo left the room with a bitter smile .

– Even if the doctor has given up, we believe in miracles . Right, Yakumo?

Haruka called out to Yakumo's back as he walked down the corridor .

21

'Do you really plan on checking all of this?' interrupted Gotou, who was at the limit of his concentration .

There was a much greater amount of security camera footage than Gotou had expected . And it was incredibly booring footage .

Rooms with nobody in them . Corridors with nobody in them . He kept watching footage of nothing happening .

Looking at abstract paintings would be more enjoyable .

'Of course . If she escaped, it should have left a trace somewhere . '

Ishii's eyes were sparkling, like he thought this was fun .

This sort of simple work might have been his specialty .

'How much left?' said Gotou, looking up at the ceiling in his exhaustion .

'Let's see... In total, there are five hundred cameras in the detention house . We have limited it to the hour and a half when the incident took place, and one person looks at four at a time, so with two people... We will be done in ninety-three hours . '

Ishii smiled, showing his white teeth .

– You kidding me?

'That's a full four days! I give up . '

If Gotou watched this for four days, he'd go nuts . This wasn't investigation – this was torture .

Sulking, Gotou lined up three chairs and used them as a bed .

'Detective Gotou, I can't do this by myself . Please help . '

'Shut up!'

Gotou rejected Ishii, who was half in tears .

– The investigation won't get anywhere no matter how long we take if we go on like this .

As Gotou grumbled in his head, he clicked his tongue . Then, the mobile phone in his jacket pocket rang .

'Who is it?'

Still lying down, Gotou answered the phone .

<I will say this again, but please fix your phone manner . >

Gotou leapt up when he heard that voice .

'Yakumo! You bastard! Where the hell were you!?' yelled Gotou into the receiver .

<Please don't speak so loudly . >

Yakumo gave his usual complaint in his usual tone of voice .

– This idiot .

Gotou had been worried about him, thinking that he might have been psychologically cornered because Isshin had been stabbed, but he was just as impertinent as usual .

Gotou felt stupid for worrying .

'What are you doing now and where?'

<I'm at the hospital . More importantly, how far has the investigation advanced?>

Gotou wanted to yell at Yakumo for being such a pain, but he decided not to .

Since Yakumo had gone out of his way to stick his nose into the investigation, it'd be troublesome if Yakumo became angry .

Yakumo was the only one who could break through any investigation, no matter how stuck it was .

'To be honest, it hasn't advanced much . '

<Is that so?>

Yakumo's response was weaker than Gotou had thought it would be .

It was like Yakumo was saying it was just as he had expected .

'Miyuki's fingerprints were found on the knife and on the window in the back of the temple . '

<Fingerprints...>

'Yeah . It's very likely that Miyuki's the culprit . '

<What are you doing now, Gotou-san?>

'We've got a theory that Nanase Miyuki escaped the detention house so we're in the middle of checking the detention house security camera footage . '

<Gotou-san . >

Yakumo sounded gentle .

Gotou had never heard this tone of voice from him before .

'What?' Gotou asked .

<You really have a lot of free time . >

'W-what?'

Gotou was surprised by the unexpected reply .

<And you are also a blockhead . >

'You bastard! Who'd you say was a blockhead!?'

Gotou's anger went to the max in an instant, and he yelled with his face bright red .

<I called you a blockhead because you're a blockhead . >

'I'll kill you if you don't stop that . '

<But aren't I right? How many days do you think it'll take to check the security camera footage from the detention house?>

Hearing that from Yakumo hurt .

Gotou himself had thrown in the towel just earlier .

'Just shut your mouth already!'

<You anger quickly when the situation turns for the worse . You really are animalistic . >

Yakumo snorted .

Gotou wanted to retort back, but all he could think of was insults like 'idiot' and 'fool' .

<Anyway, if you have enough time to watch boring videos, please come here immediately . >

'Don't use the police as your personal cab . '

<Am I wrong?>

— This brat!

Though Gotou's chest was filled with anger, the words that came out of him weren't .

'Where should I go?'

– I hate to admit it, but I want Yakumo’s brain right now .

It was impossible for Gotou’s and Ishii’s heads to solve the case . Yakumo was absolutely necessary to beat Miyuki .

Plus, since it was Yakumo, he probably hadn’t been playing around while he was out of contact .

What is Yakumo thinking and where is he heading for – Gotou wanted to know .

<I’m waiting at the hospital . >

Yakumo said that and hung up .

It pisses me off, but there’s nothing I can do now . I’ll go with you to the end – Gotou was determined .

‘Oi! Ishii! We’re going!’

Gotou said that quickly and headed for the exit .

‘Er, how about checking the security cameras!’

‘Just leave that!’ yelled Gotou .

However, it seemed like Ishii still didn’t understand the situation . His face was blank .

– Honestly . All the guy’s got is weird knowledge . He’s got no sense at all .

‘Hurry up, you fool! I’ll smack your head off!’

When Gotou raised his fist, Ishii instinctively stood up and ran .

– He fell .

Haruka sat on the bench in the hospital courtyard and waited for Yakumo to finish talking on the phone .

She realised quickly that he was talking to Gotou .

Though she couldn't hear the conversation in detail, Yakumo spoke like he had already solved the mystery behind the case .

– Does it have something to do with what he talked about with Mao earlier?

At first, there had been talking about Isshin's condition, but then the atmosphere changed before she knew it .

To Haruka, it looked like Yakumo suspected that Mao was related to the case somehow .

'Did you find anything out?' asked Haruka when Yakumo hung up .

Yakumo raised his left eyebrow and frowned, like he was a Kabuki actor[2]
.

'You really are carefree . I'm envious . '

– He's always like that .

'Yes, yes, I'm carefree . '

'What, so you do understand that?'

Yakumo started walking briskly .

– Because you just do whatever you want .

While she thought that, always chasing after his back was a depressing way to live –

Yakumo returned to the hospital again and took the elevator .

He didn't explain where he was going, but Haruka had an idea about where he was going after coming this far .

Yakumo silently got off the elevator and went straight down the corridor .

At the end of the corridor was the ICU where Isshin was accommodated .

Just as Haruka thought, Yakumo stopped in front of the ICU and looked at Isshin through the glass .

There was a doctor inside checking the machines .

Haruka remembered seeing him before . His name was Sakakibara, the doctor who first did treatment . The nurse named Furukawa was with him .

Isshin was still sleeping . He looked a size smaller .

'Yakumo-kun, is Isshin-san really brain-dead?'

She wanted him to deny it .

'I can't say, since I'm not a doctor,' replied Yakumo expressionlessly .

'Right . '

Disappointed, Haruka looked at her feet .

Haruka couldn't accept the fact . Even if it was just a silly wish, she couldn't help but want the judgement to be incorrect .

'Do you think that people who are brain-dead are dead?' Yakumo suddenly asked .

Haruka furrowed her brows as she thought .

To be honest, she had never thought about it before, so –

'I don't know... What do you think, Yakumo-kun?'

Haruka's eyes flickered to Yakumo .

His slightly downcast profile was lifeless, as if he were a statue .

'To be honest, I don't know either . '

'Oh . '

'When somebody becomes brain-dead, they cannot even breathe on their own, think or feel . The brain forms the self, so when that is stopped, it could be said that they become only a lump of meat...'

Yakumo spoke like he were reading out of a textbook .

It sounded extremely cold . Rather than Yakumo's own opinion, he was probably just listening facts .

– The body is the container of the soul .

Haruka recalled something Yakumo had said before .

That would mean –

'If somebody becomes brain-dead, what happens to their soul?'

Haruka said the question as it came to her head .

'Since this is a first for me too, I don't know . However, Uncle's soul is still in there . That's what I think . '

Yakumo sent a piercing gaze towards Isshin .

From that one sentence, Haruka felt like she could see a small light of hope .

– Yakumo hasn't given up yet .

He had probably had that exchange with Mao earlier because he still believed Isshin would get better .

– Please, Isshin-san . Open your eyes .

Haruka gripped the red stone on her necklace tightly .

'There is something called the Act on Organ Transplantation . '

This time, Yakumo brought up another topic .

'I've heard of it . '

Though she didn't know the details, she had heard the name before .

'Though there are plans to revise it, under the current law, brain-death is not recognised as death of the person . '

'Really?'

Haruka's voice showed her surprise .

She sometimes heard about organs being donated from people who were brain-dead . From that she had thought that brain death meant death of the person .

'Even if somebody is brain-dead, they are alive in the eyes of the law . '

'Then wouldn't organ donation be a problem?'

If brain-death was considered alive by the law, that would mean they were taking organs from people who were alive .

Since that would make them die, it would become murder .

'That's why there's the Act on Organ Transplantation . People who are brain-dead are only considered dead if they are registered as organ donors . '

– I'm confused .

That would mean registering or not registering to be a donor would determine whether you were alive or dead .

'That's a bit unnatural . '

Haruka said the first thing that came to mind .

'It is . It's unnatural for one card to determine whether somebody is dead . '

'Right . '

'What determines whether Uncle is dead or alive isn't science or law . It's the soul . '

Every word Yakumo spoke echoed heavily in Haruka's chest .

She felt like she understood why Yakumo had spoken coldly to Mao earlier .

The moment Yakumo agreed to the organ donation, Isshin would be determined as brain-dead . Even if his body moved, he would be considered as dead .

However, Yakumo hadn't come to a decision yet .

Where does the soul go when somebody is brain-dead – to Yakumo, the criterion for death was probably not something under the law or science but the continuation or loss of the soul .

More than anything, Yakumo believed that Isshin would recover .

'Soon...' murmured Yakumo, looking at Haruka .

'I have a request to make of you . '

He looked unusually serious .

'OK . I'll do anything I can,' said Haruka firmly .

'I want you to look into Mao-sensei . '

'Eh?' said Haruka in her surprise . Both the instructions and who they referred to were unexpected .

– So Yakumo does doubt Mao .

'When you say look into, what should I do?'

'It's simple . Just listen to what people at the hospital have to say about Mao-sensei . '

It wasn't as simple as Yakumo made it sound .

'I wonder if I'll be able to . '

'Pretend you're asking about Uncle's condition and talk to them that way . '

'But to whom? I don't know anybody...'

'Aren't there two people there?'

Yakumo pointed at Sakakibara and Furukawa inside the ICU .

She had seen them before, but –

'But what should I ask about?'

'You don't have to try to force anything out of them . Just go with the flow of the conversation and ask what sort of person Mao-sensei is . '

'I'm not confident I can do it . '

'You'll be fine . '

Yakumo patted Haruka's shoulder, turned around and started walking .

'Hey . Where are you going, Yakumo-kun?'

Haruka called out to Yakumo's back .

'Another investigation with Gotou-san . There isn't much time . '

When Yakumo turned around, his eyes looked a bit more reliable than usual .

'You'll come back, right?' asked Haruka, unable to hold back her quickly growing anxiety .

'I will . '

Yakumo gave that short reply and started walking again .

Right now, all Haruka could do was believe in Yakumo's words and see him off .

– Be sure to come back .

(Continued in the next volume)

NOTES:

[1] Different prefectures have different cards with different pictures on them, but in Nagano .

VOLUME 6 – TO THE LIMITS OF DESPAIR (2)file 02: fluctuation
(yang)

23

Ishii parked the car in the parking lot behind the hospital .

Just as he put the car into park, he let out a sigh .

– Yakumo would return soon .

When he thought about that, he felt like they had taken a big step towards the solution, even though nothing had started yet .

Gotou, in the passenger seat, probably felt the same way .

Though he was blowing out cigarette smoke in a displeased manner, he might have been the most relieved, since he had been so personally worried .

Just as Ishii was about to get off the car to look around, Gotou's mobile rang .

‘What?’

Gotou answered the phone in his usual manner .

‘Eh? What? I can’t hear you... Where are you?’ said Gotou, sticking his neck out the window to look around .

He was probably talking to Yakumo . Ishii also looked for Yakumo, as Gotou was doing .

‘I’m over here . ’

Ishii heard that directly . Then, the backseat door opened and Yakumo came in .

Ishii leapt up in surprise .

Gotou dropped his cigarette onto his lap in surprise and started flailing about the small car, yelling, ‘Hot, hot!’

When Yakumo saw that, he laughed aloud .

To be honest, Ishii had thought Yakumo would be more depressed . To perform a prank like this – Ishii felt a bit let down .

On top of that, the red left eye he always hid with a black contact lens was out in the open . Since even Ishii was used to it now, he wouldn’t shriek, but it felt like it had more pressure than usual .

‘You bastard! Did you call on purpose to do that!?’

'That doesn't matter, does it?'

Yakumo ignored Gotou's shout and ran a hand through his messy hair .

'It does! You just do whatever you want without consulting anybody!' snapped Gotou, even though it would have been better for him to step down .

'Please don't be so noisy . I hope you don't behave so disgracefully in front of Nao . '

'What the hell do you mean by disgraceful?'

'I'm talking about your awful attitude . Don't you understand?'

'Y-you bastard...'

Gotou bit his lip painfully .

There was no way for him to challenge Yakumo in an argument . Even Ishii understood that .

'Ishii-san, leaving aside this hibernating bear, let's go . '

Yakumo didn't seem to pay Gotou's anger any attention as he said that with a yawn .

'Er, even if you tell me to go, where are we heading?' asked Ishii as he turned around .

'First, please go to the detention house where that woman is being held . '

For a moment, Ishii felt like Yakumo's expression was wiped from his face .

'Oi, Yakumo . You can't really be planning on meeting that woman, right?' said Gotou, surprised . He turned towards the backseat .

Ishii had the same opinion . He felt like it would be extremely dangerous for Yakumo to meet Miyuki at this stage .

'Of course . '

Yakumo was nonchalant in the face of their anxiety .

'Look who's talking now!'

'There isn't anything strange about it . If I don't meet with her, nothing will start, correct?'

'But...'

'She wants to meet as well, doesn't she?'

It was almost like Yakumo was talking about meeting up with an old friend .

Gotou seemed to have nothing to retort after hearing that much, so he gave an order to Ishii: 'Step on it . '

'Is it really OK?'

Ishii checked once more with Yakumo before starting the car .

'Gotou-san, could you tell me all the information you know regarding the case?' said Yakumo after the car went onto the main thoroughfare .

'How much do you know?' said Gotou, returning the question .

Ishii wanted to know as well . They hadn't been in contact with Yakumo since Isshin was stabbed .

Since it was Yakumo, he wouldn't have been doing nothing during that time .

Perhaps he had much more information than they did .

'Nothing,' said Yakumo with a yawn .

'Really?'

– There's no way .

Ishii unconsciously returned that question .

'Yes . All I know is that Nanase Miyuki declared she would kill Uncle from the detention house and that Uncle was stabbed . '

'Doesn't that mean you don't know anything?'

Gotou's voice was ragged .

'Didn't I just say that?'

Yakumo didn't sound guilty at all .

'You should've prepared a bit . '

'Was it written in a textbook somewhere?' replied Yakumo, exasperated .

It was their usual exchange .

'Honestly... Ishii, explain . '

With a sour look on his face, Gotou said that in a sulk . He crossed his arms and closed his eyes .

It appeared that he really had no intention of explaining .

'I'm sorry, Ishii-san, but could you explain instead of the bear?' asked Yakumo seriously .

'Ah, yes . '

Though Ishii replied, so much had happened that he wasn't sure where to start the explanation .

'Ishii-san, there's no need to dramatise the story like a certain bear would . Just explain in chronological order . '

Gotou twitched at Yakumo's words, but since he was pretending to be asleep, he stayed silent, unable to wake up .

Just as Yakumo said, there was no point thinking so much about it .

Ishii decided to explain it in order .

'The day after the incident, we received a report that the fingerprints on the knife were found to be a match with Miyuki's . '

'I see . '

Though that should have been a forceful fact, Yakumo's reaction was unexpectedly weak .

It made Ishii think that he might have already predicted that .

'There was another thing that caught our interest...'

'Something that caught your interest?'

'Yes . Actually, when we first went to talk with Nanase Miyuki, there was a guard there . '

'A guard...'

'That guard stayed silent even when Nanase Miyuki was talking about murder . '

'That is strange . '

Yakumo's eyes suddenly became energetic .

As expected, as a university student who had been involved in so many cases, he was sensitive to such oddities .

'Then we looked into that guard's background . '

'Did something come of it?'

Yakumo crossed his arms and looked straight forward .

'Yes . His name is Yamamura Mikio . He lived right by Nanase Miyuki's home . '

'That man named Yamamura might be related to the case somehow – you think that then, Ishii-san . '

While nodding, Ishii looked at Gotou in the passenger seat .

At some point, he had really fallen asleep .

'Yes . There is another thing . On the night of the incident, Nanase Miyuki was carried to the infirmary . '

'Your theory is that she had Yamamura's help and escaped the detention house that way...' continued Yakumo .

Having Yakumo read so far ahead made explaining considerably easier .

'Yes . Then, Detective Gotou and I went to talk to Nanase Miyuki and the medical officer at the infirmary to gather evidence, but we were unable to attain our goal . '

'I see,' said Yakumo with a nod .

Perhaps because Ishii had said too much at once, but his throat felt dry, so he took a gulp from his bottle of mineral water before continuing .

'At first, we were investigating how she escaped from the detention house, but a different possibility came into our perspective . '

'A different possibility . '

Yakumo's brows were slightly furrowed .

'Yes . She may have committed the crime by using some sort of trap that she set ahead of time – that possibility . '

'Trap...'

At this stage, Yakumo's response was rather disappointing .

'Actually, a wire with blood on it was found at the temple . '

After Yakumo heard Ishii's explanation, he sighed and pinched his brow .

He appeared to be thinking .

– What on earth is he thinking about?

'Er... Yakumo-shi, which method do you think she used?'

Ishii knew that the answer wouldn't come so easily, but he still tried asking .

He thought that Yakumo might ignore him, but unexpectedly, Yakumo looked up and hmm-ed before starting to speak .

'If she escaped the detention house, I don't know what method she used . '

'That's right . '

'Furthermore, it is strange that no blood was found on her clothes, and why didn't she land the finishing blow – those questions remain . '

– I see .

Ishii was filled with admiration . Yakumo's logical words were persuasive . The important questions of lack of blood and not landing the finishing blow remained .

Which meant –

'So she really did use a trap?'

'If she used a trap, the questions I mentioned earlier would be solved, but another important one is left instead . '

'What trap did she use – is that what you mean?'

'Yes . If she made the knife fly like an arrow, it would require much calculation to ensure it hit the person accurately . '

'Yes . '

Ishii had used the cabinet's glass door as a simulation multiple times, so he felt that difficulty dearly .

'As she was trying to hit a moving person, she would need to predict those movements to prepare the trap . '

That was another problem .

Even if there was a trap in the door, some people might open the door from the front, while some people might open it from the side .

If she couldn't control the target's actions to a certain extent, it would be impossible .

But –

'Though it is difficult, I don't think it's impossible,' said Ishii, giving his own opinion .

Right now, he was leaning slightly towards the trap theory in his head .

'That isn't the only problem . '

'Meaning?'

'If she set the trap before the event, that would mean it was before she was arrested . Don't you think it's unnatural that the trap didn't set off by accident in that time?'

All Ishii could do when he heard Yakumo's words was nod .

It wasn't as if the day before yesterday was the first time Isshin had entered the temple .

Since he meditated every day, he went in and out every day . It would be difficult to think that the trap had coincidentally set off the day Miyuki announced her plans for murder .

Ishii felt a bit like his flame of hope had been cut off .

It felt like both methods had been deemed impossible in the end .

Though he had been leaning towards one method earlier, now they were balanced again .

– What on earth is correct?

'Ishii-san . Forward – '

Ack! Ishii hurriedly stepped on the brakes .

If Yakumo hadn't spoken up, they would have plunged into the traffic jam .

24

Haruka sat on the bench in front of the ICU as she mulled over her thoughts .

It was a question she had not thought about seriously before .

– What happens when you die?

In her daily life, living like this seemed natural, so she didn't think about it .

However, death came to everyone .

– The spirits of the dead are clusters of people's emotions .

Yakumo had said that before . However, those emotions wouldn't last forever either . They would come to an end somewhere .

She had seen many wandering spirits up until now with Yakumo .

Those emotions were regrets left behind in this world –

But if those regrets were severed, that spirit would disappear . It had been that way for Haruka's older sister .

Where did those spirits go after they disappeared?

Probably the world after death – but was there such a thing in the first place?

She suddenly felt a chill down her spine .

It felt like a warning against thinking in a domain she shouldn't, but also an absolute fear brought about by uneasiness towards the unknown .

The only thing she knew was that thinking about it wouldn't bring about an answer .

Perhaps Yakumo, who could see the spirits of the dead, knew the answer .

– Ah, this is no good .

Haruka stood up to try to clear her mind . Then, the ICU door opened . The doctor Sakakibara came out from inside .

When Sakakibara saw Haruka, he just nodded and tried to leave .

'E-excuse me...'

Haruka recalled her original goal and hurriedly called out to stop Sakakibara .

'What is it?'

Though Sakakibara stopped, it was obvious that he thought it a bother .

Faltering at this wouldn't get Haruka the information she needed though, so she decided to continue talking regardless .

'How is Isshin-san's condition?'

'Didn't you hear from Doctor Mao?' said Sakakibara, narrowing his eyes .

He was busy, so he didn't want to waste time talking . It was like he was saying that .

'I heard that there was a problem with his brain, but not in detail...' said Haruka vaguely, looking for Sakakibara's reaction .

'What a nuisance . '

Sakakibara took off his mask and put it in his pocket .

'What do you mean?'

'To put it nicely, Doctor Mao has a kind heart, so she ends up choosing the things she should say . '

Haruka felt like she understood what Sakakibara was saying .

'Er, I heard that Isshin-san and Doctor Mao were friends, but...'

'Seems that way . '

'What sort of relationship did they have?'

'I don't... I'm not the sort of person who talks about the past, so...' said Sakakibara with a shrug .

Haruka couldn't decide whether he really didn't know or just didn't want to say .

'I see...'

'Well, I'll take my leave then . '

Sakakibara tried to walk away .

'Will Isshin-san's organs been transplanted?' said Haruka, trying to continue the conversation .

'If his relatives consent to it . '

'That's...'

Hearing it again from the doctor really was a shock .

No matter how desperate the situation, she still wanted Isshin to live .

'Are you against organ transplants?' asked Sakakibara, perhaps sensing Haruka's inner turmoil .

She couldn't answer immediately . If she was asked whether they were necessary, she would probably say they were .

But if they had to be taken out of Isshin's body, she couldn't help but object .

Families probably had that dilemma .

'I...'

'Without organ transplants, there are children who will die,' said Sakakibara while raising an eyebrow, as if reprimanding her .

Haruka didn't deny it, but –

'Isshin-san is still breathing . '

'He isn't . We are making him breathe using a machine . If we cut the switch, he would die immediately . '

'How can you say that so calmly?'

Even though Haruka thought she shouldn't, she ended up angry .

It wasn't like Sakakibara was at fault . He was just saying something natural as a doctor . However, even if her head understood it, her heart wouldn't accept it .

'Do you think we're calm?'

Sakakibara looked depressed .

Haruka couldn't say anything more under that gaze .

As a doctor, Sakakibara had probably seen many people live and die . He had to know all too well how valuable life was .

Accordingly, he knew how important transplants were .

Haruka felt very small in her shame .

'I understand how you feel, but please face reality . '

Sakakibara said just that and walked away .

– Face reality .

Would they be able to do that?

There was no way for Haruka to know then .

25

– Now, what's going to happen next?

Gotou sat next to Yakumo on the chairs in the detention house's visiting room .

He didn't bring Ishii, since he was investigating something else . Gotou had decided that since Ishii would probably be too scared to be useful .

Gotou crossed his arms and looked sideways at Yakumo .

Yakumo's face was stiff and blank, like a Noh mask .

– Is he nervous? That's unusual . Or is he angry that Isshin was stabbed?

Gotou couldn't read Yakumo's true feelings .

Finally, the door on the opposite side of the glass opened and Miyuki came in, led by Yamamura .

With a straight back, she slowly walked towards them . She glanced at them to confirm that Yakumo was there and then smiled .

It was an uncanny smile – like that of a vampire sucking out blood .

The moment Gotou saw it, a chill ran down his spine .

When he looked at that triumphant face, he doubted – have we fallen into a trap?

– No, there's no way .

Gotou rejected the thoughts in his head .

Yakumo wouldn't be played around with so easily . Even if this was a trap, he'd flip it around and aim for a chance to strike back .

– Right, Yakumo?

Gotou looked at Yakumo again, but his face was still blank .

'Oh my, it's been a while, Yakumo-kun,' said Miyuki, sitting down on the chair for interviews .

Even though she had checked when the door opened, she was talking like she had just realised now .

Yakumo said nothing, just looking – not even glaring – at Miyuki's face .

– Just like an empty shall .

'What's wrong? Is it OK not to hide your left eye?' said Miyuki provocatively as she looked at Yakumo's red eye .

However, Yakumo didn't respond .

'That isn't it . He broke it earlier and doesn't have a spare . '

– Why do I have to listen to her talk?

In his irritation, Gotou responded for Yakumo .

'Oh, is that so? Well, I don't care about that . What is it you're here for today?'

Miyuki slowly crossed her legs .

The action of a prideful woman evaluating men .

– Now, Yakumo . What are you planning on getting out of this woman?

Gotou waited for Yakumo to speak .

However, nothing came out of Yakumo's mouth no matter how long he waited .

– Oi, oi . What's wrong?

Yakumo was the one who said he'd meet with Nanase Miyuki . Gotou had thought Yakumo had some sort of plan, but what was he doing?

Gotou elbowed Yakumo .

However, Yakumo's body just shook a bit . He said nothing .

'Was the thing with Isshin such a shock?' said Miyuki, like she was asking a child . She stifled her giggles .

Yakumo still didn't say anything .

He just looked at Miyuki dumbly .

– Damn it! What are you doing?

'Shut up, you vixen! Your ulterior motive is obvious!'

Gotou stood up, unable to stop himself .

'Oh my, you're so excited . What's wrong?'

Miyuki was unruffled .

'Don't think you can get away! Did you escape the detention house? Or did you use a trap? Eh? How the hell did you stab Isshin? Tell us!'

Gotou said that all at once .

However, he didn't think doing that would get anything out of Miyuki .

As expected, Miyuki smiled, like she enjoyed this .

'Who knows? I wonder what method I used . Will you be able to solve the mystery?'

Miyuki licked her full lips provocatively .

'We will . Right, Yakumo?'

Gotou asked for Yakumo's agreement, but Yakumo remained silent .

Miyuki laughed aloud when she saw that .

Her voice kept growing louder, shaking Gotou's earlobes .

'Oh my, I can't do this . It seems like Yakumo-kun's been broken . It must have been a shock that Isshin-san was stabbed . It was sad, right? It was painful, right?'

Miyuki raised her eyebrows and put her nose to the glass .

'Shut up!'

'But that was all your fault too . You know that, right?'

When Yakumo heard Miyuki's last words, he slumped, like the energy had left him .

– What the hell?

Gotou had thought Yakumo was doing OK until earlier, but it was like his soul had left him completely .

'Shut up! This guy isn't broken! He wouldn't lose to the likes of you!'

Gotou knew he was just putting up a strong front as he hit the protective glass .

'You're bluffing . '

'What?'

'Truth is, Yakumo-kun is already no good . '

Miyuki laughed scornfully .

Gotou looked over to see Yakumo covering his face with both hands and bent over at the waist .

'Yakumo, you...'

'What a pitiful man . '

Miyuki's scornful gaze pierced Gotou .

'You monster...'

'Seems like he's got nothing to say, so I'll excuse myself then,' said Miyuki happily . She stood up and turned her back to them .

'It's a bit unfortunate – I thought I'd be able to have some more fun . '

Miyuki left those words and then exited the room, waving at them as she did so .

When the door closed, Gotou's anger filled his right fist and he punched the protective glass .

A sharp pain ran through his bone, making Gotou cower while holding his right hand .

There wasn't even a crack in the protective glass .

'It's obvious that hitting something like that would hurt . What a blockhead, as usual . '

Yakumo, who had been silent since earlier, sat up to make fun of Gotou .

'W-w-w-what did you say?'

Gotou was so surprised by Yakumo's about face in behaviour that he shouted .

'I called you a blockhead because you're a blockhead . '

Yakumo stood up and stretched .

– What the hell is this bastard thinking?

'Oi, Yakumo! What are you doing? I brought you here 'cause you said you had something you wanted to ask that woman!'

Gotou spoke up since he didn't understand, but Yakumo just rubbed his eyes sleepily .

'Who said that?'

'Hah?'

'I just said I wanted to meet her . '

'Well... that's true, but...'

'I have no questions to ask her . If you ask that woman anything, she would just lead you somewhere unexpected . You've experienced that yourself, haven't you?'

It was certainly as Yakumo said, but Gotou was still unsatisfied .

'Then what'd you come here for?'

'You'll understand soon enough . That woman's confidence will be the death of her . '

As Yakumo said that, a fearless smile graced his lips .

26

Ishii curled up in his seat in one of the conference rooms at the detention house .

– Is there any evidence that Miyuki had contact with the outside?

In order to pursue that evidence, Ishii was going to meet with the guard in charge of general affairs .

The guard who had responded was called Kobayashi . He was thin and had kept his gaze on his feet the whole time – a shady man .

'Did she ever have contact with the outside in some form?'

In answer to Ishii's question, Kobayashi had said faintly, 'Please wait here .
' Then, he had left the room .

It had been more than thirty minutes since .

Ishii had thought about going to search for Kobayashi, but this was a detention house .

If he moved unwisely, it would gather unnecessary suspicion, and since he didn't have a key, he couldn't even go into the other ways .

'Haah . '

Just as Ishii sighed, the door opened and Kobayashi came in with an envelope under his arm .

Even though he had been gone for over thirty minutes, he didn't even say 'Sorry for the wait' – he just sat on the opposite sofa .

This lack of etiquette would garner animosity for the citizens . Ishii thought that, but he didn't say it aloud .

He was more interested in the envelope Kobayashi had brought .

'Did you find something?' asked Ishii .

Kobayashi silently took a sheet of paper from the envelope and placed it on the table .

The sheet of A4 paper had various information listed on it for visits, such as dates, names, occupations and addresses .

It was probably a list of the people who had visited her .

On the dates for yesterday and the day before, Gotou's and Ishii's names were both listed . Most of the others were from a man named Shimazu, with lawyer written in the occupation column .

For a vicious criminal like MIyuki, nobody would take up her case .

Since it was in the news, it would probably help sell their name, but the risk was higher because of it . A double-edged sword .

Shimazu was probably a court-appointed attorney .

– Other people who came to visit...

Ishii checked the names, following the list with his finger .

He gasped when he spotted a name he knew .

– I can't believe it!

He checked it once more, but he hadn't been wrong .

Name: Saitou Isshin . Occupation; Priest . Relationship: Acquaintance .

The address was his as well . The date was right after Miyuki had been sent here .

– What was Isshin's goal in meeting with Miyuki?

Ishii didn't know Isshin's intentions . If it were him, he wouldn't have wanted to meet Miyuki ever again .

'Could I take this?'

'Please go ahead,' Kobayashi replied bluntly .

'Er, is there any evidence that she contacted anybody else from the outside?' asked Ishii as he folded the list and put it in his pocket .

Still silent, Kobayashi took another sheet of paper out of the envelope and placed it on the table .

It appeared to be a copy rather than an original . There were handwritten words on the letter .

They were delicate and beautiful words .

The sender was Nanase Miyuki .

Did Miyuki really write this – it was so unlike the image Ishii had of her .

There was just one line on the document .

<The goal of all life is death . >

Ishii recalled seeing that phrase before .

They were the words of the famous Freud, who founded psychoanalysis .

– Why this document?

Though sending letters from the detention house was allowed, the guards went over the contents .

It was because there were cases of prisoners using letters to contact people on the outside to request the destruction of evidence .

If the case was not settled yet and the evidence was destroyed, it would become a grave problem .

Miyuki probably only wrote the one line because she knew it was going to be inspected .

Even if it was inspected, others wouldn't understand its meaning .

However, there was no doubt that the document had some sort of meaning .

Perhaps it was something like an anagram, where switching the order of the letters would bring about another meaning .

'Death is life all of goal the . '

Ishii tried reading it backwards, but it became even more cryptic .

Feeling a cold gaze, Ishii came to his senses and looked up .

Kobayashi was looking at Ishii strangely .

'Do you know who the recipient of this letter was?' said Ishii, after clearing his throat to cover up his weird action earlier .

In response to that, Kobayashi just said, 'Back . '

Ishii didn't understand, but he turned around . However, there was nothing there . What was going on?

He looked towards Kobayashi again .

'Back of the paper,' said Kobayashi, sounding irritated .

– Ah, I see . The back of the paper .

Ishii turned the paper around .

Written on it was the name of a woman .

27

Haruka was still sitting on the bench in front of the ICU .

The conversation she had had with Sakakibara earlier was whirling around her head .

– Please face reality .

Sakakibara had said that, but Haruka just couldn't do it easily .

After a while, Furukawa came out of the ICU .

'Excuse me...'

Haruka shook off her mood and spoke up .

Furukawa seemed to recognise Haruka right away and stopped in her tracks .

'How is Isshin-san's condition?'

'I can't say...' said Furukawa vaguely, looking away .

From that, Haruka imagined that his condition wasn't very good .

'I see...'

Yakumo had asked her to get information, but she couldn't do that when all she was doing was getting depressed .

All that came out of her mouth was a sigh .

'So that rumour really was true...' said Furukawa with a shiver as she hugged her shoulders .

'Rumour?'

'You know, the one about the ghost in the hospital . '

'Ah,' said Haruka, though it had no meaning .

So many things had happened that she'd forgotten, but the reason for her first visit to this hospital was an investigation of spiritual phenomena .

A girl's ghost was walking around the hospital, asking, 'When are you going to die?' The people who heard it would die soon after .

Haruka had seen a ghost of a girl like that, but the truth wasn't clear .

At the same time she remembered that, a question came to her .

'Isshin-san saw that ghost too – is that what you're saying?'

'I don't know, but he must have . '

Furukawa probably liked this kind of story .

She appeared to be excited in a way that was inappropriate for the situation .

She had decided on something that wasn't certain and was talking about it . Haruka realised that this was how rumours spread .

'I'm sorry . Even though you were asked to investigate...'

'It's fine . A lot of things happened . '

Furukawa nodded with a strange expression on her face .

'Er, Furukawa-san, you're in charge of emergency, right?'

'Yes . '

'Why did you consult Doctor Mao about a ghost sighting?'

That suddenly seemed odd to Haruka .

The first time they met, she hadn't been concerned since she hadn't known her position, but now that she thought about it, it was unnatural .

'I consulted Doctor Sakakibara about it first, but... He seems to be in great difficulties with his daughter . '

'Did something happen?'

'He had a divorce three years ago, and a number of things have happened since...'

Furukawa trailed off that .

It felt like she didn't want to talk any more .

'Huh...'

Though Haruka was curious, she gave a vague reply since it felt like she couldn't poke her nose in too deeply .

'I was under Doctor Mao for a while, so I consulted her . '

'I see . '

'Though Doctor Mao nags, she's considerate . '

'Is that so?'

They were words from the heart .

Though Haruka had only met Mao a number of times, she felt like she understood too .

'Well, it seems like it's tough for her since she has bad luck with men . '

'Bad luck with men?'

– What could she mean?

Saying bad luck with men could have a number of meanings .

'Yup . She's too nice so she gets tricked . '

'With money, for example?'

'Right, right . A few years ago, she got involved with an unusual man . '

'Unusual man?'

Though Haruka felt like she couldn't ask questions recklessly about a topic like this, she urged Furukawa to continue to get information .

'Her lover back then said he wanted to do something so she kept lending him money . Then he ran away with it . '

Haruka felt depressed just from listening to it, but Furukawa was talking like she enjoyed it .

It appeared she was the type who took pleasure in other people's misfortune .

'Furukawa-san . '

Somebody interrupted the conversation .

Haruka looked to see another nurse calling Furukawa from the other side of the corridor .

'Sorry, I have to go,' said Furukawa quickly . Then, she ran off .

With depressed feelings, Haruka watched her go .

28

Gotou sat on the car hood and looked up at the sky as he blew out a puff of smoke .

The sun was low in the sky, dyeing the sky a reddish purple . Together with the lines of clouds, it was a gradation of colour .

He had tried to smoke inside the car, but he was forced out: 'This car is non-smoking . '

Now that he thought about it, that was strange .

A university student had no right to tell a policeman what to do in a police car .

Gotou looked inside with the intent of complaining .

Yakumo was sitting in the backseat .

He lay across the seat, exhausted . At first glance, he looked out of it, but his eyes were the picture of seriousness .

Gotou was irritated, but he'd hold out until the end of the case .

It pained him to acknowledge it, but without Yakumo, they couldn't reveal Miyuki's crime .

Gotou looked up at the detention house building again .

It had an oppressive presence, towering over its surroundings . Like a fort from a sci-fi movie .

If Miyuki had escaped the detention house, there would probably be a huge fuss .

– Even if the case is solved, it probably won't be swept aside just like that .

While Gotou was thinking, he saw somebody come out of the detention house .

With that narrow frame, it was probably Ishii .

He was walking so casually even though he'd made them wait – the guy had no sense of urgency, as usual .

'Ishii, run!' shouted Gotou .

Ishii started running reflexively .

– He fell .

'Don't know how you're a detective with that sluggishness of yours,' grumbled Gotou as he put his cigarette out in his portable ashtray .

'I-I-I apologise for that . '

Ishii reached the car, gasping for breath .

'Ishii-san, how was it?'

Yakumo had gotten off the car at some point and called out to Ishii with a yawn .

'Ah, yes . There are two important points . '

Ishii took two sheets of paper from the envelope he was holding and gave them to Yakumo .

When Yakumo took it, his brows furrowed as he looked at the papers with a serious gaze .

'The first is the name of Nanase Miyuki's visitors,' said Ishii, continuing his explanation .

Gotou looked at the papers Yakumo was holding too .

Most of the visits were from one person, probably a lawyer, but he found just one name he recognised .

'Oi, Yakumo!'

'Please don't speak loudly into my ear . I don't need you to tell me . '

Yakumo stuck his fingers into his ears as he complained .

However, that didn't restrain Gotou's agitation .

'Why did Isshin meet Miyuki?'

'It's simple, isn't it?'

'Eh?'

'Uncle is that sort of person,' said Yakumo carelessly .

Isshin's face came up in Gotou's head, and he strangely felt like he understood .

Isshin had probably met with Miyuki to preach about the importance of life or something like that .

However, Miyuki wasn't the sort of person who'd listen to that honestly .

'What is this other sheet?' pressed Yakumo while brushing aside his fringe .

'That's a letter Nanase Miyuki wrote, but...'

Ishii trailed off, like he was some kid who'd been scolded .

'The goal of all life is death – a quotation from Freud . '

Yakumo raised his gaze .

'Freud? Who's that?'

'An Austrian neurologist who studied psychoanalysis . He is the founder of current psychiatry . '

Yakumo was the one who answered .

'So what do the words of that esteemed doctor mean?'

Gotou lit a new cigarette .

Since Miyuki had gone out of her way to write it, it had to have some sort of special meaning .

'Just as it says . People live heading towards death . No living creature can escape it . '

'Isn't that exactly what it says?'

'Didn't I say that?' said Yakumo, sounding annoyed .

'Excuse me...'

Ishii raised his hand to ask for permission to speak .

'What?'

'I was wondering if this was some sort of code...'

Though Ishii said that without confidence, Gotou understood .

That was very possible .

'Yakumo, what do you think?'

'I can't deny the possibility that it is a code, but at the current stage, I cannot say anything . '

Yakumo shook his head with a brooding expression .

'Do you know who this letter was sent to?' Gotou asked Ishii .

This was a letter . Even without deciphering the contents, they could just capture the recipient and make them cough it up .

'It's written on the back,' replied Ishii, pointing at the piece of paper .

Yakumo flipped the paper around . An address and name were written there .

'OK, let's go catch this guy . '

'Please wait a moment,' Yakumo said, interrupting Gotou's high spirits .

He looked like he was looking at some difficult algebra .

'What?'

'Don't you think it's strange?'

'What is?'

'Nanase Miyuki must have known that we would find out about this letter, right?'

'That's true,' agreed Ishii as he adjusted the position of his glasses .

Gotou understood too after Yakumo said that .

Miyuki was a very calculating woman . She could probably guess the police's movements . But –

'That's why she used a code, right?'

Gotou was confident, but Yakumo's doubtful attitude did not change .

'I think she would have seen past that . '

'Past what?'

'Our solving the code . '

Yakumo handed the letter back to Ishii .

It wouldn't be strange for Miyuki to read that far ahead, but –

'Then what are you planning to do?'

Gotou approached Yakumo .

'It would be better to watch silently until we clearly understand the goal . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair .

It made sense . If they didn't know how she committed the crime, they might destroy evidence by moving already badly and end the thing there .

'Ah, also, the recipient may be somebody I know,' added Yakumo, as if he had just remembered .

'W-w-what!? Who? Who the hell is it?'

'Please don't make a fuss over every little thing . It's just that the family name is the same . I don't know the given name . . Anyway, Gotou-san, please look into that . '

Gotou replied, 'Got it,' but then he stopped .

'You're not coming with me?'

'I have other things to investigate . '

'What other things?'

'Anyway, please don't slack off because I'm not there,' said Yakumo disagreeably .

Gotou buried the anger boiling up within him in the bottom of his stomach .

'Ah, also, please drop me off at the hospital I was at earlier,' said Yakumo with a yawn .

– What the hell does this guy think the police are?

Ignoring Gotou's anger, Yakumo briskly got into the car .

'What are you waiting for? Please start the car already . '

Yakumo stuck his head out the window .

– I can't hold back any longer .

After the case was over, this time he'd really give Yakumo a good punch .

With that determination, Gotou got into the car .

29

– It's a bit cold .

Haruka sat on a bench in the hospital courtyard .

The sun was low in the sky; dark had started to swallow up the surroundings . The air was much cooler too .

Haruka looked up to see a lamppost beaming down on her . Bugs flew about the streetlights, as if drawn in by the brightness .

When she looked up, she could see the window of the fourth floor where Isshin was hospitalised .

Within that light, Isshin was in the narrow area between life and death .

Haruka didn't want to believe that Isshin was brain-dead . She felt like he might wake up even now .

Even if it was just a fleeting hope, all Haruka could do now was believe in it .

'You were here?'

Yakumo appeared out of the darkness .

He had returned as promised . It wasn't that Haruka had doubted him .
There were things that made you anxious even if you believed in them .
Humans were weak creatures .

'You're slow,' she said, testing out a slightly angry tone .

It wasn't like they'd set a time, so she had nothing to complain about, but every time she met Yakumo, she just wanted to say something .

'The only thing you could call slow is a turtle,' said Yakumo, exasperated, as he sat next to Haruka .

He was really good at coming up with things to put her down . In a way, it was amazing .

'Who's a turtle? You're the fickle cat,' said Haruka with a pout .

It looked like Yakumo really did not like being retorted to, because he raised his left eyebrow and glared intimidatingly .

'Who's a cat?'

'You are . You're moody and do whatever you want . The picture of a cat . '

'Better than being a turtle . '

Yakumo snorted .

'Yeah, yeah, I'm a turtle,' said Haruka, gritting her teeth .

However, Yakumo just yawned, seeming bored .

'So how was your investigation?'

Yakumo brought up the topic at hand .

'I tried asking, just like you said, but...'

Her words trailed off since there hadn't been much of a result .

'There's no need to think about it too much . Just tell me what you heard .
I'll decide whether anything's important . '

Yakumo rubbed his eyes sleepily .

'OK . '

After replying, Haruka started to talk .

She explained what she'd heard from Sakakibara and Furukawa with her own thoughts .

Since she gave her own opinions and thoughts on things like organ transplants, it took much longer than she thought it would .

Yakumo didn't interrupt regardless, just sitting there and listening carefully .

'I see . It seems you've got a considerable amount of information,' said Yakumo .

– Really?

Haruka cocked her head, unconfident .

She didn't think anything she said was connected to the case .

'What information?' she asked, though she knew there wouldn't be a response .

Yakumo's eyes were narrowed as he looked into the darkness .

– What is he looking at?

Haruka was always just looking from the side . Even if she tried to see the same things Yakumo did, it was impossible .

Though she was close to him, she felt like there was a wall she couldn't pass between them .

'You'll find out soon enough,' Yakumo finally murmured .

'You never tell me anything...'

She hadn't planned on saying anything, but it slipped off her tongue .

She felt a bit gloomy .

'I don't know everything clearly yet, so I can't say . '

Yakumo looked down with a wry smile .

To Haruka, it just sounded like an excuse .

She wanted to ask him more, but she knew from experience that he wouldn't say any more even if she did .

– I'm always left behind .

Haruka looked up to clear away her feelings of depression .

At the same time, the lamppost that had been lighting up the bench went out
—

Everything was blanketed in darkness .

She had been able to see Yakumo earlier, but he was swallowed by the darkness .

– Yakumo, where are you?

Haruka was looking around frantically when something touched her hand, which was on the bench .

'Eh?'

'It's OK . '

She heard Yakumo's voice .

Yakumo's fingers were touching Haruka's hand .

Even though only a bit of their skin was touching, warmth slowly came through .

Her eyes grew accustomed to the darkness, so she could see Yakumo's profile .

'It was time for the lights to turn off . It's about time . '

Yakumo slowly stood up .

Haruka stood up too, as if pulled by a magnet .

'What do you mean?' she asked Yakumo, who was looking up at the hospital building .

'There's one more thing I want to check . '

Without explaining further, Yakumo walked deliberately, one step at a time, towards the hospital .

Haruka hurriedly followed him so that his back wouldn't disappear into the darkness .

30

Ishii looked up at the apartment building from the driver's seat of the car .

His gaze was on the corner room on the fourth floor .

However, the lights in the room were off .

He had pressed the intercom button about an hour before, but there was no response . It seemed like nobody was home .

After dropping Yakumo off at the hospital, Ishii had gone to the apartment where the recipient of Miyuki's letter lived and begun his stakeout .

Right now, that person was the key .

– The goal of all life is death .

That sentence circled his head .

What code is in that sentence – no matter how much Ishii thought about it, he couldn't find the answer .

'She's not coming back . '

Ishii rested against the wheel and looked at Gotou in the passenger seat .

'She'll probably be back soon . '

Gotou blew out smoke, looking displeased .

There were shadows under his eyes, and the wrinkles at the corners of his eyes looked deeper than usual . It was like he had suddenly aged in these two days .

– He's probably tired .

After the incident, Gotou had ended up taking Nao in .

Even though following such a complex case was arduous already, his exhaustion was naturally doubled since he was taking care of a girl who couldn't hear .

'Please rest a bit,' said Ishii .

One person was enough for a stakeout . Ishii simply wanted Gotou to rest, even if it was just for a short time .

However, Gotou didn't accept it .

'Stop nagging! Do you think I'd be worn out from something like this?'

'No, that isn't what I...'

'The incident was my fault . '

Gotou irritably pressed his cigarette into the ashtray .

'Eh?'

'I couldn't protect Isshin . The least I could do to make up for it is catch the culprit . '

'If you put it that way, I am also at fault . '

Ishii took off his glasses and rubbed his eyes .

Gotou was not the only one responsible . Ishii had been at the scene too . He had even been the one closest to Isshin . Despite that, Ishii hadn't been able to protect Isshin –

'Don't be impertinent . '

Gotou hit Ishii's head .

'No, but...'

'Nothing would've changed if somebody like you were there or not... It was my fault . '

Gotou put a new cigarette in his mouth, biting the filter tightly .

– Why are you taking everything on yourself?

Ishii asked that in his heart .

He wanted to be like Gotou . He wanted to become a proper man as Gotou's partner . Ishii did his best for that goal .

However, no matter how hard he tried, Gotou took everything on by himself .

– Does he hate me?

Ishii even thought that way sometimes .

Ishii had just put his glasses back on when light flooded in from behind them . The headlights of a car .

He turned around and saw a car coming up towards them .

A navy blue SUV .

It passed Ishii's car and stopped in front of the apartment .

A woman got out of the passenger's seat . She looked like she was in her late twenties . She wore a denim skirt and was on the chubby side .

The moment Gotou saw her, he hurriedly got off the car .

'W-what's wrong?'

'Quiet . '

Ishii had hurriedly followed Gotou off, but Gotou cut him off .

Gotou hid behind a telephone pole and watched the woman . Ishii did the same, standing behind Gotou and looking at the road .

The woman waved goodbye to the man in the driver's seat and went towards the apartment entrance .

'That woman...' growled Gotou .

– Do you know her?

Ishii had that question in his head when he recalled something Yakumo said .

– She may be someone I know .

From this response, it appeared that the recipient of the letter really was someone Gotou and Yakumo knew .

The car turned off its hazards and left .

'Number . '

As instructed by Gotou, Ishii hurriedly wrote the licence plate number in his notebook .

The woman went through the apartment's glass entrance, took something from the post box and got into the elevator .

'That was some unexpected information . '

Gotou let out his breath as he left the shadow of the telephone pole .

Ishii followed him .

'What do you mean?'

'I've met that woman before . '

– So it really was like that .

Ishii's eyes went bright . If it was somebody they knew, the investigation would advance more quickly .

'Where did you meet her?'

'The hospital . '

Gotou lit his cigarette .

– Hospital .

After hearing that word, Ishii also remembered who the woman was .

31

Haruka followed Yakumo down the dim hospital corridor .

Even though there should have been many people inside the hospital, it was surprisingly quiet . It felt like they were going through an underground tunnel .

However, Haruka knew where Yakumo was headed .

If they continued forward, they would reach the ICU where Isshin was .

– There's one more thing I want to check .

Yakumo had said that earlier . What was he planning on checking when he went to Isshin?

'Hey, Yakumo-kun, what are you going to check?' asked Haruka towards Yakumo's back .

'You'll find out soon enough . '

Yakumo stopped firmly in front of the ICU .

His back looked somewhat nervous .

Haruka could see Isshin through the glass . Life support was keeping him alive .

Every time she saw Isshin like this, her chest felt tight and the hope that had welled up within her was cut .

'So you're checking how Isshin-san is?'

'That's right,' replied Yakumo, looking straight down the dark of the corridor .

Haruka took a step forward to stand next to Yakumo .

I might be able to see something else if I stand in the same place – is what she thought, but nothing came back to her eyes . Just the cellar-like corridor .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka looked at Yakumo's profile .

He looked like something that was created – there was no life there .

'Don't move from here,' Yakumo said briefly . Then, he slowly stepped forward .

Haruka thought about following him, but she was frozen there by the unusual air emitting from Yakumo .

– Yakumo's red left eye can see something .

Haruka was almost certain of it .

With his chest out and back straight, he took careful steps forward, as if he were walking on a tightrope .

After walking about five metres, Yakumo suddenly stopped .

'You're there, right?' said Yakumo, as if beginning a speech .

– Is somebody there?

Haruka focussed her gaze .

After a while, though it was faint, something appeared in the darkness .

It was the girl with the dark face .

This was the third time Haruka had seen her . She was probably the female ghost said to appear in the hospital –

'What are you looking for?'

Yakumo knelt in the corridor as he started to speak quietly .

The ghost of the girl just stood in front of Yakumo –

'I see... That's why you're wandering...'

Only Yakumo's voice echoed through the corridor .

Haruka couldn't tell what the girl was saying .

She felt the impulse to move closer to her to listen, but she couldn't – she felt like the ghost of the girl would disappear if she did .

'I understand your feelings, but I want you to wait a bit longer . '

Yakumo reached out, like he was asking for help .

The ghost of the girl just stood there without moving .

The tense atmosphere continued –

'Please . '

Yakumo lowered his head, pleading .

Then, the girl nodded slightly and finally disappeared into the darkness .

Haruka released the breath she had been holding, as if she had just raised her head out of water . She had been so focussed that she had forgotten to breathe .

Yakumo slowly stood up and turned around .

His eyes were narrowed and his brows were lowered – Yakumo's expression was sadder than she had ever seen it .

– What happened?

Haruka wanted to ask out, but she just couldn't in this situation .

Yakumo didn't do anything . He just stood there .

It felt like Yakumo was going farther and farther away . I don't like it .
Don't go –

'Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka called out to hold on to him .

In response, Yakumo's expression softened .

'It's just as I thought,' whispered Yakumo as he came back .

'What do you mean?'

'I've solved it...'

Yakumo put his left index finger to his brow .

His eyes looked different now – they were triumphant .

'Eh?'

'I've solved the mystery of the case . '

As Yakumo said that, his red left eye trembled slightly .

Volume 6 Chapter 3: VOLUME 6 – TO THE LIMITS OF DESPAIR (2)

Chapter 3

VOLUME 6 – TO THE LIMITS OF DESPAIR (2)

file 03: separation (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

Gotou rubbed his eyes as he got up .

He looked at the clock . It was just past seven in the morning .

– It's morning already?

It appeared that he had fallen asleep at some point .

Ishii was sleeping on the desk in front of him . He was probably tired .

Gotou decided to let him sleep a bit longer .

Gotou stretched out, making his bones crack loudly . A sharp pain ran through his back . It was probably because he had slept sitting down .

Gotou took one cigarette out of the case, bit the filter and had his first puff of the day .

He watched the trailing smoke .

– Wonder how they're doing now?

Suddenly concerned, Gotou took out his mobile and called home .

<Hello, Gotou speaking . >

After two rings, Atsuko picked up .

She sounded cheerful early in the morning .

‘Ah, it’s me,’ said Gotou, feeling awkward .

<sWhat’s wrong?>

‘I just wanted to know how you were doing . ’

<Oh, so even you worry about me sometimes . >

Atsuko’s voice sounded wry .

Gotou couldn’t say anything back . He had never called home doing work to see how she was doing before .

Men were proud, obstinate, and really good-for-noting creatures . That was why they made women angry .

When Gotou kept silent for a while, Atsuko laughed aloud .

‘W-what?’

<I understand . You’re worried about Nao-chan, right?>

‘That isn’t it . ’

Though Gotou denied it, he himself knew that he couldn’t hide his true feelings .

<You don’t have to worry . >

‘I see...’

<Nao-chan's a really good girl . She even helps out . >

'She is . '

– Isn't there anything else to say?

Gotou was irritated at himself for only being able to give curt replies .

<But... she really is forcing herself . >

Atsuko spoke in a quiet tone .

It made sense . No matter how brave Nao acted, she was still seven years old .

There was no way she would be all right with Isshin like that, since he was the one who raised her . However, she was still doing her best .

It was probably tough on Atsuko to watch .

Even though she wanted to do something for Nao, there was nothing she could do .

'Right . '

Gotou wanted to say something encouraging, but since he couldn't think of anything, he just agreed .

<Oh, but are you doing OK?>

Atsuko's casual words gave Gotou a start .

Nao had brought about some sort of change in the Gotou couple – he felt it directly .

He wouldn't be able to answer if asked what had changed, but he felt like he was closer to Atsuko than he had been a few days before .

'Well, we're managing...' replied Gotou, making a conscious effort to act unruffled .

<You don't have to worry about us, so go catch the criminal for Nao-chan's sake . '

Atsuko's voice had an encouraging tone to it .

'Right . '

Just as Atsuko said, what Gotou could do now for Nao was get to the bottom of the case as quickly as he could .

<But don't overdo yourself . >

Atsuko's murmur tickled Gotou's ear, but at the same time, it felt pleasant .

She had often said things like this after they had just got married .

'Got it . I'm hanging up then . '

Gotou suddenly felt embarrassed and hung up after declaring that .

He had just let out his breath and pressed his cigarette into the ashtray when he met Ishii's eyes .

Ishii was grinning, though Gotou had no idea what he thought was so funny .

'Ishii, how long have you been awake?'

Gotou glared at him .

'J-just earlier . '

'How long were you listening?'

'I just wanted to know how you were doing – about there . '

– Isn't that all of it?

Embarrassed, Gotou's anger peaked at once .

'You bastard – if you're awake, say so!'

Gotou leant over the desk, gripped Ishii by the collar and shook him .

'D-D-Detective Gotou, your m-m-mobile is ringing . '

With a shaking head, Ishii pointed at the desk .

Gotou thought that Ishii was trying to trick him, but he was wrong . His mobile was vibrating on the desk . Gotou clicked his tongue and then thrust Ishii forward before answering the phone .

'Who is it?'

<Like I said, please fix your phone manners . >

Yakumo spoke in his usual tone .

He chose words purposefully to make people angry .

'I don't want to hear that from a contrary brat like you!'

<You're not a child, so it would be better if you stopped yelling just because things aren't going your way . >

Yakumo's smirk came up in Gotou's head .

Even if he said more, he wouldn't win against Yakumo .

'So what is it?'

It was Yakumo . He wasn't the type to call to kill time . There was what happened yesterday too . He must have grasped a thread to solve the case .

Gotou expectantly awaited an answer .

<Please come to pick me up in three hours . >

'I've said this before, but I'm not a cab company!'

<Is that so? So you don't want to know the truth behind the case then, Gotou-san . >

'What?'

<That's too bad . I'll call the cab company . >

Yakumo hung up .

– He said that on purpose .

He really was a troublesome guy if you ticked him off .

Gotou called Yakumo's mobile .

<What is it? I'm busy – I have to call the cab company . >

Yakumo said that immediately after answering .

– What an obstinate guy .

'Where should I go?'

<What are you supposed to say if you've done something bad?>

Gotou tried to change the topic, but Yakumo said that .

– This bastard keeps making fun of me!

Anger boiled up within Gotou, but if he said anything, Yakumo would get angry again .

'S-s-sorry,' said Gotou in mortification, as if the words were being strangled out of him .

<So you can do it if you try, can't you? Please come to the hospital's front entrance . Ah, and could you also tell me Makoto-san's contact information?>

'Makoto – do you mean the reporter?'

<Is there anyone else?>

– He always says one thing too much .

Why's Yakumo need Makoto's contact information – Gotou didn't know, but since it was Yakumo, he was probably thinking of something .

Gotou took the business card he had received from Makoto in the past out of his desk drawer and told Yakumo her company and mobile phone numbers .

<Very well done . >

Yakumo said that mockingly and then hung up before Gotou could complain .

– He really just does whatever he wants .

As an outlet for his anger, Gotou hit Ishii's head .

2

Haruka sat on the bench in the hospital's waiting room .

She was waiting there because Yakumo had called her, but he still hadn't arrived even though it was thirty minutes past the time they'd set .

– He might not come .

Haruka looked at the courtyard scenery through the glass in her resignation .

The lawn was a vivid green .

The cherry blossom buds were bulging, like they would bloom at any moment .

It was so tranquil it made the events up until yesterday seem like a lie .

But the reality was different –

Haruka looked up and saw a girl standing there .

She had seen her before .

The girl had been standing there when Haruka was waiting for Isshin . If she remembered correctly, her name was Yoshiko –

'What's wrong?' asked Haruka .

Perhaps Yoshiko didn't hear, because she just stood there with her gaze on her feet .

– I don't know what to do .

'You could win the world championship for making stupid faces . '

Haruka looked up at the sudden voice .

Yakumo stood there, with messy hair and sleepy eyes .

– Who're you calling stupid?

What was that tone of his, when he was thirty minutes late? If this were a date, she would have gone home a long time ago .

'You're way past the time we set,' objected Haruka as she stood up, thrusting her wristwatch in front of Yakumo's eyes .

'Were you listening to me properly?'

'Eh?'

'I didn't say we'd meet up at ten – I said I'd leave house at ten . '

– What kind of reasoning was that?

In what world would somebody tell the person they were going to meet the time they were going to leave the house instead of the time they were going to meet? Haruka thought about complaining, but she decided against it .

There was no way she'd win in an argument against Yakumo .

'So who's this kid?'

Yakumo looked at Yoshiko .

Yoshiko took a step back, perhaps afraid of that red left eye .

'Probably Yoshiko-chan... right?'

Haruka called out to Yoshiko, who was looking down as she stood .

However, Yoshiko made no response .

'You know her?'

'When I was here with Isshin-san before, I saw her, so...'

Yakumo crouched in front of Yoshiko .

Yoshiko looked away, as if trying to run .

'Is the treatment tough?' asked Yakumo .

Yoshiko nodded .

'I see . Hang in there a bit longer . '

Yoshiko nodded again .

Yakumo looked like Isshin had a few days earlier .

'Yoshiko . '

Haruka heard somebody call for Yoshiko .

Sakakibara was walking towards them, searching for Yoshiko .

In response, Yoshiko looked up and mumbled something, but Haruka couldn't hear it .

Yoshiko turned on her heels and walked towards Sakakibara .

'Let's go then . '

Perhaps Yakumo had lost interest, because he started briskly walking away .

'Where to?'

Even though Yakumo had called Haruka to the hospital, she hadn't heard anything about their plans .

'I have something to discuss with Doctor Mao . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair and walked at a leisurely pace down the corridor .

– It seems he really does suspect Mao .

Haruka felt that as she followed Yakumo's back .

When Yakumo reached Mao's examination room, he opened the door without knocking and stepped inside .

Haruka followed after him timidly .

'Yakumo-kun, you're just on time . '

Mao smiled from her seat at the desk .

– Just on time?

That meant that Yakumo hadn't been late- h e really had planned on leaving his home at ten from the start .

Haruka really wanted to complain, but Mao was in front of her too .

Instead, Haruka poked Yakumo in the side .

Yakumo leapt like a cat, stuck out his chin and glared at her, as if to ask 'What the hell are you doing?', but Haruka ignored it and sat on a chair .

'Yakumo-kun, you sit down too,' Mao urged .

Yakumo looked dissatisfied, but he reluctantly sat on a chair .

'You have something to discuss with me, yes?' said Mao after Yakumo had settled in .

Mao had been looking back and forth for a while now, unable to relax .

'Yes . There is something I would like to confirm about my uncle . '

'Confirm?'

Mao cocked her head at Yakumo's words .

'Yes?'

'What is it?'

'It is about when my uncle was carried to this hospital . '

'What do you want to know?'

'You said that he stopped breathing for a while, but is that true?'

Though Yakumo's tone was disinterested, it still sounded intimidating .

'It's true . He had already stopped breathing,' replied Mao after clearing her throat once .

Though she was acting calm, she was becoming visibly paler .

'There isn't any doubt about it?'

'No, there isn't . '

Mao's lips were trembling slightly .

'I talked to the detective who had been in the ambulance with him .
According to him, my uncle was unconscious on the ambulance, but he was breathing . '

'... What do you want to say?'

Beads of sweat were on Mao's forehead .

'Doctor Mao, if both your testimony and that detective's testimony are correct... that would mean that Uncle was breathing in the ambulance but stopped breathing when being carried to the surgery room . '

Yakumo's eyes were clearly full of suspicion .

However, Haruka didn't think that the conversation was that strange .

'That would be the case,' replied Mao, licking her dry lips .

'I see . Assuming that was the case, please let me ask one more thing . '

'What?'

'Why can you declare that my uncle had stopped breathing?'

'What do you mean?'

'You aren't in charge of emergency . You're not the detective in charge . In short, you weren't present . Then why?'

'That's...'

Yakumo's sharp gaze was piercing, as if he had caught his prey . Mao hesitated .

Haruka's heart was pounding .

She finally understood what Yakumo was trying to get out of Mao .

'Doctor Mao, please answer honestly . Were you in the surgery room that day?'

Yakumo's eyes were even more forceful .

Mao bit her lower lip and looked up at Yakumo .

It was a bitter expression .

'On that day, I was...'

After saying that much, Mao paused .

No matter how she tried to hide it, it was obvious that she wasn't sure how to continue .

'I wasn't there . I was at home when I heard that Isshin-kun was carried in .',

Mao leant back on her chair, seeming exhausted, and looked up as she said that .

– She's lying .

Haruka felt that in her skin, but she didn't dare to say it .

Yakumo must have realised it too . Haruka was sure that he would question Mao and reveal that lie .

However, contrary to her expectations, Yakumo stood up while running a hand through his hair .

'I see . That was all I wanted to confirm . '

After saying that, Yakumo turned his back to Mao .

– Why aren't you questioning her more?

Haruka had that question as she stood up like Yakumo .

'Ah, that's right . '

Yakumo had reached out to open the door, but he suddenly stopped .

'Eh?'

Mao lifted her haggard face .

'I forgot to say something . About Uncle's organ donation...'

Mao held her breath .

'I absolutely refuse . Uncle's soul is still alive . '

After a long silence, Yakumo said that forcefully and left the room .

Haruka bowed to Mao and ran after Yakumo .

– Uncle's soul is still alive .

Yakumo's words went deep into Haruka's heart .

Yakumo really hadn't given up yet . Isshin would definitely come back from the dead . When Haruka thought that, tears welled up in her eyes .

3

Ishii drove into the hospital's front entrance and saw Yakumo waiting there .

Haruka was there too .

She was in skinny jeans and a white lace dress . It had an incredibly spring-like vibe .

– She really is cute .

So many things had happened that he hadn't had many chances to talk to Haruka, even though she had been nearby .

'Ishii-san, you're right on time . '

Yakumo got into the backseat just as Ishii parked .

'Ah, yes...'

'Before that, explain what's going on . '

Gotou turned around from the passenger seat and glared at Yakumo with the face of a demon .

However, Yakumo ignored Gotou and put his head out the window .

'I'm counting on you then,' said Yakumo .

'Eh, wait . '

Troubled, Haruka's brows furrowed .

– What's going on?

'Ishii-san, please start the car,' said Yakumo, closing the car window .

Haruka pressed up against the window and tried to say something .

'Is it OK?'

'Yes . '

'Understood . '

Ishii nodded at Haruka and started the car .

He saw Haruka's shocked figure in his rear-view mirror . When he looked at her sad expression, his chest felt tight .

'Excuse me... Did something happen to Haruka-chan?' asked Ishii after driving onto the main road .

'Nothing at all . '

Yakumo yawned, seeming bored .

'But...'

'She's much stronger than you think she is, Ishii-san . '

I know her better than you – though Yakumo might not have had that intention, that was what it sounded like, and Ishii was left with complicated feelings .

He wanted to say something, but in the end, he couldn't think of anything .

'So where're you planning to go today?' interrupted Gotou, changing the topic .

'Please head to the detention house,' Yakumo said, face blank .

'Hah?'

'I'm going to meet with Nanase Miyuki . '

'W-what!?' howled Gotou .

Though Ishii didn't let out his voice, he felt just as surprised .

'Please don't speak so loudly . '

Yakumo stuck his fingers in his ears .

He didn't seem nervous at all .

'How could I be quiet!? And you always...'

'I'm going to explain, so could you be quiet?' said Yakumo, interrupting Gotou . He ran a hand through his hair .

Gotou looked like he wanted to say something, but he collapsed back into the passenger seat, like he thought it would be pointless to retort .

Yakumo started his explanation after Gotou had calmed down .

'First, it is necessary to organise everything that we know so far . '

'Organise, is it...' said Ishii, hands on the wheel .

'To explain this case simply, Nanase Miyuki declared that she would kill somebody from inside the detention house, and my uncle was actually stabbed . '

'Yes . '

Just as Yakumo said, that was where the case started .

'The problem there is how on earth a crime was committed from inside the detention house, from which it is impossible to explain . '

'That is the biggest problem,' replied Ishii, looking at Yakumo's face through the rear-view mirror .

His eyes seemed filled with confidence .

– Have you already solved the mystery behind the case?

Yakumo's expression made Ishii think that .

'I know the method behind the crime,' said Yakumo, as if he had sensed Ishii's thoughts .

'Oi! That true?'

Contrary to Gotou, who was agitated, Yakumo seemed bored as he yawned .

– How can you be so calm?

Ishii didn't understand .

Even though Yakumo said he understood the method behind the crime, Ishii was sceptical .

He had felt personally when investigating that the case this time would not be solved by ordinary means .

There wouldn't be a breakthrough this easily .

'The method she used was actually very simple . '

Yakumo put his index finger on his brow .

As if that were a switch, Yakumo's gaze grew sharper .

'What method is it?' asked Ishii after a gulp .

'A trap?' interrupted Gotou .

'It wasn't a trap,' declared Yakumo .

'But something like a wire was found at the scene of the crime . '

It wasn't like Ishii himself had been confident about the trap theory, but he wanted to object when it was denied so readily .

'That is probably a fake . '

'Fake...'

'Yes . I discussed this before, but if a trap were used, there is a big problem .
,

'Ah!'

Ishii recalled what Yakumo had said earlier .

If a trap were used, it would have been set up before Miyuki was arrested .

Isshin used the temple daily to meditate . It would be difficult to time it so that the trap was triggered after Miyuki declared her killing intent .

But –

'Wouldn't it be possible if she hid the trap somewhere and made it trigger if a special action were taken?' said Ishii, changing his perspective .

'Ishii-san, do you know what the priest at a temple does every morning?'

– Something a priest does every morning?

Meditating, reading scriptures, preparing breakfast – but Ishii could tell that wasn't the reply Yakumo wanted .

– Then what on earth does Yakumo want as a reply?

The answer suddenly came to Ishii's head .

'Oh, cleaning . '

After Ishii said that excitedly, Yakumo nodded, seeming satisfied .

'What're you talking about?'

Gotou looked confused as he stuck his neck in .

'The priest of the temple cleans the temple daily . Very thoroughly at that . '

'It would be unlikely for a trap not to be set off or found when the temple was cleaned every morning . '

Ishii explained further .

'I see . '

Gotou clapped his hands together in understanding .

Just as Yakumo said, this would eliminate the trap theory . Then there was one possibility left .

'So Nanase Miyuki really did escape the detention house and stab Isshin-san . '

Ishii said that with certainty, but Yakumo's response was unexpected .

'That is also wrong . '

Yakumo quietly shook his head .

'Eh?'

Ishii was disappointed .

If it wasn't a trap, there shouldn't have been any method but escape from the detention house .

'Nanase Miyuki did not take even one step out of the detention house . '

'How can you be sure?' said Gotou .

'It would be better to hear it from the person herself rather than from me . '

Yakumo's smile was full of confidence .

It certainly would be better to confirm with the person herself, but Miyuki wasn't the sort of person who would answer questions honestly .

— What on earth is he planning to do?

With uneasy feelings, Ishii continued driving the car .

Haruka sat on the bench in the waiting room .

She sighed .

Yakumo had made a number of requests earlier .

Because of what happened to Isshin, she didn't object to helping, but it didn't feel great being asked to help without knowing anything – she felt like an accomplice to fraud .

It also made her sad that Yakumo wouldn't tell her anything .

<Saitou-san, Saitou Yakumo-san . >

Finally, there was a call from the reception .

Haruka stood up and headed towards the reception in Yakumo's stead .

'Excuse me... I'm here as Saitou Yakumo's representative...'

After Haruka said that, the woman at the reception handed her a brown envelope .

He'd probably told her in advance that somebody would come pick it up for him . Inside the envelope was a copy of Isshin's clinical records .

In the recent years, there was a movement to implement the browsing of clinical records .

It differed depending on the hospital, but if the person or the person's relatives requested it, they could browse their clinical records .

'Haruka-chan . '

Just as Haruka was walking away with the envelope, somebody called out to her .

She turned around and saw Hijikata Makoto standing there .

She wore a grey pant suit and had a large bag hanging from her shoulder .
Her long hair was tied behind her elegant face .

Haruka didn't often speak directly to Makoto, a newspaper reporter, but they had worked together on a number of spirit-related cases .

Makoto had helped out a lot during the last case too .

'Hello, Makoto-san . '

Haruka bowed .

'Hello . '

'Are you here to gather material today?'

'Didn't you hear anything from Yakumo-kun?'

Haruka was surprised by Makoto's unexpected words .

'Not at all...'

'Actually, Yakumo-kun asked me to come here and hand something to you, Haruka-chan...'

Makoto smiled wryly .

– He really doesn't tell me anything at all .

At this point, rather than anger, Haruka felt stunned .

'I see... I'm sorry for the trouble . '

Haruka bowed her head, but Makoto smiled pleasantly .

'It's fine . I know what sort of person Yakumo-kun is too . '

'He really isn't all here . '

Haruka pouted .

'Right, right . Let me hand it to you before I forget . '

Makoto held out a file .

'What is this?'

'You'll find out if you give it to Yakumo-kun . '

'Is that so?'

'Since it's personal information, be careful of how you use it . '

'Yes,' replied Haruka, taking the file .

– I wonder what he's looking into?

She might find out if she looked into the file, but she felt like she shouldn't just look at it so she put it into her bag along with the envelope she had received earlier .

'Well, shall we go?'

After saying that, Makoto started walking towards the exit .

The way she said that made it sound like they were going together, but Haruka didn't understand .

'Where are we going?'

'You've got something to bring to Hata-san's hospital, right?'

'Eh, ah, yes...'

Yakumo had told her to get Isshin's clinical records and bring them to Hata .

– Why does Makoto know that?

'Yakumo-kun told me to bring you to Hata-san's hospital, Haruka-chan,' said Makoto with a smile, like she had sensed Haruka's question .

'I-I see...'

Haruka felt perplexed . A lot of things seemed to be going on without her knowing it .

'Yakumo-kun's unexpectedly nice too . '

'I'm not sure about that...'

Though Haruka didn't understand, she followed Makoto out of the hospital .

They went to the guest parking lot and got into a red family car .

'It's quite a state of affairs,' said Makoto as she started the car .

It really was . .

'When I think that Isshin-san might disappear like this, I can't stand it...'

Haruka felt a piercing pain in her chest .

It forced her to think how much having Isshin there up until now had saved her .

'I know...'

'I feel like I have to do something, but I can't do anything...'

Haruka gripped her hands into fists in vexation .

She couldn't help Isshin, comfort Yakumo who was suffering, or make efforts to catch the culprit .

All she could do was watch .

It was frustrating –

'Haruka-chan . '

Makoto put her left hand on Haruka's shoulder .

'Yes . '

'Isn't there something only you can do?'

'Something... only I can do?'

'Yakumo-kun is acting that way, but I think he's actually suffering a lot . I think he wants somebody to save him . '

'Really?'

Haruka couldn't think of Yakumo needing anybody .

No matter how much he suffered, he decided it all himself and just told Haruka after the fact . The words 'painful' and 'sad' had never left Yakumo's lips .

He kept them to himself, as if those feelings were his only .

Yakumo was always alone .

'Really . '

'But Yakumo-kun won't tell me anything . '

'That's because you don't tell him anything either, Haruka-chan . '

Haruka's heart jolted when Makoto said that .

– That might be true .

Strangely, she understood .

Yakumo won't tell me anything – while she grumbled about that, she acted strong herself and restrained her feelings .

Even though she really wanted to leap into Yakumo's arms and sob, she held back those feelings .

'Well, I'm not good at being honest either, so I can't say anything about anybody else . '

Makoto stuck out her tongue and smiled mischievously .

Haruka smiled back with complicated feelings .

5

'We've seen through your plan!'

Gotou yelled through the protective glass at Miyuki, who had a faint smile on her face .

However, her expression didn't change, as if she hadn't heard anything at all . Instead, Ishii, beside Gotou, leapt up from his chair .

This was the fourth consecutive day that they had visited her in the detention house .

– I want to make this the last .

Those were Gotou's inner thoughts .

'Seeing you angry makes me very excited . '

Miyuki's eyes narrowed as she let a long breath out of her half-open lips .

– This woman . She's so confident she's trying to provoke us .

Gotou ground his teeth together, making a grating sound .

'Just cough up the code behind your letter already!'

Gotou hit the protective glass .

However, Miyuki still did not stop smiling .

– If this glass weren't here, I could smash her nose in and make her cough up .

'Code? What are you talking about?'

Miyuki shrugged .

'Don't play stupid . '

'I'm not . i don't understand what you're talking about,' said Miyuki with a sneer, eyes still narrowed .

This response . There must be something in the letter – so Gotou felt .

'The letter you sent to Furukawa . I won't let you say you don't know what I'm talking about . '

Gotou took the copy of the letter from his pocket and pressed it against the glass so she could see .

Miyuki's expression still did not change .

'Gotou-san, this won't be a visit if you do that – it'll be an interrogation,' said Ishii quietly .

'Shut up!'

Gotou hit Ishii's head with a fist, emptying all the negative feelings that had built up within him .

Ishii curled up with his head in his arms, as if he were about to collapse .

– Might have hit him too hard in my excitement .

'No matter when I see it, your comedy duo is always funny . '

Miyuki made a Yakumo-like sarcastic comment and laughed .

– What the hell do you mean, comedy duo? Making fun of me .

'Shut up! Tell us already!' Gotou said even more forcefully .

'It seems you are rather cornered . You're so pitiful I don't mind telling you . But I have a condition . '

Miyuki looked up at him with an inviting glance .

– She bit .

The response was just as they had planned . Yakumo had been right .

'Condition...' repeated Gotou, acting troubled .

'If you release me from here, I don't mind telling you,' said Miyuki with a triumphant smile .

'Will you really?' said Gotou, trying not to smile .

'Yes . '

'Got it... I'll negotiate...'

Gotou tried to restrain himself, but he couldn't . He lost control and started laughing aloud .

Miyuki's mouth went wide in surprise at Gotou's response .

Ishii, who had been curled up for a while now, started laughing too .

'W-what...'

Miyuki had thought she was in control, so she had felt superior and decided on a confident attitude .

However, Gotou's and Ishii's responses appeared to be unexpected for Miyuki .

Her eyes were uneasy .

'You're a stupid woman . '

'What did you say?'

'Did you really think I'd accept that condition?' said Gotou, grinning .

'What's so funny?'

Miyuki's eyes narrowed as she stood up .

It was exactly what Yakumo thought she would do . What a guy .

'What's so funny? You don't get it?'

Gotou put his nose up to the glass to provoke her .

'...'

'If you don't get it, I'll tell you . You just asked to be released from here . '

'What about it?'

'That's a funny thing to ask for . '

Miyuki jolted . She had realised the true meaning of Gotou's words .

However, it was too late to realise now .

'You escaped from the detention house to stab Isshin, right? If that were the case, wouldn't it be easy for you to get out?'

There was no response to Gotou's question .

That became evidence for one fact .

Miyuki had not taken one step out of the detention house . To put it correctly, she couldn't . She acknowledged that herself .

Gotou could tell that behind Miyuki's lips, in a thin line, her teeth were grinding together .

She was probably so frustrated she couldn't help it .

'Too bad, isn't it? I said it already – we've seen through your plan,' said Gotou, sticking out his chin .

'It was Yakumo, right? He gave you this hint...'

Miyuki looked bitter .

– It's too late to realise now .

Miyuki had let her guard down since she was talking to Gotou .

However, that had been part of Yakumo's plan . Gotou had just been talking as Yakumo had directed him to .

Miyuki had gone along and talked too much .

Last time, Yakumo had said nothing and acted quiet as part of his plan to make Miyuki let her guard down .

'Yakumo has a message for you . '

'...'

A shadow came over Miyuki's face .

'His uncle is still alive . You're just a braggart . You can't even kill a bug from inside the detention house – so he said . '

Miyuki's head drooped and she started mumbling something .

At first, Gotou couldn't hear what she was saying .

However, her voice grew firmer and finally the clear words reached Gotou's ears .

'... I'll kill you I'll kill you I'll kill you . '

Though she spoke quietly, the words had more pressure than an angry yell .

It was like there was a black aura behind Miyuki .

However, she couldn't do anything from the other side of the glass .

'It's absolutely impossible for you to kill somebody from inside the detention house . '

In response to Gotou's words, Miyuki lifted her head and her eyes opened wide . Her bloodshot eyes looked like they would fall out .

'I can . This time I'll kill Yakumo-kun . '

After saying that, Miyuki laughed uncannily, showing her canines .

'Really . I look forward to it . '

Gotou said that and then left the room .

Ishii hurriedly followed him .

'You did it, Detective Gotou . '

Ishii's eyes were sparkling like a child's, but there was something Gotou wasn't satisfied with .

He'd provoked Miyuki just as Yakumo had told him to, but was that the right decision – it was like Yakumo was using himself as bait to lure Miyuki .

– He can't be rushing to his own death, right?

Gotou murmured that in his heart .

Haruka went into the hospital that Makoto had dropped her off at .

It was so different from the hospital Isshin was at that it could be called its complete opposite . With its old white walls, it looked extremely like a hospital .

The truth was that Haruka would have liked Makoto to come with her, but they had split up at the front of the hospital since Makoto had something else to investigate .

Now there was nothing Haruka could do but go, even if she was anxious .

Haruka timidly stepped in from the front entrance, passed the reception and took the emergency stairs by the elevator hall .

A dim corridor went on in front of her .

The walls were stained and cracked, and the air felt unclean . Furthermore, the fluorescent lights were flickering loudly .

It made Haruka think that she had lost herself in a different world .

Haruka was going to meet with Hata, the coroner .

Hata had been involved in many cases with Yakumo and Gotou, so Haruka knew him, but it was the first time she'd gone to meet him on her own .

Though she knew she shouldn't judge people by their appearances, Hata had a somewhat uncanny atmosphere to him – to put it frankly, he was scary .

– Demonic old man .

Gotou often described him that way, but Haruka agreed too .

Haruka took a deep breath to calm herself down and knocked on the door of the room at the very end of the corridor .

'Excuse me, my name is Ozawa . Yakumo asked me to...'

'Door's open . '

A hoarse voice called out from inside the room .

'E-excuse me . '

Haruka obeyed the voice and opened the heavy door to peek inside .

She saw Hata sitting at his desk and leisurely sipping tea .

Though his face was as wrinkled as a dried persimmon, his eyes popped out like a fish's .

'I heard from Yakumo-kun . Well, sit down . '

After Hata said that, he let out a creepy giggle .

It made Haruka think she'd be gobbled up if she let her guard down .

Haruka uncomfortably sat in a chair, as Hata suggested .

'You don't have to be so afraid – I'm not going to eat you,' said Hata, like he had read Haruka's mind . He giggled again .

'No, that isn't...'

'I'm not interested in living humans . '

Though he had probably meant that to be reassuring, it was even scarier .

Hata normally preferred dead people over living people – and burnt corpses were no good . He was an eccentric who boasted about how he liked fresh corpses .

'Hata-san just has a pure interest in the life and death of people as a coroner . ' Yakumo had said that, but to Haruka, it didn't seem like that at all .

She brought up the topic at hand before the conversation went off track .

'Er, what did Yakumo-kun say to you?'

Haruka took Isshin's clinical records from her bag and handed them to Hata .

'Oh, that's right . Now, let's see how he was stabbed . '

Hata took the paper and put it close to his face so that his nose was almost touching it as he read it, making hmm noises as he did so .

Could he really see it like that? It felt more like he was sniffing it than looking at it with his eyes .

'I see . This is just as Yakumo-kun said,' said Hata, nodding his head a number of times in admiration .

'Er, what do you mean?' asked Haruka, curious about what Hata saw . Hata turned his cloudy eyes towards Haruka .

It felt like she'd turn into a rock if he continued .

After a while, Hata slowly began to explain .

'When I look at these clinical records, it says Isshin was stabbed diagonally from beneath his ribs upwards, but...'

Hata showed the paper to Haruka and pointed at the picture in the shape of a human body .

The right part of the picture – at the stomach, there was a mark in pen .

That was probably where Isshin had been stabbed .

'Ribs, arteries, other organs – there're no signs of injury . It's like the stab avoided them . '

Haruka cocked her head, not really understanding Hata's words .

'Is that strange?'

'If the culprit stabbed Isshin with the intention of killing him, this would practically be a miracle – the culprit would be an incredible dunce . '

Hata clutched his stomach and started giggling like he thought it funny .

'Does that mean the person who stabbed Isshin-san did not plan on killing him?'

'I don't know . They might not have planned on killing him, or they might have been but missed the vitals by some miracle – both are plausible . '

Hata said that the vitals were missed, but the main problem of Isshin being in a coma continued .

Her head was a bit mixed up .

'Well, tell Yakumo-kun it was just as he thought . '

Hata handed the copy of the medical records back to Haruka .

She took them, still confused .

'Ah, that's right . Yakumo-kun asked for something else too . '

After Hata said that, he took a large paper bag from under his desk and handed it to Haruka .

She took the bag and looked inside .

Inside there was a piece of clothing .

'What is this?'

'You can tell by looking, right? I got somebody I know to bring it,' said Hata with a smirk .

What on earth would it be used for?

The colour was awful – it wasn't fashionable . If Yakumo was going to wear this, Haruka would prefer to refrain from walking beside him .

'He isn't going to wear this, right?'

'I just got what he requested . I don't know what he's going to use it for . '

Hata's body shook as he laughed .

7

With a light heart, Ishii followed Gotou .

After reaching the parking lot in the back of the detention house, he saw Yakumo by the car .

He had his hands in his pockets and was looking up at the clouds in the sky in boredom .

– Yakumo's plan went wonderfully .

They tricked Miyuki so easily . While that brain of his was commendable, at the same time, it was frightening .

The sort of guy you didn't want as your enemy .

'Hey, we're back . '

Gotou raised his hand and called out to Yakumo .

'You're late . Were you eating grass on the side of the road? You aren't a cow,' said Yakumo with a yawn .

'The thing I hate most is being treated like a brat by a brat!'

'How pitiful; you haven't realised that you're the most brat-like person here . '

Yakumo snorted .

'You bastard! You talking about me?'

'There isn't anybody else I would be talking about, is there?'

'You brat!'

Gotou's face reddened in a flash and he grabbed Yakumo .

– Again .

He couldn't beat Yakumo in an argument . Even though he knew that, it appeared that he couldn't hold himself back .

'Detective Gotou, please stop . '

Ishii hurriedly walked towards them to stop Gotou .

'Let go of me!'

'Please calm down . '

'Shut up! I won't be satisfied until I punch this guy!'

Gotou flailed even more violently .

Ishii felt like he was riding a bucking horse . He gripped on as tightly as he could, but he was flung away; he couldn't beat Gotou in strength .

Ishii hit the asphalt .

'Don't get in my way!'

At some point, Gotou had turned his anger towards Ishii instead .

'B-but...'

Ishii managed to stand up in his stinging pain .

– Eh?

Yakumo had disappeared in the middle of the fight .

'Please don't dawdle; let's hurry up and go . '

Ishii heard Yakumo's voice .

He turned his gaze and spotted Yakumo in the back seat of the car, yawning . It was like the matter didn't concern him at all .

This made even Gotou lose his spirit . He kicked the car tire and got in .

Ishii felt tired .

'Oi! Ishii! Hurry up and start the car!'

Hurried by Gotou, Ishii sluggishly got into the driver's seat and started the car .

'How was it then?' drawled Yakumo .

It was like he had forgotten the earlier scuffle entirely .

'Just like you said . She didn't say it outright, but that woman admitted herself that she didn't leave the detention house . '

'So that really was the case then . '

Yakumo crossed his arms and looked up at the ceiling .

'Hey, Yakumo . How'd you know Miyuki didn't leave the detention house?'

Ishii thought Gotou's question was very appropriate .

In the end, Miyuki had admitted that herself, but Yakumo had realised before that .

– How?

'It's simple . I knew because it was impossible . '

'That's all?'

It was such a simple answer that Ishii was surprised and had to ask the question again .

'That's all . '

'Is that really all?' Gotou pressed .

'Of course . You should know more about the security at Tokyo Detention House than I do, Gotou-san . '

'Well, that's true, but...'

Gotou nodded, though he didn't look satisfied .

'Then you understand, right? Do you think it is possible to return to the detention house after committing a crime, let alone escaping in the first place?'

'Well...'

'And without being noticed by anyone . '

After thinking about it, Yakumo was right .

It might have been different in the past, but if you thought about it realistically, it was impossible to pass the detention house security, stab somebody and return without anyone noticing .

'It's impossible...'

Gotou scowled .

'In the first place, she declared that she would kill somebody from inside the detention house as an act to direct your attention that way . '

'An act...'

Ishii thought over that word .

Now that Yakumo said that, it made sense . Miyuki's words had been superfluous from the beginning .

'Furthermore, being carried to the infirmary was also a charade . She probably used some sort of drug to make it look like she had a fit . By doing so, it made it seem as if there was a period of time she could escape in...'

It was probably just as Yakumo said .

Ishii and Gotou had been led by the nose .

'But Isshin was stabbed . That's a fact . How'd that happen?' said Gotou carelessly, biting a cigarette that wasn't lit .

That didn't make sense to Ishii either .

He accepted that it wasn't a trap and that it was impossible to escape from the detention house . How did Miyuki commit the crime then?

Yakumo's eyes narrowed as his lips turned up into a smile .

When Ishii saw that expression, a chill ran down his spine and he almost let go of the wheel .

Even though he hadn't done anything, he was sweating .

Yakumo slowly put his left index finger to his brow .

'Isn't it obvious? She didn't stab my uncle . Somebody else did . '

'W-w-w-what!?'

Gotou rose from his seat in surprise .

Yakumo wasn't moved .

'Is there any other method?'

'Well, I get what you're saying, but...'

'No matter how unbelievable the truth, that is the only option . '

Ishii understood what Yakumo was saying .

But –

'How about the fingerprints? Her fingerprints were found on the knife's handle,' Ishii said quickly .

It was because of the fingerprints that they hadn't doubted that it was Miyuki's crime .

Even though they knew there was no other method, if they didn't solve the problem of the fingerprints, they would just have to go back .

'The culprit had her fingerprints and put them on the knife,' said Yakumo matter-of-factly .

Ishii wasn't being stubborn, but he still couldn't understand .

It was true that it would have been possible to use something like gelatine to preserve Miyuki's fingerprints and make fake fingerprints .

You could make it with just a couple hundred yen . Frequently used by those illegally entering the country, it was a big problem .

However, that wouldn't solve everything .

'Where did the culprit get her fingerprints? She was inside the detention house . '

Ishii spoke the question just as it came to his head .

If the culprit did not have the fingerprints in the first place, they could not make a fake .

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair .

It didn't look like he was thinking . Yakumo already had the answer . Ishii felt that directly .

'Your question makes sense, Ishii-san . That was why there was a letter . '

'Ah! I see!' Ishii exclaimed as he unexpectedly arrived at the answer .

'Don't shout all of a sudden!'

Gotou hit Ishii's head .

'I-I apologise . '

'I don't care which one of you does it – just explain it so I can understand . '

Gotou was probably irritated about being the only one who didn't understand . He crossed his arms indignantly .

'Ishii-san, please explain to the bear . '

Yakumo turned his eyes out the window in apparent disinterest .

Ishii fixed the position of his glasses with his finger before beginning to explain .

'The only thing you can send out of the detention house is a letter . '

'What about it?' Gotou said disagreeably .

'She put her fingerprints on that letter and sent it to the culprit on the outside . That's what it means . '

Ishii recalled the contents of the letter .

– The goal of all life is death .

Making it look like a code was just to turn their eyes away from the existence of the fingerprints .

Miyuki's true goal in sending out a letter was to give out her fingerprints .

'I see . So that's how it is...'

Gotou clapped his hands together, but he suddenly coughed, like a small bone had been caught in his throat .

'But wait... Wasn't the letter examined? Other people's fingerprints would be on it too, so the culprit wouldn't be able to say which ones were Miyuki's, right?'

Ishii was startled by what Gotou said so casually .

That was right . It wasn't like there had been names on the fingerprints . If other people touched the letter, it would be difficult to determine which fingerprints were hers .

Ishii looked at Yakumo's face through the rear-view mirror .

However, he didn't seem concerned .

'She didn't leave fingerprints on the letter . She left them on the inside of the envelope,' he said disinterestedly .

— I see .

If she put her fingers on the inside of the envelope, nobody would touch them . The culprit would be able to get Miyuki's fingerprints clearly .

That solved most of the mystery .

'Does that mean the person who got the letter, that nurse Furukawa, was the one who stabbed Isshin?' mumbled Gotou .

Without replying, Yakumo stared out the window .

A question came to Ishii .

'Excuse me, but there's one thing I don't understand . '

'How the plan was drawn up, yes?' said Yakumo, finishing Ishii's question .

'What are you talking about?'

Gotou interrupted immediately .

'Ishii-san, please go ahead . '

Yakumo left the explanation to Ishii again .

'Ah, yes . Even if there is a culprit on the outside, how did they decide on using fingerprints – and also, Miyuki announced the crime ahead of time . The day and time would also become a problem . '

'Well, you know, they used that... Couldn't they have talked on the phone?'

Gotou gave a negligent reply .

'That would be impossible . '

'What?'

'Miyuki was in the detention house . The only people who came were the lawyer and Isshin-san . The only other sign of contact with the outside was that letter,' Ishii said quickly .

'What's going on then?'

Unable to come up with an answer, Gotou turned around and looked to Yakumo .

'Who knows? I don't understand that either . '

Yakumo closed just his left eye and scratched his head .

It was a rather irresponsible answer since he had been the one who brought them to this conclusion .

'Ah! I see!'

A light bulb suddenly flashed over Ishii's head .

How did Miyuki draw up the plan – Ishii had realised .

'What? You're so noisy . '

Gotou frowned .

'Detective Gotou, Yamamura did it . '

'What did that guy do?'

– Why doesn't he understand from what I said?

Though Ishii felt irritated, he started his explanation .

'Yamamura, the guard, met up with Furukawa . He can leave and enter the detention house . '

To be honest, he was confident this time .

With Yamamura's cooperation, it would be possible to discuss the details of the plan . There was no other method .

'Ah, that's very likely... OK, let's go meet Furukawa now . Yakumo, you come too . '

Gotou leant back towards the backseat .

'I refuse . If you know that much, the rest is police business . Please work for your taxpayers' money . '

'W-what did you say!?' yelled Gotou as he tried to fly at Yakumo .

At that moment, Ishii was pushed and the wheel spun to the right . Ishii hurriedly turned the wheel back to the left, but Gotou was still flailing, so it was difficult .

The car veered right and left . Car horns started honking around them .

'Please stop! It's dangerous!' Ishii shouted, his anger apparent .

The car was silent .

Gotou had stopped moving in his surprise . His eyes were as large as plates .

'Er... I mean...'

– I never thought that I would shout at Gotou .

Actually, Ishii was the most surprised .

He might be hit once or twice for this . Ishii raised his shoulders in preparation .

'S-s-sorry . '

For some reason, Gotou bowed his head, looking troubled .

Yakumo clutched his stomach as he laughed in the backseat .

8

– I can't cheer myself up for some reason .

With gloomy feelings, Haruka waited in Yakumo's secret hiding place, the <Movie Research Circle> room .

Yakumo wasn't there .

Yakumo was sniffing something out, but Haruka didn't know where he was headed .

Even though Yakumo must have been suffering a great deal what with what happened to Isshin, he wouldn't express his feelings .

It felt like he was bearing with the pain all alone .

– That’s because you don’t tell him anything either, Haruka-chan .

The words Makoto said to her kept running through her head .

She wanted to deny it, but she couldn’t .

Unable to sort her fraying feelings, Haruka put her head against the table .

At almost the exact same time, the door opened and Yakumo came in .

‘You’re late . ’

Haruka wasn’t really angry, but she raised her head and complained anyway .

‘You’ll make a good mother-in-law,’ said Yakumo as he sat in the chair opposite her .

Even if he didn’t say it, she could tell he was tired from his expression .

His eyes were a little red . Perhaps he hadn’t slept much recently .

‘Why were you late?’ she asked, though she knew there wouldn’t be an answer .

‘I’m fairly busy too . ’

A vague answer, as expected –

Like that, he took everything on himself . Haruka would only find out once the case was over .

‘So how was it?’

Yakumo asked for a report of her investigation as he yawned .

Haruka swallowed her swelling dissatisfaction and handed over the file Makoto had given her .

'This is from Makoto-san . '

'I see . '

Yakumo took the file and looked at it with a serious gaze .

Haruka didn't know what was written on it .

I'm always kept out of the loop –

'How about Hata-san?' asked Yakumo after reading the file once .

'Hata-san said that if the culprit had planned on killing Isshin-san, it would be a near miracle since Isshin was stabbed without injuring any of his bones or organs...'

Haruka explained just as Hata had told her .

'So that really is it . '

Yakumo nodded, seeming satisfied .

Haruka didn't know what was 'really' about it .

'What do you mean?'

'Exactly what the words mean . The culprit didn't plan on killing Uncle . '

'Didn't plan on killing him?'

Haruka's brows furrowed as she mulled the words over .

'Correct . It would be troublesome if he died – perhaps that might be easier to understand . '

– I don't understand at all .

Currently, Isshin was wandering the boundary between life and death .

To Haruka, it felt like there was a clear killing intent .

'Why did they stab Isshin-san if they didn't plan on killing him?'

'Who knows? I don't know either . '

Yakumo stood up while running his fingers through his hair . Then, he opened the refrigerator door and took a bottle of tea out .

– He's lying .

Haruka felt that instinctively .

Yakumo's attitude just made it seem like he was avoiding the topic purposefully .

Even though he knew everything, he wouldn't ever talk about it . Yakumo was always like that . That was how he shouldered his harsh fate .

It hurt to watch him .

– Even though I'm prepared to shoulder the pain with him...

'Tell me the truth . '

Haruka spoke, even though she didn't think she would .

Yakumo suddenly stopped .

'I did . '

– Another lie .

'Can't you trust me?'

'I don't think that . '

Yakumo slowly sat in his chair .

– He really is shouldering everything himself .

Haruka suddenly felt frustrated .

Being together wasn't always full of good things . There was pain, frustration, and suffering . However, they could still share the burden .

People lived like that, while supporting each other .

I want to be that existence for Yakumo – she wanted that, but there was a wall she just couldn't cross .

Haruka's existence just circled that wall –

She would cry if she stayed with him any longer .

'I'm heading home . This is from Hata-san . '

Haruka said that quickly and stood up, leaving the paper bag from Hata on the table .

She hadn't planned on saying anything special, but after those words that sounded like a farewell, she felt miserable .

– Yakumo won't be tied down by anything .

Isshin's words came up in her head .

It was just as he said . Yakumo was like a cloud . No matter how you tried to hold on to him, he would slip through, since he had no substance .

– I don't know if I can do this anymore .

'Bye . '

Haruka turned her back to Yakumo and opened the door .

'I'm still thinking about it . '

Yakumo spoke .

'Eh?'

'That's why I can't say anything right now . This is a problem I have to solve . '

Yakumo's words lit Haruka's anger .

It flared up in an instant; she couldn't restrain it .

'If you're thinking about it, why not talk about it!?'

Before Haruka noticed it, she was yelling .

She tried to stop herself, but it was no good . It kept coming out .

'Nobody can understand me – you say things like that! Aren't you just distancing yourself from everyone!? Always acting like you're the only one who understands anything! Even though you don't understand how I feel at all, Yakumo-kun! I'm sick of being pushed around!'

Losing herself to a wave of emotion, the words came out of Haruka all at once .

She hadn't thought about it too deeply before . It was frustrating, it was sad – but this had to be how she truly felt .

Her body was trembling .

The tears that had welled up rolled down her cheeks, dripping one by one from her chin .

Haruka couldn't look at Yakumo to see what sort of expression he was making .

'It's not just me...'

She'd thought that she'd said everything, but words kept bubbling up from inside her chest .

'Gotou-san and Ishii-san and Makoto-san and Hata-san . Everyone – everyone's worried about you and trying to understand your heart, Yakumo-kun... But what do you say? It's got nothing to do with me, or it's troublesome – how can you say that!?'

Haruka's breathing was ragged, as if she were nearly drowning .

It felt like she would be crushed and die from the pressure .

She couldn't stand . She sat right there .

– It was quiet .

So quiet you'd think nobody was in this room –

Perhaps there really wasn't anybody there .

Yakumo might have already left the room without listening to Haruka's yells .

Without Isshin, it felt like his bonds to everyone would fall apart at the seams and crumble .

– No, that's wrong .

Haruka might have been the only one who thought there was a bond there, when it had really just been an illusion .

– Which is it?

She didn't know . Haruka didn't care anymore .

She just wanted to run away as quickly as she could .

– Haruka .

She heard somebody call her name close to her ear .

– Who is that? Yakumo? It can't be .

Yakumo had never called her name before .

Haruka slowly stood, dragging up her heavy body .

'I'm sorry . I'll tell you everything . '

This time, she heard it clearly .

There was no doubt about it . It was Yakumo's voice –

9

Komatsu relaxed after eating dinner while reading a magazine in the break room .

Then, the internal telephone on the desk rang, breaking that relaxation .

<Doctor! It's an emergency!>

When Komatsu picked up the receiver, he heard a frantic voice on the other side .

'Symptoms?'

<Coughing up blood . >

'I see,' replied Komatsu, writing it down on a piece of paper as he did so .

<Breathing is also weak; it appears there are convulsions as well . >

'Can you carry the patient?'

<We're heading there now . >

'Got it . '

Komatsu hung up and headed right for the infirmary .

From the voice on the telephone just now, it was serious .

Finally, the guards carried the patient in on a stretcher . The patient's arm hung over the side .

'That bed . '

Komatsu instructed the guards .

When Komatsu saw the person on the bed, he was startled .

– This woman again?

She had been carried in because she was coughing up blood just the other day .

The detective who came earlier had suspected it was an act . Komatsu had denied it then, but to be honest, he thought there was a possibility .

– I can't let my guard down around this woman .

It wasn't something specific . If he was forced to say it, it was those eyes . He'd never seen such cold eyes before .

He decided to stop thinking about it for now . He'd determine if it was a faked illness after examination .

Komatsu put his ear close to her mouth to check that she was breathing .

Her breathing was faint .

He checked her pulse using her wrist .

It was so weak with the beats spread out to the point that he wouldn't have noticed unless he was looking for it .

– This isn't an act .

He was sure . People could act like they were suffering or in pain and even consciously make their breath weaker, but they couldn't do the same thing with the pulse .

He suddenly felt impatient .

He took a penlight out of the pocket of his white doctor's gown, opened her eyes and shined the light on them . The pupils remained as they were .

'This is bad...'

He said that without thinking .

'How is she?' asked the guard who had brought her in .

The patient was unconscious .

They wouldn't be able to do anything in the infirmary of the detention house . Komatsu decided that .

'Get permission from head office to transport the prisoner . I'll call an ambulance . '

Once Komatsu said that, one of the guards flew out of the room .

In the case that one of the prisoners held at the detention house suddenly became ill and could not be treated at the infirmary, they would be transported to the nearby hospital with the permission of head office .

Komatsu picked up the phone on his desk and directly called the hospital .

He told the doctor who answered the current situation, received permission to take the patient and hung up .

The woman on the bed groaned, sounding like she was in pain .

'Will she be all right?' asked the guard who had remained .

'I don't know,' said Komatsu .

From the woman's symptoms, it was clear that it wasn't a faked illness, but uneasiness still smouldered in his heart –

10

'Before I say anything, there's somewhere I want to go . '

After Yakumo said that, they headed for Gotou's home .

Haruka realised what Yakumo was thinking after coming this far . He had come to check up on Nao .

When Yakumo pressed the intercom button at the entrance, Atsuko welcomed them in pleasantly .

They took the lift up to the fourth floor and were just about to press the intercom button there when the door opened and Nao showed up .

The moment Nao saw Yakumo, she smiled from cheek to cheek and scratched her face like a cat .

It seemed she'd been lonely .

'It's nice to meet you . '

Atsuko showed up behind Nao and smiled at Yakumo .

'Thank you for all that you've done . My name is Saitou Yakumo . '

Yakumo bowed his head awkwardly .

'You're so stiff . I get enough of that from my husband . Anyway, come in,' said Atsuko mischievously .

In agreement, Nao pulled Yakumo's hand and took him inside .

Haruka followed after them, as if she had been pulled too .

After going into the living, Haruka sat next to Yakumo on the sofa .

'Please don't trouble yourself,' said Yakumo .

'Don't worry about it,' Atsuko replied, and she started making tea .

Nao was sitting opposite Yakumo, but then she stood up and ran to the kitchen to help Atsuko .

There was a very fun atmosphere coming from the kitchen .

At first, Haruka had been worried, but it seemed like Atsuko and Nao had made fast friends .

Yakumo looked at them with a heavy gaze .

'I'm glad Nao-chan seems to be doing well . '

Haruka really felt that way .

Atsuko's presence had probably supported Nao in these harsh circumstances . Atsuko was incredibly tolerant .

That was Gotou's wife for you .

'Nao doesn't remember her mother . '

Yakumo's eyes closed slightly .

Haruka had heard about Nao's mother from Isshin before . She had died when Nao was one .

Just as Yakumo said, Nao probably couldn't remember her mother .

'I see...'

What would happen to Nao if she lost Isshin too?

Haruka didn't want to think about it, but her anxiety showed on her face .

Finally, Nao came back with a tray of tea . Atsuko was right behind her .

'Ah!'

Nao held out the tray as she spoke up .

'Thank you,' said Haruka, taking a teacup .

Yakumo did the same thing, smiling awkwardly .

'Well done . '

Atsuko patted Nao's head .

Nao laughed, like she was ticklish .

'Is she causing you any trouble?' asked Yakumo as he stared at his teacup .

'Trouble?'

Atsuko looked surprised .

'Yes . Suddenly taking Nao in must have been a bother . '

'Why?'

'Er, well...'

Yakumo's brows furrowed at Atsuko's response .

Atsuko smiled pleasantly when she saw him .

'You're a bit different from what I imagined . '

'What you imagined?'

'My husband and Haruka-chan said that you were incredibly contrary...'

Yakumo glanced at Haruka .

Haruka looked down .

'Right, Nao-chan?'

Atsuko looked to Nao for agreement .

Whether she understood what was being said or not, Nao nodded a number of times .

When Haruka looked at Atsuko and Nao communicating like this, somehow —

'It's like they're really mother and daughter . '

It slipped out of Haruka's mouth .

'It really is...' whispered Yakumo .

Haruka thought that it really was a good thing that Atsuko was here this time . Without her, Nao probably couldn't have smiled like this .

'I'm sorry, but please take care of Nao for a little longer,' said Yakumo as he stood .

There was an extraordinary air to him . As if he was preparing for something —

'I don't mind at all, but you have to come back . '

Atsuko turned a sharp gaze towards Yakumo .

Next to her, Nao looked up at Yakumo anxiously .

'I know,' said Yakumo, his head then . Then, he lightly patted Nao on the head and walked to the entrance .

Haruka stood up as well . She tried to follow him, but Nao grabbed her hand .

Nao's eyes were pleading .

Haruka understood even if she didn't say anything . Nao was worried about Yakumo .

'Yakumo-kun's OK,' said Haruka, drawing Nao close .

Finally, Nao nodded and let go of Haruka .

'Haruka-chan, I'll leave the rest to you . At times like this, women have to be firm,' said Atsuko just as Haruka walked to the entrance .

'I will . '

Haruka nodded and then went outside after Yakumo .

11

– We've finally come this far .

As Gotou looked up at the apartment that stood out in the dark, he felt relief .

He'd seen Furukawa enter her flat just earlier .

Last time, they hadn't known the point of the letter, so they had been stuck just watching her, unable to go further, but this time was different .

Yakumo had made the point of the letter clear .

Furukawa had taken Miyuki's fingerprints and used them when she stabbed Isshin . That had to be right .

'OK! Let's go!'

Gotou called out to Ishii, who was beside him, and went through the apartment's entrance .

They took the elevator to Furukawa's room on the fourth floor .

She had met with Isshin using a ghost sighting at the hospital before the incident occurred . That couldn't be a coincidence .

She had called Isshin out purposefully – it was natural to think she was wrapped up in the case .

But there was something Gotou just didn't understand .

Motive –

Why did Furukawa have to stab Isshin?

– Well, there's no point thinking about it .

Gotou shook his head and threw aside his thoughts . He'd decided to act rather than think about unnecessary things now .

Gotou stood in front of the door and signalled Ishii with his eyes .

Ishii replied with a nod and timidly pressed the intercom button .

<Hello . >

There was a guarded voice from the intercom .

'Ah, good evening . We're police . '

Ishii spoke in a polite and cheerful voice so as to not disturb Furukawa .

Gotou had thought Ishii was just a fumbling guy, but at some point, he'd learnt a technique like this .

<Police?>

The guarded tone was stronger in Furukawa's voice .

'Oh, it's nothing important, but there's something we'd like to ask you for reference . '

As Ishii spoke, there was the sound of rustling from the room .

She was searching for something . Or hiding something .

After a while, Furukawa opened the door .

It was obvious that she didn't want them to come in .

'Actually, we're investigating an attempted murder case... You know about Saitou Isshin-san's case, yes?' said Ishii, asking for agreement .

'Ah, yes . '

Furukawa's eyes were flicking about .

She was clearly afraid .

'You met the victim, Saitou Isshin, before the incident, yes, Furukawa-san?'

'Eh, well...'

'On what business did you meet him?'

'Er... How should I explain it...'

Ishii and Furukawa continued to talk .

– Ah, get it over with already . Don't make me irritated .

If they kept on asking small things like this, it'd take until morning . Even though they could just get to the point .

Just as Gotou was about to interrupt since he was at the limit of his patience, he saw something move in the back of the room .

A black shadow –

Gotou's body moved before he could think .

He pushed Furukawa aside and walked in in his shoes .

It was a common one-room flat of about eight tatami in size .

After going in, he spotted a man crouching with his hand on the window that connected to the balcony .

– So that really was it .

'Yamamura!' yelled Gotou as he charged .

Yamamura's eyes went wide .

'Wait – what are you doing!?'

Furukawa's expression changed as she clung onto Gotou .

'Let go . '

Gotou shook Furukawa off .

Yamamura used that time to go out the window onto the balcony and jumped right there .

– As if I'd let you get away!

'Ishii! Watch that woman!'

Gotou ran after Yamamura and jumped off the balcony .

– Crap .

When he thought that, it was already too late .

He was on the fourth floor . It was far too high to jump .

After a feeling of floating, his two feet hit something .

However, it wasn't as great a force as he thought it would be .

Gotou had landed on the roof of the entrance rather than the ground .

Luckily, the building's entrance stuck out .

Gotou was relieved, but he didn't have the time to relax . Yamamura had also landed on the roof and had jumped to the ground . He was running away .

'As if I'd let you get away!'

Gotou jumped right after him and ran after Yamamura .

Yamamura ran out from the apartment premises onto the road .

At that moment, a car ran into him and Yamamura's body flew into the air .

It was like a slow-motion movie .

The car veered into the bushes .

Yamamura fell onto the asphalt .

– Is he dead?

He was unexpectedly calm as he worried about that .

'That hurts!'

Yamamura grabbed his leg, writhing like a fly that had been hit with bug spray .

– He's alive then .

'He suddenly ran out . '

The driver got off the car and was lamenting with a pale face .

Gotou ignored the driver, approached Yamamura and grabbed him by the collar .

'Sorry you couldn't get away . This puts you under guard now . '

Yamamura's eyes were filled with tears as he bit his lip .

'Detective Gotou, are you all right?'

Ishii, who had heard the commotion, had rushed out .

'Call an ambulance now!' Gotou ordered .

At the same time, his mobile phone started vibrating inside his jacket .

– Who the hell's calling now?

Gotou quickly cuffed Yamamura and answered the phone .

'Who's it?'

<It's me!>

He heard Miyagawa's voice .

Gotou had been prepared to hear complaints about his phone etiquette, but unexpectedly, they skipped that .

<Things are a mess . >

Miyagawa sounded tense, which was unusual for him .

That was enough to tell Gotou how serious the situation was .

'What happened?'

<Nanase Miyuki escaped . >

– What kind of joke was that?

Gotou cocked his head .

He'd told Miyagawa that Miyuki couldn't have escaped the detention house to commit the crime .

'What are you saying? It's impossible to escape from the detention house, isn't it?'

<She got out of it . >

'That's impossible . '

While Gotou denied it, his heart was beating loudly .

<About an hour earlier, Nanase Miyuki collapsed in her room and was carried to the infirmary . >

'And then?'

<At the instruction of the medical officer at the detention house, she was transported to the nearby hospital...>

'That's transport, not escape, right?'

<There's more to the story . Listen properly . >

Miyagawa's voice was unsteady, which was unlike him .

Gotou felt anxious too when he heard that voice .

'More... to the story...'

<After arriving at the hospital, they opened the back of the ambulance, but it was empty . >

'Empty?'

– What was going on?

<She disappeared . We're in a state of emergency, but...>

Gotou ignored Miyagawa and hung up before he could finish .

The tips of his fingers were trembling .

'Oi! Yamamura! Why'd you stab Saitou Isshin?'

Yamamura had collapsed, but Gotou grabbed him again by the collar .

Yamamura's lips were shaking in pain and fear .

'I-I-I don't know... Who is that? Hurry and call the ambulance already . It hurts . '

'Don't play dumb . Nanase Miyuki asked you to do it, right!?'

'What are you saying? I just...'

Yamamura looked away in the middle of speaking .

– He's clearly hiding something .

'Just what?'

'N-nothing . '

'Cough it up already! I can just write you off as dead in a traffic accident!' yelled Gotou, slapping Yamamura's left cheek .

'W-what are you doing? Can the police do this?'

'I can . '

'I'll press charges in court . '

'Do whatever you want . '

Gotou glared at Yamamura and raised his right arm .

This time he'd hit him with a fist instead of his palm .

'I-I-I got it . I'll talk, so please stop . '

Yamamura seemed to realise that common sense wouldn't work on Gotou, so he frantically pleaded .

'Hurry it up then! I don't have the time!'

'I just gave that woman the medicine she ordered . '

'Medicine?'

'Painkillers, tranquillisers, stuff like that . That's all . '

Gotou let go of Yamamura and stood up .

His ears were ringing .

On the day of the crime, Miyuki had had spasms and had been carried to the infirmary .

Plus, Miyagawa had said she'd collapsed in her room earlier . The medical officer had decided she'd needed to be transported .

– Is the medical officer in on it too?

'No . '

Gotou rejected that thought aloud .

Miyuki hadn't been faking it . She had definitely had real symptoms .

Furukawa had probably got the medicine from the hospital, handed them to Yamamura who had given them to Miyuki .

Yamamura and Furukawa had had another role .

That was to be Miyuki's speciality – a fake trail .

By leaving evidence well, she made the investigation turn to Yamamura and Furukawa .

And we fell right into that trap –

When Gotou realised that, his body jolted, like electricity had run through it .

Gotou remembered what Miyuki had said .

– This time, I'll kill Yakumo-kun .

When Gotou tricked Miyuki then, he had gone along with the mood .

– Looking forward to it .

He'd said that . There was no way for her to kill him . He'd thought that .

But the situation was different now . Miyuki had escaped from the detention house . She was walking freely . She could kill Yakumo too .

– You kidding me?

'Detective Gotou, I called the ambulance,' said Ishii, out of breath . He didn't know anything .

'Oi, Ishii! I'm leaving the rest to you!'

Gotou ran off before he finished speaking .

'Leaving what to me, Detective Gotou!?'

Ishii wailed from behind him, but Gotou ignored it, getting into the plain car parked on the road .

– Please . Yakumo . Be all right .

Gotou slammed down the pedal as he prayed and started to drive .

The surroundings were dark .

In that dark, Haruka walked with Yakumo towards the hospital where Isshin was .

Since it was past the time for the lights to be put out, only a few lights were on .

The cold wind passed between them .

Haruka looked at Yakumo, walking beside her .

His moonlit profile was as expressionless as a wax figure's .

After leaving Atsuko's home, Yakumo told her what had happened so far .

It became a very long conversation .

However, Haruka didn't understand everything .

Just as Yakumo had said, there were only a number of facts for the case, and Haruka couldn't put them together .

However, everything was probably connected in Yakumo's head .

After reaching the night entrance, Yakumo suddenly stopped and took his mobile phone out of his pocket .

'What? It's you, Gotou-san... I'm at the hospital right now... I see... She did...'

Yakumo's voice became quieter and quieter as he spoke .

Haruka couldn't hear what they were talking about, but she could tell it wasn't something good .

'I see . I have something I want to discuss as well . Let's meet at the hospital . '

After saying that, Yakumo hung up .

'Hey, did something happen?'

Haruka spoke to Yakumo's back .

'Nanase Miyuki escaped from the detention house . '

Yakumo said it in a nonchalant manner, but that was truly terrifying .

Her heart was as noisy as a dead branch being blown about by the wind .

Nanase Miyuki had been the start of this case .

No, not just this one . She had been involved in a number of cases in the past . She was the one who abducted Yakumo last time too .

Just as Yakumo had solved the puzzle, she escaped – it was like a bad omen .

'You OK?' said Haruka, hiding her uneasiness .

'I'm fine . I'll protect you, at least . '

Yakumo said just that and started walking again .

– Protect .

It made Haruka happy to hear that, but her anxiety didn't leave her .

Even if she was OK, if something happened to Yakumo, she wouldn't be able to bear it .

Just as she was about to call out to Yakumo, she felt somebody's gaze .

It was a chilling gaze .

Haruka turned around, startled .

However, she didn't see anybody .

There was only a deep darkness .

It felt creepy since she couldn't confirm anything .

'Don't dawdle . Let's go . '

Yakumo urged her on, so Haruka jogged into the hospital .

They passed the reception and went down the corridor, stopping in front of the door to an examination room .

She had been here before .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . This place...'

'Correct . It's Doctor Mao's examination room . She should know I'm here .
,

'Why?'

'It's obviously because I contacted her . '

Yakumo's brows furrowed as he looked at her like she was stupid .

Normally, Haruka would object, but when she thought about what was going to happen next, she just didn't feel like it .

Yakumo opened the door . Just as he'd said, the lights in the room were on and Mao was sitting at her desk .

'Welcome . '

When Mao looked at them, she looked a bit tired .

Her face was haggard; it was like her heart wasn't here .

'Hello,' said Yakumo, stepping inside, but he chose to lean against the wall rather than sit .

Haruka went inside after bowing .

'You're here too? Please sit . '

Mao urged them to sit, but Yakumo refused: 'I'm fine here . '

Haruka couldn't sit either then . She closed the door and stood next to Yakumo .

'So what did you have to talk about?'

Mao crossed her legs and looked at Yakumo .

'It isn't anything important, but there was something I wanted to confirm,' Yakumo said lightly, shrugging as he did so .

'What is it?'

Mao sighed . Her expression was stiff .

It appeared that she knew Yakumo wasn't here just to talk about something unimportant, even though he said that .

'Doctor, won't you tell me the truth already?'

Yakumo's narrowed left eye seemed to have a light within it .

'The truth? I don't know what you're...'

Mao shook her head with a wry smile .

'Will you feign innocence until the end?'

Yakumo's eyes became more forceful .

So Mao really is related to the case —

Mao was Isshin's friend from university and had used to like him .

It might have been naive of Haruka, but she couldn't think – didn't want to think – that such a person would be related to the case .

Haruka looked at Mao with that wish .

'I'm not feigning innocent . '

Mao looked away .

No matter how she denied it aloud, her attitude showed the truth .

'Yes, you are . There's something, isn't there? That you're hiding from me .
,

'There isn't!' Mao said loudly, as if trying to drown out Yakumo's words .

She couldn't hide her disturbance .

'Is that so? Then let's say it clearly . The reason that my uncle fell into a brain-dead state is not only because he was stabbed – there is the possibility that it was a medical mistake . Am I wrong?'

Yakumo's words seemed to cut Mao's heart like a sharp knife .

Mao looked anguished; her cheek twitched .

'That can't be . There's no way...'

Those words that sounded like they were strangled out of her were as brittle as glasswork .

No matter how she denied it, it was apparent that Yakumo's words were true .

'That's right . This time, it wasn't a medical mistake . '

'Eh?'

'My uncle was purposefully put into a brain-dead state,' said Yakumo with a sharp glare .

'Wait, Yakumo-kun . That's saying too much,' interrupted Haruka, unable to bear it .

Putting aside whether it was a medical mistake, saying that his uncle was purposefully put into a brain-dead state –

That would be murder .

He couldn't suspect that, even as a joke .

'I'm not saying that lightly . You heard from Hata-san, didn't you? If that were a stab to kill, it was near miraculous that none of the organs was injured . In short, Uncle's injuries were lighter than they looked . '

'That's...'

Haruka swallowed the words she was about to say .

Isshin's medical records and his current status – she had noticed the great contradiction between them .

'That isn't a coincidence . It was fate . '

However, Yakumo's words came into her head, stopping her from trying not to believe it .

'Fate?'

'Correct . In short, the culprit's goal was to put Uncle in a brain-dead state . '

After Yakumo said that, he looked straight at Mao .

Mao's body jolted as Yakumo's gaze went straight through her .

'Why would they have to do that?'

Haruka had the same question as Mao .

Why would somebody go out of their way to make someone brain-dead – if they stabbed Isshin because they hated him, they could have just killed him .

'The reason is simple . The culprit wanted my uncle's organs . Isn't that right? Doctor Mao . '

'Organs...'

Mao repeated what Yakumo said in an incoherent mutter .

'I did a bit of investigation,' said Yakumo . He took a folded piece of paper from his pocket, unfolded it and handed it to Mao .

This was probably what Makoto had given to Haruka to hand to Yakumo .

'Where did you get...'

'That isn't the problem right now . The name on the top of that list . I won't let you say you don't know,' said Yakumo with a hard expression .

Haruka leant forward to look at that list .

It was titled Organ Transplant Registry List and had many people's names on it .

Mao closed her eyes and let out a long sigh .

As if she had let out everything she'd been holding in, her expression seemed a bit softer .

'If you know that much, there's no point hiding it...'

'So you'll talk then . About what you've shouldered,' said Yakumo quietly .

'Yes, I will,' replied Mao listlessly . She looked up at the ceiling .

So Mao really is the culprit – but why?

Feelings of doubt and not wanting to believe it went through Haruka's head, making her confused .

'That day, when I was at home, I was contacted . Isshin was carried in . When I got there, I heard that he might be brain-dead . '

'And then?'

Yakumo urged her to continue without regard for Mao .

'When I looked at the record, I immediately thought it was strange . I'd heard that he had stopped breathing for a while, but it would be strange to think that happened from the injury . '

'Then, you started investigating on your own, thinking it was possible that it was from a medical mistake . '

Mao nodded at what Yakumo added .

After coming this far, a number of things had connected in Haruka's head .

When she came before, Yakumo questioned Mao about Isshin's state when he was carried in . Mao had had an obviously unnatural attitude .

It appeared that it was because she herself had doubts about Isshin's condition .

However, that would mean there was another culprit .

Just as Haruka came to that thought, the internal telephone on the desk rang .

'What? I'm having an important talk right now so if it isn't an emergency, leave it for later...'

Mao spoke brusquely, but as she listened to the response, her face grew rapidly paler .

Haruka knew immediately that something terrible was happening .

'Uncle's disappeared then,' said Yakumo once Mao put down the phone .

'Yes, he has . '

Mao nodded, biting her lip .

– Isshin-san's disappeared?

It was so unexpected that Haruka couldn't hide her confusion .

'Doctor Mao, I understand how you feel, but you can't hide anything anymore . '

'You're right . '

Mao stood, as if dragged up by Yakumo's words .

'Let's go . Before it's too late . '

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Ishii dumbly watched Yamamura being carried away by the ambulance .

Because of the police cars that came later, the front of the apartment was surrounded by curious onlookers in no time, and he also spotted some people from the media .

However, probably none of the people here knew what had happened .

Like moths to a flame, they had just come because there was a commotion .

'Ishii!'

Ishii saw Miyagawa running towards him with a furious expression .

'Yes sir . '

'Where's Gotou?' asked Miyagawa, gasping .

Ishii wanted to respond immediately, but he hadn't asked Gotou where he was going .

'That is... He suddenly ran off...'

'That idiot!' yelled Miyagawa after clicking his tongue .

Ishii felt something was incredible upon seeing that expression .

'Excuse me... Did something happen?'

'Did something happen? Didn't you hear?'

'No, I didn't . '

Miyagawa frowned, as if trying to hold in his anger, and then looked around before walking so close to Ishii that their shoulders were almost touching .

'Nanase Miyuki's gone missing . '

'W-what are you talking about?'

Ishii was so surprised he thought his chin would come off .

Miyuki should have been in the detention house . He'd met with her just a few hours earlier . How could she be missing?

Miyagawa explained the details of how Nanase Miyuki had gone missing to Ishii, who was confused .

'C-could it be that Detective Gotou...'

'He knows . '

– Is that why he ran off so quickly?

Once Ishii understood, he grew pale .

Miyuki had said she would kill Yakumo next . Gotou had probably gone to try to stop that .

However, that would mean flying right into Miyuki's trap .

'I-I'm going to go look for Detective Gotou . '

'I can't leave the scene . I'm counting on you . '

Miyagawa hit Ishii's shoulder hard .

It was a heavy responsibility, but Ishii had to respond to it now .

'Yes sir . '

After responding, Ishii took out his mobile phone and called Gotou .

He might not answer . Ishii thought that, but Gotou answered immediately .

<What do you want?>

'Detective Gotou, are you all right?' Ishii asked frantically .

<Of course I am, you fool!>

Gotou's voice came back, almost too energetically .

Ishii was so relieved he almost sat down .

'I'm glad . Where are you now?'

<The hospital . >

'Please wait until I get there . '

<You're so annoying! As if I could wait for you!>

The call cut off .

From the situation, Gotou was probably at the hospital where Isshin was .

– I'll catch up to him right away .

Ishii started running through the crowd .

As he passed through the people, he suddenly came to his senses .

He'd been running ahead just on his emotions without thinking about what to do at all . Gotou had taken the car . It was five kilometres to the hospital from here .

He didn't have the time to leisurely walk there .

– What should I do?

While he was thinking, he spotted a face he recognised in the throng of people .

'M-Makoto-san,' called Ishii .

Makoto noticed immediately and walked towards him . Since she was a reporter, she had probably heard about the commotion and come for material .

'Ishii-san, did something happen?'

'If I don't get to the hospital soon, Detective Gotou will...'

He couldn't explain properly in his hurry .

Regardless, Makoto seemed to sense the tension and nodded .

'My car is there . '

'Thank you . '

Ishii ran after Makoto .

– He fell .

Gotou drove, urged on by his impatience .

Even though Yakumo had heard about Miyuki's escape, he didn't seem disturbed at all . It was like he was looking forward to meeting Miyuki again .

– Does Yakumo plan to finish things with Miyuki?

Last time, it just happened to work out well, but confronting Miyuki would be like suicide .

– Yakumo wouldn't do something so rash .

Gotou had meant to deny the possibility with confidence, but there was anxiety in the corner of his heart .

Sometimes, Yakumo did things that would hurt himself terribly .

Like he was looking for a place to die –

'There's no way!' yelled Gotou, clearing away the bad thoughts in his head .

Yakumo might have done it in the past, but he was different now .

– I'm almost at the hospital . Be safe .

Gotou prayed as he stepped on the accelerator .

Finally, the hospital came into view .

He drove onto the hospital premises and parked his car at the front entrance .

He ran at full strength and tried to pass through the automatic doors, but he hit his forehead with a dull thump .

'Not going to open!?'

He'd forgotten that you couldn't go in from the front at this time .

Gotou ran towards the night entrance while holding his head .

Just as he was about to go inside, his mobile phone rang .

It was from Ishii .

'What do you want?'

<Detective Gotou, are you all right?>

When he heard Ishii's hesitant voice, his irritation doubled .

'Of course I am, you fool!'

<I'm glad . Where are you now?>

'The hospital . '

<Please wait until I get there . >

'You're so annoying! As if I could wait for you to get here!'

After spitting that out, Gotou hung up .

Just as Gotou was trying to open the door, his mobile phone rang again .

'What?'

<As usual, that isn't proper phone etiquette . >

Gotou had thought it would be Ishii again, but Yakumo was the one who called .

– So you're still alive .

Gotou heaved a sigh of relief .

'Stop complaining so much!'

<Where are you right now?>

'The exit . '

While talking, Gotou pushed open the door .

He showed the guard his police ID and headed down the corridor .

<I see . Please come right to the surgery room . >

'Surgery room? What for?'

Gotou asked a question, but Yakumo hung up .

'He just does whatever he wants!'

While Gotou's dissatisfaction was at a peak, he checked the hospital's information map and ran at full speed .

He went up the stairs to the fourth floor and headed towards the surgery room at the end of the corridor .

– There he is!

Gotou spotted Yakumo in front of the door to the surgery room .

Haruka and Mao were there too .

'Yakumo! You bastard!'

Gotou ran up to Yakumo and grabbed him by his collar .

'You're so noisy . Please be quieter – this is a hospital . '

Yakumo said that in his usual troubled tone and brushed aside Gotou's arms .

'What'd you say?'

Gotou got closer, but Yakumo put his fingers in his ears with a disagreeable look .

'This isn't the time to have a silly argument . The person who stabbed my uncle looms in this surgery room,' said Yakumo, putting at the door with his chin .

Then, Mao tried the doorknob to force it open .

However, the door didn't budge .

– Looms?

'What do you mean?'

'I don't have the time to explain right now . Anyway, please open this door .

Yakumo pointed at the door .

– I see . That's why he called me .

Gotou saw the <In Surgery> light on above the door .

'Step away,' Gotou told Mao . Then, he rammed his shoulder into the door .

However, the door just shook slightly without breaking off . There was probably a bolt or something on the other side .

– Don't think that's going to stop me .

Gotou headed down the corridor and started running at about ten metres to ram into the door again .

Crack!

The door opened with the sound of something snapping .

Gotou tumbled forward and hit the wall with his back .

'Please think ahead before acting,' said Yakumo, looking down at Gotou after stepping into the surgery room .

'Shut up! You're the one who said to hurry!'

Gotou stood up with a hand on his back . He looked around .

A surgery room surrounded with white walls –

The culprit was here . Yakumo had said that .

There was one bed in the corner of the room . A girl was sleeping there .

Isshin lay on the surgery table in the middle of the room .

– Why's Isshin here?

Gotou walked towards the surgery table .

However, a man walked in front of him to block his ways .

The man wore a green surgical gown . He had a cap and mask on, so Gotou couldn't see his face clearly .

– Is this guy the perp?

'Who are you?'

Instead of answering the question, the man thrust the scalpel in his hand in front of Gotou's eyes .

– Don't do that all of a sudden .

Gotou glared at the man without flinching .

Gotou wanted to leap at him, but he couldn't .

With the scalpel still out, the man had his left index finger on a switch of a machine by the surgery table .

Gotou couldn't say for certain, but it was probably something that kept Isshin alive . If Gotou moved, Isshin's life would be in danger .

– Now, what to do?

'So this really was the case . '

Yakumo spoke .

The man cautiously stepped back from Yakumo .

Yakumo didn't seem to care as he walked towards Isshin, touched his hands and narrowed his eyes .

He looked down . His profile was so expressionless it was like he was wearing a mask .

However, Gotou could tell that within Yakumo there was anger, resentment and sadness .

Gotou was tense .

Finally, Yakumo slowly lifted his face .

'Let's stop this already, Doctor Sakakibara . '

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– Doctor Sakakibara .

Haruka couldn't believe what had come out of Yakumo's mouth .

Sakakibara was the doctor who had first treated Isshin . Why would he?

Contrary to Haruka's emotional state, Sakakibara looked resigned as he took off his cap and mask to reveal his face .

'I am going to operate now . I want you not to interfere . If you do...'

Sakakibara spoke firmly as he turned the tip of the scalpel towards Yakumo .

Yakumo didn't even budge as he looked at Sakakibara with his red left eye .

'Doctor Sakakibara, let's stop this already . '

Mao pushed past Yakumo and pleaded with Sakakibara .

'How could I!?'

This time, Sakakibara thrust the scalpel in front of Mao's eyes .

'What you are trying to do is a crime,' Mao continued .

'You're wrong! It's an organ transplant surgery!' insisted Sakakibara, his chest puffed out .

Haruka looked at the bed in the corner of the surgery room .

Lying there was Yoshiko, whom Haruka had seen a number of times before at the hospital .

If she remembered correctly, there was something wrong with her heart – which probably meant Sakakibara was trying to transplant Isshin's heart to her .

– But why would he go so far?

'I'm not wrong . Isshin-kun's family did not agree to a transplant, so this is...'

'Shut up! The law doesn't matter! This is a transplant to save my daughter!'

Sakakibara interrupted Mao .

He was terribly agitated . His shoulders shook violently as he breathed .

'Yakumo . Explain . What's going on?' said Gotou disagreeably .

Yakumo sighed, like he thought there was no way out of it, and spoke after running a hand through his hair .

'The girl sleeping there is Kimura Yoshiko-chan . Though her family changed after the divorce, she's Doctor Sakakibara's daughter . '

'W-what?'

'I had Makoto-san investigate for me . The two of them are definitely father and daughter . '

— So that's how it is .

When Haruka heard it like this, she understood what Yakumo had been looking for .

From Furukawa's gossip at the hospital, they'd found out that Sakakibara was divorced and troubled about his daughter . When looking into his background, it was revealed that Sakakibara and Yoshiko were father and daughter – that was probably it .

'That true?' asked Gotou, but Sakakibara didn't respond .

After a breath, Yakumo continued his explanation .

'She has a terrible heart disorder . Without a transplant, she will die . The name of the disorder is dilated cardiomyopathy...'

'How do you know that?' asked Gotou .

'I had Makoto-san look into this as well . Yoshiko's name was at the top of the recipient list for heart transplants . She was probably in considerably serious condition . '

Sakakibara's expression twisted at Yakumo's words .

Even if he didn't say it, it was evidence that what Yakumo said was true .

'Wait a second! How's that girl's condition related to this case?' Gotou said quickly .

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair, looking annoyed, while shaking his head .

'Don't you understand? He was looking for a donor to offer a heart . '

'Donor...' Gotou repeated in a hoarse voice .

'That's right . Then, Doctor Sakakibara participated in the plan . '

'What?'

'He broke the glass of the back window before the event and put Nanase Miyuki's fingerprints there . He sneaked into the temple and waited for my uncle to come . '

There, Yakumo paused and shut his eyes, turning his head towards the ceiling .

Perhaps he was thinking of the scene, because he bit his lip, looking pained .

'This guy did...'

'He did . After Doctor Sakakibara stabbed my uncle, he hurried back to the hospital . '

'Why? He could've just run . '

'It was because he needed to perform the emergency operation on my uncle to purposefully put him in a brain-dead state . '

'This guy... did it then...'

Gotou's expression was filled with anger .

Haruka had never seen Gotou look so frightening before .

'Gotou-san, you and Ishii thought you were guarding Uncle, but actually, you were given the important role of calling the ambulance . '

'What?'

'There could not have been a transplant unless Uncle was brain-dead . '

– So that was how it was .

Haruka could see the whole picture too .

Sakakibara stabbed Isshin, operated on him himself, and purposefully put Isshin in a brain-dead state, though he had been breathing .

What Sakakibara had done was absolutely unforgiveable .

However, his motive had not been hatred or a grudge . He had done it to save his daughter –

Haruka looked at Yoshiko sleeping on the bed .

Her young sleeping face . She had done no wrong . But –

Haruka felt her chest constrict .

'Do you have proof?' Gotou asked Yakumo .

That was a big problem . No matter how much circumstantial evidence they had, without physical evidence, they couldn't build a case against Sakakibara .

'I have none at this point, but if there is a careful reinvestigation, while fingerprints are probably impossible, there will probably be hair or fabric .

'Really?'

'Yes . Nanase Miyuki's fingerprints were a red herring to lead the investigation away from Doctor Sakakibara . '

First, Nanase Miyuki announced her intent to murder .

Just as she declared, Isshin was stabbed, and her fingerprints were found .
That led the police's investigation in her direction .

'No . Wait . But what about the letter with the fingerprints? Furukawa received that . '

Gotou asked his question in a panic, but Yakumo was calm .

'I had Makoto-san look into this as well, but it seems that Furukawa-san works the day shift every Thursday, while Doctor Sakakibara has the day off . '

'So if she got the letter there on Thursday, he'd be able to get it?'

'Correct . '

Yakumo nodded in response to Gotou .

'Nanase Miyuki planned it and Sakakibara executed it then . '

Gotou's expression was sour .

'No, that's wrong . '

'What?'

'Doctor Sakakibara probably never met with Nanase Miyuki . '

'If not Nanase Miyuki, then who?'

Gotou couldn't hide his confusion .

Haruka felt the same way . From the flow of the conversation, it should have been Nanase Miyuki's plot .

Haruka turned her eyes to Yakumo for an answer .

After a silence, Yakumo slowly moved to stand in front of Sakakibara .

'A man with two red eyes – am I correct, Doctor Sakakibara?'

Yakumo looked at Sakakibara with his red left eye .

He showed no open anger or hatred . Just a straight gaze –

Sakakibara made no response .

The tip of the scalpel he was pointing at Mao just trembled slightly .

'Please stop it already,' pleaded Mao, walking forward .

'Shut up!' yelled Sakakibara, making a slicing motion with the scalpel .

'Aah!' screamed Mao . She crouched while clutching her right arm .

Blood dripped down –

'You bastard!'

While Gotou yelled, he couldn't move .

The tip of the scalpel was still pointed at Mao . Furthermore, Sakakibara still had his hand on the machine Isshin needed for life support .

If Gotou made a move, both their lives would be in danger .

All Haruka could do was ball her sweaty hands into fists .

It was a perfect deadlock .

'Doctor Sakakibara, please let me ask one thing . '

The one who broke the silence was Yakumo .

Sakakibara looked at Yakumo with a expression twisted in pain .

'Do you think feel sorrowful about your daughter's likely death? Or are you sad to think about your daughter disappearing from in front of you?'

As Yakumo spoke, he slowly approached Yoshiko's bed and glanced at Gotou .

For that one moment, it looked to Haruka like the two were talking with their eyes .

It was some sort of sign .

Then, Yakumo put his hand close to Yoshiko, as if to touch her .

'Don't touch her!'

Sakakibara swung the tip of the scalpel to point it at Yakumo .

Gotou took that chance to move .

He charged wildly, elbowing Sakakibara's back with all his strength .

Sakakibara's body curled like a shrimp's . He fell to the floor on his knees .

Then, Gotou kicked Sakakibara's face .

Sakakibara's eyes rolled up as he collapsed backwards, and the scalpel fell from his hands .

Gotou briskly turned Sakakibara around, pulled his hands behind his back and cuffed him .

It all happened in a blink . All Haruka could do was stand there in shock .

'You move agilely for a bear,' said Yakumo, poking fun .

'Shut up!'

Gotou yelled back, but his face looked happy somehow .

– This is the end .

Haruka sighed in relief, but then, something squirmed into her vision from behind Yakumo's back .

Yakumo appeared to notice it too and turned around .

There was a girl in a red dress .

Her face was shadowed, completely black .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . That...'

Just as Haruka said that, the girl turned around and started running towards the corridor .

Yakumo silently left the surgery room to follow the girl .

Haruka ran out into the corridor too, as if pulled along .

However, the girl had disappeared . She looked at Yakumo beside her .

'That's Yoshiko-chan,' murmured Yakumo .

'Eh? But she's...'

– Alive .

The girl earlier had to have been a ghost . Plus, Yoshiko was still lying in bed .

'A living ghost[1] . '

'Living ghost?'

She'd heard the term before .

But if asked what it was exactly – Haruka wouldn't know .

'When a living person has an especially strong feeling, their spirit can leave them . '

'Like an out-of-body experience?'

'Something like that . In her case, it might have been easy for her spirit to leave her body in the first place . '

'Then the ghost that's been spotted in the hospital...'

'Was Yoshiko-chan . '

When Yakumo said that, Haruka understood .

Yoshiko's strong feeling was the desire for an organ .

She would be saved if she received a heart transplant from somebody in a brain-dead state . Yoshiko's living ghost knew that, so she asked the patients of the hospital when they were going to die .

She was frantic in her attempts to live, but –

'Yakumo-kun, when did you realise it was Yoshiko-chan?'

'I talked to her in front of the ICU, remember?'

'Ah!'

Haruka recalled Yakumo speaking with the ghost in the hallway .

Yakumo had probably seen through the case's trick then .

'Stay here,' said Yakumo . Then, he started slowly walking down the dim hallway .

Haruka's eyes couldn't see Yoshiko's living ghost any longer, but it was probably not the case for Yakumo .

Haruka swallowed and watched Yakumo's back .

Suddenly –

Somebody jumped out from behind a pillar to block Yakumo's way .

A long-haired woman with a cold smile on her lips –

It was Nanase Miyuki .

Haruka couldn't even shout in her surprise .

Miyuki had a knife which let off a suspicious light in her hand .

'Yakumo! Get away from that woman!'

Gotou's yell echoed through the hallway .

16

After detaining Sakakibara, Gotou noticed that Yakumo had disappeared from the surgery room .

No, not just Yakumo . Haruka was gone too .

– Where'd they go?

Gotou went into the corridor to look for them .

Then, he saw something unbelievable .

Yakumo stood down the corridor with his back to Gotou . In front of him stood Nanase Miyuki .

'Yakumo! Get away from that woman!' shouted Gotou .

Yakumo turned around for just a moment in response .

For some reason, it looked like he was smiling .

– Why's he smiling?

'Stay away!'

Yakumo stopped Gotou before he could run over .

Without thinking, Gotou stopped under that pressure .

'W-what the hell are you saying!?'

'Please stay away . I'm going to do what my uncle couldn't . '

'What?'

'I'm going to cut off the chain of hatred . '

Yakumo's back seemed unspeakably tragic .

– He plans on dying .

Gotou could feel it in his skin .

'You want to kill me, right? Do it . '

Yakumo turned to Miyuki again, spreading his arms wide .

'Your determination is admirable . '

Miyuki licked her lips .

– He's kidding, right? As if I could watch this silently .

'Don't take another step towards Yakumo!' yelled Gotou as he started running .

Miyuki waved the knife, as if scorning Gotou .

– Make it in time!

With just one step left, Gotou's feet tangled and he fell forward .

'Nooo!'

Haruka's scream echoed through the corridor .

Gotou stood right up, but the knife was coming down heartlessly towards Yakumo's chest .

Everything seemed to be in slow motion .

'Yakumo!'

Gotou reached out as he shouted .

However, his hand didn't reach its goal .

For a moment, his vision went white .

Yakumo fell backward, clutching his chest –

'You idiot!

– Why!? Yakumo! Why!?

Gotou grabbed Yakumo and shook him .

However, Yakumo's eyes were closed . He made no response .

'You son of a bitch! This is exactly the same!'

He hadn't been able to save Takagishi or Isshin . This time, even Yakumo had fallen in front of his eyes .

– I won't let anybody die . I won't let anybody get killed .

He'd said that in such a high and mighty manner, but in the end, he hadn't been able to save anybody .

Frustration and anger welled up within him, threatening to explode .

'Yakumo-kun . Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka had come up too and was calling out to Yakumo frantically .

However, Yakumo was as still as a doll .

'I said it, didn't I? That I'd kill Yakumo next . '

Miyuki covered her mouth as she laughed, shoulders shaking .

– What's so funny? This bitch!

'I won't forgive you!'

Gotou stood up in his anger .

His body was so hot it felt like it would burst into flames .

'It's too bad for you . '

Miyuki smiled triumphantly as she waved about her knife .

'You bastard! You did this to...'

At first, Gotou had just thought Yakumo was a hateful brat .

But still, he couldn't abandon Yakumo, who continued to do his best to live even while shouldering that sadness by himself .

Normally, they just said spiteful things at each other, but after several cases, Yakumo had become somebody irreplaceable to him before he'd noticed .

'I'll kill you . '

For the first time in Gotou's life, he wanted to kill somebody .

He really thought he would kill Miyuki .

Gotou gripped his hands into fists and charged right at Miyuki .

However, Miyuki evaded him, as if she were a matador .

Gotou's body collapsed to the floor .

Miyuki took this chance to pick up the fire extinguisher by the pillar and threw it at Gotou's face .

Thunk!

It made a dull sound . Blood dripped down his forehead .

'You bastard...'

Gotou glared at Miyuki through the pain .

'My, you're unexpectedly sturdy,' said Miyuki as she looked down at Gotou . Then, she ran off while giggling .

– I won't let you get away!

Gotou got up and ran after Miyuki .

17

Ishii sat in the passenger seat of the car Makoto was driving .

Though he had been the one to call out to her, when he sat in a car alone with a woman like this, he was strangely nervous .

'Thank you so much, Makoto-san,' said Ishii, wiping the sweat from his forehead .

'It's nearby . '

'Eh?'

'My house . '

'But Makoto-san, don't you...'

Ishii had gone to Makoto's house before .

He recalled her living with her parents in a house on the corner of a quiet residential street .

'I'm living alone now . '

Makoto shrugged with a smile .

Ishii understood when he saw that expression and recalled that case .

Makoto's father had been the chief of the police, but he had lost his position because of that case . Makoto had been the one who wrote the article that prosecuted him then .

It was easy to imagine that would have put a rift in their father-daughter relationship .

'Ishii-san, is it true that Nanase Miyuki has gone missing?' asked Makoto to clear the heavy atmosphere .

'Did the information slip out?'

'Yes . There was a big commotion . '

'I see...'

A prisoner had escaped from the detention house . It was natural that there was a big commotion .

'Was the commotion earlier related to Nanase Miyuki as well?'

'Yes . '

'As I thought...'

Makoto's expression clouded over .

Now that Ishii thought about it, Makoto had experienced something terrible during the last case because of Nanase Miyuki .

'Detective Gotou is probably chasing Nanase Miyuki now . '

'You're heading there too then, Ishii-san . '

To be honest, he didn't want to go .

However, if he hesitated because of fear, he would lose something important like last time .

No matter how scared I am, there are some things I must do – Ishii had realised that .

That said, no matter how he tried to encourage himself, his terror didn't leave him .

After a while, the car arrived at the hospital .

– Detective Gotou . Please wait .

Ishii hit his cheeks with both hands and got off the car .

'Ishii-san . '

Just as Ishii was about to walk away, Makoto called out to stop him .

'W-what?'

'Please run . '

'Yes?'

Makoto said that with a somewhat frightened expression .

– Why is she saying that?

Ishii didn't understand what Makoto meant, but there was incredibly pressure in her words .

'If it's dangerous, please run . '

'Why?'

'I want you to be safe . So please...'

There seemed to be tears in Makoto's eyes .

'I will . '

After replying, Ishii reluctantly ran off, though he was still confused .

He tried to enter from the front automatic doors, but they appeared to be closed at this time, so his head rammed right into them .

He turned to the night entrance while clutching his head and went into the waiting room .

The dim space was empty –

All he could rely on was the green emergency lights .

– I'm scared .

Ishii quickly started to regret coming .

Even though he'd said the hospital, it would be difficult searching such a large building .

Ishii looked around cautiously and chose to go further in .

Thump, thump, thump .

He heard somebody running towards him .

Ishii looked down the corridor, where the sound was coming from .

Then, a woman flew towards him .

'Aaah!' shrieked Ishii in surprise .

The person he wanted to meet least was right in front of his eyes . Nanase Miyuki .

Miyuki panted as she glared at Ishii .

'Ishii-san, could you move out of my way?' Miyuki said slowly .

Gripped by that cold gaze, Ishii couldn't even move his fingers .

'Ishii! Don't let that woman get away!'

Gotou's yell echoed through the waiting room .

With that, Ishii came back to his senses .

Right . Right . He couldn't let Miyuki get away .

Miyuki turned around to see Gotou running after her and then waved the knife in her hand .

'There's no time then,' she said quietly . She swung the knife down .

– Oh no . I'm going to be stabbed .

Ishii promptly crouched and thrust his head towards Miyuki .

With that force, he rolled a number of times, and before he'd noticed, he was lying face up .

– Was I stabbed?

Ishii sprung up and checked his body, but there was no blood or pain .

– Good . I'm alive .

He sighed in relief .

'Ishii, well done . '

Ishii turned to look at the source of the voice .

Gotou was straddling Miyuki, who was lying face up .

Ishii didn't know what happened, but they'd caught Miyuki . Ishii refrained from sitting down in relief .

'You bitch! I'm definitely not going to forgive you!'

Still on top of Miyuki, Gotou gripped her by the collar .

She simply smiled confidently regardless .

How could she be so confident when she was trapped?

'Could you let go of her?'

Ishii heard a voice close to his ear .

A low voice, like a tremor –

Ishii tried to turn around, but he couldn't .

Somebody had reached out from behind Ishii and was holding a knife to his neck . There wasn't even a millimetre between his skin and the knife .

If he moved even slightly, his pulmonary artery would be cut .

A cold sweat ran down his back . His throat dried up .

– Who on earth is it?

18

'Damn it!'

Gotou bit his lip .

Right in front of him, there was a knife at Ishii's neck . Gotou recognised the man .

He wore sunglasses and a black suit, and his long hair went down his back . His face was as pale as a dead man's, but his lips alone were strangely red .

An unearthly black energy emanated from his whole body .

Yakumo's father, the man with two red eyes –

He had been involved in several cases up until now . The man never directly interfered, instead manipulating people's hearts and leading them to murder .

'Let me say that again . Could you let go of her?'

The man took his sunglasses off with his left hand .

His two eyes were a deep red .

They were clearly different from Yakumo's . They seemed to let out an ominous light .

The man that Gotou had not been able to catch no matter how he tried was right in front of his eyes, but in this situation, he couldn't even move .

The man with two red eyes would not hesitate . It wasn't a threat . If Gotou moved, he would definitely slit Ishii's throat .

Miyuki started laughing, still lying face up .

'Gotou-san, it's too bad . '

'You...'

'I'm sorry, but could you let go?' said Miyuki triumphantly .

Gotou had never felt more humiliated .

This woman hadn't just involved Isshin in the case – she'd turned that knife towards Yakumo as well . It wouldn't be enough if he beat her to death right here, right now .

But –

'Detective Gotou, you can't!'

When Gotou was about to let go of Miyuki, Ishii yelled .

His eyes were so wide that they could've fallen out, and his head was covered in sweat . Still, he was frantic .

Ishii must have been afraid to die too, but he was battling while knowing that .

'Ishii...'

'If you let go of her, the same thing will happen again, so please...' pleaded Ishii, his face covered in tears .

Gotou had thought Ishii was just a good-for-nothing, but at some point, he'd become competent . Gotou thought it was a good thing . He came to his decision .

It wasn't like his frustration and anger was gone, but –

There was no replacing Ishii's life .

– I won't let anybody die . I won't let anybody get killed .

That was Gotou's belief . He knew this was a trap, but he couldn't have Ishii follow Yakumo in losing his life .

Gotou let go of Miyuki and slowly stood up .

'You aren't honest at all,' said Miyuki mockingly as she stood up .

Then, she turned her back to Gotou and walked away .

'You can't let that woman go . '

Gotou heard a voice . Yakumo's voice –

Gotou thought that his ears were playing tricks on him, but he was wrong .
Yakumo appeared from the dark corridor .

– Did he die and become a ghost?

So he thought, but it seemed he was wrong .

Yakumo stood there as a person firmly living in reality .

Haruka was next to him .

'Yakumo... Why?'

'That isn't important . More importantly, hurry!'

Urged on by Yakumo, Gotou turned away his gaze and saw Miyuki reaching for the knife on the ground .

– As if I'd let you do that .

Gotou instinctively twisted Miyuki's arm and stopped her from moving .

The knife fell to the ground again .

Miyuki glared at Gotou while gripping her shoulder .

'Do you plan to watch this young man die?' said the man with red eyes coldly .

Ishii bit his lip and shook his head .

Though Gotou had immediately caught Miyuki at Yakumo's instruction, nothing had changed .

They were at a stalemate for what to do . It hurt to admit it, but if he didn't let go of Miyuki, Ishii would die . this wasn't a guy you could negotiate with .

'I can't abandon Ishii...'

Gotou tried to let go of Miyuki .

'Gotou-san, it's fine . For that man, it is impossible to kill Ishii-san,'
Yakumo said firmly .

What do you mean, impossible – the man with red eyes wouldn't hesitate to take somebody's life .

'If you don't hurry, Ishii-san really will die . '

Miyuki's shoulders shook as she laughed .

'Detective Gotou... Forget about me! Please...'

Though Ishii shouted bravely, it felt like he wouldn't be able to stand much longer from fear .

– I can't leave Ishii like this .

'I understand . I'll let go of this woman, so you let go of Ishii . '

Gotou glared at the man with red eyes .

The man with red eyes nodded with a smile .

'Gotou-san, don't let them trick you!'

Yakumo held Gotou with his sharp gaze .

Gotou could understand how Yakumo felt after Isshin was stabbed . He wanted to catch Miyuki and the man with red eyes no matter what . But Gotou couldn't let Ishii die .

'I'll save Ishii,' said Gotou, determined .

'If you won't accept it even after I tell you, let me prove it now . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair in exasperation and then looked at the man with red eyes .

Then, he walked right towards him .

'If you walk any closer, he dies,' said the man with red eyes .

However, Yakumo didn't stop walking .

'Yakumo! Back off!' yelled Gotou, but Yakumo ignored him .

He stood right in front of the two of them .

Gotou had thought that the man with red eyes would slit Ishii's throat immediately if they didn't agree to his demands, but he was wrong .

He looked back at Yakumo without budging .

'Now . You're going to kill Ishii-san, right? Do it if you can . '

Yakumo's sharp voice echoed through the waiting room .

– This is strange . What's going on?

Even though Yakumo was being so challenging, the man with red eyes was silent .

Miyuki was grinding her teeth in frustration .

– What the hell's going on?

'Is it truly all right if I kill him?' asked the man after a silence .

However, his words didn't have the pressure they had had before .

Ishii swallowed loudly .

'Please go ahead . That is, if you can –

A smile graced Yakumo's lips .

All Gotou could do was watch .

'Yakumo, it's just as you say . I cannot kill him . I will withdraw for today .
,

After saying that quietly, the man with red eyes disappeared into the darkness before Gotou's eyes –

Yakumo let out a long breath .

Haruka looked shocked . She had her hands on her mouth .

Ishii fell over right there, released from the tension .

'Oi! Yakumo! What the hell was that just now!?'

Gotou came back to his senses and yelled .

The guy hadn't just escaped . Gotou didn't know what method he'd used, but that man had suddenly disappeared in front of his eyes .

'You don't understand? That man is already dead,' Yakumo said quietly, his eyes narrowed .

'Dead?'

– I don't understand .

'Correct . That man is dead . That was why he couldn't kill Ishii-san . '

Yakumo put his left index finger to his brow .

'You saying that guy was a ghost?'

'Exactly . He is a ghost . That was why the plan this time was possible,' said Yakumo, eyes narrowed .

'What do you mean!?'

Gotou's voice was ragged .

His head felt like it would burst from confusion .

– That man's a ghost? As if I'd accept such a stupid story!

And Yakumo said that the plan this time was possible because the man was a ghost . What did he mean?

'The method of passing along the fingerprints . The meeting about the day of the crime . In order to execute the plan, it was essential that they had her cooperation from inside the detention house . '

Yakumo turned the finger at his brow towards Miyuki .

It was true that there was still that question .

Yamamura had got the medicine for Miyuki, but he'd denied stabbing Isshin . That probably wasn't a lie .

Then who had gone between Miyuki in the detention house and Sakakibara?

'You're not saying that that man was their go-between, are you?'

'That is exactly what I'm saying . '

Yakumo concurred with the words Gotou had said in his confusion .

Even if that man had been the go-between –

'How... You can't just go in and out of the detention house!'

Yakumo snorted .

'Gotou-san . Please listen to what I say properly . That man is a ghost . The security is irrelevant . '

It was just as Yakumo said .

If that man was a ghost, it didn't matter how strict the security at the detention house was .

But Gotou still couldn't accept it .

'That man's appeared in front of us a number of times before!'

In his confusion, his tongue wasn't working properly .

'Gotou-san, that's incorrect . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair, looking annoyed .

'Even if you say he's appeared in front of you, you've only seen him, correct? Furthermore, he has never appeared in front of me clearly before this,' declared Yakumo .

— That's true .

Gotou felt like an electric jolt had gone through his body .

He'd heard about the man before . He'd seen him in photos and even spotted him, but he'd never actually touched him once .

He suddenly appeared, leaving no trace as he disappeared like smoke . Just like a ghost .

'It isn't just this case . That man has manipulated people's emotions and led them towards crime . '

'Right...'

'That isn't because he dared to do so, but because that was all he could do . '

With that one sentence, something that had always been a mystery made sense .

Gotou only ever saw the man with red eyes . Miyuki had always been the one who took action .

But –

'Why did he hide himself?'

'It's simple . If he appeared in front of me, it would become clear that he was dead . '

– That's right . Yakumo's red left eye can see the spirits of the dead .

If he showed up in front of Yakumo, that would mean revealing his true identity . During the last case, he'd showed up in front of Yakumo, but that was because he knew that Yakumo was psychologically exhausted from imprisonment and torture .

That was why he only showed off without directly doing anything .

– Everything linked .

'If that man is a ghost, then how about you? Your mother...'

Gotou hurriedly swallowed the words he was about to say .

This topic was taboo, but that didn't mean he didn't have that question . Yakumo's mother was imprisoned and violated by that man .

And then Yakumo was born –

Was it possible for a ghost to make a living human pregnant?

'That man was still alive when the incident with my mother occurred . I won't be certain until further investigation, but that man probably died two or three years ago,' said Yakumo with confidence .

'How can you be sure?'

'That man appeared in front of me again, though he had disappeared even since the incident with Takagishi-sensei . '

That one sentence brought up memories in Gotou's head .

Yakumo was right . After that case, he'd completely forgotten about that man, but about a year and a half ago, he'd started hearing rumours about him again .

If he's still loitering around Yakumo after his death –

'What's that man's goal?'

When Gotou asked that, Miyuki's shoulders started to shake as she laughed .

'Gotou-san, you really are slow . Yakumo-kun's realised the reason . '

– Really?

He looked at Yakumo .

'That man wants my body . '

Yakumo said something awful in a calm tone .

'Body... you say...'

Even as Gotou said it, he felt a chill run down his spine .

During the last case and inside the detention house, Miyuki had said the same thing . 'I can't kill Yakumo-kun . '

'Yes . That man lost his own body, so he wants the living body of the only person who has inherited his left eye...'

'You mean taking over your body?'

– What a guy .

'It's a bit difference . '

The one who spoke was Miyuki .

Gotou gripped Miyuki by the collar and pushed her with all her strength against the wall .

There was a dull thump .

'What do you mean?'

'Honestly . Don't be so violent . '

Miyuki smiled as she said that .

'Something similar happened before, didn't it? A dead person's spirit cannot fully take over a living person's body . '

Yakumo spoke instead of Miyuki .

Gotou remembered that case . The case when Makoto was possessed by a ghost –

Yakumo had said the same thing then . If there were two spirits in one body, they would reject each other .

'Then what's he planning?'

There was no point doing something he knew he couldn't .

'He's tuning him . '

Miyuki looked at Yakumo like he was prey .

'Tuning?'

'Yes . By making me despair and putting me in a similar psychological state, he is trying to attune me to him . '

Yakumo's expression twisted as he spoke .

If they had the same psychological state, he'd be able to use his body without any resistance –

The bottom of his stomach was hot . Gotou felt his anger flare up like a fire .

That man needed to push Yakumo to the very bottom of despair in order to fulfil his wish of using him as a vessel for his own soul .

That was why he played with Sakakibara's feelings for his daughter and made him stab Isshin .

In this plan, in order to draw Yakumo towards him, he'd attacked Isshin, who had been Yakumo's support, which also made Yakumo taste despair .

– Are you kidding me!?

Even though parents were supposed to protect their children even if it meant their own deaths, he was forcing his own wish on his son –

'What kind of bastard is he!?' spat out Gotou .

Yakumo glared at Miyuki with sharp eyes .

'The two of you let your guard down . '

'What did you say?'

Miyuki's confident expression suddenly changed .

'That man thought that I would easily succumb to despair after losing my uncle and carelessly revealed himself . '

It appeared that Yakumo had met with the man with red eyes without Gotou knowing .

However, that had made Yakumo realise what he was .

'Yakumo-kun, what are you going to do with me? I don't mind if you kill me . '

Miyuki provoked Yakumo as she looked up at him .

'I...'

'If you don't, somebody important to you will die again . '

After declaring that, Miyuki started laughing scornfully .

– There's no saving this woman .

If Yakumo took the knife in his hand and tried to stab her, Gotou wasn't confident that he would stop him .

If he thought about the anger and sadness that Yakumo had experienced, Gotou couldn't think about stopping him .

If Miyuki lived, there would be more victims .

Yakumo slowly walked towards Miyuki .

His expression was as blank as a doll's .

'This is the end of the farce,' Yakumo said quietly, face still blank .

'What are you? Don't you hate me?'

Miyuki looked terribly confused .

She probably couldn't accept how Yakumo was acting with her perspective .

'Gotou-san, please take this woman away immediately . '

Yakumo said just that and turned around .

'Don't act so strong! You want to kill me, right? Just do it!'

Miyuki screamed at Yakumo's back .

However, Yakumo didn't turn around . Together with Haruka, he walked away .

Miyuki had planned on pushing Yakumo to the limits of despair with this case – but what Yakumo had seen there was not anything as small as hatred or anger .

Miyuki had underestimated Yakumo . In a way, Gotou had too –

'Too bad . Didn't go as you planned . '

As Gotou said that, he knocked his head into Miyuki's nose .

Miyuki fell to the ground clutching her nose .

'Yakumo's much stronger than you thought!'

19

Ishii was frozen as he sat on the floor .

It felt like his core had been taken out of him .

Other officers had arrived on the scene and taken Miyuki away from Gotou . All Ishii could do was watch .

– I'm saved .

He felt honestly relieved .

'You OK?'

Gotou slowly walked towards Ishii .

'Ah, yes . Somehow...'

Ishii hurriedly stood up .

– I couldn't do anything useful this time either .

That thought suddenly filled Ishii's head .

Though he was glad that the man with two red eyes had been a ghost, if not, they might have lost Nanase Miyuki .

When Ishii thought about that, he felt incredibly sorry .

'I-I apologise . '

Ishii bowed at the waist towards Gotou .

Then, something hit his head . Gotou's fist had come down .

It made sense for Gotou to be angry .

'Because of me...'

Ishii raised his head which stung from pain .

Just as he expected, Gotou looked frightful .

'You fool . '

'I am truly sorry . Because of my negligence...'

'That isn't it!'

Gotou gave Ishii's chest a push .

Ishii stumbled backwards, unable to brace himself when it was so sudden .
However, Gotou quickly closed that distance .

'Eek . '

Ishii unconsciously let out a squeak under Gotou's pressure .

'Got this? Don't ever waste your life again . '

'Eh?'

Ishii cocked his head at Gotou's unexpected words .

'I'm saying that I'd rather let Nanase Miyuki go than let you die!'

Gotou's yell shook Ishii's heart and body .

It was like he'd been hit by lightning .

– Detective Gotou! You can't!

Ishii had yelled that when the man with red eyes held a knife to his neck .
Those words had surprised Ishii more than anyone else .

In the past, he would have definitely wanted to be saved .

However, at that moment, those words had undoubtedly been his true feelings .

'I was just trying...'

'I'd be troubled if you died,' Gotou said awkwardly, looking away from Ishii .

Ishii hadn't thought that Gotou felt that way about him . For the first time
Ishii's left, he felt like somebody had acknowledged his existence .

'Don't cry . It makes me feel sick . '

When Gotou said that, Ishii realised that he was crying .

'I-I apologise . '

'Don't apologise . Fool . '

Gotou hit Ishii's head with his fist again before walking away briskly .

The pain in his head felt different from usual .

– No matter what happens, I'll follow this person .

As Ishii watched Gotou's back, he came to that decision again .

'Ishii-san . '

Ishii saw Makoto running at him .

'Makoto-san...'

Makoto was panting when she reached Ishii . She raised her head and smiled .

Normally, she looked very mature, but she looked like an innocent child now .

'I'm so glad you're OK . '

Makoto put a hand to her chest .

'Yes . Somehow...'

'I'm really glad . '

Ishii felt embarrassed and replied with a wry smile, but then he realised that he wasn't nervous even though Makoto was in front of him .

20

Haruka sat on the bench in the hospital's waiting room .

There were a number of police cars parked outside . Their red lights were blinking .

Though it had been dim earlier, the lights were on now and officers were running about . Everything felt disorganised .

Yakumo was just idly watching from beside her .

– You can kill me .

Did Yakumo want to kill Miyuki when she said that – Haruka wanted to ask, but she didn't dare .

In the end, Yakumo didn't kill Miyuki . That was enough .

'Oi, Yakumo! I forgot something important!'

Gotou shouted as he approached them .

'You're noisy, as usual . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair, seeming extremely annoyed .

'You were stabbed by that woman . '

'Ah, that's what you're talking about...'

'What do you mean, that's what you're talking about? How can you be OK?'

'Do you know what a stab-proof vest is?'

As Yakumo said that, he stood up and undid the buttons of his shirt, showing what was inside .

It was what Haruka had received from Hata to give to Yakumo .

At first, she hadn't known what it was, but Yakumo had explained while they came to the hospital .

It was called a stab-proof vest, and per its name, it was an article of clothing that protected its wearers from stab attacks .

Made of nylon, if something was worn on top of it, it couldn't be told apart from a regular piece of clothing .

Yakumo had known that Nanase Miyuki would come to stab him .
Furthermore, she would do it in a way that wouldn't kill him –

There was a reason she couldn't kill Yakumo .

'Where'd you get that?' said Gotou, eyes wide as saucers .

'I borrowed it from Hata-san,' replied Yakumo matter-of-factly .

'Borrowed, you say... Then you should've told me in the first place!'

'You didn't ask me, did you?'

Yakumo lightly let Gotou's anger pass .

It finally felt like things were back to normal . Haruka ended up laughing too .

Then, Gotou's sharp gaze turned to her .

'Did you know, Haruka-chan?'

'Ah, yes . I was the one who went to borrow it from Hata-san . '

'Then what was the scream?'

It hurt to have him point it out .

'Even if I did know, I was surprised...'

Feeling apologetic, Haruka bowed her head and said, 'Sorry . '

The way Yakumo collapsed had been so realistic that she had been upset even though she knew it was an act .

'You two really are the worst couple,' said Gotou, sounding disappointed .
He sat himself next to Yakumo .

Then, he mumbled, 'Well, long as you're all right . '

Gotou also was the type who couldn't be honest .

No matter how they quarrelled, the two of them had a relationship of trust .

'But that man was a ghost, eh...' grumbled Gotou, an unlit cigarette in his mouth .

'That's right,' agreed Haruka, recalling the time she had met the man with red eyes at the mountain cottage in Nagano .

At the time, the man had kept threatening Haruka, thrusting a knife at her .

However, he had disappeared without doing anything in the end .

Now that she thought about it, it was incredibly unnatural .

'Well, the mystery's solved, so that wraps one thing up . There's no point chasing that man any longer,' said Gotou emotionally .

Yakumo looked at Gotou grimly .

'What are you saying? Nothing has changed . '

'What do you mean?' Gotou cocked his head .

'Remember that man's modus operandi . He never does anything directly .
He leads the darkness in people's hearts to commit crime . '

'So he's going to keep doing the same thing...'

Gotou stood up .

'Correct . As long as there is darkness in people's hearts, that man will continue to commit crime, while we cannot arrest him or kill him...'

Yakumo's voice rang darker than Haruka had ever heard it do before .

There was a dilemma . Yakumo had the unique ability to see the spirits of the dead, but all he could do was see them – he couldn't exorcise spirits .

In short, he couldn't stop the man with red eyes, who was a ghost .

– The same thing will keep on happening .

When Haruka thought that, it made her shiver .

'What do you plan to do?' asked Gotou as he bit the cigarette filter .

'Unfortunately, I'm out of options right now,' Yakumo replied listlessly .
Then, he suddenly stood up, as if he had seen something .

– What did he see?

Haruka stood up and looked in the same direction .

At the end of the corridor, she saw a man slowly walking towards them . It was Sakakibara .

He was handcuffed and was surrounded by police .

Because of the commotion earlier, his face was swollen and there was blood above his eye and below his nose .

This person had fallen to hell to save his daughter . Strong feelings for somebody could turn good or bad .

When Haruka thought about that, it was too much for her .

Yakumo silently walked up to Sakakibara .

Haruka thought about following him, but the sparks between their eyes had so much pressure that her feet couldn't move .

The police officers by Sakakibara tried to move Yakumo away .

'Oi, Wait . Let him talk . '

Gotou stopped them .

Yakumo had always been a bystander in the cases he had been involved with before .

But this time, it was different .

With the victim being a relative, he had been put in the most painful position .

After the incident, Yakumo hadn't put his feelings into words, but he had felt a deep sadness and a boiling anger .

And then he had disappeared for a day –

Yakumo had decided something then . That was why he still had his red left eye out in the open, with no contact lens .

'Because of you... My daughter – my daughter... Why did you get in my way!?'

Sakakibara yelled from the bottom of his stomach .

The police held onto him to stop his shaking .

His eyes were bloodshot . No, not just his eyes . His whole body was red, the embodiment of fiery anger .

Yakumo didn't appear disturbed at all by Sakakibara .

He just looked at Sakakibara's face emotionlessly .

'Because of you, my uncle is in the state that he is . '

'I love my daughter . '

'You aren't the only one who has somebody he loves . My uncle is as important to me as your daughter is to you . '

Yakumo seemed to be testing each word .

'My daughter is my only treasure . I can't lose her . '

Sakakibara didn't back down, gritting his teeth .

The last resistance of a captured carnivore –

'Do you still not understand? My uncle has a daughter . Just one daughter . She is only seven, and she is deaf . Can you still say the same thing? That it's fine as long as you can save your daughter...'

Yakumo paused . He took in a deep breath and continued .

'Every person has somebody they love . '

Sakakibara's chin was shaking .

He must have realised what he had done – but he was still trying to justify himself .

People were terribly prideful creatures .

'Shut up! Shut up! That man had a brain tumour! He would've died anyway! What's wrong with making his life useful!?'

Sakakibara's words sounded like the screams of a dying man .

'That doesn't make it acceptable to take a life!'

Yakumo's shout stopped time .

That one sentence had been filled with many feelings . The strong beliefs that had piled up from everything that Yakumo had experienced up until now –

His words after having his one and only parent taking away from him –

They were heavier than anything someone else could say .

Sakakibara's face went pale as his mouth flapped like that of a fish asking for bait .

He might have been looking for words to object with .

However, no words could argue with Yakumo now .

'I can kill you . It would be easy to throw your daughter aside . '

'Agh...'

Sakakibara groaned and shut his eyes tightly .

He doesn't want to accept his daughter's death –

After a silence, Yakumo took another deep breath .

'Please open your eyes . '

Sakakibara did as Yakumo told him and opened his eyes .

Yakumo did not glare at him . He just looked straight at Sakakibara's eyes .

'I have no intention of continuing this chain of hatred . '

This was the conclusion Yakumo had chosen –

Yakumo had stayed with his beliefs even after losing Isshin .

He was incredibly awkward . It hurt to watch him . But that was why he was Yakumo .

'I give my consent for the transplant,' said Yakumo in a whisper .

Sakakibara's body shook . He held his handcuffed hands out towards Yakumo .

He looked like a figure from a religious painting . A peasant begging for mercy from their god .

'... Will you save her? My daughter...'

'That is what my uncle would want . '

When Yakumo said that, tears started falling from Sakakibara's eyes .

His tears, dyed red with blood, fell one by one to the floor .

'However, please do not forget . A life was lost in order to save your daughter . That death brought about the same anger and sadness that you were feeling just earlier... You must not forget...'

'Ur... gh... I...'

Something fell from Sakakibara's shoulder .

His body shook as he fell to his knees .

Yakumo walked up to him and said this close to his ear .

'It has nothing to do with your daughter . This is a burden for you to bear alone . '

When Yakumo said that, Sakakibara collapsed to the floor and started sobbing like a child .

His cries echoed through the hospital .

Yakumo turned his back to Sakakibara .

'Let's go back . '

Haruka nodded silently and left the hospital with Yakumo .

The night wind was cold .

'The goal of all life is death . '

Looking up at the sky full of stars, Yakumo said just that .

NOTES:

[1] The specific term used is ikiryou (生霊) which has the kanji for life and spirit so I translated it directly, but there is more about it on WIKI if you're curious .

Volume 6 Chapter 4: Epilogue.

VOLUME 6 – TO THE LIMITS OF DESPAIR (2) epilogue ()

Haruka looked outside from the bench in the hospital waiting room.

The cherry blossoms in the courtyard were starting to bloom.

Spring was the season which breathed life, but right now, someone irreplaceable was disappearing before her eyes.

‘How long are you going to sit there for?’

Haruka turned around at the voice.

Yakumo looked at her with his eyes, which were sleepy as usual.

‘Is it done?’

‘Yeah. I just had to sign a document,’ Yakumo replied brusquely.

Isshin’s medical examination had determined that he was brain-dead.

Just as Yakumo had declared to Sakakibara, he gave his consent to transfer Isshin’s organs.

Haruka knew that nothing could be done now, but she still wanted to hear how Yakumo really felt.

‘Yakumo-kun, are you really OK with this?’

He didn’t reply immediately.

Yakumo's eyes were narrow as he looked at the cherry blossom tree in the courtyard.

Haruka couldn't tell how he truly felt from looking at his profile.

– You always hide your heart like this.

'... It's what Uncle would want,' Yakumo murmured.

'Right.'

That was all Haruka could say.

The truth was that she wanted to scream.

– It's a lie! Isshin-san is still alive!

However, Yakumo must have had the same feelings, and much more strongly at that.

'I think Uncle probably knew this was going to happen to him,' said Yakumo, his hands in his jeans pockets as he looked at his feet.

His words made sense.

The day Isshin was stabbed, Mao had told him he had a brain tumour.

He had been prepared.

– From now on, I'll leave Yakumo to you.

Isshin's words had had a heavy meaning to them, but Haruka hadn't realised then.

'Right...'

'When Uncle heard from Gotou-san that his life was in danger, he still went to do his daily meditation.'

'He did.'

'He was probably trying to cut off the continuing chain of hatred with his own hand.'

Yakumo's words echoed heavily in Haruka's heart.

Isshin had probably thought that the man with two red eyes, Yakumo's father, would come to kill him himself.

Then, he had tried to end things, in exchange for his own life.

That was how Isshin used his life.

Isshin had probably believed that even if he was gone, Yakumo wouldn't lose his way –

But the person who actually came to him was Sakakibara –

'Let's go. Uncle's waiting.'

Yakumo smiled bitterly.

– That's right. Isshin-san's waiting.

'OK,' replied Haruka, and then she started walking.

They walked silently to the ICU where Isshin was.

A nurse showed them inside.

Isshin looked so healthy on the bed that it made Haruka think he might wake up at any moment.

Even though he was using an artificial respirator, his chest was moving up and down slightly. When Haruka saw him breathing, she felt another bout of disbelief.

Haruka stood next to the bed and held Isshin's hand.

– It's still warm.

She couldn't believe that he would die in just a few hours.

– Are you really going to go, Isshin-san? Are you going to disappear without saying goodbye?

Haruka called out in her heart, even though she knew her words wouldn't reach him.

Yakumo looked down at Isshin silently.

What could he be seeing with his red left eye?

He must have been recalling the many memories he had had with Isshin.

Isshin had been closer to Yakumo than anybody, so they must have had countless memories together.

Tears welled up in Haruka's eyes just from thinking about it.

'... You're not here anymore then,' Yakumo said quietly.

– Not here anymore?

Haruka didn't understand what Yakumo meant.

All she could do was grip Isshin's hand again with both of her own to express feelings that wouldn't reach him.

Isshin had saved her countless times. He had given her courage. He had shown the path that everyone should take. He had been like a light in the dark.

I had so much I wanted to talk to him about –

People always had regrets.

– But please don't worry. I'll continue to watch over Yakumo.

So please rest well –

Haruka touched Isshin's cheek.

* * *

Gotou took Atsuko and Nao to the ICU just as Yakumo and Haruka were stepping out.

'Hey,' he said, raising his hand.

Haruka was sobbing and couldn't speak.

Yakumo was as expressionless as usual and just sent a glance Gotou's way.

This is nothing. It was like he was saying that.

Nao walked up to Yakumo.

Yakumo crouched and hugged Nao, patting her head.

Nao started sobbing into Yakumo's chest.

– This girl's been holding it in too. These siblings really tough it out.

However, no matter how much they tried to put up a brave front, both of them were still children.

Gotou looked at Atsuko's face.

Her lips were in a thin line. She nodded.

He understood even if she didn't say anything aloud.

When Atsuko looked like this, she was prepared. She had looked the same way when she decided to marry Gotou.

'Oi. Yakumo. There's something I want to talk with you alone.'

When Gotou called out to Yakumo, he replied with a silent nod, perhaps sensing Gotou's intention.

Gotou sat next to Yakumo on the bench in the hospital courtyard.

Come to think of it, this might've been the first time he'd talked to Yakumo about something that wasn't for a case. When he thought about it, he felt a bit awkward.

However, it seemed that Gotou was the only one who felt that way, because Yakumo let out a bored yawn.

'Hey, what happened to your contact lens?'

Ever since Isshin was stabbed, Yakumo hadn't worn the black contact lens that hid his red left eye.

At first, Gotou had thought he just didn't have a replacement for the one that broke, but it had been a number of days already.

'I don't need it anymore,' Yakumo said firmly.

Gotou was surprised, but then his expression softened.

Yakumo had detested that red left eye in the past. He had even tried to cut it out with a utility knife. For Yakumo to say he didn't need to hide it any more – it was incredible progress.

– Old man, you watching this?

Gotou looked up at the sky and called out.

'So what did you have to discuss?' said Yakumo, like he wanted Gotou to hurry up.

'Actually, I have a request,' Gotou said formally, an unlit cigarette in his mouth.

'I won't lend you money.'

Yakumo yawned.

– Really, what a hateful brat.

'Don't look down on the police.'

'Gotou-san, you're a part of the police?'

'What did you think I was?'

'A NEET[1].'

'You an idiot? I don't have the free time to talk to you about stupid things.'

'I feel the same way. Please get to the point already.'

Yakumo ran his fingers through his hair.

Gotou cleared his throat and tried to speak, but he didn't know how to start.

He knew Yakumo would complain, but Gotou couldn't stop himself. He lit his cigarette and let the nicotine flow through his body.

Yakumo looked displeased, but Gotou was able to relax a bit.

'My request is, er.... about Nao.'

After Gotou said that, Yakumo's brows furrowed as he cocked his head.

Even Yakumo, who was so intelligent, probably couldn't read into what Gotou was going to say next. It was a funny thought.

'I discussed with my wife. We want to take Nao into our home.'

'Did you hit your head?'

Yakumo looked at Gotou as if he were something filthy.

He probably couldn't understand why Gotou had made such a suggestion.

'I'm serious. I can't let that girl be picked up by some foster parents from who knows where.'

'Isn't that just your ego?' Yakumo said coldly.

Gotou understood that even without Yakumo's telling him.

'We still need Nao.'

Gotou took Nao in for this case and had planned on protecting her.

However, that wasn't what happened.

Nao had saved Gotou. By trying to protect Nao, Gotou could face his wife Atsuko for the first time.

— That's ego too.

But he still couldn't leave Nao alone.

Nao had suffered so much up until now.

Her actual mother had been killed, and now this had happened to Isshin, the person who'd raised her. He didn't want to let Nao feel sad again.

No matter what happened, no matter what he had to do, he was prepared to protect Nao.

'That isn't something for you to decide on your own, is it, Gotou-san?'

'I said I talked to my wife, didn't I? It's the first time we've agreed on something.'

'What do you gain out of this?'

'Are you an idiot? It's not a matter of profit or loss. We want to be her parents. That's all.'

Gotou was so forceful that the words sounded like a threat.

Yakumo had lived his life doubting people. He had protected his heart that way.

That was why he thought that every person acted for their own gains. But that wasn't everything in the world.

It seemed Gotou had put Yakumo in a bad mood, because he suddenly stood up.

'If you do that, wouldn't that make us family, Gotou-san?'

— This guy. Why'd he have to put it like that?

'I don't care what you think, but me and you were like family in the first place! What's the point of talking about that now!?' yelled Gotou angrily, standing up as well.

'I don't think you're fit to be a parent, Gotou-san.'

'Nobody's born a parent! They have children and become one!'

'Who'd you hear that from?'

Yakumo snorted.

— This brat! When I was being so nice about it!

Contrary to Gotou's agitated state, Yakumo had his usual sleepy eyes as he plucked the cigarette out of Gotou's mouth.

'I wouldn't mind thinking about it if you stop your bad smoking habit.'

— And he's complaining like a sister-in-law!

If it was for Nao, quitting smoking was nothing.

Gotou put the cigarette in the case and threw the whole thing into the rubbish bin.

* * *

Haruka was in the living room of the priests' quarters.

Isshin's funeral had ended and many people had gathered.

Gotou, Atsuko and Nao were sitting together, like a real family.

Opposite them, Ishii and Makoto sat respectfully.

Hata was by himself, sipping tea leisurely.

Next to Haruka was her mother, Keiko. When she heard about Isshin's death, she rushed over from Nagano.

It was only a blink of an eye since Yakumo consented to the organ transplant.

The heart Isshin donated was probably with Yoshiko now. According to the list Makoto got, her name had been at the top of the recipient list.

Haruka wanted to check, but there was no way to confirm it legally.

Isshin hadn't just donated his heart. Liver, kidneys, pancreas, corneas, lungs, small intestine – he had donated every organ he could.

After the surgery, Isshin's body had been empty – so light that a single person could pick it up.

Isshin was still living in other people's bodies – Haruka wanted to think that.

Reminiscing about him was gentle and warm, like his character. He had been like the spring summer.

Now that Haruka thought about it, she had always felt like there was something gloomy in Isshin's smile.

He had never lived for himself.

He had been incredibly self-sacrificing.

Haruka looked up and noticed that Yakumo alone wasn't participating in the reminiscing, just looking out the window.

His left eye flickered about, like it was looking for something.

Even after the funeral, Yakumo had not let anybody see him cry even once.

Even though he must have been sad, because of his obstinate nature, he kept that sadness within himself.

Finally, Yakumo stood up and went out of the room, as if to escape the gazes of everyone around him.

However, Yakumo was the only one who thought he wouldn't be noticed. When he left, everyone went quiet.

Haruka felt everyone's gazes turn to her.

– A silent pressure.

'Excuse me. Should I go check up on him?'

Ishii stood up.

'Are you an idiot!? Read the atmosphere!'

Shut down by Gotou, who had an artificial cigarette in his mouth, Ishii's shoulders slumped and he sat back down.

Makoto comforted him.

Hata started giggling like he thought the scene amusing.

On top of Atsuko's lap, Nao let out an 'Ah!' and then grabbed Haruka's shirt.

Everyone understands you better than you think they do. You need to understand that better.

Right –

'Haruka, if you don't go, I will.'

Keiko poked Haruka's arm.

'Why would you go, Mum?'

'If you're going to complain, go yourself.'

Keiko pushed Haruka's back.

– From now on, I'll leave Yakumo to you.

She might have just imagined it, but she felt like she had heard Isshin's voice.

Haruka stood up from her seat and left the room to find Yakumo.

Though she didn't see him, she had an inkling of where he went.

Haruka went out the entrance and walked through the gravel garden.

The cherry blossom tree on the grounds was in full bloom.

Haruka took off her shoes and went up the wooden stairs to the temple.

Careful not to make any noise, she opened the sliding door.

She spotted Yakumo sitting in the lotus position in the centre of the dim temple.

'... You're still here?' said Yakumo, looking up at the ceiling.

Haruka was about to respond but she realised immediately that the words weren't directed at her.

Though Haruka couldn't see anything, Yakumo probably saw Isshin's spirit.

Yakumo was talking with him.

'You worry too much, Uncle. I don't need to hide my red eye anymore.'

With this case, Yakumo had taken another step forward.

He didn't need to worry about other people's gazes and hide his left eye anymore.

'Nao and I are fine. We're not alone. We have a family. Even though we're not connected by blood...'

He was right. It was just as Yakumo said.

Without Isshin, Yakumo had lost the last person in his family that he was related to by blood.

However, he had people with whom he had bonds which were stronger and firmer than that.

They compensated for each other's shortcomings. Stubborn, selfish and straightforward people –

'That's why... you should go already,' said Yakumo.

– An awkward farewell.

Even though he really wanted to tell Isshin not to go, he acted brave until the very end.

– Are you going to continue to live while keeping everything to yourself?

Haruka just heard the sound of the wind.

While listening to it, she watched Yakumo's rounded shoulders.

'You really left...'

Yakumo said that to himself.

Haruka looked up at the ceiling.

However, all she saw was stained beams – she couldn't spot Isshin.

'Did Isshin-san say something?'

She had never been so envious of Yakumo before.

Of course Haruka and the others couldn't even say goodbye to Isshin at the end.

He had suddenly disappeared, like he'd never even been there in the first place –

However, Yakumo had been able to say what he had to at the end.

'He said he was happy... He was smiling,' Yakumo said quietly.

– I see.

Even though so many things had happened to him, Isshin was still worried about others at the very end and donated his own organs. Isshin still thought that his life had been happy.

– That's just like Isshin-san.

That at least made Haruka feel better.

'And he said... thank you...'

Yakumo's voice was hoarse. His shoulders were slumped and his back was shaking. He was still holding himself back.

– Really, how obstinate.

Haruka walked up to Yakumo and hugged him from behind with both arms.

'Yakumo-kun, you're not alone,' she murmured.

Yakumo's hands gripped Haruka's hands tightly.

– Don't take everything on by yourself. You're not alone.

Yakumo started weeping.

His body shook violently as his tears dripped one by one to the floor.

Haruka felt like the sadness that filled his heart had come into her.

Isshin was gone. But his death left a mark in many hearts.

That became a strong, firm bond, tying us together.

So please don't worry, Isshin-san.

We're fine.

And also –

Thank you –

One month later – Hokutou Newspaper Excerpt

Patrol Wagon Overturned, Catches Fire! Prisoner Dead?

At about 8 PM last night, on the city highway near Kosuke ICU, a patrol wagon carrying a prisoner overturned and caught fire after hitting the middle divider. The four guards were able to safely escape, but the prisoner Nanase Miyuki (26) has not been confirmed. It is believed that she died within the car.

The cause of the accident is not yet clear. Though the police had not made an official announcement, eyewitness testimonies state that the investigation is looking at it as an accident caused by a driver who dozed off.

On the day of the incident, prisoner Nanase was in the middle of being transported back to Tokyo Detention House after escaping and being rearrested.

[1] NEET stands for Not in Education, Employment, or Training. This generally derogatory term was originally used in the UK but Japan and some other countries took it up.

Volume 7 Chapter 0: Prologue

VOLUME 7 – THE LOCATION OF THE SPIRIT prologue ()

The woman was running –

She ran through the cedar trees.

It was hard to travel in this marshy area. Furthermore, because she was holding a child's hand, she couldn't move the way she wanted to.

However, this hand was the one thing she couldn't let go of. If she did, she wouldn't be human any longer.

The woman tightened her grip on the child's hand.

After heading forward further, she went through the forest into an open space.

The area was so overgrown with white skunk cabbage[1] it was dazzling –

She saw a small cottage ahead.

If I get there – just as the woman thought that, the child whose hand she was holding tripped.

‘You OK?’

The woman helped the child up.

The child lifted a face covered in dirt and nodded expressionlessly, but the woman saw that blood was coming out of the child's knee.

The child had a deeper injury than she had thought. Running would be impossible with that leg.

'There!'

The woman leapt up at the voice that flew into her ears.

She turned around and saw somebody running from the forest. No, the expression on the person's face wasn't fit to be called human.

– Just like a demon.

With the child's leg injury, they would be caught in no time.

The woman came to her decision without any hesitation.

'Can you run there?'

The woman pointed at the cottage a little ways ahead.

The child nodded.

'What a good child you are. Live – you'll live.'

The woman hugged the child tightly. After feeling that warmth one last time, she pushed the child's back.

The child ran, dragging the injured leg through the skunk cabbage –

The woman turned her eyes to the farewell, as if to say farewell.

Her pursuer would soon reach her.

Tears welled up in the woman's eyes. It wasn't because she was frightened. She was sad because she was parting from the child she loved.

'Live.'

The woman said that once more, even though she knew it wouldn't reach her child's ears.

[1] Asian skunk cabbage is called mizubashou (水芭蕉) which literally means water banana. The name comes from how its appearance is similar to the leaves of a certain type of banana. It has lovely white flowers (as seen).

Volume 7 Chapter 1: VOLUME 7 – THE LOCATION OF THE SPIRIT

Chapter 1

VOLUME 7 – THE LOCATION OF THE SPIRIT

file 01: altar (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

‘Aah . ’

Oomori Masato groaned without thinking as he looked up at the cedar tree .

At the centre of the marsh, surrounded by white skunk cabbage, the cedar tree stood as if it had been left behind .

It was probably taller than ten metres . The branches that jutted out seemed to cover the sky entirely .

At its roots was a gigantic rock about one metre tall . It appeared to be of ancient and honourable origin, but there was no way for Masato to know that detail .

He just felt pressured by its existence .

‘You still looking around?’

Masato turned around at the voice to see his classmate Tomoya standing there .

Tomoya was short for a sixth grader . Masato had to look down at him .

'Ah, yeah . '

Tomoya looked up at the cedar tree too .

When it was decided that they would go to Kinasa[1], all he would say was 'What a pain', but it seemed like he was enjoying the trip considerably .

'That's really amazing,' said Tomoya .

'Ah, yeah . '

'That's all you ever say . '

'Eh? Ah, yeah . '

'You're weird . '

Tomoya's half-closed eyes closed even further when he smiled .

The day Masato transferred in, Tomoya had been the first to talk to him .

Why'd you move here? Where were you before? Masato had thought that he'd be asked those questions, but Tomoya hadn't asked any of those .

What anime do you like? Do you like soccer or baseball better? All he asked was silly questions like that .

Masato had lost his father in the incident half a year ago . His mother already had another family, so his uncle took him in and he moved to Nagano .

Before transferring, he had been concerned about how to explain his complicated circumstances, but since he wasn't asked about it, it had been conversely anticlimactic .

At the same time, he was happy . He felt like he had been accepted .

'Hey, Masato, you come too . '

When he looked over, he saw that Tomoya had at some point climbed on top of the rock at the cedar's roots and was standing with an intimidating pose .

'Eh, but...'

'It's a great view . '

'Ah, yeah . '

'Hey, you two . It's time to group back together . '

Masato was just about to climb the rock too when his classmate Yumiko called out to them .

She was a girl who left an impression, with big round eyes and long glossy black hair . Her somewhat playful voice was similar to the trainee teacher who had supported Masato with all her might when the incident with his father happened .

The worrywart teacher who sent him letters every week to see how he was doing –

'Come on – hurry up!'

Yumiko urged them on .

Masato spotted the teacher in charge and the other students gathered in front of the cottage a little ways away .

'There's still time, right?' yelled Tomoya from the top of the rock .

'Climbing again? It's dangerous . '

'It's fine – I'm athletic, unlike you . '

'That's not the point . '

Yumiko puffed out her cheeks sulkily .

Masato ended up laughing at their amusing conversation . Then, Yumiko looked at him .

'You too, Masato-kun . '

'S-sorry . '

Masato quickly wiped the smile off his face and looked away .

'If you don't like it, try coming up here . '

Tomoya stood on one leg and held out his arms to balance himself .

'Just leave that guy alone . '

Yumiko took Masato's hand .

The pleasant coolness of her hand surprised him .

'O-OK . '

Masato started walking, pulled along by Yumiko .

'Oi, Masato! You betraying me!?' yelled Tomoya .

The next moment, Tomoya's body trembled and he slipped off the rock –

'Tomoya-kun, are you OK?'

After Masato's eyes met Yumiko's, he hurriedly ran towards Tomoya .

Tomoya wasn't moving .

'That's why I said...'

Yumiko sank to the floor with a pale face . Then, Tomoya sat up .

'That hurts!'

Tomoya stood up while scratching his back .

It seemed he was OK . Masato's expression softened, but that was just for a moment .

He shuddered –

A chill ran down his spine .

An unpleasant feeling, like somebody was watching him .

He hurriedly looked around, but all he saw was a wide field of white skunk cabbage and the mountains behind them .

However, he didn't relax .

The feeling of being followed was still there .

His heart was beating loudly .

He gulped . Suddenly, a hand touched his shoulder .

'Aah!'

Masato jumped without thinking .

'What?'

Tomoya looked surprised .

'Ah, no, it's nothing . '

Masato shook his head .

My mind's just playing tricks on me – so he told himself as he looked at the cedar again .

There was a person standing by the rock at its roots .

No, to be correct, it was a shadow in the shape of a person .

Masato knew immediately that it wasn't something from this world . He couldn't explain it . His instinct told him that .

The shadow approached Masato .

Masato stepped back as confusion and dread bubbled up within him .

'Masato-kun, are you OK?'

Yumiko looked at Masato with concern .

– Oh no .

The moment he thought that, it was too late . Yumiko's body jolted and she fell on top of the white skunk cabbage with her eyes wide open .

'Oi, Yumiko... What's wrong?'

Tomoya shook her shoulders as he spoke, sounding like he would burst into tears at any moment . However, Yumiko made no response, as if she were a doll .

– What? What's happening?

Masato stood there in confused shock .

2

After stepping through the ticket gates of Omotesando Station, Ozawa Haruka took the long stairs from the subway up to above ground .

There was not even one cloud in the blue sky .

'What nice weather . '

Haruka covered her eyes with a hand .

The straight road was lined neatly with green-leaved keyaki trees, with open-air cafes and shops with large show windows on both sides[2] .

Though there were many people, it seemed relaxed, as if representing the current sunny weather .

Haruka looked at Saitou Yakumo, who stood beside her .

Wearing a shirt and jeans, he yawned, looking bored as he ran a hand through his messy hair .

He was the same as always .

On the other hand, Haruka had taken over an hour to decide on an outfit .

Since she was going out with Yakumo, she had been rather troubled over how to coordinate her clothes . She had decided to change her hairstyle and makeup just a bit as well .

If she told Yakumo, he'd probably make fun of her for wasting her time .

'So where are we going?' said Yakumo, sounding sleepy .

'Are you leaving everything to me?'

'You're the one who dragged me all the way out to Omotesando because you said there were good shops here . '

– All the way out to Omotesando, he says .

Haruka thought about complaining, but she decided against it . She couldn't win against Yakumo in an argument .

However, not that she thought about it, Yakumo really didn't match up with Omotesando . It was like a cat swimming in the sea .

When she thought about that, Haruka ended up smiling at the amusing image .

'What's so funny?'

Yakumo glared at her .

Haruka's heart skipped when she saw his red left eye .

That deep and vivid red was so beautiful that she felt like she was being sucked in every time she saw it .

'N-nothing really...'

Haruka quickly stopped smiling .

Yakumo's left eye wasn't just red – it also had the unique ability to see the spirits of the dead .

In the past, Yakumo hated it and covered it with a black contact lens .

However, one month ago – because of the incident when he lost his uncle Isshin, Yakumo stopped hiding his red left eye .

It might have been Yakumo's own way of mourning .

To be honest, Haruka was a bit worried . Wouldn't some people see the left eye and find it disturbing or frightening – and if that happened, would Yakumo shut off his heart again?

However, she was being overanxious .

It would be a lie to say that nobody obviously thought it was disturbing, but it was only a small number of people . Most didn't care .

– The world won't change just because my left eye is red .

The person who had said that was Yakumo himself .

He had lost Isshin, who had been important to him, but Haruka felt like one of Yakumo's clouds had cleared .

'That's creepy . '

Yakumo glanced at Haruka .

'What is?'

'You are . '

'Me?'

'You've been smirking creepily for a while now . '

– That was an awful way to put it .

'Smirking... don't you think saying that is rude?'

'I wouldn't say it if I did . '

'Honestly . '

He ruined the mood with just one sentence . He's the worst –

3

'Please wait . I can't do it on my own . '

Gotou Kazutoshi ignored Ishii Yuutarou's cry and left the <Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room> .

Though Ishii was almost in tears, it wasn't like there was a big case . All he had to do with paperwork which wasn't particularly urgent .

Gotou got in the white sedan that was parked in the parking lot and stepped on the pedal .

When he was waiting for the light to turn at the intersection, he unconsciously looked out the window .

Though the sun had already sunk into the valley of buildings, the sky was still bright .

The trailing clouds were died a reddish purple .

Now that he thought about it, he hadn't left the precinct this early ever since becoming a detective .

He also felt like he had placed himself in that murderously busy atmosphere to make an excuse not to go home .

However, things were different now . He wanted to go home as quickly as he could, even if it were just by a minute or a second .

– I have somewhere to return to .

He felt surprised that he was honestly pleased by that .

Passing through the road in front of the station, he drove onto the road to the university, turned at the second corner and stopped his car at the gates of the temple on the top of the steep slope lined with ginkgo trees .

A few months ago, he'd come here as a guest, but now this place was Gotou's residence .

After he'd decided to take Nao in, they had looked for a place where the three of them could live, but he couldn't find one . When Gotou was troubled, the priest who was Isshin's teacher, Eishin, called out to him .

Though he was considerably old, his body and attitude were large – he was a remarkable character .

After Isshin died, Eishin had undertaken everything, from the temple's funerals to memorial services .

Because of him, the Gotou family were temporarily staying at the temple where Isshin had lived .

Normally, priests' quarters were possessed by the religious group, so Gotou, an outsider, wouldn't be allowed to stay there, but Eishin had anticipated that .

On top of acting very kindly to the Gotou family, he had urged Yakumo to take over for Isshin .

Thanks to that, Yakumo showed up even less frequently at the temple .

Though Gotou felt bad about Yakumo, they now had a place they could live at a reasonable price, though it was only temporary .

Gotou went through the gravel garden and opened the sliding door to the priest's quarters .

'You're early . '

Atsuko called out from the kitchen .

Instead of replying, Gotou took off his shoes at the entrance, passed through the living room and entered the kitchen .

'Where's Nao?'

He asked that straightaway .

'Reading in her room,' said Atsuko, shaking her head in exasperation . '

'I see . '

'Hey, is it really OK for you to skip out and come home?' asked Atsuko when Gotou was about to go to Nao's room .

'There isn't any important work . '

'You really are a useless employee . '

'Shut up . Ah, that's right . Where are those two?'

Gotou changed the topic .

Those two of course referred to Yakumo and Haruka .

'Come to think of it, they're not back yet . Even though we can't start until the cake's here . '

'Aren't they just loafing around on their date?'

'They might not come back . '

'It's possible . '

When Gotou shrugged, Atsuko laughed aloud .

After they started living with Nao, Atsuko really laughed much more often . It wasn't a bad thing . It was pleasant talking to her like this .

However, Gotou just couldn't get used to it . He felt embarrassed .

Gotou escaped from the kitchen just as Nao came into the living room .

She wore a pink shirt under her overalls and had a book as thick as a dictionary in her hand .

The back of her bob cut stuck out like a spring .

'Ooh aah eii,' said Nao, lifting her head to show her big and round eyes, which were sparkling .

Other people might not be able to understand Nao's words, since she was deaf . However, Gotou understood more than enough .

'Hey . I'm back . '

He patted Nao's head .

Right as he did so, Nao smiled brightly and leapt into his arms .

There were people who would sacrifice everything and even kill others for their children . Gotou couldn't understand it before .

However, things were different now . He felt like he could lose anything if it were the sake of this child .

When he'd first taken Nao in, he had felt anxious .

Would a seven-year-old child who had just lost Isshin, the person who raised her, ever accept them? More importantly, would he be able to become a parent? That anxiety had coiled about him .

Though he didn't know if he'd become a parent, Nao's smile saved him .

He sat cross-legged in front of the table and Nao sat on his lap . Then, the sliding door opened .

'Honestly . I can't believe you . '

Haruka showed up as she voiced her dissatisfaction . She had paper bags in both hands .

Though she spoke in an angry tone, she looked like she was enjoying herself .

'It's a difference in knowledge . '

Yakumo came in after her while running a hand through his hair .

He looked as sleepy as always .

Nao stood up and walked up to them .

'You're so slow! Where were you loafing about?'

Yakumo looked up at Gotou's words .

'I didn't think I'd ever hear those words from you, Gotou-san . '

'What do you mean?'

'I mean that I don't want to become an irresponsible adult . '

After the incident with Isshin, Gotou had thought Yakumo had become a bit more honest, but his mouth hadn't changed one bit .

'I'll punch you!'

'Don't fight like children – help out . '

Urged by Atsuko, who had peeked out at them, Haruka immediately went to the kitchen .

Nao followed her like a puppy .

Yakumo shrugged, looking exasperated, and he sat across from Gotou .

'It's OK, right?' Gotou said quietly .

'Who knows? I didn't choose it . '

'If you didn't choose it, it's fine . '

'What do you mean by that?'

'Just like you always say, I mean exactly what I said . '

Though Yakumo's expression was blank, his cheek twitched like a cat's .

'You should help too!'

Atsuko interrupted the conversation .

After sharing a look with Yakumo, he smiled wryly and headed towards the kitchen .

Once the preparations were completed, they had a cheerful meal .

Before Nao had come, he always eat a lunchbox from the convenience store with Ishii . He didn't eat around a table with a bunch of people like this .

Finally, Atsuko and Haruka chose a good time to leave their seats .

Yakumo yawned, seeming bored . Nao's eyes were shut, perhaps because she felt tired after eating .

'It's too early to sleep . '

Gotou shook Nao's shoulder lightly .

Nao's eyes darted around .

In the dark, Atsuko brought in a cake with candles, which faintly lit up the living room .

Haruka followed her .

'Nao . Happy birthday,' said Atsuko as she placed the cake on the table .

'This is a birthday present . Happy birthday . '

Haruka gave a wrapped box with a red ribbon to Nao .

'Happy birthday,' Yakumo murmured .

'Nao . Happy birthday . Blow out the candles then . '

Gotou patted Nao's shoulder .

However, Nao didn't move, her face downcast .

The silence continued in the flickering light of the candles .

'What's wrong?'

When Gotou spoke to her again, Nao shook her head back and forth .

Her shoulders were trembling .

Finally, she started to cry loudly .

This child had held in her feelings all this time . It was her custom .

She had probably acted cheerfully so as not to worry the people around her .

Now that Gotou thought about it, Nao had lost her real mother soon after she was born . After that, she lost Isshin, the person who had raised her, and Gotou and Atsuko had taken her in .

There was no way she could have remained composed with such great changes in her living environment . The young girl had lived her life while doing her best to bear with everything .

– No matter what anybody says, Nao is my daughter .

With that thought, Gotou hugged Nao tightly .

Nao hugged him back as she sobbed .

'That's right . You're our daughter,' said Atsuko in a tearful voice .

Haruka had tears in her eyes as well .

'I don't care, but if you don't blow out the candles soon, the cake will burn .
,

With the perfect timing to ruin the moment, Yakumo interrupted .

Though he was looking away, as if he thought the whole scene uninteresting, Gotou didn't miss how his eyes were wet .

– Honestly . What an awkward guy .

Though Gotou thought that, he didn't say it aloud .

Nao nodded . She took a deep breath in front of the cake and then blew out the candles .

A moment of darkness –

When the lights turned on again, Nao was smiling .

I will protect this space .

– That is what I live for .

Gotou vowed that once again in his heart .

4

'I wonder if she's OK...'

With a backpack[3] on, Masato was talking with Tomoya as they walked away from school .

Ever since the day they went to Kinasa for their field trip, Yumiko had not come to school . It had already been three days .

'It's probably just a cold,' Tomoya replied carelessly .

'But...'

There was a reason Masato couldn't accept it as lightly as Tomoya did .

The black shadow that had appeared then –

After Yumiko collapsed at the bottom of the cedar tree, she hadn't come to school . Masato didn't know what that shadow was, but she thought there might have been a connection .

'If you're so concerned, why not go?'

'Eh?'

Masato was surprised by Tomoya's suggestion, which he hadn't expected .

'Just go visit her . '

'But...'

'She'll be OK . '

'Really?'

'Really . Let's go . '

Tomoya turned around before Masato could answer and started running, making his backpack rattle .

Masato ran after him .

Tomoya's actions always surprised Masato . At the same time, he was envious . Masato always thought twice before doing anything . His past experience had a great influence on that .

The case he lost his father in –

– It isn't your fault .

That person said that to him . However, that case still stayed in his heart .

Somebody might be hurt because of me – when Masato thought that, he felt like his lungs were being constricted .

'It's probably just ahead . '

Tomoya stopped and pointed at the narrow footpath by the convenience store .

Masato saw a house with a black roof at the end of the twisting road . To Masato, it had a terribly uncanny feel to it, partly because it had started getting dark .

'Let's go . '

'Ah, yeah . '

Masato swallowed and then walked after Tomoya, as if hiding behind him .

It felt like it was getting darker with every step they took down the footpath .

'Eh?'

After walking about halfway, Tomoya stopped .

'What is it?'

Masato stopped too .

Tomoya turned around with a suspicious expression as he pointed down the footpath .

There was a black shadow there .

It was getting closer –

Masato recalled the shadow he had seen at the cedar tree and stiffened .

'Oh, it's Yumiko,' said Tomoya .

'Eh?'

Masato squinted in the dim light .

Since she was looking down as she walked, Masato couldn't see her face clearly, but it was definitely Yumiko .

'Oi, Yumiko . '

Tomoya waved .

Normally, she would run towards them with a smile, but she was acting strange . She continued to walk forward with her head down, as if she hadn't heard Tomoya's voice .

'Yumiko-chan . '

Masato spoke when Yumiko was right in front of them .

Yumiko stopped firmly .

'Are you OK?' said Tomoya .

Yumiko didn't move, staring at her feet . She was definitely acting strange .

'Are you crying?' asked Masato, trying to look at Yumiko's face .

Yumiko still didn't reply .

'What's wrong?'

Tomoya's hand brushed Yumiko's shoulder .

Then, Yumiko slowly lifted her face .

'Ah!'

Masato yelped without thinking when he saw that face .

Yumiko's face was as pale as a corpse's . That wasn't all . Her wide eyes were bloodshot and her half-open mouth was foaming .

'Are you really Yumiko?' said Tomoya in a trembling voice .

Yumiko looked back and forth between Masato and Tomoya with her bloodshot eyes .

Then, her purple lips moved . They looked like a different living thing entirely .

'Whaaarr...'

Her voice shook the earth .

Tomoya reflexively leapt away from Yumiko .

'Uuunnn... Gaagiii...'

Yumiko looked at Masato .

– Eh? What?

Masato couldn't move in his confusion and terror .

Yumiko stuck out both hands, put them on Masato's neck and tightened her grip .

– I can't breathe .

Yumiko's bloodshot eyes looked right at Masato . Her face was that of a demon's .

– I'm going to be killed .

The moment Masato realised that, he used all his strength to force Yumiko away from him .

'Aaah!'

While screaming, Masato ran away at full speed .

I'm scared – controlled by that emotion, he continued to run as fast as he could –

5

'Ishii-san . '

After Ishii finished work, he was leaving the precinct when somebody called out to him .

Ishii turned around at the familiar voice .

– It really is Hijikata Makoto .

Perhaps because of her hair, which she had put up today, she looked more elegant than usual . With a slender body, her grey pantsuit matched her well .

'Ah, hello . '

Ishii stopped to greet her .

As she was a newspaper reporter, he often met her like this .

'Are you finished work?'

'Yes, for now...' he replied vaguely .

Ishii was stationed at the department of the <Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room> . It sounded nice, since it could be called following up cases that were unsolved, as per the name, but it was actually just paperwork .

There was an incredible amount of it, which made it near impossible to finish . Accordingly, he wasn't sure if he had actually finished work or not .

'Would you like to have dinner?'

'With... me?'

Ishii couldn't hide his confusion at Makoto's sudden suggestion .

It wasn't as if he had any special feelings for Makoto . It was just that he hadn't ever been invited out by a woman like this .

'Yes . Actually, there was something I wanted to consult you about, Ishii-san...'

'Me?'

'Yes . '

Makoto nodded happily .

However, Ishii was even more confused . Makoto was an intelligent woman . He couldn't think of anything she would want to consult him on .

'Do you have other plans?'

Makoto peered at Ishii's face when he didn't reply . She looked incredibly lonely .

'No, that isn't...'

'Then, let's go . '

'Eh, ah, yes...'

Ishii left the police precinct, led away by Makoto .

They headed for a family restaurant about a five-minute walk from the precinct .

'So what is it you wanted to consult me about?' asked Ishii after they sat at a window seat .

Then, Makoto's expression suddenly became hard . It appeared to be a serious topic . Ishii gulped and waited for her to reply .

'Actually, I am writing a report on somebody for work . '

'A... report?'

'Yes . '

'Who is this report on?'

'Nanase Miyuki . '

When Ishii heard that name, he felt like he had been pushed off a cliff .

With gooseflesh on his skin, for a while he couldn't even open his mouth in his shock .

Nanase Miyuki hadn't only brutally murdered her own family at the age of ten – she had also been involved in a number of cases while cooperating with Yakumo's father, the man with two red eyes,

In the case that occurred half a year ago, she stabbed Gotou and seriously injured him .

Just remembering that cold smile made Ishii shiver .

'W-why?'

Ishii was finally able to squeeze just those words out of himself .

Thinking about writing a report on such an evil crime was enough to make him frightened .

'It's work . But it's also true that I have a personal interest in her . '

'Interest?'

Ishii didn't understand . What was interesting about a woman who would kill people for fun – and there was no way you would understand her no matter how much you investigated .

'Yes . Why did Nanase Miyuki commit those crimes?'

'She always had that disposition . '

That was how Ishii truly felt .

There were some things about Nanase Miyuki, such as her family environment, that he should have empathised with . However, her act of killing her whole family at the age of ten was beyond understanding .

Rather than the environment changing her, Ishii felt like she had been born with an evil disposition .

'Is that really the case?' said Makoto doubtfully .

'What do you mean?'

'I've just started investigating, but I think that there was a deep love behind her actions . '

'Love?'

Ishii mulled over it .

– Love .

There was no word that could be more inappropriate for Nanase Miyuki . Ishii thought that it was because she didn't have anything resembling human love that she went mad .

'I think that she killed her family in the beginning because she wanted love . '

'Killing because she wanted love... I feel like it doesn't connect . '

'Is that so?'

'Eh?'

'I think there is a paper-thin difference between love and madness . '

Makoto's eyes were sparkling so brightly it was uncanny .

Ishii even felt afraid – he looked away and bit his lip .

'A woman can be incredibly cruel for love . No, I don't think it's cruel .
Rather, it could be perceived as sublime . '

'Sublime...'

'When Nanase Miyuki killed her family at ten, she met the man with two
red eyes . '

'Yes . '

'What sort of existence was the man with two red eyes to her?'

'That's...'

Ishii did feel that their relationship was connected more deeply than just
conspirators .

However, Ishii didn't know what it was .

'I think that to her, he was a lover and a father . '

'Huh...'

'I think that she loved the man with two red eyes from the bottom of her
heart and worshipped him . To her, I think he might have been a symbol of
her existence .

'A symbol of her existence?'

Ishii hadn't had that perspective .

He hadn't even thought about how Nanase Miyuki and the man with red
eyes had been tied together .

'A woman could go anywhere if it were with the person she loves . '

'Is that so?'

'Yes . There was a person named Abe Sada in the past, yes?'

'Yes . '

Ishii knew the outline of the incident .

Abe Sada, who worked at a small restaurant named Yoshidaya, had an adulterous relationship with the owner of the shop named Ishida .

When that relationship was revealed, the two of them ran away together . After having sex, she strangled Ishida to death .

The disturbing actions of Abe Sada came afterwards . She cut off Ishida's penis and kept it on her person until she was arrested .

'Abe Sada killed the man she loved . It wasn't because she hated him . She killed him because she loved him . It seems contradictory, but in her head, it was the same . '

She killed him because she loved him?

'I don't really understand...'

Ishii, who didn't have proper experience with love, had no way of understanding the warped shapes of love –

6

'I don't know . She was gone before I noticed...'

Masato spoke to the uniformed officer sitting in front of him .

After that, Masato and Tomoya went together to Yumiko's house . They had thought that their eyes must have been playing tricks on them and that Yumiko was at home . However, they were wrong .

When Masato and Tomoya visited, Yumiko's family also realised that Yumiko had disappeared and called the police in a panic .

Since they were the ones who saw her last, Masato and Tomoya were called to the local police station and were questioned by the police .

'Do you remember anything else?'

'No . '

Tomoya shook his head .

It seemed like he didn't plan on talking about how Yumiko had strangled Masato . Masato felt the same way .

He wanted that to be some sort of mistake .

'How about you?'

The officer turned to Masato with narrowed eyes .

Even though somebody had gone missing, this officer didn't seem nervous or impatient . It was like the officer didn't care about Yumiko at all .

Masato might have been irritated by that attitude . He said something he hadn't planned on saying .

'A demon...'

'What?'

The officer's eyebrows furrowed .

'A demon was there . '

'Demon?'

The officer shook his head, like he was fed up .

– He really didn't believe me .

After Masato sighed in resignation, somebody gripped his shoulder .

– Who's there?

Masato turned around and saw an old woman there, about seventy years old . He had greeted her once before . It was Yumiko's grandmother .

Though her face was wrinkled, her eyes were opened unusually wide . It was bloodcurdling .

'Is what you said just now true?' said Yumiko's grandmother .

Her hand gripped Masato's shoulder even more tightly . It was surprising that there was such strength in such a thin hand .

'Granny, we'll talk to you later, so please wait . '

The uniformed officer tried to turn Yumiko's grandmother away, but she pressed Masato further .

'Did you really see a demon?'

'Y-yeah, I did...'

When Masato responded, Yumiko let out a cry – he couldn't tell whether it was a shriek or a moan – and stumbled backwards .

She had lost her strength from earlier and was trembling, as if afraid of something .

'Are you all right?' the uniformed officer asked, panicked .

'She was spirited away . That girl was spirited away . '

Yumiko's grandmother covered her face with trembling hands and sat on the floor .

The uniformed officer frantically tried to sooth her, though he seemed confused .

Masato didn't understand what had happened .

However, the words 'spirited away' remained incredibly raw in Masato's ears –

After leaving the local police station, Tomoya spoke to him .

His eyes were filled with a strong anger . Masato looked to his feet, unable to face his eyes directly .

'It's your fault,' Tomoya said with ragged breathing .

'Eh?'

'Yumiko disappeared because you ran away . '

Tomoya's quiet words pierced Masato's heart .

– Because I ran away .

He felt like everything that had built up until now had collapsed all at once .

'I...'

While Masato was looking for a reply, Tomoya turned on his heels and ran off at full speed .

– Tomoya's gone too .

All Masato could do was see that back off .

7

Higashino Hiroyuki gripped the wheel nervously .

It wasn't that he wasn't used to driving . It was just that it had been five years since he started working as a guard . It was the first time he'd driven a patrol wagon with a prisoner on it .

Nothing would change just because a prisoner was there . He knew that, but he just felt an incredible pressure from behind him .

When he looked at the rear-view mirror, he saw a woman sitting with her head down between two guards in the backseat through the metal grid that divided them .

The woman's name was Nanase Miyuki .

She had fair skin and elegant features that would make you think she was a model, but she was a criminal who had been involved in a number of crimes up until now .

Higashino couldn't understand why she had committed such repulsive crimes .

She had a faint smile on her face .

Higashino didn't know if it was a natural smile or a smile because she had noticed him, but it was so beautiful he had to swallow his breath .

'You curious?' said Yano, the senior guard sitting in the passenger seat .

His eyes were cold .

'No, that isn't...'

'It's said that beautiful roses have thorns . '

Yano smiled frivolously, like he thought something was funny .

'Is she really a criminal?'

Yano let out an incredibly gloomy sigh .

'That's not for us to think about . '

'But if she was falsely accused...'

'Why do you think that?'

'That's...'

He couldn't reply immediately . Higashino had just said what he felt – he didn't have any proof .

It could be called a feeling close to delusion .

'You're the type who'd get serious about a hostess . '

'There's no way I would,' replied Higashino, offended .

Then, he looked up and saw something unbelievable .

In the middle of the road lit up with headlights, there stood a man . He had long hair that flowed down his back and wore a black suit and sun glasses .

He was just ten metres away .

'Watch out!'

Higashino slammed the brake just as Yano yelled .

Just as he thought his body had shaken from the recoil, the car veered sharply to the right . The violent impact ran through his body .

Higashino fainted –

How long had he been out? There was the smell of something burning when Higashino opened his eyes .

Black smoke filled his vision .

Higashino took off his seatbelt and climbed out the car from the broken front window .

Black smoke was coming out from the area where the petrol tank was . It seemed like it had caught fire from the accident .

The tank might burst at this right .

'Yano-san...'

Higashino looked around . Yano was still buckled into the passenger seat .
If he didn't save him now –

Before Higashino could return to the car, a man stood in his way .

A black suit and sunglasses – the man who had suddenly appeared in the world earlier .

'You're lying...'

Higashino spoke those words without thinking .

When he slammed on the brakes, the man had already been in front of his eyes . He couldn't have made it in time . but the man had no injuries at all .

The man looked at Higashino and smiled .

A cold smile that sent a shiver down Higashino's spine .

Then, the man slowly took off his sunglasses .

His two eyes glowed red like a blazing flame –

8

Haruka ran –

She passed through the gates and went straight for the back of Building B to see the two-storey prefabricated building .

It was used by student circles, lent out by the university . The <Movie Research Circle> at the very end of the first floor was where Haruka was headed .

'Yakumo-kun, there's big trouble!'

Haruka opened the door forcefully .

'You're being so noisy so early in the morning . '

At the back of the room that was about four and a half tatami in size, Yakumo sat up in his sleeping bag .

He ran a hand through his messy hair and yawned with half-open eyes .

<Movie Research Circle> was just the name – Yakumo actually lived here . He made up some bogus documents, tricked the university and used the place as his own room .

'It's not the time to be relaxed . '

'It would be stranger to get worked up without knowing the reason . '

'Oh, I see . '

She strangely understood .

'Slow and steady wins the race . Anyway, why not sit down?'

At Yakumo's suggestion, Haruka became just a bit calmer .

It was true that there was no point getting worked up by herself . First, she would calm down . Haruka told herself that and sat in the chair .

Yakumo slowly got up and sat in the chair opposite Haruka while rubbing his eyes .

'So what trouble do you have for me this time?'

Though the way he said it irritated Haruka, since she really had brought trouble this time, she couldn't object .

'I got a call from Masato-kun this morning,' said Haruka after taking a deep breath .

'When you say Masato, do you mean that Masato?'

'Yeah . '

'Come to think of it, we promised to go visit him, but we still haven't gone...'

Yakumo's eyes narrowed .

Haruka and Yakumo met Masato about half a year ago – he was a student at the elementary school where Haruka was a trainee .

He was involved in a certain case, lost his father and received a grave wound psychologically .

Yakumo had run about with her to save him .

After the case was over, Masato's uncle took him in and he moved to Nagano, but Haruka had still been concerned so she continued to send him letters .

She was worried about his emotional state and about whether he was used to his new environment .

However, it seemed like his uncle and aunt treated him well and he had made friends at school – he seemed to be much more cheerful than when she'd first met him . Masato might have been able to stand up again . Haruka had thought that, and then she had received the phone call .

'What's wrong?'

After Haruka asked, Masato explained all the strange things that had been happening around him at once .

Going to Kinasa for a field trip . His female classmate who had suddenly fainted there . And then her disappearance –

When Haruka heard that, she went to Yakumo to consult him .

At times like this, Yakumo was really the only person she could rely on .

'So what happened to Masato?'

Yakumo still didn't seem nervous . He stifled a yawn .

'He called me earlier . '

'Is he doing well?'

'He asked me to help him...'

'What do you mean?'

Finally, Yakumo's expression became serious .

'He said his friend was spirited away...'

Haruka stated Masato's words just as he had .

'Spirited away?'

'Yeah . '

'Tell me in more detail . '

Yakumo's eyes glittered .

9

'What a pain,' grumbled Gotou, once he saw the pile of documents on the desk .

Gotou had always been better at acting than thinking, but all he did day in and out was paperwork . He hated it from the bottom of his heart .

His building irritation made him want to start smoking again .

'Detective Gotou . '

Sitting at the opposite desk, Ishii spoke up while smartly adjusting the position of his silver-framed glasses .

'What?'

'Your hands have stopped . '

'Shut up!' said Gotou, clicking his tongue .

Somehow or other, Ishii had started sharing his opinions with Gotou recently .

Though Gotou was happy Ishii had grown, he didn't like having Ishii nag at him like a sister-in-law .

'No, but...'

'To hell with your "but"s . I hate paperwork . '

'But if we don't finish this, we can't participate in the investigation . We have to pick up what we didn't do last night . '

Even though Ishii talked around it, Gotou didn't like being complained about .

Just as Gotou raised a fist to hit Ishii, his mobile phone rang .

'Who is it?' answered Gotou with a snort .

<I'll say it again, but please correct your telephone manner . >

From the phone, he heard Yakumo's extremely sleeping-sounding voice .

Yakumo's voice was grating .

'I don't want to hear that from an unsociable guy like you . '

<Even without your saying it, anybody would know that you're incorrigible . >

He was acting like he misheard on purpose .

Yakumo had to be the best in Japan at angering others .

'You making fun of me!?'

<Correct . >

'I'm gonna hang up if you've got nothing to say . '

<Do you think I have so much free time that I would call you for no reason, Gotou-san?>

There had to be a better way to say that .

'Then tell me what you're calling me for . '

<Please come now . >

'Hah?'

<I'll wait at the front gates . >

'Am I a cab?'

<Something like it, right?>

'What!?'

<Please don't speak so loudly . >

Gotou stamped his foot .

<Anyway, it's an emergency . Please hurry . >

'Don't screw with me . '

<Why not? You must have nothing to do anyway . >

'You bastard! What do you mean by that!?'

Gotou let out a yell, but Yakumo had already hung up .

– Really, what a selfish guy .

Gotou grumbled inwardly and looked at Ishii, who was quietly doing paperwork .

Though Gotou could just ignore Yakumo's request, it'd let Gotou get out of this boring work .

'No way out of it . '

Gotou put his mobile in his pocket and stood up .

'Detective Gotou, where are you going?'

Ishii looked up .

Though Ishii might not have intended it to sound this way, it felt pointed .

'Going out for a bit . I'll leave the rest to you,' said Gotou . Then, he left the room .

10

'He left...'

Ishii watched Gotou leave the room and grumbled without thinking .

From the earlier phone call, Yakumo had probably called Gotou out . Gotou probably thought it was a way to escape the paperwork . Ishii didn't mind .
But –

'I wish he would have invited me...'

Those were Ishii's true feelings .

Gotou wasn't the only one who didn't like paperwork .

Ishii was depressed too, stuck in this room .

'Gotou, you here!?'

Interrupting Ishii's thoughts, the door opened, and Chief Miyagawa came in .

Though he was of small stature, he had a shaved head and a glint in his eyes . If you didn't know him, he looked more like a member of a gang than a detective .

'Ch-Chief Miyagawa . '

Ishii stood up automatically .

'Where's Gotou?'

'Ah, er, Detective Gotou went to the washroom...' lied Ishii, still standing pencil-straight .

Miyagawa's eyes were wide open as they stared at him .

'By washroom, you of course mean that he went home . '

'Ah, er...'

He found out –

'Well, fine . Ishii, you come alone,' said Miyagawa .

'W-where to?'

'The investigation, obviously . '

'Eh? Just me? Detective Gotou is...'

'Stop flapping your mouth . You're a detective too, aren't you?'

Miyagawa's words pierced Ishii's chest .

That was right . He was a detective too .

Up until now, he had relied too much on Gotou and even forgot such an obvious thing . That thought roused his body .

'Y-yes sir!'

Ishii took the jacket from the back of his chair and ran after Miyagawa, who had left the room with a wide stride .

He fell –

'Don't lag behind!'

Ishikawa was pulled back up by Miyagawa's yell and he jogged up to Miyagawa .

'Excuse me, but what investigation is it exactly?' asked Ishii, taking a memo pad and pen out of his shirt pocket as he did so .

Miyagawa stopped and pulled Ishii's shoulder close as he started speaking quietly .

'A patrol wagon carrying a prisoner yesterday was in an accident . '

'An accident? Shouldn't that be the duty of traffic...'

'I know that without you telling me . Wait 'til I'm done!''

'Y-yes sir . '

Ishii stiffened under Miyagawa's pressure .

Miyagawa cleared his throat awkwardly, like he thought he had said too much .

'The patrol wagon in the accident was carrying Nanase Miyuki . '

– Nanase Miyuki .

When Ishii heard that name, he thought his heart might stop .

'W-what happened to her?'

'That's what we're investigating . '

'I see...'

'If you've got it, let's go . '

Miyagawa started walking briskly .

Ishii wanted to follow, but his feet wouldn't move the way he wanted them to .

— I don't want to go .

It seemed his body was reflecting that .

Something incredibly awful was going to happen . That premonition disturbed Ishii's heart .

'Hurry up!'

Miyagawa yelled back at him .

Ishii automatically replied with a 'Yes sir!' and started running . His feet tangled .

He fell —

11

Gotou drove the car .

He took the main street in front of the station and went up the curving road to see Meisei University, his destination .

When he approached the front gate, lined with red bricks, he spotted Yakumo standing there .

Gotou honked and started the car . Yakumo got into the passenger seat immediately .

'I was tired of waiting . '

That was the first thing Yakumo said .

'What kind of tone is that?'

Though Gotou complained, Yakumo let out an incredibly bored yawn . He even finished with another complaint: 'If you have the time to complain, please start the car already . '

'I don't mind starting the car, but where to?'

'Anyway, please head to the Kobomatsu intersection[3] . '

'2-chome?'

'Yes . '

Gotou felt somewhat like he really had become a cabbie .

'So what happened?' Gotou asked while stepping on the pedal .

Since it was Yakumo, he wouldn't call Gotou out for no reason . There must have been some sort of trouble .

'Do you remember Masato?'

'That kid from the incident at the school?' said Gotou as the boy's face came up in his mind .

He had an atmosphere incredibly similar to Yakumo's and seemed to have a considerable psychological wound from the incident .

'Yes . It seems he's got into some sort of trouble . '

'So you're going to help him?'

'Well, yes . '

Yakumo looked out the window .

Unusual for him, Yakumo had a proactive reason .

Gotou wasn't unrelated either . He was concerned about the boy .

'Got it . I'll go too . '

He said that naturally .

Yakumo looked surprised .

'How rare . '

– You too, buddy .

Gotou swallowed the words he was about to say . Yakumo would just complain anyway .

After a while, the car reached a junction of five streets .

'Around here then?'

'Please go to the front of that apartment . '

Yakumo pointed ahead of the intersection .

With cream-coloured walls, it was a pretty apartment with a glass entrance . It was probably for students living alone .

'Meeting somebody?'

Though Gotou asked that, Yakumo just yawned and looked out the window . It looked like he didn't want to explain .

– Honestly .

After Gotou sighed, he saw somebody coming out of the entrance .

It was Haruka .

She wore skinny jeans and a pink parka as she walked towards them with a large tote bag .

It was like she was going to go on a trip .

'I'm sorry for the wait,' said Haruka as she caught her breath . Then, she got into the backseat, as if it was a matter of course .

Gotou turned around and asked, 'Haruka-chan, you're going too?'

'Of course,' replied Haruka with ragged breathing .

'Gotou-san agreed to cooperate,' Yakumo said with a smirk .

'That's Gotou-san for you . '

Haruka clapped her hands together .

Somehow, Gotou didn't feel happy . He had no proof, but he felt like Yakumo had cornered him .

'Anyway, please head onto the highway and drive along the road,' instructed Yakumo with a yawn .

Though Yakumo's lofty attitude riled Gotou up, there was no point saying it now . Gotou just started the car .

After a while, Gotou asked, 'So where are we going?'

'Nagano,' replied Yakumo, still looking out the window .

– Nagano, eh?

Gotou mulled over it for a while, but he thought something was off .

'Which Nagano?'

'Obviously the one in Nagano prefecture . '

Gotou slammed the brakes, shocked by what Yakumo had said in such an obvious manner .

Gotou was forced forward . The seatbelt dug into his shoulder .

'Gotou-san, that's dangerous,' protested Haruka from the back seat .

Yakumo was glaring at him furiously from the passenger seat too .

However, Gotou was the one who wanted to complain .

'Shut up . I didn't hear anything about going to Nagano!' Gotou yelled .

'Of course you didn't . I didn't mention it,' Yakumo said naturally . It made Gotou even more irritated .

'What?'

'I said, I didn't mention it . It's natural that you didn't know . '

'That's not what I'm talking about . '

'That what is it?'

'I have work . I can't go so far away with you!'

Gotou hit the wheel in his agitation .

'Didn't you say you would cooperate for Masato's sake?' said Yakumo in an expressionless voice as he ran a hand through his hair .

'That's a different story . '

'How is it different? Your heartlessness doesn't change . '

'You brat...'

Gotou ground his teeth together .

'I understand . If you don't want to, it's fine . '

'Eh?'

When Yakumo backed off like this, it gave Gotou a bad feeling .

'I'll consult Atsuko-san . '

'Why're you bringing up my wife?'

'If it were Atsuko-san, she would take us to Nagano . '

Yakumo crossed his arms and looked up at the low ceiling .

This was bad . This wasn't a threat . If Gotou refused here, Yakumo really would use Atsuko as a cab . That'd be a problem in and of itself .

'Fine . But I'm just driving you to Nagano . '

'Yes, drop off and pick up is enough . '

Yakumo smiled with narrowed eyes .

When he showed this expression, he was always plotting something .

– I've got a bad feeling about this .

Gotou started the car with uneasy feelings .

12

– Yumiko's gone because you ran away .

As Masato took the bus to Nagano Station, those words kept repeating in his head .

Tomoya had said that last night .

Those words pierced to the deepest part of Masato's heart, making him remember what happened with his father half a year ago .

Masato had run away in his fear then too .

As a result, his father died . That wasn't all . A lot of awful things happened too .

– I won't run away any more .

He had made that vow and started his new life in Nagano, but he had run away again . Because of that, Yumiko was gone .

Anxiety curling in his chest, Masato got off the bus at the Nagano Station traffic circle .

He sat on the blue bench at the bus stop and hated that all he could do was wait .

The regular bell for the departing Shinkansen pierced his ears .

When it was decided that he would live with his uncle in Nagano, he had been anxious, but his uncle and aunt had welcomed him kindly .

The two of them didn't have children of their own – they'd said that Masato was like their own son .

Though they sometimes scolded him, it wasn't through illogical violence the way his past father had done . They would reasonably explain what was wrong with what Masato had done .

He'd fit in more quickly at the new school that he'd thought he would too, because Tomoya and Yumiko were there .

Their smiles had saved him .

To Masato, they were the first friends he'd made – they were irreplaceable .
But still, he ran away - that thought kept running through his head .

'What should I have done?'

Though he spoke aloud, nobody replied .

When he looked up, he could see a chain of tall mountains overlooking the whole town . Masato now felt resent towards those sublime mountains .

The field trip he'd taken to those mountains had been the start of it .

Then –

He looked towards the clock by the escalator to the station platform .

It was exactly five o' clock . It was the arranged time .

He looked around, but the person he was looking for wasn't there .

– Will she really come?

He wanted to believe in her, but with his heart as fragile as it was now, he couldn't help but be anxious .

To escape the weariness in his shoulders, Masato curled up and hugged his knees . Though it was May, the wind was cold at this time . It chilled him to the centre of his body .

– What should I do?

'Sorry for the wait!'

At the same time as the voice, somebody tapped him on the back .

Masato leapt up in surprise .

In front of his eyes stood Haruka's smiling figure .

Unlike the suit she wore during training, her casual attire of jeans and a parka made her look younger .

Next to her stood a large-framed middle-aged man . He raised his hand and said, 'Hey . '

After the incident with his father, Haruka told Masato the story . This was probably Detective Gotou .

'It's been a while . '

Yakumo appeared from behind Gotou .

As usual, he wore a shirt and jeans and had a hand in his messy hair as he yawned .

However, one thing had changed .

When Masato had last seen Yakumo, he had hid his red left eye with a black contact lens . However, now the red left eye was bare and unhidden .

Yakumo also seemed to have a different air to him .

'Sorry we're late,' said Haruka, touching Masato's shoulder .

'It's all this bear's fault . '

Yakumo pointed at Gotou .

'Why's it my fault?'

'Didn't you get lost?'

'You! Who do you think brought you here!?!'

'Please don't speak so loudly in the middle of the street . It's embarrassing .',

Yakumo put his fingers in his ears to complain .

'I...'

Masato opened his mouth, but he couldn't think of what to say .

When he saw Haruka's and Yakumo's faces, he felt whatever it is that had been stuck in his chest snap . He started crying .

13

Together with Miyagawa, Ishii went to the hospital affiliated with the police .

Yano, the man who had been in the passenger seat, wasn't gravely injured, but his whole body was bruised . He also had third-degree burns on his legs and was currently undergoing treatment in the ICU .

Higashino, the man who had been driving, got off with light injuries and was able to talk .

When Ishii went into the hospital room, he saw a man in his early thirties lying on a bed . He was probably Higashino . He had a cut on his cheek, but there were no other obvious injuries .

Higashino seemed to notice Ishii and Miyagawa and sat up with a nervous look .

'I'm Miyagawa of the Setamachi precinct . '

'My name is Ishii . '

Ishii followed Miyagawa and showed his police ID .

'Oh,' Higashino replied flatly . There was no energy in his face – it was like his heart wasn't here .

'Please tell us about the incident,' said Miyagawa, pulling the round chair for guest use that was nearby and sitting down . Ishii remained standing and took out his memo pad .

'What happened?' Miyagawa asked directly .

Higashino's brows furrowed as he played with his fingernails, looking troubled .

'It was so sudden...' Higashino said helplessly .

'What was?'

Miyagawa turned his sharp gaze towards him . To escape it, Higashino looked out the window .

'A man suddenly appeared on the road . '

'He jumped out?'

When Miyagawa asked that, Higashino shook his head vigorously .

'That isn't it . It was sudden . A man in the middle of the road...'

'Then?'

Miyagawa didn't look like he had accepted Higashino's testimony, but he urged him to continue .

'It was too late when I noticed . I couldn't make it in time... so I thought as I slammed the brakes and turned the wheel . '

'And then you turned sideways,' said Ishii, recalling the state of the scene .

'What was the distance?' asked Miyagawa, his voice one step lower .

'About ten metres...'

'How many KM were you driving at?'

'I think it was about fifty . '

'Then you probably didn't make it even if you stepped on the brakes . '

Higashino's shoulders shuddered in fear .

It was just as Miyagawa said . If he had been driving at fifty kilometres per hour and suddenly stepped on the brakes, it would take thirty metres to stop . If the man had been ten metres ahead, he would have definitely been hit .

'I thought that I hadn't made it in time too . '

'Did you hit that man?' interrupted Ishii .

'No guy like that was at the scene . '

Miyagawa was the one who rejected Ishii's thought .

That was right . If that man had been hit, he should have been at the scene, but there was no such man there .

'He was,' said Higashino, gripping the sheets tightly .

'What are you talking about?' Miyagawa pressed .

'I got out of the car immediately . Yano-san was still inside and the car was burning . I was going back to save him . Then, that man appeared in front of my eyes . '

'The man who'd been standing in the road?'

'Yes . He had a creepy smile on his face and he took off his sunglasses . The man's eyes were...'

After saying that much, Higashino's whole body shook and he covered his face with both hands .

He was probably gripped by terror . That emotion came through to Ishii as well . Then, Ishii realised . What Higashino was afraid of—

'That man's eyes were deep red . '

When Ishii said that, Higashino raised his face in shock .

There was a silence .

So it really was that man .

If Higashino had seen the man with two red eyes, it would explain how he suddenly appeared in the road and also how the car didn't hit him .

He was already dead . In short, he was a ghost .

'Then what happened?' said Ishii .

With ragged breathing, Higashino continued his story .

'That man said this . Open the back of the car and take off her handcuffs – '

'So you did what he said without saving your colleague!?' Miyagawa yelled angrily, standing up as he did so .

Higashino covered his face under that pressure .

'There was nothing I could do . He would've killed me if I didn't . So...'

'So you let a criminal escape?'

With a frightful expression, Miyagawa gripped Higashino by his shirt .

'W-wait, Chief Miyagawa . Please calm down . '

Ishii frantically separated Miyagawa from Higashino .

Making a fuss now wouldn't change anything . Though Ishii didn't want to admit it, this was absolute proof that Nanase Miyuki had escaped .

'Are you all right?' Ishii asked Higashino .

'There was nothing I could do...' said Higashino in a tearful voice .

'I understand . '

'Eh?'

'Because I felt the same way . '

'Same?'

Higashino cocked his head, confused by Ishii's words .

Ishii had felt himself the terror that was the man with two red eyes . He had died, so he couldn't directly harm the living .

However, Ishii couldn't blame Higashino . If Ishii had been in the same situation, he would have let Nanase Miyuki escape too .

That was how frightening that man's red eyes were .

'Excuse me, but would you allow me to ask one thing?'

Higashino nodded .

'Was Nanase Miyuki injured?'

Ishii had seen pictures of the scene – it had been quite an accident . It would have been near impossible for Nanase Miyuki to escape without injury . There had also been blood thought to be hers on the asphalt .

'Yes . It looked like she had broken her arm, and there were burns on her face as well...'

'There's chance she would've gone to a hospital then . OK, Ishii – let's go .',

No sooner than Miyagawa had said it, he flew out of the hospital room .

'Thank you very much . '

Ishii thanks Higashino and followed Miyagawa out the hospital room .

'I ran away then,' said Masato, his small hands in fists .

Though there were tears in his eyes, he was trying his hardest not to let them fall .

Haruka could feel that painfully .

'Masato-kun . '

Haruka hugged Masato tightly .

She could feel Masato shaking through her palm .

He was probably afraid, but more than that, he was filled with anger at himself for not being able to do anything – that was how it seemed to Haruka .

After meeting them again, Masato told them everything that happened so far, spilling out everything he had held in until now .

His field trip to old Kinasa village to see the skunk cabbage . The ghost-like thing he'd seen there, and his classmate Yumiko's sudden collapse after that .

Then, the terrifying experience he'd had going to visit Yumiko last night, and how he'd run away .

Haruka thought it made sense for him to, but Masato didn't feel the same way, so he was blaming himself .

'I get the gist of it . Let's calm down a bit and discuss . '

At this lull in the conversation, they went with Gotou's suggestion to a coffee shop in the station .

It was a cramped chain store, but the interior was beautifully kept .

After ordering drinks for four at the counter, they went to a table that seated four at the back of the shop .

'So what's happened to that girl Yumiko?' asked Yakumo after a moment .

'I don't know . They said they're looking but can't find her...' replied Masato in a trembling voice .

Not just a ghost sighting . A girl had gone missing too – that fact made the atmosphere one level heaving .

'I wonder if she was kidnapped...'

'Then there should be a ransom request . '

Gotou shot down Haruka's suggestion .

'That's right . '

'You two are too hasty,' Yakumo said scornfully as he sipped his coffee .

'I can't let that pass,' Gotou replied immediately .

'Ransom isn't the only goal of kidnapping . '

'Ah!'

'Gotou-san, are you really a detective?'

Yakumo looked needlessly surprised .

'Shut up . '

Gotou sulked like a child .

When Haruka understood, a bad feeling spread through her chest .

Just as Yakumo said, ransom wasn't the only goal of kidnapping . Sometimes the goal was the murder or to satisfy some twisted lust – there was many motives .

'Could that girl...'

Those words slipped out of Haruka's mouth .

If it wasn't for ransom, that girl might have already been killed .

'I said, you're too hasty . '

Yakumo glared at Haruka .

Then, Haruka finally remembered that Masato was beside her . She shouldn't say anything careless about his classmate when he was right beside her .

'Sorry...'

'Right . We don't even know if it's a kidnapping or now . '

Gotou offered timely help .

'Anyway, more information is necessary . Do you know anything else?'

Yakumo turned the conversation to Masato .

Masato suddenly took a photo from his pocket, as if he'd just remembered it, and placed it on the table .

In the photo, there was a cedar tree and a large rock at its roots . There were three children speaking by it .

One was Masato . The other two were a boy and girl of about the same age .

'What's this?'

Yakumo took the photo into his hand with furrowed brows .

'My teacher took the picture . After this, Yumiko-chan fainted...' replied Masato .

'This was the ghost Masato saw then . '

'Mm . '

Yakumo and Masato both seemed to understand, but Haruka didn't .

'Is there a ghost in this photo?'

'Do you have holes for eyes?'

Yakumo always said one thing too much .

'Thanks to you . '

'Here . '

Yakumo put the photo on the table and tapped the area by the rock with his finger .

Haruka and Gotou leant forward to look at the photo .

'Oh!'

Gotou noticed first and shouted out .

Haruka noticed it too . She'd thought it was a shadow at first, but it wasn't .
Though it was faint, she could see a person there .

She couldn't see the face clearly, but it was probably an adult woman .

'How is this related?'

'I don't know yet . Is there anything else?'

Yakumo looked to Masato again .

'Spirited away – '

After a silence, Masato whispered that .

'You said that on the phone too, right? Who'd you hear it from?'

Yakumo looked at Masato with a searching gaze .

Gotou, who didn't read the atmosphere, slurped his iced coffee loudly through his straw in a carefree manner .

'You're noisy . '

After reprimanding Gotou, Yakumo urged Masato to continue again .

'Yumiko-chan's granny said that . That she was spirited away,' said Masato, leaning forward .

'Spirited away? Does that mean the culprit is a tengu[5]?' Haruka asked Yakumo to confirm .

'Though the tengu are famous for it, depending on the location, it might be a demon, fox spirit or mountain witch . '

'A youkai war, eh?' joked Gotou, but Yakumo sent him a piercing gaze to shut him up before continuing his explanation .

'Normally, disappearing without notice in sacred mountains and forests is called being spirited away . '

'Do people really get spirited away?' asked Makoto .

'Recently, sudden disappearances have been called being spirited away . In that meaning, they do happen . '

'Can people be found after being spirited away?'

'There are occasions when people will be suddenly found in a faraway location, while there are also occasions where they are never seen again . '

'I don't want to happen . '

Masato looked straight at Yakumo .

Masato couldn't forgive himself for running away . That fastidious of his, so similar to Yakumo's, would corner him . Yakumo probably felt it himself as he awkwardly ran a hand through his hair before speaking .

'I acknowledge the existence of ghosts, but I don't acknowledge the existence of as-yet-unknown creatures like tengu and demons . '

'Eh, but you just said people do get spirited away...'

Yakumo did say that earlier .

When Haruka interrupted, Yakumo looked at her scornfully .

'Listen properly to what people say . I said that people disappear without notice – in that sense, people are spirited away . The people of the past just assumed that that was the work of tengu and demons . '

'It isn't?'

'That girl suddenly disappeared . That's the only reason it could be called spirited away . '

So that's what he meant – Haruka understood now . But the problem still remained .

'Is there a way to find her?'

'I really shouldn't have run away,' declared Masato .

His fists were shaking . It hurt to look at him .

'Listen . Even if you didn't run away then, Masato, what could you have done?'

Yakumo stared at Masato .

Masato's head drooped under that pressure .

'I...'

'Depending on the situation, running away can be the best choice . '

'But...'

Masato looked up again to talk back .

'If you didn't run away then, you might have disappeared as well . Then there would be the possibility that the very existence of the incident would have been unknown to us . '

Yakumo spoke in his usual well-reasoned way with harsh words, but his tone was gentle .

He was trying to lighten Masato's psychological load, even if only by a little .

'Let's put aside what has happened so far . The question is what we do from now on . '

Though Masato still didn't look like he had accepted Yakumo's opinion, he nodded .

It was just as Yakumo said . There was no point regretting what had happened .

Haruka gripped Masato's hand .

'Hey, wouldn't it be better to leave it to the local police?' interrupted Gotou, biting his straw .

'We will leave the search to them, but there is something we can do as well . ,

Yakumo's words were unusually forceful .

His sharp gaze was almost frightening .

'Something we can do?'

Gotou crossed his arms with a frown .

'What is the true nature of the ghost Masato saw? If we understand that, we might know where that girl has disappeared to . '

Yakumo licked his thin lips and narrowed his eyes .

'What do you plan to do?' said Gotou, seeming bored as he looked up at the ceiling .

'First, we'll go to the place where the incident started . '

Yakumo tapped the photo with his finger .

'I'm going too . '

Masato stuck out his chin and spoke up loudly .

He sent a forceful gaze towards Yakumo .

'Naturally,' said Yakumo with a smile .

'Then I'm going back . '

Gotou stretched and stood up .

Though Haruka wished he would accompany them a bit longer, he'd already brought them all the way to Nagano .

But –

'I think it'd be impossible to get to the place where the cedar tree is without a car . '

'So he says . '

Yakumo shrugged and looked up at Gotou .

'Oi, oi . I'm in charge of dropping off and picking up . I've done my job . '

What Gotou said made sense .

'Dropping off and picking up means that you have to drop us off and pick us up . You'll be done when you drop us off at Tokyo . '

'That's just quibbling . '

Gotou ground his teeth together .

However, his expression didn't make it look like he completely objected . It felt like he even enjoyed the situation .

'Now, let's head out . '

Yakumo finished drinking his cup of coffee and stood up .

'So? You know where the place is?'

Standing next to him, it appeared that Gotou had already come to a decision .

'I know where it is . It's near my parents' home,' said Haruka .

It would be best to go before Gotou changed his mind .

With Masato's hand in hers, Haruka stood up .

15

When Ishii left the hospital room and went into the corridor, Miyagawa was talking on his mobile .

'Go straight to the nearby hospital . Nanase Miyuki might be undergoing treatment there . This is an emergency . '

After saying that in a frenzy, Miyagawa turned to Ishii .

'All right . We're going too . '

'W-where to?'

'Weren't you listening? Nanase Miyuki should be being treated at a hospital . We're gonna get her before she runs . '

'Oh...' Ishii replied listlessly .

Nanase Miyuki was injured . Just as Miyagawa's decision to search the hospital was not incorrect . However, something felt odd to Ishii .

– What could it be?

'Anyway, let's go . '

Miyagawa interrupted Ishii's thoughts and started walking away with wide strides .

Ishii followed after him .

Nanase Miyuki was a coldblooded, heartless woman . However, that wasn't all . She was also a woman who could coolly and objectively look at a situation .

That cunning smile appeared in Ishii's eyes .

Then, he realised what was strange .

'Excuse me, Chief Miyagawa,' said Ishii once they got to the parking lot .

'What?'

Miyagawa looked at him, clearly irritated .

'Nanase Miyuki is a fugitive . '

'I know that . '

'With this much evidence, she must know that the police have realised she escaped . '

'So what?'

'Would she go to a hospital in this situation?'

That was what felt off to Ishii .

If she went to hospital, she was likely to be caught by the police . It would be difficult to run while being treated .

This was Miyuki, who had tricked the police a number of times . She must have known that .

'But this isn't just some scratch . Even she'd need treatment . '

According to Higashino, she'd even broken bones .

With that level of injury, it would be difficult to escape without treatment . However, that didn't wave away Ishii's suspicion .

'Er, this is just a possibility, but...'

'What?'

'She could treat it herself...'

'Hah?'

Miyagawa cocked his head .

Even Ishii thought it was a ridiculous idea, but he couldn't throw away the possibility . He thought that she might do something like that .

'But she'd need things to treat it herself,' said Miyagawa .

It was just as he said . If the injury was serious, it would need to be stitched up, and if there were broken bones, they would need to be set . Burns needed to be disinfected . Furthermore, she would have to do this in a place where other people wouldn't notice .

– So that's no good then?

Ishii felt the thought disappear .

Just like Miyagawa said, it might be good to check the hospitals thoroughly .

'That's right...'

There was no strength in Ishii's reply as he got into the driver's seat .

'Don't be discouraged . It was a good idea,' said Miyagawa, getting into the passenger seat .

There was sympathy in that voice . Ishii had thought Miyagawa was something like a demon, but it appeared he was a bit wrong .

'Hah...'

'You're a bit too focussed on Nanase Miyuki . Well, I shouldn't talk . '

Miyagawa smiled dryly .

It was fifteen years ago – when Nanase Miyuki committed her first crime, Miyagawa had been the first at the scene . In a way, he'd known her longer .

Ishii first encountered Nanase Miyuki half a year ago with the incident at the school . No, that was wrong . She hadn't showed herself then, but she'd been involved in the case earlier –

'Ah!'

A light bulb flashed in Ishii's head .

There would be some medical equipment there . Not just that – people wouldn't see her .

'What's wrong?'

'I know where Nanase Miyuki is hiding . '

'What?'

Miyagawa looked at Ishii in surprise .

16

After leaving the cafe, Haruka got into the passenger seat of Gotou's car .

Now that they knew where the place was, they had bought a guide . In the back seat, Yakumo and Masato sat next to each other .

'I'm sorry you have to come all this way with us . '

Haruka bowed her head to Gotou in the driver's seat as he started the car .

'I wish that guy'd learn a bit from your honesty, Haruka-chan,' said Gotou, looking at Yakumo through the rear-view mirror .

However, Yakumo didn't appear to hear . He just looked out the window to look at the dark scenery . Haruka had no idea what he was thinking about .

Masato's knees were tightly together and he was looking at his hands, as still as a statue .

He probably had a lot to think about .

Haruka turned to face the front and noticed that the mobile phone on the dashboard was vibrating .

'Gotou-san, your phone is ringing . '

When Haruka said that, Gotou frowned, looking annoyed .

'It's Ishii . Been calling this whole time . What a persistent guy . '

'Is it all right not to answer?'

'I'll answer when I'm back . '

Gotou smirked . It was a mean way to put it .

'The way you said that was similar to Yakumo-kun . '

'Don't compare us . Anyway, wouldn't it be better to call that kid's home?'

Gotou changed the topic .

Come to think of it, he was right . A girl from the neighbourhood had just disappeared . There would be a big fuss if Masato disappeared too .

'That's right . '

Haruka took her mobile phone out immediately and called Masato's home .

When she gave her name, Masato's aunt, who answered the phone, immediately recognised her . Since Haruka had called a number of times before in her concern, they were rather familiar with each other .

After Haruka explained the situation, Masato's aunt replied that she understood .

Masato's aunt apologised so many times that Haruka felt ashamed herself . It was clear that Masato's aunt loved Masato like her own son .

For Masato, who had been involved in such a ghastly case, his uncle and aunt might have been a stroke of happiness within that bad luck .

Haruka promised to bring Makoto back home before it was late and hung up .

'So where should I head?'

Gotou asked for guidance after waiting for her to finish .

'Please head right . '

'Right . '

Up until now, they had gone straight along a street in Kinasa .

If they turned at the intersection and went towards Togakushi around Arakurayama, they would reach the cedar they were headed for .

From now on was a winding mountain road . The road suddenly became narrower, and there were no traffic lights either .

There were only houses with lights on popping up every once in a while .

'Is this your hometown, Haruka-chan?'

While driving, Gotou changed the topic .

'It is . '

'I feel like I know why you're so pure . '

'What do you mean?'

'He's saying that this is way out in the country,' Yakumo said loftily, his legs crossed .

He only responded at times like this .

'My bad . '

Though it was just a thought, this was her hometown, so she wanted to object .

'You're probably friends with tanuki . '

— Well .

'They're human . '

'They just changed shape . Since you're easy to trick . '

This person just –

'Tanuki changing shapes – what age do you think we live in?'

'Don't take things so seriously . '

– Ah, honestly .

'Oi . Where to next?' interrupted Gotou .

'Please head along this road . '

'Which road?'

'Just straight ahead . '

'Straight ahead? There's no road here . '

'There is . '

Haruka pointed with her finger .

Though it was only wide enough for one car to pass, there was a road there .

'That's a road?'

Gotou cocked his head .

She knew it was just that he wasn't used to it, but she felt like she was being made fun of .

'Please just go!'

She ended up speaking in an irritated tone .

'Y-yes,' replied Gotou, sounding a bit afraid .

In the back seat, Yakumo and Masato stifled their laughter .

Were they just making fun of her? Or were they trying to make Masato feel more to ease? Though Haruka didn't know, since Masato had laughed, she let it go

About forty minutes from Nagano Station, they finally reached the place they were headed for .

They went up the twisty wooded road to an opening, where there was a marsh .

'This is the right place, right?'

'Yes . '

'Where to park...'

Speaking to himself, Gotou stopped the in front of the cottage by the marsh .

— We're finally here .

Haruka stretched as she got off the car .

The air was different here in the middle of the mountains . It prickled her with cold .

'The stars are amazing,' said Yakumo, as he got off the car and looked up at the sky .

Haruka looked up as well .

'They are . '

Unlike Tokyo, the air was clear . Nothing got in the way of the shining stars .

'Let's finish this quickly . '

Gotou got a torch from the back of the car and started walking briskly .
Then, he yelped .

It seemed he'd gotten stuck in one of the marsh's puddles .

'It's because you advance without thinking,' said Yakumo scornfully as he carefully stepped only on the firm parts of the ground and walked along the skunk cabbage .

'Shut up,' complained Gotou, following after Yakumo .

'Let's go . '

Masato pulled Haruka's hand .

His face was stiff . No matter what he'd said, he was probably frightened about returning to the place where he saw something so terrifying .

Haruka took Masato's hand and started walking .

Finally, they reached the cedar in the middle of the marshy area . At its roots was a large rock about a metre tall .

'Amazing,' said Gotou, pointing the torch's light up at the cedar tree .

Just as he said, the cedar tree had a strange presence to it .

It probably wouldn't have stood out much in the middle of a forest, but because it stood alone, surrounded by a flat marsh, it find excessively amazing .

'Gotou-san, please lend that to me . '

As Yakumo said that, he took the torch from Gotou and crouched by the roots, lighting it up .

'Aah!'

She yelled without thinking .

Lit up by the torch, there was a statue of the Buddha at the tree's roots .

The stone statuette was broken at places from wind and rain . The right half was covered in green moss .

It must have been here for a while without any care .

Masato gripped her hand tightly .

'It's all right,' she said, to herself as well .

Masato didn't say anything; he just nodded .

'Masato . Do you remember this?'

Yakumo picked something up from the ground and handed it to Masato . It looked like an old rope .

'Yeah . It was wrapped around the stone, but when Tomoya-kun fell from it, the rope fell off too,' replied Masato .

'I see . This is a shrine,' said Yakumo, placing the rope on the stone .

'Shrine?' replied Gotou .

'A shrine . A place where Shinto spirits gather . Like an altar,' Yakumo replied disinterestedly .

'Altar?'

Haruka looked at the cedar tree and rock again .

Come to think of it, it did look like that .

'The rope wrapped around the rock was used to cordon off the consecrated area . It probably enshrined this cedar tree . '

'So that's why the Buddha statue is here . '

'Somebody put this here later . '

'How can you tell?'

'Having a statue of the Buddha at a Shinto shrine is unnatural . '

'That's right... but why?'

'Who knows? I don't know that much . Anyway, it would be better to come back when it's bright,' drawled Yakumo .

'What?' exclaimed Gotou exaggeratedly .

'The light of a torch won't be enough . '

Yakumo threw the torch back to Gotou and looked at the cedar tree .

'What? I thought I'd be able to get back home today too,' complained Gotou as he started walking to where he'd parked the car .

'Let's go . '

Haruka pulled Masato's hand and started walking away from the tree, but then she turned around, noticing that Yakumo wasn't walking with them .

Yakumo stood silently, facing the cedar tree .

'Wait a bit . '

Haruka left Masato there and walked back to Yakumo .

Even though she was standing next to him, Yakumo just looked up at the tree, unmoving .

It wasn't that he didn't notice her . It felt like he knew but was still looking up at the tree .

It was like he was talking with the cedar tree .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . '

When Haruka called out to him, Yakumo murmured quietly .

'This is Kinasa...'

NOTES:

A general note about the chapter title . In Japanese it is called himorogi (神籬), a Shinto term for a sacred place where one worships . Originally, a himorogi was just an area of sacred land surrounded by evergreens . Rocks in the middle of a himorogi are called iwakura (岩座) . HERE is an example on Wikipedia of the one at Rokkosan Country House .

[1] Kinasa (鬼無里), written with the kanji for place with no demons, was a village in Nagano prefecture located in Kamiminochi that has been merged into the city of Nagano . There are a number of legends about it .

[2] THIS is the street in question, nicknamed Keyaki Street (けやき通り) because of the trees .

[3] Masato is wearing a randoseru, which is the iconic backpack used by elementary students in Japan . Traditionally these would be red or black but there are many more varieties now, as can be seen on this WEBSITE .

[4] THIS is the intersection in question; zoom in to see the five roads .

[5] A tengu (天狗) literally translates to heavenly dog and is a legendary creature . In Japan it is depicted with a very long nose . KURAMA MOUNTAIN has a statue of one .

Volume 7 Chapter 2: VOLUME 7 – THE LOCATION OF THE SPIRIT

Chapter 2

VOLUME 7 – THE LOCATION OF THE SPIRIT

file 02: witch (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

After parking the car, Ishii took deep breaths .

He was near the Tamo River at one corner of the residential street, in front of the <Kinoshita Surgery: Maternity and Gynaecology Department > .

A flat-roofed three-storey building with white walls – it stood uncannily in the darkness .

The first time Ishii came here was about half a year ago, during his first case with Gotou . During that case, the owner of this hospital was arrested, so it was now empty .

All the windows were covered by curtains, and weeds grew at the entrance . The sign with the name of the hospital was written in dirty undistinguishable letters .

It was completely abandoned .

Ishii thought Nanase Miyuki was hiding in this building .

‘Why do you think she’s here?’ asked Miyagawa .

'There are materials she could use here to treat herself without being spotted . Those are the requirements . '

'But there are other abandoned hospitals . '

Just as Miyagawa said, there were other abandoned hospitals too, if those were the only requirements . However, if they became too old, the materials couldn't be used for treatment . Furthermore –

'The man with two red eyes was involved in the case with Doctor Kinoshita . Though she didn't appear in the foreground, Nanase Miyuki was probably involved as well... so she must know about this place . '

That was why Ishii thought that Nanase Miyuki would use <Kinoshita Surgery: Maternity and Gynaecology Department> as her hideout .

'Why do you think she'd choose a place she knows?'

'I used geographic profiling . '

'Profiling, eh? How complicated . '

Miyagawa smiled wryly .

'That isn't the case . Profiling is just thinking from the standpoint of the criminal . '

'Though people look as if they are behaving erratically, they unconsciously limit their actions . '

'Limit?'

Miyagawa cocked his head .

'Yes . Concealment means hiding yourself . People unconsciously choose some place they think is safer . '

'So places you don't know are unsafe . '

'There are exceptions, but this is not an escape but concealment .
Furthermore, she is injured . There is a high risk to hiding in a place you
don't know . '

'Well, instead of thinking about it, we'll find out if we go in . '

As Miyagawa said that, he got off the car .

Ishii took the torch and got off the car .

– Nanase Miyuki might be here .

Now, fear welled within him and his feet froze . However, he had suggested
this himself . He couldn't run now .

'Let's go . '

Unlike Ishii, Miyagawa spoke as lightly as if they were heading out for a
stroll and walked briskly . Ishii gulped and started walking as well .

They stood in front of the glass entrance .

'All right . '

Then, Miyagawa smashed the glass, put his hand in and unlocked the door .

That was the person who taught Gotou for you . His methods were forceful
.

'Don't dawdle . '

'Y-yes sir . '

Ishii went into the building, hiding behind Miyagawa's back .

Ishii lit the torch . Though they were small, there was a reception and
waiting room and a cavernous corridor beyond them .

– I'm really frightened .

Ishii wanted to cling to something, so he stuck to Miyagawa's back .

'That's creepy . Back off . '

Miyagawa pushed Ishii away .

'I-I apologise . '

'I'll look at the examination room . You check the delivery room,' said Miyagawa, sounding exasperated . Then he opened the door and went into the examination room .

– I'm going alone?

Ishii wiped his sweaty palms on his trousers and gripped the torch tightly . He felt like his heart would leap out of his throat .

The delivery room was at the end of the corridor .

Ishii walked a step at a time .

'It's OK . It's OK . '

Ishii said that to himself as he pushed open the door to the delivery room .

Then, the smell of disinfectant assaulted his nose . Without thinking, he covered his nose and mouth with his hand .

On the dusty metal cart, there were medicine and medical tools, and there was a bed in the middle of the room .

Ishii immediately noticed something was strange .

There were bandages at his feet . He turned the torch towards them and realised they were bloody .

'It's still fresh...'

When Ishii spoke up, he saw something move in the corner of his eye .

'Eh?'

It was too late when he noticed .

Something leapt out of the darkness and attacked Ishii .

Ishii couldn't even scream .

2

'Hello!' said Haruka, opening the door to the soba restaurant .

They dropped by after seeing Masato off .

It was thirty minutes by car from Nagano city . It was a soba restaurant for tourists, the middle of five at the bottom of Togakushi mountain .

It had a long history – a wooden shop with a thatch roof . White walls that stood out even from the road . It had a wide parking lot . Besides the table for eight inside the shop, there were two tatami rooms . There was also an inn, though it was simple and at a bit of a distance .

To be frank, it was Haruka's home .

'Sorry, we're already closed...'

Haruka's mother, Keiko, came out of the kitchen in an apron .

'I'm back . '

'Oh, it's you, Haruka,' replied Keiko, sounding a bit disappointed .

'Couldn't you be a bit more surprised?'

Haruka pouted, but Keiko didn't care . She didn't respond to anything . That was her personality .

'My body wouldn't be able to bear it if I was surprised by everything you did . '

'It's not like I do anything that surprising . '

'Really now . Didn't you come home crying about how "Yakumo-kun disappeared" the other time?'

– She couldn't say anything to that .

'I wasn't crying . '

'Oh really,' said Keiko mischievously .

Haruka wanted to retort, but she couldn't just keep talking like this .

'Hey, friends came with me, but could I ask them in?'

Haruka didn't wait for Keiko's answer . She opened the sliding door and showed Yakumo and Gotou in .

'Sorry to bother . '

Gotou passed through the curtain first .

'Oh my, you're Nao-chan's...'

Keiko clapped her hands together before Haruka could introduce him .

Haruka had thought they hadn't met before, but now that she thought about it, they'd met at Isshin's funeral .

'Oh, is this your home, Haruka-chan?' said Gotou, looking at Keiko .

'I didn't say?'

'Didn't hear anything about it . '

'If you're going in, please hurry up . You're in the way,' interrupted Yakumo, sounding displeased .

'You're so fussy,' complained Gotou, but he stepped inside the shop to let Yakumo in .

'Oh, Yakumo-kun too!'

Though Keiko didn't have much of a response to her daughter's return home, when she saw Yakumo, she was so pleased it looked like she'd leap up .

'Hello . '

Yakumo greeted her with his usual expression .

'What is it? Why are you all here?'

Keiko was as excited as if she had met old friends ago .

'A lot happened . '

'Oh, did you decide when to have your marriage?'

'Whose?'

'What? Don't play dumb . '

Haruka refused to be dragged along by Keiko's excitement .

'Anyway, I'm starved . '

Gotou interrupted the parent-child banter .

'We came all this way because you said you'd let us eat something . '

Yakumo made a follow-up comment .

It seemed like neither of them knew the word restraint .

'Sorry . This was so sudden . The part-time worker's already gone home, so it'll just be whatever we have on hand . '

'I don't mind . '

'No problem here . '

After Yakumo and Gotou replied, Keiko urged them to sit – 'Would the tatami room be all right?' – and they went to the tatami room .

The three of them sat at a long table .

Haruka hadn't thought she'd be here at home with Yakumo and Gotou . It was strange .

'Anyway, I'll get a beer,' said Gotou the moment he sat down, without looking at the menu .

'You can't drive if you drink, right?' interrupted Yakumo .

'We can just sleep in the car . '

'I refuse . '

'A sleeping bag and a car seat aren't that different, right?'

'How about this?' interrupted Keiko . She had a hand at her waist with a triumphant expression . Haruka had a somewhat bad feelings .

'You can just stay here,' said Keiko, eyes sparkling .

'Eh?'

Ignoring Haruka's surprise, Gotou slapped his knee . 'That'd be great . '

'We don't have many hands since it's the off season, so we won't be able to do much for you . '

'Anywhere's fine as long as I can sleep . Yakumo, let's stay here tonight . '

Gotou hit Yakumo's shoulder to ask for his agreement .

For just a moment, Haruka's eyes met Yakumo's . Even though it wasn't like they would be sleeping together, Haruka's face suddenly grew hot and she looked down at the tatami without thinking .

'If it isn't any trouble,' said Yakumo, running a hand through his hair .

'OK! It's decided then . '

After saying that, Keiko took a bottle of beer out of the fridge and placed it on the table along with glasses for all of them .

Gotou opened the bottle immediately and started pouring beer into each glass .

For some reason, Yakumo was looking at the amber-coloured liquid filling his glass unpleasantly .

Perhaps –

'Yakumo-kun, you can't drink?'

He glared at her .

With Keiko, Gotou called out and they clinked their glasses for form's sake .

Yakumo stuck took one sip, like he was lapping it out of the glass, and then he stuck out his tongue again, scowling . It looked like he really couldn't drink .

– That's a bit cute .

When Keiko asked for their orders, Gotou just said, 'We'll leave it to you . '

'Leave it to me then,' said Keiko . She finished drinking her glass of beer and then went into the kitchen .

Haruka couldn't hear clearly, but there was talking in the kitchen . Keiko was probably talking with Haruka's father, Kazuhiro .

'This your parents' shop, Haruka-chan?' asked Gotou, pouring himself a second glass of beer .

'Yes . Though there are also a number of part-time workers . '

'Is your dad the cook?'

'My father's fairly famous . He's even been in some gourmet magazines . '

'Oh? We should greet him . Since we'll be staying for a night . '

'I'll introduce you afterwards . '

When Haruka finished speaking, there was a loud cracking sound of something breaking in the kitchen .

– What?

Haruka turned around to see Kazuhiro fly out of the kitchen with a red face .

He had a small frame with his hair trimmed short, but his eyebrows and the corners of his eyes were low on his face, so he looked a bit unreliable . He was normally gentle – Haruka couldn't remember him ever being angry .

Now, Kazuhiro's cheeks were twitching and he was gritting his teeth as he glared .

'D-Dad, I'm home . '

Haruka called out to him, but Kazuhiro didn't appear to hear . He alternated his glare between Yakumo and Gotou .

'Which one's Yakumo?' asked Kazuhiro in a low voice .

Haruka looked at the kitchen and saw Keiko peering out from inside as she stifled her laughter .

'He's Yakumo . '

Ignoring Haruka, who was troubled for a response, Yakumo pointed at Gotou with a disinterested expression .

'You?'

'Hah?'

Kazuhiro approached Gotou .

Gotou cocked his head in confusion .

'Somebody like you . '

'Hah?'

'What's good about this unattractive middle-aged man?'

Kazuhiro looked at Haruka .

There appeared to be a crazy misunderstanding .

'That's not it . Yakumo's that one . '

Gotou seemed to realise what had happened and pointed at Yakumo .

'What?'

With the speed of a beast hunting prey, Kazuhiro looked to Yakumo, but Yakumo just looked with disinterest at the soba refining process written on the back of the menu .

'He treats Haruka-chan like a slave . If you don't do something soon, it'll be a problem,' Gotou continued with a large grin as he fanned the fire .

'A-a slave?'

Kazuhiro's eyes went so wide they looked like they would fall out .

Kazuhiro was serious, but because of that, he didn't understand jokes . He believed everything he was told .

'All right, all right . Calm down a bit, dear . '

Keiko, perhaps satisfied by the teasing she'd done, took Kazuhiro's arm and pulled him back into the kitchen .

– This is the worst .

Haruka lay on the table, exhausted .

'Why is your father picking a fight with me?' complained Yakumo, his chin in his hands .

'Because you're toying with his unmarried daughter . '

Gotou's shoulders were shaking in laughter .

'What are you talking about?'

'Don't act like you don't understand . '

'I don't . '

Even Yakumo was angry now .

There was no point continuing this conversation .

'Hey . What are we going to do next?'

Haruka sat up straight and changed the topic .

'Ah, that's right . Let's clean this up fast,' agreed Gotou, placing his glass on the table .

'I'm also curious about where that girl has disappeared to . '

Yakumo had looked tired, but his gaze suddenly became serious .

'Is that girl OK?'

'Yes, probably . '

Yakumo replied to Gotou's question .

'How do you know?'

'Earlier, we discussed being spirited away . '

'Yeah . '

'This is my theory, but I think that such incidents are caused by ghosts . '

'What do you mean?'

Gotou's face twisted in confusion .

'Tengu and demons only exist in humans' imaginations . Things that do not exist cannot make somebody disappear . '

'Right,' replied Gotou with a belch .

'However, people really do disappear without any notice – in that sense, people are spirited away . Then why do they disappear?'

'They were in some sort of accident . '

Haruka said the first thing that came to mind . Then, Yakumo glared at her .

'I'm not talking about accidents right now . '

'S-sorry . '

You don't have to say it that way – Yakumo was unusually displeased, perhaps because of what just happened earlier .

'So why do they disappear?'

Gotou went back on topic .

'Probably...'

As Yakumo said that, Kazuhiro brought bowls for the three of them on a wooden tray .

Kazuhiro wasn't good with words so he rarely left the kitchen, leaving the customers to Keiko . So what was happening now –

Kazuhiro placed the bowls in front of them silently .

He didn't forget to glare at Yakumo when he left .

'What's this?'

Gotou stuck his chopsticks into the bowl .

'You don't know? It's sobagaki[1] . '

'Sobagaki?'

Gotou cocked his head .

Though it was famous in Nagano as local cuisine, it wasn't common in Tokyo restaurants – perhaps there were many people he didn't know about it .

'Buckwheat flour is kneaded into a mochi-like state . It's delicious . '

Its appearance and colour was similar to a rock, but its fluffy texture and the way the aroma of buckwheat spread through your mouth was amazing .

'Oh! This goes well with the beer . '

As Gotou ate, he expressed his pleasure .

'Right?'

It made Haruka happy to hear her home cooking praised .

Come to think of it, Haruka hadn't eaten sobagaki at home much recently either . After murmuring 'Let's eat' in her heart, she picked up her chopsticks . Kazuhiro's sobagaki was softer than the other stores' . That feeling filled her mouth .

– This taste . It's Dad's .

'Is this really sobagaki? It just looks like a rock to me,' said Yakumo, ruining the atmosphere .

– Honestly . This contrary guy .

'If you're going to say that, you don't have to eat . '

'Look . '

Yakumo showed the inside of his bowl .

There was a plop as a rock rolled in his bowl .

Haruka couldn't believe it . Yakumo's bowl had a real rock in it .

'Hey! Dad!'

Haruka let out an angry yell .

3

'Ack . '

Ishii fell backwards .

The black shadow that came flying at him was human . The person sat on top of Ishii and swung something .

A sharp pain ran through his left shoulder .

'Aah!'

It appeared he had been stabbed by something .

He looked to see a surgical scalpel . It had stabbed the top of his shoulder .
Blood was coming out, dyeing his shirt .

'Ishii-san, it's been a while . '

He heard a voice in his ear .

Though it had a bewitching echo to it, there was something incredibly dark eddying in it . It was a voice he could never forget .

– Nanase Miyuki .

'You can scream if it hurts . '

Nanase Miyuki brought herself close to Ishii's face .

The left half of her was covered in burns . There was no trace of her graceful self .

Miyuki twisted the scalpel in Ishii's shoulder, gouging the wound . A pain incomparable to the one earlier ran through his shoulder .

'Ack...'

Ishii bore with the pain .

If I scream now, it'll be her win – that was how he felt .

'Why not call for help? Chief Miyagawa might come . '

'Eh?'

She knew that Miyagawa was here .

For her to be so composed – a bad feeling spread within Ishii .

'From that world . '

Miyuki's eyes had a cold light .

'T-that's...'

Miyagawa was killed – Ishii couldn't accept what Miyuki said .

'Even though I thought you were just useless, you sniffed this place out .
You're unexpectedly troublesome . '

'I...'

'Would you die already?'

Miyuki smirked .

The terror in Ishii suddenly grew . She wasn't joking . If she said she would kill him, she really would .

Miyuki pulled the scalpel out of Ishii's shoulder .

Then, an electrifying pain ran through it, and he twisted his face without thinking .

'Farewell,' said Miyuki, raising the bloody scalpel .

– No . No . No . I don't want to die yet!

Within Ishii, stronger than fear, a tenacity for life took root . Compelled by that feeling, Ishii suddenly grabbed Miyuki's left arm .

'Aah!'

Then, Miyuki screamed and let go of Ishii .

Ishii stood up reflexively .

Miyuki held her left arm as she knelt on the floor and glared at Ishii . Then, Ishii remembered what Higashino had said .

She broke her arm in the accident –

Ishii's action of the moment had luckily hit her weak point . However, though he had saved his life, that was only temporary . He would be killed unless he got out of this situation .

While pressing the injury in his left shoulder, he confronted Miyuki .

– What do I do?

He tried to work his brain, but his fear was getting in the way . A cold sweat ran down his back and his knees were shaking .

While he couldn't think of anything, Miyuki slowly got up . Her right hand held the scalpel . He would be killed like this .

He tried to run, but his legs wouldn't move .

– Move, move, move .

He hit his knees, but it was no good . Miyuki slowly walked towards him and raised the scalpel .

– It's too late .

The moment he thought that, the door opened and Miyagawa ran in .

'Ishii!'

'Chief Miyagawa...'

Miyagawa was bleeding from his forehead . Miyuki had probably hit him .

There was the sound of something cracking .

Ishii looked to see that Miyuki had broken the glass in the window and was about to climb out .

– I have to follow her .

Ishii thought that for a moment before his knees buckled underneath him . His nervousness had fled him .

'You kept your life then . '

Ishii looked over to see Miyagawa had sat down as well .

It was just as Miyagawa said . It was a good thing she fled –

Ishii heaved a sigh of relief .

4

After eating, Gotou went to the separate two-storey building .

He went in through the entrance to see a counter . He got a key there and was taken to the room at the very back of the first floor .

It was a Japanese room of ten tatami in size with a table, fridge and television .

Haruka's family mainly worked at the soba shop but it had a Japanese inn as well . It seemed that there were quite a number of soba shops with inns for tourists in the Togakushi area .

That was why Keiko could easily tell two men who suddenly came by to stay .

A yukata[2] was prepared for him . Though there was no hot spring, there was a cypress bath, so Gotou submerged himself in it . When he came back, two futon had been laid out .

– Good preparation .

When Gotou opened the fridge, there was a row of beer cans . This was good preparation too .

With no reservation, Gotou opened a can of beer and took a gulp .

It really was different drinking right out of the bath . The cold beer flowed through his warmed body, spreading to every part of him .

After taking a breath, he took out his mobile phone . Ishii had called an incredible number of times, but it was probably nothing, so he ignored Ishii and called home .

<Hello . >

Atsuko picked up at the first ring .

'It's me . '

<Will you be late tonight?>

Atsuko, who didn't know the situation, sounded relaxed through the phone .

'I don't think I'll be back . '

<Staying overnight?>

'I'm in Nagano now . '

<Nagano? .

Even Atsuko sounded surprised .

Gotou quickly explained what had happened up until now . When Atsuko said <I see>, it sounded disappointed to Gotou, but it was probably just his imagination .

'So how's Nao?' said Gotou, changing the subject . Atsuko's mood changed in an instant .

<She's already asleep . She loves the teddy bear she got for her birthday present . She even brought it to the bath . It was quite the problem . '

Yakumo and Haruka had bought it for Nao's birthday .

'She likes it that much?'

<She says it looks like you . >

Gotou snorted without thinking .

Come to think of it, when Nao drew a picture of Gotou bear, it looked just like a bear .

He'd asked, 'Am I a bear?' Then they laughed together .

<Will you be back by tomorrow?>

'I don't know . It might be a bit tough . '

They didn't know anything about this case yet . It didn't seem like there would be a sudden breakthrough . After coming this far, Gotou planned on sticking with them the whole way .

<Be careful . >

Gotou felt hot at Atsuko's words .

Am I blushing – no . Just the alcohol .

'Good evening . '

Just as Gotou hung up, the door to the room opened, and Haruka showed up in room wear .

She had probably just got out of the bath . Her hair was a bit damp .

'Hey . '

'Oh? Where's Yakumo-kun?' asked Haruka, looking around the room .

'Still in the bath . '

'It's been a while, hasn't it?'

'He's always used the school showers . He's probably relaxing in the tub . '

'I see...'

'He'll probably be back soon though?'

'Then I'll wait . '

Haruka sat on the tatami .

'Your dad was pretty angry,' said Gotou, handing Haruka a can of beer .

'Honestly . That was just too much . '

Haruka pouted, seeming displeased .

It seemed like she was rather unhappy about her father's trying to make Yakumo eat a rock . It wasn't like Gotou didn't understand how Haruka felt . But –

'I understand how your dad feels . '

No matter the situation, his daughter, who lived far away, had suddenly brought back a man . There was no way he wouldn't be angry .

'I didn't think I'd hear that from you, Gotou-san . '

'I wouldn't have understood before . But...'

'Is it Nao-chan?'

'Even I've started to feel like a parent . '

Though it had only been a short time, Nao's presence had brought a drastic change to the Gotou couple . He felt like this was what it meant to become a parent .

'Would you be angry if Nao-chan brought back a boyfriend?'

'I'd smack him down!' yelled Gotou, becoming serious without intending to .

'You wouldn't accept him?'

'Impossible . '

'How intolerant . '

'I don't care . I feel bad for your dad too, Haruka-chan . Since it's Yakumo of all people . '

'What dissatisfies you about me?'

With bad timing, Yakumo opened the door and came in .

Since Yakumo had pale skin, his cheeks were flushed more than usual after coming out of the bath . His hair was also straight, unlike its usual bedhead .

'Nothing . '

'Please think about me, since I have to use the same bath and sleep in the same room as you of all people, Gotou-san . '

In his yukata, Yakumo casually dried off his hair with a towel and sat cross-legged on the futon .

'If you don't want to be with me, why not sleep with Haruka-chan?' said Gotou, knowing Yakumo would be angry .

Just as expected, Yakumo sent Gotou an incredible glare .

Meanwhile, Haruka went red to her eyes and dropped her gaze to the tatami .

'We aren't in a situation where you can tell jokes that aren't funny,' said Yakumo, looking annoyed as he put the towel he used to dry his hair around his neck .

'All right, all right . So what are we going to do?'

Gotou finished drinking his beer, crushed the empty can and left it on the table .

'Continuing where I left off earlier, but I think that the spiriting away incident is related to the ghost Masato saw . '

When Yakumo said that, Haruka recalled the spirit photo Masato had shown them .

The black shadow by the rock that was a shrine –

'So a ghost made the person disappear?'

'Gotou-san, you're an idiot,' said Yakumo, exasperated .

'That's what you said, right?'

'I didn't say anything like that . I just said that a ghost was involved . '

'How is it involved?' interrupted Haruka .

'Possession . '

Yakumo's eyes narrowed .

'Possession – so a ghost took over her body?' asked Gotou to check .

'Correct . It is likely that a ghost possessed that girl and led her to leave home with her own feet and disappear . '

'Like hypnotism?'

'Similar . I think that most cases of spiriting away happen like this . '

Gotou felt like he understood .

He'd seen people possessed by ghosts before . They did things they wouldn't normally do and even lost consciousness temporarily .

Looking at it like this, it was just like being spirited away .

If the girl called Yumiko was currently in this situation, her illogical actions made sense .

But then Haruka had a question .

'Hey . Is Yumiko-chan all right?'

'I can't say anything at this stage . Furthermore, I am also concerned about her weakening body . '

Yakumo's shoulders fell, as if he was exhausted, and he looked up at the ceiling .

'What do you mean?'

'Exactly what I said . She's been possessed by a ghost and walking around without drinking or eating . '

'Three or four days,' Gotou continued .

Since she disappeared yesterday, today would be the second . They couldn't relax .

'Hey . Let's go look for her . '

Haruka leant forward unconsciously .

'The local police and firefighters will search . Furthermore, if we move around in the forest at night, we'll be the ones who disappear . '

Even though Yakumo said that disinterestedly, his expression was hard .

It was just as Yakumo said .

Even if they did the same thing as the police and firefighters were doing, they wouldn't be much help . They would just have to find Yumiko using the methods only they could use . But –

'What should we do?'

'First, we find out what the ghost Masato saw was – we need to make that clear,' said Yakumo quietly .

5

'Ouch!'

Ishii cried out without thinking .

Though the emergency officers treated his wound, the disinfectant stung more than he thought it would .

But feeling pain was a part of living .

The moment Nanase Miyuki attacked him, the reason Ishii could move his body, frozen from fear, was because of his tenacity for life .

Ishii looked up in pain at the <Kinoshita Surgery: Maternity and Gynaecology Department> building .

It was surrounded by police cars and lit up by outdoor lights . Detectives and forensic officers were running amok .

The quietness from earlier had disappeared .

'You all right?'

Miyagawa walked towards him with a gauze bandage wrapped around his head .

'Yes, somehow... Thank you very much . It would have become a situation if you had not been there, Chief Miyagawa . '

Ishii bowed his head .

Even though Miyagawa had been injured then, he ran into the room to save Ishii . Otherwise, Ishii might have died .

'That doesn't warrant thanks . '

'If only Detective Gotou were here now...'

Ishii hadn't meant to say it, but it slipped out of his mouth .

For Ishii, Gotou was a pillar . Having him there made it possible for Ishii to advance .

'Still can't contact him?'

Miyagawa sent him a sharp glaze .

'I can't . I've called him a number of times, but...'

Ishii had just called him earlier, but the phone just kept ringing and Gotou didn't answer . He was worried that something had happened to him .

However, it looked like Miyagawa had a different impression .

'Just forget about that idiot . '

'B-but...'

'Ishii . You rely too much on Gotou . '

'That is...'

It was absolutely right . I have to act on my own – is what he thought, but when it came to the crunch, he froze .

'You're doing great even without Gotou . '

'I have no confidence...'

Ishii had just dropped his gaze to his feet when a forensics officer ran over with a dreadful expression .

'Chief Miyagawa . '

'What's wrong?'

'There's something I would like you to look at...'

'Got it . Ishii, let's go . '

'Ah, yes sir . '

Called by Miyagawa, Ishii followed the forensics officer through the <Kinoshita Surgery: Maternity and Gynaecology Department> entrance .

For a moment, Ishii prepared himself, but he didn't feel frightened because the lights were on and it was full of detectives .

They went down the corridor to the delivery room where Miyuki had attacked him .

Unlike earlier, the whole room was lit up .

Medicine and medical tools were scattered across the floor which was splattered with blood . It was probably from the mess earlier .

'Please look at this . '

The forensics officer stood in front of the cold storage in the corner of the room . It was probably for medicine that needed to be refrigerated .

'May I open it?'

The officer looked at Miyagawa and Ishii .

Ishii felt strangely nervous because of the way the officer was acting . Ishii took a deep breath to calm himself down .

Miyagawa sent the officer a signal with his eyes and the officer opened the cold storage door .

'Eek!'

Ishii jumped back with a scream without thinking .

He couldn't believe what he'd seen . It wasn't possible –

'The hell is that?'

Even Miyagawa was surprised, looking inside the cold storage with a bitter expression .

Ishii wiped the sweat off his forehead and looked inside the cold storage again .

He groaned quietly . There was no mistaking what he was looking at .

In the cold storage, there was a glass cylinder . Inside it was a human head –

6

The next morning, Haruka waited for Yakumo and Gotou in front of the car in the parking lot .

They had decided to change their investigation direction after eating breakfast .

However, even though their appointment time was past, neither Gotou nor Yakumo had showed up . Haruka was just thinking about going to their

room to pick them up when Yakumo walked towards her with an incredibly sleepy expression .

His hair was such a mess that she wanted to ask how he had slept .

'You're late,' complained Haruka as she waited for Yakumo to arrive .

However, Yakumo didn't look like he felt guilty .

'It isn't my fault . Gotou-san's snoring was so loud I couldn't sleep . '

'That's quite a mouth you've got . The way you sleep is even worse,' interrupted Gotou, coming after Yakumo .

'It makes sense for me to turn about in my sleep when your snoring is so loud . '

'You just keep going on, brat . '

'Anyway, what are we going to do?' interrupted Haruka .

It would have been fine to let them continue if they were on holiday, but they had to search for Yumiko, who had gone missing .

'We talked last night about how a ghost might be possessing the girl who's gone missing,' said Yakumo, running a hand through his hair .

'Yeah . '

'First, we need to determine what that ghost is and why its goal in wandering . '

'What do you mean by goal?'

When Haruka asked that, Yakumo let out an exasperated sigh .

'I've said this before, haven't I? Ghosts were originally human . '

'Right . '

That was Yakumo's theory .

Ghosts weren't some new form of creature or demon . They were like a cluster of the emotions of people who died – that was why there was feeling there .

'It shouldn't be wandering recklessly – there should be a goal in its actions . If we make that clear, we should be able to find it . '

'I see . ' agreed Gotou .

Haruka understood that much, but the problem was –

'How do we make that clear?'

'I'm going to explain that now . '

Yakumo glared at him .

Haruka felt like he was displeased with her for getting ahead of him, so she said, 'Sorry,' looking at the floor .

'We will split up from here on . First, you and Masato will look into whether any murders and disappearances have occurred in the Togakushi and Kinasa region . '

Then they could probably determine who the ghost possession Yumiko was .

'OK . But...'

She didn't mind investigating, but she didn't know how .

'Just get Makoto-san to introduce you to some local newspaper reporter . '

'Ah, right,' said Haruka .

A newspaper reporter probably knew that sort of information . Makoto, a newspaper reporter in Tokyo, could introduce them to a local one . But –

'Wouldn't it be quicker for Gotou-san to go to the local police?'

'Don't be stupid,' Gotou replied immediately .

'Stupid...'

'I'm in the Metropolitan Police Department . IF I sniff around in the Nagano jurisdiction, there'll be a lot of fuss . '

'Really?'

'Police are serious about their own turf . '

Gotou shook his head, like he thought it annoying .

'It sounds rather troublesome . '

“Well, that's how it is . So what are we going to do?” Gotou asked Yakumo disgruntledly .

'Gotou-san and I will go there once more . '

As Yakumo said that, his eyes looked somewhat sad .

7

'Hey, tell me if you understand something . '

As Gotou drove, he looked at Yakumo in the passenger seat .

Though he looked like he was just gazing out the window, Yakumo's heads must have been filled with circling thoughts .

'What are you talking about?' replied Yakumo was a yawn .

No matter how he tried to look expressionless, Gotou could tell, since he'd known him for so long . Yakumo was hiding something .

'Don't play the fool . We're going there again 'cause you have some hunch, right?'

When Gotou said that, Yakumo laughed self-derisively .

'That's rather sharp for you, Gotou-san . '

'You said one thing too much . '

'That's Kinasa . '

'I know the name of the place,' replied Gotou peevishly .

A number of years ago, it had combined with three other villages to join Nagano city, but before that, it had been called Kinasa . It was a small village in the north of Nagano prefecture by the source of the Susobana River .

'That isn't it . There's a special place here . '

'Special?'

'Momijigari[3] . '

'Momijigari? Sounds like a school trip . '

'As usual, you have a pathetic imagination . '

'Shut up . Don't circle the subject and just get to the point . '

Gotou's irritation was obvious .

Yakumo glanced at Gotou and then started explaining with incredible reluctance .

'There once was a couple who couldn't have children, so they made an offering to the demon king and received a baby girl . Her name was Kureha . It is said that she had unusual spiritual power ever since she was born . '

'Oh?'

Though the conversation had taken an unexpected turn, it was perfect for killing some time before they got there, so Gotou urged Yakumo to continue .

'After time passed, Kureha grew to be a beautiful woman, so her name was changed to Momiji and she went to Kyoto . There, she caught the eye of an influential person at the time named Minamoto no Tsunemoto and she gained his favour . '

'Sounds like smooth sailing . '

'It wasn't . After a while, an unknown sickness spread through the imperial court . '

'Sickness?'

'Yes . A priest was called from Mount Hiei[4] to determine the cause of the sickness . He said that the cause of the sickness was Momiji's curse, so she was chased out of Kyoto . '

'Was it really Momiji's curse?'

When Gotou asked that, Yakumo sent him a hateful glance .

'I don't know . Anyway, after being chased out of Kyoto, she reached a settlement called Minase and she lived quietly there for a while . '

For a while – which meant there was more to this story .

'Then what happened?'

'One day, she suddenly changed and led a group to attack villages .

'Like mountain bandits?'

'Well, something like that . People started to call her a witch, or a demon woman . '

'Demon...'

'Yes . This story travelled to Kyoto, and Minamoto no Tsukemoto despatched Taira no Koremichi to subdue the witch . However, he couldn't do anything against her witchcraft . One day, an old priest appeared in Koremichi's dream and gave him a demon-killing sword . He sliced off Momiji's head with that sword and killed her . '

'Sliced off her head, eh...'

'Ever since then, the area was called the place the demon left – Kinasa . '

Gotou understood Yakumo's summary . But –

'You saying that witch was the ghost Masato saw?'

'Of course not . '

Yakumo looked at Gotou coldly .

'Hah? That's what you were talking about, right?'

'What was I talking about?'

'The story about the witch . '

'Who said that it was related? In the first place, this Momiji legend is over a thousand years old . '

It was true that Yakumo hadn't said it was related . He had just suddenly talked about it .

'Then why did you talk about it?'

'To kill time . '

– This brat!

Gotou thought about yelling, but he decided against it . Even that would just be killing time for Yakumo .

Gotou didn't know what Yakumo was hiding, but there was no point talking now .

He'd understand soon enough –

8

Ishii entered the <Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room> .

He had undergone treatment at the hospital, so he arrived a bit late, but Gotou still wasn't there .

As he sighed and sat down, a jolt of pain ran through his left shoulder .

It was where he had been stabbed the night before . Though the injury hadn't been that deep, it had required four stitches .

He didn't like the situation with Nanase Miyuki, but he was more concerned about Gotou . Ishii decided to try calling him once more . Just as he took out his mobile phone, the door opened .

Makoto came into the room .

'Ishii-san!'

Makoto rushed towards him .

'Eh, ah, Makoto-san...'

'Are you all right?'

'Yes, my shoulder is just slightly injured . '

'I'm so glad . '

Ishii smiled wryly while pressing a hand against his wound . Makoto sighed in relief .

It seemed she had been worried for him .

'I was surprised . When I heard that you were injured, Ishii-san...'

'Is that so?'

'She escaped then . '

Makoto's expression suddenly turned serious .

Even she, a newspaper reporter, had heard about Nanase Miyuki's escape .

'She did . '

There was no point hiding it now . Ishii nodded .

'Is that why Detective Gotou is in Nagano?' Makoto said quietly, bringing her face close to Ishii's .

'Eh?'

– Gotou? Nagano?

Though Makoto was calm, Ishii didn't understand what she was talking about .

'What did you say just now?'

'I asked whether Detective Gotou is in Nagano for the Nanase Miyuki case .
,

'W-w-what are you talking about now? Detective Gotou in Nagano...'

Ishii was so agitated he stood up, knocking his forehead into Makoto's .

Makoto cowered, holding her forehead .

'I-I'm sorry!'

Ishii hurriedly apologised . Makoto smiled back as she rubbed her forehead .

'I'm fine . More importantly, you didn't know?'

'I didn't . Actually, I've been troubled since I haven't been able to contact Detective Gotou since yesterday . '

'Really? Actually, Haruka-chan called me this morning . '

'Haruka-chan?'

Ishii was even more confused .

'Yes . She wanted me to introduce her to a reporter in Nagano prefecture for a case no matter what . I don't know the details, but it seems Detective Gotou and Yakumo-kun are there with her too...'

'I see . '

Ishii finally understood .

Yakumo and Haruka had probably brought some trouble to Gotou, so he'd gone to Nagano .

As long as he was fine, it was OK .

'Anyway, about the Nanase Miyuki matter...'

Interrupting Makoto as she tried to get back on topic, the door opened forcefully and Miyagawa ran in with a red face .

He still had a bandage around his head .

'Gotou's still out?' said Miyagawa, looking around the room .

Though Ishii stood up, he didn't know what to say next .

He knew where Gotou was from what Makoto said just now, but it was an absence from work without permission . He wouldn't be let off the hook easily if he told Miyagawa that .

'That idiot...'

Miyagawa seemed to sense the situation even without Ishii saying anything, as he said that while clicking his tongue .

Ishii just stood there in fear .

'Ishii, we're going, even if it's just you . '

'Ah, yes sir . '

'Goodbye then,' Ishii said to Makoto with a bow . Then, he left the room with Miyagawa .

'What happened?' he asked as they walked .

'There's something I want you to see . '

'W-what is it?'

'You'll know when you see it . '

Miyagawa's careless words felt unlucky to Ishii .

9

'Couldn't sleep?' said Haruka to Masato, sitting beside her .

Just like yesterday, they were sitting at a table in the coffee shop inside Nagano Station .

'I'm fine . '

Though he said that, Masato's eyes were puffy and his face was pale too .

– This child is still blaming himself .

It was obvious to Haruka . IT was the same with the last case . He blamed himself more than necessary and shut up inside himself .

'It's not your fault, Masato-kun . '

Masato shook his head .

'It is my fault . Because I ran away . Tomoya-kun said that too...'

Masato's neck stiffened along with his body .

The boy called Tomoya had been with Masato when Yumiko disappeared .

Though Haruka hadn't met him to talk, she felt like Tomoya's words had a different meaning .

The boy called Tomoya was probably blaming himself too, but he couldn't accept that so he turned his anger towards Masato .

So –

'It's fine,' said Haruka, hugging Masato's shoulders .

'Er... Ozawa-san, correct?'

A tall man greeted her . He looked to be in his thirties . He wore a casual outfit of red-framed glasses and a jacket with jeans . Though he had a beard around his mouth, it was trimmed neatly .

'Yoshii-san, yes?'

When Haruka said the name she'd heard from Haruka, he replied with an incredibly happy expression, 'Yes . '

'I'm sorry to have you come all this way . '

Haruka stood up and bowed her head . Masato did the same .

'It's a request from Hijikata . I don't mind at all . '

Yoshii waved his hand, sat down opposite them and ordered a coffee .

'Did you know Makoto-san from before?' asked Haruka .

'Actually, she was a year under me in university . '

'Really?'

'Since she was pretty quiet, I didn't know if she'd do OK in a newspaper agency, but it seems like she's just fine . '

After saying that, Yoshii laughed aloud .

It appeared he was somebody who said things straight out . Though Haruka had been a bit on guard, she felt more at ease now .

'Well, to get to the point, you want to hear about incidents around Kinasa and Togakushi, right?'

After a pause, Yoshii brought up the topic at hand as he sipped his coffee .

'Yes . '

'Ignoring crimes like theft, there was just one incident...'

Yoshii took a folder out of his bag and spread it open on the table . It was a copy of a newspaper article .

The title on the front was <Brutally murdered corpses found at Sunahachiyama!> .

Sunahachiyama was the mountain separating Kinasa and Togakushi, and it was where the witch that came up in the Momijigari legend was said to be . It was known for having a cavern of demons .

The date on the newspaper was more than twenty years ago –

The words brutally murdered stood out, piercing Haruka's heart .

After taking a deep breath, Haruka continued to read past the title .

<Brutally murdered corpses of two men were found at a cottage . The two had gone missing two days ago . The local firefighters had been searching for them ->

Perhaps the brutally murdered corpses were the ghosts possessing Yumiko . That was what Haruka thought, but two men had been killed .

It seemed like it wasn't that simple .

Yoshii started explaining as he flipped through a notebook .

'It happened around Togakushi and Kinasa . It was a pretty big incident . '

'Are there no other cases?'

'There aren't . They're small villages,' said Yoshii, lighting a cigarette .

'What happened with this case?' asked Haruka, curious .

'The article after that is in the file too . '

'Thank you very much . '

'The culprit for the incident wasn't actually caught,' said Yoshii, blowing out cigarette smoke towards the ceiling .

'Eh? Really?'

'Yeah . The statute of limitations is already up . And...'

Here, Yoshii paused and leaned forward before speaking in a lower tone .

'It's clear that this wasn't some casual crime like robbery . '

'Why is that?'

'The corpses were stabbed all over with a knife . '

'Stabbed all over...'

Haruka gulped unconsciously .

'Plus, there were scrapes and bruises too . The police said there might have been torture . '

– Torture .

Haruka murmured that in her heart .

She felt her shoulders grow heavy .

'Why would they do that?'

'Who knows? The culprit wasn't caught . '

'That's right...'

Haruka looked to her side and saw that Masato was very pale .

It had been more awful than she had imagined it would be . She shouldn't keep Masato here .

'Masato-kun, want to wait outside?'

'I'm fine . '

Masato shook his head .

Though he was afraid, he probably wanted to find Yumiko more . Haruka decided to continue talking . '

'What sort of people were the victims?'

'A local officer of the village and the landowner's son . Both of them were men . '

'Why would that happen?'

'Though I investigated around...'

Yoshii smiled, like he'd been waiting, and put his cigarette out in the ashtray .

'What is it?'

'This is just a rumour, but at the time, people wondered if it was a curse . '

'There's no such thing as a curse . '

Masato was the one who said that . He leant forward, looking at Yoshii challengingly .

The word <curse> has a special meaning to Masato . In an incident he was involved in before, the word <curse> had thrown Masato about, making him suffer .

'That's right . There's no such thing as a curse,' said Haruka, agreeing with Masato .

For a moment, Yoshii leant back, seeming surprised, but then he fixed the collar of his jacket and continued .

'Well, putting aside whether there are curses or not – there's a reason why there was a fuss about that . '

'Reason?'

'Do you know about Momijigari?'

'The legend of the witch?'

'Right . '

Yoshii nodded, seeming satisfied .

Anybody from the region would know the Momijigari legend . It was known even in Noh theatre and performed every year .

'My dad used to be a reporter too and I heard from him, but forty-five years ago, there was some turmoil with the witch in Kinasa . '

'Eh, but wasn't that more than a thousand years ago...'

'Well, it'd be more correct to say it was similar . '

'Similar?'

'One day, a young man was brought into the clinic in Kinasa . He'd been healthy the day before, but after he died right after he was brought in .

'Huh...'

Haruka nodded .

At this point, nothing connected the story to Momijigari .

'That clinic had been reputable before, but after that, it was said that this was the curse of the lady there . She was called a witch and people wanted to chase her out of the village . '

'Then what happened?'

'I don't know . '

'Eh?'

Haruka had thought Yoshii knew the circumstances from the way he was talking about it, so she felt let down .

'That clinic isn't around anymore . '

'Is that so?'

'The person who egged the villagers on to chase the witch out was the victim of this case . '

Yoshii tapped the file on the table .

A jolt went through Haruka's spine . The same thing seemed to happen to Masato . His eyes were wide open .

– That's why it was called a curse .

If what Yoshii said was true, it wouldn't be strange for there to be a rumour like that .

'If you want to find out about the case in more detail, I'll introduce you to somebody who knows about it . '

'I would appreciate it,' said Haruka, leaning forward .

10

'Ahh . '

After getting off the car, Gotou put his hands at his waist, looked up at the sky and stretched .

Normally, he just drove through shopping and residential districts . He wasn't used to driving winding mountain roads . It was more exhausting than he'd thought it would be .

'It's unbecoming, so please don't make strange noises . '

Yakumo got off the car with a yawn .

– This brat .

'You drive back then . You have a licence, right?'

'I refuse . '

'Why?'

'I've decided not to drive ever since the incident with the tunnel . '

– Ah, that .

Strangely, Gotou understood .

Ignoring Gotou, Yakumo headed towards the lone cedar tree, walking through the white skunk cabbage .

'Honestly . '

Even as Gotou grumbled, he followed Yakumo's back .

'Why's such a huge cedar tree here anyway?' asked Gotou, looking up at the cedar tree once more .

In a marshy area of white skunk cabbage, there was just one cedar tree and the rock at its roots . It was elegant but also unnatural .

'I talked about the story of Momijigari earlier,' said Yakumo .

'Yeah . '

'I said this was a shrine last night too . '

'Right . '

A shrine was like an altar . Where something was enshrined .

'This is probably where the head of the witch in the story about Momijigari was buried . '

'What?'

Though Gotou was surprised, at the same time, he understood . So that was why this was a shrine .

Gotou didn't know whether the legend of Momijigari was true or not, but the people at the time might've put a large stone here and grew a cedar tree to keep her here .

There was no way for Gotou to know the truth now though .

'Gotou-san, if you have the time to space out, please help . '

Yakumo had his hand at his waist and looked incredibly resentful .

'Help with what?'

'To move this . '

Yakumo pointed at the statue by the rock .

Moving his body was Gotou's strength . After taking off his jacket and placing it on the rock, he rolled up his sleeves and moved the stone statue as Yakumo directed .

It took some effort since it was heavier than expected, but Gotou managed somehow .

'Next, please dig here . '

Yakumo pointed at the place where the statue had been .

'Why?'

'You'll find out if you dig . '

'You the Hanasaka Jiisan[5]?'

'If you have the time to tell boring jokes, please just do it already . '

'Right, right . '

– As usual, the guy never stops talking .

While expressing his dissatisfaction in his heart, Gotou took a nearby tree branch and started digging .

Since the ground was wet, the earth was soft and easy to dig . Gotou wiped his sweat with his shirt and silently continued his work .

Suddenly, he noticed that he couldn't see Yakumo anymore .

When Gotou stood up and looked around, he spotted Yakumo talking on his phone a little ways away .

Gotou thought about complaining, but he decided against it . It was probably news from Haruka .

After breathing out, Gotou started digging the earth again .

'Are you done?'

After a while, Yakumo came back .

'You help too . '

'I don't want to . My hands will get dirty . '

– This brat!

Gotou swallowed his rising anger .

'How's the situation with Haruka?'

'It seems there was a murder case twenty years ago . '

'Then the person in that photo...'

'The truth isn't as simple as you are, Gotou-san . '

– This guy just keeps on going .

'What do you mean?'

'The people killed were a local officer and the landowner's son . Both were men . '

The person in the photo was a woman . It didn't match up . Even though Gotou knew the situation now, Yakumo could have put it more nicely .

'Honestly...'

Gotou let out a breath and returned to digging the earth .

After digging about eighty centimetres, he hit something hard .

He put down the branch and brushed away the dirt to find something round and pale . Gotou realised what it was immediately .

There was no doubt about it . It was a skull .

'I dug up something unbelievable . '

Gotou stood up and wiped the sweat off his forehead .

'Gotou-san, please hurry up and call the police . '

'I'm...'

A police officer too, Gotou was about to say, but he stopped .

This was Nagano prefecture . This wasn't Gotou's jurisdiction . He'd need to contact the local police .

– Honestly . What a pain .

11

Miyagawa led Ishii to the general hospital where Hata was .

After entering the room in the basement, Hata welcomed them with a creepy demonic giggle .

The room was desolate, with just a desk and cabinets lining the room .

Hata, the coroner, was a strange man whose interests lined up with his work .

Ishii even thought that Hata himself would be arrested if he took just one step out of line .

'So, Hata-san . Is what you said true?'

Miyagawa brought up the topic at hand .

'It'd be better to see for yourself . '

Hata got up and left the room .

Miyagawa went right after him . Since Ishii didn't understand the situation, he didn't have any idea about what these two were doing .

Though he was confused, Ishii followed the two of them out of the room .

He thought that they would be going far, but it seemed he was wrong . Hata opened the door to the room beside his and went inside with Miyagawa .

Ishii entered the room as well . It was an autopsy room –

'Ugh...'

Ishii scrunched up his nose at the strange medical smell .

There was a stainless steel bed in the middle of the room with carts covered with various tools scattered around it .

The wall at the very back had doors that probably led to cold storage, and Hata opened one of them .

After putting on latex gloves, Hata took something out of the cold storage and casually placed it on top of the stainless steel bed .

'Aaah!'

Ishii leapt up with a scream .

Hata had placed a human head in a cylindrical container on top of the stainless steel bed –

'Don't make a fuss . You've seen it before, right?' rebuked Miyagawa . Hata was smiling like he thought the scene incredibly amusing .

This head was probably the one that was found last night at Kinoshita Surgery . Ishii had seen it before, but that didn't mean he could be calm .

The head was suspended in liquid in the container . It was probably formalin .

Ishii swallowed his scream and looked away from the head .

If he looked at it any longer, it would appear in his dreams .

'Ishii-kun . Get the mask and goggles from that shelf for me,' instructed Hata .

'Ah, yes . '

Ishii did as he was told and took the mask and goggles from the shelf, handing them to Hata .

'There's formalin in the container . You should wear these too,' said Hata as he put his mask on .

Formalin was antiseptic . It was popular, used in school science classrooms to preserve frogs .

However, it was on the other hand highly toxic . It would burn the mucous membrane of the eyes and mouth .

Ishii and Miyagawa put on goggles and masks as told .

'Ishii-kun, press this a bit for me . '

Hata waited for them to finish before tapping the container .

'Eh?'

– I have to touch this container?

Ishii shivered just thinking about it .

'Hurry up and do it!'

'Ah, yes, er...'

'Just hold it for a bit . '

'Just a bit . '

Ishii was forced into pressing the container with both hands .

Hata used something like pliers to take out the metal stopper and remove the container's lid .

That moment, an indescribably strong smell came through Ishii's mask .

He coughed a number of times .

Hata coolly took the head out of the container .

'Agh...'

He was already at his limit . Ishii leapt away from the bed .

'This head is a man's . '

Hata ignored Ishii and started speaking .

'I can tell from looking,' Miyagawa replied disgruntledly .

'It's been kept in formalin . The flesh is pretty swollen . It'll take quite some time to determine the time of death . '

'And?' urged Miyagawa .

'And the problem is just as I said on the phone . The eyes of this head . '

'Ishii, look . '

It seemed like Miyagawa knew Ishii hadn't been looking, because he grabbed Ishii's neck .

'Er, but...'

'To hell with your butts!'

'Y-yes sir . '

Ishii couldn't do anything when faced with Miyagawa's yell, so he looked at the head .

The colour of the skin looked strangely pale . The long black hair seemed alive . It looked like the head could start talking at any moment, which gave Ishii a shiver .

– It looks like somebody .

Ishii felt so uncomfortable he might throw up as he had that impression .

'These eyes...'

As Hata said that, he pointed at the head's eyes and wrenched them open .

There was a splintering sound .

'Aaahhh!'

Ishii was already at his limit –

Under the slowly opened eyelids were two eyes that glowed red like a blazing flame .

12

Haruka and Masato rode the bumpy municipal bus .

Besides Haruka and Masato, the only rider was a middle-aged woman napping in the seat in the very front .

Yoshii introduced them to somebody named Ookura who worked at the Kinasa Museum near Arakurayama Shrine and was supposed to know details about the event .

Haruka was able to contact Ookura immediately by phone .

She thought that Ookura might keep a distance if she mentioned the murder case right away, so she asked to talk as somebody researching the history of Masato's school .

If that's the case – was the answer she received immediately . Haruka felt bad about tricking Ookura, but there was nothing she could have done .

'Hey, Masato-kun . '

Haruka called out to Masato, who was looking down silently .

Instead of speaking, he lifted his head slightly .

His expression was as blank as if he were wearing a Noh mask . He had been like this the first time Haruka met him too .

– He's holding everything in again .

'You can't take on everything by yourself . We'll definitely find her . '

'I ran away...'

Masato bit his lower lip and sniffled .

'There was no helping it . I would've run away too . '

'But I promised big brother Yakumo that I wouldn't run away any more .
But I still...'

– I see .

So Masato had made a promise to Yakumo during the last case, saying he wouldn't run away any more . He was blaming himself for breaking that promise .

Masato might have run away when he met Yumiko on that night right, but he had done that to protect himself – he wasn't running away from the problems in front of him .

'Aren't you facing the problem properly now?'

'I...'

'Right?'

'Yumiko-chan and Tomoya-kun were nice to me . '

Masato began to speak in a hollow voice .

'Mmhm . '

'When I transferred schools, Tomoya-kun was the first to talk to me . '

'Really?'

'And he even suddenly asked whether I watched the anime that was on the night before . '

When Haruka listened to Masato's story, she found herself growing to like the boy called Tomoya even though she hadn't met him yet .

He didn't interrogate Masato when he transferred schools – instead, he connected to him like they had always been together .

'What did you reply?'

'I told him I watched it . Then Yumiko-chan started talking to me too, asking what character I liked...'

After saying that much, Masato's voice caught .

Haruka felt like Masato was correct in moving after that incident .

He had made good friends . Without caring about why Masato had transferred there, his friends had connected to him innocently, just happy that their number of friends had increased .

They had probably healed his heart, which had been hurt by the incident, and found him a place here .

That was why he felt so much pain at not having been able to save that friend .

'If something happened to Yumiko-chan, I...'

Masato shut his eyes tightly, like he was trying to hold something in .

He would become like how he was before . Masato might have been thinking that .

In the past, Masato put a wall up around his heart and was unconcerned about others – a bit cold . He had his hands full with his own problems .

Now, he hurt himself when trying frantically to save his friends .

It was an incredible change that would have been unthinkable for the old Masato .

'You must like Yumiko-chan . '

'That isn't it . I like Tomoya-kun and Yumiko-chan . '

Masato's face went bright red .

He had a disadvantageous personality . He shut away his feelings like this .
This part of him was like Yakumo .

'If Yumiko-chan is gone, Tomoya-kun will be sad too...'

Masato's shoulders shook .

'It's OK . We'll definitely find her . '

Haruka didn't want to let such a good kid feel sad . No matter what
happened, she would find Yumiko .

Haruka vowed that again in her heart .

She hugged Masato's shoulders gently and felt Masato's pulse come gently
through her arms .

13

Gotou sat on the car's bonnet as he looked up at the cedar tree .

Though the place had felt lonely earlier, it had completely changed .

There were two men that looked like detectives and about ten uniformed
officers . There were four people from investigations too . There were even
some onlookers peering in .

Since it turned out there was a whole torso buried there rather than just a
skull, with the help of local construction workers, they had started to dig it
up .

'It's unlike you to think . '

Yakumo walked towards him with a slightly scornful smile .

'Shut up . Anyway, you knew there was a body buried here, didn't you?'

Gotou brought his face close to Yakumo's .

Now that he thought about it, the meaningful words Yakumo had said yesterday were probably about the corpse . That was also he didn't let Haruka and Masato come with them .

'It's not like I had evidence . '

'It's the same thing, right?'

'It isn't . More importantly, Gotou-san, I have something I would like to talk to you about...'

Yakumo lowered his voice .

He was probably going to say something no good . While suspicious, Gotou brought his ear closer .

'I want to know the situation about the investigation into the girl's whereabouts . '

'About Yumiko-chan?'

'Couldn't you sniff around somehow?'

Yakumo glanced at the officers by the cedar tree .

'Don't ask the impossible . It's out of my jurisdiction . '

'Please work it out somehow . '

Gotou saw two men who looked like detectives walking towards them .

One was wearing a tight suit that wasn't the right size, a chubby man in his late twenties . The type who'd investigate with energy only .

He had his nose up and was snorting like a wild bull .

The other was a bald detective past his fifties . The corners of his eyes were lowered and he seemed gentle at first glance, but he had a sly air to him .

'Why were you digging there?'

The younger detective raised hell the moment he stopped in front of them, without checking their names or giving his own .

Crew cut, thick eyebrows . With dark skin, he looked like a member of a judo club .

He was obviously stubborn .

'Watch your tone . '

Even though Gotou knew that rebutting would just be his loss, he had a tendency to become serious when interacting with this type of person .

'Aren't you high and mighty!'

The agitated young detective grabbed Gotou by the collar . Gotou hadn't thought he'd be so violent .

– What a star .

Gotou grabbed the young detective by the wrist and flung him away .

The young detective rolled to the side, falling face-up onto the ground .

Gotou wasn't so old that he could be caught by some greenhorn .

'You bastard!'

The young detective stood up, bearing with the pain, and tried to approach Gotou again .

– Seems like the only thing good about him is his fighting spirit .

'Give it up already . '

The one who spoke was the bald detective .

Even though he didn't grab the young detective's arm or yell, that one sentence was enough to make the young detective stop immediately .

'I'm sorry . The blood goes to his head quickly, you see . Please forgive him . '

The bald detective bowed his head deeply, showing them his bare head .

'It's fine . '

'Our introductions are late . I'm Wakabayashi of the Nagano precinct, and this is Kurita . '

The young detective named Kurita wiped off the dirty portions of his jacket and just bowed for form's sake .

'I'm Gotou of the Setamachi precinct, from the Metropolitan Police . '

When he showed his ID, Wakabayashi's eyes narrowed and his expression suddenly hardened .

'So what's a detective from the Metropolitan Police doing here?'

– Like I said .

His calm tone hit exactly where it hurt – that was a veteran for you . Gotou wanted to reply honestly, but he couldn't say that they were searching for a ghost .

'I took some days off for a short vacation . '

'A detective from the Metropolitan Police just happened to take a break, just happened to come to Kinasa, just happened to dig under a cedar tree and just happened to dig up a skeleton – that's it, right?'

Wakabayashi smirked .

Gotou was even worse with this type .

'Everything just happened . '

'Does this happen a lot in Tokyo?'

'What?'

'Just happening to find corpses . '

– I'm really no good with guys like this .

'Oi! What about it?'

Kurita lost his temper, breaking the silence .

It felt like no matter how neat the lie, Wakabayashi would see through it .
Gotou looked to Yakumo for help .

'Do you believe in ghosts?' said Yakumo, looking up at the sky .

Even Wakabayashi had to look blank at that .

Gotou was grateful for Yakumo's help, but it felt like this would make things unnecessarily complicated .

'This brat! You making fun of us!?'

As expected, Kurita approached Yakumo, but Wakabayashi stopped him immediately .

'I do . There are ghosts . '

The corners of Wakabayashi's eyes were wrinkled as he looked at Yakumo with a friendly smile .

It felt like he was going along with the conversation for now because he didn't understand his opponent's move .

'I think that too . Ghosts exist . '

After declaring that, Yakumo put a photo on the car's bonnet .

It was the ghost photo Masato had brought them . Though it was an incredibly straight explanation of the situation, this might have been the best move .

'That cedar...'

'Yes . We were asked by the boy in this photo to see if the ghost photo was real . '

'And then you found a corpse...'

Wakabayashi rubbed his chin as he spoke .

'That's right . '

Yakumo put the photo in his pocket .

'Is that boy somebody you know?'

'He's a friend . '

'I see . I understand the situation . But would a detective from Tokyo go all this way to investigate a ghost photo?'

Wakabayashi's grizzled brows furrowed . It looked like he was still suspicious .

'This person is something like my manservant,' said Yakumo nonchalantly .

– This guy . There's something missing from what he says .

'When'd I become your manservant?'

'The day we met . '

'What'd you say? I'll kill you!'

'Wakabayashi-san, please arrest this man . He is about to commit a murder .
,

'Wakabayashi started laughing so loudly Gotou thought his jaw would come off .

'I see . It must be tough, being dragged around like this even on your days off . '

After laughing, Wakabayashi said that an unguarded expression, completely different from before .

No matter how it happened, it looked like he wasn't suspicious anymore .

However, Kurita didn't look like he'd accepted them yet and was still looking at Gotou like an enemy .

That was probably because Gotou flung him to the ground .

'Could I ask one thing?'

Perhaps thinking of something, Yakumo called out to Wakabayashi who was about to walk away .

'What is that cottage?'

Yakumo pointed at the cottage right by them .

Gotou was curious too .

'Nobody's there now,' said Wakabayashi, his eyes distant .

'Why is that?'

When Yakumo asked that, his thin lips turned up in a smile .

The guy knew the answer already .

'It's the secondary residence of the landowner here, but his successor died .
That's why it's ended up like this . '

'Could that have something to do with the murder case that happened here
twenty years ago?' asked Yakumo, playing dumb .

Wakabayashi looked at Yakumo, holding his tone .

– There's something there .

'Also, one more thing . '

Yakumo called out to Wakabayashi, who had tried to walk away again .

'What?'

Wakabayashi turned around, sounding annoyed .

'I heard that the girl in the photo earlier has gone missing . '

When Wakabayashi heard Yakumo's sentence, his expression immediately
stiffened .

There was a heavy, malicious air .

'What about it?'

'I was wondering if you would tell us a little about the case . '

Wakabayashi closed his eyes and looked up at the sky for a while, acting
like he was thinking . Then he turned towards Yakumo again .

'Is that related to the ghost?'

'I think so, yes . '

'I'll have some time at night . '

After thinking for a while, Wakabayashi turned his back and said that .

'So it seems . '

Yakumo looked at Gotou like what Wakabayashi said had nothing to do with him .

'What? I'm going?'

'I don't know how to handle police . '

'I'm a policeman too . '

'Like I said, I dislike police . '

— What a mouth . He just thinks it'd be a pain .

'Ah, also, I'd like information about the murder case that occurred twenty years ago too . '

He'd like information too? Saying it was easy enough .

Gotou wanted to complain, but Yakumo wasn't listening . He stretched his neck and peered into the cottage .

'What are you doing?'

Yakumo ignored Gotou and got into the car's passenger seat .

'Honestly...'

Gotou let out a long sigh .

14

Ishii held his head while sitting on the bench in the hospital waiting room .

'Come on . '

He looked up at the voice . Miyagawa came towards him and gave him coffee in a paper cup .

'Ah, I apologise for the trouble . '

Ishii accepted the coffee and took a sip .

The hot coffee slowly went down his throat, going to his stomach . He felt a little bit better .

In the autopsy room earlier, Ishii had fainted from fear .

He would have been able to bear with it if it were just a head, but Hata had wrenched those closed eyes open . The ears peering out had been dyed a deep red .

When Ishii saw them, he lost consciousness from terror .

'Do you think it's that man?'

Miyagawa sat next to Ishii .

Ishii had thought it . It was hard to tell from the face, but those red eyes were better proof than anything .

'I think so . '

'I think so too, but I don't understand . '

'What don't you understand?'

When Ishii asked that, Miyagawa finished drinking his coffee at once and crushed the paper cut in his hand as he opened his mouth .

'If that head's the head of the man we know, who brought it to Kinoshita Surgery?'

'Eh?'

Ishii's head was full of what he'd seen so he hadn't thought that far .

However, that was a problem now that Miyagawa mentioned it .

'Did it just happen to be kept there? Or did Nanase Miyuki bring it there?'

'Wouldn't Nanase Miyuki have brought it there?'

Ishii didn't have proof, but it was too much to be a coincidence .

'Where from? What for?'

Miyagawa's eyes had a glint in them .

'I don't know . '

Ishii shook his head .

Nanase Miyuki was a fugitive . She should have wanted to make her load as light as possible . Carrying a human head would limit her movement .

'It's just like the Abe Sada case...'

One side of Miyagawa's lips turned up into a smirk .

The Abe Sada case – come to think of it Makoto and Miyagawa had both used Abe Sada as an example to describe Nanase Miyuki's actions .

'Well, no point thinking about that now . '

Miyagawa stretched and stood up . Ishii followed him in standing .

'I'll . . '

Go too – is what Ishii was about to say when Miyagawa interrupted .

'You get some rest . '

'No, I'm fine . '

'It's only been a day . You're more tired than you think you are . '

'No...'

Miyagawa seemed to think that Ishii had fainted from exhaustion earlier, but that wasn't actually the case . He had just been frightened .

That said, Ishii couldn't explain .

'Stop whinging and go rest . '

Miyagawa hit Ishii's left shoulder .

When Miyagawa touched his injury, Ishii let out an 'Ow' and fell to his knees right there .

'See?'

Miyagawa walked away while laughing . It looked like he'd hit his injury on purpose . He had probably meant it as encouragement, but Ishii wished he had been a bit gentler .

'Also, call me if you get a hold of Gotou . '

Miyagawa said that as he left .

15

Haruka got off the bus together with Masato .

There was a large parking lot in front of the bus stop with a souvenir shop and a food court for tourists . Across the road was the Kinasa Museum they were looking for .

The Kinasa Museum had historical and cultural exhibits about Kinasa . That sad, it wasn't that large, just a two-storey multipurpose hall .

They quickly crossed the road and went inside through the glass sliding doors .

They took their shoes off at the entrance and switched into slippers .

When Haruka went to the reception, an old person with dark hair streaked with grey in a red cardigan peered through a small window in an irritated manner .

'Hello . '

The old man spoke in a casual tone .

Haruka remembered the voice . She had heard it when making an appointment over the phone earlier . This person was probably Ookura .

'Hello, my name is Ozawa . I called earlier . '

'Ah, the call from earlier . Come in from there . '

Haruka and Masato opened the door Ookura pointed at and went inside .

The room was six tatami in size with a desk and locker . There was a white table with four folding chairs . It felt like a reception area .

'Well, sit down . '

Ookura gestured at the folding chairs .

'Thank you very much . '

Haruka and Masato sat on the folding chairs .

'So you're looking into Momijigari . '

Ookura sat on the opposite chair and lined the table with long and thin pamphlets . All of them were pamphlets in colour for tourists .

It looked like Ookura had prepared for them after accepting their call .

'Actually, what we're looking into is the incident with the witch which occurred forty-five years ago,' said Haruka, interrupting Ookura .

That moment, a tremor went through Ookura's body and his eyes went wide .

'Why do you want to know about that?'

Ookura's words sounded accusatory .

Yakumo might have been able to get the information skilfully, but Haruka wasn't as good with her words . She didn't know if Ookura would believe her, but she explained everything that had happened so far – the spiritual phenomenon Masato had experienced, Yumiko's disappearance afterwards .

Ookura had his eyes closed and arms crossed as Haruka explained .

Did he fall asleep – it made Haruka wonder .

'I heard about the girl who's gone missing too . It's terrible . But is that really related to what happened forty-five years ago?' said Ookura, slowly scratching his chin .

Haruka couldn't reply clearly to that question, but –

'I think it does . '

'Please tell us,' added Masato, bowing his head deeply .

'Can't do anything then . ' Ookura rubbed his head . 'I was born in Togakushi – the village over – so I can't remember it clearly . ' He started with that .

'It was about fifty years ago . A mother and child were found collapsed in the mountains in Kinasa . '

'Collapsed...'

Haruka repeated it unconsciously . That would be unthinkable now .

'That mother and child were brought to the Kinasa clinic . Luckily, they survived, but since they didn't have anywhere to go, they started living at

the clinic . ’

‘Where were they from originally?’

If she knew the woman’s origins, it might become a clue, but Ookura just said with a wandering gaze, ‘Hm, where was it?’

‘What were their names?’

Masato was the one who asked .

‘The doctor was, if I remember correctly... Doctor Kawakami . The woman was named Rin . ’

‘Rin-san . ’

Haruka repeated the name after Ookura .

Ookura cleared his throat and started again .

‘There were some people who harassed them for being outsiders, but after a while that stopped . Doctor KAwakami and Rin actually married . ’

A peaceful life in the place she ended up in –

Ookura’s eyes were distant . He looked out the window for a while before continuing .

‘But there was an incident forty-five years ago – the year I graduated from middle school . ’

‘Incident?’

Haruka swallowed as she looked at Ookura .

‘There was a landowner called Kitaoka who had that piece of land . His oldest son Hidetaka suddenly had a fit . He was brought to Doctor Kawakami’s, but he died within the day . ’

'Was he sick?'

'Who can say? I don't know, but...'

Ookura stopped talking .

'But what?'

'There were a lot of rumours . That the doctor made a mistake, that he was poisoned – things like that . '

Though Haruka was just imagining this herself, she felt like they sounded malicious .

'Why would people make rumours like that?'

'I wonder . I didn't go myself, but while Kawakami had always been a good doctor, people stopped going there after that . '

'That's...'

'Then, Hidetaka's younger brother Takafumi and the local officer made a fuss, saying Rin's curse was why Hidetaka died . '

'That's awful . '

Even though he had died at the clinic, saying it was a curse was jumping to conclusions .

'Then the people of the village started agreeing and even wanted to chase Rin out . '

That was strange, no matter how Haruka thought about it .

She didn't know how the man died, but there was no way it was a curse .

'That's bullying!' shouted Haruka, unable to keep her anger in .

Ookura dropped his gaze to his feet and sighed .

'You might be right . Ever since there, the clinic had a bad name . People broke the windows, threw rocks – it was rather awful . '

Why would adults do something so terrible?

How much was the woman named Rin hurt by that –

Thinking about it was enough to make it hard for Haruka to breathe . Her chest hurt .

'What happened afterwards?'

'Doctor Kawakami fell into the Susobana ravine and died .

'That's...'

What an unlucky woman .

She lost the person she was relying on in when she was suffering so much –

How would she feel if she lost the people important to her who supported her when she was suffering?

That thought suddenly passed Haruka's mind .

She probably wouldn't be able to bear it .

'After that day, Rin and her son suddenly disappeared from the clinic . '

'They went missing?'

'They did . There was a rumour that on top of killing Hidetaka, Rin had even laid a hand on Doctor Kawakami and run away . '

'There's no way!' Haruka objected, leaning forward .

She couldn't forgive such an unjust accusation .

'I didn't that myself . '

Ookura looked taken aback .

'Sensei . '

When Masato spoke to her, Haruka came to her senses .

Just as Ookura said, he wasn't the one who had said those words . He was just saying that there was a rumour like that .

'I'm sorry . '

Haruka bowed her head .

'Ah, no, it's fine . '

Ookura awkwardly scratched his head .

Haruka understood the gist of the story .

However, there was one point she just didn't understand .

That was –

'Why did the villagers believe in something like a witch?'

'I didn't see them myself so I can't say, but...'

Haruka's heart was beating loudly .

Masato swallowed as well with a hard expression .

After a pause, Ookura finally opened his mouth slowly .

'I heard that the mother's and kid's eyes were both deep red . '

'Deep red...'

'Mm . And the kid's forehead had a horn growing out of it,' said Ookura, pointing at his own forehead as he did so .

Red eyes and a horn .

Wouldn't that make the child a real demon –

16

'So where are you going?'

Once Gotou got into the driver's seat, he asked Yakumo in the passenger seat that question .

Yakumo hadn't explained anything, but if he'd stepped into the car, it probably meant he wanted to go somewhere .

'To the local real estate office for now . '

Yakumo stretched .

He always did this, but his movements were incredibly catlike .

'Why the real estate office?'

'Aren't you curious about that?'

Yakumo pointed at the cottage right in front of them .

With a characteristic sloped triangular roof, there was a wide terrace at the entrance with a log table and bench . There were thick cypress pillars and white walls – a building with a calm appearance .

Gotou had thought it was somebody's vacation cottage, but he'd heard Wakabayashi's explanation earlier .

'It's the landowner's, right?'

'In the past, it was . '

'Nobody's living there now . '

'Is that really true?'

The corners of Yakumo's lips turned up into a meaningful smile .

Gotou felt a chill down his spine .

'What do you mean?'

'If what Wakabayashi-san said earlier were true, that would mean it's been abandoned for over twenty years . '

'Right . '

'Then it's unnatural . '

Yakumo put his left index finger to his brow .

'What is?'

'The entrance door is locked . '

'You'd lock the door, wouldn't you?'

It's be more unnatural not to .

Yakumo's triumphant smile didn't waver even after Gotou replied .

'The shape of the lock is the problem . '

'Shape?'

'That lock is a dimple lock . '

Dimple locks were used to prevent theft through picking locks and spread after being introduced in 2000 . If the building had been abandoned for more than twenty years, the years didn't match . That was probably what Yakumo was trying to say .

But –

'There's a chance that somebody switched it recently . '

'That would be possible if it were just the lock . '

'Is there anything else?'

'The wall clock . '

'Hah?'

Gotou was even more confused by the sudden change in topic .

'There is a wall clock in that cottage . '

– When did he check?

Gotou thought about asking, but he decided not to .

Yakumo had peered into the cottage through the window earlier . He'd probably checked then .

'So what's the problem with the wall clock?'

'It's working . '

'Working...'

Yakumo moved his hand back and forth like a wall clock's pendulum .

That would be unnatural . A wall clock couldn't work for twenty years without winding the key or changing the battery . But –

'But even if that were the case, how is it related?'

'The scene of the crime twenty years ago that was discussed earlier was probably that cottage . '

'W-what?'

Gotou was so surprised he got up from his seat .

This was where the landowner's son and the local officer were killed – and a skeleton had been found at the cedar tree right by it .

A village that had nothing to do with crime . It didn't seem like just a coincidence . That was why they were going to sniff around at the real estate office .

– This is becoming even more of a pain .

Gotou mumbled in his heart as he started the car .

17

When Ishii entered the coffee shop, Makoto was already at a table .

'I apologise for the wait . '

Ishii hurried over and bowed his head, but Makoto replied with a smile . 'I just got here as well . '

Ishii sat down, still feeling guilty .

Then, a jolt of pain ran through his shoulder .

'Is your injury all right?'

Makoto seemed to have noticed Ishii's expression because she spoke up immediately .

'Ah, yes, I'm fine . '

'It really was quite an incident . '

'It was . '

Ishii smiled faintly .

'But it's rare for you to invite me, Ishii-san,' said Makoto happily after ordering drinks from the waiter .

It was true that it was rare for Ishii to invite somebody out, but Ishii really was troubled .

'Actually, there was something I wanted to ask your opinion on, Makoto-san . '

'If I can be of help . '

'It's about Nanase Miyuki . '

When Ishii said that name, Makoto's expression stiffened immediately and the mood turned heavy .

Meanwhile, the waiter put coffee for two on the table and left .

Ishii put sugar and milk into his coffee, slowly took a sip and started talking .

'You know that I encountered Nanase Miyuki at Kinoshita Surgery yesterday, yes?'

'Yes . '

'Something was found there . '

'Something?'

'Yes . Er...'

Ishii hesitated to say it was a head .

'What was it?'

'A human head . '

'A head that was cut off then?'

A wrinkle appeared between Makoto's well-shaped eyebrows .

'Yes, furthermore, it might be the head of the man with two red eyes . '

'It's just like Abe Sada, isn't it?' said Makoto .

That was exactly the reason why Ishii had invited Makoto . She had said she was writing a report on Nanase Miyuki . Also, she had compared Nanase Miyuki's actions to Abe Sada .

Ishii thought that Makoto might be able to draw close to Nanase Miyuki's psychological state .

If he knew that, it would be helpful to finding out her location . That was what Ishii thought .

Makoto also seemed to understand Ishii's goal, as she said, 'So that's what it was . '

'To get to the point, I want to know why Nanase Miyuki had the man with red eyes'...'.

'Why she had his head?'

Makoto clearly spoke the words Ishii had hesitated to speak .

'Yes, that's it . '

'I still don't completely understand Nanase Miyuki's psychological state, but Abe Sada herself had explained the reason she walked around with the genitals of the lover she killed . '

'What was it?'

Ishii gulped and leant forward .

'She didn't want to let other people touch him... so she said . '

'Didn't want to let other people touch him...'

Ishii didn't understand the line of thinking .

'I understand somewhat . '

Makoto's eyes narrowed as she propped up her chin with her hand and looked out the window .

Ishii was startled . It was partly because of the words, but it was more that he was fascinated by her profile, which looked entranced .

'W-what do you mean?'

'To put it simply, it's the desire to monopolise . Women want to make the person they love their own . '

'Make them their own...'

'Yes . Of course, walking with a part of the body like Abe Sada did is a bit much . But... I don't know how to say it, but...'

Makoto looked straight at Ishii .

Ishii looked down at his coffee to avoid that pure gaze .

– I really don't understand .

'Ishii-san,' said Makoto after a silence .

'Yes . '

'Ishii-san, are you chasing Nanase Miyuki?'

'I want to, but... to be honest, all I can do by myself is gather information like this . If Detective Gotou were here...'

He hadn't planned on it, but he ended up saying something weak .

However, it was how he truly felt .

'Have you still not been able to contact Detective Gotou?'

'I haven't . I keep calling him, but...'

Whether or not he knew the situation Ishii was in, Gotou wasn't answering the phone .

'Then why not try calling Yakumo-kun?'

'Ah!'

Ishii stood up without thinking at Makoto's words .

Makoto had told him that Gotou was with Yakumo and Haruka in Nagano .

If they were together, he could just call Yakumo .

Ishii called Yakumo immediately . Yakumo answered at the first ring .

'H-hello . Er, this is Ishii Yuutarou speaking . '

<What is it? It's rare for you to call me, Ishii-san . >

Yakumo casually answered the phone .

'Actually, I wanted to contact Detective Gotou . I've been calling him since yesterday, but he wouldn't answer...'

<He's out right now . If you have a message, I'll give it to him . >

'Actually, it's a rather serious matter...'

ishii started with the patrol wagon accident and explained everything that happened in detail to Yakumo .

<I see...>

Yakumo spoke in a quiet tone after Ishii finished explaining .

It was a weak response, to the point that it was disappointing . He didn't seem to care at all .

'I want to ask Detective Gotou to help with the search for Nanase Miyuki as quickly as possible... is what I was thinking . '

<Gotou-san won't be any help at all . >

Yakumo said that in a light tone .

'But...'

<Also, even if you leave her alone, Nanase Miyuki will show herself . >

'Is that so?'

<I believe so . >

'But...'

<I also have something I would like to ask of you, so I will call you later . >

'E-er...'

Ishii called out to stop Yakumo, but he had already hung up .

'How was it?'

Makoto lifted her head, looking concerned .

'He said Nanase Miyuki would appear even if I didn't look for her...'

'I think that too . '

Unexpectedly Makoto agreed .

18

'Sorry to bother!'

Gotou went through the real estate office's automatic doors .

There was a counter for clients which would be cramped for two and two desks behind it – a small office .

'What is it'

A man who looked about fifty spoke from the desk in the back .

He sounded rather annoyed even though he was talking to a customer, which made Gotou annoyed, but he sat down without saying that .

'There was a property I was interested in . '

When Gotou said that, the man finally stood up and sat opposite the counter .

'Which property is it?'

The man took reading glasses out of his jacket pocket and put them on .

It was difficult to explain even if he asked which property . Gotou spotted a map by the counter, took it and spread it out .

After looking around the map for a while, he finally found the spot he wanted .

'Here . There's something like a cottage here, right?'

'Er...'

The man put his face so close Gotou thought he would hit the map .

'Ah, here...'

'Right . I heard nobody was living at this property now . I was looking for a vacation home around here and thought it'd be perfect . '

Gotou couldn't say he was a detective from the Tokyo Metropolitan Police in Nagano prefecture so he gave the lie he had prepared .

'Actually, this property's being rented out . '

'Rented out?'

'Yes . This property has a bit of history...'

'There was a murder there, right?'

When Gotou said that, the man lifted his head with his eyes wide behind his thick glasses .

'You knew about it?'

'It's famous,' Gotou replied matter-of-factly .

'I see... Actually, our owner bought the property at a low price from a distant relative of Kitaoka-san, the owner who was killed, who had been troubled over how to manage the property . '

'And then?'

'Well, because of that, it's always been empty, but about ten years ago, I think... we found a renter . '

'Somebody rented it knowing the history?'

'I didn't recommend it, but well...'

'Are they living there now?'

'About half a year ago, we stopped receiving rent and we lost contact as well . We were thinking of ending the contract soon . '

As the man said that, he smiled .

Gotou understood now why the man had talked so freely about the situation . If the contract was going to be ended, he wanted to have Gotou as a customer .

'What sort of guy lived there?'

'I didn't seem him myself, but according to the owner, it was a rather dashing man and his daughter...'

There was no way to find out the identities from that .

Gotou thought about asking to see the contract, but that would be too much . Since he'd come as a customer, he wouldn't be able to see the contract, which was confidential .

'Got it . I'll come again . '

Gotou flatly refused the man who asked for his contact information and left the real estate office .

When he returned to the car parked outside, Yakumo was talking to somebody on his mobile .

'Is it Haruka-chan?' asked Gotou after Yakumo finished .

He hadn't heard the speaker's voice, but he could tell it was serious news .

'It was Ishii-san,' replied Yakumo with a yawn .

'What?'

Ishii wasn't good with dealing with Yakumo . For Ishii to call Yakumo went past rare to extraordinary .

'What'd he want?'

'The patrol wagon Nanase Miyuki was on was in an accident . '

'Accident?'

Gotou had a bad feeling .

'The police are under a gag rule, but Nanase Miyuki appears to have escaped . '

'W-what!?'

'Please don't speak so loudly by my ear . '

Yakumo's face scrunched up as he stuck his fingers into his ears .

This was no time to be calm . Nanase Miyuki had escaped – it was terrible .

'Why didn't Ishii contact me about something so important?'

'Isn't it because you didn't answer your phone, Gotou-san?'

'Ah!'

That was right . Ishii had called over and over again . But Gotou hadn't answered since he figured it wasn't important .

However, now that he knew, he couldn't stay silent .

'Oi . Yakumo . We're going back . '

'Why?' Yakumo responded nonchalantly .

'What do you mean why? Obviously we're going to go back to catch Nanase Miyuki . '

'What do you plan on doing about Yumiko-chan?'

'That's – '

'Will you abandon her?' Yakumo said sharply .

'Of course I can't . '

It hurt, but it was just as Yakumo said . Gotou wasn't so coldblooded that he could leave now . Yumiko had gone missing, but more importantly, Masato was looking for her so desperately .

'Ishii-san will continue the search . Let's believe in him . '

– Believe in Ishii?

Gotou had always thought it curious . Yakumo had an incredibly high opinion of Ishii . Miyagawa did too . Gotou just thought of him as useless .

Gotou wanted to ask why, but Yakumo would just say something like 'He's better than you, Gotou-san' .

'So what are we going to do next?'

'It seems there is a place with an old clinic in Kinasa . Let's go there . '

Yakumo spoke disinterestedly, but Gotou didn't understand .

'Why a clinic?'

'According to her information, there was some fuss with a witch forty-five years ago that started at that clinic . '

It appeared that Haruka had also contacted Yakumo while he was waiting in the care .

'So what's this fuss about a witch about?'

'I'll tell you when you're older . '

Yakumo smirked .

'You making fun of me?'

'No I'm not . I'm mocking you . '

'Honestly . '

– What a hateful brat .

It was irritating, but in a situation like this, all Gotou could do was obey Yakumo . Gotou started the car .

19

After leaving the Kinasa Museum, Haruka visited Yumiko's house with Masato as her guide .

Her goal was to investigate how Yumiko had been before going missing .

They got off at the Asakawa bus stop, went straight and turned into the street by the convenience store . It became a footpath surrounded by rice paddies . Haruka saw a splendid house with a tiled roof ahead .

'This is where I met Yumiko-chan . '

Masato stopped about halfway down the footpath .

His back looked incredibly fragile . He probably wanted to turn time back, but that was impossible, no matter how hard he tried .

Nothing would start if they just regretted things that were past, so for now –

'Let's go . '

Haruka pushed Masato's back forward .

Masato nodded and slowly but steadily started walking .

Yumiko's house had a large, well-kept garden with big pine trees .

When Haruka pressed the intercom at the entrance, she heard a hoarse voice: 'Who is it?'

'It's Oomori Masato . '

Masato answered while Haruka was thinking up a reply .

'Oomori-san's... Please come in . '

A response came back immediately .

Haruka opened the sliding door and went inside with Masato .

An old woman about seventy years old welcomed them . It looked like she had bad legs as she was dragging her right foot slightly . She was probably Yumiko's grandmother .

'Hello . '

'Hello . Who is your acquaintance?'

'This is my teacher . '

Masato bowed politely .

'Nobody is here because they are looking for my grandchild, but please . '

Haruka did as Yumiko's grandmother insisted .

Perhaps they had just switched them, because the tatami were green in the six-tatami parlour they were led to .

'Please don't fuss over us . '

Though Haruka said that, Yumiko's grandmother diligently brought out tea and sweets regardless .

'I sincerely apologise for visiting at such a busy time . '

Haruka apologised while waiting for Yumiko's grandmother to sit .

'To be honest, I want to search with everyone as well, but my legs are bad .
,

As she said that, she looked out at the veranda with slightly tearful eyes .

'Actually, I wanted to ask something about Yumiko-chan...'

'About my granddaughter?'

'We are also searching for Yumiko-chan . '

'Really? Thank you . '

'We heard a rumour that Yumiko-chan was spirited away . '

Even though Haruka's question was so sudden, Yumiko's grandmother did not like suspicious . She just nodded and started speaking .

'She had a fever right after returning from her field trip . '

'Did she go to the doctor?'

'Said it was a cold, but she had terrible nightmares . I knew immediately that there was someone inside Yumiko...'

'Someone inside her?'

'A demon . '

Yumiko's grandmother's gaze was like a glare .

Haruka had no way of knowing what emotions were in that gaze .

'A demon?'

'A demon came for her . '

Yumiko's grandmother rubbed her wrinkled hands together as if praying while saying that .

'Have you told anybody?'

'I have . To my son and his wife, but they probably just thought it was an old woman's joke...'

Her fingers were restless on top of her knees .

'They didn't believe you?'

'Everyone was so frantic right after Yumiko disappeared . I should have said it more clearly . '

When she said that, Yumiko's grandmother suddenly looked a size smaller .

'I didn't say it clearly then either . '

Masato looked right at Yumiko's grandmother's face .

'Did you see a demon?'

Yumiko's grandmother peered at Masato .

'I don't know if it was a demon, but during the field trip, I saw somebody standing nearby . But... If I had said it properly then...'

'No, no, I'm the one at fault . '

Yumiko's grandmother shook her head with slumped shoulders . Masato dropped his head as well like he had lost his will .

Haruka understood how they felt, but nothing would be solved if they just sat here depressed like this .

'Excuse me, but you mentioned that Yumiko-chan had nightmares . What were they?'

Haruka asked a question to clear the heavy atmosphere .

'Where? Where? That was what she said . '

Yumiko's grandmother put both her hands in front of her and moved them about .

'Was she looking for something?'

'It felt like she was searching for an enemy to clear away a grudge of many years . '

To clear away a grudge –

Did that mean the spirit had a strong and violent hatred that didn't disappear even after death?

'Ah!'

Masato suddenly lifted his head .

'What is it?'

'I heard that too . She said something like “Whaaar”... I didn't understand then, but it must have been “Where” . '

Masato leant forward as he said that .

'A demon . It's the work of a demon – '

As Yumiko's grandmother murmured that, her eyes looked distant .

20

'Is this really the right road?'

Gotou asked Yakumo in the passenger that question as he drove .

'It should be,' replied Yakumo while looking at the map .

A clinic that stopped business forty-five years ago . It wasn't on the map, so they headed for Kinasa with no directions and walked around, asking the people they met about the clinic .

However, since it was so long ago, virtually none of the people remembered it . After wandering for about thirty minutes, they finally found somebody who knew it . An old farmer with bad ears . They asked the same question

multiple times before the farmer finally marked the location for them on the map .

That made Yakumo's map incredibly suspicious .

'We should arrive if we head along this road,' replied Yakumo with a yawn .

– Along the road, eh?

Gotou headed along the road for a while, but finally the road was so narrow a car couldn't pass .

'What now?'

Gotou stopped the car .

'Let's walk the rest of the way . '

Yakumo folded the map and put it in his pocket . Then, he got off the car and briskly started walking .

– Honestly . He just does whatever he wants .

Even though Gotou grumbled within his heart, he got off the car and followed Yakumo .

For a while, the road was flat, but it suddenly became a sharp slope . It wasn't even paved . The ground was wet so it was easy to slip in leather shoes .

Grass and tree branches filled the road . Gotou didn't really think a clinic would be up ahead .

'Is this really the right place?' Gotou asked Yakumo as he wiped the sweat from his head .

'Probably . '

'What an unreliable guy . '

'I don't want to hear that from you, Gotou-san . '

'Quit whining . '

On such a steep slope, even talking was difficult .

'Gotou-san, it seems like your friend is here . '

Yakumo suddenly stopped .

– A friend?

'What are you talking about . '

'That . '

Yakumo was pointing at a sign .

<Beware of Bears!>

'You bastard!'

Even though Gotou yelled, Yakumo continued walking without a care .

– How does he have the energy to make fun of people?

Gotou sighed and started walking again .

After about five minutes, Yakumo stopped again .

'What now?'

'It's here . '

– Really?

Gotou didn't believe it, but there really was an old building a little ahead on the road .

He walked forward together with Yakumo .

The branches and leaves of the many trees covered the sky, making the area dim . There was also a mist as thick as smoke .

df – It's creepy .

'It seems we've arrived . '

Yakumo breathed out in front of the building .

Since it was a clinic, Gotou had imagined something made of concrete, but in front of him there was a wooden house with a flat roof that was slightly tilted .

It felt more like house from the Edo period than a clinic .

'Is this really the place?'

When Gotou spoke his suspicions, Yakumo wiped the wooden sign by the entrance . Though it was covered with dirt and dust, Gotou could read the words Kinasa Clinic off of it .

Yakumo stood in front of the entrance and slid open the doors with the frosted glass –

Even though there was no wind, Gotou felt like something passed by him .

Though he thought it creepy, he peered in from behind Yakumo .

In the small entrance area, there was a tall shoe shelf with a waiting area about eight tatami in size .

'Gotou-san, please be careful . '

Yakumo turned around to say that and then slowly stepped in .

The floor was covered in dirt and dead leaves .

There was a half open wooden door ahead which was creaking as it shook .

Past that door –

Gotou felt a chill run down his spine .

– I can't go past that door .

It wasn't like there was anything . His instincts told him that .

'What's this?'

'Someone is here . '

Yakumo's red left eye was forceful .

Gotou couldn't see anything, but Yakumo's red left eye could see something in the back of the clinic .

'Who's there?'

Yakumo didn't answer Gotou's question . He opened the half-open door and stepped inside .

Gotou peered into the back of the room from behind Yakumo's back .

There was just a bedframe with a desk and bookshelf covered in dust and cobwebs .

This was probably the examination room .

Gotou could tell Yakumo was uneasy from his tense back .

'Who are you?'

From the centre of the room, Yakumo asked that question towards the empty room .

Gotou felt all the hair on his body stand on end . Though he couldn't see anything, Gotou could feel it as well .

– Somebody’s here .

'I see... You’re looking as well...' murmured Yakumo .

He wasn’t speaking to Gotou . He was probably speaking to the other person in the room .

'Notebooks...'

Yakumo murmured again .

He appeared to be conversing with whoever was here .

'Is somebody here?'

'It’s the person who used to be the doctor at this clinic,' said Yakumo . Then, he walked further into the room and stopped in front of the shelf .

'Gotou-san, it’s your turn . '

Yakumo stuck out his chin, signalling for Gotou to come over .

Though the world was wide, Yakumo was probably the only university student who would use his chin to signal for a police officer .

'What?'

'We are going to move this bookshelf . '

'Guess I have to . '

Gotou rolled up his sleeves and dragged the dusty bookshelf aside with Yakumo’s help .

He thought that something might come out, but he was wrong . There was just the mouldy floor .

Yakumo went onto his knees and wiped away the dirt on the floor as he started to search for something .

'Oi . What are you doing?'

Though Gotou spoke up, Yakumo ignored him, as was his speciality .

Finally, Yakumo found a gap between the boards, stuck his fingers in and pulled the board out .

He continued to take off three of them and stuck his hands into the hole in the floor .

After groping about for a while, he finally pulled out an old box .

He placed it on the floor . He blew on it, making the dust fly off .

The dust danced in the air like smoke .

It was a square metal box with sides about thirty centimetres in length . It looked fairly old and was completely rusted over .

'What's that?'

'I will investigate that now,' Yakumo said in a voice full of irritation . Then, he took the lid off the box . Inside there were many dusty notebooks and documents with an old photo on top .

'Found it . '

Yakumo murmured that as he took the photo into his hand –

NOTES:

[1] For the curious, [HERE](#) is an English recipe with pictures to make sobagaki .

[2] The yukata that would have been laid out wouldn't be a fancy summer one but just something that Japanese inns and hotels often have for their guests . It would just have a plain pattern like [THIS ONE](#) .

[3] Momiji (紅葉) is both the name of of Japanese maple and for autumn colours . Momijigari hunting or momijigari (紅葉狩り), besides being the name of the legend, also means viewing autumn colours, which explains Gotou's confusion .

[4] Mount Hiei is a mountain northeast of Kyoto famous for the temple of Enryakuji . Incidentally the legend Yakumo telling is a real folktale from Nagano . I couldn't find anything about it in English but if you're curious you can look up 紅葉伝説 and Google translate it .

[5] A fairy tale about a couple who had a dog they really loved . When the husband sprinkled the dog's ashes on cherry trees, they bloomed . Please read in more detail on WIKIPEDIA .

Volume 7 Chapter 3: VOLUME 7 – THE LOCATION OF THE SPIRIT

Chapter 3

VOLUME 7 – THE LOCATION OF THE SPIRIT

file 03: release (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

‘Masato-kun, don’t be selfish . ’

Haruka pulled at Masato’s arm as she pleaded .

However, he didn’t reply . He just looked at his feet without moving .

After leaving Yumiko’s house, Haruka was going to take Masato home, but once they reached the convenience store, he started being stubborn, saying, ‘I won’t go back . ’

It wasn’t like Haruka didn’t understand how Masato felt . He wanted to find Yumiko no matter what . But the sun had already set and the surroundings were becoming dark . Since they had been late the day before as well, Haruka couldn’t bring him around any longer .

Yumiko, a child the same age as him, had gone missing . His uncle and aunt must have been worried .

‘I won’t go back . ’

Masato’s tone was forceful .

He wouldn't budge an inch until he found Yumiko . That strong will came through clearly .

'Your uncle will worry, right?'

'I don't want to go back . '

'Masato-kun . '

'I'm going to look for Yumiko-chan until I find her . '

It looked like Masato felt that was his duty .

Haruka looked at Masato's face and placed a hand on his shoulder .

'I can't do anything, in the end . '

Masato bit his lip .

'That's not true . '

'It is . I still haven't found Yumiko-chan . '

He really did believe everything was his fault . It hurt to watch him .

'Please believe in us . '

'I don't want to!'

Haruka had said that to console him, but Masato interrupted her with a shout .

'Masato-kun . '

'Sensei, you always save me – I can't do anything . Even though I should be the one to search, this is just the same as last time . '

Masato's face was red as his eyes welled up with tears .

Haruka was trying to determine what to do when Yakumo called .

'Hello . '

<Did something happen?>

Yakumo said that as if he had seen right through Haruka's troubles .

Even though he acted like he didn't have any interest in others, the truth was that he paid more attention than anybody else .

'Masato-kun doesn't want to go home . '

<Doesn't want to go home?>

'He says he's going to search for Yumiko-chan . '

<So you don't know what to do . >

'Yeah . '

Haruka felt like Yakumo was smiling on the other side of the phone .

<Hand the phone to Masato . I've got a request . >

'A request?'

<Just hand it over . >

Haruka did as Yakumo told her to, giving the mobile to Masato and telling him that 'Yakumo-kun has a request' .

'Hello...'

Masato answered the phone, sounding confused .

Haruka didn't know what they were saying, but she could see Masato's dispirited expression becoming energised before her eyes .

'Got it . I'll go back and look into it . '

After saying that, Masato returned the phone to Haruka .

Yakumo had changed Masato's mind in such a short time – it was just like magic .

'Hey, what did you say to Masato-kun?' asked Haruka quietly, turning her back to Masato and stepping a little ways away .

<I asked him to look into something for me . >

'Look into something?'

<Yeah . I asked him to talk to family and firefighters to find out where they've searched for Yumiko-chan . >

Could it be –

'An excuse to make Masato-kun go home?'

<I'm not you – I wouldn't lie like that . >

'But . '

<I have an idea, though vague, about where she is . >

'Eh?'

Her voice jumped an octave in her surprise .

<At this stage it is just a theory, but if that location has already been searched, that would mean my theory is wrong . >

'I see . '

<Well, I can't deny that it was also an excuse to make him go home . >

If it was just asking about the search, it didn't have to be Masato . That was probably the main intention .

<You'd be wrong if you think Masato's just a kid . He has his own firm will . >

The way Yakumo said it was like he was talking to himself .

Yakumo could be right . Masato had his own firm will . He would hate being treated as a child most .

'Then what are you going to do?'

<Gotou-san is taking me back . >

'Then I'll drop Masato-kun off and come back too . '

After saying that, Haruka hung up .

Yakumo said that he had an idea about where Yumiko was . Perhaps they would find her soon .

Haruka's chest was filled with that hope .

2

After exiting the clinic, Gotou drove Yakumo to Haruka's home and then drove to the town area where the Nagano precinct was .

He was going to get information from Wakabayashi .

Yakumo had given him the request easily, but it would be rather difficult getting information from a precinct in a different jurisdiction .

Gotou parked in the Nagano precinct parking lot with heavy feelings .

The three-storey building with a flat roof seemed incredibly large . Gotou hit his cheeks to clear his mind and went through the front entrance .

He passed through the waiting area lined with sofas, put his elbows on the reception counter and called out to a uniformed officer nearby .

'Sorry, but could you call the officer named Wakabayashi-san for me?'

'What is your business with him?'

The officer looked incredibly annoyed .

'Gotou from the Metropolitan Police came – he'll understand if you tell him that . '

When Gotou said that with a hand wave, the officer cocked his head but still picked up the internal phone . After a short exchange, he said, 'Please wait there . '

Gotou sat on the bench by the wall and absentmindedly watched the traffic safety video playing in the lobby .

'You really came?'

After about five minutes, Wakabayashi showed up with an exasperated smile .

When Gotou nodded back, Wakabayashi gestured with his chin to suggest they go out .

Little gestures like this reminded Gotou somewhat of Miyagawa . He was probably angry since he'd been gone for two days without leave – Gotou started worrying about that a little bit too late .

'Do you have a car?' asked Wakabayashi after they exited the front entrance .

'Yes, I do . '

'Then shall we go around the block?' said Wakabayashi .

Gotou was grateful for the suggestion . Inside the car, he wouldn't have to worry about anybody listening in and they would be able to talk in depth .

'It's this one . '

Gotou walked with Wakabayashi towards the parking space where he'd parked his car .

'I'm sorry about how Kurita acted earlier . '

Wakabayashi bowed his head as he walked .

This man was a much greater man than he'd imagined if he could offer an honest apology like this to a detective outside his jurisdiction .

'Ah, that? I did something unnecessary too . '

'That's true . '

Wakabayashi laughed heartily with shaking shoulders .

He didn't seem like a bad guy .

Gotou sat in the driver's seat and Wakabayashi sat in the passenger's .

'Do you mind if I smoke?'

Wakabayashi took a case of Short Hope cigarettes[1] from his pocket .

That was some refined taste .

'Go ahead . '

'How about you?'

With a cigarette in his mouth, Wakabayashi held the case out towards Gotou .

Gotou wanted to smoke, but he had promised Yakumo that he would stop smoking when he took in Nao .

'I stopped . '

'Worried about your health?'

'No, it's for my daughter . '

Even though he was the one who said it, he couldn't help but feel embarrassed .

'You have a daughter?'

'That surprising?'

'You don't look married . '

Gotou didn't ask why .

People often thought Gotou was still a bachelor . He didn't understand the reason well himself, but it seemed like he didn't smell like family .

'I'm often told that,' replied Gotou .

Wakabayashi smiled as he lit his cigarette .

The nostalgic smell of tobacco made him feel itchy, but Gotou started the car .

'Do you know who the body is?'

After driving for a while, Gotou spoke to Wakabayashi again .

'I can't tell you... is what I want to say, but it's going to be in the newspapers tomorrow anyway . We don't know who it is right now . Waiting on blood type too . All we know is it's a woman . '

'Is that all...'

Gotou felt disappointed about the lack of information, but it had just been a short time . The corpse was a skeleton – it wouldn't be easy to discern anything .

'And we don't have certain investigation results yet, but that corpse is at least thirty years old . '

'It must have been buried for a while . '

'Not definitely . '

'Eh?'

'It could have been buried there recently . '

'AH . '

Gotou certainly couldn't deny that possibility .

'Are you really a detective?'

'Thinking isn't my strong point . '

'Seems like it . '

Wakabayashi snorted .

Thinking about it, it was an awful thing for Wakabayashi to say, but mysteriously, Gotou didn't get angry . Perhaps because of Wakabayashi's atmosphere .

He turned left at the intersection and left the town area . '

'Do you know how she died?'

'There was a sign of a depression of the skull . Probably hit with something blunt in the head . '

'Rather awful . '

'Really . Ganging up to beat a frail woman to death isn't something a person should do . '

Wakabayashi said that with anger .

It really wasn't something a person should do – Gotou looked out the window grimly . Though it wasn't as if there were no lights, there weren't many .

'So how's the case with the missing girl going?'

Gotou asked another question after a pause .

'That's tough too... No leads at all . '

Wakabayashi blew out smoke and scratched the back of his neck .

Gotou could feel his irritation at the investigation that wasn't going the way he thought it would .

'Has it been two days since she's gone missing?'

'We've focussed on searching around her house, but we can't even find any evidence . '

'Do you not know the reason either?'

'We don't . She's too young for a disappearance . It would be easy to think somebody kidnapped her, but there was no ransom...'

So we have no place to start searching – was probably how Wakabayashi felt .

'Do you think she was spirited away?' said Wakabayashi while pressing the cigarette into the ashtray .

'Spirited away?'

'Like when tengu or demons take children away . '

Come to think of it, Yakumo had said that .

'Putting aside whether she was spirited away or not, we think that she disappeared because of a ghost . '

That wasn't what Gotou thought . It was a second-hand opinion from Yakumo . Normally, Gotou would think he would be laughed at, but for some reason he felt like Wakabayashi might believe him .

'A ghost?'

'Yes . That girl is possessed by a ghost . That ghost is leading her to wander while ignoring what she wants to do . '

Wakabayashi didn't agree or deny what Gotou said . He just looked out the window silently .

The silence continued .

Finally, Wakabayashi spoke, like he was holding something back .

'Actually, the girl that disappeared is my relative's kid . '

Everything added up with that one sentence .

Wakabayashi was listening to crazy stories about ghosts seriously and cooperating with Gotou from outside his jurisdiction because he was in a situation where he had to take any port in a storm .

Wakabayashi suddenly seemed much older .

'Is that so...'

'You two think that the kid's disappearance and the discovery of the corpse are related somehow, right?'

'Though it's just our instinct . '

'Tell me what you're thinking . '

Wakabayashi crossed his arms .

It made Gotou feel somewhat nervous .

'The ghost that's possessing the girl is probably the corpse found under the tree . '

'I see . '

'Who is that? Why is she possessing the girl? If we understand the reason, we can find the girl . That's what we think . '

Though Gotou declared these things, this was all knowledge from Yakumo .

Wakabayashi's eyes looked distant .

'Why did this happen?'

The flickering streetlights illuminated Wakabayashi's face .

His eyes looked like they could be smiling or laughing .

For a while, neither of them spoke . The sound of the engine sounded excessively loud .

'This is the curse of the witch,' said Wakabayashi quietly with his eyes closed .

Gotou didn't understand what his words meant –

3

– I wonder what sort of woman Rin was .

On the bus ride back, Haruka thought about the woman whom she knew only the name of .

Curse? That was ridiculous . She was suspected and oppressed . She lost the person who supported her . How did she feel?

Was she angry at the people who cornered her? Or –

Haruka's chest prickled with pain as she imagined it .

When she returned home, she headed for the room Yakumo and Gotou were staying in .

'Yakumo-kun . '

When she opened the sliding door, Yakumo had his chin in his hand as he read something that looked difficult .

He didn't lift his head .

'What are you reading?'

She peered in from beside Yakumo .

It was a notebook covered in dust and brown from age . There was a pile of similar notebooks on the table .

Words were written closely together on it, but at points, some of them were blurred .

'I found this at the Kinasa Clinic . '

Yakumo finally lifted his head .

He had an unusually grim expression .

'The clinic – as in the place where the mess with the witch began?'

'Yeah . I found something interesting . '

Yakumo fished through the box on the table and pulled out a photo .

It looked like it was taken at a high elevation, with the Togakushi mountain ridge in the background . In the foreground stood a middle-aged man in a

doctor's gown and a long-haired woman who was looking slightly downwards .

It was black-and-white with the colours warped at places, so it was hard to determine anything clearly . But –

'Could this woman be...'

'Correct . She's Rin-san,' said Yakumo .

'She...'

Haruka took the photo in her hand and looked at it again .

She really couldn't see the face clearly, but from her appearance, she didn't look like a witch at all . She looked as dignified as her name would suggest[2] .

'The person beside her is the clinic doctor . His name is Kawakami Harunobu...'

Kawakami was smiling in the photo .

'Were they married?'

'I don't know . But...'

'What?'

'No, never mind . '

Yakumo smiled self-derisively and took back the words he had started to say .

When he responded like that, Haruka became even more interested . She thought about asking again, but Yakumo spoke up before then .

'How did your side of things go?'

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair .

'Ah, well . A lot of things are still vague, but...'

She'd only given a summary on the phone . Haruka started from the beginning and reported the details of the information she had gathered to Yakumo .

Yakumo looked disinterested with his chin in his hand, but when she mentioned that Rin's son had red eyes and a horn on his head, his expression changed completely .

'Is that true?'

'I don't know . There was a rumour like that...'

'I see . '

Yakumo said that quietly and crossed his arms .

'Oh, also . '

Haruka gave the file she had received from Yoshii to Yakumo . It was a file of copies of articles about the murder case that had occurred at the cottage more than twenty years ago .

Yakumo looked through it with a difficult expression .

Finally, he murmured, 'I see,' and shut the file loudly .

'Did you figure something out?'

'I have no positive proof, but I see the outline of the case . '

'Hey, what do you mean?'

'There's something I need to confirm,' Yakumo said, evading Haruka's question and taking out his mobile .

Ishii received a call from Yakumo in the evening .

– There’s something I want you to look into .

After receiving Yakumo’s instructions, Ishii went to the hospital immediately .

He was there to meet the coroner, Hata .

He went through the entrance, took the stairs to the basement by the elevator and advanced through the dim and damp corridor to push open the door to the autopsy room .

‘Who is it?’

A creepy grin appeared on Hata’s wrinkled face .

Because they were in the autopsy room, it doubled how terrifying his face usually looked .

‘E-excuse me... It’s Ishii Yuutarou . ’

‘Oh, it’s you, Ishii-kun? Haven’t found Gotou yet?’

‘No, I know where he is, but... More importantly, there is something I would like you to confirm...’

Ishii wiped the sweat from his forehead .

‘Confirm? Keep it short . I’ve got to play with that soon . ’

Hata pointed at the stainless steel bed in the middle of the room .

The head was on top of it .

Its skin was swollen so Ishii couldn’t tell how old it was or what its face used to look like . Only those open eyes kept looking at Ishii blankly .

And those eyes were dyed deep red –

'Actually, that is what I would like you to confirm . '

Even while Ishii prepared to run away, he looked at the head .

'Oh? What do you want to know about this guy?'

Hata stooped over and looked at the head, smiling happily .

He really was appropriate for his job as a coroner . Ishii felt like he would faint at any moment .

'Ah, er . Actually, Yakumo-shi had a request...'

Ishii cleared his head and continued speaking .

'From Yakumo-kun?'

'Yes . '

'What is it?'

'Ah, yes . About that... He wanted to confirm whether there were any injuries on that head . '

'Injuries... That man died from a head injury... Is that what Yakumo-kun thinks?'

'I don't know...'

Ishii wasn't certain .

That was all he had heard from Yakumo on the phone . Ishii didn't have any idea why he wanted to confirm that .

'Well, fine . I planned on looking into that even without being told . '

'Is that so? Then please contact me once you have the results . '

Ishii wanted to leave this place as soon as he could .

'Ishii-kun . '

'Yes?'

'Could you help me a bit?' said Hata, rubbing his hands together .

'Eh? Me?'

– Again?

'It won't take any time at all . '

Even though Ishii didn't recall agreeing, Hata took latex gloves out of his doctor's gown and threw them at Ishii .

'Er, I have an urgent...'

'Could you hold this for a second?' said Hata, ignoring Ishii .

– Hold this?

'Hurry it up!'

'Ah, yes, er...'

'You just have to hold it . '

Hata's eyes goggled at him like a fish's . A shiver ran down Ishii's spine .

It was the first time Ishii had seen Hata look like that . If Ishii refused, he might be eaten from the head down . Ishii reluctantly put on the latex gloves he was given .

'J-just for a bit . '

'You just have to press down the head . '

'Ugh...'

When Ishii approached, the smell of formalin prickled at his nose .

Ishii held down the head with shaking hands .

The skin was swollen so it was squishier than he imagined .

– I really can't do this .

Ishii jumped back, pushing forward with both hands .

Then, the head fell off the stainless steel bed and rolled to Ishii's feet .

The deep red eyes stared at Ishii .

'Eek!'

He was already at his limit . As Ishii shrieked, he fainted .

5

'I'm back . '

When Gotou opened the sliding door, Yakumo and Haruka were sitting opposite each other . The atmosphere was so suffocating they could have been talking about a breakup .

'What's with this awful mood?'

When Gotou spoke up, Yakumo lifted his head, looking extremely annoyed .

'You're much more awful, Gotou-san . '

'What's that supposed to mean?'

'Obviously, I mean exactly what I said . '

Yakumo shook his head like he was fed up .

This guy really gets on my nerves – Gotou swallowed his irritation and sat cross-legged on the tatami .

'So did you get any information?'

Though Yakumo asked the question himself, he let out a disinterested yawn .

– What kind of attitude is that?

Though Gotou was angry, he explained in as much detail as he could the information he'd got out of Wakabayashi . He wanted to keep it short, but he didn't know what Yakumo would pick up on .

'I see...'

When Gotou finished explaining, Yakumo crossed his arms and let out a sigh .

'How about you?'

Gotou wanted to know the information Yakumo and Haruka had gathered . The story was so scattered that parts of it were confusing .

Like he thought explaining would be a pain, Yakumo threw the responsibility of explaining to Haruka: 'I'll leave it to you . '

Though Haruka complained, she explained in detail about what she'd heard from the journalist named Yoshii, Ookura at the Kinasa Museum and also Yumiko's grandmother .

She spoke particularly emotionally about the woman named Rin who was persecuted as a witch forty-five years ago . It seemed that she empathised with her situation .

'So what do you know?'

When Haruka finished explaining, Gotou asked Yakumo that question .

'Before I explain, I want you to confirm what Masato has found out about the search for Yumiko-chan,' Yakumo instructed Haruka .

'OK,' replied Haruka, taking out her mobile phone to contact Masato . She spread out a map and took notes for about ten minutes before hanging up .

'How was it?' asked Yakumo .

'The search is from the town to the mountain forest by the Togakushi plateau . It seems like they're focussing on the reservoir and river . '

'I see . '

Gotou nodded at Haruka's explanation .

It appeared they had expanded the search area from where she disappeared . Probably to determine if she had become lost or if there was an accident .

'Hey, do you know where Yumiko-chan is?' asked Haruka, hurrying Yakumo on .

For a while, Yakumo put his index finger to his brow and sat there, but he finally lifted his head like he had thought of something .

There was a sharp glint in his red left eye .

'Probably...'

Yakumo said just that one word .

Gotou and Haruka gulped as they waited for Yakumo to continue .

'She's probably around here . '

After a lengthy pause for effect, Yakumo traced an area on the map .

It included the clinic he'd gone to with Yakumo today and the cedar tree in Arakurayama .

'Why do you think she's here?' asked Gotou .

There was a twenty-kilometre distance between Asakawa, where Yumiko lived, and Arakurayama . And it was a steep mountain road . Gotou didn't understand why she would go there .

'Gotou-san, from what you said earlier, the corpse found at the cedar tree is from more than thirty years ago – correct?'

'Yeah . '

'That corpse is probably Rin-san, persecuted as a witch forty-five years ago . '

'That's... Then, Rin-san...'

Haruka's voice was filled with sorrow .

'She's already dead . She was killed,' Yakumo said indifferently .

'That's awful...'

After her surprise, Haruka lowered her eyelashes sadly .

However, Gotou wasn't surprised . After hearing what Haruka said, it linked up .

Haruka must have felt the same way . She probably just didn't want to believe it .

'Rin-san's ghost possessed Yumiko-chan and is searching . '

– Searching?

'What for?'

'I have Ishii looking into that for me now . '

– Ishii?

Why was Ishii coming up in the conversation now? Gotou didn't understand .

'That doesn't have anything to do with it, right?'

'It does . '

'How's it related?'

'You'll find out soon enough,' said Yakumo meaningfully . Then, he shut his mouth .

– Putting on airs .

Gotou clicked his tongue .

6

After discussing with Yakumo and Gotou, Haruka went to the shop parking lot alone .

The jet black mountains had a strange atmosphere to them .

When she looked up, the dark night sky was filled with stars . There were many more stars than she could see in tTokyo .

The air also felt tense .

'We'll be up early tomorrow . You should sleep . '

She heard a voice from behind her .

She could tell without turning around . It was Yakumo .

'I wonder if Yumiko-chan's OK,' Haruka said, still looking up at the sky .

'If you doubt that, you won't be able to do anything any more . '

Yakumo stood next to her .

Though he always acted collected, he was just pressing down his feelings – he was anxious himself . Haruka knew that .

'That's right . '

Haruka looked at Yakumo's profile .

With the moonlight, his red left eye seemed to glitter .

'Do you think Rin-san is resentful?'

As Yakumo said that, he looked up at the sky .

She was persecuted as a witch . She lost the person who supported her . In the end, she died herself too . It was such a sad life . It would be natural for her to hate the world .

But –

'I feel like Rin-san doesn't hate anyone . '

It was just a wish, but Haruka felt like in the ghost photo, Rin didn't have any resentment but rather some other emotion .

Normally Yakumo would get angry – 'Don't make a decision with speculation' – but he nodded, like he was agreeing .

'In my theory, Rin-san isn't resentful – that is the premise . '

'Then if she is resentful?'

'We won't find Yumiko-chan . '

Yakumo's voice reverberated deep into Haruka's ears .

Though Yakumo always revealed his theory after obtaining clear evidence, this time, it was different .

He might not have been able to do anything else .

Normally, he would meet the ghost that was possessing the person, listen to them and solve the case, but this time, Yumiko, who had been possessed, had disappeared . They hadn't met her even once .

Furthermore, the search area was wide, included dark forests, and they couldn't guarantee the time .

Even if it was just a wish, all they could do now was believe in it and act .

'This is why you grew up . '

Yakumo suddenly spoke up .

'Yup . I was born here and grew up here . This is my hometown . '

'When I came last time, I didn't know that,' Yakumo said awkwardly, smiling while showing his white teeth .

He was probably talking about the time he was abducted and confined . Yakumo had come here then too, but there hadn't been the time to look up at the starry sky like this .

'It's a nice place, right?'

Haruka knew he would complain, saying something like 'It isn't or 'It's the countryside' . But what Yakumo replied was completely different from what she expected .

'This is my hometown too . '

– Eh?

Yakumo-kun shouldn't have been born here . Then why?

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . What do you...'

'You'll understand tomorrow . '

After saying that, Yakumo narrowed his eyes .

His red left eye looked a little bit wet –

7

Gotou rubbed his sleepy eyes as he drove on the winding mountain road .

Yakumo in the passenger seat had even messier bedhead as usual as he vacantly looked out the window . In the back seat, Haruka and Masato sat next to each other, looking anxious .

'Hey, Yakumo . Who killed that Rin woman?'

From what he'd heard yesterday, Rin was killed by somebody . Gotou thought that finding that out would lead them to solving the case .

'You don't know?' said Yakumo, still looking out the window .

The way he said that made Gotou think Yakumo already knew the answer .

'I don't know . '

'Please think about it calmly,' Yakumo said quietly, turning his gaze to Gotou .

'I'm asking because I can't figure it out even after thinking about it!'

'Please don't speak so loudly . '

Yakumo stuck his fingers in his ears .

'Just tell me already . '

'Though this is just a theory, there were people who were prejudiced against Rin-san, yes?'

'The landowner's son and the local officer?'

'Yes . '

Yakumo nodded .

The first person who made a fuss about Rin being a demon were Takafumi, the second son of the landowner family Kitaoka, and the man who was the local village officer .

'So they didn't just chase her out – they killed her?'

'That is very likely . '

'They can't have really thought she was a witch, right?'

'They really thought she was a demon . '

Gotou's eyes went wide at Yakumo's unexpected answer .

'You're kidding, right?'

'No . As is clear from the information gathered yesterday, Rin-san wasn't treated as a witch just by those two but by the whole village, and she was persecuted for it . '

'Why would that happen?' Haruka interrupted, like she couldn't hold herself back .

'That's the sort of place this is . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair, seeming annoyed .

'What do you mean?' asked Gotou .

'I mentioned the Momijigari story in Kinasa earlier, correct?'

'Yeah, but that's just...'

'It's not just anything . This area has been considered as a sacred mountain where spirits gather for a very long time, and women were prohibited from entering . '

Yakumo spoke quickly .

'Oi, oi . You're kidding right?'

Gotou couldn't believe what Yakumo was saying .

'I'm not lying . There was a building called the nyonindou, which was as far as women could go . '

'I can't believe it . '

'In Togakushi, there is something called the nun's rock . '

'The nun's rock?'

'Yes . In the past, a nun stepped beyond the border . That moment, she incurred the wrath of the gods and was turned into a rock . '

'So that rock is the nun's rock[3] . '

Yakumo nodded .

'Why'd they do that?'

'Because women were thought of as impure . '

Impure . To put it simply, that would be dirty .

Saying something like that in current society would make people doubt your humanity, but at the time, it had been correct .

From Yakumo's explanation just now, Gotou felt like he sort of understood .

A place with a sacred mountain where spirits gathered and the legend of Momijigari where women were prohibited –

The existence of witches was much closer here than in other places .
People's hearts had probably been filled with awe and fright .

A question came to Gotou after hearing this much .

'But the two guys who said Rin was a witch were found as corpses twenty years ago, right?'

There was an article about the case in the documents Haruka received from the newspaper reporter named Yoshii yesterday .

'That is the case . '

Yakumo yawned, seeming bored .

'Who killed those two?'

'Who knows? I haven't reached that conclusion yet . '

Though Yakumo shrugged, Gotou knew immediately that it was an act . He had an idea, but he didn't want to say it at this stage .

That meant Yakumo wouldn't reply no matter what Gotou asked . Well, the truth would be revealed soon enough .

Gotou gave up and drove the car .

8

Ishii opened his eyes on a seat in the precinct .

He had planned on helping Hata last night, but he had fainted for the second time and returned branded as useless .

It seemed like he'd put his head down on the desk and fallen asleep just like that .

Just as he had stretched and put on his glasses, his mobile phone rang .

'Hello, Ishii Yuutarou speaking . '

He answered immediately and heard a creepy giggle .

He felt wide awake immediately .

<I've found out a number of things . >

'R-really?'

<There would be no point lying about it . >

'That's true...'

<Anyway, if you want to know the results, come yourself . >

After saying just that, he hung up .

You could have told me over the phone – is what Ishii thought, but he didn't say it aloud, as was his personality . When he thought about seeing that head once more, he couldn't do anything but be depressed .

Ishii picked up his jacket and left the room .

After leaving the precinct through the front entrance, he headed towards the parking lot where he had parked the car .

He had just put his hand on the door when he suddenly felt somebody's gaze on him . He looked around, but nobody was there .

– It appears to have been my imagination .

Since Nanase Miyuki had escaped, he might have been a bit on edge .

Ishii sat in the driver's seat and started the engine .

The moment he was about to step on the pedal, the door to the backseat opened .

– Eh?

He saw somebody get into the backseat through the rear-view mirror .

A woman . The left half of her face was burnt and her unusually red lips were twisted into a smile . She was –

– Nanase Miyuki .

It was already too late when Ishii realised .

She held a cold and glittering knife at his neck .

The blood left his face all at once in his terror .

'Ishii-san, we meet again . '

Nanase Miyuki's breath brushed his ear .

Ishii's terror doubled . He couldn't move even an eyebrow, let alone resist .

'Where is he?' murmured Nanase Miyuki .

– He?

'W-what are you talking about?' replied Ishii in a shaking voice .

Then, the knife at his neck drew closer . A jolt of pain ran through him . Ishii held his breath .

'You know, right? I don't mind if you don't want to say . I'll kill you and ask somebody else . '

Nanase Miyuki's sadistic smile was reflected in the rear-view mirror .

She wasn't lying . If Ishii resisted, she would thrust that knife into his neck without any hesitation .

Ishii could feel it in his skin .

'So, where is he?' said Nanase Miyuki calmly .

The 'he' she was talking about was probably the head of the man with two red eyes .

'Hospital...'

'Hospital? Why?'

'To be autopsied...'

Nanase Miyuki let out a beastly scream before Ishii could be finished speaking .

'Don't joke with me! I won't allow low-class humans like you to touch that man!'

– She didn't want to let other people touch him .

Makoto had given that reason to explain why Nanase Miyuki was walking around with the head of the man with two red eyes .

She might have been right . Nanase Miyuki wanted, loved and revered the man with two red eyes so much she was mad .

'Start the car,' said Miyuki with ragged breathing .

'W-where to?'

'You know, right? I'm going to take him back . I'm going to take that man back . '

Ishii couldn't resist .

He swallowed his fear and started the car .

9

Haruka held Masato's hand as they walked down the narrow road, which was like an animal trail .

Yakumo and Gotou were walking right in front of them, leading the way .

'You OK?'

It was a rather steep slope, so she spoke to Masato . Though his head was covered in sweat, Masato nodded .

He was propelled by his wholehearted wish to save Yumiko .

Finally, she saw an old wooden building in the middle of the thick forest . That was probably Kinasa Clinic .

'Nobody's here,' said Gotou in a disgruntled tone as he stood in front of the clinic with his hands in his pockets

'I just said that it was likely she would be around here,' said Yakumo in exasperation as he shook his head .

'Hey, why do you think she'll be around here?' asked Haruka .

Though she had come here because she believed in Yakumo, she didn't know what proof he had .

'This is a place close to Rin-san and her son . In other words, their home . '

'I see . '

If Rin's spirit was possessing Yumiko, it made sense to think she would visit her home .

'Let's split up . '

'That would be more effective . '

Gotou agreed with Yakumo's suggestion .

'Gotou-san and I will search over here . You and Masato wait here . '

'OK . '

Haruka nodded .

Masato looked rather tired and it would be dangerous to walk around the mountain . It would probably be better to wait and leave this to Yakumo and Gotou . The moment she thought that, Masato spoke up .

'I don't want to . '

'Masato-kun . '

Haruka wanted to comfort him, but Masato didn't respond .

'I'll look too . Yumiko-chan disappeared because of me, so...'

As Masato said that, his eyes were filled with a strong will .

He wanted to find Yumiko himself no matter what . If they crushed that will, Masato might hole up within himself again .

'Hey, I'll go search with Masato-kun,' suggested Haruka .

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair, as if to say, 'Guess I can't do anything about it . '

'Let them search . He's not a kid either – he wants to take responsibility for himself . '

Unexpectedly, Gotou agreed .

'Got it . You and Masato search near the clinic . I'll go to the east, and Gotou-san, I'll leave the west to you . '

Beaten by their persistence, Yakumo gave out instructions .

Masato's face became brighter at once .

'Promise me one thing . Even if you find Yumiko-chan, don't chase after her or approach her . Contact me . OK?' Yakumo said to Masato .

'OK, I got it . '

Masato nodded with a hard look on his face .

'Let's meet up again here in thirty minutes . '

Everyone nodded at Yakumo's words .

'I'm going then . '

Gotou briskly started walking towards the west .

'I'll leave Masato to you,' Yakumo said to Haruka quietly . Then, he started walking towards the east .

'Let's go too . '

'OK . '

Haruka and Masato started walking together .

They went along a trackless path . It was humid here and there was leaf mould, so their feet sunk into the ground . It was terribly difficult to walk . It was easy to slip on slopes too .

Furthermore, there were points which were like steep cliffs, so they had to be very careful not to lose their footing .

'Watch your step,' she said to Masato .

'OK . '

Masato nodded with a stiff expression .

He was probably worried about Yumiko .

'IT's fine . She's OK . '

Yakumo might have said it was irresponsible of her if he heard, but they couldn't search without hope .

'Hey . '

Masato suddenly stopped .

Masato's forehead was covered in sweat . He might have walked too quickly .

'Shall we take a break?'

When Haruka spoke to him, Masato shook his head and took a deep breath .

'Why was it Yumiko-chan?'

'Why?'

'Tomoya-kun and I were there then . But...'

That was true . Why did Rin possess Yumiko instead of Masato or Tomoya?

Yakumo had said something before .

The wavelengths might match – a body easy to attract, or in short, somebody with a body easy to possess .

However, Haruka felt like that wasn't what Masato was trying to say .

'Masato-kun, don't blame yourself . '

'I should've been possessed instead . '

Masato's eyes welled up with tears .

He was angry at the unreasonable world . He resented himself for being powerless .

Would Masato's heart be able to take it if the worst-case scenario occurred? The upright and clean-handed Masato would blame himself .

Because he was an awkward but straightforward kid, like Yakumo –

'Let's go . Yumiko-chan's waiting . '

Haruka put both of her hands on Masato's shoulders .

'Is Yumiko-chan OK?'

'I believe so . Do you think differently, Masato-kun?'

Masato sniffled and shook his head .

His eyes were lit up again . He started walking with a strong gait, yelling, 'Yumiko-chan! Where are you?'

– I have to do my best too .

When Haruka started walking again, her heart started beating loudly .

– Rustle .

The verdant trees were shaking loudly .

She felt her breath caught, like she was in a damp cave .

– Somebody's watching us .

10

Ishii passed through the hospital entrance .

Nanase Miyuki was right behind him . Ishii wanted to run away, but he couldn't do anything about the knife at his side .

If only somebody would notice – is what he was hoping, but it appeared to be no use .

He went down the stairs to the basement by the elevator . He walked along the dim, cavernous corridor with heavy feet .

'Please knock on the door . '

After coming to the autopsy room, Nanase Miyuki whispered that in his ear .

A jolt went down his spine .

In his terror, Ishii knocked on the door just as he was told .

'Who is it?'

He heard Hata from Inside .

At Miyuki's urging, Ishii spoke, conscious of the tremor in his throat .

'I-it's Ishii . '

'It's open,' said Hata .

At Nanase Miyuki's insistence, Ishii opened the door with trembling hands .

'What? You got caught so easily? How pathetic . '

When Hata turned around, he didn't speak like he was surprised at the situation .

'Sorry, but could you return him to me?' said Miyuki, looking at the head on the stainless steel bed .

Miyuki had been calling the head 'him' . Just as Makoto had said, she didn't want to give it to anybody . It was probably special to her .

'This is a rare research opportunity . I won't give it back so easily . '

After Hata said that, he let out a laugh inappropriate for the situation .

'Would it be acceptable if I added one more head for your autopsies?'

Nanase Miyuki put the tip of the knife at Ishii's neck and pressed down so hard it hurt .

If she put in just a bit more force, it would definitely break through the skin and make him bleed .

Ishii's forehead started spewing sweat .

'There's no point in researching Ishii-kun's head . Even if you added a head like that – '

Hata was mumbling, sounding dissatisfied .

'Now, what will you do?' said Miyuki with a pointed tone .

It was a worst-case scenario . Even if Hata returned the head of the man with red eyes, Ishii didn't think Nanase Miyuki would just head home .

She would slice both Ishii and Hata up in a bloodbath .

'Got it . Do what you want . '

After saying that, Hata looked at Ishii .

– Eh?

Ishii was confused, but then he noticed Hata was holding a bottle of fluid that had been on the wagon . Ishii could read the word formalin from that bottle .

It was dangerous, but it seemed like all Ishii could do now was bet on Hata .

'My, my . You're unexpectedly honest . '

Miyuki smiled .

'Take this too . '

Hata threw the bottle in his hand .

It arced over, shattering at Ishii's feet .

Ishii shut his eyes tightly and stopped breathing .

Formalin splashed everywhere . Ishii felt an electrifying pain when doused with the strong formalin, but Nanase Miyuki appeared to feel the same way .

'No!'

Miyuki's shriek cut through the room . At the same time, the knife left Ishii's neck .

Ishii used that opportunity to run .

'Old man! You did it now!'

He heard Miyuki's furious voice .

However, the alarm bell started ringing, blocking it out . Hata had probably sat it off .

He heard somebody running off .

'She got away . '

While saying that, Hata went over to Ishii, who was on all fours, and wiped Ishii's face with a wet towel .

'It's OK now . '

When Hata said that, Ishii timidly opened his eyes .

Though there was still a stinging pain, it wasn't unbearable .

'T-thank you very much . '

While hating himself for being useless, Ishii thanked Hata .

'It'd be better to get out of the room for now . '

'Y-yes . '

Ishii stood up while answering . Then, he noticed that the head had disappeared from the stainless steel bed .

'Hata-san, the head...'

'Ah, looks like she took it away – '

Hata murmured that in a truly disappointed voice .

11

– Who is it?

Haruka felt somebody watching her, so she looked around frantically in the dark forest .

Her heart was beating like a hammer .

Maybe I imagined it – is what she thought when a woman appeared in the corner of her vision .

About five metres in front of her . By a craggy rock, a woman with long hair in a white blouse and navy skirt .

– Is that...?

The moment Haruka tried to approach her, she disappeared, like she had melted into the forest .

'What was it?'

Haruka walked over to the rock where the woman had been standing . Then, she spotted a white running shoe on the floor .

– Could it be?

'Masato-kun, over here . '

Haruka called out to Masato who was a little away from her as she walked towards the rock .

There was a hole between the work and the ground about forty centimetres tall and one metre wide .

She saw a girl lying there .

– We've found her!

She had to be Yumiko .

'Hang in there!'

Haruka crouched on the ground and shook Yumiko's body as she called out to her .

It was faint, but her chest was moving up and down .

– Thank goodness . She's alive .

Though Masato kept stumbling, he ran towards her with a pale expression .

Haruka took her mobile phone out of her pocket immediately and called Yakumo . However, she couldn't contact him since she was out of range .

'Whaaarr...'

Haruka heard a voice in her ear .

Her body froze like she was paralysed . She slowly looked up and saw the woman from earlier standing there .

Her long hair hung around her face . Her deep red lips moved like worms .

Haruka couldn't speak in her fear .

'Whaaarr...'

– I need to run .

Though Haruka thought that, her body wouldn't move the way she wanted it to .

The woman's hand reached out .

Haruka's forehead was sweating furiously . Her throat was dry . She couldn't even breathe .

– It hurts .

'Stop!'

Masato shouted out and ran in front of Haruka to protect her from the woman .

With his small body, he spread his arms as wide as he could .

'Masato-kun, no!'

– If you do that, you'll –

Haruka shouted, but it was too late .

A spasm ran through Masato's body, like he had been hit by lightning . Then, he fell to the ground, unmoving .

'Masato-kun . Are you OK?'

Haruka went to him immediately and called out .

– Oh no . What should I do?

Haruka was panicked when suddenly Masato grabbed her wrist .

'Masato-kun . '

Just as Haruka spoke, Masato opened his eyes .

Those eyes – weren't Masato's .

Somebody else was inside him . It wasn't her reasoning – Haruka could feel it .

Haruka's whole body started to sweat .

' ... '

She heard somebody whisper .

It seemed to go straight to her brain .

' ... Whe... re... am... I... '

Haruka was so frightened that she shook off Masato's hand and covered her eyes .

However, she could still hear the voice .

'Nooooo!'

She screamed as loudly as she could to try to erase the voice following her ears .

Her body wouldn't stop shaking .

How long have I been doing this – she suddenly came to her senses .

The voice had stopped .

She noticed that she was cowering on the floor .

She timidly lifted her gaze . Yumiko was collapsed in front of her .
However, Masato was nowhere to be seen .

'Masato-kun? Masato-kun?'

Haruka looked around frantically, but she couldn't spot him .

She heard the footsteps of somebody running towards her .

'Masato-kun?'

Haruka turned around . Yakumo was there .

'What was that scream just now?' said Yakumo, still panting for breath .

'Masato-kun... Masato-kun...'

'Was I too late?' muttered Yakumo, his eyes narrowed .

– I did something unthinkable .

12

'What happened?' Gotou asked Yakumo, who had his arms crossed as he leant against the hospital wall .

They had heard a scream from the forest and ran over to find Yumiko collapsed there . They quickly brought her to a nearby hospital . The doctor said she would be fine if she got some rest – so they had the doctor's word . However, Masato had disappeared instead .

Gotou felt like the situation had become more serious .

'It's simple . '

Yakumo lifted his head slowly .

However, he was sure tense for something that was supposed to be simple .

'What's simple?'

'The ghost that was possessing Yumiko-chan possessed Masato . '

He said it matter-of-factly, but –

'Why?'

'Because Yumiko-chan was weakened and her body couldn't move any more . '

– I see .

If they had done as Yakumo ordered and didn't add Haruka and Masato to the search, leaving them in the clinic, this might not have happened .

Gotou was partly responsible . But he didn't have the time to regret it now .

'We need to find Masato right away . '

'Yes . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair as he looked out the window .

'So what are we going to do?'

Gotou leant against the wall and looked out the window like Yakumo as he said that .

The grey clouds blocked out the sun . It made Gotou feel uncomfortable, like it was a sign of what was to come .

'We still have a trick up our sleeve . '

Gotou felt like Yakumo's red left eye was filled with force .

'What?'

Just as Gotou asked that, his mobile rang . It was from Ishii .

Gotou wanted to ignore it, but he decided that would be bad and answered .

'What?'

<D-Detective Gotou . You finally answered . >

Ishii spoke like he was talking to his only surviving parent .

'Forget about that . What is it?'

<Ah, yes sir . A-actually, it is quite the situation here...>

His voice was so faint it sounded like he would cry at any moment .

'It's even worse here . '

<No, I believe it's worse here . >

'Shut up! We've got a real situation here!'

<It is quite the situation here as well!>

'How long are you going to have this fruitless exchange for? It doesn't matter, right?'

Yakumo looked at Gotou coldly .

'What's the problem?'

Gotou urged Ishii to continue with a click of his tongue .

<Ah, yes sir . A-actually, Nanase Miyuki showed up again . >

'W-what did you say?'

Gotou's body stiffened instinctively . That really was a problem –

<She came to take the head . >

Gotou had heard from Yakumo . The head of the man with red eyes that Ishii and Miyagawa had found .

Why was she so focussed on something when she should be escaping – Gotou had no way to understand .

'Then what?'

<We let her get away...>

It felt like Ishii's voice would disappear at any moment .

'You let her get away again!? You idiot!' yelled Gotou, kicking the corridor wall in his anger .

Once was already bad enough, but to let her get away twice – he really was useless .

'Gotou-san, please lend that to me . '

Right after saying that, Yakumo took Gotou's mobile from the side . Gotou was about to complain, but Yakumo walked away down the corridor while talking on the phone with Ishii .

– Whose mobile does he think that is?

13

'It's my fault...'

Haruka held her head as she sat on the sofa in the hospital waiting room .

It was about four tatami in size with only a sofa for four and a magazine rack – a dreary room .

– Why couldn't I move then?

That thought kept circling her head .

Masato tried to save Haruka . A boy in elementary school had tried to save her, but Haruka had shut her eyes and ears in her fear .

She hated herself so much for her uselessness .

If anything happened to Masato – when Haruka thought that, her body heated up and her chest felt like it would collapse .

Masato must have felt this way ever since Yumiko disappeared .

'Want a coffee?'

Haruka looked up at the voice and saw Gotou standing there with two cans of coffee .

– How can he be so calm?

His relaxed attitude irritated Haruka for some reason .

'Anyway, drink and calm down a bit . '

Gotou held the can of coffee out towards Haruka, sat down next to her and suddenly spoke .

'The girl called Yumiko's weak, but it's not serious . '

'I see...'

'Her parents will be here soon too...'

Most of Gotou's words didn't enter Haruka's ears .

Even if Yumiko was saved, Masato had disappeared . Nothing had changed .

'It seems like she doesn't remember anything from when she was possessed . '

Gotou finished talking .

He probably didn't mean it that way, but the way he said it made it sound like the case had ended completely .

Haruka gripped the can of coffee in her hand tightly .

'It isn't over yet...'

It slipped out of her mouth .

Gotou's brows furrowed and he looked at Haruka doubtfully . She didn't understand why he looked like that .

'I know how you feel, but regretting what's happened won't start anything . '

Gotou pulled open the tab on the can and poured the coffee down his throat .

'It's my fault . Of course I regret it . '

'There's nothing you could've done . '

'There was!'

She spoke more loudly than she thought she would .

However, Gotou didn't look disturbed . He looked straight at Haruka .

It was a sharp and forceful gaze .

'There's nothing you could've done . '

'How can you say that so lightly? If I had done what Yakumo-kun said, this wouldn't have...'

Even as Haruka spoke, she could feel her throat tremble .

'You can't be sure . '

'It's a fact . '

'Got nothing to do with it . '

'That's right . This case doesn't have anything to do with you, Gotou-san . '

– What on earth am I saying?

Throwing a tantrum wouldn't change anything . Haruka knew that . But she couldn't put a stopper on her emotions .

The corners of her eyes felt warm .

'That's right . This case doesn't matter to me at all . '

'That's awful...'

While being surprised by the unexpected words that had come out of Gotou's mouth, a ripple of disappointment spread through her chest .

Gotou really had just been wrapped up in this case against his will this time, but Haruka had thought he had wanted to help . But –

'To say it outright, I don't care about the truth of the case at all . It'll be enough for me if Masato comes back safely . '

Even though Gotou looked like he felt awkward, he said it clearly .

I –

'Am I wrong?'

Haruka shook her head at the question .

Then, the tears that had welled up in her eyes came spilling down her cheeks .

'Then lift your head . We don't have the time to regret what's happened . '

Haruka nodded at Gotou's words, sniffled and lifted her head .

'So you say some good things sometimes . '

Yakumo had come up to them unnoticed .

Though he was running a hand through his hair and seemed annoyed, his red left eye was unusually sharp .

'Yakumo-kun, I – '

Yakumo looked straight at Haruka and snorted .

'If you want to blame anyone, blame me . '

'Eh?'

'No matter what you said, I shouldn't have added Masato to the search . '

'That's...'

'There'll be no end to it if we talk about things we should have done then .
The past is past . '

– That's right .

'Then we'll work for the best outcome now . That's the best and only method for us now,' declared Yakumo . Then, he handed a mobile phone to Gotou .

Both Yakumo and Gotou were already thinking about what to do next, but Haruka had been stuck there, looking behind her .

When she thought about that, she felt so embarrassed she thought her face would light on fire .

– We have to go forward .

'Well, we're all on the same page now . Time to go search . '

Gotou stood up after finishing his can of coffee .

'Do you have any idea as to where he went?' asked Haruka, wiping away her tears .

'Of course not,' replied Gotou in a proud tone, hand at his waist .

Going without a plan was reckless . If they searched the wide mountain blindly, it would be hard to find Masato .

'Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka looked at Yakumo with an expectant gaze .

After thinking for a while, the corners of Yakumo's lips turned up in a smile .

It was the expression he always had when he had thought of something .

'First, we need to make the truth clear . '

As Yakumo said that, his red left eye seemed somewhat sad .

14

After explaining to Yakumo, Ishii sat on the bench in the hospital waiting room .

Since the fugitive Nanase Miyuki had appeared, the hospital was bustling with officers .

– I'm alive .

Ishii let out a sigh .

'That was a disaster . '

Miyagawa was the one who spoke .

'I-I sincerely apologise . I let her escape not once but twice...'

Ishii reflexively stood up and bowed .

That might have been their once-in-a-million chance to arrest Nanase Miyuki, but Ishii hadn't been able to do anything .

He was furious with how useless he was .

'There'd be no point if you died . '

Miyagawa sat on the bench with a gentle smile .

Since Ishii had thought Miyagawa would get angry at him, it was anticlimactic .

'B-but Detective Gotou would have...'

If Gotou had been in the same situation, he would have definitely rushed straight forward and caught her .

'Don't act like that idiot . '

Miyagawa snorted in exasperation .

'But...'

'He's him, and you're you . '

'H-huh...'

What Miyagawa said was obvious, but Ishii felt like his true meaning was somewhere deeper .

Ishii couldn't find that meaning, so he gave a vague response .

'Hey, Ishii . '

After a pause, Miyagawa spoke, his eyes distant .

'What is it?'

'I don't understand the woman named Nanase Miyuki . '

'Don't understand?'

'Yeah . She should be running away . '

'Yes . '

'But why would she come to take back the head, putting herself at risk of being caught? I don't understand at all . '

Miyagawa slapped his forehead with his palm .

Ishii didn't understand Nanase Miyuki's psychology either, but if he borrowed Makoto's words, it would be –

'Love...'

'Hah?'

Miyagawa's face twisted like he was looking at something unpleasant . Perhaps he had misunderstood terribly .

'Ah, this isn't from me . It's something the newspaper reporter Hijikata Makoto-san said . '

Ishii hurriedly added to his explanation .

'The ex-chief's daughter, eh...'

Miyagawa looked up, as if he were searching his memories .

'Ah, yes . In her opinion, Nanase Miyuki might be committing crimes for love...'

'Love, eh?'

Miyagawa's brows furrowed .

'That also might be the reason she came to get the head even though it would put her in danger...'

'Love? That's idiotic . '

Miyagawa snorted and stood up .

Ishii understood how he felt . Thinking about it rationally, Nanase Miyuki's actions were completely unreasonable .

However, there were people in this world who had completely different worldviews than they did .

To Ishii and Miyagawa, it was just a head, but to Nanase Miyuki, it was probably something so important she would do anything to keep it with her, no matter how dangerous .

Maybe we won't ever be able to catch her unless we understand her – Ishii felt that way .

'Just right up a report after . '

Ishii watched Miyagawa walk away after saying that .

15

Gotou was in the parking lot of the hospital Yumiko was in .

Yakumo was next to him . He looked discouraged .

'What are you thinking about?'

Yakumo gave a short reply – 'Nothing much' – to Gotou's question . But that wasn't the case . When Yakumo looked like this, he was looking at a truth that Gotou couldn't see .

After a while, a black family car stopped and a man came out from inside . It was Wakabayashi from the Nagano precinct .

Gotou had called him out at Yakumo's instruction .

'What are you going to do now that I've called him out?' Gotou asked Yakumo .

'You'll understand soon enough . '

'Sorry, I was a bit late . '

Wakabayashi walked towards them with a smile .

It was a good mood that didn't fit the location .

'I apologise as well for calling you out to a play like this . '

Gotou bowed his head formally towards Wakabayashi .

'Don't worry about it . You found Yumiko for me . I wanted to thank you . '

'I'm just glad she's safe . '

'I'm glad . Really glad . '

Wakabayashi looked like he would cry at any moment .

Yakumo had said that Wakabayashi was related to the case .

He was an old detective who had given information to Gotou even though he was out of his jurisdiction, because he was worried about his relative's kid Yumiko's safety . Was he really related –

'Wakabayashi-san, if it's all right with you, I have something to ask . '

Yakumo took a step towards Wakabayashi .

'You're here too? I'll tell you anything I know,' responded Wakabayashi with a smile . He was the complete opposite of Yakumo with his intimidating air .

'There's no time, so I'll be direct . What we found under the cedar tree was the woman named Rin who was killed forty-five years ago . '

'Wha... Why do you know...'

Wakabayashi's face went pale .

After a moment of silence, Wakabayashi cringed, like he was saying 'Shoot', but it was too late .

'The police haven't been able to confirm her identity yet, correct? But the response just now makes it seem like you knew who was buried there from the beginning, doesn't it?'

Yakumo looked at Wakabayashi with a sharp gaze .

'How would I know about something so long ago?'

Wakabayashi's cunning eyes were darting back and forth, unable to calm down .

'Do you really not know?'

Yakumo took another step forward, cutting down the distance between them . Wakabayashi looked down . His gesture just now admitted that it was a lie .

'I don't know . '

Wakabayashi's voice as he denied it was terribly weak .

'Then I'll ask this . You said this to Gotou-san, correct? "Ganging up to beat a frail woman to death"... '

Wakabayashi had said that to Gotou .

He hadn't thought it was strange at the time, but now he understood what was unnatural .

'Urgh...'

Wakabayashi's forehead was damp with sweat .

Yakumo took another step towards Wakabayashi to shorten the distance between them .

'It sounds like you were saying there were multiple culprits . '

'You're just jumping to conclusions . '

Wakabayashi's breathing was ragged . Gotou could easily tell that he was troubled .

It can't be –

'Were you the one who...'

Gotou said that without thinking .

'You're wrong!'

Wakabayashi's eyes were bulging as he shook his head back and forth and stepped back .

'Please tell me the truth . '

'I don't know anything!'

He wouldn't speak no matter what . Gotou felt that stubborn will .

'Wakabayashi-san, my red left eye can see the spirits of the dead . '

As Yakumo said that, he suddenly brought his face close to Wakabayashi's .

Wakabayashi looked away to avoid that gaze . Yakumo continued regardless .

'I can hear her voice . You can hear it too, can't you...'

Yakumo whispered in Wakabayashi's ear .

'... Where?'

Gotou heard a woman's voice from somewhere .

It didn't seem like it was his ears playing tricks on him . Wakabayashi looked around too, his eyes still round .

'... Where?'

– Again .

'Where!'

A woman appeared from the thicket at the end of the parking lot .

The woman wore a white blouse and a navy skirt . Since she was far away, was looking down and had her long hair hanging around her face, Gotou couldn't see her face .

'I don't know . I really don't know . '

Wakabayashi's eyes went rounder the moment he saw the woman and stepped back while speaking in a voice close to a scream .

'Where!'

The woman let out a shrill shriek and slowly approached them .

'I'm sorry! I'm at fault! Forgive me!'

Wakabayashi prostrated himself, forehead rubbing against the ground, and yelled in a voice an octave higher than before . His body was shaking

violently .

'So you really do know . '

Wakabayashi's shoulders fell at Yakumo's voice .

'You can stop now . '

When Yakumo spoke, the woman lifted her head and took off her wig . It was Haruka . That was quite the performance - Gotou had felt afraid, even though he knew .

Wakabayashi looked blank .

'W-what are you planning?'

Wakabayashi had finally understood the situation . He spoke frantically .

'You will tell us the truth . '

Yakumo knelt down on one knee to look at Wakabayashi, still on the ground .

'I...' said Wakabayashi with a gasp .

His eyes were bloodshot and his voice was trembling terribly too .

'Let's put an end to this, for your sake . '

Yakumo looked at Wakabayashi with his red left eye .

For a while, Wakabayashi accepted the gaze straight on, but he finally shook his head, giving up .

'I didn't want anyone to find her...'

Wakabayashi's voice was faint and weak .

'The person who killed her was the local officer at the time – your father, correct?'

Wakabayashi bit his dry lips and gave a small nod .

'You'll talk, yes?'

Urged on by Yakumo, Wakabayashi started speaking one sentence at a time .

'Forty-five years ago – a man died at that clinic . Kitaoka Hidetaka, the eldest son of the landowner . My father and the second son, Takafumi, said it was the curse of Rin, who lived at the clinic . '

'Why did they say that?'

Gotou's voice was ragged . He didn't understand at all .

Even if it was a place with a legend about a witch, it was ridiculous for both Takafumi and Wakabayashi's father to believe in this .

'I'll explain later . Let's listen to Wakabayashi-san now . '

Yakumo shut down Gotou's question .

Gotou didn't understand, but he decided to listen to Wakabayashi for now, just as Yakumo told him to .

Wakabayashi's legs collapsed underneath him as he continued speaking .

'The villagers believed it too and started harassing the clinic . Nobody would talk to them any more or sell them anything . I was told not to go near them too . '

'That wasn't all, right?'

Yakumo urged Wakabayashi for more .

Wakabayashi's face twisted, like he was in pain . Then, he continued .

'They threw rocks at the clinic and left dead things at the door, and some people even set it on fire...'

'Why would they do that? Rin-san wasn't a demon!' shouted Haruka, leaning forward with a hand on her chest .

'I-I'm sorry . '

Wakabayashi lowered his head again .

'Apologising won't make up for it!'

Haruka yelled more in her anger .

It really was a horrid story . What they were doing was just bullying .

'Stop . '

Yakumo placed a hand on Haruka's shoulder .

'But . '

'Wakabayashi wasn't the one who did it,' admonished Yakumo, since Haruka still wouldn't back down .

Haruka finally became calm again . She ground her back teeth and looked away from Wakabayashi .

'It was really awful...'

Wakabayashi's eyes were distant .

'So that persecution kept escalating,' said Yakumo after taking a deep breath .

'After a while of this, Doctor Kawakami from the clinic fell into the valley and died . The rumours about it being witchcraft became even louder . '

'And then the incident happened . '

'That day, I went to the mountain to gather mushrooms . Then, I saw her running away with her son . It looked like somebody was chasing her...'

'That was...'

Gotou swallowed .

'Yes . My father, the local officer, and Takafumi, the landowner's second son . '

'Finally, they caught her and killed her then,' said Yakumo .

Wakabayashi nodded . 'That – wasn't something a person should do,' he said with tears in his eyes .

'That was a demon . '

Wakabayashi's words filled the silence .

'Demon?'

When Gotou repeated it, Wakabayashi nodded again and continued .

'The two of them suddenly hit her . She collapsed to the ground . She was in pain, but they kicked her . Again, and again, and again...'

Tears rolled down Wakabayashi's face, like he was letting out sediment that had gathered for a very long time .

– Disgusting .

'Her screams echoed through the mountains . I covered my ears and shut my eyes . All I could do was cower behind the trees . '

Wakabayashi shut his eyes and covered his ears, perhaps recalling what had happened .

Haruka's face was completely pale . She was sitting down while hugging her own shoulders .

The trees moved in the wind .

After a silence, Wakabayashi suddenly opened his eyes and planted the hands that had been on his ears on the ground .

'How do you think my father looked as her tormented her?'

'That's...'

'He was smiling . '

That one word slashed at his chest like a sharp Japanese sword .

– Smiling .

Why? How could somebody laugh while tormenting someone weaker than them? Why would you smile when killing somebody?

'Please let me confirm something . Where was Rin-san killed?' said Yakumo, index finger on his brow .

'By the cedar tree... After she was killed there, she was buried...'

'So that really was the location . '

Yakumo nodded in understanding . But Gotou couldn't understand . 'Why'd you keep silent about it all this time!?'

Gotou grabbed Wakabayashi by the collar in his anger .

Wakabayashi lost his balance and fell backwards . Gotou climbed on top of him .

'Answer me!'

Gotou brought his nose close to Wakabayashi's, closing the distance further .

'He couldn't speak even if he wanted to,' interrupted Yakumo .

'Why? Somebody died!'

'Could you say it, Gotou-san? At the time, Wakabayashi-san was only ten years old, and he was his son . Would you be able to say that your own father had tormented a woman to death?'

'That's...'

Gotou was lost for words .

I could say it – he wanted to declare that, but he wasn't honestly confident that he would really be able to say it if he were in that situation .

Now he didn't know who the demon was . She had just been a victim . The real demons were the two who killed her .

Yakumo had said that Rin's spirit was searching for something .

She had to be searching with violent hatred for the two people who killed her .

16

– Could you say it?

Yakumo's words reverberated heavily in Haruka's chest .

Whether she wanted to or not, it made her think of the case with Masato .

He was put in a similar situation . He wanted to speak, but he couldn't . He was burdened with that darkness .

At times like this, children were powerless .

'Gotou-san, please get off of him already . '

Gotou did as Yakumo said . He got off of Wakabayashi and stood up .

Wakabayashi sat up but didn't try to stand up .

'Wakabayashi-san, please let me confirm a few things . '

Wakabayashi looked frightened at Yakumo's words .

I've already told you so much . It was like he was saying that .

'What happened to her son?'

'I don't know . '

Wakabayashi shook his head .

'It isn't certain whether he lived or died, yes?'

'She made her son alone run away before she was caught... After that, I...'

Yakumo smirked, looking satisfied by Wakabayashi's answer .

'One more thing . Did your father have money troubles?'

'He had a bad alcohol problem, so he regularly borrowed money . '

'Did that suddenly fix itself after the incident?'

Wakabayashi didn't answer, but that was answer enough .

'So that really was the case,' murmured Yakumo . Then, he put his index finger to his brow .

'Lastly...'

Give me a break already – was how Wakabayashi looked when he lifted his head .

'Her son had a horn on his forehead, yes?'

'A horn? Don't be ridiculous!'

Gotou stomped on the ground as he yelled .

Wakabayashi nodded silently –

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . What does this mean?' Haruka interrupted without thinking .

'Recall what Ookura-san from Kinasa Museum said . '

Haruka let out an 'ah' .

Haruka had heard that Rin's son had a horn on his head and told Yakumo that . But –

'Is that possible?'

'Though it's called a horn, to be more correct, it's the keratin in skin . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair .

'Do you mean the layer of skin that gets all dry in the winter?'

'That's right . '

Haruka had been prepared for Yakumo to get angry at her, but his unexpected answer made her even more confused .

Keratin made up part of the skin . It was completely unrelated to horns .

'How would keratin become a horn?' Haruka asked, grabbing Yakumo's arm .

'I'm not an expert, so I can't explain in detail, but keratin preserves moisture and protects against bacteria . That's why the keratin in areas that are often impacted like the heel and the palm naturally become thicker . '

'Now that you say that . '

The skin on the heel clearly felt different from other areas .

'Keratin can become hard in areas too . '

'Really?'

'An easy-to-understand case where keratin becomes thick is the corns . '

'Corns?'

Haruka understood the word . The speck-sized wart-like things that would show up on the bottom of feet .

However, Haruka didn't really understand .

'Corns occur when skin is impacted in a local area and the keratin becomes thicker to protect itself, going under the outer layer of skin . '

'I see . '

So they occurred when people wore shoes that weren't the right size .

'Other ways that the keratin would become thicker are genetic or viral – there are a number of causes . In Rin-san's son's case, since it was on his forehead, it is likely that it was a virus . '

'But corns are only a centimetre or two, right? They don't look like horns . '

'Occasionally, the keratin becomes thicker beyond its physical boundaries . Though this differs between people, in some cases, it can exceed ten centimetres . '

'That's...'

'Yes . Like a large corn from the thickening of keratin . '

'Does that really happen?'

Gotou spoke before Haruka could .

'It is extremely rare, but there have been cases reported where things like horns have grown from foreheads . '

Haruka had heard something like that before .

She felt like she'd seen a photo of an old person with a horn in the back of the head like a water buffalo's .

'Aah!'

Gotou suddenly yelled .

Yakumo put his fingers in his ears, but Gotou continued speaking regardless .

'Her son had a horn in his head . That's why the villagers accepted the ridiculous story about the mother and son being demons . '

Just like Yakumo had been persecuted because of his red left eye, Rin and her son had been thought of as strange and persecuted because her son had a horn on his head .

People could be terribly cruel to those who were different from them .

'In the first place, she wasn't a local . She came from somewhere else and was found collapsed with her son . The doctor at the clinic saved them...'

Yakumo slowly began to speak .

Why did they collapse in a place like this? Though it was just a theory, Haruka could guess .

They had probably been persecuted in the same fashion in other places . She had run all the way here with her child .

'A parent and child with red eyes . Furthermore, her son had a horn in his head . That would be more than enough to make up a demon . '

When Yakumo finished speaking, he closed his eyes .

Did Yakumo mean that the mother and child who were chased out of the village were demons? Or did he mean the villagers who called them that?

Haruka didn't have the courage to ask .

'Rin-san lived together with Doctor Kawakami at the clinic, right?' said Haruka .

'Yes . '

Gotou agreed .

'Then he should have been able to cut off the horn . '

Haruka asked the question that had come to her head .

Yakumo took the notebook from his back pocket and handed it to her . It was the dusty notebook he had been reading yesterday .

Haruka took it into her hand and flipped through the pages .

The words written inside were blurry so she couldn't read them clearly, but she understood some of the words .

Demon... the keratin in the skin... in the cornea...

'What is this?'

'Research notes,' said Yakumo, covering his face with both hands .

'Of what?'

'Of course, they're about her son . '

Then, everything connected .

Haruka felt discomfort circling her stomach .

The doctor at the clinic had looked at the child with a horn as his own research material .

'That's awful!'

'You're mistaken . '

Yakumo's eyes were distant .

'Eh?'

'Doctor Kawakami loved that mother and son . He had been trying to treat him . That's what the research was for . '

A blank expression and sleepy eyes . Yakumo looked the same as always . However, his left red eye alone looked shadowed .

After taking a deep breath, Yakumo continued to speak .

'Even after he died, he was always at the clinic, watching over Rin-san and her son . '

Yakumo's words echoed hollowly in her heart .

She recalled how Doctor Kawakami and Rin had looked in the photo .

The two of them had been nestled together . They might have just wanted to live a peaceful life, like everyone else .

However, that little dream was trampled underfoot .

'Let's go . '

After a silence, Yakumo spoke .

'Where to?'

Yakumo slowly turned around at Haruka's question .

'To search for Masato, of course...'

17

While driving, Wakabayashi's sad face came up in Gotou's head .

Come to think of it, Wakabayashi had just happened to head out to the mountain and ended up burdened with a secret that he shouldn't have had to shoulder for forty five years .

It was like the situation Masato had been in before . Children were powerless in such unreasonable circumstances .

He had probably also been a victim .

'It's rare for you to be thinking,' said Yakumo from the passenger seat, like he had seen through Gotou .

'I just think it's awful . '

'It is . To treat them as demons just because they look different...'

Haruka agreed from the backseat .

'That's a bit different . '

Yakumo was the one who spoke .

'What do you mean, different?'

'Gotou-san, do you think they were really killed just because of red eyes and a horn?'

Yakumo replied to Gotou's question with a question .

'They weren't?'

'They weren't,' Yakumo said firmly .

'Wait a second . What do you mean?'

That was different from what Yakumo had been saying earlier . Though Gotou was confused, Yakumo was as nonchalant as ever .

'According to the notes Doctor Kawakami left, aconitine was found from the body of Kitaoka Hidetaka, the land owner's eldest son . '

'Aconitine?'

'Aconite... Would that be easier to understand?'

Gotou swallowed .

Monkshood was a wild grass with beautiful purple flowers . Its roots were incredibly poisonous .

It caused breathing difficulties, arrhythmia and drop in blood pressure . On top of its prompt efficiency, there was no antidote . It was said that three milligrams was enough to kill somebody .

Despite how poisonous it was, it grew throughout the mountain forests and was incredibly easy to obtain – a rather troublesome find .

If aconitine was found, that meant –

'Could it be – '

'It could be . The first person to make a fuss about Rin being a witch was Takafumi, the younger brother of the dead Hidetaka . '

A chill went down Gotou's spine .

'So his brother Takafumi poisoned him . '

'It would be appropriate to think that way . '

'What the hell...'

That was enough for Gotou to imagine what had happened .

The second son, Takafumi, had probably poisoned the eldest son, Hidetaka, because of some inheritance issues .

After Hidetaka was carried to the Kinasa Clinic, he died, just as Takafumi wanted .

It was a village clinic without medical equipment . The incident should have been written off as a death from illness .

However, Kawakami, the doctor at the clinic, realised .

If Kawakami made a fuss, Takafumi would be in danger . Then, Takafumi joined up with Wakabayashi's father, the local officer at the time, and raised a rumour about it being a witch's curse .

– What a disgusting guy .

In his anger, a question came to Gotou .

'Wait a second . The doctor called Kawakami...'

Died after falling into a ravine . That might not have been an accident .

'The two of them probably pushed him in to kill him . '

Yakumo ground his back teeth together loudly .

'That's awful...'

Haruka raised a voice full of sadness .

If that were true, it was just as horrible as Haruka said . But –

'Do you have proof?'

'Yes . '

Yakumo flipped open to the last page of the notebook that he had shown Haruka earlier .

There was just one short sentence: I'm going to meet with him in the presence of the local officer, Wakabayashi-san .

'So he thought it'd be safe if he went with the local officer present . '

'Yes . However, he must have thought he was in danger, since he hid this notebook under the clinic floorboards just in case . '

'So the landowner was always in on it?'

'I confirmed that with Wakabayashi-san earlier . The relationship between him and the landowner's second son, Takafumi...'

Gotou had heard too .

They had been friends since they were students, and he'd also borrowed money .

'Money, eh...' said Gotou, swallowing his anger .

He probably contrived to get his cut after Takafumi got his inheritance .

At first, Takafumi had only poisoned the eldest son, Hidetaka . However, since he was found out, the situation changed .

In the end, he decided to kill Kawakami and Rin –

'That isn't something a person should do,' said Gotou with a click of his tongue .

However, Yakumo denied his anger-filled words .

'That isn't true . '

'Eh?'

'Killing people for their own selfish desires – only people do that . '

Yakumo's quiet words pierced deep into Gotou's heart .

Unable to agree or disagree, Gotou just bit his lip .

After a while, they reached their destination . Gotou parked the car in front of the cottage . When he looked at the cedar tree with his knowledge, it felt a bit sad .

'We going then?'

Gotou was about to get off the car, but Yakumo stopped him .

'Gotou-san, I have a request . '

As he said that, a fearless smile appeared on Yakumo's lips .

18

Haruka stood in front of the cottage with Yakumo .

The solemn columns and white walled building matched its forested surroundings .

On top of the log table on the terrace, there were two old coffee cups which had been left behind .

What did the people who lived here before think as they looked at the cedar tree?

That thought suddenly came to Haruka's mind .

'Is Masato-kun really here?' asked Haruka, gripping onto Yakumo's arm .

'He is,' declared Yakumo .

'Why do you think that?'

Haruka didn't know why Masato – no, why Rin, who was possessing him, would come here .

Without responding, Yakumo put a hand on the front door . However, it wouldn't open – it appeared to be locked .

'You must not step away from me . '

As Yakumo murmured that, he went around to the back of the building .

After walking through the weeds for the while, Yakumo suddenly stopped like he had found something .

Yakumo was looking at a small window at his waist .

The glass was broken .

'Let's go . '

After saying that, Yakumo went inside through the window frame .

Haruka took Yakumo's hand, which he stuck out from inside, and stepped into the house as well .

Because the curtains were closed, the room was dark .

The room had a red carpet . Perhaps it was used as a bedroom, as there was a large double bed .

On top of the sideboard, there was a vase .

Though it was empty now, flowers might have kept in it before .

Yakumo turned on the torch he had borrowed from Gotou and slowly headed deeper into the building .

They went straight through the room and opened the door to see a living room with a fireplace . Chic rocking chairs were lined up next to each other .

In the back of the room, there was a large wall clock with a moving pendulum .

Rustle –

Something moved .

Yakumo slowly pointed the light of the torch at it .

Haruka saw a black shadow in the corner of the room .

'Masato-kun!'

Haruka cried out without thinking .

Masato had his back to the wall and was sitting there hugging his knees .

Haruka tried to run towards him, but Yakumo grabbed her arm .

'Don't just run over there!'

'But Masato-kun!'

'That isn't Masato . It's the spirit of Rin-san, who was called a witch . '

Haruka finally came to her senses when she heard Yakumo's words .

Even if he looked like Masato from the outside, a different person was inside him – Rin .

In the dark, Masato's bloodshot eyes stood out .

Was there a violent hatred because of being persecuted and killed in those eyes?

'What should we do?' Haruka asked Yakumo .

She knew Masato was possessed by Rin's spirit, but she couldn't leave it like this .

'She isn't resentful,' said Yakumo with pity .

'Then why is she wandering?'

'She isn't wandering . She's searching . '

Yakumo lowered his sad gaze .

'Searching? What for?'

'Obviously, the son that separated from her when she was killed . '

– Her son .

That was right . Rin had a child . Ookura and Wakabayashi had said that .
That child was missing .

Yakumo had said that if Rin were filled with hatred, they wouldn't have
been able to find Yumiko . Haruka felt like this was what he meant .

'But why here?'

'Yesterday, we found Yumiko-chan near the clinic where Rin was . This is
where she sent her son off before she was killed . '

'I see...'

That was why Rin had chosen this place . Even after her death, she was
looking for her son . This was an emotion much stronger than hatred – love
.

'Rin-san . '

Yakumo slowly approached Masato as he said that .

Masato – no, Rin – let out a howl like a wolf trying to intimidate its
enemies as she glared at Yakumo . It felt like she would bite his neck if he
let his guard down even slightly .

However, Haruka strangely felt no fear .

'Please . Return Masato-kun . I will search for your son, so...'

Haruka looked straight at Rin's eyes as she pleaded .

She had been in a terrible situation . She was persecuted as a witch and even lost her life in the end . Still, what she wanted in the end was for her beloved son to be safe .

'Please . Don't suffer any more . '

Haruka reached out to hug Rin .

'Back off . '

Yakumo stepped between them and forced her away .

'Why?'

'Rin-san just wants to meet her own child . So...'

Haruka's body was shaking . She started crying naturally .

Why did this happen? Rin had just wanted something that was natural, so why did somebody trample on that wish?

Haruka didn't understand .

'Even though his eyes were red and he had a horn, he was still human . But...'

With anger and sadness mixed together, Haruka didn't know what she wanted to say .

'That's enough . Thank you,' murmured Yakumo, laying a hand on Haruka's head .

Why did Yakumo say 'Thank you' – before Haruka could ask, Yakumo stood in front of Rin again .

'It's nice to meet you, Rin-san . '

Yakumo had a gentle smile that didn't fit the atmosphere as he continued .

'I'm your grandchild . '

'Eh?'

Even Haruka thought her voice sounded strange .

That was how unexpected Yakumo's words were .

While Haruka was still confused, there was the sound of metal on metal as the door opened .

– Gotou-san?

Haruka glanced over, but the person standing there was completely different .

– Nanase Miyuki .

Her long hair hung around her face, covering the left half of it .

With a twisted smile on her lips, she walked straight for them with a cold gaze filled with ill intent .

She was holding a square wooden box on her left side and a knife with a wide blade that could cut firewood in her right hand .

'Look what the cat's dragged in! if it isn't Yakumo-kun,' Miyuki said in a low voice .

Haruka was shaking in fear, but Yakumo didn't look disturbed at all .

'So you really came,' he said quietly .

'Really? It's like you knew I was going to come . '

'It's not like I knew – I did know . '

'Acting so smart . '

'I'm not acting . This is an important place to you, so...'

'Shut up!'

Miyuki let out a shrill shriek, interrupting Yakumo .

Perhaps because of her anger, her right hand holding the blade was shaking . Though she acted calm when things went her way, when something unexpected happen, she suddenly became angry, losing her senses .

'You become emotionally so quickly . '

Yakumo looked at Miyuki scornfully .

'You always get in my way . Stealing the things that are important to me . '

Miyuki glared at Yakumo as she took ragged breaths .

'Steal? That isn't correct . You lost it yourself . No, that isn't correct either . What you wanted never existed in the first place . '

'Shut your mouth! What do you know? I won't give it over to you!'

Miyuki bared her teeth as her cheek twitched .

It was like something had snapped within her .

'Die!'

Miyuki raised the blade .

Right after the glinting tip came down – a huge bearlike figure rushed in .

'Gotou-san!' exclaimed Haruka in her surprise .

Miyuki was blown away by the surprise attack like she had been in a traffic accident and fell down face-up .

The wooden box fell and something like a ball rolled out, hitting the wall .

It wasn't a ball . It was a human head . And its eyes were deep red .

'Aaahh!' screamed Haruka, jumping up .

'Just as you expected,' said Gotou as he pulled up the sleeves of his shirt with ragged breathing .

'I would have preferred it outside . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair in irritation .

Before coming here Yakumo had told Gotou to hide himself . Now Haruka understood the reason .

But – d

'How did you know Nanase Miyuki would come?'

'I want to know too,' agreed Gotou as he took out handcuffs and cuffed Miyuki's left hand to the window frame .

'I'll explain later . First...'

Yakumo picked up the head that had rolled to the wall in both hands and turned towards Masato again .

'That was quite an interruption . '

Masato didn't respond . He just looked out .

Yakumo continued speaking regardless .

'This is what you're looking for . '

Yakumo held the head out to Masato –

'Oi! What are you talking about?' yelled Gotou .

Why would Rin, who was killed forty-five years ago, be searching for the head of the man with two red eyes?

Gotou walked over to Yakumo with a wide stride .

'Please be quiet,' said Yakumo, turning around .

'How could I be quiet? Explain properly . '

'Rin-san isn't looking for the people who killed her . '

'Then what is she looking for?'

'Her son . '

Yakumo spoke in pieces, as if he were confirming his words .

Gotou understood now . Rin had taken her son with her when she ran from the village . Then, the son disappeared after the incident .

'Could it be...'

The answer that inevitable came to Gotou made him speak aloud in his surprise .

'Correct . The man with two red eyes is Rin-san's son . '

Gotou couldn't believe it .

But –

'He doesn't have a horn, right?'

Yakumo had said earlier that Rin's son had a horn .

However, the man with two red eyes didn't have a horn .

'He did . '

As Yakumo said that, he brushed aside the hair on the head's forehead and showed the skin underneath it .

'Ah!' said Haruka, though she was still frightened .

Gotou could see as well .

'It's the scar from removing the "horn",' said Yakumo .

'How'd you know that man and Rin's son were the same person?'

'There aren't many men with two red eyes . '

That was true –

But wasn't jumping to a conclusion from just that dangerous? Perhaps Yakumo sensed Gotou's question, because he continued his explanation .

'Furthermore, I was held captive before in a log house in the Togakushi mountain area . Kamiyama-san also met with this man in Togakushi . '

That was –

'Not a coincidence . '

As Gotou said that, he recalled what he'd heard at the real estate office .

This cottage had a parent and child living here – that was probably the man with two red eyes and Nanase Miyuki .

'Twenty years ago, the local officer and the land owner's second son, Takafumi-san, were killed here by that man . '

The story made sense . The man with two red eyes probably killed Wakabayashi's father and Takafumi in revenge for his mother .

'Afterwards, he made this his secret hiding place,' said Yakumo, looking down at Nanase Miyuki, who had fainted .

Gotou understood . That was why this woman, after having her hiding place in Tokyo by Ishii, returned here . But –

'Why'd he make this his hiding place?'

'Please remember . Fifteen years ago, this man ended up moving together with Miyuki, who had killed her own family . She had been just ten then . He needed a place to settle down . '

That was why he ended up renting this cottage to live in . There wouldn't be many people around here – they might have been able to live secretly . But was that all?

'There were other places to hide, right?'

'It was his hometown . '

'Hometown?'

'Furthermore, he could see the cedar tree where his mother was buried here .
,

Yakumo pointed out the window .

When Gotou looked out the window, he could see that cedar tree through the gap in the curtains . It was just like a grave marker .

'Would that man care about that?'

Even while Gotou asked that, he came to the answer .

The man with two red eyes killed the local officer, Wakabayashi's father, and the landowner's second son, Takafumi, in revenge for his mother .

That was evidence of how he thought of his mother and his connection to his hometown .

'Though I don't know whether he himself was conscious of it...'

As Yakumo said that, he smiled bitterly .

That means –

'Nanase Miyuki didn't think you'd be here then . '

'That is a little bit wrong . '

Yakumo shook his head .

'Hah?'

'It's because I was here that she was anxious . '

'What do you mean?'

'This is where that man and Nanase Miyuki lived together . There are probably traces of the various incidents they have been involved in up until now . '

Yakumo's father, the man with two red eyes, and Miyuki had pulled the strings of a number of cases in the past, but that wasn't all . There had to be cases they didn't know about yet .

There was information here that she didn't want them to know, which was why –

'She didn't want us to find it...'

'Furthermore, to her, this place has her memories with that man . She wouldn't want me to see it . '

On top of loving the man with red eyes, Nanase Miyuki was jealous of Yakumo, who was connected to that man with blood and also had a red left eye .

Because that was who she was, when she found out Yakumo was in Nagano, she wanted to clear things up before he found anything unnecessary .

'She was also going to kill me this time since I am an eyesore to her . '

Even though his life had been in danger, Yakumo spoke coolly . Gotou understood the situation . But what were they going to do next?

While Gotou was thinking, Yakumo turned towards Masato and took a step forward .

'Rin-san . You died . Forty-five years ago...'

Masato's body shook . Resisting the truth . That was how it looked .

Masato's breathing was ragged .

It was too late when Gotou noticed .

Masato had lowered his body . He kicked the floor with incredible force and charged forward .

'Gotou-san, please stop him!'

Responding immediately to Yakumo's yell, Gotou spread his arms to block Masato's path, but it was too late .

Masato ducked under Gotou's arms and ran out .

Yakumo placed the head he was holding on the floor chased after Masato with the nimbleness of a cat .

'Don't go!'

As Haruka yelled, she ran out .

'Damn it!'

Gotou ran after the two of them a step later .

'Don't go!'

Haruka yelled as she ran after Masato .

Yakumo was right outside the cottage . He was looking at Masato .

Masato stood between the cottage and the cedar tree and stared at Yakumo .

Standing in the middle of the skunk cabbage, the cedar tree shook in the wind .

'Masato-kun!'

'Wait!'

Haruka was about to run towards Masato, but Yakumo stopped her immediately .

'Why? Masato-kun is – '

'It's still Rin-san . '

'But...'

Masato or Rin – Haruka didn't care . If she watched silently like this, they would disappear . That was how Haruka felt .

Haruka turned away from Yakumo and started to approach Masato when she saw a man standing by the cedar tree .

His long hair flowed down his back and he wore a black suit . His eyes were dyed deep red like a blazing flame .

The man whose head had been cut off .

Even after he had died and become a spirit, he misled people's hearts and instigated a number of crimes .

'Oi! Yakumo! That guy!'

Gotou had just come out of the cottage when he yelled in surprise .

'Gotou-san, please watch her,' instructed Yakumo .

'She can't run away though . '

'Just do it!' said Yakumo in his irritation as he turned towards the man with two red eyes again .

'Yakumo-kun...'

When Haruka called out to him, Yakumo slowly started walking .

– Yakumo's going to disappear . With that worry, Haruka swallowed her fear and followed Yakumo, hiding behind his back .

In response, the man with two red eyes started walking slowly as well . They both narrowed the distance between them, stopping right as they had Masato between them .

Haruka's hands were in tight fists as she looked at Yakumo's back .

'Rin-san . '

After a silence, Yakumo opened his mouth .

Masato slowly lifted his head .

'No, I should say Grandmother . He is your son . '

As Yakumo said that, he pointed at the man with two red eyes .

Yakumo had said that earlier . Rin's son was the man with two red eyes . That he was her grandson .

– This is my hometown too .

What Yakumo said yesterday flashed through her mind . She felt like this was what he meant .

Masato slowly turned to look at the man with two red eyes .

Then, the atmosphere completely changed .

'Oh... ohh...'

As Masato spoke, he lifted his arms and pointed out shaking fingers as he walked towards the man with two red eyes .

'Yakumo-kun!'

It would be dangerous to let him go to that man . Haruka grabbed Yakumo's arm tightly in her worry .

Masato stood in front of the man with two red eyes .

'Don't move from here . '

After saying that, Yakumo grabbed Masato's arms .

'Grandmother . You don't have to search for anyone any more . '

Yakumo looked at her with pitying eyes .

It was the first time Haruka had seen his eyes look like that .

'Ah...'

Tears started falling out of Masato's – no, Rin's eyes .

She had been looking for her son this whole time .

It didn't matter that her son had a horn in his head or red eyes . To her, he was her beloved son –

But that was all .

She wasn't a demon . She was a mother who thought of her child .

'Grandmother, it's over now . You protected your son . That blood has continued and is still living now . '

When Yakumo said that, he embraced Masato from behind, enveloping his body .

The muscles in Masato's body relaxed as he slowly collapsed into Yakumo's arms .

For a moment – just a moment – Haruka felt like she saw the figure of a faintly smiling woman .

'Masato-kun!'

Haruka rushed towards Yakumo and Masato .

'I'll leave Masato to you . '

After Yakumo said that, Haruka took Masato into her arms .

He was breathing .

– Thank goodness . Really, thank goodness .

Haruka lost her strength in her relief and started crying . She wiped those tears and looked up to see Yakumo facing the man with two red eyes .

'Your hatred is directed at the wrong place . '

Yakumo's voice reverberated, pregnant with hostility .

'On that day, I saw the true nature of humanity...'

The man with two red eyes smiled dauntingly .

When he was young, he probably saw his mother killed with unreasonable violence . What did he think as he heard his mother scream in the agony of her death? What was born in his heart?

Haruka couldn't even imagine it . No, she was afraid of imagining it .

'You didn't see everything . '

'People are arrogant, selfish and avaricious . They are different from others . That reason is enough for them to scorn, hate and fear . People are terrible beyond reason . '

'Your mother is also human . She gave up her life to protect you . That isn't some awful emotion . It is pure love . '

'You talk like you know everything . You don't know the darkness of humanity . '

'Aren't you human as well?'

'I'm a demon . At that time, I threw away all my emotions and became a demon . '

'Then why did you avenge your mother? Why did you make the place where your mother slept your hiding place?'

'There isn't a reason . '

'Then why did you carry on your family line?'

To Haruka, it looked like Yakumo's shoulders were shaking slightly .

'A whim . '

'That's a lie . My existence is a contradiction to your thoughts . Even a person like you has emotions . '

'I don't have emotions . I am a demon made by the actions of humanity . '

'Are you asking for sympathy? You weren't made by anyone . You are you . No matter what the circumstances, the person who chooses your path is you yourself . '

Yakumo's voice seemed to echo off of the trees .

Yakumo was absolutely right . Haruka did sympathise .

The man with two red eyes was born into this world as an anomaly, was persecuted and wandered as he searched for a place he belonged to .

When he finally arrived here, he was given the dirty title of murderer, chased out as a demon, and had to watch his mother beaten to death before his eyes .

But –

'Your reasoning is no reason to kill somebody!'

At the end, Yakumo declared that .

'It seems we really can't understand each other...'

With that weak ending, the man with two red eyes disappeared as if he had melted into the scenery .

Haruka felt like she had caught a glimpse of his heart .

Because he was different from others, he was scorned, persecuted and feared . The people important to him were taken away – he might have walked in despair all this time .

Like that, hatred started to well up in the bottom of his heart and he took a step onto the path of madness .

But –

'Yakumo-kun, what you said wasn't wrong . No matter what the reason, it isn't a reason to kill somebody,' Haruka said towards Yakumo's back .

'I know . '

When Yakumo turned around, his expression was his usual, which was anticlimactic . He ran a hand through his messy hair and yawned with sleepy eyes .

That was right . Yakumo knew that best .

'Is it over?'

Gotou called from the entrance .

'Yes . Rin-san has gone . '

Yakumo's eyes narrowed as he looked up at the sky .

– This is the end .

'Aaaaaahhh!'

Just as Haruka had relaxed, there was a sudden beastly howl .

It was probably a human scream .

She looked at Yakumo . They looked at the cottage, where the voice had come from .

Miyuki had been in there –

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Gotou heard a beastly howl as he stood in the entrance .

He turned around and saw Miyuki standing there .

Wasn't she handcuffed? He found the answer to that question once he looked at her .

Miyuki had the head of the man with two red eyes under her left arm and a knife with a wide blade in her right . The handcuffs hung from her left wrist .

She had broken the window frame with the knife .

She had probably hurt herself when breaking it . Blood dripped from her left wrist .

Her dry lips were twisted into a frown . The eyes that peered through her fringe were filled with madness .

Just like a witch .

'Damn it!'

– That was my mistake .

Even though Yakumo had told him to watch her, he had looked away, sure she wouldn't be able to escape .

– But I won't let you get away again .

With ragged breaths, Miyuki glared at Gotou .

'I won't let you get away . '

Gotou glared back at Miyuki .

Bend over, rush at her, grab the knife – while Gotou was thinking about his plan, Miyuki laughed aloud .

– How can she laugh in this situation?

As if responding to Gotou's question, just as he thought he smelt something burning, black smoke started enveloping the area .

Seemed like she had set the cottage on fire .

The flames danced, crackling as they did so .

Nanase Miyuki's laughter grew louder .

'You!'

At the same time as Gotou's yell, Miyuki ran at Gotou, pushing him aside as she fled out of the cottage .

'As if I'd let you get away!'

Gotou kicked the ground and ran after Miyuki .

– I'll get you this time .

Miyuki ran into the forest in front of his eyes .

On top of the ground being hard to walk on, he had to zigzag through the scattered cedar trees . The distance, rather than being shortened, was growing larger .

Miyuki's laughter echoed through the forest .

As she reached a mossy rock about as high as a person, she stopped and turned to face Gotou .

– Did she give up?

Just as Gotou thought that, Miyuki kicked the rock and jumped .

'Damn it! Wait!'

Then, she disappeared .

Gotou didn't realise at first what had happened .

Gotou dragged his feet onto the rock where Miyuki had been and then he understood .

When he looked down, he saw that he was on a cliff with a river flowing below .

He couldn't see Miyuki any more –

NOTES:

[1] Short Hope (シ ョ ー ト ホ ー プ) or Shoppo (シ ョ ッ ポ) are nicknames for the ten-cigarette pack named Hope . There used to be . It is called Short Hope because there used to be a pack of twenty for long-size cigarettes called Long Hope . Now, all Hope cigarettes are called Short Hope even if they are regular size because of the old twenty-pack of Hope . Hope cigarettes are seen as a counterpart to Peace cigarettes . Hope and Peace cigarettes are short and strong – the most typical Japanese cigarettes, which is why Gotou calls Wakabayashi's taste refined .

[2] Rin's name is written with the kanji 凜, which is used in the expression 凜とした (rin to shita) meaning dignified, commanding .

[3]The nyonindou is written as 女人堂 so it is a hall for women . The nun's rock is the bikuni ishi (比丘尼石), wherein bikuni refers to a bhikkuni, a fully ordained female Buddhist monastic . Like everything else mentioned in Yakumo, this actually exists .

Volume 7 Chapter 4: Epilogue.

VOLUME 7 – THE LOCATION OF THE SPIRIT epilogue

‘Hey! Doing well?’

Haruka went with Yakumo to Masato’s hospital room.

At the reception, they ran into Masato’s aunt and heard in brief about his condition.

He didn’t have any major injuries and didn’t seem to remember the time when he was possessed by a ghost, but he was very healthy besides that. He was only in hospital for a check-up and would be able to be discharged tomorrow.

Masato’s aunt apologised again and again, saying, ‘I apologise for the trouble we’ve caused.’

‘Ah!’

On the bed, Masato looked incredibly healthy. His expression brightened at once.

The inside of Haruka’s chest felt warm when she thought about how this child could smile like this now.

‘We’re going back today so we thought we’d visit before then.’

‘You’re already leaving?’

Masato’s voice went down.

With the fuss with the incident, Haruka hadn't been able to talk with Masato at length. She felt a bit guilty.

'We'll come another time, when there's no case,' said Yakumo, running a hand through his hair.

'You say that, but you didn't come, right?'

Masato pouted.

'We'll come next time. Promise.'

'Really?'

'Yeah. I have to visit my grandmother's grave too, so I'll visit you along the way.' said Yakumo.

That was right. Rin was Yakumo's grandmother. Yakumo's background had been a mystery until now, but a lot of that had been revealed with this case.

'Along the way?' said Masato, sounding dissatisfied, though he didn't look like he really cared that much.

'Not happy with that?'

'Well, it's fine.'

'Let's eat soba at my house then,' added Haruka.

'Your house gives out rocks as food,' said Yakumo with a discouraged expression.

Haruka's father, Kazuhiro, had given Yakumo an actual rock while calling it sobagaki.

'That was...'

'What's up with your dad anyway? Yesterday, he suddenly forced himself into the room with some rice rine.'

'You're kidding!'

Haruka hadn't heard about that at all.

'He stayed until morning. Even though I was tired – it wasn't welcome.'

What on earth had they talked about? Haruka was curious, but on the other hand, she was too frightened to ask.

'Hey. Are you two dating?' asked Masato with a wide grin.

Haruka hadn't thought that Masato would ask that question.

Her body heated up all at once.

'E-er, that's...'

Haruka was fumbling for words to reply when another boy Masato's age ran in.

She'd seen him in a photo before. It was probably Tomoya.

'Masato! I'm so glad you're OK!'

Tomoya leapt onto the bed and hugged Masato.

'Tomoya-kun, that hurts.'

'Shut up! You went off and searched on your own. This is punishment.'

Tomoya jostled Masato.

Haruka had heard that he blamed Masato when Yumiko disappeared, but it seemed like that hadn't been how he really felt – it had probably come from mortification at himself for not being able to do anything.

'Wait, Tomoya. Masato-kun doesn't like that.'

Yumiko interrupted them.

When Haruka saw the bright smile on Masato's face, she felt how much he had changed.

'Let's go.'

Turning away from the cheerful children, Yakumo said that to Haruka quietly.

'Masato-kun, see you again.'

'See you again!'

With Masato's smile behind her, Haruka followed Yakumo out.

* * *

Gotou sat on the sofa in the hospital waiting room with Wakabayashi.

Wakabayashi's eyes were distant – he looked much older than yesterday, to the point that he looked like a different person.

'Are you all right?'

Gotou spoke up without thinking when he saw how small Wakabayashi looked.

'Yeah. I haven't fallen so much that I need you to worry about me.'

Wakabayashi smiled wryly.

'So? What did you want to talk about?' said Gotou, feeling uncomfortable.

I have something I want to talk to you about – Wakabayashi had said that.

'There's something I want to give you.'

Wakabayashi took an old photo from his jacket pocket and gave it to Gotou.

'What is it?'

Gotou accepted it.

There was a middle-aged man with black-rimmed glasses. It was probably the doctor named Kawakami. Next to him stood a beautiful woman with almond eyes. She was Rin.

Between them was a boy who had his head turned down.

Gotou realised immediately who it was.

He could see a lump on his forehead.

This is the horn Yakumo talked about –

When Gotou saw it like this, it really didn't look like a horn. It was just a bulge.

There was something wrong with the people who would treat him like a demon for something like this.

'I only talked to that boy once.'

'I didn't...'

Wakabayashi hadn't mentioned that even in front of the cedar tree.

'When I went to the clinic about my father, I played cards with him in the garden.'

'Cards.'

Just from knowing the several awful things that the man with two red eyes had done, that felt incredibly unnatural.

'At the time, he smiled. He smiled just like any other kid. I thought, so even demons laugh.'

'What are you trying to say?'

Wakabayashi breathed loudly before continuing.

'Was he always a demon? Or did the children around him turn him into one?'

Was the madness within somebody always there? Or was it brought out of them because of their circumstances?

Gotou had been on many cases.

He sometimes thought that circumstances definitely changed people. But on the other hand, he also felt there was madness from birth that normal people couldn't understand.

Which is correct – Gotou thought about it, but he gave up right away.

'I don't understand things as difficult as that,' he replied curtly.

The man with two red eyes had said that the true nature of humanity was darkness. Yakumo had said that he could see a small light when he faced that darkness.

Rather than which was correct or incorrect, Gotou wanted to believe there was a light.

When he looked up, he saw Yakumo and Haruka walking towards him.

Wakabayashi stood up and bowed at both of them.

Yakumo received him with a nod.

'Let's go.'

Yakumo was the one who said that.

Right. Gotou really had to get back soon or it would be bad.

'Bye,' said Gotou as he stood up.

* * *

As usual, Ishii was dying from boredom because of paperwork.

When Gotou reported that Nanase Miyuki was spotted in Nagano prefecture, the search here had been stopped.

Why did she go to Nagano? And how did Gotou encounter her?

There was a mountain of things Ishii wanted to ask once Gotou returned.

Interrupting Ishii's thoughts, the door opened and Makoto appeared.

'Hello.'

'M-Makoto-san.'

'Detective Gotou hasn't returned yet then,' said Makoto, sounding a bit disappointed as she looked around the room.

'He hasn't. Earlier, he contacted me to say he was returning, but...'

'I see. I have a number of things I want to ask him.'

'Is it about Nanase Miyuki?'

'Yes.'

Makoto looked somewhat sorrowful.

'Though only slightly, I feel like I understand what you were saying, Makoto-san,' said Ishii, though he was a bit divided on whether to say it.

'Eh?'

'About the reason for Nanase Miyuki's actions. She stole back the head of the man with two red eyes even though it put her in danger.'

'She will definitely show up again,' said Makoto with confidence.

'Why do you think that?'

'Because of Yakumo-kun.'

'Yakumo-shi?'

Makoto said that matter-of-factly, but Ishii didn't understand.

'To Nanase Miyuki, Yakumo-kun is...'

Interrupting Makoto's words, the door opened with a bang.

'Where's Gotou?'

Miyagawa flew into the room.

'Er, um, I think he's heading her...'

'I'm going to fire that guy!'

Miyagawa's face was red with anger. His menacing look made Ishii anxious.

'No, please, anything but that...'

Ishii wiped the sweat off his forehead as he tried to smooth things over.

For some reason, Makoto laughed as she saw that.

'Well, whatever. Ishii, come with me.'

Miyagawa signalled for him to come with his chin.

'Eh? Again?'

'You don't want to?'

Miyagawa glared at him fiercely.

'I'll go!'

Ishii stood up reflexively and ran out after Miyagawa.

He fell –

* * *

Haruka closed her eyes in front of the cedar tree, a dwelling for spirits, and put her hands together.

Surrounded by white skunk cabbage, it felt sacred here.

This was where Rin had slept for a long forty-five years.

Her son had looked different from others. Even though that was all, people didn't accept him. They persecuted her, making her lose her life.

However, she tried to protect her son until the end.

Even after death, she searched for him frantically, worried about his safety –

Though she had been in awful circumstances, it felt like her hope had been carried through.

How could Yakumo's father be in such darkness even after death when he was so loved?

He had said this.

– I am a demon made by the actions of humanity.

Haruka couldn't deny it. People were terrifyingly cruel to those who were different from them.

When those negative emotions connected, incidents like the one forty-five years ago occurred.

In that meaning, that person might also have been a victim.

But –

Yakumo said this.

The only person who chooses your path is you yourself –

Haruka wanted to believe in Yakumo's words. No matter how dark the circumstances, there was a small light ahead. When people couldn't believe in that any more, they would step off the path.

'Let's go already.'

Yakumo, who stood behind her, ran his hand through his messy hair in irritation.

'Already?'

'We're going to your sister's grave too. If we don't hurry, we'll have to stay another night.'

– That's right. I have to visit my sister too.

'OK.'

Haruka stood up and looked at the sky.

The sun had set. The dusk sky was dyed red.

The mountain was also tinged with red, like the red leaves of autumn –

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Chapter 1

VOLUME 8 – THE VANISHED SPIRIT

file 01: suspicion

Life is a momentary phase

The end of life is a momentary phase

– Dougen

1

‘Stop!’

Saitou Yakumo woke up to his own yell .

His body was covered in sweat as he lay on the wooden floor .

– A dream?

After realising that, Yakumo slowly sat up .

He didn’t remember the contents of his dream, but he was left with a smouldering impression in his chest that it had been incredibly unpleasant

That’s how dreams are –

His vision was blurry, as if he were surrounded by fog .

The back of his neck hurt like it had been squeezed tightly .

– Did I hit it on something?

Then, his surroundings became clear . He had thought he was in the university's Movie Research Circle room, where he usually slept, but it seemed he was wrong .

It was dim –

There were candleholders in the four corners of the room, with the small lights of the candles flickering . The room was about twenty tatami in size .

At first glance, it looked like a temple, but rocks dripping with water jutted out of the ceiling and the wall in the back and the narrow pillar in the middle of the room supported the limestone ceiling, which looked like it might collapse at any moment .

This was probably built out of some limestone cave .

– Why am I here?

Yakumo was trying to search through his memories, but the pain in the back of his neck stopped him . He let out a groan and closed his eyes .

His forehead was covered with a cold sweat .

He was taking deep breaths to try to calm down when an offensive smell suddenly assaulted him .

Yakumo knew what that smell was immediately .

Blood –

'This is...'

Yakumo leant back without thinking .

There was an aging fifty-year old man collapsed there in priest's robes .

His eyes were wide . A purple tongue hung from his half-open mouth .

He had dug his fingernails into the floorboards, probably because he had frantically struggled to get away .

There were stab wounds all over the man's body .

The large amount of blood that had come out of his wounds spread around the man, as if to draw his figure .

It was clear to anyone that Yakumo was already dead .

Yakumo knew this man .

His name was Seidou . The chief priest at the temple .

'What is this...' murmured Yakumo, covering his face with his hands . Then, he suddenly felt something strange .

He felt something sticky on his palms .

– It can't be .

Yakumo held his hands up in front of his eyes .

They were a deep red –

From his palms to his fingers, congealed blood stuck to his hand .

Again, Yakumo looked at Seidou, who lay face-down .

There was a knife stuck in the floor .

The blade was stained with blood up to the handle .

Yakumo had a creeping suspicion .

There was no sign that Seidou had been dragged . The blood seeping into the floor around him also showed that he had been killed here .

– Something happened .

The more he tried to remember, the more the back of his neck hurt . Like there were memories there that he himself wanted to forget .

While bearing with the pain in the back of his neck, Yakumo slowly stood up .

– I won't forgive you .

Yakumo heard a voice from somewhere .

A woman's voice that echoed with darkness, like it had been strangled out of the bottom of her stomach –

When Yakumo turned around, he saw a woman with her head facing down standing in front of the double doors which were the only exit .

She wore a navy blazer with a short check skirt . It was probably a uniform from some high school .

Her wet hair clung to her face .

Her skin was so pale that her veins appeared, faintly blue, and she was sickly thin .

Yakumo knew that in front of him wasn't a living person but a ghost that he was seeing with his red left eye .

Yakumo looked at the girl .

– I won't forgive you .

The girl said that again in a voice filled with hatred as she slowly lifted her head .

Her eyes were bloodshot, as if she were possessed by something .

Hatred, resentment, envy – those eyes condensed a variety of negative emotions .

– Die . Pay for it with your death .

The girl repeated herself in a voice as hoarse as an old woman's .

'Why would you go so far...'

Without replying to Yakumo's question, the girl went through the entrance, as if she had been sucked in, and disappeared .

'Wait . '

Using the wall for support, Yakumo chased the girl .

Just as he was about to try to push open the doors, he suddenly stopped .

'This is...'

There was a piece of paper about the size of a business card stuck on the doors .

There was a short message on the piece of paper .

The moment Yakumo read the message, his eyes went wide .

If someone who didn't understand looked at it without knowing the point, it would probably be difficult to understand the meaning from the message . However, Yakumo was different . He immediately understood the dreadfulness indicated by that message .

– This is bad .

Yakumo wanted to make a call, but he didn't have his mobile . That wasn't all that was missing . He couldn't find his wallet or key either .

He turned around, but they hadn't fallen in the room .

Either he dropped them somewhere, or – anyway, looking at the situation, it would be useless to stay any longer . He needed to get out of here as soon as he could .

Yakumo took the paper off the doors and stuck it in his pocket . Then, he took a candleholder in his pocket and pushed open the doors .

With the help of the faint light of the candle, he looked around .

Right in front of the doors, he saw the bare rock face of a limestone cavern .

Water dripped from the rocks above his head . The cave continued, about five metres wide and two metres tall .

– Seems like this is the only way to proceed .

Yakumo tried to advance, dragging his body forward, but his feet were unsteady, as if the ground were shaking beneath him .

After walking a few steps, he put his hand against the rock wall and took deep breaths with heaving shoulders .

He heard footsteps .

Somebody's here –

The moment he lifted his head, he was hit by a strong light .

Yakumo's vision went white, like a smokescreen had been put up in front of him .

'What are you doing here?'

It was a man's voice . It had an intimidating tone to it .

After blinking a number of times, he finally saw the person standing in front of him .

It was a middle-aged uniformed officer holding a torch .

'I...'

Yakumo was lost for words .

At the current stage, his memories were still vague, so he had no way of explaining .

'You look a bit pale...'

The middle-aged officer walked towards Yakumo .

'I'm fine,' replied Yakumo, looking away from reflex . But it was a bit late . The middle-aged uniformed officer looked surprised .

'Your eye...'

Yakumo knew what he was going to say even without hearing the rest .

His left eye was red – that was why he was surprised . In the past, seeing a response like this would hurt him deeply, but now he thought of it like nothing .

People were frightened of others who were different than they were . It was natural as a living being .

'It's terrible!'

A voice echoed through the limestone cavern, interrupting the silence .

Yakumo turned his eyes towards the doors to the cave, which were still open . A young uniformed officer stood there, pointing inside agitatedly .

It appeared he had noticed the corpse in the cave .

'What happened?' asked the middle-aged uniformed officer in a relaxed manner .

'S-somebody's dead!' shouted the young uniformed officer .

That was the sign .

Yakumo pushed the middle-aged uniformed officer aside and ran .

The middle-aged officer fell on his behind and yelled, 'Wait!' Unfortunately, Yakumo couldn't obey that command right now .

Yakumo just ran with all his strength towards the exit .

After running about fifty metres, the path took a large curve .

He saw the light of the exit after the turn .

'Oi! Wait!'

The officers' voices and footsteps followed him .

Even if he ran out of the exit, with his exhausted body, he would probably be caught soon . That would be the end of everything .

– What to do?

Yakumo stopped and looked around . He spotted a gap between the rocks .

Limestone caves were complex – there wasn't only one exit . Perhaps this gap would connect to another exit . However, if it was a dead end, that would be like running into a cage himself .

Yakumo made his decision and decided to dive into the gap, hiding himself quickly .

He stifled his breath –

The footsteps of the officers caught up soon after, but they went right by .

After a pause, Yakumo moved to look at the exit .

After the officers discussed something at the exit, they split up, running left and right .

Yakumo let out a sigh of relief, but then he returned to the problem at hand .

He couldn't hide here forever . The officers wouldn't search that far either . If they couldn't find him, they'd return to the limestone cave .

That said, going to the limestone cave's exit now would be suicide .

He really would have to go through the gap in the rocks to the end .

Yakumo stooped over and stepped into the deep darkness .

Suddenly, the bloody image of Seidou flashed through Yakumo's mind .

– Did I do that?

He wanted to deny it – there was no way – but at this point, Yakumo didn't have the evidence to .

Anyway, he had to escape now .

After moving about ten metres, he saw a small light .

There was an exit ahead .

With relief, he took another step . Then, his foot slipped .

'Damn . '

It was already too late when he spoke .

The rock he had stepped on crumbled loudly .

Yakumo fell into the darkness, dragged in by gravity –

After Ozawa Haruka finished her orchestra circle practice, she headed for the prefabricated building in the back of Building B .

There were ten small rooms of four and a half tatami in size on each floor .

Haruka stood in front of the room at the very end of the first floor . There was a plate that read Movie Research Circle on the door, but it was a blatant lie .

The owner of the room, Saitou Yakumo, had fooled the university's student union, created a fictional club and used the room as his own .

Yakumo's left eye had been red from birth and had the unique ability to see the spirits of the dead .

– A hateful guy .

That had been Haruka's first impression . A contrary person who was unfriendly and hated to deal with others .

Starting with Miki's case . Haruka had experienced many incidents with Yakumo .

Most of them had been depressing, but with those experiences, Haruka's impression of Yakumo had changed a lot .

Because of Yakumo's unique ability, his own mother had tried to kill him and others looked at him like he was strange .

After experiencing hardship, Yakumo had put a wall between himself and others to protect his damaged heart .

However, inside he noticed more than anyone and had a kind side to him .

After Haruka noticed that, Yakumo seemed cute to her .

Somehow, she could relax with him . Though he probably didn't intend it himself, she felt like she was being protected .

Now, she would go see him whenever she had time .

One of her friends had asked her if they were dating before . Unfortunately, the answer was no .

Though she had experienced many things with Yakumo, time had passed without any particular developments, and before she'd noticed it, she was here, half a year from graduation .

After that – there was probably nothing .

They might have experienced too much to become more than friends .

Close, but far . That was her relationship with Yakumo .

I wonder what Yakumo thinks – she did want to ask, but she felt like doing so would ruin everything they had built so far .

She was very afraid of that .

– What am I thinking about?

Haruka smiled self-derisively and looked towards the door again .

Today, she hadn't been involved in some case like usual . It would be Yakumo's birthday soon . She had thought about giving him a present, but she didn't know what he would like .

After worrying about it, she decided to ask the person himself and came here .

'Yakumo-kun, you here?'

Haruka called out as she opened the door .

However, Yakumo was missing .

'What? He's not here...'

With a sigh, Haruka sat on her usual seat by the door .

A dreary room with nothing in it –

Even the chair she sat on was just a rusty folding chair that could be found anywhere . That said, it made her calm .

It was a small room, only four and a half tatami in size, but she didn't have to put on airs here – she could be herself .

Haruka rested her head on the table .

It was quiet .

'Yakumo, won't you come back soon...'

Once he got back, he would definitely complain, saying something like 'What are you doing here?' or 'Do you have this much free time?' .

When Haruka had first met Yakumo, she would become seriously mad by what he said .

However, now it was as natural to her as a 'Good morning' . It was comfortable .

She had never felt this way with anyone else before .

– I probably like...

To clear her head, Haruka took out her mobile and started typing a message .

It was to Yakumo .

She had never received a reply from Yakumo after messaging him . It was just a one-way digital signal .

It was mysterious how she still felt like they were connected this way .

<Do you want anything?>

Haruka sent a short message and lay on the table again .

3

I have so much time –

Gotou Kazutoshi yawned as he sat on the chair .

Nothing case-like had happened recently . He knew that he shouldn't want cases as part of the police, but sitting at a desk didn't suit him .

The Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room that Gotou was stationed at had the goal of cleaning up cases that had been placed aside, as per the name .

That said, most of it was just paperwork . For Gotou, who thought before he acted, it was like torture .

After Gotou had sighed for the nth time, the door opened .

'D-Detective Gotou! I-it's terrible!'

Ishii Yuutarou flew in with a panicked expression .

'You're so noisy,' responded Gotou with a click of his tongue .

Gotou could count on one hand the number of times things had actually been terrible when Ishii said they were .

'But...'

Ishii faltered, suddenly losing his momentum .

Gotou had thought that Ishii had grown a bit, but he really didn't have his feet firmly planted on the ground .

'What are you making such a fuss about?'

'E-er, I passed . '

'For what?'

'That . I passed . '

As usual, Ishii didn't get to the point .

'What's that? Say it clearly . '

'The promotion exam . '

Ishii's breathing was ragged .

'Promotion exam?'

'Like I said, I passed . The assistant inspector promotion exam . '

'That's good . '

Gotou wasn't properly listening, but when he understood the meaning of the words, he suddenly come to his senses .

'What did you say just now?'

'I said, the promotion exam...'

'That isn't it . I meant the rank . '

'Assistant inspector . '

Ishii puffed up his chest in pride .

'You're going to be an assistant inspector?'

'Yes sir . '

— What the hell .

Gotou's sleepiness flew away all at once .

'What's wrong? You look pale...'

Ishii looked at Gotou's face in concern .

Though he probably didn't mean it this way himself, it felt like he was pitying Gotou . It irritated him .

Gotou lifted his hand to hit Ishii's head, but he didn't drop it .

'Excuse me...'

Ishii adjusted the position of his silver-framed glasses with his fingers . His gesture, which annoyed Gotou even normally, especially grated on his nerves today .

'What?'

'Aren't you happy for me?'

– Happy? You kidding?

Gotou hurriedly swallowed the words he had almost said .

If those words left his mouth, it would be like he had acknowledged the dirty jealousy in the bottom of his heart .

'Congratulations, Assistant Inspector Ishii . '

Gotou turned his chair around so his back was facing Ishii .

He knew himself he wasn't acting like an adult, but knowing that didn't change anything .

'Are you angry?'

Ishii walked in front of Gotou as he said that .

– This guy really can't read the mood .

'I'm not angry!'

'But...'

Ishii's brows furrowed in his confusion .

'Do you know my rank?'

'You're a police inspector . '

There was no malice in Ishii's words . That just made Gotou more irritated .

'I'm the same as you . Assistant inspector . '

'Are you joking again, sir?'

Ishii shook his head, as if to say 'My, my' . That gesture made Gotou even more annoyed .

Gotou clicked his tongue and stood up .

'E-excuse me... Where are you going?'

'I will be having lunch . Assistant Inspector Ishii . '

Gotou bowed theatrically towards Ishii .

'Please stop that . '

Ishii wriggled like a mollusc and clung to Gotou .

'Let go of me!'

Gotou thrust Ishii away and left the room, but then his feet suddenly stopped .

— Why am I so angry?

He didn't have a response .

– The corporate ladder can kiss my ass!

Like that, he had done whatever he wanted up until now . He hadn't even tried taking the promotion exam, since it was annoying .

Even though nobody had told him to do it – even though it was what he himself wanted – why was he so irritated?

'Damn it!'

Gotou kicked the wall and started walking .

4

Splish, splish –

Yakumo regained consciousness while hearing the periodic sound of dripping water .

– I'm still alive .

When he opened his eyes, he saw limestone, winding like a gigantic organism .

Yakumo sat up from his face-up state .

He saw a faint light coming in from outside . Though it was small, there was a hole to the outside . It looked like he could get out if he crouched .

A creaking pain ran through his left leg, making Yakumo's expression contort .

The lower left half of his jeans was ripped and soaked with blood

With the support of a rock jutting out from the ground, Yakumo got up and started walking, dragging his injured left leg behind him, and escaped the limestone cave while stooped over .

He was in the middle of a forest of cedar trees .

He looked up and saw the summer sun peeking through .

He naturally narrowed his eyes and covered them with his hands . Then, he heard the sound of running water .

About five metres ahead, he saw a stream .

It was about as deep as his ankle . It seemed like a spring was the water source – he could see clearly to the bottom of the stream .

Yakumo went into the stream, put his face to the water to drink it and wet his dry throat, and washed the wound on his left leg .

Then, he rubbed his hands together in the water to wash the blood off .

The red water slowly flowed away .

It would probably soon fade into the rest of the water, making it indistinguishable .

Yakumo got out on the rock on the opposite side . He ripped the left sleeve of his shirt from the shoulder and wrapped the injury on his left leg on it, using the sleeve as a bandage .

Yakumo went to the nearby cedar tree, sat down and calmed his breathing .

– Why did this happen?

After he had regained his calm, that question came to Yakumo's brain .

The man who died was the priest of the temple, Seidou . The two of them had walked this weedy path last night and went into the limestone cavern – he remembered that .

Something was following them then .

But Yakumo wasn't sure of what . When he tried to remember, his head started hurting, as if to stop him .

Yakumo gave up on trying to remember what happened around the incident and started organising his thoughts in order .

Yesterday morning, a man came to the Movie Research Circle at the university .

It was Eishin . He was fairly old, but he had a large frame with a good physique . At first glance he looked gentle, but he was broadminded .

He had been the teacher of Yakumo's uncle, Isshin .

After Isshin's death, he had been persistent in trying to get Yakumo to continue at the temple, so Yakumo found him troublesome .

'There's something I'd like to request . '

Eishin had said that the moment he entered the room .

'I refuse . '

Despite Yakumo's refusal, Eishin continued anyway .

'Do you know about reincarnation?'

Eishin smiled .

– Reincarnation .

Yakumo was half-dumbfounded when he heard the word .

Rustle .

The rustling of a tree brought Yakumo back to his senses .

Something had run through the grass .

A raccoon .

Yakumo was relieved, but he knew he couldn't stay here forever .

If the police found his way out of the limestone cave, they would probably come here right away . He had to put as much distance as he could between them before them .

Most importantly, he couldn't just keep running like this .

He needed to gather information and confirm what had happened . No matter what terrible truth was waiting for him, it was his duty to know .

Yakumo stood up with determination and began to walk along the stream –

5

With complicated feelings, Ishii threw himself into the paperwork .

I want to become like Gotou as quickly as I can – he had frantically tried his hardest with that mind set and taken the assistant inspector promotion exam for that reason, but he hadn't thought he would really be able to catch up .

And he was also surprised that Gotou's rank was assistant inspector .

Did he fail the test? No, that wasn't it . He probably hadn't had the time to even take it .

Rather than taking a promotion exam, Gotou had chosen to act as a detective inspector . And how was Ishii in comparison to that?

After asking himself that, Ishii thought he was horribly lowly .

His shoulders slumped just as the door to the room opened .

The chief of the detectives, Miyagawa Hideya, showed up .

Though he had a small frame, he had a bald head and thick eyebrows . Underneath that, he had glaring eyes with a sharp glint in them which had the pressuring air of a carnivore .

'Where' Gotou?' said Miyagawa in a forceful and gravelly voice after looking around the room .

'Ah, er, he just stepped out . '

'Slacking off at a time like this . '

Miyagawa walked in angrily with large strides and then sat on top of the desk with his arms crossed .

'Did something happen?' Ishii asked timidly .

'This morning, a corpse was found in the back of a limestone cavern in Nishitama,' said Miyagawa with a sigh . '

'A corpse...'

The victim was Todayama Seidou, the priest of a nearby temple . Fifty-eight years old . '

Miyagawa continued his explanation in a flat tone .

'The incident occurred at about nine this morning . There was an anonymous tip about a corpse in a limestone cavern in the mountain area of Nishitama . '

'Anonymous...'

It wasn't rare for anonymous information to come to the police .

Especially in big incidents, informants didn't want to get involved .

'It seems like that limestone cavern's famous as a spiritual spot . '

'Perhaps he went there to test his courage?'

'We don't know the details yet, but it's possible . Anyway, two policemen went that and found a corpse, like the tip said . '

'Oh . '

Ishii gave a response lacking feeling .

He saw the outline of the case, but it was out of their jurisdiction . He didn't know why Miyagawa had gone out of his way to talk about it .

'It seems like the corpse was stabbed all over . '

'Stabbed... all over...'

The image of a priest covered in blood in the limestone cavern came up in Ishii's head . He gulped .

If he actually saw it, he probably would have screamed .

'So the Nishitama precinct sent a request for cooperation . '

'To us?'

Ishii was surprised .

'Yeah . '

'Why is that?'

'The two officers he went witnessed a suspicious man at the scene . '

Miyagawa's way of speaking was impassive, like he was reading a speech, but his expression was unusually grim .

'Is he the culprit?'

'The Nishitama precinct says it's likely . '

'I see . '

'In the officers' testimony, the man who ran from the scene had a red left eye . '

Miyagawa said that without a pause .

'Eh?'

It took some time for Ishii to understand .

Ishii only knew one person with a red left eye .

– Saitou Yakumo .

But that was just from the people Ishii knew . He couldn't deny the possibility that there were other people with red left eyes .

'Look at this . '

Miyagawa might have sensed what Ishii was feeling, because he took a piece of paper from his breast pocket and placed it on the desk .

It was a copy of an identity card which looked like a student ID .

'T-this is...'

When Ishii saw what was written there, he was lost for words .

– Meisei University, Saitou Yakumo

'There was a wallet at the limestone cavern . Seems like this was in it,' explained Miyagawa .

'That's...'

Yakumo's head flashed through Ishii's mind .

Well-defined features and skin was white as porcelain . Terrible bedhead and sleepy eyes .

He had a blank expression and acted indifferent ot everything, but in the back of his eyes, he coolly observed others' words and actions .

It was true that his perception had led them to solve many cases, but at the same time, Ishii felt frightened .

When he stood in front of Yakumo, he felt like Yakumo saw right to the bottom of his heart, so Ishii couldn't relax . There was something mysterious about Yakumo .

It might have been because Yakumo was the son of that man –

'The Nishitama precinct's sending a detective over,' said Miyagawa while crossing his arms .

'Could it be that we are – '

'Exactly . '

'Eeeehhh!'

Ishii exclaimed without thinking .

They were going to cooperate with a detective from the Nishitama precinct and chase Yakumo . To Ishii, it just seemed like a bad joke .

'Don't complain . I told them in advance that you're Yakumo's acquaintances . '

'I-isn't that bad?'

'They'd find out anyway . It'd be even worse to hide it . '

'I see...'

It was just as Miyagawa said . If they hid it, the information would come out easily once they searched . If it was found out later, it would become an even worse problem .

'Anyway, get Gotou back before they get here . '

Miyagawa finished with that and then briskly walked out the room with his bow-legged gait .

Ishii felt like a gigantic weight had been placed on his shoulders . It seemed like he would be crushed flat .

– Did Yakumo really kill someone?

Ishii couldn't find the answer to the question eddying in his heart .

6

Assistant detective inspector? To hell with that .

Gotou was walking on university premises in his irritation .

The first term of university had ended and now it was summer vacation . It wasn't bustling like usual – it was rather leisurely .

Gotou was headed for the Movie Research Circle room, where Yakumo was .

Gotou didn't know himself why he had come here .

If they met, Yakumo would just complain and make Gotou more irritated .

Despite that, Gotou would want to meet Yakumo when he was in an ill humour . This wasn't the first time .

It would be difficult to explain, but Yakumo made him feel that way .

'Sorry to bother!'

As Gotou said that, he opened the door to the Movie Research Circle .

'If you know you're a bother, please leave . '

– This brat!

Gotou swallowed the words he was about to say and his eyes went wide .

In front of him wasn't Yakumo but Haruka .

'... is what Yakumo would say . '

Haruka laughed, shrugging her shoulders .

'Oh, it's you, Haruka-chan?'

Gotou sat on the folding chair in the corner of the room and loosened his tie .

The room had no air conditioning – just an electric fan . If he stayed an hour in this room, he'd be drenched in sweat .

'Would you like something to drink?' asked Haruka, standing up .

'Anything's good as long as it's cold .

'Roger, Detective Inspector Gotou . '

'It's Assistant Detective Inspector . '

Gotou hadn't meant to say it, but it slipped out of his mouth .

'Eh?'

Haruka looked confused .

'It's nothing . Anyway, something cold . '

'OK!'

After saying that, Haruka went to the refrigerator in the back of the room .

Recently, it had become so natural that he hadn't noticed, but looking at it like this, Gotou felt like he'd visited the house of a newly-wedded couple .

Even though a man and woman of the same age were at such an intimate distance, they weren't dating . It boggled Gotou's mind .

Rather than the two of them both not being honest with themselves, they were probably just not good with romance .

'Though I don't have the right to say anything...' said Gotou as he stretched .

'Did you say something?'

Haruka came back with a bottle of tea .

'It's nothing . Anyway, where's Yakumo?'

Gotou accepted the tea from Haruka and gulped it down .

'Gotou-san, you weren't together with Yakumo-san then,' said Haruka, sitting down on the folding chair and propping her head up in her hands . From that response, Haruka didn't know where Yakumo was either .

'Yeah . '

'Is there another case?'

Haruka looked at him doubtfully .

It appeared that she thought Gotou only came to see Yakumo when there was a case .

'That's not it . I was just wondering how he was since I haven't seen him around lately . How about you?'

'I felt the same way . '

Haruka smiled .

At this lull in their conversation, Gotou's mobile phone rang .

The display showed Ishii's number .

'Your mobile's ringing . '

Gotou thought about ignoring it, but with Haruka's comment, Gotou had to answer .

'What?'

<Detective Gotou, it's terrible!>

He heard Ishii's agitated voice from the phone .

'Don't make such a fuss . '

<But it really is terrible!>

'Then talk,' Gotou said curtly .

It really did make him irritated to think that this useless guy was on the same level as him .

<Ah, yes sir . After you went out, Detective Gotou, I was doing paperwork for a while, when...>

'Forget the preamble,' Gotou interrupted .

<I-I apologise, sir . This morning, a corpse was found in a limestone cavern in Nishitama . >

'And?'

Though Nishitama was a neighbouring city, it was a different jurisdiction .

The police organisation was very aware of its borders . If people stuck their necks into other jurisdictions' business, there'd be trouble .

<The police are chasing a man as an important person of interest because of evidence and eyewitness testimony . >

'So that's the culprit then . '

<W-wait! That's not it!>

Ishii hurriedly stopped Gotou before he could hang up .

'What's not it?'

<The name of the person of interest is Saitou Yakumo-shi . >

'Ah, I see . '

Gotou was about to hang up when he suddenly realised what Ishii had said .

– It can't be .

<Excuse me... Detective Gotou...>

Ishii's wavering voice came through the receiver .

'What'd you say just now?'

<I said that the person of interest was Saitou Yakumo-shi...>

Gotou hadn't heard wrong .

'When you say Yakumo... You mean that Yakumo!?'

Gotou sat up as he shouted in his agitation .

Haruka looked at him anxiously, seeming to sense that something terrible had happened .

<Yes sir . That Yakumo-shi, the one we know . >

'You're kidding me . '

Gotou couldn't accept Ishii's words .

However, Ishii wasn't the type to fool people or joke around . That made his words ring true .

Yakumo was a person of interest in a murder case – like Gotou could accept something as stupid as that .

As if to deny Gotou's thoughts, something somebody said flashed through his mind .

– That child will kill people .

Yakumo's mother, Saitou Azusa, had said that .

It was a rainy night fifteen years ago .

That day, Azusa had had her hands on the neck of her own son, Yakumo, while incoherently saying, 'That child will kill people . '

Were those words that came from delusion or a prophecy –

Now, Gotou couldn't see the answer .

<Hello, Detective Gotou?>

Gotou came back to his senses when he heard Ishii's voice .

This wasn't the time to remember the past .

'Explain in detail . '

Gotou sat down on the chair again with a hard expression .

7

Yakumo stopped his walking along the river .

A drop of water hit his cheek .

He looked up . Thick clouds blanketed the sky .

'An evening shower...'

As if they had waited for Yakumo's murmur, large raindrops suddenly started to fall .

Climbing down the mountain would be dangerous in the rain .

Yakumo looked around and saw a large rock with a hollow in it a bit beyond the river .

He could probably take shelter there if he stooped over .

Yakumo quickened his pace while dragging his left foot and slid his body into the hollow of the rock .

The large raindrops hit the ground loudly, creating a light mist . Yakumo decided to rest until the shower was over .

He ran both his hands through his hair and wiped them off .

After letting out a long sigh, a woman's face flashed through Yakumo's head .

– Ozawa Haruka .

He couldn't remember clearly now what his first impression of her had been .

Somebody troublesome has come along – he had probably just thought something like that .

She would disappear once she had used him and didn't need him any more . He had thought she'd be one of that type . After some time, he wouldn't think about her again . Like scenery passing in a car window .

However, the word Haruka had said so casually had destroyed the prejudices and sense of values that Yakumo had had up until then .

– Beautiful .

Haruka had said that when she saw Yakumo's red left eye .

Though Yakumo didn't say it, that word had healed Yakumo's impoverished heart more than anything that had ever been said to him up until now .

Because of his red left eye, which could see the spirits of the dead, he was viewed as something strange and looked at by the world with curiosity .

'Creepy . '

'Scary . '

'Pitiful . '

Hate . Fear . Pity –

Each of those words hurt Yakumo's heart, as if they were sharp blades .

– I'm not wanted .

It was natural for him to think that way .

I don't want to be here . I want to disappear . Yakumo had wished for death countless times, but as somebody who could see the spirits of the death, he knew that death was not a release from pain .

Yakumo felt like the word Haruka had said when she saw his red left eye – beautiful – had pulled out a stopper that had been in his heart .

Like it had told him it was all right for him to exist .

There had been many cases after that . While going through those, Haruka had become more than somebody who was just passing by .

That wasn't all . After she had become a part of his life, Yakumo's world had started to change .

Isshin and Nao . And Gotou – Yakumo had realised that there were other people who wanted him to be there .

At some point, the world had become something he didn't want to lose, and there were people he wanted to protect .

In the past, he would have thought that troublesome, but it was different now .

It was pleasant . He had been taught that he wasn't the only person in the world . It felt like he was being released from the suffering that he had been burdened with up until now .

– Why am I suddenly thinking about this?

With a self-derisive smile, Yakumo shut his eyes .

Perhaps because his nerves had calmed, he was assaulted by a heavy sleepiness .

He had somewhere he could return . That was why he had to return . There were people who were waiting – people he wanted to see –

Just as his neck lost its strength, Yakumo's eyes flew open .

He couldn't fall asleep carelessly in a place like this .

Yakumo shook his head .

At the same time, part of his memory came back to him .

He was in the cavern at the back of the limestone cave . Where Yakumo had woken up .

The flames of the candles were flickering .

Seidou stood there with lifeless eyes, as if his soul had left him, and gripped a knife .

'What do you plan to do after knowing the truth?' asked Seidou in a flat voice .

At the time, Yakumo had said something, but he couldn't remember what –

'I see . Then...'

Seidou smiled slightly and gripped the knife more tightly .

Everything suddenly went dark – and then another image appeared in his mind .

A place like a temple .

'Do you believe in reincarnation?' said Seidou .

A girl had been standing next to him .

She had bobbed hair and well-defined features, like a doll .

'I'm the reincarnation of my mother . '

Though the girl smiled, there was no emotion there .

This girl was empty .

– You?

While he was thinking, a jolt of pain ran through the back of his neck, bringing him back to reality .

A piece of a memory, just a moment . Everything was jumbled . He couldn't determine at this stage what it meant .

However, it appeared clear that there had been some sort of quarrel between Yakumo and Seidou .

Furthermore, Seidou had been holding a knife . It wouldn't be difficult to believe that after their quarrel, Yakumo had stabbed Seidou .

The doubt that had started to disappear came back again .

'That can't be . '

By saying it aloud, Yakumo cut down the growing anxiety in his heart .

If he theorised recklessly without all the information, he would become bound by a hard perspective and would be able to arrive at the truth .

For now, he wanted information . In order to do so, he would need to go to Seidou's temple .

Yakumo waited for the rain to stop .

8

'What's wrong?' Haruka asked Gotou once he finished his call .

Though she hadn't heard clearly, she could tell that something terrible had happened to Yakumo from the bits and pieces of the conversation she did hear .

Her heart was pounding .

It made Haruka recall what had happened half a year ago . The incident when Yakumo had disappeared without a word –

The corners of her eyes felt warm just from thinking about it .

She didn't want to feel that way again .

Gotou sat there silently with a stiff expression without answering Haruka's question .

It felt like he wasn't sure if he should talk .

That attitude made Haruka even more worried about the gravity of the situation .

The heavy silence continued .

The sound of the rain sounded incredibly loud .

The rain was heavy – the sound of the countless raindrops hitting the ground rang through the room .

'Please tell me . '

Haruka gripped Gotou's arm .

Guess there's no avoiding it – with that expression on his face, Gotou let out a breath in resignation and said 'I don't know the details yet' as his preface .

'A corpse was found in a limestone cave in Nishitama . '

'A corpse...'

Could it be –

Haruka felt like she had suddenly fallen into a bottomless darkness .

Tell me it isn't true – Haruka stared at Gotou with that wish .

'The person who died was the priest of a nearby temple,' said Gotou, as if he had sensed Haruka's feelings .

'I see...'

She knew it was indiscreet, but she was relieved that the corpse wasn't Yakumo .

'The police are chasing Yakumo as a person of interest . '

'Eh?'

Haruka said that without thinking .

It wasn't like she hadn't heard what Gotou said or that she didn't understand what the words meant .

She just couldn't believe it .

'The detectives witnessed a man with a red left eye fleeing the scene . And there was a wallet left behind as evidence . Yakumo's student ID had been in it . '

'That's...'

'From that situation, it's likely Yakumo's involved in the case somehow . '

Gotou had said what Haruka didn't dare to say .

She felt like a knife had been thrust through her .

'... It's a lie . '

After a silence, Haruka said just that .

She was saying that to herself . That can't be it . She wanted to believe that . She wanted that to be true .

Words from a terribly desperate wish –

'I know that . '

Unlike Haruka, Gotou's words had force behind them .

There was no doubt there . There was a confidence in them – like it was natural .

'That's right . '

'Right . There's no way he'd kill anybody . '

'You're right . '

Though Haruka gave a firm reply, she couldn't clear a niggling doubt .

– Why?

'The question is what to do now,' said Gotou, interrupting Haruka's question .

'That's right . '

They needed to find out the truth to see why this had happened . And –

'Where's Yakumo-kun now?'

'I don't know . '

Gotou crossed his arms in his displeasure .

'Did he run?'

'Seems like it . '

Haruka realised what had been bothering her .

'Why did Yakumo-kun run?'

Haruka didn't understand .

If he hadn't killed anybody, he wouldn't have needed to run . He could have just explained what he was doing .

And Yakumo must have known that running in that situation would be unbeneficial for him .

'I don't know . '

Gotou frowned .

'Was there something that happened that made it necessary for him to run?'

'It'd be faster to ask him . '

'But we don't know where he is . '

'We'll find him . '

Gotou puffed out his chest with confidence .

'But how?'

'We just have to check the places we think he might be . '

Gotou wasn't joking – he probably really meant to do that .

However, Haruka didn't think they'd be able to find Yakumo that way .
Going around mindlessly wouldn't do anything – they needed to find a clue .

'Are there no leads?'

'Ah, that's right . '

Gotou seemed to recall something after hearing Haruka's words . He clapped his hands together .

'What is it?'

'Seems like the place where the corpse was found was a spiritual spot . '

'A spiritual spot...'

Haruka murmured that as she mulled it over .

It was likely that Yakumo had been there following some spiritual mystery for some reason .

Even if that were the case, it was incredibly unlikely that Yakumo would chase a case related to spirits of his own volition .

'Did somebody bring a spiritual investigation to Yakumo?'

Haruka said the question that came to mind .

'It's possible . '

'But who would it be?'

'I don't know . '

'I don't either...'

Haruka thought about it, but she couldn't think of anybody .

Just as the conversation had come to a lull, the door opened .

'Yakumo-kun?'

Haruka stood up and looked at the door, thinking Yakumo might have returned .

However, the person standing there wasn't Yakumo –

9

Ishii's shoulders slumped in his disappointment .

He took off his glasses and leant on the back of the chair, looking up at the ceiling .

The detective from the Nishitama precinct would be here soon, but it didn't seem like Gotou would be coming back – he'd hung up the phone, saying <Only share info> .

Ishii understood why Gotou thought that way too .

If he met up with somebody from the Nishitama precinct, he wouldn't be able to move freely . And he probably didn't want to be asked too much about Yakumo .

However, Ishii didn't like being left behind . He couldn't explain why Gotou wasn't here, and he didn't have the confidence to do this alone .

Ishii covered his face with both hands . Then, he heard a knock on the door .

'Ah, yes . '

Ishii hurriedly put his glasses back on and stood up .

'Excuse me . '

The door opened . Ishii looked at the door and saw a woman standing there .

She was probably in her late twenties . She was tall, but she had an elegant figure .

Her hair was very short . With almond eyes, she looked strict at first glance, but she was quite the beauty with her feline features .

'My name is Natsume Youko . I'm from the Nishitama precinct . '

While saying that with good enunciation, she took out her police ID and held it in front of Ishii's eyes .

'Ah, I apologise for not introducing myself sooner . I am Ishii of the Setamachi precinct . '

Ishii was still troubled as he gave a polite bow .

'I believe that Chief Miyagawa has already contacted you . '

Youko walked right up to Ishii .

When she looked at him with her clear eyes, Ishii felt awkward and dropped his gaze to the floor .

'Ah, yes . I heard earlier . '

'So... where is the other detective?' said Youko, looking around the room dubiously .

She had hit him where it hurt .

'E-er... today... er, he wasn't feeling well...'

It didn't look like Youko was going to accept Ishii's explanation as she fixed him with a stare .

It wasn't like she was glaring at him, but it made Ishii feel timid .

'A-anyway, please sit down . '

Ishii tried to change the subject and took out the folding chair in the corner of the room .

'About cooperating with the investigation...' said Ishii once Youko sat down .

'I'll say this now, but you don't need to cooperate with the investigation . '

Youko's eyes narrowed as she said that in a clear tone .

'Eh?'

Ishii was so surprised that that was he replied with .

'I said that you don't need to cooperate with the investigation . '

'Yes, but . . '

'What is it?'

Youko looked at Ishii sharply .

Though Ishii was surprised by what Youko said so suddenly, he felt like she and Gotou were a bit similar .

An aloof detective who liked working independently . That was the impression Ishii had .

'But... the superiors have said...'

'The people at the top don't know the situation . Working with an impromptu team would be no help at all . Furthermore, investigating with a man...'

Though Youko didn't finish, her feminist side could be seen .

'Then what did you come to do today?' asked Ishii after gulping .

If she didn't want to ask for help with the investigation, why did she come all the way here? Ishii didn't understand .

'You know Saitou Yakumo, right?'

That gave Ishii a start .

He couldn't reply immediately – his gaze just wandered . However, it wasn't as if the answer was stuck to the walls or the ceiling, so he was just wasting time .

'You know him, right?' repeated Youko .

'Ah, no... Rather than knowing him... Well, I do...'

Ishii wiped the sweat on his forehead .

He knew it was a pointless answer . He really was useless .

'Why is he?'

It was a straight question . Like Gotou, she appeared to be the type who hated beating around the bush .

'No, we don't know where he is either right now...'

If they did, they would have already gone to meet him .

'Then tell me where you think he would go . '

Youko's eyes were forceful .

Under that pressure, it was difficult for Ishii to breathe . No criminal could escape if she were chasing them . It made Ishii feel that way .

'Places I think he would go...'

'Places he often visits . His lover's house, his friend's house . Anything's fine . Just tell me the information you know . '

There was fervour behind Youko's words .

It appeared that she had already jumped to the conclusion that Yakumo was the culprit at this stage .

'Detective Natsume, do you think Yakumo-shi is the culprit?'

After a silence, Ishii finally said just that .

'It's certain that he's the most likely suspect . '

For a moment, Youko looked surprised by Ishii's response, but then her expression became blank again and she replied in a flat tone .

'I see...'

'What do you think?'

'I...'

When Youko asked a question back, Ishii was lost for words .

It appeared like Gotou thought there was no way for Yakumo to kill anyone, but Ishii couldn't say that for certain .

Yakumo, who could see the spirits of the dead, respected life more than anybody else . Ishii knew that .

But on the other side of that, Yakumo was sometimes cold – to the point it was obsessive – about the things he couldn't forgive .

'What's wrong?' said Youko, sticking out her pointy chin .

'I believe it is too early to say...'

'Is that from the situation? Or your personal opinion?'

Another difficult question .

'I...'

Ishii adjusted the position of his glasses .

– Which is it for me?

As if throwing a bone to Ishii in his confusion, Youko's mobile rang .

'Hello, Natsume speaking . '

Youko answered immediately .

Ishii couldn't hear the conversation, but from the atmosphere, it looked like she had new information about the case .

'Understood,' replied Youko, sounding agitated .

'Did you find something out?' said Ishii once Youko hung up .

'We were able to confirm this from a trainee monk at Seidou's temple . '

'What is it?'

'Saitou Yakumo and the victim Seidou appear to have left the temple together late last night . '

Youko smiled triumphantly .

Though they were still at the stage of gathering evidence, that testimony made it seem more like Yakumo was the culprit .

But –

'That is only one testimony about the situation . '

'That's not all . '

'Eh?'

'Fingerprints from the cup that we believe he used in the temple's living quarters match the ones left on the knife at the scene . '

'Fingerprints...'

Ishii couldn't breathe .

If even the fingerprints matched, he couldn't say anything .

No, it was still too early to come to a decision . Ishii shook his head .

There was no proof that Yakumo really used that cup . They just believed that – that was what Youko had said .

'Fingerprints will be taken from Saitou Yakumo's room,' said Youko, anticipating Ishii's thoughts .

It looked like that she hadn't overlooked anything .

If they matched the fingerprints from Yakumo's room, that would confirm their suspicion .

'If the fingerprints from the room match the knife, he would go from being a person of interest to a suspect . '

'That's...'

'Hurry and tell me where Saitou Yakumo is . '

Youko looked like she might like her lips at any moment .

Ishii couldn't help but look away from her persistence .

10

– Yakumo might be back .

Haruka looked with hope towards the door but standing there was a priest in religious clothes .

He appeared rather old, but he had a large frame that rivalled Gotou's with a round, shaved head . He had a good physique and looked like a good person .

'What an awful shower,' said the priest in a forceful tone as he wiped the raindrops off his clothes .

It was an unreserved attitude . It felt like he'd mistaken them for someone else .

'Excuse me...' said Haruka, confused .

'Oh, what's this?'

The priest looked at Haruka like he had just noticed her .

'Do you need something?'

'Oh, it's the first time we've met . You're Ozawa Haruka, right? Just as the rumours say, you're quite the pretty girl . '

After taking a hard look at Haruka, the priest said that and gave a hearty laugh .

It appeared he was a considerably lively man .

'Don't be so loud, you damn monk,' said Gotou .

'Is it OK to say that? Who do you think helped you get the place you're staying in now? You can't have forgotten . '

The priest puffed out his chest .

It looked like Gotou knew the priest . And the priest knew Haruka's name . Haruka felt like she was the only one who was left out .

'Er...'

Though Haruka spoke up, she had so many things she wanted to ask she didn't know what to say .

'That's right . I haven't introduced myself yet . That's my bad . '

The priest awkwardly scratched his head as he said that, like he couldn't overlook Haruka's confusion . Then, he sat in the chair Yakumo usually used .

'Excuse me...' said Haruka after the priest sat down .

'You don't need to worry; I'll tell you . '

'Ah, yes . '

'My name is Eishin . As you can see, I'm a humble priest . '

After Eishin said that with a voice full of energy, he smiled, his eyes closing as he did so .

'A priest...'

Actually, Isshin was my disciple . I heard about you from him, Haruka-san .

'I-is that so?'

Isshin was Yakumo's uncle – the person who had raised him .

Haruka had been in his care a number of times too . Though he had already passed away, to Haruka, he was somebody unforgettable .

'The teacher watches his disciple and teaches him . We're alike, right?'

'Yes?'

Haruka was confused .

Though they had just met, his appearance and personality – no matter how she looked at it, Isshin was –

'You're not alike . '

Gotou spoke Haruka's feelings .

'Can you really say that?'

Eishin looked at Gotou meaningfully .

It looked like Eishin had a hold of one of Gotou's weaknesses, because Gotou just said weakly, 'My bad . '

'Gotou-san, er... Do you know Eishin-san?' asked Haruka .

'The hell I know him . He's just a damn monk . '

'Can't you give a better explanation?' Eishin interrupted immediately .

Somehow, when she watched their exchange, Eishin seemed less like Isshin and more like Yakumo .

'To put it simply, he's like my landlord . '

'Landlord?'

Even after Gotou explained, Haruka didn't really understand .

'The priests' quarters that Gotou is staying in belongs to the religious organisation . '

'Eh? Is that so?'

Eishin gave an additional explanation which made Haruka surprised .

Since Isshin had lived there before, she had thought it belonged to him .
Haruka had thought that Yakumo had let Gotou stay there while thinking of Nao, but it seemed that wasn't the case .

'Normally, those unrelated to the religion are not allowed to stay there, but my wheedling got them special permission to stay there . Under the condition that Yakumo would take on the temple duties . '

'I see...'

Though Haruka spoke like she understood, the last sentence Eishin said came up in her head .

– Under the condition that Yakumo would take on the temple duties .

'Is Yakumo-kun going to become a priest?'

'Don't take what the damn monk says seriously . '

Gotou snorted .

'That's my plan . '

'Yakumo didn't agree to that . '

'He will . '

'What's with that baseless confidence of yours?'

Gotou and Eishin continued to quarrel .

'Why did you come here today?'

Haruka asked a question to stop their conversation .

'Oh, that's right . '

Eishin clapped his hands together .

'Actually, there's something I want to ask Yakumo . Where is he?'

Eishin looked around the room . The room was small . He should have been able to tell if he wasn't here, but his movements were exaggeratedly large .

– Can we tell Eishin the situation right now?

Haruka looked at Gotou since she wasn't sure .

Gotou nodded and started to speak .

'Yakumo's in some trouble right now . '

'Trouble?'

Eishin cocked his head .

'Yeah . There's no point hiding it, so I'll say it clearly . The police are chasing him as a person of interest in a murder case that occurred in Nishitama . '

'Could it be the victim is Seidou?'

'How'd you know that?'

'I heard earlier that Seidou was killed . '

'Was he an acquaintance of yours?'

Gotou bit onto the words Eishin said without any hesitation .

'Not just an acquaintance –I was the one who told Yakumo to go to see Seidou . '

'What did you say!?'

Gotou stood up in his excitement .

Unlike him, Eishin had a sad expression on his face .

'Excuse me... Could it be that you requested Yakumo's help in an investigation of a spiritual phenomenon...?'

Haruka said what came to her mind .

'You're quite quick . '

Eishin nodded a number of times in admiration .

'How are you so calm!? You're the start of this! You damn monk!'

Gotou grabbed Eishin by the collar, but Eishin just smiled .

'Wait, Gotou-san . Please calm down . '

Haruka stepped between them and tried to pull them apart, but she didn't have the strength .

'I need to punch this damn monk . '

'This isn't the time to quarrel . Let's ask Eishin-san what happened . '

'... Fine . '

Haruka's frantic convincing finally got through to Gotou, who let go of Eishin and sat back down in a sulk .

Haruka sighed . She felt in her flesh and bones how tough it must be for Ishii .

'Would you please tell us what happened?'

After sitting down on the chair again, Haruka asked Eishin that question .

Eishin looked a bit troubled, but then he nodded and his expression changed back .

'I met Yakumo here yesterday morning . '

'Yesterday...'

'Actually, Seidou came to me for advice a little while back . '

'Was that related to a spiritual phenomenon?'

'Hm, not exactly . Well, something like it . '

It was an incredibly vague response . It looked like it was difficult to talk about .

'What does that mean?'

'To put it in one word, reincarnation . '

– Reincarnation .

In Haruka's head, that word reverberated with the inauspiciousness of a curse .

11

– Reincarnation .

In the hollow of the rock, Yakumo glared at the rain while crouching . The voice echoed in Yakumo's ear .

When Eishin had said that, Yakumo had had a terribly bad feeling .

'There's a girl who says she was born again . '

Yesterday, Eishin had gone to Yakumo's room and said that with a troubled expression .

Why is he troubled – Yakumo remembered feeling that was odd .

In Buddhism, after somebody died, they were reincarnated in one of the six realms based on their actions when they were alive .

It should have been natural for a Buddhist like Eishin .

Though he didn't know too much about it, Buddhism had a no-soul stance .

The reason why Yakumo wouldn't agree to Eishin's request that he inherit the temple was largely related to that .

For me, who can see spirits, to put my faith in Buddhism, which doesn't recognise the existence of spirits –

It would be incredibly unnatural .

'That's outside my jurisdiction,' Yakumo had said .

However, Eishin hadn't backed down easily .

'Why do you say that?'

'I can see the spirits of the dead . I don't know what they were in their past lives . '

'But don't you have any interest in it?'

'I don't,' Yakumo said firmly .

'Really?'

'What do you mean by that?'

'I'm interested . '

Eishin smiled .

'Then why not go yourself?'

'I did . Now I'm asking you . '

He really was persistent . Yakumo ran a hand through his hair .

'I said this earlier . I see the spirits of the dead . Not their past lives . '

'What if that girl says she was her own mother in her past life?'

Yakumo had thought he had misheard, but Eishin just smiled with no intent of changing what he said .

'That doesn't make sense,' said Yakumo, leaning on the back of the chair .

It would have been more sensible if it were the father, but the mother gave birth to the child . It would be impossible to be reincarnated then .

'Don't you think it's mysterious?'

Eishin's eyes narrowed .

He probably thought that Yakumo was the type of person who would become interested in a puzzle and act on it .

Yakumo knew himself that he had a side of himself that was like that, but he couldn't shake the thought that this case really was outside of his jurisdiction .

'Please ask somebody else . '

At the time, he really had meant to refuse .

'The girl in question was an abandoned child . She's in a temple now . '

Eishin continued speaking .

'Is that so?'

'That temple's one that Isshin trained in when he was young . '

'Uncle...'

Something shook within Yakumo .

Come to think of it, when Isshin was alive, Yakumo had just relied on his kindness – he'd never talked to him at length .

He knew practically nothing about the sort of life Isshin had walked – he hadn't tried to know either .

I can talk to him whenever . That was what he had thought .

– I should have talked to him more when he was alive .

Regret gripped his heart .

'The head priest, Seidou, was Isshin's senior disciple . '

'So?'

'You've gone to that temple before too . '

'I did?'

Yakumo cocked his head .

'That's right . That was around when Isshin decided to take you in...'

Eishin looked up, as if searching his memories . Yakumo unconsciously started searching his memories as well .

He recalled an old temple . It wasn't Isshin's . Someplace else .

There was a statue of the Buddha at the front .

Sitting atop of lotus leaves in meditation . His half-open eyes seemed to see right through Yakumo – he couldn't relax .

Isshin was next to him .

While gripping Yakumo's hand, Isshin said something . Something very important – but Yakumo couldn't remember .

– What did he say?

Yakumo closed his eyes and asked himself that .

At the time, Isshin was about the same that Yakumo was now . Yakumo had remembered thinking that Isshin was old, but now that he thought about it, he had been quite young .

But still, Isshin had determined to take in the child that his sister had tried to kill .

– Why?

Now, that doubt bubbled up from deep within Yakumo's heart .

When Isshin was alive, Yakumo had never thought about that . He felt like the answer to that question was in the words that Yakumo couldn't remember .

– The answer is in that temple .

Yakumo had no proof, but he had started to feel that way .

'Won't you go to that temple to take a look?' Eishin asked again .

It didn't take much time for Yakumo to decide .

The rain had stopped while Yakumo was recollecting what happened .

Yakumo crawled out from the hollow in the rock and looked up at the sky .

The clouds, which had been so thick, had become much thinner . They had probably dropped at the raindrops they had been holding .

Though the clouds were thinner, the sun had already hidden itself behind the mountains, so the sky was dyed scarlet .

Night would fall soon . It would be better to hurry .

Yakumo started walking .

12

Eishin's story was a strange one .

It was too confusing for Gotou to swallow .

'So that girl said she was her mother reborn?'

Eishin nodded .

'Isn't that strange?' interrupted Haruka as she leant forward .

'It is . It is strange, but...'

It was rather bad enunciation for Eishin .

'Isn't that girl just lying?'

'That's what I thought at first . '

Eishin shook his head .

'Then...'

'First, I need to talk about that girl's story . '

Eishin nodded to himself .

'The girl's?'

'That's right . That girl isn't Seidou's daughter . About ten years ago, she was abandoned in front of the temple . A baby just a few days after she was born . '

'That's horrible...'

With wide eyes, Haruka covered her mouth with both hands .

Though Gotou's expression didn't change, he felt the same way as Haruka .

It was inhuman to abandon a baby who couldn't even live on its own yet .

But it was undoubtedly true that there were parents like that .

'So the priest called Seidou took the kid in . '

'That's correct . He adopted her and named her Hatsune . '

'How about her mother?'

'She hasn't been found yet . '

'Then there's nothing to prove she's her mother's reincarnation . You don't even know if she's alive or dead . '

Gotou voiced the question that came to his head .

Gotou had seen a number of television programmes in the past about reincarnation .

The people on these shows always declared they had memories of the past, which proved that they were reincarnated .

During investigations, the information that police gave the media was limited .

Knowledge that only the culprit could know could become a confession .

In this case, since they didn't know who the mother was, they couldn't tell whether the girl was telling the truth .

'There's that . '

Eishin looked even more troubled .

'Eh?'

'About three months ago, it seems like Seidou and Hatsune went foraging for mountain plants, but at that time, Hatsune said that there was a limestone cavern ahead . '

'And there really was one?'

Eishin nodded . 'Right . ' Deciding just from that was much too easy .

'Couldn't she have gone there to play by herself?'

'It's not the sort of place a child can go alone . '

'She just happened to know, right?'

'That might be the case, but there are other odd things . '

'Like what?'

'She also said correctly that there was a lake about three kilometres from the temple,' said Eishin quietly .

'A lake... You can see that from a map . '

Gotou snorted .

It was a bit unreasonable making an uproar about past lives just from that .

'Well, you can think about it that way, but the problem's still ahead . '

'Ahead?'

'Hatsune said that there was a corpse at that lake . '

'A corpse?'

'Right . Her mother's... No, maybe I should say her own...'

Eishin crossed his arms and cocked his head, focussing on something odd .

'A corpse is quite the matter . '

'Right . '

'Then?'

Gotou urged Eishin to continue, but Eishin looked blank .

Honestly . The old man was playing the fool .

'So was there a corpse there?'

'I don't know,' Eishin replied immediately .

'You didn't check?'

'Of course not . How would I?'

'How? You could just call the police...'

'If I called the police about a corpse because a girl who said she was her mother's reincarnation said there was a corpse there, do you think they'd send people to the lake?' Eishin said, pressing Gotou for an answer .

Even Gotou couldn't rebut after Eishin said that much .

Just as Eishin said, the police probably wouldn't move unless a part of the corpse was found . But –

'Then there's no proof of her past life . '

'Don't be in such a rush . There's still more . '

'More?'

'About ten years ago, there was a rumour near the lake . '

'What sort of rumour?'

'The people there used to say they could hear a woman's screams coming from the lake every night . That's right about the time when Hatsune was abandoned . '

'You saying something's there?'

'Though I don't like putting things together so simply, this time, Seidou was killed in the limestone cavern . Don't you think we should take the story seriously?'

After Eishin said that much, something seemed odd to Gotou .

'Could the limestone cave that the priest called Seidou was found in be...'

'You just noticed? What a fool . '

Eishin snorted scornfully .

A corpse was found in the limestone cavern pointed out by the girl who said she was her mother's reincarnation – so that was it .

That did make it seem like something was there .

'So you asked Yakumo-kun to investigate,' interrupted Haruka after listening to the story silently .

'Well, that's how it is . '

Eishin laughed loudly like he thought something was funny .

Gotou understood the gist of it . It certainly was an odd case . However, there was something that Gotou just couldn't accept .

'I can't believe Yakumo agreed to investigate . '

To be honest, Eishin's story was incredibly suspicious . Because of Yakumo's personality, Gotou couldn't think that Yakumo would stick his

neck in .

'The temple in question is a place where Isshin trained in the past . Seidou is Isshin's old acquaintance too . '

'Isshin-san's...' murmured Haruka, half-closing her eyes .

– So that's how it was .

Gotou understood now .

To the old Yakumo, it wouldn't have mattered what sort of temple it was .

He had built a wall around him and decided to keep everyone out of it, regardless of what other people thought or how they lived their lives . However, it was different now .

Something besides spiritual phenomena had aroused Yakumo's interest .

'The problem's what came after that,' said Gotou, clearing the heavy air .

'That's right . What can we do?'

After Haruka agreed, Eishin nodded as well .

The conversation had just got back on track when Gotou's mobile rang . It was from Ishii .

– What bad timing this guy has .

'What do you want!?!'

Gotou yelled at the phone's receiver .

13

Yakumo dragged his injured left foot along as he walked beside the river .

It was already dark .

All he could rely on was the faint light of the moon .

He didn't even know if there was a path here . Furthermore, the shower earlier made it easy for him to slip .

He had to walk through the weeds while keeping in mind his injured leg .

Yakumo placed a hand on a cedar tree and wiped the sweat off his forehead .

It wasn't just his forehead that was sweaty . His body was drenched with sweat, making it sticky .

How far had he walked? How much further did he have to walk before he could get out of this forest? He didn't have any idea .

Like a realisation of Yakumo's current state .

He had gone to the limestone cavern in Seidou's car last night . It was about fifteen minutes away .

Even if he left out the time he had been stuck during the evening shower after falling in the lime stone cave, he had walked for more than three hours . He should have been arriving at the temple soon, but it didn't seem like it would happen .

Perhaps he'd taken a wrong turn somewhere, or perhaps he was just circling the mountain, but whichever was the case, he had made the wrong choice .

The exhaustion made his body heavy . With an empty stomach, he had no strength .

His left leg pulsed with pain like it had been struck with a hot iron .

– Why am I running like this?

That question suddenly came to Yakumo .

He had also had the choice of staying there and explaining the situation to the police . That would have been much easier than running .

Running would also make the police more suspicious .

– I might have killed him .

One big reason was that Yakumo couldn't clear that thought out of his head .

He remembered up to when he went to the limestone cavern with Seidou, but he had lost his memories of what happened after that .

Boxers who were knocked out in a match often remembered standing in the ring but forgot that they had participated in a match .

The strong impact on their brain made them forget the memories around the event .

However, that didn't mean that the memories had been erased . It was just temporary memory loss . When they watched a video of the match, they would sometimes remember that something had happened .

Yakumo had to go to that temple and recall what had happened at the limestone cavern .

– To protect somebody important to me .

Yakumo took out a piece of paper that he had stuck in his pocket . It had been stuck on the doors to the cavern .

All that was on it was a short message .

<You're the one who killed him . If you're caught by the police, somebody important to you will die . >

It was like something out of a novel .

However, Yakumo understood the true meaning of the message .

The biggest reason why Yakumo had made the choice to escape .

'I have to go . '

Yakumo now had somebody who was important to him – who he wanted to protect no matter what he had to give up in exchange .

And so –

Yakumo gritted his back teeth and started walking again .

14

'Was that Ishii-san just now?' said Haruka after Gotou hung up .

If it was Ishii, he might have some new information .

'Yeah . There's a problem . '

Gotou sounded depressed, which was rare .

'Eh?'

'Fingerprints thought to be Yakumo's were found at the temple . They match the ones on the knife left at the scene . '

'That's...'

Haruka couldn't say anything else .

'Well, at this stage, they're just thought to be Yakumo's . They haven't been proven to be his . '

Gotou said that in a forced cheerful voice, like he couldn't let Haruka look so down .

'That's right . You're right . '

Haruka said that for herself, but it didn't clear her worries .

'Anyway, I'm going . '

Gotou stood up .

'Where are you going?'

'Police are coming here now . '

'Police?'

'Yeah . To get Yakumo's fingerprints . If I meet up with them, it'll be a problem . '

Gotou's face looked pained .

'What if the fingerprints in this room match the ones on the knife?' asked Haruka, though she knew the answer .

Gotou looked like he felt awkward, but then he spoke after sighing .

'Then the police will change Yakumo from a person of interest to a suspect .',

Though Haruka had known, hearing it made it feel like she had been pushed off a cliff .

'Then what are you planning to do after leaving here?' said Eishin in a casual tone that didn't match the atmosphere .

He appeared to be a terrifyingly laidback guy .

'Whaddaya mean, what am I planning to do!? I'm going to look for Yakumo!' said Gotou with determination .

A complete opposite of Gotou, Eishin just said, 'I see,' like the matter wasn't related to him .

'I'm going too,' said Haruka .

She wanted to meet Yakumo as soon as possible . And she wanted to confirm .

– You haven't killed anyone, right?

It wasn't that she didn't believe in him, but she wanted to hear it from his mouth .

'You can't . Haruka-chan, you can't come along,' Gotou said firmly .

'Why not?'

Haruka stood up and pressed Gotou for an answer .

She couldn't just wait by herself in this situation . She knew she would just be a hindrance, but she still wanted to go .

'There's something else I want you to do . '

Gotou placed a hand on Haruka's shoulder .

'Something else?'

'Yeah . Even if I do find Yakumo, he's a fugitive right now . '

'That's why we have to look for him . '

'Listen to me . '

When Haruka repeated her request, Gotou rebuked her .

'I...'

'Haruka-chan, you meet up with Ishii . '

'With Ishii-san?'

'Right . To solve the puzzle behind this case . Make a place that Yakumo can return to . '

– A place that Yakumo can return to .

Gotou was probably right . Even if they did find Yakumo, they couldn't do anything if the police were still chasing him .

He would be a fugitive for his whole life if they didn't clear his name . But
—

'Can I do it...'

'That's a silly question . '

Gotou snorted .

'Eh?'

'It's not about whether you can do it or not . You're going to do it . '

'Yes sir!'

Haruka gave a bright reply .

She felt like Gotou's words had saved her . All she could do now was believe and act . If they didn't do anything, they couldn't save Yakumo .

'OK, let's get out of here now . I'll walk you part of the way . '

'Thank you very much . '

'Do your best!'

As Haruka and Gotou were about to leave the room, Eishin said that with a small wave .

Gotou's face went red when he saw that response .

'You're coming with me, you damned monk!'

'Why?'

In contrast to Gotou's agitation, Eishin was just sitting on the chair placidly .

'Don't you "Why" me! You're responsible for this mess!'

Gotou's anger had reached its peak .

15

Ishii was waiting for Haruka at a coffee shop .

It was a privately-owned coffee shop near the station . There was a broken and unmoving wall clock there .

Ishii sat at the round table in the very back of the first floor and watched the entrance .

He would meet Haruka soon . And it would be just the two of them –

If the situation weren't like this, he would have been so happy, but he felt depressed thinking about what was going to happen .

It looked worse and worse for Yakumo .

The police were probably getting Yakumo's fingerprints from the room at the university now .

If the fingerprints matched – Ishii didn't want to think about it .

'Ishii-san . '

Ishii lifted his head at the voice .

Haruka was standing in front of him .

Ishii had been so lost in his thoughts that he hadn't noticed Haruka coming in .

A mistake he would never live down –

'E-excuse me . '

Ishii hurriedly stood up and bowed deeply .

As he did so, he knocked over the coffee cup on the table .

'Ack!'

'Ishii-san, are you all right?'

Haruka went to the counter and borrowed a towel, wiping up as much of the coffee Ishii had spilled as she could .

This act that she did so casually made Ishii feel like his heart had been pierced .

'Ah, no, I'm really sorry . '

'It's all right . Would you like the same thing?'

'Eh? Ah, yes . '

While Ishii was troubled, Haruka ordered two coffees from the waiter .

Ishii really was useless . You couldn't tell which of them was older .

'This is quite the situation . '

After they sat down across from each other and had calmed down, Haruka brought up the topic at hand .

Ishii couldn't ignore the shadow in Haruka's eyes . Though she was acting calm, it must have been tough for her .

'It has... Detective Gotou said to solve the mystery, but to be honest, I don't know where to start...'

Ishii adjusted the position of his glasses with his finger .

He wanted to act cool in front of the person he liked, but the situation this time was too serious .

'We have some new information, so I should tell you about that, Ishii-san . '

'What is it?'

Ishii's brows furrowed .

'The reason why Yakumo-kun went to the scene of the crime . '

'Ah . '

Ishii understood now .

Come to think of it, he didn't know why Yakumo had gone to Nishitama .

Though Nishitama was the neighbouring city, the scene of the crime was quite remote . It would take an hour to get there by train .

It was a bit too far just for a stroll .

'A priest named Eishin-san requested that Yakumo-kun investigate a spiritual phenomenon . '

Haruka started to explain after taking a sip of coffee .

Her explanation was a complicated and strange one related to reincarnation . A girl who said she was her mother reborn, and the screams of a woman that could be heard from the lake –

Perhaps because of the way Haruka said it or the story's innate strangeness, Ishii's hair stood on end as he listened .

'Is that really...'

That was the first thing Ishii said after Haruka finished .

Ishii had read a number of books about reincarnation .

Young children talking in a language of a country that had never been to, or talking about people from a different age – things like that .

Recently, it was even claimed that some people could recall their past memories under hypnotism .

Ishii didn't know if it was true or fake, because human memories were incredibly subjective .

'I don't know if it is true or not, but...'

Haruka put her chin in her hand and stirred her coffee with a spoon .

'What is it?'

'I thought it might have something to do with Yakumo-kun . '

'Huh...'

Ishii gave a flat reply .

It was probably true that Yakumo had gone there chasing a spiritual phenomenon, but it was difficult to think that it was related to Seidou's murder case at the current stage .

'Do you doubt it?'

'Ah, no . '

Ishii frantically shook his head after Haruka saw through his faults .

'It's all right . I think it's a bit forced myself... But I think there's no point in investigating the same thing as the police . '

'That's right . '

It was just as Haruka said .

If they investigated the same thing, they could just leave it to the police .

'That's why I thought that we could investigate from a different perspective that the police . '

'A different perspective...'

Unlike Ishii, who was troubled, the corners of Haruka's lips turned up in a confident smile .

'Yes . It might be a bit forced, but we can investigate with the premise that the spiritual phenomenon and the murder this time are related . '

Haruka leant forward .

Ishii leant back a bit from the pressure .

'But even if you say they are related, how...'

'Putting together what Eishin-san said, it is likely that somebody died near the temple, limestone cavern and the lake . '

'In short... We'll be investigating something that occurred near there in the past . '

'Yes . '

'But a murder case...'

Ishii stopped .

If a murder case occurred in the same place in the past, they should have received information about it .

'It doesn't have to be a murder,' said Haruka, like she had read Ishii's thoughts again .

'Eh?'

Ishii lifted his head in confusion .

'Accident, suicide, disappearance – anything is fine . '

'I see . We can just pick up whatever seems related . '

'Yes . '

'You really are amazing, Haruka-chan . '

'I'm not just helping Yakumo-kun for show . '

Haruka smiled bashfully .

When Ishii saw that, he felt a twinge of pain run through his chest .

I wonder if Haruka would be so frantic if I were the one being chased as a murderer – Ishii suddenly thought that .

He knew the answer .

Haruka was always glad and sad by turns while at Yakumo's side . To her, Yakumo was somebody special who couldn't be replaced by anybody .

– How cute .

That had been Ishii's genuine thought when he first met Haruka .

After experiencing a number of cases, Haruka had become much more adult-like, but that adorable smile hadn't changed .

Ishii didn't know how many times it had soothed Ishii's exhausted heart, but Haruka's eyes had never been on Ishii .

The same person was always reflected in Haruka's eyes .

Ishii felt that all over again .

'Ishii-san, what's the matter?'

Haruka waved a hand in front of Ishii's eyes .

'Ah, no, it's nothing . Anyway, I'll look into incidents and accidents that occurred in the past . '

Ishii came to his senses and spoke after clearing his throat .

'Let's both do our best . '

Haruka smiled .

'No, I couldn't...'

'I'm the one who asked . '

'No, I'd love your help, but information about cases is personal information . If we showed it to civilians, there would be a number of problems . '

'I see...'

Haruka's shoulders slumped .

It was like she was stricken with her powerlessness .

'Could you look into this on the internet for me, Haruka-chan?' suggested Ishii, feeling guilty .

'The internet?'

'Yes . I'd appreciate it if you look into rumours about spiritual phenomena or incidents in the area online . '

'I see . We could do that as well . That's Ishii-san for you . '

Haruka's expression became brighter all at once .

Normally, Ishii would feel happy about the distance between him and Haruka shortening, but today was different .

No matter how short the distance between him and Haruka, that would still be the distance between friends . That was because Haruka's heart was

filled with Yakumo .

If Yakumo were arrested as a murderer, would Haruka's feelings change?

Ishii ended up thinking something imprudent –

16

Gotou drove the car .

He got stuck in traffic, so he took more time than he expected . It was already dark out .

He got off the highway and turned onto the winding mountain road . He was almost at his destination .

In the passenger seat, Eishin was sleeping soundly .

– Damn . He looks so comfortable .

'Oi . Wake up . '

Gotou shook Eishin's shoulder .

However, his lips just flapped open and close – it didn't look like he would wake up at all .

He was terribly laidback . Even Yakumo had his hands full with Eishin . but that he had to agree with .

'Wake the hell up already!'

When Gotou yelled, Eishin finally sat up and rubbed his eyes .

'You're so noisy . What do you eat to have such a loud voice?' said Eishin while stretching .

– This monk doesn't shut up .

It even made Gotou think Eishin, rather than Isshin, was the one who raised Yakumo .

'I'll listen to your complaints later – tell me directions . '

'Left at the next intersection . Then just drive along the road,' said Eishin, sounding annoyed, and then he lay back on the seat again and closed his eyes .

It looked like he planned on sleeping again . What kind of joke was this?

'What sort of man was Seidou?' asked Gotou, looking at Eishin .

'What is the point of asking that?'

'It might give us a lead . '

'It won't be much help . '

Eishin got up and wiped his face with both hands .

'Why not?'

'People's hearts change moment by moment . That's why there isn't one set shape of a person . In short, the person named Seidou that I know is only who he is at a certain time, and a subjective perspective on top of that . '

When Eishin spoke like that, it was like he was reading a sutra . His eyes seemed to be unfocussed as he looked forward .

'Don't say something so difficult . '

– Don't hide this with smoke .

'It isn't difficult . For example, you think that Yakumo wouldn't kill somebody . '

'Of course not . '

– What are you saying this for now?

Gotou wanted to spit that out in his irritation .

'What is your proof?'

'That's the sort of guy he is . '

'Let's change the question . When did you last meet Yakumo?'

Gotou was lost for words at the unexpected question .

He couldn't remember the exact date, but –

'About a month ago . '

'In the month you haven't met him, something might have changed in Yakumo's heart that led him to murder . '

'Don't be ridiculous . People's feelings don't change so easily . '

Gotou hit the wheel in his anger .

'Is it that ridiculous? Hasn't Yakumo changed already?'

Eishin had pointed out something that hurt, so Gotou couldn't reply .

He had first met Yakumo fifteen years ago –

On a rainy night, Gotou saved Yakumo from his mother, who was about to kill him . At that time, Yakumo had had eyes so cold and expressionless they made you think he wasn't a seven-year-old child .

– What's going to happen to this kid?

Gotou had been worried about Yakumo's future .

When they met again, Yakumo was fifteen .

At the time, it had been dangerous for Yakumo .

It felt like he would crumble if anything happened .

If Yakumo had killed somebody then, Gotou would have probably thought, 'He finally did it...'

But Yakumo had met Haruka . He had changed greatly .

People's hearts continue to change with time and outside influences . That's how it is – Gotou understood that, but he shook his head in denial .

'He wouldn't kill anybody, now or in the past . '

'How frank . '

Eishin stifled his laughter .

'Are you going to praise me or speak ill of me? Make up your mind . '

'Why would I praise you?' Eishin said without a pause .

– This damn monk is really annoying!

Gotou buried his urge to yell into his stomach . They were off topic .

'Forget about that and just tell me what kind of man Seidou was!'

'Letting the blood get to your head so quickly is a bad habit . '

'I don't need your concern,' said Gotou with a click of his tongue .

Even talking with Yakumo might have been better than talking with Eishin .

'Well, the Seidou I knew was a good man . '

'Anybody would be when compared with a damn monk,' said Gotou, his voice filled with all the resentment that had built up .

'That's true . Seidou was meticulous and reliable . He always thought of others . '

Gotou had meant to say that sarcastically, but there was no point if Eishin was just going to admit it .

'And?' Gotou urged .

'He was Isshin's senior, but he was good at watching over him . Isshin looked up to him like a real older brother . They were quite similar . '

'A faultlessly good guy then?'

'I said this earlier, didn't I? That's just that person at a certain time . '

'I know that . You're saying that there might've been a reason you don't know that he was killed, right?' Gotou said casually .

'Well, that's what I'm trying to say . Though I shouldn't say this, Seidou had a son...'

Eishin spoke in a slow tone .

Gotou noticed that Eishin said 'had' in the past tense, but he didn't ask about it .

'And?'

'He committed suicide . '

'Suicide...'

'Yes . He hanged himself in the temple . '

Gotou swallowed . It was because he understood what Isshin was trying to say .

A faultlessly good man, but his son killed himself –

Gotou didn't know if Seidou was the cause of it, but it was a fact that Seidou hadn't noticed that his son had been cornered to the point of suicide .

People's hearts changed . The person somebody knew was only one side of them .

– What do I know about Yakumo?

Gotou asked himself that .

Perhaps I think I know but actually don't understand anything at all –

17

After Haruka returned to her flat, she turned on her computer right away .

She opened an internet search and typed in 'spiritual phenomena' and 'Nishitama' .

There was a considerable number of hits .

There were personal sites about spiritual spots with maps and photos .

Haruka clicked each of them and glanced over them .

Though it was boring, simple work, she also knew that this was all she could do now .

– Where's Yakumo-kun now? What's he up to?

For just a moment, Haruka's hands stopped as she looked out the window .

The evening shower had probably cleared the clouds . She could see a bright fool moon .

– What if Yakumo really killed somebody?

With no preamble, that question came up in her head . No, that wasn't true . The truth was that it had been in the back of her head, but she had tried not to think about it .

'I...'

She couldn't answer that right now .

As if pulling Haruka away from her negative thoughts, the mobile phone on the table started vibrating .

The number on the display was the newspaper reporter Hijikata Makoto's .

She had experienced many cases as well .

<Are you all right?>

The moment Haruka picked up, she heard Makoto's frantic voice .

'Yes, I...'

<OK . Yakumo-kun... is in quite the situation...>

'Excuse me... Has the information already got out?'

<Yes . Though the name was kept out, I know an officer at the scene saw a young man with a red left eye . >

That was Makoto the reporter for you . She was quick with information .

'I see...'

Haruka knew herself that she sounded depressed .

Yakumo killed somebody – though she didn't want to believe it, that information was spreading on its own .

People who didn't know the true Yakumo would just see the information and decide he was a murder . Haruka's chest hurt when she thought about

it .

– Yakumo isn't that kind of person!

Haruka wanted to yell, but that voice wouldn't carry to anyone no matter how much she did .

<Isn't there anything I can do?>

'Eh?'

<Let me help with something . >

Makoto's forceful words made Haruka happy .

When Haruka first met Makoto, she had seemed somewhat difficult to approach . Perhaps because of that, they hadn't talked very much .

However, that impression had changed after a number of cases .

Haruka didn't know if it was because Makoto had changed or because Haruka's thoughts had changed . However, it was an example of something that made her feel how human relationships changed .

'Is that all right?'

<Of course . Yakumo-kun's helped me a lot as well . Plus...>

Haruka heard Makoto breath out awkwardly .

'What is it?'

<I can't believe it either . >

'Can't believe it...'

<I can't . I can't believe Yakumo-kun would kill somebody . >

Haruka felt like Makoto's words saved her .

It wasn't just her . Other people believed in Yakumo too . Knowing that made Haruka happier than anything else .

At the same time, she felt how pathetic she was for being shaken earlier .

No matter what happened, she had to believe in Yakumo until the end . Haruka bit her lip and strengthened her feelings .

<Haruka-chan, you believe in Yakumo-kun too, right?>

'Of course . '

Haruka gave a forceful reply .

Now that she thought about it, there was no reason to doubt Yakumo .

She might have just been shaken by the flow of information and started to doubt Yakumo .

18

Gotou looked at the temple from his car, parked by the side of the road .

Like guards, two uniformed officers stood at the tiled roof of the temple gate . Gotou also saw a number of men in suits that looked like private detectives coming in and out .

That was foolish, even for me – Gotou cursed at himself .

He'd come all the way to the temple to search for Yakumo, but naturally, the police in the jurisdiction were here .

There was nothing he could do about it, but the problem was that he didn't have any plan now .

'What do you plan to do?' said Eishin with a grin .

He had probably sensed what Gotou was feeling . Gotou felt like Eishin was mocking him for being an idiot .

'Don't you have any ideas?'

Gotou turned the question around to Eishin .

'I was just forced here by you . '

– Damn, what a mean monk .

Gotou lay back on the seat with a click of his tongue .

It had always been Yakumo's job to think . Gotou just followed those instructions and charged .

'I have one suggestion...' said Eishin .

'What?'

'You might be able to hear the story from a trainee monk . '

– I see .

If he talked to a trainee monk at the temple, he might find out what happened between Yakumo and Seidou last night . But detectives from the Nishitama precinct were crawling around the temple .

'But we can't get in, right?'

'There's one walking around there . '

Eishin pointed out the window .

Gotou looked out and saw a young man with a shaved head walking in robes just beside the car .

– This is a chance .

'Oi, you . '

Gotou ran out of the car and called out to the man in robes .

The robed man leapt in surprise, but he stopped and timidly turned around .

'Y-yes?'

He had pale skin and was skinny, like a beansprout . He was fidgeting like he couldn't relax . It was just like Gotou was looking at Ishii .

'Police . I want to talk to you a bit . '

Gotou showed his police ID .

'I said all I know earlier...'

The robed young man seemed confused .

'Relax . This detective is my friend . '

Eishin got off the car and said that to the young man in robes .

'Master Eishin . '

The robed man put his hands together and bowed his head in awe .

'Oi . Are you some big shot?' said Gotou, surprised by the young man's sudden change in attitude .

The person who replied was not Eishin but the robed young man .

'Master Eishin is a man of exceptional virtue . '

'That so?'

Gotou couldn't believe it .

'Yes . Without being tied to a temple, he supervises all the temples in this area . He has a role similar to that of a counsellor . '

'Doesn't look like it . '

Gotou looked at Eishin's face .

He didn't know how the people at the temple viewed him, but to Gotou, Eishin just looked like a selfish monk .

Anyway, if what the young man said was true, Eishin would be of help at the temple . At first, Gotou had regretted taking him, thinking of Eishin as luggage, but he might be unexpectedly helpful .

Gotou got the robed young man to sit in the passenger seat, and then Gotou sat in the driver's seat while Eishin sat in the back so that they could listen to the young man talk .

The robed man was named Shuuei .

Gotou didn't know whether that was his real name or his monk name, but that wasn't the problem right now .

'How many people in the temple?' Gotou asked Shuuei to understand the situation .

'Normally, there are Master Seidou and myself . Hatsune-san makes three . '

'The number of people who want to become priests has dropped lately,' lamented Eishin .

It looked like few people wanted to be bound by the rules of the temple .

'Were you there last night?'

'Yes . '

'Was Yakumo really at the temple?'

Shuuei looked up with a start, like a kid blamed for a prank . His eyes were wet and looked like they would cry at any moment .

'Yes . '

'How was he?'

'How...'

Shuuei looked troubled as his brows furrowed together .

It seemed like he was troubled about whether to speak as his mouth flapped open and shut .

'He knows about Hatsune,' interrupted Eishin .

'I see...'

Shuuei's shoulders lowered as he relaxed .

'You haven't told the others why Yakumo came?'

'Ah, er... I was told to keep quiet about Hatsune-san, so... And the police wouldn't believe it, would they?'

It hurt to hear that .

Just as Shuuei said, the police wouldn't accept a story like reincarnation . Even if there were some who personally believed in it, it wouldn't have influenced the direction of the investigation .

'Then what did you say about Yakumo?'

'Er, I said that nephew of Master Seidou's friend came to play...'

– I see . He didn't lie .

'So how were the two of them?'

'Though I wasn't there directly, they discussed with Hatsune-san for a rather long time . '

'And after that?'

'When it became night, they said that they would go out, just the two of them . '

'About what time?'

'If I remember correctly... I think it was about ten,' replied Shuuei, his gaze wandering as he tried to remember .

'Where'd they go at a time like that?'

Gotou put the question that came to his head into words .

If they were in the city, they could have gone out for a drink to chat some more, but that was difficult to believe in the middle of the mountains .

'Though I don't know what they went to do, they said that they were going to the limestone cavern,' said Shuuei in a fading voice .

'I see...'

The two of them went to the limestone cavern late at night, and one of them became a corpse, stabbed all over . The more Gotou investigated, the more unfavourable the situation seemed for Yakumo .

'If I had stopped them then...'

Shuuei's voice wavered as he sniffled .

'Nothing will start if you regret the past,' Eishin said quietly .

'Were you the one who contacted the police?'

After the conversation had come to a still, Gotou asked another question .

'No . '

Shuuei shook his head .

That was probably true . Shuuei looked like the type who couldn't lie .

'Then who was it?'

'I don't...'

Shuuei hesitated . He wouldn't know . But –

'Did you leave things as is even though Seidou didn't come back?'

'Though I was concerned, that limestone cavern is also a meditation spot . In the past, he had gone there to meditate through the night, so...'

After Shuuei replied, Gotou looked at Eishin in the backseat . Gotou couldn't tell if the story was true .

'That happens sometimes . '

Eishin nodded, sensing Gotou's intention .

'I see . That was a great help . '

Gotou let Shuuei off the car, stretched out and leaned back on the seat .

'What will you do next?' said Eishin, leaning forward from the backseat .

He didn't seem concerned at all, as usual . It was like he was enjoying the situation .

To be honest, Gotou couldn't think of a concrete plan . He wasn't Yakumo, but at a time like this, for now –

'I'll go to the scene of the crime . '

19

Yakumo finally got out of the forest .

He arrived at the bank of a smile lake .

It was probably about a hundred metres to the opposite bank . Weeds grew rampant – it appeared to be a place iwth few visitors .

The shining moon was reflected on the water's surface .

– I was killed and sunk into the lake .

The words of the girl called Hatsune flashed through Yakumo's mind .

Hatsune said that she was killed by somebody before she was born and that she sank into a lake by a tree with red flowers .

Yakumo looked around and spotted a tree with red flowers . It was probably crape myrtle .

It was likely that this was the lake Hatsune had mentioned .

If the location information he'd heard from Seidou was correct, this lake was about three kilometres direct from the temple .

After falling in the limestone cavern, he had taken a long detour, but it seemed like he would be able to get to the temple soon .

Perhaps because he relaxed, his body suddenly felt heavier .

Yakumo spotted a rock nearby and sat down on it .

His muscles were screaming after walking down mountain paths that he was unaccustomed to . Dragging his injured left leg had also been a heavy burden .

Furthermore, he hadn't eaten anything since last night .

He was terribly hungry – it felt like his stomach was twisted .

– I'm exhausted .

Yakumo hung his head .

All he could hear was the sound of the wind and insects .

– It's quiet here .

He shut his eyes and let out a deep breath . Then, a sleeping memory came back to him .

A memory from when he visited Seidou's temple yesterday evening .

Yakumo walked into the temple together with Seidou . There was tatami there with a statue of the Buddha at the entrance .

It was an incredibly strange situation .

Zen Buddhism did not acknowledge the existence of spirits . The soul and body were one; they were not to be separated .

They also believed that if one focussed on life, that would create worldly thoughts, becoming an obstruction to religion .

In such a Zen Buddhist temple, he, who could see the spirits of the dead, was standing to solve an incident regarding reincarnation .

Yakumo was smiling self-derisively when his eyes met those of a girl standing in the corner of the temple .

That was Hatsune .

A girl with glossy black hair . Her face was somewhat reminiscent of Nao's .

However, there was something decisively different .

– She's hollow .

Yakumo felt that the first time he saw her .

Not her appearance, but her heart .

She was as expressionless as a manmade doll . He couldn't tell where her round eyes were looking .

'You are?'

Yakumo bent over to ask Hatsune that .

'Hatsune . But before, I was Minami,' said Hatsune expressionlessly .

There was no ill will there . It felt like she believed that wholly .

'Which should I call you?'

'Whichever you want . I mean, both are me . '

Hatsune smiled awkwardly .

'I see . Then, Hatsune-chan, where is your mother right now?'

Yakumo stared at Hatsune's large black eyes .

The answer to that question was –

'Damn it . I can't remember . '

Yakumo said that aloud and ran a hand through his hair .

He lifted his head in resignation, but then he saw a girl in front of him .

Lit up by the moonlight, she glared at him from below the crape myrtle tree .

She had on a uniform of a knee-high skirt and a blazer – the same girl he'd seen in the limestone cavern .

– She knows something .

Yakumo stood up while pressing a hand against his hurting left leg .
Dragging his heavy body forward, he started to walk towards the girl .

The distance of about ten metres felt considerably long .

'Who are you?' said Yakumo after walking up to the girl .

– I won't forgive you . Absolutely not .

The girl's dry purple lips moved as she said that in a voice that echoed to the bottom of his stomach .

It was a voice trembling with hatred .

It was almost as if a black flame of hatred had engulfed the girl's surroundings .

Yakumo felt a chill .

A strong hatred that had still not dissipated after death . Yakumo didn't know how to soothe feelings this strong .

– I won't forgive you .

The girl said that again and then disappeared into the darkness .

20

Ishii groaned as he looked at the computer monitor .

Though he'd declared to Haruka that he would investigate the past cases, he didn't know where to start, to be honest .

It would have been fine if it were just murder cases, but including accidents and suicides greatly increased the number of documents . Furthermore, they didn't have a set time . It was like looking for a needle that had fallen in the desert .

'Hah...'

Ishii had just let out a sigh when he heard a knock on the door .

'Please come in . '

Ishii had thought it would be Miyagawa, but the person who opened the door and came in was Youko .

'Ah!'

Ishii stood up at the unexpected arrival .

'There's something I want to ask you . '

Youko walked over briskly and sat in Gotou's seat, opposite Ishii .

'If it's something I can answer...' replied Ishii, readying himself . To be honest, there were some things he could say and some things he couldn't .

'Who is Saitou Yakumo?'

'Eh?'

The question was so sudden that Ishii didn't understand .

'I've looked into him . '

'Which means...'

Ishii looked at Youko's face .

He tried to see her true intentions, but all he could see through his glasses was Youko's cold and expressionless face .

'it appears he's stuck his nose into a number of cases . '

'I-is that so?'

Why does Youko know that – though Ishii had that question, he played dumb .

When Ishii wrote work reports, he had done his best never to mention Yakumo's name – it was an ordeal every time . That meant there was no way Yakumo's name would come up in the cases .

'Don't play dumb . Most of the people at the precinct here know his name . There's a whole rumour about how he's the one solving all the cases . '

Youko said that all at once . Perhaps because she was agitated, her cheeks were a bit red .

Even if Ishii hid it in the documents and he and Gotou kept quiet, Yakumo showed up at the scene so often that it was natural for the other investigation members to suspect something .

However, he still didn't know how to explain Yakumo .

'Is it true that he can... er, see them?'

Youko glanced at Ishii awkwardly .

So the rumour's that wide – while Ishii was surprised, he came to a decision .

'Yes . Yakumo-shi can see the spirits of the dead – that is, he can see ghosts . '

'Please don't be ridiculous . There's no such thing as ghosts, right?'

Youko spread her hands in an exaggerated appeal .

Perhaps she wanted him to deny it . People didn't believe things they didn't experience themselves .

'There are,' Ishii said firmly .

'Do you have proof?'

'He has always led us to case's solution . Those cases are proof . '

'Are you saying that the cases were solved because he could see ghosts?'

Though Youko was acting tough, her heart was unsteady . Ishii could see that easily .

'I am . Yakumo-shi hears the spirits of the dead and solves the mystery behind the case as a result . '

'Even if that were true, why did he kill somebody this time?' said Youko, tapping the desk with her finger .

'I don't know . That's why I'm investigating . '

'You think Saitou Yakumo's not the culprit?'

Youko's eyes narrowed .

Ishii couldn't reply to that question immediately . The reason being –

'I don't know . '

Ishii shook his head .

The doubt within Ishii hadn't left him .

Did Yakumo kill somebody, or –

21

Yakumo stared at the lake where the girl disappeared for a while, but then he turned around, suddenly having the unpleasant feeling that somebody was watching him .

His eyes met a gaze within the grass .

The two eyes, lit up by moonlight, were dyed a deep red .

Yakumo swallowed .

A speckled pattern, a triangular head . It stuck out a brown tongue as its tail went back and forth .

– A pit viper .

'This is bad . '

Yakumo regretted entering the thicket carelessly .

Pit vipers were a venomous snake common in Japan .

The venom of the pit viper was a haemotoxin which destroyed the tissues, blood and blood vessels within the body . Since it caused internal bleeding, there would be intense pain in the affected area . It could also cause fever and confusion .

A number of deaths had been reported before as well .

– I can't be bitten .

Yakumo regulated his breathing and stepped back, trying to avoid making any sound .

Crack .

He'd stepped on a tree branch .

Yakumo turned around, startled by the sound . Then, the pit viper bared its fangs and attacked .

Yakumo leapt back, but his injured left leg wouldn't move the way he wanted to . He staggered .

The pit viper's fangs sank into his left leg .

As Yakumo fell to the ground, he grabbed a tree branch and brought it down on the pit viper's head .

It hit .

The pit viper separated from Yakumo's leg immediately and disappeared into the thicket .

'Damn it . '

Yakumo took off his belt, wrapped it around his left thigh and bound it tightly .

It was to avoid letting the poison spread . However, if he bound it too tightly, it would interrupt the blood flow, speeding up the necrosis of his tissue from lack of oxygen .

He would have to regularly loosen the belt to allow blood to flow .

Yakumo rolled up his jeans to check on the injury .

There were two small red dots a bit above his ankle . Fortunately, because of his jeans, they didn't appear to be too deep .

Putting your lips to a snake bite to suck out the poison wouldn't reverse the effects .

On top of likely infection, bacteria such as those from tooth decay could invade .

All he could do now was wait .

Even if he started to walk to a hospital, he didn't know where there was one . Even if he did, it would have been very far .

If he moved, it would quicken his heartbeat, spread the poison more quickly and worsen his physical state .

Most importantly, going to a hospital would be going to get caught by the police himself .

Yakumo crawled to a nearby rock, stretched out his legs and sat, resting his back against it .

The symptoms from the pit viper's venom would show up in twenty to thirty minutes .

With exhaustion and an empty stomach, he didn't know how much he would be able to resist, but all he could do was wait .

Yakumo looked up at the shining round moon .

When he looked at the captivating pale moon, he felt himself calm down .

– I might die .

A feeling close to resignation spread throughout Yakumo .

– I wonder where I'll go when I die .

Yakumo could see the spirits of the dead . However, those were only the spirits who had unfinished business and were remaining in this world .
Yakumo didn't know where spirits without unfinished business went .

Now that he thought about it, it was an unfortunate fate .

It felt like he'd been fighting against the current all this time .

All he had experienced from that was a great amount of sadness .

However, he had no regrets . The reason being –

If he had just one wish, before he died, just once more –

I wish I could have seen her again –

22

'Oi . How long does this slope go?'

Gotou called out to Eishin's back as they climbed up the slope .

He'd thought that they'd be able to get to the limestone cavern by car, but the asphalt-paved road had stopped . After that, he'd had to walk through the weedy path with a torch in hand .

He was out of breath . Even his underwear was soaked with sweat .

'Don't whine . It's only a bit more . '

Even though Eishin was fat, he walked with incredibly light footsteps as he climbed the slope .

They'd had this exchange a number of times already, but it had already been twenty minutes . Gotou thought he would die from exhaustion .

'Let's take a short break . '

'I said, it's only a bit more . '

'I know . '

Gotou took off his tie, unbuttoned down to the third button of his shirt and then started walking more quickly .

'See? We're here . '

Right after that, Eishin stopped . Gotou stood next to Eishin .

There was a craggy rock mountain with a black hole in its middle .

On both sides of the entrance, there were two uniformed guards .

It looked like they'd noticed them, as they came towards them with the light of a torch .

'I'm Gotou of the Setamachi precinct . '

Gotou showed his police ID .

'Setamachi precinct?' said an officer . What's a detective out of his jurisdiction doing here? That question was written on his face .

He looked incredibly serious – inflexible . However, Gotou was used to dealing with people like this .

'The person of interest is in my jurisdiction . I was instructed to check on the situation . '

'At this time?'

'Since when've the police worked at a set time? If there's a case, the time shouldn't matter . '

'Ah, no...'

Gotou's sudden forcefulness startled the officer .

'Or does your precinct stop investigating once time's up? Who's in charge here? I'll beat them into shape . '

'P-please forgive me . G-go ahead . '

The officer looked ashamed as he replied, spine pencil-straight, but he gave Eishin a glance .

'This is Master Eishin, friend of the victim . He's coming in with me – you don't mind, right?'

'Please go ahead . '

Gotou casually walked towards the limestone cavern's entrance .

'So you can do it if you try . '

Eishin slapped Gotou's back while grinning .

Even though Gotou was being praised, for some reason, he couldn't be honestly happy about it .

'Stop talking – let's go . '

Gotou walked into the limestone cavern with Eishin at his side .

– It's cold .

Cold air enveloped him, like he had walked into a refrigerator .

It was probably because light didn't come in from outside . It was pitch black . He couldn't see anything that wasn't lit up with the torch .

Drip, drip . He could hear water falling .

'Quite a guy to think of meditating here,' said Gotou as he took careful steps .

'He was a zealous and serious man . '

'Unlike you?'

When Gotou said that, something pushed his back .

Gotou slipped and almost fell, but he managed to avoid that by grabbing a nearby rock .

'What the hell are you doing!?'

'If you yell so loudly, you'll fall again,' said Eishin as he stifled his chuckled .

– I can't let my guard down .

'I don't like meditating in places like this,' said Eishin, suddenly stopping .

'You afraid?'

'Don't be ridiculous . It's a problem of thinking . '

'Thinking?'

'Meditation must be done in the middle of life . Walking all the way to a place like this to meditate isn't meditation . '

Eishin had his hands together and eyes half-closed – he looked solemn, as if his arrogance and laziness up until now had all been a lie .

However, admitting that would irritate Gotou .

'Forget about the pretentious talk and hurry up . '

Gotou walked briskly into the depths of the limestone cavern .

After about five minutes, there was a wide space . One corner appeared to be a room surrounded by boards . That was probably where the crime occurred .

Gotou stood in front of the door to the room .

There were lights there, probably from the investigation team . Gotou flipped the switch . The bright light disoriented him .

Just as his eyes had grown accustomed to the light, he slowly opened the door .

A raw smell pierced his nose .

'That's an amazing stink . '

Eishin coughed .

Gotou covered his mouth and nose with his arm and walked inside the room .

Creak .

Every time he took a step, the floor creaked .

Gotou turned the light of his torch towards the ground and suddenly saw a dark red stain . This was probably where Seidou was killed .

Gotou bent over and looked carefully .

The floor looked like they had been scratched with fingernails . This was where he had been trying to run away but was stabbed more .

Not just the floor . Gotou spotted blood sprayed on the walls too .

It was much more brutal than he had imagined .

'This is awful,' murmured Eishin .

'Agreed . '

Gotou sighed .

The culprit had repeatedly stabbed somebody trying to get away . Did they enjoy seeing him in pain? Or had they continued to stab because they were so absorbed they couldn't stop?

Whichever one it was, it gave Gotou a chill just imagining it .

'So what are you going to do now?' said Eishin, crossing his arms .

Gotou had thought he'd be able to find something out by coming to the scene, but it looked like things weren't going to be that easy .

However, he couldn't just wait because there weren't any leads .

'I'll go over everything with a fine-tooth comb . '

Unfortunately, that was the only method he had right now .

Eishin shook his head, looking exasperated .

23

– I'm losing consciousness .

Yakumo's head hung because he was unable to keep his neck straight .

His body felt hot . A burning pain ran through his left leg and had near doubled in size .

The ground was moving, as if Yakumo had just been rolling his eyes about . The pit viper's venom was eating away at his body .

He consciously breathed slowly .

He put his left hand up in front of his eyes . He couldn't focus . He saw doubles of his fingers .

– This is no good . I have no strength .

His left hand felt as heavy as a way . Unable to keep it up, it fell back to the floor .

He wanted to vomit . It felt like something was stirring up his stomach .

– Am I going to die?

Yakumo lifted his head with the last of his strength .

Standing there was a man . He had on a black suit with long hair that went down his back . He smiled triumphantly .

His eyes were dyed a deep red .

'A pathetic ending...' the man said expressionlessly .

That might have been true . Without anybody watching, rotting away all alone at the edge of a lake – d

'Says a dead man . '

Yakumo gritted his teeth and glared at the man with two red eyes .

He was already died . He was just a spirit .

'How about it? Won't you come with me?'

The man held a hand out towards Yakumo .

– Where to?

Yakumo didn't know the destination, but if he took that hand, he felt like he would be released from his suffering .

'I'm waiting . '

The man disappeared into the darkness with a faint smile on his face .

– Where are you waiting?

Before Yakumo had that answer, he saw the back of a woman standing by the lake .

He thought it was the spirit of the girl from earlier, but he was wrong .

When she turned around, he saw it was Haruka .

'You...'

Yakumo's expression relaxed .

Haruka didn't say anything . Her brows were furrowed, like she was troubled, as she looked at Yakumo .

'Don't look like that... Is it trouble again?'

Haruka shook her head . There was a trace of tears in her eyes .

Yakumo hated seeing Haruka cry .

At first, he had thought it was because he was irritated, but then he noticed that wasn't the case .

'Smile for me...'

When he saw Haruka's smile, he felt the dregs in his heart wash away .

It made him feel idiotic for worrying . He felt like it said it was all right for him to be here – all right for him to live .

I should have died when my mother tried to kill me – he had always thought that .

He wasn't needed by anyway .

He hadn't ever thought that somebody would smile when they saw his red left eye .

Though Yakumo coldly thrust her away, in the depths of his heart, he was thankful that he had been able to see that smile again .

He should have talked to her properly .

The truth was there were other things he wanted to talk to her about . He wanted her to know him . And he wanted to know her .

– My eyes are blurry .

Haruka melted into the darkness .

– Don't disappear .

With all his might, Yakumo reached out, but his hand didn't reach her .

Just as Yakumo was stricken by his powerlessness, a man appeared .

A man with a smile like Maitreya . It was Isshin .

– Uncle .

Isshin made no reply . He just smiled .

– That's right . Uncle always smiled for me too .

No matter how hateful the things Yakumo said to him, Isshin had smiled and accepted them all .

– Why did you go?

What Uncle said was always correct, but I didn't try to accept them honestly .

But still, Uncle stayed with me .

He always welcomed me with a smile .

– Thank you .

I could never say the words I wanted to tell him most, even at the end .

I see . Uncle's here to take me with him .

I have a lot I want to talk to him about .

I'll be there soon, so listen to what I have to say .

I –

Yakumo's hazy consciousness fell into a deep darkness .

Volume 8 Chapter 2: VOLUME 8 – THE VANISHED SPIRIT

Chapter 2

VOLUME 8 – THE VANISHED SPIRIT

file 02: escape (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

– Where is this?

Haruka stood up on the wooden floor in her bare feet .

There were candleholders in the four corners of the room . The small flames of the candles flickered .

It appeared to be a temple .

– Why am I here?

As if to answer Haruka's question, a dark shadow walked in front of Haruka . It was somebody Haruka knew well .

‘Yakumo-kun, where did you go? I was worried . ’

Yakumo didn't reply .

The muscles in his face were flaccid and his eyes weren't focussed . His fingers occasionally twitched .

He looked a bit strange .

'Hey . Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka called out once more . Then, Yakumo suddenly started laughing aloud .

He clutched his stomach as he convulsed with laughter .

'What's so funny?' Haruka said at last, though she was confused .

Yakumo suddenly stopped .

'What's so funny, you say?'

Still smiling, Yakumo held up a knife in front of Haruka's eyes .

The knife, coldly glinting, was dyed red . Blood dripped from its tip .

'Yakumo-kun... right?'

'That's right . I've finally realised my true nature . '

'True nature?'

Haruka stepped back .

Yakumo took a step closer as if to chase her .

'That's right . Killing people... is fun . '

'You're lying . '

'Want to test me?'

Yakumo licked his lips .

Before Haruka noticed, his two eyes were dyed a deep red .

'Stop!'

Haruka sat straight up .

She opened her eyes not in a temple but her own room . It looked like she'd fallen asleep on the table .

– That was a dream .

'Thank goodness . '

Haruka heaved a sigh of relief and looked at the clock .

It was just past four in the morning . This wasn't the time to sleep . She rubbed her eyes and looked back at her computer monitor when she felt somebody's presence .

– Somebody's here .

When Haruka turned around, she saw somebody sitting against the wall .

'Aah!'

Haruka leapt up .

The person sitting there with his head hung slowly lifted his head .

'Yakumo-kun!' exclaimed Haruka, her eyes wide .

There was no doubt about it . It was Yakumo .

His skin was so pale and his lips so dry and purple that it made her doubt he was alive .

His white shirt was covered in dirt and the left leg of his jeans was stained with blood .

'Why are you here...' said Yakumo in a hoarse voice .

'Why...'

That was what Haruka wanted to ask .

But this wasn't the time for that . Anyway, she had to bring Yakumo to a hospital to fix his horrible condition .

'I ran here from the limestone cavern...'

'Tell me later . Anyway, I'll call an ambulance . '

Haruka took the mobile on the table in her hand .

'Then I went to the lake... Red flowers bloomed...'

Yakumo was talking deliriously .

'Lake?'

'I see... I'm... already dead...'

'Don't say something so stupid!'

'It's fine... I got to see you... in the end...'

As he spoke, Yakumo's shadow became gradually fainter and finally disappeared, as if he had melted into the room .

'Yakumo-kun? Hey, where are you?'

Haruka called out frantically, but Yakumo made no reply –

2

– So noisy .

Gotou woke up to the ringing of his mobile phone .

He'd gone round looking for Yakumo, but he couldn't find him . He hadn't thought it'd be so easy, but he still felt tired and disappointed .

He had planned on taking a break by sitting in the car's driver seat, but then he had fallen asleep .

In the passenger's seat, Eishin was sleeping while snoring loudly .

Unlike Gotou, who had searched for Yakumo frantically, Eishin had returned to the car soon after and fallen asleep after saying, 'There's no way we'll find him when it's this dark . '

Gotou looked at his wristwatch . It was just past four in the morning .

– Who's calling at this time?

'Gotou speaking . '

Gotou answered the phone while rubbing his eyes .

<Yakumo-kun came!>

He heard Haruka's hysterical voice on the other end of the phone .

The way she was so agitated wasn't normal .

'What about Yakumo?'

<I said he came! Just earlier! In an awful condition!>

'Calm down a bit . Explain what you're talking about . '

Gotou sat up and tried to calm Haruka down by speaking slowly .

Finally, it seemed like Haruka had regained her calm . He heard her take deep breaths .

<Earlier, Yakumo-kun came to my room...>

Haruka spoke in a hoarse voice .

'W-what?'

– He went back to Haruka?

It was possible . It irritated Gotou that Yakumo did that without contacting anyone, but he didn't care as long as he was fine .

'So Yakumo's there now?'

If possible, Gotou wanted to talk to him . There was a mountain of things he wanted to ask .

<;He... vanished...>

'Vanished?'

<Yes . Just like... smoke...>

'Weren't your eyes just playing tricks on you?'

<That's impossible!>

Haruka yelled loudly .

It was true that Haruka for one wouldn't mistake somebody for Yakumo, but –

'He vanished, right?'

<That might have been Yakumo-kun's spirit... Yakumo-kun might already...>

Gotou could hear Haruka start to sob .

A heat close to anger started boiling up within Gotou's stomach .

'Yakumo-kun won't die!' he yelled, overcome by his emotion .

– Don't screw with me . Yakumo died and went to see Haruka?

It wasn't that Gotou was angry at Haruka, but he didn't want to believe it .
That guy wouldn't die so easily .

<But...>

'I'm saying he won't die! So he won't die!'

<That's right . >

Though it was in a tear-filled voice, Haruka's reply was firm .

She had become panicked by the sudden event, but it looked like she'd come back to her senses .

She had really become stronger . That was the woman in Yakumo's heart for you .

'If you did see Yakumo's spirit, Haruka-chan, did he say anything that could be a lead?' Gotou said quickly .

<He said, 'Why are you here? '>

'Anything else . '

<He said he got to a lake...>

'Lake?'

<And that red flowers bloomed...>

'Red flowers . '

'There's a lake nearby . '

Eishin had woken up at some point and he spoke from the passenger seat .

He had probably heard their conversation .

'Really?'

'Yeah . The red flowers are probably crape myrtle . '

Eishin let out a big yawn as he leant back . It seemed like he didn't realise the importance of his words .

'Where?'

'I said it at the beginning, right? There's a lake near the temple where a woman's screams...'

He had said that .

That was when Gotou had heard about the reincarnation of the girl called Hatsune . He'd completely forgotten because of everything that had happened .

But that was a place with spiritual connections .

'Can you go to that lake from the limestone cavern?'

'There's a path through the cavern . If you go along the river from there, you'll get to the lake . '

A path through the cavern – that was the first Gotou had heard of it .

Maybe . Just maybe . But this old man was too laidback .

'You should say that from the beginning!'

'You didn't ask,' said Eishin without any shame .

– Are you Yakumo!?

Gotou bit back the urge to retort and sighed .

<... Gotou-san, did you realise something?>

Haruka's anxious voice came from the phone .

'I'll go to the lake near the temple . '

<I'll also...>

'No . There's no time to go pick you up . '

<I understand . >

Haruka accepted it straightforwardly without fighting back .

'I'll call you later . '

<Gotou-san . >

Just as Gotou was about to turn on the car engine, Haruka spoke .

'What?'

<Please absolutely bring Yakumo-kun back . >

Though Haruka spoke firmly, Gotou felt like there was a tremor there .

To be honest, he couldn't make that irresponsible promise . But –

'I promise . '

<Thank you . >

Gotou hung up and started the car .

3

Ishii turned around at the sound of the door opening .

Youko came into the room . She had a number of files in her arms .

'That was quick .

Youko didn't reply to Ishii's words .

She mechanically placed the files on Ishii's desk and then sighed, covering her face with her hands .

'If the higher-ups knew I was helping out with things like this, it'd be quite a problem . ' Youko glared at Ishii while propping her chin up in her hand .

Last night, Ishii had told Youko about the cases Yakumo had been involved in in the past .

It had been a long conversation .

At first, Youko had laughed scornfully, thinking it was ridiculous, but as Ishii continued to talk with fervour, her expression changed .

Then, with this case as the background, Ishii talked about how Yakumo had received a request to investigate a spiritual phenomenon related to reincarnation .

Youko had said she didn't need Ishii's cooperation, but that thinking had turned one hundred and eighty degrees .

She probably thought that solving the mystery behind the reincarnation story would be necessary to solve the case .

However, Ishii felt divided .

It was because he wasn't confident that the method they had chosen was correct . And his suspicion about Yakumo was still smoking inside of him .

– Perhaps Yakumo really did kill him .

'I'm sorry . '

Ishii bowed his head, feeling apologetic in a number of meanings .

It looked like Youko didn't like his attitude, because she waved her hand like she was swatting a fly and looked away .

'Then what are we doing next?' said Youko, tapping the files on top of the desk with her finger .

Ishii had asked Youko to take the files about murders, accidents, suicides and disappearances that had the name Minami in them from the Nishitama precinct .

Minami was the name that Hatsune, who said she was a reincarnation, claimed she had in her previous life .

'We're going to look for something like it in these files . '

'Something like it?'

'Yes, something like it . '

'Can't you explain more properly?'

It looked like his explanation had been too vague . Youko tapped the desk loudly in her irritation .

When she acted like this, she was somewhat like Gotou .

'That's right... Let's say people who might be Hatsune's mother...'

'Well, all right . We just have to look for something like it, right?' said Youko, sounding exasperated, but she took the files in hand and started flipping through them . Ishii started the same work, but his hands suddenly stopped .

'Excuse me...'

'What?'

Youko's brows furrowed in irritation .

'Why do you feel like helping now?'

'You said this, right? Though Saitou Yakumo is being chased by the police, he should be chasing the reincarnation mystery . If I chase that mystery as well, I'll reach him . '

Just as Youko said, Ishii had said that last night . But –

'Is that all?'

Ishii leant forward .

Though Youko usually had good enunciation, she looked troubled .

'... I have a personal interest . '

'Interest?'

'He can see them, right... Er, ghosts...'

It looked like it was difficult for Youko to say .

'Ah, yes . '

'I've seen them once too,' said Youko in a low tone as she narrowed her eyes .

'I see...'

Ishii understood now .

Normally, even if he said that Yakumo could see ghosts, people wouldn't believe it, but Youko had seen ghosts herself, so she believed what Ishii said .

'What sort of ghost was it?'

'What a strange question . '

Youko smiled, seeming exasperated .

So she can make this sort of expression too – it made Ishii a bit happy .

'Is it...'

'It is . You're strange . '

'Strange?'

Ishii didn't think he was different from other people . He was just a regular old useless guy .

'Yes . How should I put it...'

Though Youko started to speak, she looked down awkwardly and shook her head .

'What is it?'

'It's nothing . '

'Why not tell me? Please do . '

He couldn't help but be curious now that she had said that much . Ishii pressed further .

'I don't know how to say it, but I think you're unsuited for detective work .
,

'Unsuited?'

'Yes . You're too pure . '

'Eh...'

Ishii made a vague reply .

– Too pure .

He had been told the same thing countless times before, but Ishii didn't know what part of him was supposed to be pure .

'Anyway, the ghost story,' said Youko, changing the subject .

'Ah, that's right . What sort of ghost did you see?'

'The ghost of my dead lover . '

'Eh?'

Ishii swallowed .

The regret he felt about asking spread through his chest .

Though it was just his own imaginings, he had thought that the ghost Youko had seen would have been something like a scary story .

'Though it seemed like that person was appealing to me for something, I couldn't hear that voice...'

'Is that so...'

Ishii almost asked why that person had died, but he didn't have the courage .

Youko probably wanted to meet that lover of hers again and hear those words .

That was why she was helping to look for Yakumo .

Just as the atmosphere had gotten a bit solemn, Youko's mobile rang .

'Yes, Natsume speaking . '

When Youko answered, she stood up and moved to the corner of the room .

Though Ishii couldn't hear the conversation, he saw her expression stiffen in a flash and knew how serious it was .

'I'll do the rest myself . '

Youko said that quickly and hung up . Then, she tried to leave the room .

'Did something happen?'

Ishii stood up immediately and followed Youko .

Youko put a hand on her chin and looked up at the ceiling . It looked like she wasn't sure whether she should talk about it .

'The information will come in soon enough,' Ishii said, giving it a try .

'Another corpse was found . '

'Eh?'

'It's unknown yet whether it's related to this case . '

'Do you know the identity?'

'I can't say anything else . '

Youko said just that and then briskly left the room .

– What on earth is happening?

Ishii wouldn't stand for being left behind in this situation .

He hurriedly ran after Youko .

– He fell .

4

Gotou stepped down hard on the pedal as he drove .

Haruka said she saw Yakumo . Normally, he'd have put it aside, thinking it was foolish, but he didn't feel like that right now .

He didn't have any other leads anyway, so all he could do was charge there now .

There was a sharp curve, but Gotou just turned the wheel at the same speed .

He went right out into the other lane and the tires let out white smoke .

'You're going too quickly . '

Eishin sounded displeased about being thrown around by centrifugal force, but Gotou didn't have the time for him right now .

'Hold on tight . '

Gotou pressed down further on the accelerator .

Eishin grabbed the door handle so that he wouldn't be thrown about .

'You're being rash . '

'I have to be rash, or I wouldn't be able to keep up with Yakumo . '

Eishin snorted at Gotou's reply .

Though Eishin kept complaining, he looked like he was having fun .

'Here!' yelled Eishin, like he'd suddenly remembered something .

Gotou slammed on the brakes in response . His body slammed into the seatbelt from the impact .

'Can't you stop more quietly?'

'Then tell me earlier . '

'You were driving too quickly . '

– This old man never shuts up .

'So where is it?'

'Just up this slope . '

Eishin pointed at the weedy path that stretched along the side of the asphalt .

'Another trail?'

With a click of his tongue, Gotou opened the door and got off .

The sky was starting to grow light .

He passed through the grass and practically had to crawl as he went up the slope .

After about ten minutes, he saw a lake .

Since it was called a lake, he'd thought it would be bigger, but it was only a hundred metres at most to the opposite shore – more of a pond .

'Yakumo!'

He yelled from the bottom of his belly .

The voice just echoed back into his ears with no reply .

'Where are you!?! Yakumo! It's me! Gotou!'

Gotou kept yelling as he slowly walked around the lake .

'Oi! Yakumo!'

Though he kept yelling, no reply came back to him .

– Damn it! Where is he?

Gotou looked around frantically .

Red flowers came into his vision . That was probably the crape myrtle they'd talked about .

'Over there then?'

Gotou rushed there on an impulse .

He stopped in front of the crape myrtle tree, out of breath, when he saw something moving in the grass .

– A pit viper .

Gotou kicked a rock by his feet .

The viper slide away .

'Don't scare me . '

He had just wiped the sweat off his neck when he saw somebody's foot sticking out from behind a rock .

– Could it be?

Gotou ran over .

'Yakumo...'

There was no doubt about it . It was Yakumo .

He had his back against the rock and was sitting with both legs out . His arms hung at his side and his head hung limply as well .

'Oi! Yakumo! Hang in there!'

Gotou took Yakumo's face in his hands and pulled him up .

His skin was deathly pale . His body was considerably cold too .

– Don't screw with me . Did he really die?

'Yakumo, wake up!'

Gotou slapped Yakumo with an open hand .

However, he was as unresponsive as a doll .

'It looked like he was bitten by a pit viper . '

Eishin came over and said that as he pointed at Yakumo's left leg .

His jeans were rolled up to his thigh . The leg that stuck out was very swollen and there were two small injuries, as if pricked by a needle, in his shin .

'Pit viper?'

He should've bit off that pit viper earlier .

'He tightened his belt above the injury . As you can see, it looks like the bite isn't that deep . '

'Can he be saved?'

'I don't know . I can't tell how long it's been since he was bit . Anyway, we need to get him to a hospital right away . '

Gotou was about to reply when he remembered something .

'Yakumo's a fugitive . '

'So what?'

Eishin stood up with eyes wide open . He looked just like a demon .

'Well, the police...'

'Right now, Yakumo's life is the most important,' said Eishin, interrupting Gotou .

That was right . Gotou had been so upset he'd almost forgotten what was most crucial .

'Right . My bad . '

'I know a doctor near here . If I ask, the doctor probably won't report him to the police . '

Eishin's eyes narrowed back to his usual expression .

Despite what he said, Eishin seemed to be worried about Yakumo from the bottom of his heart . Gotou might have misjudged him .

'Right . Anyway, let's carry Yakumo . '

5

– She left .

Ishii returned to his desk alone .

He had run out after Youko, but he fell partway and was left behind . He felt like things like this just kept on happening this time .

'No, this isn't the time to feel depressed . '

Ishii hit both of his cheeks and took the files that Youko had brought into his hands for a change of pace .

– I'll look for something like it from these documents .

Now that he thought about it, it was vague . Though that hadn't been the words Youko used, he didn't know where to start .

'Oh, you're here?'

The door opened and in came Miyagawa .

He walked over with a bowlegged gait and sat down on the desk, but he didn't seem to have his usual pressure – or rather, ambition .

Like an old soldier tired of war .

'Were you still here?'

'It's been busy on my end of things too,' replied Miyagawa with no energy in his neck . It looked like his exhaustion had really piled up .

'Is that so...'

'Anyway, there's something I want to talk to you about . '

'Ah, yes . '

'Where's Gotou?' said Miyagawa, looking around the room .

'Ah, er, he hasn't yet...'

Ishii thought that he would be yelled at and pulled up his shoulders, but all that came back was a resigned 'That so' .

'Did something happen?'

'Got a report from forensics earlier . '

Miyagawa took a cigarette out of his pocket and lit up .

'Forensics...?'

Ishii took an ashtray from the desk drawer and placed it in front of Miyagawa .

Miyagawa took in a deep breath of smoke and waited a long while before beginning to speak .

'The fingerprints in the university clubroom that Yakumo lives in match the fingerprints on the knife left at the scene . '

'Eh?'

'Seems to be ninety-nine per cent accurate . '

'That's...'

Ishii felt like somebody had hit him in the head with a blunt object .

Even though he had suspected that Yakumo might have killed him in his heart, the shock was stronger than he had expected .

Ishii realised that he, like Gotou, had been certain that Yakumo would not kill somebody .

He might have just thought Yakumo could have been the culprit because of his feelings towards Haruka . That would have been better for him –

Ishii also knew what sort of person Yakumo really was .

Ishii didn't know how many times Yakumo had saved him . But he had forgotten his debt of gratitude and couldn't throw away the doubt that Yakumo had committed a murder from the corners of his heart because of his own terrible jealousy .

– I'm such a lowly person .

Ishii gripped his fists tightly and bit down the urge to scream .

'Jurisdiction will change Saitou Yakumo from a person of interest to a suspect . '

– Saitou Yakumo, suspect .

Ishii had never thought that Yakumo would be described that way .

'But at this stage, it's just that the fingerprints match, yes? Isn't it too early to make him a suspect?' said Ishii with a hopeful perspective .

Miyagawa shook his head forcefully .

'Besides the physical evidence, there's also eyewitness testimony . Plus, he ran away from the police himself . There's nothing that can be done now . '

'But...'

'That's all . I came to tell you guys to back off . '

Miyagawa looked at Ishii seriously .

It was a somewhat sad gaze .

'Back off?'

'Yeah . What happened so far is fine, but if you involve yourself with Yakumo any more, you'll be suspected without cause . I won't be able to stick up for you . '

What Miyagawa said made sense .

Now that Yakumo was a suspect, they would be suspected to be involved in the crime if they went in too deep . If they found out where Yakumo was and kept quiet, that would be aiding a fugitive .

Ishii knew that . But still, he couldn't reply with a 'Yes sir' .

'With all due deference to you, Chief Miyagawa, the possibility that Yakumo-shi has been falsely accused...'

'Don't say any more! I know that myself!'

Miyagawa's angry yell from the bottom of his stomach shook the room .

Though they had been brief, various emotions had been condensed in those words .

It wasn't only Gotou and Ishii who had worked with Yakumo . Miyagawa had gotten to know Yakumo as well through various cases .

Miyagawa himself thought that Yakumo wouldn't kill anybody .

However, he couldn't protect Gotou and Ishii any further .

He had forced everything he wanted to say to the bottom of his stomach and made himself to be the bad guy so as to push Gotou and Ishii away from the case .

'You guys don't want to handcuff Yakumo either, right?'

Miyagawa said just that and pressed his cigarette into the ashtray . Then, he left the room with slumped shoulders .

Ishii couldn't think of anything to say to that back .

– What should I do?

6

Haruka held on to her mobile tightly as she paced around the room .

She was irritated with herself for being unable to do anything at a time like this .

Just thinking about Yakumo's state made her chest hurt like it was being ripped apart .

– Please . Be safe .

All she could do was wish for that .

She felt that she was terribly small and unreliable .

'Yakumo-kun...'

Just by saying that name aloud, a number of emotions welled up within her, bringing her close to panic .

She placed the mobile on the table . By gripping the red stone on her necklace, she was somehow able to calm her emotions, which had been threatening to explode .

The intercom rang .

– Could it be?

With that thought, Haruka rushed to the monitor .

On the display was Gotou's wife, Atsuko, and her adopted daughter, Nao .

'I'll open up now . '

Haruka quickly unlocked the auto-lock at the entrance . After a while, the doorbell rang .

She opened the door immediately and welcomed Atsuko and Nao inside .

'Sorry for coming at this time, but I just couldn't sit still...' Atsuko said quietly .

'No . I don't want to be alone now either...'

'That's right . It's really quite the matter,' said Atsuko quietly .

'Yes . '

'My head's a mess . Even though this is such a serious affair, that person won't tell me anything . When he called home yesterday to say he wouldn't be coming back, finally... And he didn't explain the situation in detail either . He just told me to ask you, Haruka-chan... There's a limit to being irresponsible . '

Atsuko said that all at once in her agitation .

Though Haruka understood how she felt, Gotou must have been frantic as well . Currently, Haruka was also doing her best to search for Yakumo – she hadn't thought to contact Atsuko and Nao .

'Haruka-chan, are you all right?'

Atsuko put her hand on Haruka's shoulder .

Haruka felt like everything that she had been holding in came loose .

She wanted to just cling to Atsuko and cry, but then Nao jumped in front of Haruka .

She buried her face in Haruka's chest and started to sob .

Haruka hugged Nao tightly .

'It's all right,' Haruka said, rubbing Nao's back gently .

It was mysterious . Though Haruka had been the one about to collapse just earlier, when she took in Nao's sobs like this, she felt her heart naturally calm down .

– I need to be more reliable .

It made her feel that way .

'Yakumo-kun hasn't...?' said Atsuko after things had calmed down .

'Gotou-san is going to search for him now . '

'I see . If he doesn't find him, feel free to hit him . I give my permission,' said Atsuko jokingly .

'It's fine . Gotou-san will definitely find him . Right, Nao-chan?'

Haruka pat Nao's glossy hair .

Nao, who couldn't hear, had no way to understand Haruka's words . But it seemed like Haruka's meaning had come across, as Nao nodded with her head still buried in Haruka's chest .

– Yakumo . Come back soon .

7

The hospital was about fifteen minutes from the lake .

It was a small one-storey town clinic .

Gotou parked at the front entrance . Gotou took Yakumo's head and Eishin his feet . They went into the clinic and placed Yakumo on the bench in the waiting room .

Since Eishin had contacted ahead of time, the examination room was open, but it was still early, so there were no other patients .

After Eishin set Yakumo down, he went right into the examination room .

'Yakumo . Hang in there . '

Gotou called out to him frantically .

But Yakumo didn't wake up .

– I'm begging you . Don't die .

Gotou prayed as he gripped Yakumo's hand tightly .

Doing that wouldn't make Yakumo get better sooner . He knew that .

There are things people realise for the first time when they lose something .

Gotou had thought of him as a damn impudent brat who always said hateful things, but at some point, Yakumo had become like family to him .

It became natural for him to be there – if he disappeared, Gotou would be troubled .

Like his wife Atsuko and his daughter Nao, Gotou would protect Yakumo even if he lost his own life in the process .

'The doctor will see him now . We have to carry him to the examination room . '

When Eishin hit Gotou's shoulder, he came back to reality .

'Right,' responded Gotou immediately . Then, they carried Yakumo to the examination room .

After they placed Yakumo on the bed in the examination room, an old man with a hunched back and white hair hobbled over .

He was somewhat like the coroner, Hata .

'This is Nakamoto-san . My old friend . '

Eishin gave a simple introduction .

Gotou was about to introduce himself, but Nakamoto started to examine Yakumo, saying 'Let's see' like he wasn't interested in pleasantries .

'It looked like he was bit by a pit viper,' said Eishin, crossing his arms .

'A pit viper... when?'

Nakamoto's eyes went wide .

'We don't know exactly, but we think it was a while back . '

'Bring me the serum immediately . '

Nakamoto instructed the nearby middle-aged nurse .

She looked a bit surprised and stood there with a blank expression for a while, but when Nakamoto urged her – 'Hurry' – she rushed out of the examination room .

Nakamoto looked at the injury with a penlight and checked Yakumo's pupils, but then he sighed deeply .

'Can you save Yakumo?' Gotou pressed .

'I don't know yet . '

'What do you mean, you don't know! You're going to save him!'

Gotou's emotions boiled over and he grabbed the collar of Nakamoto's gown .

However, Nakamoto just looked up at Gotou like he had seen something unpleasant .

'Eishin . Take this idiot outside . '

'W-what!?' yelled Gotou .

Eishin held Gotou from behind .

Gotou tried to fight, but Eishin was stronger than he had been expected and so Gotou was dragged out of the examination room .

'Calm down, idiot,' said Eishin, like he was rebuking a child .

'How could I calm down?'

'Will your yelling make Yakumo get better?'

Gotou gritted his back teeth .

He knew that even without hearing a lecture from a monk .

'Anyway, you wait there . '

Eishin pushed Gotou to sit down on the bench in the waiting room and returned to the examination room .

All Gotou could do was glare at the door, which slammed shut .

'Damn it!'

Gotou's yell echoed through the waiting room .

He was so angry he wanted to punch somebody with all his might . Just as he put his fists down on his lap, his mobile phone rang .

When he checked the display, he saw that it was from Ishii .

'What do you want?'

Gotou answered the phone with evident irritation .

<D-Detective Gotou, it's t-terrible . >

Ishii's faltering voice made Gotou even angrier . If Ishii had been in front of him, he would have smacked his fist into his head .

'Talk already . '

<Ah, yes sir . Actually, Chief Miyagawa told me this information earlier...>

'Like I said, what?'

<Yakumo-shi's fingerprints match the ones on the knife . >

'What!?'

Gotou stood up without thinking .

Matching fingerprints was positive evidence . It looked like Yakumo had definitely held the knife .

<The Nishitama precinct is going to change Yakumo-shi from a person of interest to a suspect . >

'Don't joke with me . '

As Gotou muttered that, his eyes landed on the news on the television in the waiting room .

A horse-faced male reporter stood in front of the Nishitama precinct's entrance and spoke in a rushed manner towards the cameras .

<Just now, according to the information we received, the Nishitama precinct has concluded that city university student, Saitou Yakumo, is the

suspect...>

As if to interrupt the reporter's words, a picture of Yakumo appeared on the screen .

It was probably the photo from his student ID or something like it . He had a white shirt on and a composed expression on his face .

It was probably from when he still wore his black contact lens . Gotou couldn't see Yakumo's red left eye .

<Detective Gotou?>

Gotou heard Ishii call out to him from the other end of the phone .

'I can hear you . I'm looking at the news right now . '

<And there was one more piece of news . >

'What?'

<Another corpse was found in the Nishitama jurisdiction . >

'Serial?'

<I don't know . But with this timing...>

So it could be serial .

Not just one person but two had been killed – a big case . The Nishitama precinct would probably chase Yakumo with all their strength .

Not all . Detectives from central government would be out soon .

If that happened, all of the police force would be chasing Yakumo .

<What should we do?>

Ishii's off-the-point question stopped Gotou's thoughts .

'What?'

<I said, what should we do now?>

– That?

'How would I know?'

<Eh?>

'Think about what you should do on your own!'

After yelling that, Gotou hung up .

When he sat down on the bench, Gotou realised that he'd forgotten to tell Ishii that he'd found Yakumo . He thought about calling again, but decided against it . It would be better not to tell Ishii .

If he found out, he would have to report to the higher-ups . It'd bring about problems if he knew and kept quiet about it .

– I can't get Ishii any more involved in this .

After smiling derisively, Gotou called Haruka's number from his mobile phone's contact list .

He'd call just to say they found him .

<Hello?>

She had probably been waiting for a call . Gotou heard Haruka's cornered voice right away .

She had probably been in more pain than anyone . It felt like she might start crying at any moment .

'It's Gotou . '

<Did you find Yakumo-kun?> Haruka said immediately .

So many things had happened up until now . To Haruka, Yakumo was irreplaceable, just like how he was to Gotou .

If Haruka lost Yakumo, she would probably carry that with her for her whole life .

When Gotou thought that, he couldn't speak .

<So you didn't find him...>

Haruka's voice sounded like it would fade off at any moment .

– I...

'Like I promised, I found him,' said Gotou, before his heart was determined .

<Really?>

Haruka's voice was so bright it sounded like a different person's .

Now, Gotou couldn't say the truth .

– It's fine . Yakumo will be saved .

Gotou said that to himself and made his decision .

'Yeah, really . '

<Is Yakumo-kun all right?>

'Of course . '

<I want to talk to him . >

'Ah, no, right now's no good . He's got a bit of an injury . A doctor's looking at him . '

<An injury...>

'He's fine . Nothing big . He's getting it looked at just in case . '

Gotou was hit by a wave of regret after saying that .

– What am I saying?

However, it was too late now that he'd said it . If anything happened, he'd make the same thing happen to that quack doctor .

<Thank goodness... Really, thank goodness...>

Gotou could tell that Haruka was crying on the other side of the phone .

– I'm really counting on you .

Gotou glared at the door of the examination room .

<Where are you now, dear?>

Suddenly, Gotou heard Atsuko's voice from the other side of the phone .

'W-why are you there?'

Gotou became flustered in his confusion .

<What do you mean, why? Nao and I are also worried about Yakumo-kun . Don't just run off like that . >

'I'm sorry . '

Gotou's voice toned down under Atsuko's pressure .

He'd know this, but she really had some guts .

<So how is the case?>

'Don't want to think about it . It's the worst-case scenario . '

<I see...>

'The fingerprints on the murder weapon match Yakumo's . '

<Yakumo-kun could never kill someone...>

'I know that . '

Eishin's words came up in Gotou's head .

– People's hearts change moment by moment .

That might be true . There was probably a side of Yakumo that Gotou and the others didn't know . But still, he wanted to believe in Yakumo .

There was a line that people couldn't cross . No matter what, Yakumo wasn't the sort of person who would cross that line .

'Hey, Atsuko . '

Gotou called his wife by his name .

He felt like it'd been a while since he'd done that . He didn't know why, but since they married, it'd become natural for her to be by his side and he'd just gotten by with things like 'Oi' .

But he felt like calling her by her name right now .

There was something he had to say properly while facing her .

<What?>

'The police are chasing Yakumo as a suspect rather than a person of interest . But I can't believe it . '

<Right . >

'Could I ask you one thing?'

<Yes . >

'If I end up quitting the police, what will you do?'

The moment Gotou said that, he heard laughter from the other side of the phone .

Perhaps Atsuko wasn't taking what Gotou said seriously . Or she didn't understand the meaning of the question –

But Gotou's answer cleared away those feelings of Gotou's .

<If I had to say what I like about you, there's one thing . You rush forward with your stupidly honest belief in others . >

'And if you had to say what you hated?'

<Your job . >

– She hates me being a police officer?

It was the first time he'd heard of it . It seemed like Atsuko had seen through all of Gotou's worries .

He'd thought he'd been flying around freely up until now, but it looked like he'd actually just been dancing around in Atsuko's palm .

He'd made an unbelievable woman into his wife .

'Got it . I'll try not to be hated . '

Gotou hung up and stood .

There was no reason to hesitate any more . Gotou was determined .

Yakumo might not like it, but he'd go with him to the ends of hell .

8

– I'm so glad .

Haruka gripped the red stone on her necklace tightly .

After seeing Yakumo in her room this morning, she recalled the time when her friend Shiori died and it had felt like her heart was in her mouth .

Nao was hopping around the room in happiness .

'That's great . '

Atsuko held Haruka's shoulders tightly .

'Yes . '

'My husband's quite the guy, isn't he?'

Atsuko really looked proud .

Haruka had to thank Gotou . Not just this time – he had stood on the front lines time and time again and protected them with his body .

'Thank you very much . '

Haruka knew her voice was trembling .

– No good . I'm going to cry again .

'Now, let's stop with the sentimentality . There's something we have to do too, right?' said Atsuko .

'Yes,' replied Haruka, wiping away her tears with her finger .

Just as Atsuko said, they had something they had to do .

Yakumo had become a suspect . If they didn't prove his innocence, he couldn't return even if he was safe .

As if to reply to Haruka's feelings, the mobile phone on the table rang .

The number on the display was Makoto's .

'Hello . '

<Sorry for calling early in the morning . >

Makoto's clear voice came through the phone .

'It's fine . '

<I found a number of interesting things while investigating . >

'Interesting things?'

<A mysterious story about that limestone cave . >

Makoto lowered her tone .

'A mysterious story... is it?'

Haruka lowered her tone as well .

<Yes . Old newspapers were no good, but about ten years ago, the publication department of my newspaper agency put out a book about spiritual phenomena and there was a story about that limestone cave in it . >

Though her voice was quiet, Makoto spoke quickly . It was evident that she was agitated .

'What sort of story was it?'

Expectation welled up within Haruka too .

<Fanatics about that sort of thing said that a woman's screams could be heard from that limestone cave . >

At this stage, Haruka didn't know what that really meant, but she couldn't ignore it .

<And there's a rumour that you can also hear a woman's screams at the lake near the limestone cavern . >

'At the lake...'

Haruka recalled what Eishin had said .

Hatsune, who said she was her mother's reincarnation, had said she was killed and sunk into the lake .

Hatsune was a girl of about ten years old . The time matched up . It could have something to do with it .

<That caught my interest, so I acted like I was going to gather material for this case and called people in the area . And then...>

Makoto spoke, interrupting Haruka's thoughts .

'Did you find something out?'

<I got different testimony . >

'Different testimony?'

<Yes . Though he was an old man already past sixty, that person said he heard a crying baby in that limestone cave when he was a kid . >

Though Haruka didn't know the precise age of the person who had given the interview, she imagined that this was about fifty years ago .

The time was completely different, and a woman's screams and a baby's cries were completely different .

She had thought things might have been related, but she felt now that everything was falling apart .

'Isn't that a different story?'

<Probably . >

Makoto said that as if it were a matter of fact .

When Makoto said that so firmly, it made Haruka more confused . Why had Makoto talked about a different spiritual phenomenon?

Makoto continued to speak, sensing Haruka's question .

<That old man went into the limestone cavern to find out where the baby's cries were coming from . >

Makoto's voice changed . Haruka's heart beat loudly .

Haruka held the mobile tightly and waited for Makoto to continue .

<He saw a woman there holding a child . >

'A woman?'

<Yes . That isn't all . He said that both of the woman's eyes were dyed a deep red...>

– A woman with two red eyes .

Haruka couldn't speak in her surprise .

<I don't know for certain, but don't you think one of these might be related to the case?>

Haruka agreed with Makoto's opinion .

Two spiritual phenomena that had occurred in the same place . Hatsune, who claimed to be her mother's reincarnation . If they found the thread that tied these three things together, they would solve the mystery of the case .

9

– Think about what you should do on your own!

Gotou's words kept circling his head like a round .

For a while, he had thought that Gotou had abandoned him and had been dazed in his shock .

But after some time, he had understood the true meaning behind those words, as if they had slowly spread within his heart .

Gotou hadn't abandoned him . He'd entrusted the matter to him .

When Ishii realised that, he had trembled from head to toe, like electricity was running through him .

No matter how much Miyagawa was against it, there was something he had to do .

Ishii was determined .

First, he needed to gather information . Youko had said that another corpse was found in the Nishitama jurisdiction . He would find out its identity .

The direction of his investigation would change depending on whether that corpse was related to Yakumo's case .

Ishii took the phone from the desk but was troubled about his decision .

If he contacted Miyagawa through the internal line, the chief would probably be furious . That said, calling the Nishitama precinct without an official request would cause discord .

– What should I do?

Just as he held his head in disappointment, somebody's face flashed through Ishii's mind .

'That's right . Makoto-san might know . '

Ishii quickly called Makoto's number from his mobile phone contacts list .

<Hello, Hijikata speaking . >

After a number of rings, Makoto picked up .

Ishii felt like it had been a while since he'd heard her voice . Since he had felt like he'd been left behind on his own, this relaxed him a bit .

'It's Ishii . It's been a while . '

<Actually, I was just about to contact you too, Ishii-san . >

'Eh? Is that so?'

– What could it be?

'I was investigating Yakumo-kun's case with Haruka-chan . >

Makoto answered Ishii's question .

'I see...'

<How about you, Ishii-san?>

'Of course, I'm calling about Yakumo-shi's case . There's something I want to know, but...'

<If it's a question I can reply to, of course . >

'It seems like a corpse was found in the Nishitama jurisdiction this morning . '

Makoto seemed to sense the general situation just from Ishii's explanation and put the phone on hold after saying 'Please wait' .

A melancholic melody started to play .

While listening to it, Ishii realised that his impression of Makoto had changed .

In the past, he would become nervous in front of Makoto, but now that wasn't the case .

– I wonder why .

<I'm sorry for the wait . >

Makoto spoke breathlessly, interrupting Ishii's thoughts .

'What is it?'

<Though I don't know too much...>

'That's fine . '

<His name is Matsumoto Hiroshi . Twenty-seven years old . He's a high school teacher . He had taken an unauthorised leave from work since two days ago, and when a colleague from school went to check out on him, it looked like he had been stabbed multiple times with a knife . >

Ishii felt his feet shake when he heard what Makoto said .

Stabbed multiple times with a knife – that was the exact same method that Seidou had been killed with . Though it was too early to say it was the same perpetrator just from that, it was worth looking into .

<And the location of the crime was about five kilometres from that temple .
>

Makoto added to her explanation .

It wasn't that far . Ishii's suspicions grew stronger .

<Does it seem related?>

Makoto said that as if she had read Ishii's thoughts .

'I can't say anything at this stage...'

<I see...>

Ishii was about to hang up, but then Makoto stopped him, saying <Ishii-san> .

'What is it?'

<I also have information that I've gathered . Shall we meet up later?>

That was a welcome suggestion .

He had to explain the situation to Haruka as well, and it would be better to have more heads to think about it .

'That sounds good . '

<Then I'll pick up Haruka-chan and meet you . >

'Thank you . '

Ishii hung up and looked at the mountain of files that Youko had left behind . It was possible that something that connected Seidou and Matsumoto Hiroshi was in there .

Ishii rolled up his shirt sleeves and picked up a file .

10

– Still not done?

Gotou glared at the examination room door with his two hands in fists .

It had been more than two hours since .

He was irritated at himself for only being able to wait . At times like this, he longed for the cigarettes that he had stopped smoking .

'Damn it!'

Just as Gotou spat that out, the door opened .

Eishin came out . His forehead was drenched with sweat . He looked like he had lost weight .

'How is he?'

Gotou stood up immediately and approached Eishin .

Eishin let out a long breath and then his expression relaxed .

'Seems he'll be fine if he gets some rest . '

'T-that so?'

All the force in Gotou's body left him – it felt like he'd fall right to the floor .

Gotou was surprised himself that Yakumo's existence had had such an impact on him .

'So what do you plan to do now?'

Eishin looked at the glass door at the entrance, like he had sensed something .

Gotou looked as well .

He saw two uniformed officers approaching the examination room .

The nurse had probably informed the police after seeing the news . This was bad .

'Take Yakumo out of here,' Gotou said forcefully .

'Are you serious?'

Eishin's brow was furrowed .

Like Gotou had the time to tell jokes now .

'I'll stop the officers . You take Yakumo then,' said Gotou, glaring at Eishin .

For a while, Eishin just looked back at Gotou silently, but he finally shook his head in resignation .

'My, my . To think that I would become a partner in crime...'

'You were the start of this . You should be prepared . '

'Got it . '

Eishin smiled wryly and headed to the examination room .

'Now, time to go . '

Gotou walked over with wide strides to the officers that had come in and showed them his police ID .

'I'm Gotou of the Setamachi precinct . '

'Thank you for your hard work . '

The uniformed officer immediately replied with a salute .

'Did something happen?'

'Yes . There was a report that the escaped suspect Saitou Yakumo was here...'

– So that really was it .

Gotou clicked his tongue looked at the examination room .

With bad timing, Eishin came out, carrying Yakumo .

One of the uniformed officers noticed and tried to approach Eishin, but Gotou grabbed the officer's arm to stop him .

'Wait!'

'No, but...'

'It was decided that Saitou Yakumo will be turned over to the Setamachi precinct . '

– Please . Believe me .

Gotou looked at the officer whose arm he was holding with that thought in his head .

'I will confirm that . '

After the other officer said that, he took his wireless in his hand .

– No good, eh?

Gotou turned around and kneed the officer with the wireless between the legs .

'Agh!'

The officer put his two hands to his crotch and screeched .

'Don't think badly of me . '

Gotou kicked the man's defenceless chin .

The officer fell down backwards and stopped moving, losing consciousness .

'W-what are you doing?'

The other officer seemed in shock as he put his hand to the gun holster at his waist .

– As if I'd let you do that!

Gotou grabbed the officer's arm as he tried to take out his gun and then rammed his head into his nose .

'Aaahhh!'

The officer staggered backwards while gripping his nose .

Gotou took a big step forward to approach the officer and performed a lariat with his outstretched right arm .

The officer fell backwards and stopped moving .

– I've done it now .

Though it was to save Yakumo, he was interfering with a public servant in the execution of his duties by aiding a fugitive . And he'd been violent on top of that . It wasn't something a police officer should do .

He wouldn't be able to be a police officer again with this .

Gotou had thought he would be disappointed, but strangely, his chest felt light . He had been bound by the organisation called the police up until now and had undergone many hardships, but now he was free .

'Shouldn't have done that,' Eishin said, poking fun .

As usual, this guy had no sense of nervousness .

'Anyway, let's hurry . '

Right after saying that, Gotou ran .

There was no time to be sentimental . Once the officers regained consciousness, help would probably come right away .

They had to get as far away as they could before that happened .

Gotou got in the car's driver seat and turned on the engine .

He waited until Eishin put Yakumo in the back and sat himself in the passenger seat before starting the car .

'There was a movie like this before . The one with a pair escaping after committing a train robbery,' said Eishin, smiling like he was enjoying this .

Gotou knew that movie too, but he didn't want to compare themselves to it if he could .

'Do you know how that movie ended?'

'No, how did it?'

Eishin cocked his head .

– Really, what a laidback old man .

'In the end, they were surrounded by the army and shot full of holes . '

11

– What's this?

Ishii was looking through the files when he spotted the circumstances of a certain case and his hands stopped without thinking .

It was about a girl's disappearance ten years ago .

Masuoka Minami, who lived in Nishitama City, was seventeen years old at the time . She went missing on the way home from school . Minami had still not been found .

From her friends' testimony, Minami had seemed very depressed two or three days prior to the incident .

As well, on the day of her disappearance, she was spotted talking the train at the station in the direction of Shinjuku .

Her father had failed at work and lost his job and her mother was working part-time to support their family . Though she had wanted to go to university, but she was forced to give up .

It appeared that Minami had expressed her dissatisfaction with her family to her friends . The police had conjectured that she ran away from home because she hated her family .

After just looking at this much, it was a case that could happen often .

However, there was a reason Ishii had focussed on this case .

First was the name .

Furthermore, the person who had last seen Minami . That person was the victim of the case this time, Seidou .

There were other things that caught his interest . Matsumoto Hiroshi, the corpse that was found this morning, was the same age as Minami .

Was this just a coincidence – no, it was too much for that .

Ishii felt agitated .

Calling Minami's family for information would be one method .

'Where's Gotou!?'

The door slammed open . Miyagawa ran in with a terribly angry expression .

His face was completely red – it looked like he could explode at any moment .

'No, I...'

Ishii stood up reflexively, back pencil-straight .

'Where's Gotou?'

Miyagawa brought his face so close to Ishii's that their noses were almost touching .

His eyes were bloodshot . Ishii felt like Miyagawa might bite into his neck at any moment .

'No... I...'

'I told you to back off already . What idiotic...'

Miyagawa covered his face with both hands and sat down right there .

Ishii had no idea what had happened, but when he saw Miyagawa's unusual reaction, the feeling that something unbelievable was happening grew stronger .

'What on earth...'

When Ishii asked that, Miyagawa stood up there with a reproachful expression and clicked his tongue .

'There's nothing else to say . This is the end...'

As if to interrupt Miyagawa's explanation, the door opened .

Youko came in . Her expression was as wild as Miyagawa's .

'You've done it now!'

'Yes?'

'Did you know?'

Youko said that hysterically as she approached Ishii .

— What on earth is it?

Ishii's head felt like it would split in his confusion .

'What about?'

'Your partner acted violently against two uniformed officers and escaped with Saitou Yakumo . '

'Eh?'

It was so unexpected that for a while, Ishii couldn't understand the meaning of the words .

– It can't be .

'Do you understand what this means? Aiding a fugitive and interfering with a public servant in the execution of his duties . And violence, on top of that . '

'You're lying . Detective Gotou wouldn't do that . '

Ishii looked at Miyagawa for help .

'It's true . He really did something stupid...'

Miyagawa spat that out .

'That's...'

Ishii stood there, unable to believe it .

– I see .

Now, Ishii finally understood . Gotou had already found Yakumo when they talked on the phone . He had been planning on escaping with Yakumo from the very beginning .

That was why he didn't tell Ishii about finding Yakumo – so as to not cause trouble for Ishii .

– Think about what you should do on your own!

Ishii understood the true meaning of Gotou's words .

A bitter taste spread through his mouth .

'Even though... I wanted to go with Detective Gotou...' murmured Ishii .

'What did you say?'

Miyagawa pressed him for an answer, but Ishii didn't feel like replying .

– He left me behind .

That feeling quickly spread through Ishii's chest, becoming so heavy it was hard to bear .

Ishii respected Gotou from the bottom of his heart .

Gotou had everything that Ishii didn't . Ishii wanted to become like him .
He wished for that . That was why he had recklessly chased after that back .

And yet –

'I need to go . '

Ishii's mouth moved naturally .

'Go? You...'

'I have to go too . '

Ishii took the file he had started reading and started running before he'd noticed himself .

'Wait!'

He didn't stop at Miyagawa's yell .

He just ran down the corridor frantically, as if he was possessed by something .

Though his feet tangled, he somehow managed to fix his posture .

He didn't have the time to fall .

If he didn't continue running, Gotou would leave him behind . That was –

'Not acceptable . '

Ishii continued to run, as if he was being chased by something .

12

'Is this really OK?' Eishin said to Gotou, who was driving .

'Is what OK?' asked Gotou, confused by the question .

'You can't return to the police any more . '

Eishin's narrow eyes narrowed even further .

It seemed like even this laidback old man was unusually worried .

'You should ask things like that before I actually do the act . '

Gotou snorted as he turned the wheel .

Even if Eishin said that now, Gotou couldn't take it back . And he had already known that he couldn't be a police officer any more .

It'd be much more frightening to be abandoned by Atsuko .

'... Gotou-san . '

Gotou heard a faint voice that could disappear at any moment .

He turned around frantically .

It was Yakumo –

It looked like he'd finally regained consciousness .

Gotou pulled the car over to the curb right away and leant over to check on Yakumo .

Yakumo's shoulders heaved as he took painful breaths, but he slowly got up from the backseat . It looked like his swollen left leg was in pain, as his expression twisted like he was in agony .

'So you're alive?'

Though Gotou said that with a cluck of his tongue, he naturally smiled broadly .

– I'm glad . Really glad .

It was worth running against the police . Now Haruka wouldn't have to call him a liar .

'Gotou-san, you're more of an idiot than I imagined...' said Yakumo, his expression twisting in pain .

'That's the first thing you say? Can't you honestly say "Thanks for saving me"?''

Though Gotou was grumbling, Gotou could see tears on Yakumo's face through the rear-view mirror .

– Well, I'd probably hit him if he honestly thanked me because it would be so unpleasant .

Gotou murmured that in his heart .

'... I don't remember asking you to save me . '

After saying that, Yakumo started to cough .

Gotou had to take off his hat to Yakumo, who would go to those lengths to say such hateful things .

'It's fine – just go sleep for a bit . '

'I can't... do that...'

Though Yakumo looked pained as he breathed, he looked at Gotou with a sharp glance .

Even if his body was in shambles, his mind seemed clear .

'There's something I want to ask you first . '

Eishin was the one who interrupted .

'Yes, I understand . '

Yakumo gave a small nod . It felt like he knew what Eishin was going to ask .

'Did you kill Seidou?'

There was no waver in Eishin's voice . He was just looking for the truth . That was how it seemed .

Eishin really was somewhat like Yakumo . No, would it be the other way around?

'I'll be honest...'

After saying that, Yakumo licked his dry lips .

His expression was stiff . It was the first time Gotou had seen Yakumo look this way .

– It can't be .

An uneasy feeling spread through Gotou's chest . The longer the silence, the more that thought spread . An unpleasant sweat drenched his forehead .

'I don't know . '

Yakumo looked down .

'What do you mean, you don't know?' interrupted Gotou .

For a while, Yakumo stayed silent, head looking down, but then he suddenly lifted his head .

'I was in that limestone cavern before I noticed . I remember up until I went to that limestone cavern with Seidou-san, but everything after that...'

'You don't remember?'

'I don't . '

Though Yakumo was good at speaking, he couldn't lie skilfully .

He probably really didn't remember . But if that was the case –

'Why did you run?'

Eishin spoke before Gotou could .

Yakumo stuck his hand into his jeans pocket and took out a crumpled piece of paper .

Eishin looked at it first . Then, it came around to Gotou .

There was a short message on the piece of paper .

<You're the one who killed him . If you're caught by the police, somebody important to you will die . >

Gotou's brows furrowed .

– What the hell is this?

'It was on the door to the cave,' Yakumo said, as if to answer Gotou's question .

– Who'd do this?

Gotou was about to ask, but then he suddenly realised . Gotou only knew one person who would do something as roundabout as this .

'Could it be Nanase Miyuki?'

'Probably...' said Yakumo with a sigh, running a hand through his hair .

It was that women . Just as the note said, if the police caught Yakumo, she probably really would kill somebody close to Yakumo .

In the past, Isshin had lost his life like that to her scheme .

Is her next target Nao or Haruka – a chill ran down Gotou's spine just from thinking about it .

He was really glad he'd taken Yakumo out of there .

'Who's that?' Eishin asked, sounding interested .

'Ah . There's a reason there . She's the bitch who took Isshin's life . '

As Gotou said that, he leant back on his seat .

If Nanase Miyuki was involved, the situation was more annoying than he'd thought . And the situation was awful .

While running from the police, they had to find out the truth of the case .

There was too much to think about – it felt like his head would explode .

'What are you going to do?' asked Gotou, though he knew .

'I will solve the mystery of the case . '

Yakumo's eyes narrowed . His red left eye seemed to be filled with force .

Just the answer Gotou had expected . No matter how battered he was, Yakumo probably planned on not giving up until the end . But –

'How are you going to solve the mystery?'

'First, I will meet once more with the girl called Hatsune who claims to be her mother's reincarnation . '

'What are you going to do after meeting her?'

'I want to fill the missing parts of my memory . '

– I see .

'Got it . I'll take you there . '

Yakumo's eyes went wide in surprise at Gotou's words .

– What's so surprising?

'I'll do it myself . I can't cause you any more trouble . '

After Yakumo said that, his mouth went into a thin line . He was trying to shoulder everything himself again .

When Gotou saw that, he felt anger start bubbling up in his chest .

'Trouble!? What are you saying now!? If we don't clear your name, I won't be able to return home, let alone to the police!'

When Eishin heard Gotou's yell, for some reason, he started to laugh .

'It's because you act without thinking ahead that this sort of thing happens,' said Yakumo with a bitter expression while running a hand through his messy hair .

That caused Gotou's anger to explode .

'You bastard! That's enough! I'll kill you right here!'

'Would you lay off?'

Eishin grabbed Gotou's hair and pulled him back .

In the backseat, Yakumo laughed .

13

Haruka was driven by Makoto to the police precinct so that they could meet with Ishii .

'I'm really sorry about inconveniencing you again . '

In the passenger seat, Haruka bowed her head towards Makoto .

Makoto hadn't just arranged the meeting with Ishii . She had also gone to Haruka's flat to pick her up .

Haruka had an image of Makoto as a quiet person, but through these cases, that image grew much more active .

'Don't worry about it . '

Makoto smiled .

'But...'

'It's fine . I don't believe Yakumo-kun would kill somebody either . And if this turns into a false accusation, this'll be a scoop for me . You don't have to feel sorry . '

When Makoto said that, it made Haruka feel slightly better .

Haruka put a smile on her face and replied, 'All right . '

'Ah, he's here . '

Makoto pointed at the front entrance of the police precinct .

Haruka saw Ishii running with limbs flailing .

'He looks a bit odd . '

'He does . '

Makoto agreed with Haruka's opinion .

When Haruka looked more carefully, she saw a man with an incredibly angry expression chasing Ishii .

'That person...'

– I've seen him somewhere before .

'It's Miyagawa-san, the chief of the police,' Makoto said, as if to reply to Haruka's question .

It looked somewhat like a detective chasing a criminal .

'Ah, please open the door!'

Ishii hit the window right as the car arrived and said that in a voice near a scream .

He was like a zombie from a horror movie .

'Please sit in the back . '

Makoto quickly gave the instructions .

Ishii was looking around in panic, but he opened the door, got in and immediately locked the door .

'Please drive right away!'

There was a bead of sweat on Ishii's forehead and his glasses were askew as he yelled frantically .

He looked so strange that Haruka and Makoto exchanged blank looks .

'Aah! He's here! Hurry!'

Ishii looked out the window .

Miyagawa had got to the car . His expression wouldn't lose to Ishii's – he looked like a demon .

'Ah, yes . '

Though Makoto looked confused, she started the car .

'Stop! I said stop!' howled Miyagawa .

'Is this OK?' said Makoto, looking at Miyagawa's figure growing smaller in the rear-view mirror .

'It's fine . There was a slight problem...'

Ishii heaved a sigh and wiped the sweat on his forehead with his shirt sleeve .

'Did something happen?' asked Haruka, turning around .

Ishii had been odd, but Miyagawa's appearance hadn't been normal either . She felt like something unbelievable was happening .

'Ah... It's difficult for me to say, but actually, Detective Gotou... er...'

Ishii started to speak after adjusting the position of his glasses with his finger, but then his voice trailed off and was drowned out by the car engine .

'Er...'

'Ah, sorry . Er, Detective Gotou is now also being chased by the police...'

'Eh?'

– Why Gotou too?

Haruka didn't understand at all .

'To put it simply, Detective Gotou acted violent against the uniformed officers who tried to arrest Yakumo-shi and then he fled . '

'That's...'

Haruka felt like she'd been stabbed in the chest .

She had been the one who told Gotou where Yakumo was . She wanted Yakumo to be safe . But that had been all . That had brought about results that she hadn't even thought about .

'That's just like Gotou-san . '

Makoto was smiling, the complete opposite of Haruka, whose heart was in pain .

'It is . '

Ishii agreed .

It was true that it was like Gotou to strike the people who got in his way, but that wasn't the problem .

'It's my fault...'

Just as Haruka said that, her mobile phone rang .

The number on the display was Gotou's but the voice she heard from the phone wasn't .

<It's been a while . >

'Yakumo-kun!' exclaimed Haruka .

What does he mean, it's been a while? Don't act so carefree when you don't even know how I feel . The anger flamed up in Haruka's heart .

<Don't speak so loudly . >

Yakumo said that in his usual voice .

That attitude just added oil to Haruka's anger .

'What? You don't even know how I feel . You can't imagine what I thought...'

She didn't have the words to continue .

Haruka's eyes welled with tears .

Though she had been angry, in the bottom of her heart, she was relieved by hearing Yakumo's voice .

Yakumo was important to her . That feeling was stronger than any other in her chest .

<My bad...>

Yakumo said that awkwardly .

If he did feel bad, at least a little, that was fine .

Haruka sniffled and rubbed at her eyes to clear her head .

'Where are you now?

– I want to see him as soon as I can .

<I can't say . >

Yakumo replied immediately .

'Why not?'

<I'm the suspect in a murder case and am currently a fugitive . >

The words Yakumo said so smoothly were a heavy weight on Haruka's heart .

'Hey . How can I clear your name, Yakumo-kun?'

Yakumo laughed aloud at Haruka's question .

Haruka didn't know why he was laughing . That was a serious question –

'What's so funny?'

<You're the same as always . >

Yakumo said that in a voice that made it sound like he was smiling .

'What do you mean?'

<Aren't you going to ask?>

'Ask what?'

<Whether I committed the murder...>

Haruka hadn't even thought about asking that question . The reason being –

'You didn't kill him, right, Yakumo-kun?'

<How can you be sure?>

Yakumo said that after a pause .

Why – Haruka was troubled when asked that .

However, no matter what happened, Yakumo wasn't the sort of person who would kill somebody . She knew that best .

'I don't have a reason . '

<That's why I said you were the same as always . >

'Are you praising me?'

<Why would that be the case?>

Yakumo stifled his laughter .

Haruka felt like the conversation wasn't meshing at all .

'So isn't there anything I can do?'

Haruka returned to the heart of the matter .

<Where are you now?>

'I'm investigating the case with Ishii-san and Makoto-san . '

<I see... Stay with those two until the case is over . >

'Why?'

<Because that would be safer . >

'What do you mean?'

<Anyway, make sure you're never alone . >

Yakumo was speaking in an unusually grave tone . It made Haruka felt like she was being cross-examined .

She didn't know what had happened, but when he talked like that, it made her anxious . She had the feeling that something incredibly awful would happen –

<Sorry, but could you hand the phone over to Ishii-san?>

'To Ishii-san?'

<Please . There isn't much time . >

'All right... Ishii-san . '

Haruka handed the mobile to Ishii in the backseat .

'Me?'

'Yes . '

Ishii looked confused, but he took the mobile phone .

14

'Hello...'

Ishii was confused as he took the phone from Haruka .

When he thought about how the person on the other end was a suspect in a murder case being chased by the police, it made him even more nervous than usual .

<It's Yakumo . >

'Ah, yes, it's Ishii . '

<I apologise for involving you in something so troubling . >

Yakumo said that in a formal tone .

It appeared that he hadn't lost himself even at a time like this .

'No... I haven't... Er, how is Detective Gotou?'

<Very lively . To the point that it's annoying . >

Yakumo let out a dry laugh .

'I see... I'm glad . '

Gotou had done something that he couldn't return from, but it was fine as long as he was well .

<Actually, there's something I want to ask of you, Ishii-san . >

'Me?'

Ishii's voice cracked .

His heart was beating loudly . He had a bad feeling .

And – he had no confidence . Gotou had tried to save Yakumo even though it meant abandoning his own life . Would Ishii be able to do that when it was necessary?

<Yes . It's something I can only ask of you, Ishii-san . >

'Only of me...'

Yakumo's words lifted Ishii's sunken heart .

There was something only he could do even in this situation .

<I want you to protect her . >

'Protect her?'

<Yes . I want you to protect her for me . >

Yakumo's words shook Ishii's core .

He probably meant Haruka .

Ishii looked at Haruka sitting in the passenger seat . Though she always smiled brightly, that expression was clouded right now .

'Is she in danger?'

Ishii lowered his voice .

<There was a message left at the scene of the crime . If I'm caught by the police, somebody important to me will die...>

'Somebody important...'

An uneasy feeling came to Ishii .

– Somebody important .

So Yakumo also thought of Haruka that way?

Ishii had thought so, but hearing it from the person himself made him feel like something had pierced his chest .

<Please . I don't want the same thing that happened with my uncle to happen again . >

Yakumo said that in a trembling voice, which helped jog Ishii's memories .

– Could it be?

'Is she... Is Nanase Miyuki involved in this case?'

<It is likely . >

That's why Yakumo ran away from the scene – it made sense to Ishii now .

Yakumo ran away from the police, knowing that he would be suspected as the culprit, so that he could protect Haruka .

Ishii couldn't do nothing while Yakumo had done so much .

'Please leave it to me!'

In response to Ishii's loud voice, Haruka turned around from the passenger seat .

'What is it?'

'Ah, no, it's nothing . '

Ishii forced himself to laugh and turned away .

'I will definitely protect her,' he said in a quiet voice so that Haruka wouldn't hear .

<Thank you very much . >

Yakumo breathed out like he was relieved on the other side of the phone .

Protecting the person you yearned for . Though it made him feel proud – like he had become a knight – the person who had asked him to do so was his rival in love .

Though Ishii felt conflicted, this wasn't the time to think about that .

Protecting Haruka was his highest priority . And if Nanase Miyuki were involved, the problem was even larger .

'As long as the case isn't solved, Haruka-chan will be in danger . '

Ishii hunched over in the seat so that Haruka wouldn't hear him speak .

Yakumo couldn't keep running forever, and it would be realistically impossible for Ishii to spend his whole life watching Haruka too .

<She will . >

'Something must be done...'

<Which is why I have another request to make of you, Ishii-san . >

'What is it?'

<Could you tell me the information you know at the current stage to solve the mystery?>

'Yes . '

Ishii took out his notebook immediately .

15

'What did you talk about?' Gotou asked after Yakumo finished his call .

At first, it had seemed like he was talking to Haruka, but then it turned to Haruka and the call had gone on for a while .

It felt like Yakumo had been listening to something in detail .

'I asked Ishii-san to do something,' replied Yakumo, fiddling with the mobile phone .

'Asked him to do what?'

'I asked him to guard her . '

Gotou understood now .

There was that message . Yakumo had asked Ishii to guard against any attack . But –

'Is Ishii going to be enough?'

'Is there anybody else who would believe the words of a suspect?'

Yakumo responded with a question .

Gotou couldn't argue with that .

Yakumo was a fugitive – he had enemies on all sides . Though Ishii was a bit unreliable, he was the only one Yakumo could rely on .

'So Nanase Miyuki had planned even this situation...'

'Seems so . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair in his irritation .

Gotou was astonished by Nanase Miyuki's meticulousness .

She had stolen Yakumo's freedom with just one slip of paper . But Gotou didn't understand .

'What does she want to do by doing this?'

'I wonder... She probably wanted to look into something regarding the girl who claims to have been reincarnated on top of making me alone,' said Yakumo .

'Reincarnation, eh...'

Gotou had no way of knowing what truth waited for them if they chased that mystery .

'Gotou-san, shouldn't we get off of this car soon?' said Yakumo .

'Why?'

'Isn't it obvious? Because of the number . Moving in this car is the same as running around with a sticker that says "Culprit on board" . You should know that much as an ex-police officer,' Yakumo said mockingly .

It was just as Yakumo said, but Gotou didn't like his tone .

Even though he'd been practically dead earlier, he was like this now . And he'd said ex-police officer .

'That's your fault!'

'If you are going to blame anything, please make it your own rashness . '

'I shouldn't have saved you!'

Gotou hit the wheel in his anger .

'You're so noisy . I can't sleep,' said Eishin as he rubbed his eyes in the passenger seat .

– Was this old man sleeping in this awful mess?

'Ah, that's right . Everything was my fault . '

'As long as you understand that . '

Yakumo's words made Gotou so angry he could have died, but if he responded, Yakumo would fight back exponentially . Gotou let out a long sigh .

'We can get off the car, but do you plan to go on foot?'

'Please stop with the jokes,' said Yakumo with a laugh .

'Then what are we going to do?'

'Please buy a new one . '

'Are you an idiot? Cars aren't toys . '

'You must be poor . '

'You bastard!'

'Can't you keep quiet?' interrupted Eishin .

'Do you have any ideas?'

Though Eishin hit his head like he was exasperated, he opened his mouth to speak .

'There's a temple I'm familiar with nearby . Let's borrow one there .

'I see . So where's that temple?'

'Near the station . '

'I'm asking where that station is . '

'What should you say when asking people for something?'

Eishin smirked .

He was just like Yakumo at times like this – he was a malicious person deep down .

'Please be so kind as to tell me how to get there . '

Gotou bowed his head, bearing with the mortification .

'As long as you understand . Turn right at the next light,' said Eishin triumphantly .

He had to deal with these two malicious people . Gotou cursed his unluckiness as he turned on the right turn signal and stopped at the light .

Yakumo opened the car window completely and stuck his head out like he'd thought of something .

'What are you doing?'

Ignoring Gotou's question, Yakumo threw Gotou's mobile phone onto the back of the mini truck beside them .

'You bastard! What the hell are you doing!?!'

In the corner of Gotou's eye, the light changed and the mini truck drove on .

'It's fine . I transferred your data to the SD card . '

Yakumo seemed proud as he held up the memory card in his fingers .

– What's fine about that?

'That isn't the problem!'

'Are you really an ex-police officer?'

'What did you say?'

'Mobile phones send out radio waves . The position can be located from that . '

Yakumo smirked .

'That's no reason to throw it away . '

'I'm not throwing it away . It's a trap . The police should follow that mini truck for a while . '

Though Gotou understood Yakumo's explanation, he was still irritated .
Yakumo had consigned countless of Gotou's mobile phones into oblivion .

He was just about to complain when people started honking .

– I'm going, I'm going .

Gotou stepped on the accelerator and started the car .

16

'So the girl's disappearance might be related somehow?' said Haruka after listening to Ishii's explanation .

The girl who disappeared ten years ago, Minami – the last who saw her was Seidou, and the name Hatsune claimed to have had before her reincarnation was Minami .

There were many points that matched up, but it still hadn't come together for Haruka .

'Though this is only my theory...'

Ishii's eyes narrowed behind his glasses .

Though Ishii said that, Haruka felt like he sounded confident .

'But how about the story that Makoto heard of the baby and the woman with red eyes that occurred fifty years ago? And reincarnation is...'

Haruka realised why she had thought the case was off .

The keywords of this case were all over the place – she didn't know where to start .

'That's right . I'm curious about that too . '

Ishii's brows lowered as he scratched his cheek, looking troubled .

'Why not stop thinking about that for now?' said Makoto as she drove .

'What do you mean?'

Ishii stuck out his neck like a chicken .

'We don't have any other leads, so let's just go with it . If we're wrong, we'll go with the next one . '

'Ah . '

'That might have come off a bit forceful . '

Makoto stuck out her tongue and smiled, seeming embarrassed .

'Right . The best plan might be to go through all of them one by one . Detective Gotou and Yakumo-shi are looking into the girl who reincarnated, so let's put that aside for now . '

Ishii clapped his hands in agreement .

'How about it?' said Makoto with a smile .

'That sounds good,' agreed Haruka .

It was impossible to get to the conclusion right away . It might be fastest to clear the possibilities one by one . Haruka had so wanted to clear Yakumo's

name that she hadn't been thinking clearly .

Haruka also knew that worrying without acting was one of her bad habits .
Because of that, she had her current relationship with Yakumo .

I haven't said anything or approached him actively . But I wonder how he thinks of me – she just worried about that .

If she had acted, there would have probably been a different result waiting for her .

Anyway, all she could do now was act .

'You were thinking about Yakumo-kun right now, weren't you?'

Makoto smiled .

'T-that isn't true . '

Haruka hurriedly denied it, but that just made her more embarrassed . She went red to her ears .

'It's written on your face . Right, Ishii-san?'

'Eh, ah, yes . '

Ishii was flustered when Makoto suddenly turned the conversation to him .

'So where should we go first?' asked Haruka, changing the subject .

'I was thinking that we could meet up with Minami-san's mother first,' suggested Ishii .

To be honest, Haruka felt a bit anxious about investigating without Gotou, but that had been needless worrying .

She'd thought that Ishii was always following Gotou, but he looked livelier without him here .

'Do you know the address?' said Makoto, looking towards the backseat .

'Yes . It's near here... Er... in Setagaya ward...' replied Ishii, flipping through his notebook .

'Not in Nishitama?' said Makoto, surprised .

'No . It appears that she moved a number of years ago when her father died .
,

'Was it illness?'

Ishii awkwardly looked down at Makoto's question .

'No . It appears to have been suicide . '

That one word from Ishii made the mood in the car much darker .

Though making everything related would be a problem, Haruka couldn't help but think this way .

– Does the father's suicide have to do with his daughter's disappearance?

Haruka couldn't give the answer to that question right now .

17

Gotou went to the temple gates and waited for Eishin to return .

In his boredom, it made him long for the cigarettes he'd stopped smoking .

Smoking a cigarette wouldn't change anything, but he would be able to take his mind off things .

'Your irritation won't change anything,' said Yakumo from beside him, as if he'd sensed Gotou's feelings .

'Don't want to hear that from you . '

'Right . '

Yakumo looked down with a bitter smile .

He was being unusually honest . Though he spoke hatefully, his heart probably hurt quite a lot .

'Hey, Yakumo . '

'What is it?'

'You accepted that damn monk's request because of Isshin, right?' said Gotou, recalling what Eishin had said yesterday .

'Well, something like it . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair .

His narrowed eyes looked incredibly sad .

'What did you want to know about Isshin?'

There was a silence –

Rather than not wanting to talk about it, it felt like he was troubled about how to talk about it .

'Uncle decided to take me in at that temple,' Yakumo said in a disinterested tone .

It wasn't that he wasn't interested, but more like he was consciously leaving out the emotion .

'And?'

'At the time, Uncle took my hand and said something . '

'What?'

'Something incredibly... important . '

Yakumo lifted his head .

His gaze was on the brilliant summer sun . Gotou had no way of knowing what was reflected in his eyes, narrowed in that brightness .

'What was it?'

'I don't remember . '

Gotou understood everything from that sentence .

Yakumo wanted to know what Isshin said at that temple – if he went there, he would remember . That was probably what he'd thought .

'Can I ask one thing as well?'

Yakumo dragged his feet a few steps forward and said that, his back to Gotou .

Yakumo's usual aloof tone was slightly perplexed .

'What?'

'Why did you save me?'

Without thinking, Gotou burst into laughter at Yakumo's question .

He didn't think that Yakumo would ask 'Why?' now .

'What's so funny?'

Yakumo turned around and glared at Gotou .

'Do I need a reason?'

Gotou replied with a question after he'd stopped laughing .

For a while, Yakumo's eyes were wide in surprise, but then he finally looked down with an embarrassed smile .

'I guess not,' he said .

– That's how it is, you contrary guy .

Gotou murmured that in his heart .

Yakumo thought that he was an unnecessary person because of the environment he'd grown up in .

That was why, when people did something for him, he would become unnecessarily perplexed and try to determine the reason behind it . But that was in the past .

'Since bears move on instinct,' said Yakumo with a smirk .

'What'd you say!?'

– Ruining everything with just one sentence!

Gotou grabbed Yakumo's collar in his anger .

However, Yakumo remained nonchalant, like he didn't care at all . Really, what a hateful brat .

'There's no time to quarrel . '

Gotou turned around at the voice and saw Eishin standing there with two large paper bags .

Eishin had gone to borrow a car .

'What are those?'

'Change of clothes for you and Yakumo . I thought it'd be better to change your appearance,' said Eishin, sounding proud .

'Why do we have to change?'

'Isn't it obviously because we're fugitives? You really are an idiot,' said Yakumo, looking exasperated . He always said too much .

'So where's the car?'

'We can use the one in the garage . You can also change there and have something to eat . '

When Eishin stuck out his chin, as if to tell them to come with him, he started walking briskly .

'Yeah, yeah,' grumbled Gotou, though he admired how well Eishin had thought things out .

Gotou's head had been filled with the car – he hadn't thought about clothes or food at all . Come to think of it, he hadn't eaten anything since last night what with all that had happened .

When they got to the temple's garage, the car that was there was actually a black BMW .

'Is the wheel on the left[1]?'

Though Gotou wasn't proud of it, he'd only ever driven cars manufactured in Japan .

'If you've got complaints, I'll get us a bicycle instead,' Eishin said without a moment's delay .

'I'll just drive then . '

'As long as you understand . And for the clothes, these are Yakumo's and these are yours . '

Eishin put the paper bags down in front of them .

Yakumo fished through his .

Inside were a monk's working clothes in navy and a towel .

'Sorry . This is a temple, so this is all they have . '

'It's fine . '

Yakumo started changing immediately . It suited him quite well .
Unexpected, it might fit Yakumo well if he became a monk .

Gotou looked inside his own paper bag .

Inside was a brilliant purple shirt and skinny enamel pants .

'Sorry . This is a temple, so this is all they have . '

Eishin's shoulders shook with laughter as he said the same thing to Gotou that he'd said to Yakumo .

These were clearly clothes for some hooligan . There were even sunglasses .

'You making fun of me?'

'If you don't like it, go naked . '

The old man really never shut his mouth .

'I'll just change then . '

Gotou said that brusquely and put on the shirt and pants .

'Doesn't it suit you well?' said Yakumo, cackling after Gotou put on the sunglasses .

Gotou didn't even feel like retorting any more . He just snorted and looked away .

'Where's the food?' Gotou asked Eishin .

'This is Yakumo's and this is yours . '

Eishin gave a sweet roll to Yakumo and a can to Gotou .

When Gotou saw that can, he couldn't put up with it any more .

'This is cat food!' he yelled, throwing the can of cat food with all his strength .

Clunk!

The can of cat food hit the BMW's bonnet, leaving a huge dent before rolling to the floor .

'You're paying for repairs,' Eishin said nonchalantly .

18

Ishii stood in front of the door to the apartment and cleared his throat .

Though this was for the investigation of the case, he felt uncomfortable .

It would have been different if they had found the missing daughter, but they had no new information and were just trying to dig up the past .

He couldn't imagine what awful things would be said to him .

'Are you all right?'

From beside him, Makoto peered at his face in concern .

'Ah, yes . I'm fine . '

If they came in a large group, it would put the other party on guard, so Ishii had left Haruka in the care and come with only Makoto .

Haruka had said, 'I'll go too . ' I want to do something for Yakumo – that feeling ran ahead of her .

Ishii understood, but Haruka looked like a student . If the other party became suspicious, they would need to make up an explanation . The other

party might also keep their mouth shut . Somehow, he managed to make Haruka understand and had her stay behind .

Ishii pressed the intercom button .

After a while, a woman with hair streaked with white opened the door .

'Excuse me... Are you Masuoka-san?'

'Yes,' the woman replied in a hoarse voice .

It appeared that she was Minami's mother, Masuoka Tamae .

From the documents, Minami's mother should have been in her early fifties, but she looked ten years older .

'My name is Ishii . I was the one who called . This is Hijikata,' said Ishii while showing his police ID .

They'd be out if she asked who Makoto was, but Tamae just replied 'Ah, yes' in a faint voice and opened the door to let them in .

'Excuse me . '

Ishii went inside after exchanging glances with Makoto .

It was an old one-room flat with a kitchen, probably near thirty years old .

Ishii and Makoto sat next to each other, while Tamae sat opposite them .

'Why... now...'

Tamae's wrinkled face looked at Ishii .

Her eyes were so lifeless it made Ishii suspect she might actually be dead .

Her daughter had disappeared and her husband had committed suicide .
Tamae had lost far too much .

That feeling of loss had stolen all her strength .

Swallowed up by that air, the excuse Ishii had come up with got caught in his throat .

'Actually, through the investigation of another case, it seems that we may be able to attain information related to your daughter's location .
Accordingly...'

Makoto responded for Ishii, who had been at a loss for words .

Ishii felt like she was more accustomed to the situation than himself, though he was a detective .

'I see...'

Tamae looked down .

'A-anything is fine . Would you please tell us what you remember?'

Ishii finally said just that .

'I know . '

'Eh?'

'She isn't alive any more,' said Tamae in a voice that sounded like it would fade away at any moment .

'Isn't alive...'

'She was killed . '

Ishii was shocked .

Partially it was because of the weight of those words, but it was also because he'd felt like there had been a black flame smouldering in Tamae's lifeless eyes for a moment .

'What is your evidence for thinking that?' said Ishii while wiping his forehead .

'I know . I'm a parent...'

Tamae looked to the corner of the room .

There was a small altar there with the images of a smiling girl and a middle-aged man . The girl was probably Minami .

She had black eyes and seemed like a refreshing girl, somewhat like Haruka .

'I understand how you feel, but...'

Makoto stopped in the middle of her sentence .

Tamae wasn't listening .

She slowly stood up and opened the sliding door to the closet, taking a cardboard box out of it and placing it on the table .

'All of her things are in here . '

Tamae's shoulders drooped like all the air had come out of her .

'Would you allow us to borrow this?'

Tamae just gave a small nod to Ishii's question .

– Tamae wants to die .

That was what Ishii thought .

Rather than living with their memories, she wanted to go to where her daughter and husband were .

The sun set between the mountains, dyeing the mountain range red .

Gotou hid in the thicket behind Seidou's temple and looked at the empty sky .

It had been over two hours . Mosquitoes had bitten him all over – it itched like hell .

And he could never be sure if he might get bitten by a pit viper like Yakumo in a place like this .

'But it's late,' said Gotou, hitting the mosquito on his arm .

– Did he run off?

At Eishin's instructions, Gotou had parked the car near the temple and walked through the thicket .

There were probably still police at the temple . Since they knew what Gotou and Yakumo looked like, they couldn't just walk up .

That was why Eishin had gone himself .

He'd given his mobile to Gotou and said something unreliable – 'I'll call you if it goes well' – before leaving .

'You can go back if you don't like it,' said Yakumo from beside him, yawning as he did so .

Easy for him to say . Unfortunately, Gotou didn't have anywhere to return to, so he was waiting for Eishin here . That came to his head, but he was too tired to even retort .

When he turned his eyes, he saw another mosquito on his arm .

'Damn it!'

Gotou brought his palm down, but the mosquito got away .

'Are you having fun?' said Yakumo, looking at Gotou like he was something dirty .

'Of course I'm not . There's a hell of a lot of mosquitoes here . '

'It's because you're wearing a tasteless shirt . '

Yakumo pointed at Gotou's purple shirt .

– This guy never shuts up .

'This isn't my shirt!'

'Please don't speak so loudly . They'll find us . '

Yakumo stuck his fingers in his ears to complain .

Gotou restrained his anger by balling his hands into fists . This guy could just get bitten by a pit viper again .

Just as Gotou had spit out, the mobile phone rang .

'You're late!' said Gotou with all his pent-up dissatisfaction .

<Don't say that . It was tough on me too . They suspected that I was the monk who ran away together with the detective at the clinic . >

Eishin said that with a sigh .

'Of course you were suspected . It was you . '

<Then should I give myself up to the police? I was forced by the violent detective – I had no choice...>

'Yeah, my bad . '

Gotou quickly apologised . Since it was Eishin, he might really do it .

<You should just be honest from the start . >

Gotou bit back the urge to scream .

'So how's the situation?'

<The police are standing guard outside the doors . Come around the back to the main temple . >

Because the temple itself wasn't the scene of the murder, the police had two guards just in case, but they hadn't gone inside . However –

'How do we get in?'

Even if the police weren't on the premises, they would notice if there were noises from the thicket .

<You can see a large rock a bit deeper in, right?>

After Eishin said that, Gotou looked to the back of the thicket .

– There it is .

A large rock covered in green moss . It was the height of a person's waist .

'I see it . '

<There's a narrow secret path by that rock . It goes to the main temple . >

'Why's there a secret path?'

Gotou cocked his head .

This wasn't some ninja house . He didn't understand why on earth somebody had made that .

<Monks in training are forced to live their lives in abstinence . Though that isn't the case now, that policy was thoroughly enforced in the past . >

'So monks in training that couldn't do it any longer dug a secret path?'

<Well, something like it . It used to be a well, but since it was no longer in use, there was a tunnel there . >

Eishin said that proudly .

From that tone, Eishin had probably played a part in the creation of that secret path . So he was a depraved monk, just like he looked .

Though Gotou felt half-astonished, he said 'Got it' and hung up .

When he looked up, the sun had set and night had fallen .

— This is a good chance .

'Yakumo . Let's go . '

Gotou went ahead and started to walk towards the rock .

20

'Please go ahead . '

At Makoto's urging, Haruka went through the entrance .

After leaving Tamae's house, they went talk in Makoto's flat to organise their thoughts .

Makoto led her through the corridor to a room of ten tatami in size .

'What a lovely room,' said Haruka, looking around .

The furniture and curtains were chic and calming .

'It makes me happy to hear that . Please sit down . '

'Ah, yes . '

Haruka sat on the dining room chair near the kitchen counter .

Makoto went into the kitchen and started preparations, boiling water and taking out cups .

'I'll help . '

'Don't worry about it,' replied Makoto with a smile .

Just as Haruka was feeling like she had nothing to do, Ishii came into the room with a cardboard box . It contained Minami's belongings, which they had received from Tamae .

It looked like Ishii didn't have a good grip and might trip and drop it at any moment .

'I'll hold this . '

'Ah, sorry about that . '

Haruka helped Ishii place the cardboard box on the dining room table .

'Thank you for the help . '

'No, it's nothing . '

Haruka sat across from Ishii at the table .

With perfect timing, Makoto took a tray out with a number of coffee cups . After placing a cup in front of each of them, she sat next to Ishii .

'You look a bit like a newly married couple,' said Haruka as she looked at Ishii and Makoto sitting next to each other .

Both Ishii's and Makoto's eyes went wide in surprise . Then, they both went red up to their ears .

'More importantly, let's investigate . '

Makoto quickly opened the cardboard box and started laying its contents out on the table .

There were things like notebooks, textbooks, albums and essays .

'Where should we start...'

Haruka looked at Ishii .

'Ah, that's right... Something... that looks like it might be useful?'

Ishii cocked his head .

'Let's just look at all of it first . '

Makoto took a notebook near her and started flipping through it .

Just as she said, rather than thinking so much, just looking at it might be quicker . Haruka took an essay near her and started flipping the pages .

After that, they continued looking through the contents of the cardboard box without talking .

When Haruka looked at the papers and photos that came out of the cardboard box, the blurry image she had had of Minami became clearer .

Minami had pale skin and well-defined features – she was quite a beauty . She was in the drama club and seemed o have wanted to become an actress in the future .

Her grades weren't bad either . Though she wasn't good at maths, she was strong with the classics and world history .

Doing this made Haruka feel like Minami had been one of her own classmates .

However, Minami's life, which should have been smooth sailing, had broken off right before her graduation . Like everything before it had been an illusion –

Haruka suddenly stopped and looked up at the ceiling .

– Will doing this really clear Yakumo's name?

That question came to her head .

In the first place, they had no clear proof that Minami was related to the case . They just had the theory that she might be related to a spiritual phenomenon that occurred at the scene of the crime .

After drinking some cold coffee, Haruka spotted a white envelope .

<To Minamie> was written on it in strong, angular letters .

There was a letter inside .

<And as my love is sized, my fear is so:

Where love is great, the littlest doubts are fear .

Where little fears grow great, great love grows there . >

It looked like a quotation from a poem .

Though it was roundabout, it was easy to tell it was a love letter . At the end, there were initials .

<Y . N . >

It looked like Minami had had a lover .

Haruka was going to mention the love letter, but Ishii stood up before then with a loud noise .

'Aaahhh!'

Ishii's mouth was so wide that it felt like his chin might come off .

'What is it?'

Makoto grabbed Ishii's arm .

'Ah, no, I mean...'

Ishii pointed at the graduation album he had been looking at .

It was from a high school graduation . Ishii had it open to a page with the names and faces of the students in each class .

'Minami-san's photo is in here,' said Haruka as she looked at the page .

'Since she disappeared right around graduation, maybe she was put in the album anyway?'

'T-that isn't it . '

Ishii shook his head at Makoto's explanation .

'Is there another reason?'

'No, that isn't it . This person . '

Ishii pointed at a man on the page .

– Matsumoto Hiroshi .

He was thin and had angled eyes . Though he looked like a sensitive person, that was all .

'What about this person?' asked Haruka .

'No, I mean, it's this person . '

'Eh?'

'The person who was found dead in Nishitama this morning . '

Ishii was agitated, continually pointing at the photo as he said that .

Haruka was shocked by that fact and looked towards the album again .

'Hey, wait a second...'

Makoto put her chin in her hand as she murmured .

'What is it?' asked Ishii .

'The family name of the dead Seidou-san was, if I remember correctly...'

'Er... It was Todayama,' replied Ishii after looking at his notebook .

'I wonder if this could be...'

Makoto pointed at a young man in the middle of the page .

The young man was short and stout and had eyes as narrow as string, fat eyebrows that didn't match and fleshy lips .

– Todayama Takahiro .

Todayama was a rare family name . It would be difficult to think of it as a coincidence .

'This is troubling . I'll go back to the precinct to confirm . '

In a hurry, Ishii attempted to leave the room .

'Please wait . '

Haruka called out to stop Ishii .

There had been such an amount of information that Haruka had almost forgotten .

'What is it?'

'I also found something interesting . '

Haruka held out the letter . Ishii and Makoto took turns reading it .

'So she had a lover,' said Ishii .

'And as my love is sized... This is Shakespeare . A line from Hamlet,' said Makoto .

At that, Haruka had an idea .

'Minami-san was in the drama club, right? Somebody who'd send a love letter like this might have been in the drama club...'

'That's possible . Somebody in the drama club with the initials Y . N,' agreed Makoto .

'Yes . '

'I see . '

Ishii nodded with his arms crossed, seeming impressed .

'Let's split up the work . Ishii-san, please head back to confirm . Haruka-chan and I will look for the person with these initials . '

Makoto briskly split up the roles .

'Right . That would be more effective . Please do so . '

After Ishii replied, he quickly ran off .

'Now, let's start too . '

Makoto clapped her hands together .

'Yes,' replied Haruka .

Though they had been jumping at shadows, Haruka felt like they were now much closer to the truth .

Gotou was stooped over as he proceeded down the dark tunnel .

It was so narrow they had to go one at a time, and if he lifted his head even slightly, he would hit the ceiling .

The uncomfortable moistness made it hard to breathe . His back was drenched with sweat, making his shirt stick to him .

– Can we really get to the temple through here?

His anxiety grew the further he advanced .

'Gotou-san . '

Yakumo spoke up from right behind him .

'What?'

'Please illuminate this . '

In this situation, Gotou had no idea where Yakumo was talking about .

Gotou painfully turned himself around .

'Here . '

Yakumo said that again and pointed at his feet .

Gotou did as he was told and pointed the light of his torch towards his feet .

Though it was faint, there was a footprint there .

The toes were pointing in the opposite direction from them . It was clear that it wasn't their footprint .

'What's this?'

'A footprint,' Yakumo replied immediately .

'I know that . What I was asking is...'

'Please hurry up and turn towards the front again,' said Yakumo, interrupting Gotou .

'What?'

'It is difficult to look at our face at such a close distance, Gotou-san . '

'That's unnecessary . '

Gotou clicked his tongue and then turned around again in the narrow tunnel before starting to walk once more .

Sweat was rolling down his forehead . After advancing about fifty metres, the path ended and he exited into a round space .

It looked like they'd reached the old well . Finally he could stretch out his waist .

Gotou stretched and looked up . It was about five metres tall . There was a wooden cover on the well .

'There's no staircase . How are we supposed to get up?'

'You can just climb, right?' said Yakumo with a yawn .

It looked like Yakumo had no intention of climbing himself . Though it irritated Gotou, for Yakumo, whose left leg was still swollen, it was true that he wouldn't be able to climb .

Gotou rolled up his sleeves, put his fingers in the cracks between the rocks in the well's walls, and dragged himself up, placing his feet in another crack . It was like rock climbing .

– Looks like it'll be all right .

Gotou gritted his teeth and climbed up the well's walls .

Though the first metre went well, it suddenly became more difficult after that .

His fingers were numb and his arms were shaking .

His legs were strained, making it difficult for him to plant his feet .

'Are you already tired?'

Yakumo was looking up in a carefree manner from the bottom of the well .

'Shut up! I'm completely fine!'

Gotou was acting strong as he reached for the next stone, but perhaps because of the loss in concentration, he couldn't grab on properly and slipped .

– Crap .

It was too late when he thought that .

Pulled down by gravity, Gotou fell to the bottom of the well .

There was a dull thump as he hit the floor .

For a moment, he stopped breathing and coughed a number of times .

'You fell because of your excess flesh,' said Yakumo, running his fingers through his hair .

– This guy is really annoying .

Gotou wanted to hit Yakumo's head, but the pain from his back made him unable to even stand up .

'You go next,' said Gotou .

'I will . '

Just as Yakumo said that, the lid to the well opened and Eishin peered in from the round hole .

'I'll lower a rope now . '

Eishin swiftly let the rope down .

– Why didn't you come earlier?

Gotou finally got up while bearing with his pain .

'Well, I'll go on ahead then,' said Yakumo triumphantly, grabbing the rope .

22

After leaving Makoto's room, Ishii went to the road and waved over a taxi .

'To the Setamachi precinct . '

He told the driver his destination and called Youko's mobile phone immediately .

To be honest, he felt awkward calling her when Gotou was running away .

However, it would be worse to call Miyagawa . He felt like Youko might cooperate .

'It's Ishii . '

<Where are you now?>

Youko spoke with a pointed tone .

'Even if you ask me where...'

<Answer my question . >

'I'm in a taxi, heading to the precinct .

<Detective Gotou isn't with you?>

'He isn't . '

I'm not lying, Ishii told himself . He'd talked with Yakumo on the phone, but he didn't dare to say that aloud .

<What were you doing?>

'Actually, I was investigating a number of things...'

<Investigating?>

Ishii explained everything he'd found out so far to Youko .

Starting with the spiritual phenomenon near the limestone cavern, he investigated the missing woman named Minami and met her mother, Tamae .

Then, he spotted the name Matsumoto Hiroshi, the person who was found dead this morning, in Minami's classmates . And a name with the same family name as Seidou –

Ishii held his breath as he waited for Youko to speak .

<In short, you want to check if the Matsumoto Hiroshi in that album is the same Matsumoto Hiroshi who was killed . >

Youko said that with a sigh .

'Yes . And...'

<And you want to know whether the boy called Todayama in the same class was Seidou's son . >

Youko interrupted Ishii's agitated words .

'Yes!'

<Did you think I'd believe that?>

Contrary to Ishii's agitation, Youko's tone was cold .

If Youko didn't believe him, he wouldn't be able to get any information .
Gotou wouldn't have a place to return to – he would remain a fugitive .

Ishii was determined to absolutely not back down .

'You may believe it is unrelated, but don't you think it's too much to be a coincidence?'

<That's...>

Though Youko was always firm, she was lost for words .

– She's undecided .

That was how Ishii felt .

'This isn't a coincidence . '

<If the police could solve cases by chasing spiritual phenomena, we
wouldn't have any problems . >

'However, that is how we have done things before . From seemingly
unrelated spiritual phenomena, we investigate a number of things and reach
the truth . '

Ishii's speaking was unusually erratic from his agitation . He knew that .

<You can't say it'll be the same this time, right?>

'In order to confirm that, we need to investigate . '

<There's no time to do that . We need to search for Detective Gotou first . >

'That's wrong!'

Ishii had yelled before he'd noticed it .

<What's wrong?>

Youko said that after a pause .

Ishii didn't know either . What was he saying was wrong –

However, there was one thing Ishii did know .

'I want to save Detective Gotou . '

By saying it aloud, the anxiety in Ishii's heart grew larger and he was moved to tears .

Gotou had always walked together with Ishii without abandoning him .

'If Detective Gotou is gone, I'll just be an empty shell . I want to make a place for Detective Gotou, no matter what I have to do . '

Even though he hadn't meant to say it, those words naturally fell out from his mouth .

He knew it was inappropriate for him to say that as a detective, but those were his true feelings .

<You really like Detective Gotou . >

Youko laughed, sounding exasperated .

'I look up to him .

<I had somebody like that before too . >

'Eh?'

Ishii recalled the story of Youko's dead lover's ghost .

That was probably the person Youko looked up to .

<I'll look into it . >

She hung up after saying that .

The strength left Ishii's body and he sank into the backseat .

'Did you make up?'

The taxi driver smirked while looking at the rear-view mirror .

It seemed like he had misunderstood something, but Ishii didn't have the energy to correct him .

'Yes, somehow,' replied Ishii with a smile .

23

Haruka was looking at the list of drama club members for somebody with the initials Y . N .

There weren't many male members . Even if she switched the family name and given name, the only boy that fit was Naitou Yousuke .

'Let's try calling him . '

Right after saying that, Makoto called the number in the register .

Haruka was astonished by Makoto's quick decision-making .

While Makoto was calling, Haruka sipped her lukewarm coffee and looked at the love letter from earlier .

In Haruka's head, Yakumo's face came to mind .

When Minami became missing, the person who sent the love letter must have been like her – worried about the safety of the person he thought so dearly of, believing she would return .

When Haruka thought about that, her chest hurt .

'Thinking about Yakumo-kun again?' said Makoto mischievously . She had finished her call .

'No, that isn't it . Just...'

'What?'

'It must have been tough . For his lover to have been missing for over ten years – I can't think about it...'

Haruka said exactly what she had been thinking .

'So you really were thinking about Yakumo-kun . '

Makoto laughed with shaking shoulders .

'More importantly, how was it?' asked Haruka to change the subject .

'Ah, right, right . After calling the number, I was told he was living by himself in an apartment now, so I lied and said I was a classmate from high school and got his address and mobile phone number . '

Makoto flipped open her memo pad while sticking out her tongue like a child who had played a prank .

'I'll call him now . '

'I'll do it . '

Haruka felt awkward leaving everything to Makoto .

Haruka leant forward and took the memo Makoto was holding .

'Will you be all right?'

'Yes . '

'All right . Thank you . '

Makoto seemed to have sensed how Haruka felt, as she smiled and slowly drank her coffee .

Haruka took her mobile from her bag and input the number on the memo right away . The call connected and rang .

– One, two, three .

She counted in her heart .

However, no matter how she waited, nobody picked up .

Thinking that she might have mistaken the number, she checked the memo, but she hadn't been wrong .

'Won't answer?' said Makoto .

'Yes . Perhaps it's because it's a number he doesn't recognise?'

'Perhaps...'

Haruka placed her mobile on the table and lay her head on it .

She had worked herself up and was disappointed for it . It might be better to leave some time before calling again .

'Right . '

Makoto seemed to have thought of something and snapped her fingers .

'What is it?'

'Anyway, shall we go take a look?'

'Eh?'

'At this time, I think it won't even take an hour if we drive quickly . '

Makoto stood up while looking at the clock .

,

That's right . '

Haruka stood up as well .

24

Gotou stood in the temple with Yakumo .

The wide wooden space had a statue of Buddha in the front .

The air was tense .

There was a heavy atmosphere – it felt like it was a different world .

Yakumo, standing next to Gotou, was looking down while facing the Buddha statue . It was like they were talking .

'Anyway, let's sit . '

Gotou sat down cross-legged on the wooden floor, but Yakumo didn't even budge .

Perhaps because he was wearing monk's working robes, he looked like a real monk .

'Sorry for the wait . '

Eishin walked in through the corridor .

Behind him, there was the trainee monk named Shuuei that Gotou had met yesterday along with a girl about ten years old .

She was Hatsune, the girl who claimed to have been reincarnated –

With pale, almost translucent skin, her lips alone were a vivid red, which seemed ridiculously coquettish .

Perhaps Eishin had changed along with the temple's atmosphere, because his joking attitude from before had completely disappeared . He walked into the temple, pulling Hatsune along until they stood in front of Yakumo .

'I brought her, like you wanted,' said Eishin monotonously .

Yakumo nodded silently .

Gotou cleared his throat loudly and swallowed .

After Yakumo took a deep breath, he walked up to Hatsune and knelt, as if he were about to pray .

Hatsune just stood there without even a tremor .

'We've met before . Do you remember?' said Yakumo in a murmur .

Hatsune nodded .

'I have something I want to ask you today, Hatsune-chan . '

'I'm not Hatsune . I'm called Minami . '

Hatsune spoke in a pleasant, ringing voice, like the bells that monks used .

– What are you going to do, Yakumo?

Gotou watched carefully to see what would happen .

'Then, Minami-san . Could I ask you one thing?'

Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair .

'What?'

'Have you met Minami-san – that is, your mother before?'

Gotou cocked his head . He didn't understand the point of Yakumo's question .

If Hatsune was Minami's reincarnation, there would be no way for her to meet Minami . Since she was Minami herself .

However, unlike what Gotou thought, Minami nodded with a smile .

'Yup . Mother's always with me . '

'She talks to you . '

'Yes, she does . '

'I see . So you really can hear her . '

— What does he mean?

Without saying anything, Eishin held his elbows horizontally and placed his hands together in front of his chest, standing still .

Just like Buddha .

From behind him, Shuuei was looking down, seeming troubled .

'Oi, Yakumo . '

Gotou spoke up, unable to keep quiet .

'Please be quiet . '

When Yakumo turned around, his eyes were menacing .

'M-my bad...'

Gotou shut up under that pressure .

Yakumo ran his hands through his hair in his exasperation and turned towards Hatsune again .

'Your mother said it, right? That you were her reincarnation...'

'She did . Mother told me,' Hatsune replied cheerfully .

'So that really is how it is...'

After Yakumo murmured that, he narrowed his eyes and put the index finger of his left hand to his brow .

'Did you find something out?' Gotou asked, but Yakumo glared at him right away .

'Not yet!'

When Yakumo said that, he looked incredibly sad .

'Is this kid really a reincarnation?' asked Eishin .

'You should know that she isn't, Eishin-san,' replied Yakumo with a frown .

Eishin laughed pleasantly when he heard that .

Though the two of them were on the same page, Gotou didn't understand .

'What are you talking about?'

'The one thing that is clear is that she isn't a reincarnation,' said Yakumo .

– She isn't a reincarnation .

Then what was she? She had taken Minami's name from nowhere . And why did she know the location of the limestone cavern and the lake? Where'd she hear about being murdered and sunken into the lake?

Questions kept coming up in Gotou's head, burying him as he couldn't solve them .

'Where are Seidou-san's things?'

'The police took them . '

Eishin responded to Yakumo's question .

That was natural . The police must have been frantically searching for a link to Yakumo in Seidou's things .

'I see... Does this temple have another place like an archive?'

'Does it?'

Eishin turned his head and looked at Shuuei .

'At a little distance, yes...'

Shuuei seemed to have sensed their intentions, as he responded while looking down .

'Would you show me the way?' Yakumo said quietly .

His expression was filled with confidence – as if he had solved all the mysteries .

25

Ishii waited for Youko in a family restaurant by the highway .

To be honest, he had wanted to return to the precinct .

Since he'd run out of there, he had just left documents on his desk .
However, he had changed his mind after going close to the precinct .

The police precinct had been surrounded by an amazing number of people from the press . It was natural, now that he thought about it . A current police officer had escaped with the suspect in a murder . This was a huge incident that was yet unheard of .

Ishii didn't want to think about what the other members – not just Miyagawa – would say if he returned there so carelessly .

He wouldn't even be able to investigate .

He contacted Youko immediately and they decided to meet up at this family restaurant . Ishii used his free time to try to call Gotou's mobile, but there was no response .

He had spent nearly an hour drinking coffee while whiling away the time .

If he had known this was going to happen, he would have helped Haruka and Makoto more with the investigation, but it was too late now .

'It seems like I've made you wait . '

Youko hurried over and sat across from Ishii .

'Ah!'

Ishii's spine went as straight as a rod as he greeted Youko .

Her face seemed a bit flushed .

Did she rush here, or —

Youko called a server over with deliberately slow actions . After ordering a drink, she took a file from her bag .

'How was it?' asked Ishii, like a dog badgering for treats .

'Amazing . '

Youko breathed out and brushed back her hair . She looked satisfied .

'Er...'

'Calm down . '

After Youko reprimanded him, Ishii's shoulders slumped .

'First, Matsumoto Hiroshi, the corpse found this morning, is the same Matsumoto Hiroshi in the album . '

'A-as I thought!'

Ishii was so excited that he shouted . He hurriedly covered his mouth with both hands .

Youko looked exasperated as she put her chin in her hand .

'I don't know if you're really tired or just a scatterbrain . '

'I-I'm sorry . '

Ishii's shoulders slumped again as he lost his energy .

He knew he was clumsy . He always did something wrong . That was why he tried not to mess up, but that just made things worse .

'You feel like the type people can't leave alone . '

'It's true . I'm unreliable . '

'That isn't it – more like... Well, it's fine . Let's return to the topic at hand,' said Youko with a sigh .

'So... How about Todayama-san?' asked Ishii, regaining his spirits .

'It was as you thought on this point too . The person in the album is Seidou's dead son . '

'So it was just as I thought . '

Ishii gripped his hands into fists .

Now, it couldn't be a coincidence . Minami, who disappeared ten years ago . The murdered Matsumoto Hiroshi . And Seidou's son, Takahiro . They were in the same grade at the same school .

'Come to think of it, Seidou-san's son, Todayama Takahiro-san...'

'Committed suicide,' finished Youko .

'Do you know the reason?'

'I was curious as well and caught the person in charge before coming here to ask...'

Youko had a complicated expression on her face .

'How was it?'

Ishii brought his face closer to Youko's and held his breath .

'It seems like there was no note . It seems like there's no doubt it was a suicide from the situation . From the testimony of people around him, he had been rather depressed before the suicide . '

'I see...'

'But...'

'What is it?'

'It seems like the first to find him was his father, Seidou . '

Youko's words echoed in Ishii's chest .

The father found his child's corpse . Just thinking about it hurt . How must he have felt then?

Ishii had no way of imagining it .

Suddenly, the mobile phone on the table rang .

Ishii's shoulders jolted . He just watched the mobile phone vibrate .

He had a very bad feeling .

If he answered the phone, it would become a big problem . That vague anxiety went through Ishii's whole body .

'Aren't you going to answer?'

'Ah, yes...'

Urged on by Youko, Ishii picked up the mobile .

'Hello...'

26

Haruka was in front of an apartment outside of Nishitama Station's shopping street .

She was looking around from the passenger seat of the car parked at the side of the road .

It was dark . On the street devoid of people, there was a three-storey building .

Naitou Yousuke's room was Room 203 . In the middle of the second storey .

'The lights are on,' said Makoto from the driver's seat .

Just as she said, there was light coming from what was probably the frosted glass window of the kitchen .

'We're lucky . '

Haruka's expression softened .

Though the owner might have just forgotten to turn the lights off, it was likely that he was in his room . It would be a waste if they came without meeting him .

'Shall we go then?'

Makoto got off the car . Haruka followed her .

They went up to the second storey using the metal stairs outside and stood in front of the door .

When Haruka put her ear near the door, she could faintly hear people talking . Haruka nodded . Makoto pressed the intercom button .

There was a noise outside the room – ding dong .

However, the door didn't open .

Makoto pressed the button a number of times, but still nobody came out .

'Good evening . '

Haruka spoke as she knocked on the door .

However, the result was the same .

Something was strange . Haruka had a bad feeling .

'Is he out...'

Makoto tried the doorknob . There was a click – the door opened slightly .

Haruka's heart started beating more quickly .

– You can't go inside .

She felt like somebody had whispered that in her ear . Haruka knew immediately who it was . It was the cry of her own heart .

While Haruka was troubled, Makoto opened the door more widely .

There was a corridor with a kitchen in front of the entrance, and on the right, there was a washroom . Ahead of the corridor was a room with a wooden floor .

The television was on .

A talk show with a comedian was playing .

The voices Haruka had heard earlier must have been from the television .

'Excuse me, Naitou-san . '

Makoto called out from the entrance .

However, there was no reply .

'Please excuse me . '

Makoto took off her pumps at the entrance and went inside .

Haruka followed her .

'It seems like he really isn't here,' said Makoto with slumped shoulders as she peered around the room .

Leaving the television and lights on when going out – it was a bit hard to believe .

'I see...'

Though Haruka said that, the anxiety in her heart didn't clear .

– What is this feeling?

'Shall we go?'

Makoto went back to the entrance to leave .

Haruka was about to follow her when her eyes fell on the frosted glass of the bathroom .

Her forehead was covered with a cold sweat .

'What's wrong?'

Without replying to Makoto's question, Haruka stood in front of the door to the bathroom .

– Here .

She had no evidence . She just felt it instinctively .

Haruka opened the bathroom door with a sweaty hand .

When she saw the scene in front of her, she couldn't even make a sound .
The strength in her body left her and she collapsed right there .

Inside the bathtub, a man, covered in blood, lay with his limbs dangling out .

3

Gotou opened the sliding door to the temple .

It was quiet –

All he could hear was the sound of the pouring rain .

Eishin was sitting in the middle of the temple with his hand in some sort of religious gesture .

He had his spine straight and was looking straight forward – he was as still as if he had become Buddha .

Though his half-open eyes seemed hollow, there was a strong light in them .

Gotou didn't understand the heart of Zen, but as Eishin sat there, it looked like he was emitting some mysterious aura .

'Oi . '

Though Gotou called out, Eishin didn't move .

– Did he not hear me?

'Oi, you damn monk . '

Gotou called out again while walking up to Eishin .

'I know you're there even without all that noise,' said Eishin .

When he spoke, only his lips moved – it was creepy, like he was a talking mechanical doll .

'f you know, then reply . '

Gotou sat cross-legged in front of Eishin .

'What do you want?'

'That's quite a tone . I can't think of you as Isshin's teacher,' said Gotou, expressing his dissatisfaction .

Suddenly, the days Gotou had spent with Isshin came to mind .

Isshin was a broadminded man . He was always gentle and kind to everyone . Just seeing that smile would make Gotou feel better for some reason .

– Why did Isshin have to die?

Gotou still thought that sometimes now .

'You say that because you don't know what Isshin was like before . '

Eishin breathed out, relaxing his body . His face became more human, like he had taken off a mask .

'What do you mean?'

'Isshin is very similar to Yakumo . '

Gotou didn't understand what Eishin said .

'What part of him?'

'Before Isshin took Yakumo in, he had been terribly troubled . At one point, he denied his own existence . '

'Denied?'

'He was filled with anger that had no outlet – he always had a grim expression on his face . '

'That guy did?'

Gotou really didn't understand .

No matter how Gotou searched his memories, Isshin was always smiling in them .

'Because he found out the truth . '

'The truth?'

Gotou didn't understand .

He felt like they were talking about somebody else entirely .

'It's not like Isshin was at fault, but because of his personality, he tried to shoulder all the blame . '

'What are you talking about?'

'You could call it fate...'

Eishin stared into nothingness .

– Fate?

'You talking about Yakumo?'

'Yakumo is only one part of a larger flow . I'm talking about a fate that continued from much before then . Everything started in this temple, when a man and woman met . '

'Explain in a way I'll understand . '

Gotou pressed Eishin for an answer in his irritation .

However, Eishin continued, still staring into nothingness .

'Isshin compared that fate with his own existence . At that time, he had forgotten heart of ensou, which is the basis of Zen .

'Ensou?'

'That's right . If the heart is not in order, one cannot see clearly . Isshin's fate had shaken his heart . '

Gotou really didn't understand what Eishin was talking about .

He didn't understand, but for some reason, he was curious .

'So then what happened?'

'The one who changed Isshin's heart was Yakumo . '

Eishin's lips relaxed into a small smile .

He alone held all the cards . That was how it looked like to Gotou .

'What part of Yakumo changed Isshin?'

'His existence . By walking with Yakumo, Isshin was able to face his fate . He became his original self . '

'What's that fate you're talking about?'

'You know as well . It's that man . '

Eishin's mouth shut tightly .

Gotou knew who that man was .

'The man with two red eyes?'

'That's right . Isshin has a connection with that man that cannot be cut . '

'Isshin was just wrapped up in the incident, right?' said Gotou offhandedly .

'Wrong . '

Eishin shook his head .

'What do you mean?'

Without responding to Gotou's question, Eishin stood up .

'Answer me . '

Gotou continued to hound Eishin .

'You'll understand soon enough . More importantly, what did you come here for?'

Eishin sudden changed the subject .

Stopping the conversation right before the crucial point – he really was just like Yakumo . Eishin probably wouldn't say anything no matter what Gotou asked . Gotou gave in and stood up .

'I want to ask a favour . '

'Do you want me to introduce you to a woman?'

There was a lascivious smirk on Eishin's face .

Even though he was so solemn when meditating, there was not even a fragment of that now .

'I've got a wife . '

'So you're more proper than you look . '

– It really didn't sound like something a monk should say .

'That isn't the problem . Anyway, I came to borrow your mobile . '

'What do you say when asking for a favour?' said Eishin with a laugh .

He really was like Yakumo .

'Please lend me your mobile . I would greatly appreciate it . '

Gotou buried his anger in the pit of his stomach as he lowered his head .

'You should have been honest like that from the start,' said Eishin while taking his mobile out for Gotou .

– Meditating with his mobile there – what an awful monk .

Gotou said abusive words in his heart while taking the mobile .

4

'Excuse me . '

After saying that to Youko, Ishii stepped away from the door .

The number on his mobile was unfamiliar to him . Who could it be –

Though confused, Ishii answered the phone .

'Hello . '

<It's me . >

– Detective Gotou!

Ishii was about to yell that, but he hurriedly stopped himself .

'P-please wait . '

There were police officers everywhere . If they found out he was talking with Gotou, it would be a serious problem .

Ishii looked around for a place he could talk without being watched .

The first and second floors were filled with people, but there were practically none on the third .

'I apologise for the wait,' said Ishii after walking to the outside corridor of the third floor .

<It's really noisy . >

Gotou sounded displeased .

'Ah, actually...'

Ishii explained in detail everything they had investigated up until now, including how Haruka and Makoto had found a corpse .

Though it was quite the complicated story, Ishii focussed on explaining chronologically, as Yakumo always told him to .

Gotou didn't interrupt, which was unusual .

<Seems like things are a mess over there too . >

Gotou said just that after Ishii finished his explanation .

'It is a bit confusing . '

Ishii had run about frantically up until now, but once he heard Gotou's voice, he relaxed a bit and became weak .

His eyes were becoming wet with tears .

<It's my fault . Sorry . >

Gotou said that .

– Why is he apologising?

Ishii was confused . Though Gotou always got angry at him, he never apologised . Rather, Ishii was the one who wanted to apologise .

He had planned on investigating frantically to make a place for Gotou to return to, but there had been no developments at all .

He was completely useless like this .

'I'm the one who must apologise . If I had been more reliable...'

<Are you an idiot?>

'Eh?'

<This case is outside of your jurisdiction . That's not all . What I've done will make people give you a lot of flak . >

Gotou's voice was quiet and weak .

– Don't talk like that .

Ishii murmured that in his heart .

'Please don't worry about someone like me . Detective Gotou, I believe in you and Yakumo-shi . That's why I'm working . That's all . '

Ishii wasn't lying .

It was true that he had been a bit troubled earlier, but that had gone away completely .

<Well don't you sound competent . >

Gotou snorted .

Was that praise? Or was it a reprimand? Ishii didn't know .

He just felt that Gotou's voice sounded a bit stronger .

'Detective Gotou . '

<What?>

'If there's anything I can do, please tell me . If you want to flee overseas, I will help prepare . '

<Don't be ridiculous . I'm not the sort of guy who likes running . >

'That's right . '

<There's a request from Yakumo - will you hear it?>

'Of course,' Ishii replied immediately .

He would do anything if it would allow Gotou to come back, no matter what sacrifices he had to make .

<I want you to contact old man Hata and get the autopsy results for the victim . >

'Please consider it done!' declared Ishii .

<I'm counting on you, Assistant Inspector Ishii . >

'Yes sir!'

NOTES:

[1] In Japan, people drive on the left side of the road and the steering wheel is on the right side of the car .

Volume 8 Chapter 3: VOLUME 8 – THE VANISHED SPIRIT

Chapter 3

VOLUME 8 – THE VANISHED SPIRIT

file 03: ensou (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

Gotou and Yakumo went to something like a hut connected to the main temple by a corridor .

It was fairly dark; only two bare light bulbs hung from the ceiling .

It was a Japanese room of about ten tatami in size . Right past the entrance, there was a short Japanese-style writing desk . The rest was buried in books .

‘Amazing,’ said Gotou in admiration, but Yakumo started searching without any care for that .

‘What are you looking for?’

Gotou didn’t understand the situation, so he didn’t know why Yakumo had come to this archive .

Yakumo’s hands suddenly stopped . He ran a hand through his hair, looking annoyed .

'Seidou-san was a meticulous person . I think he may have kept something like a diary . '

'A diary, eh...'

Gotou muttered that as he started looking for a diary in the piled-up books and accounts .

Though it was just picking up books and checking the contents, all of the words were difficult to read .

Gotou had never been good at simple work like this .

He lost his concentration in no time .

'Hey, Yakumo,' said Gotou, his hands stopping .

'What is it?'

'You said that the girl wasn't reincarnated, right?'

Yakumo appeared to have understood the answer already, but there were too many things Gotou didn't understand .

'Yes,' Yakumo replied curtly .

'Then what is she?'

'She is who she is . '

Yakumo sent a glare Gotou's way .

Even if he looked at him with such scary eyes, Gotou couldn't understand the meaning of Yakumo's words .

'She is who she is... It's like some Zen question . '

'It isn't a Zen question . I'm saying she is nothing but herself . Even if she did have memories of the past, she would still be who she is . '

Yakumo's words were like some mathematics problem, inviting sleep .

Gotou yawned .

'How complicated . '

'No . It's simple . '

'Sounds complicated to me . '

'Should I explain it with a picture book?' Yakumo's expression softened as he said that .

'You making fun of me?'

'Good job; you understood . '

Yakumo applauded .

It seemed like he was seriously making fun of him . Gotou clicked his tongue .

'This isn't the time to be making stupid jokes, right?'

'What a coincidence . I was just thinking that I didn't have the time to waste it talking with you, Gotou-san . '

— This brat never shuts up .

Though Gotou was irritated, he was happy to be able to talk with Yakumo like this again .

'Gotou-san, if you don't feel like helping, could you check the situation with Ishii-san?'

'Ishii, eh...'

Gotou looked up at the ceiling .

Come to think of it, he hadn't been able to talk properly with Ishii this time .

Before coming to the temple, Yakumo appeared to have made a request of Ishii . Gotou wanted to know what happened after that too .

That said, since it was Ishii, he had probably just wandered around without doing anything useful .

'I'll go call then . '

Gotou stood up, but then he noticed a great problem .

'Oi . Yakumo . '

'What is it?'

'I don't have a phone . '

Yakumo had thrown Gotou's mobile phone on to some guy's truck .

'Can't you just borrow one from Eishin-san?' said Yakumo, flipping through the accounts .

That was right . He'd borrowed Eishin's mobile while they were waiting outside the temple too . He could just do the same thing . But –

'Where's he?'

'Probably the temple . '

Gotou left the archive, but then he noticed another problem .

'I don't know his number . '

Since the mobile phone had become explosively popular, people would just rely on the contacts list – nobody remembered other people's numbers any more .

Gotou didn't remember other people's numbers either .

'Here . '

As Yakumo said that, he threw something at Gotou .

Though he was surprised, Gotou caught it in front of his chest . It was an SD card for a mobile phone .

'The number is on there . '

Now, Gotou recalled what Yakumo had said about moving the data and put the SD card in his pocket .

'I'm going out for a bit . '

'Ah, that's right . '

Yakumo called out to Gotou as he was about to leave .

'What?'

'If the autopsy results for the corpse are out, please tell him to ask Hata-san for information .

'Yeah, yeah . '

After replying, Gotou left Yakumo in the archive and went to the temple through the corridor .

2

Ishii was irritated as he sat in the passenger seat

Rain hit the window .

'It's really pouring,' said Youko as she drove .

'It seems like a typhoon,' replied Ishii, staring out the window with bitterness .

It was because the typhoon was coming .

The rain was melancholy, fanning Ishii's anxiety .

– Somebody's dead .

The call Ishii received in the family restaurant was from Makoto .

Though her voice was shaking, she managed to keep her calm as she explained the events in order .

After receiving the information, Ishii immediately left the shop and was going to the scene in Youko's car .

Though it was only forty minutes, it felt incredibly long to Ishii .

'It's just ahead . '

Youko turned the wheel left .

Ishii could tell where the scene was right away . There was yellow tape around the area to stop people from trespassing and around it, there were curious onlookers and people from the press .

There were lights for the investigation and for cameras . Though it was night, it was as bright as noon .

'This is serious,' murmured Youko as she drove .

'It is...'

So many things had happened .

Starting with the discovery of Seidou's corpse, Yakumo's name came up as a suspect, the second corpse was found, Gotou became a fugitive while

aiding Yakumo's escape, and then Haruka and Makoto found the third victim – d

To be honest, Ishii was so frightened and confused he didn't know what to do .

However, he managed to keep himself together because Haruka and Makoto had been the ones who first discovered the corpse .

– I have to keep it together .

Led on by that impulse, Ishii opened the door and ran out the moment the car stopped .

The cold rain wet his cheek .

'Sorry, excuse me . '

As Ishii shouted that, he pushed through the crowd .

He showed his police ID to the uniformed officers there and tried to pass through the yellow tape, but somebody grabbed his arm .

'Excuse me, but this is out of your jurisdiction, isn't it?'

The young uniformed officer looked at Ishii with suspicious eyes .

'Ah, yes, but...'

Ishii couldn't think of an excuse to enter right away .

He thought it was annoying himself . At times like this, Gotou would have just said something like 'Shut up' and forced himself in, but Ishii couldn't do that .

He had just run forward with the want to go in, which made things even more unnatural .

'Natsume, from Criminal Affairs . I'm bringing him along . He can come in with me, right?'

Youko had come up behind him and said that as she showed her police ID . It was a firm attitude that didn't allow anyone to doubt it .

'Ah, yes . Please go ahead . '

The uniformed officer looked divided but he let Ishii and Youko pass .

'Thank you . '

After thanking Youko, Ishii went past the yellow tape .

He spotted Haruka and Makoto sitting by the flower garden in front of the apartment .

The two of them looked exhausted, but it didn't seem like they were injured . Ishii sighed in relief and went up to them .

'Ishii-san . '

Makoto noticed Ishii immediately and stood up .

'Are you all right?'

'Yes . '

Makoto's voice was clear .

Ishii looked towards Haruka .

Though she stood up, she stayed silent . It was clear she wasn't feeling well .

She had found a corpse that was stabbed all over . There was no helping it .

'I can't believe things turned out like this...' said Makoto, putting her hands together in front of her chest .

'It really is a serious matter . '

Ishii agreed with Makoto .

This case had gone beyond their expectations .

'Are they the ones?' said Youko, sounding curious .

'Ah, yes, that's right . '

For a moment, Ishii was confused as to why Youko knew Haruka and Makoto, but then he remembered that he'd talked to her about the investigation .

'This is Ozawa Haruka-chan and Hijikata Makoto-san . '

Ishii introduced each of them to Natsume . He was going to introduce Youko, but she showed her police ID before he could .

'I'm Natsume of the Nishitama precinct,' said Youko promptly .

'Excuse me...'“

Haruka opened her mouth like she wanted to talk about it .

'I've heard most of the situation from Ishii-san . To be honest, I think Saitou Yakumo isn't the culprit of this case either . '

Youko said that in a quiet voice after looking around .

'Is that so?'

Though Ishii said that in his surprise, he understood soon after .

Come to think of it, if Youko still doubted Yakumo, she wouldn't have cooperated so much .

It could be said that he had gained a powerful ally .

'Detective Ishii, I'm going to go look at the scene, but...'

Youko looked up at the door to the room where the corpse was found .

– I don't want to see it .

The corpse had been stabbed all over . If possible, he didn't want to step into such a grisly place .

He had just one reason . He was afraid .

However, he was in front of Haruka and Makoto, and he felt like he wouldn't be able to see the truth of the case if he didn't look at it himself .

'I'll go too,' said Ishii in a trembling voice . Then, he started following Youko up the stairs to the second storey .

His legs were shaking .

He really was frightened . But he couldn't go back now .

At the door, Ishii's mobile phone rang with good timing .

3

Gotou opened the sliding door to the temple .

It was quiet –

All he could hear was the sound of the pouring rain .

Eishin was sitting in the middle of the temple with his hand in some sort of religious gesture .

He had his spine straight and was looking straight forward – he was as still as if he had become Buddha .

Though his half-open eyes seemed hollow, there was a strong light in them .

Gotou didn't understand the heart of Zen, but as Eishin sat there, it looked like he was emitting some mysterious aura .

'Oi . '

Though Gotou called out, Eishin didn't move .

– Did he not hear me?

'Oi, you damn monk . '

Gotou called out again while walking up to Eishin .

'I know you're there even without all that noise,' said Eishin .

When he spoke, only his lips moved – it was creepy, like he was a talking mechanical doll .

'f you know, then reply . '

Gotou sat cross-legged in front of Eishin .

'What do you want?'

'That's quite a tone . I can't think of you as Isshin's teacher,' said Gotou, expressing his dissatisfaction .

Suddenly, the days Gotou had spent with Isshin came to mind .

Isshin was a broadminded man . He was always gentle and kind to everyone . Just seeing that smile would make Gotou feel better for some reason .

– Why did Isshin have to die?

Gotou still thought that sometimes now .

'You say that because you don't know what Isshin was like before . '

Eishin breathed out, relaxing his body . His face became more human, like he had taken off a mask .

'What do you mean?'

'Isshin is very similar to Yakumo . '

Gotou didn't understand what Eishin said .

'What part of him?'

'Before Isshin took Yakumo in, he had been terribly troubled . At one point, he denied his own existence . '

'Denied?'

'He was filled with anger that had no outlet – he always had a grim expression on his face . '

'That guy did?'

Gotou really didn't understand .

No matter how Gotou searched his memories, Isshin was always smiling in them .

'Because he found out the truth . '

'The truth?'

Gotou didn't understand .

He felt like they were talking about somebody else entirely .

'It's not like Isshin was at fault, but because of his personality, he tried to shoulder all the blame . '

'What are you talking about?'

'You could call it fate...'

Eishin stared into nothingness .

– Fate?

'You talking about Yakumo?'

'Yakumo is only one part of a larger flow . I'm talking about a fate that continued from much before then . Everything started in this temple, when a man and woman met . '

'Explain in a way I'll understand . '

Gotou pressed Eishin for an answer in his irritation .

However, Eishin continued, still staring into nothingness .

'Isshin compared that fate with his own existence . At that time, he had forgotten heart of ensou, which is the basis of Zen .

'Ensou?'

'That's right . If the heart is not in order, one cannot see clearly . Isshin's fate had shaken his heart . '

Gotou really didn't understand what Eishin was talking about .

He didn't understand, but for some reason, he was curious .

'So then what happened?'

'The one who changed Isshin's heart was Yakumo . '

Eishin's lips relaxed into a small smile .

He alone held all the cards . That was how it looked like to Gotou .

'What part of Yakumo changed Isshin?'

'His existence . By walking with Yakumo, Isshin was able to face his fate .
He became his original self . '

'What's that fate you're talking about?'

'You know as well . It's that man . '

Eishin's mouth shut tightly .

Gotou knew who that man was .

'The man with two red eyes?'

'That's right . Isshin has a connection with that man that cannot be cut . '

'Isshin was just wrapped up in the incident, right?' said Gotou offhandedly .

'Wrong . '

Eishin shook his head .

'What do you mean?'

Without responding to Gotou's question, Eishin stood up .

'Answer me . '

Gotou continued to hound Eishin .

'You'll understand soon enough . More importantly, what did you come here for?'

Eishin sudden changed the subject .

Stopping the conversation right before the crucial point – he really was just like Yakumo . Eishin probably wouldn't say anything no matter what Gotou asked . Gotou gave in and stood up .

'I want to ask a favour . '

'Do you want me to introduce you to a woman?'

There was a lascivious smirk on Eishin's face .

Even though he was so solemn when meditating, there was not even a fragment of that now .

'I've got a wife . '

'So you're more proper than you look . '

– It really didn't sound like something a monk should say .

'That isn't the problem . Anyway, I came to borrow your mobile . '

'What do you say when asking for a favour?' said Eishin with a laugh .

He really was like Yakumo .

'Please lend me your mobile . I would greatly appreciate it . '

Gotou buried his anger in the pit of his stomach as he lowered his head .

'You should have been honest like that from the start,' said Eishin while taking his mobile out for Gotou .

– Meditating with his mobile there – what an awful monk .

Gotou said abusive words in his heart while taking the mobile .

4

'Excuse me . '

After saying that to Youko, Ishii stepped away from the door .

The number on his mobile was unfamiliar to him . Who could it be –

Though confused, Ishii answered the phone .

'Hello . '

<It's me . >

– Detective Gotou!

Ishii was about to yell that, but he hurriedly stopped himself .

'P-please wait . '

There were police officers everywhere . If they found out he was talking with Gotou, it would be a serious problem .

Ishii looked around for a place he could talk without being watched .

The first and second floors were filled with people, but there were practically none on the third .

'I apologise for the wait,' said Ishii after walking to the outside corridor of the third floor .

<It's really noisy . >

Gotou sounded displeased .

'Ah, actually...'

Ishii explained in detail everything they had investigated up until now, including how Haruka and Makoto had found a corpse .

Though it was quite the complicated story, Ishii focussed on explaining chronologically, as Yakumo always told him to .

Gotou didn't interrupt, which was unusual .

<Seems like things are a mess over there too . >

Gotou said just that after Ishii finished his explanation .

'It is a bit confusing . '

Ishii had run about frantically up until now, but once he heard Gotou's voice, he relaxed a bit and became weak .

His eyes were becoming wet with tears .

<It's my fault . Sorry . >

Gotou said that .

– Why is he apologising?

Ishii was confused . Though Gotou always got angry at him, he never apologised . Rather, Ishii was the one who wanted to apologise .

He had planned on investigating frantically to make a place for Gotou to return to, but there had been no developments at all .

He was completely useless like this .

'I'm the one who must apologise . If I had been more reliable...'

<Are you an idiot?>

'Eh?'

<This case is outside of your jurisdiction . That's not all . What I've done will make people give you a lot of flak . >

Gotou's voice was quiet and weak .

– Don't talk like that .

Ishii murmured that in his heart .

'Please don't worry about someone like me . Detective Gotou, I believe in you and Yakumo-shi . That's why I'm working . That's all . '

Ishii wasn't lying .

It was true that he had been a bit troubled earlier, but that had gone away completely .

<Well don't you sound competent . >

Gotou snorted .

Was that praise? Or was it a reprimand? Ishii didn't know .

He just felt that Gotou's voice sounded a bit stronger .

'Detective Gotou . '

<What?>

'If there's anything I can do, please tell me . If you want to flee overseas, I will help prepare . '

<Don't be ridiculous . I'm not the sort of guy who likes running . >

'That's right . '

<There's a request from Yakumo - will you hear it?>

'Of course,' Ishii replied immediately .

He would do anything if it would allow Gotou to come back, no matter what sacrifices he had to make .

<I want you to contact old man Hata and get the autopsy results for the victim . >

'Please consider it done!' declared Ishii .

<I'm counting on you, Assistant Inspector Ishii . >

'Yes sir!'

After ending the call, Gotou returned to the archive where Yakumo was .

It looked like he had finished searching already, as he was sitting cross-legged at the Japanese-style desk while reading an account book written by hand .

The way he looked – wearing a monk's working clothes while reading accounts – was incredibly fitting .

'Is it interesting?'

When Gotou spoke, Yakumo turned around with an incredibly displeased look .

'It's a matter of subjectivity . '

'Are you saying I wouldn't be able to enjoy it?'

'You can't read, right?'

'Shut up!'

Gotou said that with a click of his tongue as he sat down on the tatami .

'So how was it?' said Yakumo, turning his eyes to the account book again .

'Things turned serious . '

Gotou told Yakumo what Ishii had just told him .

At points, Yakumo interrupted, saying things like 'In more concrete terms...' , but he seriously listened to Gotou .

'I see . '

After Gotou finished speaking, Yakumo shut the account book and lifted his head .

His eyes looked unusually sharp .

'Did you figure something out?'

'There are still a number of things I need to confirm, but I can see the outline of the case . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair .

'So Ishii was of some use then . '

'Yes . Actually, this time, I have done practically nothing . Ishii-san, Makoto-san and her – the things they've investigated are very close to the truth . '

'That's right . '

Gotou agreed with Yakumo's opinion .

When he was talking with Ishii earlier, he'd underrated him, thinking Ishii probably wouldn't be able to get any useful information .

Gotou had thought of Ishii as the type who didn't move unless told to .

However, this time was different . They'd decided their own direction from the situation and investigated . Ishii had grown at a much quicker speed than he had imagined .

Of course, it was the same for Haruka and Makoto .

'To be honest, I'm surprised . I would have probably searched in the same manner if I had been there . '

Yakumo scratched his cheek awkwardly .

'Do you think you'll get to the truth?'

'I wonder,' Yakumo said evasively as he yawned .

Gotou stared at Yakumo's face, but he couldn't see his true feelings . All he could do now was believe in Yakumo .

'I'm counting on you . I can't go home if you don't solve the mystery . '

'Atsuko-san and Nao might be happier if you don't . '

Yakumo smirked .

'Say what you want . '

Gotou crossed his arms, looked away and walked to the wall .

– I wonder how Atsuko and Nao are doing?

Gotou had been troubled about whether or not to call home after calling Ishii . However, he decided not to in the end .

The police would probably think Gotou would call home and well probably waiting there . It was the house of a suspect, after all .

– I've caused trouble for them .

Gotou realised once more the weight of what he had done, but strangely, he didn't regret it at all .

It was probably because he believed Yakumo would bring the case to an end .

'Gotou-san . '

Yakumo was running a hand through his hair with his head facing down as he said that .

'What?'

'Could I borrow the phone?'

'Sure . '

Gotou took the mobile out of his pocket and gave it to Yakumo .

'Thank you . '

'Who are you calling?'

'There's something I want to check... with her . '

Yakumo's words were stiff, which was unlike him .

– I see .

Gotou understood everything and stood up .

'Where are you going?'

Yakumo looked puzzled .

– There's probably some things that'd be hard to talk about with me here .

Yakumo would probably get angry if Gotou said that, so he muttered it in his heart .

'It's stuffy in this room . I'm going to take a nap in the temple . '

'It's easier to sleep on tatami . '

'I'm fine . The wood's cooler . '

Gotou ended the conversation and left the archive .

When he went out into the corridor, the rain became stronger . It felt like it might cause a flood .

'Man . '

Gotou went into the temple, used a cushion in the corner as a pillow and lay down .

Come to think of it, he'd gone without sleep or rest for these two days . His body was much more tired than he'd thought .

Gotou fell asleep –

6

Haruka went into her room with a heavy heart .

After that, the Nishitama precinct detectives questioned her about the situation . Since she was Yakumo's friends, they had clearly suspected her at first, but with the words of Youko, the Nishitama precinct detective who had been there with Ishii, she was able to be let out quickly .

Still, the things that had happened these two days had had such an impact that she was psychologically and physically exhausted .

She went into the room and lay down on the bed .

The blanket felt nice, but she didn't feel sleepy .

– I wonder what Yakumo is doing now?

Even when she closed her eyes, questions kept coming up in her head .

'Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka opened her eyes and called out towards the white ceiling .

As if to respond to that, her mobile phone rang .

'Hello . '

<You're rather carefree in such a state of emergency . >

'Yakumo-kun!'

Haruka leapt up like a spring .

<Your voice is loud . >

Yakumo sounded nonchalant .

Though that tone irritated Haruka, she noticed that she was also relieved .

'What do you mean, carefree? You don't know anything about how I'm feeling . '

<My bad . >

Yakumo said that quietly .

So many things had happened since she heard about the case . She had been very surprised and worn away at her nerves as she worried about his safety – terrible things had happened .

However, it was mysterious how that one sentence made her feel like she could forgive everything .

– The weakness of somebody in love .

'I'll forgive you this time . '

Haruka lay down on her bed again . Though it was the same bed, it felt more comfortable than before .

Anyway, she could hear his voice . That was enough .

'Hey, where are you now?' asked Haruka, curling up like a cat .

<A room with many books . >

'What is that? A library?'

<Your imagination is poor . >

Yakumo laughed .

Haruka felt like it had been a while since she'd heard that voice . When she talked with him like this, the situation she was in this time felt like a dream .

'Really, where are you?'

<It'd cause you trouble if you knew . >

'Why?'

<If you knew where I was and kept quiet, you would be aiding a fugitive . Since I'm a suspect . >

'I see...'

She was brought back to reality in an instant .

<I received a lot of information from Ishii-san . >

'Yeah . '

Ishii had said he'd received a phone call from Gotou when in front of the apartment .

<It was a great help . >

Haruka didn't think that Yakumo would say something like that .

'We've been doing our best too . '

<You have . But...>

'What?'

<Don't over do it . >

'But at a time like this...'

<I'm saying it because it's a time like this . >

Yakumo interrupted Haruka .

'Eh?'

<Because it's a time like this, even if something happens, I can't save you .
>

Haruka's heart ached at Yakumo's words .

He's worried about me . Yakumo is –

It was natural for a friend to be worried, but Haruka was still happy .

'I won't overdo it . Ishii-san said that too . I'll be acting alongside Ishii-san tomorrow too, so it'll be fine . '

<I see . That's good . Then...>

'Hey . '

Haruka sat up and called out to Yakumo, who had been about to hang up .

<What?>

'You'll come back... right?>

She wanted to confirm just that .

She knew he wouldn't be able to reply at this stage, but she wanted an answer, even if it was a lie .

<Yeah . I'll definitely come back . >

Yakumo replied .

Even though there was no proof, if Yakumo said that, Haruka felt like she could believe it .

'I'm waiting . '

Yakumo just laughed instead of responding .

Even after hanging up, Haruka gripped her mobile tightly in that lingering memory .

– Yakumo will definitely come back .

That thought gave her peace of mind, and Haruka fell asleep .

7

'Don't sleep here . You're in the way . '

Gotou woke up to that voice .

Eishin had his arms crossed in a displeased manner as he looked down on Gotou .

When Gotou looked up at him like this, there was considerable pressure .
Gotou's sleepiness flew away at once .

Gotou had planned on leave just while Yakumo was calling Haruka last night, but it looked like he'd fallen right asleep .

'It's my choice where I sleep . '

Gotou sat up while rubbing his eyes .

He really shouldn't have slept on the wooden floor . His body ached all over .

'That's why I told you . '

Eishin laughed when he saw Gotou's expression twist in pain .

– He's so noisy .

Gotou looked at his wristwatch in an unpleasant mood . It was only six in the morning .

'It's a pain being woken up so early in the morning . '

'Early in the morning? My day starts at four . This is actually late . '

Eishin's nostrils flared as he said that and opened the window to look out .

The large raindrops continued to hit the ground .

The wind was strong too – there was the sound of howling .

'It's really pouring . '

Gotou got up and stretched .

Something in his arm and foot made a loud crack . It was hard to move as if he was wearing a suit of armour .

'Seems like a typhoon's coming . '

'Typhoon? That'll be another issue...'

They were frantically running around – they didn't have the time to care about the weather .

'It'll land soon . '

'What a pain . '

Gotou frowned .

If it were just rain, it'd be fine, but a typhoon was different . They wouldn't be able to move freely .

'So what are you planning to do today?' said Eishin, as if he'd seen Gotou's anxiety .

Wait in the temple for the typhoon to pass, or forcefully go out – both were risky .

It was hard to come to a decision .

'I'll ask Yakumo . '

'You don't try to think on your own, do you?'

Eishin snorted .

'What did you say?'

'It's the truth, right? That's why your brain is deteriorating . '

– This monk really is annoying .

Somehow, Gotou swallowed his anger .

There was something else of more concern . What was Eishin going to do?

He had gone with them so far . Gotou had brought Eishin along because he was partially responsible for Yakumo's becoming a suspect .

However, they had found Yakumo . It could be said that Eishin's role ended here, but Eishin had clout . Though he was hateful, Gotou would rather have him here .

'What are you going to do now...'

The sliding door to the temple opened, interrupting Gotou's question .

At the door was the trainee monk named Shuuei . There was sweat on his forehead and his shoulders were heaving as he panted .

His working clothes were drenched from the rain .

'What is it?' said Eishin .

'Police have come . '

'Police?'

Gotou stood up instinctively at those words .

'Just chase them out,' replied Eishin .

However, Shuuei's eyebrows lowered as he looked troubled .

'That is... It seems that somebody reported that there is an escaped suspect here...'

Shuuei's shoulders slumped as he hung his head like a child being scolded .

It was hard to even look at him, but there was no time to sympathise . This was really problematic .

'Run right now,' Eishin said sharply while pointing to the well .

Gotou was about to respond from that force, but then he recalled something .

'How about Yakumo?'

'Shuuei . Call him right now . '

'Yes . '

Shuuei turned around briskly and ran off .

'Don't dawdle . Hurry and go . '

Urged on by Eishin, Gotou flew out of the temple .

The pouring rain continued .

He stooped over to hide in the thicket as he advanced . In front of the well, he stood up again and looked at the main temple gate .

He saw Shuuei talking to the police there .

'That bastard . He should've been going to call Yakumo...'

It seemed like Shuuei had been the one who gave the secret report to the police . Gotou gritted his teeth .

– What to do?

'Hurry up and go! Idiot!'

Eishin yelled from the corridor .

There was no point in both of them getting caught .

'Damn it! What a pain!'

Gotou used the rope to go into the well .

8

The rain was heavy –

Haruka watched the rain pouring down from the apartment entrance .

The news said that a typhoon was coming .

If the typhoon hit, they wouldn't be able to move freely . Haruka couldn't relax .

She saw a car parked in front of the apartment .

It was probably Ishii's car .

Haruka left the entrance and went up to the car, holding an umbrella .

'Good morning . '

Ishii nodded from the driver's seat .

His hair was as messy as Yakumo's and hair was growing in on his chin .
He was also wearing the same thing as he had been yesterday .

He had probably worked without sleep or rest . Haruka felt a bit apologetic .

'I'm sorry for asking something so selfish . '

Haruka apologised formally as she got into the passenger seat .

Last night, Ishii had said, 'Please leave the rest of the investigation to me . '

Haruka didn't think that anything would change if she continued . Rather, she'd get in the way . Though she knew that, she had still said, 'Please let me do something . '

Their arguments ran parallel, but in the end Ishii folded .

'No, to be honest, I didn't want to investigate by myself either . '

Ishii smiled as he said that, starting the car .

Haruka knew he was just being polite, but it still made her feel better .

'How are things with the police?' asked Haruka, curious .

Now that Gotou had run as a fugitive, there must have been a big fuss at the police .

'Actually, I haven't returned to the precinct . '

'Eh?'

'I've been contacting Chief Miyagawa by phone, but if I return, they probably won't let me out again . '

Ishii let out a dry laugh .

'Why would that be the case?'

'Since I'm Detective Gotou's partner...'

Ishii's eyes narrowed .

'Are you being suspected as well, Ishii-san?'

'Though that isn't the case, they think I might give Detective Gotou information . '

'That's...'

For Ishii to be suspected as well – Haruka had a heavy heart just imagining it .

'Please don't be so down . It's the truth,' said Ishii with a shrug .

'The truth?'

'Ah, well, I talked with Detective Gotou on the phone yesterday . I told him everything I know, so the police's opinion is correct . '

To Haruka, Ishii seemed nonchalant . It might have been resignation .

– He'd do anything for Gotou .

That will was probably pushing him forward .

'We'll need to clear their names then . '

Haruka smiled at Ishii .

'Of course,' Ishii replied immediately .

If they didn't find out the truth behind the case, everyone would be in trouble .

It wasn't just Yakumo's problem .

Haruka's determination became firmer .

Gotou went down the narrow tunnel at the bottom of the well, feeling like he was being pulled back by the hair .

'Dam nit!'

After getting out the tunnel, Gotou hid behind the rock and watched the second hand on his wristwatch as he waited .

'Hurry up and come . '

Gotou just prayed for that as he gripped his hands into fists .

The rain hit his body .

Even his underwear was soaked in no time .

Water dripped from his chin .

Ten minutes passed –

But Yakumo still didn't come .

If he hadn't come after Gotou had waited so long, was he hiding in the temple or caught by the police –

'What to do?' Gotou asked himself .

Only the sound of the rain replied .

Gotou stood up, left the thicket and stood on the asphalt road .

The raindrops bounced off the ground, creating a faint mist .

At the temple, Gotou could see red flashing lights . Yakumo was still on the premises .

The open ground on the opposite side of the road had a BMW there – the one they'd taken here .

Gotou put his hands in his pockets and found the key .

– If you're caught by the police, somebody important to you will die .

The words on the note that was probably from Nanase Miyuki came up in Gotou's head . If Yakumo was caught by the police, Haruka would be in danger .

In that situation, Yakumo would be stuck in the detention house . He'd probably be stricken with helplessness and an unspeakable pain .

Like with Isshin –

'I see . '

Gotou understood everything now .

That might have been Miyuki's goal . That woman had been stuck in the detention house before because of Yakumo .

Though she had escaped in the end, this was revenge for that . She probably planned on meeting Yakumo after she had placed her hands on Haruka .

When Gotou imagined that, a shiver ran down his spine .

He was looking up at the sky blanketed in thick clouds when Atsuko's and Nao's faces appeared in his head .

Even if he got away now, he couldn't get to the truth without Yakumo . He would have to continue running for the rest of his life .

He wouldn't be able to meet Atsuko and Nao .

Then it'd actually be better to be caught by the police .

Come to think of it, Gotou had decided what he should do from the moment he'd gone to save Yakumo and acted violent against the officers .

No, that was wrong –

His fate might have already been decided from the moment he'd saved Yakumo from that abandoned building fifteen years ago . It had been raining like this on that day too .

He and Yakumo were one in body and soul .

'I'll go with you to the ends of hell . '

Gotou said just that and started walking to the BMW .

10

To be honest, Ishii had thought Haruka would be a bit more depressed .

However, this morning, Haruka had an energetic expression this morning – it looked like she had returned to her usual self .

Though Ishii wanted to know what had changed in her psychological state, Ishii couldn't ask aloud .

Ishii drove through the parking lot, trying to get as close to the entrance as he could .

He was at the entrance when Haruka ran out with an umbrella .

Though they only shared the umbrella for twenty minutes, it was a time of pure bliss for Ishii . They went through the entrance and took the stairs by the elevator .

They were headed for the room at the end of the basement corridor .

The dim corridor which smelled of disinfectant was always creepy to Ishii, but he felt less frightened than usual .

It might have been because Haruka was there with him .

'Hata-san, it's Ishii . '

Ishii called out as he knocked .

'It's open . '

A hoarse voice called out from the room .

'Are you all right?'

Haruka nodded in response to Ishii's words .

'Excuse us . '

Ishii opened the door to the room .

A small space of about six tatami in size . Cabinets surrounded it . Partly because there were no windows, it had a suffocating pressure to it .

There was just one desk by the wall . Hata sat there .

'You've brought an unexpected person with you . '

Hata looked at Haruka with fish eyes .

Ishii had been troubled about whether to meet Hata with Haruka, but then he remembered that they had met a number of times before .

'Do you remember me?'

Haruka bowed her head with a smile .

'My mind's still active . '

After tapping his forehead with his finger, Hata let out a creepy giggle .

When Ishii heard Hata's laugh, a chill ran down his spine . It made him afraid that Hata might one day bare his fangs and gobble someone up .

'So I see . '

Haruka smiled, though she seemed troubled .

'Excuse me... About the matter I discussed yesterday...'

Ishii brought up the topic at hand .

'I've got it for you . '

Hata patted his grizzled hair and then took two A4-size envelopes out of the drawer .

The names Seidou and Matsumoto Hiroshi were written on them .

'Thank you very much . '

Ishii picked them up immediately and took the insides out, but then his eyes saw a frightful picture that he instinctively looked away from .

Normally, he would have shrieked, but he probably couldn't do that because Haruka was next to him .

Haruka's brows grew close together as she covered her mouth with both hands .

The events of last night had probably doubled Haruka's terror .

'Are you all right?'

'Yes, I'm fine . '

Haruka acted strong at Ishii's words, but her face was completely white .

'Anyway, please sit . '

Ishii encouraged Haruka to sit in the nearby round chair .

'I'm sorry,' said Haruka, sitting on the chair and hugging her shoulders .

Hata was light-heartedly poking at youkan[1] with a toothpick .

Only Hata would be able to look at this photo and continue eating calmly .

'What do you think, Hata-san?'

Ishii put the photo back in the envelope and turned to Hata .

This was the most important . To be honest, when Ishii looked at the photo, he just felt frightened .

He wanted to hear Hata's opinion as an expert .

'Well, there were a number of things that were off . '

Hata sipped his tea .

'Things that were off?'

'Yes . First, it was a haemorrhagic death . '

That meant that there had been no fatal injury – death had been caused by blood loss .

'Is that so?'

'Though there are many injuries, each was shallow in contrast to that . '

'Shallow...'

Ishii repeated what Hata said, but he didn't know what it meant .

'It was probably done to hurt the victim . '

Hata's shoulders shook as he giggled .

Stabbing over and over while keeping the victim from dying . That was a terribly awful way of murder . The murderer might have been an unbelievable sadist . Or –

'Then there must have been quite a grudge against the victim . '

'The suspect in this case is Yakumo-kun, right?' said Hata, rubbing the white stubble growing out of his chin .

'That's wrong!' Haruka said, leaning forward .

'Missy, listen to the end of what I have to say . '

Hata's rebuke made Haruka immediately say 'I'm sorry' and look at her feet .

'What I want to say is that if Yakumo-kun committed the crime, he was ill-prepared . '

'Ill-prepared?'

Ishii repeated it without thinking .

'Think about it . How many cases do you think Yakumo has been involved in up until now?'

'That's...'

Yakumo hadn't been involved in just one or two cases . Ishii understood what Hata was trying to say .

'Yakumo-kun must know very well how the police work . Would he grip the knife and take the time to stab somebody multiple times despite that?'

'If Yakumo-shi were the murderer, he would probably pick a more effective method, wouldn't he?'

Hata nodded .

Ishii understood . If Yakumo were the culprit, he would have killed the victims differently .

At least, he wouldn't have gripped the knife with his bare hand . However –

'Wouldn't it be possible to think that he might have become emotion after some sort of trouble?'

'That's impossible,' said Hata with a snort .

'Eh?'

'Then the injuries would be deeper . '

'Is that so?'

'I said this earlier, didn't I? The culprit probably used enough force not to kill the victim in order to hurt them . '

'Ah, I see . '

Ishii understood now .

If the culprit had become emotional and lost control, they wouldn't be able to stab somebody without killing them .

'The culprit must have coldly watched the victim suffering . That might have been the goal . '

Ishii shivered at Hata's words .

'How frightening,' said Ishii in a trembling voice .

11

– I can't go back now .

Sitting in the driver seat of the BMW, Gotou gripped the wheel with sweaty hands as he steeled himself .

At the temple gate in front of him, he could see two police cars . The uniformed officers ahead of them were looking around frantically in their raincoats .

He looked towards the archive where Yakumo had been .

The door was open . However, he couldn't see inside . If he didn't know the situation, he had no way of moving .

As if to respond to Gotou's irritation, there was a knock on the car's side window .

Eishin peered in, completely drenched .

'You look awful,' said Gotou as he looked at Eishin, who was drenched from head to toe .

'You look worse . '

'Can't say you're wrong . '

Gotou laughed together with Eishin .

'So how's it look inside?'

After laughing for a moment, Gotou asked that, and Eishin's expression became serious .

'Sorry . Yakumo was caught . '

'As I thought... Did that trainee monk called Shuuei report him?'

Gotou glared at Eishin .

For once, Eishin looked as his feet awkwardly .

'Don't blame Shuuei . He just did what he thought was right after thinking about it . '

'I know . '

Gotou wasn't lying .

From Shuuei's perspective, on top of his master being murdered, the suspect in that had suddenly appeared at the temple .

He hadn't reported it immediately because Eishin, the temple's advisor had been there .

Gotou would think gratefully of him for keeping quiet until this morning .

'What do you plan to do?' said Eishin, wiping the water from his face .

Gotou was determined without a doubt .

'I can't go back . '

'Right . Then I'll go with you . '

Eishin smirked .

Gotou had thought of him just as a hateful monk, but in this situation, he was a strong ally . But –

'You OK with that?'

'I'm partially responsible, right?' said Eishin with a snort . That was the end of it then .

'Then shall we go?'

Gotou started the engine .

'Do you have a plan?'

'As if . '

He'd imagined things from this situation, but he couldn't see the result .

Tricks would be no use . He'd go with a straight-on surprise attack .

'It's troublesome accompanying an idiot . '

Though Eishin said that, he looked happy .

Gotou calculated the timing while waiting for the engine .

A uniformed officer came out of the archive .

Yakumo was behind the officer . Though his hands were shackled, he was looking forward with a firm gaze .

Behind Yakumo, there was another uniformed officer . He was led to the police car, surrounded .

– Not yet . A little longer .

Gotou swallowed the urge to rush .

He only had one chance . If he failed, it'd be game over .

The officers and Yakumo walked up to the police car at the temple gates .
The officer in front opened the backseat door .

'Now!'

As Gotou yelled, he slammed down the pedal and drove forward .

He put his lights on high beam and kept honking the horn .

When the officers saw the BMW rushing towards them, they jumped away in different directions .

Yakumo was left in the middle .

'We're going!'

Without slowing down, Gotou rammed into the police car with the open door .

There was a grating crash – the impact ran through Gotou .

The police car's side was dented in and the door impossibly bent, but the BMW didn't have that much damage .

Foreign cars really were different in sturdiness .

'Hurry up and get on!'

Even Yakumo looked astonished by the unexpected event, though he immediately came over, sensing the situation .

However, one of the uniformed officers came to stop that .

It'd be a problem if they were caught . Gotou was about to get off the car when Eishin kicked the officer's leg .

The officer lost his balance and fell forward .

'Well done,' said Gotou without thinking .

Eishin really wasn't just a monk . Though he was hateful, he was reliable .

Yakumo took that chance to get into the backseat .

'We're going!'

Gotou waited for Eishin to get back in and made a U-turn in the BMW .

Because of the high speed, Yakumo and Eishin were flung to the side of the car from the centrifugal force, but Gotou didn't have the time to worry about that .

Gotou slammed down the pedal .

12

'That was rather reckless,' said Yakumo in the back seat .

'That a problem for you?'

Gotou turned around with a smile .

'No, it was a great help . '

Unusual for Yakumo, he thanked Gotou honestly .

Gotou ended up laughing at how ridiculous that attitude was .

'Is something funny?'

Yakumo said that, seeming displeased . He tried to run a hand through his hair, but the handcuffs got in his way .

His actions were like a playful cat's, making Gotou laugh aloud again .

'You're rather carefree in this emergency . '

My bad . '

If Gotou laughed any more, it felt like Yakumo would really be angry . Gotou swallowed his laughter .

'So where are you going now?' asked Eishin from the passenger seat .

He'd mentioned the part that hurt most . Gotou couldn't respond immediately . He wasn't driving with a destination in mind .

He'd gone along with vigour – he didn't know what to do next .

'As usual, you have no plans . '

Yakumo shook his head, as if disappointed by Gotou's thoughts .

'Tell me if you have any ideas then . '

Nothing would start if they argued now . Gotou asked that question to Yakumo while looking through the rear-view mirror .

Yakumo probably had some sort of plan .

'Please head to the lake,' said Yakumo with a hard expression .

'By lake, do you mean the one where you got bitten by a pit viper?'

'You don't have to say unnecessary information,' said Yakumo with a scowl .

It looked like it really bothered him . Yakumo might grow to hate snakes .

'What's there?'

'Something that will bring us to the truth of this case . '

That was a pretty vague way of putting it .

In his heart, Gotou complained – 'Explain more clearly' – but if Yakumo said that, Gotou was sure there was something there .

He might have found something important in the account books he was looking at in the archive last night .

'Oi, you damn monk . Tell me how to get there,' Gotou said to Eishin in the passenger seat .

However, Eishin just looked at Gotou like he was a cockroach or something .

'Don't make me say this again . There's a proper attitude you should take when you're asking people to do things,' said Eishin with a sigh .

'I don't know the way . Would you be so kind as to tell me how to get there?'

– Man, what annoying car passengers .

Gotou pitied his unluckiness but he bowed his head to Eishin . He'd return this humiliation when the case was over .

'Say that from the beginning . '

'Yeah, yeah . '

'Turn right at the next road . '

Eishin said that right before the intersection .

– He couldn't stop the car that quickly .

'Idiot . It was that road,' said Eishin with irritation .

'I know . Tell me sooner . '

Gotou slammed on the brakes .

The tires slipped in the rain – it took longer to stop than he'd expected .

Gotou made a U-turn and went onto the road as directed .

The road was one long, curving slope . Gotou recalled that he'd gone on this road when he had gone to search for Yakumo yesterday .

He would get to the lake if he just went straight here .

'Hey, Yakumo . You figured something out?' asked Gotou after things had calmed down a bit .

'Though it isn't everything yet, what Ishii-san investigated was of quite some use . '

'That so...'

'Yes . From what I know, Hatsune-chan is not her mother's reincarnation . '

Gotou had heard that yesterday .

'Then who is she?'

'Like I said yesterday, Gotou-san, your question is strange . '

Gotou didn't know what was strange about it at all .

He looked at Eishin in the passenger seat . He had his arms crossed and was going 'hm, hm' like he understood, lying back on the seat .

Looked like Gotou was the only one who didn't understand . It was really irritating .

'Just explain already . '

'First, if you think about it calmly, it would be impossible to think of a child being their mother's reincarnation, as the mother is the one who gave birth to them,' said Yakumo, putting his hands together as he did so .

Gotou understood that too .

'And?'

'Next, Hatsune-chan still called herself by the name of her mother, Minami, despite that . '

'yeah . '

'Hatsune-chan's mother, Minami, is probably the person who became missing ten years ago that Ishii-san is investigating . '

'I see,' replied Gotou in understanding .

'After putting these two truths together, there is only one possibility . '

Yakumo was looking straight forward .

That hard expression was sometimes frightening to the point that it gave Gotou a chill .

'What?'

'Do you really not understand?'

It was Eishin who responded .

If he was going to interrupt with boring comments, Gotou would prefer that Eishin slept .

'I'm asking because I don't understand . '

Gotou hit the wheel .

'It's simple . Somebody told Hatsune-chan this . That she was Minami's reincarnation . '

'Wha...'

Gotou was so surprised that he couldn't say anything else .

'Somebody said that over and over again to Hatsune-chan . You are your mother's reincarnation – Over many months and years, Hatsune-chan was brainwashed and grew to believe she really was her mother's reincarnation...'

Yakumo's words were as flat as if he were reading a sutra .

However, the weight of each word thrust painfully into Gotou's chest .

If what Yakumo said was true, Gotou couldn't forgive it . It was the same as robbing Hatsune of her identity .

'I see... That's why you said she was herself . '

Gotou finally understood what Yakumo had been saying .

Yakumo nodded with a grim expression on his face .

No matter what happened, you couldn't be anything but yourself . No matter what you were told otherwise, that fact didn't change .

However, there was still something that Gotou didn't understand .

'What did somebody do that for...'

'That answer will come soon . '

Yakumo gave a vague reply and then leant back on the seat, looking up at the ceiling .

It looked like his battery had run out .

Though Gotou hadn't been able to get a response out of Yakumo, Gotou had a vague idea about the answer to who it was .

– Over many months and years .

Yakumo had said that .

Only somebody who was always close to Hatsune would be able to do that
–

13

After leaving Hata's hospital, Ishii went with Haruka to a family restaurant .

When they went inside Youko was already waiting there at a window seat .

'I'm sorry for the wait . '

Ishii and Haruka sat opposite Youko .

'You're the one from last night...'

Youko looked at Haruka with suspicious eyes . It was an expected response . There was no point making excuses now .

Ishii explained how things were to Youko .

'I understand how you feel, but what I'm going to say now is confidential information regarding the invitation . '

That was what Youko said immediately after Ishii finished his explanation .

He'd thought that she'd understand, but he had been naive . Come to think of it, it was natural . It had become natural for Yakumo and Haruka to be a part of investigations, but they were civilians . Furthermore, Haruka was in a strange position, as a friend of the suspect .

It would be more of a problem for her to be a part of the investigation .

'I'm sorry for asking something unreasonable . I'll wait outside . '

Haruka seemed to accept the situation before Ishii did and she got up from her seat .

'I'm sorry . There are circumstances . To be honest, it's enough of a problem talking with Ishii-san . '

It sounded like Youko was being considerate of Haruka .

To Ishii, Youko's attitude was unexpected .

– It is unnecessary for you to help with the investigation .

Ishii recalled what Youko had said when they first met .

It was like she was a different person . However, Ishii thought that gap in character was pleasant .

'Please wait in the car . '

Ishii handed the car key to Haruka .

'Yes . '

Haruka didn't look depressed . She responded with her usual smile and left the family restaurant .

Ishii confirmed that Haruka had got into the car through the window and then turned his eyes to Youko .

Youko was looking out the window as well .

She looked entranced, like a girl in love .

'Excuse me...'

When Ishii spoke, Youko looked surprised .

'Ah, sorry . She looks like...'

'Looks like whom?'

'A friend . '

'Ah...'

Ishii gave a vague response .

He couldn't say anything since he had never seen that friend .

'Let's talk,' said Youko after letting out a short breath .

'Ah, yes . '

'First, I want you to look at this . I looked into the case from ten years ago when Minami-san went missing . '

Youko took files out of her bag .

It was a rather impressive amount . It was as thick as a dictionary . Had she investigated that much in half a day – while Ishii took the files in his hand, he was astonished by Youko's work .

'This is amazing . '

'I've put labels on the important points . '

Just as Youko said, there were coloured labels sticking out all over the files .

'First, there are a few testimonies from the investigation of the disappearance that caught my interest . '

Youko started explaining in a flat tone .

'The last to see her was Seidou-san, but the timing of that testimony is a bit strange . '

'Strange?'

'Yes . The investigation into the disappearance had started already . After a week, he went himself to the police to give testimony . '

'That is strange . '

Ishii agreed with Youko's opinion .

It would make sense if he'd recalled after being asked by the police, but this was different .

He had suddenly said that he'd seen a person somewhere a week after .

'There is another strange testimony,' continued Youko .

'What is it?'

'The classmate that testified that Minami-san had been depressed was Matsumoto Hiroshi . '

'As I thought,' murmured Ishii .

He hadn't had proof, but he had thought that was the case .

'There are other odd points . '

After saying that ,Youko turned the files towards herself and started searching for something .

Finally, she took a copy of a class attendance sheet .

'How did you get...'

'Look here . '

Youko ignored Ishii's surprise and pointed at a specific place on the sheet .

It was Matsumoto Hiroshi's column .

From mid-February, there were many incidents where he was absent, late, or left early .

However, it wasn't that unnatural .

When students got to February of their third year at high school, most of them had obtained their placements . It wasn't strange for them to want to spend the rest of their high school lives in leisure .

'Look here . '

It seemed Youko had sensed Ishii's thoughts, as she pointed at a different column . The name of Seidou's son, Todayama Takahiro, was listed there .

There were also many absences in his column starting from mid-February .

Furthermore, they were always on the same day as Matsumoto Hiroshi . However, that wasn't too odd either .

'Might they not have been hanging out together?'

'They might have been, but I think there was something else . '

'What do you mean by something?'

'What I think is...'

Interrupting the conversation, Ishii's mobile rang .

'You can answer . '

'Ah, OK . '

With Youko's permission, Ishii answered the phone .

'Hello...'

14

Gotou got off the BMW ahead of the path to the lake .

He was about to head to the destination, but there was something he had to do before then . While being hit by the rain, Gotou opened the trunk .

Fortunately, there was a toolbox there .

'What do you plan on doing?' said Yakumo, sounding displeased as he stood in the rain .

'I'm going to take off the handcuffs . '

Gotou took pliers out of the toolbox .

Though it wasn't well known, the role of handcuffs wasn't just to keep the hands in check . By connecting the hands together closely, people couldn't keep their balance and wouldn't be able to run .

It was fine while moving in the car, but when thinking about what they'd had to do next – it'd be a problem if he left the handcuffs on Yakumo .

'Are you an idiot, Gotou-san? You can't take these off . '

Yakumo looked obviously disgruntled .

'It's just as Yakumo said . If you have the time for that, just head to the lake already,' said Eishin after getting off the BMW .

– Amateurs .

Gotou called them names in his heart .

'You guys didn't study at police school, did you?'

'Of course not . We aren't police officers,' said Yakumo with a shrug .

'The handcuffs police officers use aren't all the same type . '

'What differs?' interrupted Eishin .

'Strength and weight . '

As Gotou said that, he walked up to Yakumo, pulled him by the handcuffs and placed them on the car's bonnet .

'What do you mean?'

'In the past, police officers only used steel handcuffs, but then the handcuffs are heavy . '

'And?' urged Eishin, sounding interested .

'In particular, police officers have their police baton and wireless – it's pretty heavy . '

On top of that, with winter coats and raincoats, it was like wearing armour . Then they wouldn't be able to move quickly when they needed to .

Gotou put the pliers on the chains linking Yakumo's cuffs together and pressed down hard .

Yakumo seemed to have understood the situation, as he kept quiet .

'Recently, the police have been focussing on mobility, so handcuffs aren't strong – they're made of a light aluminium alloy . '

If it was for a heinous crime or arrest, police officers would carry steel cuffs, but normally, they just carried the aluminium alloy ones .

'Oh!'

'And police officers don't usually use handcuffs except in emergency arrests . '

'I see . '

Eishin clapped his hands together in understanding .

'In short, we'll be able to do something with these tools . '

'If you're taking them off, please hurry up and take them off,' said Yakumo with a yawn .

– He really is a hateful brat .

'There!'

Gotou used his body weight to press down .

However, he slipped in the rain – it wasn't going well .

'Help out some . '

'All right . '

Unusual for Eishin, he responded honestly .

Gotou had Eishin hold the chains . Gotou used both hands with force the pliers together .

After quite some effort, they managed to snap the chains .

'Though the cuffs are still on,' said Yakumo, sounding dissatisfied as he raised both hands .

The chains were cut and his hands were free, but the cuffs were still around his wrists .

'You can move – stop complaining,' said Gotou as he started walking the path towards the lake .

'Gotou-san . '

Yakumo called out to him .

'What?'

'Please bring the toolbox too . '

'Why?'

'It's obviously because it's necessary,' said Yakumo, running his hand through his hair .

– Damn, using me like a gopher .

15

Haruka leant back in the passenger seat and watched the endless rain .

Inside the car, it was warm and humid – she was sweaty even though she wasn't going anywhere .

The events so far spun through her head like a revolving lantern .

Though she felt like they were closer to the truth, she couldn't picture it, like it was an illusion .

'I wonder how Yakumo-kun is...' murmured Haruka . Then, her mobile rang .

It was a call from Makoto .

'Hello . '

<Ah, Haruka-chan . Where are you right now?>

Makoto's voice sounded a bit agitated .

'I'm waiting in Ishii-san's car . '

<I see . I called Ishii-san's phone earlier but he was in the middle of a call...>

Haruka looked at the window seat of the family restaurant where Ishii was .

Past the curtain of rain, she could see Ishii on the phone . He looked dumbfounded, like he had been surprised by something .

'He is on the phone . '

<Right . Actually, I wanted to ask something... is it OK?>

'Would I be helpful?' said Haruka, anxious .

<Of course . >

Makoto responded in a bright voice .

'What is it?'

<We might have made an unbelievable misassumption . >

Makoto's tone was hinting at something .

It sounded to Haruka like Makoto had solved the whole mystery . She naturally gripped the phone more tightly .

'Misassumption?'

<Yes . We were looking for Minami-san's lover and arrived at Naitou Yousuke . >

'Yes,' replied Haruka, recalling yesterday night's events .

He might know something as her lover . That was their thought when they acted . However, the worst result came about –

<I thought it was strange . >

'What was?'

<That Naitou Yousuke was Minami-san's lover . I thought that he didn't match...>

Haruka agreed with Makoto's opinion .

She wouldn't know how to explain it exactly, but the impression she had of him hadn't matched somehow . But –

'There are couples that work unexpectedly well even if they don't seem to suit each other though . '

<Right . At first, I thought it was just my mistake, but when I looked through Minami-san's things again – the ones we got from Tamae-san – that changed . >

'Did you find something?'

<Yes . There was a photo with Minami-san and Naitou Yousuke . >

'Is that so?'

Haruka couldn't remember seeing it .

<In the photo, Naitou Yousuke tried to put an arm around Minami-san, but she looked really unhappy about it . Like a physical rejection . '

Haruka hadn't seen the photo, so she couldn't say anything .

'Maybe it was from before they started dating . '

<I thought that at first too . Then I found something when I investigated once more . >

Haruka could tell Makoto was agitated on the other side of the phone .

'...What did you find?'

<I know who Minami-san's lover is . Y . N . -san . >

'Really?'

<Yes . My thoughts changed . A lot of things suddenly connected . >

– I want to know right now .

That feeling grew rapidly within Haruka .

'Please tell me . '

<That's...>

Haruka couldn't hear what Makoto said last .

It was because somebody suddenly opened the door on the driver's side came in .

It was somebody Haruka knew .

'You're...'

Haruka started to speak, but then a stun gun was held to her neck .

'It's been a while . '

With a smile that showed her white teeth – it was Nanase Miyuki .

The left half of her face was covered in a keloid, and from her left wrist onward, there was a stump . When Haruka saw Miyuki's glinting eyes, she went pale at once .

Sixteen years ago, this woman brutally killed her own family and had then manipulated many cases up until now with Yakumo's father, the man with two red eyes .

She was also the ringleader of the case that took Isshin's life .

Haruka could hear Makoto saying <Hello...> from the phone .

'Let's talk slowly later . Please sleep until then . '

Without waiting for Haruka's answer, Miyuki turned on the stun gun .

Haruka felt pain – like a needle had stabbed her – and fell unconscious .

16

The falling rain created countless ripples on the lake's surface .

'It's cold,' Gotou said without thinking .

Though it was quite warm, being hit by so much rain made his body colder .

'Please complain afterwards . '

Yakumo, who was walking behind Gotou, pushed Gotou's back .

Gotou lost his balance and was about to fall forward, but he managed to avoid it .

'What are you doing?'

'It's because you were dawdling,' said Yakumo, brushing aside the hair that stuck to his forehead after being drenched by the rain .

Eishin was laughing with shaking shoulders .

– I shouldn't have taken off those handcuffs .

With regret, Gotou walked along the lake towards the crape myrtle tree ahead .

It was where Yakumo had been bitten by a pit viper .

Perhaps because he was concerned about that, Yakumo was stepping carefully as he walked .

'This place OK?'

'Yes . '

After Yakumo answered Gotou's question, he started looking around .

At the roots of the crape myrtle tree, there was a rectangular rock – like a gravestone . It was the rock Yakumo had been resting against after being bitten by the pit viper .

'This, eh...' said Yakumo, looking at the rock .

'What's this rock?'

'Gotou-san . Please move this rock . '

That was Yakumo's response to Gotou's question .

Using a person like a slave . Yakumo had been a hundred times cuter when he was on the verge of death .

Though Gotou felt dissatisfied, he put his hands on the rock . It was quite heavy . He decided it would be impossible to lift it up and put his body weight against it to push it over, but it wouldn't move .

Eishin brought over a wooden stick and put it underneath the rock as a lever, lifting it up slightly . Gotou took that chance to push the rock with all his might .

There was a thump as the rock fell .

'Next, please dig here . '

Yakumo pointed at the revealed ground .

'Am I the Hanasaka Jiisan?' complained Gotou, but Yakumo acted like he didn't hear .

'Come on . '

Eishin gave the toolbox he had brought to Gotou .

– Looks like Eishin doesn't plan on helping any more .

Though Gotou wasn't happy about it, he took a hammer out of the toolbox and started using the side for pulling nails out to dig a hole in the ground .

– At some point, I became Yakumo's manservant .

Though he thought it, he didn't say it aloud . Since he couldn't use his head, he had to do physical work like this or he'd just be in the way .

Gotou focussed all his energy on digging, but when he had dug about fifty centimetres, he hit something .

He didn't know what was buried, but it looked like they'd reached their goal .

Gotou put the hammer aside and started scooping the dirt out with his hands .

Finally, he found something like a board .

He brushed away more dirt .

Something like a metal box appeared .

'Is this it?'

'Probably...'

Yakumo gave a short reply .

Gotou took the box out of the dirt .

When he brushed the dirt off of it, he could see it was a small portable safe . It was the type that had a password with a dial .

'Do you know the password?' asked Gotou .

'I don't . That's why I brought tools . '

Yakumo's response was as expected .

'Yeah, yeah . '

As Gotou replied, he took a flathead screwdriver out of the toolbox .

If it were a large heat-resistant safe, it'd be impossible for an amateur to open it with tools . However, they'd manage somehow for a portable one .

'Hold it down . '

'Got it . '

Eishin responded to Gotou's instructions and held the safe down .

– Things like this keep happening today .

Gotou put the screwdriver in the gap underneath the cover and hit the back of the screwdriver with the hammer as hard as he could .

There was a crack as the cover warped .

Gotou put the screwdriver deeper into the wider gap and hit the screwdriver with the hammer .

He repeated his .

After about ten minutes, the cover of the safe finally opened .

What came out was a wallet, necklace and mobile – a collection of small items .

'What's this?'

Yakumo didn't answer Gotou's question .

He just looked at the lake .

It was like somebody was at the end of his gaze .

Yakumo's red eye could probably see something . A spirit of the dead – ?

'Something there?'

'Yes . '

Yakumo responded immediately .

His eyes seemed sad .

A drop of water fell from Yakumo's chin .

'They want something?'

'She is full of hatred . She couldn't throw that hatred away even after her death . '

'Why does she hate so much?'

'She isn't at fault . It is natural for her to be full of hatred . '

'Can't it work out somehow?'

'I don't know how to heal that amount of hatred . '

As Yakumo said that, his profile looked both angry and sad .

17

<It's terrible!>

Through the phone, Ishii heard Miyagawa's agitated voice .

Things had been terrible throughout this case . It made Ishii think that nothing worse could happen .

'What happened?' asked Ishii, confused .

<This morning, there was a report from the Nishitama precinct . That Saitou Yakumo was hiding in Seidou's temple . >

'Eh?'

Ishii was surprised in more than one meaning of the word .

Hiding in the temple of the victim, Seidou –

There was that saying – can't see the forest for the trees . The Nishitama precinct had focussed on the rails and had searched on the mountains as well .

However, Yakumo had hid right in the middle of the wide search net .

Youko looked at Ishii with a dubious expression .

'So Yakumo-shi...'

Ishii hunched over, hiding from Youko's gaze as he spoke .

<An officer chased him and performed an emergency arrest . >

'That's...'

Yakumo had been caught .

Though Ishii was shocked, he had another question .

'Excuse me... What happened to Detective Gotou?'

Gotou should have been with Yakumo . If Yakumo was arrested, then Gotou –

<There's the problem . When the officer caught up to Yakumo, Gotou hadn't been at the scene . >

'That's great . '

<No it isn't!>

Miyagawa let out a yell that sounded like it had erupted from the bottom of his stomach .

'Eek . '

Ishii let out a voice close to a shriek .

<That idiot ran his car into the police car and escaped with Saitou Yakumo!>

It looked like Gotou and Yakumo had both been able to escape .

– Thank goodness .

Though Ishii thought it, he didn't say it aloud . That would incur Miyagawa's wrath .

<I can't cover for him any longer . >

It sounded like Miyagawa might cry at any moment .

'Could it be that Detective Gotou...'

<Reinstatement is hopeless . He's getting a disciplinary dismissal . And you and me are both getting some sort of punishment . >

For a moment, Ishii's vision went dark .

He didn't care about himself, but he couldn't accept the fact that Gotou would receive a disciplinary dismissal .

<Got this? Whether Yakumo is the culprit or not isn't the problem any more . If anything else happens, we won't be able to fix this . >

'Yes sir...'

<Forget about me . Even if I continued to work, it'd just be two or three years . But it's different for you . >

Miyagawa's voice was shaking slightly .

Even at a time like this, this person was worried about Ishii . When Ishii thought about that, his heart wavered .

<Come back right now . >

'I can't do that!'

Ishii gave a firm refusal .

He understood Miyagawa's feelings so much that it hurt, but the case wasn't over yet .

Like Ishii could go back in this situation . Though he was shaken, his determination hadn't changed .

He couldn't do anything about Gotou's not being allowed to return to the police, but he had to at least make a place that Gotou could safely return to .

<Do you understand what you're saying?>

'I do . I won't return until I reveal the truth of the case!'

Ishii interrupted Miyagawa and hung up without waiting for an answer .

'What happened?'

Youko looked troubled as she spoke .

It would probably be better to tell her the situation . Ishii opened his mouth, but then his mobile rang again .

He thought that maybe it was Miyagawa calling again, but he was wrong . The number on the display was Makoto's .

'Hello, Ishii speaking . '

<Ishii-san, where's Haruka-chan?>

Makoto was clearly upset .

'What happened to Haruka-chan?'

<Is she there?>

'Er... She should be waiting outside...'

Ishii looked out the window .

'Ah!'

The car that should have been there wasn't there . Even though it had just been there earlier –

Ishii's heart beat furiously .

His hands were shaking . A cold sweat burst out on his forehead .

<Just earlier, I was talking with Haruka-chan on the phone . Then the call suddenly wouldn't connect...>

While listening to Makoto, Ishii walked unsteadily towards the exit .

His vision was unstable .

He opened the door and went outside . No matter how he looked, he couldn't find the car .

The rain continued hitting the ground loudly .

– If you're caught by the police, somebody important to you will die .

The phrase Ishii had heard from Yakumo came up in his head .

– I want you to protect her .

Ishii had made a promise with Yakumo .

– But then why did I leave Haruka alone?

'Aaagh!'

Hit by a wave of regret, Ishii fell to the ground on his knees .

18

When Gotou returned to the car, he turned on the engine and air conditioning .

His body was soaked . If he didn't dry off at least a bit, he would catch a cold .

In the passenger seat, Eishin was drying himself off with a towel that had been in the glove box .

In the back seat, Yakumo was focussed on checking the contents of the portable safe they had dug up, like he had completely forgotten that he was drenched .

'Did you find something?' asked Gotou as he turned around .

'Yes . It is just as I expected . '

Yakumo continued searching .

'Explain properly . '

'These items belong to Minami-san, who disappeared ten years ago . '

Yakumo held out a student ID in a leather case .

Gotou took it and looked at the photo of a girl who was looking straight forward .

It looked rather old and the colour was faded, but he could still tell that Minami was quite a beauty .

'After Minami-san was killed, her body was sunk into the lake . Her belongings were put in this safe and buried there . '

'Yakumo . The ghost you saw earlier...'

'It was Minami-san,' said Yakumo, looking up suddenly .

– I see .

The events that had been blurry in Gotou's head came together . However, a new question came up .

'How'd you know the belongings were buried under that tree?'

'It was written in Seidou's diary... right?'

Eishin spoke before Yakumo did .

'So you did know . '

Yakumo looked at Eishin coldly .

Eishin leant back on his seat, as if to run away from that gaze, and sighed .

'I didn't know for certain, but I had felt it faintly . '

Eishin's prise was surprisingly quiet .

Yakumo and Eishin knew everything, but Gotou really didn't understand .

'Don't just continue talking . Explain it so I can understand . '

'What did you start not understanding?'

Yakumo sounded disappointed .

– Where? That’s obvious .

'From the beginning . '

'You really are an idiot . '

Yakumo looked blatantly displeased by Gotou’s reply as he ran a hand through his hair . It made water fly everywhere .

Like a dog coming out of a bath .

'Stop talking so much...'

Interrupting Gotou’s words, Eishin’s mobile rang .

'It’s a number I don’t know,' muttered Eishin, but he answered the phone .

After a simple conversation with the person on the other side of the phone, he handed the mobile to Gotou .

'It’s probably for you . '

'What do you mean, probably?'

'He’s frantic – I can’t understand what he’s saying . '

Eishin was frowning .

– That idiot .

Gotou was angry as he took the phone from Eishin .

'Hello . '

<Detective Gotouuuuu!>

Ishii’s panicked voice came through .

Ishii was always cowering, but this level of panic wasn’t natural .

'What's wrong?'

<I sincerely apologise . Because of my mistake, something awful happened...>

It sounded like Ishii was already crying .

Even if he suddenly apologised, Gotou didn't know what it was for .

'What happened? Calm down and talk . '

<Haruka-chan...>

Ishii started sobbing .

A chill ran down Gotou's spine . The message left by Nanase Miyuki ran through his mind . Could it be –

Yakumo seemed to have sensed something, as he was biting his lip as he held his breath .

No, it wasn't certain that something had happened to Haruka yet . Gotou calmed his nerves .

'What happened to her?'

<She disappeared . I took my eyes off of her for a moment...>

Ishii spoke in tears .

– Disappeared?

19

Ishii wanted somebody to destroy him .

Yell at him, beat him, tear him apart . He couldn't exist here right now .

The person important to him had been taken away because of his own carelessness .

If something happened to Haruka, he would be crushed by his regret .

<I'm handing the phone over to Yakumo . >

Gotou spoke on the other side of the phone .

Ishii's mind went blank . He didn't know what to say to explain things to Yakumo .

– I want you to protect her .

Yakumo had made that request, and Ishii had accepted it . But he hadn't been able to protect her .

<Ishii-san, it's Yakumo . >

'I... I'm sorry . Because of me... Even though I promised... I...'

Tears fell from Ishii's eyes .

He couldn't breathe properly .

– It hurts .

<Ishii-san, could you cry afterwards?>

That one sentence from Yakumo left a strong impact on Ishii's heart .

'I...'

<I do not plan on blaming you, Ishii-san . There's no time for that . Something must be done for her . >

Yakumo spoke curtly, but his words were filled with a strong will that encouraged Ishii, who had been about to break .

'Y-yes . '

– That's right . This isn't the time to cry .

He could blame himself for his error later . The most important thing right now was to get Haruka back safely . But –

'How can we find Haruka-chan?'

<It would probably be difficult to find her even if you start searching now .
If Nanase Miyuki is the one who abducted her, murder is her goal . >

Yakumo said that quietly .

However, the meaning of those words were too heavy for one person to carry .

It was like he was saying it was hopeless .

'That's...'

Ishii had just regained his spirit, but his feelings couldn't bear the weight and started to sink again .

<Please don't be so pessimistic . >

'But...'

<Ishii-san . You know her mobile phone address, yes?>

He had it recorded in his contacts list .

However, Ishii didn't understand why Yakumo had suddenly brought that up .

'Er... Do you mean Haruka-chan's?'

<You know it, correct?>

Yakumo asked him that again .

'Yes . '

<Then please send what I am about to say in a message . >

'What are you trying to do?' asked Ishii, unable to hold back .

He didn't think sending a message would tell them where Haruka was .

<If it is impossible to search for her, I can just call her out . >

Yakumo spoke in a clear tone .

– Call?

'Do you mean, to send a message and call out Nanase Miyuki?>

<Correct . >

Ishii felt like he had been hit by lightning .

Ishii hadn't thought of that . It might really be possible to save Haruka . It made him feel that way .

<Could you note this down?>

'Yes . '

Ishii took out his memo pad immediately and wrote down what Yakumo said .

<Ishii-san . >

After conveying his message, Yakumo spoke formally .

'Yes . '

<Please don't blame yourself no matter what happens . >

'But...'

No matter what Yakumo said, Ishii couldn't stop blaming himself .

If he had watched Haruka properly, this wouldn't have happened . That was an unchangeable truth .

<I have regrets myself . >

'Eh?'

<If she hadn't met me, this wouldn't have happened to her...>

Yakumo's words carved deep into Ishii's chest .

He hadn't thought that Yakumo would think that way . But if regret piled up, that was probably where it would end .

'That's...'

<But I don't want to think that . That's why...>

'Yes . '

<Then...>

'Excuse me . '

Ishii called out to Yakumo as he was about to hang up .

<What is it?>

'I will go too . '

<You'll come even if I tell you not to, won't you . >

'Yes . '

<I understand . Then I will see you later . >

The call ended .

Ishii gripped the mobile tightly .

He didn't know how things would end . All he could do now was believe and act . That was the only and best method they had .

– I really can't win against Yakumo .

That feeling suddenly came to Ishii . There was a strong bond between Yakumo and Haruka that nobody could contend with .

'Ishii-san . '

Ishii lifted his head in surprise when somebody called out to him .

It was Youko .

'You're going somewhere, right? Shall I drive you?' said Youko, spinning her car keys .

To Ishii, she looked like a goddess come to his rescue .

20

'Do you think Nanase Miyuki would really come just like that!?' said Gotou, his anger erupting out of him .

Miyuki's goal was to kill Haruka . Yakumo had said that himself . Then there was no way she'd just come at his invitation .

She'd kill Haruka and end things quickly .

No, she might already have killed her –

'She'll come,' said Yakumo with a blank expression .

His eyes even looked full of confidence .

'How can you be sure?'

'You know this as well, don't you, Gotou-san? She is an unbelievable sadist . '

Yakumo's gaze was forceful .

When those eyes looked at Gotou, it made him remember the incidents she had caused in the past .

All of them were appropriately sadistic . With Isshin, she had purposely called out Gotou and Ishii to tell them she was going to kill him .

Rather than the act of murder, she took pleasure in seeing how people suffered from it .

'But you're being chased . You can't just run around town . '

'That's why I called her out to the place where the case started – the limestone cavern . '

– I see .

At the limestone cavern, if they just got past the two uniformed guards at the entrance, it could be called a safe place where people wouldn't see them .

If they were lucky, the officers might have left because of the typhoon .

In that meaning, it was likely that she might agree to the invitation .

She'd take Haruka's life in front of Yakumo .

For a sadist like Miyuki, nothing could be a better show . But –

'She wouldn't have already killed her, right?'

After saying that, Gotou immediately regretted it, but it was too late .

Yakumo gave Gotou an amazing glare .

Under that pressure, Gotou couldn't breathe .

Gotou knew this . Even though Yakumo was acting calm, he was the one who was the most distressed .

While feeling like his chest was being wrenched apart, he was wagering on the few methods to save Haruka . By believing in them, he was managing to keep his calm .

Though it was a dangerous tightrope, it was his only path .

If Yakumo lost Haruka after Isshin, he would probably fall backwards into a deep darkness, like the man with two red eyes .

– I won't let that happen .

Isshin had entrusted them to Gotou . Nao and Yakumo both – that was why he had thrown away the bothersome ties of obligation that were the identity of a police officer and was here now .

'My bad . '

Gotou gave an honest apology .

'It's fine,' said Yakumo .

Gotou didn't understand what was 'fine' about it .

'What do you mean?'

'Nanase Miyuki wouldn't have killed her yet . She would only do it after she has made her suffer sufficiently . '

Yakumo bit down on his lip .

His veins stuck out from his tight fists .

– Don't burden yourself with all the pain .

Gotou murmured that in his heart .

As if he'd heard Gotou's voice, Yakumo looked up with a bitter smile .

'We'll get Haruka-chan back no matter what . '

'Of course . That was always my plan . '

Yakumo's expression relaxed just slightly . That was the end of the conversation . But the problem was still ahead .

'Even if Nanase Miyuki agrees to the invitation, do you think she'll just show up?'

'She'll probably set some sort of trap,' Yakumo said, as if it were a matter of fact .

'What do you plan to do?'

'Trying to imagine what sort of trap she'll set is a waste of time . '

That was true . Trying to think something up in this short time would just give them a plan full of holes .

This time, there were too many unknown variables . But –

'Is that really fine?'

'What a stupid question,' replied Yakumo, looking straight forward .

21

Haruka woke up in the car's backseat .

Her hands were bound behind her with packing tape . They seemed to be wrapped quite tightly – she couldn't move even when she tried with all her strength .

'You've woken up then . '

She heard a voice .

Haruka lifted her head and saw Nanase Miyuki's face through the rear-view mirror as she drove .

She had a smile on her face that was so cold that it made Haruka shiver .

'Why...'

'You want to ask me why I'm doing this, right?' interrupted Miyuki .

Her eyes were a very deep dark .

'You should know the answer yourself . '

Miyuki's words doubled Haruka's terror .

Haruka understood somewhere in her heart as well . Nanase Miyuki wasn't the sort of person who would abduct somebody else for a ransom . Her goal was to murder –

No, that wasn't it – Miyuki was trying to hurt Yakumo by killing Haruka .

'Yakumo lost the game . '

Miyuki's shoulders shook as she giggled .

'Game?'

'Yes . I warned him . I told him that if he was caught by the police, somebody important to him would die...'

When Haruka heard Miyuki's words, everything came together .

Though she hadn't heard anything about it, it was because of that situation that Yakumo ran off and told Haruka to move with Ishii and Makoto .

– Sorry .

Haruka looked down .

In the end, she had ended up being in the way, like always .

Then, Haruka realised something .

'Yakumo-kun...'

'Was caught by the police . Somebody spotted him hiding at the temple . '

Miyuki smirked triumphantly .

'That's...'

'Though Gotou got in the way and they escaped again . '

Haruka sighed in relief .

Yakumo wasn't alone right now . He had Gotou, a strong ally . Anyway, she was just happy that he was safe .

'But he did get caught, so the game's over . You're going to die . '

Miyuki's eyes narrowed .

She looked like she was in a trance, as if she were imagining in her head how she would kill Haruka .

– I'm going to be killed .

It didn't seem real . Her heart couldn't accept it .

A mobile rang to signal a message . Haruka noticed that it was her own .

Miyuki looked at the mobile phone in the passenger seat .

'It's a last message to you . '

Miyuki smiled like she was enjoying this . While waiting at the traffic light, she picked up the mobile and read the text .

After reading it, Miyuki laughed aloud with shaking shoulders .

– What’s written there? I want to know .

As if to respond to Haruka’s wish, Miyuki started reading the message aloud .

‘I will be waiting in two hours at the limestone cavern . Let us bring this to a conclusion at the place everything started . From Yakumo... That’s what it says . ’

‘Conclusion...’

That word circled Haruka’s head .

Since it was a message, it was difficult to see the true meaning there, but to Haruka, it sounded like Yakumo was prepared for his own death .

‘Isn’t he an idiot? Does he think I’d agree to an invitation like this? What a guy . ’

Miyuki smiled .

It was a twisted smile that made Haruka’s core shake in fear –

22

The rain was growing stronger –

Gotou huffed as he took the path to the limestone cavern .

After getting out into the open, he spotted the entrance to the limestone cave .

He hid behind the trees and looked around .

Fortunately, his guess had been right . There were no officers at the cavern's entrance – just a yellow tape that forbid trespassing .

There could be a landslide or flood . He wanted to finish this quickly .

'It's OK!'

Gotou turned around and said that to Yakumo, who was hiding in the thicket .

There was rustling as Yakumo and Eishin showed up .

– Putting Yakumo aside, does Eishin really need to hide too?

Though Gotou was dissatisfied, he walked along the wet ground to the limestone cavern .

The yellow tape made a diagonal cross across the entrance .

It looked like nobody had come yet .

It'd have been troublesome if Miyuki got here first . Gotou couldn't go inside in his relief .

He ripped the tape off of the entrance .

'Shall we go then?'

Yakumo stepped into the dim limestone cave .

'You're unexpectedly hasty . '

While complaining, Eishin followed Yakumo with a torch . Gotou ended up being at the rear .

Just when he'd heard something clattering, a rock the size of a fist fell on Gotou's feet .

Water dripped from the ceiling .

'Oi – isn't this bad?'

Gotou spoke without thinking .

'A limestone cavern is a space where limestone has been corroded by rain and underground water . They become more fragile as they grow in size and in the end, they collapse . It grows with time and dies . In the same way that people do . '

Eishin stopped and pointed his torch at the ceiling as he said that .

Points on the ceiling were wet with water .

'Let's pray that it doesn't collapse now . '

Gotou started walking again .

'Yakumo . Why did you call Nanase Miyuki here?'

Gotou thought that Yakumo had called Miyuki to this limestone cavern for a reason besides the lack of prying eyes .

'To speed things up,' Yakumo replied curtly .

'Eh?'

'Unfortunately, I am still a fugitive . Even if I get her back, that fact won't change . '

'Well, that's true . '

'In order to solve the mystery, it is necessary to check the scene of the crime once more . I called her out here so I could do that at the same time . '

'So to speed things up . '

Gotou understood now .

Yakumo's words meant that no matter what result was waiting for them, the end of the case was near . After coming this far, Gotou'd see it to the end .

Gotou walked forward with refreshed determination .

Passing through the curving path, they went to the back of the limestone cavern and finally reached the doors to the cavern which was the scene of the crime .

There was yellow tape here as well, as if to seal the doors shut .

Yakumo took the tape off, opened the door and stepped inside .

The light of the torch wasn't enough .

'I can't see anything . '

As if to interrupt Gotou's words, the sound of an engine echoed through the limestone cavern .

– What's that?

Gotou hurriedly looked around .

Suddenly, the room became bright .

Because his eyes weren't accustomed to the light, his vision went white and he had to look away .

'It's a generator,' said Yakumo .

After blinking a number of times, Gotou was able to see Yakumo standing by the doors .

At his feet, there was a small generator . The black cord that came from it went to the lights in the four corners of the room .

Then they wouldn't need the torch .

'So what are you going to investigate?'

Without replying to Gotou's question, Yakumo knelt at the location Seidou had collapsed and stared at the white outline in the shape of a human being .

The fresh bloodstains were a dark red .

Then, Yakumo went to the back of the room .

There were rusted chains there .

'So that really was the case...' said Yakumo as he ran a finger along the floorboards .

Gotou didn't know what was the case .

'Hey, Yakumo . '

As usual, Yakumo didn't answer Gotou . He just stared at the back wall of the room .

That was the only place where the rock showed through .

As if to check to the temperature, Yakumo placed his palm on the limestone and closed his eyes .

It was like he was praying –

'Unkai...'

Yakumo said just that .

'What's that?'

'Eishin-san, there is something I would like to ask . '

Yakumo ignored Gotou's question and turned towards Eishin .

It looked like Eishin already knew what he was going to ask, as he looked back at Yakumo with a stiff expression .

'How long as this room been here?'

'It's probably already been sixty years...' said Eishin while touching the pillar in the middle of the room .

'Uncle wasn't the only one who trained at that temple, correct?' said Yakumo .

– Why is he asking something so obvious?

Gotou didn't understand the point of Yakumo's question . That temple had a long history . It must have had countless monks training there .

However, it looked like Eishin did understand, as he nodded silently .

'My grandfather is included in that number, yes?'

'W-what did you say?'

Gotou spoke automatically, but then he realised it wasn't something to make a fuss about .

Though he hadn't met him, it was natural for Yakumo to have a grandfather . And temples often accepted people through a hereditary system . It wouldn't be strange for his grandfather to be a monk .

'I understand a number of things now . '

Yakumo's narrowed eyes looked side .

'What do you understand?' asked Gotou .

Yakumo ignored him again and walked towards Eishin .

'Why didn't you tell me from the beginning?'

Though Yakumo spoke quietly, his tone was full of force .

'It's not something to let other people here . Your own fate is something you should confirm with your own eyes and ears,' replied Eishin with a blank expression .

Their gazes met, and a suffocating silence continued –

Interrupting that silence, the doors to the room opened .

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With the light of the torch, Ishii advanced alone into the limestone cavern .

Youko was waiting at the cavern entrance .

Nanase Miyuki was coming . If anything happened, Ishii would call Youko for assistance immediately .

– But this place really is creepy .

Ishii's fear increased as he advanced, and he found it hard to breathe .

The echo from the rocks made his footsteps sound doubled .

Just as he had started to regret coming alone, he reached the room which was probably the scene of the crime .

With the rock face at the back and wooden walls on the other three sides, there were a set of double doors leading in .

A faint light came out of the gap between the doors .

– Gotou and Yakumo should be on the other side .

Ishii wiped the sweat on his palms on his pants and opened the door .

He spotted three people – Yakumo, Gotou, and a large-framed monk in robes .

'D-Detective Gotou!'

Ishii rushed over to Gotou .

'Don't cling to me!'

Gotou pushed Ishii aside .

Ishii lost his balance and almost fell, but he managed to hold on .

'Everyone, I am glad you're safe . Now, who might this be...'

Ishii looked at the monk he didn't recognise .

'The damn monk who was the start of this case . '

Ishii remembered after hearing Gotou's explanation .

If he recalled correctly, this was Eishin, the monk who was Isshin's teacher
—

'Ah, it's nice to meet you . My name is Ishii Yuutarou . '

Ishii bowed his head .

'So who's that behind you?'

Gotou looked sharply behind Ishii's back .

'Eh?'

Ishii frantically turned around .

Youko was standing there . He sighed in relief .

'Please relax . She is a detective from the Nishitama precinct...'

Ishii was about to continue when Youko suddenly stepped forward .

'Natsume Youko of the Nishitama precinct . '

Youko showed her police ID .

Her voice had the air of one intimidating a culprit .

'Er...'

'You're Saitou Yakumo, aren't you?'

Youko interrupted Ishii again .

Yakumo looked dubious, but he finally breathed out, as if accepting it .

'Yes . So it really was you?' said Yakumo, as if he had known Youko from before .

When Youko heard those words, she didn't look particularly surprised .

'Ishii-san, I'm sorry . '

Ishii didn't know why Youko was apologising .

Youko quickly turned aside and kneed Ishii in the crotch while he was still confused .

'Urgh . '

The fierce pain coming up from Ishii's lower half made him curl up and fall to the floor .

Then, Youko took a pistol from her bosom and pointed it at Yakumo .

'Saitou Yakumo . I am arresting you under suspicion of murder . '

Ishii couldn't understand what Youko was doing .

She had investigated with him . She had believed that Yakumo wasn't the murderer . Yet –

'W-why...'

Ishii looked up at Youko's face while withstanding the pain .

Her wet hair hid her face so he couldn't see her expression clearly .

'What the hell did you do that to Ishii for!'

Gotou stooped over and tried to rush at Youko .

However, Youko pointed the pistol right at Gotou and held him in check . If it were a knife, Gotou would probably have rushed on anyway, but he couldn't move in the face of a pistol .

'You don't plan on arresting me, right?'

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair .

If she doesn't plan on arresting him, then what is she going to do –

A cold sweat ran down Ishii's back as he thought frantically, but he couldn't come up with the answer .

'What do you mean?'

Gotou asked Ishii's question .

Yakumo put an index finger to his brow .

'The culprit to the series of cases this time, Natsume Youko-san, is you, isn't it . '

Yakumo's sentence pierced through Ishii's chest .

– That's impossible .

He couldn't believe it . They had worked together up until now . She had led Ishii here . For her to be the culprit –

Though Ishii tried frantically to deny it, a theory came to his head . What if Youko got close to Ishii to find out Yakumo's movements?

– No, that can't be it .

Ishii sat up while bearing with the pain .

'That isn't true . Natsume-san isn't the culprit... You have no reason, right? Natsume-san, please stop it with the pistol . Yakumo isn't the culprit . '

Even as he pleaded, Ishii noticed that his heart was trembling .

Yakumo's reasoning had never been wrong before . Then that meant Youko really was –

'The reason why Natsume-san killed three people, starting with Seidou-san, is this . '

Yakumo took a photo out of his chest pocket .

It was completely drenched, and the distance made it impossible to see clearly . Perhaps sensing Ishii's thoughts, Yakumo pinched the photo in his fingers and flung it .

It spun in the air and fell at Ishii's feet .

'This is...'

In the photo Ishii picked up, there were two girls wearing blazer uniforms .

One was Minami, the girl who had disappeared ten years ago . And the other was –

Ishii looked up at Youko's face again .

'That's right . The girl in that photo is me . '

Youko said that coldly –

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'What did you say?'

Gotou spoke up without thinking .

The detective named Natsume was the friend of Minami, the girl who disappeared ten years ago –

Just as Gotou realised that, new questions kept coming to his head .

'In order to solve the mystery of the case, it is necessary to go back ten years in time . '

Yakumo turned his back to Youko .

It was composure that suggested he knew that Youko wouldn't pull the trigger .

'Ten years ago, Minami-san was kidnapped by the dead Matsumoto Hiroshi, Naitou Yosuke and Todayama Takahiro with the intent of assault . '

'As expected...' murmured Ishii .

Gotou had figured that much out too .

'Then... she was imprisoned here . '

Yakumo slowly walked up to the chains and ran his finger along them, as if in sympathy .

Gotou understood without him saying anything .

Minami had probably been held by those chains .

'Minami-san was a strong woman . Even while she was kept captive and bearing with the humiliation, she continued to call out: "I won't forgive you . " However, that backfired on her...'

Yakumo turned towards Youko again .

Youko wasn't moving, still holding the pistol . Gotou would have flown at her if she gave him a chance, but she seemed to know that .

'Minami-san was killed by the classmates who kidnapped her...' Ishii said in a murmur .

However, Yakumo shook his head to deny it .

'No, they were not the ones who killed her . They were frightened by her words and lost the chance to let her escape . '

'So they kept her here?' said Gotou, as if the words were strangled out of him .

'Correct . '

'That's... So they were going to let her starve to death...'

Yakumo shook his head again .

'That isn't correct either . The person who killed Minami-san was Seidou-san . '

'Wha!'

Gotou shouted in his surprise .

Ishii's eyes were as round as plates and his mouth was wide open .
However, Youko and Eishin were expressionless .

'Why would the monk kill her?' asked Gotou in his agitation .

Yakumo slowly walked up to Eishin .

'I said this earlier as well, but Seidou-san's son, Takahiro-san, was also a part of the members who kidnapped Minami-san . '

– So that's why .

Gotou realised what Yakumo was getting at, but that selfishness disgusted him .

'So he knew and kept quiet to hide his son's crime...'

He wanted Yakumo to deny it, but Gotou's hope was dashed .

'Though Seidou-san felt compassion for Minami-san, he couldn't indict his son . So, every night, he came to this limestone cavern and gave Minami-san food . '

Gotou wanted to cover his ears .

That wasn't compassion . It was just self-satisfaction –

It would've been different if he'd let her go, but he'd just let her live longer in captivity – who'd be satisfied with that? For her, it was probably nothing but suffering .

'Finally, Seidou-san noticed something . '

'Something?' asked Ishii .

Eishin bit down hard on his lower lip and looked down .

'Minami-san was pregnant . '

'Pregnant?' said Youko in shock .

Her eyes had been cold earlier, but now they trembled faintly .

'So you really didn't know . You were just manipulated by Nanase Miyuki . She twists the truth as she likes...'

'You're the one who's twisting the truth! Minami was tormented by them, killed by Seidou and sunk into the lake!'

Youko's voice was hysterical and tears welled up in her eyes .

– I'll be able to stop her now .

Gotou lowered his centre of gravity and tried to rush at Youko .

'Gotou-san, you can't!'

Yakumo was the one who yelled –

Youko seemed to come to her senses at that voice . She wiped her eyes and turned the pistol towards Gotou .

'Why'd you stop me?'

That could have been their last chance . Gotou glared at Yakumo, but Yakumo didn't seem to care .

'If you move now, you'll be playing into her hands,' said Yakumo with a sigh .

He probably meant Miyuki . Miyuki still hadn't come with Haruka –

'Minami... had a child...'

Youko mumbled that deliriously .

'Yes . After Minami-san gave birth, Seidou-san killed her and sank her into the lake . '

'Why did he kill her...'

Gotou looked at Yakumo again .

He had fed her to keep her alive and killed her in the end . His actions seemed inconsistent .

'He couldn't bear it any more,' replied Yakumo with sad eyes .

'His guilt?'

'It's a little different . Do you recall what happened to Seidou-san's son?'

'Yeah . '

Gotou nodded .

Eishin had told him . Seidou's son, Takahiro, had killed himself in the temple –

'To his son Takahiro, Seidou-san's act of keeping Minami-san alive was nothing short of psychological torture . When he found out that she had given birth to a daughter, he couldn't bear it...'

Yakumo's voice weighed heavily on Gotou .

Seidou had kept quiet about Minami in order to protect his son . That was also why he hadn't released Minami from her captivity .

At the same time, Seidou felt pity for Minami and kept her alive by continuing to give her food .

However, that had cornered Takahiro psychologically .

'After Takahiro-san's death, Seidou-san realised that if he had no intention of releasing Minami-san, his actions were only for self-satisfaction . '

'What the hell...' said Gotou in a shaking voice .

Seidou's first choice had been wrong . If he had notified the police after noticing his son's crime, this wouldn't have happened .

'The pregnant Minami-san gave birth to a child . It was a girl . That girl is still alive . '

Yakumo raised his voice one level higher .

'Eh?'

Youko's brow furrowed in her astonishment .

From that reaction, it looked like she really hadn't known .

However, after coming this far, Gotou knew who that child was .

– Hatsune .

The girl who claimed to be her mother's reincarnation .

After thinking that much, Gotou came to a theory .

Yakumo had said that Hatsune was told by somebody that she was her mother's reincarnation and came to claim that herself .

'Could it be that... the one who told Hatsune she was a reincarnation was...'

'Correct . The spirit of the dead Minami-san . '

So that really was it .

When Yakumo met Hatsune, he had said, 'You can hear her . ' The true meaning of that was probably that she could hear the voices of the spirits of the dead .

'Why... did she...'

'To try to make her child take revenge . '

Yakumo looked down sadly .

To make her own child take revenge – Gotou couldn't understand it .

Even if parents would sacrifice themselves for children, they couldn't use children for their own selfish reasons .

Gotou looked at Yakumo unconsciously .

Come to think of it, Yakumo had been born under similar circumstances to Hatsune .

'Let's get back to the topic at hand . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair and suddenly walked up to Youko .

'Don't come any closer . '

Youko pointed the pistol at Yakumo .

However, Yakumo continued talking without even a slight change in expression .

'Minami-san's child was taken home by Seidou-san and treated as an abandoned child . He raised her as his own . '

'Don't say such irresponsible things . Where's the proof of that?' Youko said shrilly .

'What I've just said was all in Seidou-san's diary,' said Yakumo .

Gotou understood now . Yakumo had been looking for that in the archive last night . And he found it .

'So that's how you got to the truth?' asked Gotou .

'I actually realised the truth upon coming to Seidou-san's, and then Seidou-san and I had a dispute . However, the back of my head was hit and I fainted, and I had forgotten the crucial part...'

Yakumo frowned as he ran a hand through his hair .

That had been the most troublesome . If Yakumo hadn't lost his memory, they would have solved the case sooner .

'Natsume-san . You were the one who hit me that day, yes?' said Yakumo, looking at Youko's eyes .

Youko didn't respond .

However, that itself proved that what Yakumo said was true .

'After you made me faint, you killed Seidou-san and stabbed him with a knife, over and over again...'

'But the fingerprints...' said Ishii, standing up waveringly .

He probably still couldn't believe that Youko was the culprit .

'Do you know about fake fingerprints?'

'So that was it?'

Gotou understood immediately .

They were a problem recently . They were frequently used by illegal immigrants – silicone fingerprints about one millimetre in thickness that had other people's fingerprints on them . If you wore them on your fingers, you could pass customs .

Overseas, they could be obtained for less than seventy yen for one .

Wearing fake fingerprints, she gripped the knife and stabbed Seidou . She probably used the same method for the other victims .

'If investigated properly, it should become clear that even if the fingerprints match, the hand size is wrong,' Yakumo explained further .

However, there was still something Gotou didn't get .

'Why would she do so much? Would you do that much for a friend?'

'They weren't friends . Minami-san and Youko-san were lovers . '

Yakumo's voice echoed through the room –

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– They were lovers .

Even after hearing those words, Ishii wasn't that surprised .

He had reasoned to a point that this series of murders was revenge for Minami . He had felt like it was by a lover .

Searching for a man had been a blind spot .

However, after hearing Yakumo's words, a number of things connected .

– Furthermore, investigating with a man...

– The ghost of my dead lover .

The things Youko had said circled Ishii's head .

He should have noticed sooner .

Ishii had denied that Youko was the culprit earlier, but there were other things that pointed to her being the culprit .

Youko had agreed with Ishii that Yakumo wasn't the culprit at a fairly early stage . That had also just been an excuse to determine Yakumo and Gotou's movements .

Now that he thought about it, the documents she'd shown him at the family restaurant had been too great in number to gather in just half a day .

However, Ishii still couldn't see Youko as a cold-blooded killer .

'Lover... So Natsume wanted to be a man...'

Gotou's mouth was trembling .

– That's not it .

Ishii cried out in his heart . Romance wasn't only between men and woman .

'Gotou-san, that's prejudiced,' said Yakumo, as if representing Ishii's heart .

'What?'

'Natsume-san, as a woman, loved Minami-san, who was a woman . '

'A lesbian...'

'Don't sum up what I had with Minami with that word!' Youko said shrilly .

'I feel the same way . '

Yakumo was the one who agreed .

Youko's eyes went wide as she looked at Yakumo .

She had lived up until now under the eyes of prejudice . She probably hadn't thought Yakumo, as a man, would agree with her .

'Regardless of the partner's gender, the feeling of caring about something does not change . Just because a relationship is between two women does not make those feelings weaker than the relationship between a man and a woman . Natsume-san just happened to love a woman; that's all . '

Yakumo's voice echoed against the walls .

Youko's expression softened just slightly and her mouth moved .

Though Ishii couldn't hear her, he felt like she had said 'Thank you' .

Gotou didn't try to say anything else . It felt like he didn't agree, but he understood .

It seemed like all the mysteries had become clear, but for Ishii, there was still something odd .

'Why did you try to make Yakumo-shi the suspect?'

If Youko had been trying to take revenge, there was no reason to place the responsibility on somebody else .

If you were planning on running away, you shouldn't try for revenge .

Ishii looked at Youko .

'To buy time . '

The one who replied was not Youko but Yakumo .

'To buy... time...'

'Correct . In order to take revenge, I needed to kill three people . It took time to do that . There would be no meaning to it if I were arrested before then . '

'So you focussed the police's attention on a suspect and used that chance to kill he others?'

Gotou clapped his hands together in understanding .

'That's correct . '

Yakumo nodded .

The reason Youko had created a suspect was clear, but there was still something Ishii didn't understand .

'Why did it have to be Yakumo-shi?'

Ishii leant forward .

Then, Youko turned the pistol towards Ishii's forehead .

'Isn't that enough of the truth...'

Youko's eyes were wet with tears .

She was suffering . Ishii could feel it .

Did Youko really take revenge because she wanted to – wasn't there another goal?

'You were told by Nanase Miyuki, correct? To make me the suspect...' said Yakumo .

– I see . So it was her . ’

Just from hearing that name, Ishii felt like he understood everything . Youko had been manipulated by Miyuki .

‘I... wanted to save her...’

Youko turned the pistol to Yakumo .

Her voice was weak and wavering .

‘Minami-san’s spirit wants revenge and is still suffering, unable to rest in peace . In order to save her, you would need to take revenge . Miyuki told you that, right?’

Youko didn’t respond to Yakumo’s words .

She took deep breaths with her shoulders, as if to calm her surging emotions .

‘To me, Minami was everything . I thought that we’d always be able to be together . But then she suddenly went missing...’

‘Detective Natsume . ’

Ishii looked at Youko’s profile sadly .

Ishii could slightly understand how Youko felt . He was in that exact same position right now .

The woman he loved, Haruka, was missing .

That emotion wrenched his body apart . A pain that made him feel like even dying would be better –

‘Ten years ago, I searched for Minami frantically... But I couldn’t find her... Minami wouldn’t disappear and leave me behind . I said that again and again, but nobody believed me...’

As she spoke, tears kept spilling out of her eyes .

– It hurts . Save me .

To Ishii, it sounded like she was saying that .

'You didn't give up . You continued looking for Minami-san . '

'That's right . After graduating from high school, I became a police officer . Whenever I had time, I investigated . It took ten years for me to arrive at Matsumoto and Naitou, but I had no proof . '

'And then Nanase Miyuki appeared . '

Instead of replying to Yakumo's words, Youko started to sniffle .

Ishii could tell what was next even without her saying it .

Miyuki told her the circumstances surrounding Minami's death, twisting the truth when it was convenient to her, and made her believe that Minami's spirit was in pain and continuing to wander .

She had probably hidden the fact that she had a daughter because Youko might have chosen to live with her .

– Youko didn't want revenge . She wanted to save Minami's spirit .

Ishii felt like he had understood everything .

'Natsume-san, Minami-san's spirit is still wandering now . That is true . '

Yakumo slowly walked forward and stood at a distance close enough to touch Youko .

The hand Youko was holding the pistol with was shaking .

'Then...'

'But doing something like this cannot save Minami-san's spirit . '

'I...'

Youko bit her lip .

'The only person who can save Minami-san's spirit is you . '

'To save her... I... What should I...'

'I'll help . '

Ishii suddenly walked up to Youko .

In surprise, Youko looked at Ishii with tearful eyes .

Ishii finally realised when he looked at those eyes .

'Detective Natsume, at the bottom of your heart, you must have known that doing something like this couldn't save Minami-san,' said Ishii, leaning forward .

Youko's heart had always been wavering .

– Can this really save Minami?

She must have asked herself that countless times . While worrying and suffering, without coming to a decision, she had come here .

She wanted to end it already . That was why she gave Ishii the necessary information and even cooperated with the investigation .

Even though she had been calling out for him to notice so many times, Ishii hadn't seen it .

'I...'

Youko looked down .

Her sadness came through to Ishii so much that it hurt .

The person she loved had disappeared, leaving a hole in her heart for ten years . How painful must it have been?

But that was still –

'Let's end this . '

Ishii gripped Youko's shoulders .

In response, Youko looked up .

Her tearful expression was as artless as a young girl's .

'Ishii-san... I...'

Youko couldn't continue .

Then, there was a bang – it sounded like the door had opened – and somebody came flying into the cavern .

It was too late when he'd realised . Youko let out a moan as her body collapsed to the floor .

There was a knife in her back .

'Please hang in there!'

Ishii tried to shake Youko awake, but she didn't move at all .

'What a stupid woman . Even though I told her to exterminate the people in the way, she let herself be instigated . '

Ishii looked up at the voice and saw Nanase Miyuki standing there .

In order to hide the burnt left half of her face, she let her fringe hang down . She was smiling, showing her white teeth .

Blood rushed to Ishii's head .

It was from anger .

'Why did you...'

Ishii tried to rush at Miyuki, but she picked up the pistol Youko had dropped before he could .

With the pistol facing him, Ishii froze, like his stop button had been pushed .

'If it isn't Ishii-san? It's been a while . '

Miyuki looked at Ishii with condescending eyes .

When she looked at him, it made him feel terribly uneasy .

'So you showed up?'

Yakumo's eyes narrowed .

'What are you looking at me like that for?'

'I'm pitying you . '

Though Miyuki threatened him, Yakumo didn't seem to care .

'Aren't you composed? Can you still be composed after seeing this?'

Miyuki left the room with a leisurely gait .

– What on earth is she going to show him?

While Ishii was thinking, the door opened again and something fell to the floor .

It was Haruka .

Her wrists were bound with packing tape, and her nose and mouth were covered with packing tape too .

Perhaps because she couldn't breathe properly, she was limp .

Miyuki stepped on Haruka's back with her right foot and smiled triumphantly .

If they moved unwisely, Haruka's life would be in danger .

'What are you...'

Ishii glared at Miyuki .

He was the one closest to Miyuki right now . If he found the right opportunity to rush in, it might be possible to save Haruka .

'Sorry, Ishii-san, could you step away a bit?' said Miyuki .

It looked like she'd anticipated his thoughts . Ishii slowly stood up and staggered backwards, just as Miyuki instructed him .

– This is the worst-case scenario .

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Haruka managed to lift her head, though her consciousness was blurry .

She could see Yakumo in her cloudy vision .

Gotou and Ishii were there too . And another person . A large-framed person in robes – probably Eishin .

– It's hard to breathe .

Packing tape covered her nose and mouth . She could only breathe through a small gap .

She didn't even have the strength to fight back .

It took all her energy to keep her consciousness from falling into the darkness .

Miyuki had probably planned that and gave her a small gap to breathe through .

A cold and calculating woman .

It might have been the end of everything when she got caught by Miyuki .

– Sorry, Yakumo .

Haruka looked at Yakumo .

She couldn't see him clearly with her hazy vision .

– Even though we finally met again .

She had really wanted to meet him with a smile, but – in her pain, tears came to her eyes .

She always held him back .

If something happened to Yakumo because of her, she wouldn't be able to stand it . She would rather –

'Now, the start of an entertaining show,' murmured Miyuki .

That voice echoed unpleasantly in Haruka's ears .

A chill ran down her spine .

'Relax . '

She heard Yakumo's voice .

She couldn't see his expression, but it seemed full of confidence .

'Well, aren't you composed? Your lover might die,' said Miyuki as she laughed .

It pleased her to see other people suffer . An unbelievable sadist .

'She won't die . I'll save her . '

Yakumo's voice was firm .

Even if it was just a front, it eased Haruka's wavering heart and made her less frightened .

'I wonder about that?'

Miyuki put more strength in the foot on Haruka's back .

Her heel dug in .

With the pressure on Haruka's waist, it made it even harder to breathe .

Oh no . I'm losing consciousness –

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'Yakumo, what do you plan to do?'

Gotou spoke quietly, his eyes still on Miyuki .

To put it bluntly, this was the worst-case scenario .

Miyuki wasn't just some woman . If they moved, she would probably kill Haruka without any hesitation . That wasn't all . She would definitely fire at anybody who went at her .

Gotou didn't want to think about how many people would become sacrifices if he ran at her . If he did anything careless, all of them would be headed for the other world .

Yakumo silently looked up at the ceiling .

Water dripped down from limestone . It looked like it was growing more fragile from the typhoon .

The pillar creaked loudly .

'Gotou-san, I'll buy some time,' said Yakumo in a voice that was barely audible .

– I see .

Gotou could tell what Yakumo was trying to do .

Though it was a considerably dangerous method, they had no other choice . Gotou nodded at Yakumo and then looked to Eishin and Ishii .

'Do you know what sort of place this is?' said Yakumo, slowly shortening the distance between him and Miyuki .

'I'm just going to say this, but if you get any closer, this girl will die . And trying to buy time is useless, so just stop,' Miyuki said coldly .

Yakumo's feet froze .

– She realised everything .

Gotou glared at Miyuki .

She really didn't let anything pass her . She had seen right through their ulterior motive .

– What are you going to do, Yakumo?

'This is where that man was born . Did you know that?'

Yakumo smiled .

For just a moment, Miyuki's expression clouded over .

'What are you saying?'

'I'm saying that this is where that man – my father – was born . Do you know his real name?'

'Name?'

'His name is Unkai[2] – '

'You're making this up!' spat out Miyuki .

However, there was doubt in her eyes .

Miyuki probably didn't know the real name of the man with two red eyes .

'I don't mind if you think that, but it is the truth . Isn't that right, Eishin-san?'

Yakumo turned towards Eishin .

In response, Eishin nodded .

'It's just as Yakumo says . In the past, a woman lived in this village . Her name was Rin...'

Gotou remembered the name Eishin said .

Three months ago, he had heard that name in Togakushi, Nagano . The woman who was the mother of the man with two red eyes, and Yakumo's grandmother –

Because of an appearance that differed from those around them, she was treated as a witch and lost her life .

Rin had taken her child with red eyes to Togakushi in Nagano . So this was where she came from –

'She fell in love with a monk . That monk was a senior apprentice to me . He was also Yakumo's grandfather,' Eishin said quietly .

'Wait a second . Then that man with red eyes...'

Gotou interrupted Eishin, unable to restrain himself .

'That's correct . The man with two red eyes was the child of my grandfather and Rin-san,' Yakumo said with a blank expression .

'Though the two of them had a child, they were not married . In the end, Rin was chased out by the people of the temple and left the village with the child,' continued Eishin .

'Why did the people of the temple force Rin out?'

Gotou voiced the question that came to his head .

'Because she could see ghosts . '

Yakumo was the one who answered .

Gotou didn't understand what he meant .

'Why would they force her out for being able to see ghosts?'

'In Buddhism, especially the temples that sympathise with Zen Buddhism, they do not acknowledge the existence of the spirits of the dead,' said Eishin with a sigh .

'W-what did you say?'

Gotou couldn't understand at all . In his everyday knowledge, temples were the ones who did funerals, and they would chant sutras to mourn the dead .

That was why he'd thought that temples believed that the spirits of the dead existed .

'It's true . In Buddhist teaching, it is believed that the body and mind are one . That's why the spirit, which is the mind, cannot remain behind without the body...'

After Eishin said that, he looked at Yakumo .

If what Eishin said was really true, then people who could see the spirits of the dead disproved Buddhism itself .

So they forced her out –

'After Rin-san disappeared, my grandfather made a family with another woman and gave birth to my mother and my uncle,' Yakumo said, continuing Eishin's story .

– Which meant .

'So the man with two red eyes and your mother were half-siblings?'

'Yes . '

Yakumo nodded quietly .

Gotou was shocked into silence, but at the same time, he understood .

It meant Yakumo and the man with two red eyes were connected by blood stronger than that of a parent and child . That was why he was so fixated on Yakumo .

'Don't be ridiculous! Did you think that would surprise me? You're wasting your time!' screamed Miyuki .

However, in contrast to her words, it felt like her heart was shaking violently . She probably hadn't heard that fact from the man with two red eyes .

'Do you still not understand?'

Yakumo gazed sharply at Miyuki .

'I don't . '

Miyuki glared back .

'That man didn't just want to make me the suspect in this case – he wanted to reveal the truth of his birth . '

Yakumo's voice grew stronger .

'So... what...'

'No matter how you wish for it, that man will not open his heart to you . He is only using you for his own goal . '

Yakumo's voice echoed, so Gotou heard it layered .

The goal of the man with two red eyes . It was to take Yakumo's body, which had taken the most of his own blood .

Even after his death, that man was fixated on life .

'You're so noisy... I don't care about that . Even if I'm being used, I want to be with him...'

Miyuki's voice wavered terribly .

The trust she had inside of her for the man with two red eyes was shaking . That was how it felt to Gotou .

'Is that fine with you?' asked Yakumo .

There was a silence –

Miyuki's mouth was trembling, but then the expression suddenly left her face .

There was a cold glint in her eyes .

'You can just die . All of you can just die . '

That was Miyuki's answer .

'Back off!'

'Take a good look as the person important to you dies in front of your eyes!'

Miyuki put the end of the pistol at the back of Haruka's head .

'Stop it!'

Yakumo's yell reverberated .

Gotou tried to charge as well, but he wouldn't make it in time –

Just as she had cocked the pistol and was about to pull the trigger, Miyuki stopped .

Youko, who had collapsed, had grabbed Miyuki's right leg with both hands .

'Give Minami... back to me...'

Youko spoke in a hoarse voice .

On the verge of death, she had probably overlapped Haruka with Minami, her lover who had gone missing .

'Let go!'

Miyuki kicked Youko's face .

But Youko still didn't let go . She wanted to save her . Her lover –

'Stop!'

While yelling, Ishii ran out to try to stop Miyuki, just as Yakumo rushed at Miyuki .

– This is my chance .

Gotou kicked the pillar in the middle of the room with as much force as he could .

The pillar bent with a loud crack .

Miyuki noticed Yakumo and Ishii and turned the pistol towards them .

'Like I'd let you do that!'

Gotou kicked the pillar again .

The pillar snapped .

At the same time, the portion of the limestone ceiling that the pillar had barely been managing to hold up collapsed with a thunderous noise .

Gotou ducked instinctively and avoided the falling rocks .

Water poured in through the hole in the ceiling .

Yakumo thrust Miyuki away in her astonishment and picked up Haruka .

However, Haruka lay limp without moving .

'How could you do that!?'

Miyuki was furious as she turned the pistol towards Yakumo and Haruka with the face of a demon .

– This is bad!

Gotou ran towards them right away, but he knew he wouldn't make it in time .

Time seemed to flow slowly, as if this was stop-motion .

The moment Miyuki's finger pulled the trigger, Ishii's body smashed into hers, knocking her to the floor .

There was a gunshot .

Miyuki was lying face-up on the floor . The bullet she shot hit the ceiling .

More water came out from there .

'It'll collapse! We have to run!'

Eishin was the one who yelled .

As if that had been a sign, rocks started crumbling down around them loudly . More water poured out, covering his feet .

Gotou was delirious .

He just carried Haruka together with Yakumo and ran towards the exit –

NOTES:

[1] Youkan is a Japanese dessert that has the consistency of a firm jelly . It's usually sold in a big block which is then cut into slices; Hata would be poking these slices with his toothpick . HERE is an example .

[2] Unkai (雲海) is written with the kanji for cloud and sea (and is usually translated as sea of clouds); incidentally, Yakumo (八雲) is written with the kanji for eight clouds (and means thick clouds) .

Volume 8 Chapter 4: Epilogue.

VOLUME 8 – THE VANISHED SPIRIT epilogue

Like an empty shell, Ishii sat at the desk and looked up at the ceiling.

Though a week had passed since the incident, he still hadn't been able to get back on his feet.

After the limestone cave collapsed, with Eishin's help, he somehow managed to carry Youko out.

However, she had already stopped breathing.

– I couldn't save her.

Ishii's regret had left a deep scar in his chest.

If he had noticed Youko's cry for help earlier, she wouldn't have lost her life.

– She had planned on dying from the beginning.

That was what Yakumo had said.

Youko might have really been thinking that way, but that didn't make Ishii's regret go away.

During the investigation afterwards, it was proven that Yakumo had been falsely charged. Though there was still the interference with a public servant in the execution of their duties, the situation was taken into account and it became a non-indictment because of extenuating circumstances.

There was a non-indictment for Gotou too, but there was a disciplinary dismissal from the police.

Even if it had been a false charge, he hadn't just helped a suspect escape – he'd even used violence against a police officer. It couldn't be overlooked.

Ishii understood that. But still, he didn't accept it.

Normally, it wouldn't have been strange if Ishii had been giving a disciplinary dismissal as well, but Gotou hadn't let that happen – he'd taken all the blame on his own shoulders.

The police wanted everything to settle down as quickly as possible too, so they dealt with the situation by saying that Gotou had ran off alone and that Ishii hadn't been involved.

'I was never suited for detective work,' Gotou had said with a laugh.

But what was he going to do now – it didn't seem like he had thought about anything in particular.

Ishii didn't know how the Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room was going to be without Gotou either.

It would be difficult for Ishii to continue alone. The Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room would probably be shut down, with Ishii being shafted to another division.

It was a barren room with just two desks and no windows, but it was still full of Ishii's memories.

He had first met Gotou in this room.

He had been involved in many cases after that – the time had flown by.

He would be truly unhappy about the place where he had so many memories disappearing.

Ishii took off his glasses, rubbed his arms and wiped the tears that had welled up in his eyes.

However, there was a silver lining in the case.

It was Hatsune, Minami's daughter who had been raised by Seidou. Minami's mother, Tamae, had taken her in.

Tamae had been like an empty shell until then, but then her grandchild appeared.

Tamae's eyes were energetic – like a different person's.

She would definitely treat Hatsune well. And Hatsune would probably have her own life, rather than being her mother's reincarnation.

There was another thing on Ishii's mind.

Nanase Miyuki had suddenly disappeared from the collapsed limestone cave.

– She's still alive.

Ishii was sure of it. They would meet again soon.

What would he be able to do then, by himself? He thought about it, but nothing came to mind.

'Detective Gotou, it really is impossible for me on my own.'

Ishii's shoulders drooped as he murmured that.

'Stop crying.'

The door opened.

Miyagawa was standing in the door with a cardboard box in both hands.

'C-Chief Miyagawa! W-why...'

Ishii stood up instinctively.

'You haven't heard?'

'Eh?'

'Don't just say "Eh". I was demoted. So, that's... er...'

Miyagawa fumbled for words awkwardly.

Ishii had an idea of what he was trying to say.

'Could it be that you were transferred to the Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room...'

'Unfortunately, that's exactly it,' said Miyagawa with a sigh.

Though Ishii was happy that the Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room hadn't been closed, he had a terribly bad feeling.

'What's with that displeased look on your face!?'

Miyagawa glared.

'Ah, no, that isn't...'

Even while Ishii replied, he couldn't clear away his anxiety about the future.

* * *

— That felt good.

That was the first feeling Gotou had after receiving his punishment.

He'd thought that he'd feel some regret after a couple of days, but he didn't.

He realised anew that he hadn't been suited for being in the organisation in the first place.

He had been nervous about how Atsuko would react when he explained, but she was more nonchalant than Gotou had been.

'I don't like the police anyway.'

She said the same thing that she had on the phone. Gotou had thought she had just said that to encourage Gotou, but it looked like she'd meant it.

'I'll do part-time until things calm down,' said Atsuko firmly, without seeming troubled or worried.

As a man, there was nothing more embarrassing than having his wife look after him, but Gotou decided for now to honestly depend on her.

'If you drive without paying attention, you'll get into an accident.'

Gotou came back to reality when Yakumo called out to him.

Gotou noticed that the light in front of him was red and hurriedly stepped on the brakes.

'Isn't that dangerous?' said Haruka with a dissatisfied frown as she sat in the backseat.

– Man. Who do these two think kept them safe?

Gotou thought it, but he didn't say it aloud.

Though a lot had happened, he was just happy that they were all OK and together.

Of course it was the case for Yakumo, but Haruka was like family to Gotou too.

Family wasn't just made up of blood ties.

Even without them, people connected with each other. Gotou thought that.

'Gotou-san, what do you plan to do from now on?' said Yakumo.

Even Yakumo, who always spoke so hatefully, seemed to be concerned.

It wasn't like Gotou had no plans at all about the future.

'I'm thinking of starting a business.'

'What is it?' said Haruka, sounding very interested as she leant forward.

'Work that can be done by an ex-police officer is limited.'

'I have a bad feeling,' interrupted Yakumo while looking aside.

– His feeling's probably on the money.

'I'm going to open a detective agency.'

'Oh, you're going to be a detective?'

'Right. And a detective specialising in spiritual cases, at that.'

'So a spiritual detective then.'

Haruka laughed.

In contrast to that, Yakumo's expression was stiff – he seemed to sense what was coming next.

'Well, that's right. So I'm looking for an excellent assistant.'

'I'm just going to say this, but I won't help,' Yakumo said coldly, having read Gotou's thoughts.

'Whose fault do you think it is that I lost my job?'

'Please don't blame your own incompetence on others.'

Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair.

– This brat. Acting so high and mighty just because I was holding back!

'It's your fault!'

'I don't remember asking for your help,' Yakumo said plainly.

– I really shouldn't have saved this guy.

Though it was a bit late, regret spread in Gotou's chest.

* * *

Haruka visited Seidou's temple with Yakumo.

Gotou said that he would wait in the car. It looked like he didn't want to see Eishin.

'Thanks for coming.'

The one who welcomed them in the temple was that very Eishin.

He had a gentle smile on his face. When Haruka looked at him like this, he really did seem like Isshin's teacher.

'Hello.'

Haruka bowed her head.

'That really was a terrible situation you were in,' said Eishin, scratching his bald head.

'It was,' agreed Haruka.

When she was caught by Nanase Miyuki, she thought that she really would die, but in the end, Yakumo saved her.

It seemed like she was one of the people Yakumo thought was important to him, at least. That was enough for now.

'Half of it was your fault,' Yakumo told Eishin brusquely.

'Well, I can't deny it.'

Eishin was rather bold. His expression didn't change at all when Yakumo said that to him.

'Could I ask one thing?'

'What is it?'

Eishin looked at Yakumo

'When did you realise what Seidou-san had done?'

'I was curious when he told me about Hatsune-chan's reincarnation, so I looked in to it. Though I didn't know for sure, I thought that might've been the case.'

Eishin's eyes were faraway.

'Why didn't you ask him?'

'Because I wanted to believe that Seidou still had a conscience... Would it sound like an excuse if I said that?'

'It would.'

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair as he looked down.

Haruka thought that Eishin wasn't lying.

He had wanted Seidou to go to the police himself. He had probably sent Yakumo to give him that chance.

'One more thing.'

Yakumo put up his index finger.

'What?'

'About my... grandfather. How long?'

There was a silence.

Eishin looked up at the ceiling as if reminiscing and then finally started to speak in a murmur.

'I knew from the start.'

'Why...'

'Because I didn't think it was something you should hear from another person, but something you should find out on your own,' said Eishin, interrupting Yakumo's words.

In the back of his eyes, it looked like there was a deep sadness.

'That might be true...'

Yakumo's eyes narrowed as he looked down.

'Could I ask one thing?'

This time, Eishin looked at Yakumo.

'If it isn't a pointless question.'

'What happened to Minami-san?'

'She... is with Youko-san.'

Yakumo's expression softened.

'So the two of them were able to meet again.'

'They were.'

Yakumo gave a short reply to Haruka's words.

– Was Minami released from her hatred?

That question suddenly came up in Haruka's head, but she couldn't find an answer.

If she could be with the person she loved, there was no need for her to hate anyone. Because that was the happiest thing –

Haruka thought that the both of them must have been released from their worries. Though that might have just been a convenient way for her to think –

Yakumo stood in front of the Buddha statue at the temple's entrance.

When he looked straight at it like that, it was like they were talking.

'After I was almost killed by my mother, I came here together with Uncle,' murmured Yakumo.

'With Isshin-san?'

'Yes. Uncle held my hand and said this.'

'What did he say?'

'You are my older brother's child and my older sister's child. But I decided to be with you for another reason.'

Yakumo's eyes looked a little wet.

'Another reason?'

'I want to be together with you, Yakumo. If I don't, I feel like I'll be crushed by my fate. Save me... That was what Uncle said.'

'Save...'

'That's right. But I was the one always being saved by Uncle. Without knowing anything, I had thought that I was the only unfortunate one.'

'Yakumo-kun...'

'Even though I really wanted to say thank you, he left before then...'

Yakumo bit down hard on his lip.

While supporting each other, Isshin and Yakumo had faced their fates, which they couldn't run away from. Haruka felt that anew.

Isshin wasn't here now. But Yakumo wasn't alone. There were many people who had inherited his feelings.

— I'm one of them.

Haruka gently held Yakumo's hand —

Volume 9 Chapter 1: VOLUME 9 – THE SPIRIT OF SALVATION

Chapter 1

VOLUME 9 – THE SPIRIT OF SALVATION

file 01: encounter (TRANSLATION NOTES)

That forest summons the spirits of the dead –

‘You can see them too, right?’

When Aoi Hideaki called out, he slowly turned around .

It was a corner of a graveyard, twilight imminent .

His narrowed eyes were facing Hideaki directly . His eyes were dark and appeared to be filled with sadness .

They became classmates in the third year of high school . They had been in the same classroom for nearly a year, but this was the first time he had called out to him .

Hideaki had thought about doing it numerous times up until now . However, he hadn’t been able to . It was because he had had an atmosphere that made it feel like others couldn’t approach .

He put a wall up between himself and others and did not let anyone in . However, that didn’t mean he wasn’t interested in other people . He observed from a height . A superior existence –

'What is it?'

His voice was unexpectedly calm .

'Spirits of the dead... That is, ghosts . '

'Idiotic . '

He laughed quietly .

He had probably meant to feign innocence, but Hideaki wouldn't let him .

Hideaki hadn't noticed that they had the same ability at first, but because of an incident, he realised that he was the same .

He saved Hideaki's younger sister's life, but he wouldn't have been able to do so if he couldn't see .

'Don't try to hide it . '

When Hideaki glared, he grew silent .

His gaze shook slightly . It appeared to be a sign of his shaken heart .

'I don't know what you're talking about . '

'Don't play dumb . You're the same kind as me . '

'Don't put me together with you . '

He immediately denied Hideaki's words .

'Why?'

'You show off your ability to see . '

Just as he said, Hideaki didn't hide the fact that he could see . Rather, he declared it .

He definitely wasn't showing off though . There was a reason he did it .

Also, the reply just now was obviously admitting that he could see .

'Want to talk for a bit?'

'I refuse . '

'Why?'

'I have no reason to . You and I are conclusively different . '

'What's different? We're both the same in that we can see, right?'

'It's different,' he declared . Then, he tried to walk away .

Hideaki might never have a chance to talk with him again if he left now, even though Hideaki had gathered the courage to call out to him .

'Wait . '

When Hideaki called out, his feet stopped . He didn't turn around .

Hideaki continued to talk regardless .

'I've always thought that my ability was disgusting . '

'I agree . '

When Hideaki heard his sad voice, he felt like he understood the true reason he had called out .

'But it's not just a sad thing . By lending an ear to the spirits of the dead, there are people who can be saved, she said...'

'Who said?'

'My sister . '

'A joke . Seeing them doesn't save anybody . '

'It does . That's why I can see . That's what I believe . '

'I couldn't save anyone important to me...'

When he turned around, his eyes looked just a little bit wet .

He must have lost somebody important to him because of his ability . It might have been impossible then, but next time –

'You can save them . '

'You're strong . '

'Eh?'

'I'm not that strong . If I'm just going to lose them, I'd rather not have anything important to me in the first place . '

After declaring that, he slowly started to walk .

Hideaki could only watch him leave .

He had chosen to live alone .

Hideaki couldn't condemn that choice . The pain of being able to see wasn't a light matter .

However, one day, if he also found something he had to protect, his mind would probably change . Like Hideaki's had –

'Let's meet again,' Hideaki said quietly .

A strong wind blew .

Hideaki looked down to escape a cloud of sand .

When Hideaki looked up again, he was already gone .

That was the last time Hideaki spoke to him during high school –

1

'Hey, let's go back already . '

Maehara Rina spoke to Hiroki, who was walking ahead of her . Hiroki might not have heard her voice, as he continued to walk farther in .

They had been walking for over fifteen minutes since entering this forest .

The forest, thick with hinoki cypress trees, was dim, even though it was day, and it was wet . Furthermore, the changeless scenery continued endlessly .

If we go any farther in, we'll never be able to get out – that anxiety was in her head .

'Let's go back!' shouted Rina, halting as she did so .

Finally, Hiroki's feet stopped .

'What? Let's just go a bit farther . '

Hiroki, smirking, held a Handycam video camera .

Rina had come to the Kawaguchi lake shore[1] cottage for the tennis circle's training camp . She'd worked up a light sweat in the morning, and then there had been free time after lunch .

Then, Hiroki, who had come with her, called out to her .

– Want to explore the Sea of Trees?

Rina had understood that as 'Want to be alone?' . She'd had an interest in Hiroki since before, so she had thought that it'd be a good chance .

However, Rina's faint expectation had been betrayed .

Hiroki was really exploring the forest . With a camera in one hand, he was focussed on trying to catch spiritual phenomena on tape .

'I don't care any more . Let's go back . '

Rina was about to cry .

'Rina-chan's afraid . '

Hiroki zoomed in on Rina's face with the camera .

To put it frankly, it was bad taste . Rina looked away to avoid the camera .

– I can't bear with him any longer .

She'd go home herself . After deciding that, Rina started to turn back through the forest .

'Honestly, this is the worst...'

Rina was walking away when she stopped, suddenly feeling something's presence .

– Ooooooh .

She heard something like a groan .

Maybe Hiroki had come following her . She turned around, but nobody was there . Just the dark forest spreading out in front of her .

'Hiroki-kun, are you there?' said Rina .

There was no response, but she felt like somebody was watching her .

'If you're there, come out!'

As expected, there was no response .

– Am I thinking too much?

Rina was just about to start walking again when her feet stopped immediately .

'Gi... ll... d...'

She heard somebody moaning in her ear .

– Eh?

She couldn't look . She knew that in her head, but her body wouldn't listen . Rina slowly turned around .

However, nobody was there .

– How creepy .

Rina was stricken by an indescribable fear and she started running to escape .

However, something caught her feet immediately and she fell .

It seemed like her foot had slipped on moss . Her knee had hit a rock, and a stinging hot pain spread through it .

'This is the worst...'

To try to get up, Rina placed her hand on something beside her that looked like a rock .

– Flump .

A soft feeling . Not a rock . What was it?

Next to her lay a large mass, burnt completely black . When she took a careful look, she saw that it was the shape of a person .

– This is a corpse .

'Aahh!'

When Rina realised that, she shrieked and tried to run .

However, as if to block her escape, a man stood in front of Rina .

Though the forest was dim, that man wore black sunglasses . With all that had happened confusing her, Rina couldn't speak .

Sneering at Rina, the man slowly took off his sunglasses .

The two eyes looking down at Rina were dyed a deep red, like fresh blood .

'The true nature of the human spirit is darkness...'

The man said that quietly –

2

Ishii Yuutarou was up to his head in paperwork .

He was in the Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room, one of the divisions of the detective department .

Though the name was splendid, all he actually did was the simple task of sort paperwork for past unsolved cases by year .

Though they were sometimes sent out as additional help for other divisions, that was rare

– I'm bored .

Just doing paperwork like this made him feel down . He felt like that boredom had grown especially ever since Gotou had left .

When Gotou had been here, his actions, which could be called wild, had brought about a variety of incidents .

He had been afraid at the time, but now, strangely, he felt that things had been good then .

It had been tough, but at least he hadn't been bored .

'Oi, Ishii . '

He lifted his head at the voice .

Miyagawa Hideya sat across from him and glared at the paperwork with a difficult expression on his face .

Miyagawa had been the chief of the detectives until a month ago, but he had been demoted because of the incident with Gotou and put in the Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room .

Though he had a small frame, with his scary face and bald head, rather than a detective, he looked like the people he was supposed to be fighting .

'What is it?'

'Where am I supposed to stamp this document?'

Miyakawa tapped the document on the desk .

Even though he already had a frightening face usually, when he showed his irritation, he looked like a demon .

'Er... Here . '

Ishii peered at the document and pointed at it .

'Who the hell made a document that's so hard to understand?'

'Miyagawa-san, you did . '

Ishii spoke without thinking .

'What?'

Miyagawa turned his glare towards Ishii .

'Ah, no, I mean, Miyagawa-san, you acknowledged the introduction of these forms . '

Ishii hurriedly added an explanation .

Miyagawa hadn't been the one who made them, but he had decided to introduce these documents when he was chief of the detectives .

'You saying it's my fault?'

Miyagawa raised an eyebrow .

'Ah, no, er... I apologise . '

– He's going to hit me .

So Ishii thought, preparing his body, but nothing happened .

'I see . It was me...'

Miyagawa sighed .

It looked like he truly regretted it . His body looked a size smaller .

Though Ishii was happy that he hadn't been hit, for some reason, he felt like something was lacking . If it were Gotou, Ishii would have been hit with a fist before he even finished speaking .

– Detective Gotou, please come back .

Ishii murmured that in his heart .

It wasn't that Miyagawa was bad . If speaking about work, Miyagawa dealt with it more seriously . Gotou just leant back on the chair and slept without doing any paperwork .

But still, for some reason, Ishii longed for those times . It was a strange thought, but he wanted to be hit .

Just as Ishii sighed, the door opened and a man appeared .

It was Honda, the current chief of the detectives . A mid-career hire, he was young – he had just turned forty . The person who had taken over Miyagawa's position after he was demoted .

Ishii had no way of knowing how the higher-ups thought of him, but with his high-handed attitude being the ruin of him, his subordinates didn't trust him much . Ishii often heard people badmouthing him .

'Chief Honda . '

Miyagawa's expression clouded the moment Ishii spoke .

'There's some work I want you guys to do . '

Ishii offered Honda a chair, but he ignored it and spoke while standing .

'What? Hurry up and say it . '

Miyagawa put his chin in his hands and looked up at Honda .

Speaking casually to Honda, who was his boss, was probably from his pride as the previous chief, but Ishii broke into a cold sweat from watching it .

'Watch your tone . '

Honda glared at Miyagawa .

He had his own spirit . Even if Miyagawa was the previous chief, Honda probably couldn't keep quiet when somebody below him spoke rudely .

'Shut up, brat...' Miyagawa muttered, clicking his tongue .

'So what is the matter you wanted to talk about?' Ishii questioned to cover Miyagawa's words .

Honda didn't look pleased, but after clearing his throat, he brought up the topic at hand . Miyagawa crossed his arms sulkily .

'You know about the robbery that occurred two days ago, right?'

'Ah, yes, that . '

Though Ishii and Miyagawa weren't directly related to the case, they knew of it .

A nursing student named Aoi Yuuka who lived in a city apartment had been found fainted in her room by her older brother, Hideaki, who lived with her .

Hideaki took Yuuka to the hospital, but her head had been injured and she still hadn't regained consciousness .

Her room was a mess and her wallet was stolen, so the police were investigating it as a burglary injury case .

'The victim's older brother said he wanted the police's cooperation . '

'Did he see the culprit?'

'No, the victim's brother didn't witness the culprit . '

'Then what does he mean?' asked Ishii, which made Honda scowl . It looked like he wasn't very pleased .

'Seems like the victim's brother can see . '

'What can he see?'

'Ghosts . '

'Eh?'

Ishii spoke up without thinking .

'To be honest, I don't think I can go along with something that ridiculous, as a policeman . But it'd be a pain if the victim's family made a fuss about being treated unkindly . '

'So you're pushing the trouble to us,' said Miyagawa, voice dripping with sarcasm . However, Honda didn't lose to him .

'The work's perfect for you guys, right? You've got the free time . '

'What'd you say!? Try saying it again!'

'Now, now . '

This was just a kid's fight . Ishii stepped in as mediator .

'Right now, he's in the reception room, so just listen to him . '

Honda said just that and left the room . Miyagawa kicked the desk before the door was even fully closed .

'Miyagawa-san, let's calm down . '

'Don't you hate this?'

Ishii knew what Miyagawa wanted to say . He was probably irritated by the tone of Honda's words, but Ishii knew well that getting angry wouldn't change anything .

'I'm used to it . '

When Ishii smiled, Miyagawa looked up at the ceiling in exasperation .

'More importantly, let's start our investigation immediately . '

Ishii stood up from his seat for a change of pace .

Is the young man who says he can see ghosts the real thing – Ishii noticed that he was a bit excited to find out .

3

Gotou Kazutoshi stood in front of the door with his arms crossed .

Next to him stood a middle-aged woman . Her name was Nakazato Yoriko . She was in her mid-forties .

'Please save my son...'

Yoriko put her hand on her mouth and sounded like she had a lump in her throat . It felt like tears could fall from her eyes at any moment .

Gotou looked at her face and sighed . He didn't feel like sympathising .

'Sorry, but there's nothing I can do . '

Gotou's careless words made Yoriko's eyes grow wide .

'That's... Please . My son has been possessed by an evil spirit . '

Yoriko clung to Gotou .

'What do you mean, evil spirit?'

Gotou shook Yoriko off .

With the previous case, Gotou had been let go from the police and had started work as a detective who specialised in the spiritual .

For work he could do as an ex-police officer, there was work as a guard and as a detective . He had decided to specialise on spiritual phenomena because he'd thought he could use his experience up until now and that he'd be able to pull Yakumo in if he needed to .

However, after actually starting, there weren't any real spiritual phenomena at all – all of the cases were just at the level of giving advice about concerns .

It was the same with Yoriko beside him right now .

After graduating high school, her son hadn't gone to the university he had been enrolled in and just stayed in his room . Yoriko believed it was the work of an evil demon .

However, after listening to her talk about it, it turned out that her son was just addicted to online games in his room . And on top of that, he never failed to eat rice every day . That was definitely not an evil spirit . Just a shut-in .

'Please . The evil spirit in my son...'

'You going to keep saying that!?' Gotou yelled .

'Eek . '

'Don't blame ghosts because of your own inability to raise your child!'

'B-but he won't come out of his room . '

'If he won't come out, you can just go yourself . '

'It's locked...'

Yoriko shook her head and started to cry .

– Ah, I'm pissed .

'You can get past locks if you've got the guts!' yelled Gotou and then gave the door a kick .

The door opened with a crack .

Yoriko was stunned . Her son in the room was even more surprised . He slipped from his chair and fell to the floor .

'Oi, brat . '

Gotou walked into the room briskly and glared at the face of Yoriko's son, who was on the floor .

'Y-yes...'

The son gulped loudly .

He was shivering so much it was pitiful, probably from fear, but that was convenient .

'I'm Gotou . A detective . Came at your mum's request . '

'D-detective?'

'Yeah . Seems like you're possessed by a ghost . '

'G-ghost...'

'If you keep inside this room, I'll need to come check on you every day . '

'E-every day...'

'Yeah . Every day, until you leave the room and go to school . '

'I...'

The son's face twitched .

'If you don't like that, stop playing online games and go to university every day . Got it?'

Gotou grabbed the son by his collar and glared at him . The son nodded fervently .

'Right . That's a promise . '

'Y-yes . '

'Your voice is too quiet!'

'Yes!'

'The spirit's been exorcised!'

Gotou hit the son on the head and stood up .

Yoriko looked like she wanted to say something, but Gotou ignored her . It was probably just going to be a complaint .

'Deduct the door repair fees from the payment for the request . '

After saying just that, Gotou left the house briskly .

When he quit the police, he had felt refreshed . He wouldn't have to be bound by stiff rules any more . He'd thought that he would be free .

Recently, though, the freedom he was supposed to have grasped felt strangely suffocating .

Even though he'd complained, wasn't working cases with Ishii better – he frequently thought that .

– I wonder if Ishii's doing well?

Gotou shook away the image of Ishii's face that suddenly came to his head . Then, he stuffed himself into the driver's seat of the red Mini Cooper parked by the road .

It was too late to regret now .

And Gotou hadn't quit the police because he wanted to – he'd been forced to retire .

'Damn...'

Gotou spat that out and started the car's engine .

4

A dry wind blew through –

'It's already autumn now . '

That thought came to Ozawa Haruka as she looked up at the sky . Just a little while before, she had thought it was hot and humid, but in no time at

all, the refreshing season had come .

Haruka walked towards the prefabricated building behind Building B .

It was in order to see Saitou Yakumo . She didn't have any trouble . She was just going to see him .

She thought that being able to just walk to him for no reason in particular was an amazing step forward .

On the other hand, the sad reality was that there had been no developments in their relationship .

The person of the opposite sex in her age group that she was the closest to – keeping that position, she hadn't advanced any further .

When she thought about that, she felt a bit heavy-hearted .

After cheering herself up, Haruka opened the door to the Movie Research Circle room, at the very end of the two-storey prefabricated building .

'You again?'

Yakumo looked up, sitting at his usual spot .

As always, he had messy hair and sleepy eyes . His left eye was also a vivid red .

Yakumo's red eye had been red from birth .

That red eye could see the spirits of the dead – that is, ghosts .

Using that unique ability, he had found the solution to many cases, but because of that strange ability, many people had shown him hatred . In order to evade that, he had hidden his red left eye with a black contact lens until a little bit earlier .

The death of Yakumo's uncle, Isshin, had changed him .

Because of Isshin's death, Yakumo had stopped hiding his red left eye .
Haruka thought that he was determined to accept himself now .

'What do you mean, again? It makes it sound like I'm troublesome . '

Haruka pretended to be angry as she sat across from Yakumo .

'It doesn't make it sound like it . You are troublesome . '

'Can't you welcome me every once in a while?'

'Why?'

'Why, you say...'

'You came the other day too, right? Do you have a lot of free time?'

Yakumo yawned .

A lot of free time – she couldn't deny it . In the fourth year of university, rankings were pretty much set, so there were virtually no lectures .

'Isn't it fine?'

'If you're not careful, you'll become a jobless university graduate . '

Yakumo propped up his chin with his hand, looking bored .

'Too bad for you . I've already got that decided . '

'That's the first I've heard of it . '

'Because you didn't ask,' said Haruka, puffing out her chest . That was a line Yakumo always used .

'I can't believe a business would hire you . '

'You have it wrong . It's not a business . I'm going to be a teacher . '

She had just got the results from the teacher employment examination that she took in the summer the day before . She had come today to inform Yakumo .

It was also the seed for Haruka's worries .

'You, a teacher... It's the end of the world . '

'I don't need your concern . '

Haruka warned Yakumo but he just let out a sleepy yawn . There was really no point in talking to him .

– How long will I be able to do this?

That question suddenly came to Haruka's head .

It was fun being able to talk to Yakumo like this . It was because she didn't want to destroy this space that she had never spoken the feelings buried in her heart . However, now that her future was determined, she realised something .

This time wouldn't last forever .

Once she graduated, she wouldn't be able to visit Yakumo like this . Their individual lives would begin and they would drift apart – that anxiety filled her head .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun . What are you going to do?' asked Haruka, placing a hand on her chest to calm her wildly beating heart .

Yakumo's expression turned just a little stiff .

She wanted to hear the answer to the question, but she didn't – shaken by her confused feelings, Haruka's heart was in her mouth .

'If I had to say whether it's decided or not, it is . '

'What's with that vague answer?'

Because Haruka had been so concerned, she felt it was anticlimactic .

'There's a place I've been invited to, but I've put it on hold . '

'Where?' asked Haruka, leaning forward .

That was unexpected . She hadn't thought that Yakumo had been on a serious job search . Not just that – he was even worried about his placement .

'You know Professor Mikoshiba, right?'

'Yeah . '

Mikoshiba was an associate professor at Meisei University . Though Haruka had never met the professor herself, it seemed like Yakumo and Mikoshiba often played chess together .

'He...'

Yakumo started speaking, but he suddenly stood up, looking surprised .

His gaze was on the door right in front of him .

– What?

Haruka turned around to look at the door, but nothing was there .

'What's wrong?'

Yakumo interrupted Haruka .

'Why are you here...' he murmured .

Yakumo's red eye could probably see somebody there . All Haruka could do was swallow and watch him .

Ishii cleared his throat as he stood in front of the door .

– I can see ghosts .

The young man on the other side of the doors had apparently declared that .

The answer to whether that was true or false was behind the door . When Ishii thought about that, he realised that he felt incredible excitement rather than anxiety .

'Don't dawdle . '

Miyagawa pushed Ishii aside and opened the door .

Ishii hurriedly followed him, putting aside his feelings .

A young man was sitting on the reception sofa in the back of the room .

- He is Aoi Hideaki .

Big brownish eyes and a smallish nose and mouth . His face as a whole looked soft and young .

When Hideaki noticed Ishii and Miyagawa, he stood up quickly and bowed .

'My name is Aoi Hideaki . '

'I'm Miyagawa . A detective . '

'My name is Ishii . '

After everyone exchanged greetings, Ishii and Miyagawa sat opposite Hideaki .

'I apologise for taking up your time . '

Hideaki smiled gently .

In contrast to his young appearance, he was very calm and the picture of politeness .

'Well, please sit down,' Ishii urged .

Hideaki's expression softened and he sat once more on the sofa .

Before coming here, Ishii had taken a look at Hideaki's info .

Hideaki had lost his parents in the third year of high school . He had quit high school after that . One of his father's friends got him a job at a transport company . He was working now as well .

He lived with his sister, Yuuka, in the apartment his parents left behind . It seemed like Hideaki paid for all of Yuuka's nursing school fees .

Even in such tough circumstances, he had lived with all he had, and still he had gotten wrapped up in an incident like this – it hurt Ishii's heart to think about it .

'So you say you can see ghosts . '

Unlike Ishii, who wasn't sure whether to talk about it, Miyagawa said it carelessly .

It was like he didn't believe it from the start .

Hideaki seemed to sense that too, and his face twitched slightly .

'Yes . That said, it isn't like I can do it constantly . At some times, I can only sense them, and sometimes it's faint – it's very uncertain . '

Without flinching from Miyagawa's attitude, Hideaki replied in a clear voice .

Ishii felt sincerity from those words .

He didn't feel that he was suspicious, like he would from a fake exorcist trying to deceive someone . However, that didn't mean he could just believe

him .

Furthermore, his eye wasn't red . Yakumo's ability to see the spirits of the dead came from his red left eye .

'Is there any way to prove it?' asked Ishii .

Hideaki shook his head .

'There's no proof besides my words, since nobody else can see them . It's easy to prove the existence of things that can be seen, but you can't prove the existence of something that can't be seen . '

'So you saying that you can't prove it, but we should believe you anyway?'

Miyagawa looked doubtful as he lit his cigarette .

Hideaki nodded with a smile . Ishii was surprised by that uprightness .

Normally, people would make excuses here, but he was different . On the contrary, when he was so straightforward, it made Ishii want to believe him .

'I can't prove my own ability . However, I can't just keep quiet because you won't believe me . Especially since my sister is involved this time...'

Hideaki gripped his hands into fists, sounding like he had a lump in his throat .

Anger, sadness, frustration – he probably had feelings fighting within him . Hideaki's expression twisted .

'I understand how you feel, but leave the investigation to the police . '

Miyagawa hit Hideaki's shoulder .

For a while, there was silence . Hideaki slowly took deep breaths . Ishii had no way to know what thoughts were in his head .

'The police won't be able to catch the culprit...' Hideaki said .

'What do you mean?' asked Ishii . He felt like there was a special meaning to Hideaki's words .

It was hard to believe what Hideaki had said .

'It's because the culprit is already dead . '

Hideaki's eyes, directly on him, seemed for just a moment to let off the colour red .

'What do you mean? Depending on what happens, we'll have to arrest you,' threatened Miyagawa, sounding agitated . Ishii felt such pressure from him that he wanted to shriek just from watching, but Hideaki was calm .

'I met the ghost of the culprit . '

'Please speak in a more concrete manner,' interrupted Ishii, restraining Miyagawa, who was growing twitchy .

'When I went to visit my sister's hospital, a man appeared . '

'He's the culprit?'

'He apologised a number of times to my sister . Asking her to forgive him somehow, since he had paid with his own life...'

'So the person who did it killed himself,' said Ishii .

Hideaki nodded .

– This young man's the real thing .

It wasn't Ishii's reason speaking to him . He was sure of it in his gut .

6

'I'm back . '

Gotou opened the sliding door to the temple's priests' quarters .

While taking off his shoes, he heard Nao's laugh from the living room . She was probably playing with his wife, Atsuko . Gotou went down the corridor and opened the sliding door to the living room .

'You're late . '

The one who spoke wasn't Atsuko but Eishin, wearing a priest's robe .

Eishin had been Isshin's teacher and managed temples in the Kanto region, so he was something like a boss, but to Gotou, he just looked like a depraved monk .

'Ahh . '

Nao, who had been playing with Eishin, noticed Gotou and flew towards him .

Gotou pet her on the head and then sat cross-legged in front of Eishin . Nao followed him and sat next to Gotou .

'What are you doing?'

'Atsuko-san's out shopping right now,' Eishin said, playing dumb .

'That's not it, you damn monk . '

'Watch your tongue . Who do you think helped you find work?'

– Hitting me where it hurts .

To be frank, Eishin had been the one who introduced the request today to Gotou .

No, not just this one . All the requests he'd had since starting his detective agency had been from Eishin .

It hurt for Gotou to say it, but without Eishin, he would've been out of a job ages ago, but Gotou didn't want to admit it honestly .

'Shut up . You're just giving me the tasks you find annoying, right?'

'Do you want to lose the roof over your head?'

– Hitting me in another place where it hurts .

When Gotou took in Nao after Isshin's death, he had looked for a place to rent for their family, but he hadn't been able to find one . Then, Eishin had offered him a helping hand .

He had let them stay in the temple's priests' quarters, where Isshin had been living .

At the time, Gotou had thought he'd take any port in a storm, but now, he felt like Eishin had got a grip of his weak point and was using him however he liked .

'My bad . '

It hurt, but Gotou had to acknowledge his defeat .

Eishin smiled triumphantly, like he was saying, 'As long as you get it . '

'So how was it?' Eishin asked more formally .

'I kicked down the door and threatened the shut-in inside . '

Gotou had thought Eishin would scold him, but unexpectedly, Eishin laughed aloud .

'That funny?'

'Good medicine for that mother and child . '

'What?'

'Ah, Yoriko-san believed it was the work of demons and wouldn't listen to anyone . And I can't be forceful like you . '

It looked like Eishin had known from the start that it hadn't been a spirit .

'You're a cunning old man,' Gotou said carelessly .

'Saying hateful things doesn't become a splendid monk . '

'What?'

Eishin's sudden words made Gotou doubt his eyes .

'I'm saying that that won't let you become a splendid monk . '

'Who?'

'You . '

'Don't be stupid . '

Gotou waved his hand, as if to brush away a fly .

For a joke, it wasn't funny at all .

'I'm serious . '

Eishin's gaze was serious, which was unusual . It had an incredible pressure .

'Why do I have to be a monk?'

'Ever since Isshin's death, this temple's had no monk . '

'I get that, but...'

After Isshin died, Eishin's disciples had been doing the work at the temple .

But that couldn't continue forever .

'With Yakumo like that, he won't agree . So only you can continue . '

'Don't be ridiculous . '

'What's ridiculous about it? If you become a monk, you can continue to use these priests' quarters . And you can keep up your spiritual detective work . Requests would just keep coming . Not a bad idea, right?'

Eishin's words were strangely convincing . Gotou almost nodded .

– This is dangerous .

'Y'know, there are things people are suitable for and things they aren't . I'm not suitable . '

'I think you are . '

'Don't be stupid . '

'You're the type of guy who can't leave people who are troubled alone . '

'If you don't keep your jokes in check, I'll hit you!'

Gotou spoke angrily, but Eishin didn't seem to care . He smirked at him .

If Gotou kept talking, he might really end up becoming a monk .

'If you don't have anything to do, get out already . '

Gotou tried to chase Eishin out, but Eishin just continued smirking at Gotou .

For some reason, Gotou had a bad feeling .

'Actually, I have another request . '

– My feeling was right .

Gotou put his head in his hands and sighed .

Haruka gulped and looked at Yakumo .

'No good, eh...'

For a while, Yakumo looked at the door, but finally he sat back down in his chair, seeming exhausted .

There was a wrinkle between his brow and he had a difficult expression on his face . He looked pale too .

'Hey, what happened?' Haruka asked, leaning forward .

'There was a ghost there earlier . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair .

Even though Haruka hadn't been able to see it herself, she had sensed it from Yakumo's reaction .

'Someone you know?'

She had sensed that from Yakumo's words and actions too .

When Yakumo looked at the door, he had said 'Why are you here...' He had said those words because it was someone he knew .

'Yeah,' replied Yakumo, pressing a hand against his left eye .

There was no will-power in his voice . He must have had a great shock .

'A friend?'

'We weren't that close . '

— That's a lie .

Haruka felt that . She could tell from how Yakumo had panicked .

She wanted to confirm it, but since it was Yakumo, he would probably just hide it .

'I see...'

'In any case, I need to look into this in detail . '

'Look into what?'

'There's something I want you to call Ishii-san about to check . '

'Ishii-san?'

'Yes . I want you to ask whether this name's come up in any deaths from incidents or accidents . '

After saying that, Yakumo quickly wrote a name on a memo .

– Aoi Yuuka .

A woman's name . Probably the ghost who had been here earlier .

The urge to ask how they knew each other came to Haruka's head, but before she could, Yakumo tried to leave the room .

'Where are you going?'

'There's something I want to check,' Yakumo said quickly . Then, he left .

I've been left behind – there were a number of things Haruka wanted to ask, but first, she had to confirm about that woman .

Haruka called up Ishii's phone number from her mobile's memory and made the call .

After a number of rings, Ishii answered .

'Hello, it's been a while . It's Ozawa Haruka . '

<H-H-Haruka-chan!>

Ishii's loud voice came through the receiver . He sounded the same as always .

'I'm sorry for calling so suddenly . Do you have any time right now?'

<Yes, if it'll just be for a bit . >

Ishii's voice dropped down a tone .

Perhaps somebody was beside him . It seemed like it would be best to keep it short .

'Actually, there's something I want to ask . '

<What is it?>

'I want to know whether a woman named Aoi Yuuka has died in an incident or accident . '

<Aoi Yuuka!>

Ishii's voice jumped an octave on the other side of the phone . From that response –

'Do you know her?'

<A woman who was assaulted in a robbery two days ago had the same name . >

'Eh?'

– Assaulted in a robbery .

Haruka felt her throat grow tight at those unexpected words .

<Right now, she's undergoing treatment at the general hospital's ICU . >

'Is she alive?'

<Yes . Though her condition isn't good...>

– Thank goodness .

Haruka sighed in relief .

She didn't know what relationship Yakumo had with that woman, but if she was important to him, Haruka wanted her to be safe . Those were her true feelings .

<Excuse me, but why are you asking about her?>

Ishii's question sounded doubtful .

'That's... I don't really understand either . Yakumo-kun just asked me...'

<Yakumo-shi did?>

'Yes . '

<Actually, there's something I'd like to ask Yakumo-shi as well . >

'Something you'd like to ask?'

<Yes . It's actually about Aoi Yuuka-san's case . >

'What is it?'

<No, er... It's a bit hard to explain...>

Ishii fumbled for words .

'I understand . I'll tell Yakumo-kun once he's back . '

<Thank you . >

After thanking Ishii, Haruka hung up .

She had no proof, but something terrible was going to happen – she had that feeling .

8

After Ishii finished his call with Haruka, he returned to the Unsolved Cases Special Investigations Room .

Up until now, just hearing Haruka's voice would make him beside himself with joy . He was still happy now, but something was different .

Ishii felt once more that his feelings towards Haruka had changed in a complicated manner .

It might have been because he had seen the strength of her feelings towards Yakumo during the incident one month ago .

'Who was the call from?'

Miyagawa looked up from his papers as he leant back on he seat .

'Ah, just an acquaintance...' Ishii replied with a smile .

It would definitely be bad if he told the truth . He had blabbed about the investigation to a civilian .

Though Gotou didn't really care about that, that wouldn't fly with Miyagawa .

Ishii didn't know if Miyagawa believed Ishii's lie, but he didn't press any further .

'So what do you think?' asked Miyagawa, lighting his cigarette .

'What do you mean?'

'That Hideaki guy earlier . You believe him?'

Miyagawa threw the documents onto the desk .

Those documents had a man's details in them . A man named Imoto Yasuo .

After that, Hideaki had said the name of the burglar who had assaulted his sister, Yuuka . His name was Imoto Yasuo . After checking the police database, they had found him .

About two years ago, he had been violent towards his wife and there had been a police intervention .

In the past, Imoto had entered a rising religious organisation called Jikoukoushinkai and had donated a considerable amount of money . That had been the cause of the couple's quarrel .

However, with just this information, they couldn't know what type of person Imoto was .

'I don't...'

'You don't seriously believe that the guy can see ghosts, right?'

Miyagawa leant forward, a furrow between his brow .

'I would like to deny it, but...'

'What?'

'There is Yakumo-shi's case . '

When Ishii said that name, Miyagawa made a 'hmm' sound .

Miyagawa knew that Yakumo's unique ability to see the spirits of the dead had solved a number of cases .

Because of that, he couldn't reject what Hideaki said without listening to him .

'But that guy's eye is red . '

Miyagawa pointed at his own eye .

'But we don't know whether he can see them because of the red colour of his eye . '

'Well, that's true...'

Miyagawa frowned .

Yakumo had said this before . 'I just have the physical ability to see . '

If the ability to see the spirits of the dead was just something genetic, it wouldn't be strange at all if people besides Yakumo could see the spirits of the dead . However, in contrast to that, there was Kamiyama's case as well . At that time, Ishii had completely believed him and met with unfortunate circumstances .

Earlier, this was what Ishii had wanted to consult Yakumo about . Yakumo would be able to tell whether Hideaki was the real thing or not .

Perhaps Yakumo had already stuck his neck into the case .

That's why he'd asked Haruka to look into the victim, Yuuka – Ishii had that theory .

'Well, there's no point thinking about it here . '

Miyagawa pressed his cigarette into the ashtray and stood up, determined .

'Eh?'

'What do you mean, eh? We'll find out whether he's the real thing or not if we meet Imoto Yasuo . '

Miyagawa tapped the documents .

'Ah, that's right . '

Ishii stood up from his seat .

Gotou would have probably made the same choice . The answer wouldn't come to them just from thinking about it, so they had to move .

If Imoto Yasuo was alive, that would prove Hideaki's words to be a lie, but on the other hand, if Imoto Yasuo had really committed suicide – no, he'd stop thinking for now .

Ishii hit his own cheeks and ran out after Miyagawa .

– He fell .

9

'So where should I go?'

As Gotou drove the Mini Cooper, he posed the question to Eishin, who was in the passenger seat .

When two people with large frames rode it, it made Gotou feel like the air in the car was thin .

'There's a residential area away from the city, right?'

'Yeah . '

'Just head towards there . '

'What? Isn't this the opposite direction?'

'Yes, it is . '

In contrast to Gotou's anger, Eishin was nonchalant .

'Then say it earlier . '

'You're the one who slammed the pedal without asking where we were going, right?'

What Eishin was saying was true, but his tone irritated Gotou . Eishin was mouthy enough to be comparable to Yakumo .

'My bad,' grumbled Gotou . He made a U-turn and then looked at Eishin again .

'So what kind of request is it?'

'The daughter of a family who supports a temple went to Lake Kawaguchi with people from her university circle . '

'And then?'

Lake Kawaguchi had a lot of camp sites and multipurpose venues . Since it was close to the city, university circles often went there for camps .

'It seems like she went exploring with a male friend in the same circle . '

'That's just an excuse, right?'

Gotou snorted .

A guy and a girl – and in this season – would definitely not just go out with the intent of exploring .

'I thought that too, but it seems they really went to the Sea of Trees to explore . '

'By Sea of Trees, do you mean the one in Aokigahara?'

'Yeah . '

Eishin nodded, a complicated expression on his face .

A chill ran down Gotou's spine . Exploring Aokigahara's Sea of Trees of all things – it was stupid .

Aokigahara's Sea of Trees was a primeval forest at the base of Mount Fuji . It was considered a natural treasure and ideal for hiking or a peaceful walk

through the woods .

However, because the same scenery continued, if an amateur just walked in carelessly, they could get lost even in the day . If they weren't careful, they wouldn't be able to leave the forest .

That wasn't the only problem .

In Aokigahara, near a hundred corpses from suicide were found a year . It was famous as a spot for suicides .

In short, there were countless hate-filled spirits in the forest . It wasn't a place you should just go for fun .

It was like asking to be possessed by a ghost .

'So you saying they saw a ghost?'

'Well, rather than saw...'

Eishin had just put his chin in his hand when a mobile phone rang . Gotou used a hands-free function to answer .

'Who is it?'

<I keep saying this, but...>

'You want to tell me to fix my phone manner, right?' said Gotou, interrupting the voice on the phone . If he had to hear Yakumo's whining on top of Eishin's annoying blather, he'd burn a hole through his stomach .

<If you understand that, please act on it . >

'I'll think about it . So what is it?'

Yakumo wasn't the type to call somebody for no reason .

<Actually, there's something I would like to request . >

'Sorry, but right now I'm being used by old man Eishin . '

Gotou glanced at the passenger seat . Yakumo wasn't good with Eishin . He wouldn't say much if Gotou was with Eishin .

<Are you still committing fraud?>

'It's not fraud . I'm a detective . '

<It's something like it, isn't it?>

'It's completely different . '

<I don't care either way, but it would be better for amateurs to keep their noses out of spiritual affairs . >

'Acting so high and mighty . '

<Gotou-san, you'll be possessed by a ghost . >

'Enough with the chitchat . What do you want to ask?'

<Please call me once you've settled down . I'll tell you in detail then . >

After declaring that by himself, Yakumo hung up .

– The guy does whatever he wants, as usual .

'That Yakumo just now?' asked Eishin .

'Yeah . '

'If you're going to meet him, I'll come too . There are a few things I want to say . '

'Do what you want,' Gotou said carelessly .

If Eishin was with him, Yakumo would probably be a bit quieter .

'So what were you saying?'

Gotou brought the conversation back on topic .

'Ah, that's right . Actually, it seems like they found a corpse . '

Gotou's face twitched . Though corpses weren't a good thing, at Aokigahara, it wasn't that unusual .

They had probably found the corpse of somebody who had committed suicide .

'What an exploration . '

Gotou snorted .

'Indeed . Since the corpse of somebody who'd been murdered was found in that Sea of Trees . '

'W-what did you say?' said Gotou without thinking .

He'd been sure it was a corpse from a suicide, but it was a different story if it was a murder .

'Don't make a fuss . '

'It's a murder . Of course I'm making a fuss . '

'You're not a detective any more, right? And it's a different jurisdiction . '

'That's...'

Exactly as Eishin said . Gotou wasn't a detective any more . He couldn't stick his neck into the case .

Even if he were a detective, murder cases were done in the area the corpse was found . Since it was Aokigahara's Sea of Trees, that would be done by the Yamanashi precinct .

'Well, it seems like there've been questionings, but it was proven that she had nothing to do with the case . '

'So that's settled . '

'Are you an idiot? We're talking about a spiritual phenomenon right now . '

'My bad then . What about it?'

Eishin's tone always irritated him, but there was no point quarrelling about it now . Gotou urged Eishin to continue .

'After going back, it seems like that girl got a phone call . '

'From whom?'

'The ghost . '

'What?'

Gotou's eyes flew wide in suspicion, but Eishin's expression was the picture of seriousness .

'A call from a ghost, eh...'

'She got it on her mobile . When she answered, there was the voice of a man . '

'Wasn't it somebody's prank?'

'But it'd be pretty nasty for a prank . '

'What?'

'On the other side of the phone, the man kept saying the same thing . '

Eishin slowly turned towards Gotou .

When he looked up at him, his large face seemed incredibly creepy .

'What?'

'You killed me...'

Eishin's words made a chill run down Gotou's spine .

10

'How was it?'

That was the first thing Yakumo said after returning to the room .

Haruka told Yakumo what she had heard from Ishii . As she did so, she felt like it was hard to breathe .

Even though she had come here to tell Yakumo about her future career, she had ended up wrapped up in an unexpected case .

'I see...' said Yakumo curtly once Haruka was finished .

Perhaps it was because he knew that Yuuka was alive that his expression seemed a bit relieved .

However, there was something Haruka didn't understand .

'Earlier, the ghost that appeared in front of you was the woman named Yuuka-san, right?'

'Yeah . '

'Why would she show up as a ghost if she's alive?'

That was Haruka's question .

Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair .

'To put it simply, it's an out-of-body experience . '

'Out-of-body experience?'

'Yes . Something similar happened before, right? With my uncle's incident...'

'Ah!'

Haruka finally understand .

Just as Yakumo said, something similar had happened in the past . A girl's spirit had left her living body and wandered a hospital .

Yakumo was probably saying that this incident was similar .

'It makes me suspect your memory . '

'Yes, yes, I have a bad memory . So what were you doing, Yakumo-kun?' asked Haruka .

Yakumo combed his hair back and looked up at the ceiling .

'I contacted Gotou-san, thinking I'd get him to help . '

'Is Gotou-san well?'

Haruka hadn't seen Gotou since the last case .

After hearing his name, Haruka felt like seeing him again . Come to think of it, since Gotou had quit the police, they had much fewer chances for all of them to meet .

'Yeah, he's the same as always . '

'That so?'

'And I tried calling her older brother, but the call didn't go through . '

Here, Yakumo looked displeased .

'Her older brother?'

'Yeah . Her older brother, Aoi Hideaki, was in the same class as me when I was in the third year of high school . '

'Were you friends with him?' asked Haruka .

Yakumo had a difficult expression on his face .

'Friend . Where does being a friend start and end?'

'Eh?'

Haruka didn't understand the meaning of the question .

'What's the definition of a friend?' Yakumo said reluctantly .

When Haruka looked at his face, she felt sad .

Yakumo had always been like this . He perceived the relationships between people with his thoughts rather than his feelings .

That's why sometimes he couldn't straightforwardly accept that people liked him .

– It's sad .

Haruka felt that .

'There's no definition for a friend . Isn't it fine as long as you both think that you want to be together?'

'It's fine for you . You're simple . '

Yakumo's eyes narrowed as he smiled wryly .

'You make things too difficult, Yakumo-kun . '

'That might be true...'

After saying that, Yakumo let out a quiet laugh .

'Even if you aren't friends, you're related somehow, right?'

Otherwise, Yakumo wouldn't be so disturbed .

'There was an incident when I was in the third year of high school . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair .

'Incident?'

'Though it wasn't anything that serious, that caused Hideaki to realise that I could see . '

'Eh?' said Haruka in surprise . That meant –

'He knew about my eye . One of the few people who did . '

Yakumo pointed his index finger at his left eye .

'Is that so?'

If that was true, he must have been somebody special to Yakumo .

'Anyway, let's go see how she is . '

After a silence, Yakumo stood up, as if for a change of pace .

'OK,' replied Haruka, standing up too .

The two of them had just left the Movie Research Circle room when something came to Haruka's mind .

'Hey, what did Yuuka-san's spirit say?' asked Haruka .

Yakumo stopped and looked up at the sky .

The clear blue autumn sky had just one little stray cloud, blown by the wind .

'A deep forest...'

Even though Yakumo was beside her, his voice sounded far away for some reason .

'Forest?'

'Yeah . A deep forest . And that... she wanted me to save someone...'

That moment, Yakumo looked incredibly sad .

11

Ishii walked on the pedestrian path beside the Tamo River .

He saw the water gate in the distance . That place had a lot of memories for Ishii . During the case that he had first paired up with Gotou, he had run down this path with all his might .

Even though it had only been a month since Gotou left the police, Ishii felt very nostalgic about the time they'd spent together .

'Honestly . What a pain,' grumbled Miyagawa, walking beside Ishii .

Ishii understood how he felt . They had really been given something troublesome to deal with . However, Ishii wasn't that negative about it .

'However, we might find out the truth to the burglary case . '

'You're optimistic . '

'Is that so?'

'Yeah . When we first met, to be honest, I thought you were a pretty hesitant man . '

'That's true...'

Ishii couldn't deny that .

Ishii couldn't be confident, and when he was hesitant, he always did nothing .

That was why he had looked up to Gotou . He was never hesitant . He didn't think about what might happen .

He just rushed straight down the path he believed in .

'But you've changed recently . '

'Eh?'

'Especially after pairing up, I've started thinking that my impression was wrong . '

'What do you mean?'

'I'm saying you've got your feet planted firmly on the ground . '

'Feet on the ground?'

Ishii repeated Miyagawa's words, but he didn't really understand .

'Yeah . On top of that, you're bad at giving up and you're stubborn . You'll be a good detective . '

'Eh?'

Ishii stopped for a moment, so surprised that he had been praised .

He'd never even thought in his dreams that he'd hear those words from Miyagawa . To be honest, he even felt that he wasn't apt to be a detective .

'Don't dawdle!' said Miyagawa, interrupting Ishii's thoughts .

Before Ishii had noticed, Miyagawa had already walked fairly far ahead . Ishii hurriedly ran after him .

His feet tangled and he almost fell, but somehow, he regained his footing .

'I think this is it . '

After walking for a while, they went off the pedestrian path to the road .
Miyagawa stopped in front of an apartment building .

It was probably thirty years or so since it was built . It was an old apartment . There were cracks all over the walls and the steel stairs outside were rusty .

Ishii checked the address on the map . This was the place, no doubt about it .

'So, now we'll find out if that guy's story is the truth or a lie . '

Miyagawa rubbed his hands together as he said that .

In the files, it said that Imoto Yasuo had lived in this apartment ever since his divorce .

'Yes,' replied Ishii, though his heart was beating loudly .

For a moment, Hideaki's face came up in his head .

His eyes had had no doubt in them . They were the eyes of someone who knew the path they should take .

– Can he really see ghosts?

'Let's go . '

Miyagawa, standing in front of the door, pressed the intercom button .

However, there was no response . Miyagawa pressed the button multiple times, but there was still no response .

'Maybe he's not here?'

Miyagawa clicked his tongue and knocked on the door .

However, there was still no response .

When Ishii looked at the mailbox by the door, he saw that there were a lot of advertisements stuffed inside it .

So he hasn't been back for a while, or —

'No helping it . Let's come back later . '

Miyagawa stuck his hands in his pockets and turned around .

'Please wait a moment . '

Ishii called out to stop him .

Hideaki had said that Imoto felt guilty and had committed suicide . If that was true, there was no way that there'd be a response .

'Want to go around the back?' said Miyagawa .

Though Ishii hadn't spoken, it seemed that Miyagawa had sensed his thoughts .

Ishii responded with a nod .

They went to the back of the apartment, between the fence and the building . There was a garden facing the balcony .

'There . '

Miyagawa pointed at the balcony that was probably for room 102 .

The glass door for the balcony had curtains covering it, so they couldn't see inside .

Ishii climbed the fence onto the balcony . There was a small gap between the curtains . He put his face up to it to peer inside .

It was a dim room . Then —

'Eek!'

After peering in, Ishii shrieked without thinking and leapt back . His back hit the fence .

'What's wrong?'

'A-a person...'

Ishii's voice was shaking .

Inside the room, a man had hanged himself to death –

12

Haruka visited the general hospital with Yakumo .

She had visited this hospital a number of times before . Hata Hideyoshi, a strange coroner who called his work his hobby, worked at this hospital .

'I was thinking about who it could be, but it's you, Yakumo-kun?'

After going through the entrance, somebody suddenly called out to them . Haruka turned around in surprise .

Speak of the devil . Standing there was Hata in his doctor's gown . His shoulders shook as he let out a creepy giggle .

He had a body like a dried mummy, but his eyes alone shone brightly .

Haruka always thought he looked like a demon .

'It's been a while . '

Yakumo bowed his head .

'That bear isn't with you today?'

'Wasn't that bear chased out of the forest for causing too much trouble?'

'Oh, that's right . '

Hata smiled, looking incredibly pleased .

'I'm here on a different matter today . '

'I see . That's too bad . Come play every once in a while . '

'You plan to dissect me, don't you?'

'You could tell?'

Yakumo and Hata were exchanging distasteful jokes .

It was hard for Haruka to join the conversation .

'Putting the jokes aside, you can come to play . I'll show you my collection,' Hata said with pride . Then, he hobbled away .

After that, they went to the reception and asked for Yuuka's hospital room . They were told that she was currently in the ICU and couldn't see anybody .

Yakumo tried to ask about it in detail, but naturally, because of privacy, they couldn't be told .

'Anyway, let's just go to the hospital room,' said Yakumo .

He started walking . Haruka nodded and followed him .

They took the stairs up to the third floor and went to the ICU with the help of signs . Then, Yakumo suddenly stopped .

Though it was through a glass, they could see inside .

There was a bed with a woman lying face-up . She was probably Yuuka .

She had a respirator attached to her mouth and IV drips hanging from her arm . Her head was wrapped in bandages, covered in blood .

'Why did this...' murmured Haruka .

From what Ishii had told her, Yuuka had been assaulted during a burglary .
Why did a woman who had done no wrong have to suffer like this –

It was too much for Haruka .

'She said she wanted me to save someone...'

As Yakumo said that, he looked straight at Yuuka .

His voice sounded just a little hoarse .

'Yes . '

'Who on earth could she want me to save after being assaulted during a burglary, and how?'

'I don't know . '

Haruka shook her head .

She didn't know, but she did know that Yuuka was a kind woman .
Normally, after suffering something like this, somebody would first feel hatred and resentment towards the culprit .

However, she probably had something more important to her than that .

'What are you hoping for?'

After saying that, Yakumo turned on his heels and started walking .

What is Yakumo thinking right now – Haruka wanted to know, but at the same time, she felt like knowing would be a very scary thing .

'Her brother Aoi Hideaki said something to me,' said Yakumo as he walked down the corridor .

'What did he say?'

'That he could see the spirits of the dead . '

'No way...'

Haruka was shocked by those words .

Somebody besides Yakumo could see the spirits of the dead – but now that she thought about it, it wasn't that strange .

The man with two red eyes could see the spirits of the dead too .

Haruka could see ghosts too sometimes, depending on the timing and situation .

'Couldn't you understand each other since you had the same ability?' asked Haruka .

Yakumo shook her head .

'At the time, I couldn't accept him . '

'Why not?'

Haruka didn't understand .

Because Yakumo could see the spirits of the dead, he had suffered for many years . Hideaki should have been a special existence to him, as somebody he could understand and be understood by .

'We were completely different . '

'How were you different?'

'To put it simply, hope . '

'Hope?'

'Yes . He believed that being able to see would change something . He even thought of it proudly . '

That would be the complete opposite of Yakumo, who had suffered because of his ability to see . But –

'Yakumo-kun, you also...'

Yakumo had used his ability to see to solve many cases up until now .

He had saved many spirits that hadn't been able to rest . He wouldn't have been able to do that without hope .

'I was envious of him . Even jealous . '

Yakumo's brow furrowed .

The light of the fluorescent lamps made it look like his red eye was shining .

'Jealous...'

'He naturally did something I couldn't . He had something he should protect, but I didn't...'

Yakumo smiled bitterly, looking down, and shut his mouth .

– Something he should protect .

Those words struck a chord with Haruka .

Yakumo must have felt that way in high school because of the matter with his middle school homeroom teacher, Takagishi .

After reaching the entrance, a young man stood in front of Yakumo .

His big brown eyes were impressive .

'Saitou Yakumo... Why are you here...'

He spoke up the moment he saw Yakumo . In contrast to the young man's surprise, Yakumo was calm .

'Aoi Hideaki . It's been a while,' said Yakumo, with narrowed eyes .

13

'Here?'

Standing in front of the house, Gotou asked that question to Eishin, who was standing next to him .

Around here, about five years ago, the mountain was cut open for a new residential area which had houses that all looked the same . Even looking at the nameplate, Gotou wasn't sure about it .

Eishin nodded and pressed the intercom button . Immediately, a woman's voice came back: 'Yes?' Eishin gave his name . After a while, the entrance door opened and a middle-aged woman welcomed them .

The woman had a plump face and was probably in her early fifties .

'Master Eishin, I'm sorry you had to come all this way . '

The woman bowed at her waist .

'Don't concern yourself about it,' Eishin said kindly . Eishin was incredibly good at keeping up appearances . His expression was gentle – he was like a completely different person than when he talked with Gotou .

The woman's expression became slightly gentler . Then, she turned her eyes to Gotou . She didn't actually ask 'Who is this?' but Gotou could hear her doubt .

'This man is my manservant . His name is Gotou Kumakichi[2] . '

– Who the hell's his manservant!? Who the hell's Kumakichi!?

Gotou had a mountain of things he wanted to rebut to, but with the person who'd made the request in front of him, he managed somehow to hold it in .

'I'm Gotou . '

'My name is Maehara Fumiko . '

After Gotou introduced himself, the woman politely bowed again .

'This is sudden, but could we meet your daughter?' asked Eishin .

'Please follow me,' replied Fumiko, inviting them into her home .

After passing through the entrance, they went into what was probably the living room . Gotou and Eishin sat next to each other the sofa, while Fumiko left the room . She was probably going to call her daughter .

'Who the hell's Kumakichi?'

Gotou glared at Eishin .

'You . '

'I'm not called Kumakichi . '

'But Yakumo called you Kuma . '

'You're saying that on purpose, didn't you . I'll punch you,' said Gotou threateningly . Then, the door opened and Rina came into the room .

Though she looked young, she had dyed brown hair with heavy makeup on her eyes, like a model . She felt very much like a current university student .

'You don't have to be so afraid . Let's sit down and talk,' urged Eishin .

Rina nodded and sat down on the opposite sofa .

Then, Eishin asked her to explain what had happened in the Sea of Trees . It was pretty much the same as what Gotou had heard before .

Just as Gotou was starting to feel bored, Rina said something strange .

'I don't know if you'll believe me, but...'

'What? Just say it,' urged Gotou .

Rina continued, though she seemed hesitant .

'Just as I was trying to run after finding the corpse, a man appeared in front of me . '

'Man?'

'Yes . That man had two deep red eyes...'

Rina's body shivered, like she was remembering the incident .

'That true?'

In his agitation, Gotou grabbed Rina's shoulders .

Rina's eyes welled up with tears, perhaps in fear, but she nodded .

'Calm down a bit,' reprimanded Eishin . Gotou let go of Rina and sat down on the sofa again .

– What's happening?

If that man showed up with the spiritual phenomenon, they couldn't go with ordinary methods . He had to be planning something inconceivable .

'Let's get back on topic . Do you have the mobile you mentioned?' said Eishin after clearing his throat .

'Yes,' replied Rina . Then, she hesitantly put her mobile on the table .

Besides the number of character straps from a pirate manga dangling from it, it was a completely normal mobile phone .

'How many calls did you get?'

Eishin continued his questions .

'I don't know . I was so afraid that I turned off the phone immediately . '

Rina shook her head .

'Did you check the call display?'

This time, Gotou was the one to speak .

'It was an unknown number...'

'What do you think?' Eishin said to Gotou quietly .

'There's something suspicious about it,' said Gotou, glaring at the mobile .

The little amount of information made it hard to come to a decision, but at this stage, rather than a spiritual phenomenon, it seemed more like a prank by somebody who knew the situation .

'It's true . Please believe me,' pleaded Rina with wide eyes, perhaps sensing Gotou's thoughts .

'I'm not denying what you experienced . '

'But...'

Rina looked down feebly .

'Anyway, we need to confirm this . '

Eishin was the one who spoke . That would probably be the quickest .

Gotou took the mobile on the table and turned it on . After a while, the screen lit up .

The waiting screen had a photo of a dim forest on it . Gotou couldn't say he really liked it .

'Why'd you make a photo like this the waiting screen?'

When Gotou showed the screen to Rina, she let out a shriek and jumped back to the sofa . Her body was shaking terribly .

'What's wrong?'

'I-I don't know... I don't recognise that photo,' responded Rina in a hoarse voice . That response – it didn't seem like she was lying .

Even Gotou had a bad feeling . Something unexpected was going to happen . He had that feeling .

Riiiiiiing –

Interrupting Gotou's thoughts, the mobile phone rang .

14

The scene was busy with activity because of the hanged corpse that was found .

An ambulance carried away the corpse as investigation members began their search of the scene . Ishii watched from a corner of the apartment grounds .

The corpse that was found was definitely Imoto Yasuo .

A will was found in the room . It appeared that the will's contents hinted that he had done the burglary himself .

Furthermore, Aoi Yuuka's lost wallet had been found .

The situation made it seem like Imoto Yasuo had assaulted Aoi Yuuka during a burglary, but in Ishii's heart, there was still something that didn't seem right .

'Oi! What the hell are you doing!?'

A yell that sounded like Miyagawa's suddenly reverberated through the area .

Ishii turned to look to see Miyagawa approaching Honda, who was giving out orders . It seemed like Miyagawa might punch Honda at any moment .

'Miyagawa-san . '

Ishii hurriedly ran over .

'You shut up!' Miyagawa responded immediately .

'But...'

'This guy's telling us to keep away from the investigation . '

'Eh?'

So that was the cause of Miyagawa's anger – the moment Ishii understood that, anger sprouted up within him too .

There was no way that Ishii could accept it if Honda had made them deal with Hideaki because he thought it was troublesome, only to tell them to back off once they found the corpse .

'This isn't a game . If you're going to complain, I've got my own thoughts too . '

Honda's words were the picture of highhandedness .

It was like throwing oil into the fire for Miyagawa's anger .

'You're the one who's playing around!'

As expected, Miyagawa shouted angrily at Honda .

'Miyagawa-san, please calm down . '

Ishii pulled Miyagawa back by force, even as he continued to yell .

If this continued, Miyagawa might get demoted again . Miyagawa's reputation had already dropped because of the matter with Gotou .

'That fool!'

After leaving the apartment premises, Miyagawa kicked the ground with as much force as he could .

'I understand how you feel, but...'

'Even if you don't tell me, I get it,' replied Miyagawa, the force completely gone from his voice .

He seemed incredibly tired .

'Miyagawa-san...'

If the incident with Gotou hadn't happened, Miyagawa would have been the one giving out orders, but now, he was completely left out of the loop .

Ishii thought that Gotou's choice then had been correct . That was why Miyagawa didn't blame Gotou either . That just made it hurt more .

Perhaps this was what it meant to make a choice .

'You think he's the real thing?'

After a silence, Miyagawa asked that question while lighting a cigarette .

'Are you talking about Hideaki-shi?'

'Yes,' replied Miyagawa, his face solemn .

They found the corpse because of Hideaki's testimony . If his ability was real, they had nothing to worry about .

However, if it was false, a number of problems arose .

'I don't... How do the higher-ups plan on dealing with this case?'

One thing bothered Ishii .

If the culprit was found from a regular police investigation, there wouldn't be any problem, but the situation was a little different this time .

Ishii was curious about how the detective department, starting with Honda, would conclude this .

'That fool's completely useless . '

Miyagawa glared at Honda, who was giving orders in front of the apartment .

'Eh?'

'He plans on pulling Hideaki in as an accomplice . '

'Why would he?'

'It's simple . His theory's that Hideaki knew about Imoto because he killed him . Honda's going to make Hideaki confess in an interrogation . '

Miyagawa's frown was so deep that it couldn't be any deeper .

'But that's...'

That was far too hasty .

Rushing forward with just a theory would make the investigation veer off course . Furthermore –

'That room was a locked room . '

The apartment door had been locked . That wasn't all – there was a chain lock on the inside too .

Ishii and Miyagawa had gone in by breaking the glass door .

'That guy's going to get that out of Hideaki too . '

'It won't go that easily!'

Even Ishii ended up raising his voice .

'Don't tell me that . If you're going to say it to anyone, say it to that pampered brat . '

Miyagawa looked at Honda again .

Ishii felt disappointment spread throughout him . If it were Gotou, he would have probably gone at Honda without mercy, but unfortunately, Ishii didn't even have the courage to share his opinion with the chief of the detectives .

Even if he could give his opinion, Honda had chosen to leave Ishii and Miyagawa out of the investigation . He definitely wouldn't listen to what they had to say .

'This leaves a bad taste in my mouth . '

Miyagawa put his cigarette into his portable ashtray .

'It really does... What do you plan to do, Miyagawa-san?'

'Nothing . '

'Eh?'

'We've been left out of the investigation . There's nothing we can do . '

After glaring at the scene, Miyagawa walked away briskly .

Miyagawa probably felt uncaring because he had been left out of the investigation . Ishii understood those feelings . Anybody would feel angry after being treated that way .

However, was it acceptable for them to back down?

Hideaki was being treated as a suspect . Ishii himself just couldn't accept that .

'I...'

Ishii was irritated with himself for being unable to make a decision .

15

Riiiiing –

The mobile phone rang on top of the table .

Gotou thought that Rina was going to scream, when she just covered both ears and kept repeating 'Stop it already...' like a spell, sitting down right there .

Gotou looked at Eishin .

Riiiiing –

The phone kept ringing .

Gotou slowly reached out and took the mobile in his hand . He looked at the number displayed on the screen . It read <Unknown> .

– Is it really somebody's prank?

'Why not try answering?' said Eishin, peering at the mobile .

That was right . Just looking at the mobile wouldn't get anything started . If it was a prank, Gotou could just give a good scolding . If it was really a call from a ghost, he'd bring in Yakumo . That was all .

Gotou was just about to accept the call when the ringing stopped .

'It's because you were dawdling,' Eishin said mockingly .

'Shut up . '

'Even though your body's as big as a bear's, your heart's smaller than a flea's . '

Eishin smirked .

– This damn monk!

'I can't keep it in any longer! We're going outside! I'll punch you a good one!'

Riiing –

The mobile phone started ringing again, drowning out Gotou's yell . Just like earlier, the display showed <Unknown> .

'Come on,' said Eishin, elbowing Gotou's stomach .

– You don't have to tell me .

Gotou answered the call and put the mobile by his ear .

'Who is it?' asked Gotou, but there was no answer .

On the other side of the phone, he could hear wind and crackling branches .

'Hello? I'm asking who's there,' said Gotou more forcefully .

He could now hear somebody breathing quietly . It looked like somebody was on the other side of the phone .

'If you don't stop screwing around...'

<You...>

Gotou heard a voice .

A man's voice, similar to a beast's .

'What?'

<You... did...>

The man's voice echoed in Gotou's ears .

A chill ran down his spine .

– This isn't a prank . It's a real ghost .

Gotou was sure of it . This was bad . Answering the phone was the wrong choice .

– I need to hang up now .

That was what Gotou thought, but his body wouldn't work the way he wanted t .

His forehead was drenched with sweat .

'What's wrong?'

Eishin spoke up . He seemed to have sensed something was wrong .
However, Gotou was unable to answer .

He felt like something incredibly dark was flowing into him through the phone .

<You...>

– No . It wasn't me .

<Killed...>

– No .

Gotou frantically fought back .

However, that resistance was futile . That dark something swallowed Gotou's consciousness –

16

Haruka stood by a maple tree in the hospital courtyard .

Yakumo was facing Hideaki a little away from her .

Evening approached . Its reddish purple light made it difficult to see their expressions clearly .

'I feel kind of nostalgic,' said Hideaki in a gentle tone .

'Yeah,' Yakumo replied brusquely, his tone a bit stiff .

It felt like there was a difference in the distance they felt between each other .

'She your girlfriend?' said Hideaki . For just a moment, his eyes met hers .

'No, that isn't...'

Under that straight gaze, which seemed to look straight through her, Haruka felt flustered .

'No . She's just a friend,' Yakumo said bluntly .

Though he wasn't incorrect, being denied so readily like that made Haruka's heart plummet . Don't come any closer to me – it was like he was telling her that .

Hideaki started to laugh, his shoulders shaking, as if he thought something was funny .

'You've changed, Saitou . '

After laughing for a while, Hideaki looked at Yakumo again .

'Nothing's changed,' replied Yakumo a bit testily .

'You have . The old Saitou would never have called somebody a friend . '

'I don't remember . '

Yakumo looked at his feet as if to try to escape Hideaki's gaze .

'I see... Well, whatever . More importantly, what are you doing here today?'

'I came to visit your sister . '

This time, Hideaki was the one who looked away .

'To see Yuuka...'

Hideaki gripped his hands into fists and his face twisted, as if in pain .

It felt like he was forcing himself to hold back emotions that could explode out at any moment .

'I heard about the incident . '

'Is that so?'

'Your sister came to me . '

'What?'

Hideaki's eyes widened in shock .

'Her spirit left her body . '

'I see... Yuuka went to you...'

Hideaki's expression softened just a bit . It seemed like he understood what happened .

'She came to me for help . '

'Help? Why from you?'

'I don't know . '

Yakumo shook his head .

'I see...'

'She left two messages . '

'What were they?'

"“Deep forest” and “I want you to save someone” . '

'Save someone in a deep forest... What does it mean?'

'I came to confirm that . '

Hideaki was silent as he looked down for a while, but then he suddenly looked up .

'I feel like I understand . '

'Understand?'

'Actually, the man who assaulted my sister appeared in front of me yesterday . Well, to put it more accurately, this was in Yuuka's hospital room . The man kept apologising to Yuuka . He probably felt guilty about what he did...'

'And then?'

'The man was already dead . He committed suicide...'

Hideaki shook his head slightly . Though it was faint, it looked like his eyes were wet with tears .

'So why would that translate into saving someone?'

Yakumo looked at Hideaki sharply .

'Yuuka must want to save the man who killed himself...'

'I can't save someone who's already dead . '

Hideaki smiled bitterly at Yakumo's words .

'Hey, do you remember what we talked about before?'

'What we talked about?'

'How you can save people by seeing the spirits of the dead . '

'Ah... that...'

Yakumo's eyes seemed distant .

'At the time, Saitou... you said that you couldn't save anything . '

'You said that you could . '

'I still believe that . There must be something I can save . '

'Why are you so...'

Interrupting Yakumo's words, a woman in a suit moved to stand in front of Hideaki .

– What?

While Haruka was confused, a man appeared behind Hideaki . They had him sandwiched .

The woman in front showed a police ID .

'I'm Shimamura from the Setamachi precinct . You are Aoi Hideaki, correct?'

– Police?

Even Yakumo appeared surprised by the situation, but Hideaki didn't seem disturbed . He replied confidently with a 'Yes' .

'I apologise for the trouble, but there are a number of things we would like to ask . Would you come with us to the precinct?'

'Is this optional? Or is this an arrest?'

'Of course, this is optional . '

'So that means I can refuse,' Hideaki replied calmly .

That moment, the woman showing her police ID frowned .

'You can refuse, but it won't do you any good,' the man behind Hideaki said threateningly .

'I understand then . Saitou, let's talk at length at some other time . '

Hideaki smiled at Yakumo . Yakumo received that smile expressionlessly .

All Haruka could do was watch in shock as Hideaki was taken away .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun...'

Haruka spoke up, but the shrill ring of a mobile phone interrupted her .

17

– Did Imoto really commit suicide?

After Miyagawa left, Ishii continued to watch the scene at the apartment as he mulled over his thoughts .

If it bothered him so much, he should just snap at Honda like Miyagawa did and suggest they continue the investigation . However, Ishii couldn't do that .

It wasn't just this time either . He was always like this . Running away was his habit .

'Ishii-san . '

Just as Ishii had put his head in his hands, somebody called out to him .

When he lifted his head, he saw Hijikata Makoto walking towards him .

He had met Makoto because of a certain case . Ever since then, it had felt like something had kept bringing them together .

'M-Makoto-san...'

Makoto was a newspaper reporter . She had probably come to gather information .

Her father had been the chief of the police . The reason he had been forced to quit was his daughter's article .

There must have been a lot of conflict, but Makoto never mentioned it .

– I envy her .

Ishii looked up to Makoto's straightforwardness .

'It's been a while . '

Makoto stopped in front of Ishii with a smile on her face . Her long and glossy black hair fluttered .

Ishii had been afraid of Makoto before . The circumstances they had met under had been bad .

When he first met Makoto, she had been possessed by a ghost . Because of that, Ishii had suffered a fair amount .

As a result, his heart would start thumping every time he saw her .

However, he felt like the nature of his heart's palpitations had changed lately .

'Are you here to gather information?'

'Yes . Ishii-san, you were the one who found him, correct?'

'Yes, well... how should I put it...' replied Ishii, flustered .

Though they had been the one to find him, the path there had been complicated .

'Actually, there was something I heard...'

Makoto brought her face close to Ishii's .

'W-what is it?'

'I heard that a young man who could see ghosts was involved in the case .
Could it be Yakumo-kun?'

So a rumour's already spreading throughout the reporters – Ishii was a bit surprised at the speed of information .

'No, Yakumo-shi isn't related to this case . '

'Then it was nonsense?'

'No, that's...'

Though Yakumo wasn't related, it was true that a young man who said he could see ghosts was involved .

Makoto pressed forward, not letting Ishii's moment of hesitation escape her .

'What do you mean?'

Surprised by how close Makoto's face was to his, Ishii leant back without thinking .

'No... How should I say it...'

Makoto, as a reporter, did have quite some force behind her . Even though Ishii was hesitant, in the end, he explained everything that had happened, as Makoto asked .

After Ishii finished, Makoto nodded a number of times in understanding .

'So what are you going to do, Ishii-san?'

'Eh?'

'About the case . '

'I... I've been left out of the case, so...' Ishii replied weakly .

'But you want to know the truth, right?'

'That's...'

Of course he wanted to know the truth . He wouldn't be able to sleep like this .

If he could, he wanted to see the case until the end . But –

'Then let's investigate together,' Makoto said indifferently .

'No... I...'

'Shut up . We're going . '

Makoto's sudden harsh words made Ishii's eyes widen in shock .

When Makoto saw that, she started laughing, her shoulders shaking as she did so . Ishii didn't understand what was happening .

'Er... Makoto-san?'

'Did it sound like him?'

'Like who?'

'I was mimicking Gotou-san . '

'Oh . '

After hearing that, Ishii ended up laughing too .

Gotou would have said that . It didn't matter who said what . He went forward on his own path .

'So Ishii-san, you can just investigate it if it bothers you . '

'That's right,' agreed Ishii without another thought .

He felt silly for being hesitant . There was no point floundering because he'd decided on his own that he couldn't do it .

'Chief Honda's instructions don't matter . I'll follow this case until the end . '

Ishii thrust a fist up into the air .

'That's the spirit . '

'Thank you very much . I feel like I've woken up now that you've given me a push, Makoto-san . '

'If you're all right with me, I'll give you a push any time . '

With a wide smile, Makoto pushed Ishii's back forward .

Because of how sudden it was, Ishii lost his balance and almost fell, but luckily, he managed to regain his footing .

Makoto laughed aloud happily .

As Ishii looked at the bright smile, for some reason, his heart beat loudly –

18

– Things are serious .

Because of all that had happened, Eishin couldn't speak at first .

After Gotou answered Rina's mobile, he had suddenly collapsed, like he had been stricken by lightning .

Even Eishin had panicked . He'd tried to shake Gotou and hit him, but he still wouldn't open his eyes .

Since Gotou was breathing and his heart was beating, he wasn't dead, but he wasn't in a good state .

'H-he's been possessed by a ghost!' shrieked Rina .

Rina was curled up in a corner of the room in her fear . Perhaps it was just as she said .

– Gotou's been possessed by a ghost .

In a situation like this, there was nothing Eishin could do any more .

– Seems like I'll need Yakumo to come .

Eishin pulled his mobile phone from his robe's sleeve and called Yakumo's number, which he had stored in his contacts .

After a number of rings, Yakumo answered .

<What do you need?>

He was cold, as always .

Since Eishin had been calling persistently to tell Yakumo to take over the temple recently, Yakumo probably held a grudge about that .

'Actually, there's been a spot of trouble . '

<There's trouble here too . Please call me later . >

Yakumo was going to hang up the phone .

Eishin didn't know what had happened, but it looked like Yakumo had some difficulties on his end too . Eishin would be in a tight spot if he let Yakumo hang up here though .

'Gotou's been possessed by a ghost,' Eishin said quickly .

Even Yakumo seemed surprised . For a while, there was silence .

<What do you mean?>

It seemed like Yakumo finally felt like listening .

'Actually...'

Eishin explained in detail from Rina's request to Gotou's collapse . When Eishin finished, Yakumo sighed .

<And then he was possessed by a ghost...>

'Looks like it . '

<I've always thought Gotou-san was an idiot, but there's really no helping him . >

'Now, don't say that . He's still Nao's father . You can do something, right?'

Eishin said admonishingly .

However, there was no response .

Eishin knew though . Yakumo wasn't the type who could leave this situation alone . He was like Isshin in that sense .

<Anyway, nothing will start if I don't take a look . Could you bring Gotou-san?>

'Understood . I'll do that . '

After saying that, Eishin hung up .

– Now, the problem is how to carry this big man to the car .

Eishin crossed his arms as he thought, but as if to interrupt that, he heard a scream .

He turned to Rina and saw that her eyes were wide and her body was shaking . Gotou, who had been collapsed on the floor, was slowly getting up .

'You awake?'

Eishin tried to approach Gotou, but he stopped immediately .

There was clearly something strange . Gotou's eyes were bloodshot . He ground his teeth together as he growled .

It looked like he really had been possessed .

'You... did... '

As Gotou's huge body shook, he approached Eishin like a zombie .

'Stop that . Can't you tell it's me?' Eishin said, raising his voice . However, Gotou still kept walking towards him .

He had completely lost it .

Gotou's hands reached for Eishin's neck .

– No helping it .

With determination, Eishin struck Gotou's head with all his might .

It had an impact . Gotou's large body slowly fell forward .

'Don't blame me,' Eishin said to Gotou on the floor .

'W-w-what's happening...'

Fumiko ran into the room, perhaps because she heard the commotion .

'Ah, sorry, but do you have some rope?' asked Eishin .

Even though Fumiko's eyes were darting about in confusion, she left the room .

'Honestly... What a pain,' muttered Eishin .

19

Haruka waited for Yakumo's call to end .

Though she couldn't hear the call, she could tell from Yakumo's expression that it was an urgent situation .

Her heart beat loudly .

'What happened?' she asked Yakumo, who had ended the call with a sigh .

Yakumo frowned .

'It's bad...'

'Are you talking about Hideaki-san?'

'No . '

Yakumo shook his head in irritation .

'Eh?'

'I'm concerned about his situation, but there's another problem . '

– This isn't a light matter .

'What happened...'

Haruka's voice started shaking .

'I got a call from Eishin-san just now . '

'By Eishin-san, do you mean the monk?'

Haruka had met Eishin before .

He was a monk who had taught Isshin . They had met after Isshin's death . He had a round face and seemed gentle at first glance, but he was rather self-assertive .

'Yeah . You know that Gotou-san's doing detective work with him, right?'

'Yup . '

After leaving the police, Gotou had started work as a spiritual detective .

Haruka had heard from Yakumo that Eishin brought requests to Gotou .

'It seems like Gotou was investigating a spiritual phenomenon when he was possessed by a ghost . '

– Possessed by a ghost?

Haruka was becoming more confused .

Even though Haruka already couldn't understand why Hideaki had been suddenly taken away by the police, a new problem had arisen .

And for Gotou to be possessed by a ghost – to be honest, Haruka couldn't believe it .

She couldn't see Gotou as the type of person who would be possessed .

'What do you mean?'

Her tone grew restless from her irritation .

'I don't know the details, but it sounds like the ghost came out of the phone . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair .

– The ghost came out of the phone?

'Is it possible to be possessed through a phone?'

'It's the first time I've heard of it, but I can't deny the possibility . 'Eh?'

'The spirits of the dead have no physical influence . However, it is possible for them to interfere with electromagnetic waves . '

'That's...'

Haruka felt like she had fallen off a cliff .

Her head felt dizzy . She felt like she might have to sit down at any moment .

'Anyway, I need to confirm Gotou-san's condition first,' said Yakumo quickly .

It was just as Yakumo said . Though Haruka was concerned about Hideaki, saving Gotou was the priority .

'That's right,' replied Haruka .

She and Yakumo started walking .

The wind felt terribly cold .

It made Haruka afraid, like it was hinting at the location they were going . Haruka suddenly looked towards Yakumo .

His left eye seemed to let out a hard glint, lit up by the setting sun .

20

'I can see ghosts . '

Hideaki kept repeating the same words .

They would never believe him, but he was used to that reaction .

When he was in high school, Hideaki had declared that he could see ghosts . His friends had either accepted it as a joke or made fun of him for being strange .

Hideaki didn't take it seriously and object either . It wasn't like he wanted them to believe he could see ghosts . There was just a need for him to do what he did .

Hideaki smiled self-derisively .

The moment he did so, the male detective in front of him glared at him fiercely .

If Hideaki remembered correctly, his name was Nakamura .

'Stop fooling around,' he threatened .

However, Hideaki didn't think him frightening . No matter how he was cornered, Hideaki replied with the same thing .

'I'm not fooling around . I can really see them . '

Perhaps Hideaki's cool attitude bothered Nakamura, because he grabbed Hideaki by his collar .

'Stop that . '

The female detective named Shimamura immediately stopped Nakamura from beside him .

'B-but... . '

'This isn't an interrogation . This is only a voluntary questioning . '

'But...'

'Stop whining and go outside for a bit . '

Shimamura cut Nakamura down . Though Nakamura looked unsatisfied, he left the room dispiritedly .

After a moment, Shimamura said gently, 'Sorry about that . '

It was such a sudden change that Hideaki was surprised .

'No...'

'Let's pretend everything up until now didn't happen . Tell me about you . '

'About me?'

'Why did you quit high school after your parents died?'

'Because I had to live...'

His parents had died suddenly . They had been returning home from shopping when they were in a hit-and-run incident .

When Hideaki was contacted about it, his head had gone blank .

However, when he saw Yuuka sobbing, he managed to regain his senses . He had to be reliable – that was what he thought .

'But there was life insurance – you must have had some money, right?'

'Yes, but there was my little sister...'

Though there was life insurance, when Hideaki thought about reserving money for the future and about his sister, he decided to quit school and start working .

He wanted to at least let his sister Yuuka do what she wanted to do with her life, even if he couldn't do it himself .

Naturally, Yuuka had objected . She had insisted that she would work too, but Hideaki hadn't allowed it .

For a while, they had been on parallel lines of thought . In the end, Hideaki quit school on his own and started working at the company of one of his father's friends .

By acting, he had forced Yuuka to accept it .

'But she isn't your real sister, right?'

Shimamura probably meant no harm by those words, but that was a matter Hideaki didn't want to touch .

'Is there a problem with that?'

He ended up speaking more roughly without thinking .

'There isn't, but...'

'Even if we're not related by blood, we're siblings . '

Hideaki's mother had run away from home, leaving her child behind . Hideaki had been raised without knowing a mother's love .

He had always lived together with his father .

Hideaki's life had changed in middle school, when he was introduced to Kaori, his father's new wife, and her daughter, Yuuka .

Of course he had objected at first, but now that he thought about it, it might have been fear from his inexperience with love .

Kaori had been a kind woman . She had treated Hideaki like her own child .

She had scolded him at times, but that had made him happy . It had felt like she was really looking at him . For the first time in Hideaki's life, he had experienced a mother's love .

It had felt like their dark and lonely home had been lit up . It had been warm and pleasant – a place of his own . That was why –

'I see . I know a couple who've adopted a child . '

'Is that so...'

'When I see that family, I think that blood isn't the only thing that makes a family . '

Those were probably Shimamura's true feelings . She had a very gentle expression on her face .

'I believe so . '

'That was a bit off-topic . You can go home for today . '

Shimamura stood up .

Hideaki felt troubled by how sudden it was .

'Is that OK?'

'Yes . I said this earlier too, but this is a voluntary questioning . '

With a smile, Shimamura left the room .

Hideaki, left behind, leant back on his chair, exhausted .

If that accident hadn't happened, his life would have been very different . When he thought about that, his feelings became complicated .

However, what he had lost wouldn't come back, no matter how much regret he felt over it .

21

Before he'd noticed, Gotou had entered a dark forest –

Lush trees stood around him . At his feet, there were rocks covered in moss .

It was chilly . It felt like a creepy place .

– Where am I?

He felt like his body was floating .

While it felt like he was in a dream, for some reason, there was a sense of reality to it . It was a strange feeling .

– If I don't get back soon, Atsuko and Nao will be waiting at home .

Gotou tried to walk forward, but no matter where he went, the same scenery continued . It was like a maze .

A tree branch rustled .

– What?

Gotou looked around to see a man slowly walking towards him .

He was a young man . He had something heavy on his back as he took one step at a time through the forest, which was hard to travel through .

'Oi! You!'

Gotou called out to him, but he didn't even turn to look, like Gotou's voice didn't reach his ears .

He continued walking silently, with some sort of determination .

Finally, the man came right in front of Gotou .

'Oi . '

Gotou tried to reach out to the man, but his hand went through him .

That wasn't all . The man walked through Gotou's body and went deeper into the forest .

– What? What's happening?

Gotou turned around, confused .

'Oi! Wait!'

Gotou bellowed from the bottom of his lungs . The man stopped in front of a rock about as tall as he was .

Finally, Gotou's voice had reached him . That was what Gotou thought, but it looked like he was wrong . The man crouched carefully, put down what he was carrying and put it on the rock .

Next, the man started to pour a liquid onto his belongings .

– What's he doing?

Oblivious to Gotou's confusion, the man lit a match and threw it at his belongings .

Then, flames rushed up .

Tears fell from the man's eyes, lit up by the brilliant flames .

– What the hell's happening?

Though Gotou was still confused, he took a step towards the man . However, the ground collapsed underneath him .

'Agh!'

As Gotou screamed, his consciousness fell into a deep darkness .

– Sorry .

He felt like he heard somebody's voice in his ear .

NOTES:

[1] Lake Kawaguchi is one of the Fuji Five Lakes . It is the most popular one among tourists . The MT FUJI SITE has some photos of the lake in all twelve months .

[2] Kuma (熊) is Japanese for bear . Kichi (吉) is a common suffix for male names .

Volume 9 Chapter 2: VOLUME 9 – THE SPIRIT OF SALVATION

VOLUME 9 – THE SPIRIT OF SALVATION

file 02: frenzy (TRANSLATION NOTES)

1

Haruka was shocked as she looked at Gotou .

In the corner of the Movie Research Circle room which Yakumo made his secret hideaway, Gotou was sitting in a wheelchair .

His hands and arms were bound with rope . It looked like he wasn't conscious – he sat limp like a puppet which had had its strings cut . There was no trace of the usual Gotou there . Haruka had never even dreamt of seeing Gotou again like this .

'Please tell me in detail what happened,' Yakumo said in a harsh tone, standing directly in front of Gotou .

'Sorry . It was my fault . '

The weak response came from Eishin .

Eishin had both a large body and a large personality, but even he was listless in this situation .

'It doesn't matter right now whose fault it was . '

With a sigh, Yakumo sat in his usual seat .

'Right...' Eishin said to himself, and then he started explaining what had happened up until now .

In Aokigahara's Sea of Trees, a woman had found a corpse while exploring . Then, there had been a phone call from a ghost –

And then Gotou had answered the ghost's call, and no other than Eishin had been the one to goad him into doing it .

That was probably why he was saying it was his fault .

'Honestly . I have to say it was careless . '

Yakumo put his chin in his hand, exasperated .

Haruka felt the same way . If they had been a bit more careful, this wouldn't have happened .

'Painfully so . '

Eishin smiled bitterly .

'So what are you going to do?' asked Haruka, leaning forward .

There was no point blaming what had happened . The problem was what to do next .

'In all probability, the spirit possessing Gotou-san is probably the ghost of the corpse that was found . '

'The problem is the corpse's identity then . '

'Yeah . But there's something that concerns me . '

'The man with two red eyes?' asked Eishin .

Haruka was concerned about that too . The man with two red eyes whom Rina had seen in the Sea of Trees – it couldn't be just a coincidence .

'If he's involved in this, there's a chance that there's some involvement with the case . '

'I see,' replied Eishin, scratching his chin .

'Well, there's no point thinking about it now . First, we have to gather information . '

Yakumo put his index finger on his brow .

His almond eyes seemed to let off a cold light .

'Then what should I do?' asked Eishin .

'That's right . First of all, Eishin-san, could you talk to the man who went exploring with Rina-san?'

'There might be new developments... right?'

'Yes . '

'Got it . I'll give it a try . '

Eishin briskly got up and left the room .

'This is really troublesome...' grumbled Yakumo . Then, he looked at Gotou again .

Haruka felt the same way as Yakumo . She had never thought that Gotou would be possessed by a ghost .

'Hey, why was it Gotou-san?'

Haruka asked the question that suddenly came to her head .

There were people who were possessed by ghosts, and people who weren't . This time, Gotou wasn't the only person who answered the phone . The woman named Rina had also answered .

But Gotou was the one who was possessed – why was that?

'I talked about this before, but I think it's something similar to wavelengths . '

Yakumo's eyes narrowed .

'Wavelengths...'

'The wavelength of a soul differs with each one . When they match up, possession can occur . '

Yakumo had compared possession to an organ transplant before . For the transplant to be successful, various conditions such as blood type had to match up .

'So Gotou-san's wavelength just happened to match . '

'That's it,' said Yakumo .

Then, Gotou slowly lifted his drooping head .

Perhaps he had woken up .

'G-Gotou-san . '

Haruka tried to rush over to him, but Yakumo stopped her .

'Give it up . '

'But...'

'Ur... gh... Ya... Yakumo... Why are you here?'

Gotou spoke in a pained voice .

Yakumo got up from his seat and crossed his arms in front of Gotou .

'How do you feel?'

'The worst... My head hurts...'

'What happened?'

'I don't know... I... answered the phone... and then...'

As Gotou spoke, it seemed like it hurt him to breathe . His body wrested about violently . However, because he was bound with rope to the wheelchair, he couldn't move as he wanted .

Gotou's body rattled loudly .

'Gotou-san! Please get a hold of yourself!' Haruka yelled frantically .

Gotou let out a beastly howl, throwing his head back . Then, he stopped moving .

'Yakumo-kun . '

'It's fine . He's still alive . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair .

– Things have become really serious .

All Haruka could do was look in shock .

2

Ishii visited Meisei University with Makoto .

After Ishii called Yakumo to tell him there was something he wanted his advice on, Yakumo had told him to come to the Movie Research Circle room .

'It feels a bit strange,' said Makoto, looking around the campus like it was something mysterious . They had passed the school gates and were walking along the brick road .

'What do you mean?'

'Doesn't being at school remind you of your school days?'

'Ah, now that you mention it, it does,' agreed Ishii .

Ishii felt that way sometimes too . However, Ishii didn't have many enjoyable memories of his youth to remember .

I wonder what sort of university life Makoto had – Ishii suddenly wanted to know .

'And it's even stranger to be walking with you, Ishii-san . '

'I-is that so?'

'Yes . It feels a bit strange . But it's fun . '

Makoto stuck out her tongue playfully .

Why was Ishii's heart beating so loudly? He thought about it, but he couldn't find the reason .

While this was happening, they reached the prefabricated building in the back of Building B . After taking a deep breath, Ishii knocked on the door that had a plate that read <Movie Research Circle> .

'It's open . '

Yakumo's voice came from within .

'E-excuse us . '

Ishii hesitantly opened the door .

'Ishii-san . '

Ishii saw Haruka there . Next to her was Yakumo .

'It's been a long time,' greeted Ishii, putting a hand on his head .

Ishii was surprised at how strangely calm he was now, when his heart would soar just from seeing Haruka's face in the past .

'Makoto-san's with you too, I see,' said Yakumo, noticing Makoto .

'Yes . It's been a while . I apologise for coming uninvited . '

'No, I actually had a number of things I wanted to ask you too . Please come in . '

At Yakumo's invitation, Ishii and Makoto entered the room .

'Ah!'

Then, Ishii's eyes spotted somebody unexpected .

'Detective Gotou!'

Ishii had called Gotou after he quit, but it had been about a month since they had last met in person .

Ishii was so happy that he was about to embrace Gotou, but Yakumo grabbed Ishii's arm, making it impossible for Ishii to approach Gotou any further .

'Please don't carelessly approach him,' Yakumo said sharply .

'Eh? Why not?'

'Gotou-san has been possessed by a ghost,' Yakumo said with a sigh .

– Eh?

'By ghost, do you mean that ghost?'

'Yes, that ghost . '

Ishii leapt away without thinking when he heard those words, which he was so sensitive to .

'W-w-w-w-wha!?'

When Ishii took a good look from a distance, he saw that Gotou was bound to a wheelchair and that his head was hanging limply .

It looked like he was unconscious .

'It's because he runs ahead and does unnecessary things that this happens . '

Yakumo kicked the wheelchair casually .

'T-that's awful . '

'It's fine, since the one thing that's sturdy about Gotou-san is his body . '

'No, that's not the...'

'It seems like things are quite troublesome . '

Even Makoto sounded surprised by the situation .

'Yes, it's an unwelcome nuisance . More importantly, please sit down first .
,

Yakumo urged them to sit in the opposite chairs .

After Ishii shared a look with Makoto, he sat down, though he was still confused . Yakumo waited until they were seated to sit down himself .

'Excuse me... Will Detective Gotou be all right?' Ishii asked .

'To be honest, I don't know . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair .

His words sounded incredibly irresponsible .

'But that's...'

'I don't know who the ghost possessing Gotou-san is or what the ghost is trying to do . There's nothing that can be done . '

Yakumo had a point, but still –

'I need to help Detective Gotou right now!'

'Ishii-san, you're following a different case right now, right?'

'That's true, but...'

'This is just a suspicion I have, but I think that the ghost possessing Gotou-san and the case you are following are connected in some way . '

'I-is that so?'

'It's only a suspicion, but she mentioned a deep forest and told me to save someone...'

'What are you talking about?'

'Just talking to myself . Please don't concern yourself over it . '

'Haa...'

Ishii didn't understand, but he didn't press any further .

It was Yakumo . He had to be thinking of something .

'Anyway, first we have to clean up the various problems in front of us . I think that will be a shortcut to solving the case . '

It sounded like Yakumo was trying to convince himself with his words .

3

Eishin sat at a table in a family restaurant in front of the station .

Since it was dinnertime, the shop was rather crowded . Perhaps it was unusual for a robed monk to be sitting by himself – a lot of people were staring . He was used to it though .

'Are you the monk named Eishin?'

After a while, a young man came in front of Eishin .

He had a long, thin body and a wide grin .

Eishin had asked Rina to call out the young man who had gone with her into the Sea of Trees so that Eishin could talk to him . The truth was, it would be faster to have her here too, but she refused .

It seemed like she had been disillusioned by the incident with him in the Sea of Trees .

'Are you Hiroki-kun?'

'Yeah,' Hiroki replied with a shrug .

– Deplorable .

Young people these days didn't know how to speak to their elders . Maybe they were trying to act like people in Europe or America, but Japan had Japanese culture .

'Well, sit down,' Eishin urged, repressing his irritation .

'Hey, you an exorcist?' asked Hiroki once he sat down .

– An incredibly rude guy .

'Decide for yourself . '

'Eh!? Seriously?! Try showing me!'

Hiroki's eyes sparkled like a child, like he was happy about something .

– He’s really annoying .

'If you tell me what happened in the Sea of Trees, I’ll put a curse on you . '

'OK!'

After giving that carefree reply, Hiroki started talking about the events that occurred in the Sea of Trees .

However, since there was an incredible amount of bragging and sound effects in his story, it took him a long time to get anywhere . It took a full forty minutes for Hiroki to finish, but in contrast to that length, there was no substance . If you talked normally, it would only take five minutes .

'So you didn’t see a ghost?’ asked Eishin .

Hiroki nodded .

'I see . So then you contacted the police . '

'Yeah . Rina-chan had fainted so I was seriously panicked,’ said Hiroki, shuddering dramatically . Though his gestures were exaggerated, there was no anxiety in his words .

It looked like he couldn’t even understand the gravity of finding a corpse .

'Were you questioned by the police?’

'Yeah, but they just acted where I was and stuff like that and took the video camera I was using to film . '

'Oh?’

'Actually, I’d like you to get that back . '

'Me?’

Eishin couldn’t believe his ears .

'I'm begging you, man . It'd be a pain to go all the way to Yamanashi . '

Hiroki leant back and forth, like a kid begging for a toy .

– Why do I have to do your errands?

Eishin swallowed his anger right before it erupted and stood up from his seat .

'That was helpful . '

'If that's all you need, call me any time . '

Hiroki stood up and patted Eishin's shoulder .

That moment, the anger within Eishin erupted . Yelling at a brat like this wouldn't have any effect though .

'Hiroki-kun, right?'

'Yeah . '

'I'm just going to give you a warning . '

'What?'

'The spirits in the Sea of Trees are incredibly ill-willed . You'll be the next to be cursed . '

'Joking around?'

Hiroki laughed .

However, Eishin's expression didn't change . He looked straight at Hiroki .

Led by the force in Eishin's eyes, Hiroki's smile turned into a frown . Then, sweat started pouring down his forehead .

'You're kidding, right...?'

Hiroki's voice was shaking .

'Unfortunately, you'll die in the near future .

'W-wai... Stop that . '

Eishin ignored Hiroki's frantic pleas . He went to the counter to pay and then left the family restaurant .

– It'll be good medicine for him .

Eishin let out a satisfied sigh before walking away .

4

Haruka headed for the temple where Gotou lived .

She was going to tell Atsuko, Gotou's wife, what had happened . She passed through the gate and went to the priests' quarters . Her legs felt weak .

She really didn't want to go tell such heavy news .

However, there was no point standing here and worrying about it . Haruka gathered her determination and pressed the intercom button at the entrance .

'Yes?'

Haruka heard a voice . Then, the entrance's sling door opened to show Atsuko .

'Oh, hello, Haruka-chan,' said Atsuko, sounding surprised .

It was the first time Haruka had come here alone since Isshin had died .

'Good evening . Actually, there is something I need to tell you...' said Haruka, still feeling troubled .

Atsuko seemed to sense something as her expression hardened . 'Come in,' she said, inviting Haruka inside .

Haruka went to the living room and crouched on the tatami . Nao, drawing in a sketchbook, looked up .

'Nao-chan, it's been a while . '

After Haruka said that, Nao's face lit up . Nao leapt towards her .

'You doing well?' said Haruka, patting Nao's head .

– Yeah!

Haruka heard that voice in her head . Nao couldn't hear, but in exchange, she talked directly to people's hearts like this .

'Well, sit down,' urged Atsuko .

Haruka sat on a cushion . Nao sat next to her with a smile .

'Would you rather have tea or coffee?'

'Please don't mind me . '

'You don't have to restrain yourself . We're going to be relatives in the future anyway . '

'Eh?' said Haruka, confused .

'Well, when you and Yakumo-kun get married, won't we be relatives?'

Though Haruka understood what Atsuko meant, unfortunately there were no plans of that .

Haruka didn't want to take it seriously and deny it either, so she decided to let it pass with a wry smile .

'Then I'll have tea . '

After a while, Atsuko returned with tea from the kitchen .

'So what did you have to tell me?' said Atsuko, sitting across from Haruka .

With Atsuko in front of her like this, Haruka didn't know what she should say .

However, thinking about it wouldn't start anything . Haruka took in a deep breath and started to speak .

'Actually, this is about Gotou-san...'

'Did something happen?'

Atsuko's expression became grim immediately .

With a deep breath to calm herself down, Haruka told Atsuko what had happened to Gotou .

Atsuko listened to Haruka in silence . Since Atsuko's expression didn't change much, Haruka didn't know what she was feeling .

After a silence, Atsuko put a hand over her mouth and started giggling .

'Eh?'

'He really is an idiot . '

Atsuko laughed aloud like she couldn't keep it in any longer .

Nao started laughing too .

'Excuse me... I don't think it's a laughing matter...'

Haruka wasn't sure what to do with the unexpected response .

'It is . It's like that saying – going for wool and coming home shorn . '

'Aren't you worried?'

'I am . '

For just a moment, Atsuko's expression clouded over .

Those were probably her true feelings – Haruka understood that .

'I'm worried, but all I can do at a time like this is believe, right?'

Atsuko showed Haruka a smile .

'Atsuko-san...'

– She's strong .

Haruka felt that anew .

When Gotou had gone missing before, and when Isshin had been stabbed, Atsuko had stood firmly on her own .

No matter what happened, she waited and believed . Perhaps she had the resolve to do that .

'I thought it'd be tough when I married him,' Atsuko said suddenly .

'Eh?'

'I mean, he never thinks before acting, right? He always sticks his neck into danger . '

'Yes, well...'

Haruka felt like she understood .

Even though Gotou treated others' lives with care, for some reason, he didn't have that same care for his own . Yakumo was the same way .

That was why it frightened Haruka to watch . It was hard to be the one waiting .

'At first there were many sleepless nights for me, but I realised something .
,

'What did you realise?'

'No matter how reckless he is, he always comes back . That's why I wait
and believe in him . '

'I see . Definitely...'

'And it's fine with Yakumo-kun there . He'll do something about it . '

Atsuko patted Haruka's shoulder .

'Yes . '

Haruka nodded .

'Ah, that's right . I'll show you something good . '

It looked like Atsuko had remembered something as she clapped her hands
together and stood up .

'Something good?'

'Old pictures . '

After saying that, Atsuko left the living room .

Nao took Haruka's hand and smiled . She definitely believed in Gotou too .
That was why she could smile like this .

– I need to believe to .

In her heart, Haruka thought that with conviction .

After Ishii returned to the precinct, he contacted Shimamura Eriko of the Criminal Affairs division immediately .

She was one of the detectives in charge of Hideaki's case . Ishii chose her because she had been Gotou's past partner .

Ishii thought that she would give him a bit more information than another detective .

'I would like some information regarding Hideaki-shi's case, but...'

After saying that, Ishii was told to wait at the conference room .

Ishii went into the conference room, as he was instructed . It looked like Shimamura wasn't here yet . Ishii sat on a chair and leant back .

He had never thought that Gotou would be possessed by a ghost .

Yakumo had said that Gotou's incident and Imoto's suicide in his flat were connected, but Ishii didn't understand why Yakumo thought that .

However, all Ishii could do was believe and act .

'Sorry I'm late . '

About ten minutes later, the conference door opened, and a woman in a dark blue suit came in .

She had wide shoulders for a woman and a heavy frame . It felt like she could be in a gang .

'No, I'm sorry for calling you out . '

'It's fine . '

Shimamura waved away Ishii's concern and sat across from him .

'Ah, I'm sorry, I haven't introduced myself yet . My name is...'

'Ishii, right? I've heard about you from Gotou and Atsuko . '

'Eh?'

Ishii cocked his head unconsciously .

It made sense for Shimamura to know Gotou, but Ishii hadn't thought that she also knew his wife, Atsuko .

'You didn't know?'

'Didn't know what?'

'I'm the one who introduced Atsuko to Gotou . '

'Eh!?'

Ishii was so shocked that he almost fell from his chair .

'Unexpectedly, you don't know much about Gotou, even though you were his partner . '

It was true .

Though Ishii and Gotou had always been together as partners, they virtually never talked about their private lives .

They unexpectedly knew very little about each other .

'I-I'm sorry . '

'It'd be better for you to stop apologising so quickly like that . '

'Ah, no, but...'

'I'm just saying this here, but Gotou's got high hopes for you . '

'Eh?'

Ishii was shocked once more .

'He's a clumsy guy so he can be cold, but he's different on the inside . '

'I-is that so?'

Ishii couldn't believe it .

Ishii had never seen even a tiny amount of that from Gotou . Ishii felt like he had always just been tripping over himself and causing trouble .

'You didn't even realise that?'

'I-I'm sorry . '

'You're apologising again . '

'I...'

Ishii hurriedly swallowed the words he was about to say .

'Ishii'll become a good detective, he said...'

'Me?'

'When he quit being a detective, he went out of his way to find me and bowed his head to me . Telling me to help you if you were in trouble . '

'Detective Gotou did that...'

Ishii felt something warm welling up within him .

Will I be able to live up to those expectations – Ishii had lamented the lack of Gotou's presence and had given up, thinking he could do nothing, and shut himself inside a shell . His own biased view .

– I'll live up to Detective Gotou's expectations .

Ishii was filled with strong determination .

'Let's leave the soppy stories now . Here're the case files . '

Shimamura placed a bundle of documents on the desk .

<Thank you very much . Also, how did Aoi Hideaki's questioning go?' asked Ishii, looking at the files .

'He kept saying he could see ghosts, but there's no way that police can believe that . '

Shimamura smiled wryly .

As members of the police, they really had no way to accept the existence of ghosts .

'So he's still in detention?'

'We didn't keep him . '

'Eh?'

'It wasn't an arrest . It was just a questioning . '

That was true . At this stage, he was just suspicious – there was no proof .

'Do you think he's the culprit?' asked Ishii .

'It seems like Chief Honda thinks that . He's going to have him questioned again . '

'What do you think personally, Shimamura-san?'

'Innocent, obviously,' said Shimamura, seeming exasperated .

'Why do you think that?'

'I don't know how to answer, but if I had to say, it's my gut feeling from many years on the force . '

'Gut feeling?'

'Yeah . It's been a while since I've seen eyes as straight as his . He's the not the type of man who could kill someone . '

'Then he really can see...'

'I don't know about that, but that flat was a completely locked room . '

Ishii knew best, as the first eyewitness, that the flat where the corpse was found was a locked room .

'Yes, it was . '

'And Imoto had posted on an internet forum in a way that suggested he would commit suicide . '

'An... internet forum?'

'Yes . There's a site where people who want to commit suicide gather, right?'

'You're talking about that?'

Ishii hadn't accessed the site himself, but he had heard rumours .

People who wanted to kill themselves gathered on that forum and revealed the emotions they felt . In the past, people who met on that forum had committed a group suicide, making it a societal problem .

'Honestly . Even though everything's a mess already with the corpse from Aokigahara . What a mess...' said Shimamura with a click of her tongue .

'Aokigahara?'

'The Yamanashi precinct requested help regarding the Aokigahara corpse case . '

If Ishii remembered correctly, Gotou had been investigating a spiritual phenomenon in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees when he became possessed by a ghost .

– So they really are related somehow?

'Excuse me... Why was help requested for the Aokigahara case?' asked Ishii .

'Seems the victim was from here . One of the leaders of Jikoukoushinkai . '

'Jikoukoushinkai...?'

'Imoto, the guy who died in the flat, was part of the same religious group . '

'Eh?'

Yakumo's theory might really have been right . The Aokigahara case and Hideaki's case were related .

6

'Honestly... This is awful,' grumbled Yakumo, standing in front of Gotou, who was in a wheelchair .

If this was going to happen, I should have seriously stopped him when he told me he was going to become a spiritual detective – the wave of regret within Yakumo kept pushing forward .

'Uuuurgh...'

Gotou let out a groan . His body writhed . Then, he slowly lifted his head .

Yakumo put strength into his left eye's gaze .

'Who are you?' Yakumo asked towards Gotou .

However, there was no response . It looked like he was in pain .

'You... gil... ed...' said Gotou .

To be accurate, they were the words of the spirit of whoever was possessing Gotou .

'Were you killed?'

'Aiii... wa...'

There were no words after that . Gotou's head dropped down and he stopped moving, as if he had been unplugged .

'No luck, eh...'

Yakumo looked up at the ceiling, pressing a hand against his left eye .

The fluorescent light seemed bright .

After doing that for a while, Yakumo looked at Gotou again .

He couldn't feel the usual energy from Gotou . Yakumo was surprised that it made him feel lonely .

He had met Gotou more than fifteen years ago . Gotou had been a novice officer, and Yakumo had just been a boy .

At that time, Gotou had saved Yakumo's life .

Because fate was a mysterious thing, a few years after that, Yakumo ended up meeting Gotou again because of a certain case .

At first, Yakumo had just thought of Gotou as a greedy detective who wanted to use his ability .

It was only recently that Yakumo realised that Gotou's true intentions were not as he thought . Gotou was clumsy, but he supported Yakumo in his own way .

At some point, Yakumo himself had started to trust Gotou .

He had felt that painfully when his uncle Isshin died . At that time, Gotou had said that he would take in Nao .

Though Yakumo hadn't said it aloud, he had thought that with Gotou, he could entrust Nao to him with no concern .

During an incident a month ago, Yakumo had been pursued as a suspect . Gotou had come to save him without any hesitation .

Gotou had known that doing so would force him to leave the police, but he hadn't paused anyway .

The man was so straightforward that it was stupid . That was why –

'It would trouble me if even somebody like you disappeared,' murmured Yakumo, closing his eyes .

Then, he suddenly felt somebody's gaze .

– Who's there?

When Yakumo opened his eyes, there was a woman standing there .

'Aoi Yuuka...'

Yuuka's mouth moved, as if she was trying to urge Yakumo to do something .

However, it was too faint . Finally, Yuuka's spirit disappeared, as if it had melted into the air .

'So the two cases really are related?' said Yakumo to himself .

7

The next morning, Haruka went to the Movie Research Circle room .

To be honest, she hadn't been able to sleep well the day before . It had been a great shock .

'Yakumo-kun, you here?'

When Haruka opened the door, Yakumo greeted her with a yawn .

Though he always looked sleepy, it felt like he had gone a step above that today .

'You...?' said Yakumo, rubbing his eyes and stretching .

'How's Gotou-san?'

Haruka looked at the corner of the room and saw Gotou in a wheelchair, in the same spot he had been in yesterday .

'Honestly . Because of this bear, I wasn't able to sleep properly,' said Yakumo, stifling a yawn .

'Was he violent?'

'No, his snoring is loud . Seems like you snore even if you're possessed . '

Haruka ended up laughing without thinking .

It was irresponsible of her, but she thought that things would be fine if Yakumo could still speak lightly like this .

'So how are Atsuko-san and Nao?' asked Yakumo after Haruka sat down .

'They accepted it more calmly than expected . '

Atsuko had been unexpectedly unruffled . She had even shown Haruka pictures of Gotou's younger days .

However, even if Atsuko acted like that, she was actually concerned .

'I see...'

'So what are you going to do next?'

'First, I'm moving this bear elsewhere . '

'Where?'

He couldn't be put back in his home .

The ghost might leave Gotou's body and possess Atsuko or Nao .

'I was thinking of leaving him to Hata-san . '

Yakumo glanced at Gotou .

Now Haruka understood . If Gotou was left here, Yakumo wouldn't be able to move freely . Hata worked at a hospital . If anything happened, he would be able to respond to it . But –

'Is that OK?'

'What?'

'I mean, Hata-san is...'

Hata wasn't a bad person, but there was a problem with his interests .

He called his work as a coroner his hobby, and every time he saw Yakumo, he would cheerfully say something awful like 'Let me autopsy you' .

If he saw Gotou like this, he might cut him up with glee .

'Even Hata-san wouldn't do that . '

Though Yakumo was calm, Haruka was concerned .

'Right...'

Just as Haruka said that, the door opened .

'Good morning . '

It was Makoto .

'Ah, Makoto-san . '

Haruka immediately gave her seat to Makoto and moved to the seat beside Yakumo .

'I'm sorry for coming early in the morning,' said Makoto, sitting down .

It seemed like she hadn't had enough sleep either, as she looked a bit tired .

'How was it?' said Yakumo, getting to the topic at hand .

Yesterday, he had asked Makoto to investigate the corpse Rina found in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees .

'There's still a lot I don't understand, but...'

Makoto took newspaper clippings out of her bag and lined them up on the table .

Yakumo started reading immediately .

'Maehara Rina was the one who found the corpse . That's what was reported, but there was a man named Urakawa Hiroki with her . '

Makoto took out her memo pad and started explaining as she looked at it .

'The police think it's a murder . '

'Yes . The corpse was burnt black . At first, they thought it was self-immolation, but they found a stab wound in the chest . '

'Do they have the identity?'

Yakumo's eyes narrowed .

'Yes . Hiyama Kenichirou, fifty-two years old . '

Makoto placed a photo on the table .

Yakumo took the photo and gazed at it . Haruka took a peek at the photo too .

The man was slender with chiselled features . He seemed composed .

'This is definitely the person possessing Gotou-san,' said Yakumo after a silence .

Though Haruka couldn't be optimistic yet, but knowing who was possessing Gotou was a big step forward .

'What sort of person is he?' asked Haruka .

Makoto took more files out from her bag .

'Hiyama Kenichirou-san was one of the leaders of Jikoukoushinkai, a rising religious group . '

'Jikoukoushinkai?'

Haruka cocked her head . She had never heard the name before .

'I will look into the details after, but it seems like they worship mountains as sacred and suddenly grew in power in these past two years . '

'How are the police viewing this case?' asked Yakumo .

'A murder case related to the religious group's internal interests... is what they're thinking . '

'What is their reason for thinking so?'

Even the police wouldn't just suspect that it was an inside job because the victim was a leader of a rising religious group .

'A khakkhara had been dropped at the place where the corpse was found . '

'What's a khakkhara?' asked Haruka .

'To put it simply, it's a staff with a number of metal rings on top . It's used in religions like Shugendo[1] so that when walking in the mountains, the noise makes beasts and snakes scatter . '

Yakumo's explanation helped Haruka see an image in her mind . She had seen something on television before where a mountain priest walked with something that kept ringing in his hand .

'So that religious group used a khakkhara,' said Haruka .

Makoto nodded .

However, it looked like Yakumo still hadn't accepted it .

'That isn't the only reason, right?'

'It isn't . There was a rumour of a split in the inner group before . Currently, the Yamanashi precinct and the Setamachi precinct, where the main base for the religious group is, are investigating together . '

'The religious group's base is here?' said Yakumo, sounding surprised .

It was a surprise for Haruka as well . She had been sure it was in Yamanashi prefecture .

'It seems like that . '

'That's strange . '

With a wrinkle in his brow, Yakumo rubbed his chin .

'What is?' asked Haruka .

Yakumo looked at her sharply .

'Earlier, Makoto-san said that the religious group worshiped mountains as sacred . '

'Yup . '

'Worshipping mountains as sacred means that they believe that mountains have supernatural powers, which is the reason they worship them . '

With that explanation, Haruka could also understand why Yakumo was suspicious .

'So it'd be normal for them to have their base somewhere near mountains . '

'Right . '

'That's not the only thing that's strange,' said Makoto, after Yakumo nodded .

'What else is there?'

'It seems like the founder, a woman named Minegishi Kyouka, says that she can see the spirits of the dead – that is, ghosts . '

'Is it true?' said Haruka in surprise .

However, Yakumo remained expressionless .

'Don't take everything at face value . '

'But...'

'In either case, we'll need to pay a visit,' Yakumo said quietly .

His narrowed red left eye seemed to be filled with curiosity .

8

Ishii woke up to the sound of his mobile phone ringing .

Since his glasses weren't on, he couldn't see properly . He fumbled around his desk and picked up his mobile .

'Hello...'

Since he had just woken up, his voice was hoarse .

He had looked at documents until late last night . Then, he had just fallen asleep at his seat without returning home .

<Good morning . >

The voice he heard from the opposite end of the phone was Yakumo's .

'Ah, hello . '

Ishii fumbled around the desk again and then put on his glasses . Then, he slapped his cheeks . That woke him up a bit .

<How was it?>

'That...'

Ishii explained the information he had received from the documents and Shimamura to Yakumo .

<In short, the possibility of suicide is high at this stage . >

'Yes, that's the case, but...'

<Ishii-san, you can't accept that explanation . >

'I can't . '

There were just too many things that didn't seem to fit together . He didn't know where to start .

<Ishii-san, did you see the scene of the crime?>

'Not too clearly...'

Ishii had been the first eyewitness, but he had had his hands full with reporting the crime and at the time, he hadn't been able to observe the scene carefully .

After that, Honda had taken them off the case, so he couldn't enter the scene .

<If possible, I would appreciate it if you could go see it with your own eyes and report what you see to me, Ishii-san . >

Ishii agreed with Yakumo's opinion . Looking at it with his own eyes might bring about new information .

'Understood . I'll give it a try . '

Ishii had just hung up the phone when Miyagawa came into the room .

'Ah, Miyagawa-san . '

'Don't just say "ah",' said Miyagawa, sounding like he was in a bad mood . He sat at the opposite desk .

'I-I'm sorry...'

'So what did you do?'

'Ah, no... er...'

For a moment, Ishii wasn't sure if he should tell the truth .

However, hiding it wouldn't start anything . Miyagawa would definitely understand .

Ishii told Miyagawa everything that had happened yesterday after they split up, including how Gotou had been possessed by a ghost .

'Idiot!'

That was the first thing Miyagawa said after he had finished hearing Ishii's story .

Even as Ishii apologised, he looked at Miyagawa with disappointment . He had been sure that Miyagawa would understand –

'If that happened, why didn't you contact me earlier!?'

Miyagawa's fist slammed down onto the desk .

In contrast to Miyagawa's anger, Ishii welled up with happiness . Miyagawa really was whom Ishii believed him to be . No matter what Miyagawa said, he wasn't the type of person who could leave something alone .

'What are you grinning for?'

Ishii quickly corrected his expression .

'I'm sorry . '

'So what did you find out?'

'Ah, yes . There are a number of parts . '

Ishii handed the documents he had borrowed from Shimamura yesterday to Miyagawa . After Miyagawa accepted them, he started reading them with a stern face .

– He might give me a new opinion .

Ishii looked at Miyagawa with hope .

'If I had to make a decision from this situation, it has to be a suicide . '

Miyagawa threw the files onto the desk .

'Looking at it from the situation, that is the case . However...'

Ishii had thought frantically last night as he stared at the files .

The flat had been locked . It didn't look like anybody had fiddled with it . That room had been completely shut off .

However, Ishii still couldn't shake away his suspicions .

'The reason for suicide isn't that strong,' said Miyagawa .

It was just as he said . That was the biggest reason for Ishii's doubt .

'Yes . '

Imoto had attempted a robbery and ended up in a confrontation . He had punched Aoi Yuuka . That had caused her serious injury, and Imoto had committed suicide in his guilt –

At first glance, it lined up, but he must have known in the first place that it was likely that somebody would be harmed in a robbery .

Furthermore, Ishii would have understood Imoto's guilt if Yuuka had died, but she was still alive . Also, the police's investigation hadn't reached Imoto . In short, he hadn't been pursued .

– Would he have thought as far as suicide in that situation?

The investigation team had had doubts about that too . That was why they had questioned Aoi Hideaki, thinking he had killed Imoto for revenge .

'But there's no evidence anywhere that it was a murder . '

'There isn't . '

Ishii had doubts, but he had returned to the same place .

'In any case, Aoi Hideaki has the key to this,' muttered Miyagawa .

'Yes . '

Was Hideaki's ability real or fake – the answer to that question would change the direction of the case .

'So what do you plan to do?'

'I was thinking of looking at the scene once more . '

He had no proof that he would find something, but perhaps he would see something by going there once more . However –

'Got it . Then the guards there will be in the way . '

Miyagawa smirked, like he had read Ishii's mind .

9

Eishin stood in front of Yakumo's secret hideaway, the Movie Research Circle room .

He was here to report on what happened yesterday and to move Gotou .

When he opened the door, he saw Yakumo, Haruka, and one other woman there .

'Oh?' said Eishin .

'Come to think of it, it's the first time you've met . This woman is Hijikata Makoto-san . She's a newspaper reporter . She's helping out with a variety of things,' explained Yakumo, sensing Eishin's question .

'My name is Hijikata Makoto . '

Makoto stood up and made a polite bow .

She had a refined air to her and was a woman with polite manners . Haruka, and then Makoto – why did beautiful women gather around Yakumo?

'My name is Eishin . I am pleased to make your acquaintance . '

Eishin returned the bow .

'Please sit down,' Yakumo urged . Eishin took the seat next to Makoto .

After a pause, he spotted Gotou in the corner of the room . He was in a wheelchair, completely still .

'Is he alive?'

'So far as it goes,' replied Yakumo, giving Gotou a glance .

When Eishin looked more carefully, he could see Gotou's shoulders moving up and down slightly . It was strange for a man who was like walking noise to be quiet like this .

'So how was it?'

Yakumo turned his gaze towards Eishin .

That was right . Eishin almost forgot . Eishin told them what he had heard from Hiroki yesterday .

He kept the little threat he made a secret .

'A video camera...'

As expected, Yakumo showed interest in that .

Eishin didn't know if it'd be useful, but he wanted to see himself .

'Excuse me... Perhaps I would be able to acquire it . '

Makoto was the one who spoke, raising a hand .

'Is that so?' asked Yakumo .

Makoto nodded .

'Yes . I can't guarantee it, but...'

'Could I request that of you?'

'Yes, I'll try . '

A refreshing smile appeared on Makoto's face .

'Hey, what are you going to do next?'

After the conversation came to a lull, Haruka looked at Yakumo .

'We're moving Kumakichi, right?'

Eishin responded for Yakumo .

'Ah, right . You're taking him to Hata-san, right?' said Haruka, who had heard about it before .

However, Yakumo contradicted that .

'Let's change the plan a bit . '

'What are you talking about?' said Eishin in dissatisfaction .

He had gone out of his way to borrow a HiAce[2] with a lift from somebody with a job related to social welfare .

If the plan was changed, all his hard work would be for nothing .

'We'll just be making a number of stopovers . '

Yakumo slowly stood up .

There was a daring smile on his face . It felt like he was planning something dastardly .

However, Eishin didn't dislike that sort of thing .

'Where're we headed?'

'A number of places,' Yakumo replied vaguely .

– I don't get it, but it feels like it'll get interesting .

Eishin felt unbecoming expectation well up within him .

10

Ishii went with Miyagawa to the apartment where the incident had occurred .

Ishii could see that there was a rope in front of the room barring access and one uniformed guard on watch .

'There is a guard, as expected,' said Ishii, feeling disappointed .

It was possible to go through the front and show their police IDs to gain access, but Ishii and Miyagawa had been taken off the investigation .

If the guard checked with the investigation team, that would make things troublesome afterwards .

'Leave it to me . '

Miyagawa hit his chest and then walked straight for the door .

'Wait, Miyagawa-san!' said Ishii, running after Miyagawa .

'I'm Miyagawa from Criminal Affairs,' said Miyagawa with a hard expression on his face . He placed a hand on the guard's shoulder .

'Ah...'

'Actually, I want to go inside to check it out . '

'I wouldn't mind, but...'

'I know . Honda told you not to let people in without his permission, right?'

'Yes, well...'

'That's why I'm asking you in private . '

Miyagawa suddenly brought his face closer to the guard's .

'But...'

'Did you become an officer to be Honda's dog? Or to protect the safety of the citizens?'

'Of course it was for the safety of the citizens,' responded the guard clearly, eyes shining .

'Then go along with that conviction . '

The guard, completely pulled in by Miyagawa's cajolery, handed over the key to Miyagawa .

That was definitely consent to let them in .

Ishii and Miyagawa nodded at each other . Then, they opened the door and went inside .

There was a sink and a washroom in the narrow corridor . It looked like there was a bathtub too . That was unusual, these days .

In the back, there was a room as living space, but it was a small space, only four and a half tatami in size .

Though it wasn't unbearable, there was a strange smell . Perhaps because of the food waste around the room or because of the corpse – Ishii couldn't tell .

He held his breath as he looked around the room carefully . There was a gap in the wood above the door that would allow a rope through, and there was a mark there from friction . Imoto had probably put the rope here and hanged himself . There was a stain on the tatami below .

'Urgh...'

The image of Imoto hanging in the room came up in Ishii's mind . Ishii shut his eyes and shook his head to get rid of the image .

The glass door to the veranda was broken from the outside .

Ishii and Miyagawa had done that . At the time, they had stuck a hand through to unlock the door .

The glass door had been shut, if he remembered correctly .

Ishii looked towards the entrance . That had been locked too, and there had been a chain lock too .

This room really was a locked room –

The only place to get out would be the hole for the vent in the room's wall . Ishii had seen a movie where a liquid-metal robot had slipped in through a gap like that, but that was unrealistic .

– So there's really nothing?

Ishii was about to give up when his eyes fell on a photo in the corner of the room .

He crouched and picked it up .

It was a photo of a family . On the left of the photo, there was Imoto Yasuo . In the centre, there was a child of about two years old . On the right, there was a woman with a gentle smile .

– Why is there a photo here?

Ishii tried standing underneath the wood when Imoto had hanged himself .

He thought about Imoto's state of mind . Then, Ishii realised it .

Imoto had probably been looking at this photo when he hanged himself .

Then, he ran out of breath, so the photo slipped from his hand, falling into the corner of the room . He might have really been prepared to kill himself .

That thought grew stronger within Ishii .

'Where are we?' asked Haruka, looking up at the ten-storey apartment building . It seemed to be built for families, and was rather large from the outward appearance .

– Make a number of stopovers .

Yakumo had said that . Then, he had had Eishin and Gotou wait in the car and come to this apartment .

'This is where the Aoi siblings live . '

Yakumo slowly walked towards the apartment .

'So for your stopover, you were going to meet Hideaki-san?'

'Yes . '

'But that person...'

Yesterday, the police had come and taken him away . Would he have been let out so easily?

'He wasn't arrested . He had agreed to questioning . Since it hadn't been forced, he was probably let out a while ago . '

Yakumo ran a hand through his messy hair and pressed the intercom button .

<Yes . >

Hideaki's voice came back immediately .

'It's Saitou Yakumo . I was thinking about talking with you for a bit . '

<I'll open the door now . >

The automatic doors opened .

With an anxious expression, Haruka followed Yakumo through the automatic doors .

They went through the entrance and into the elevator, where Yakumo pressed the button for the third floor .

'What are you going to talk to Hideaki-san about?' asked Haruka .

'I didn't think about it...' Yakumo replied briefly . Then, he fell silent .

His expression was unusually stiff .

Finally, the elevator reached the third floor . They went down the corridor to the door to the room at the very end . With good timing, Hideaki opened the door and looked out .

'It's the first time you've come, Saitou,' said Hideaki with a smile, inviting Yakumo and Haruka into the room .

They went past the entrance to the room at the end of the corridor . It was a living-cum-dining room ten tatami in size, with a kitchen counter . It had a relaxing atmosphere to it .

'Please sit . '

Hideaki urged them to sit at the dining table .

Haruka and Yakumo sat down together . Hideaki sat opposite them .

'It's a large room,' said Yakumo while looking around .

'Mum and Dad left this to us . Thanks to that, I didn't have any trouble looking for a place to live with my sister . '

Hideaki was smiling as he glanced at the sideboard .

There were photos there . In the photos, Hideaki and Yuuka, and people who were probably their parents, were smiling .

They were peaceful and happy family photos .

'Where are your mother and father?' Haruka said without thinking, and that moment, Hideaki's expression clouded over .

In that instant, Haruka thought – Shoot . Earlier, Hideaki had said, 'Mum and Dad left this to us . ' She should have been able to realise from those words .

'I-I'm sorry...'

Haruka bowed her head, but Hideaki shook his head with a smile .

'It's fine . My mum and dad passed away four and a half years ago . It was a traffic accident...'

'Is that so...'

Haruka dropped her gaze to the table .

Hideaki and Yuuka had lived alone after losing their parents . On top of that, Yuuka had been wrapped up in this case .

When she thought about that, it was intolerable .

'So what did you come here for today all of a sudden?'

After a pause, Hideaki turned his eyes to Yakumo .

'It seems like it's been tough...' said Yakumo, sitting in front of Hideaki .

'That's not true . '

It wasn't just the matter with his sister, Yuuka . He had been questioned by the police too . It must have been tough, but Hideaki was showing them a smile .

Haruka couldn't tell whether he was putting up a strong front or if he was just a strong person .

'What were you asked by the police?'

'He asked why I knew the person who assaulted Yuuka . '

'How did you respond?'

'I said I could see ghosts . '

Hideaki didn't falter when he said that .

'The police didn't believe you, right?'

'They didn't . They kept asking the same question, but since it was the truth, I couldn't say anything else . '

Hideaki smiled wryly .

'A stubborn guy,' said Yakumo, more to himself, and then he got up from his seat .

He looked around the room and stopped by the sofa .

'Your sister collapsed in this room, right?'

'Yeah . '

Hideaki nodded and stood up . Then, he stood by Yakumo and looked at the floor .

He was probably remembering the incident . Hideaki's brown eyes looked like they were wet with tears .

'The culprit wasn't caught on the security cameras?'

'According to the police, the data was wiped . '

'I see...'

Yakumo's brow furrowed just slightly .

'Hey, do you remember?' Hideaki said suddenly .

'What?'

Yakumo looked at Hideaki with a bewildered expression .

'You saved Yuuka in high school, right, Saitou?'

'I don't remember . '

Yakumo looked away .

Perhaps it was a topic he didn't want others to touch .

'Don't try to hide it . Yuuka was caught up in a case . Because of that case, I realised that you could see ghosts . '

Hideaki walked to where Yakumo was now looking . Yakumo's expression was blank, like he couldn't hear him at all .

What could the case be – Haruka was curious, but she felt like she definitely couldn't ask .

'It's not like I was trying to save her . That just happened as a result . '

After a long silence, those words came out of Yakumo's mouth, like that had been strangled out .

'That's what I thought at first too . At school, Saitou, you never showed any interest in anyone else, and I thought you were really cold guy . '

'Just as you say, I'm a cold person . '

'That's not true . '

When Hideaki denied Yakumo's words, his tone changed – it was firm .

'It is . '

'It's not . Do you remember our conversation in the graveyard?'

'Did that happen...'

'At the time, Saitou, you said that even if you could see ghosts, you couldn't save anyone . But that's not true . Saitou, you're kinder than anyone else . That's why you suffer . Because you don't want to lose your friends, you didn't make them in the first place . I realised that . That's why...'

'That's enough about me,' said Yakumo in a voice that wouldn't allow any discussion, interrupting Hideaki .

Their gazes met . It felt like sparks would fly .

Haruka didn't know Yakumo in high school, but she thought that Hideaki's opinion was correct .

The reason for that was that Haruka had also thought the same way when she first met Yakumo . Yakumo wasn't a cold person . He was kinder and more sensitive than anyone .

Haruka's opinion of Hideaki had changed greatly .

The two of them might not have been friends in high school . They might not have talked . But still, Hideaki tried to understand Yakumo . He was one of very few .

Rather than being interested in Yakumo because they shared the ability to see ghosts, it was more like Hideaki had looked at Yakumo as a person .

'A stubborn guy . '

After looking at Yakumo for a while, Hideaki's expression suddenly softened .

'Me?'

'Yeah . That hasn't changed . '

'We weren't that close . '

'I could tell just from looking . '

Hideaki smiled .

'Sorry for coming over suddenly today . I'll come again . '

Saying just that, Yakumo suddenly left the room .

– Eh, no way!

'E-excuse me . '

Haruka didn't want to be left here alone . She bowed towards Hideaki and hurriedly ran after Yakumo .

She finally caught up to him in front of the elevator .

– What's the hurry?

Haruka was about to ask when Yakumo turned around .

'I feel like I saw the truth, just slightly . '

'The truth?'

'Yeah . What his sister wanted to save...'

Yakumo's narrowed red left eye probably saw something that Haruka didn't understand .

12

– I got wrapped up in a case unexpectedly .

After Makoto returned to the newspaper company and sat at her own seat, that thought came to her .

She was the most concerned about Gotou . Makoto had been possessed by a spirit before .

She felt a chill when she recalled that time, even now .

Feelings of somebody who wasn't her had flown through her, seeping into her heart . It was more terrifying than could be imagined .

– I want to save him, no matter what .

With strong determination, Makoto took her mobile and called the number of her old co-worker, Takizawa .

He was currently at a newspaper that dealt with Yamanashi, but he had been at the same company as Makoto before .

He had given her a variety of information during a certain case . Fortunately for her, he was at a Yamanashi newspaper company now .

<What, it's you?>

When Makoto said her name, she heard a sigh from the other end .

It wasn't unreasonable for him to have that reaction . She had called him last night too to get information .

The information she had given Yakumo this morning had all been from Takizawa .

'I'm sorry for calling again . '

<What do you want this time?>

'I heard that the young man who found the corpse had been filming the scene with a video camera . '

<Ah, that?>

Takizawa sounded exhausted .

'Do you know of it?'

<Yeah . There was a local detective there . He showed me it in private, but it had been pretty creepy . >

'Creepy?'

<Yeah . You're pretty knowledgeable about spiritual stuff, right?>

To be accurate, Yakumo was the one who was knowledgeable .

However, because Makoto had been involved in many incidents of that kind, she was now known within the company as a reporter who was knowledgeable about spiritual phenomena .

'Though I'm not that knowledgeable... Was something filmed there?'

<Filmed there, eh... . Anyway, that detective had been pretty afraid . Since it was from a rising religious group, the detective thought there might be a curse . >

'A... curse?'

<Anyway, I'll send the data, so once you've checked it out, I want your opinion . >

'Understood,' responded Makoto . Then, she hung up .

She had thought it'd be difficult to get the video, so this was a bit underwhelming .

After she took a break, she suddenly thought about Ishii .

He had seemed rather depressed about the incident with Gotou yesterday . Makoto picked up her phone and called Ishii's number .

<Hello, Ishii Yuutarou speaking . >

She heard a more cheerful voice than she had expected from the phone .

'It's Hijikata . '

<Ah, Makoto-san . >

'You seemed down yesterday, so I was wondering... if you were OK...'

<I'm fine . I'll do anything to save Detective Gotou . I don't have the time to be depressed . >

Makoto felt happy for some reason when she heard Ishii's energetic voice .

When they first met, she had thought that he was an unreliable person, but after getting to know him, she came to understand that he was a kind person .

She felt like he seemed more confident lately .

'That's great . Please continue to work hard . I'll help as much as I can . '

<Thank you very much . >

'Then...'

<Excuse me!>

As Makoto was about to hang up, Ishii called out to stop her .

'Yes?'

'I didn't do...'

<No, it was thanks to you, Makoto-san . >

'Then maybe I'll have you thank me somehow next time . '

<Please ask anything of me . >

'Then a date . '

When Makoto said that as a joke, Ishii became speechless on the other side of the phone .

The image of an red-faced Ishii, stock still, appeared in Makoto's mind . She thought that side of him was cute .

– Maybe that's tasteless of me .

As she thought that, Makoto said, 'I'm looking forward to it . ' She hung up .

When did she start thinking of Ishii as somebody of the opposite gender – she wasn't sure . At some point, she had become attracted to him .

To be honest, Makoto liked men who pulled her in . Ishii was the complete opposite .

– So why?

Makoto asked herself that in her heart . She couldn't come up with an answer .

Mysteriously, she enjoyed not understanding .

13

'Let's visit Imoto's ex-wife,' Ishii suggested to Miyagawa .

At first, Miyagawa didn't look that pleased . It was because he had already gone to question her .

As a result, it was proven that she had an alibi for the date of the incident and that they hadn't kept in contact after the divorce . Miyagawa probably didn't think that going to talk to her again would get them any new information .

Ishii couldn't deny that, but he still wanted to meet her .

Putting what the wife thought aside, Imoto had thought about the family he had lost in his last moments .

He must have felt something special then .

Because of Ishii's needling, Miyagawa folded in the end .

Imoto's wife lived in a residential area two stations away .

Ishii stood in front of the door and pressed the intercom button . Then, a girl of about seven – probably Imoto's daughter – showed up .

'Excuse me, is your mother here?' asked Ishii, but she had already gone inside .

After a while, a woman in her late thirties opened the door . She was probably Manami, Imoto's ex-wife .

'Who might you be?'

She was clearly on guard .

'Excuse me, my name is Ishii . I'm from the Setamachi precinct . '

'It's Miyagawa . '

'You came yesterday as well, didn't you? I've already told you about him...'

I'm sick of this already – it was evident she felt that way . However, Ishii couldn't back down here .

'I'm sorry, but we would like to hear you once more . '

Ishii bowed from his waist .

There was no response .

'Please . When Imoto-san died, he had been looking at a photo . It was a photo with you,' Ishii said quickly, head still bowed .

'That doesn't matter . '

Manami tried to close the door, but Miyagawa held it open with his hand .

'Even if it doesn't matter to you, it mattered to Imoto, who's dead now . '

'I...'

'Even a little is fine . Talk to us . '

For a while, the two of them looked at each other, but finally Manami said, 'Please come in,' her voice as quiet as a mosquito . Perhaps she had lost to Miyagawa's stare .

Ishii looked at Miyagawa and then entered the room .

it was a 2DK . They went to a six-tatami room in the back . Ishii and Miyagawa sat opposite Manami at a table .

She didn't put out cushions or tea . She probably wanted them to leave quickly .

'What do you want to know?' Manami said quietly, looking at her lap .

'What was the reason for your divorce?'

That was what Ishii asked first .

Since Imoto had taken great care of his family photo, Ishii knew that he hadn't wanted the divorce .

'His mother got cancer . '

'Cancer?'

'Yes . She suffered quite a bit . Then, somehow he got solicited into a strange religious group . '

'Solicited...?'

'They said that his mother's sickness would be cured if he gave them offerings . Things like that...'

'I see . '

Ishii heard about things of the like often .

'He even took out loans to give money to that group . Meanwhile, loan sharks started coming to our home...'

'I see... And how about his mother?'

'She died . '

For a moment, Manami's eyes seemed blurry with anger .

She must have known that her mother-in-law wasn't at fault, but she had to point her anger there .

'I see . '

'I thought that would wake him up, but... the group told him they needed money because his mother would suffer even after death... If that continued, my daughter might... That's what I thought, so I divorced him . '

Manami sniffled .

Ishii understood painfully how she felt . He decided to change the question .

'Excuse me, but did you really not have any contact from him before he died?'

Imoto had had a photo of his family at the time of his death . If he thought of them so dearly, he must have wanted to talk to them before he died .

'I didn't . '

Manami looked away .

– She's lying .

Ishii felt that instantly .

'Really?'

Miyagawa seemed to have sensed the same thing as he pressed Manami for an answer .

Ishii thought about pressing forward too, but before he could, he saw a letter case on the wall .

Though it was in the middle of the conversation, Ishii stood up, as if drawn towards it .

'A letter came, didn't it,' said Ishii . Manami's shoulders shuddered .

Ishii could see a man's handwriting on a letter in the letter case . Though he didn't know who the man was, it was obvious from the reaction .

'He's such an idiot...'

Manami looked down, biting her lower lip .

'What are you talking about?' asked Miyagawa .

When Manami looked up again, her eyes were red .

'There was a letter . '

'What did he write?'

Though Ishii could have found out by reaching out and looking inside the envelope, he felt like he shouldn't touch it .

'I couldn't do anything up until now . Take this in exchange for child support... His life insurance certificate was inside . '

'Life insurance...'

'He didn't pay consolation money or child support after the divorce . He couldn't have . He was troubled by his own loans...'

'Is that so...'

'But you won't get any money from killing yourself right after signing up for life insurance... He really is an idiot...'

Manami shook her head .

Tears fell from her eyes –

Ishii couldn't look at her face, so he averted his eyes .

Just as Manami said, even if he did have insurance, if he killed himself within the exemption term, he wouldn't receive the money .

And yet he had gone out of his way to send his life insurance certificate to his ex-wife .

– Why?

A new question came up in Ishii's mind .

14

'Are you really going?' asked Haruka, standing next to Yakumo .

After leaving Hideaki, Yakumo had said that they were going to go to Jikoukoushinkai's main base . Then, they had gone up a small hill that was about fifteen minutes from the station by car .

'Of course . '

Yakumo was expressionless as he looked up at the temple in front of him .

This temple was Jikoukoushinkai's headquarters . It seemed they had purchased a temple that had once belonged to another religion .

Perhaps it was prejudice, but since it was the headquarters of a new religious group, it felt creepy .

'Am I going too?' said Eishin, taking Gotou's wheelchair out of the car .

'That's the plan,' Yakumo said nonchalantly, but Eishin looked troubled .

'In these clothes?'

Eishin spread his arms and looked at his own monk's robes .

Haruka did feel like that would be a problem . They were going to meet a rising religious group . It was like going to a church in monk's robes .

However, Yakumo's expression still didn't change .

'Won't it be interesting to see their reactions when you go there in those clothes?'

It was like Yakumo was enjoying this . Haruka thought that Eishin would object, but then he agreed with a smile .

– I have a bad feeling about this .

Ignoring Haruka's concern, Yakumo pressed the intercom button by the door .

<Yes . >

A woman's voice responded immediately from the intercom .

'Actually, I came because I want to consult your founder . '

<What is your business?>

'One of my friends has been possessed by a ghost . Just as I was bewildered about what to do, I heard a rumour about your founder . I thought that the founder might save my friend . '

Yakumo's explanation made it sound like he was at his wits' end .

This always happened, but Haruka admired Yakumo for being able to lie so easily about something like this . Yakumo was probably the type that would never be found out even if he cheated on his partner .

<That must be of great concern to you . Please enter . >

When the intercom cut off, the door opened automatically .

'That was a pretty good response . '

Eishin seemed like he was enjoying himself a lot .

First, Eishin pushed Gotou's wheelchair through the door, and then Yakumo and Haruka went in after them .

'Please follow me . '

A woman called out to them . She wore white hakama and a black sash that had a red Brahma on it . Her clothes were reminiscent of a mountain priest's . Her fringe rested on her forehead and she wore glasses . She was so expressionless that it was creepy – she seemed rather shady .

She led them down a promenade .

'Nothing ventured...' said Eishin to himself as he followed .

'We're going . '

'Ah, right . '

At Yakumo's urging, Haruka hurriedly followed .

After reaching the building's entrance, she took a quick look around . Just as the door closed .

– Will we be able to go back?

That question flashed through Haruka's mind .

They were led into the building into a large room with wooden flooring . A unique smell like that of incense filled the room .

The ceiling was about five metres tall . There was an altar at the back of the room with a statue of Acala, sitting .

In the centre of the room, there was a large metal object that seemed like a box, surrounded by four pillars which were bound with a shimenawa .

'Hey, what's that?' Haruka asked Yakumo, pointing at the box in the centre of the room .

'That's a homa-mandala . '

Eishin was the one who responded .

'Homa-mandala?'

Even after hearing the name, Haruka didn't understand what it was .

'It's used during Shugendo cedar-burning exorcisms . The shimenawa is the boundary . '

'You know about it in detail . '

'It's my job . '

Eishin smiled proudly and then continued .

'Also, during the Meiji period, Shugendo was forbidden . Then, the people who practised Shugen had to either join a Buddhist sect which shared their world view or abandon their teachers to become Shinto priests . '

'Oh?'

After Haruka expressed how impressed she was by Eishin's explanation, a woman in white hakama and a sash with a red Brahma came into the room .

She was probably in her forties . She was as beautiful as a Japanese doll .

– Shiiing .

The khakkhara in the woman's hand rang .

'Though Shugendo was abandoned once, I now carry the teachings that had travelled down by mouth . '

The woman's voice was cool, not sharpened by the sound of the khakkhara .

'Who are you?' asked Yakumo .

'I apologise for the late introduction . My name is Minegishi Kyouka . '

Kyouka gave her name and slowly bowed .

Each of her actions was graceful and beautiful . It was like watching a dance .

'My name is Saitou Yakumo . This is Master Eishin . And she's an assistant .',

Yakumo introduced all of them .

'Why is a Buddhist master in a place like this?'

Kyouka looked at Eishin .

Her response made sense . Eishin had thought that from the beginning .

'I only came to be sure . Please don't let it concern you,' replied Eishin, puffing out his chest .

'To be sure of what?'

'To be sure that this wasn't a cult or something . '

Eishin was clearly provoking her .

However, Kyouka's expression did not change at all .

'Why would you say this is a cult?'

'I don't have to say it . I hear this group asks for a lot of money for fake exorcisms . '

'You are saying that we do...?'

'Yes . '

When Eishin nodded, Kyouka covered her mouth and laughed .

'What's so funny?' asked Eishin, astonished .

'We have never forced anyone to make offerings . Everyone gives offerings because they want to . '

'It's the same thing . '

'If what we do is a crime, what you do is the same, Master Eishin,' said Kyouka, still smiling .

'What are you talking about?'

'Don't Buddhist temples also accept offerings from families? We are no different from you, Master Eishin . '

'Wha – '

Eishin bit his lip .

Kyouka had easily deceived Eishin into believing her . She had quite a way with words .

– What are you going to do?

When Haruka looked at Yakumo, for just a moment, he was smiling .

'I apologise . Please forgive our rudeness . '

Yakumo slowly bowed his head .

'I am accustomed to it . Please do not concern yourself . '

Kyouka smiled at him .

'Though this is sudden, I have a request . I would like you to exorcise the spirit from the pitiful man who has been possessed by a ghost,' Yakumo said fluently, pointing at Gotou, who was in a wheelchair .

Shiiing .

The khakkhara rang .

'You are trying to test me, are you not?'

Kyouka slowly walked towards Gotou and murmured that .

'What do you mean?' asked Yakumo .

Kyouka turned towards Yakumo and looked at his face .

'That eye . You can see as well, can't you,' Kyouka said quietly .

15

Ishii stopped at the station gates .

It was because he had spotted a sign for a life insurance company . The sign had a pure and innocent actress smiling on it . Ishii often saw her on

television .

Though he normally didn't notice it, because of what happened earlier, his eyes were drawn there .

'Is this your type?'

Miyagawa stopped as well and looked at the sign .

Though the actress was beautiful, that wasn't what caught Ishii's eye .

'Ah, no, that isn't it... I was just wondering... why Imoto got insurance...'

'Didn't he just want to leave his money to his wife and kid since he caused them trouble?'

'But he committed suicide...'

'He probably didn't know that he wouldn't get money if he committed suicide . '

Manami had seemed to think the same way, but Ishii couldn't accept that simple answer .

'They're supposed to explain that money isn't given out for suicides when you get insurance . '

'The insurance company probably forgot . '

That was possible, but –

'If he wanted to leave his insurance money to his wife and daughter, he should have checked that . '

'Well, that's true...'

Miyagawa cocked his head, scratching his chin .

'But he still killed himself...'

It just seemed off to Ishii .

Something was wrong . But he didn't know what that something was . Not knowing irritated him .

'Maybe the insurance and suicide were separate?' said Miyagawa, frowning as he stuck his hands in his pockets .

'Eh?'

'Like... he just happened to be solicited and signed up for insurance . After that, he committed a robbery and decided to kill himself . '

It sounded plausible, but there was a hole in that line of thinking .

'He had borrowed a lot of money . Would he pay for expensive insurance just because he was asked to?'

'That's...'

Miyagawa was lost for words .

Imoto didn't have the money to join insurance, but he still did . Then, he sent that certificate to his wife, Manami .

There must have been a reason here .

Manami's crying face, the last expression she showed Ishii, flashed through his mind . She hadn't wanted money . She hadn't wanted Imoto to die – that was what Ishii thought .

'I wonder why Imoto gave so much money to a religion – to the point that it destroyed his family . '

Ishii said the question exactly as it came to his mind .

If he hadn't joined the religious group, he might have had a different life .

'When people are faced with a reality that they just can't change with their own power, they want to cling to gods,' said Miyagawa with a bitter expression .

'Is that so?'

Perhaps it was because Ishii was an atheist, but he just couldn't understand that feeling .

'I've seen a lot of people go that way . '

'I think they'd realise it was strange when they were tricked into giving away all their money though...'

'They don't think that they're being tricked . That's the magic of religion . '

'But...'

'There was a religious group that committed a terrorist act on the subway before, right?'

'Yes . '

There had been an unprecedented terrorist attack before where poison nerve gas was let out on the subway . It had been planned by a cult .

'Even after that tragedy, the believers still believed in their founder . '

'I do remember that . '

The aforementioned religious group changed their name after the incident and still existed[3] .

It was terrifying .

'It's not just that group . Look at history . How many people do you think have died in the name of a god?'

Miyagawa looked straight at Ishii . His eyes were terribly dark .

Ishii felt himself shudder .

It was just as Miyagawa said . People calmly killed others for the teachings they believed in . Giving away their money to them could even be considered a better method .

'But no matter how much money he paid, the gods didn't save him,' said Miyagawa in a caustic tone .

Putting aside saving altogether, the religion had caused his downfall –

'So what are you going to do?'

Miyagawa's brow furrowed .

At times when they were stuck, they needed to go to the beginning . It would be necessary to confirm whether there was a possibility of murder .

'Let's try asking Hata-san for his opinion . '

'That demon?'

'Yes . '

'Can't say I want to...'

Miyagawa's brow furrowed even deeper .

16

'You can see as well, can't you . '

The moment Kyouka said that, even Yakumo couldn't hide his surprise .

As if scorning Yakumo's reaction, a light smile appeared on Kyouka's face . It was an incredibly coquettish smile .

'What are you talking about?' Eishin asked in Yakumo's stead .

'I mean exactly what I said,' Kyouka said calmly . It made it impossible to answer .

'Just as you say, I can see as well . '

After a silence, Yakumo spoke . The surprise had already disappeared from his face .

It looked like he had managed to get a hold of himself .

'Then you should be able to save this person as well . '

Kyouka gestured at Gotou .

'Unfortunately, all I can do is see spirits . I cannot exorcise them . '

Yakumo looked directly at Kyouka .

After they stared at each other for a while, Kyouka's expression softened .

'Is that so?'

'I heard that you could exorcise spirits, Kyouka-sama . Can I ask that of you?'

Yakumo bowed his head, looking like he had nowhere else to go .

— What a frightening man .

Eishin thought that to himself . Yakumo was good at getting people to go along with him .

When Eishin tried to provoke Kyouka earlier, that was because Yakumo had instructed him to do so in advance . By doing so, she had no place to run, and they were in this situation now .

'I understand . I shall exorcise the spirit possessing this man,' declared Kyouka .

– This'll be worth seeing .

Eishin crossed his arms and looked at Kyouka .

'Thank you very much . '

Yakumo bowed at his waist .

'Preparations for exorcism!' Kyouka said, raising her voice .

'Understood . '

There was a voice from outside the room –

Then, four men who were wearing the clothes of Shugendo, just as Kyouka was, rushed in through the door .

After they moved Gotou in his wheelchair to the centre of the shimenawa barrier, they stepped outside the edges of the barrier .

As Kyouka watched, she made her khakkhara ring .

'Today, in this hall, we come to the mountain for its teachings . '

Kyouka stood in the front, raising her voice .

'Today, in this hall, we come uninvited to perform an exorcism,' the four men chorused .

This unique exchange was that of Shugendo . Kyouka wasn't a complete amateur – it looked like she had some knowledge of the religion .

'Our guides for the exorcism will perform . '

'We receive the command . '

The four men responded to Kyouka's words as well .

– Shiiing .

After Kyouka made the khakkhara ring, she entered the barrier .

Then, fire sprang up from the homa-mandala .

There was no smoke . The homa-mandala probably had a gas burner .

Actually burning wood inside would be bad .

Kyouka, who stood in front of Gotou, closed her eyes and took deep breaths, her shoulders moving as she did so .

She appeared to be gathering her concentration .

After a while, Kyouka suddenly opened her eyes .

– Shiiing . Shiiing .

She made the khakkhara ring .

'Purity of Heaven, purity of Earth, purity of within, purity of the six without...'

Kyouka started to chant[4] .

'The ceremony has been abridged a fair bit,' murmured Yakumo while covering his mouth .

Eishin had noticed that as well .

Though Kyouka had imitated the Shugendou ritual, the contents of it had been rather condensed . However, that wasn't rare .

Rituals became condensed naturally . Even the Buddhist prayers chanted in temples were different than they had been originally – they had been shortened .

'That's how it is,' said Eishin .

'That's true,' replied Yakumo quietly .

Kyouka still continued to chant .

'Purify the Heaven and Earth and within and the six roots of perception that are without – the eyes, the ears, the nose, the tongue, the body, the mind...'

Shiiing, shiiing –

The khakkhara rang .

As if in response, Gotou's body started to shake .

'Yakumo-kun...'

Haruka looked surprised as she tugged on Yakumo's sleeve .

However, this was probably no surprise to Yakumo . He watched silently .

Shiiing –

The khakkhara rang louder and the chanting stopped .

The room fell silent .

'I ask the spirit possessing the man . Who are you?'

With narrowed eyes, Kyouka looked directly at Gotou .

As if to respond, Gotou slowly lifted his head .

'Ah!'

Even Eishin was surprised .

However, Yakumo was as expressionless as always .

'This is not your place . Leave at once . '

Shiiing –

Kyouka made the khakkhara ring .

'Uuurgh...'

Gotou let out a groan . Then, he glared at Kyouka with a sharp gaze .

His eyes were frightening, filled with hatred .

'Guides, perform the kuji[5] . '

'We receive the command . '

The four men responded to Kyouka's words .

'Rin Pyou Tou Sha Kai Chin Retsu Zai Zen[6] . '

In front of Gotou, Kyouka joined the kuji reading and put her hands together in a mudra .

Next, she held up her right hand's index finger and middle finger to form a dagger and cut sideways .

— Shiiing .

The four men rang their khakkharas together .

As if that had been a sign, Gotou slowly stood up, groaning as he did so .

It felt like he might attack Kyouka at any moment .

'Oi, Yakumo . '

Eishin looked at Yakumo .

However, Yakumo did not move .

'Yakumo-kun...'

Haruka sounded anxious too, but Yakumo was still like a rock .

Could he not move, or did he not dare to? Eishin didn't know .

'You... did...'

With saliva dripping out of his mouth, Gotou held his hands out towards Kyouka .

– Just like before .

That was what Eishin felt . When Gotou was possessed by a spirit in Rina's house, he had assaulted Eishin in the same way .

However, Yakumo didn't move . That wasn't all – Kyouka just stood with a blank expression .

'Youu...'

Gotou put his hands on Kyouka's neck .

'Eishin-san! Please stop Gotou-san,' Yakumo yelled .

Eishin ran at full speed .

He reached out and performed a lariat on Gotou's throat .

Normally, Gotou would probably have fallen on his behind, but as he was possessed by a ghost and couldn't brace himself, he fell, rolling along the floor and smashing into the wall . He stopped moving .

'I might've done a bit too much . '

'In any case, he's alive,' said Yakumo after walking up to Gotou and checking his breathing .

Haruka seemed confused about what had happened – she was just standing there with her mouth wide open .

Even in this situation, Kyouka's expression didn't change at all as she looked at Yakumo .

'That was rather violent . '

'I apologise . I thought that it was a dangerous situation...'

Yakumo returned Kyouka's gaze .

His eyes seemed to let off a sharp light .

17

'It's been a while . '

Ishii and Miyagawa went to Hata's room, in the basement of the hospital .

There were no windows . Cabinets lined the walls . The room felt oppressive and suffocating .

However, Hata didn't seem to care at all as he sipped his tea lazily .

'Ishii-kun? And... who was this again?'

Hata cocked his head and looked at Miyagawa .

'Miyagawa . '

'Ah, that's right . Boiled Octopus-kun, right . '

'Old man, you're saying that on purpose, aren't you!'

Miyagawa was angry, but Hata just let out a creepy giggle .

A strange person, as usual –

'So what do the both of you want?' asked Hata, the creepy smile still on his face .

'Actually, we're here about the corpse of the person who committed suicide that was found the other day...'

When Ishii said that, Hata replied, 'Ah, that?'

'I'll ask directly . Is it possible that the corpse was murdered?' asked Ishii .

Hata crossed his arms . 'Hm . '

'So, was it?' Miyagawa urged .

Perhaps Hata didn't like that, as his eyes flashed open to glare at Miyagawa .

'It must be tough for you, Ishii-kun . '

'What must be tough for me?'

'A boiled octopus after a bear . You must be unable to bear being paired up with idiots one after another . '

'Er...'

The question was difficult to answer .

'Stop fooling around already, you demonic old man,' threatened Miyagawa . However, Hata ignored that and handed Ishii the documents .

Ishii took the documents and flipped through the pages .

Suddenly, a photo of the dead Imoto appeared in front of him . He looked away unconsciously .

'The cause of death was most definitely suffocation . There are no external wounds . No signs of drugs . There were no points of pressure besides the rope wrapped around his neck,' Hata explained disinterestedly .

'So... it really was a suicide . '

'I'm just saying the facts . '

'Which means?'

Ishii cocked his head . He didn't understand Hata's point .

At this stage, it's clear from the situation that it was a suicide – it would be simpler to understand if Hata would just say that .

'You still don't get it?'

'I don't . '

'My job is to determine the job of death . Saying whether it's suicide or murder – that's your job, right?'

'That's...'

That was exactly it, thought Ishii .

Hata just found the facts from the corpse . To look at it a different way, if it was possible to kill Imoto with a rope without using drugs or causing external injuries, it would be a murder .

Perhaps Ishii had just been naive, wanting somebody to decide for him where he should go next .

'Thank you very much . '

Just as Ishii bowed towards Hata, the business phone on top of the desk rang .

Hata answered the phone . After talking for a while, he stood up quickly .

'Did something happen?'

'Wait for a bit . '

After saying that, Hata hurried out of the room .

'The old man just does whatever he wants,' grumbled Miyagawa . Then, he sat down in the seat where Hata had been .

Ishii leant against the wall .

'Hey, is Gotou-san OK?'

Haruka looked at Gotou again .

They had taken Gotou, who had collapsed at Jikoukoushinkai base, straight to the hospital where Hata was at .

Gotou lay on a hospital bed . His forehead was wrapped in gauze . Now, they were waiting for the results of the examination .

'He's probably fine,' said Yakumo, sounding disinterested as he leant against the hospital wall .

He didn't seem anxious at all even though it was such a critical situation .

'Probably, you say...'

'Now, don't be in such a rush,' reprimanded Eishin, sitting on the stool by the bed .

Eishin had been the one who hit Gotou . If Haruka acted worried here, it would make Eishin feel guilty .

Haruka let out a deep breath to calm herself down .

'You're all together . '

Hata came into the hospital room .

He was grinning, like he thought something was funny .

'How is he?' asked Yakumo .

'Unfortunately...'

Hata pursed his lips like he had eating something sour and looked up at the ceiling .

'Eh?'

Haruka couldn't believe it .

Yakumo and Eishin were quiet . The atmosphere in the hospital room was instantly heavier .

'There seems to be nothing wrong with his body . I thought that I'd be able to autopsy him, but I can't . It's unfortunate . '

After saying that, Hata started giggling .

Haruka couldn't laugh at all . The strength left her body all at once, to the point she wanted to collapse to the floor .

'Don't say something so inauspicious,' said Eishin, looking astonished .

'Oh? There's a sea bonze[7] here . '

Hata goggled at Eishin .

'An old man who looks like a dried plum has no right to call someone a sea bonze . '

'You're an old man too, aren't you?'

Hata casually brushed away Eishin's retort and started cackling, which made his throat shake .

It was a strange exchange .

'Thank you very much . '

Interrupting the two of them, Yakumo spoke .

'Don't worry about it . Anyway, Ishii-kun came to visit me . I'll tell him to come here . '

After saying that, Hata left the hospital room .

Haruka was finally able to relax, but she still had questions .

'Hey, what happened to the spirit possessing Gotou?'

'Right now, Gotou-san isn't being possessed by a ghost . '

Yakumo raised his left eyebrow .

Haruka couldn't say anything from shock .

'So that exorcist was the real thing?'

'I can't say anything at this stage . '

'But the ghost isn't possessing Gotou . Doesn't that mean the exorcism succeeded?'

'Are you an idiot?'

'Idiot...'

That was an awful way to put it . Haruka didn't think that she had been so off the mark .

'Explain what you're talking about,' said Eishin .

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair, seeming annoyed . Then, he began .

'It's true that once the exorcist started the exorcism, there was an unusual change to the spirit possessing Gotou . '

'Unusual change...'

Haruka had felt that too .

Gotou's body had started to shake and he had lifted his head, as if to go with the chants .

'Though it looked like the ghost was reacting to her chants, there is another way to look at it . '

'Another way?'

'Got this? The spirit possessing Gotou is a person named Hiyama Kenichirou, who was found in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees . He had been a part of Jikoukoushinkai . '

'I see . '

Eishin showed a nod of understanding, but Haruka didn't understand .

'What are you talking about?'

'To Hiyama-san – the spirit possessing Gotou-san – that place must have had a lot of memories for him . In short, it is possible that he was responding to that . '

'So that's what you meant?'

Yakumo's explanations were always meandering and difficult to understand .

For Hiyama, who was part of the religious group's leadership, that was where he had lived . It could be called his home .

He must have felt a lot there . But –

'Right now, Gotou-san isn't being possessed . '

'That's right . '

'Where did he go?' asked Haruka .

Yakumo's mouth opened .

Haruka swallowed and waited for the answer .

However, the door burst open, thrusting the anxious atmosphere out . Ishii and Miyagawa ran into the room .

'D-Detective Gotou!'

Ishii ran straight for Gotou's bed, like he didn't see anyone else at all .

'What a busy man,' said Eishin, sounding exasperated as he stood up .

'Ishii-san, please calm down a bit,' Yakumo admonished, patting Ishii on the shoulder .

Thanks to that, Ishii came back to his senses .

'I-I'm sorry . Hata-san told me that Detective Gotou was brought here injured, so I...'

Ishii scratched his head, looking incredibly apologetic .

Since it was Hata, he had probably exaggerated the story for his own amusement .

'Please don't worry . I think Gotou-san will wake up soon,' said Yakumo as he picked up a vase on the sideboard casually and took out the flower inside .

'I-is that true?'

'Yes . If you just pour this holy water on him, he'll wake up . '

'Holy water?'

'Yes . Please pour it on his face all at once . '

Yakumo smiled .

— What a poor joke .

Even as Haruka thought that, she silently watched Ishii .

Ishii nodded . He brought the vase close to Gotou's face and emptied it all at once .

Water splashed down onto Gotou's face .

'Damn, that's cold!' yelled Gotou, flying right up .

Then, his eyes met Ishii's .

'Ishii, you bastard – did you do this?'

'Ah, no, this...'

Ishii didn't even have time to explain . Gotou's fist came down on his head .

Even though Haruka had spent the whole day in constant worry, if Gotou was this full of energy, he would be fine .

For some reason, even Ishii, who had been hit, seemed happy as he pressed a hand against his head .

19

'Is that true?'

Makoto was incredibly relieved after hearing Ishii's news over the phone .

<Yes . According to Yakumo-shi, the spirit that had been possessing him has also gone . >

Ishii's voice was as bright as a young boy's .

Sometimes, Ishii showed a childish side like this . To Makoto, this was so cute it was unbearable .

'That solves it then . '

<That...>

Ishii stopped speaking .

'Is there still something else?'

<Yes . According to Yakumo-shi, the incident isn't over...>

'Isn't over?'

<Yes . In the first place, Detective Gotou's possession was just an accident . My original goal was the matter of Imoto-shi's corpse, which was found in his flat . >

'Ah, that's right . '

<I'm ashamed to say it, but I was so happy that I completely forgot about that until Yakumo-shi pointed it out . >

'I'd forgotten as well,' said Makoto while laughing .

Makoto had been the one who said 'That solves it then' earlier . She had been so concerned about Gotou that she had almost forgotten the main problem .

<I have a message from Yakumo-shi requesting that you continue the investigation . >

'I understand . '

usef<Thank you . >

'Ishii-san, please don't forget that you promised me a date . '

Makoto hung up before Ishii responded .

She felt that it was a bit mean of her, but if she didn't do this, she didn't think Ishii would invite her, since he was so shy .

She looked at the computer again, and with good timing, she saw an email from Takizawa .

<I've attached the video . Please take a look at it . >

It was a short email . The attached video was a WMP file . It was probably the video taken in the Sea of Trees .

Makoto used the mouse to play the video .

The video was the Sea of Trees one, as Makoto thought . For a while, the video continued silently through the forest .

Makoto had gone to Aokigahara's Sea of Trees before, just once . At the time, she had just been going on a determined hiking route, so she hadn't run into anything inexplicable .

However, the further the video went in, the dimmer and eerier it became .

Though it was famous for suicides, why would somebody want to die here – Makoto didn't understand .

With the mouse, Makoto fast-forwarded the video and started playing just as the video changed .

<I don't care any more . Let's go back . >

The woman with the man taking the video was complaining .

The video zoomed in on her . She looked irritated by that, since she ran off .

<Hey, wait...>

Makoto heard the voice of the man holding the camera .

The camera stayed there for a while as the man grumbled, but finally, the camera followed the woman who had left .

Then, a shriek rang through the forest .

<What was that?>

After murmuring that, the man holding the camera ran towards the direction where the shriek came from .

He seemed in a hurry, as the camera was shaking violently and was pointing straight up .

Finally, the camera landed on the woman, who had fainted, and a burnt corpse .

<You OK?>

As the man said that, he threw the camera aside .

The camera fell to the ground and continued to film at an angle .

For a moment, something passed by –

'Eh?'

Makoto rewound a bit to check again .

– Here .

Makoto stopped the video at the moment that something passed by .

A chill ran down her spine . The video was showing somebody Makoto knew .

20

'So I was possessed by a ghost...'

Gotou hung his head on top of the bed .

After Yakumo, Haruka and Eishin explained, Gotou understood what had happened to him .

He could remember clearly up until he answered the phone, but his memories after that were vague and patchy .

He had never thought that he would be possessed .

'In any case, I'm glad . '

'I'm not glad . Because of Gotou-san's disdainful actions, we were pulled around in a dozen different directions . '

In contrast to Haruka's smile, Yakumo appeared displeased .

'My bad . '

Gotou bowed his head honestly, which made Yakumo look away awkwardly .

'So, Gotou-san, could you tell us what you remember?' said Yakumo after clearing his throat .

'What I remember?'

'Yes . Just as it was with Makoto-san, people are filled with an image of the person possessing them while they're being possessed . '

Come to think of it, that was right .

When Makoto was being possessed by a ghost, the ghost's attachment to life had flowed through her .

Gotou looked up at the ceiling and thought about it . Then, images buried away in his memory started to come back to him slowly .

'A dark forest... A man in a mountain priest's clothes...'

Gotou said exactly what came to his mind .

'A... mountain priest?'

Yakumo's brow furrowed .

'Yeah . I couldn't see the face, but that guy lit a fire in the forest...'

'Wouldn't that be that religious group?' Haruka said excitedly .

'What?'

Gotou didn't understand what 'that religious group' was supposed to be .

'It'll take too long to talk about it,' Yakumo said, cutting the conversation short, but there was no way Gotou would accept that .

'Just explain,' Gotou said .

Yakumo shook his head, looking fed up, and said to Haruka, 'I'll leave it to you . '

'Honestly,' said Haruka, pouting, but she still explained in detail about the religious group called Jikoukoushinkai .

'In short, Minegishi or whatever founder person exorcised the spirit for me...'

'Why would you think that?'

Yakumo looked at Gotou with scorn .

'I'm wrong?'

'You're wrong,' Yakumo said firmly .

'Then...'

'That's the end of the conversation . More importantly, do you remember anything else?'

Ignoring Gotou's dissatisfaction, Yakumo urged him to continue .

Gotou clicked his tongue, but he looked through his memories again . Then, he recalled one word .

'Sorry...'

'What do you mean?'

Yakumo cocked his head .

However, Gotou had no way to answer, since those weren't words that he said .

'I heard that in my head . Sorry . '

'Sorry . '

Yakumo put a finger to his brow as he repeated the word .

– Can you think of anything?

Just as Gotou wanted to ask that, the hospital room door opened . Nao and Atsuko had arrived .

The moment Nao saw Gotou, she jumped on top of the bed and hugged him .

'Sorry for worrying you . '

Gotou patted Nao on her head .

'Honestly . You get into scrapes like this because you don't think before acting,' said Atsuko by the bed .

Though her tone was angry, her expression was gentle .

– I got back safely .

Gotou finally felt that .

'Please take your time to rest,' said Yakumo . Then, he and Haruka left the room .

To be honest, Gotou felt completely fine . He could get to work right away, but he decided to do as Yakumo said .

'Sorry...'

Gotou spoke in his own words to Atsuko and Nao .

When Eishin saw that, he smiled approvingly .

21

After the call with Makoto, Ishii called Shimamura to get information about the case for Hiyama Kenichirou, the corpse found in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees .

Since Jikoukoushinkai's main base was under the Setamachi precinct's jurisdiction, they were currently cooperating with the Yamanashi precinct . Come to think of it, Shimamura had been grumbling yesterday .

After telling Shimamura what he needed in brief, they decided to meet at a cafe near the hospital, since Shimamura was out .

'Why do you need to investigate the Aokigahara case?' said Miyagawa unpleasantly as he sat next to Ishii in the cafe .

'It's connected to the current case,' Ishii said firmly, but that wasn't his own opinion . Yakumo had said it – their cases are connected .

Yakumo had instructed him to gather information about the investigation .

Without any clues, all Ishii could do right now was believe in Yakumo and follow his instructions .

'No helping it . I'll come with you,' grumbled Miyagawa, lighting his cigarette .

No matter what Miyagawa said, he accompanied Ishii . Ishii was grateful for that .

After a while, Shimamura came into the shop .

'Miyagawa-san too...' said Shimamura in surprise .

'Hey . You look well . '

'That's not true at all . It's tough being told what to do by a rich kid who doesn't know what to do . '

'Don't whine to me . '

'Miyagawa-san, won't you come back?'

'Don't get it wrong . I didn't leave – I was left out,' said Miyagawa with a snort .

Shimamura's shoulders fell down in disappointment . She sat down opposite them .

After the coffee they ordered came, Shimamura looked at Ishii and said, 'Hiyama's case, right?'

'Yes . '

'I was investigating Imoto until yesterday . You done with that already?'

It looked like Hiyama also thought something was off about that .

'Imoto's and Hiyama's cases may be related . '

'I don't think so, but...'

'Don't say that and just tell us,' Miyagawa said admonishingly .

Shimamura looked like she would say something again, but then she shook her head and took out some documents .

'You know the outline of the case, right?'

'Yes . '

Yakumo had explained before Ishii came here .

'Right now, we're gathering suspects with the idea that it was an internal incident . The information from questioning's in these documents . '

'Thank you very much . '

'To be honest, there hasn't been much of a development, but at the conference earlier, the detective that staked out the group had strange news .
,

'What was it?'

Ishii leant forward .

Shimamura dropped sugar and milk into her coffee and slowly stirred it, almost teasingly .

'An old man wearing monk's robes, a young man and woman, and a man in a wheelchair visited the group . '

'Ah!'

Ishii spoke up without thinking .

They were probably – no, they were definitely –

'What?'

'Ah, that was definitely Detective Gotou and the others,' Ishii said reluctantly .

'How much are you all going to tamper with the case?' said Shimamura in exasperation . Then, she drank her coffee all at once .

22

– There are a number of things to investigate .

After leaving the hospital, Yakumo had said that . Now, he and Haruka were walking silently .

– I wonder where we're going .

Haruka had that question, but she didn't say it aloud .

'Here . '

After about twenty minutes of walking, Yakumo suddenly stopped .

Haruka saw a building that looked like a storehouse with a number of trucks parked outside . Haruka could read the words 'Red Horse Transportation – Setamachi Branch' on the sign .

'A transport company?'

'Yes . Where Hideaki works . '

After saying that, Yakumo started walking towards the prefabricated building by the storehouse . Haruka jogged after him .

'Hello . '

Yakumo opened the sliding door to the prefabricated building without any hesitation .

'Yes?'

A man in his sixties looked up suspiciously as he drank tea at his desk .

'I apologise for coming so suddenly . My name is Saitou . I'm a reporter from Hokutou Newspaper,' Yakumo lied casually .

Haruka felt like it'd be easier for to get information if he said he was Hideaki's friend, since Hideaki worked here, but Yakumo had to have a reason for lying the way he did .

'What is your business here today?'

The man stood up and walked to the sliding door .

Haruka felt her throat grow tight . The man was clearly suspicious .

'I wanted to listen to what the employees here have to say . '

'Have to say?'

'Yes . About Aoi Hideaki's case . '

When Yakumo said that, the man's expression changed at once .

'What do you want to know about Hide?'

'The police are treating him as a suspect in an incident, because his sister was injured in a robbery . I would like to write an article criticising the police for that . '

The man's expression relaxed, like he had accepted Yakumo's explanation .

'If that's it, I'll talk about anything . Come in . '

The man led them to a corner of the room separated by a partition . It looked like a break room .

Yakumo and Haruka sat on folding chairs . Then, the man gave Yakumo a business card .

The name 'Maeda Hirohisa' was written on it .

'Honestly . I don't know what the police are doing . A detective came here too and treated Hide like the culprit right from the start . It drives me crazy . '

'They really are awful,' said Yakumo, nodding .

Maeda continued talking, seeming pleased .

'He's like his father . Stubborn, but serious . He works his hardest for his sister . A man like that could never kill someone . '

'Did you also know Hideaki-san's father?' Yakumo asked briskly .

'We were in the same grade in high school . When he died, I thought about whether there was anything I could do, and then I hired Hide . '

'I see... Has Hideaki-san seemed strange recently?'

When Yakumo asked that, Maeda looked testy .

He knows something . Haruka could feel that too . However, from that expression, it didn't seem like he planned on talking .

'I don't know . '

As expected, Maeda frowned .

'It's important . '

'I don't know . '

'There is the possibility that somebody used Hideaki-san . '

'Used...'

Haruka could tell that Yakumo's push had shaken Maeda .

'Please tell me,' Yakumo pleaded .

Perhaps that convinced Maeda, as he cleared his throat and began to talk .

'I don't think it's got anything to do with the incident, but a man came looking for Hide . At the time, Hide had been out . After I said that, he gave me his contact information and left . '

'Who was it?'

'He didn't give his name . '

'Did you give Hideaki-san the contact information?'

'Yes . '

'What did he say?'

'That it was some invitation to a religion...'

– Invitation to a religion?

It looked like Yakumo was bothered by that too, as his eyes grew just slightly narrower .

23

'Honestly, it was awful,' grumbled Gotou on the bed .

Though he didn't have any heavy injuries – just a small cut on his forehead – he was in the hospital, just in case .

'That's what happens if you act without thinking,' said Eishin, laughing as he sat on the chair by the bed .

'You're the one who told me to answer the phone, old man . '

'That so?'

Eishin was playing dumb, even though he knew it himself .

'Don't blame other people . How worried do you think we were?'

interrupted Atsuko . She looked exasperated as she sat with Nao .

'S-sorry . '

Gotou bowed his head honestly .

It was a strange feeling . In the past, Gotou wouldn't have been able to apologise to Atsuko like this .

'Honestly . You should learn to be a bit more patient . '

'What are you talking about patience for? I've lived like this my whole life .
,

'You have to change . It's for their sakes too . '

Eishin looked at Atsuko and Nao with a smirk .

As usual, Eishin was unscrupulous in his methods . This was like making the two of them hostage .

'You know...'

'You'll need to be patient to be a monk . '

'You're saying that again!?' objected Gotou forcefully .

He understood why Yakumo avoided Eishin . Eishin was unimaginably persistent . He would probably keep saying that same thing until Gotou said yes .

'Come on, you're getting worked up over a small thing again . '

'What do you mean by "be a monk"?' asked Atsuko, raising her eyebrows .

'Actually, I was thinking of having this man take over for Isshin and become a monk at that temple . '

The moment Eishin finished his explanation, Atsuko started laughing aloud . Nao started laughing happily too, following Atsuko .

It kind of irritated Gotou that they were laughing so much .

'What's so funny?'

'I mean, you becoming a monk – that's like trying to stop the tide . '

'What?'

'You wouldn't even be able to remember the sutras, right?'

That was an awful way to put it . It made Gotou want to object .

'Don't make fun of me . I could be a monk . '

'Oh, so you want to now?'

Eishin crossed his arms and nodded approvingly .

'I was just saying that . Don't take it seriously . '

Though Gotou denied it hurriedly, Eishin didn't listen .

'Now I can relax a bit . I'm counting on you . Now what to do for your monk name...'

'Stop fooling around already!' yelled Gotou, forgetting that he was in a hospital room .

24

'What sort of person was Hideaki-san during high school?' Haruka asked Yakumo as they left the transport company, knowing that she would be ignored .

There was a long silence .

The sound of the passing cars sounded louder because of it .

'To be honest, I hated him then...'

'Why?'

There must have been a reason if Yakumo was expressing his emotions so directly .

'He could see ghosts – that's what he'd say . '

'OK . '

Haruka had heard that too .

'He didn't try to hide it . He talked about it freely . At the time, I couldn't stand it – couldn't forgive it . '

'Couldn't forgive...'

'Yeah . Even I think I'm a shallow man . Even though I was suffering, he was fine . I thought it was unfair . '

'I see...'

Haruka realised that Yakumo looked incredibly sad .

It wasn't as if she didn't understand Yakumo's feelings . Because Yakumo could see ghosts, he had undergone a lot of trauma and suffered .

And yet Hideaki didn't act that way – he even declared that he could see ghosts to other people .

'Now that I think about it, I think I looked up to him . '

'Looked up to him?'

'Yeah . I should have been able to behave the way he did, but I didn't . '

'Why not?'

'Probably because I was twisted, hiding myself in my own shell . '

Yakumo laughed self-derisively .

'That's...'

'I might have just wanted somebody to acknowledge my existence . But because I'm a coward, I was afraid of being rejected . '

'That's...'

– Not something to be ashamed of .

Haruka tried to say that, but for some reason, her voice wouldn't come out of her mouth . Instead, she softly gripped Yakumo's shirt .

Even though that wouldn't express her words –

'One day, I realised . '

Yakumo stopped walking .

'Realised what?'

'The reason he declared he could see ghosts . '

'What was it?'

'Love . A deep, deep love...'

'Love?'

Haruka didn't understand why love would make Hideaki declare he could see ghosts .

'His deep love for his sister made him do that . '

'His sister...'

'Perhaps the two of them would have been happier had they not been siblings...'

After saying that, Yakumo looked up at the sky . The clear sky spread above him .

– I wonder what Yakumo's thinking as he looks up at this sky now .

After that, they didn't talk . It looked like Yakumo was thinking so there was no chance to .

'I'll see you tomorrow . '

They parted in front of the station .

As Yakumo walked away into the darkness, he looked incredibly lonely .

For some reason, Haruka felt like she would never see that back again .

25

After Ishii returned to the precinct, he spent the day reading the documents from corner to corner .

Hiyama Kenichirou, found in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees, had been an optometrist originally . Then twenty years ago, he met the exorcist Minegishi Kyouka and started his religious activities .

'Why would a doctor become completely absorbed in a religion?' said Miyagawa to himself with a cigarette in his mouth .

He probably didn't think that a doctor would be tricked by something like that, but reality wasn't like that .

'It was the same when the cult spread poison nerve gas in the subway, but many of the people who immerse themselves in these religious groups are highly educated . '

'Ah, now that you mention it...'

Miyagawa looked up at the ceiling and blew out smoke .

'Though I don't know why...'

'Maybe the wealthy have unexpectedly unsatisfied hearts,' said Miyagawa, deep with feeling .

That made sense . Though they were satisfied with money and status, that was just conceit and a sense of superiority . They didn't give relief or repose .

Ishii looked at the documents again .

Minegishi Kyouka and Hiyama Kenichirou didn't start something as large as a religious group right away .

They moved to Yamanashi prefecture and did something like consultations about spiritual phenomena .

For a while after that, they didn't do anything that stood out . However, about two years ago, they moved to Tokyo, changed their name to Jikoukoushinkai and started to gather a large number of followers .

'Two years ago... I wonder what happened?' said Ishii, putting the question that came to his mind in his mouth .

Miyagawa looked sour .

'Dazzled by money?'

'Perhaps...'

Ishii just couldn't accept that .

'People can do anything for money . '

'However... If that was the case, couldn't they have begun their activities earlier?'

'Maybe... they didn't think about it . '

'I don't think so . '

Miyagawa didn't object . He seemed to find something odd about his own opinion himself, frowning .

The two of them, who had been working quietly, wouldn't suddenly be dazzled by money . Even if that were the case, there must have been a trigger .

That's the key that will solve the mystery of this case – Ishii felt that .

'Well, in any case, Minegishi Kyouka's got to be the murderer . '

Miyagawa tapped the photo of Kyouka in the documents . Murder caused by internal strife – it would certainly be normal to think that way . However, the police couldn't arrest Kyouka . The reason being –

'She has an alibi . '

From the estimated time of death to the time when the corpse was found, Kyouka hadn't left Tokyo .

'Maybe Minegishi Kyouka killed him and got one of the followers to toss the body? A khakkhara used by the group was found at the scene, right?'

'That is possible . However...'

That was exactly what was troubling the investigation team .

If a believer had disposed of the body, they couldn't determine who that believer was . They had gone around questioning them, but as believers, their mouths were sealed tightly .

Because they wouldn't easily talk, the investigation had run aground .

'So what are you going to do?' Miyagawa said carelessly, throwing the documents aside .

Ishii understand how Miyagawa felt . Though they had tried gathering information, with a case like this, infiltration would be most useful .

Ishii didn't think that their actions would make things any clearer .

Just as Ishii sighed, his mobile rang . Makoto's number was displayed on the screen .

'Hello, Ishii Yuutarou speaking .

<It's Makoto . >

'Ah, er, hello...'

– Please don't forget you promised me a date .

The words Makoto said came back to Ishii's head, which made Ishii heat up for some reason .

<I called Yakumo-kun, but I couldn't get him, so I called you instead, Ishii-san . >

Her voice sounded cornered .

'Did something happen?'

<Actually, there's something I want you to see . >

'W-what is it?'

Ishii had a terribly bad feeling .

26

After finishing a tasteless dinner at the hospital, Gotou lay down on the bed .

Atsuko, Nao and Eishin had all gone home .

He looked at the clock . It had just turned seven . Though he was tired, he just couldn't sleep .

He sat up, thinking that he could watch television, when he heard a knock on the door .

'It's open,' said Gotou .

The door opened quietly . When Gotou saw who was there, he was surprised . It was Yakumo .

'What is it?'

Yakumo should have left the hospital already .

He didn't look very good .

'This is just while I'm at it,' said Yakumo, sitting on the chair by the bed .

'While you're at it?'

'Yes . An acquaintance of mine is hospitalised here . '

'The woman who came to ask you for help?'

'Well, yes . '

'Did you find something out?' asked Gotou .

Yakumo pressed the corner of his eyes and covered his face .

It was unlike him .

'I know... whom she wants me to save . '

'Who?'

'I can't say that now . '

'Why not?'

'I don't know how to save them . '

Yakumo shook his head listlessly .

– He's lost .

Gotou felt that . Yakumo could probably see the outline of the case in his head .

However, he wasn't sure whether he should say it aloud .

Something similar had happened before . If the person in question was bad, then he could just be angry, but sometimes that wasn't the case .

Yakumo often supported the weak . Even though he could just let them slip away, that would conflict with his upright self . He suffered more than necessary .

But Gotou didn't hate Yakumo when he was like that . And it made him happy that Yakumo had come to him when he was unsure .

'Hey, want to take a walk?'

Gotou got out of bed and put on slippers .

'If you overwork yourself, your body will let you hear it later . '

'This is just a scrape . Hospitalisation is an overreaction . '

Gotou put a hand on the gauze on his forehead .

He wasn't lying . The cut was already healed . It virtually didn't hurt at all now .

'Why do you plan to go?'

'When you're troubled, you should walk around without thinking . '

'You've never been troubled by anything, right, Gotou-san?'

'I'll punch you,' said Gotou with a click of his tongue . He left the room .

Even though Yakumo had said all that, he followed Gotou silently . They went through the corridor and down the stairs to the waiting room .

Reception time was already over – the lights were off, so it was dim .

Gotou bought two cans of hot coffee from the vending machine by the wall . He threw one at Yakumo .

'This is rare for you, Gotou-san, being so stingy,' said Yakumo, looking at the can of coffee like it was something mysterious .

As usual, he wasn't honest with his feelings .

'Shut up and drink it . '

Gotou pulled the tab of the coffee can open and drank a sip . Then, he walked to the hospital's courtyard .

The air was colder than he'd expected . He shivered .

'What are you worried about?' Gotou asked .

Yakumo held the can of coffee in his two hands and looked up at the sky .

Autumn's harvest moon . The round moon shone brightly . Even in the city where stars never showed, it made Gotou feel calm .

'I don't know... how to save them...'

'Trying to save someone is just ego . '

'Those words are unlike you . '

'Maybe . But nobody knows how things'll end up . Wriggling around for somebody else's sake'll just make you regret it . '

'But you acted for my sake, Gotou-san . '

Yakumo was probably talking about the previous incident when Gotou had had to quit being a police officer . He seemed to feel a debt for that, but that chastened attitude wasn't like Yakumo .

'I was just going with my beliefs . '

'That's like you, Gotou-san . '

Yakumo smiled, just a little .

His eyes, which had been so gloomy just earlier, seemed to have a bit more strength in them .

'Hey, Yakumo...'

Just as Gotou spoke up, he was startled .

Yakumo's eyes flashed open and he slowly fell forward . The can of coffee that slipped from his hand fell onto the courtyard's lawn .

– What happened?

Gotou was bewildered . He tried to run up to Yakumo, but somebody got in his way .

He couldn't see clearly in the dark . The person wore hakama with a belled sash . In their hands was a hexagonal bar .

'You...'

As Gotou started to say that, he was hit forcefully on the head .

The ground shook . He fell forward . Then, he lost consciousness –

'What am I supposed to look at?' Ishii asked hesitantly .

Makoto had come to the Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room because she had something she wanted Ishii to see .

His heart had been pounding unpleasantly since earlier .

'It's a video from when the corpse was found in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees,' explained Makoto, taking the laptop she was holding and setting it up quickly .

From her expression, the video must have had something of great impact in it .

– I don't want to see it, if possible .

That was how Ishii really felt, but he couldn't say it aloud .

'A video, eh?'

Miyagawa didn't seem interested as he blew out cigarette smoke .

'I'll play the video,' said Makoto after she finished .

Ishii bit his lip and gripped his fists as he looked at the monitor .

The monitor showed Aokigahara's deep forest . Cypress trees grew thick, making it seem like everywhere was blanketed in fog .

This place was famous as a suicide spot . Ishii didn't know how people could go there for fun .

'I'll skip this part . '

Makoto used the mouse .

The setting changed . A shriek, probably a woman's, echoed through the forest .

It looked like the person filming was running, as the screen was shaking wildly . It made Ishii feel sick just to watch .

For a moment, Ishii looked away .

'Here,' said Makoto .

'Eh?'

Ishii had completely missed it . He brought his face close to the monitor . Miyagawa peered in too, his brow furrowed .

Makoto used the mouse to rewind a little .

On the screen, there was a woman collapsed on the ground and a blackened corpse .

'Ee...'

Ishii hurriedly swallowed the shriek that had almost escaped his mouth .

'Here . '

Makoto stopped the video . Ishii saw somebody's feet approach the woman on the ground .

'What about it?'

Ishii cocked his head .

It didn't seem like an image special enough for Makoto to go out of her way to show them .

'Please look here carefully . '

Makoto used the mouse to zoom in on the centre of the image .

When Ishii saw the image, he leapt back without thinking .

'T-this is...'

Ishii and Miyagawa looked at each other . Then, they looked at Makoto .

'Yes . The man with two red eyes . '

Makoto's words echoed in Ishii's head like a death sentence .

For a while after that, nobody could speak .

– That man has something to do with the case?

As if to interrupt the tense air, a mobile started to ring .

Ishii's shoulders shuddered . He put his hand on his mobile . The display showed Gotou's name . Ishii had a terrible feeling about this .

Haruka was in her bed in her room, before she'd noticed .

After parting with Yakumo, she had returned to her room in the apartment and collapsed on her bed . She remembered up to that .

She seemed to have fallen asleep .

She slowly sat up . Her head felt heavy .

These two days had just been hectic . So many things had happened that, to be honest, her head was still confused .

She looked at the clock . It had just turned ten at night .

She stretched and stood up . She was thinking about taking a shower to refresh herself when she saw her mobile vibrating on the table .

Yakumo's number was displayed –

'Hey . '

Haruka picked up the phone .

There was no response . Haruka could hear the sound of rustling branches – perhaps Yakumo was outside .

'Hey, Yakumo-kun?'

Still, there was no response .

– Something's definitely strange .

In Haruka's head, the image of Yakumo walking away came up again .

Once she imagined something dreadful, her thoughts just started getting worse, like they were rolling down a slope .

'Yakumo-kun, what's wrong? Hey, talk back to me!'

Haruka continued to talk frantically, but no response came back to her .

If she strained her ears, she could faintly hear someone breathing .
However, she could tell immediately that that someone wasn't Yakumo .

'Who are you?' Haruka timidly .

There was a silence . Haruka gripped the mobile tightly .

<Saitou Yakumo is in the forest . >

It seemed like the person was using a voice changer, as their voice sounded mechanical . Haruka couldn't tell if they were a man or a woman .

'Forest? What are you talking about?'

<Where the corpse was found . >

'Who are you? What do you mean, where the corpse was found? Yakumo-kun...'

Haruka was going to continue, but she stopped .

The call had already ended .

— What happened?

Haruka took deep breaths and managed barely to stop herself from panicking .

Though she didn't know the details, she knew that something terrible had happened to Yakumo . Determined, Haruka called Yakumo's mobile again .

However, no matter how long she waited, all she heard was the phone ringing . Nobody answered .

— What should I do?

While Haruka was thinking about this, her mobile rang .

She thought that it might be from Yakumo, but Gotou's number was the one that was displayed . However, that would be helpful .

'Hello, Gotou-san, actually, earlier...'

<Yakumo's been abducted . >

Gotou's bitter voice interrupted Haruka .

That moment, it felt like she had fallen into a dark hole .

'Abducted...'

<Sorry . If I had just...>

The words sounded like they had been strangled out of Gotou's throat .

Though Haruka felt like she was in despair, she said, to cheer up both their spirits, 'That's not true . '

29

– Where am I?

Yakumo slowly opened his eyes .

He could feel that his hands and feet were numb . He had been talking with Gotou in the hospital courtyard just earlier .

He forced his creaking body up and looked around .

He was in a deep forest .

A forest that had no boundaries to its darkness, because only faint moonlight shone down –

'I...'

Yakumo tried to think about what had happened, but the numbing pain stopped him .

Yakumo used a nearby large rock to support himself . It was slippery and dark – there was no way for him to move .

He searched his pockets to see if there was anything there, but his mobile and wallet were gone .

– So I'll have to spend the night here?

Yakumo's body shivered . He was quite cold .

'It's been a while . '

He heard a voice from behind him .

Yakumo's body froze at that familiar voice .

– This is the worst .

As he whispered that in his heart, he slowly turned around .

Just as he imagined, there was a man standing there . The man with two red eyes . Yakumo's father, Unkai .

In this dark forest, his eyes alone let out an unnatural light .

'I didn't want to see you,' said Yakumo, glaring .

– I can't let myself be drawn in .

He told himself that . If Yakumo showed any sign of wavering in front of this man, he'd grab a hold of it . Yakumo had to calmly observe the situation .

'That's a cold attitude you have towards your parent . '

The man shook his head slightly .

'I don't think of you as my parent . '

'It's not a problem of whether you think so or not . Isn't that red left eye of yours proof? We are father and son...'

'Even if we have the same blood, I'm different from you,' said Yakumo .

No matter what happened, Yakumo had to continue to refuse this man . If he accepted any of his words, that would be when Yakumo stopped being human .

'We're the same . You just don't know it . '

'Don't know it?'

'That's right . You don't know true despair... Once you understand that, you should understand . The true nature of the human soul is darkness . '

'Stop spewing drivel!' yelled Yakumo, gripping his fists together .

Yakumo knew despair from the terrible childhood he had suffered, but he still believed there was a light ahead of the darkness .

'Then let's try it out . '

The man with two red eyes smirked .

'What?'

'Do you know where you are?'

'Some forest, right?'

'It isn't just any forest . This is Aokigahara's Sea of Trees . Do you understand what I'm saying . '

'Urk...'

Yakumo gritted his teeth . At the same time, terror welled up within him .

Aokigahara's Sea of Trees was famous for being a suicide spot where a hundred or so unidentified corpses were found every year . In short, that number of spirits wandered here .

Furthermore, most of them were spirits who had ended their lives and were not at piece .

Before Yakumo noticed, the man with two red eyes had disappeared .

– Where is he?

Yakumo looked around, and then his eyes went wide open .

A terribly thin old man was right next to Yakumo . He had probably hanged himself . His neck was unusually long .

– Give her back! Give my daughter back!

The old man clung to Yakumo .

'T-that wasn't me . '

Yakumo tried to shake him off, but it was no use .

– It's your fault!

He heard a voice at his feet . He looked down and saw a middle-aged woman with a pale face grovelling there, looking up at Yakumo .

'Wha...'

– Why did you betray me?

He heard a voice behind him .

When he turned around, he saw a young person with blood gushing out his head . He reached out towards Yakumo .

'Stay away . '

Yakumo started to run in an attempt to escape .

However, his footing was unsteady in the forest, and he fell before he got anywhere .

– Wahhh, wahhh .

He heard a baby crying somewhere .

When he looked up, he saw a woman holding a newborn baby looking down at him .

– I died because of you .

'N-no . I...'

In this chaos, more spirits of the dead appeared from the forest . The number kept increasing .

Yakumo was surrounded by countless spirits before he'd noticed .

Their hatred, sadness and anger flowed into Yakumo's heart mercilessly .

– No . No . No .

Yakumo held his head in his hands .

No matter how he tried to shake them away, he couldn't shut off his heart . As he took in the spirits' negative emotions, Yakumo's heart – crumbled .

'Aaahhhhhh!'

Yakumo's scream echoed through the forest, as if he was in the throes of death –

NOTES:

[1] Shugendo is a Buddhist religion from pre-feudal Japan that combines a number of religious influences, including Shinto . HERE is an example of

the traditional outfit for a person who practises Shugen .

[2] The Toyota HiAce is a van that comes in many forms and is tall enough to accommodate a wheelchair . The WIKIPEDIA ARTICLE has a photo .

[3] Miyagawa and Ishii are referring to the Subway Sarin Incident that occurred on the Tokyo subway and was organised by Aum Shinrikyo (オウム真理教 or Supreme Truth), which is considered a terrorist organisation . The group is currently known as Aleph, and there is also a breakaway group named Hikari no Wa (ひかりの輪), which means Circle of Light .

[4] This is taken from the Tenchi Issai Shoujou Harai (天地一切清浄祓 or The Purification of Heaven and Earth) . You can see the full Japanese [HERE](#) .

[5] Kuji means nine syllables (九字) and refers to mantras with nine syllables used for purification . It is common in Shugendo .

[6] This is the Ryobu kuji in its original Taoist syllables translated into Japanese . The translation given by Wikipedia is '[Celestial] soldiers descend and arrange yourselves in front of me' .

[7] The sea bonze, or Umibouzu (海坊主), is a spirit that capsizes boats . It has a round head like a monk . [HERE](#) is an illustration of it .

Volume 9 Chapter 3: VOLUME 9 – THE SPIRIT OF SALVATION

Chapter 3

VOLUME 9 – THE SPIRIT OF SALVATION

file 03: salvation

1

Haruka cleaned herself up reasonably and flew out of her room .

She went to the main road and flagged a taxi, told the driver her destination and leant back on the seat .

She felt a sense of déjà vu as she watched the city's nightscape pass by through the window . Come to think of it, she had looked out a taxi window like this when Isshin had been stabbed too .

– No .

Haruka cleared that thought out of her head .

She couldn't think bad thoughts . 'It'll definitely be OK!' Haruka told herself that and managed to calm herself down a bit .

She got off the taxi in front of the hospital . After gathering herself, she hurriedly went to the waiting room through the night entrance .

She spotted Gotou sitting on the bench .

His head looked injured, as it was bound by gauze . The gauze was a bit wet with blood .

'Are you all right?' asked Haruka . Gotou looked up .

'Sorry . I was there, but...'

'More importantly, what's happening?'

Haruka spoke over Gotou .

Gotou glanced at the back of the waiting room . Ishii was there talking with a number of uniformed officers .

Ishii seemed to notice Gotou's gaze as he stopped talking and walked towards them .

'Haruka-chan . '

'Ishii-san . What's happening?'

Haruka quickly finished her greeting and asked Ishii for more information .

Ishii fixed the position of his silver-framed glasses with his fingertip and began his explanation .

'From the situation, it seems that the culprit stunned Yakumo-shi with a stun gun and then hit Detective Gotou with something like a rod to make him faint . And then, that person took Yakumo-shi away – is what I think . '

'Why was I the only one who was hit?' said Gotou with a frown, looking like he was bearing with the pain .

'I think the culprit was probably using a stun gun that could not be used quickly in succession . '

'So they didn't expect there to be two people,' Gotou said bitterly .

'We are currently checking the security cameras as there is the possibility that the culprit might be recorded on them . '

'The person who got me was wearing a white hakama,' said Gotou angrily .

'Jikoukoushinkai may be involved . '

'We're going to their base . Yakumo has to be there . '

Gotou threw his gauze bandage into the rubbish bin and stood up .

'Please wait . '

Haruka called out to Gotou before he could leave .

'What?'

'Actually, I had a phone call from somebody who is likely the culprit . '

'What?'

'What did you say?'

Gotou and Ishii expressed their surprise simultaneously .

Haruka explained in detail about the mysterious call she had received from Yakumo's mobile .

'The forest probably means Aokigahara's Sea of Trees in this situation . '

Gotou scratched his chin .

Haruka felt the same way . If Yakumo's abduction was related to this series of cases . it was likely that the forest in question was Aokigahara's Sea of Trees .

The culprit had also said that a corpse had been found there .

'This is definitely a trap,' objected Ishii .

Haruka had thought that too . If the person who had called was the person who had abducted Yakumo, there was no reason for them to tell Haruka where Yakumo was .

If they were going to just tell her without asking for anything, they wouldn't have needed to abduct Yakumo in the first place .

But –

'We can't ignore it . '

'That's true,' agreed Gotou .

'But there is also that video,' continued Ishii .

'What video?' asked Gotou .

'Actually... in the video the young man who found the corpse at Aokigahara took, that man... there was the man with two red eyes . So...'

'Even if it is a trap, I won't be able to relax until I go!' declared Gotou .

'B-but...'

'You go check out that religious group . I'm going to the Sea of Trees . '

'I'm going too!'

Haruka called out to Gotou, who had been about to leave .

'You can't . It's dangerous . '

Ishii grabbed her arm, but Haruka shook his hand away .

She couldn't just wait silently when all this was happening .

'You're going to come even if I say no, right?' said Gotou, turning around .

'Yes . '

Haruka looked right at Gotou .

Just as Gotou said, she planned to go no matter how they objected .

'Right! Let's go!'

'Yes,' replied Haruka . She followed Gotou out .

2

– They're gone .

Ishii watched Gotou and Haruka leave in a daze .

Perhaps he should have stopped them, but for some reason, he couldn't . No matter what he said, he probably wouldn't have been able to stop the two of them .

They stood on such strong bonds .

All Ishii could do now was hope they would be safe .

'Ishii . '

Ishii turned around at the voice and saw Miyagawa .

'What is it?'

'We've got the pictures from the security cameras . '

'Ah, yes . '

Ishii and Miyagawa went to the security room behind the reception .

It was a small three-tatami room . There was one desk and a folded futon by it for naps . On top of the desk, there were three monitors .

'So which one is it?' Miyagawa asked the male guard at the desk .

The man mumbled something as he used the keyboard . Then, he pointed at the monitor in the centre .

'This one . '

Ishii peered at the monitor and could see Gotou and Yakumo standing in the courtyard . Since there was no sound, he couldn't tell what they were talking about .

After a while, Ishii saw a shadow appear behind Yakumo .

White hakama with a sash with a red Brahma on it . The clothes of Shugendo . The man pressed a stun gun into Yakumo's shoulder .

Yakumo lost consciousness from the shock and collapsed right there .

Gotou noticed something was strange and put himself on guard, but the person in white quickly hit Gotou with a hexagonal bar .

It only took a moment .

After that, the man in Shugendo clothes went out of the frame . After that, a car came in and stopped in front of Yakumo .

The man in white got out of the driver's seat . It was probably the same person as the one earlier .

He picked Yakumo up and put him in the car . Then, he got into the driver's seat and drove away .

'That was efficient . '

That was how Ishii felt .

He didn't even pay attention to Gotou . It was clear that his goal was to abduct Yakumo from the start .

'Yeah,' replied Miyagawa . Then, he said to the guard, 'Could you show us the video again?'

The security guard silently rewound the video as told . Miyagawa put his face close to the screen .

'Stop!'

He spoke up when the car came into the frame .

In response, the guard stopped the video . Miyagawa was probably trying to check the car's licence plate .

Ishii also went up close to the monitor to see .

However, it was no use . The number was covered with packing tape . They had no way to see it .

He must have been thinking about the security cameras . A thorough criminal .

'Damn it,' Miyagawa said, full of feeling .

It was true that they couldn't see the number . However, Ishii had found something else . It was –

'Could you enlarge this portion?'

Ishii pointed at the chest of the man in Shugendo clothes .

'The image will be fuzzy,' said the guard, enlarging the photo .

Ishii could see the word Jikoukoushinkai on the black sash .

'So it's really that religious group...' said Miyagawa, who seemed to have sensed Ishii's intentions .

'Yes . '

'Ishii, let's go . '

'Yes sir,' Ishii responded loudly . Then, he left the security room together with Miyagawa .

3

'It's fine . We'll find him,' Gotou said, driving the Mini Cooper, to Haruka in the passenger seat .

Rather than encouraging her, it was more for himself .

'Yes, definitely...'

Haruka was acting strong .

She probably would have been half in tears in the past, but she was different now .

'What's so amusing?'

After Haruka said that, Gotou realised that he was smiling .

'I was just looking back . '

'On what?'

'When I first met you, Haruka-chan, it was during that case with the university's deserted building, right?'

'It was . '

Haruka's expression softened just slightly, perhaps as she thought back on the incident as well .

'I thought you were a pretty weak girl at the time . '

Back then, Haruka had looked like she would cry at any moment as she sat next to Yakumo .

They had met again afterwards during a number of incidents, but Gotou felt like Haruka had been crying every time .

Maybe she was worrying about Yakumo, or feeling sorry for the victim – but at some point, Gotou had stopped feeling weakness from her tears .

He could feel that she had the strength to go forward even as she cried .

And now, even though she must have wanted to cry, she was restraining those feelings . Maybe she'd decided that she wouldn't cry until she found Yakumo .

Now that he thought about it again, she wasn't just a weak girl who cried all the time .

That was probably why Yakumo was charmed by her .

'Why are you using the past tense?'

Haruka puffed out her cheeks, as if in anger .

“Cause you've changed . ’

'Is that so?'

Haruka might not really feel it herself, but Gotou could tell, as an observer .

Haruka had definitely changed from meeting Yakumo .

'Since I'm saying it, there's no doubt about it . ’

'Hmm...'

'But you're not the only one that's changed, Haruka-chan . ’

'Eh?'

'Yakumo's changed too . ’

'Really?'

'Yeah . People change because they love each other . '

Gotou had started thinking that way recently .

'Somehow, that doesn't really sound like you, Gotou-san . '

'Really?' said Gotou, playing dumb .

But he understood in his heart . More than anything, Gotou himself had changed . He felt like, after meeting Yakumo and Haruka, he had found the path he was supposed to take .

It wasn't just Gotou . Atsuko, Nao and Ishii had changed too .

These people who had all been lacking something had come together, hurt each other at times, and continued to change .

But Gotou thought it was a good thing . That was why –

'Let's find Yakumo no matter what . '

'Yes . '

Haruka responded with a smile .

There was not even an atom of doubt there . Yakumo would definitely come back –

'All right . Going to put the pedal to the metal . '

Gotou stepped firmly on the pedal . If he went quickly, they would probably reach Aokigahara's Sea of Trees in two hours .

For Haruka's sake and his own, he would definitely bring Yakumo back .

Gotou reaffirmed his resolve .

'This is a bit creepy,' said Ishii without thinking .

The Jikoukoushinkai base was outside of town and was so quiet it was eerie .

It seemed like they had renovated an old temple . It was more quiet than Ishii had thought it would be . That made it even creepier .

'Yeah,' agreed Miyagawa, hands in his pockets .

To be honest, Ishii was afraid of going inside, but strangely, he didn't think about running away .

With determination, Ishii reached out to press the intercom button .

'Oi . '

Miyagawa grabbed Ishii's arm .

'What is it?'

'Is it OK not to call for reinforcements?'

Miyagawa's words brought Ishii back to reality .

'Reinforcements?'

'Reinforcements . '

'Er...'

To be honest, Ishii hadn't even thought about calling for reinforcements .

They had no decisive evidence at this point . Even if they called reinforcements, they wouldn't be able to search the place .

'You've changed,' said Miyagawa while laughing .

'I've changed?'

'Yeah . Just a little in the past, you'd've been the one who suggested calling for reinforcements . '

Now that Miyagawa said that, Ishii felt like it was true .

Yakumo's role had been to frantically step on the brakes when Gotou was running wild . No, that was an excuse – Ishii just hadn't had confidence in his actions . That was why he would want reinforcements to get instructions from the higher ups .

Mysteriously though, he didn't feel like that right now .

'Shall I call for reinforcements?' asked Ishii, thinking that he should at least ask .

'Just us two is enough . '

Miyagawa smirked and puffed out his chest .

'Yes,' replied Ishii . If they got orders from above, they would just be slowed down . Sometimes, it was necessary to take gutsy actions . Especially since Yakumo's life was in danger right now .

Ishii reached out and pressed the intercom button .

<Hello, who may you be?>

There was a response immediately .

'I apologise for coming late at night . I am Ishii of the Setamachi precinct . '

<The police?>

'Actually, we are investigating a certain case... We would just like to consult you...'

<Does it have to be today?>

It was already past midnight . Perhaps this response was normal .

'Yes . It has to be today . '

<Please wait . >

Then, the intercom stopped . They were probably checking if it was OK .

'Do you think they'll let us in?' asked Miyagawa .

'No, I think they'll refuse,' said Ishii .

If Yakumo's abduction was related to Jikoukoushinkai, there was no way they'd let them in .

Ishii's instinct was right . Through the intercom, they were told to please come again tomorrow because the founder, who had been feeling unwell, was already asleep .

After that, no matter how Ishii pressed the intercom button, there was no response .

'What are we going to do now?' said Miyagawa with a sigh .

The past Ishii would probably have retreated, but –

'Miyagawa . '

'What?'

'This wall looks climbable . '

When Ishii pointed at the wall, Miyagawa's eyes went wide .

'You serious?'

'Yes . '

'If people find out we did this, we're finished . '

Ishii knew Miyagawa was right, but –

'However, if we don't, and the person who abducted Yakumo-shi is from this group, we won't be able to undo this,' Ishii replied .

For some reason, that Miyagawa started chuckling .

'You've really changed . You're becoming more and more like Gotou . '

'Is that so?'

To be honest, Ishii didn't really feel that way .

5

After Makoto returned to the office, she decided to research Jikoukoushinkai again .

She was concerned about Yakumo's abduction .

However, nothing she could do would change anything . She would believe that Ishii and Gotou would bring him back and start working on what to do next .

That was the conclusion Makoto had come to –

When Gotou contacted her, her plans had fallen through, but Makoto had a theory . She was going to confirm it .

Makoto called Takizawa on her mobile .

'I apologise for calling at night . '

<What, it's you again?>

Takizawa was acting curt, but it was his usual attitude .

'I'm sorry . '

<So how was the video?>

'You were talking about the red-eyed man in the video, right?'

<Yeah, him . Well, sometimes eyes look red because of the light, but there was definitely somebody else there . >

That hadn't been because of the light .

'I know that man . '

<What? Who is he?>

Takizawa was agitated .

It was very difficult to explain who the man with two red eyes was . The reason being –

'He's already dead . '

<So he's a ghost...>

Takizawa wasn't that surprised .

A newspaper journalist had to acknowledge the existence of ghosts even if they didn't want to . They didn't proclaim it publicly, but they saw more than one or two ghosts while gathering information and taking photographs .

'So there was something I wanted to check . '

<What?>

'It's about the group called Jikoukoushinkai...'

<Yeah . >

'It seems that the base used to be in Yamanashi . '

<Seems like it . >

'I want to know of any rumours about the location . '

<Why do you want to know?>

It made sense for Takizawa to have this question .

However, this was extremely important to prove Makoto's theory .

'Jikoukoushinkai moved to Tokyo about two years ago . '

<If I remember correctly, yeah . >

'Why did they suddenly expand... I think that's the key to solving this case .
,

<I don't really get it, but fine . I'll look into it for you . >

'Thank you very much . '

After thanking Takizawa, Makoto hung up .

Jikoukoushinkai had been managed by the founder, Minegishi Kyouka, and Hiyama Kenichirou, who had been found as a corpse in Aokighara's Sea of Trees .

The group had suddenly moved to Tokyo two years ago and expanded .
That perfectly matched the time when she appeared .

She – that is, Nanase Miyuki .

Makoto felt a chill run down her spine just from thinking the name .

6

Ishii knelt on the floor, bearing with the weight on his back .

'Just a bit more . '

Miyagawa, standing on Ishii's back, reached out to try to grab the top of the wall, but it wasn't going well .

– This is no good .

Ishii's arms were shaking . At this rate, he'd collapse under the weight .

Just as he thought that, his back was hit with an impact . Miyagawa had jumped to try to grab the curb .

Ishii couldn't bear that force and fell flat on the asphalt .

'Oi, Ishii . Hurry,' said Miyagawa, reaching towards him from the top of the wall .

'Ah, yes . '

Ishii bore with the pain in his back as he grabbed Miyagawa's hand .

With good timing, Ishii jumped as Miyagawa pulled . Ishii almost fell, but he managed to hold on .

Then, they climbed over the wall onto the grounds .

However, Ishii didn't absorb the impact well and fell forward, hitting his nose .

He felt the hot pain start spreading .

– This is the worst .

Ishii had started to regret their attempt at infiltration .

'What are you doing? Let's go . '

At Miyagawa's rushing, Ishii started walking, stooped over and holding his nose .

The premises were silent . There were no lights on in the rooms .

'So what are we going to do?'

'What shall we do?' replied Ishii .

Miyagawa put his head in his hands, exasperated .

Though it was good that they had managed to get in, to be honest, Ishii didn't know what to do next .

'You can't have no plan . '

'I-I apologise . '

'Anyway, let's go take a look at places which might be monitored . '

'Ah, that'd be good,' agreed Ishii .

Miyagawa pushed Ishii's head .

'You're all talk, aren't you?'

– He was happy .

It was the first time Miyagawa had hit him like this since they partnered up . It was strange, but it felt like they were closer – like Miyagawa had acknowledged him .

'What are you grinning to yourself for?'

'I-I'm sorry . '

Ishii hurriedly made his face stern .

'There's a detached building up ahead . '

Miyagawa pointed at a building that looked like a temple and another building that was connected to it by a corridor .

'Yes . '

'Doesn't it look suspicious?'

'It does,' agreed Ishii . He and Miyagawa nodded at each other and slowly advanced .

They kept their heads low so that people wouldn't notice, so it took them a long time to advance just ten metres .

'So how are we going in?' said Miyagawa, crouching with his back to the wall .

Ishii had looked at the building as he came up to it . There were bars on the window . It didn't look like they could get in .

It meant they would have to go in through the front .

As Ishii said that, Miyagawa looked towards the front door .

'No, it's locked,' Miyagawa said quietly, making an X sign with his hands .

'Shall we go to the back?'

'Looks like we'll have to,' agreed Miyagawa .

They went to the back of the detached building with their backs still to the wall .

The back window fortunately didn't have bars . The light was even on .

'It seems like we can look in from there,' said Ishii . Then, he had a strange thought .

'It feels kind of like we're thieves . '

'Wha?'

Miyagawa cocked his head .

'Ah, I was just thinking that thieves have it tough . '

'Don't be stupid . Let's go,' Miyagawa reprimanded .

'Ah, yes sir . '

It was true that this wasn't the time to be thinking about useless things like that .

Ishii moved to look inside, but it was no use . The window was too high up .

'Ishii, act as a stool,' said Miyagawa .

'Ehh!?'

Ishii let out a loud voice without thinking . He hurriedly covered his mouth .

'They'll find out we're here . '

'I-I apologise . But... Earlier, I was the stool, so...'

To be honest, his back still hurt . He wasn't sure he could be a stool again . Perhaps Miyagawa sensed Ishii's inner feelings as he grumbled, 'Guess there's no helping it,' and knelt on the floor .

Thank goodness – though Ishii thought that, he felt awkward about stepping on his boss's back .

'Hurry up,' said Miyagawa . Ishii gathered himself and climbed onto Miyagawa's back .

He slowly reached up to peer inside .

It was a small tatami room . In the centre, there was a woman in a white kimono . It was the founder, Minegishi Kyouka .

However, she seemed strange .

With her head hung, her body was shaking .

– What is that?

Perhaps she had sensed Ishii, as she slowly lifted her head .

There was no life in her face . Her eyes weren't focussed . Her mouth was open in an unsightly fashion and drool was coming out .

– That's just like...

'What are you doing there?'

Suddenly, Ishii heard a voice and turned around .

A man in a mountain priest's clothes had stuck his head out the temple's window .

– Oh no . They noticed us .

Immediately as Ishii thought that, Miyagawa's body shook underneath him . Ishii fell from Miyagawa's back to the ground .

He started coughing from the impact .

'Let's go!' yelled Miyagawa .

Ishii got up while bearing with the pain and hurriedly ran after Miyagawa's back .

7

– Dark . Complete dark .

Yakumo's consciousness wandered a dark forest .

The despair of the spirits in this forest was much deeper than he imagined .

Some were betrayed by friends, and others by the family they lived –

Some did not even have people who could betray them – those who had spent their lives alone .

– They weren't even able to find salvation by dying .

Yakumo heard a voice . He couldn't see him, but Yakumo knew who it was .

– That's not true .

Yakumo gritted his teeth together and denied it .

– What isn't true?

– They must have had hope .

– Where?

Yakumo couldn't respond right away .

Had the people who died in this forest really had hope?

Nobody had reached out to help . Even if they continued to live, their suffering would have just continued .

– This is the true nature of humanity . Do you understand the true reason they were led to their deaths?

– The true reason?

– Hope .

– Why?

– Because humans have hope, they despair . Because they believe, they are betrayed .

– That's not true!

– There is nothing untrue about it . You understand too, don't you?

– It's not true . It's not true . It's not true .

Yakumo denied it frantically, but his heart was flowing away with the current .

Yakumo couldn't completely deny what he was saying . Without hope, they wouldn't have despaired . The faint hope that people hold could make them suffer .

It had been that way for the doctor named Kinoshita . He had held the imaginary hope that he might be able to revive his dead daughter .

It was the same for Kamiyama . He had seen a dream of his bright future with his lover . That was why, when that dream was trampled on, he hadn't been able to stop himself .

That wasn't all . There had been a man who had tried to become somebody else . There had been a woman who wanted the love of a family .

Because they had hoped, they had tasted despair .

– If you say it is untrue, can you save them?

– Save?

– Can you save all the spirits in this forest?

– I... can't . I can't save them .

Yakumo felt painfully how powerless he was .

There was no way to save the countless number of spirits in their despair, since Yakumo could only see them .

– I'm powerless .

Something that he had been protecting in his heart cracked loudly .

What had he been trying to protect up until now? Where had he been trying to go?

If he hoped, all that lay ahead of him was despair . No matter how he struggled, there was no way he could escape the current .

If that was the case, then it would have been better if there had been no hope in the first place .

If there was nothing there, there was nothing to lose .

– Ah, I'm being swallowed by the darkness .

Yakumo felt his consciousness being eaten away, but he no longer had the will to resist it .

Rather, he even felt it pleasant .

8

The car ran along Highway 139 –

The road that went across the Sea of Trees had no streetlights . It was like a dark tunnel .

– Yakumo is in this forest .

Haruka believed that . Her hand enveloped the necklace with the red stone that was hanging from her neck .

'It was around here . '

Gotou turned the wheel to drive onto number 300 towards Lake Motosu and parked the car after driving a bit further .

About fifteen minutes ahead was where the corpse had been found .

Aokigahara's Sea of Trees was wide . It would be impossible to search the whole area with just the two of them . They were going on the call Haruka

had received and decided to search the area near the corpse .

After Haruka got off the car, she felt the cold wind blowing .

They were high up, and the wind blew down the mountain . It was very cold . Haruka's body shivered .

'Right . Go time?'

Gotou held a torch up and walked forward .

Haruka followed him into the forest .

Even though she had only taken a step forward, she had a bad feeling . The air felt suddenly heavier .

Perhaps it was because she knew this forest was famous as a suicide spot .

'Are you all right?'

Gotou turned around .

'Yes,' replied Haruka with a nod .

She couldn't stop . If she didn't go forward, she couldn't find Yakumo .

With the rocks coming out of the ground, it was very difficult to walk . She went farther and farther in through the cypress trees .

'I wonder why the perp kidnapped Yakumo...' said Gotou .

'I don't know, but...'

'What?'

'Perhaps it was because Yakumo-kun understood the core of the case . '

That was what Haruka thought .

When she parted with Yakumo on the road, Haruka had felt faintly that Yakumo had already seen through the structure of the case –

'And so the perp kidnapped somebody who was getting in the way,' said Gotou to himself .

'Yes . '

'But then why go out of their way to kidnap him?'

'That's...'

'There are other methods to get rid of somebody . And I don't know why they went out of their way to call you . '

Haruka cocked her head at that .

Why had the culprit told her that Yakumo was in the forest – that was like telling her to find the person they'd abducted .

'Well, no point thinking about it now . First, we need to find Yakumo,' Gotou said self-derisively and started walking through the forest silently again .

Haruka had thought it was cold at first, but her back was sweaty, perhaps because she was walking .

– I wonder what the people who came to this forest to commit suicide were thinking .

That thought crossed Haruka's mind .

Gotou was here now, but the people who committed suicide must have walked this forest alone . Perhaps that reconfirmed their solitariness .

And then, they died without anyone knowing . There was only deep despair there .

'No . '

Haruka shook her head .

She cleared her head and continued walking silently .

'It should've been around here...'

Gotou stopped and took a look at the map while lighting it up .

However, no matter how he looked at the map, it probably wouldn't be much use in the dark forest . They could only walk forward and judge by distance .

'Shall we split up and search?' suggested Haruka .

Gotou's face clearly hardened .

'Don't be stupid . If we split up in this forest, it'd be a disaster . '

'But...'

'Should be just a bit more . Let's go . '

Gotou interrupted Haruka and started walking again .

Haruka gritted her teeth and stepped forward .

– I'll definitely find you .

She kept wishing that in her heart as she walked forward .

However, the farther she went, she felt like that wish was being swallowed by despair .

'Ah...'

The moment her will weakened, she slipped .

She almost fell face-up when Gotou grabbed Haruka's arm . Thanks to that, even though she lost her balance, she managed to not fall .

'Thank you very much . '

'Watch out . We're close . We'll find him soon . '

Gotou's voice wasn't even slightly weak .

I'll find Yakumo no matter what – that strong will seemed to flow out of his whole body .

– I won't give up either .

Haruka gathered her strength and walked forward .

'There . '

Gotou spoke up after they headed forward some more .

With his torch, he pointed at a large rock about five metres ahead of him .
The rock was green from moss .

'The corpse was found near that rock, if I remember correctly . '

As he said that, Gotou pointed the torch around the area .

That light illuminated a person .

A person sitting against the rock . It was –

'Yakumo-kun!' called out Haruka, running forward .

Even though she kept tripping on rocks, she somehow managed to reach Yakumo .

'Yakumo-kun!'

Haruka embraced Yakumo tightly .

His body was completely cold . However, she could hear his breathing .

– He’s alive .

Haruka felt that with her whole body .

9

'Damn, I suffered a lot,' said Miyagawa a while after escaping back to the precinct .

Ishii felt the same way .

Current police officers had trespassed . If they had been caught there, it would have been a big problem . However, they couldn't relax just because they had escaped .

If people from Jikoukoushinkai reported it to the police, they wouldn't be let off easily .

'So what did you see?' asked Miyagawa, lighting a cigarette .

That was right . Ishii had been so frantic that he hadn't reported what he'd seen there to Miyagawa .

'It seems it's true that the founder is feeling unwell . '

'What?'

Miyagawa raised his eyebrows .

Ishii explained in detail what he had seen from that window .

'That's strange...'

That was what Miyagawa said first after Ishii finished .

Ishii thought it strange as well, but he had a theory .

'Perhaps she has been possessed by a spirit . '

'What?'

Miyagawa looked shocked .

'Makoto-san and Gotou-san had also been like that when possessed . '

Since Ishii couldn't see like Yakumo, he had no proof . However, Ishii's experiences told him that that was a person being possessed by a spirit .

Kyouka's face from back then came up in Ishii's head, which made him shudder .

'If that's true, it'd be a big problem for the group . '

'It would . '

If the founder of the group had been possessed by a spirit, that would affect their prestige . The believers would lost their belief and it would be difficult to continue to support the group .

'But why did that happen?'

Ishii couldn't answer that .

'Something probably happened . '

Ishii cocked his head . Then, his mobile rang . The number of the display was Gotou's .

'Hello, Ishii Yuutarou speaking . '

Ishii answered the phone with vigour .

<You don't have to say your name every time . I know it's you . >

There was a lot of noise, perhaps because of bad reception . Ishii managed to hear Gotou though .

'That is an honour . '

<Are you an idiot?>

'I-I apologise . '

<Anyway... we found Yakumo . >

'Eh? Really!?' yelled Ishii, jumping up .

<Don't be so loud . >

'I-I apologise . Was he really in the Sea of Trees then?'

<Yeah, he was . >

While Ishii was relieved upon hearing Gotou's reply, he had a question .

That would mean that the call to Haruka had been correct . Why would the abductor tell Haruka the abductee's location?

Ishii expressed his question to Gotou .

<I don't know . Anyway, we have to take Yakumo to a hospital first . >

'T-that's right . '

<Then I'll call you again later . >

After Gotou said that, he hung up .

'They found him?' said Miyagawa after Ishii was done .

'Yes, it appears that way . '

'That's a relief . '

'Well, that's true, but...'

Ishii just couldn't be completely happy .

He didn't understand the perpetrator's intentions at all . What on earth had they wanted to do –

'What's with that displeased face?'

'Ah, actually...'

Ishii told Miyagawa the question he had asked Gotou .

'That's...'

Miyagawa stopped talking halfway and became silent .

He probably couldn't find an answer either, but if they didn't solve this question, they wouldn't solve this case . Ishii felt that way .

10

'Let's go then . '

After Gotou finished his call with Ishii, he carried Yakumo, with Haruka's help .

He stepped forward with that heavy weight on his back .

It was slippery so he couldn't move forward as he wanted . It became hard for him to breathe .

'Gotou-san, are you all right?'

Haruka sounded concerned as she lit up the ground with the torch .

It would be pretty tough to walk through the Sea of Trees with Yakumo on his back, but Gotou still didn't plan on stopping here .

Gotou had decided long ago that he would carry this weight, so –

'This is nothing . He's light . '

Gotou showed Haruka a smile .

It wasn't a lie . If Gotou compared it to the weight Yakumo carried from seeing the spirits of the dead, it was nothing .

Gotou told himself that and went forward .

It took much more time, but he managed to get out of the forest and carry Yakumo to the car .

'Ooph!'

He was exhausted . He put Yakumo down by the car and stretched .

His back cracked loudly .

He had called the ambulance before calling Ishii . They should be here soon .

'Are you all right?'

'I'm fine . '

Gotou looked Yakumo .

Though it was faint, Gotou felt like Yakumo's eyelids had moved .

'Yakumo-kun...'

Haruka seemed to notice that too and she peered at Yakumo's face .

'Ah...'

With a moan, Yakumo slowly lifted his head .

– I'm so glad .

Gotou was relieved, but that was only for a moment .

Yakumo's eyes slowly opened .

His red left eye looked right at Gotou .

Gotou shuddered subconsciously . That eye was just so cold .

'Yakumo-kun . '

Haruka tried to approach Yakumo .

'Keep away!'

Gotou grabbed Haruka's shoulder to stop her .

'Why?'

'That... isn't Yakumo...' Gotou said, looking at Yakumo again .

Yakumo slowly stood up .

Lit up by moonlight, his red left eye was the colour of fresh blood .

There was a faint smile on his lips . It was a terribly cold smile .

Gotou felt like he was shivering from the very core of his body .

Yakumo had had this look when Gotou first met him . Detesting everything in the world, denying his own existence .

'Dark... Complete dark...'

After standing up, Yakumo said that, the faint smile still on his lips .

'Yakumo-kun, what's wrong?' said Haruka . However, it didn't look like her words reached Yakumo's ears .

Yakumo narrowed his eyes and looked at Gotou and Haruka curiously .

Then – he started laughing loudly, shoulders shaking, as if he had gone insane .

He had completely lost his mind .

– What should I do?

'Yakumo-kun!'

While Gotou was troubled about what to do, Haruka shook off Gotou's hand .

11

Haruka stood in front of Yakumo –

'Yakumo-kun!'

The eyes looking right at her were clearly different from Yakumo's usual ones .

Haruka's body shook . Her instincts were speaking to her . It's dangerous . It's frightening . However, Haruka still stood her ground .

– I won't run .

Yakumo had braved countless dangers to save Haruka up until now . He had risked his life to save her . That was why –

No . That wasn't true . She wasn't saving him because he had saved her .

– I want Yakumo with me .

That pure emotion was what drove Haruka .

'Dark... Complete dark...'

Yakumo said that in a hoarse voice .

Perhaps Yakumo couldn't see Haruka right now . What was there was darkness –

'Yakumo-kun, it's fine . It's fine . It's not dark . '

Haruka hugged Yakumo tightly .

'Let me go!'

Yakumo thrashed wildly to fight her off .

However, Haruka just hugged him with more force .

'Haruka-chan, let go!'

She heard Gotou's voice .

However, Haruka wasn't going to let go of Yakumo . If Yakumo fell into a deep darkness, she would go with him . That was her resolve .

She didn't care what was there .

Where Yakumo was, she was . She'd rather –

'Aaaghh!'

Yakumo let out a howl just like a beast .

That echoing voice sounded like a cry for help to Haruka .

Haruka shut her eyes and hugged Yakumo's body even more tightly .

Their bodies, their minds – it was like they were melting together .

Haruka's eyes could see several spirits of the dead . Every one was filled with despair, grief and suffering .

– They must be the people who committed suicide here .

Haruka understand that not through thought but through feeling .

Why did the culprit bring Yakumo here – Haruka finally understood .

Aokigahara's Sea of Trees was filled with unfulfilled spirits who had ended their own lives .

For Yakumo, who could see the spirits of the dead, it must have been hell .
He had received the full force of the eddying negative motions .

The culprit had destroyed Yakumo this way .

'Yakumo-kun...'

Tears rolled down Haruka's cheeks –

If only she could understand just a little of the suffering Yakumo underwent .

'Yakumo-kun . '

Yakumo's body, which had been violently protesting until now, finally lost its energy . Haruka frantically stopped Yakumo's leaning body .

However, that weight quickly lightened .

She saw Gotou hugging Yakumo .

'He's heavy if you're carrying him yourself, right?'

Gotou smiled, looking embarrassed .

'Gotou-san . '

'Sorry . I just got the jitters...'

As Gotou said that, his expression looked somewhat cheerful –

Ishii greeted the morning with his face on his desk .

This made the second day in a row . Miyagawa leant back on his seat at the opposite desk, snoring while sleeping .

Ishii's head felt heavy . He had discussed a number of things with Miyagawa last night, but they hadn't come up with an explanation in the end .

After sighing, Ishii recalled something important . He hadn't told Makoto that Yakumo had been found . She must have been worried too .

Ishii hurriedly took out his mobile and called Makoto .

<Hello, Hijikata speaking . >

He heard a hoarse voice from the other end of the phone .

'I apologise for calling so early in the morning . It's Ishii . '

<Ah, Ishii-san . >

'I just wanted to tell you that Yakumo was found safely last night...'

<Really?>

Makoto's voice became suddenly brighter .

When Ishii heard that, for some reason he was the one who was relieved .

'Yes . Detective Gotou contacted me last night . It appears he was taken to Aokigahara's Sea of Trees . '

<Is he all right?>

Makoto's voice grew lower .

'Eh?'

<Aokigahara's Sea of Trees is a famous spot for suicides . If Yakumo-kun, who can see ghosts, went there...>

Ishii understand even without Makoto finishing .

To be honest, Ishii hadn't thought that far, but now that he did, it was terrible .

For somebody who could see spirits, it was probably like hell, with all the spirits of the dead lamenting their lack of salvation in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees . Ishii felt a chill run down his spine just from imagining it .

'I will confirm with Detective Gotou afterwards . '

Just as Ishii hung up, the door to the Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room opened .

Shimamura came into the room .

'Ah, good morning . '

Ishii hurriedly stood up and greeted her .

Miyagawa woke up in response . 'What, it's you, Shima?' he said in a gravelly voice as he stretched .

'Honestly, I'll get sick of that,' said Shimamura, leaning against the wall .

'What happened?'

'I'm so disgusted I can't even say . '

'Eh?'

It looked like Shimamura was very angry, but Ishii didn't understand what was going on at all .

'Miyagawa-san, please do something about it,' Shimamura begged .

'Tell me what happened,' urged Miyagawa .

Shimamura took in a breath loudly before beginning her explanation .

'Rich boy Honda's started saying today that Imoto, the one who died in his flat, committed suicide . '

'With what proof?' asked Ishii, which made Shimamura frown .

'I wouldn't be angry if he had proof . That spoiled idiot was told by higher-ups to solve the case already, so he's trying to clean it up quickly by calling it suicide . '

'That's awful,' agreed Miyagawa .

Though Ishii didn't say it aloud, he felt the same way .

Honda had left Ishii and Miyagawa out of the investigation because they thought it wasn't a suicide, and he'd questioned Aoi Hideaki about the case, but now, just because the higher-ups told him to, he was saying it was a suicide . It was incredibly untrustworthy .

'So what are you going to do?' Miyagawa asked Shimamura .

'Like I can do anything . The Aokigahara case that we're working on with the Yamanashi precinct isn't going well, so it's being pushed that way . '

'I see . '

Miyagawa lit a cigarette with a grim expression .

The higher-ups had probably urged them to solve the apartment case sooner because they were angry that there had been no progress with the Sea of Trees case with Hiyaama .

Even though they had both had lives, they were prioritising the more sensational one . It was a sad reality .

'Come to think of it, I heard something interesting about the Aokigahara case . '

Shimamura clapped her hands together .

'What is it?'

Ishii leant forward in interest .

'Last night, some nearby residents spotted two men climbing the religious group's building walls and escaping . We don't know if they were petty thieves or believers, but it might have something to do with the case . '

– Oh no .

They couldn't ever say it was them . In contrast to Ishii's panic, Miyagawa was stifling laughter .

'I think you don't have to worry about those two,' Ishii said timidly .

'Why?'

'No, even if you say that...'

Miyagawa couldn't hold back his laughter when he saw Ishii so flustered .

Shimamura looked confused as to what was happening .

'Those two people were Ishii and me,' explained Miyagawa .

'Wha?'

Shimamura's eyes went wide in shock .

When Miyagawa saw that response, he started laughing even more loudly .

'Really... I want to join the Unsolved Cases Special Investigation Room too now . '

Ishii had thought Shimamura would be angry, but unexpectedly, she said that and left .

'So what now?' Miyagawa asked once he had calmed down .

'Shall we try talking to Aoi Hideaki-shi once more?' said Ishii, still unsure .

The apartment case had been determined to be a suicide, but it hadn't been solved at all . There had to be something there, and Aoi Hideaki had the key .

'I've come this far . I'll go with you to the end,' said Miyagawa as he stood up .

'Thank you . '

13

Makoto put her head on her desk at work .

She had been investigating a number of things last night and had barely slept .

The case that she had thought was simple at first had unexpectedly deep roots, making it impossible to see all of it at once .

She had been thinking the whole time when Ishii called her this morning too .

Even though she should have been happy that Yakumo had been saved, she felt anxious .

He had been found in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees .

It was an evil forest where countless spirits who had ended their own lives writhed . Yakumo must have experienced something unimaginable there .

Something so strong it could make his perspective – his character crumble –

Even if his body was fine, it didn't mean his heart was . It was very possible that he was no longer himself .

A call from Takizawa interrupted Makoto's thoughts .

'Hello, Hijikata speaking . '

<Sorry for calling so early . >

Takizawa sounded exhausted . He might not have slept much either .

'No, not at all . '

<About that thing you asked me to do yesterday... It's a bit strange . >

'What do you mean?'

<I got information about the time when Jikoukoushinkai was in Yamanashi... People had a pretty good impression of it . >

'Is that true?'

Though Makoto's voice sounded surprised, that wasn't how she really felt .

The theory in the back of her mind was becoming more real .

<They didn't have believers until two years ago . Minegishi Kyouka and Hiyama Kenichirou had just been doing fortune telling and consultations . >

'That couldn't be called a religious group . '

<Yeah, they legally registered as a religious group two years ago . >

'Is that so...'

Did something really happen to Jikoukoushinkai two years ago?

That had turned them completely around . It probably had something to do with Minegishi Kyouka and Hiyama Kenichirou's dispute .

<The local police said they cared for the people who tried to commit suicide in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees and listened to their problems . >

'Cared for people who tried to commit suicide...'

It was clearly different from how Jikoukoushinkai was now .

<It seems like they started researching ghosts afterwards . >

'Research?'

<Yeah . They were trying to explain the existence of ghosts scientifically . >

'Explain it scientifically . '

Makoto thought it over while taking notes .

The word scientifically just didn't sit right with her . Right now, Jikoukoushinkai was focussed on worshipping mountains – it was completely a religious group .

There was no science about it .

<And this is what interested me most...>

Takizawa spoke with airs of importance .

'What is it?'

<Minegishi Kyouka says she can see ghosts, right?>

'Yes . '

<There's a rumour that Hiyama Kenichirou was the one who could see them . >

'Eh?' exclaimed Makoto .

Hiyama, not Minegishi, was the one who could see – if that was true, she would have to think things over completely .

Makoto swallowed her confusion and hung up on Takizawa .

14

– Thank you .

Haruka heard a voice as she slept .

It was a very kind and pleasant voice .

– Who could it be?

Haruka slowly opened her eyes . She saw white sheets . The sun's light reflecting off of them made it seem like they were sparkling .

– Where am I?

Haruka quickly recalled what had happened last night .

After Yakumo had fainted, the ambulance arrived . They took him to a nearby general hospital .

According to the doctor, Yakumo's body temperature was low and he was exhausted, but his life wasn't in danger .

In her worry, Haruka had watched over Yakumo sleeping in his bed, and it looked like she had fallen asleep herself .

'Yakumo-kun!' said Haruka, sitting up immediately .

Yakumo was sitting on the bed and looking out the window . In the morning sun, his body seemed to glow .

– Thank goodness .

It looked like his body was fine, but Haruka suddenly remembered something else .

She had another concern . Yakumo had completely lost his mind then . Even if he had looked like Yakumo, it had felt like something completely different was inside .

– How is Yakumo’s mind?

'Yakumo-kun...' Haruka called out again .

Yakumo slowly turned around .

The light from behind him made it so that Haruka couldn't see his expression clearly .

– It's Yakumo-kun, right?

Haruka held her breath and softly touched her necklace with the red stone .

For a while, Yakumo said nothing . He just looked at Haruka . It felt like forever .

Finally, he slowly opened his mouth .

'Thank you...'

'Eh?'

'You called my name, didn't you?'

'Your name?'

'Yeah . When it was completely dark and I couldn't see the light, I had lost myself... but I heard it . Your voice . Your voice calling my name...'

'Yakumo-kun...'

– You came back .

Haruka felt that . The person in front of her was Yakumo, no doubt about it .

'That voice became a light for me... Thank you for calling me . '

Yakumo looked embarrassed as he smiled . Then, his hand touched Haruka's cheek .

Haruka tried to hold it back, but that warmth made her burst into tears .

'I'm so glad... I'm really glad...'

No matter how she tried to keep them in, the tears kept coming out .

Haruka tried to cover her face with her hand so that Yakumo wouldn't see her face covered in tears, but Yakumo grabbed that hand .

'It's the second time that you've saved me . . '

'I'll do it any time...'

Haruka shook her head .

The number didn't matter . If anything happened to Yakumo, she would go save him without any hesitation . The reason was that for Haruka, Yakumo's existence itself was her light .

Just as Haruka was about to embrace Yakumo, the hospital room door opened .

'Sorry to bother . '

It was Gotou .

Haruka hurriedly backed away from Yakumo and wiped her tears .

'Oh, am I really a bother right now?'

After looking at Haruka and Yakumo, Gotou smirked and tried to leave the hospital .

'You aren't . '

Yakumo was the one who spoke .

'Don't worry about me . I'll let you be alone a bit longer . '

'Gotou-san!' said Haruka .

If he left now, she'd be the one who felt awkward .

'What?' complained Gotou, but he still sat on the chair by the bed .

'I need to thank you as well, Gotou-san,' Yakumo said formally, looking at Gotou .

However, Gotou just waved his hand .

'Stop that . If you thank me, something unlucky will definitely happen . '

'That's an awful way to put it . '

Yakumo smiled wryly .

'I just followed my own beliefs . '

After Gotou said that, he scratched his nose, looking like he felt embarrassed .

— That's just like Gotou-san .

Haruka felt that . Gotou hadn't saved Yakumo for his thanks . He had just done it because he wanted to .

'So who assaulted you?' said Gotou after clearing his throat .

'I didn't see their face . However... I know who it is . '

'Eh?'

Haruka spoke up without thinking .

15

'What are you saying?'

Gotou leant forward from his seat by the bed to ask Yakumo that .

Yakumo said that he knew who had abducted him . His confident expression made it seem like he understood everything .

'I can't say right now . '

'Wha?'

Gotou's brow furrowed .

– It's started again .

Yakumo hated speaking when he only had speculation . Therefore, even if he understood something in his head, he didn't say it out loud . As a result, Gotou was pushed around without knowing anything .

'The corpse found at Aokigahara's Sea of Trees . Aoi Yuuka, who was robbed . The man who committed suicide . These three incidents are connected . '

Yakumo had said that before too .

Gotou and the others had run forward believing in those words, but Gotou felt like they had just wasted their time since they hadn't been able to find the connection .

'How are they connected?' asked Gotou .

Yakumo's expression suddenly became grimmer .

It was an unusually frightening expression .

'It is because they are connected that the order is important . '

'The order?'

Haruka cocked her head before Gotou could .

'What are you talking about?' Gotou pressed, like he was landing the final blow .

'The order that will reveal the truth . If that order is incorrect, there will be victims . '

After saying that, Yakumo cast down his eyes, just slightly .

Yakumo looked like he was suffering . Even when he had been at the hospital before being abducted, he had been suffering like this .

Gotou had a ton of things he wanted to ask, but after coming this far, he decided to just go with Yakumo until the end without saying anything .

If he did that, Yakumo's suffering should become lighter, even if just by a little .

'So what should we do?' asked Gotou with resolve .

'You'll help?'

Yakumo's eyes went wide in surprise .

He wasn't used to other people's kindness . This was one of Yakumo's cute points .

'I planned on doing that from the start . '

'Well, that is natural . It was your possession that made things so troublesome from the start,' said Yakumo, running hand through his messy hair .

'What kind of tone is that? You should thank me honestly at times like this .
,

'Didn't you say that something unlucky would happen if I thanked you?'
Yakumo said triumphantly .

– What a hateful brat .

But it felt like Yakumo had finally returned – it made Gotou happy . This was thanks to Haruka, who had faced Yakumo head-on without running away .

When Gotou looked at Haruka, she cocked her head, looking confused .

'Let's stop the pointless chitchat now . Please contact Makoto-san . '

Yakumo put his index finger to his brow and started his explanation .

'The newspaper woman? What do you want to ask?'

'Jikoukoushinkai was based in Yamanashi before . Please ask for the location . '

'Are you planning on going?'

'That is... if it remains . '

Yakumo smirked, looking amused .

Since Yakumo had said it, there was probably something there .

'Got it . '

'Also, please contact Ishii-san . '

'What do you want to ask him?'

'I'm not asking – I have a message . '

'A message?'

'Yes . A message from me . '

When Yakumo finished speaking, he slowly stood up . Though his expression was blank, it was frightening enough to give Gotou a chill down his spine .

16

'Gotou-san, I'm just glad you're OK,' Makoto said happily when Gotou called her .

<Yeah, somehow . >

'So, Yakumo-kun...' asked Makoto, gulping .

That was the biggest reason for her anxiety . He had gone into Aokigahara's Sea of Trees . It shouldn't have been an easy trip .

<Fit as a fiddle . >

'Really?'

To be honest, Makoto couldn't believe it .

<For a while, I was worried, but Haruka-chan called that guy back . >

When Makoto heard that, she relaxed .

Yakumo had Haruka . She would probably save Yakumo no matter what she had to sacrifice .

At first, Makoto had thought that Haruka was just a girl who cried all the time, but that impression had changed .

Haruka had a strong will and lived straightforwardly .

Her feelings for Yakumo had probably made her stronger . Being able to love someone so much was a happy thing .

'I'm envious...'

Makoto hadn't been planning on saying it, but the words slipped out of her mouth .

<Of what?>

Gotou had heard Makoto's words to herself . It was so embarrassing she felt like her face was on fire .

'N-nothing,' Makoto said hurriedly .

<Well, that's fine . I've got a request . >

'For... me?'

<Yeah . Yakumo asked . Jikoukoushinkai was based in Yamanashi before, right?>

'Yes . '

<He wants you to tell him the location . >

'Does he plan to go there?'

<Seems like it . >

This timing – Yakumo might have been thinking the same thing as Makoto .

Makoto told Gotou the address she had heard from Takizawa . Takizawa had said there was still an empty building there .

<Got it . >

'Er, I don't know if this will be helpful or not, but...'

Maokto stopped Gotou, who had been about to hang up, and told him the news she had heard from Takizawa about Jikoukoushinkai earlier .

Perhaps it would be the key to solving the puzzle . That was what Makoto thought .

<Then it wasn't a religious group there like it is now . >

That was what Gotou said after Makoto finished her explanation .

'Yes, it seems that way . '

<I'm even more confused . >

'I feel the same way . '

<Anyway, thanks . >

'No, I didn't...'

<I'll call again if there's anything else . >

'Please wait . '

Makoto called out to Gotou for the second time .

She had forgotten to say something important .

<What?>

'Please be careful . '

'Got it . '

After saying that, Gotou hung up .

Something terrible will happen – though it was vague, Makoto had that feeling .

Ishii received Gotou's call when he was about to leave the precinct .

'D-Detective Gotou!'

<Don't speak so loud . >

'I-I apologise... How is Yakumo-shi?'

<He's probably flirting with Haruka-chan right now . >

Gotou probably said that carelessly, but Ishii had complicated feelings about it .

Ishii had felt painfully during the incident one month ago that Haruka only had Yakumo in her eyes . Even though he should have been unbound now from his unattainable love, his feelings were swayed .

– Love is a strange thing .

<How are things on your end?>

Gotou asked that question .

Come to think of it, their call had ended after Ishii was told that Yakumo was safe .

He hadn't told Gotou anything about his information .

'That...'

When Ishii told Gotou that he and Miyagawa had infiltrated Jikoukoushinkai, Gotou burst out laughing .

Ishii glanced at Miyagawa . He was smoking, looking bored as he waited for Ishii to end the call .

He was keeping quiet because he knew Ishii was talking to Gotou .

<So what happened?>

Gotou urged Ishii to continue, still laughing .

'Ah... That...'

Ishii explained what how Minegishi Kyouka had looked when he peered in from the window .

<What?>

That was what Gotou said first off after Ishii finished his explanation .

'I think she might have been possessed by a ghost...'

<The founder, possessed by a ghost?>

Gotou's voice screeched in surprise .

'That's just my theory though . '

<Your theories can't be counted on . >

'I-I apologise...'

It was true . Since Ishii couldn't see ghosts like Yakumo, his theories weren't very trustable . However –

<So what are you going to do next?>

That was Gotou's next question .

'Actually, I was thinking of going to speak with Aoi Hideaki-shi . '

<That's perfect . >

'Eh?'

<Actually, I've got a message for you to give to Hideaki . >

'You do, Detective Gotou...?'

<No, not me . A message from Yakumo . >

'Ah . '

Ishii understood now .

He'd heard that Yakumo and Hideaki had been classmates in high school .
Perhaps the message was of a personal nature .

However, the message that came from Gotou's mouth was not what Ishii
had imagined .

'Is that definitely it?'

It was so unexpected that Ishii had to confirm it .

<Yeah . >

'What does it mean?'

<Like I know . >

Gotou gave a careless reply .

Since it was Yakumo, he had probably not told Gotou the meaning of or
reason for the message . He was always like that . He didn't reveal the truth
until the end .

However, it was a fact that he had always shown them the correct paths .

'I understand . I'll pass on the message . When will you be back, Detective
Gotou?'

<Who knows . Taking a bit of a detour now . >

'Detour?'

<Anyway, that's how it is . >

Gotou hung up .

'Gotou?'

Ishii was still a bit dumbfounded when Miyagawa spoke .

'Ah, yes . '

'What'd he say?'

'Er... I don't really know . '

'I see . Well, that's fine, isn't it?'

Miyagawa's voice was incredibly bright .

'Eh?'

'We've come this far . Why not keep going?'

'That's true,' agreed Ishii .

There was no point thinking about things now . No matter what conclusion awaited them, after coming this far, all they could do was go with Yakumo's speculations .

18

'Are you really all right?' said Haruka to Yakumo, who had changed quickly and left the hospital .

So much had happened . Haruka thought it would be better for him to take more of a break .

'There isn't enough time . '

Yakumo stopped and turned around .

His expression was terribly cold .

'Time?'

'Yeah . If I don't hurry, I won't be able to save anyone . '

After saying that, he looked up at the snow-capped Mt Fuji .

Though it was only three hours by car from Tokyo, when Haruka saw that grand form, it felt like they had gone incredibly far .

'Save?'

'Save is an exaggeration . '

Yakumo smiled self-derisively .

'Exaggeration?'

'Yeah . Salvation might be impossible to find anywhere . What I'm trying to do is probably just self-satisfaction...'

'Eh?'

'In that forest... when I was surrounded by spirits who had committed suicide, I realised how powerless I am . No matter high and mighty I might act, there is no way I can save all the people who died there . '

'Yeah . '

That was probably true . Not even a god could bring salvation to all the people in the world .

'The people in that forest had no salvation anywhere . That was why they ended their lives . '

'That's so... sad . '

After saying that, Haruka bit her lip .

Haruka couldn't see the spirits of the dead . It was difficult for her to understand what Yakumo had experienced .

However, she could imagine it . Many people had chosen to end their own lives in that forest .

It was undeniably fact that many people had been forced to take that choice in this world .

'I guess it is sad... But I want to save them, if it's possible . '

'Yes . '

'But for one person to save another – it's just ego . '

'Eh?'

Haruka felt an impact, like somebody had thrust her back .

– That's not true .

Haruka tried to say that, but the words didn't come out of her mouth . It was because she could kind of understand what Yakumo was trying to say .

Is life salvation? For the people who ended their lives in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees, death might have been their only salvation .

'But I still want to save them . Even if it is ego, I don't want somebody to die in front of my eyes . '

'Of course . '

Something warm welled up within Haruka's chest .

That was why Yakumo was Yakumo . No matter the circumstances, he couldn't abandon somebody suffering in front of him .

'And if this case continues, I can't guarantee that her life will be safe . '

Yakumo narrowed his eyes in the sunlight and ran his hand through his hair .

'By her, do you mean Yuuka-san?'

'I do . '

'How is this incident related to Yuuka-san's life?'

'I'll talk about it afterwards,' said Yakumo . Then, he started walking toward the parking lot .

Everything was wrapped in smoke again . When Yakumo was like this, no matter how Haruka pressed him, he wouldn't talk .

Though Haruka felt unsatisfied, she chased after Yakumo .

'Oh, you're here?'

Gotou waved at them from in front of a red Mini Cooper in the parking lot .

'You're early . You two could've spent some more time alone,' said Gotou, smirking the moment Haruka and Yakumo arrived .

The incident from earlier in the hospital came back to Haruka and she went red to her ears from embarrassment .

'Please stop that already,' Haruka said angrily, but Gotou wasn't listening .

'Why don't the two of you stay at a hot spring inn overnight?'

– The two of us at a hot spring inn overnight .

Haruka wanted to object, but Yakumo spoke before she could .

'Next time then . '

Yakumo said that with a blank expression . He was probably just dealing with Gotou, but Haruka felt strangely self-conscious . Next time – would

there be one?

'More importantly, let's go,' Yakumo said with a stiff expression .

'OK,' Gotou replied .

Haruka nodded too, after clearing her head of silly thoughts .

19

Ishii sat opposite Aoi Hideaki .

There was a broken wall clock at a privately-owned little cafe near the station .

Smoking was forbidden . Miyagawa played with the unlit cigarette on the table .

'So what did you need today?' said Hideaki after the coffee they ordered arrived .

The police had questioned him a number of times . Still, he did not seem resentful or irritated .

Normally, people would have expressed their anger . It wouldn't have been strange if he had a complaint or two .

— Where does his calm come from?

Ishii had that question as he looked at Hideaki .

'About ghosts . '

'You can't believe me... That's what you want to say, right?'

'No, actually, I've met Saitou Yakumo-shi as well... His help has solved a number of cases, so...'

'Is that so?'

Hideaki's face became instantly brighter .

It was a childish expression, completely different from his calm from before .

'I'm asking this as a personal question, but what is it like to see?'

Miyagawa looked displeased, furrowing his brow beside Ishii .

His response made sense . This had nothing to do with the case . It was just Ishii's curiosity .

Though he had been with Yakumo for so long, strangely, he had never asked .

'What is it like?'

'In short, how do the ghosts appear...'

When Ishii asked that, Hideaki smiled, seeming amused .

'Detective, you're an interesting person . '

'Eh?'

'I never thought that a detective would ask me that . '

'Is that so?'

'Yes . In my case, unlike Saitou, I can't see them clearly . '

'Is that so?'

'Yes . It's like a vague shadow . Well, if the spirit's emotions are strong, sometimes I can see them clearly . '

Hideaki seemed very lively as he talked about ghosts .

It was like he was proud of it . It was the opposite reaction to Yakumo, who stubbornly tried to hide it .

'When did you start being able to see?'

'Before I noticed, I could see them . Perhaps it's just my blood...'

'Blood...'

'Ishii!'

Miyagawa elbowed Ishii's side .

Get to the point already – was probably what Miyagawa wanted to say . If Ishii talked about anything else unrelated, Miyagawa would really get angry .

Ishii cleared his throat .

'I apologise for getting off track . I have something I'd like to ask about the case...'

'What is it?'

'The ghost of Imoto, who assaulted your sister, went to the hospital . You saw him... correct?'

'Yes . '

'There's one thing I don't understand . '

'What is it?'

'If Imoto-shi felt guilty, why didn't he go to the hospital when he was alive?'

The investigation couldn't find proof for murder – that passive reason was why it was determined that Imoto had committed suicide .

Ishii would have determined it was a suicide from the scene too .

However, the motive just seemed off . If Imoto felt guilty enough to kill himself for a robbery, it would be more of a retribution to confess to the police .

Perhaps people thought differently, but there was also the life insurance .

– Something is definitely off .

Hideaki took a sip of coffee and looked up as he thought . Miyagawa stopped fiddling with the cigarette to watch Hideaki's odd change in demeanour .

There was a long silence –

'I don't know . I can only see . '

For such a long pause, it was a harmless answer .

Ishii had the impression that Hideaki was a cunning person .

'Is that all?'

Hideaki narrowed his eyes as he looked at Ishii .

'Do you have other plans?'

'I want to visit my sister . '

As Hideaki said that, his eyes were sad .

His sister, Yuuka, was still in a comatose state . She was the only person who knew the truth .

Even though the case would advance so much if they could just talk to her –

'Understood . There's just one more thing . '

Ishii took in a deep breath and looked at Hideaki .

Hideaki looked suspicious, like he sensed something from that gaze .

'What is it?'

'Yakumo-shi has a message . '

'A message?'

Ishii took out his memo and read what was written there .

'I understand what your sister wants to save . She wants to save you . '

After reading that, Ishii looked at Hideaki .

He was frozen, like time had stopped .

'Detective . Please stop with the lies . '

After a silence, Hideaki smiled bitterly .

'It isn't a lie . Yakumo-shi was abducted by someone yesterday, but he was found safely and should be coming here today . '

'Is that so . I'm glad...'

In contrast to his words, Hideaki didn't sound happy at all .

The atmosphere became heavy along with Hideaki's mood, and for a while, nobody said anything .

'Detective . '

How long was it before he spoke? Hideaki suddenly looked up .

'What is it?'

'I'm the one who killed Hiyama Kenichirou . '

Ishii was at a loss for words upon hearing Hideaki's confession .

20

Gotou looked out the window as he drove the Mini Cooper .

He had reached the Kawaguchi lakeshore . The lake's surface reflected Mount Fuji with its red leaves – it was quite a sight . If there weren't a case, Gotou would have liked to stop the car and appreciate its beauty .

He looked at the rear-view mirror to see the backseat, where Yakumo was sleeping, arms crossed .

He'd said a lot, but he had to be exhausted .

'Gotou-san . '

Haruka spoke from the passenger seat .

'What is it?'

'Gotou-san, you met with Yakumo-kun in high school too, right?'

'Yeah . '

Gotou had started really interacting with Yakumo because of an incident when he was in the third year of middle school .

'What was Yakumo-kun like then?'

Gotou went back through his memories .

'It felt like he was just running after cases . '

'So Yakumo-kun was involved with cases then too . '

Haruka's eyes went wide in surprise .

At that time, Gotou went to Yakumo whenever anything happened . Though part of it was because he was using that ability of his, Gotou felt like it was just an excuse to interact with Yakumo .

'Yeah . So many things happened that I couldn't tell you it all . '

'That many?'

'Yeah . Almost died a few times too . '

'How was he in school?' asked Haruka .

Unfortunately, Gotou couldn't answer .

'Hm... He almost never talked about school . '

'Is that so?'

'Yeah...'

Gotou felt a bit of hatred for himself .

He had planned on watching over Yakumo, but in the end, he might have just used him for investigations .

'I see...'

Haruka looked at her lap, seeming a bit let down .

When Gotou saw her profile, he remembered just one thing .

'Come to think of it, I don't remember exactly when, but Yakumo saved a girl who was in the same high school . '

'Eh?'

Haruka's eyes flashed open in surprise .

'There was a pair of corpses – wife and husband – that were found in the river . '

'The river?'

'Yeah . The investigation found out they'd been hit by a car . '

'That's awful...'

Haruka pressed a hand against her chest .

Gotou felt the same way . The culprit had thrown the corpses into the river after hitting the husband and wife to erase the evidence .

Come to think of it, something similar had happened to Haruka .

'The police had started their investigation on a bigger scale when a man confessed . '

'At least there was that . '

Gotou shook his head .

'Unfortunately, that wasn't the case . '

'What do you mean?'

'The true culprit was the son of the man who confessed . '

'So the father confessed to hide his son's crimes?'

Haruka's disgust was obvious .

'That's how it is . But somebody realised the truth . '

'Yakumo-kun . '

'No, before that, the victim's daughter realised the truth . The real culprit – the brat – thought it'd be bad, so he kidnapped her to try to keep her quiet .

,

'Keep her quiet...'

The anger was apparent on Haruka's face .

He was a really awful guy . He didn't care about other people's lives if it was to save his own skin .

'So Yakumo and me noticed the same thing, so we went to save her and catch the real perp . '

'So the girl saved then was Aoi Yuuka-san,' said Haruka .

'I think that was her name... Ah!'

Gotou finally realised .

'I can't believe you just remembered that . '

The one who interrupted was Yakumo, who was supposed to be sleeping .

After rubbing his eyes, he let out a large yawn .

'You were awake?'

'Your voice was so loud that I couldn't sleep properly, Gotou-san . '

Yakumo was as hateful as always .

Gotou should've just left him in the Sea of Trees .

'My bad . '

'Honestly . There is something wrong with your memory,' Yakumo said, sounding disappointed .

'S-shut up...'

Though Gotou objected, there was no power in his voice .

He had always had that connection to the case, but he'd just remembered it now .

'I thought that you were talking about it because you knew, Gotou-san . '

Haruka was looking at Gotou critically too .

'Yeah, yeah, my memory is bad,' said Gotou with a click of his tongue .

'After that incident, Hideaki quit high school and started working so that his sister could continue to live the way she had,' Yakumo said in a flat voice .

'It must've been tough . '

Those were Gotou's true feelings .

Catching the culprit didn't take back the lives that had been stolen away .
Cases warped people's lives .

'No, he didn't feel pain from that . Rather, he was happy . I didn't understand that feeling then . '

– So you understand it now?

Gotou wanted to ask that, but he stopped, since it felt like Yakumo would make fun of him for it .

'A big brother who cares for his little sister,' said Haruka .

However, Yakumo shook his head .

'Those two aren't real siblings . When their parents remarried, they were both kids from previous marriages who became siblings . '

'Eh? Really?'

'They're not even real siblings, and he'd go so far?' asked Haruka .

According to Yakumo's story, even though they were siblings, they weren't related by blood at all . They could be called complete strangers . But –

'There are bonds even when people aren't connected by blood . Sometimes, there are bonds even thicker than blood . '

After saying that, Yakumo looked out the window .

– Bonds even thicker than blood .

Gotou understood now that he'd taken Nao in and was raising her as his child . Even if they were just complete strangers, he would do anything for Nao's sake .

People's bonds did not come only from blood .

21

'What do you mean by that?' asked Ishii, leaning forward .

–I'm the one who killed Hiyama Kenichirou .

Hideaki had said that . In contrast to the weight of those words, his expression was incredibly calm .

'I mean exactly what I said . I killed Hiyama-san,' repeated Hideaki calmly .

'W-what are you talking about?'

Ishii cleared his throat, gulped and finally managed to ask that question .

'Hiyama-san tried to use me . '

'Use?'

'Yes . Hiyama-san's Jikoukoushinkai claimed to be able to see ghosts . '

'Yes . '

Ishii knew about that .

'But they didn't have that ability . I found out . '

'Because... you can see ghosts?' said Ishii .

Hideaki nodded .

'What's that got to do with killing him?' interrupted Miyagawa with a suspicious look .

That was the biggest problem . Being able or unable to see ghosts wasn't a reason to kill someone .

'Hiyama-san tried to get me to join Jikoukoushinkai to expand the group, since I can see ghosts . '

'Join...'

If Hideaki really could see ghosts, Jikoukoushinkai would be desperate to have him .

'Even though I kept refusing, they kept soliciting me . In the end, they even came to my workplace...'

'And you killed him for that?'

'I didn't plan on killing him, but when that man realised I wouldn't respond, he started to threaten my sister . '

'Could it be...'

Ishii had an idea .

Imoto, who had committed suicide in his apartment, had been in Jikoukoushinkai .

'That man ordered one of the believers to attack my sister . When I returned home, I found my sister collapsed...'

At this stage, Hideaki's face, which had been like a Noh mask, twisted .

Tears welled up in his eyes, and his voice grew faint . He seemed so weak that he might collapse at any moment .

Perhaps he felt guilty for involving his sister Yuuka .

Ishii didn't want to press any further, but as a detective, he had to .

'Then what did you do?'

'I figured out that Hiyama-san was related right away . First, I called an ambulance to take my sister to the hospital . Then, I called out Hiyama-san .

'I couldn't forgive him... I couldn't forgive that man for doing that to my sister...'

Tears rolled down Hideaki's cheeks .

What a sad case – it was intolerable for Ishii .

Just because Hideaki could see ghosts, a religious group had pursued him this far and hurt his only family, his sister .

Even though it had been for revenge, murder was unforgiveable . Ishii knew that, but he still felt sympathy for Hideaki .

'Why did you take him all the way to Aokigahara's Sea of Trees?'

Miyagawa spoke up in Ishii's stead, since Ishii was at a loss for words .

'That was where Jikoukoushinkai's base had been before . I thought that the police investigation would focus on the religious group if I left him there...'
replied Hideaki with a snifle . His thoughts weren't wrong .

The police suspected Jikoukoushinkai's higher-ups, and had thought it was an internal incident with the believers and founder .

When Hideaki finished talking, a new question came to Ishii .

'Why did you feel like talking?'

Hideaki's expression was inscrutable .

'Saitou Yakumo . '

'Was it that message?'

'Yes . I understood after hearing it that he already realised the truth behind the case... so... '

Hideaki shivered .

Ishii realised something when he saw that .

'You were the one who abducted Yakumo-shi,' said Ishii, carefully but firmly .

'Yes,' said Hideaki, shoulders slumping .

'Why did you do that?'

'Because it was possible that he would notice . '

'The truth, you mean?'

'Yes . But I couldn't kill him . That's why I thought I'd just leave him aside for a while . '

'That's why you told Haruka-chan where he was . '

Hideaki nodded .

Now Ishii understood the inexplicable call . Hideaki hadn't want Yakumo involved in the case, but at the same time, he didn't want his friend to die .

Aokigahara's Sea of Trees was a nest for spirits that had not found peace . Hideaki had probably thought that leaving Yakumo there would give him psychological damage and make it so that he couldn't move for a while .

'Saitou can see the spirits of the dead, like me . That's why I had a bad feeling when Saitou showed up . I thought he'd reveal the truth...' said Hideaki to himself .

Yakumo's message had probably conveyed that he knew the truth . Hideaki had sensed that and resolved to confess everything, knowing he wouldn't be able to run away any longer .

'Thank you for telling me . '

Ishii bowed his head .

Hideaki's eyes went wide in surprise .

'I didn't think I'd be thanked by a detective...'

Though Hideaki showed a smile, his voice sounded full of tears .

22

They could see Kawaguchi Lake from their height .

It was a tranquil place with a lot of green .

'Let's go . '

After Yakumo called out to her, Haruka ran after him .

They reached a lone two-storey home . It looked like nobody lived here now . The garden was filled with dead leaves .

'This should be the address...'

Gotou looked up at the building .

'Let's confirm that . '

Yakumo started walking briskly . He tried the doorknob, but the door appeared to be locked and wouldn't open .

'What will you do?' asked Haruka .

Yakumo smirked .

In response, Gotou went forward and kicked the door . The door opened with a crack .

'It's open,' Gotou said proudly .

What he'd done was a bit much .

'Let's go . '

Ignoring Haruka's doubts, Yakumo and Gotou went inside .

Haruka felt like she'd become a criminal one day when she was with Yakumo and Gotou . Though Haruka was pessimistic, she followed the two in .

When she went inside, she saw bookshelves all along the walls, completely filled with books .

She looked at the spines . Most of them were books related to spiritual phenomena . She could see a number of medical ones too .

'This is an amazing number of books . '

'According to Makoto-san's information, Jikoukoushinkai used to seriously study spiritual phenomena,' said Yakumo, running a finger along a book's spine .

'So these are the ones that have been left behind?'

Gotou opened a cardboard box in the corner of the room and pulled out files and notebooks .

Just from looking at this room, it felt more like a research facility than a religious group .

'Why do you think they were researching so much?' Yakumo asked .

Gotou cocked his head .

'Who knows . '

'Perhaps to make a religious group afterwards...'

When Haruka said the first thing that came to mind, Yakumo looked incredibly displeased .

'If they had been planning to become a religious group from the start, they would keep those books, wouldn't they?'

Just as Yakumo said, the bookshelves didn't seem to have any relation to religion . Maybe they weren't interested .

'Then what are we supposed to search for here?'

'For something . '

Yakumo replied vaguely to Gotou's question and went into a room in the back .

Haruka and Gotou looked at each other .

'"Something", he says . '

Gotou's grumbling made sense .

They had no way of helping if they didn't know what to search for .

'First, let's check what's inside that box . '

Since there was no point grumbling, Haruka crouched in front of the box Gotou had opened and started looking through it .

There were a number of old notebooks .

They were filled with writing . Haruka could see the word 'soul' a lot . She didn't really understand the contents .

When she went deeper into the box, she found an old album .

– What's this?

Just as Haruka was about to check, Gotou's mobile rang .

'Who's it?'

Gotou answered the phone .

He seemed to be having a serious conversation, as his voice kept getting lower . What had happened?

'W-what!?'

Suddenly, Gotou's loud voice reverberated through the room .

Haruka jolted and looked towards Gotou . Yakumo had come back from the other room to see what had happened too .

'What is it?' Yakumo asked when Gotou finished his call .

'It was Ishii . He went to question Aoi Hideaki and...'

'He confessed to killing Hiyama Kenichirou-san then . '

Yakumo spoke before Gotou .

23

'Why do you know that?'

Gotou pressed Yakumo for an answer .

Gotou had just heard the news from Ishii that Aoi Hideaki had confessed to killing Hiayama Kenichirou .

He would understand if Yakumo had been listening to the phone next to him, but Yakumo had been in another room . There was no way for him to know .

'Please don't take it so seriously,' Yakumo said calmly, in contrast to Gotou's agitation .

That attitude just riled Gotou up more .

'Of course I'm taking it seriously! Explain what you mean!'

'I gave him a message, correct?'

'Yeah . '

'I was proving whether my theory was correct with that,' said Yakumo as he crouched in front of the cardboard box, took an old album out and flipped through the pages .

'What?'

'If my theory was correct, I believed that my message would cause him to confess to the crime . '

So his theory had been correct .

'Hey, was he the one who abducted you?' said Haruka, joining the conversation .

Gotou could reply to that too .

'He confessed to that too . '

After Gotou said that, Haruka turned to Yakumo .

'It is just as he said . Aoi Hideaki was the one who abducted me . '

'Why would he do that?' said Haruka, sounding like she might cry at any moment .

Gotou wanted to know too . Ishii hadn't given the reason .

'It's simple . I had been close to the truth . '

Gotou recalled what he had been talking about with Yakumo when Yakumo had been abducted .

Yakumo had been troubled . Not about who the culprit was, but how to save them –

At the time, Yakumo had probably already known that Hideaki was the culprit .

'That's awful . So he tried to kill you – his classmate – because you got in the way?' said Gotou .

He hadn't met Hideaki, but he had thought that he had been a better person . Killing somebody to hide a crime was a terrible thing to do .

'He didn't try to kill me,' said Yakumo . Maybe he was trying to cover for him, but...

'But he...'

'If he had planned to kill me, he could have done it at any time . He was just trying to get me to leave the case . '

'Oh, so that's why he told me where you were . '

Haruka was the one who spoke .

Come to think of it, that was right . Gotou had been wondering why the abductor would go out of their way to explain where the abductee was .

Hideaki hadn't planned to kill Yakumo, but he had wanted him to keep away from the case .

He had probably left him in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees for that purpose . Putting somebody who could see spirits there would cause them a lot of psychological damage .

But Gotou thought that was worse .

'Did Aoi Hideaki know what leaving you in the Sea of Trees would do?' asked Gotou .

Yakumo smiled bitterly .

'He probably didn't understand the true meaning of it . '

To Gotou, that sounded like Yakumo's wish .

'So what are you going to do?'

In either case, Hideaki's confession had solved the case .

'Now I will lay the final touches . '

After saying that, Yakumo shut the album loudly .

24

'If he's fine, at least call to say that . Are you an idiot?' said Eishin after Gotou called . He knew it sounded like a lecture .

He was glad that Yakumo was fine, but Eishin had heard nothing about it until now . It was like Gotou, but for the people worrying about it, it was unbearable .

<I was busy too . >

'You can at least call, right?'

<You're a noisy old man . >

'Watch your tongue . Atsuko-san stayed awake all night waiting for you to call . '

<W-wait a second . Why do you know that, old man?>

'Obviously because I stayed at your house . '

<Don't just go in without asking!>

Gotou was howling on the other side of the phone .

Eishin ignored that and looked at Atsuko and Nao, who were sitting opposite him at the table .

'Anyway, it seems he's fine . '

After Eishin said that, Atsuko's expression softened .

Though she had been acting calm, she must have been terribly worried .
And still she hadn't said anything – she had silently endured it .

She really was too good for the likes of Gotou .

<Oi! Old man! You listening?>

Eishin could hear Gotou's yell from the receiver .

'I can hear you even if you don't speak so loudly . '

<Liar . Listen up . The next time you just go into somebody's house without permission, I'll beat you . >

'I'd like to see you try . I'll kick you out right away . '

Though Eishin had meant that as a joke, Atsuko's eyes went wide . In response, Nao looked anxious too .

It looked like a joke of this level was a bit harsh for these two .

'It's fine . I won't do that . '

Eishin covered the receiver and smiled at Atsuko and Nao .

<Anyway, I'm leaving that to you . >

Gotou said something on the other end of the phone .

– That?

'Eh? What are you talking about?'

<You really weren't listening!>

'Like I said, don't be so loud,' rebuked Eishin, annoyed .

After a click of his tongue, Gotou explained again .

<It's a request from Yakumo . Seems he wants you to look into this person .
>

'I'm not a detective . '

<According to Yakumo, it'd be faster to use the network of families that support the temple for this than for the police to investigate . >

'Hm . '

That could be true .

It was difficult for the police to gather detailed information, but the families that supported the temple were people who lived in the area, each with their own networks .

<He wants you to look into...>

Eishin took down Gotou's message on a memo and hung up .

'Noisy as always . '

After Eishin sighed, Atsuko finally laughed . In response, Nao smiled too .

To be honest, Eishin had been worried about this family at first .

Nao wasn't their real child . Eishin had worried about whether they could be a family – but that had been needless anxiety .

Even if they weren't connected by blood, bonds arose between people .

The Gotou family had taught Eishin that .

'Maybe I should go . '

As Eishin stood up, Atsuko did as well .

'Please stay a bit longer . '

Eishin appreciated the offer, but he couldn't just slack off .

'Sorry, maybe next time . I've got a role to play too . '

After saying that, Eishin left the room .

25

– I'll investigate it directly .

Makoto decided that while researching Jikoukoushinkai .

Thinking up theories wouldn't get her anywhere . If she went herself and met the founder, Minegishi Kyouka, she might figure something out .

Makoto grabbed her bag and stood up just as her mobile vibrated .

Unexpectedly, Yakumo's number was displayed on the screen .

'Hello, Hijikata speaking . '

<It's Saitou Yakumo . >

His voice, ever calm came through the phone .

'Are you all right?'

<Yes, somehow . >

'Is that so...'

Makoto was relieved .

She had heard from Gotou that Yakumo was fine, but she hadn't been able to clear her anxiety until she heard his voice .

<Actually, there is something I would like you to check, Makoto-san . >

'What is it?'

<I heard that you investigated Jikoukoushinkai . Please tell me what you know . Gotou-san's explanation was insufficient . >

<What do you mean by that!?!>

Makoto could hear Gotou's yell through the phone .

Makoto laughed without thinking, partly in relief .

'What I've investigated...'

Makoto sat back down, took her notebook out of her bag and explained in order the information she had gathered .

<As expected, your work is organised . >

'No, not at all . More importantly, could I share my opinion with you?' asked Makoto .

<Please go ahead . >

Yakumo gave his reply .

'Why did Jikoukoushinkai suddenly change into a religious organisation two years ago... That is the biggest puzzle . '

<It is . >

'My instincts tell me they're involved...'

<The man with two red eyes and Nanase Miyuki . >

Yakumo responded in a quiet voice .

As expected, he was quick . Perhaps he had seen the same possibility from the very start too .

'What do you think?' asked Makoto .

There was a pause .

<Makoto-san, could you perhaps be thinking of going to Jikoukoushinkai now?>

'Eh?'

That was exactly it . Makoto had a jolt . It felt like Yakumo had seen right through her .

<Please wait a bit before going . >

'Why?'

<I am heading there too . >

'Is that so?'

<Furthermore, your theory is likely correct . It would be dangerous to go alone . >

– The theory's correct .

That meant that Nanase Miyuki was there .

Makoto wanted to confirm that, but before she could, the call ended .

26

Ishii looked at the rear-view mirror while driving .

He saw Hideaki in the backseat . He was looking down and seemed to be enduring something . Next to him, Miyagawa had his arms crossed unhappily .

– Don't arrest him .

Yakumo had given those instructions through Gotou .

Hideaki had confessed . But Yakumo had said not to arrest him . Did that mean he wasn't the perpetrator?

Ishii stopped his car in front of Jikoukoushinkai's base . Yakumo had also been the one who directed him here .

What on earth is going to start – Ishii had that question as he got off the car .

'Ishii-san . '

Ishii looked towards the source of the voice and saw Makoto standing by the gate .

'Makoto-san . Did Yakumo-shi...?'

'Yes . '

Though Makoto replied, her expression showed bemusement .

It seemed like she didn't know the details either .

'So what are we going to do?' said Miyagawa, who had got off the car .
Hideaki was with him .

Since they hadn't arrested Hideaki, he wasn't handcuffed . Miyagawa had grabbed his arm to stop him from escaping, but to be honest, Ishii was uneasy .

'I... Yakumo-shi is coming now, so there's nothing to do but wait until then . '

'Honestly . '

Miyagawa let out an exasperated sigh .

Hideaki used that chance to ram himself into Miyagawa . Miyagawa fell from the surprise attack and let go of Hideaki .

– He's going to get away .

By the time Ishii thought that, it was too late . Hideaki turned on his heels and dashed off .

'Catch him!' yelled Miyagawa as he got up .

'Yes sir!' Ishii responded, but Hideaki had put some distance between them .

I don't think I'll be able to catch him – just as Ishii was about to give up, a red Mini Cooper drove up and drifted over to block Hideaki's path, parking right there .

Hideaki turned around to try to run, but Ishii and Miyagawa were there .

'Let's put an end to this already . '

The Mini Cooper's backdoor opened and Yakumo came out .

Hideaki froze upon seeing him .

'Saitou Yakumo...' said Hideaki, gasping .

'No matter how you deny it, I will reveal the truth . '

Yakumo looked at Hideaki .

Upon receiving that gaze, Hideaki ground his teeth together in frustration and looked down . Miyagawa took that chance to grab Hideaki's arm .

'Like we'd like you get away!' said Gotou as he got out of the driver's seat .

Haruka came out the passenger seat .

'D-Detective Gotou . And Haruka-chan . '

Ishii hurriedly ran over to them only to receive a fist from Gotou on his head .

A hot, prickling pain ran through Ishii, but it made him happy .

'So what are you going to do?' said Miyagawa, still holding onto Hideaki .

'To clean up . '

Yakumo, the only one who understood everything, went straight for Jikoukoushinkai's gates .

'I don't get it, but looks like all we can do is go,' complained Gotou, though he followed after Yakumo anyway .

Ishii and Miyagawa exchanged a glance and then walked forward, with Hideaki between them .

Makoto followed as well .

Everyone gathered at the gates . Yakumo confirmed that and then pressed the intercom button .

<Who might you be?>

Perhaps the speaker had seen the commotion outside . The voice was filled with wariness .

'My name is Saitou Yakumo . I've come to exorcise the evil that has possessed your founder, Minegishi Kyouka-sama,' Yakumo declared in a ringing voice .

'Eh? Then she really...' said Ishii .

Yakumo nodded .

'Just as you theorised, Ishii, Minegishi Kyouka-san is possessed by a ghost .

– So that really was it . But then...

'Will they let us in?'

'I'm going even if they refuse . '

'But the gates...'

'Gotou-san can destroy a gate of this level,' said Yakumo recklessly, which made Gotou roll up his sleeves eagerly .

Though Ishii wasn't sure whether the person on the other end could hear this conversation, the gate slowly opened and a woman in white hakama with a sash that had a red Brahma on it came to welcome them .

She was as expressionless as a Noh mask . She had a long fringe and wore glasses . The woman had a very dark look to her .

'Will you really save the founder?' she asked expressionlessly .

'Everyone's idea of salvation is different . All I can do is exorcise the spirit .

Yakumo smiled daringly .

This was the second time Haruka had come to Jikoukoushinkai's base .

Just like last time, she didn't know what was going to happen . All she could do was hold her breath and watch .

Yakumo stood in front of the homa-mandala . Gotou had his arms crossed beside him . Diagonally behind them, Ishii and Miyagawa were standing with Hideaki sandwiched between them .

Haruka stood with Makoto, watching for a bit of a distance .

'What are you going to do?' asked Gotou, tired of waiting .

'An exorcism . '

'Wha?'

Gotou's brows knitted together . Haruka understood his feelings .

– I can't exorcise spirits .

Yakumo himself had said that . And who on earth was he going to exorcise?

As if in response to that, the door opened and the woman who had shown them here came in, pushing a wheelchair .

Haruka was startled .

Minegishi Kyouka sat in the wheelchair . Perhaps she was unconscious, as her neck was limp . She looked just like Gotou had when he had been possessed .

'Please bring her here . '

The woman nodded in response to Yakumo's instruction . She pushed the wheelchair up to Yakumo and took a step back .

'Then I will start . '

Yakumo clapped his hands together .

The sound reverberated, raising the tension a level higher .

'In order to exorcise the spirit from her, there are a number of things that must be made clear,' said Yakumo . Then, he moved to stand in front of Hideaki .

Hideaki slowly lifted his head . His expression was very different than the one Haruka remembered .

He glared at Yakumo with what seemed like killing intent .

However, Yakumo didn't budge . He turned his gaze to Ishii .

'Ishii-san . He confessed to killing Hiyama Kenichirou . '

'Eh, ah, yes,' replied Ishii, though he sounded confused .

'Unfortunately, he didn't kill Hiyama Kenichirou,' declared Yakumo .

'What are you talking about?' interrupted Gotou, unable to bear it .
However, Yakumo just raised a hand to quell Gotou and turned towards Hideaki again .

'He made a terrible mistake . That was the motive for murder that he gave Ishii-san . '

– Motive for murder?

Haruka hadn't heard that .

'What motive?' asked Haruka .

Yakumo looked at Ishii .

'Ishii-san, please explain . '

'Ah, yes . Hiyama Kenichirou-shi approached Hideaki-shi to try to use his ability to see spirits . Because Hideaki-shi refused, his sister was assaulted... is what he said . '

'That is a lie,' Yakumo said the moment Ishii finished his explanation .

'What do you mean, lie?' interrupted Miyagawa .

'He abducted me . He left me in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees to try to distance me from the case . Do you understand what that means?'

'Ah!'

Makoto was the one who spoke up first .

Everyone's gazes focussed on her . At Yakumo's nod, Makoto began her explanation .

'If he could see spirits, he couldn't have gone to Aokigahara's Sea of Trees and been fine . '

'I see...'

Haruka understood from that explanation .

If Hideaki could see the spirits of the dead, the moment he entered that forest, he would have been surrounded by countless spirits who had committed suicide, just as Yakumo had .

However, that didn't happen . Which meant that he couldn't see .

'I see . If he can't see spirits, there wouldn't be a motive for murder,' said Ishii .

Hideaki pushed Ishii with the face of a demon .

'That's not true! I killed him!'

'Don't make a fuss . '

Miyagawa tried to push Hideaki down, but Yakumo stopped him .

Yakumo slowly walked towards Hideaki .

'Listen . You didn't kill him . You have no reason to . '

'The reason doesn't matter! I killed him 'cause I didn't like him!'

Hideaki grabbed Yakumo by the collar .

However, Yakumo accepted that expressionlessly .

'You aren't so foolish that you would kill someone for a reason like that . '

'Don't decide that for me! What do you know? You just hid by yourself in your shell – what do you know?'

Haruka felt sad for some reason as she looked at Hideaki screaming .

Why was he going so far to claim he killed someone? What would that do for him?

The response to those questions came to Haruka surprisingly easily .

– He's trying to protect .

'It's true that I did not have any companions in high school, but still – no, because of that, I understand something .

'What?'

'I always thought it strange . Why did you lie about being able to see?'

'Stop! Stop it! Please! Just say I killed him! Please! That's what happened! I'm begging you!'

Hideaki knelt, putting his forehead to the ground .

Yakumo's eyes seemed terribly sad as he looked down at him, but they were also kind .

'I can't do that,' Yakumo said quietly . Though the words seemed cold, Haruka didn't feel like they were . Yakumo's human warmth was there .

Hideaki looked up .

'If it's not him, who the hell killed Hiyama?' asked Gotou .

Yakumo slowly turned his gaze towards Gotou .

'Aoi Yuuka . '

The impact of those words made Haruka's head go blank .

– Why her?

28

'Oi, Yakumo . What are you talking about?' said Gotou, raising his voice when he heard Yakumo speak the shocking name of the culprit .

It wasn't only Gotou who was surprised . Ishii had leapt back with an 'Ehh!?' Miyagawa's eyes were wide and he looked like he couldn't even speak .

Meanwhile, Hideaki's face was white as he looked at the floor .

'Though part of this is my theory, this is the truth . '

Yakumo paused and crouched in front of Hideaki, who had collapsed .

'When he returned home, the door was unlocked . Though he was suspicious, he entered the room and saw something unexpected . That was...'

'Stop!'

Hideaki grabbed Yakumo's arm .

Gotou could tell even from a distance that there was some force behind it, but Yakumo still continued .

'Hiyama Kenichirou-san, collapsed on the ground with a knife in his chest . And then his sister, Yuuka, collapsed, blood all over her head . '

'I said to stop!'

Hideaki thrust Yakumo away .

Yakumo fell on his behind, but he got up immediately and looked straight at Hideaki .

'I won't stop . This is what your sister wanted . '

'Stop joking away! Nobody would want this! That's just your ego speaking!'

'Perhaps...'

'Then why do you keep talking!?'

'Do you still not understand!?' yelled Yakumo at the top of his lungs .

It was the first time Gotou had seen Yakumo raise his voice like this .

Forced down by that explosion of emotions, Hideaki faltered for a moment, but he immediately gained a hold of himself and continued to bite at Yakumo .

'You're the one who doesn't understand, Saitou . '

'Listen . At this rate, your sister will die . '

Hideaki stopped at Yakumo's words .

– Die .

'What are you talking about?' interrupted Gotou, unable to bare it .

'She won't open her eyes in hospital . The doctors say she has recovered . Then why won't she wake up?'

– Why not?

'Could her spirit have left her body...'

Haruka was the one who responded to Yakumo's question . Her hands were clasped in front of her chest . She appeared to be shaking .

Yakumo nodded .

'She is trying to stop her brother – you . Those emotions have taken her soul out of her body . As a result, she cannot wake up . '

'T-that's a lie...' said Hideaki with a gasp .

'It isn't a lie . It's your fault that she won't wake up . '

'I...'

Hideaki looked at his own hands as he trembled .

Nobody could say anything to the chain of unexpected facts . There was a long silence until Yakumo spoke again .

'Let us get back on topic . When he saw this situation, he determined that his sister, Yuuka, had killed the man . Then, he tried to take the blame for the crime . '

'B-but... rescue workers went to the scene,' said Ishii, touching his silver-framed glasses with his finger .

'Ishii-san, please recall what happened . The rescue workers didn't go to their home . '

'Ah, that's right . He drove his sister there in his car...'

Ishii clapped his hands together .

'Exactly . The corpse was left there . He returned to his flat and then wiped it down for fingerprints . After that, he deleted the data from the security cameras using the internet . '

'Wait a second . There was an investigation for robbery assault after, right? Wouldn't there be results from the blood?' asked Gotou .

Even if fingerprints had been wiped away, blood wouldn't go that easily . It should have been found .

'Hiyama-san's injury was only a stab to the heart . There wouldn't be much blood if the knife were left in . '

'I see...'

It was just as Yakumo said .

If you didn't take out the knife, blood didn't splatter . That was why there was no blood left behind .

'He took Hiyama Kenichirou-san's corpse out of the flat, put it in his car and drove it to Aokigahara's Sea of Trees . Then, he lit it to make it harder to determine the time of death . '

After hearing Yakumo's explanation, Gotou could see an image in his mind .

An image he had seen when Hiyama's spirit had possessed him . Somebody walking through the forest with heavy baggage . So that had been Hideaki .

29

The truth Yakumo revealed was forceful .

All Ishii could do was listen in silence .

'Though the corpse had been taken care of, his sister was in hospital, injured . He had to think of a reason for that . Then...'

'He faked the robbery assault,' said Ishii in a hoarse voice .

That was probably why the victim report had come in the day after the incident . However, there was something Ishii didn't understand .

'Excuse me... How about Imoto-shi, who committed suicide?' asked Ishii, raising his hand .

'If the corpse hadn't been found, he would have left things as is . However, the young man and woman who went exploring in Aokigahara's Sea of Trees found the corpse . That meant there was a possibility it would trace back to him . There, he tried to make it into two separate cases . '

'Separate cases?'

Ishii cocked his head .

'To put it simply, it made it necessary to solve his sister's case . '

'I see . '

If the corpse was found and the investigation continued, Yuuka could be suspected . That meant that her case had to be solved .

'There he advanced the plan that he had prepared ahead of time . '

'The murder of Imoto-shi, whom he made to look like the perpetrator . '

'No, that isn't correct . '

Yakumo immediately rejected Ishii's opinion .

'Eh?'

'Imoto-san had planned on committing suicide from the start . He had accessed a site frequented by people with suicidal tendencies . '

'Yes . '

After responding, Ishii realised what Yakumo was trying to say .

'He accessed the site as well, chose an appropriate target and contacted him . '

'And that target was Imoto-shi...'

'Correct . He had been a believer of Jikoukoushinkai in the past and had a loan . Nobody would be a better candidate to blame for a robbery assault . '

'B-but he had life insurance...'

That was what Ishii had been troubled by .

– Why did somebody planning on committing suicide get life insurance?

'In order to make it seem like a robbery assault, there had to be evidence of it . In order for that, he needed Imoto-san's cooperation . '

'The wallet left in the room . '

'Correct . He had one requirement . He wanted him to keep proof that it was a robbery assault . In exchange, he said he would make it seem like a murder...'

'Imoto-shi believed that and committed suicide...'

After Ishii said that, Yakumo looked solemn .

Ishii understood why . Imoto had had a heavy loan and separated from his wife and child – he had been in despair .

At the end, Imoto had tried to leave behind insurance money as atonement for everything up until now .

However, that promise had not been fulfilled . How did he feel right now?
And Hideaki –

Ishii looked towards Hideaki .

He seemed to have lost the will to stand . He just lay on the floor with his head hung .

'Afterwards, he made up the story about being able to see ghosts and led Ishii-san to where Imoto-san had committed suicide . '

'So we were completely used...' said Miyagawa with a pained expression .

Ishii felt the same way . To be honest, he had completely believed that Hideaki could see ghosts .

If he had been more suspicious, he might have noticed at an earlier stage, but –

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Hideaki's shoulders slumped . He felt powerless .

He had had a bad feeling the moment he met Yakumo again . The feeling that he would reveal everything soon .

And that feeling had been correct –

'Why did he lie about being able to see ghosts?' asked Gotou from beside Yakumo .

'I had wondered the same thing in high school . '

Yakumo's response surprised Hideaki .

'You knew I couldn't see...?'

'I did,' responded Yakumo expressionlessly .

Yakumo's words had a strong impact on Hideaki .

'To be honest, I hated you . I wondered how you could lie so calmly even though you couldn't see...'

'I... '

Hideaki gripped his fists tightly .

It wasn't like he had lied because he wanted to . He had had a reason .

'But I realised during this case . The real reason that you claimed to be able to see ghosts...'

'W-what?'

Hideaki saw Yakumo's red left eye .

When he looked at that vivid colour, he felt like it saw right through to the bottom of his heart .

'I realized the reason you were lying after this incident occurred . '

'Saitou...'

'Your sister came to me for help . Why was that?'

'You...'

'She knew I could see . How did she know... It was because she herself had the ability to see,' Yakumo said calmly .

Hideaki thought about objecting, but the words wouldn't come out of his mouth .

Just as he said, the one who could see ghosts was not Hideaki, but his younger sister, Yuuka . During high school, when Hideaki asked Yakumo, 'You can see them too, right?', that had been a request from Yuuka, who had wanted to confirm it .

'You wanted to protect your sister . That was why you said that you could see spirits . '

Yakumo's words were like an attack .

Tears spilled out of Hideaki's eyes . They wouldn't stop . Before he'd noticed, he was on the ground, sobbing .

He had first met Yuuka when he was in the first year of junior high . His father had remarried and Yuuka had been introduced to him as his father's wife's child .

Until then, Hideaki had not known a mother's love .

He had often doubted his reason for existing, thinking that he wasn't necessary to anyone .

However, after meeting Yuuka, he had been needed by somebody for the first time in his life . She had grown close to Hideaki immediately .

His life, which had been solitary up until then, quickly became full of energy .

For Hideaki, it had been a happiness he had never experienced .

He never wanted to lose the comfortable place he had found .

– I can see ghosts .

One day, Yuuka confessed to Hideaki .

She said that her friends had practically all left her because they thought it creepy . Hideaki vowed to protect Yuuka no matter what .

From the next day onwards, Hideaki began to declare in front of his friends that he could see ghosts .

He took the brunt of it himself so that others wouldn't find out about Yuuka's unique ability .

That was also why he said that being able to see was in his blood .

People knew that Hideaki and Yuuka were stepsiblings . By saying that, he was indirectly claiming that Yuuka did not have that ability .

Perhaps he had been trying to understand Yuuka's suffering by undergoing the discrimination she had .

And then, four years ago, after their parents died, Hideaki reached a decision .

– I'll at least protect Yuuka .

He didn't want to lose anything else . That was why –

'Stand . '

Yakumo held a hand out towards Hideaki .

His face still covered in tears, Hideaki looked at Yakumo .

'Your mistake was your inability to believe in your sister . '

'In my sister?'

Hideaki's eyes went wide .

He didn't understand what Yakumo was trying to say .

'What you did threw the case off track . '

'W-what are you talking about?'

'Don't get it wrong . I didn't come here to trap you . I came here to save you . So believe in me . There is still something you should say . '

Hideaki didn't know that Yakumo was the sort of person who could speak with such fervour .

Though Hideaki was hesitant, he took Yakumo's hand .

It felt like Yakumo's warmth was coming through to him via his palm, which gripped his so tightly .

'Now, the real performance begins . '

Yakumo smirked as Hideaki stood up .

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– Now, the real performance begins?

'What do you mean?' pressed Gotou, unable to stop himself . It made it sound like everything until now had been a side show .

Yakumo ran a hand through his hair, seeming annoyed .

'Exactly what I said . '

'What?'

'I'll explain now, so please stop making a fuss . '

Yakumo stuck his fingers in his ears .

Gotou bit his lower lip . Yakumo annoyed him, but all Gotou could do was deal with it .

'Now, let us begin her exorcism . '

Yakumo moved to stand in front of Minegishi Kyouka, who sat in a wheelchair .

Kyouka's body slowly shook, as if in response to Yakumo, and she let out a low moan .

'I will say this first . The spirit possessing her is Hiyama Kenichirou-san . '

'W-what?' said Gotou unconsciously .

Hiyama's ghost had been possession Gotou . Why was he possessing Kyouka now?

'When I brought you here before, Gotou-san, Kyouka-san performed an exorcism,' explained Yakumo .

Gotou couldn't remember it, but he'd heard .

'So you're saying that Minegishi Kyouka screwed up the exorcism and got possessed herself?'

'Not exactly . '

'What?'

'Minegishi Kyouka-san cannot perform exorcisms . '

'But Gotou-san had been...' said Haruka, leaning forward .

'Unfortunately, that was just your wrong impression . By bringing Gotou-san here when he was possessed by Hiyama-san's spirit, Hiyama-san met with Kyouka-san again . Hiyama-san's spirit took that chance to leave Gotou-san's body . Why?'

There was no response to Yakumo's question . Everyone kept their mouths shut .

Gotou thought about it, but he came up with nothing .

'Then let me change the question . Gotou-san . '

'Wha?'

'When you were possessed, you felt Hiyama-san's thoughts, correct?'

'Ah...'

Just as Yakumo said, Gotou had sometimes seen a few images vaguely .

'What did he say?'

'Sorry... That's what he said . '

'That was meant for the Aoi siblings . '

'W-what?'

'Furthermore, there was more to the words “You did” . '

'More?'

'He had been trying to say, “You didn't kill me . ”'

Now that Yakumo said it, Gotou felt he was right .

He had stopped listening when he realised that the phone call was from a ghost .

'Now it is your turn to talk . '

Yakumo looked towards Hideaki .

'Me?'

'Yes . You knew Hiyama-san from before, didn't you?'

Hideaki didn't reply . However, Yakumo didn't press him further .

Yakumo probably already knew the answer .

'What are you talking about?' Gotou asked .

'Hiyama Kenichirou-san was Aoi Yuuka's real father . '

'What?'

'Hideaki and Yuuka aren't real siblings . Hideaki's father and Yuuka's mother both came into the marriage with children from their previous marriages . '

'B-but Hiyama-shi wasn't married either, so he couldn't have had children... . ' interrupted Ishii .

For some reason, it looked like he wanted to cry .

'Yuuka's mother gave birth out of wedlock . '

So her dad had been Hiyama Kenichirou . But –

'Why do you know that?' asked Gotou .

'There was an album in the old Jikoukoushinkai base . '

Yakumo had been looking at an album attentively then .

'What was in it?'

'Old photographs . '

After saying that, Yakumo handed Gotou a photograph .

It was old . It was a photo of Hiyama Kenichirou when he was young with another woman .

'This woman...'

'I thought that this was Yuuka's mother and had Eishin-san gather information for me . '

– Ah, I see .

Gotou understood then . Actually, he had been the one who told Eishin to do that .

He hadn't understood just from hearing the name . So that was what it meant .

'Why didn't Hiyama marry even though they had a kid?'

Gotou didn't understand .

He wouldn't have felt any disgust for that in the past, but it was different now that he was a parent . Why had Hiyama abandoned the woman who gave birth to his child –

'He hadn't known that she had given birth . '

The person who showed the most surprise at Yakumo's words was Hideaki .

'Didn't know?'

Hideaki looked pleadingly at Yakumo .

'Hiyama-san had the ability to see the spirits of the dead – that is, ghosts . '

'W-what?'

'So that really was the case,' said Makoto, in contrast to Gotou's surprise .

'How do you know that?' asked Gotou .

Makoto seemed hesitant, but she began her explanation .

'When Jikoukoushinkai was based in Yamanashi, Hiyama-san had been the one working as a spiritual consultant . But when they became a religious group...'

'They switched?' said Gotou . He understood now .

But he didn't understand why they'd needed to switch . Yakumo added to the explanation as if he had read Gotou's mind .

'Hiyama-san didn't approve of switching Jikoukoushinkai into a religious group . That wasn't all – he had left...'

'But his name is in the registry...' interrupted Ishii .

'That was probably because of her lingering affection,' said Yakumo, gesturing at Minegishi Kyouka .

– Lingering affection .

In short, Hiyama and Kyouka's relationship had been that of a man and a woman .

'So Hiyama abandoned Yuuka's mother because he got Kyouka, a new woman?'

'That's incorrect . '

Yakumo immediately rejected Gotou's words .

Gotou didn't get it any more .

'Then why?'

'Though part of this is theory, I think that Hiyama-san loathed his ability . He knew that it was something he had received from his parents . Then, he heard from Yuuka's mother, his lover at the time, that she was pregnant...'

Yakumo bit his lip .

It probably reminded him of his own situation . Yakumo's mother must have had the same conflict .

'So he tried to get her to have an abortion . '

'Yes . However, Yuuka's mother lied about getting an abortion and gave birth to her child . After that, she left Hiyama-san . '

– What the hell?

It was too much for Gotou . He understood why Hiyama would hate his own genes . He also understood why Yuuka's mother would want to give birth to her own child .

They had each had their own conflict and come to their own conclusion .

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– So that's how it was .

Ishii continued to be surprised by the chain of facts .

Yakumo slowly turned his gaze towards Ishii .

'Let us talk about Jikoukoushinkai once more . '

Here, Yakumo took a deep breath and left a pause before continuing .

'Minegishi Kyouka-san continued to try to convince Hiyama-san to return, but he did not respond . He continued trying to research the existence of souls . He didn't want the ability that he had suffered for to be used for that purpose . '

Though Yakumo was speaking disinterestedly, his expression twisted for just a moment .

If Yakumo felt like it, he could probably make a lot of money by starting a religion .

However, he didn't do that . He probably didn't want to use his ability for money, just as Hiyama hadn't .

However, from Kyouka's perspective, it had been a matter of life or death .

She had started a religious group, but she had no ability . If she didn't get Hiyama back somehow, the future would be troubling .

'Then, Minegishi Kyouka-san found out about Hiyama-san's daughter . '

'Yuuka-san . '

Yakumo had said that she could see the spirits of the dead – that is, ghosts .

She had inherited her father's ability .

'Correct . Minegishi Kyouka-san contacted Hiyama-san's daughter and tried to get her to join the religious group . However, Hiyama-san didn't forgive that . '

'Could it be...'

Hideaki lifted his head, like he had sensed something .

'That's why I said to believe . '

Yakumo's eyes narrowed . It seemed like the answer had already revealed itself to the two of them .

However, Ishii didn't understand .

'W-what happened?'

'One day, Minegishi Kyouka-san visited Yuuka's house . She was going to get her to join Jikoukoushinkai even if she had to use force . '

'There'd be no point forcing her to join, right?' said Gotou . Ishii agreed with that opinion .

Forcing somebody to do something they didn't want to do would lead to failure .

'Let me put it differently . She used her as a hostage to negotiate with Hiyama-san . '

'I see . '

Ishii understood now .

She had tried to use Hiyama's daughter as a hostage to get Hiyama to join her again .

'However, Hiyama-san could not forgive that . That situation led the three of them to gather in Yuuka's room...'

'M-Minegishi Kyouka-shi was in that room too?'

In shock, Ishii looked towards Kyouka, who sat in the wheelchair with her head hung .

Perhaps Kyouka was responding to Ishii, as she slowly lifted her head . When Ishii saw that pale face, he wanted to shriek .

Yakumo didn't hesitate . He crouched in front of Kyouka and met her eyes .

'Kyouka-san and Hiyama-san got into an argument . Yuuka tried to stop them and was thrust away . She hit her head and fainted...'

'Eh?'

Hideaki's body was trembling –

'Then, Hiyama-san was furious . Kyouka-san, in her fear, picked up a knife from the kitchen and thrust the blade into his chest... and then she escaped from the scene . Then, you returned . '

Yakumo gave Hideaki a sharp look .

What came next was probably as Yakumo had explained earlier .

Hideaki had seen Hiyama dead with the kitchen knife in his chest, and Hideaki had mistakenly thought that his sister had killed him .

Then, he had forged evidence to protect his sister and made the case more complicated .

'I-I...'

Hideaki was shaking violently .

Yakumo slowly stood up and faced Hideaki . However, Hideaki didn't have the means or strength to oppose Yakumo .

'I said it earlier . Your mistake was your inability to believe in your sister . '

Ishii thought Yakumo was absolutely right .

Hideaki should have believed in Yuuka and just called for an ambulance and the police .

Kyouka's fingerprints would have been found in the room and on the knife, and the police would probably have been able to make a case against her .

However, Ishii couldn't blame Hideaki for his actions .

The reason was that his actions had come from love . He hadn't been trying to hurt anyone .

That wasn't all . He had sacrificed his own life to try to cover up Yuuka's crime .

'You've never thought of Yuuka as your sister . '

Yakumo's words made Hideaki's breathing ragged .

'N-no... I...'

'Don't hide it any longer . You love Yuuka . Of course, this is not as a sister, but as a woman . That's why you've done this much . '

'I...'

'She's noticed your feelings as well . That's why you can stop hiding it already . '

Yakumo placed a hand on Hideaki's shoulder .

That moment, Hideaki collapsed, as if all the strength had been stolen from his body, and started sobbing loudly .

His sobs, which sounded like cries, echoed throughout –

– I came to save you .

Now, as Haruka looked at Hideaki, who was crying on the ground, he understood what Yakumo had meant by his words .

Even as Yakumo saw through the case, he had been trying to save Hideaki .

If Hideaki had expressed how he felt, perhaps he would have made a different choice .

Not only had he kept his feelings to himself, he hadn't been able to believe in Yuuka .

It wasn't just him . His father Hiyama, Yuuka's mother and Kyouka had been the same . If they had properly expressed their feelings, this sad incident wouldn't have occurred .

Haruka looked at Yakumo .

She replaced Hideaki's feelings with her own . If she didn't express her feelings, she might lose her ability to believe in Yakumo one day . That was why –

Haruka came to a decision .

'It's your turn,' said Yakumo . He looked at Kyouka in her wheelchair . His gaze was kind, as if he was pitying her .

In response, Kyouka let out a low moan .

'It has ended . There is no longer a reason for you to wander,' Yakumo said, placing a hand on Kyouka's shoulder . Then, for just a moment, Kyouka smiled . Then, she fainted .

Yakumo's eyes narrowed as he looked up at the ceiling, as if watching something .

'He left . '

Quietly, Yakumo declared that the incident was over .

Everyone there was relieved . It had been a painful and depressing case, but now everything was over .

However, for some reason, Yakumo's expression stiffened again .

'You're still here though . '

After saying that, Yakumo looked at the woman in a mountain priest's outfit, who had shown them in .

The woman smirked for just a moment in response .

'Whatever do you mean?'

The woman cocked her head .

'I mean exactly what I said . Let's end this lacklustre performance already, Nanase Miyuki-san . '

'Eh?'

The unexpected name that left Yakumo's lips gave everyone a chill .

They all looked towards the woman, but she didn't bear the slightest resemblance .

'Oi, Yakumo, what are you talking about?' yelled Gotou .

'I mean exactly what I said . She is Nanase Miyuki-san . '

'B-but her face...'

'It's a silicone mask . Though they are not common in Japan, you can have masks that look exactly like the person you want made to order overseas . '

'B-but...'

Wouldn't they have noticed if there was a mask?

'There have been cases in America where the police did not realise that the suspect was wearing a mask and arrested the wrong person . However, the mask has a weak point . It is expressionless . '

'Come to think of it...'

It had been the same when they met her earlier . This woman was shockingly expressionless . So that was the reason?

'Furthermore, she cannot hide that hand . '

Yakumo gestured at the woman's left hand . Now that Haruka took a closer look, she noticed that it was artificial . She hadn't looked that far .

Haruka recalled the last case . Nanase Miyuki had lost her left hand from the wrist up .

'You really are an annoying child . '

The woman's tone changed . No, not just her tone . Her voice had changed greatly as well .

Haruka had heard that voice before . It was definitely Nanase Miyuki .

Miyuki tried to escape, but Gotou moved more quickly . He tackled her to the ground .

'You think we'd let you get away!?'

Gotou sat atop her back and pulled her right arm behind her . Then, he ripped the silicone mask off her face .

Underneath it was Nanase Miyuki's face . The genuine article .

'You have to treat ladies more kindly . '

Nanase Miyuki had a fearless smile even in this situation .

'You're not even human!'

Gotou had no mercy .

'W-why is she...'

Ishii spoke up hesitantly .

Makoto was the one who responded .

'Jikoukoushinkai became a religious group two years ago . She was the one who orchestratedated that . '

'Correct,' responded Yakumo .

So she really was involved – the moment Haruka understood, she felt a sense of terror .

'So the religion was their front,' Gotou said bitterly .

'Furthermore, Hiyama-san had also been a candidate to be the vessel of the man with two red eyes,' Yakumo said coolly .

The goal of the man with two red eyes had become apparent during Isshin's case . He was searching for a new body, now that he was dead .

He had probably focussed on Jikoukoushinkai because Hiyama could see ghosts .

'That man was no good at all,' Miyuki said calmly, not shaken by the situation at all .

– There's something she's not telling us .

Haruka felt that . She could tell from what she'd experienced up until now . Miyuki was the type that flared up when things didn't go her way .

For her to be acting so calmly, something was definitely strange .

The moment Haruka realized that, the homa-mandala in the middle of the room was lit up with fire . Sparks flew, lighting the shimenawa .

'I fiddled a bit with the homa-mandala . If you don't leave now, everyone will burn to death . '

Miyuki giggled shrilly .

Ishii and Miyagawa tried to put out the fire, but it was no use . In no time, the fire crawled across the floor and enveloped the room .

'Everyone, run!' yelled Gotou . However, that moment, he loosened his hold on Miyuki, just a little .

Miyuki didn't let the chance escape her .

She slipped out from under Gotou and pulled out a knife swiftly .

She smiled, looking extremely amused .

'You'll die too . '

Yakumo glared at Miyuki . However, she continued to smile regardless .

'Don't think you can get away with all of us here . '

Gotou got up immediately and went towards Miyuki .

It was true that it would be easy to subdue Miyuki with so many people .

'True . With all of you here, it is pretty tough . Maybe I'll cut down the number . '

'W-what?' said Gotou .

Miyuki slowly looked at all of them and then looked straight at Ishii .

'You first, Ishii-san . '

'Eh?' said Ishii in confusion .

'Freeze,' said Nanase Miyuki . Ishii's eyes went wide in shock as his body froze .

Haruka couldn't understand what had happened .

'Ishii-san, did you forget? I hypnotised you . Unfortunately, you won't be able to move any more . '

Miyuki smiled .

Those words made Haruka remember . In the past, Yakumo had said it was likely that Ishii was still under hypnotic suggestion from Nanase Miyuki .

'Damn...'

Yakumo's expression twisted .

Miyuki walked towards Ishii with her knife .

Ishii couldn't move . Fear made his face twitch .

Yakumo and Gotou ran to try to stop Miyuki, but they didn't make it in time . Haruka shut her eyes unconsciously .

A moment of silence –

When Haruka opened her eyes again, she saw something unbelievable .

Makoto stood in front of Ishii to protect him . Miyuki had stabbed her knife into Makoto's stomach .

'M-Makoto-san!'

When Haruka yelled, Makoto collapsed to the floor .

Red blood spilled onto the ground .

'I won't forgive you!'

Yakumo flew at Miyuki . Perhaps he had become emotional – that was far too careless .

'No!' screamed Haruka, but it was too late .

Miyuki turned the knife towards him .

'Aaagh!' shouted Yakumo as he fell backwards .

'Yakumo-kun!'

Haruka ran towards Yakumo .

As he lay on the ground, Yakumo had both hands on his left eye . Blood was flowing out between his fingers .

Could his left eye –

'Haruka-chan! Get Yakumo out now! Miyagawa-san, take care of Ishii!'

Gotou gave directions to the rest of them, who were stunned, and picked up Makoto himself .

Smoke filled the room . Haruka could barely see .

She couldn't see Nanase Miyuki .

In the confusion, Haruka tried to get Yakumo up, but it wasn't going well . At this rate, everyone was going to die .

Haruka was filled with an emotion close to despair .

'I'll carry Saitou . You get her . '

Hideaki looked at Kyouka and then carried Yakumo like he was lending him a shoulder .

'Thank you . '

Haruka left Yakumo to Hideaki and pushed Kyouka in her wheelchair .

She was frantic .

After rushing out of Jikoukoushinkai, she turned around and found it red with flames .

– Yakumo-kun?

She looked around and found Yakumo leaning against Hideaki .

His left eye was dyed red with blood .

Volume 9 Chapter 4: Epilogue.

VOLUME 9 – THE SPIRIT OF SALVATION epilogue

Ishii silently looked at Makoto, who lay on the bed.

Makoto had been brought to the hospital by ambulance immediately after that. Her life have been saved by the surgery, but she hadn't woken up.

– It's my fault.

He should have been the one on that bed, but Makoto had used her own body to protect him.

He was always like this. People always protected him. He couldn't even save a single person.

Something hot welled up within Ishii.

It was anger.

– Unforgivable.

He couldn't forgive Nanase Miyuki, who had stabbed Makoto, but more than anything, he couldn't forgive his powerless self.

'Ishii-san...'

He heard a voice. Makoto's voice.

When he looked at her, he saw that she had her eyes open, though only slightly.

'M-Makoto-san,' said Ishii, in surprise and relief.

'Thank goodness... Ishii-san, you're all right,' said Makoto weakly.

Something hot stabbed Ishii in the chest.

– Why?

Makoto had suffered so much, but the first thing out of her mouth was concern for Ishii. Ishii didn't understand why.

All he understood was that there were tears coming out of his eyes.

'Why... are you crying?'

Makoto smiled, though it looked like she was in pain.

'I don't know.'

Ishii shook his head.

Perhaps it was inappropriate, but he was just so happy. He was so happy that he could speak with Makoto like this again.

Ishii sniffled and wiped his tears with his sleeve.

'Ishii-san... are you all right?'

Makoto gripped Ishii's hand. There wasn't much strength behind it. He just felt her warmth enveloping him. His heart was melting –

'Makoto-san, why did you save me?'

When Ishii asked that, Makoto's eyes narrowed. It looked like she felt awkward.

'I wonder why. I don't know... Before I'd noticed, I was standing there...'

'Please stop it.'

'Eh?'

'Next time, Makoto-san, I'll save you. So please stop doing that sort of thing. I'd rather die than lose you.'

Ishii himself was surprised by the words that came out of his mouth.

He had spoken without thinking, but at the same time, he knew that those were his true feelings. That was what Makoto meant to Ishii.

Ishii looked straight at Makoto, which made her hide her face with the blanket.

'Please don't look at me like that.'

'Eh?'

'It's a bit embarrassing.'

'Ah, er, um, I'm sorry.'

Ishii hurriedly bowed his head.

Ishii was the one who felt embarrassed now. He was about to leave the room, but Makoto grabbed his hand.

'Could you stay just a bit longer?' asked Makoto, her face red.

* * *

Gotou was sitting on the bench in the waiting room when Miyagawa walked over, grumbling, 'Damn, what a mess...'

He looked exhausted – like he had aged ten years.

'It really is,' responded Gotou with a bitter smile.

'How's that newspaper reporter, Hijikata?' said Miyagawa, sitting next to Gotou.

'The injury was shallower than expected, so her life isn't in danger. Ishii is with her now.'

'Oh? That's great.'

Miyagawa sighed in relief.

Gotou felt the same way. He had been worried for a while. He wouldn't have been able to sleep at night if somebody became a victim in front of his eyes. And –

'How's that brat?' asked Miyagawa, interrupting Gotou's thoughts.

He was probably talking about Yakumo.

'Yakumo's life isn't in danger either.'

'That's great.'

'But the place where he was cut...'

'His red left eye...'

'Yes.'

Nanase Miyuki had cut Yakumo's left eye. They were waiting for the results, but the worst-case scenario was that he might lose his sight in that eye.

If that happened, how would Yakumo accept it?

Gotou thought about it, but he couldn't imagine.

'So how's the case?' asked Gotou. There was no point thinking about what he didn't know.

'The founder woke up. She's being interrogated now.'

'Is that so...'

'Seems she's confessed to killing Hiyama Kenichirou.'

'That's great.'

'Yeah.'

Had she realised she couldn't run any more, or had she felt regret when Hiyama Kenichirou possessed her – in either case, it seemed like the case would be solved.

'So how about that brat, Hideaki?'

'Probably going to be arrested soon for tampering with a corpse and instigating a suicide.'

Miyagawa's explanation seemed a bit careless.

Hideaki hadn't been trying to hurt anybody. He had just wanted to protect his sister, Yuuka. But that didn't mean what he had done was forgivable.

'One silver lining though. Seems his sister's woken up.'

For just a moment, Miyagawa's expression softened.

'Really?'

'Yeah. Seems her condition's stable.'

Just as Miyagawa, perhaps that was the one silver lining.

Yakumo had said that Yuuka wouldn't wake up because she was trying to stop her brother, Hideaki, and had left her body to wander.

Now that the case was solved, her spirit had probably returned to her body.

However, the problem was what came next. Even though she had been living properly, she had been wrapped up in an unbelievable case.

She would have to live while facing reality.

'The root of this awfulness was that woman.'

– That woman. Nanase Miyuki.

Nanase Miyuki had used the founder, Minegishi Kyouka, and changed Jikoukoushinkai into a religious group.

Without her, the incident might not have occurred. And Yakumo and Makoto wouldn't have ended up like this.

A fierce anger boiled up within Gotou –

'Right now, we're searching for Nanase Miyuki with all our resources, but...'

Miyagawa stopped in the middle and looked up at the ceiling quietly.

We can't catch Nanase Miyuki – that was probably what he was thinking. Gotou felt the same way.

Nanase Miyuki had slipped out of countless police nets. She wouldn't be caught so easily. She would definitely show up again though.

– I'll definitely catch her next time.

A strong resolve took root within Gotou.

* * *

Haruka timidly opened the hospital door.

Yakumo lay on the bed inside the quiet hospital room.

His left eye, which had been cut by Nanase Miyuki, was bandaged. The bandage was a bit wet with blood. It looked like it hurt.

Haruka had thought that he was sleeping, but Yakumo opened his right eye and stared up at the ceiling blankly.

'Yakumo-kun...'

She called out to him.

Without moving, Yakumo murmured, 'You...'

His voice was incredibly weak.

'How's your injury?' asked Haruka as she walked up to the bed.

If it was only the eyelid that had been cut, the injury would probably heal quickly, but if the eyeball had been injured, he might lose his sight in that eye.

Yakumo slowly sat up, pressing his left eye through the bandage.

'It's mysterious...'

'Eh?'

'I hated this left eye. Why could only I see the spirits of the dead... If all I could do was see, it would be better not to. I had thought that...'

'Yes.'

Haruka nodded.

Isshin had told Haruka in the past about an episode when Yakumo had tried to injure his red left eye himself.

He had despised his ability that much.

'And yet now it would irritate me not to see... even though I hated it so much...'

Yakumo smiled awkwardly.

Haruka understood his feelings painfully. She didn't know Yakumo in the past, but the current Yakumo believed that his red left eye with the ability to

see the spirits of the dead could save people, and he was trying to accept it.

And then it had been injured. His heart must have been filled with terrible conflict.

'Yakumo-kun...'

'To be honest, I'm afraid. If I can't see any more...'

Yakumo looked up at the ceiling.

His narrowed right eye seemed a little wet.

'It's fine. You don't have to be afraid.'

Haruka enveloped Yakumo's hand with her own.

An exasperated smile appeared on Yakumo's face.

'You're optimistic.'

'Is that praise?'

'Why would I have to praise you?'

'Honestly!'

Haruka pretended to be angry, but she was a bit relieved.

The usual Yakumo had returned.

She didn't know what was waiting for them, but she swore in her heart to be by Yakumo's side no matter what happened.

At that time, Haruka had no reason to suspect that the next case had already begun –